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Prologue:

United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland by Eliot Ashton

'Your meddling in continental affairs, and trying to make yourselves a great military power, instead of attending to the sea and commerce, will yet be your ruin as a nation. You were greatly offended with me for having called you a nation of shopkeepers. Had I meant by this, that you were a nation of cowards, you would have had reason to be displeased; even though it were ridiculous and contrary to historical facts; but no such thing was ever intended. I meant that you were a nation of merchants, and that all your great riches, and your grand resources arose from commerce, which is true. What else constitutes the riches of England. It is not extent of territory, or a numerous population. It is not mines of gold, silver, or diamonds. Moreover, no man of sense ought to be ashamed of being called a shopkeeper. But your prince and your ministers appear to wish to change altogether l'esprit of the English, and to render you another nation; to make you ashamed of your shops and your trade, which have made you what you are, and to sigh after nobility, titles and crosses; in fact to assimilate you with the French... You are all nobility now, instead of the plain old Englishmen.' – Napoleon Bonaparte on St. Helena

Part 1: Introduction

For the vast majority of people, for the vast majority of its history: the island of Great Britain has been a great place to live. Compare Britain to the rest of the world and it's not been a bad ol' place to live. The government has always troubled imposing any tyranny, the market economy has been promoted over any other ideology, the individual has been promoted over the collective and levels of wealth on the island have long surpassed comparative continental countries. Admittedly, it has not all been plain sailing. The World Wars were hard, but much easier than a comparative

experience in France or Germany; the original industrialization process was far more brutal than the experience in other countries; but above all the island given a good life to most who have lived on it.
In fact, rather than nationality, rural-urban, or race; the main divide on the island hasn't changed since Norman times. Britain has a major class divide which is still struggles with today. No amount of welfare or technology has ever changed the sheer divide that lives on the island. In some ways, it a marker of its success. A high degree of wealth has meant there had been few bread riots or outright rebellion. A small island with good transport connections has meant the rural areas are as rich, if not richer, than the cities.
The process of industrialization changed the island like nothing since farming was introduced, and with Britain having been the originator of new technologies, it's probable that it was the biggest transformation on the island ever. The 'Dark Satanic Mills' that popped up in the late 18th century changed Britain, drastically – though the process of industrialization can be seen as having been underway for some centuries. The move from agrarian to pre-industrial economy happened in the 12th century which saw the woodlands of the island chopped down for wood, and later charcoal. What was once a land of fair maidens, taverns, travellers and a lack of crime, that was perhaps best encapsulated in Tolkien's Lord of the Rings which showed The Shire of the Hobbits, as an idealized version of pre-industrialized Britain, was something that is disappeared.
Yet the island, faced with innumerable problems over the centuries never quite became one unified island. The Kingdoms of England and Scotland, together with the principality of Wales; and later the Kingdom of Ireland formed together over a millennia to form what we now call today the United Kingdom. It was England and Scotland which together formed the Kingdom of Great Britain, with Wales having been formally annexed by England in the 16th century. When Ireland joined the Union making the entire archipelago one political entity, it resulted in the name changing to the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland, which was a pure political invention to solve problems at home and abroad.
You might this episode is a bit of a stretch, because this is an episode on inventions not on countries, but like our episode on the United States, I argue that the United Kingdom was a deliberate invention and as worthy to be on this list as the telegraph or steam engine – and as an invention – a greater invention than the United States.
The United Kingdom was invented because of at least a two millennia old problem. The island was utterly unconquerable. England was almost unconquerable from the continent; something achieved only twice: by the Roman and then Normans. Wales was conquered only twice, partially by the Romans and then in piecemeal fashion by the Anglo-Normans and later the Tudors. While Scotland, well Scotland to this day, has never truly been conquered. And Ireland, well Jesus, Mary and Joseph, that's a whole story in itself.
The island has strangely been thought of as very homogenous over its history. With perhaps only a few exceptions, the subject of more inward migration like the Irish moving to English, or the rural workers moving to the city; but in reality Britain has been something of a global migration hub. In years gone past this was more emigration as the rapid population build up was solved by mass migration to colonies of the Crown. Yet in recent years it was changed into a more immigration friendly country.
Over time, the historical inwards migratory periods like the Anglo-Saxons, Danes and Norsemen, the Normans, and the Huguenots all came to England for various reasons but were all accepted into wider society more quickly and easily than elsewhere because of their respect for the market economy.
A large theme of this podcast will be the constant and unchanging respect over the millennia in Britain for the freedom of the market economy and its general power over that of centralized rule. This market economy has had an ability to integrate newcomers into the island more than any government policy or proclamation. Divisions throughout history like Anglo-Saxons, Danes, Normans, Scots or later European immigration, and today immigration from across the world have

largely settled peacefully into the market economy. The lure of easy living in a prosperous island is in truth a more powerful force than any other on the island.

Despite or perhaps because of the strength of the market economy, no great power, even those on the island themselves could get a political unification of the land. The Celts, who were slightly more advanced than perhaps we're told, but never managed that one crucial development – political centralization and unity to fight the coming of the Romans.

When the Romans came, they tried to unify the island, but famously failed in any invasion attempts in Scotland, later building Hadrian's Wall to mark the trading border. Later, the Normans would push further and further north but never could beat the Scots. The Normans had a hard enough time subduing the north of England for Scotland to be too much of a lure. For centuries in the medieval and early modern period; English armies tried and failed to conquer Scotland.

So how do you solve a problem like the British? You have to appeal to the only thing the entire island has in common: appeal to common sense and pragmatism.

An artificial construct, the United Kingdom, was invented to join together the island in a political union that otherwise could not have existed. Neither side could conquer the other, and so, something had to be done: the result was political Union; with a legal fiction of equality within the Union. For this invention, we have a clear date: the 1st May 1707.

So this episode is very straight forward but as you have probably worked out, quite long. In it, we will talk about how the United Kingdom was formed, why it was important, and how it impacted on the world.

We all know what the United Kingdom is, don't we? Well I don't think many actually do, even the people of the United Kingdom don't really know of how they came to live in the political polity they live in. Unlike the United States, the story of the United Kingdom is never taught with the same gusto and verve. Yet it's a fascinating story almost as long as the story of people on the island itself. So what of the island itself? What were its unique characteristics compared to the European continent: diversity. Diversity in the traditional sense of the world has been the key to the United Kingdom's success over the centuries.

The British island had long been one of the wealthier countries in Europe on a per capita basis. As result of its low population and diverse natural wealth. Geographically there is no one style to the island. It has a northern French style breadbasket in East Anglia, it has mining regions, moorlands, highlands, rivers and streams. On a continental landmass famous for its east-west axis – the United Kingdom has a North-South axis. The geology of the island, having been formed in numerous periods is highly diverse, giving it a huge abundance of materials under the land, the island status has given it a distance from the madness that occasionally raged across the narrow channel sea, while the sea itself was a hugely beneficial resource from fisheries to later oil reserves.

But despite this, geography isn't destiny. It was in the mid-late 18th century when the island, predominantly the north of England and then rapidly spreading, used many of these abundant materials including coal, to became the first country to industrialized.

So this makes the United Kingdom not an invention like a steam engine, but an invented idea. And we do have many 'software' inventions in this show, software's that enable the hardware and provide a sort of feedback loop without which innovation would not take place. Philosophies, theories and models have to be created to allow physical products to be invented and improved.

The daddy of all human progress: the industrial revolution took place in Britain centuries ago now. Though I'm not somebody who wishes to live back in the industrial era, never mind how much I like steam locomotives and canals, but it is perhaps the central story of the UK in the world. The French have the French Revolution, the Americans and the Revolutionary War, the Russians have the Russian Revolution, and the Germans have that 30 year period between 1914-1945 when they went a bit crazy – shall we saw.

Yet for that 200 years following the Union in 1707, the United Kingdom went through a period of transformation never seen before in human history. The coming together of various technologies allowed the British people's far more power, per capita, over the world than had ever been seen before. One Brit could rule over 2 million Indians in the empire that followed industrialization. The

new technologies allowed the Royal Navy to become more dominant navy than any navy before it. An important start for an island nation.
Britannia began ruling the waves, and with this naval power; it changed most of the world. Britain brought home foreign ideas, allowed its technologies to be exported to new territories for a tidy profit, and spread its power across the world in a far more peaceful way than any global empire before. Not that there weren’t bad incidents, or bad people, or bad decisions along the way. And whether the British Empire, and the result of British economic domination, was an overall good or bad for the world is a debatable subject, but the United Kingdom has perhaps had more impact, on more people, than any other political polity in history.
We will, like we always do, end of the episode with a small talk about the future of this invention. How will the future of the United Kingdom, outside the European Union go. Will it be good or bad? For Britain to succeed, like any country; it needs to have a natural diversity in its economy, in its regions, its peoples, its ideas, and in its politics. Britain has natural diversity in abundance. I have much malignity for the modern use of ‘diversity’. It has been overused and misused; but historically speaking the diversity found in Britain from the Scots, Welsh, Southerners, Cornish, to the north of England; has given it a historic strength to specialize and diversify in many different ways. All of which has come together to form the United Kingdom.
So what was the legacy of the United Kingdom? Well I would argue its the industrial revolution, but more broadly, it was a longer lasting and more global impact upon the entire species of man than any political power before it. No South American, African or Asian country were impacted by the Roman Empire; Europe wasn’t impacted by dynasty changes in China. But Britain was different; more than its politics, it took its technology and culture all over the world.
British style railways and commerce, politics and language, culture and sport were taken to places the world over. The importance of football in South American, Cricket to India, Rugby to Polynesian culture, is entirely down to British influence. The empire, arguably starting in Ireland in the 16th century, then spreading to Bermuda and North America spread across the world to Australia, New Zealand and Africa ended officially in 1997 with the handover of Hong Kong the China, but the writing was well on the cards.
Over the 20th century, the United Kingdom’s position of world leader was passed to the United States, a creation itself borne of and in the spirit of British ideals, which to me, further underlines this inventions importance.
So where do we start in our story of Britain. Well I just want to go through a very brief overview of how the United Kingdom came to be formed, before we get into things in more detail.
The island had been populated for millennia, and due to its isolation there was a slow coming together of people in Celtic times, but nothing official, and what political polities there were, were small and transitory. The island was settled over the centuries as various places across Europe dealt with overpopulation by migrating around the continent.
There was little known resistance to these new migrants, unlike Roman attempts to stop migration. Migratory tribes crossed the channel, but at no point were there really much attempt at forming a strong political polity. There was never any political unification to speak off on the island. For comparison, Japan unified by the 9th century.
Meanwhile across the English channel, Britain’s archrivals, the neighbors from hell: the French, was beginning to fill in most of its semi-autonomous princelets and duchy’s by the mid-14th century in a unification drive. Many had tried to unify the Britons as we spoke about before, but Britain was slower in unifying.
No amount of wars seemed to be able to conquer the Scots, even as the English became more and more powerful and wealthier. Yet around the Early Modern Period, and what really began unifying the island was not war, but religion and money. Scotland became a protestant country around the same time England was, and Scotland auld ally, the French began feeling more distant.
Protestantism was an ever stronger pull for Scotland towards a Protestant Union than independence with reliance on Catholic France could provide. Then when Elizabeth I died, it turned out the natural heir to England was the King of Scotland. The Tudor regime passed from history, as the

Scottish Stuarts unified the crown in 1603. Two massive pieces of historical luck that suddenly bound the island together in cultural, religious, and political importance, without the need for an adversarial war.
So what of this island? For the island of Great Britain itself is worth talking about. In my opinion, it's a fairly unique island. As much a mini-continent in the same way as Japan, or the Indian subcontinent, as it is a mere region of Europe. Like Russia with an internal struggle of whether it is a western or Asiatic power; Britain too, has a constant internal dialogue over whether it's really European, or something unique in and of itself.
The British archipelago, including Ireland, is however, far different to the continent. The Isles are incredibly geologically diverse for a start. Almost everything you need for a modern world economy: oil, coal, gas, marble, tin, copper, lithium, and huge fisheries have been found in huge abundance on or around the Isles. Meanwhile Europe is one large plain of agricultural land with far fewer minerals. Further, compare Britain to Japan. Japan has almost no natural resources to speak off.
The British islands are also a great agricultural power, with warm heat and natural minerals coming from the gulf stream providing a rich and plentiful agricultural land, and making British farming land highly productive. Furthermore, the British fishing waters have long been some of the most abundant in the world. Just ask yourself why fisheries became such an important part of the EU withdrawal debate.
Further too, the English channel is just about big enough to provide easy transport to the continent, but far enough distance to make invading difficult; giving a natural internal stability and protection from the threat of outside invasion.
In short, the British islands are naturally wealthy and fairly safe, with not just lots of diverse materials, but some of the highest quality of minerals too. The islands are the most diverse geological area of Western Europe. The historic wealth was noted by lots of foreigners to the islands. Ceaser recognized the tin mines of Cornwall as one of the most valuable places in the known world, and had perhaps heard of the stories of the fertility and productive of the agricultural sector, which was starting to produce the seeds of a market economy around Kent, which was acting like a Maritime Kingdom. He also later found much gold in Wales and silver mines dotted around the country.
It took a while to finally achieve, but the Romans did invade and conquer England. England and Britain didn't have the centralized political power of say the Germanic hoards, making it capable of a brutal war against the Roman's it might have taken to repel Rome. Like the modern day Germans in the Teutoburg Forest, which secured German independence almost permanently against Rome. But the Romans didn't annex England in the way we're familiar with, but merely attempted to control the market economy and to Romanize the elites of the country. While on the islands, the Roman discovered the natural abundance in materials that allowed a degree of self- sufficiency to avoid long-supply lines and helped to reinforce Roman Rule. It also precipitated the breaking out of a market economy on the island. Roman Rule later waned as despite the relatively strong rule on the island, the Empire needed to move its troops elsewhere. When the Romans left, the people on the island didn't establish a strong centralized rule, instead breaking down into a feudalism that slowly looked to be gaining centralization if it wasn't again for those pesky Europeans getting involved again and causing trouble.
In 793 AD men from the North, we now call Vikings or Norsemen, raided the holiest place in the Northumbrian Kingdom, Lindisfarne. A rich and peaceful place, the attack on the Christian way of life, by pagans from the north marked the start of a centuries long battle with these new invaders. Primarily they wanted to loot, plunder and settle the wealthy islands to escape the overflowing Scandinavia, where populations had begun to outgrow the natural resources of the fairly barren landscape. The Viking chiefs needed more resources for their people, and so they plundered, repeatedly, the wealthiest place they could find: Britain. They quickly saw the advantages of the market economy they found, and were as much traders in places like York, as they were genocidal tyrants. Even the most brutish can see the advantages of the great wealth available in commerce and

trade and the benefits of this peaceful and wealthy life, over that of life of constant looting, plunder and murder.

William the Bastard, himself part Norseman, was the man to put an end to the Viking Age. He too wanted a piece of the market economy on the island. He saw the dynastic troubles of England, with its part Celtic, Anglo-Saxon, Danish, and as he saw it; Norman heritage, and the weakness of the institutions after centuries of Viking warfare and settlement. The wealth of the island was too much to resist. He invaded and claimed sovereignty over all the land introducing a feudal style that clashed with much of the freedoms of common law before it. Still a legacy ordinary Brits have to deal with.

The economy under Normans rule boomed enough to pacify the population into accepting the rule of William. The booming market economy was helped in part by Jewish financiers who could provide high quality financial skills to aid the development of a modern market economy. The financial skills of pre-Norman English to that of the great medieval powers like Venice or Genoa showed that and England was still centuries behind in this regard. The City of London became the center of these new skills with its already well established free market economy and diverse population with all sorts of different nationalities trying to establish trade on the Thames.

The island continued to boom, long after 1066. Silver mines across the Norman realm, from Derbyshire, Cumberland, Somerset, North Wales, Flintshire, Hopedale and Englefield provided sources of new sliver which in turn increased the silver coinage that could mint a powerful and strong new currency. A pound of silver became one Pound Sterling. England had a coinage good enough to compete with the great maritime trading powers of the Med. England began to boom.

The growth suffered under the black death, though was somewhat reinvigorated by the new population cull as the black death led to the end of Norman feudalism, and England carried on its slow economic rise, even increasing the rate of growth as serfdom ended. This might not have been noticed much by the people of the day, in how much better off they were than previous generations, but England was slowly going through the gears.

England’s lower population following the plague meant food was plentiful and living was cheap. In this flourishing free market economy that resulted in new found freedoms, you needed materials and skills to flourish. The materials had always been there, and these had led to a high skill level in England. As England became more and more of a market economy these skills moved from say archery, to woodworking, to new industrial skills; as skills became less needed for a war state, and more applicable in a free market economy.

Much English wealth had been built around exporting raw materials to Europe in the late Norman period, but this slowly developed into a trend of developing the raw materials at home, as an ever increasing knowledge of industrial and manufacturing process seeped into the country - something only hyper charged by the Printing Press which allowed knowledge to spread.

English skills became entirely market oriented, rather than for warfare or farming. Skills led to new jobs and industries like shipbuilding, which also led to a strong merchant shipping fleet, mining production went up, and rather than being exported, the materials began to be developed at home into iron, and then further into tools or building materials. The cloth trade grew and grew, and nudged along a slow and inefficient British textile industry into competing with the Belgians and French.

If we compare Britain to France in the early modern period we would notice a stark difference. France supported a huge population of agricultural labourers. Its huge population, the largest in Western Europe, was reliant much more on farming than the English. This gave France a huge army capable of fighting across the continent, but it never did develop the skills at home that would push it into the next level of economic advancement.

The Tudor period in England saw much largess from Henry, but a flourishing economy under Elizabeth sowed the seeds of Empire, as England found its place in a world economy. Britain’s increasing domination over the Atlantic trade, and the success of its more free and economically prosperous colonies, meant that during the 17th century Britain boomed.

The British Revolutions and political struggles over the course of the 17th century to an outsider, made it look like a nation in trouble, but it was never threatened from abroad; and these early civil wars actually helped the island develop a stronger political system which over the centuries would prove itself capable of stopping the political turbulence that engulfed the continent at various times over the centuries. The resultant Civil War, the result of a Parliamentary Revolution, gave Britain what it had lacked over the previous centuries; strong enough political centralization to become a European power, and fight off any threats from the continent.

The market economy was never really tampered with during this time, and the Parliamentary Revolutions are today, something of a footnote compared to the huge growth in industry, trade and wealth in Britain during this time. By 1720, and Daniel Defoe described the English as the most: "Diligent nation in the world. Vast trade, rich manufactures, mighty wealth, universal correspondence, and happy success have been constant companions of England, and given us the title of an industrious people."

Britain's new trading wealth was not new. Other countries across Europe had gotten to about where Britain was: Venice and Genoa, and some German states; were increasingly wealthy following the boom of the Baltic and North Sea trade, but then something very remarkable happened in Britain - that occurred nowhere elsewhere. Britain's economy didn't plateau and result in a war for more territory, as had happened throughout much of the rest of the world. Britain instead developed new technologies that had never existed elsewhere and grew internally.

Britain never looked to expand by building an Empire of neighbors. and imposing its will on say France or Spain. By the start of the 18th century and the Act of Union 1707, most of the populous were content with the market economy in Britain. Why? Well the economy was booming, and new technologies like the Steam Engine were about to take advantage of new energy sources to power what we now call industrialization; a process that would provide far more wealth and opportunity than even the greatest riches the New World had to offer.

Part 2: Epistemological Content

In this mini-section I want to talk about how I'm going to approach this episode. For any regular listeners, you'll know, most of this podcast series is a mix of technological history, with a bit of analysis thrown in. Occasionally we add in social history or a bit of political economy. Well this episode, like the US one, is going to be a bit of history, but mostly about the political economy of the island of Great Britain, which resulted in the Union of the island.

If case you haven't worked it out by now, I am of course English. And this begs the question of how should an Englishman approach the subject of England and Britain - and how should I talk about it as an invention. I could just go through decade after decade of history, from the Act of Union to the modern day, but you could just read a book for that. Podcasting allows you to do what you want. So in the spirit of E.P. Thompson's words in the 1960s, that the natural Englishman's intellectual strengths were Protestantism, the natural sciences and political economy; I'm going to approach this episode as a piece of political economy. In viewing the country we call the United Kingdom as an artificial construct, it makes sense to approach the subject as a form of Political Economy. By looking at the relative financial successes or disappointment of the country in political economic terms is how most voters judge the success of its government, so it makes sense to approach the entire history this way. The problem of Britain, is that, historically, there are comparatively few cultures wars or genuine wars to worry about. French and German history is a series of wars and revolutions; in Britain, it is a series of financial collapses and booms. Therefore, elections are won by the prospects of the economy, not nationalism.

Every day we are bombarded with political economy on TV and in the papers, via the general state of the economy. The obsession with houses on every daytime TV show and its importance to the economy is near ubiquitous. The housing market is in effect propping up the British currency.

This is natural. There has long been a deep romanticization of land and property in England and Britain, which has led to a natural interest in political economy. The importance of political economy is underlined by looking at British elites' education. Britain educates its political leaders at Oxford and Cambridge in Politics, Philosophy and Economics; essentially training them in political economy. Much of the Brexit debate, apart from the strange people obsessed with race and 'Little Englanders', was focused on the issue of political economy, and how well Britain will do in or outside of the European Union.

Britain it has been said, has never produced a great intellectual of the Goethe, Leonardo or Voltaire type. But Britain has never needed this type of intellectual. Much of the moral work in British life had been done by the Anglican Church, which over time essentially made itself redundant by promoting Anglican Utilitarianism, later taken up by Bentham and Mill and becoming the closest thing to a moral compass of the political elite. Meanwhile British natural scientists: from Darwin, Maxwell, Faraday, Turing, Hawking and of course the daddy of them all, Newton; led the way in developing the island into one of the most scientifically modern. And even when Newton was not dabbling in the occult, or wasting his time discovering modern physics and inventing gravity, he was also something of a political economist. It was Newton, as Master of the Royal Mint, who moved Britain from the silver to the gold standard.

Political economy in Britain is vital to the national mood and spirt. All countries are run by the idealization of their national spirit. The United States looks towards businessmen and the military to run their country; the French want a philosopher-king, with an emphasis on the philosopher – and then end up with Sarkozy, Hollande and Macron et al.; meanwhile the British want a country run by political economists. And to a large extent Britain is still run by political economists. The Civil Service, Treasury and most senior politicians aim to run the country sensibly, and not in some great overarching philosophical way.

This development has been helped by Britain having a long line of the world's greatest political economists: Adam Smith, David Ricardo, John Maynard Keynes, Arthur Pigou, David Hume and Robert Malthus were all influential political economists, and so influential that Ricardo, Smith and Keynes were as influential in Britain as any of their contemporary politicians.

So in this tradition, we'll be approaching the subject and invention of the United Kingdom as a piece of political economy, looking at how it changed the world, how the world then changed Britain, and now how the future might look.

So where do I come from politically? Where what my political economist outlook like? I would describe myself as somewhere between a proto-Marxism and old fashioned Whig. Marx was right about the problems of capitalism, and how capitalism easily morphs into corporatism - how the wealth moves upwards and doesn't trickle down, but of course, he was wrong in every single way with his solutions to the problems. What he never emphasized was individual liberty, stable deflationary money that valued labour, and in Britain at any rate, an adherence to a common law system. The law of the land is should be determined by the people.

This is what results in freedom; and freedom results in wealth. A Whig view of the world; this is a belief in Classical liberalism, capitalism, and a freedom of the individual that was undoubtedly a cause of the British and later American dominance of the world. Whiggism is somewhat unfashionable now, with the rise of Wokeism - which is essentially dressed up Marxism.

The unfashionability of Whiggism has meant their natural focus on British institutions role in providing the seeds of the industrial revolution is downplayed by some. But it must be beyond doubt that the British state and the various British political institutions did play a part in the rise of Industrial Revolution. Britain's move towards the first industrial market economy was because of a mix of these types of paradigms and paradigms shift in technology that caused rapid advancements. But even I, as something of a Whig, would never claim industrialization was solely down to British exceptionalism, but there must be something said for the Whig point of view. After all, we only have one independent case of industrialization in the world. There was no competing industrializing power in East Asia or South America. Even today, Parliamentary supremacy, the rule of law, and common law are still relatively unique amongst countries the world over. Those that have inherited these precepts, such as former British colonies, have tended to do a lot better than those who haven't.

Nobody will ever be able to run a randomized control trial to see how British institutions impacted the industrial revolution, but I cannot believe they played no part. So what other reasons are we going to claim for the uniqueness of the industrial revolution in Britain? Well Britain, in hindsight, was a very convenient place for an industrial revolution. Its highly productive and responsive agricultural sector; its abundant and accessible supplies of minerals; and its foreign trade that, sustained by the Royal Navy that led to feedback effects of state investment in naval power – leading to more investment into innovations and high quality skills, resulted in a strong natural base for an industrial market economy to grow.

The industrial revolution is the key to Britain's greatness since its invention in 1707. The ways Britain pushed the world forward technologically is highlighted by this podcast in which Brits and Britain, play a crucial development in many inventions. And if it isn't somewhere in Britain, it tends to be in the United States.

So in the next part of the podcast, we will look at the pre-history of the island of Britain and how the foundations of its institutions were developed. Then we will look at the formation of the political entity first called the Kingdom of Great Britain, and then the United Kingdom, before we get onto the industrialization of the island.

Part 3: Pre-Industrial history of the island of Britain

So we've gone over some of the history of the island previously in the introduction, but now is the time for the pre-industrial history and how everything changed. Well one of the main reasons, that is never talked about, is what this podcast is about: the political unification.

The result of this political innovation was a clear and radical benefit for both Scotland, England and Wales. Wales was a principality (hence there being a Prince and Princess of Wales), because of a series of laws enacted between 1535 and 1542. The full union of the entire island of Great Britain meant that for the first time in history, the island off the western edge of Europe was unified with no internal enemies. It has a huge moat around its territory making the island almost uninvadable.

The unification of British natural borders happened 100 years before the French attempted it under Napoleon, as the concept of a 'natural France' bordering the Rhine, Alps, Pyrenees and Atlantic was promulgated. Yet Great Britain had already secured its natural borders and has already begun unleashing a century of outwards exploration.

The Union of 1707 was a meeting of two people: the English and Scots. The result was that the English Empire, became the British Empire, but could have been called the Anglo-Scottish Empire. We should remember, the populations of the two countries were much more equal than today. At unification in 1707, it saw England at around 5 million and Scotland at 2 million; making it a far more equal Union. It still made the new country demographically small compared to its bitterest rival France – meaning it needed all the internal security it could get. The British problem of a divided island was especially problematic to the English, as Scotland's longtime antipathy towards the English had seen it become a near permanent ally to the French, in a relationship historians call the Auld Alliance. But this began to change following union of the Crowns in 1603. England and Scotland become ruled by the same man. It permanently allied Scotland towards England, and away from France. This wasn't a surprise to anybody at the time.

England and Scotland had been growing closer due to increased intermarriage between Nobles, Aristocracy, and the Royal Families of Scotland and England – but it was the Protestantism sweeping the entire island, over that of the Catholic aristocrats in France, that truly allied the normal English person and the average Scot.

This was only made permanent with the Union of 1707 that formalized and recognized a new political entity that cemented Scotland and England together and away from France. England was always to be the primus inter pares (first amongst equals) of the union due to its greater wealth. But the bold experimental political union was seen as the best way to unify the island, over that of conflict and violence.

It was a more elegant and peaceful solution than annexation. The union of the island would result in an outward looking country with few domestic disputes. Parliamentary supremacy for the island, with a bold Dutch inspired capitalist free market, where the primary focus of the nation was not Religion, of Kings or Queens but a capitalism regulated by Parliament – who tried not tamper in the market economy, through fear of aggravating everybody from the banking and merchant classes, to laborers; and the new class of industrialists who were increasingly powerful across the land.

This Union changed the nature of the island, like no military or project before. There were unique benefits to this arrangement. Scotland and England, before 1707, had different histories, languages, education systems, military systems and cultures. But in coming together, they provided each with mutually needed skills and opportunities. Scots moved across the new country, with their great education and increasing anglicization. Capital began to be poured into Scotland, as towns like Glasgow grew up benefitted by the Union and its easy access to water. It was perhaps the north of England that benefitted mostly from the exchange; as a mix of Scottish technical skills and northern factory workers began to change the nature of the economy. The United Kingdom may have been built around the supposed more ‘civilized’ English model, but the Scots were vital to keeping it in check.

The merchant democracy that had been built in England was imported into Scotland. Scots had now free access to England’s colonies for exports, meaning Britain’s wealth also became more geographically diverse. Aristocrats across the country stayed across the country, meaning there were large capital reserves to build local products; unlike France where Paris and nearby Versailles saw a great royal court at the hands of Louis XIV. Sure, many built London townhouses, but there was far less centralization. This, like nothing else, created internal competition amongst the aristocrats to get the most out of their land, meaning they were receptive to new technologies and industries that could provide them an economic edge.

A focus on economics following political unification, saw a development of the natural wealth of the island. The growth natural wealth also led to a population able to develop even more skills.

The Union’s increasing military power before, but accelerating during and after the Union, saw Britain in many European wars to try and maintain a balance in Europe - and to avoid the French army getting too powerful. These wars were all fought by Parliament, not the monarch.

The independence and security of this new state was gotten quickly. British supremacy was assured during the Spanish War of Succession as John Churchill, the 1st Duke of Marlborough, was instrumental in cementing this new country’s role as a Great Power of Europe; by preventing Boubon domination of Europe. Britain fought an economic war to stop Bourbon succession in Spain, and its financial power meant it could fight on land and at sea against any European hegemon.

In a strange irony of history, John Churchill’s victory can be see a nice starting point of Britain’s domination of the world. His victories as Allied commander, most famously at Blenheim, forced Bavaria out of an alliance with France and forced it to ally with Austria. Meanwhile an Anglo-Dutch force captured Gibraltar, the key to the Mediterranean, which of course Britain still holds. The French attempt at controlling Spain was looking shaky, and despite a huge French army - Britain managed to win battle after battle on land and at sea over the French to push them back. Marlborough’s early victory meant France never really had the momentum to keep the Spanish Netherlands, and poor harvests on the continent and Britain’s naval supremacy ground down the Bourbon monarchy. After nearly 10 years of war, Bourbon Philip won the throne, but had to renounce his claim to the French throne and Spain’s claim to Gibraltar, meaning there would never be a Union of the Crowns of France and Spain; like there had been 100 years ago on the British Isles.

The War of the Spanish Succession showed that for the first time this new Britain was a continental level player. A small population and a small army, but highly skilled, with some of best technology money can buy, bolstered by an immensely powerful navy. It demonstrated the power of Britain’s pre-industrializatising society during this war.

Cast your mind 200 years forward and Winston Churchill, descendent of John Churchill, the Duke of Marlborough - found himself in a similar situation; this time fighting with the French against the Germans to maintain peace across Europe, and to ensure no state was too powerful. International relations over the previous two centuries moved Britain’s primary enemy from the French to the Germans, and what the 20th century was showing was the cost of Britain falling behind technologically to Germany. It had allowed the German state to catch up and seemingly threated British sovereignty. Winston Churchill won this war, but it cost Britain's the superpower status it gained from John Churchill's victories…

What the Spanish War of Succession showed was what the British fiscal-military complex could do against a French agrarian-military complex. Britain could afford to fight across the world and was the only power able to fight the war against the Bourbon succession to the Spanish throne on every front. A newly established Bank of England had enabled England to access far more capital than its European counterparts, who were relying purely on the Crown's purse. The Bank of England largely funded Britain's fighting of the war, with the Bank knowing a successful British victory was the best way to get a return on its loans.

The result of the war was numerous for the new Kingdom of Great Britain. Firstly, the Duke of Marlborough was granted Palace, the grandest non-royal Palace in England, at what was named Blenheim, named after the location of his greatest victory. The House of Spencer which the Duke belonged to, remains one of the most pre-eminent non-royal families in the land. The 20th century saw two of the most famous Brits both coming from this family: Winston Spencer Churchill and Diana Spencer.

Further, in the Peace of Utrecht, Britain forced Spain to cede the territory of Gibraltar; as Britain established naval dominance across Europe, and left France as the primary land army of Europe. The Dutch, the primary capitalist rival to Britain, were nearly bankrupt by the war; while the German states of Bavaria and Prussia were able to challenge Austria for power in the Holy Roman Empire.

The rise of Britain over the 18th century, led from this victory. Through various technological developments, a move to a bimetallic currency standard, numerous military victories over continental rivals, the expansion of the Empire, and the industrialization starting in the 1760s; is all too big and complex to go into in full depth, but we look at bits and pieces later in the episode. But for now, we have to actually find out how the Kingdom of Great Britain was formed, so now we are now going to deal with the process of the unification of the island of Great Britain, and then the temporary unification of the British Isles.

Part 4: Act of Union 1707 and 1800, Laws in Wales Acts 1535 – 1542, and the Irish Free State Constitution Act 1922

'The Englishman has long been used to living in a certain haze as to what his country – whether England, England-and-Wales, or Great Britain, or the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, or the United Kingdom plus its dependent territories or that large unit which he used to call the British Empire.' – Sir Dennis Robertson, 1953.

As the quote suggests, trying to define this invention isn't too easy. The United Kingdom is lots of things to different people, but in principle it is the equal coming together of the peoples of Scotland and England, and Northern Ireland and Wales. In reality, it sees Wales a principality of England, Northern Ireland as mere territory of the Crown, and while Scotland is legally an equal partner to England, with it granted a kingdom, in reality, it lags far behind England due to its wealth and now it's much larger population.

Unlike the American constitutions that legally give equality to all the states, equal representation in the Senate and a degree of self-governance; all of which is well known in US through the teaching of the founding of the nation and these legal documents, the Acts of Union grants almost no power to anything other than Parliament – and is hardly remembered today in Britain.

The Union was not really borne of any great love, but practicality and obedience towards common sense. It was the ability to weigh up the costs of a loss of sovereignty, but greater riches that would come from unification that allowed unification. It gave everybody in Britain a focus on shared prosperity and security in being in a united island, and then a fully politically integrated archipelago.

Expansion of English power across the island and natural borders was somewhat different to the French wars of conquest in its interior, which was far more brutal at times. And here we can do some small comparison in how the Parisian elite completed the same process. While Great Britain was aiming to integrate Ireland largely peacefully, the wars of the Vendee in France, with its protestant population and revolutions against Catholic Parisian control, was far more brutal than any English takeover of Ireland - with this time a Catholic population rebelling against Protestant British control. The wars in the Vendee from 1793-1796 were more brutal than any British activity in Ireland.

So in this section, we are going to look separately at how the Celtic regions of the British archipelago: Wales, Scotland, and Ireland came to be involved in a Union with the more mongrel nation of England, and then how Ireland left the Union leaving a very strange political situation on the archipelago.

Part 4A: Scotland

Scotland's entry into the Union is a story of how, in effect, a backwater, but a proud one, at the northern most third of the island of Great Britain, became the one of the most civilized, respected and intellectually honest places in the world. By 1600 and Scotland was still poor, but starting to grow. The Thirty Years War interrupted commerce with Europe, but Scotland was far enough away to not be overly effected. A lack of warfare in Scotland was contributing to Scotland growing something of a market economy over the early modern period. Scotland even at this point had a unique culture known across Europe. And when Elizabeth I died in 1603, it meant James VI of the ancient house of Stuart was offered the throne of England. James' accession brought together old enemies in England and Scotland, but it didn't make them friends.

In Stuart Scotland, there were around 1 million people, and there had been a significant population rises creating poverty and large amounts of what were called 'idle beggars.' Scotland was starting to get a reputation of solving population problems through emigration; largely to England. Meanwhile, Scottish life was run through 1000 baronies which largely organized rural life; and was something like a lord of the manor in England.

Scotland was already anglicizing, and by the 17th century most Scots spoke a language that most English speakers would understand. This only increased after the accession of James, as Scotland became more anglicized.

Gaelic speaking communities in the Highlands and Islands became rarer. Scotland around this time was still highly rural, comparing more to Scandinavia than England. The four major towns; Edinburgh, Aberdeen, Dundee and Perth were the economic heartlands of the country; while Glasgow only grew upon the later reliance of the Atlantic trade.

So in 1603 when James heard the news he was the monarch of England, that he had inherited the throne of England, and he was overjoyed as you can well imagine. He rode down to London in three weeks and as self-styled ruler of Britain, he ruled in peace and fostered an heir: Charles I.

James wanted to solve what we could call the 'British problem' of how to rule England and Scotland, two enemies, who were so different, and yet lived on the same island. He wanted to be an example to the other European monarchies. Many Kingdoms of Europe were patchworks of kingdoms and principalities: the Spanish monarchy; the Polish-Lithuanian commonwealth; and Denmark and Norway were multiple monarchies. Yet both Scotland and England had the problem of quite strong Parliaments who were increasingly frustrated at rule from a palace. No King was likely to be able to unite the Parliaments through a show of force.

The death of James and the accession of Charles was of course, the end game for the debate of Parliamentary rule vs Royal rule. Scotland was highly involved in this conflict, the War of the Three Kingdoms, or whatever Game-of-Thrones inspired naming you want to give for it, but it could be called in Scotland – the Scottish Revolution.

Scotland had been unhappy with Charles' increasingly Anglo-focus of his rule. Civil War had broken out in England, and Scotland reacted by setting up groups to express new political ideas. By mid- 1643 the Civil War had been raging for a year, and Scots were coming up with ideas like reforms of Parliament and new religious ideas including independent congregations. Mostly this radicalism was by Scottish landowners, and this new radicalism was threatened by the possibility of Charles winning in England, and coming up to Scotland and putting down rebellion.

The Scots formed themselves into a self-styled Covenant and made a deal with the English Parliament. Scotland has no standing army and so the Coventanters negotiated with the English Parliament and the Dutch to fund their war. I'm imagining the Dutch, going through their golden age, to be somewhat similar to Iron Bank of Braavos from Game of Thrones.
To make things even more confusing, many of the Scottish Covenanters were royalists, even if they were radicals. Cromwell sent the New Model Army to subdue Scotland, and the Covenanted government in Scotland lasted as long as the Commonwealth of England. Under the Commonwealth, Scotland was treated as though it had been incorporated in England and not a separate country.
The Commonwealth of Cromwell turned Scotland into a ruled province, but George Monck, commander of the Scottish forces marched into England with his Scottish troops and averted any new war that might have arisen following the removal of Richard Cromwell, Oliver's son who came to the throne after his father death. Monck restored the monarchy, and Charles II opened up the country and allowed theaters to open, sex and Christmas; all the things Cromwell has banned.
The misnamed later Glorious Revolution of 1688-1689 was mostly an English affair, but it had huge implications for Scotland. In it, the Stuart line was deposed by a cohort of financiers and Parliament to bring in a more distant Dutch line, which aimed to keep Britain protestant.
Despite Scotland and England being closer together in the 17th century than ever before, what caused actual political Union? There was so many political controversies and experiments over this time frame that picking through them all would be a nightmare. Even Mike Duncan's Revolutions podcast, which had a series on the 17th centuries Revolutions, could hardly even scratch the surface.
The actual reasons are complicated, and there might have bene a sense that by now there was an inevitability about it; but there were a few events around the turn of the 18th century that made full blown unification more likely. The events surrounding Union are fascinating from a political economy point of view.
What were the motivations? Well for the Kingdom of England, they were clear: national security, and reducing the chances of the Spanish or French being able to use or manipulate Scotland as France had done numerous times to England's chagrin. For England, Scotland too, had a well-educated population that could benefit the country. Scotland's arable land was limited for a country of that geographic size, but its other vast natural resources were underexplored. In short it was an entirely economic, pragmatic and security reason. For this, the English were prepared to form a new country and give up some power, on the proviso the English Parliament would remain sovereign.
What was the reason for the Scots to agree to unification? Well most famously it was the state-financed government mess that caused the collapse of 'The Company of Scotland Trading to Africa and the Indies' which founded in 1695 to try and colonize the mosquito-infested swamp of Darien, in Panama. Just look at our Canal episode for the reasons why that was so stupid.
Great promises were given to those who left for New Caledonia' but hundreds were killed by disease and starvation, not to mention attacks by the natives. One has to think though, had the mission been successful, the Scots would have colonized the most important geo-strategic position in the Americas, where the later Panama Canal would be built. But the entire enterprise went bust, with one estimate suggesting one quarter of all Scottish wealth was liquidated. And so, not for the last time, the Scots went to the English asking for a bailout.
It wasn't just the collapse of New Caledonia that attracted Scots to England. The populous of Scotland were a pessimistic bunch and thought they would get poorer in future and so it seemed to make sense to many. There were also, of course, heavy rumours too, heavy enough rumours to basically be true, that the Scottish Parliamentarians were bribed by those in London. Many Parliamentarians had debts and pension arrears, and so financial inducements to vote for Union also played a large part. There were small Scottish protests, never quite reaching rebellion, but Union can't have come to a surprise to the ordinary Scot. Scottish political economists had been talking around the idea of Union for decades, highlighting Scotland's underperformance compared to

England, which even made 50,000 Scots move to Ulster for what could only be a marginally better life.
Despite all this, in 1704 it looked unlikely Scotland would want much of a Union with England. The two nations looked remote from one another, but by 1705 negotiations began and John Campbell the Duke of Argyll should get most of the credit for the soft power he was able to exert; convincing Parliament of England that the Queen of Scotland should appoint the commissioners on Scotland's behalf to give credence of the legal fiction of an equal Union.
The Scottish Parliament was summoned and asked whether to continue with the treaty of Union. Daniel Defoe was on hand to report exactly what happened in October 1706 as the Scottish Parliament voted. He reports that angry mobs were assaulting pro-Unionists and breaking windows. The local guards, or police as we'd call them, even refused to intervene. The English Army moved to the border to defend the Scottish Parliament against the mobs; or to ensure on Union - depending on your point of view.
The treaty had 25 sections but only the first really mattered. The unification of the two kingdoms into the one: to be called Great Britain. It passed with a majority of 32. Other articles covered things like Hanoverian succession, the creation of a single Parliament, and free trade. With no opinion polls or anything, it's hard to gauge exact opinion, but most people and newspapers seemed to oppose Union.
But being anti-Union meant, was also tied up in general Scottish general antipathy to the Hanoverian monarchy, who had taken the crown in 1688 – removing the Stuart line. It wasn't like a Scottish monarch was on the throne anymore, yet any serious attempts at regicide in Scotland would most likely have led to war with the English.
The full treaty was ratified in Scotland on the 16th January 1707 and in England on 1st March, and the Scottish Parliament was packed away for 300 years. On 12th May 1999 Winnie Ewing, MSP at the opening of the Scottish Parliament claimed to have reconvened the Scottsh Parliament, except this time there was no Scottish sovereignty in its Parliament. Scottish sovereignty was given away on the 28th April 1707 to Westminster and it has remained the same ever since.
Like the European Union today, talks of an ever more perfect union existed at the time and the English talked about 'rendering the Union more complete.' In reality, the new British state had little control over Scotland. In its slow dismantling of Scottish institutions, it meant that the Highlands became almost semi-autonomous; leading one commentator to say Scotland was 'in a state of semi-independence.' It was only the rebellions from the Jacobite's, Catholics intent of regime change, that focused British rule in Scotland and to put it up into some sort of order. Mostly, this was done by encouraging the more rebellious to move to the America's, where of course Highland rebelliousness against the British Crown would continue.
The Act of Union was a dull document, with none of the rhetorical flourishes of the American founding documents, but the dry understated way Scottish and English proceeded – though I suppose we should start calling it British proceeded, produced profound consequences. The Scottish enlightenment was one result, leading to profound change in the political economy. Adam Smith almost single-handedly created the British trading nation with his work in 1776, while James Watt is as important an individual as exists in the industrial revolution. Scotland became prominent part of Empire, with Barbados especially attractive to young Scots.
Glasgow became a centre of the tobacco trade with 40% of imports coming into Glasgow from the New World, most designed for re-exporting to Europe. Whether the Union created or even today, has created, a genuine British identity is still to be answered. More and more are feeling English or Scottish rather than British, but while the Union of England and Scotland has gone through trials and tribulations - I don't think it's under any real threat. If the economy of the island starts to boom again, the realization what the Union is really about: money; will rear its head again. Perhaps England and Scotland are united only in one thing: common sense and pragmatism.
Part 4B: Wales
Cyril Fox, one of the great archeologists, once compared the island of Britain to a personality. Stating there were different parts, with a lowland part represented by the south and east of the island

represented by the eastern and southern part of England, and a then highland part on the north and west represented by Scotland, parts of the north of England, Cornwall and Wales.
Wales has often been thought of as a permanent backwater to the island. Yet this belies a certain self-suffienctly and surprisingly advanced peoples. During Pre-Roman Britain, Wales became noted for its Hill Forts, its metallurgy and unique culture. The Hill Forts were once thought to be the work migrants, but is now more accepted the Iron Age in Wales and Britain were indigenous in developments. The hill forts suggest Wales was somewhere near an urban style of community. The Celts, once called the first European community, used to dominated the west of Europe. Ireland to Anatolia had Celtic roots, but they never managed to develop a strong civil society or centralized state. And this in essence, was the Welsh's problem over the millennia.
Over the first decades following Ceaser's landing on Britain, the south of England became more and more under the control of Rome, and the Romans slowly moved across the island. Wales was prized by the Romans for its rich minerals like gold, copper, lead, zinc and silver. Wales was rebellious to Roman rule, with the large amount of hill forts and garrisons placed around making it more capable of fighting back – yet the Romans still managed to dominate the Wales. However, as Roman Wales isn't that interesting or well documented –let us move on.
The decline of Rome in Europe has been well attested too, and in Wales it occurred as troops were pulled away from guarding trade routes, and were moved towards Rome. After, Irish settlers began crossing over the narrow sea to flee the overcrowding Ireland and to the less populated Wales. This marks the start of the so called Dark Ages, that followed Roman withdrawal. Once, the most westerly bastion of Roman civilization, Wales became a backwater; with little political authority across the region and decreasing trade. Yet despite the economic problems, the spread of Western learning that entered the island of Britain through the clergy meant that language became more formalized across Britain and Welsh Celtic became considered more of the Welsh we think of today. Wales managed to avoid large-scale Anglo-Saxon migration from Germany to keep its own, fairly weak lords and barons.
The Norman invasion changed the island story drastically. William seized all the land of England, and even Cumbria from the Scots. But he treated the Welsh well. Their lords were treated as almost equals to the Normans, while the Anglo-Saxon English were treated as second class citizens in their own land. Wales was strong and independent enough to provide William with problems. He gave English border regions to his strongest barons to protect the kingdom from Welsh invasion, and allowed them free reign to try and plunder the Welsh regions – giving himself a certain degree of aloofness from any international relations blowback. The Welsh responded building castles along the border. What didn't help the Welsh during the Norman period, were the constant internecine political struggles in Wales itself. The Normans got dragged into it, but never had the stomach to try and annex Wales.
Not that Wales wasn't wanted. England over time, through commerce initially, started to take an interest and increasing influence over Wales. This control didn't start of out through the military, but via marriage. Numerous inter-marriage caused Wales to fall ever more inside an English sphere of influence. It meant that Wales was granted a similar relationship to England, as was Scotland.
By 1200, Welsh rulers were not calling themselves King, or Rex; but Prince. It represented a change in how Wales saw itself. Before the Welsh King claimed themselves as the King of the Britons, a hangover from when Celts ran the island; but now they were happy to be called a mere Prince. There were actually 2 Welsh prices during this time, compounded by many lords. In the hierarchy, a Welsh prince outranked an English baron, but it was clear that Wales was now, informally at least, becoming a vassal to England.
Following the death of King John and the signing of the Treaty of Worcester in 1218, the Pope recognized English preeminence in Wales. Within 5 years, the castles of Wales were seized by the English, as the Welsh aristocracy were slowly interblended into the English court. Henry III in 1240 upon the death of Llywelyn of Gwynedd ruled that Welsh rulers held allegiance to the English crown. And the Pope ordered that should the new ruler of the most independent Welsh kingdom of Gwyneddd, Dafydd, die without an heir, England could claim the south of Wales for itself.

This centralization of the realm wasn't just fought back by the Welsh, but the English too. Simon de Montford led other English barons and Welsh Princes to fightback, and Wales as a concept was just about saved. The fightback meant that Wales was established informally, as a principality, within an larger Empire of England. Wales managed to avoid just being another English territory, and fought for its own limited-independence. The Welsh Prince still owed funds to the English King, but they had enough independence to finance it.

The age of Llewelyn II in the 13th century saw Welsh populations boom, and turned Wales into something of a rebellious stronghold. The country was almost unified under Llewelyn II's reign, but the dominance of the English meant the Welsh never truly stuck to their guns and rebel – instead they gradually immersed themselves in the English market economy. Welsh rulers got luxuries from Paris and London and sold cattle, cheese, timber, horses to fund it. This of course meant that the Welsh could become controlled, by controlling their market economy.

And of course this is what happened when the most powerful English medieval monarch took advantage. In 1277, the Principality of Wales was attacked by Edward I, who over 6 years, slowly annexed the territory. After a fairly tedious court drama in which Llywelyn's was due to marry Simon de Montfort daughter, the same Simon de Montford who had rebelled against the Crown, it gave Edward the opportunity to get on the war path. He was probably itching for the invasion that had been coming for 200 years. Llewelyn wanted to talk, but Edward wanted to fight.

Edward mustered an army not seen on the island since 1066, and by August 1277 16,000 soldiers, many of whom were Welsh, reached the Welsh heartland. They were supplied from Dublin and Chester. Edward attacked the Welsh food supply to start with, and with Llywelyn lacking in supplies, he met Edward to ask for terms. He was allowed the title of Prince of Wales, but his land was reduced to a mere parcel of what it was.

Edward began building castles, and with the English monarch more in control of Wales than any previous monarch, he could now insist the Welsh use English Common Law rather than their own Welsh Law.

In 1282 a part of North-East Wales controlled by the Crown started to revolt against the Crown. Llewelyn waited a bit, and then he eventually gave his full support to the revolt. The revolt was initially successful, taking castles and capturing men.

The Pope intervened to ask for peace, and Llewelyn asked that the Welsh be allowed to follow their own laws and customs. The King of England demurred, arguing Welsh law was the work of the devil and the Welsh needed to be saved from their own sloth and barbarity. But the Welsh victories were stacking up and then – like a scene from Game of Thrones, Llewelyn was killed in a duel by a Shropshire solider - who did not realize who he was in combat with.

Llewelyn's head was sent back to London and the revolt continued, but it was diminished without its leader. Edward instantly sent a communication to the Pope of the death of the only rightful heir of the Welsh throne, and Llewelyn the Last as he was known – the last Welsh leader for a dynasty that had survived 8 centuries, was gone. 1282 saw Welsh resistance crumble after a valiant effort to save their own laws and customs. Even to this day, Wales lives under an arguably foreign legal system.

The parts of Wales that supported the King were left to their own devices, while the conquered lands were treated as new colonies for the English, with sheriffs appointed to collect taxes and rents. The Sheriffs instituted English Law and some see this as Edward's greatest achievement in Wales, the imposition of Common Law.

The Common Law helped to foster a stronger market economy in Wales, something that was already happening. Edward's activities in Wales had cost 1/3 of a million about 10 times annual income. Edward borrowed from Italian bankers, and so turned to Parliament to raise taxation.

Wales did quite well out of the settlement economically. Trade took off in Welsh ports, and the economy was seen to be flowering. It was still an agrarian economy, but an increasingly successful one.

In 1485 Henry Tudor took to the throne. North Wales was generally supportive of the Lancastrians, while the South of Wales supported the Yorkists. The 30 yearlong ‘War of the Roses’ saw only about 13 weeks of action, so it was more a cold war, but Wales was a strong part of it.
The Tudors were historically a North Welsh house, and later Welshman like John Wynn and George Owen, claimed the Tudor victory was a victory for Wales. It was certainly a climax of the English and Wales wars and conflicts that had occurred since 1066. The Tudors never claimed they were Welsh, but the Welsh claimed the Tudors as one of their own.
Henry Tudor, or Henry VII, never did much for Wales, but Welsh opportunities in England were enhanced. The King in this new Wales had more power in the land than any previous Welsh King or English King. Large parts of the South had been become Crown lands, and the Welsh aristocracy that remained were newly empowered.
The death of Henry Tudor brought with it a great change in English administration. Henry VII didn’t so much change the government, as make it more effective and to return it to a stable footing. The English government had been unchanged since Edward I, and as Wales was brought more and more into English administration, it began to follow English geopolitics. The centralization of an efficient administration, of increasing power and wealth resulted in perhaps the most powerful man ever to have lived on the island of Britain: Henry VIII.
Henry unleashed the most revolutionary change in British history. In effect, the separation of Britain from the continent. This relationship was started by the Romans and then taken over by the Roman Catholic Church; but Henry changed it all. It was easily the largest geopolitical event of the time, and was recurrent throughout British history: the relationship of the island to the continent.
The break from the Church of Rome had ripple effects all throughout the island. When Henry declared the end of the Catholic Church in England and Wales and declared himself the head of a separate Protestant Church of England - there were huge repercussions. For Wales, it meant something of a democratic problem. It saw itself as a colony and it had no Parliamentary representatives, and so was not even able to debate the measures.
The move away from Rome, the dissolution of the monasteries, and the decline of the perceived threat from Welsh barons, meant that Henry continued a process that had been going on for centuries. He completed the annexation of Wales into England. In reality; it was nothing more than codifying laws and giving Wales representation in Parliament. The real impact had been done centuries before, but over a period of 7 years from 1535 to 1542 a number of laws were passed to formalize it. The first was giving Welsh Lords responsibility for administration.
A few weeks later the most consequential act was passed, called the Act of Union by Owen Edwards, it was no such thing. The Act of Union of 1707 and 1800 made Ireland and Scotland at least in theory on an equal level to England, but the Act passed in February 1536 stated ‘Wales… is and ever hath bene incorporated, annexed, united and subjecte to and under the imperialle Crown of this Realm.’ Wales began its life as somewhere between a principality and a colony.
The English could argue that Wales was united back in 1284, and that the act was nothing more than a unification of the various Welsh baronies and territories. But a critic would call it annexation by salami tactics – slice by slice. In the eyes of the law, the Welsh were now English. But the acts did grant Wales a fair representation in Parliament.
Wales would be a strange part of the later Union. Legally part of England, but also a principality. The title Prince of Wales honours the Celtic freedom fighters who fought for their liberty and self-identity; meaning Wales would not be a unique area of the United Kingdom. It wouldn’t end up like Cornwall and a mere region of England.
In the 2020s, the status of Wales is still up for debate. While Scotland was granted a Parliament under devolution; Wales was given a less powerful assembly. Welsh cricketers play for England; yet Wales plays football and rugby under its own flag.
Wales has never quite had the impact on the Union that Scotland has, but it should not be underestimated. Wales was a key driver of the industrial revolution with its rich minerals and heavy industry; Welsh liberalism led to some of the greatest reforms of British society around the turn of the century; and even today, Wales is an agricultural powerhouse with its supposed obsession with

sheep. Since 1998 Wales, like Scotland, has a degree of self-governance once again in the Welsh Assembly, but hasn't used it well. Whether Wales will boom and become an economic powerhouse, or continue to be reliant on England, remains to be seen.

Part 4C: Ireland

Ireland has long had the most troublesome relationship with the other nations of the archipelago, but primarily its beef has been with the English. Ireland, the smaller island compared to Britain, is in some ways in the perfect spot and the worst spot. It's the western most rock of Europe. But surrounded by the island of Britain. It's the only land neighbour to Britain, and despite being friendly with much of the rest of Europe, it has never been able to move where it is in the ocean. Ireland also naturally looks across the ocean, towards the America's, but is too far away for the Americas to have much of an impact on it. Therefore Ireland has to look towards Britain, and more specifically, England, throughout its history. This has caused many problems throughout history.

Like Wales, Ireland had a long Celtic-culture before Christianization, but by the 5th century AD, Christian missionaries from England had started what would become the central Irish question: less its relationship to Europe, but more its relationship with these strange Anglo-Saxon Celtic Christian people, with their strange ways and their strange religion. The new Christian culture of Ireland mixed with the Celtic culture to create a culture of what is usually called Gaelic.

Trade with parts of the continent in Ireland, like Scandinavia, brought merchants and invaders. Dublin became the primary settlement of the Vikings in Ireland, and Ireland became something of a cosmopolitan part of the European trading area, giving access to trade routes that went from the Baltic to the Middle East.

Ireland was not really a unified Ireland as we think of today. It was feudal, with no overall king. Kings led more local and regional kinship groupings which fostered political instability that during the second millennia AD, became a permanent part of Irish life. One dynastic dispute led to a Norman English invasion to depose the King of Leinster, which opened up Ireland to English colonization and control.

Ireland's constant infiltration from Christianity, to Vikings, to the English left it somewhat confused. It lost wars because it still practiced a form of feudal-guerilla warfare, even as much of the rest of Europe had moved on towards more advanced forms of war. It was isolated geographically and diplomatically. Without being a unified island, it never managed to get support from the French or Spanish that the Scots usually had.

As England gained control over the island of Ireland, the English began to introduce their practices like Common Law, as the English, and increasingly Welsh settlers, brought over new crops to begin changing Irish life. The English built roads in Ireland, and increased trade with places like Bristol; while at the same time seizing any land they could legally claim ownership of. Yet this new ownership meant this Anglo-Irish aristocracy became increasingly Irish. The plague of the 14th century led to a sense English rule was weakening, as the Irish peasants and Anglo-Irish aristocracy intermingled.

Irish life by the 16th century was a strange mix of a very English settlement around Dublin and a Gaelic culture in the interior of the island. The Protestant Reformation in England further heighted a divide between them and the Irish. The Pope in 1150s granted England control over Ireland, but now, rule from Rome was unimportant following Henry VIII's break. Now England had to control Ireland by politics, and not religion.

The reign of the Tudors in England resulted in new and increasing colonization and conquest of Ireland. Settlements called plantations were set up, in the hope that they would provide inspiration for the Irish in how to live in a more civilized manner; as many in London were bemused that Ireland had not yet been brought under official political control. The Irish question and its exact nature and status, and how it saw itself in a political union across the archipelago was tricky, even back then.

By Elizabethan England, and the Irish aristocracy saw themselves as superior to the common English settlers; but the English settlers saw themselves as far more civilized compared to the peasant Irish. But it was the unreformed Irish, who carried on with their Papacy, that became to be seen as the major divide between the settlers and natives. These conflicts, like in much of Europe - became violent. Always considered separate from the 30 Years War, Reformation conflicts still flared in Ireland. Rebellions brewed, which were arguably the first colonials wars the English got into, if you're an Irish republican – or failed attempts at unification if you are more of the Whig/High Tory bent.

The Tyrone Rebellion, sometimes called the Nine Years War was fought between an Irish band of rebels supported, by the French of course, and Tudor England between 1593 to 1603. The English fought using a scorched Earth policy, a tactic so brutal it shocked even the English forces. The English won and retained control of Ireland.

Despite the scorched earth policy used by the English in fighting the war, Ireland remained a woodland for the most part; but this was due to change. In the 17th century as the woods were chopped down for fuel and material. The English Civil War, or British Revolutions of the mid-17th century turned Ireland into a battlefield.

In the 1640s as the war raged in Britain, there were five armies in Ireland: Royalist, Parliamentarian, Scottish, Scottish settlers and the Confederate – an Old English and Irish alliance. Battles between the Five Armies were intermittent and punctuated by a series of ceasefires and negotiations. It must have felt like Syria. But it was all to come to a head following the execution of Charles I by Oliver Cromwell in January 1649.

Cromwell's New Model Army campaigned over in Ireland on a swift and ruthless conquest. The Royal Navy could keep the Irish sea clear, and could keep supply lines open. Cromwell' victories at Drogheda and Wexford were amongst the most brutal in British history, but they were effective.

The final victory of Parliamentary forces in Ireland led to the creation of an all Protestant Irish Parliament. From 1695 to 1709, various laws were passed by the Irish Parliament to reduce the power of Catholic Ireland. The debate of whether Ireland was a colony or kingdom was surely settled now: it was a colony. In 1728, Catholics were not permitted to vote and in the 1730s Catholics were banned from local government office and attending University. Most Irish land was now owned by the protestants and some nonconformists.

So why were there not constant rebellions? Well the protestant ascendancy in Ireland had allowed the market economy to boom. Irish exports increased 5 times over the period from 1660 to 1770. Ireland was importing New World items at cheap prices. The infrastructure boomed as roads were built to connect market towns to cities.

Most famously, these economic booms meant that the population of the island was booming. There were just over 2 million people in 1706, which more than doubled to 4.4 million by 1791.

But the American Revolution proved that rebellion against the Crown was possible. This was followed up by the French revolution, which further proved a spur to Irish patriots as with Paris became a regular port of call for Irish radicals. This resulted in some loosening of restrictions on Catholics, with the Catholic Relief Act 1793 allowing them to bear arms and attend University. But all these revolutionary activities came to ahead in 1798.

A revolt was initially suspected in May in Dublin, but by the end of May there were fights taking place across the country. The rebellion lasted only weeks and was brutally put down with 30,000 deaths, but the rebellion showed to the British elite's the division in Irish society between the protestants and Catholics. In order to stop any more rebellions taking place, Prime Minister William Pitt renewed an old idea: Union.

Union would end Ireland as a separate kingdom and integrate it into the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland. The Irish Parliament would be abolished, and Ireland would get representatives in the British Parliament. The move was not fully supported by the Irish Protestants for a variety of reasons like commercial opportunities, and the idea that Irish protestants might leave for the mainland, further reduced some Protestant support for full Union in Ireland. The Act of Union was rejected in the Irish Parliament in 1799, but a second vote was taken in 1800 with 'compensation' packages handed out, which again, sounds an awful lot like bribes to me. Catholics were kept onside were kept onside by the prospect of emancipation, but George III later rejected the idea, causing much discontent.

The Act of Union came into force on 1st January 1801, and the Kingdom of Great Britain became the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland as the Irish red cross was added to Great Britain's flag, giving us the Union flag we all know today. This full unification would last for 121 years, but unlike Scotland and Wales; Ireland has never been a natural fit.
The official Union added another level of debate into the question of whether Ireland was now a fully equal constituent country inside the United Kingdom or still a province; a colony, run from London with rule imposed by a Protestant Unionist aristocracy. When Ireland was a separate kingdom, it was perhaps possible to live alongside the protestants who had been there for generations by then. But after Union, or annexation, it became a lot harder to think of Ireland as somewhat separate or equal. Ireland has always proved a tricky country to define. The anti-Papacy of much of the British ruling elite, meant that the Irish people never truly felt British.
Ireland in the 19th century saw many changes and challenges, surely well enough attested too we don't have to go into great detail here. The new productive crops and agriculture of the potato had found a home from home in Ireland, where the weather was perfectly suited to the new crop. The potato boom was Ireland's very own agricultural revolution and like dozens of other places, these food booms resulted in an unsustainably high population. One potato blight in the mid 1840s created tragedy. Many Irish left to move to pastures new in the New World or across the Irish Sea to places like Glasgow and Liverpool. These communities are perhaps the most recent example of Intra-British migration that's happened throughout history, creating unexpected problems. Liverpool and Glasgow got cheap labour, but a recreation of the Protestant-Catholic problems that flared up in Ireland itself.
These issues were and never have been solved, but it really took until the First World War for a revolution inside Ireland to break out.
The Victorian period in Ireland had seen much cognitive dissonance. Ireland boomed at the end of the 19th century. Irish artists, painters and writers were well respected in Britain, and Union gave the Irish a great opportunity for prosperity and fame they may not otherwise have gotten. Yet there was still great dissatisfaction with the nature of the Union. Home Rule in Ireland became one of the great causes of the 19th century in British politics. Home Rule very nearly happened, but was always was just averted. Like much of European history, it was the First World War that changed everything. The Easter Rising of 1916 was the final death nell for the experimental Union between the two main islands of the British archipelago.
Unionism, as a proactive political concept, had begun in the 1880s as a reaction against the Home Rule movement. When Home Rule was passed in 1912, 26% of the population who could be classed as Protestants were prepared to fight against it. Many saw British rule as uniformly good. The industrial counties in the north called Ulster benefited from British capital and technology, but much of the southern Catholic Ireland felt neglected. This resulted in petitions for home rule, but the Ulster Volunteer Force declaring their will to resist home rule by force if need be. Irish nationalists set up a similar paramilitary force to fight for home rule, they were called the Irish Volunteers.
By 1914 there were genuine concerns the two fractions would take up arms against each other, and there was imminent prospect of civil war in Ireland, which would require sending in the army and reducing numbers that could be sent to Europe. Civil War was averted by the outbreak of European War, in which 200,000 Irish men served.
All parties agreed this was no time for civil war with much more important things to sort out. Home Rule became law on 18th September 1914 but postponed until the war was over. Some Catholics saw a moral duty to fight in the British army to defend Catholic Belgium against Protestant Prussian Germany; whilst hoping good service would lead to home rule.
On 24th April 1916 Easter Monday, a small group of militants seized a number of buildings around Dublin. The Rising would not have happened if there was no war on; but as there was a war on, the British response to the rising was to brutally put it down. A massive mobilization of troops was launched. Marshal law imposed the day after the rising and rebel positions were bombarded by the

military. The insurgents surrendered only 5 days later with 488 killed and much of Dublin city centre in ruin.
Most Irish Catholics were against the Rising, most simply because they saw the militants as starting a conflict on the quiet streets of Dublin, but many did sympathize with the rebels against the British. About 90 revolutionaries were caught and 15 shot.
The British carried on with the war effort, and Asquith later commuted all the other death sentences, but the continuing marshal law placed on the entire island of Ireland meant many moderates believed Ireland as a whole was being punished.
Sinn Fein, who formed in 1905, were amongst the primary beneficiaries of the whole incidence. Founded by a journalist Arthur Griffith, with a blend of economic nationalism and a proponent of a dual monarchy like the Austria-Hungary monarchy. Sein Fein in Irish meant ‘Our Selves’ but the Sein Fein set up by Griffith was coopted and soon became a catch-all term for nationalists.
The collapse of Home Rule during the war caused this new movement to get more aggressive. Opinion hardened as the German breakthroughs on the Western Front in 1918 almost brought conscription to Ireland. In the 1918 general election after the war, Sein Fein won 73 of Ireland’s 105 Westminster seats.
On 21st January 1919 newly elected Sein Fein members of Parliament never took their seats, instead boycotting it and vowing to set up their own Parliament in Dublin. They declared Irish independence, at the same time as an unrelated explosion took place where two police officers were killed by a new group who went under the name of the Irish Republican Army. The IRA continued to wage guerilla warfare on the British, as the military wing of the Sein Fein political movement.
The IRA in 1920 became more audacious and almost collapsed the police and judicial system of British forces in Ireland in 1920. The British fought back with might and, far too reminiscent for some British troops, the British began fighting using counter-insurgency tactics similar to how the Germans put down the Belgians in the First World War. Even amongst the English, the war in Ireland was not too popular.
Bloody Sunday in November 1920; though not the bloody Sunday featured in that god awful U2 song, saw 15 British officers killed and led British forces to open up firing at a Gaelic football match in Croke Park.
On 11th June 1921, the IRA and the British agreed to a truce. The war ended in stalemate with both wanting something, either repression or independence. In the end a settlement was reached. The 26 counties in the southern part of Ireland would be called the Irish Free State, in a similar position to the earlier dual monarchy position, while the northern 6 states of Ireland would remain British.
This really marks the last great constitutional change of the United Kingdom: the partition of Ireland. In 1949 the last act of British rule was severed for the southern 26 counties, which was already nothing more than a constitutional nicety at this point. Southern Ireland became a true Republic and the northern 6 countries called Ulster, where the majority of the Anglo-Irish all those centuries ago had come from, was called Northern Ireland.
The United Kingdom in 1922 was changed from the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland, to the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland. So now we’ve filled in the map; let’s get on with industrialization.

Part 5. The Process of Industrialization

When Industrial Britain was in its pomp rarely looked towards Europe, the most likely urban legend of a newspaper headline that said ‘Fog in Channel - Continent Cut Off’ probably says as much about Britain’s self-image during its industrial era as any list of stats or military battles won.
The idea of Britain as a separate mini-continent, rather than an extension of Europe was the thought amongst most Brits.
This process of Britification became a natural process by the body politick, which began to grow, following the move away from Rome by Henry VIII. Future battles, like the repulsion of the Spanish Armada, and a focus in the 17th century on political civil conflicts only highlighted this move that Britain was a unique entity to Europe as Britain interlinked history with Europe started to delink. There came a slight lull of anti-Europeanness in the late 17th century as a Dutch monarch

came to the throne, which injected a good dose of Dutch influence into the country from free market capitalism, to an English obsession with Gin; but it was the War of the Spanish Succession, the English and then British colonial expansion, and then Seven Years War which made Britain. It turned away from any notion of being a European Power, national identities first started a shift towards being both English and British, and it made the world's first global power.

During this time, the people on the island became more self-confident and wealthier than Europe. Britain began to diverge markedly not only in cultural and linguistic aspects to Europe, but financially and socially.

The celebration of this Union never became a holiday or a moment of celebration, like it might have been in other countries. The process was done in traditionally understated British fashion.

Then of course the industrial revolution happened. If you've listened to my Monetary Revolution podcast, or even other episodes of this series, you'll know just how important the industrial revolution was in British and human history. Well now we finally get to talk about it. The date of the industrial revolution is commonly said to be 1760, but there is no real specific date. It's not like the French Revolution, with the 14th July 1789 as a starting 'date'.

In the run up to industrialization, England especially began reaching a pre-modern, pre-industrial capitalism state, similar to the Netherlands during its golden age. Industrialization in Britain could be dated to what really began Britain's bull ahead of even Dutch style capitalism. Well one invention proved to be a catalyst. It was Thomas Newcomen's Steam Engine in 1712 that changed the groundwork by allowing for energy to be used. Yet it was only really after 1750 when these new technologies started to intermingle and change the island.

The reason quite why the revolution happened, and uniquely in Britain, is much more debated and much more important than any arbitrary starting date. There are many background and foreground reasons for the revolution, and I've mentioned many of them over the course of this series, but for this podcast want to introduce another possible reason why it suddenly took off in around 1760.

It was the Seven Years' War, or the French and Indian War as it's called in the United States, that lead to increased demand for supplies and materials to supply the war than created economic stimulation to really push Britain over the industrialization edge. Funded largely by debt; this stimulation of demand led to great changes within Britain during the war. Britain needed to increase supply quickly - as more war materials were needed. Ever more Coal needed to be moved ever quicker - which led to the first industrial canal, the Bridgewater Canal. With the disruption to supply lines, more food production was needed at home; this at a time when rapid population expansion meant there was an increasing need for food. To keep food production high at home, there were waves of agricultural innovations. These massively increase food supply and at the same time, had the impact of leading to a mass redundancy of farm workers - as more food was being produced with less need for farm hands. These workers moved to cities, which themselves were on the edge of using these new technologies to start producing products like clothing for domestic markets..

I'm not going to go into the Seven Years War itself. It is far too complicated to explain, and its causes were perhaps best summed up by the book 'The Luck of Barry Lyndon' by William Makepeace Thackeray famously turned into a film by Kubrick which said of the war 'It would require a greater philosopher and historian than I am to explain the causes of the famous Seven Years' War in which Europe was engaged; and, indeed, its origin has always appeared to me to be so complicated, and the books written about it so amazingly hard to understand, that I have seldom been much wiser at the end of a chapter than at the beginning, and so shall not trouble my reader with any personal disquisitions concerning the matter.'

Many have explained why the war broke out, but like for the causes of the First World War; it's almost impossible to parse the difference between causes and reasons for the outbreak of war. And I took, am neither a great enough historian or philosopher, nor have I spent enough time looking at the war, to answer Thackeray's call to investigate. Maybe that'll be my next podcast series; the causes of the Seven Years War.

Anyway, what nobody can deny are that wars are expensive, deadly and hugely politically challenging. They also don't happen spontaneously. The war, which lasted from 1756 to 1763,

marked the start of greatest change in mankind had seen since the Neolithic Revolution. For whatever reason the war isn't talked about too much today, perhaps overshadowed by the American Revolution in the USA, the French Revolution in France and the Industrial Revolution in British history. Yet it was almost the first true World War, fought across continents and it saw a biggest shakeup in European power relations for 100 years. It's consequences all directly led to the American, French and Industrial revolutions. Britain's victory saw a decisive turning point in its new superpower status. It moved from great power status to commercial hegemony. It also marked the decisive change of hegemon in Europe away from France, Austria, Spain and towards the Kingdom of Great Britain. It would also mark a turning point in German history, as the continent had to deal with increasingly powerful German states, best represented by Prussia.
Britain's agricultural productivity, its commercial power, and naval hegemon was noted before the war. But with a rapidly growing population, Britain used its new industry to become the first country to rescue itself from the Malthusian trap of mass poverty, malnutrition, disease and mass death. There is also quite a bit of first hand evidence from American and continental chroniclers that industrial acceleration of the British economy happened primarily during the war.
So let's look at Britain's agricultural sector. How different was it from Europe? Well Britain has always had very good yields per arable hectare, comparing favorably to Europe and even the agricultural powerhouses of India and China. Why? Well Whig historians look at Britain's property rights and tenurial agreements that allowed large farms to proliferate, and they compared these to the small subsistence farms of France or India as one reason for higher yields. This is what historically was the cause. But as automation increased, during the 1750s, giving Britain an even more productive agricultural sector, farmers left their rural heartlands and moved to the city.
What came first, the pull of higher wages in the city, or the drying up of farm work as the farmlands became more automated leading to fewer jobs? Well there was probably an intermingling. And cities began to need more labour to make new textiles and rural areas had less work. A great internal migratory shift occurred. On some occasions people might only be moving 5, 10 or 20 miles to the nearest city, but it was the biggest move they'd ever make in their lives.
Even today, many of the people in the suburbs and inner cities of the great northern towns like Manchester, Birmingham, Newcastle or Sheffield will be related to these movers and shakers. Those families that moved in the 1750s and 1760s will have descendants whose families have never left the towns these people moved from.
Those in the Lancashire and Cheshire area moved to Manchester, those on the moors of Yorkshire moved to Leeds and Bradford, those in Kent and Surrey moved to the south of the City of London, while the breadbasket of England, those in East Anglia moved towards the East End of the City of London. This period also marked something of an aristocratic grab for land, as small farm owners who still remained in the rural areas tried to sell their land.
Britain's agricultural productivity had been noted for a few centuries, with a large animal population providing high value food at cheap prices, meaning the cost of living was cheap and labour could be focused on something other than agriculture.
Britain further developed farming by a series of innovations like organic fertilizer, centralization of land, crop rotation and selective breeding made its agriculture sector soar. As Britain boomed, Ireland suffered. Wages in England were so attractive that cheaper Irish labour poured into the country, and many got work by digging all those canals the aristocratic classes were increasingly seeing as economically viable.
Britain's natural resources were also some of the most plentiful in the word, but as E.A. Wrigley noted, they were also of better quality than elsewhere. By the early 19th century, Brits were using 15 million tons of coal a year, compared to just 3 million tons of coal a year on the continent as a whole. Europe and Asia still largely relied on peat, wood, water, wind and human energy, at the same time as Britain was having a coal revolution. Coal allowed for heat intensive industrial processes such as metallurgy, glass making, brewing, refining sugar and salt, chemistry, in baking food and bricks to be mechanized through the reliability of cheap energy.

The nature of trade in Britain's industrialization is debated, but Britain's easy access to water, only increasing with the canals of the late 18th century, meant British goods were not only cheap to make but cheap to transport. Over the course of the 1700s British export quantities multiplied 4 times in just a century, compared to a mere doubling from 1500 to 1700. Exports as a source of national income went from 4% during the reign of Elizabeth I to 12% under the mad King George III. About half of British industrial produce was going abroad.

Britain also became a highly adept country at raising taxation. The nature of Parliament, constitutionally designed to pacify at first the barons and then the commoners into agreeing to taxation, was a far superior method to the Ancient Regime's raising of taxes. Britain was rich, while the French monarchy was constantly bankrupt; a huge cause of the reason for the final ending of the monarchy' power in France. Between 1670 and 1815 taxation in Britain rose by a factor of 17; as national income rose by 3 times.

The English and then British navy, following the feudal wars of British dynastic succession, which were fought as civil wars on land, became the ultimate arbiter and protector of British sovereignty from overseas threat. There was nothing that could be done to halt British rising power.

The British Navy, funded by this huge rise in taxation, caused economic feedback loops. The investment in skilled workers to build, innovate and sustain the huge fleet also opened up sea lanes, sparked innovation and demand for the highest quality and cheapest products, which further grew Britain's global commerce empire.

Without prior knowledge of what to do, British entrepreneurs made stabs in the dark in how to advance an industrial economy. For the workers it would have been depressing and awful work, but for a growing middle class – Britain felt like it was booming. The transition for the British working classes from agrarian to industrial was probably amongst the most miserable in industrial history, but it did work.

Britain's growth demolished that of other European golden periods, such as the Italian Renaissance, Dutch Golden Age or Spanish New World gold rush. In Britian, labour productivity; the real marker of economic growth, reached levels never seen before and kept on rising. British labour productivity reached levels of 87% above the baseline European average by 1800.

It didn't take long for British industry to move around the world. The appearance of British machinery had been noted on the continent before the French Revolution, such as in Catalonia, but the process of industralisation elsewhere was largely diffusive and much slower than in Britain.

So, I've often labelled 1760 as the start of the first Industrial Revolution, but really any date from 1756 to 1763 could be given as the date, I just like canals enough to argue the dating of the Bridgewater canal should be seen as the demarcation point. But it's clear that the Seven Years War sped up a slow process of industrialization that before the war was lumbering towards something, and afterwards it turned it into a revolution. Debt poured into the British economy to fund the war, and the huge demands stimulated to fight the war led to a beginning of knitting of technologies together, that had led to the general rise in human productivity via mechanization that we call the Industrial Revolution.

Part 6: Pax Britannia

'The inhabitant of London could order by telephone, sipping his morning tea in bed, the various products of the whole Earth, in such quantity as he might see fit, and reasonably expect their early delivery upon his doorstep; he could at the same moment and by the same means adventure his wealth in the natural resources and new enterprises of any quarter of the world, and share, without exertion or even trouble, in their prospective fruits and advantages… The projects and politics of militarization and imperialism, of racial and cultural rivalries, of monopolies, restrictions ,and exclusion, which were to play the serpent to this paradise, were little more than the amusements of his daily newspaper, and appeared to exercise almost no influence at all on the ordinary course of social and economic life, the Internationalization of which was nearly complete in practice.' – John Maynard Keynes, 1919

The rise of the first industrial nation led to a global power never seen before. Strangely, not interested in dominating its closest neighbors; Britain moved to dominate the rest of the world. Not

in a militaristic empire, per ce, the British Empire would become a financial and commercial empire, held together by the Royal Navy.
This is not strange. Rome, the Mongols, and later America were all essentially empires of commerce, except Britain was the first to outright care about commerce as much as its military. The private East India Company led to way, dominating the lucrative trade to the east. Trading outposts around the coast of Africa were set up to provide safe ports for commerce. Later trade would be developed in even more lucrative markets: gold, silver, spices and opium. Singapore and Hong Kong were developed as islands city states; somewhat similar replicas of the City of London, to provide a military base, logistical, and financial support for the growing British domination of Asian trade.
The huge wealth generated from not only being the world's primary industrial power but dominating some of its most lucrative trades meant that Britain was booming. It's capital reserves were used across the world. Much British capital for example went into investing in the expansion of the North America continent, where financial and cultural, if not political interests were still maintained. Places too like Argentina, India and Europe got huge investment for railway expansions following the British pioneering of the technology.
It was not only the British economy that boomed during this time, but its population too. The Malthusian trap of a population too large to sustain itself, was solved by accident: increasing food production and emigration. Britain became a source of emigration as people moved out to colonize the world. The Highlands of Scotland, the last refuge of anti-Union feeling had revolted twice in the early years of the Union and it would be these Scots who were amongst the most encouraged, or pressed, into leaving. Yet all across the island – bored of the drudgery of Britain, people left. The United States, Australia, New Zealand, Canada were amongst the most colonized new lands, but even the places that saw little outright British colonization, such as Argentina, became deeply indebted to the United Kingdom in many ways. The railway workers who went to South America and Europe, brought with them their footballs along with the railway lines; leaving a soft power legacy that would outlive the Empire itself.
The British military became the most feared armed forces on the planet. From the start of the industrial revolution in the Seven Years War, to the First World War, it was nothing short of victory after victory on the military front. Not always easy at times, the Napoleonic Wars saw Britain facing almost the entire continent at once. It's solution was to rely on the Royal Navy to defend itself – most famously at Trafalgar, and to rely on its commerce to undermine French trade, while picking off the French in various strategic locations such as Portugal.
The Continental trading system set up by Napoleon, was set up to exclude British commerce from the continent. Banning the cheapest and highest quality products on the continent was never going to prove successful and the blockade was penetrated by British smugglers who got through the blockade, mostly going through Portugal and most famously Russia – this being one of the primary reasons for the disastrous French invasion in 1812.
The British had been fighting in the Peninsula War, with their oldest allies, the Portuguese, where a certain Arthur Wellesley was starting to make a name for himself. The chipping away at the French control, either through its direct military actions in Iberia or through commerce to sew division in Napoleon's Empire, made the Emperor commit one of the greatest military blunders ever: a land war in Russia; which slowly moved turned into a land invasion of Russia during the winter. Britain managed to turn much of the continent against Napoleon following the retreat from Moscow and the Battle of the Nations, or Battle of Leipzig, was perhaps the most consequential defeat for Napoleon as it now meant France was largely alone against much of Europe, as former allies realized his weakness and turned.
The later Battle of Waterloo was the final curtain for this period of history. A closely fought battle, but it was largely symbolic. French war capacity was much smaller now after 2 decades of constant fighting. The amount of men France was able to muster during the wars had once been the largest, but had massively reduced. The Russians, Germans, Spanish, Austrians and British were circling in. Even victory at Waterloo for Napoleon would not have done much to stop the coming defeat.

Though it was the Prussian army, under Gebhard von Blücher who rather saved Arthur Wellesley, the Duke of Wellington's, skin in the battle. Blücher came to his aid as Napoleon was turning the battle, but today it is Wellington who gets the majority of the credit and the glory for the battle. The Napoleonic War in France was so devastating that we can pretty much say that England, or Britain, had finally defeated its enemy of nearly 1000 years. France was never again taken seriously as a global military power. It would still be a great power, but it would never again challenged Britain. The battle was also symbolic for the future of European conflicts as it was the last time that the British and the Prussians fought side-to-side.
European domination would follow for Britain. This was largely manifested through commerce, yet with the lack of British land power, there was room for a new land army to cause Britain problems. Increasing Prussian militarism would become the great power problem of the 19th century and in to the 20th century in Europe. Nobody in Britain realized this at the time, and even 100 years later, the French were still seen as the primary enemy by many Tommy's before the First World War. Yet in the highest areas of the country, there was a realization in political circles that France was a former power, now a British supported bulwark against the German Empire. The balance of power in Europe no longer meant keeping France down, it meant keeping the Germans down. France still remained strong and proud, but it lost its advantage.
Britain ruled the world for 100 years, and never overly interfered in the continent to stop the rise of the Prussians. Britain fought only one war on the continent between Waterloo and 1914. During the Crimean War– which Britain fought with its growing ally, the French, did it interrupt its splendid isolation. Prussia meanwhile, continued where von Blücher left off. Prussia gained power and influence over the continent. In the peace of Vienna, Prussia was given Saxony and more power in western Europe, allowing it to turn westwards in its interests, rather than looking towards Russia. It was given 3/5th of Saxony, and that allowed Prussia to start industrializing, rather than focusing on its traditional agricultural industry as the basis of its power.
Prussia become the primary German state, gradually pushing for the unification of the German speaking peoples. A far larger, but much more divided grouping than the French speakers who had been unified and then centralized centuries before.
In 1815 the Prussian state was still largely agrarian, but highly disciplined and utterly ruthless. Over the course of the 19th century, their military thinkers and strategists were the best in the world and when Otto von Bismarck was appointed in 1862 to the position of Prime Minister of Prussia, Europe was about to undergo its largest transformation since 1815.
Britain, long the primary bulwark against any European domination took little interest in this, and Prussia gained surrounding territories in small war after small war. This process quickened around the time of the 1850s and 1860s, and then turned into a wave in 1870 as the Prussians took the fight to the French. Prussia had changed from an agrarian economy to a military-industrial one. It had better technology to fight than most of Europe and its army devastated the French, who were still fighting battles using Napoleonic tactics. The Prussian fought with new tactics from the American Union Army on how to fight an industrial war. These tactics were used to devastate France in 1870. The Prussian Army fought one of the most devastating wars in the history of the European continent. It smashed the French army and its people. It sieged Paris, and forced a humiliating surrender on the proud French people, many of whom were still arrogant enough to think France was still the primary land power in Europe. France before 1870 was home to the greatest army in Europe; after 1870, it became clear to everybody that France was a country in permanent decline. The victory of 1870 saw Prussia able to hold enough political capital to declare itself as the first German Empire. A unified political union under the command of the brutal Prussians; it was now clear to the British who the main enemy on the continent was. Over the end of the 19th century, public consciousness to the new Teutonic threat increased with everything from invasion fiction of German invasions in the Victorian Period increasing; to newspapers reporting on the rise of Germany.
It was quickly feared Germany was catching up to Britain in many ways. Not as an Imperial power, but that this industrial Germany was now so prosperous and the new German industry was

outcompeting Britain in many areas. Without an empire, German excess profit was reallocated back into Germany, causing further innovative industrial techniques as the Germans quickly broke new innovative ground and began to dominate many areas of a the second industrial revolution. Automobiles, steel, railways, chemicals, and pharmaceuticals all boomed in Germany, as Britain was using its industry and capital to hold together an empire. Britain began to struggle to compete in some areas.

So if this was the state of play in Europe during Pax Britannia, what of the world. Well Britain's splendid isolation was going well, most thought. The reign of Victoria has seen limited political reform at home, coupled with a doubling of the population. The attempted domination of Ireland became the main domestic problem. Meanwhile education was expanded to all, the Royal Navy dominated the world, while the politicians of the day are still some of the greatest parliamentarians to have stood for office: Gladstone, Disraeli, Peel, Palmerston; to name a few.

Britain was so rich that the poorest were starting to have more leisure time to do things like organising sporting contests. During Britain's golden age: literature and the arts boomed, as the British led to way in the sciences. From theoretical physics, to the use of electrical currents, meanwhile even far off things like computers were theorised. Thermodynamics knowledge greatly improve, and infrastructure developments like the telegraphs and wireless commutation remained the most innovative and modern in the world.

Most famously of all British science during this time, was the development of the theory of natural selection by Charles Darwin. More than just a piece of work that influenced biologists, it changed the very nature of Victorian Society by the late 19th century. Social Darwinists started to grow in British society, and of course across the world. Social Darwinism drew the link between the nature of animals and the disturbing yet unalterable fact that humans too are just animals.

These Darwinists began to look at the body politic in Britain and saw huge levels of poverty and drudgery that still existed amongst many in the British working class. They were compared unfavourably to the ordinary German. It was a dawning moment as many British elites realised just how much Germany was catching up to Britain. It also went the other way and not in pity at British working classes, but in downright objection to many other cultures and ways of life. Before the British were just interested in trading relations, and Empire morphed into an empire of social and cultural superiority. Taming, developing and civilising the natives in British territory became a primary push of Empire. At the same time, various reforms were put in place in Britain itself to drive up the state of the British body politic.

Despite various problems at home, and with Germany and the United States catching up to the workshop of the world, the course of Pax Britannia from 1815-1914 saw Britain as still ahead of the world. The Royal Navy was the biggest but also the most technologically advanced. It could crush anything that came its way, demonstrating this in Crimea and China. The Royal Navy opened sea lanes for all, keeping an eye on the vital Suez Canal before annexing Egypt to keep an even closer eye on it.

Speak softly and carry a big stick, from Trafalgar to Jutland, the Royal Navy was not only undefeated but hardly even challenged. It moved from a fleet of sail ships in the 1840s and in the 1850s to steam, then introducing the huge Dreadnought class ship at the start of the 20th century. These were the first capital ships to be powered by a steam turbine and it further propelled the Royal Navy to maintain its global supremacy. HMS Dreadnought was launched in 1908 and proved that when Britain wanted to, it could still lead the world. By 1913 and Britain moved its ships primary fuel from coal to oil, providing a spurt of empire growth to capture oil reserves in places like Persia, whereupon the Anglo-Persian Company was bought up by the British government in 1914, to ensure a regular supply of the superior fuel source.

The eventual challenge of the Royal Navy, after its domination of the seas since Trafalgar, took place at the Battle of Jutland in 1916. It saw the Germans finally square off the to the Royal Navy, but the battle was a bit of a damp squib. After the stalemate of the battle, Germany did not dare challenge the Royal Navy. The battle should be largely seen as a British strategic victory. The

Germans had much more to gain from the risking of its entire fleet than the British, whose power almost solely rested on the Royal Navy.
The Royal Navy was blockading the Germans off from almost all overseas trade. The people of Germany slowly starved over the war due to this blockade. The German Navy could have tried a marine blitzkrieg tactic to try and break British grip on control of the North Sea. Instead, the Germany Navy retreated to port. The Royal Navy had worked. It was seen as too powerful and too easily rebuilt to risk the sinking of the German Navy for possible victory. Yet the Germans would continue to starve.
Had the Germans gone for it, the Royal Navy, most likely, would have been able to eventually defeat the Germany Navy. Yet, with the Germans not even trying, the Royal Navy's maxim of carrying a big stick to avoid conflict was maintained. Yet Jutland was almost the final flourish of British naval supremacy. The First World War slowly brought down Pax Britannia. Britain was the greatest power in Europe; yet the United States and Japan were looking good. Russia was undergoing great change, but it had great potential and Germany could never be written off as a competitor.
The War turned Britain from a huge global creditor to a debtor. The massive loss of life, of the youngest and most able in the country; and a complete reorientation of the economy towards warfare meant that industrial competitiveness had been sucked out of the British economy, and began to move towards the United States. Sir Edward Grey, the British Foreign Minister, who said at the time of the July Crisis in 1914 that, 'the lamps are going out all over Europe. We shall not see them lit again in our time,' became a truly profound statement. Stimulated by demand from Europe during and after the war, America jumped ahead, as Britain recovered slowly in the 1920s. The Americans went on to develop a consumer products boom in the 20s, that could have happened in Britain had capital not been taken out of the country. While London and much of Europe still relied on gas street lamps, the growth of American industrial and technological might meant that the USA had electric lighting working as street lights. While fairly symbolic, it showed from Edward Grey's statement that the lamps are going went out in Europe, as America released light bulbs.
Europe's capital had been drained. Reinvestment that could have bene used for technological innovations had been wasted on warfare. The most advanced region was now located in the New World.
Part 7: The Disastrous 20th Century
The United Kingdom is not a unique country, but certainly a lucky one. It is a mineral resource rich island, with huge coal deposits capable of powering the country for another 300 years despite its small size. This has meant that for two centuries Britain was the energy powerhouse of the world. Even before coal, the islands huge woodlands provided energy in the form of wood and charcoal. Further, for much of its history, the island has been hugely underpopulated, giving it a comparatively large per capita wealth and leading to a high skill base.
The relative free market meant there were obvious rewards for high skill levels, and led to a respect for the intellects and eccentrics of society, when more autocratic regimes shunted free-thinkers and eccentrics. The 'genius in the shed' story of the first industrial revolution isn't far wrong - as a generation of clever Brits tinkered their way to an industrial revolution.
Wealthy local aristocrats could invest in pretty much anything they thought could provide returns. Compared to the French aristocracy, who were much poorer and much more centralized around the Bourbon King and court at Versailles than their English counterparts. Yet France was far more centralized than Britain.
The middle classes in England were well paid, as the poor had well-paying jobs in a productive agricultural sector, and later an even more productive industrial sector. Parliament increasingly dominated and over time became more representative as ordinary people got more and more wealth. London became the capital reserve of the world during the industrialization push.
The British ruling class, as we turn into the 20th century, not only ruled and owned Britain, but increasingly the world. This was passed off as the British Empire, but really it was an empire bought for, and only occasionally fought for. The economic boom in Britain meant that huge

numbers of children were being born and surviving into adulthood. Many emigrated to the United States, Canada, South America, Australia, Africa, India, Hong Kong and elsewhere. These close foreign links allowed Britain to increase the power of the homeland through close financial and political ties across the globe; powering the empire to keep on growing.

Industrialization led to a centralization of the economy, with the 10% of the population owning 92% of Britain by the Edwardian Period at the start of the 20th century. Add this fact that cumulative national wealth was four times that of British income itself; and the amount of the wealth controlled by the British elite become stark.

Britain’s Navy, easily the most powerful in the world, grew over the centuries from a mix of merchant and military force, to a blue-sea power projecting behemoth. The rocky outpost on the edge of Europe could dominate sea lanes across the world, in lieu of not needing to dominate on land due to its island status. The Empire of Japan in many ways tried to copy this model in controlling Asia, but Japan never became an Eastern Britain. Theodore Roosevelt at the start of the 20th century was the only person who managed to emulate this huge navy. Leading to a building up of the US Navy, to mean that by 1945 it was by far the more powerful in the world.

Yet if we go back for a minute and compare Britain and Japan a little more. For they make an interesting comparison. Britain has had far more natural resources than Japan, but it was also far more receptive to change. The market economy dominated Britain in a way it never quite did in Japan. The Japanese did try and replicate Britain, in a move away from its medieval period dated to 1868, as the country attempted to modernize all at once.

However, for my mind, Japan always lacked the idea of a market economy being the true sovereign of the land. Japan had a population of 30 million in the 17th century, but looked more like an island France, than an Eastern Britain. Japan was at the peak of an agricultural nation, but with no natural resources and little open access to foreign markets following its isolation, it was bound to be unable to catch up. This is what gutted Japan. By 1945 it still relied on imported energy, which was easily cut off by the Americans and meant it was bound to lose the war, even if it managed to fight ferociously to the end.

So back to Britain. Britain from 1900 to Britain in 1950 to Britain in 2000 to Britain in 2021 are remarabkly different countries. Britain in 1700 to Britain in 1800 would not have been as radical a change as Britain in 1921 to 2021. But even looking at Britain in 1900, it was a remarkably modern country. Sure, Germany and the USA were catching up technologically, but British developments in chemicals, automobiles, textiles; and it’s still rapid innovations in things like aviation, railway modernization and the domination of its navy still meant Britain was still the most modern country in the world. For sure, by 1900, Britain was gliding on its Empire, but in many areas its economy was still ahead of the rest of the world. Farming output per person and per acre were some of the highest in the world. The United Kingdom was industrial rather than agricultural, maritime rather than land bound, and free trading rather than protectionist. It was an import-exporter merchant democracy with a strong free market; with a strong industrial economy at its backbone. Britain was the Saudi Arabia of the day, with the sheer abundance of coal found on the Island meaning it could power itself and much of the rest of the world. 70% of the global sea trade of coal was British in origin. Such was the success of its coal industry and the high quality coal and its mines easy access to water, that it was cheaper to get British coal to Berlin, than it was to get German coal to Berlin.

Yet the period of 1900 – 1945 was disastrous for Britain, not just in economic terms, but in social terms. Once the leader of the world, Britain was almost bankrupt twice in a generation. It was drained of its natural wealth in fighting something that for a millennia had caused the British state problems: Europe. As time moves further and further away from events of the Second World War, and the more I read about pre-WW1 Europe, Edward Grey’s prediction in July 1914 that the lights may go out in Europe and may not be relit in his lifetime were prophetic. And perhaps still true.

Britain of 1900 to 1945 moved from a wealthy yet highly unequal country, but focused on individualism and personal responsibility; to become a much more state led country, but still much poorer country than in 1900, and yet still highly unequal. The state control began a move away from the British and their innate love of making things and selling them, into a country of services, housing markets, and gliding on a soft power that was a legacy of Empire.

The 20th century saw manufacturing decline following the Second World War. The process of nationalization could not innovate British industry enough compared to the growing world manufacturing in the US, France and Germany among many other places. This led to a hollowing out of the world industrial breadbasket.

Anything and everything used be made in Britain, but Britain was now broke with the state unable or unwilling to modernize and compete. The ultimate price was paid for the British following the two world wars: it cost the United Kingdom’s industrial economy. In the 1980s the state began to re-privitaise what industry it still controlled, but it was little more than managed decline. By 2000 and British manufacturing was almost non-existent. There was almost nothing of British manufacturing that was truly world leading anymore – except a few weapons manufacturers. Not even the British state was silly enough to sell off its war capacity.

Britain in 1900 was a wonderous place. Not perfect, but as advanced a civilization as anywhere in the world and had ever been. Poverty was still rife in much of the country, and wealth was highly concentrated, but things were getting better. Child labour laws were strict, education for everybody was mandatory and increasing. Meanwhile, perhaps the most underrated aspect of being British was the right to leave the country. Didn’t like it, and you could move to almost anywhere in the world. Whether it was the New or Old world, you were free to leave the country. Many did, and they prospered across the world. Because of course, at this point in history; Britain dominated, almost by accident, a quarter of the world. Leaving a huge cultural influence even in places the Union Flag did not officially fly.

The British workforce of 1900 was advanced too. While the majority of the French workforce still worked in agriculture, Britain had has many coal miners as farmers, with 100 times as much coal as wheat coming out of the country. The energy superpower of its day, the United Kingdom’s farming productivity still had the highest yields per acre of grain. Britain also was quick to move into new areas. When the American’s were showing the world the superiority of oil over coal, the British with the Dutch, were the only real international competitors to the American dominance of the black gold. The Anglo-Persian company, later BP; and the merged Royal Dutch Shell company were producing oil in Russia, Romania, Venezuela, Mexico and the US.

Brit’s in 1900 were rich enough that housewives were consumers of foods - not producers. A full English breakfast was made from Danish bacon, Dutch eggs, and Canadian or Argentine wheat.

Meanwhile the only two geopolitical threats to the dominance of the British Empire were not natural enemies. The United States was of course very British in many ways, and even the up and coming German Empire had many similarities with the British. During WW1 many Tommy’s still believed the French were the natural enemies, even as they fought against the Germans.

But to highlight the dominance of the British pre-1914, we should look at its capital markets, which showed that it was Britain that was the ruler of the world. This capital, concentrated in the British ruling class, meant the British ruling class dominated the world; setting standards wherever they went. Fashion, sport and commerce were dominated by Brits.

More modern day Monty Python style caricatures make the case that the British ruling class are upper class twits. But this was the product of 1960s declinism. Pre-1960 the upper classes of Britain were seen as natural guardians of the country, not upper class twits.

For much of the 20th century, the British upper class were extremely efficient in their use of capital. This British upper class did not work, they merely acquired their money from the ownership of assets. Business magnets ran Britain back then, as much as they do today in the US. But there was also an understated element of meritocracy in Britain. Gentlemen industrialists were comfortable, and could compete on a playing level with the aristocracy. The level of wealth and opportunity was not utopian. The chances of a coal miner being able to get his many children further up the social ladder were small. Opportunities were there, but they were difficult to get; and as British growth slowed at the end of the 19th century and into the 20th, investors continued to look overseas for investment rather than at home, further harming investment in the poorest areas.

The decline in health and standards of the British working class led to calls from the Liberal and new Labour Party for a wealth tax, an idea which rumbled on for much of the early 20th century. National wealth was 4 times that of national income and was seen as the easiest way to redistribute the gains of industrialization and Empire. But this never came to pass.
So what of the Empire. There was no Imperial Parliament, but there was a clear sense of Empire under British rule.
The Empire's dominance fed into Britain's overseas wealth. One third of all British capital was located overseas. Half of British capital was invested overseas. Brits owned foreign debt, foreign assets and foreign natural resources. The railways in South America were funded and built by Brits. Yet this wealth dried up in the long run, as massive changes in political fortunes caused the wealth of the nation to dissipate as two huge wars drained Brits of their wealth.
But still, by the 1950s, one could get a regal sense of British domination and exceptionalism. Britain in 1900 was more industrial then in 1850, but the Britain of 1950 was still more industrial than that of 1900. Britain of 1950 could still claim to be the most industrial country in the world, and could probably still claim to be a workshop of the world. But things were changing. The rise of the US meant British competitiveness was slipping away. Meanwhile the complete remaking of French and German industry's after the war also provided new competition.
This new competition forced the British into doing something. With Labour and socialist Prime Minister Clement Attlee in charge, he chose the option of protectionism. By the 1950s the dye was cast and Britain became more and more of a protectionist country. Industry became nationalized to protect against foreign competition, which impacted on its worldwide competitiveness. British wealth became ever more state dominated. Foreign capital, once welcomed, was seen with mistrust. This shift had perhaps started after the disasters of the First World War. During the interwar years especially, international capital was seen as 'Jewish-German cosmopolitism' as Britain slightly retreated from what it previously once was.
The Second World War marked such a change in British life that it's difficult to talk about it Britain as the same country. As much as 1066, 1533 and the break from Rome, or the slower process of industrialization in the 1760s, the period of 1939-1945 radically changed Britain over a shorter time period more than any other event. Some huge national events are political in nature, or economic or social. The war was everything to all people.
It might not have gone this way. The 1930s saw something of a recovery for Britain after the First World War as the Great Depression impacted Britain far less than other countries as it was less reliant on the United States, than say Germany, but the devastating effects of the war, as much on the political economy, and the whole society was huge. British loss of life was not as huge as in other parts of Europe. It was never invaded. But instead it was fought with social capital and economic capital. It nearly bankrupted the state.
The Britain of 1900 was the most cosmopolitan, liberal, and free-trading country in the world. By 1950 a mix of politics and circumstance had created a new Britain. Less a new Jerusalem, more a slow a regression to the European mean. The 20th century saw British exceptionalism decline and replaced by a much meeker national spirit. Since 1945, Britain has tried everything to rekick start growth. From mass centralization after the Second World War, Harold Wilson's white heat of technology, entering the European Community and then signing the Maastricht Treaty, mass immigration, mass welfare and then today, by leaving the European Community and going it alone. So far, Britain has tried many things to regain former glory, but none has so - far worked. The Britain of 1900 does still resides in pockets and elements across the country today, but for the majority of the population, the Britain after the Second World War became one based around the state, not the individual.
This was a remarkable change, but one that took the two most destructive events in the United Kingdom's history: the Two World Wars. The post was consensus of how to solve all the issues highlighted and caused by the Wars was seen to be a big government running state corporatism. Called nationalization, it was really state corporatism; which is in effect communism-lite. It was initiated by the Labour Party in 1945 after their election victory to try and rebalance the economy.

The economic plan was remarkably similar to Oswald Mosley's book 'The Greater Britain,' Mosley was, at the time, the leader of the British Union of Fascists.
Mosley wanted to create something of an autarky for Britain, to avoid exploitation by what he called international financiers, a euphemism he used for Jews, who he saw as undercutting British labour in favour of cheaper products and workers overseas. He wanted the profits from a British Corporate State to enable everybody in the country to share the profits of this new company. And whilst perhaps not politically correct to state; the post-war political consensus of 1945 to 1979 was almost exactly this; an attempt to move Britain away from international markets to some extent, and by using the Bretton Woods system which had somewhat favoured Britain despite the awful financial mess it had got itself in, it was able to just about sustain itself for a while. Yet the system was mediocre. The profits imagined by Mosley were the first problem: British industry after about 1950 was never profitable on the international market. When Nixon left the gold standard in 1971 and free floated the dollar it effected the rest of the world. Sterling dropped in price meaning it could no longer import materials cheaper, but the sluggish British corporate state could not compete, even as exporting got cheaper.
The 1970s in Britain were a lost economic decade. With the pound now free floating, stagflation hit the economy. That's economic stagnation and inflation hitting the economy at the same time. British attempts at state imposed autarky were now failing, as the British Corporate State could no longer be propped up by American good will towards Britain and the dollar. For a decade during the 1970s, the British state failed to come to terms with this issue. Attempts at building a British Corporate State were seen as failures. Other than Concorde, which was never really commercially viable, British industry failed to compete en-masse with the world.
Other areas could have helped Britain out during this era. The discovery of North Sea oil for example could have been a boon to the economy, but the process of the using the proceeds for north sea oil was managed terribly. The British chose to basically not negotiate with the Norwegians over oil rights in the North Sea; instead they offered the Norwegians very generous drilling rights for immediate settlement, instead of facing the possibility of a long protracted dispute. Britain needed immediate revenue from oil to prop itself up. Britain could and probably should have negotiated harder, and it would have succeeded in gaining larger oil reserves, but the need for money meant they never took the chance.
The Winter of Discontent of 1979 was final end of British autarky. The British economy was gutted and everybody saw a change was needed. The British experiment with the political economy of John Maynard Keynes and his focus on focusing on full employment, and the logical extension of this, turning Britain into a sort of Brave New World corporatist state was over.
The earlier entry of Britain into the European Community in 1973 was seen as a way to somewhat open up markets. The EEC was presented as a way for Britain to sell its goods to a growing common market. Yet this largely failed for once reason. The Germans with their Volkswagens, and the French with their Renaults, were not going to start buying British Leyland cars. They were worse quality and more expensive than their European counterparts. British entry into the European Community was a short term failure, and was largely successful in highlighting the decline of British manufacturing. Brits could now get much cheaper and often higher quality European products tariff free. And for what it's worth, Europeans could continue avoiding British goods, which they done in since about 1914.
The victory of Margaret Thatcher in 1979 started the re-opening up of Britain to international finance. Thatcher gutted most of the refuges of British state corporatism. It was largely failing industries that was seen to beyond the pale of saving. It was one thing to fail to compete with the Americans, and complete other thing to fail to compete with Europe. Thatcher realigned Britain to the United States and attempted something of a middle way between Atlanticism and mild-Europhilia. Her reforms were never quite completed, but were unchangeable after the success of the Big Bang of 1986 opened up financial markets even more and the economy boomed. Thatcher further led Britain away from anything smelling of socialist big government. She continued the British state favouring automobiles over the railways; she opened up council housing to be bought

by tenants in her attempt to sew a property-owning democracy into the working classes, and she strengthened British defence commitments to NATO.
Thatcher was a natural Eurosceptic and tried to find a middle ground in a country that hadn't yet found its role in the world. Had she lasted long enough, she would have probably chosen not to enter Europe following the Maastricht Treaty of 1992.
Thatcher was removed from power, after trying to raise even more revenue from the already hard-up poorest, through the Poll Tax, causing riots across the country. It was an unnatural fit for a supposed libertarian of the Austrian School to want to tax everybody in the country for simply being alive. The tax was seen as fundamentally un-British and anti-freedom; and so she was booted out of office. Bland but competent John Major took power. Major was a natural Europhile and moved the Conservative Party towards a predominantly pro-European party, at the same time he almost crashed the currency in 1992.
Major opened up higher education to all, turning the Polytechnics into full blown Universities. This also partially opened up of the still old-fashioned Universities, but also saw the final death nell of the manufacturing sector, as now millions of working class and lower middle class youngsters saw their future in the new service sector by getting, which were powered by graduated leaving universities. It completed the Thatcher move towards a service economy.
Thatcher's long-term financial reforms were taking off by the 1990s, and Britain began to look confident around the world. English Premier Leage football took off around the world, everything from the Spice Girls to Oasis were world beaters; Cool Britannia took off. Following this, Britain did something it had not done since 1945. It gave the Labour Party a huge majority. The Conservatives had changed Britain drastically since 1979, but they were going nowhere as a party. Stuck between Thatcherism and Christian conservatism.
The Labour Party of the 1990s and 2000s was as transformatory for Britain as the period of the Conservatives before it, but this time, less for what it did and more for what it didn't do. So let's start with what it did do. It opened up the country to low-skill European immigration, the country continued to benefit from Britain's successes in the financial services sector, which was used to fund a huge increase in welfare and benefits, but most famously of all, the Labour Party started the war in Iraq. The most contentious war in British history since the Boer War. The Iraq War, for many, has seen the Labour Party lose the electability it had tried so hard to win back after its years in the socialist wilderness. The Iraq War was not popular but Blair managed to win another election in 2005; before leaving in 2007. In 2008, Britain's economy crashed a year after Blair left office, leaving Gordon Brown to try and pick up the pieces. His attempt to spend his way out of trouble was disliked by voters and in 2010 a Conservative-Lib Dem coalition was formed, to roll back much of Brown's and Labour's spending.
Yet it's interesting to think back to what this modern Labour Party could have done. The good state of British finances and the huge political capital it had was kind of ignored and nothing grand was ever attempted. Blair had no interest in his supposed working class base. At every opportunity his attempts were to pacify the poor and not to boost them. Welfare payments of all stripes: from handouts to increased spending on free services were popular; free things always are, but there was a feeling it created a worse country.
The Blair government also allowed open the country's borders. Worldwide and European immigration soared during the Labour years. This largely effected the poor as the immigrants coming over were also poor. In British history, only the arrival of the Anglo-Saxons has any comparison. Yet despite all of this, the Labour Government refused to provide competitive manufacturing and high quality jobs for the working classes and new immigrants.
Instead, Blair bought them off. The large scale welfare spending, stereotyped in the papers as working class families choosing not to work, living on welfare, having more kids than they could afford, but comfortable with their Sky Television watching the highly successful Premier League was quite a common sight in British media at the time. This was of course, not people's fault, but the governments. Rather than making work pay, and making work productive; loyalties were bought

off. Money that might have been used to invest in manufacturing or infrastructure was merely used to fund huge welfare spending and the supporting of mass immigration from Europe.
The result of the 2008 financial crisis and its devasting impact on the British economy was more profound in structural terms on these islands, than anywhere else. The Ponzi scheme that was British banking needed huge bailouts from the British government. It created resentment and distrust in banking, and the state. It showed that even a Labour government had no choice but to keep the banks solvent, at huge expense to its own political capital. It showed banking was more important than the state. A power move if ever there was one.
Structural problems in the British economy were never really solved. During the 2010s coalition government, Britain simply muddled through; doing everything in its power to reorient the state towards a more sustainable economic model and away from mass welfare spending. Yet still doing everything in their power to reform government spending, without reforming the financial system.
So where do I want to leave this chapter. With the logical conclusion of British political economy for the last 50 years: Brexit. In reality; what Brexit represents is the unsolvable problem of the British archipelago. Like Russia and its oscillation between being a European or Asiatic power, Britain’s main problem for the past 1,000 years has been its relation to Europe.
Much of Britain’s most prosperous times have been when it has separated itself from continental affairs, and yet it is has always been dragged back into European affairs. A catch-22 if ever there was one.
What the Brexit debate showed, was a stunning lack of self confidence in the body politic that Britain, a self-governing territory for all of its history, was unable to once again manage and govern itself, without rule from the European Union.
British exceptionalism, or in the words of the Sex Pistols whether Britain ‘was just another country,’ became the only thing talked about for 5 years.
Eventually Brexit was muddled through, and Britain left the European Union. It left a political bloc with a failing currency, ageing population, and massive economic problems most highlighted in its pension crisis. A never ending immigration issues, crumbling infrastructure and the only continent on Earth in an economic decline in relative terms. Britain, having been part of the same bloc, is in many ways in a similar situation to the European Union, but rather than being tied to Europe’s destiny, Britain chose to go its own way.
Part 8: The Rebirth of Britannia?
So like most inventions, we look at the future of them and where they can go. The United Kingdom, in 2021 – post Brexit, is at a crossroads. Britain has left the European Union, a source of stability and prosperity from the dark days of stagflation of the 1970s to the financial crisis of 2008 where Europe looked to act more together, was gone. The government and associated institutions have gone down of ‘Global Britain.’ Some say it’s a move to Singapore-on-Thames, but to me, I think the best comparison is in British history itself. Brexit and Global Britain is a move to get Britain back to a period of 18th century, Georgian style trade and commerce. Make Britain Trade Again could be its motto. Rather than becoming a part of an internal market with the slowest growing region of the world; Britain will become and importer/exporter, with a prime location between the new and old world, coupled with the dominance of its language and culture; Britain wants to become an international trading hub.
A trading hub would lead to a desire to once again buy local products and make locally sourced products more viable. It could kick start a culture of making things to sell on. High labour costs may lead Britain, if all goes to plan, into needing a new technological boom, some are calling the Fourth Industrial Revolution, to stay internationally competitive. Britain will aim to start making things to sell, to compete on an international marketplace. This will raise wages, reduce living cost,s and improve life for all. This is the good side of the Brexit debate. The bad side of this, pushed by the EU’s fans, is that Britain could become an offshore hub, hated and shunned by the EU and the world and will see a return to 1950s style corporate autarky. The remainers haven’t got much right yet, so we’ll wait and see if that comes true.

Now, if you remember back to the start of the episode, we opened with a supposed quote from Napoleon on St. Helena about Britain being a nation of shopkeepers, which he stated he never meant as an insult. Well, making money in a market economy has long been the British way. More fulfilling than toiling as a peasant in farms, with a longer life expectancy than living in war state. Trade gives the ordinary person the possibility of wealth beyond that of merely agriculture or war. Free commerce and a return to a nation of shopkeepers could be the answer to life outside the European Union. Buying and selling leads to competition. Competition leads to innovations, and that leads to a demand to take risks.

Britain may or may not return to the standard of living it once had, relative to the rest of the world, but the opportunities are there. There are still huge mineral riches on the island; a workforce well integrated to the digital economy, and a country still obsessed with wealth and money. There is a natural diversity on the island, not just religiously and ethnically, but geographic. From the home counties, to the midlands, to the north of England, Wales; to the lowlands of Scotland to the Highlands and islands, then of course Northern Ireland; there is a potential for an incredibly diverse economy being powered into a new technological revolution.

Britain's location between the old world and the new gives it the opportunity to be a great trading nation with easy access to water, which is still the cheapest form of transport centuries after the canals of Britain were dug for precisely this reason. The English language and the Anglosphere culture dominates the world. In London, Britain has perhaps the worlds primary city as it's capital. In Oxford and Cambridge it has two of the best universities in the world; to say nothing of the excellence of other Universities comparative to the rest of the world.

Britain will never have a manufacturing sector like China's. British manufacturing will have to grow using less labour, but more technology and innovation. Britain will look to make high quality, unique and highly desired products. It will look to the brightest and most intelligent to immigrate and allow the free market to power Britain, truly, into the 21st century.

There is no reason Britain cannot boom, but many reasons; including government interference and poor policy why it could fail. In the end, only time will tell.

Part 9: Conclusion

This has been an episode purely focusing on the makeup of Britain itself. We've not touched on the Empire. Whatever your opinions of said empire and the industrial revolution that took hold in Britain, the impact of Union around the world has dwarfed that of even the Union of the 13 colonies in the New World.

We're not here to judge the good or badness of inventions, only to judge their importance. And it cannot be argued that the United Kingdom has perhaps been more successful and more important than another other political polity in human history.

Sparta and Athens had hugely important repercussions for Western Civilization. Rome had a huge influence over the South of Europe, the Med, and Asia Minor. The various Chinese polities over the millennia, had again, a huge influences over South-East Asia, but never really impacted the world. The Prussian led - German Empire, changed the course of the world over a period from 1914-1945, but it was never a long lasting legacy. The United States itself, has had huge importance over the course of the 20th century, but in many ways, was a continuation of British rule; not a drastic change in world order. The United Kingdom has led the world with its ideas of commerce and capitalism. That is what made Britannia rule the waves. Britain has never been an ethno-nationalist project – no matter how much the SNP want to make it one; nor has it been a regime focused on tyranny. The United Kingdom was and is a financial project and a financial arrangement.

The political unification off a small island, off the western coast of the Eurasian landmass should not have been world changing, but as we've seen throughout history; sometimes it is the outsider that changes history. The archipelago has never been satisfactorily unified. Ireland's role has changed with the centuries, and it may continue to do so. The North of Ireland may leave the UK and join a unified Irish Republic, though I would also say it's never impossible to rule out Ireland rejoining the Union – despite all the obstacles in its way. Ireland is a strong market economy inside

the European Union, but if the EU starts to fail Ireland and its standard of living drops compared to Britain, what might happen?
So whether the United Kingdom is still a relevant part of the world has been much talked about throughout my life time. And for all of my lifetime, it seems to be sliding down the pecking order. It lost an empire and never found itself in the world; yet the hope for the future is that Britain may return to what it has always excelled at being: a merchant capitalist democracy.

Chapter 1

Civilisation, as a foundationalist ontology[1], is fashioned by ideas, before it is constructed as social

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[1] Positivists believe that a social reality exists and that reality is knowable and you can study it. (Porta and Keating, 2012; 23) Positivists emphasise the "science" in social science, far more than the social constructivists who believe that reality is constructed. Positivists say that if gravity or natural selection can be considered a truth, then surely it is possible to be as certain about things that are socially constructed. Positivism however, is not a theory; it is an approach informs a researcher how to approach a chosen subject or topic. This short critical review will look at some of the main points and debates within positivism, explaining what it is and how it influences our study of the world.
Positivism has been the dominant mode of study in international relations in the last forty years. (Smith, 1996; 11) The importance of studying epistemological approaches is the theory of the approach 'underpins and informs international practice…Once established as common sense theories become incredibly powerful since they delineate not simply what can be known but also what it is sensible to talk about.' (Smith, 1996;13) Different approaches of study can result in different results and trying to gain an empirical view of the world.
The positivist position is firmly based upon a foundationalist ontology. (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 193) The world according to the positivist exists independently from our view of it. It is from this position that positivists try and gain knowledge about the world.
The difficulty for positivists is that empiricism is a lot harder to prove in the natural sciences. That Andy Burnham is prime minister is a fact (at the time of writing), and you would struggle to find anybody who would dispute this. Yet despite some truths being self-evident, the studying who is the prime minister does not occupy the minds of scholars. The world is far more complex and has more moving parts
What is the methodology used by positivists? Furlong and Marsh say that to the positivist, the natural sciences and social sciences are 'broadly analogous,' (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 194) they say that positivists can use hypotheses which can be tested by direct observation. Furlong and Marsh continue to say that it is positivists aim to 'establish causal relationships between social phenomena.' Positivists continue to say that one can separate empiricism from normative questions, "questions about what is," to questions about, "what should be." (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 194) Their ontological position is clear: they believe that social reality does exist.
Not only do positivists believed that the world quantifiable, but also that the world is fixed. (Parker, 2016; 44) This ontological position then informs their epistemology and their methodology of how they gain knowledge.
Positivist epistemology, Nicholson claims, makes 'generalisations about the social world… which are verifiable.' (Nicholson, 1996; 128) This is how positivists gain knowledge of the world via direct observations and trying to 'predict the consequences of actions carried out now or in the future.' (Nicholson, 1996; 132) Positivists identify a theory, and this must be testable by observation, via deduction or direct observation. When one calls themselves a positivist, it is not a view of the world, but how to investigate the world.
Despite their reputation for being cold scientists, positivists are idealists, they try to fit the complex world into data sets for it to be analysed is not an easy task. Some things may be easier to quantify

phenomena by institutions.

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than others, ‘red-haired people usually have blue eyes.’ (Nicholson, 1996; 135) But trying to answer the question in a scientific manner of what caused the French Revolution or the vote for Britain to leave the European Union causes a mountain of problems. These are complex and difficult and have been debated for a long time, and will continue to be debated. If a political historian in the positivist tradition tried to study the French Revolution they would be struck with a lack of hard data from the time. In the case of Brexit, there is plenty of data, but untangling it proves extremely difficult. Nicholson raises several other problems with quantifying, if you ask ‘what is the population of London,’ and ‘how many languages are spoken in London,’ you are faced with the quantification problem of what are the boundaries of London, and what is a language?’ (Nicholson, 1996; 137) The arbitrariness of entities in the social world is far more complex than in the natural sciences. There are two main criticisms of positivism (Furlong and Marsh, 2010); 195) First is the pragmatic position that Quine (1961) takes in his famous essay,’ Two Dogmas of Empiricism.’ He claimed that there was no easy way to separate the analytic-synthetic distinction. Analytic distinctions that are true by their meaning and synthetic statements are those ‘deemed true by convention,’ (Smith, 1996; 20) and the second criticism as Smith writes is that, ‘even the most simple acts of “pure” observation involve a web of belief which is both far removed and far more complex than the individual act of observation.’

Furlong and March say that while Quine’s observations might be true, some positivist social sciences ‘minimize these difference’ while others accept this trade off as part of their research. This leads towards a middle ground that could be called an ‘interpretivist epistemological position.’

The obfuscation between certain positivist and interpretivist approaches highlighted by writers such as David Sanders points at a new era in the positivist tradition. Sanders argues that a new movement called the ‘post-positivist’ has emerged from those who still see themselves as largely positivists but accept the interdependence of theory and observation. (Sanders, 2010; 40) Sanders accepts that interpretation and meaning is important. He states that ‘there are other areas - relating to the way in which individuals reflect, to a great or lesser degree, upon themselves - here behavioural electoral research has simply not dared to treat.’ (Sanders, 2010; 31) Positivism has ‘change in response to criticism.’ (Furlong and Marsh, 2010; 198)

Smith states that he believes positivism ‘cannot be resurrected.’ (Smith, 1996;38) However Smith credit positivism with an important effect on the nature of the study of international relations.The problem of how to gain empirical knowledge made its first steps with the positivist approach, but the search for a ‘valid theory in the Popperian sense,’ (Bernstein et al. 2000; 44) is still elusive. The political sciences have tried, but after 50 years of ‘developing analytical tools’ we are still nowhere nearer to gaining a grand theory on the scale of natural selection or Newtonian physics.

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For more than a year Britain had existed in a strange stillness. Streets had emptied, trains had fallen silent, offices had closed their doors, and ordinary life had been reduced to government announcements, supermarket queues, and conversations conducted through glowing screens. Every week seemed to promise an imminent return to normality, and every week normality retreated a little further into the distance.

As Britain hurried to forget the years of restrictions and recover the habits of ordinary life, Eliot became increasingly convinced that everybody had already forgotten the government overreach – which his new colleague – Dr. Alexander Thorne had already caused a stir about calling the Government 'satanic'.

Eliot wanted to know what came next.

He could not have known that the answer would arrive only a few weeks later, in the form of a single email waiting quietly in the inbox of a newly rented apartment in Sheffield.

By the spring of 2021, Britain had spent more than a year suspended between memory and expectation. The pandemic that had emerged from China had transformed daily life into something once thought impossible. Governments had responded with extraordinary restrictions, emergency powers, and sweeping lockdowns intended to slow the spread of the disease. To some, those measures had been necessary; to others, they had gone far beyond what events ultimately justified. Whatever one's view, the result was unmistakable: an entire society had been placed into an extended state of waiting.

People waited for restrictions to end. Businesses waited for customers to return. Students waited for lectures to resume. Families waited to embrace one another again without hesitation or apology, but nothing like that ever came. The country itself seemed to wait, uncertain whether it was preparing to return to the old world or stumbling into an entirely new one. When the reopening finally began, there was almost no universal desire in anything at all.

The conversations shifted from infection rates to the cost-of-living crisis, from emergency legislation to a country without any direction without diktat. Offices never reopened. Coffee shops closed. Friendship groups never reacquainted. The media moved on.

Yet history has always possessed an unfortunate habit. It leaves behind questions. Questions about economics. Questions about power. Questions about society. Questions about history. Questions about the institutions that governed modern civilisation and the assumptions upon which they rested. Most people were content not to ask them. Eliot Ashton was not most people.

While much of Britain counted the days until normality returned, Eliot had spent the lockdown immersed in books that were decades, sometimes centuries, old. His apartment had become less a place of residence than an accidental library. Economics lay beside philosophy. Political theory shared shelves with historical inventions. Ancient dialogues competed for space with papers on monetary policy and distributed computing.

The silence of lockdown had given him something increasingly rare in the twenty-first century. Time. Time to think. Time to write. Time to connect ideas that ordinary life seldom permitted anyone to connect. By the time the country reopened, he and Dr. Alexander Thorne, had completed a manuscript few believed anyone would read.

The Monetary Revolution. It was part philosophy. Part economics. Part technological manifesto. It argued that money was no longer merely an instrument of exchange but had become information itself; that digital scarcity would reshape institutions just as industrial machinery had reshaped the nineteenth century; and that sovereignty, finance, and technology were converging into something altogether new. It was far from a bestseller. Alexander had asked Eliot to release it as an underground podcast, to make it more difficult to pick up – an ode he claimed, to Adam Back's Proof-of-Work – with which Alexander Thorne had become most closely attached to. The podcast strategy worked. Almost nobody had heard the Monetary Revolution. It was too philosophical for economists, too economic for philosophers, too technological for political theorists, and too political for technologists. It belonged nowhere, which was perhaps why it quietly began to belong everyone who read it – decided the ultimate rebellion in life is to prioritise your own well being, by learning all there is to know about the marvellous invention of bitcoin – and moreover, as Eliot learned – to make as much money as possible, which, to those who listened was, as Eliot pointed out, it's original intention. It was picked up – heard by families trying to save for the future in bitcoin, the theory of money had gone high - discussed in shadowy circles by a few who listened to Eliot's voice making the case for everybody to have as much money as they can get.

And yet, in the writing of the Monetary Revolution, the two of them had made large amount of money from the side projects – with the help of Alexander Thorne's capital and business acumen and Eliot's knowledge of economics – picked up a little here and little there over the years - had driven through large sales of this and that during the lockdown.

Eliot Ashton's new apartment occupied the fourth floor of a red-brick building overlooking one of Sheffield's older streets, where Victorian warehouses stood beside cafés that many imagined were to be that of programmers, graduate students, and people who carried expensive cameras without ever appearing to take photographs. Yet the country was now in an unspoken recession which had gone unnoticed by all other than the most eagle eyed.

There were now afternoons when Eliot Ashton found himself staring at the cursor on his laptop, waiting for it to become an idea. Visiting the occasional coffee shop.

His desk was cluttered with open books, half-written out papers, coffee cups that should have been washed hours ago, and a copy of *The Monetary Revolution*. He had opened the laptop intending to write another essay, only to discover that he had nothing new to say.

He checked his emails. Nothing. He refreshed the news. Nothing worth reading. He closed the browser and leaned back in his chair. Post. He would check the post.

Opening the apartment door, he wound himself down the stairs and a single cream envelope resting neatly in the pigeon hole.

No stamp. No return address. Just one line written in careful black ink. **Mr Eliot Ashton**

Dear Eliot,

I know you're the author of *The Monetary Revolution.* You never put your name to it, but your voice gave you away. The North is a very small place. I thought you'd like to know that people are reading it.

I have a friend who might be interested in meeting you.

Keep writing.

— Luna

Chapter 4

Humanity had always lived between the tension between freedom and constraint; authoritarianism and anarchy. For Eliot Ashton it was high liberalism that sought to escape that pendulum, not through compromise, but with a new and higher alignment – the harmony of sovereignty and tradition, innovation and technology. High Liberalism was a philosophy for the age of digital acceleration, a philosophy of new horizons, a philosophy for the epistemic advance that hard work can gain. It was age in which the neo-liberal order faltered; where individual began to rise, not by tearing down those around them, but by building on the better angles of human society.

High liberalism to Ashton was a call to excellence, a declaration that human greatness was the very essence of progress. Today, in a pub in Sheffield, a call was about to find its voice. It was in the evening, as gathering in pubs tends to be, where the Rutland Arms had turned into a buzzing space. Sticky tables bore the weight of nearly full pints and already gathering arguments, while the air hummed with expectation. In the middle of it all sat Eliot, a man who belonged to both Sheffield and the future.

Eliot was leaning back in his chair, his arm draped over the back like a man who could solve the problems of the universe for fun. Around him, a half-circle of admirers and challengers clung to his words, as though they themselves were a scarce resource.

The room hummed as Eliot's table and those around him started to get a little nosier. The noise had settled into a focused silence, broken only by the occasional clink of glassware. Eliot sat at the centre, one leg crossed over the other, a pint balanced on the edge of the table. Around him, the crowd leaned in—students, thinkers, a journalist with a notebook, and a sceptical engineer who looked like he'd been dragged there against his will.

"Here's the thing about tradition," Eliot said, his voice cutting through the noise like a blade. "It's not a prison. It's scaffolding. We don't worship tradition for its own sake, and we don't tear it down because we're bored. We use it. We build on it. That's what progress is—a conversation between the old and the new, not a shouting match about what little should remain." He tapped the edge of his glass for emphasis, the sound drawing the attention of nearby tables.

The group leaned in closer, their glasses forgotten. "Alright, Eliot," said the young journalist scribbling furiously in the corner. "But what about power? What about people who'll never let go of the reins?"

Eliot's expression sharpened, his grin shifting into something darker, more deliberate. "Ah, yes. Power." He set his glass down with a soft clink. "That's the real question, for philosophers, isn't it?

Not how you get it, or who holds it, but how we take it back. Should we remove ourselves from state control if we don't like it? If we don't require the state or its 'help'" he said, making quotation marks with his fingers, "then they don't truly have power over us. Influence?… perhaps, but power, no. Power needs official control over somebody else."

A young woman with a streak of blue in her hair, a philosophy student named Lucy, broke the silence. "Alright, Eliot. Everyone here's heard the buzzword you keep spouting—hypermodernism, high liberalism. But what does it actually mean? Is it just another way of sounding impressive? Is it all to get everything moving quicker?"

Eliot smiled, not dismissively but like a teacher coaxing a good answer out of a student.
"It's not about speed," he said. "It's about what speed does. Hypermodernism is the condition of living in a world where change isn't the exception; it's the rule. We're not just reacting to the future anymore. We're building it—and fast. The question isn't whether this is good or bad. The question is how we navigate it."

He leaned forward, his voice softening. "Modernism told us to tear down the old and make a new. Postmodernism told us to laugh at the ruins. Hypermodernism says: we can build something new—and make it better from what came before. To put things together, to realise that everything has been torn down, that it could be rebuilt. At least in my conception of it, we can build upon the best of the old, the forms can be similar, a grand theatre can be a grand theatre, we don't need to remake the very conception of the play, but we can build on what makes it great, an improve on it, and make it a new without changing its very form."

The engineer, a wiry man named Daniel, crossed his arms. "Sounds like some form of libertarianism dressed up with some shiny new jargon. All this talk about building and freedom—what's the difference between you and what's come before?"

Eliot raised an eyebrow, his grin widening. "The difference, Dan, is that libertarianism is about tearing the state out by its roots and leaving the garden to grow wild and free. I am about pruning. The state has its place, but only as a framework. It's there to protect freedom, not to stifle it. High liberalism is a scaffolding we use to build higher and stronger, not the cage we lock ourselves in."

He gestured toward the room. "Think of Bitcoin. It's not just a currency—it's a system, a promise. It's what happens when technology empowers individuals instead of institutions. Hypermodernism is about taking that ethos and applying it to everything: politics, culture, community."

The journalist, barely out of his twenties, leaned forward, pen hovering over his notebook. "Alright, but what about people? This all sounds great in theory—decentralisation, sovereignty, progress. But aren't we just making everyone lonelier? Technology's supposed to connect us, but it's driving us apart. Where does meaning come into this?"

Eliot nodded, his face serious now. "That's the heart of it, isn't it?" He set his pint down, leaning both elbows on the table. "The internet isn't the problem. It's how we've been using it—like a spotlight instead of a mirror. Hypermodernism is about turning it into a tool of liberation, not alienation. Meaning doesn't come from algorithms or likes. It comes from building—relationships, communities, ideas. High liberalism gives us the political framework. Hypermodernism gives us the cultural tools. Together, they let us create meaning for ourselves instead of waiting for someone else to hand it to us."

Lucy tilted her head, a frown creasing her brow. "So you're saying it's all about the individual? That does sound... lonely."

Eliot shook his head. “Not lonely. Sovereign. There’s a difference. Sovereignty isn’t isolation; it’s responsibility. It’s the ability to choose, to create, to contribute. Hypermodernism doesn’t reject society—it redefines it. We don’t need hierarchies that stifle us or collectivism that crushes individuality. We need communities of choice, bound by shared values and voluntary cooperation.”

He gestured to the group around him. “Take this pub. None of you were forced to be here. You came because you’re curious, because you want to understand, because you want to better yourself. That’s what society should be—something we build together, not something imposed on us.”

Lucy smirked, raising his glass. “Alright, but how does all this play out in the real world? What’s your utopia look like—robots and Bitcoin ATMs everywhere?”

Laughter rippled through the group, but Eliot only chuckled. “Not robots, Lucy. People. Real people, living sovereign lives. Trading, creating, building—not because someone told them to, but because they chose to.” He raised his glass in return, his voice dropping to a conspiratorial murmur. “And yes, maybe a Bitcoin ATM in every pub.”

The table laughed, but as the moment settled, Eliot caught sight of a figure lingering at the edge of the crowd. A man in a tailored suit, out of place in the noisy pub, was watching him intently. Their eyes met, and the man nodded, stepping forward.

“Eliot Ashton,” he said, his voice cutting through the din. “Your ideas are getting attention. We need to talk.”

The man cleared his throat. “Mr Ashton, let me get straight to the point. I’m Alex Reid, a features editor at The Internationalist. Your name’s been coming up in some interesting circles. High liberalism, hypermodernism—whatever you want to call it—it’s gaining traction online. We’d like to run a feature on you, your ideas, your... movement.”

“Ahh,” said Eliot, smiling. “I thought I was in trouble there for a moment, or I was faced down with a serious intellectual challenge. Let’s talk outside.”

The beer garden was a stark contrast to the buzzing pub interior—quieter, lit by the faint orange glow of streetlights and the distant murmur of the city. Eliot leaned against the wooden railing, his long fingers deftly rolling a cigarette. The man in the tailored suit stood opposite him, shifting slightly as though unused to the casual setting.

Eliot looked up, cigarette half-rolled, and chuckled. “So you say I’m starting a movement? Alex, I’m just a bloke in a pub talking nonsense.”

Reid didn’t laugh. “Blokes in pubs don’t get quoted by MPs. They don’t inspire think pieces in The Guardian. Your ideas are cutting through. People are listening.”

Eliot licked the edge of the cigarette paper, sealing it with a slow, deliberate motion. He lit it and took a drag, letting the smoke curl lazily into the night air before replying. “Look, Alex, I’m flattered—really—but I’m not looking to be anyone’s poster boy for a revolution. I’m just happy having a pint, arguing with friends, and maybe, just maybe, making someone think a little differently about the world.”

Reid pressed on. “But think of the reach. The influence. You could shape the conversation on a national—global—level. Isn’t that what you want?”

Eliot tapped ash from his cigarette, a small smile tugging at the corner of his lips. “What I want,” he said slowly, “is to finish my drink and enjoy a quiet night with these fine people inside. But if you’re that desperate for a quote, stick around. There’s another journalist in there from The Sheffield Star. Take a seat, listen, take notes. The more the merrier.”

Reid hesitated, then nodded. “I’ll do that.”

Eliot pushed off the railing, tossing the cigarette stub into a nearby bin. “Good man. Now, let’s not keep the masses waiting.”

As Eliot returned to the table, the atmosphere had shifted. A few more people had drifted in—students, locals, a couple of sharp-looking men who might have been academics. They hovered near the edges, their faces lit with quiet anticipation.

Eliot settled into his chair, his easy grin returning as he scanned the table. “Right then, where were we? Ah, yes—Sam was accusing me of wanting robots to run the world. Anyone care to defend me?”

Laughter rippled through the group, and a young woman—one of the new arrivals—spoke up. “I’ve got a question,” she said, leaning forward. “You talk about hypermodernism as this balance between tradition and progress. But isn’t that just an excuse to avoid picking a side? I mean, what do you actually stand for?”

Eliot’s eyes gleamed, the challenge igniting something in him. “Balance isn’t avoidance. It’s mastery,” he replied. “Think of it like walking a tightrope. You lean too far one way, you fall. Too far the other, same result. High liberalism—hypermodernism—it’s not about picking sides. It’s about finding the line that lets us move forward without toppling over. Freedom and responsibility. Tradition and innovation. They’re not enemies. They’re partners.”

Another voice chimed in, this time from one of the older attendees. “And how does Bitcoin fit into all this? I keep hearing you bang on about it, but isn’t it just another tech fad?”

Eliot chuckled, running a hand through his hair. “Bitcoin’s not a fad. It’s a foundation. It’s proof that we can build systems that don’t rely on centralised power. Money without banks. Contracts without courts. Sovereignty without kings. If that’s a fad, it’s one I’m happy to ride.”

The crowd was growing now, people squeezing into chairs or standing at the edges of the group. Conversations overlapped, questions fired in quick succession:

Eliot fielded them all, his tone shifting effortlessly from playful to serious, from teacher to provocateur. He didn’t dodge the hard questions, but he didn’t answer them directly either. Instead, he reframed them, turning doubts into provocations, pushing his listeners to think beyond their assumptions.

At one point, the journalist from The Sheffield Star leaned over to Alex Reid, whispering, “Is he always like this?”

Eliot leaned back in his chair, letting the questions ripple around him like waves. He had a way of letting silences settle just long enough to turn a room’s noise into focus. When he finally spoke, it was quieter, more deliberate, drawing everyone closer.

“Sheffield,” he began, tracing the rim of his pint glass with his finger, “is the perfect place for a revolution.”

A murmur ran through the group, a mix of intrigue and disbelief. Lucy tilted her head, her voice sceptical but curious. “Sheffield? You mean the city that peaked with steel and hasn’t quite figured out what to do since?”

Eliot smiled, but there was steel in his tone. “Exactly. Sheffield knows what it’s like to be great—and to lose that greatness. It’s a city that’s been left behind, not because it’s incapable, but because the structures it relied on were too rigid to evolve. And that,” he said, pointing a finger in the air, “is where we start. Not from top-down plans or some grand council of technocrats. Change doesn’t come from command and control—it comes from people taking their lives back, right here, right now.”

He leaned forward, his voice low but carrying. “The revolution starts in your own head. You stop waiting for permission to live, for someone to tell you what you’re allowed to think or build or dream. You stop relying on systems that don’t care about you. High liberalism isn’t about smashing the state. It’s about outgrowing it. It’s about creating spaces—communities—where people thrive because they want to, not because they’re forced to.”

A young man who had been hovering near the edge of the group spoke up. He was wiry, with a sharp face and the kind of intensity that made people nervous. “And how do we do that? What does this revolution actually look like?”

Eliot tapped his temple. “It looks like this. First, you take back your mind. You stop thinking like a subject and start thinking like a sovereign. Then, you act. You support local businesses, you use technologies like Bitcoin to bypass gatekeepers, you build communities that rely on trust instead of rules. You don’t need permission to live the life you want. You just need to start.”

As Eliot spoke, a voice from the back chimed in, cutting through the intensity with an easy drawl. “Bloody hell, Eliot, you sound like a sage again. You’re going to scare off the newcomers.”

Laughter rippled through the group as a tall, broad-shouldered man stepped forward, a pint in hand and a mischievous grin on his face. “Everyone, meet Paul,” Eliot said, shaking his head but smiling. “He’s here to keep me grounded.”

Paul gave a mock bow. “And you’re welcome, by the way.”

Next to him, a woman with a sharp bob and an air of quiet authority rolled her eyes. “Don’t listen to him. Paul loves the sound of his own voice almost as much as Eliot does.”

“And that,” Eliot said, gesturing to her, “is Sophie. The actual brains of this operation.”

Sophie smirked. “I wouldn’t go that far. But someone has to remind you that revolutions need art not just rhetoric.”

As the conversation continued, more voices joined in. A student with a nose ring argued passionately about how Sheffield’s abandoned factories could become hubs for innovation. A middle-aged woman shared her experiences running a community garden, tying Eliot’s ideas to something tangible.

Even Alex Reid, the journalist, found himself nodding along. He scribbled something in his notebook, muttering to himself, “This isn’t philosophy, it’s a bloody drinking session.”

Eliot smiled at the growing momentum, but his tone stayed measured. “Look,” he said, “this isn’t about me. It’s not about one person or one philosophy. It’s about what we can do together, starting right here in Sheffield. You don’t need to tear the system down. You just need to stop letting it tell you what’s possible.”

Paul clapped him on the back. “Not bad, mate. Reckon you’ve convinced half the room.”

Eliot smiled, his eyes catching Reid’s. “Half’s a good start.”

“So, Eliot,” Alex began, his tone casual but curious, “you’ve talked about Sheffield, philosophy, liberalism... but what about you? What’s your life like, outside of all this?”

Eliot exhaled a plume of smoke, leaning back against the railing. He smiled, not the self-assured grin he wore when discussing ideas, but something softer, almost self-effacing.

“What’s my life like?” he echoed, as if the question amused him. He glanced at the cigarette in his hand, turning it over as he thought. “Simple, really. I live in a flat in Crookes. It’s nothing fancy—just a place to keep my books and my tea kettle. I spend most of my time reading, writing, or walking the Peaks when I can. A bit of cycling when the weather isn’t miserable.”

He took another drag, his gaze drifting. “Ambitions? I’m not trying to be a saviour, if that’s what you’re asking. I’d like to finish the book I’m working on—*Hypermodernity and Sovereignty*. Maybe teach again, though I’m not sure academia would have me back.” He grinned, shaking his head. “Turns out universities don’t appreciate lecturers who tell students to question the whole system.”

Paul leaned in, his grin wide. “What Eliot’s not telling you is that he’s also Sheffield’s worst five-a-side goalkeeper. You’d think someone so tall would block a ball once in a while.

Eliot grinned. “That being said, I hit the gym 5 times a week, mostly callisthenics and gymnastics”

Sophie smirked, sipping her wine. “Eliot Ashton, philosopher, Austrian Economist, and athlete. It’s quite the résumé.”

Eliot waved their teasing away, turning back to Alex. “Look, I’m not that complicated. I like a good pint, a good argument, and the occasional bad decision on a Friday night. Actually scrub that, I like many bad decisions on a Friday night.”

The whole room was looking over at Eliot and Alex. “Philosophy’s not about sitting in a tower somewhere—it’s about living. What’s the point of all these ideas if they don’t make your life a little richer? This is where it happens. Here, in places like this. Not in some ivory tower or a boardroom. Ideas are alive when they’re shared. That’s what I do—share them. And then I let people decide what to do with them.”

Alex tapped his pen against his notebook. “And what about the bigger picture? You’ve got people quoting you, journalists like me writing about you. Where do you see this all going?”

Eliot’s smile faded slightly, and he stubbed out his cigarette. “Honestly? I don’t know. I didn’t start this to lead a movement or change the world. I started it because I couldn’t not. If people take something from it, great. If they don’t, well, I’ve still had some damn good conversations along the way.”

He paused, glancing at the growing crowd inside. “But if I had to guess... maybe this is how change starts. Not with speeches or manifestos, but with a few people deciding they’ve had enough of being told what’s possible.”

“Here’s the thing about Sheffield,” he began, his voice steady but charged with conviction. “This city doesn’t need to wait for someone else to fix it. It’s got everything it needs to reinvent itself—right now, we could do with some business and trade to start with. Economics isn’t just about looking at who has money, it’s about creating a culture of trust, a new way of living that isn’t dictated by boardrooms or bureaucrats.”

Paul, ever the sceptic, raised an eyebrow. “You’re talking about doing Bitcoin again, aren’t you?”

Eliot grinned. “Bitcoin’s a part of it, yeah. But it’s not the whole picture. Circular trade means we stop waiting for permission to make things happen. It’s about people dealing directly with people—sharing skills, goods, ideas. Imagine a Sheffield where the old factories are filled not with rust but with innovation. Makerspaces, artists, coders, brewers—hell, even bakers—trading with each other in ways that don’t rely on banks or big corporations. A network that’s local, resilient, and ours.”

Paul tilted his head, intrigued. “And how’s that different from what’s already happening? Sheffield’s got its indie shops, its markets.”

“It’s about scale,” Eliot replied. “Indie shops are great, but they’re still playing by someone else’s rules—tax codes, rent hikes, supply chains they don’t control. Circual trade changes the game. It’s about creating an economy that’s not just local, but self-sustaining. It’s about people building their own systems, their own rules. Sheffield doesn’t have to wait for Westminster to notice it exists. It can show the rest of the country how it’s done.”

Sophie leaned in, her brow furrowed. “But why Sheffield? Why not Manchester or Leeds? What makes this city special?”

Eliot gestured around the room, as if the pub itself were proof of his argument.

“Sheffield knows how to make things. It’s in the bones of the city. Steel might not be the future, but the spirit behind it is—the craftsmanship, the pride in building something that lasts. That’s the culture we need to bring back, but on our own terms. Whether other cities follow is their problem. Sheffield can do this in its own way, for its own people. And if it works, it’ll inspire others. The first always does.”

The journalist from The Sheffield Star spoke up, her notepad balanced on her knee. “Alright, but let’s talk practicality. How does this circular economy thing actually work? Are we trading bread for Bitcoin?”

Eliot laughed, shaking his head. “Not quite. It’s about creating systems where people can trade value without friction. Maybe that’s using Bitcoin or having local loan issuers and ICO’s. It’s flexible—built by the people who use it. And it’s not just about money. It’s about culture. When people trade directly, they build relationships. They create a sense of community that top-down systems can’t replicate.”

He paused, scanning the group, his voice softening.

“Think about it. Every transaction becomes a story. You’re not just buying bread; you’re supporting the baker down the street who tells you where the grain came from, from the peaks or Derbyshire. You’re not just buying bread; you’re working with someone who cares about your vision. That’s culture. That’s what remakes society—not policies or slogans, but people connecting, building, and thriving together.”

The table buzzed with murmurs of agreement, scepticism, and curiosity. A man in a beanie chimed in from the back. “Sounds like a pipe dream. People aren’t going to ditch convenience for some idealistic experiment.”

Eliot met his gaze, unflinching. “Maybe not. Not all at once. But revolutions don’t happen overnight—they start small. A conversation here, a market there. It’s not about tearing everything down tomorrow. It’s about planting seeds that grow into something bigger. Sheffield’s the perfect place for that.”

The energy at the table shifted again, the laughter fading as Eliot leaned forward, his eyes bright with conviction. He gestured with his pint, using it as a prop to punctuate his thoughts.

“Culture,” he said, “isn’t something handed down from above. It doesn’t trickle out of London offices or get stamped with the approval of the BBC. Real culture—thriving culture—comes from here, from people who stop waiting for permission to create.”

He tapped the table for emphasis. “Take music. Sheffield’s always been a cultural city. It’s just what we do here, from Jarvis Cocker to Arctic Monkeys. But why should a local band wait for some label in London to ‘discover’ them? Why should artists have to fight for scraps when they could be building something right here—a scene that’s not just surviving but thriving?”

Sophie nodded, her voice sharp and clear. “That’s already happening, though, isn’t it? You’ve got DIY raves popping up in warehouses, DJs selling out local venues. They’re not waiting for a middleman—they’re doing it themselves.”

“Exactly,” Eliot said, pointing to her. “And that’s the blueprint. Those DIY raves aren’t just parties—they’re acts of independance. Every time someone sets up decks in an abandoned factory or fills a back room with local bands, they’re proving we don’t need permission to thrive. We don’t need London to tell us what’s good or what’s possible.”

Paul grinned. “What about the BBC? You should get on there.”

Eliot smirked, shaking his head. “Give me a break. Nobody has watched the BBC in years. The BBC has no right to tell people what good taste is. If anything, it’s a bottleneck. Sheffield doesn’t need a committee deciding what gets airtime. It needs venues, it needs collaboration, and it needs people who care about the art more than the algorithm.”

Lucy raised her hand, her scepticism tempered but still present. “Okay, but how does that tie into everything else you’ve been saying? Circular trade, Bitcoin—it’s all pretty abstract. How does a DIY culture fit into your whole individualism or sovereignty idea?”

Eliot’s grin widened. He loved a good question. “It’s all connected. Culture is sovereignty. When a band presses their own vinyl on a local manufacturer's 3D printer and sells it at gigs, that’s sovereignty. When a rave collective sets up ticket sales through lightning to avoid platforms that take a cut, that’s independence. Every time a local community creates something for itself instead of begging for scraps from London or Los Angeles capital markets or wherever, it's practising individualism. And the best part? It's contagious. Culture isn't static—it spreads. A thriving music scene here makes Sheffield a hub, not a satellite."

The man in the beanie spoke again, his tone still sceptical. "That sounds great, but it's just localism, isn't it? A bit small-minded, maybe?"

Eliot shook his head. "It's not small-minded—it's smart. Localism doesn't mean isolation. It means strength. When local business's thrive, they don't have to sacrifice themselves for some Keynesian grand plan. They don't need to keep the whole economy afloat by draining their own resources. Sheffield doesn't need to play saviour for the national economy. It can thrive on its own terms—and inspire others to do the same."

He leaned back, gesturing to the crowd. "And if that's small-minded, then maybe it's time we rethink what 'big' really means."

As Eliot spoke, the crowd in the pub seemed to swell. People drifted closer, the buzz of conversation rising and falling in waves. Someone from the bar shouted, "Oi, Eliot! What about football? Is Sheffield United part of your revolution?"

The room erupted in laughter, and Eliot raised his pint in salute. "Absolutely. As long as they start paying their players in Bitcoin."

The laughter died down, but the energy lingered, electric and alive. Eliot glanced at Alex Reid, who was scribbling furiously in his notebook, and then back at Sophie and Paul.

"Sheffield doesn't need permission to succeed," he said, his voice quieter but no less firm. "It doesn't need London's approval or anyone else's. It just needs people who are willing to take their lives back, piece by piece. The question isn't whether it's possible. The question is whether we're ready to stop waiting and start building."

The table fell silent, the weight of his words hanging in the air. For a moment, the pub seemed smaller, tighter, as though the world outside had ceased to exist.

Paul clapped Eliot on the back. "Well, if that's the plan, you'd better buy us all another round first."

Eliot laughed, standing to head to the bar. "The revolution will be fuelled by lager, apparently. Keep the ideas coming—I'll be back."

The scene as Eliot waves through the crowd, his presence sowing the seeds of something bigger beginning to take root. Sophie leaned in, her tone quieter now, almost conspiratorial. "You know this isn't just talk anymore, right? People are listening. It's not just us at this table—it's spreading."

Eliot set down the drinks, giving her a sideways glance. "What's spreading?"

"Your ideas," she said, gesturing subtly toward the room. "Look around. Half the people in here came because they heard you'd be here. They're not here for the beer, Eliot—they're here for you."

Eliot paused, his gaze sweeping the pub. She was right. Conversations lingered on his words, faces he didn't recognise turned toward him, watching, waiting. He could feel it now—the weight of something larger than himself.

Before he could reply, a man in a leather jacket approached the table. He was scruffy, unshaven, and carried a nervous energy. He held out a folded piece of paper.

“This is for you,” the man said, his voice low, almost hurried.

Eliot took the note, his brow furrowing. “What’s this?”

“Something you’ll want to read,” the man replied, glancing nervously around the room before slipping out the door.

Paul raised an eyebrow. “That was dramatic.”

Eliot unfolded the paper, it was from Samuel Ashcombe. He read the print out, signed with the Ashcombe Family PGP key. Eliot's face moved slightly.

“What does it say?” Sophie asked.

Eliot read it aloud. “They’re listening: the State. Become who you are. S.A. ”

The table fell silent, the words hanging heavy in the air. In the background, the pub’s hum seemed to grow louder, as though the room itself was alive with whispers of change. More people were arriving now, filling the small space with a charged atmosphere.

“Who is it?” Paul asked.

“It’s Pindar.” he said

Chapter 2:

Eliot sat cross-legged on his sofa, his laptop balanced precariously on a stack of books with The Internationalist open on the screen, a bold headline staring back at him. He took a deep breath, taking a sip of tea as Paul walked in, carrying plates with a steak on it.

Paul flopped onto the armchair, handing Eliot a sandwich. “Right then, Philosopher, let’s hear it. Read it out loud.”

Eliot groaned. “Don’t call me that.”

Paul smirked. “Come on. You know you love it.”

Eliot rolled his eyes but obliged, scrolling back to the start of the article.

The Internationalist
Dicey: Hypermodernism - The Philosopher Lighting Up Sheffield

In a modest pub in the heart of Sheffield, a quiet revolution is brewing. Its leader isn’t a politician or a business tycoon but a 30-something philosopher with a pint in one hand and a cigarette in the other. Meet Eliot Ashton, the man behind the philosophy of hypermodernism and High Liberalism, a movement that’s redefining culture, economy, and community from the ground up.

Ashton’s philosophy—what he calls high liberalism—combines the progressive energy of liberalism with the grounded pragmatism and call to excellence of High Toryism. It’s an unusual synthesis:

liberalism provides the framework for individual sovereignty and economic freedom, while High Toryism anchors those freedoms in responsibility, tradition, and excellence. Together, they offer a vision of society that prioritises small, agile governance and decentralised, community-driven solutions.

Ashton's ideas are deceptively simple. He argues that modern society has outgrown its systems of control—that individuals and communities can thrive without relying on the slow-moving bureaucracies of government and corporate overlords. At the heart of his philosophy is the concept of "sovereignty": the idea that true freedom comes from taking control of your own life and connecting with others on your own terms.

In the past year, Sheffield has become an unlikely petri dish for a new kind of political and economic thought—one that challenges not just Westminster orthodoxy but the foundations of the modern state itself.

"High liberalism," Ashton says, "isn't about smashing the state. It's about outgrowing it."

Sheffield, once defined by its industrial past, is emerging as the testing ground for Ashton's ideas. Peer-to-peer trade networks are popping up across the city, powered by technologies like Bitcoin and driven by a DIY ethos. From local markets to underground music scenes, the city is reimagining what it means to live, work, and create outside the shadow of centralised systems.

Ashton, a former academic himself, is a paradox—both charismatic and self-effacing, deeply intellectual yet approachable. He resists labels like "leader" or "guru," insisting he's just a thinker sharing ideas over a pint. But those ideas are catching fire, inspiring a new generation of Sheffielders to take their lives into their own hands.

"The public sector," Ashton says, "has become bloated, a lumbering giant that stifles creativity and autonomy. What we need isn't bigger government—it's better people. Sovereign individuals who take responsibility for themselves and their communities. That's how we thrive—not through mandates from above, but through choice and collaboration from below."

This message is finding traction not only among Sheffield's grassroots movements but also in the halls of power. Several MPs, particularly on the Conservative backbenches, have begun citing Ashton's ideas in speeches, arguing for a reduction in public sector size and a shift toward private-sector innovation. Some have even adopted his language, referring to the state as "scaffolding" rather than "structure."

At the core of Ashton's vision is Hypermodernism—not just as a mode of living but as a metaphor for a new way of organising society. Hypermodernism, he argues, embodies the principles of technology, decentralisation, and sovereignty that are key to a better pace of life.

For the past four years, Ashton has worked tirelessly to spread these ideas across Sheffield. He's hosted Bitcoin workshops in community centres, given talks in pubs, and even helped local businesses set up wallets to accept bitcoin. Today, the fruits of that labour are evident.

The question now is whether hypermodernism and high liberalism can extend beyond Sheffield. Ashton himself is cautious, insisting that the movement must remain rooted in local communities rather than becoming a top-down initiative.

Perhaps the most visible example of this cultural shift is Sheffield's rave scene, which has taken on a distinctly cypherpunk flavour. DIY raves are nothing new to the city, but recent years have seen an evolution. Events are no longer merely acts of defiance; they are experiments in decentralisation.

"It's pure," one DJ said, setting up turntables in a disused steel mill. "No one's trying to make a fortune. It's about the music, the people, and the freedom to do it our way."

"Sheffield doesn't need the BBC or The Guardian to tell us what's good," says a podcast host who interviews local musicians and artists. "We're creating our own culture, on our own terms."

For Ashton, this is precisely the point. "Culture is sovereignty," he says. "When a city like Sheffield stops waiting for approval and starts creating for itself, it doesn't just survive—it thrives. And it shows the rest of the world that you don't need centralised systems to build something extraordinary."

"We're not just making art," one painter said at a co-op gallery. "We're building a culture where artists don't need to beg for scraps. We own this."

The synergy between Sheffield's music scene and the cypherpunk ethos was almost inevitable. Both shared a DIY ethic, a belief in pushing boundaries and creating outside the rules.

The fusion of cypherpunk ideals with Sheffield's DIY culture is not without its challenges. Local authorities have begun to notice the growing prevalence of unlicensed events and economic transactions taking place over the bitcoin network. Some worry that the city's embrace of decentralisation could lead to further fragmentation.

"Every city has its own rhythm," he says. "Sheffield's revolution won't look like Manchester's or London's. It's not about one-size-fits-all solutions. It's about sovereignty—starting where you are, with what you have, and building from there." Whether hypermodernism will reshape the political and economic landscape remains to be seen. But in Sheffield, at least, the fire has been lit—and it's spreading fast.

Eliot closed the laptop and leaned back, staring at the ceiling. The article captured the spirit of what he'd been building, but seeing it written down—seeing MPs quoted, Bitcoin markets described as a "revolution"—made it feel almost surreal.

Paul nudged him with his foot. "You alright, mate? You look like you've just been knighted."

Eliot smirked. "Just trying to decide if this is a good thing or a terrible mistake."

Paul tapped the article with a grin. "This is big. International press, posh magazine, fancy words. I mean it's The Internationalist! You're officially Sheffield's philosopher-in-chief."

Eliot smirked. "Don't get carried away. It's just one article."

Paul snorted. "You call this 'just one article'? They're calling you the bloke who's lighting up Sheffield. I mean, it's not like they're wrong, but still."

Eliot leaned back, staring at the ceiling. "It's surreal, isn't it? I spent years talking to anyone who'd listen—pub regulars, students, people I used to work with, the managers you know, trying to get them to pay me in Bitcoin, the odd journalist who would meet me. Now I'm in The Internationalist. People are actually quoting me, Paul. Quoting me."

Paul laughed. “You sound surprised. You’ve been banging on about sovereignty and circular economies for ages. Turns out people actually care.”

“All that hard work, all those years of work and effort,” he said, “all those people I talked to, who weren’t interested, all those times girls on dates got the glazed eyes when I talked about this stuff. And look at me now.”

“You are in the process of becoming.”

Eliot stood, pacing the room as thoughts tumbled into place. “I’ll print out copies of the article. Hand them out at the rave. Get people talking, spreading it around. It’s not about me—it’s about the ideas.”

Eliot’s phone buzzed, cutting through the moment. He picked it up, glancing at the screen.

Lucy: “Read the article. Mad respect, Eliot. You’re blowing up.”
Sophie: “You’ve gone national! Pint on me later.”
Unknown Number: “This is Joe from the HeeleyKollective. The article was fire. Let’s meet soon—big project brewing.”

The messages kept coming, a steady stream of congratulations, questions, and invitations. Each one felt like another thread tying him closer to the city’s growing network of people inspired by his ideas.

Then a new message popped up from a familiar number.

DJ Vince: “Plot 22 today, for you mate. Massive rave. All the best people will be there. You down?”

Eliot grinned, showing Paul the message. “Looks like there’s a rave at Plot 22. Vince says it’s going to be big.”

Paul raised an eyebrow. “You going?”

“Of course,” Eliot said.

Paul leaned back, watching him with a smirk. “You’re really leaning into this whole philosopher-of-the-people thing, aren’t you?”

Eliot paused, glancing at his reflection in the window. “I mean... why not? People are listening. Sheffield’s waking up. And if I’m the one holding the mic, I’m going to make sure it’s worth their time.” He hesitated, a flicker of something deeper crossing his face. “You think I’m getting ahead of myself, don’t you?”

Paul shrugged. “Maybe. But then again, who else in this city is getting random texts about underground raves and think pieces? Face it, mate—you’re the top guy in Sheffield right now.”

Eliot chuckled, but the thought lingered as he sat back down, staring at the article on the table. Am I? he thought. Am I really Sheffield’s top guy now?

He shook his head, the moment of self-reflection quickly replaced by a sharper resolve. “Right, I’m going to get those articles printed out to hand out. Plot’s going to be something else tonight.”

Paul grinned. “If you’re handing out articles, you’d better dress the part. Can’t have Sheffield’s philosopher showing up in his usual scruffy jacket.”

Eliot laughed, the tension breaking. “Sovereignty doesn’t care about dress codes, Paul. But fine—I’ll at least wear something better than my grey joggers, though we all know how much the girls love them grey joggers.” Eliot stood in front of the mirror, straightening a dark T-shirt. Paul lounged on the bed behind him, scrolling through his phone with a mix of amusement and boredom.

“You sure you don’t want to go full philosopher chic?” Paul teased. “Tweed jacket, pocket square, maybe a cravat for good measure?”

Eliot smirked, adjusting his cuffs. “I’d rather not look like I’m in Downton Abbey. Besides, it’s a rave, not a book launch.”

Paul laughed, pulling himself up. “Right, mate. But you do realise half the people there are probably going because they read about you in that article. You’re presence is basically the headliner.”

“Thanks for the pressure,” Eliot muttered, grabbing his wallet and phone.

The air outside was cool and electric, the kind of night that hinted at something bigger brewing. Eliot and Paul climbed into the back of a waiting taxi, the faint hum of the driver’s radio filling the silence.

“You going anywhere good, lads?” the driver asked, glancing at them in the rear-view mirror.

“Harwood Road, just off Eccleshall Road,” Paul said, leaning back. “Big night ahead.”

Sophie lived in one of those classic Sheffield terraces—small but full of character. LED lights framed the windows, and the muffled thrum of music spilled out as Eliot and Paul knocked on the door.

Sophie answered, glass in hand, already half-dressed for the rave in a sleek black jumpsuit. “About time,” she said, pulling the door open. “Everyone’s inside. Grab a drink.”

Eliot followed Paul into the living room, where a mix of familiar and unfamiliar faces filled the space. The air buzzed with chatter, laughter, and the occasional clink of glasses.

Sophie began introducing everyone, gesturing as she spoke.

“You know Lucy, of course,” she said, nodding to the philosophy student from the pub, who raised her glass in acknowledgment. “And that’s Max—he’s with the Kelham*Kollective*. You’ve met him before, haven’t you?”

Eliot nodded, shaking Max’s hand.

“And this is Charlotte,” Sophie continued, motioning to a striking woman with dyed green hair and a confident smile. “She’s a DJ—does a lot of the techno raves.”

“Big fan of your work,” Charlotte said, smirking as she sipped her drink. “You’ve made my life a whole lot better.”

“Glad to help,” Eliot replied with a grin.

Sophie moved on. “That’s Dan—he’s in a band. And over there’s Mia, she’s doing a zine about all this peer-to-peer bitcoin stuff. Oh, and the guy in the corner is Ash—he’s working on some mad project about decentralised energy grids. You’ll like him.”

Eliot waved at Ash, who nodded back, holding up a beer in silent greeting.

As Sophie finished the introductions, Eliot stood in the centre of the room, looking around at the group. Some faces he knew well; others were strangers with shared ambitions, drawn together by a common energy.

Paul handed him a beer, breaking his train of thought. “What do you reckon, mate? Sheffield’s finest minds all in one room?”

Eliot chuckled. “Something like that.”

The drinks flowed as the music from Sophie’s speakers switched to a pulsating electronic beat, setting the mood for the night ahead. The group sprawled across the small living room—some on the sofa, others perched on armrests or cross-legged on the floor. Laughter rippled through the room, mixing with the faint clink of glasses and bottles.

Paul, already two drinks deep, nudged Eliot. “You know this is where the night actually starts, right? Forget Plot—Sophie’s pre-drinks are legendary.”

Eliot smirked, raising his glass. “Good to know.”

From the corner of the room, Charlotte leaned forward, her green hair catching the glow of Sophie’s LED lights. She placed a small baggie on the coffee table with a theatrical flourish.

“Right, lads and ladies,” she said, her voice playful but commanding, “time to take things up a notch.”

Murmurs of approval rippled through the group as Charlotte began preparing lines of ketamine with practised ease. Sophie rolled her eyes but didn’t stop her.

“Just don’t wreck my place before we even leave,” Sophie said, taking a sip of wine.

As the first wave of ketamine hit, the room relaxed into a looser, more conspiratorial energy. There was a vibe shift, as there always was with Ketamine, as Charlotte glanced around, her eyes gleaming. “Right, people,” she said, her tone playful but commanding. “Let’s turn this into a proper pre-drinks. *Never Have I Ever*. And none of that boring stuff. We’re here to get to know each other, yeah?”

Paul groaned dramatically, but the grin tugging at his lips betrayed his enthusiasm. “Fine, Charlotte. But if this turns into a therapy session, I’m out.”

Sophie rolled her eyes, settling back into the sofa. “Go on then, Charlotte. Start us off.”

Charlotte’s eyes sparkled as she scanned the room, her lips curving into a mischievous smile. “Alright. Never have I ever... made out in public.”

Laughter rippled through the group as most people took a drink, Paul tipping his beer back with exaggerated gusto.

“Of course you have,” Sophie said, smirking at him. “You’re incapable of subtlety.”

“Hey,” Paul replied, feigning offence. “I’m just a fun loving guy.”

Lucy leaned forward next, her cheeks already pink from wine. “Okay, never have I ever... had a crush on someone in this room.”

The group erupted into a mix of groans, giggles, and mock protests.

Paul immediately raised his beer. “Alright, guilty again.”

“Shocking,” Sophie deadpanned, taking a sip of her wine.

“Not my fault the way you brush your hands against my crotch every time we go out.” Sophie rolled her eyes but didn’t say anything.

Charlotte’s eyes narrowed playfully as she sipped her gin. “Interesting. Care to elaborate?”

Paul waved her off, but the room’s energy had shifted—laughter mingling with something warmer, more charged.

“Never have I ever... kissed more than one person in a single night.”

The room broke into laughter and a chorus of drinks raised, including Eliot’s.

“Eliot?” Charlotte questioned, laughing. “I thought you were a good boy, full of morals, and strong ethics.”

Eliot shrugged, his smirk understated. “What can I say? It was a very good party.”

Paul, emboldened by the atmosphere, decided to stir the pot. “Never have I ever... slept with someone whose name I didn’t know.”

Groans and laughter erupted as a few people sipped, including Charlotte, who waved her glass in mock triumph.

“Shocking,” Paul said, grinning.

“Oh, come on,” Charlotte replied. “Sometimes you’re just living in the moment.”

Eliot, finally leaning into the energy of the room, raised his glass. “Alright, never have I ever... hooked up on a night out.”

This time, nearly everyone drank.

Paul, sensing the room's energy, decided to up the ante. "Never have I ever... been part of a threesome."

There were a few groans. “Why is it always that question?” Max said.

A few folks in the room drank, including Charlotte, who seemed to wear her experience like a badge of honour. "Come on, it was Boomtown. Anything goes," she said with a laugh.

Lucy added the next question, "Never have I ever... had sex in a hot tub."

Sophie got up and made noises of discontent. "Alright, that's enough. We've learned plenty about each other tonight. There's still some decorum allowed in society. Let’s get taxis anyway. Plot 22’s not going to wait for us.”

Paul groaned, stretching his arms over his head. “Finally! I was starting to think we’d just stay here all night.”

“I was enjoying that game,” Charlotte shot back, grinning as she stuffed her ketamine baggie into her jacket pocket.

Sophie waved her phone in the air. “Taxis are booked. Two should be here in five minutes, and the rest in ten. Quadruple up, people, and don’t leave anyone behind.”

The room dissolved into chaos as people gathered their coats, checked their phones, and debated who would ride with whom.

Eliot, who had been nursing the last of his drink, suddenly sat up. “Tobacco,” he muttered, patting his pockets.

Paul glanced at him. “What?”

“I’m out of tobacco. I’ll be back in two minutes—shop’s just round the corner.”

Sophie raised an eyebrow but didn’t protest. “Fine, but don’t miss the taxis. I’m not waiting for you.”

The cool night air hit Eliot as he jogged down the street, the muffled sounds of the city humming around him. The corner shop’s fluorescent lights flickered faintly as he pushed the door open, nodding at the tired-looking cashier.

“30 grams of American Spirit Tobacco please,” Eliot said. “Do you accept bitcoin?”

“You’re the third person to ask me that today. It really is taking off. Cash or card only please.” Eliot half nodded and half grunted as he handed over two crisp Friedrich Hayek £20 notes and received his change. He dropped the pouch into his pocket and made his way back to the taxis just as they were getting in them. As soon as he got in the taxi jolted into motion, its interior vibrating with the beat of the speaker. Sophie leaned back against the seat, her sharp bob catching the dim streetlights as they passed.

“You’re buzzing tonight,” she said, glancing at Eliot.

He nodded, still catching his breath. “Feels like a good one. The city’s... alive, you know?”

Max grinned, tapping the beat on his knees. “Plot 22’s going to be something else tonight. Everyone’s talking about it. Such limited tickets.”

Lucy chimed in. “I’m pretty sure half the city’s trying to get in. They’re selling resale tickets to see the Eliot Ashton after all.”

Eliot laughed, shaking his head. “I’m just a guy with a pint, not a headline act.”

Sophie smirked. “Keep telling yourself that, Philosopher man. You’re Sheffield’s hype man at this point.”

“Please stop saying that.”

The taxis sped down Sheffield’s streets, the energy inside them buzzing. Outside, the city shimmered with life—pubs spilling over with revellers, late-night food stalls already doing brisk business, and the occasional burst of laughter breaking through the hum.

The taxis pulled up near the venue, the thud of bass already audible from the street. Eliot stepped out, taking in the scene: a massive crowd milling around outside, out onto the pavement. The air was electric, charged with the pulsing music and the buzz of anticipation.

People shouted to each other over the noise, their breath visible in the cool night air. Groups huddled together, laughing, smoking, and exchanging QR codes for digital tickets. A pair of bouncers stood near the entrance, their expressions a mix of boredom and watchfulness as they checked IDs.

“Bloody hell,” Paul said, surveying the scene. “This is chaos.”

“This,” Sophie said, stepping forward, “is why you’ve got me.”

With her phone held high, Sophie cut through the crowd like a blade, the glowing QR codes on her screen acting as a beacon. “Excuse me. Coming through. Tickets ready,” she called, her tone authoritative but not unkind.

The group trailed behind her, Charlotte shouting playful apologies to the people they brushed past. “Sorry, VIPs coming through!” she said with a cheeky grin, earning a mix of laughter and glares.

Eliot followed close behind, his eyes scanning the crowd. He recognised faces—some from previous raves, others from the pubs and makerspaces where he’d spent the past few years spreading his ideas.

Sophie reached the front of the line, holding her phone out to the bouncer with a confident smile. “Six tickets. All here.”

The bouncer scanned the codes, nodded, and gestured for the group to enter.

“Appreciate it,” Sophie said, flashing him a grin before turning to the others. “Come on. Let’s get inside before they change their minds.”

The group slipped through the doors, the music hitting them like a wave—deep, resonant bass that seemed to vibrate through their very bones. The darkness of the entryway gave way to a cavernous space bathed in shifting lights, the crowd already moving in sync with the pulsing beat.

As they stepped into the main room, the energy of the rave enveloped them completely. Eliot paused for a moment, taking it all in—the surging crowd, the kaleidoscope of lights, the raw, unfiltered joy that seemed to fill the air.

Sophie leaned close, her voice just audible over the music. “Told you this would be worth it.”

Eliot smiled, his pulse matching the rhythm of the music. “You were right.”

The group dispersed into the crowd, each pulled in different directions by the magnetic chaos of the night. For Eliot, it felt like stepping into the heart of something bigger than himself—a city alive, a movement in motion, a night that promised anything.

The music hit Eliot like a tidal wave as he stepped into the main room of Plot 22. The bass throbbed in his chest, vibrating through the floor and up into his limbs, pulling him into the rhythm of the night.

The room was a kaleidoscope of light and sound, strobes flashing against industrial walls, their stark beams slicing through the darkness. The crowd moved as one—arms raised, heads bobbing, bodies swaying in perfect sync with the relentless drum and bass beat. The DJ, silhouetted against a backdrop of shifting colours, commanded the room with an almost godlike presence, their hands darting across the decks with hypnotic precision.

Eliot paused near the edge of the dance floor, letting the atmosphere wash over him. Sophie was already in the thick of it, her sleek jumpsuit catching the light as she danced with wild abandon. Paul was nearby, his usual swagger replaced by a loose-limbed groove that was almost impressive.

Charlotte appeared at his side, leaning in to shout over the music. “You just going to stand there, Philosopher, or are you going to dance?”

Eliot laughed, letting the beat take hold. “Alright, let’s do this.”

Eliot joined the crowd, the press of bodies and the pounding music dissolving the boundaries of thought and self. This wasn’t about philosophy or sovereignty—it was about being alive, fully present, moving with a collective energy that was as electric as it was primal.

The drum and bass track shifted, its tempo climbing as the crowd erupted in cheers. Charlotte spun in place, her green hair a blur under the flashing lights, while Paul shouted something unintelligible but clearly joyful.

Eliot closed his eyes for a moment, losing himself in the rhythm. Each beat felt like a heartbeat, each drop like a surge of adrenaline. The philosophy he’d been preaching—the sovereignty, the individuality—it all blurred into the collective pulse of the rave.

After what felt like hours but was probably less, Eliot pulled himself out of the crowd, his shirt clinging to his back and his pulse still racing. He slipped through the side door into the cool night air, the muffled thrum of the music following him.

The smoking area to Plot 22 was a mix of shadows and neon, its walls scrawled with graffiti and QR codes that glowed faintly in the light of the streetlamp. A few people lingered nearby, smoking, laughing, or simply catching their breath.

Eliot leaned against the wall, fishing a pouch of tobacco from his pocket. His hands moved automatically, rolling a cigarette as he stared at the faint wisps of cloud drifting across the moonlit sky.

The door opened behind him, and Sophie emerged, her face flushed and her hair slightly damp. She lit a cigarette of her own, leaning next to him with a satisfied sigh.

“Needed a breather?” she asked, exhaling smoke.

“Yeah,” Eliot replied, his voice low but content. “It’s... a lot. In the best way.”

Sophie nodded, her eyes distant for a moment. “This is it, though, isn’t it? The city, the music, the people—it’s alive. And you’re in the middle of it.”

Eliot chuckled, shaking his head. “I’m just another body on the dance floor, Sophie.”

She smirked, taking another drag. “Sure you are.”

The two of them stood in silence for a moment, the sounds of the rave still pulsing faintly behind them. For Eliot, the night felt like a glimpse of something infinite—an energy that connected everything and everyone, whether they knew it or not.

The alley outside Plot 22 was beginning to fill up with people needing a break from the intensity of the rave. Cigarettes glowed faintly in the dark as muted laughter and conversation hummed against the steady thrum of bass from inside.

Eliot leaned back against the wall, his thoughts drifting, when a man in his mid-thirties stumbled slightly into his space. He was dressed in a sharp blazer that seemed out of place for a rave, his dark hair dishevelled but his eyes bright with excitement.

“Sorry, mate,” the man said, steadying himself. He lit a cigarette and exhaled a plume of smoke before looking at Eliot properly. His expression shifted into one of recognition. “Hang on. You’re Eliot Ashton, aren’t you?”

Eliot chuckled softly, nodding. “That’s what they tell me.”

“Brilliant!” the man said, leaning in slightly as if sharing a secret. “I’ve been following your stuff—Bitcoin, sovereignty, all that. Didn’t expect to bump into you here.”

“You must be the only person who didn’t know I was coming I think,” Eliot replied.

The man grinned. “True enough. I’m James, by the way. Big fan. Can I pick your brain for a second?”

Eliot raised an eyebrow but gestured for him to go ahead.

James took a drag from his cigarette, his voice lowering slightly. “Here’s the thing. I’ve been stacking sats for years now—proper Bitcoin maximalist. I’m not just thinking about myself, you know? I’m thinking long-term. My kids, their kids, setting up generational wealth. Planning for the next 200 years, if you know what I mean.”

Eliot’s lips quirked into a small smile, and he nodded. “Go on.”

James grew more animated, his free hand gesturing as he spoke. “Bitcoin’s the most secure asset in history, right? No inflation, no centralised control—it’s perfect. If I keep building this stash, my kids will never have to worry about money. Isn’t that the dream? To give your family a life where they don’t have to struggle? I’ve been reading *The Psychology of Money*. You know it?”

Eliot took a moment, letting James’ words hang in the air before replying. “I get it,” he said, his voice measured. “Bitcoin offers something that nothing else in history really has—a way to secure wealth for generations without the usual risks of inflation or corruption. It’s a tempting idea. But...”

He paused, flicking the ash from his cigarette. “It’s not healthy to plan for Bitcoin forever. Sure, you might give your kids financial security, but if they don’t know how to earn, how to create, how to work for something, what are you really giving them? Unlimited wealth isn’t freedom—it’s a trap. Think back to the philosophers stone. It’s misdirection, don’t waste your life chasing unlimited wealth and gold. You’ll never find it, talking about generational wealth is a little like that.”

James frowned slightly, his excitement dampening. “A trap? How do you mean?”

Eliot gestured broadly, his tone softening. “Wealth, especially unearned wealth, can strip away purpose. If your kids grow up knowing they’ll never need to work, they might never feel the drive to build something of their own. They could end up hollow, living off someone else’s efforts. And worse, they might never truly understand the value of what you’ve given them.”

James nodded slowly, his gaze thoughtful.

Eliot continued. “Bitcoin isn’t just about money—it’s about sovereignty, right? And sovereignty isn’t something you can hand down like an heirloom. It’s something you have to learn, to earn. Teach your kids to work, to think, to make their own way in the world. Give them the tools, not just the treasure.”

James let out a low whistle, shaking his head. “That’s... not what I expected you to say. I thought you’d be all about stacking sats and holding forever.”

Eliot laughed, a warm, genuine sound. “I’m about using Bitcoin as a tool, not a crutch. It’s a means to an end, not the end itself. Planning for the next 200 years is noble, but the best thing you can do for your kids isn’t to give them wealth. It’s to give them a sense of purpose, a connection to something bigger than themselves. You can’t make your time preference too low. You’ve got to enjoy yourself now and again. The odd bit of consumption here or there doesn’t make you a Keynesian.”

James leaned back, his cigarette nearly burned out. “You’re a hard man to argue with, Ashton.”

Eliot smiled, nodding toward the glowing doors of Plot 22. “That’s the point of the conversation, isn’t it? Now, come on. Let’s get back in there before we start sounding too serious.”

The two slipped back through the doors, the music surging to meet them. Sovereignty wasn’t about hoarding wealth; it was about living with intention, passing on values, not just assets.

As the lights and bass enveloped him again, Eliot smiled to himself. The conversation never really stops, does it?

Inside Plot 22, time folded in on itself. The relentless beat of the drum and bass blurred one track into the next, and the surging energy of the crowd made minutes feel like seconds. Eliot danced with abandon, losing himself in the rhythm, the lights, and the collective pulse of the room.

Faces came and went—familiar and unfamiliar, laughing, shouting, moving in time with the music. Charlotte spun in a blur of green hair, Paul was somewhere in the crowd with a drink held aloft, and Sophie appeared every now and then, a flicker of sharp black jumpsuit under the strobing lights.

Eliot let the night carry him, his thoughts dissolving into the sheer aliveness of the moment.

At some point, Eliot stepped off the dancefloor and leaned against the wall, catching his breath. The air was thick and electric, the crowd still a roiling mass of movement. He checked his phone, squinting at the screen in disbelief.

4:47 AM.

He laughed quietly to himself, running a hand through his damp hair. It felt like he'd only been here an hour, but the night had slipped away faster than he could have imagined.

Eliot scanned the room, finally spotting Sophie near the bar, her sharp features softened by the unmistakable glaze of ketamine. She leaned against the counter, her wine glass empty, her expression hovering somewhere between contentment and detachment.

Eliot weaved through the crowd, tapping her on the shoulder. "Sophie," he called over the music. "What's the plan?"

She turned slowly, blinking at him as if he'd just materialised out of thin air. "Plan?" she repeated, her voice slightly dreamy.

"For the afterparty," Eliot said, grinning. "It's nearly five. You've always got a plan."

Sophie blinked again, then let out a soft laugh, shaking her head. "Oh, right. Yeah. Ash mentioned something earlier. Big house near Endcliffe Park. Loads of people going."

"Is Ash here?" Eliot asked, glancing around.

"Probably outside," Sophie replied, her words slightly slurred. "He's always outside. Smokes like a chimney."

Eliot nodded, glancing toward the exit. "Alright. I'll find him. You good?"

Sophie smiled faintly, giving him a thumbs-up. "Always good."

Eliot stepped outside into the cool, pre-dawn air, the sudden quietness almost disorienting after the chaos of the rave. The sky was a faint grey, the first hints of morning creeping into the night.

A small crowd lingered near the entrance—smokers, stragglers, and those deciding whether to call it a night or press on. Eliot spotted Ash leaning against a lamppost, cigarette in hand, talking animatedly to someone Eliot didn't recognise.

Eliot approached, the buzz of the rave still thrumming in his veins. "Ash," he called, his voice cutting through the murmurs of conversation. "Heard you've got the afterparty plan."

Ash grinned, nodding toward a waiting taxi. “Big house. Endcliffe. You in?”

Eliot glanced back at the door, thinking of Sophie and the others still inside. He smiled, a quiet excitement stirring in him. “Yeah. I’m in.”

As the bass finally faded behind them, Eliot, Sophie, and the rest of the group spilled out onto the pavement outside Plot 22, blinking against the early morning light. The crowd outside was a mix of bleary-eyed ravers catching their breath, smokers huddled against the chill, and small knots of people debating whether to head home or press on. Charlotte was leaning against the lamppost, rolling a cigarette, while Paul loudly proclaimed that anyone who didn’t come to the afterparty was officially boring.

Sophie, ever the organiser, stood at the centre of the group, her phone in hand, trying to tally who was in and who was heading off. “Taxis are coming in five!” she announced, scanning the growing circle of friends and acquaintances. Eliot stood off to the side, his jacket slung over one shoulder, watching the negotiations with quiet amusement. As the group finally agreed on numbers, the first taxi pulled up, its headlights cutting through the misty dawn. “Alright,” Sophie called, ushering people forward, “let’s go before anyone changes their mind.” Eliot grinned, slipping into the second cab with a sense of anticipation curling in his chest.

The taxi pulled up outside a sprawling Victorian house near Endcliffe Park, its façade dark except for the faint glow of lights spilling from the windows. Eliot stepped out, the cool morning air biting against his skin. Birds were beginning to stir in the trees, their tentative calls weaving into the stillness of the dawn.

Ash waved Eliot toward the door, his cigarette trailing smoke behind him. “Come on. Everyone’s already inside.”

Eliot followed, the faint buzz of anticipation settling into something calmer, more deliberate. The night had been wild, kinetic, but the promise of the afterparty felt quieter—less about the chaos of the crowd and more about the intimacy of those who stayed.

Inside, the house was alive with low, pulsing music and muted laughter. People lounged on mismatched sofas and cushions strewn across the floor. The air was heavy with the familiar scent of tobacco, incense, and something faintly chemical.

Charlotte was already sprawled on a beanbag in the corner, rolling up a line of ketamine with the precision of someone who’d done it a hundred times. She glanced up and grinned. “You made it. Thought you’d fallen asleep on the dancefloor.”

“Close,” Eliot replied with a wry smile, shedding his jacket and dropping onto a nearby cushion.

Sophie arrived moments later, looking slightly more alert than she had at the bar. She carried a bottle of wine and two glasses, handing one to Eliot as she sank down beside him.

The group settled into an easy rhythm. Conversations ebbed and flowed, punctuated by quiet laughter and the occasional sound of a phone playing a video or a song.

Charlotte passed around a small mirror, lines of ketamine carefully measured out. “Alright, who’s in?” she asked, her tone light but inviting.

Ash leaned forward, taking the first bump with a practised ease. Sophie followed, her movements slower, more deliberate.

Eliot hesitated for a moment, then shrugged and took his turn. The familiar numbing warmth spread through him, softening the edges of his thoughts, slowing the world to a manageable hum.

As the ketamine took hold, the conversations became dreamlike, words floating in and out of focus.

Charlotte leaned back, her voice slow and deliberate. “This is the best part of the night, isn’t it? When the crowd’s gone and it’s just... this.”

Sophie nodded, her head lolling slightly. “Yeah. It’s like... we’re not trying anymore. Just being.”

Eliot sipped his wine, watching the room with detached curiosity. Ash was deep in conversation with someone about 3D-printed furniture, his hands gesturing vaguely. Charlotte was talking to Paul, her words a mix of philosophy and nonsense that somehow made perfect sense in the moment.

Eliot smiled faintly, his mind drifting. The night had been wild, but here, in the quiet aftermath, was something different—a sense of connection that didn’t need words or ideas to sustain it.

The atmosphere in the room grew heavier as the ketamine began to take full effect. Conversations slowed, words hanging in the air like suspended clouds before dissolving into silence. The low music seemed to stretch, its rhythms warping and folding into the haze that enveloped everyone.

Charlotte, sprawled on her beanbag, tilted her head back, her green hair spilling over the sides. “I think,” she murmured, her words drawn out and dreamlike, “I’m becoming... a puddle.”

Paul chuckled softly from his corner of the room, though his laughter trailed off as he sank deeper into the sofa, his eyes unfocused.

Eliot sat on the floor, leaning against the wall, his wine glass forgotten beside him. The world seemed distant now, the edges of his thoughts blurring into the strange, suspended calm of the k-hole. He glanced around the room, taking in the tableau:

Sophie slouched against the armrest of a sofa, her sharp features softened in the dim light. Ash lay sprawled on the floor, one arm draped over his face, breathing slowly. Charlotte remained in her beanbag throne, one hand resting limply on the mirror as if she might pick it up again but never quite got around to it.

Eliot closed his eyes for a moment, letting the stillness settle over him. This wasn’t the first time he’d been like this, but tonight felt different. The events of the past few weeks—the article, the conversations, the growing momentum of his philosophy—hovered at the edges of his mind, waiting to be let in.

Sheffield’s philosopher.
National thinker.
The next great zeitgeist.

The words from the article echoed faintly, their weight both exhilarating and suffocating. Was this what he wanted? Was he ready for it?

He opened his eyes again, staring at the cracked ceiling. The room was quiet now, save for the faint hum of the music and the occasional shift of someone sinking deeper into the cushions. He thought about the people around him—the ones who had stayed until now, who had shared the chaos of the night and the calm of its aftermath. They weren't just friends or followers. They were... something more.

Eliot's thoughts drifted further, touching on the role he had fallen into. Not just as a thinker or a philosopher, but as someone people looked to. Someone they followed.

Is this what it means to be at the centre of something? he wondered. Not the leader, not the hero—just... the one who said something when it needed to be said.

The room was quiet now, save for the faint hum of the city waking outside. The afterparty had ebbed away into a haze of ketamine and whispered conversations, the night dissolving into the soft, golden light of morning. Eliot lay stretched out on a sofa, his jacket bundled under his head, watching faint patterns dance across the ceiling. Around him, the others had succumbed to sleep in varying states of comfort and collapse.

Sophie was curled on the armchair, her legs tucked beneath her, her face peaceful and unguarded for once. Charlotte had claimed a spot on the floor, wrapped in someone's discarded hoodie, her green hair a splash of colour against the faded carpet. Ash and Paul were sprawled on the larger sofa, one's arm draped over the other in unconscious camaraderie.

Eliot's body ached faintly, his limbs heavy, but his mind felt light, almost buoyant. The intensity of the night—the music, the laughter, the fleeting moments of connection—had given way to something quieter but no less profound. As he glanced around the room, he felt a flicker of something rare and precious.

They had shared more than a night. They had shared a moment—a crossing of invisible lines, a breaking down of walls that might never have been breached in daylight. The rave had been the spark, but it was here, in the stillness of the morning, that the real connection had settled in.

It wasn't just the ketamine, the music, or the fleeting rush of a perfect beat. It was the sense of being part of something—a shared experience that tied them together, at least for now, in a way that felt unspoken but undeniable. Eliot felt closer to them all, even the ones he hadn't known well before tonight. There was a vulnerability in the way they lay scattered across the room, their guards down, their edges softened.

He closed his eyes, letting the quiet sink in. This is what it's all about, he thought. Not just the ideas or the philosophies, but the people who share the experience. This is what keeps it real.

Eliot shifted slightly, his thoughts drifting as sleep began to pull him under. He didn't know what the day would bring, or how the connections forged tonight would hold up against the bright, sharp edges of reality. But for now, he let himself feel the warmth of it—the sense that they had all, in some small way, been a part of something more.

The room fell into complete stillness, the soft rhythm of breathing the only sound as the dawn crept in through the windows, painting their shared moment in hues of gold and quiet.

Outside, the city stirred, unaware of the small group inside the old house—dreaming, drifting, and unknowingly shaping the edges of something new.

Chapter 3:

The fountains were dancing their usual dance in the centre of the Peace Gardens, their arcs catching the morning light in brief flashes, as children watched all around. Eliot watched the water rise and fall, the water's rhythm steady and detached, utterly indifferent to the lives moving around it. He stood near the edge of the square, hands deep in his coat pockets, the cool air brushing his face. Around him, the city stretched and yawned awake, spilling its first wave of commuters onto the streets.

He had come here seeking stillness, but Sheffield no longer offered him that luxury. The city he loved had begun to love him back in ways he wasn't sure he could comprehend or was sure he wanted.

A passerby glanced at him, their eyes lingering for a moment too long. Then another. A group of students sitting on a bench whispered, one of them nudging the other and tilting their head in his direction. Eliot ignored them, or tried to, but he could feel the weight of their gazes settling on him, their curiosity prickling like static on his skin.

Fame, he thought, is a thief. He wondered how long, if ever, it would take for him to embrace this fame.

Fame stole things in pieces, small and subtle at first. It had started with the occasional nod of recognition, a polite smile, the odd question from a stranger. Now it was stares, murmurs, people stopping him in the street to ask for a moment of his time, a photo, a word of wisdom.

And they all expected him to be something. That was the exhausting part. Fame required performance, even in its quietest forms. A nod, a smile, a kind word—it all cost energy, and Eliot felt himself paying in a currency he wasn't sure he agreed to spend. Fame was like a job. You get well paid for it, and then the government comes in and takes 40% without asking your permission. No amount of expertise in monetary economics can prepare for selling part of yourself.

The fountains surged, scattering droplets onto the stone paths around them. Eliot turned away, his boots clicking faintly as he began to walk.

The city buzzed around him as he made his way toward the station, its energy muted but persistent. Eliot kept his pace brisk, his eyes down, his hands shoved deep into his pockets. Sheffield was alive this morning, its streets murmuring with the quiet hum of movement and purpose, but Eliot felt oddly detached from it all.

He passed a café near Sheffield Hallam University where he had once spent hours writing in blissful anonymity. Now, the baristas would recognise him the moment he walked in. They'd offer him a free coffee, ask him about his latest work, mention the article in The Internationalist. It was always well-meaning, always polite. And yet, it left him weary. There was an energy drain in needing to always be on and alert.

There's no quiet anymore, he thought. Not in this city. Not in this life.

The problem wasn't the people. It was the constant demand to be on. To smile, to nod, to engage, to live up to the idea of Eliot Ashton that people had constructed in their minds. He was a philosopher now, a public figure, and that role demanded more from him than he had ever anticipated.

The station came into view, the water features passing him by as he walked towards the façade, reflecting the muted grey of the morning sky. Eliot paused for a moment, leaning against a railing and watching the tide of commuters flowing in and out of its doors.

He used to enjoy walking here, watching the city move in its rhythmic chaos. It had been grounding, a reminder of Sheffield’s pulse and its unspoken connections. But now, even in a crowd, he felt conspicuous, like a single note out of tune with the symphony.

Eliot straightened, stepping back into the flow of foot traffic, his boots striking the pavement in time with the unspoken rhythm of the morning. The station loomed closer, its entrance a constant churn of faces—some familiar, most not, all fleeting. He moved past clusters of commuters with purpose, his head down but his mind spiralling upward into thought.

The station’s hum enveloped him as he stepped inside. A train announcement echoed overhead, blending with the soft hiss of steam and the distant rumble of engines. Eliot slowed his pace, his gaze drifting over the space. It was alive with motion—people rushing for platforms, clutching coffees, scrolling through phones, carrying bags too big for their frames.

For a moment, he felt something close to envy. These people were anonymous in their haste, absorbed in private worlds. They belonged to no one but themselves. He wondered if they knew how precious that was. He had given all that up now, but was it worth it?

Eliot lingered near the departures board, pretending to check the trains while a pair of teenagers passed, whispering and glancing at him. He caught fragments of their words—his name, the article, Bitcoin. A faint smile tugged at the corner of his mouth, though it didn’t reach his eyes.

You wanted this though, didn’t you? he thought. You wanted to spark something, to be heard. But did you ever think about what comes next, what it actually means?

A whistle sounded from one of the platforms, jolting him back into the present. Eliot turned, heading out of the station and toward the path that led up the steep path to the Cholera Monument.

As he climbed the incline, his thoughts churned with the weight of it all—fame, philosophy, the revolution he had unwittingly ignited. Each step felt heavier than the last, as if he were carrying more than just himself up the hill.

If the city is alive, he thought, then what does that make me? The heart, the voice, or just another pulse in its endless rhythm?

The Cholera Monument rose starkly against the pale sky, its stone edges softened by time but no less commanding. Eliot leaned against the iron railing, catching his breath as he gazed out over Sheffield. The city sprawled before him, a patchwork of industry and renewal, its chimneys and cranes tangled with the promise of something more.

The view always stirred something in him—pride, resolve, a sense of belonging. But today, as the wind tugged at his coat, all Eliot felt was the weight of doubt pressing against his chest.

His philosophy had caught fire, that much was certain. People were listening, following, reshaping their lives around his ideas of sovereignty, peer-to-peer trade, and the state as a scaffold—a temporary structure meant to be dismantled once it had served its purpose. But was it the right path?

Agreement doesn’t make something true, he thought. History is full of ideas that people rallied around, only to crumble under the weight of their own flaws.

Eliot’s gaze drifted to the edges of the city, where old factories stood alongside new developments, their coexistence uneasy but undeniable. He had always thought of the state in those terms—something built to hold society up, but never meant to last forever. A scaffold, not a fortress.

The metaphor had served him well, resonated with people. It gave them hope for something beyond bureaucracy, something freer, something better. But the more his ideas spread, the more Eliot wondered if he’d underestimated the power of the scaffold itself.

Scaffolds can become prisons, he thought. They can trap people as easily as they support them.

His philosophy advocated for decentralisation, for dismantling the structures that stifled individuality and sovereignty. Yet, as he looked out over Sheffield, he couldn’t ignore the uneasy question gnawing at him: Was he offering people freedom, or just another kind of instability?

The state wasn’t a monolith; it was a thousand tangled systems, some oppressive, some necessary. Eliot had argued that the state should step back, relinquishing control to empowered individuals and communities. But perhaps he hadn’t gone far enough.

Should I be harsher? he wondered. Should I push harder, tear down the whole edifice instead of chipping away at its edges? There are many bitcoiners and anarchists who would tear down the whole facade.

Yet the thought unsettled him. Revolutions that dismantled too much often left chaos in their wake. He had seen it before—in books, in history, in the broken remnants of movements that had burned too brightly, too quickly. What it then reformation or revolution?

What if the scaffold collapses before anyone is ready to stand on their own?

The wind picked up, cutting through the silence, and Eliot pulled his coat tighter. Influence was a strange and dangerous thing. He had always thought of himself as an instigator, a spark, not a leader. But now people looked to him for guidance, for certainty.

Do they need certainty? Or do they just want someone to tell them they’re on the right path?

Eliot gritted his teeth, the taste of doubt bitter on his tongue. The path he was walking wasn’t just his anymore. It belonged to the people who had taken his ideas and made them their own. And that frightened him more than he cared to admit.

Perhaps that was the answer. Not to dismantle the scaffold entirely, but to ensure it served the builders, not the other way around. To keep it temporary, flexible, something that could be reshaped as needed, until people were ready to step beyond it.

The clouds began to break, shafts of sunlight piercing through and casting long shadows over the city. Eliot exhaled slowly, his breath visible in the crisp air.

He didn’t have all the answers—not yet. But maybe that was the point. Philosophy wasn’t about certainty; it was about questioning, about experimentation, about pushing forward even when the path was unclear.

Eliot pushed himself away from the railing, his steps deliberate as he began his descent. The city waited, alive and untamed, and so did the people within it. For now, that was enough.

Eliot descended from the Cholera Monument, his boots crunching softly against the gravel path. The quiet hum of Sheffield wrapped itself around him—snatches of voices, the distant groan of buses, the faint clang of construction work.

As he moved closer to Park Hill Flats, the thought took root: What happens to people if they truly follow this path?

It wasn’t an idle question. His philosophy—individual sovereignty, decentralised systems, peer-to-peer networks—wasn’t just abstract theory anymore. It was action. Ideas that were taking hold, spreading like ivy through the cracks of Sheffield’s old systems. But ideas had consequences, and Eliot couldn’t pretend he didn’t know that.

The closer he got to the flats, the clearer the contradictions became.

For some, his ideas would be liberation. A chance to step out from under the weight of the state, to reclaim agency, to build something new with their own hands. Bitcoin markets, collektives, raves funded by peer-to-peer transactions—it was already happening. Communities finding freedom in the absence of hierarchy, thriving in self-made structures.

But not everyone would thrive.

Eliot’s steps slowed as he neared the imposing structure of Park Hill. Its brutalist angles and colourful panels stood as a monument to ambition and failure alike. A utopia built for the working class, now transformed into a blend of luxury flats, well luxury for Sheffield at any rate.

The scaffolding of the state, flawed and oppressive as it was, had provided stability for those who needed it most. Safety nets, however frayed, still caught people when they fell. If those were stripped away too soon, what happened to the vulnerable?

And yet, Eliot thought, stability isn’t freedom. It’s just another kind of cage.

Would they thank him, the people whose lives improved because of his ideas? Would they curse him, the ones who lost what little they had? The thought was a quiet ache in his chest. Influence wasn’t clean. It was messy, uneven, unpredictable.

Park Hill loomed ahead now, its sheer size both imposing and strangely beautiful. Eliot stopped at its base, his gaze tracing the lines of the building. This was where theory met reality, where the weight of his influence settled uncomfortably on his shoulders.

For someone who had never sought power, he realised, he held more of it than most politicians in the country now. Power not through control, but through persuasion. The quiet force of ideas and rhetoric.

And that kind of power was harder to see, harder to resist.

It wasn’t a power he wanted. Yet, here it was, growing every time someone shared his words, built something new on the foundation of his philosophy, or quoted him in debates. He had always told himself he was just a catalyst, a spark, but the fire was spreading, and fires didn’t stay controlled.

Eliot leaned against a railing, his thoughts churning. His philosophy didn't promise a perfect world. It promised something raw, something open, something uncertain. A society where people took responsibility for themselves and each other, where sovereignty replaced subservience, where freedom wasn't a gift from above but a hard-won right from below.

But freedom is frightening, he thought. It requires choice. Effort. Risk.

And some people didn't want that. Some people wanted the comfort of structure, the reassurance of being told what to do. What right did he have to disrupt their lives?

Eliot exhaled, his breath visible in the cool air. His mind circled back to Nietzsche: He who has a why to live can bear almost any how. If he could give people a "why," something that made their lives worth bearing, maybe the "how" didn't matter. Maybe that was enough.

Park Hill Flats stretched behind him, both a relic and a reinvention. It wasn't perfect—neither in its original vision nor its current state. But it was still standing, still evolving.

Maybe that's the point, Eliot thought. Philosophy doesn't have to build a utopia. It just has to help people keep building.

He pushed himself away from the railing, his steps heavier now as he moved past the flats. Eliot's boots echoed against the uneven pavement as he left Park Hill Flats behind, the path curving gently toward Fitzalan Square. The city unfolded around him, its streets narrowing and rising, the hum of distant traffic blending with the murmur of life.

The square came into view, its open space framed by the quiet dignity of worn buildings, their facades lined with stories that Sheffield didn't always share. Eliot slowed, weaving through the few early risers who had already claimed benches or were clustered near the tram stop.

Why had he chosen philosophy? The question felt almost banal, and yet it gnawed at him.

The cliché answer is easy, he thought. I've always felt different.

And it was true, wasn't it? That gnawing sense of separation, the feeling that the world around him was moving to a rhythm he couldn't quite keep pace to. Even as a child, he'd been the one asking too many questions, challenging too many answers, watching the world like it was a puzzle he'd already half-solved but wasn't allowed to finish.

There was something in his brain he couldn't put into words, something he'd always known was there but could never fully articulate. Genius? Maybe, though the word felt cheap, reductive, too easily thrown around.

It wasn't intelligence in the traditional sense, though he had plenty of that. It was something sharper, deeper—a kind of instinct, an unerring sense of what was right and true:

my judgement is perfect

The thought was audacious, even arrogant, but it wasn't untrue. Time and again, Eliot had been proven right—not just in debates, but in the quiet calculations of life itself. He could see the world's edges, its hidden patterns, the places where things could break or bend. And he didn't just see them. He understood them. Perhaps he'd at time been too conservative, too recalcitrant to push himself, too shy of his own abilities but

But understanding wasn't enough. It never had been.

The spire of the Cathedral came into view as Eliot climbed the slight incline toward it, its stone edges softened by time. Sheffield's heart, its quiet sentinel, standing watch over centuries of change. Eliot's steps slowed as the Cathedral loomed larger, his thoughts circling back to themselves.

What was he really trying to do?

The ambition gnawed at him. It wasn't power, at least not in the traditional sense. He didn't want to rule people, to control them. And yet, the drive to lead, to influence, to pull others onto the path he saw so clearly—it was undeniable.

I want them to be more like me.

The thought struck with uncomfortable clarity. That was the truth of it, wasn't it? His philosophy, his ideas, his entire revolution—it was an attempt to reshape the world in his image. To get people to think the way he thought, to see the patterns he saw, to embrace the freedom he believed in.

And that was power.

Not the power of command or force, but something quieter, subtler, perhaps more insidious. The power to shape minds, to plant ideas, to guide people toward a version of the world he believed was right.

Eliot reached the edge of the Cathedral and paused, his gaze drifting upward to the spire piercing the pale sky. He didn't doubt his path—not really. He knew he was right. That was the thing about being Eliot Ashton: he didn't second-guess his judgement.

But being right wasn't easy. It was exhausting, isolating, and—he could admit it—terrifying.

What if I'm wrong just once?

He couldn't remember a time when he had been. Not really. But the thought lingered anyway, a faint shadow at the edges of his mind.

Eliot shoved his hands deeper into his pockets and turned away from the spire, his steps quickening as he moved toward the University. The Cathedral's bell chimed faintly behind him, a reminder of Sheffield's rhythm, its unyielding continuity.

For now, he would keep walking. That was all he could do—put one foot in front of the other and hope that the path he was carving led somewhere worth going.

The University of Sheffield rose ahead, its patchwork of Gothic arches and modern glass blending old academia with the presents restless ambition. Eliot moved along the paths winding through the campus, his steps slowing as students hurried past in loose clusters, their laughter and chatter weaving faintly into the cold morning air.

They noticed him—he could see it in the double takes, the glances over shoulders, the quick whispers between friends. A few outright stared, their curiosity barely disguised. Eliot kept his eyes forward, his hands tucked into his pockets, but the weight of their gazes lingered.

They don’t know, he thought, what this might mean for them. How could they?

Philosophy had always been a shadow in society, lingering at the edges, shaping minds quietly, subtly. Yet now it felt different. His ideas were spilling out into the world—not confined to ivory towers or the dusty pages of books, but alive in raves, in markets, in conversations on city streets.

What happens when philosophy stops being an abstraction? When it starts telling people how to live, how to think, how to be?

That was the thing about philosophy, wasn’t it? Once you stepped into it, you could never truly step out again. The questions it asked didn’t just sit politely in the corner—they clawed their way into your life, demanding answers, demanding change.

And Eliot wasn’t sure if that was fair.

What right do I have to tempt people into this? To pull them into my way of thinking?

He thought of the young faces he passed, bright with curiosity and naivety. They didn’t know what it meant to carry a philosophy inside you, how it twisted and stretched your thoughts until there was no such thing as simplicity anymore.

And yet, he thought, I want them to. That’s the selfishness of it, isn’t it? I want them to live the life I believe in—not the one society tells them to live, but not necessarily the one they would have chosen on their own either.

It wasn’t just the young who concerned him. The academics were watching too, their critiques and commentaries already circling his work.

Eliot’s lip curled faintly. Academics didn’t create; they dissected, analysed, reconstructed. His philosophy wasn’t meant for sterile conferences or footnoted papers—it was meant to breathe, to move, to live in the world. And yet, they would follow it, wouldn’t they? If it grew large enough, if it became inescapable, even the ivory towers would bow.

Is that what I want?

The thought unsettled him. Philosophy wasn’t meant to be a rulebook, but a spark. A way of asking, not a way of answering. If the academics turned it into dogma, if the young followed it blindly, then what was he really doing? Was he liberating them, or trapping them in a new kind of cage?

Eliot rose walked past the university Weston Park, his body stiff from the cold and his mind heavier than it had been when he left the Peace Gardens. He shoved his hands into his coat pockets and started toward the path leading home, the distant hum of the hospital fading into the background as he left it behind.

What have you learned today, then?

The question came unbidden, a quiet challenge to himself. Eliot thought about the path he’d walked—past the fountains, the station, the monument, the flats, the university, and finally here. It had been a journey not just through Sheffield but through his own mind, the city’s rhythm weaving itself into his thoughts.

He hadn't found answers, not really. But maybe that wasn't the point. Philosophy had never been about certainty—it was about sitting with the discomfort of not knowing, about asking better questions.

Today, the questions had been sharper than usual.

Was his philosophy right? Could it really reshape lives, reshape society, without causing as much harm as good? Eliot didn't know. What he did know was that it had already begun. The people following his ideas, building on them, spreading them—they weren't waiting for him to decide.

The spark's been lit. Whether I tend the fire or step away, it's going to burn.

He thought about fame, about influence, about the power he carried without meaning to. That was another lesson—one he wasn't sure he liked. Power didn't always come from authority. Sometimes it came from the quiet weight of an idea, from the way it settled into people's minds and changed the way they saw the world.

Eliot didn't want power. But he couldn't deny that he had it, in a way that was both subtle and profound.

Maybe it's not about what I want, he thought. Maybe it's about what I do with it.

The students' faces lingered in his mind—their curiosity, their whispers, their glances as he passed. They didn't know him, not really. But in a way, he didn't know them either. The young always carried the future, but the shape of it was theirs to decide.

I can give them ideas, he thought. But I can't live their lives for them. That's the line I have to walk—between offering a path and forcing one.

The academics concerned him less. They would critique, analyse, and perhaps follow his philosophy in time. But the young? They were the ones who would live it, shape it, and change it in ways he couldn't predict.

Maybe that's how it should be.

The streets were quieter now, the city settling into its mid-morning lull. The occasional car passed, its engine rumbling low, and a cyclist weaved carefully along the road, their breath visible in the chilly air.

What have you learned today, then?

The familiar curve of his street came into view, its terraced houses standing quietly in the soft light of the day. Eliot's steps slowed as he approached his door, his thoughts finally beginning to settle.

He unlocked the door and stepped inside, the warmth of the house wrapping around him. Papers lay scattered on the table where he'd left them, his jacket slung over the back of a chair, and books stacked precariously on every available surface. The walk hadn't given him answers, but it had given him something else—a sense of perspective, of humility.

Chapter 4:

The train hummed softly beneath Eliot's feet as it sped through the Peaks between Sheffield and Manchester, its rhythmic clatter providing a backdrop to the animated conversation in their carriage. The air carried the faint metallic tang of travel, and the early afternoon light streamed through the wide windows, casting shifting patterns over the small group gathered around Eliot.

Sophie leaned against the window, her green jumper bright against the drab train interior, a steaming takeaway coffee balanced precariously in her hand. Paul sat opposite, scrolling on his phone, occasionally smirking at something on his feed. Charlotte was sprawled across the remaining seats, a paperback novel half-open in her lap, though she hadn't turned a page in twenty minutes.

"So, what's this guy's deal again?" Sophie asked, tilting her head toward Eliot. "The man we're going to see."

"Alexander Thorne," Eliot said, glancing up from his own phone. "Londoner. Lives in Manchester, though. Hardline Bitcoiner. Engineer. Pretty much rejects the state entirely. No parliament, no laws, no scaffold. Just Bitcoin and the Nakamoto Consensus."

"Sounds intense," Sophie said, raising an eyebrow.

"Intense is an understatement," Eliot replied. "He's everywhere right now. Podcasts, YouTube, social media. Calls himself a 'hyperminimalist.' Says the only thing society needs is Bitcoin and voluntary cooperation. Everything else is tyranny."

Paul snorted, looking up. "Sounds like a nutter."

Eliot shrugged. "He's sharp. Brilliant, even. But extreme. His ideas make mine look tame."

Eliot leaned back in his seat, the flicker of passing fields reflecting in the window beside him. Thorne had risen to prominence in much the same way Eliot had: ideas that caught fire, shared in raves, pubs, and online spaces until they took on lives of their own.

But while Eliot had focused on decentralisation as a tool for empowerment and community, Thorne wielded it like a weapon. His disdain for the state was absolute, his rejection of traditional systems uncompromising.

And people loved him for it.

Thorne's face had been all over Eliot's feeds in recent weeks—short clips of him debating on podcasts, his words sharpened into quotable daggers: '*The state is a cancer'*. 'Bitcoin isn't just money; it's *freedom'*. 'Parliaments are just legacy systems waiting to fail.'

Eliot got his laptop out and showed Charlotte a clip of Thorne on a podcast saying that what inflation does to a country is worse than what cancer does to the body.

"He's a bit much," Charlotte said, closing her book and stretching. "But I get why people like him. He's... dramatic. Charismatic."

"Dangerous, perhaps" Eliot muttered, almost to himself.

The train dipped into a tunnel, the interior briefly bathed in darkness before emerging into the light again. Eliot's thoughts churned, picking apart Thorne's philosophy as the countryside blurred past.

Thorne’s vision of a stateless society was seductive, Eliot could admit that. But the idea of a stateless society seemed to him to offer the same promise as Marx’s idea of a classless society, an idea that had no basis in natural reality, though there was no point denying there was a nagging idea that no bureaucracy, no politicians, just voluntary cooperation—had a certain allure.

But it was naïve, wasn’t it? Society wasn’t simple. People weren’t simple. The state, for all its flaws, wasn’t just a parasite. It was also a framework, a structure that provided stability. Eliot’s scaffold wasn’t perfect, but it was practical. It acknowledged the messiness of human nature.

Thorne’s vision might work for a small group of like-minded individuals, Eliot thought. But a nation? A world? It would crumble under its own weight—or lack of it.

The train slowed as it approached Manchester Piccadilly, the sprawling city unfurling around them. The group gathered their bags and stepped onto the platform, the crisp northern air biting at their faces as they moved toward the station’s exit.

The talk was being held in a repurposed warehouse not far from the station, its industrial bones a fitting backdrop for a discussion about tearing down old systems. As they walked, Eliot could feel the buzz of anticipation growing around him. The streets were alive with people heading to the event, their conversations punctuated with Thorne’s name.

“Look at this crowd,” Sophie said, glancing around. “Feels like half the city’s turned out.”

“They probably have,” Paul said. “Thorne’s a big deal right now.”

Eliot didn’t respond. His mind was already spinning, half-excited, half-wary. He wanted to hear Thorne speak, to understand him better. But he also knew this would be a test—not just of Thorne’s ideas, but of his own.

The warehouse was packed, its cavernous interior humming with energy. Rows of mismatched chairs filled the space, and a stage had been set up at the front, its backdrop a simple banner with the Bitcoin logo and the words *Hyperminimalism in Practice*.

Eliot and his friends found seats near the middle, the crowd around them buzzing with excitement. Strangers exchanged theories and debates, their voices blending into a low, constant hum.

On the stage, Alexander Thorne stood, his sharp suit and piercing gaze commanding the room even before he spoke. He exuded confidence, his presence magnetic in a way that Eliot couldn’t deny.

Thorne stepped forward, and the room fell silent.

“Ladies and gentlemen,” he began, his voice cutting through the quiet like a blade, “we are here because we understand one fundamental truth: the state has failed. It is failing. And it will fall. Not because we want it to, but because it is inevitable.”

The crowd erupted into applause, but Eliot stayed still, his arms crossed, his gaze fixed on Thorne.

Alexander Thorne stood at the centre of the stage, his presence commanding in a way that made the room feel smaller, more intimate despite the crowd packed wall to wall. He held the microphone lightly, as though it were an afterthought, his voice carrying with a natural resonance that made every word seem sharper, more precise.

“The state,” Thorne began, pacing slowly across the stage, “is the single greatest impediment to human freedom that has ever existed. It thrives on control, on coercion, on the illusion that we need it. And for centuries, we’ve bought into that illusion because we lacked an alternative.”

The crowd murmured its approval, scattered applause rippling through the room. Eliot crossed his arms, leaning back in his chair, his gaze fixed on Thorne.

“But we don’t lack alternatives anymore,” Thorne continued, his voice rising. “We have Bitcoin. We have the Nakamoto Consensus. We have the tools to organise ourselves without the state, without politicians, without bureaucrats. The question is not if the state will fall—it’s when.”

More applause, louder this time. People leaned forward in their seats, drawn in by Thorne’s energy.

Eliot tilted his head slightly, his thoughts already spiralling.

Thorne continued, his pacing deliberate, his words punctuated by sharp gestures. “The state feeds on fear. It tells you that without its laws, its systems its taxes, you’d descend into slovenliness, despair, and de civilise yourselves. But Bitcoin proves them wrong. Nakamoto’s vision shows us a world where trust is replaced by verification, where cooperation is voluntary, and where no one has the power to rule over anyone else.”

That’s just High Liberalism you’ve described, Eliot thought, as Thorne talked about the need for individuals to better themselves. As he was thinking this a ripple went through the audience near Eliot. Someone whispered his name, and another head turned. Then another.

“That’s Eliot Ashton,” someone murmured, loud enough for Eliot to hear. “He’s here.”

Eliot sighed inwardly, shifting in his seat as a few people leaned closer, their phones already out. A young man in a Satoshi hoodie moved to the row behind him, trying to catch a better angle. Eliot ignored them, keeping his eyes on Thorne, but the attention prickled at him.

Thorne’s voice cut through the murmurs, sharp and unrelenting. “Imagine a world without taxes. Without borders. Without parliaments that siphon off your wealth to fund wars you never voted for. That’s the world Bitcoin can create. A world where power is decentralised, where your sovereignty isn’t just a philosophy—it’s a reality.”

The crowd erupted, clapping and cheering. Eliot felt the energy around him shift, the fervour growing with every word Thorne spoke.

Thorne raised his arms, calling for silence. “Some of you might be thinking, ‘What about the roads? The schools? The hospitals?’ Let me ask you this—do you trust the state to manage those things well now? Or do you just tolerate its failures because you’ve been taught to believe there’s no alternative?”

Thorne’s voice softened, drawing the room closer. “The state is a parasite. It survives by convincing you that you need it, by draining you of your wealth, your energy, your potential. It doesn’t deserve reform. It deserves destruction.”

The murmurs around him grew louder. A young woman with a notebook had moved closer, scribbling furiously while glancing at Eliot between sentences. A man with a Bitcoin-logo hoodie leaned in from the side. “Ashton,” he whispered. “You agree with him, yeah? This is what you’ve been talking about, right?”

Eliot didn’t respond, his focus still locked on Thorne.

“Eliot!” someone else called from a few rows back.

Thorne paused mid-sentence, his eyes flicking toward the source of the interruption. For a brief moment, his gaze locked with Eliot’s, and a flicker of recognition passed over his face.

“Ah,” Thorne said, his voice carrying a sharp edge of amusement. “It seems we have another thinker in the room tonight. Eliot Ashton, ladies and gentlemen.”

The room turned, dozens of faces shifting toward Eliot as applause erupted, scattered and uncertain. Eliot offered a tight smile, raising a hand in acknowledgment.

“Well,” Thorne said, his gaze lingering on Eliot for a moment longer. “Let’s hope Mr. Ashton finds tonight’s talk enlightening.”

The crowd laughed, and Eliot sank slightly in his seat, the weight of attention pressing down harder.

Thorne stepped forward on the stage, his voice dropping slightly as he continued, the room hushed in anticipation. He had drawn them in, and now he wielded silence like a blade, each word cutting sharper against the quiet.

“You see,” he began, “what Bitcoin does is far more profound than just decentralising money. It doesn’t just take power away from banks and governments—it removes the need for power altogether. True power isn’t control over others; it’s control over yourself.”

Eliot shifted in his seat, his gaze narrowing.

“Look around you,” Thorne said, sweeping his arm in an arc that seemed to encompass not just the room, but the world outside it. “Everything we call civilisation is built on one thing: violence. The state holds power because it holds the monopoly on violence. Laws are enforced with violence. Borders are drawn and defended with violence. Taxes are extracted under the threat of violence. But what happens,” his voice rose slightly, “when you demonetise violence?”

Thorne pressed on, his words gaining momentum. “Bitcoin makes violence obsolete. Without the ability to control money, the state loses its teeth. It can no longer fund wars. It can no longer imprison you for refusing to comply. It can no longer steal from you under the guise of taxes or inflate your wealth away.”

“And without the state’s violence, what do you have left?” He paused, letting the question hang. “Freedom. Pure, unadulterated freedom. A world where no one has the right—no, the ability—to impose their will on another. No governments, no rulers, no laws. Just individuals cooperating voluntarily, freely, because it benefits them to do so.”

The crowd broke into applause, louder this time, several people standing to cheer. Eliot leaned back, his arms crossed, watching the room with a mix of fascination and discomfort.

He could almost see the world Thorne was describing—a world without coercion, where people worked together because it made sense, not because they were forced to. But the flaw in Thorne's vision was glaring.

People weren't logical. They were emotional, selfish, unpredictable. And sometimes, they needed rules—not as cages, but as boundaries. Without them, what stopped cooperation from descending into chaos?

Thorne raised both hands, quieting the applause. "Some people," he said, his eyes sweeping the audience, "say this is impossible. That humanity can't live without rules, without control, without some form of authority. But those people fail to see what Bitcoin represents.

"Bitcoin doesn't just decentralise money. It decentralises trust. It eliminates the need for middlemen, for arbiters, for rulers. And when trust is decentralised, the mechanisms of control—laws, governments, hierarchies—they become obsolete."

He leaned forward slightly, his voice dropping into an almost conspiratorial tone. "What we're talking about here isn't just a new way of organising society. It's the end of history. The end of violence. The end of oppression."

Eliot's fingers tapped against the armrest of his chair, his mind spinning. The end of history, he thought. Where have I heard that before?

Thorne straightened, his voice rising again. "Some will say we need rules. That we need laws to keep order. But I say this: Bitcoin is the rule. The Nakamoto Consensus isn't just a protocol—it's a principle. Immutable, incorruptible, voluntary. It is the only law humanity will ever need."

The room burst into applause, some people shouting their agreement. Eliot stayed seated, his jaw tightening.

The murmurs around Eliot grew louder, the whispers of his name now accompanied by prodding questions. "What do you think, Ashton?" someone asked, leaning toward him. "This is what you've been talking about, right? Decentralisation, sovereignty?"

Eliot forced a faint smile but said nothing, his thoughts a storm.

Thorne's vision was seductive, there was no denying that. But it was also dangerous in its simplicity. The Nakamoto Consensus might be incorruptible, code might be pure, but people weren't. Cooperation without structure wasn't utopia—it was anarchy. And anarchy, Eliot knew, had a way of collapsing back into power, the strongest taking control while everyone else scrambled to survive. Reality would rear its ugly head.

As the applause faded, Thorne turned toward the audience, his gaze sharp and confident. "The state will fall," he said. "Not because we fight it, but because it can't survive in a world where Bitcoin thrives. And when it does, we'll finally know what it means to be free."

Thorne's words hung in the air, the energy in the room vibrating like a taut string. The applause had barely subsided before murmurs rippled through the crowd, growing louder and more insistent. People were turning in their seats, their eyes darting toward Eliot as whispers grew into a chant.

"Debate! Debate! Debate!"

Eliot stiffened, his fingers curling around the edge of his chair. Sophie leaned closer, a smirk tugging at her lips. “Looks like they’re not letting you off easy,” she said.

Thorne, standing tall on the stage, raised his hands to quiet the crowd, a flicker of surprise crossing his face. For a moment, he scanned the audience, his sharp gaze landing on Eliot. His expression shifted, his lips curling into a faint smile.

“Well,” Thorne said, his voice smooth and commanding, “it seems my audience has made their wishes clear. And far be it from me to deny them.” He gestured toward Eliot with a flourish. “Mr. Ashton, would you care to join me on stage?”

The crowd erupted into cheers, their anticipation palpable. Eliot hesitated for a moment, then rose, adjusting his jacket as he made his way to the front. As he climbed the steps, Thorne extended a hand, his grip firm and his smile almost predatory.

“Welcome,” Thorne said, stepping back to give Eliot the microphone.

Eliot turned to face the crowd, his pulse quickening. He could feel their eyes on him, a mixture of curiosity and expectation. He took a breath, letting the moment settle before he began.

“Thank you, Alexander, for the opportunity to respond,” Eliot began, his voice steady but firm. “And thank you to everyone here for your enthusiasm. Debate, after all, is the lifeblood of philosophy.”

The crowd chuckled lightly, their energy easing into a quieter focus. Eliot paced slightly, his hand brushing the microphone as he spoke.

“I’ve listened carefully to what Alexander has said, and I admire his passion, his vision. But I believe his vision, as compelling as it may sound, misunderstands something fundamental about human nature—and about the very concept of individual sovereignty.”

He paused, his gaze sweeping across the audience.

“Sovereignty isn’t about every man being an island, completely untethered and unaccountable to anyone else. It’s not about eliminating judgement or erasing the structures that allow us to hold each other accountable. True sovereignty is about responsibility. Responsibility to ourselves, to our communities, and to the cultures that shape who we are.”

Eliot’s voice grew sharper, his words cutting through the quiet murmurs of the crowd. “Pure anarchism, the kind of society Alexander envisions, lacks something crucial: the ability to address bad behaviour. Without rules, without a framework for accountability, what happens when someone violates another’s sovereignty? What happens when one person’s freedom comes at the expense of someone else’s?”

Thorne’s expression remained neutral, but his eyes glinted with challenge. Eliot pressed on.

“The Nakamoto Consensus is brilliant—there’s no denying that. But it’s not a moral framework. It’s a mechanism, a piece of code. It doesn’t punish bad actors; it merely excludes them. And exclusion isn’t enough. Some behaviours demand consequences, not just avoidance. A society without rules or judgement isn’t a utopia—it’s a vacuum. And vacuums tend to be filled by the strongest, the loudest, the most willing to impose their will on others. The strongest,” Eliot said, his gaze steady. “The loudest. The most ruthless. The kind of people who don’t hesitate to take advantage of chaos.

Thorne's vision of pure anarchism assumes people will naturally cooperate, that trust and voluntaryism will emerge as the new default. But history doesn't work that way. Take any period of collapse. Any revolution, any power vacuum. It's not the philosophers or the visionaries who seize control. It's the opportunists. The warlords. The demagogues who know how to manipulate fear and desperation. They don't build systems—they dominate them. They impose their will on others because there's no one strong enough to stop them."

The crowd stirred, some nodding, others exchanging uncertain glances.

Eliot's tone softened slightly, his pacing slowing as he turned toward the audience. "Sovereignty isn't just about freedom from coercion. It's about freedom for something—freedom to build, to create, to connect. And that requires more than Bitcoin. It requires culture. It requires trust, yes, but also shared values, shared responsibility."

He gestured toward Thorne. "Alexander speaks of a world where no one imposes their will on anyone else. But how do we ensure that? How do we stop one person's unchecked freedom from becoming another's oppression? Bitcoin alone won't answer those questions. And without answers, we risk creating the very chaos we seek to avoid."

The room was silent, the tension thick as Eliot handed the microphone back to Thorne. For a moment, the older philosopher said nothing, his sharp features betraying no emotion. Then he smiled—a small, faintly amused curve of his lips.

"Well argued, Eliot," Thorne said, his voice steady. "But I think you underestimate the power of voluntary cooperation. Trust doesn't need a scaffold. It doesn't need rules imposed from above. Humanity has survived and thrived for millennia because we are, at our core, cooperative beings. Bitcoin merely gives us the tools to do so without interference."

He turned back to the audience, his voice rising again. "Eliot worries about chaos. But chaos is the state's propaganda. It's what they use to keep us in chains. Bitcoin doesn't create chaos—it reveals the order that already exists when people are free to choose. We only allow chaos to thrive if we allow chaos to thrive. We only allow a strongman to rule, if we allow a strongman to rule. These are tautologies not rules, but yet we all admit that human action means that we can now allow this to happen if we don't let it happen."

The crowd erupted into applause, though a few people glanced back at Eliot, their expressions thoughtful.

The room buzzed with energy as Eliot took the microphone again, his movements deliberate as he turned to face both Thorne and the audience. The applause for Thorne's rebuttal had barely settled, but Eliot seemed unfazed. If anything, the charged atmosphere seemed to invigorate him.

"Alexander," he began, his voice clear and calm, "you speak eloquently about freedom and voluntary cooperation. And I understand the appeal of a world without rulers, without hierarchies, without imposed structures. But let's not mistake fantasy for realism."

The room quieted, a ripple of tension passing through the crowd. Eliot let the pause settle before continuing.

"Plato, in his Republic, spoke of the philosopher-king—not because he believed in unchecked power, but because he understood the nature of leadership. A well-ordered society requires those with wisdom, with knowledge, to guide it. And even in his ideal city-state, with all its intricate systems of justice and harmony, Plato never once suggested pure anarchism. He knew it wouldn't work."

Eliot began to pace the stage, his hands moving slightly as he spoke, the rhythm of his voice deliberate and persuasive. "The idea that we can exist without leaders, without power dynamics, is seductive. It sounds liberating, even utopian. But it ignores something fundamental about human nature: we need direction. We need places to go, frameworks to operate within, people to turn to in times of uncertainty."

He gestured toward the audience, his voice rising slightly. "Think about your own lives. When you're sick, you look to doctors. When you're lost, you follow a map. When you're unsure, you seek guidance from those who specialise, who have experience, who know better than you do. That's not dystopian. That's realism. That's the human condition."

Eliot turned back to Thorne, his tone sharpening. "You say power is the enemy, that any form of leadership is tyranny. But power dynamics are not inherently dystopian. They're natural. We create them because we need them—because no one can specialise in everything, and no one can know everything. Leadership isn't oppression when it's built on trust, expertise, and accountability. It's what keeps society from collapsing under the weight of its own complexity."

The audience murmured, some nodding, others leaning forward with furrowed brows.

Eliot continued, his pacing slowing as he addressed the room more directly. "Take any realm—medicine, art, technology, even Bitcoin itself. We look to those who specialise in these areas to make decisions, to guide us, to innovate. Why? Because we recognise the limits of our own knowledge. That's not coercion. That's cooperation."

He paused, his gaze steady. "Pure anarchism denies this reality. It pretends that all people are equally equipped to handle every decision, every responsibility. But we're not. And that's not a failing—it's simply the way we're built. We're interdependent, not isolated."

Eliot turned back to Thorne, his expression firm. "You fear leaders because you equate leadership with oppression. But leadership isn't about imposing control—it's about bearing responsibility. It's about guiding, not ruling. And yes, that creates power dynamics. But power isn't the enemy. Misused power is. A well-structured society doesn't eliminate power—it decentralises it, distributes it, ensures it's wielded responsibly."

The room was silent now, the weight of Eliot's words settling over the crowd.

"Alexander," Eliot said, his voice softening, "your vision is inspiring. But it's incomplete. Bitcoin is a tool—a revolutionary one. But tools don't build societies. People do. And people need frameworks, leaders, and yes, rules, to thrive. Anarchy doesn't liberate. It isolates. And isolation isn't freedom. It's chaos."

He handed the microphone back to Thorne, the applause starting slowly but building steadily, a mix of appreciation and tension as the crowd looked between the two.

Thorne smiled thinly as he took the microphone, his movements deliberate as he stepped back to the centre of the stage. The tension in the room was palpable now, the crowd leaning forward, eager for the next clash.

“Eliot,” Thorne began, his voice cutting through the stillness, “you are eloquent, I’ll give you that. But your vision—this scaffold you cling to—is nothing more than a crutch for those too meek to face the reality of freedom. You speak of leadership, of accountability, of power wielded responsibly. But history shows us that power, no matter how carefully distributed, always consolidates. Always corrupts.”

He paused, letting the words sink in before delivering his next blow. “Your philosophy is just a slower march toward the same old tyranny. You call it decentralisation, but it’s nothing more than state-rebuilding in disguise. These are perpetual debates, power may decentralise, but it will always recentralise.”

The crowd murmured, a ripple of agreement spreading through some corners of the room. Thorne pressed on, his voice rising with passion.

“You talk about Plato,” he said, his tone sharp. “Plato says himself that his forms of governance converge one into another over time, they move between centralisation and decentralisation in perpetual motion. He wrote it into the laws of nature. We have the opportunity to remove ourselves entirely from this control of Ancient philosophers. It must also be remembered that Plato lived in a society where slavery was not just permitted but fundamental to its operation. All of his so-called solutions to governance—whether a philosopher-king or the rigid classes of his ideal city—relied on coercion, on forcing people into roles they didn’t choose. There was no room for voluntaryism in Plato’s world, Eliot. And yet, here you are, holding him up as some kind of ideal.”

Thorne’s gaze swept the audience, his voice now a crescendo. “The only way to avoid slavery—real slavery, the kind enforced by power structures—is to have no structures at all. No rulers, no scaffolds, no compromises. Just freedom. Total, uncompromising freedom.”

The crowd erupted into applause, some cheering loudly. Thorne turned back to Eliot, his eyes glinting. “And that’s why your vision, as polished as it may sound, will never lead to liberation. You don’t have the will to truly tear down the chains. You’re too passive, too hesitant to be a real leader.”

The applause lingered as Eliot took the microphone again, his expression calm but resolute. He waited for the room to quiet before speaking, his voice steady but firm.

“Thank you, Alexander,” Eliot said, turning slightly to face him. “You’re right about two things: Plato’s solutions were flawed. They were products of their time, shaped by a society built on inequality. But to dismiss his insights entirely is to throw away a valuable tool. Philosophy isn’t about idolising the past—it’s about learning from it. Second, I am no leader, and nor have I ever tried to be. I am a philosopher. You if you continue to tear down every power structure you see before you, the only person left in society with any authority will be you. That will make you, Alexander, the tyrant.”

He turned back to the audience, his tone shifting to something more conversational, more intimate.

“And here’s what Plato understood, and what I believe you’re missing: most people don’t want total, uncompromising freedom. Because freedom without structure isn’t freedom at all—it’s uncertainty. It’s chaos. And chaos, as history shows us, breeds fear. Fear leads to desperation, and desperation leads to power-hungry opportunists stepping in to fill the void.”

Eliot began to pace slightly, his words measured but gaining momentum. “In an ideal society, the average person has the ability to withdraw from most power structures if they so wish. That’s sovereignty. That's decentralisation. But here's the thing: most people won't withdraw. Most people will voluntarily adhere to some kind of power structure. Not because they're coerced, but because it makes sense. Because cooperation, even with its compromises, is often more beneficial than isolation."

He paused, his gaze steady as he scanned the room. "Take work, for example. Most people will sell their time to an employer to get paid. Not because they're slaves, but because they see value in that exchange. They choose to trade some autonomy for stability, for resources, for opportunities. That's not oppression. That's agency. That's choice."

Eliot's voice rose slightly, his words cutting through the crowd's murmurs. "Absolute freedom—the kind you're describing, Alexander—is a myth. It sounds noble, even revolutionary, but it's not sustainable. Humans are social creatures. We thrive in cooperation, in systems, in shared efforts toward common goals. That doesn't mean we need the state as it exists today. But it does mean we need structure, culture, and yes, leaders. Not tyrants, not rulers, but guides. People who specialise, who take on responsibilities that others choose not to."

He turned back to Thorne, his expression firm. "You accuse me of being meek, of hesitating to tear down the chains. But I'm not afraid of tearing things down, Alexander. I'm afraid of what happens after. The world you're describing doesn't end slavery—it just replaces one kind of tyranny with another, less visible kind. The tyranny of the loudest voice, the strongest will, the opportunist who fills the vacuum left behind."

Eliot stepped forward slightly, his voice softening as he addressed the audience directly. "The question we should be asking isn't how to destroy power, but how to wield it responsibly. How to create systems that allow people to opt out if they choose, but also provide stability for those who need it. That's what sovereignty means. Not isolation. Not chaos. But balance."

Thorne took the microphone again, his expression thoughtful, the fiery energy of his earlier rhetoric tempered now by a faint smile. He gestured toward Eliot, nodding slightly as he addressed the crowd.

"Eliot and I disagree on much," Thorne said, his voice quieter now, but no less commanding. "We approach the question of sovereignty from different angles—one of cautious structure, the other of uncompromising freedom. And I respect that. Debate is the crucible where ideas are tested, and tonight has proven that both of our visions hold weight."

He paused, glancing out over the audience. "But here's the reality: society can follow two paths at once. Sheffield and Manchester are heading down different roads. My Manchester embraces the hardcore approach—the total decentralisation of power, the dismantling of all structures, the purest form of individual sovereignty."

Thorne gestured toward Eliot. "Sheffield, on the other hand, under Eliot's guidance, takes a friendlier and one might say a softer path. Cultural individualism, shared responsibility, voluntary adherence to power structures. Two cities, two philosophies, each trying to answer the same question: what does it mean to be free?"

Eliot stepped forward, taking the microphone with a nod of thanks. His voice was calm, measured, as he addressed the crowd.

"Alexander is right," he said. "Sheffield and Manchester are charting different courses, each rooted in the same desire for freedom but expressed in fundamentally different ways. Manchester's path is bold, radical, and unyielding. It seeks to tear down every system, every hierarchy, every scaffold, to start anew from nothing.

“Sheffield’s approach,” Eliot continued, “is slower, more cultural. We’re not trying to destroy the old, but to reshape it. To create systems that empower individuals while maintaining the stability that allows communities to thrive. It’s a philosophy of balance, of cultural individualism, of sovereignty that recognises the interdependence of human lives.”

He glanced at Thorne, a faint smile tugging at his lips. “And as much as we may disagree, I think we can both admit that these two approaches will offer the world an interesting case study. The battle for the future isn’t just ideological—it’s practical. And the paths Sheffield and Manchester take may shape how the rest of the world decides to move forward.”

Thorne nodded, his smile wry. “It will be a battle, no doubt. But not one fought with violence or coercion. This is a battle of ideas, of philosophy, of culture. And perhaps that’s the only kind of battle worth fighting.”

Eliot turned back to the audience, his gaze steady. “The world is watching. And whatever path we choose—whether it’s Alexander’s vision or mine—it’s up to all of you to make it work. Because ideas are only as strong as the people who live them.”

The two shake hands, the applause erupting into a standing ovation as the audience rose to their feet. As Eliot stepped off the stage, the weight of the evening settled over him. He could feel the eyes of the crowd on him, their whispers chasing him as he made his way toward the exit. Manchester’s path and Sheffield’s path—two visions for the future, two competing philosophies.

And somewhere in the space between them, the world would decide.

The grandeur of the Midland Hotel was a sharp contrast to the industrial grit of the venue they’d just left. Its sweeping staircase, high ceilings, and rich furnishings seemed to absorb the buzz of the city outside, replacing it with an air of quiet luxury. Eliot walked into the lobby alongside Sophie, Paul, and Charlotte, his thoughts still tangled with the energy of the debate.

“Nice choice, Eliot,” Sophie said, glancing around approvingly as they crossed the marble floor toward the elevators. “Bit posh, though, isn’t it?”

“After tonight?” Eliot replied, pressing the button for their floor. “I think I’ve earned it.”

The others laughed, though Eliot’s smile didn’t quite reach his eyes. As they rode the elevator up, he leaned against the wall, his mind replaying fragments of Thorne’s speech, the crowd’s cheers, and his own rebuttals.

Their suite was spacious, with plush sofas arranged around a low coffee table and tall windows offering a view of the city lights. Charlotte dropped onto one of the sofas immediately, kicking off her shoes and stretching out. Paul set his phone on the table, scrolling through messages while Sophie made a beeline for the minibar.

“Wine, anyone?” Sophie called.

“God, yes,” Charlotte replied.

Eliot waved a hand dismissively as he sank into a chair, his shoulders heavy with exhaustion. "Pour me a glass. I'm too tired to get up."

Sophie handed him a glass, then flopped onto the sofa beside Charlotte. "So," she said, looking at Eliot with a mischievous grin. "That was... intense."

"Intense is one word for it," Eliot said, taking a sip of wine. He let the warmth of the drink settle before continuing. "Thorne is brilliant. Charismatic. But he's also terrifying. Pure anarchism, no rules, no accountability—he's playing with fire."

"You handled him well," Paul said, not looking up from his phone. "But you've got to admit, he's got a certain... appeal. The crowd loved him."

Eliot nodded slowly. "Of course they did. He's selling them the simplest version of freedom. No compromises, no trade-offs. It's intoxicating. But it's also dangerous."

Charlotte sat up slightly, her expression curious. "Do you really think it's that dangerous? Isn't it just a thought experiment?"

"It's not just a thought experiment," Eliot replied, his voice firm. "Ideas like his catch fire. They spread. And if they're not tempered with a dose of reality, they can do more harm than good."

Sophie leaned forward, her wine glass cradled in her hands. "So what about you, then? What's your philosophy? I mean, really. What keeps you up at night?"

Eliot hesitated, swirling his wine as he thought. "I used to think I was a radical," he said finally. "When I started all this, I wanted to tear down the old systems, decentralise everything, give people the tools to take control of their own lives. And I still believe in that, in principle."

"But?" Sophie prompted.

"But the older I get, the more I realise how fragile society is," Eliot said. "Pure anarchism—Thorne's vision—scares me. I'm not afraid to admit that. People need structure, even if it's minimal. They need boundaries, rules, leaders they can trust. Without them, freedom becomes chaos, and chaos becomes fear. That's not liberation. That's survival."

Paul looked up, raising an eyebrow. "So, what? You're a closet conservative now?"

Eliot chuckled, though there was little humour in it. "Maybe I am. Not in the traditional sense. I still believe in decentralisation, in individual sovereignty. But I also believe in responsibility—responsibility to each other, to our communities, to the systems we create. That's what Thorne doesn't get. Freedom without responsibility isn't freedom. It's just selfishness dressed up as ideology. That is my opinion of High Liberalism. It is a mix of the two traditions after all. His is pure anarchism, there's no deep thought."

The room fell quiet for a moment, the weight of Eliot's words settling over them.

Chapter 5:

<u>Economist Leader: The War of the Roses</u>

Three months ago, two cities in northern England began walking two very different paths. Sheffield and Manchester—only 40 minutes from each other by train but now rivals in philosophy—have become the focal points of a modern ideological battle. At the heart of this divergence are two figures: Eliot Ashton and Alexander Thorne. The two met at a talk given by Mr Thorne in Manchester and have since been on a clash of ideologies.

Ashton, Sheffield's reluctant philosopher-leader, has guided his city toward a model of cultural sovereignty. His vision blends principles of High Liberalism with Bitcoin and peer-to-peer markets, with a deep respect for shared responsibility and local identity. Sheffield has since become a flourishing hub of cultural individualism, with its thriving arts scene and emphasis on community collaboration drawing comparisons to the 19th-century Victorian Renaissance.

Thorne, on the other hand is more of the Philosopher King, who has steered Manchester into the uncharted waters of political sovereignty. He rejects all state structures and Manchester has become a laboratory for hardline anarchism. Taxes have been eschewed with Manchester Council rejected at some turnings and locals coming out to challenge debt collectors; public services have been replaced by voluntary cooperatives and opt in DAOs, with Bitcoin underpinning nearly every transaction. For some, Manchester represents a daring leap into the future. For others, it is chaos thinly veiled as freedom. Manchester City Council's few remaining areas of income are the leasing of its buildings. The famous Manchester Town Hall has become a tech incubator start up.

Meanwhile in Sheffield, the changes are evident in its streets and markets. DIY trade hubs now dot the city, their operations funded and facilitated by peer-to-peer trade in Bitcoin. Local artists and makers have turned the city into a creative powerhouse, free from the constraints of traditional funding structures. Sheffield's pubs and cafés are alive with philosophical debates, many inspired by Ashton's ideas of decentralised responsibility and cultural renaissance.

Yet some in the bitcoin community argue that Sheffield's approach is too cautious. While the city's decentralisation efforts have created opportunities, some say they lack the transformative potential of Manchester's radical experiment. Yet the state as a scaffold model of Sheffield still remains, with Sheffield City Council's coffers boosted by nimble yet effective deals done within the burgeoning market economy by lending its expertise into recreating the very nature of localised governance.

In Manchester, the absence of traditional governance is stark. Bitcoin has replaced the pound as the dominant currency, and decentralised networks handle everything from waste collection to education. For those who thrive in Manchester's new paradigm, the freedom is intoxicating. But not everyone thrives. Stories of vulnerable individuals slipping through the cracks—elderly residents unable to navigate the Bitcoin system, families struggling without safety nets—paint a more complex picture. Many who rely on welfare from the British government and council houses have been left to the free market, with a stark array of differing outcomes.

The divide between the two cities is as philosophical as it is practical. Sheffield's emphasis on culture and community contrasts sharply with Manchester's pursuit of pure autonomy. Where Sheffield sees sovereignty as a balance between freedom and responsibility, Manchester views it as the complete eradication of coercion.

Eliot Ashton and Alexander Thorne have become symbols of these competing visions. Ashton, with his cautious pragmatism, champions a world where freedom is tempered by shared values. Thorne, with his uncompromising rhetoric, calls for nothing less than the total dismantling of power structures and their recreation through the Nakamoto consensus.

Their philosophies have turned Sheffield and Manchester into global case studies, with cities around the world watching closely. Capital markets in the United States and Asia are looking on enviously, seeing the potential growth in both cities, while libertarians, cypher punks and bitcoin maximalists are following developments with a keen eye. In recent months tourism to both regions has soared with Sheffield coming second and Manchester coming third in tourism locations for bitcoin maximalists. Advocates of decentralisation see the North as a proving ground, while sceptics warn of the dangers of experimentation without precedent.

It remains to be seen which city's approach will resonate more widely—or whether either will endure. Sheffield's cultural sovereignty offers stability and creativity but risks economic stagnation. Manchester's political sovereignty promises transformation but flirts with chaos.

One thing is clear: the ideological divide between Sheffield and Manchester is no longer just a local experiment. It is a microcosm of a global debate about power, freedom, and the future of society.

As the world watches, these two cities march forward, their paths diverging further with each step. The question is not which city is right, but whether their respective visions can survive the test of reality—and time.

Eliot sat alone in his flat, the hum of the city faint through the window left ajar. The Internationalist article lay open on the table before him, its sharp prose cutting deeper with each re-read. He had known this moment would come—the comparison, the scrutiny, the pressure—but knowing didn't soften the weight pressing down on him now.

Manchester was surging ahead. The article had made that clear. Yet it was Thorne's latest move that was unnerving him—a decentralised stock and coin exchange at the heart of Manchester. It could be a masterstroke, a bold step toward positioning the city as a global hub of trade and innovation. Already, the buzz around it was deafening: Bitcoin maximalists and entrepreneurs from across the world were flocking to Manchester, eager to stake their claims in this new frontier.

Sheffield, meanwhile, was flourishing in its own way, but in a quieter, less tangible fashion. The city's culture was thriving, its sense of community deepening, but Eliot couldn't shake the feeling that it was being overshadowed. Better, yes. But is it enough?

Eliot leaned back in his chair, his gaze drifting to the bookshelf crammed with philosophical texts and economic treatises. He didn't want to compete with Manchester—not in the way the article framed it. Competition suggested a race, a zero-sum game with winners and losers. But Sheffield's philosophy wasn't about winning; it was about improving, about creating a city where individuals could thrive without the need to dominate or outpace anyone else.

Yet the comparisons were inevitable. Thorne's vision was flashier, more radical. Manchester was drawing headlines, investors, attention. Without it, Sheffield risked being left behind, its cultural experiment dismissed as quaint or unambitious.

The message from Sophie had come earlier that morning, her tone a mix of excitement and worry.

"Have you seen what Alexander's doing now?" she'd written, attaching a link to a news story. "Decentralised stock exchange. Global commerce. He's not slowing down, Eliot. Should we be worried?"

Eliot had read the article twice, his stomach tightening with each line. Thorne wasn't just building a city; he was building a narrative. Manchester wasn't just a place—it was becoming an idea, a beacon for those who believed in absolute freedom, in the dismantling of every traditional structure.

Sheffield's narrative, by contrast, felt murkier. Less defined. And that uncertainty gnawed at Eliot now.

He thought about Sheffield's strengths: its thriving arts scene, its emphasis on community, the quiet resilience of its people. These were things that couldn't be quantified in headlines or investor dollars, but they mattered. They were the foundation of Sheffield's identity.

Sheffield doesn't need to be louder, he thought. It needs to be clearer. More deliberate.

Eliot's philosophy was about balance—about sovereignty tempered with responsibility, freedom grounded in culture. That was the story Sheffield needed to tell, not as a rebuttal to Manchester, but as a vision in its own right.

Sophie's message buzzed in his mind again. Should we be worried?

Eliot exhaled slowly, turning back to his desk. He picked up his phone and typed a response:

"No. We don't need to worry. We need to focus. Sheffield isn't Manchester, and that's a good thing. Let's show the world why."

He hit send and sat down, his mind already turning to the steps ahead. Sheffield didn't need to compete, but it did need to act. The city's path was its own, and it was up to Eliot to make sure it stayed that way.

Eliot leaned against the windowsill, the skyline of Sheffield stretching out before him, framed by the fading light of early evening. The city's quiet hum drifted upward, mingling with his thoughts, which felt anything but quiet.

Manchester's radical decentralisation was bold, uncompromising, and relentless. Running everything through DAOs—education, health, even local governance—meant there were no traditional power structures, no leaders, no anchors. But that was the problem, wasn't it? Anchors.

What happens to culture in a city without anchors? Eliot thought.

Culture, Eliot knew, wasn't something you could codify or program. It wasn't a protocol, a ledger, or a smart contract. Culture was soft, organic, messy. It grew in the cracks of stability, thriving when people felt secure enough to express themselves, to take risks, to create without the looming spectre of survival.

In Manchester, everything seemed to orbit the hard edge of business. Thorne's vision prioritised efficiency, autonomy, and trade. And while that made for an economic engine, it left little room for the softer elements of life.

Art, music, community, Eliot thought. The things that make people feel alive, not just free.

Manchester's model might work for some, but Eliot couldn't shake the feeling that something vital was being lost. Culture needed space to breathe, to meander, to fail and start again. And for that, it needed a foundation—stability, security, a sense that the world wouldn't fall apart if you stopped to paint or write or dance.

But Sheffield wasn't immune to Manchester's influence. The world was watching, and Sheffield couldn't afford to seem stagnant or timid. Culture, for all its softness, still needed a strong base to flourish. Without adapting, without building something resilient, Sheffield risked being overshadowed, its gentler vision drowned out by Manchester's louder, harder narrative.

The paradox, Eliot thought, is that even the softest systems need strength to survive.

Strength didn't mean rigidity, though. Sheffield's strength had to come from its people, its communities, its ability to innovate without losing its soul. If Manchester's radical decentralisation was a sprint, Sheffield's cultural sovereignty had to be a marathon—a slower, steadier process that nurtured both the individual and the collective.

Eliot turned from the window, pacing the room as his thoughts spiralled. Culture couldn't thrive in chaos. That was the problem with Manchester's DAOs. They stripped away traditional systems, but in doing so, they also stripped away the safety nets. Without stability, without a baseline of security, people wouldn't create—they'd survive.

And survival wasn't the same as living.

Sheffield has to offer something different, he thought. Not just freedom, but freedom with purpose. Freedom with support.

This didn't mean clinging to the old ways. Sheffield didn't need bureaucracy or paternalistic governance. But it needed systems—flexible, voluntary, supportive systems that allowed people to take risks without fearing the ground would disappear beneath them.

Eliot paused, his hands resting on the back of a chair. If Sheffield was going to flourish, it needed to lean into what made it unique. Culture as its cornerstone. A city where art, philosophy, and community weren't afterthoughts, but central to its identity.

But to achieve that, Sheffield had to be strong—not in the hard-edged, business-first sense of Manchester, but in a way that allowed for softness to exist without being crushed. A strength that came from adaptability, from collaboration, from the quiet resilience of people who believed in something bigger than themselves.

Adaptation doesn't mean imitation, Eliot thought. It means knowing who you are and finding a way to survive in the world as it is.

Sheffield didn't need to compete with Manchester on its terms. It needed to redefine what strength meant, to build a city where people could not only be free but feel safe enough to create, to connect, to care.

Eliot exhaled, the tension in his chest easing slightly. The road ahead wasn't clear, but at least he knew what Sheffield had to be: not Manchester's rival, but its counterbalance.

Eliot leaned back in his chair, the germ of an idea taking shape in his mind. Banking. The word felt old-fashioned, almost out of place in the context of Bitcoin and decentralised finance, but the more he thought about it, the more it made sense.

Manchester's vision was raw, hard-edged—a city built on the high-octane energy of trade and exchange, where every interaction was a transaction. Thorne's decentralised stock exchange was an inevitability in that world, a natural extension of his philosophy.

But banking, Eliot thought, was different. Or at least, it could be.

At its best, banking wasn't just about numbers on a ledger or cold, impersonal transactions. It was about relationships. A banker in the traditional sense didn't just move capital; they understood it, shaped it, made it personal. They helped people turn ideas into reality, guided them through risks and opportunities, and gave them the confidence to build.

"Capital doesn't have to be faceless," Eliot murmured to himself.

Eliot sat back in his chair, Hayek's Denationalisation of Money resting on his lap, its spine cracked from years of study. The pages whispered promises of a new world—a world where currencies weren't imposed by governments but emerged naturally through the choices of free individuals.

The chapter he'd been rereading outlined Hayek's vision of private currency issuance: competing currencies vying for trust in the marketplace, with individuals deciding which to adopt based on their utility, stability, and integrity.

Eliot tapped his pen against the edge of the book. Hayek's theory had always intrigued him, but he'd never thought it could be more than theoretical. Yet now, with the rapid decentralisation Sheffield was experiencing, the idea felt tantalisingly within reach.

What if Sheffield didn't just use Bitcoin? What if the he created his own own currency—a currency that reflected the city's unique values, its identity, its culture?

SheffCoin.

The name formed in his mind before he could stop it.

It wasn't just about creating a new token of exchange, Eliot thought. Bitcoin was brilliant, immutable, and incorruptible—but it was also faceless, universal, devoid of context. Sheffield needed something more personal, more connected to the lives and aspirations of its people.

SheffCoin wouldn't compete with Bitcoin—it would complement it. Backed by Bitcoin reserves, SheffCoin could gain the trust and stability it needed to take root, while also being uniquely tied to Sheffield's cultural sovereignty.

This wasn't just about transactions; it was about relationships. Every SheffCoin spent could tell a story, reflect a choice, strengthen a bond. It would be a currency that lived not just in ledgers, but in lives.

Eliot's mind turned to Mises' regression theorem, the foundation of monetary theory. Mises argued that for any new currency to gain value, it had to be linked to something already valuable. Without that anchor, no one would trust it, let alone use it.

For Bitcoin, that link had been its early utility in niche Darknet markets, where it proved itself as a medium of exchange before evolving into a store of value. SheffCoin, Eliot realised, needed a similar bridge—a way to tie itself to something people already trusted.

Bitcoin, with its established value and global recognition, could be that bridge. SheffCoin could be backed by Bitcoin, creating a foundation of trust while carving out its own identity.

But Eliot didn’t want SheffCoin to be just another asset-backed token. It needed a deeper connection to Sheffield itself.

SheffCoin’s value wouldn’t just come from Bitcoin reserves. It would come from the lives it touched, the culture it enabled, the stories it told.

The idea began to solidify in Eliot’s mind. SheffCoin wouldn’t just be a tool for exchange—it would be a beacon, a way for Sheffield to tell its story on a global stage.

Manchester could have its cold, hard exchanges. Sheffield would have something warmer, richer, more human.

And if SheffCoin succeeded, it wouldn’t just prove the viability of localised currencies. It would show that decentralisation could be more than efficient—it could be beautiful.

Eliot closed the book and reached for his phone. There were people he needed to talk to, plans to set in motion.

SheffCoin isn’t just an idea, he thought. It’s the next step.

Eliot ran a hand through his hair, staring at the diagrams he’d sketched out. Beyond the mechanics, there was a deeper challenge: psychology. People needed to trust SheffCoin not just as a financial tool but as a representation of something bigger.

This, Eliot thought, was where Sheffield’s culture came into play. Where Bitcoin had relied on its technical brilliance and libertarian appeal, SheffCoin would rely on its humanity. It wouldn’t just be a currency; it would be a story—a narrative of community, creativity, and shared purpose.

“Money is trust,” Eliot murmured to himself. “And trust is built through connection.”

The biggest hurdle, Eliot knew, was convincing people to adopt SheffCoin in a world where most were already hesitant about Bitcoin. The key was to make the transition seamless, almost invisible.

Eliot closed the book, his thoughts racing. SheffCoin couldn’t compete with Bitcoin on scale or Manchester’s radical exchanges on efficiency. But it didn’t have to. Its strength would lie in its identity, its ability to foster connection and culture in a way no other currency could.

Hayek’s vision of private currency issuance was rooted in competition—currencies battling for dominance in a free market. But SheffCoin wasn’t about dominance. It was about belonging.

“Let Manchester chase productivity,” Eliot thought. “Sheffield will build something deeper. Something lasting.”

Where Manchester saw capital as an engine, Eliot would see it as a garden—something to be nurtured, tended to, made beautiful.

From there, the idea expanded. A Bank of Sheffield. It wouldn’t just be a financial institution; it would be a cultural cornerstone. A place where people could come to understand capital, to access it in ways that felt personal, supportive, and empowering.

It would be decentralised in principle but human in practice. A system that combined the best of Bitcoin's transparency and security with the warmth and connection that the banking sector had lost.

"It's not about competing with Manchester," Eliot said aloud. "It's about building something better."

Eliot could already hear Thorne's voice in his mind, sharp and dismissive. Private currency? A bank? That's just another power structure, another form of control.

But Eliot didn't see it that way. A bank wasn't inherently oppressive. Like any tool, its impact depended on how it was used. Sheffield's bank would be different. It would operate on principles of voluntarism, transparency, and accountability.

Let Thorne have his exchanges, Eliot thought. Sheffield will have its bank. Its heart. A voluntary network of exchange.

Eliot's pulse quickened as the pieces began to fall into place. He would need allies, advisors, people who understood both the technology and the philosophy behind it. He would need to sell the idea to Sheffield—not as a competitor to Manchester's vision, but as a complement to it.

Most of all, he would need to believe in it himself.

Eliot stood, the excitement bubbling beneath his exhaustion. The Bank of Sheffield wasn't just an idea—it was a declaration. A way to show the world that Sheffield's softer, cultural approach could be just as innovative, just as transformative, as Thorne's radicalism.

And perhaps, he thought, it could be the start of something even greater.

Eliot sat in the corner of his favourite café, the hum of Sheffield's streets filtering through the open windows. His notebook lay open on the table, pages filled with sketches, flowcharts, and half-formed ideas. The Bank of Sheffield was no longer just a thought experiment. It was becoming real, and the weight of what that meant was beginning to settle on him.

This wasn't just about launching a new currency or opening a financial institution. It was about creating a system that embodied Sheffield's values: decentralisation with a human touch, cultural sovereignty rooted in trust and community. And to make it work, he would need more than a vision—he would need people.

Eliot's first challenge was finding backers. The Bank of Sheffield needed capital to launch, and not just financial capital. It needed believers—people who shared his vision of a softer, more empathetic approach to decentralisation.

His mind turned to Sheffield's artists, entrepreneurs, and community leaders. They were already invested in the city's cultural renaissance. Would they see the value in tying their efforts to a new monetary system?

Eliot jotted down a list of potential allies:

- **Local Artists and Makers**: The cultural bedrock of Sheffield. If they embraced SheffCoin, it could become a symbol of the city's creative identity.

- **Small Business Owners**: They would benefit from a local currency that kept wealth circulating within Sheffield.
- **Bitcoin Enthusiasts**: The city's early adopters of cryptocurrency, who might be intrigued by the idea of a Bitcoin-inspired but culturally unique currency.
- **Philosophical Allies**: People who believed in Eliot's vision of cultural individualism and wanted to see it succeed.

Eliot imagined the pitch he would need to make:

"The Bank of Sheffield isn't just a financial institution. It's a foundation for a new kind of culture. With SheffCoin, we're creating a currency that isn't just about transactions—it's about relationships. Every coin represents a connection, a shared belief in what Sheffield stands for: creativity, trust, and community."

He would frame it as an investment not just in a currency, but in a future where Sheffield set the standard for what a decentralised city could be.

The next step was convincing people to deposit their wealth—whether in Bitcoin, pounds, or other assets—into the Bank of Sheffield. This was the crux of the challenge. Trust was fragile, and even the smallest misstep could derail the entire project.

Eliot knew he would need to be transparent. The bank would operate on open ledgers, with every transaction and allocation visible to the public. Depositors wouldn't just be customers; they would be stakeholders, with a say in how the bank operated.

The true test of SheffCoin would be whether it could take root as a functional currency. For that, Eliot needed to create a network where it could thrive.

The scale of the task was overwhelming. Every step—finding backers, convincing depositors, building the network—was fraught with challenges. Trust would be hard-won and easily lost. Skeptics would question the viability of a local currency in a world dominated by global systems.

And then there was Manchester. Eliot knew Thorne would seize on any sign of weakness, framing the Bank of Sheffield as just another hierarchy, another power structure.

But Eliot believed in the idea. Not as a competitor to Manchester's radical experiment, but as an alternative—a way to show that decentralisation didn't have to mean cold efficiency or ruthless autonomy. It could mean connection.

Eliot took a deep breath, closing his notebook. The vision was clear, but visions didn't change the world. Action did. He pulled out his phone and began typing a message to Sophie.

"Let's get the team together. We're starting a bank."

Eliot stared at the faintly glowing skyline of Sheffield, the city's soft lights flickering against the evening haze. His mind churned with the implications of what he was about to do. The Bank of Sheffield wasn't just a new project; it was the start of something much bigger—a vision for a society that stood in deliberate contrast to what Thorne was building in Manchester.

Thorne's Manchester was efficient, productive, and ruthlessly focused on autonomy. It was a city built on hard edges, where everything could be measured, traded, or monetised. To Thorne, this was liberation—the stripping away of all unnecessary structures to reveal a raw, unadulterated freedom. A pure free-market, but only a free market, no culture.

What's the point of sovereignty if it leaves us hollow? he thought.

Sheffield, by contrast, would be something else entirely.

The Bank of Sheffield wouldn't just be an economic institution—it would be a foundation for a different kind of society. A society where culture wasn't an afterthought to productivity, but its driving force. Where art, philosophy, and community flourished alongside innovation and trade.

Eliot imagined a Sheffield where galleries, music venues, and theatres were bustling not because they were profitable, but because they were essential. Where creators weren't chasing trends dictated by distant markets, but shaping culture in real-time, supported by a system that valued their contributions as much as any business venture.

This wasn't just about decentralisation. It was about re-humanising the way people interacted with capital. About creating a system that didn't just measure value in coins or ledgers, but in meaning, in beauty, in connection.

Manchester's radical political sovereignty, Eliot thought, treated culture as a by-product—something that might emerge if people had enough freedom and resources to create it. But Sheffield would place culture at the centre.

Productivity is important, Eliot thought. But it's not the purpose of society.

Eliot clenched his fists at the thought, his breath slow and deliberate. As much as he didn't want to admit it, this was becoming a competition. Sheffield and Manchester were no longer just cities—they were philosophies in motion, ideas made manifest in bricks, mortar, and people.

Thorne wouldn't see Sheffield's softer approach as a threat. He'd dismiss it as quaint, overly cautious, a relic of the old world trying to cling to relevance. But that didn't matter.

What mattered was proving that Sheffield's path wasn't just viable—it was necessary.

Eliot wouldn't compete with Manchester on Thorne's terms. He wouldn't chase headlines or mimic the cold precision of DAO-run governance. Instead, Sheffield would build something unique, something vibrant. A city where freedom wasn't just a means to an end, but a platform for creation, connection, and meaning.

Eliot allowed himself a faint smile. If Sheffield succeeded, it wouldn't just be a counterpoint to Manchester. It would be an example for the world—a reminder that decentralisation didn't have to mean isolation, that sovereignty didn't have to mean coldness.

This wasn't about beating Manchester, not really. It was about showing that there was more than one way to decentralise, more than one way to build a better world.

But still, the rivalry was undeniable. Sheffield and Manchester were two ideas, two visions, colliding in real-time. And the world was watching.

Let Thorne have his stock exchanges and DAOs, Eliot thought. We'll build something richer. Something lasting.

The room was quiet except for the faint hum of a heater tucked in the corner. It wasn't grand—Eliot had chosen a small function space above a local pub, its wood-panelled walls and modest furnishings lending an unassuming charm to the occasion. Around the table sat Sheffield's potential backers: a mix of local entrepreneurs, artists, Bitcoin enthusiasts, and community leaders.

Eliot stood at the head of the table, his notebook open in front of him, a glass of water untouched beside it. He'd rehearsed this pitch in his mind a hundred times, but now, faced with the expectant faces of the people before him, the weight of the moment settled firmly on his shoulders.

"Thank you all for coming," Eliot began, his voice steady but firm. "I know your time is valuable, and I appreciate you giving me some of it tonight. What I want to share with you is more than just an idea. It's a vision—a way for Sheffield to lead, not just in the North, but in the world."

He let the words hang for a moment before continuing.

"You've all seen what's happening in Manchester. Alexander Thorne has created a system that's bold, radical, and undeniably effective in its own way. But it's also cold. Manchester's decentralisation is built on pure efficiency—DAOs, stock exchanges, trade networks. Everything measured, everything monetised. And while that has its strengths, I believe Sheffield can offer something different. Something better."

Eliot glanced around the room, making eye contact with each person as he spoke.

"Sheffield isn't Manchester. And that's a good thing. Our city has always been about more than just industry or profit. We're a city of makers, of artists, of communities that care about each other. What I'm proposing is a system that reflects those values. A decentralised approach, yes, but one that places culture and connection at its heart."

He picked up his notebook, flipping it open to a diagram he'd sketched earlier. At the centre was the Bank of Sheffield, with arrows radiating outward to labels like SheffCoin, Cultural Loans, Community Investments, and Decentralised Support Networks.

"The Bank of Sheffield will be more than a financial institution," he said. "It will be a foundation for cultural individualism. A way to empower artists, entrepreneurs, and communities—not just with money, but with trust, with tools, with opportunities. Manchester is building a city based on productivity. Sheffield will build a city based on meaning. We'll be a beacon for those who believe in freedom, but also in responsibility—for those who value not just what they earn, but what they create."

He leaned forward slightly, his gaze steady. "This won't be easy. It's going to take time, effort, and belief. But I truly believe that if we do this, Sheffield can show the world that decentralisation doesn't have to be cold or impersonal. It can be human. It can be beautiful."

The room was quiet for a moment, the weight of Eliot's words settling over the group. One of the backers, a middle-aged woman with sharp eyes and a no-nonsense demeanour, spoke up first.

"It's an ambitious vision," she said. "But what about trust? People are skeptical of banks, even decentralised ones. How do you convince them to deposit their money? To believe in this system?"

Eliot nodded, his expression thoughtful. "Trust is everything. That's why transparency is at the core of this system. Every transaction, every decision, will be open for anyone to see. And this isn't just about me or the Bank. It's about you—about the people in this room, and the communities we represent. Trust comes from relationships, and that's what this is about."

Another backer, a young man with a Bitcoin hoodie, leaned forward. "How do you stop this from becoming just another power structure? Isn't this just centralisation under a different name?"

"It's a fair question," Eliot replied. "But the key difference is choice. This isn't about coercion. It's about creating a system that people can opt into—or out of—freely. Power isn't the problem. Misused power is. And by decentralising decision-making and ensuring transparency, we minimise the risks."

As the discussion continued, Eliot could see the glimmers of belief forming in the room. Questions turned to suggestions, concerns to excitement. By the end of the night, the group left with a sense that they were on the cusp of something transformative—not just for Sheffield, but for themselves.

Eliot stayed behind, staring at the now-empty room. The challenges were vast, the risks immense. But for the first time in weeks, he felt something else, too: hope.

Alexander Thorne leaned back in his chair, the article glowing on his tablet as he sipped a dark espresso. The minimalist office surrounding him—a bare desk, a single chair, and walls adorned only with charts of Bitcoin's growth—seemed an extension of his philosophy: efficient, functional, stripped of excess and some might even say style.

The title of the article read: Sheffield's Vision: The Bank of Sheffield and a New Cultural Sovereignty.

He smirked. "Cultural sovereignty," he murmured, almost amused. "Eliot Ashton, the poet-philosopher of decentralisation. Always weaving sentimentality into his systems."

He scrolled through the details of the project, his sharp eyes darting over phrases like SheffCoin, cultural loans, and community investment. The Bank of Sheffield was undeniably ambitious. It represented everything Eliot championed: community, trust, and balance.

But to Thorne, it also represented something else. Weakness.

Thorne set the tablet down, staring out the window at Manchester's skyline. The city was humming with activity, its Bitcoin exchanges buzzing with trades, its decentralised organisations coordinating in real-time. Manchester was alive with purpose—a city built on productivity, technology, and the raw power of unfiltered autonomy.

"Sheffield," Thorne said aloud, "is building a scaffold for its people. Manchester is teaching its people to build for themselves."

The distinction, to him, was clear. Sheffield's approach was softer, more centralised despite its rhetoric of decentralisation. The Bank of Sheffield, for all its transparency and voluntaryism, was still a bank—a structure designed to guide, to support, to cushion. Its SheffCoin was backed by Bitcoin, yes, but it introduced an intermediary layer, a dilution of pure sovereignty.

"Fiat by another name," Thorne muttered.

To Thorne, Sheffield's focus on culture and connection, while admirable in its own way, was ultimately a distraction. Productivity and innovation were the engines of freedom. A society that prioritised art over action, connection over competition, risked stagnation.

"Sheffield wants to create meaning," he thought. "Manchester wants to create momentum."

He respected Eliot's intellect, his vision, even his sincerity. But Thorne was confident that Manchester's radical approach—its untainted Bitcoin maximalism, its commitment to dismantling all traditional structures—would ultimately prove victorious.

Bitcoin didn't need scaffolds or soft touches. It was incorruptible, immutable, a force of nature that thrived on pure, unadulterated autonomy. Manchester's embrace of this philosophy was total. And in Thorne's mind, that purity would outlast Sheffield's cautious blend of old and new.

Still, Thorne couldn't ignore Sheffield entirely. The Bank of Sheffield was an intriguing experiment, and Eliot's charisma ensured that it would attract attention. Sheffield's softer approach might appeal to those who found Manchester's rawness intimidating.

"Let them have their culture," Thorne said, his tone dismissive. "Let them weave their stories, paint their murals, and call it sovereignty. It won't matter when the systems they rely on can't keep pace."

He tapped a message into his phone, sending it to one of Manchester's decentralised trade coordinators.

"Double down on the exchanges," he typed. "Push the DAO governance model harder. If Sheffield wants to play banker, let's remind the world who controls the real wealth."

Thorne's confidence was unwavering, but even he couldn't entirely dismiss the competition. Sheffield and Manchester were diverging rapidly, their paths irreconcilable. One city was building a system for people to feel supported; the other, a system for people to thrive or fail on their own terms.

"It's not just a rivalry," Thorne thought, leaning back in his chair. "It's a proving ground. A battle of philosophies. And history doesn't remember the soft touch. It remembers the victors."

As the light of Manchester's bustling cityscape poured into his office, Thorne smirked. Sheffield's Bank might offer solace, but Manchester's vision offered something greater: the raw, uncompromising promise of freedom.

Chapter 6:

In just a year, the Bank of Sheffield had transformed the city. What had once been a scattered network of individual efforts was now a vibrant ecosystem of interconnected hubs, each branch of the Bank acting as more than a financial institution.

The branch on Devonshire Green housed a theatre and a recording studio, its upper floors filled with office spaces where young entrepreneurs and seasoned artisans worked side by side. In Sharrow Vale, a branch known as The Workshop hosted woodworking classes, while in Kelham Island, The Foundry doubled as a café and a metal smithing studio.

Each branch was unique, designed to reflect the neighbourhood it served. Pubs, coffee shops, community rooms, and even micro-factories filled these spaces, making them central to the cultural and economic life of Sheffield.

This wasn't just a bank; it was a network of production, a series of hubs where people didn't just store capital—they created it.

The SheffCoin economy had grown exponentially, its use now ubiquitous across the city. From the smallest market stalls to artisanal phone manufacturers, SheffCoin had become the dominant currency. It powered a circular economy, driving trust and loyalty among businesses and residents alike.

Artists could sell their work directly to patrons, using SheffCoin-backed tools provided by the Bank. Local businesses could issue their own branded currencies, backed by SheffCoin, allowing them to foster deeper connections with their customers. Even those initially sceptical of the new currency had been won over, as the Bank's transparent practices and cultural investments demonstrated its value.

Eliot had grown into his role as the Bank's leader, balancing his philosophical vision with the pragmatism required to oversee such a sprawling institution. He spent his days shuttling between branches, meeting with artisans, economists, and community leaders, ensuring the Bank remained true to its principles while adapting to the challenges of its rapid growth.

Despite his success, Eliot remained deeply philosophical about the Bank's role. He saw it not just as an economic experiment but as a living embodiment of his ideals—high liberalism and hypermodernity in action. For Eliot, the Bank wasn't just about money; it was about creating a society where culture and community flourished alongside economic innovation.

The comparison with Manchester had become starker over the past year. While Sheffield had embraced a model rooted in creativity and cultural individualism, Manchester had doubled down on its productivity-focused vision.

Manchester's decentralised industrial hubs were the epitome of efficiency, powered by DAOs and automation. Factories churned out mass-produced goods, from electric cars to modular housing, their operations seamless and precise. The city had positioned itself as a global leader in industrial decentralisation, attracting investors and technologists from around the world.

But Sheffield's approach had given it a different kind of power. Artisanal car manufacturers, bespoke electronics producers, and boutique clothing designers were thriving, their products celebrated not just for their quality but for their story, their connection to the city's identity.

Where Manchester was a machine, Sheffield was an organism—complex, adaptive, and alive.

Alexander Thorne, unsurprisingly, was scathing in his critique of Eliot's work. To him, the Bank of Sheffield was a betrayal of Bitcoin's core principles.

"Fiat with a fancy hat," Thorne had called it in a recent interview. "Eliot Ashton isn't decentralising Sheffield; he's rebuilding the very structures Bitcoin was designed to destroy. Banking? Private currency issuance? It's all a smokescreen. Sheffield will crumble under its own contradictions."

Thorne's words echoed across the Bitcoin community, where purists debated whether Sheffield's experiment was a bold adaptation or a dangerous deviation.

But Eliot had little time for Thorne’s critiques. “Let him talk,” he’d told Sophie during a quiet moment at The Foundry. “We’re not trying to outpace Manchester. We’re trying to show that there’s another way.”

On one Tuesday Eliot stepped into the Bramall Lane branch of the Bank of Sheffield, greeted by the hum of activity that had become the hallmark of his creation. This was one of the Bank’s most ambitious locations: a former industrial warehouse transformed into a multi-use space that was as dynamic as the city itself.

To his left, the wide, open-floor design housed a football pitch where a local youth team was training. Shouts and laughter echoed across the space as the players passed, tackled, and sprinted under the watchful eye of their coach. Above them, the second-floor mezzanine buzzed with quiet productivity—co-working spaces filled with laptops, whiteboards, and the occasional chatter of collaboration.

Eliot paused to take it all in. This was what he’d envisioned: a place where productivity and culture coexisted, where the humblest aspirations could grow alongside the grandest.

He turned toward the quieter side of the building, where a group of people sat in a circle, their voices low but animated. A loan officer noticed him and gestured toward the gathering.

“They’re pitching a loan idea,” she said, smiling. “A mushroom cultivation business for local restaurants.”

Eliot raised an eyebrow. “Mushrooms?”

“Apparently, gourmet, medicinal, and psilocybin varieties are in high demand,” the officer replied. “They’re hoping to supply chefs across Sheffield with fresh, locally grown produce.”

Eliot nodded, intrigued. “Mind if I sit in?”

“Of course not.”

Eliot approached the group, pulling up a chair. The applicants—two young women and an older man—were mid-pitch, their enthusiasm palpable as they outlined their vision.

“We’ve already identified an empty warehouse in Neepsend that would be perfect,” one of the women was saying. “With a SheffCoin loan, we can buy the initial spores and growing equipment locally. Everything stays within Sheffield, from sourcing to selling.”

The older man chimed in, his voice steady and practical. “The culinary scene here is booming. Restaurants are always looking for unique, fresh ingredients, and mushrooms are versatile. The gourmet chefs will eat this up.”

Eliot leaned forward, resting his elbows on his knees. “What varieties are you thinking of growing?” he asked, his tone curious but measured.

“Lion’s mane, oyster, shiitake,” the younger woman replied quickly. “And we’ve been researching medicinal mushrooms, too—reishi, cordyceps. They’re gaining popularity in the wellness market.”

The loan officer cleared her throat. “The plan is sound, but I have to ask—do you have any experience in cultivation? Growing mushrooms at scale isn’t as straightforward as it seems.”

The younger woman smiled. “That’s where George comes in,” she said, gesturing to the older man. “He’s been growing mushrooms as a hobby for years. He’s got the expertise we need to get started.”

George nodded. “I’ve already worked out the humidity, temperature, and light requirements for each variety. We’ll start small, but with the right setup, we can scale quickly.”

Eliot leaned back, considering their proposal. This was exactly what the Bank was designed for: enabling local ideas to flourish, creating businesses that contributed to Sheffield’s unique ecosystem. But it wasn’t without risk.

“What’s your backup plan?” Eliot asked. “If the restaurants don’t buy as much as you’re projecting, how will you adapt?”

The younger woman nodded, unfazed by the question. “We’ve thought about that. We can sell directly to consumers at farmer’s markets, and there’s potential to partner with wellness brands for the medicinal mushrooms. The demand is there—we just need the resources to meet it. And of course we can sell the psilocybin mushrooms to some of the rave warehouses. The plan has always got opportunities.”

The loan officer turned to Eliot, her pen hovering over her notebook. “What do you think, Mr. Ashton?”

“I think,” Eliot said slowly, “that this is exactly the kind of project the Bank exists to support.” He smiled. “You’ve got my vote.”

The group beamed, their excitement filling the room. The loan officer nodded, making notes in her ledger.

As Eliot left the meeting, he glanced back at the football team still training on the pitch, the co-working spaces buzzing above, and the mushroom entrepreneurs now shaking hands with the loan officer. This wasn’t just a bank—it was a living, breathing part of Sheffield, a place where ideas took root and flourished.

It was moments like this, Eliot thought, that made the challenges worth it. Sheffield wasn’t just surviving—it was thriving.

Meanwhile, Manchester was unrecognisable from the city it had been only a couple of years ago. Its transformation had become a subject of fascination and debate across the world, a case study in decentralised economic acceleration. Under Thorne’s hardline Bitcoin philosophy, the city had adopted a radical focus on productivity, innovation, and global trade. The results were staggering, with Manchester outpacing every other city in the UK when measured by the Economic Growth Index (EGI).

The first pillar of Manchester’s success was its energy production. With its adoption of Bitcoin mining as a cornerstone of economic activity, the city had restructured its energy grid to prioritise efficiency and decentralisation. Renewable energy sources—solar arrays on rooftops, nuclear power plants and geothermal energy—had been integrated into a vast, peer-to-peer energy network. Excess energy was used to power Bitcoin mining operations, turning what would otherwise have been waste into economic value.

Energy production wasn't just a resource; it was a currency, directly tied to Manchester's ability to trade globally. By normalising energy use against the EGI baseline, Manchester's output consistently outperformed expectations. Its self-sustaining grid became the lifeblood of its industries, fostering a system where energy was as much a commodity as the Bitcoin it secured.

Factories across the city operated as independent nodes in a vast network, producing everything from modular housing units to electric vehicles. Smart contracts ensured that payments and deliveries were seamless, trustless, and instantaneous. This approach had slashed transaction costs, eliminated middlemen, and allowed Manchester to export its goods to markets around the globe with unprecedented efficiency.

The city's towering skyscrapers weren't just symbols of its prosperity; they were vertical hubs of production, housing offices, workshops, and trade nodes. Manchester's exports—high-tech goods, advanced industrial machinery, and mass-produced electronics—were in demand worldwide, their quality and cost undercutting traditional manufacturing centres.

The third and most critical component of Manchester's EGI dominance was its relentless focus on productivity growth. Automation and artificial intelligence had been embraced at every level, from factory floors to municipal services. Tasks that once required human labour were now handled by machines and algorithms, allowing the city's workforce to focus on higher-order innovation.

DAOs managed everything from waste disposal to infrastructure maintenance, ensuring that Manchester operated with unparalleled efficiency. While this approach had displaced many traditional jobs, Thorne's vision left little room for sentimentality. "Innovation requires sacrifice," he was fond of saying. "Productivity is freedom."

The city had become a magnet for technologists, engineers, and entrepreneurs, all drawn by its reputation as the ultimate laboratory for decentralised industrial progress. The influx of talent further accelerated Manchester's growth, creating a feedback loop of innovation and economic expansion.

Walking through the streets of Manchester, the pace of progress was impossible to ignore. Towering skyscrapers lined the horizon, their glass façades glinting in the sunlight. Factories hummed with activity, their operations visible through massive windows that showcased the city's ethos of transparency and efficiency.

The air buzzed with ambition. Markets operated on smart contracts, their stalls stocked with goods produced in micro-factories scattered throughout the city. Bullet trains departed from sleek new stations, carrying Manchester's exports to ports and cities across Europe.

But beneath the surface, the rapid pace of growth brought its own challenges. The city's focus on productivity often left little room for leisure or reflection. Culture, in the traditional sense, felt like an afterthought—something that emerged sporadically, rather than being cultivated deliberately.

For many, Manchester's success was thrilling, a validation of Thorne's uncompromising philosophy. For others, it was disconcerting, a reminder that progress often came at the expense of humanity's softer edges.

When measured against the EGI, Manchester was surging ahead of Sheffield. Its ability to generate surplus energy, facilitate seamless trade, and outpace productivity baselines gave it an undeniable edge.

Thorne's philosophy had seeped into every aspect of life in the city. The absence of traditional power structures had, paradoxically, created an unspoken but deeply entrenched hierarchy—one where strength, resilience, and the ability to thrive without support were the ultimate virtues.

Thorne had convinced the people of Manchester that life under his vision of decentralisation was a test of character, a proving ground for the strong and self-disciplined.

"Endure hardship, embrace challenge, do not seek softness," had become an unofficial motto, repeated in Thorne's speeches and echoed in the DAOs that governed Manchester's decentralised institutions.

The city's public spaces reflected this ethos. Parks once filled with laughter and play had been repurposed into outdoor gyms, their sleek, utilitarian designs emphasising function over leisure. Murals that might have celebrated community or art now bore quotes from Thorne or Stoic philosophers:

"The obstacle is the way."
"Man is made for toil."
"Freedom comes only to those who can bear its weight."

The people seemed to embody this shift. There was a tension in their movements, a sharpness in their interactions. Conversations were direct and utilitarian. Smiles were rare, not out of hostility but because they were considered unnecessary, frivolous.

With this neo-stoicism came aggression—not the unthinking violence of chaos, but a calculated, purposeful edge that permeated life in Manchester. The absence of traditional power structures had made personal strength and self-sufficiency paramount. In a city where no one had the authority to enforce rules, people had learned to assert themselves with unwavering clarity.

Physical fitness became a marker of status. Gyms were among the most frequented spaces in the city, and martial arts dojos thrived as training grounds not just for sport, but for survival in an unregulated world. People walked with purpose, their strides long and deliberate, their gazes unflinching.

In Manchester, even the most personal aspects of life—dating, intimacy, and relationships—had been reshaped by the city's hard-edged ethos. The stoic, utilitarian culture that dominated public life extended into private interactions, creating a dating scene unlike anything else in the world.

Gone were the days of romance, long courtships, or the vulnerability of love. Dating in Manchester was direct, transactional, and, above all, efficient. The people of Manchester, reoriented by Thorne's philosophy, saw little value in emotional entanglements or the inefficiencies of prolonged relationships. What mattered was the utility of the interaction and the satisfaction it could bring in the immediate term.

Pleasure in Manchester had been reduced to its most functional form. The orgasm, long tied to human connection and intimacy, was now seen as a measurable outcome—a goal to be optimised, perfected, and achieved with precision.

"You don't date to fall in love here," a young professional had remarked in a DAO-organised panel on modern relationships. "You date to fulfil a need. Love is messy. An orgasm is simple."

The perfect body, the perfect performance, the perfect outcome—these were the metrics by which relationships were judged. Manchester's citizens trained their bodies and honed their skills with the same discipline they applied to their work, believing that mastery of physical pleasure was not just an individual achievement but a societal good.

Physical fitness transcended mere health; it became the ultimate emblem of status and prowess in Manchester. Gyms weren't just frequented; they were worshipped as temples where the body was sculpted into a weapon of desire and dominance. Martial arts dojos doubled as arenas where one could test not only their physical strength but their sexual stamina and technique.

In this city, every aspect of life, including intimacy, was stripped down to its rawest, most primal form. Dating was no longer about connection or romance but rather a pursuit of pure, unadulterated pleasure.

The streets of Manchester buzzed with an unspoken agreement; the hunt for the perfect orgasm was on. Here, the orgasm wasn't just an act of physical release; it was a science, a performance to be perfected.

In the heart of Manchester, an underground club known simply as "The Pulse" became the epicentre of this new hedonistic culture. "The Pulse" hosted what was known as the "Peak Performance Night," where the city's elite gathered not for conversation and dance but for communal ecstasy.

The room was laid out like an ancient coliseum, with rings where couples or groups could perform, watched by others, all in the name of learning, perfecting, and sharing techniques. Biofeedback devices buzzed around, providing real-time data on arousal, heart rate, and even predicting the exact moment of climax, turning what was once personal into a public spectacle of science.

The night started with what was known as "The Warm-Up," where individuals or small groups would engage in preliminary activities, often under the watchful eyes of others. This wasn't just foreplay but a demonstration of technique, stamina, and control.

One couple, known for their ability to synchronize their orgasms, became the night's highlight. They moved with a precision that was almost mechanical, their breathing and movements choreographed to the millisecond, culminating in a shared climax that was both an achievement and a spectacle.

Post-performance, participants gathered around, not for intimacy but to discuss, critique, and learn. "Did you see how they maintained their rhythm?" one would say, while another might comment, "Their recovery time was exceptional."

In this setting, the orgasm was not just a moment but an event, celebrated with the same fervour as a scientific breakthrough. It was measured, analysed, and optimized.

"Why should we leave anything to chance when we can master our bodies and our pleasure?" was a common mantra, echoing Thorne's philosophy of autonomy and efficiency.

Yet, beneath this surface of hedonistic efficiency, questions lingered. The pursuit of perfection in pleasure left many feeling paradoxically empty, questioning if this was true freedom or merely another form of control.

And for those willing to take it further, new technologies—biofeedback devices, AI-assisted intimacy coaching—promised to push the boundaries of human sexual optimisation.

Underneath this focus on physicality and pleasure was a deeper, almost subconscious purpose. Thorne's philosophy of decentralised autonomy had no place for traditional family structures, but it quietly encouraged reproduction as a productive enterprise.

The logic was simple: a society that optimised pleasure could also optimise reproduction. The perfection of the orgasm wasn't just an end in itself; it was a means of ensuring the continuity of the city's population without relying on traditional family dynamics that were seen as reducing productivity.

Children, born of these utilitarian encounters, would be raised by decentralised cooperatives rather than nuclear families. The efficiency of this system appealed to the city's stoic sensibilities, ensuring that even the next generation would grow up within the framework of independence and self-sufficiency.

Despite his insistence on dismantling all traditional power structures, Alexander Thorne had become an undeniable force in Manchester. He had positioned himself as the ultimate decentralised node—not a ruler or governor, but the living embodiment of the city's ethos.

People didn't follow Thorne because they were told to; they followed him because they believed in him. His speeches were gospel, his ideas the framework for Manchester's new reality. In a city without coercion, Thorne had achieved something remarkable: voluntary authority.

Through his presence and philosophy, he had become the unspoken centre of the city. Decisions weren't made by him directly, but his influence was everywhere. DAOs debated and executed policies that mirrored his ideals. Communities operated with a shared understanding of his vision.

Thorne's power wasn't official, but it was immense. And it was growing.

Compared to Sheffield, Manchester was a city of raw, unyielding pragmatism. Where Sheffield's branches of the Bank were hubs of creativity, Manchester's decentralised nodes were engines of output. Sheffield's artisans and cultural producers had no counterpart in Manchester, where automation and mass production had eliminated the need for small-scale craft.

Sheffield thrived on relationships, on trust and connection. Manchester thrived on independence, on the hard edge of a society where every person was their own island.

As Manchester surged ahead on the Economic Growth Index, its critics and supporters alike debated whether its success was sustainable—or even desirable. Could a city built on such relentless efficiency sustain its humanity?

Thorne, of course, dismissed these concerns. To him, the humanity of Manchester's people wasn't diminished by their hardness—it was elevated by it. "Softness is a luxury," he often said. "And luxury is for the weak."

For now, Manchester's progress was undeniable. But as the city hurtled forward, driven by Thorne's vision, the question remained: at what cost?

The people of Sheffield, influenced by Eliot Ashton's philosophy, viewed relationships as a form of creative expression, a dance of individuality and connection. Dating wasn't about achieving perfection or maximising efficiency; it was about finding meaning in the act of being with another soul, about building something intangible and enduring.

Sheffield's dating culture thrived in the city's many cultural spaces. Couples wandered through galleries, sharing thoughts on the latest installations. First dates unfolded in the cosy corners of pubs where local musicians performed and laughter filled the air. Theatres hosted plays that celebrated the chaos and beauty of love, their audiences often leaving hand in hand, buoyed by the shared experience.

Unlike Manchester's brutal efficiency, where every encounter was judged by its immediate utility, Sheffield valued the slow burn of connection. Relationships here were as much about the journey as the destination, the small moments of discovery and understanding that came with truly knowing another person.

The city's focus on art and culture also shaped its approach to intimacy. Physical connection wasn't reduced to mere performance; it was seen as an extension of emotional and intellectual bonds. Sheffielders prided themselves on crafting experiences that were as much about vulnerability and trust as they were about pleasure.

Eliot's philosophy placed love at the heart of Sheffield's cultural revival. He often spoke about the need for relationships to inspire creativity, to challenge individuals to grow while also anchoring them in a shared humanity.

"Love is not weakness," he had once said at a public forum. "It's a mirror we hold up to ourselves, revealing both our flaws and our potential. It's the most powerful form of decentralisation, the melding of two sovereign individuals into something greater than themselves."

This belief resonated across the city. Love, in Sheffield, wasn't a frivolous luxury but a cornerstone of its ethos—a way for people to connect with one another and with the larger community.

The people of Sheffield didn't rush relationships. Courtship, a word long considered outdated elsewhere, still carried weight here. Couples took the time to explore each other's worlds, often walking together through the Peak District or attending community events. Love wasn't transactional; it was transformational.

Where Manchester's dating culture focused on the perfection of the orgasm, Sheffield celebrated the imperfections of love—the awkwardness of a first kiss, the uncertainty of shared feelings, the slow unfolding of trust.

Manchester's philosophy saw emotional entanglements as distractions. Sheffield saw them as essential.

Eliot often reflected on this contrast. "Manchester chases output," he had told Sophie one evening. "But Sheffield creates meaning. We don't just live—we thrive because we care for one another."

"I was at the Devonshire Green branch the other night—there was a storytelling event. You could feel it, you know? People connecting, sharing something real. It's messy, and awkward, and wonderful."

Eliot smiled faintly. "Messy is good," he said. "We're human. If there's no room for imperfection, there's no room for growth. That's the difference between us and Manchester."

Sophie raised an eyebrow. “Speaking of which, have you seen the latest?”

Eliot nodded grimly. Thorne’s grand experiments were all over the headlines again. Manchester was surging ahead economically, its EGI numbers soaring as its industrial engine roared to life. But beneath the surface, something colder lurked—Thorne’s strange fixation on reducing even intimacy to its most functional form.

“Thorne’s using the orgasm,” Eliot said, his tone sharper than usual. “He’s turned it into a tool. A weapon, almost. Pleasure without meaning, stripped of connection or vulnerability. It’s like he’s taken the soul out of joy.”

Sophie set her glass down. “But the people seem to be going along with it. You’ve seen the forums, the articles. They’re calling it liberation.”

“Liberation from what?” Eliot shot back. “From their own humanity? From the complexity of love, of relationships? It’s not liberation, Sophie—it’s submission. Thorne’s selling them the idea that freedom is efficiency, that connection is weakness. And they’re buying it because it’s easier than confronting their own fears.”

Sophie regarded him for a moment, her expression unreadable. “You sound angry,” she said softly.

Eliot sighed, rubbing the bridge of his nose. “Maybe I am,” he admitted. “But not at them. At him. He’s so convinced that his vision is the only path that he’s willing to strip the humanity out of everything to prove it.”

“And yet,” Sophie said, leaning forward slightly, “you can’t shake the feeling that you might be missing something.”

Eliot met her gaze, startled by her candour.

“Thorne’s vision is harsh,” Sophie continued. “But you can’t deny that Manchester is thriving in its own way. The people are productive, disciplined. Maybe they’ve found a kind of happiness in that clarity. Maybe their version of joy is just… different.”

Eliot frowned. “A joy without love?”

“Maybe,” Sophie said. “Or maybe love isn’t what they need. Maybe Thorne’s stripped it away because he doesn’t believe in it—but what if they’ve found something else in its place? What if their soulless joy, as you call it, is working better than we think?”

Eliot leaned forward, his elbows resting on his knees. “You’re suggesting I go and see it for myself.”

Sophie shrugged. “Aren’t you curious? I mean, you’re always talking about balance, about understanding other perspectives. What if you’re wrong, Eliot? What if Thorne’s vision really is working for them?”

Eliot was silent for a long moment, staring at the floor. “If I go,” he said finally, “it’s not because I think he’s right. It’s because I want to know what they’re giving up to live that way. What they’re sacrificing for his version of freedom.”

Sophie nodded, her expression thoughtful. “You’re not afraid of being wrong, are you?”

Eliot shook his head. “No. I’m afraid of not understanding. If Manchester is as happy as they claim, I need to know why. And if it’s not…”

“You’ll know what we’re fighting for here,” Sophie finished.

Eliot leaned back again, his gaze distant. The idea of walking into Thorne’s world unsettled him, but he couldn’t deny the pull of curiosity. If he was going to shape Sheffield’s future, he needed to understand the paths not taken—the choices that led to Manchester’s stark, stoic reality.

“Alright,” he said finally. “I’ll go. But not as a rival, and not as a spy. Just as someone trying to understand.”

Sophie raised her glass, a small smile tugging at her lips. “To understanding, then.”

Eliot hesitated, then clinked his glass against hers. “To understanding.”

The café had emptied as the evening deepened, leaving only Sophie and Eliot at their corner table. The low hum of Sheffield’s streets outside served as a gentle backdrop to their conversation, and the faint glow of the streetlights painted their reflections on the window beside them.

Sophie swirled the last of her wine in her glass, her gaze drifting to Eliot. “You ever think about it?” she asked suddenly.

Eliot raised an eyebrow. “Think about what?”

“Love. Relationships. All the things we’re supposed to be building here,” she said with a faint smile. “You’re always talking about love being at the heart of what we’re doing. But what about you, Eliot? Do you ever let yourself have any of it?”

Eliot chuckled, but it was a hollow sound. “That’s the problem, isn’t it? I talk about it because I believe in it. Because I think it matters. But I’ve sacrificed a lot for this vision, Sophie. Too much, maybe. Love—real love—requires time. Energy. I’ve given all of mine to Sheffield.”

Sophie leaned back, studying him. “You sound almost proud of that.”

Eliot shook his head. “Not proud. Just resigned. Someone has to hold this together, and for now, that someone is me.”

Sophie tilted her head, her expression thoughtful. “And Thorne? What about him?”

Eliot sighed, rubbing the back of his neck. “Thorne? He’s the opposite of me. He hasn’t sacrificed anything for Manchester—he’s thrown himself into it completely. The city reflects him because he lets himself live out every part of his philosophy.”

“You think he’s… what? Happy?”

Eliot shrugged. “If happiness means indulging every urge and calling it freedom, then maybe. From what I’ve heard, he’s embraced the wildness of Manchester’s scene. The efficiency, the pleasure, the detachment. No strings, no commitments. Just the raw pursuit of what he calls sovereignty.”

Sophie smirked. “You sound a little envious.”

“Not envious,” Eliot replied, though his tone suggested otherwise. “Maybe curious. He’s thrown himself into his vision so completely, and people follow him because of it. But it’s hard not to wonder if he’s just running away from something.”

Sophie leaned forward, her voice softening. “We all run from something, Eliot. I’ve been in and out of love too many times to count, and sometimes I wonder if it’s because I’m too afraid to really let someone in. But you—you’ve made your work your everything. And Thorne’s made his freedom his everything. Neither of you seems all that happy.”

Eliot looked at her, his expression unreadable. “And you? Are you happy?”

Sophie hesitated, then laughed lightly. “Happy enough, I guess. I’ve had love, lost it, found it again. I think the difference between us, Eliot, is that I’m okay with the mess of it. You’re so busy building a perfect world that you don’t let yourself live in the imperfect one.”

Eliot leaned back, exhaling deeply. “You might be right,” he admitted. “But I don’t know how to change it. This—everything we’ve built—it’s bigger than me. Bigger than any one person. If I start thinking about what I want, what I need… I’m afraid I’ll lose focus.”

Sophie reached across the table, her hand brushing his. “Maybe that’s what scares you most about Thorne,” she said gently. “Not that he’s wrong, but that he’s letting himself live in ways you won’t let yourself. He’s all in, Eliot, for better or worse. And you’re holding back.”

Eliot didn’t respond immediately. Instead, he stared down at their hands, the warmth of her touch grounding him in a way he hadn’t expected.

“I don’t know how to be anything else,” he said finally, his voice quiet. “But maybe that’s why I need to see Manchester. To see if Thorne’s way really is better—or if it’s just louder.” Eliot sat alone in the quiet of the café after Sophie had left, her words lingering in his mind. The flicker of Sheffield’s streetlights outside seemed dimmer tonight, his thoughts pulling him elsewhere. If Sheffield was his vision of what could be, then Manchester was the other possibility—a brutal, efficient mirror reflecting a world he could never fully embrace. Yet, he couldn’t shake the need to see it for himself, to walk its streets and feel the pulse of what Thorne was building. I’ll have to go, Eliot thought. Not to admire it, but to understand it.

Chapter 7:

The train rattled steadily out of Sheffield, cutting through the lush green of the Peak District. Eliot sat by the window, staring out at the rolling hills with a furrowed brow. His friends—Sophie, Paul, and a few others from his inner circle—chatted idly around him, their voices blending with the rhythmic hum of the train.

“What’s the plan when we get there, then?” Paul asked, leaning back in his seat.

“We’re going to see what they’ve built,” Eliot replied, his voice quieter than usual.

Sophie, seated across from him, gave him a pointed look. “You’re already bracing yourself to hate it.”

Eliot didn’t answer immediately. Instead, he watched as the first signs of Glossop appeared on the horizon—a cluster of rooftops framed by the Peak’s soft ridges. “I’m bracing myself to understand it,” he said finally.

As the train rolled into Glossop, their conversation was interrupted by the sight of three men waiting on the platform. Dressed in sleek, understated suits, their presence was unmistakable. Sophie leaned over, squinting.

“Is that…?”

“Private security,” Paul said, sounding amused.

The group stepped off the train, greeted by a man in his mid-40s with a clipboard and a professional smile. “Mr. Ashton,” he said, extending a hand. “My name’s Connor. I’ve been assigned to oversee your safety during your visit to Manchester.”

“Assigned?” Eliot asked, raising an eyebrow.

“Recommended,” Connor clarified smoothly. “Public figures like yourself tend to draw attention, and with Manchester’s current policies, public insurance isn’t exactly… accommodating for visitors. Private security is more reliable—and less costly in the long run.”

Eliot exchanged a glance with Sophie, who shrugged. “It’s your call,” she said.

Eliot sighed. “Fine. But I don’t want an entourage. Just keep it discreet.”

Connor nodded. “Of course.”

The transition from Glossop to Manchester was stark. As the train pulled into the city, the landscape transformed from the natural beauty of the Peaks to a bustling urban sprawl. Skyscrapers dominated the skyline, their jagged edges and gleaming surfaces standing as monuments to efficiency and productivity.

The group disembarked, the hum of the city hitting them immediately. The air was charged with energy—a mixture of the relentless movement of people and the industrial hum that seemed to permeate every street.

“Are we falling behind?” Eliot asked quietly as they stopped for a moment to catch their breath.

Sophie placed a hand on his arm. “Eliot, you knew this would be different. You came here to see their path, not to compare it to ours. What we’re doing in Sheffield—it’s not about matching them. It’s about creating something entirely different.”

“I know,” Eliot said, though his voice was uncertain. “But seeing this… it’s hard not to wonder if we’re doing enough. If we’re too idealistic.”

Sophie frowned. “Idealism is what sets us apart. It’s what gives Sheffield its soul.”

Eliot nodded slowly, but the doubt lingered.

The train hissed as it came to a halt at Manchester Piccadilly Station, the platform teeming with people moving with purpose. Eliot stepped off with his group, his gaze instinctively drawn upward to the sweeping architecture that framed the station—sharp, industrial, efficient.

Standing at the far end of the platform was Alexander Thorne. His presence was unmistakable: tall and commanding, dressed in a simple yet tailored dark suit, his sharp features illuminated by the station's cold, fluorescent lights. Around him, a small entourage of aides and advisors lingered discreetly, their movements precise, their gazes alert.

Eliot felt a ripple of recognition as people on the platform noticed the two men. A murmur spread, eyes flicking between them, whispers passing like electricity through the crowd. This wasn't just a meeting between two thinkers—it was a collision of ideas, a symbolic encounter between the rulers of two diverging worlds.

Thorne approached first, his strides long and deliberate, his hand outstretched.

"Eliot Ashton," he said, his voice carrying a warmth that felt almost out of place in Manchester's stark atmosphere. "Welcome to my city."

Eliot took his hand, their handshake firm but measured. "Thank you, Alexander," he replied. "I'm here to see what you've built."

Thorne smiled faintly, his eyes narrowing with a mix of curiosity and amusement. "And what do you think so far? Imposing, isn't it?"

"It's certainly impressive," Eliot said diplomatically.

"Don't feel too bad that Manchester is coming ahead," Thorne said with a chuckle, releasing Eliot's hand and gesturing for him to follow. "We've had the advantage of speed—sheer, relentless speed. But I still respect what you're doing in Sheffield. Private currency issuance was a clever move, even if it's not quite… pure."

As they walked through the station's grand concourse, their respective entourages trailing behind, Eliot felt the weight of the moment pressing down on him. Thorne's tone was genial, almost friendly, but there was an undercurrent of challenge in every word.

"Pure?" Eliot asked, raising an eyebrow.

"Bitcoin doesn't need intermediaries, Eliot," Thorne said, his voice smooth. "No banks, no scaffolds, no frameworks to soften its edges. That's its strength—its incorruptibility. SheffCoin, though? It's a scaffold, a step removed from the truth."

"And yet," Eliot countered, "it works. It builds trust, connection. It's given Sheffield a cultural identity that people believe in."

"True," Thorne conceded, his smile widening. "But identity is a luxury, one Manchester doesn't have time for. We're building something faster, stronger, more efficient. And the world loves efficiency."

The conversation felt less like a discussion and more like a duel, each man testing the other, probing for weaknesses. Thorne exuded confidence, his every word and movement a testament to his belief in Manchester's supremacy.

Eliot, by contrast, carried himself with quiet resolve. His doubts about Sheffield's path were still fresh in his mind, but he refused to let them show. Thorne might be ahead for now, but Eliot believed in his vision—if not in its pace, then in its depth.

"I'll give you this, Eliot," Thorne said as they reached the station's exit, pausing to look back at him. "You've done something remarkable. Sheffield is… different. Unique. And that's valuable, in its way. But remember—difference isn't always strength."

Eliot met his gaze evenly. "Neither is speed."

Thorne's laughter echoed through the station. "Touché."

"I'm glad you've come, Eliot," he said. "Truly. You might find Manchester harsher than you like, but it's worth seeing. If nothing else, it'll sharpen your resolve—or make you rethink it."

Eliot hesitated, then shook his hand. "We'll see."

Thorne gestured toward the waiting cars outside. "Come. Let's show you what we've built."

As they stepped into the Manchester night, Eliot couldn't shake the feeling that he was walking into enemy territory—not as a soldier, but as a rival king stepping onto another's battlefield.

Their tour began at one of Manchester's crown jewels: the Rolls-Royce modular factory, an industrial colossus spanning several city blocks. The facility was a marvel of precision engineering, its façade sleek and functional, with massive glass panels revealing the intricate ballet of production inside.

Thorne led the group through the main entrance, his voice confident and commanding as he gestured toward the cavernous space before them. The air smelled faintly of oil and ozone, and the rhythmic hum of machinery reverberated through the floor.

"Welcome to the Rolls-Royce Nexus," Thorne said, his tone equal parts pride and formality. "This isn't just a factory. It's the beating heart of Manchester's industrial revolution. Everything you see here was designed for one purpose: speed and excellence."

Eliot stepped inside, his eyes widening at the scale of the operation. Rows of automated assembly lines stretched out like veins in a living organism, each one dedicated to a specific component of the company's legendary engines. Mechanical arms whirred and pivoted with uncanny precision, welding, assembling, and inspecting parts in perfect synchronisation.

Above the assembly floor, a latticework of conveyor belts transported gleaming engine components, each marked with a QR code that linked it to the factory's blockchain ledger. The components passed through inspection drones hovering silently above, their cameras scanning for microscopic flaws.

Workers moved alongside the machines, their movements purposeful and exact. Unlike the camaraderie Eliot was accustomed to in Sheffield's artisan workshops, the atmosphere here was intense, almost militaristic. Each worker seemed to operate as part of the machinery itself, their focus unbroken, their efficiency unmatched.

“This line here,” Thorne said, pointing to one of the largest sections of the factory, “produces jet engines. Rolls-Royce exports these to over fifty countries. Last quarter alone, this factory processed contracts worth over £11.2 billion in Bitcoin.”

Eliot raised an eyebrow. “All from one facility?”

Thorne smirked. “All from this one facility. Every bolt, every turbine blade, is tracked and accounted for in real-time. Our DAOs coordinate the supply chains and manage quality assurance autonomously. Humans oversee it, of course, but the system runs itself.”

Thorne led them to a viewing platform overlooking a shipment bay, where completed engines were being loaded into sleek, autonomous freight trucks. Each engine gleamed under the overhead lights, its surface polished to a mirror finish.

“These engines,” Thorne continued, “aren’t just technological marvels—they’re economic powerhouses. Exports from this factory alone account for ten percent of Manchester’s GDP-equivalent. And thanks to our decentralised trade networks, every shipment is paid for instantly via Bitcoin. No intermediaries, no delays.”

Sophie leaned in toward Eliot, her voice low. “This is… overwhelming.”

“It’s impressive,” Eliot admitted, though his tone was subdued.

Thorne glanced back at them, clearly overhearing. “Impressive isn’t the half of it,” he said, his grin sharp. “This isn’t just about engines or exports. This is about showing the world what Manchester can do. We’re not just producing goods—we’re producing trust. When a Rolls-Royce engine leaves this factory, it carries the weight of Manchester’s reputation. And that reputation is unmatched.”

As they walked deeper into the factory, Thorne gestured toward a row of screens displaying live data from the factory’s blockchain. “Every unit of energy used here is accounted for. Every material is optimised. Efficiency, Eliot—that’s what separates us from Sheffield’s… slower approach.”

Eliot didn’t rise to the bait. Instead, he focused on the workers below, their faces drawn and serious. The factory was undeniably extraordinary, but its perfection felt cold, clinical. There was no laughter here, no warmth, no sense of the human touch that defined Sheffield’s artisans.

“This is your vision, then?” Eliot asked finally. “A world where everything is optimised? Where people are just… parts of the machine?”

Thorne stopped, turning to face Eliot directly. “A world where people can be their best,” he corrected. “Where they aren’t weighed down by inefficiency or sentimentality. Look around you, Eliot. This factory doesn’t just produce engines—it produces freedom. Every Bitcoin we earn here strengthens Manchester’s sovereignty. Every shipment we send out brings us closer to true independence.”

Eliot nodded slowly, though his mind churned with unease. For all its brilliance, Thorne’s vision felt brittle, like a structure built so high it risked collapsing under its own weight.

As they left the factory, Eliot lingered at the exit, glancing back at the towering structure. The Rolls-Royce Nexus was a triumph, but it was also a warning.

“This is what we’re up against,” Sophie said quietly, her hand brushing his arm.

Eliot didn’t respond immediately. Instead, he watched the freight trucks roll out into the Manchester streets, their cargo a testament to the city’s relentless drive.

“Sheffield isn’t this,” he said finally, his voice steady but uncertain. “And it can’t be.”

“But is that enough?” Sophie asked, her tone gentle but pointed.

Eliot didn’t answer. The question lingered in the air as they stepped back into the city, the hum of Manchester’s industry echoing in their ears.

Eliot walked in silence as Thorne led the group out of the factory, the crisp evening air hitting him like a wake-up call. The grandeur of Manchester’s industrial prowess weighed heavily on his mind. The scale of its operations, the seamless efficiency, the sheer ambition—it was undeniable.

Yet, something gnawed at him.

“It’s impressive,” Eliot said finally, breaking the silence. “But it’s missing something.”

Thorne glanced back, arching an eyebrow. “Missing what, exactly? We’re producing more than any city in Britain. Our exports dwarf Sheffield’s artisanal products. We’re not just surviving, Eliot—we’re thriving.”

Eliot stopped walking, his voice steady but firm. “You’re thriving materially, yes. But what about culture? People won’t look back and care how many Rolls-Royce engines Manchester exported. They’ll remember the stories, the art, the music, the lives they lived. Culture is as important as productivity—it’s what gives people thymos, a sense of pride, of being part of something meaningful.”

Thorne laughed, the sound sharp and dismissive. “Culture,” he said, shaking his head. “Overrated. You think a song or a painting will save the world? Culture is just another product, Eliot, and Manchester is perfecting it.”

“Perfecting it?” Sophie interjected, incredulous. “How do you perfect something as subjective as culture?”

“By optimising it,” Thorne replied smoothly. “By stripping away the inefficiencies. Our artists use AI to refine their work, our musicians collaborate through blockchain-powered platforms. Every piece of art, every song, is designed to resonate with its audience in the most effective way possible. Culture, Eliot, is just another system—and we’ve made ours the best.”

Eliot shook his head, his tone firm but measured. “That’s not culture, Alexander. That’s content.” He gestured broadly, as if trying to capture something intangible, something that couldn’t be calculated. “Culture isn’t just what people consume—it’s what they create. It’s how they connect. It’s the messy, unpredictable parts of life that refuse to be optimised.”

Thorne’s smirk didn’t waver, but there was a flicker of something in his eyes—curiosity, maybe, or disdain.

“Sheffield’s focus on culture isn’t about efficiency,” Eliot continued, leaning forward slightly. “It’s about meaning. Nobody remembers the factories of Sheffield or Turin. They remember the beauty of York’s cobbled streets, the cathedrals of Florence, the canals of Venice. High culture is what endures. It’s what elevates us. Art, architecture, music—they survive not because they’re useful, but because they’re human.”

Thorne chuckled, folding his arms. “And you think Sheffield’s pottery fairs and theatre nights are the same as Florence and Venice?”

Eliot didn’t flinch. “They’re a start. Culture doesn’t emerge fully formed. It’s nurtured. It grows from the people, from their struggles and triumphs. Sheffield doesn’t need to match Venice or Florence—it needs to become its own version of them, a place where the soul of its people finds expression.”

Thorne shook his head, his voice sharper now. “And while you’re busy nurturing culture, we’ll be building the engines that keep the world running. Beauty doesn’t feed people, Eliot. It doesn’t power their homes or pay their bills.”

“True,” Eliot conceded, his voice calm. “But it gives them something to live for. People don’t look back on the Industrial Revolution and marvel at how efficient it was. They marvel at the paintings of Turner, the poems of Wordsworth. Efficiency without beauty is meaningless, Alexander. And you’re building a world where meaning is a luxury.”

For a moment, the two men locked eyes, their competing visions colliding in the charged silence.

“Perhaps,” Thorne said finally, his tone measured. “But luxury isn’t something most people can afford. Not in Manchester, anyway.”

“And that,” Eliot replied, his voice steady, “is what will make all the difference.”

“And what’s meaning without results?” Thorne countered, stepping closer. “You talk about culture like it’s this sacred thing, but it’s just another part of the economy. Manchester doesn’t waste time romanticising it—we make it work for us.”

“Work for you?” Eliot said, his voice rising slightly. “Culture isn’t supposed to work for anyone. It’s supposed to inspire, to challenge, to reflect the human experience. What you’re building here isn’t culture—it’s control.”

Thorne smirked. “Control is freedom, Eliot. You just don’t see it yet.”

Sophie, sensing the tension, stepped between them. “Alright, enough philosophy for one night. What’s next on the tour?”

Thorne’s grin widened. “Ah, now we’re getting to the fun part. You’ve seen our factories—time to see our nightlife. If you want to understand Manchester’s culture, there’s no better place.”

Eliot frowned. “Nightlife? That’s your example of efficient culture?”

“Why not?” Thorne said, spreading his arms. “It’s the perfect synthesis of pleasure and productivity. Manchester’s nightlife is the most efficient in the world. No wasted time, no pointless distractions—just pure, optimised experience.”

“I’m almost afraid to ask what that looks like,” Sophie muttered under her breath.

Thorne clapped a hand on Eliot's shoulder. "Don't worry, Ashton. You might even enjoy yourself. Come on—let's show you how Manchester parties."

Eliot exchanged a glance with Sophie, his unease palpable. As they followed Thorne toward the city's heart, he couldn't help but wonder what they were about to see—and what it would say about the soul of Manchester.

The heart of Manchester pulsed with an energy that was both exhilarating and disconcerting. Neon lights glowed against the steel and glass of the city's towering structures, reflecting off polished streets alive with people moving with purpose.

"This," Thorne said, gesturing broadly, "is Manchester's culture in action."

Eliot and his group followed as Thorne led them through the streets. The air vibrated with the sound of basslines spilling out of clubs and bars, each venue seeming more packed than the last. People lined up in neat, efficient queues, scanned in quickly with QR codes tied to their wallets, and disappeared into the rhythmic chaos inside.

"Efficient queues?" Sophie whispered to Eliot, her tone laced with irony.

"Efficient everything," Eliot muttered back.

Their first stop was a nightclub known simply as The Grid, housed in a stark, geometric building of black steel. Inside, the club was a sensory overload. Walls of LED screens flashed visuals perfectly synced to the music, a seamless blend of human DJ sets and AI-generated tracks designed to hit peak emotional resonance.

Thorne gestured toward the bar, where drinks were being poured with mechanical precision by robotic arms. "Every track you hear tonight," he said, "is curated based on the crowd. AI monitors body language, heart rates—everything. It adjusts the music in real-time to keep everyone in the zone."

"And what about the people?" Eliot asked, scanning the dance floor. "Are they in the zone?"

The crowd moved in perfect synchrony, their movements almost mechanical. The joy on their faces was there, but it felt thin, forced, as if it were being pulled from them by the relentless beat.

"Of course they are," Thorne replied, grinning. "No wasted time, no awkward lulls. Just pure, optimised pleasure."

They moved to another venue, The Circuit, where the nightlife took a more intimate turn. Private booths surrounded an open dance floor, each equipped with biofeedback devices designed to monitor and enhance the patrons' experience.

Couples and groups sat in these booths, their interactions mediated by glowing screens displaying real-time metrics—heart rates, dopamine levels, even projected peaks of euphoria.

Sophie stared, wide-eyed. "Is this… normal?"

Thorne chuckled. "Normal? This is perfection. No fumbling around, no wondering if the night's been worth it. Every second is engineered to deliver the maximum experience."

“Maximum experience,” Eliot echoed, his voice heavy with disbelief. “You’ve turned pleasure into a science experiment.”

“Science is how we master the world,” Thorne countered. “Why should our nights be any different? Efficiency doesn’t end at the factory door, Eliot. It extends to every part of life—even joy.”

They stepped outside into the cool night air, the hum of the clubs fading behind them. The streets were alive with movement, but there was no chaos here. Groups moved with purpose, their plans pre-determined by apps that calculated the optimal sequence of venues for their preferences.

“What do you think?” Thorne asked, his tone almost smug.

Eliot hesitated, looking around at the polished perfection of it all. The people of Manchester seemed content—happy, even—but something about it felt hollow. The spontaneity, the unpredictability, the mess of human connection had been stripped away.

“I think,” Eliot said slowly, “that it’s impressive.”

“Impressive?” Sophie interjected, her voice sharp. “It’s terrifying.”

Thorne smirked. “Terrifying? Because it works? Because it’s better?”

“Better?” Sophie shot back. “It’s hollow. It’s soulless. Where’s the humanity in all this?”

“The humanity,” Thorne said, his voice softening, “is in the results. These people leave here fulfilled, energised, ready to take on their lives. Isn’t that what culture should do?”

As the group moved away from the glowing streets of Manchester’s nightlife, the tension in the air became palpable. Sophie was quiet, her arms crossed, her disapproval of everything they’d seen written all over her face. Eliot was lost in thought, his unease with Thorne’s vision gnawing at him.

But it was Paul who finally broke the silence.

“I don’t know,” he said, his tone casual but pointed. “I think Thorne might have a point.”

Eliot stopped walking, turning to face him. “What do you mean?”

Paul shrugged, hands stuffed into his coat pockets. “I mean… look around, Eliot. This city works. It’s efficient, it’s alive, and—honestly? The nightlife is miles ahead of Sheffield’s. No awkward pub crawls, no waiting around for something to happen. Here, everything’s seamless.”

Sophie’s eyes widened in disbelief. “You can’t be serious, Paul. That wasn’t nightlife—that was a lab experiment.”

“Maybe,” Paul said, his tone defensive. “But at least it delivers. I’ve spent years watching Sheffield stumble along, trying to find its footing. Manchester doesn’t stumble—it moves.”

Thorne, who had been quietly observing the exchange, took a step forward, his smile as sharp as ever. “You’ve got good instincts, Paul. You see what works. That’s rare these days.”

Paul glanced at him, then back at Eliot. “I’m just saying… maybe we’ve been too focused on the past, on nostalgia, on ideals that don’t really fit the modern world. Sheffield’s great, but it’s… slow. Manchester’s the future.”

Thorne clapped a hand on Paul’s shoulder. “You know, Paul, you’d do well here. Manchester thrives on people like you—people who see the bigger picture.”

Paul blinked, surprised by the directness of the comment. “What are you saying?”

“I’m saying you’re welcome here,” Thorne replied smoothly. “If you’re ready to step into the future, we can make it happen. I’d be happy to buy any SheffCoin you want to trade to help you get set up—at a fair price, of course. Bitcoin, direct to your wallet.”

The group fell silent, the weight of the offer hanging between them. Eliot’s jaw tightened, his fists clenching at his sides.

“Paul,” Eliot said, his voice low but firm. “You can’t seriously be considering this.”

“Why not?” Paul shot back, his frustration bubbling to the surface. “You talk about culture, about meaning—but what does that even mean? Manchester is doing something real, something tangible. And Thorne’s right. It’s working.”

“Working for what?” Sophie interjected, her tone sharp. “To strip people down to cogs in a machine? To turn life into a spreadsheet of optimised experiences?”

“Better that than chasing a dream that never materialises,” Paul snapped.

Eliot stepped forward, his voice steady but edged with anger. “If you leave, Paul, you’re not just giving up on Sheffield. You’re giving up on everything we’ve built. Everything we stand for.”

“And what is that, Eliot?” Paul challenged. “Some vague idea of connection and meaning? Because from where I’m standing, Manchester has the results to back up its vision. Can Sheffield say the same?”

Thorne watched the exchange with quiet amusement, his eyes flicking between Eliot and Paul. Finally, he spoke, his tone calm but laced with condescension.

“Eliot, let him go. If Sheffield’s vision is as strong as you say, it doesn’t need him. But if Paul sees the truth—that Sheffield is holding him back—why not let him move on? Isn’t that what sovereignty is all about?”

Eliot turned to Thorne, his gaze cold. “Sovereignty isn’t about selling out. It’s about responsibility. Something you seem to have forgotten.”

Thorne chuckled. “Responsibility is a luxury, Eliot. Freedom is what matters. And freedom is what Manchester offers.”

Paul looked at Eliot, then at Thorne, his face a mixture of conflict and resolve. “I need to think about it,” he said finally.

Sophie shook her head, disgusted. “Think about what, Paul? Selling your principles for a few Bitcoin?”

“Maybe I’ve just realised my principles aren’t worth as much as I thought,” Paul replied bitterly.

Eliot’s voice was quiet but cutting. “You do what you have to do, Paul. But if you walk away, you’re not just walking away from the Bank. You’re walking away from us.”

The group fell into uneasy silence as they continued down the street, the bright lights of Manchester’s nightlife casting long shadows over their fractured unity.

The walk back to their hotel was quiet, the earlier tension settling into an uncomfortable stillness. Eliot stayed at the back of the group, his hands in his pockets, his head bowed against the bright lights of Manchester’s streets. Sophie walked ahead, her shoulders tense, while Paul strode beside her, his pace brisk, his expression unreadable.

Eliot couldn’t stop replaying Paul’s words in his mind. Sheffield’s great, but it’s slow. Manchester’s the future.

It wasn’t just Paul. It was the city itself. Manchester radiated a raw, undeniable energy—an intensity that pulled people in, promising them something faster, sharper, more visceral. The skyscrapers glinted with ambition, the factories hummed with progress, and the nightlife throbbed with a curated hedonism that seemed both efficient and endless.

The contrast with Sheffield couldn’t have been starker.

Sheffield’s charm was quieter, more deliberate. The Bank’s branches bustled with creative energy, its cultural hubs fostering connections and meaning. But compared to Manchester’s sleek efficiency, Sheffield felt almost antiquated—a romantic ideal in a world increasingly drawn to speed and precision.

Are we falling behind? Eliot wondered.

Thorne’s Manchester didn’t just promise freedom; it wrapped it in precision engineered luxury, not the casual sort of luxury Sheffield offered. Rolls-Royce engines rolling off assembly lines with effortless perfection, wild nights where every pleasure was engineered to hit its mark, towering monuments to progress that seemed to scrape the sky itself. It wasn’t hard to see the allure.

What did Sheffield offer in comparison? Artisan workshops? Thoughtful conversations? The slow burn of meaningful connection? Noble ideals, yes, but were they enough? Would they ever be enough?

Eliot thought of the people they’d seen tonight—their faces glowing with the satisfaction of lives seemingly well-lived. The manicured perfection of their joy, the polish of their pleasures. In Manchester, you didn’t have to wait. Everything you wanted was there, immediate, optimised.

In Sheffield, everything took time. Building relationships, creating culture, even earning trust—it was all slower, more fragile. It required patience, vulnerability, a willingness to embrace imperfection. And maybe that was its downfall.

People didn’t want slow anymore. They wanted fast. They wanted power, pleasure, progress—things Manchester offered in abundance.

Eliot barely noticed when Sophie dropped back to walk beside him, her voice soft. “You’re too quiet. What’s going on in that head of yours?”

He hesitated before answering. “What if they’re right?” he said finally, his voice low.

“Who?”

“Paul. Thorne. Everyone who believes in this,” he said, gesturing vaguely at the city around them. “What if Manchester’s model is better? Faster, more productive, more… everything. People don’t seem to mind the lack of soul. Maybe they prefer it this way.”

Sophie stopped, grabbing his arm and forcing him to meet her gaze. “Don’t you dare,” she said firmly. “Don’t you dare start doubting everything we’ve built just because Manchester looks shiny and loud.”

“It’s not just that,” Eliot replied, his voice strained. “It’s the momentum. The pace. Sheffield’s slow, Sophie. Romantic, sure, but slow. And people… people seem to love this. The energy, the wealth, the intensity. Maybe Sheffield’s not enough. Maybe I’m not enough.”

Sophie sighed, letting go of his arm. “Do you know what makes Sheffield different?” she asked, her voice calmer now. “It’s not the pace. It’s the purpose. You built something that makes people feel human, Eliot. This?” She gestured at the neon-lit streets, the towering skyscrapers. “This makes them feel like machines. Maybe they’re okay with that now. But they won’t be forever.”

Eliot wanted to believe her. But the doubts lingered. As they approached their hotel, he looked back over his shoulder at the city, its lights shining like a beacon of everything he wasn’t sure Sheffield could be.

Am I building a dream that people don’t want? he thought.

The hotel lobby was quiet when they returned, the bright lights reflecting off polished marble floors. Eliot barely glanced at the receptionist as he walked toward the lift, his thoughts still tangled with doubt and unease. Sophie followed close behind, while Paul lingered near the entrance, his gaze fixed on the revolving doors.

“You coming?” Sophie asked sharply, pausing to look back at him.

Paul hesitated, his hands buried in his coat pockets. “I… need some air,” he said finally.

Sophie frowned. “Paul—”

“It’s fine,” Eliot interrupted, his voice low. “Let him go.”

Paul gave him a quick, almost apologetic glance before slipping outside. The doors rotated once, twice, and then he was gone.

Eliot woke to a knock on his hotel room door. Blinking against the morning light streaming through the window, he dragged himself out of bed and opened the door to find Sophie standing there, her expression grim.

“You need to see this,” she said, holding out her phone.

Eliot took it, scanning the screen. A social media post from Paul's account stared back at him, the words like a punch to the gut:

Sometimes you have to leave the past behind to embrace the future. Grateful to Thorne for showing me what's possible. Manchester is where I belong now.

Attached was a photo of Paul shaking hands with Thorne, a Bitcoin wallet QR code in the corner of the image. The caption read: A new chapter begins.

Eliot's jaw tightened as he handed the phone back. "He sold his stake, didn't he?"

Sophie nodded. "Thorne bought him out. SheffCoin holdings, his shares in the Bank—all of it."

Paul wasn't hard to find. Eliot tracked him to a café near the station, where he sat alone at a corner table, scrolling through his phone. The hum of conversation filled the air, but Paul seemed oblivious to it.

Eliot walked over, pulling out the chair opposite him without asking. Paul looked up, startled, then sighed. "I figured you'd come."

"I want to hear it from you," Eliot said, his tone cold. "Why?"

Paul set his phone down, folding his hands on the table. "Because Manchester works, Eliot. You saw it. The scale, the efficiency, the results—they're leagues ahead of Sheffield. Thorne offered me a chance to be part of something bigger, something real. I couldn't say no."

"And Sheffield isn't real?" Eliot shot back, his voice rising. "The Bank, the culture we've built—it doesn't mean anything to you?"

"It's not enough," Paul said, his gaze steady. "You're building something beautiful, Eliot, but it's slow. Romantic, sure, but impractical. Sheffield feels like a dream, and Manchester is reality. I chose reality."

Eliot leaned back, his anger simmering just below the surface. "You didn't just betray Sheffield, Paul. You betrayed me. You sold out everything we've worked for, everything we believe in."

Paul flinched but held his ground. "Maybe I did. But I had to make a choice, and I chose the future."

Eliot stood, his chair scraping against the floor. "You chose Thorne's future," he said quietly. "Don't expect to find the meaning you're looking for in it. All you'll find is a machine that keeps running, whether you're part of it or not."

He turned and walked away, leaving Paul alone in the bustling café.

Back at the hotel, Eliot sat by the window, staring out at the Manchester skyline. The skyscrapers glinted in the sunlight, their imposing forms a stark reminder of the city's relentless drive.

Paul's betrayal stung, but it also crystallised something Eliot had been grappling with since arriving in Manchester. Sheffield's path wasn't just slower—it was harder. It demanded patience, vulnerability, and faith in something that couldn't be quantified.

Maybe that's why people choose Manchester, Eliot thought bitterly. It's easier. Faster. It promises everything without asking anything in return.

But as the sun dipped below the horizon, casting long shadows over the city, Eliot felt a flicker of resolve. Sheffield's vision might be harder, but it was worth fighting for.

Paul had made his choice. Eliot would make his.

The days after Paul's defection to Manchester passed in a blur. Thorne welcomed him warmly, his characteristic charm and confidence smoothing over any lingering unease. Paul was quickly integrated into Manchester's network of DAOs and decentralised institutions, his skills in finance and strategy immediately put to use.

It was exhilarating.

Thorne made good on his promises: Paul found himself in a sleek new office in one of Manchester's towering skyscrapers, surrounded by state-of-the-art technology and a team of relentless, driven individuals. Meetings were efficient, outcomes measurable, and success tangible.

"Welcome to the future," Thorne had said during their first meeting, gesturing to the skyline visible from his office. "This is what progress looks like, Paul. You're part of something real now."

Life in Manchester moved at a breakneck pace. Every hour was accounted for, every action optimised for maximum output. There was no room for idle reflection, no space for the kind of spontaneous conversations or creative exploration he'd once taken for granted in Sheffield.

Even the city itself felt relentless. The hum of machinery was constant, the streets packed with people moving with purpose but without connection. Nights out at Manchester's famed clubs were thrilling.

Thorne kept a close eye on Paul, offering guidance and encouragement but never allowing for weakness. "You made the right choice," he would say, clapping Paul on the shoulder. "Sheffield is nostalgia dressed up as progress. This—this is where the future is being built."

Thorne's world was one of perfection, and it left no room for imperfection. Mistakes were punished not with anger but with cold indifference, a reminder that the system didn't need any one person to function.

Paul's nights in Manchester blurred together, each one a carefully calibrated mix of work and release. The city offered everything he thought he wanted: seamless efficiency, boundless opportunity, and the thrill of being part of something monumental. Yet, as the weeks passed, a quiet unease began to take root.

He would sit in his sleek apartment, its automated systems adjusting the lighting and temperature with unerring precision, and feel the emptiness creeping in. The conversations he had with colleagues were productive but transactional, always orbiting around objectives and deliverables. There was no warmth, no idle laughter.

One night, after another night of endless networking at one of Manchester's sprawling rooftop bars, Paul found himself scrolling through his old messages. The texts from Eliot were still there, fragments of a time when conversations had been messy and alive, when ideas weren't just debated but felt.

Thorne noticed, of course. Nothing escaped his attention.

“You’re hesitating,” Thorne said one evening as they stood together in his office, the city’s lights sprawling out below them. His tone was calm, almost indulgent. “It’s natural. Change is hard.”

Paul looked at him, searching for something he couldn’t name. “Is it always like this?” he asked. “So… relentless?”

Thorne’s smile was sharp. “Relentless is what wins, Paul. Sheffield is a lullaby, soothing but stagnant. Manchester is the march of history. It’s not supposed to be comfortable—it’s supposed to be progress.”

Back in Sheffield, Eliot stood in one of the Bank’s community branches, watching as a group of local musicians set up for an impromptu performance in the corner of the open-plan space. People drifted in and out, pausing to listen, some joining in the impromptu rhythm with claps and stomps.

It was imperfect, unscheduled, and undeniably alive.

Paul’s defection still stung, and Manchester’s shadow loomed larger than ever. But as Eliot looked around, he felt something stir within him—a reminder of why he had chosen this path.

He didn’t need to match Manchester’s pace or output. Sheffield’s strength was in its connections, its culture, its humanity. It was a slower path, harder and more uncertain, but it was his.

And as he stood there, the music filling the air, Eliot knew: Sheffield would endure.

Chapter 8:

The consulting room was small but inviting, the walls painted a calming green and lined with posters on holistic health. Dr. Eleanor Grace sat opposite Amelia Harrington, the newly qualified lawyer whose tailored suit and tired eyes spoke volumes about the life she was leading.

Eleanor scanned Amelia’s intake form again, her pen tapping lightly against her clipboard. “So,” she began, looking up, “you’re here because you’re feeling… what? Overwhelmed? Drained?”

“Both,” Amelia said with a small, humourless laugh. “I’m exhausted all the time, and when I do have energy, I feel like I don’t know what to do with it. I can’t switch off. It’s like I’m always in fight-or-flight mode.”

Eleanor nodded thoughtfully. “That’s not uncommon for someone in your position. High-stress environments, especially early in your career, can throw everything out of balance. But there are ways to manage it—if you’re willing to make some changes.”

Amelia tilted her head, curious but sceptical. “What kind of changes?”

“Let’s start with diet,” Eleanor said, leaning forward. “Your body’s under constant pressure, so you need fuel to match. A high-protein diet is essential—meat primarily. It’ll keep your energy levels stable and help you maintain focus during long days.”

“Meat?” Amelia asked, raising an eyebrow.

Eleanor smiled. “I know it’s not fashionable in some circles, but for a high-stress environment, it works. Just be mindful—it might impact your mood and socialisation levels over time. Some studies suggest heavy meat consumption can reduce serotonin production, which could make connecting with others a little harder. But it’s a trade-off that works in the short term.”

Amelia frowned. “So, I might end up feeling more isolated?”

“Possibly,” Eleanor admitted. “But with the right balance of exercise and social activities, you can mitigate that. The point is to give you the physical resilience you need right now.”

“What about after work?” Amelia asked. “I barely have time to breathe, let alone go to the gym.”

“That has to change,” Eleanor said firmly. “Exercise isn’t optional. Swimming is ideal—it’s low impact but works your whole body. If that doesn’t appeal, find a gym with a routine that suits you. Even thirty minutes a few times a week can reset your stress levels and boost your mood.”

Amelia sighed. “I guess I could try.”

“And socialisation,” Eleanor added. “You need to carve out time to connect with people, whether it’s friends, colleagues, or even joining a new group. Isolation only compounds stress. Being around others helps you decompress.”

Eleanor paused, choosing her words carefully. “Now, for something a little unconventional. Sometimes, to push through these periods of intense demand, pharmaceutical support can help.”

Amelia blinked, surprised. “Pharmaceutical support?”

Eleanor nodded. “I’m talking about controlled, low-dose options—things like ketamine for its mood-enhancing and dissociative properties, or stimulants for focus. These are prescribed, of course, and monitored carefully. They’re not long-term solutions, but they can help you feel more alive, more engaged, while you’re managing the stress.”

“That sounds… intense,” Amelia said slowly.

“It’s not for everyone,” Eleanor admitted. “But it’s an option, especially if you’re feeling disconnected from life. Sometimes, experiencing a shift in perspective, even briefly, can make a huge difference.”

Eleanor leaned back, her expression kind but firm. “Here’s what I suggest. Start with the basics: high-protein meals, gym or swimming sessions at least twice a week, and make time to socialise—no excuses. If after a month you’re still struggling, we can revisit the pharmaceutical side. Deal?”

Amelia considered this, her fingers tapping the edge of the table. “I guess it’s worth a shot.”

Eleanor smiled. “Good. Remember, this isn’t about perfection—it’s about finding a balance that works for you. And if you need support, we’ll figure it out together.”

As Amelia left, Eleanor made a note to follow up in a month. It wasn’t a perfect system, but it was Sheffield’s way—blending practicality with a human touch, even when the solutions weren’t easy or conventional.

The consultation room at the Royal Hallamshire Hospital was quiet again. Dr. Eleanor Grace flipped through the patient file in front of her, glancing at the handwritten notes jotted on the corner of the triage form: *Difficulty concentrating. Suspects ADHD. Frequent digital consumption*.

The door creaked open, and a young woman stepped in. She was dressed casually, with earbuds dangling from her neck and a phone clutched tightly in her hand like a lifeline. She hesitated for a moment before sitting down across from Eleanor.

“Hi,” she said, her voice uncertain. “I’m Lucy.”

“Lucy, good to meet you,” Eleanor said warmly. “I understand you’ve been struggling with concentration?”

Lucy nodded quickly, leaning forward. “Yeah, I just… I can’t seem to focus on anything. My brain’s all over the place, and it’s starting to mess with my work. I looked it up, and I think I might have ADHD.”

Eleanor offered a small smile, not dismissive but careful. “Alright. Why don’t you tell me a bit more about what’s been going on?”

Lucy exhaled sharply. “It’s like… I’ll start something, and then two minutes later, I’m distracted. I’m always picking up my phone, scrolling through TikTok or Instagram, and then I lose hours without even realising it. At work, I can’t sit still for more than ten minutes without needing to check my messages or open a new tab. It’s exhausting.”

Eleanor nodded, making a quick note. “And how often are you on your phone during the day?”

Lucy frowned, as though the question itself felt intrusive. “I don’t know… a lot, I guess. I mean, I’m always connected, you know? It’s hard not to be. Everything’s online—work, friends, news, everything.”

“Do you ever take a break from it?” Eleanor asked. “A proper digital detox—no scrolling, no notifications, just time away from the screen?”

Lucy looked at her blankly, then let out a nervous laugh. “Not really. I mean, who does that?”

Eleanor smiled faintly. “Fair point. But let me ask you this—when’s the last time you sat down with a book? Just a book, no distractions, for half an hour?”

Lucy’s face softened, a flicker of something wistful crossing her expression. “I… I don’t know. Years, maybe. I used to love reading, but now it’s like I can’t sit still long enough to get through a page.”

“Well,” Eleanor said, leaning forward slightly, “that’s where I think we should start. I’m not ruling anything out yet, but before we talk about diagnoses or medications, I want you to try something: a digital detox. Half an hour a day, no screens, just you and a book. It doesn’t have to be heavy or difficult—something you enjoy. Fiction, maybe, or poetry, or even a magazine if needed.”

Lucy blinked. “That’s… it? You think that’ll fix me?”

Eleanor’s smile widened. “I don’t think you’re broken, Lucy. But I do think your brain is overwhelmed. Constant short-form content—TikTok, Instagram—it’s like junk food for your attention span. A detox isn’t a cure, but it’s a way to start rebalancing.”

Lucy shifted uncomfortably in her chair, her grip tightening on her phone. “I was hoping for… I don’t know, something stronger. Like ADHD meds. My friend takes them, and she says they’ve changed her life. I can’t afford to keep losing focus like this. I need a solution.”

Eleanor nodded, her tone steady but resolute. “I understand. But I don’t prescribe ADHD medications unless I’m absolutely certain they’re necessary—and in most cases, I’ve found they aren’t. The effects can be temporary, and the long-term impact isn’t always positive.”

Lucy’s expression tightened. “So you’re saying no?”

“I’m saying that in my experience, holistic medicine works better for issues like this,” Eleanor replied gently. “Reading, exercise, mindfulness—they’re not quick fixes, but they build resilience. They give your mind the chance to reset, to rewire itself.”

Lucy stared at her for a long moment, the tension between expectation and disappointment playing out in her silence. Eleanor could see it: the hope for an easy answer, the reluctance to face a slower, more demanding path.

“What if it doesn’t work?” Lucy asked finally, her voice small.

Eleanor leaned back, her gaze kind but unwavering. “Then we’ll try something else. But I need you to meet me halfway on this. Thirty minutes a day, starting today. Trust me, Lucy—it’s worth the effort.”

The young woman sighed, slipping her phone into her pocket as though conceding a battle she hadn’t realised she was fighting. “Alright,” she said. “I’ll try.”

Eleanor smiled. “That’s all I ask.”

That evening, the snug The Fox and Hound was bustling with the low hum of chatter punctuated by bursts of laughter and the clinking of glasses. Eleanor slid into the booth, shaking off the chill of Sheffield’s drizzle. Ravi had already claimed the corner seat, nursing a stout and picking at a bowl of peanuts. Alice was pouring herself a glass from a shared pitcher of cider, her coat draped over the back of her chair. Alice was busy texting away under the table not paying, only half paying attention to what was being said.

“Finally,” Ravi said as Eleanor settled in. “Thought you might’ve got stuck writing one of your holistic medicine manifestos on the way out.”

Eleanor rolled her eyes. “You’ve been reading too much Ashton.”

“I don’t think that’s possible,” Ravi quipped.

Alice handed Eleanor a glass. “Long day?”

“Long, but good,” Eleanor said, taking a sip. “Patients are starting to come around to the holistic stuff. It’s slow, but when it clicks, it really works.”

Alice leaned back, resting her elbow on the edge of the booth. “Had a woman today who swore her stomach issues were from gluten. Turns out she’s been stress-snacking crisps at her desk all day. It’s not the bread—it’s the stress.”

“Office snacks,” Ravi mused. “The hidden epidemic.”

Eleanor smirked. “I had someone convinced they couldn’t focus because of ADHD. It wasn’t ADHD—it was TikTok. But convincing someone to swap their phone for a book? Feels like a Herculean task some days.”

Alice tipped her glass in agreement. “I had one last week—same thing. It’s like everyone’s overwhelmed by noise. And instead of quieting things down, they want a pill to make the noise bearable.”

“Not just patients,” Ravi said. “It’s the whole system. Noise everywhere—metrics, targets, protocols. People need to tune into the idea of holistic medicine, I am uncomfortable with prescribing pharmaceutical medication.”

Alice took a sip of her cider and leaned back, her voice casual but curious. “Speaking of holistic medicine, did either of you see Ashton’s latest? His Goethean theory of medicine, piece?”

Eleanor perked up, her hands warming around her pint. “I did. It’s… something, isn’t it? He’s taking us back to first principles—not just treating the body, but rethinking what it means to be well. It’s more than medicine—it’s philosophy, biology, even art.”

Ravi smirked but didn’t interrupt, gesturing for her to go on.

“He argues that modern medicine is trapped in reductionism,” Eleanor continued. “We isolate symptoms, diagnose problems, prescribe solutions—but we never ask what it all means. He’s saying we need to step back and see the human organism as a whole interconnected piece.”

Alice nodded, her tone more serious now. “It’s not jusht about fixing what’s broken—it’s about harmony. Goethe’s idea that nature is interconnected, that every part of a system influences the whole. Ashton’s applying that to people, to communities. It’s radical, but it makes sense in terms of practical medicine. Pharmaceuticals have done wonders here and there but they aren’t the only answer in many cases.”

“But what does that look like in practice? How do you treat a patient with harmony?”

Eleanor smiled. “That’s the challenge, isn’t it? Ashton talks about moving beyond the mechanical view of the body. Instead of asking, ‘What’s wrong with this person?’ we ask, ‘What’s disrupted the balance?’ It’s not just about curing disease—it’s about restoring equilibrium.”

“And how do you measure equilibrium?” Ravi pressed, though his tone was more curious than critical.

“You don’t measure it, at least not entirely I don’t think,” Alice replied. “That’s Ashton’s point. Health isn’t just numbers on a chart—it’s how someone feels, how they connect to the world around them. It’s their relationships, their purpose, their ability to create. Greek philosophy would say think in terms of mind, body, spirit.”

Ravi leaned back, mulling this over. “So we’re talking about medicine as an art, not just a science.”

“Exactly,” Eleanor said. “Ashton’s arguing for a kind of medical humanism. He’s bringing Goethe’s sense of nature and balance into a system that’s forgotten those things.”

Alice set her glass down, her expression somewhere between admiration and awe. “Ashton’s not just a philosopher—he’s a kind of modern Goethe. He’s not content to just think about these things—he’s reshaping the world with them.”

“And doing it in Sheffield of all places,” Ravi added. “It’s almost poetic.”

“It is,” Eleanor said, her voice quieter now. “Goethe believed that art and science weren’t separate—they were part of the same truth. Ashton’s doing the same thing with medicine, philosophy, and culture. He’s not just theorising—he’s giving people something to live by.”

“I don’t know,” Ravi said eventually. “It feels like we’re on the edge of something big. Medicine’s been stuck in the same patterns for so long. Maybe Ashton’s the push we need.”

Eleanor smiled faintly. “He’d probably say it’s not about pushing—it’s about growing. Letting things unfold the way they’re meant to.”

Alice chuckled softly. “Very Goethean.”

“Very Ashton,” Eleanor said.

Alice leaned back, her glass resting loosely in her hand, as the hum of the pub seemed to quiet for a moment. “You know, I keep wondering—do you think Ashton really believes it’s possible? I mean, truly possible? To shift the entire medical establishment toward something… well, Goethean?”

Ravi raised an eyebrow. “Belief isn’t his issue, is it? Ashton’s the type who bends reality to his will. He’s not just talking to us doctors; he’s got everyone listening—economists, artists, even politicians. That kind of reach is rare.”

“Rare,” Eleanor agreed, “and powerful. That’s what makes him so compelling—and so dangerous.”

Alice tilted her head. “Dangerous? You think his ideas are dangerous?”

Eleanor hesitated, searching for the right words. “Not his ideas, exactly. But the scale of them. He’s asking for a paradigm shift, something that doesn’t just change medicine but changes how we see ourselves. That’s not a small thing. And if it’s misunderstood—if people take it in the wrong direction—it could cause as much harm as good.”

Ravi nodded slowly. “Like the pharmaceutical giants doubling down on ‘holistic’ branding while still pumping out the same old drugs. Slap ‘natural’ on the label, and people eat it up.”

Alice sighed, swirling the cider in her glass. “Or worse—people treating it like a trend. Turning health into another consumer product. That’s not what Ashton’s about, but you can see how easily it could go that way.”

“That’s the risk of big ideas,” Eleanor said, leaning forward. “They’re like seeds. You can plant them, but you don’t control how they grow. And Ashton knows that. He’s not naïve—he’s just betting that the people who get it will outweigh the ones who exploit it.”

Alice smiled faintly. “You almost sound like you’ve spoken to him directly.”

Eleanor laughed. “I haven’t. But I’ve read enough of his work to feel like I have.”

Ravi gestured with his pint. “If you did meet him, what would you ask? What’s the one thing you’d want to know?”

Eleanor thought for a moment, her expression serious. “I’d ask him how he keeps faith in it all. He’s trying to shift the world on its axis, and he must know how hard that is—how slow, how resistant people can be to change. I’d want to know what keeps him going.”

Alice leaned forward, her voice softer now. “Maybe it’s the same thing that keeps us going. The little wins, the moments when you see someone’s life change because of what you’ve done. Maybe he’s not that different from us—just operating on a bigger stage.”

“Maybe,” Ravi said, though his tone carried a note of doubt. “But there’s something about Ashton that feels… otherworldly. Like he’s not just a part of this city—he’s shaping it into what he thinks it should be.”

“Isn’t that what all of us are doing?” Eleanor asked. “In our own small ways?”

The conversation drifted into silence for a moment, the clinking of glasses and murmurs from other tables filling the air. Eleanor glanced at her colleagues, their faces thoughtful, even a little awed.

Alice broke the quiet. “Do you think he’s right?”

Eleanor hesitated, then smiled faintly. “I think he’s asking the right questions. Whether the answers are right… that’s something we’ll all have to figure out.”

They raised their glasses, not in celebration but in quiet acknowledgment of the enormity of the task ahead—not just for Ashton, but for all of them.

“You know who’d hate all of this,” Ravi said finally, a small smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth.

Alice raised an eyebrow. “Thorne?”

“Exactly,” Ravi said, setting his pint down. “He’d call it sentimental. He’d be up there in one of his towers, saying something about how Goethean harmony is a distraction from the real work of improving humanity.”

Eleanor smiled faintly but didn’t respond immediately. It wasn’t the first time Thorne’s name had surfaced in their conversations—it was impossible to avoid. His vision for Manchester, his philosophy of perfection through biohacking and precision medicine, was the natural counterweight to Ashton’s softer, interconnected ideals.

Alice leaned forward, resting her elbows on the table. “What do you think he’d say about the human organism? That it’s just a machine?”

“More like a flawed machine,” Ravi said, shrugging. “Thorne doesn’t trust nature to get anything right. In his world, everything can—and should—be optimized. Gene therapy, mRNA technology, biofeedback implants… the works.”

Eleanor sighed. “It’s not just about optimization for him, though, is it? It’s about control. Thorne doesn’t believe the body can self-correct. He sees it as a collection of parts—genes, hormones, systems—all of them prone to failure unless someone steps in to fix them.”

“And by someone, he means him,” Alice said, her tone dry.

Ravi chuckled. “Exactly. Manchester is his grand experiment. Precision medicine, biohacking, wearable tech—he’s turned the whole city into a testing ground for his vision of perfection.”

“But is it working?” Alice asked, her voice more curious than critical. “You hear about the advancements they’re making—cancer treatments, gene editing, even life extension research. You can’t deny it’s impressive.”

“It’s impressive,” Eleanor agreed, “but at what cost? Thorne’s system treats people like machines, not humans. It’s all outcomes and metrics. He’s obsessed with the ‘perfect body’ but doesn’t seem to care about the people inside them.”

Alice took a thoughtful sip of her drink. “So, we’ve got two cities. Ashton’s Sheffield, treating the body like an organism, something that thrives on connection, meaning, and balance. And Thorne’s Manchester, where the body’s a machine to be optimized. Two completely different ways of looking at the same problem.”

“Exactly,” Ravi said. “It’s not just medicine—it’s philosophy. Ashton trusts nature, trusts people. Thorne doesn’t trust anything that can’t be engineered.”

Eleanor leaned forward, her expression serious. “And that’s where Thorne gets it wrong. Nature isn’t perfect, but it’s adaptive. The body’s designed to find equilibrium if you let it. You don’t need to rewrite someone’s DNA to help them heal. Sometimes, you just need to give them the right environment, the right support.”

“But that takes time,” Alice pointed out. “And Thorne’s about efficiency. Why wait for balance when you can edit a gene or prescribe a drug?”

“Because it’s not sustainable,” Eleanor replied firmly. “Thorne’s approach works in the short term, sure, but it ignores the bigger picture. You can’t reduce people to a series of fixes. Health isn’t just about functioning—it’s about thriving.”

Ravi chuckled, shaking his head. “And yet, have you seen Manchester lately? They’re thriving by every metric that counts—economic growth, life expectancy, even productivity. If you’re looking at raw numbers, Thorne’s winning.”

“Maybe,” Eleanor said, her tone softer now. “But do you remember what Ashton said in that piece last month? About high culture?”

Alice nodded slowly. “That no one remembers the factories of Sheffield or Turin, but they remember the cathedrals of Florence and the canals of Venice.”

“Exactly,” Eleanor said. “Manchester’s building skyscrapers and editing genes. But when people look back, will they remember the efficiency, or will they remember the humanity?”

The group fell quiet, the weight of the conversation settling over them. Ravi broke the silence with a wry smile. “You know, it’s almost poetic. Two philosophers, two cities, two visions for the future. Makes you wonder which one’s going to win.”

“It will probably be Manchester,” Eleanor said, with a sort of nonchalance, “but I like Sheffield, its more relaxing and more my vibe.”

By the time they said goodnight, Alice felt lighter, her thoughts less tangled.

The rain had softened to a faint mist as Alice stepped out of The Fox and Hound. The night air was cool and smelled of damp stone and wet leaves, the kind of smell that made her nostalgic for places she couldn’t quite name.

She pulled her phone from her pocket as she walked, her heels clicking softly on the pavement. The screen lit up with a message:

Daniel: *What are you up to?*

Alice hesitated, her thumb hovering over the keyboard. Daniel’s timing was impeccable, as always. He had a way of knowing just when she’d left the safety of a lively room and entered the quiet of her own thoughts.

She started typing: *“Just leaving the pub. What about you?”*

But before she sent it, she stopped. Did she really want to go down this road tonight?

She walked past the glow of late-night cafés and shuttered shops, the streets emptying out as the city began to settle into its quiet rhythm. Daniel had been in her life for months now, never too close but never far away. He was easy, uncomplicated—someone who didn’t ask for too much but always seemed to be there when she felt like letting someone in.

That’s what she told herself, anyway.

The truth was harder to pin down. Daniel’s presence was comforting, sure, but it also came with a kind of weight. A feeling that their connection, as light as it seemed, was holding her back from something she couldn’t quite name.

Her phone buzzed again.

Daniel: *Come over?*

Alice sighed, slipping her phone back into her pocket without replying. She turned onto Division Street, the sound of her heels punctuating the stillness.

The mist clung to her hair, and she pulled her coat tighter around her as she walked. She replayed the night’s conversation in her mind—Eleanor’s confidence in Ashton’s ideas, Ravi’s teasing but thoughtful insights, the way they all seemed to be reaching for something bigger.

What was she reaching for?

Her life felt like a patchwork of habits and half-measures. Work, drinks with friends, the occasional message from Daniel. It wasn't bad, but it wasn't enough. Not when she compared it to the scope of what Ashton and even Thorne were building, their grand visions reshaping cities and lives.

Daniel didn't fit into that world. He didn't challenge her or inspire her—he just… existed. And maybe that was fine for now. Or maybe it wasn't.

Her phone buzzed again. This time, she pulled it out.

Daniel: *Still up for it?*

Alice stopped walking, standing under the faint glow of a streetlamp. The rain had left the pavement slick, the city reflected back in muted colours.

She typed back quickly: *"Come over."*

The reply came instantly. *"On my way."*

By the time Alice got back to her flat in Kelham Island, she'd already shed her coat and kicked off her shoes. She lit a few candles—more for the warmth of their glow than for any attempt at romance—and poured herself a glass of wine.

The knock came sooner than she expected.

Daniel stood in the doorway, his hair damp from the mist, his grin as easy as ever. He stepped inside without a word, setting the wine bottle he'd brought onto the counter.

Alice didn't bother with small talk. She reached for him, her fingers curling into the fabric of his jacket as she pulled him closer. Their lips met with an urgency that surprised her, a sudden need to quiet the noise in her head.

They barely made it to the sofa, their steps heavy with desire. His hands roamed over her back, sliding beneath her blouse, each touch sending shivers down her spine. He pulled her shirt up, revealing her skin to the cool air, his lips finding the sensitive curve of her neck, where he lingered, teasing with light kisses and soft bites.

She matched his fervour, her fingers deftly undoing the buttons of his shirt, revealing the warmth of his skin. She pushed the fabric off his shoulders, her hands exploring the contours of his chest with eager, sensual intent. The room echoed with their quickened breaths, the silence shattered by the heat of their urgency.

The sofa, cramped and confining, only intensified their closeness. They moved together, finding a rhythm born of mutual need. Her body pressed against his, each arch of her back a silent plea, his hands strong yet gentle, guiding and claiming.

It was a swift, intense crescendo, leaving them breathless and spent. They collapsed into each other, her head finding the perfect spot on his chest, their bodies still trembling with the echoes of their passion.

The candles flickered, their light casting shadows across the walls. Daniel ran a hand lazily along her arm, his touch warm and steady.

Alice stared at the ceiling, her mind already drifting. The intensity of the moment had dulled the edges of her thoughts, but now they began to creep back in—the conversation at the pub, Ashton's ideas, her own uncertainty.

"Everything okay?" Daniel asked, his voice low.

She nodded, though she wasn't sure if it was true. *"Yeah. Just tired."*

He pressed a kiss to her forehead and didn't push further.

Chapter 9:

The sun was already rising over Kelham Island when Daniel slipped out of Alice's flat, the soft thud of the door closing behind him. The streets were quiet, save for the distant hum of a tram and the occasional bark of a dog. His head buzzed faintly—not from alcohol, but from the jumble of thoughts that always seemed to linger after a night like that.

Alice had stayed curled up in bed, half-asleep, murmuring something about seeing him later. He'd smiled, kissed her on the forehead, and left before she could ask any questions he wasn't ready to answer.

As he walked, the chill morning air sharpened his senses. His phone buzzed in his pocket.

"Got a gig for you. A rave collective out in Bamford needs a fixer. Electronics, programming. Could be interesting. Let me know."

Daniel stopped mid-step, rereading the message. Martin had a knack for finding unusual jobs, but this one stood out. Bamford was tucked away in the Peak District, miles from Sheffield's industrial hum or Manchester's relentless buzz.

He texted back: "Details?"

By the time Daniel reached his small workspace—a rented corner of a co-working hub funded by the Bank of Sheffield—the city was beginning to stir. People passed by on bikes, carrying coffee cups or tote bags filled with artisan bread.

His space wasn't much: a battered desk, a few neatly organized tools, and two monitors glowing faintly in the morning light. He tossed his bag onto a chair and sat down, flicking through emails and messages.

Martin's reply came through quickly:

Martin: "It's a DJ Kommune. Blockchain royalties, biofeedback loops, the works. One of their rigs crashed last night, and they've got a big gig coming up. They're based out near Bamford. I think it might be...them... Interested?"

Daniel leaned back in his chair, considering. If Martin was right about who this DJ collective was, he was in for an experience. It might be the most famous and most secretive DJ collective of them all.

Daniel: "I'm in. Send me the details."

By late afternoon, Daniel was on a train cutting through the green expanse of the Peak District. The city faded behind him, replaced by rolling hills and winding rivers, the kind of landscape that always made him feel like he was stepping out of time.

The text from Martin had been brief—just an address and a contact name: "Luna."

He stepped off the train at Bamford station, the air noticeably fresher than in Sheffield. His bag, slung over one shoulder, felt heavier with the tools and equipment he'd packed.

A battered Land Rover was waiting outside the station, its engine idling. A woman leaned out of the driver's side window, her dark hair tied back in a messy bun.

"You Daniel?" she called out.

"Yeah," he said, crossing the gravel lot.

"I'm Luna. Hop in."

The barn was tucked away at the end of a meandering dirt track that seemed designed to test the Land Rover Defender's legendary capabilities. Luna gripped the steering wheel with quiet confidence, the vehicle lurching and swaying as she navigated what felt like every pothole in Derbyshire. After three wrong turns, a brief standoff with some particularly stubborn highland cattle, and Daniel's increasingly frantic attempts to find a phone signal were defeated, the weathered stone walls finally emerged through the gathering dusk. The Peak District hills rolled away in every direction, their slopes dotted with sheep that seemed thoroughly unimpressed by the faint bass vibrations already seeping through the ancient masonry. Inside, it was a different world entirely - a pulsing, strobe-lit cavern where a hundred bodies moved to thunderous techno, the original cattle stalls now repurposed as DJ booths, and hay bales served as impromptu seating for ravers catching their breath. Luna shot Daniel a knowing smile as she killed the engine; the collective had chosen well. Even the most determined noise complaint would struggle to find this place, let alone reach it.

A tangle of cables snaked across the floor, connecting glowing synths, mixers, and screens that flickered with complex interfaces. A small group of people bustled about, their movements frenetic but purposeful.

Luna led him in, gesturing toward the chaos. "Welcome to our little slice of madness. That's the rig," she said, pointing to a half-disassembled machine near the back. "And that's what's not working."

Daniel set his bag down and took a closer look. The rig was a Frankenstein's monster of custom-built electronics, its components cobbled together with a mix of ingenuity and desperation.

"It's supposed to sync the biofeedback automatically during live sets to keep the party going," Luna explained. "But it's crashing whenever we add the biofeedback loop. We've got a gig in two days, so whatever you can do, do it fast."

As Daniel got to work, he couldn't help but notice the barn's strange energy. It wasn't just the tech or the music—it was the people. They spoke in hushed tones when they thought he wasn't listening, glancing at him with curious eyes.

During a break, one of the group—a wiry man with glasses perched on the edge of his nose—pulled him aside.

“You’ve been in Sheffield long?” the man asked, his tone casual but probing.

“A while,” Daniel replied. “Why?”

The man smiled faintly. “Just wondering how much you’ve heard about… other movements. People trying to go beyond Ashton and Thorne’s divide.”

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “Like what?”

The man just shrugged, his smile deepening. “You’ll see.”

Daniel crouched next to the rig, pulling tools and cables from his bag. The air in the barn buzzed with faint, overlapping conversations, the kind of low hum that made it feel alive. Luna hovered nearby, her arms crossed, watching him work.

“It’s a sync issue,” Daniel said, more to himself than anyone else. His fingers danced over the interface, isolating the problem. “The the memory cache is limited, you need to upgrade, to keep the data available because the biofeedback loop is eating too much bandwidth. Either delete the data or upgrade.”

“Can you fix it?” Luna asked.

“Yeah, but whoever built this was ambitious to the point of reckless,” Daniel muttered. “You’ve got conflicting AI protocols fighting for the same resources. It’s a miracle this thing ever worked. I might be able to compress the data, to allow the AI’s to pull the data when needed on the fly. But it’ll change the programming.”

He started reconfiguring the system, pausing occasionally to wipe his hands on his jeans. After a few minutes, the tangled mess of wires and code began to align, the rig’s interface stabilizing under his adjustments.

“There,” Daniel said, standing up and brushing off his hands. “Try it now.”

Luna gestured to one of the others, who flipped a switch. The machine hummed to life, its displays lighting up in smooth, synchronized patterns.

A bassline thumped through the barn, filling the space with a steady, hypnotic beat. Luna grinned. “You’re a lifesaver.”

As the collective resumed their rehearsal, Daniel packed up his tools. A wiry man approached, holding two mugs of steaming tea. He handed one to Daniel without a word, then leaned casually against a workbench.

“You handled that well,” the man said, sipping his tea.

“Part of the job,” Daniel replied.

The man smiled. “You’re not just good with tech, though. You listen. Most people come in and act like they own the place.”

Daniel shrugged. “Hard to fix something if you don’t know how it’s broken.”

The man nodded, seeming to mull over Daniel’s words. “I’m Samuel, by the way. Samuel Ashcombe.”

Daniel froze for half a second, the name bouncing around in his brain without landing. “Nice to meet you,” he said, extending a hand.

Samuel’s grip was firm but unassuming, his expression calm. They spoke for a few more minutes, exchanging small talk about the collective and Daniel’s work. But as Samuel walked away, something clicked in Daniel’s mind.

Ashcombe. The name rattled around like a loose bolt, gaining weight with every thought. He’d heard it before—read it, maybe. Somewhere important.

He turned, calling out, “Wait—are you related to the Ashcombe family?”

Samuel stopped mid-step, glancing back over his shoulder with a bemused smile. “Depends on which side of them Ashcombe family you mean.”

“The one that crashed the British economy in the Great War, crashed the US stock market, founded the computing industry,” Daniel said.

Samuel chuckled, stepping back toward him. “Something like that. That’s my family, though yes. Then I convinced them to get into bitcoin during the 2010s and we’ve gone offgrid. Proper cypherpunk style.”

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “What’s a guy from one of the most famous families in the country doing hanging out with a rave collective in a barn?”

Before Daniel could press further, Luna called out, interrupting their conversation.

“Samuel, we need you on the mixer!”

Samuel tipped his mug in a casual salute and headed toward the others. But Daniel couldn’t shake the sense that there was more to the man than he let on.

The barn buzzed with activity, but Daniel had tuned it out as he adjusted the levels on the DJ equipment. The synths were running too hot, drowning out the subtler layers of the tracks. He frowned, twisting a knob and letting the hum mellow into something richer, more textured.

Samuel stood nearby, leaning against a stack of speaker cases, watching Daniel with a mix of curiosity and amusement.

“The two cities, huh?” Samuel said, breaking the silence.

Daniel glanced up. “What about them?”

“Sheffield and Manchester,” Samuel replied. “Two paths, two futures. Doesn’t it feel like we’re living through the next great divide?”

Daniel smirked. “Sheffield feels like home. Manchester feels like a machine. I’ll take the slow life over the grind any day.”

Samuel nodded, his expression thoughtful. “I see the appeal. Sheffield’s got heart. But Manchester… it’s hard to ignore what they’re building there. Hard to not feel tempted.”

Daniel twisted another knob, letting the music settle into a smoother groove. “What about you? You sound like you’ve got a foot in both worlds.”

“I do,” Samuel admitted. “I own a fair chunk of the Bank of Sheffield—got in early through a few trust funds. But I spend most of my time out here, with the collective.”

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “You’re loaded, then?”

Samuel laughed. “Depends on how you define it. My family’s been managing wealth for a century.”

“That’s old money for you.”

Samuel’s smile dimmed slightly, his gaze distant. “Old enough. The Ashcombes were landowners in the Peak District for generations. Big estate, lots of land, the whole aristocratic cliché.”

“And now?” Daniel asked, adjusting the bass levels.

Samuel sipped his tea, his voice quieter. “Now we’re scattered. My great-grandfather tried to stop the First World War—lobbied Parliament, even tried to break the Bank of England, the whole bit. He failed, obviously. The war gutted the family here. Wealthy still but political capital was shot, there’s a whole branch of us in the United States. My grandad got into computing until the authorities gave came and took it all and then that’s where I came in.”

“But you got them all into Bitcoin?”

Samuel nodded. “I saw the writing on the wall. Gold’s great, but Bitcoin… I saw that was the future in about 2015. I convinced the family to shift some assets in the early days. It wasn’t easy, but it paid off. Now we’ve got this strange mix of old wealth and cutting-edge cryptography.”

“Must be nice,” Daniel said, his tone neutral.

“It’s not what you think,” Samuel said, his gaze steady. “We’re still living off the traumas of the past, trying to make it relevant. That’s why I’m here.” Samuel gestured around the barn. “This place is an escape. A Kommune, of sorts. We’re trying to get out of the city life, step away from the noise of Sheffield and Manchester. Out here, it’s simpler. We make music, grow some food, trade skills. It’s not perfect, but it feels… real.”

Daniel glanced at him, intrigued. “And the collective? What’s the point?”

Samuel smiled faintly. “To live differently. To show there’s another way. We’re not trying to compete with the cities—that’s Ashton and Thorne’s game. We’re just trying to carve out a space where people can breathe, where they can be themselves without the pressure of systems and metrics.”

“And the raves?” Daniel asked, tweaking the treble.

Samuel chuckled. “Part celebration, part rebellion. Music’s universal, right? It cuts through all the bullshit. We use the royalties from the gigs to fund the collective—buy equipment, pay for repairs, keep the lights on.”

Daniel paused, his hands resting on the mixer. “So you’re funding this with SheffCoin?”

Samuel nodded. “Mostly. SheffCoin for the practical stuff we need from the city, Bitcoin if we need it from Manchester and if we’re saving for long-term. It’s a balance.”

“What do you think of Sheffield?” Daniel asked, leaning back from the equipment.

Samuel considered the question, his expression thoughtful. “It’s beautiful in its own way. Creative, messy, full of heart. But it’s slow. Ashton’s vision is romantic, sure, but I’m not sure it’s enough to stand up to what Manchester’s doing.”

Daniel frowned. “You’re saying Sheffield’s going to lose?”

“Not lose,” Samuel clarified. “Just… struggle. Manchester’s playing a harder, faster game. It’s got this relentless energy, this drive to be the best. Sheffield’s trying to be the most meaningful, but that’s harder to measure. Harder to sell.”

“And what about you?” Daniel asked. “Where do you stand?”

Samuel smiled faintly. “Out here, in the middle. Let the cities duke it out. We’ll be here, making music, growing vegetables, and figuring out how to stay human.”

Samuel reached into his bag and pulled out a slim, leather-bound book, its cover embossed with an ornate family crest. He turned it over in his hands for a moment, as though weighing the decision, then held it out to Daniel.

“This is for you,” Samuel said.

Daniel blinked, wiping his hands on his jeans before taking the book. It was surprisingly heavy for its size, the leather worn soft at the edges.

“What is it?”

“A bit of my family’s history,” Samuel said, leaning back against the workbench. “It starts in 1914, the official story of the Ashcombe family. We as a family vote on the official narrative of the family, and the habit stuck. Most of the old stuff you can find on wikipedia and the like, but the new stuff you might find interesting.”

Daniel opened the book carefully, the faint scent of old paper wafting up as he turned the first few pages. The handwriting varied from entry to entry, some elegant and flowing, others sharp and hurried.

“Why give this to me?” Daniel asked, glancing up.

Samuel’s expression was unreadable, but his voice was steady. “Because I think you’ll find something in it that resonates. My family’s story isn’t just about land and wealth—it’s about decisions, sacrifices, and trying to live in a way that feels right, even when the world says you’re wrong.”

Daniel traced his fingers over the opening lines:
“On the eve of war, as Europe stood poised to burn, the Ashcombe name still carried the weight to tip the scales of history. In late July 1914, the air in England hung thick with summer heat and uneasy whispers. Across the Channel, diplomacy faltered under the weight of telegrams that spoke in terse, clipped language, each a promise of blood should the pen falter. Lord Reginald Ashcombe of Bamford sat at his desk, a sheaf of reports before him, their contents as grave as the faces of the men who brought them. In Vienna, ultimatums turned to declarations; in Berlin, troop movements began under the guise of precaution.”

“This is… intense, I’ve heard all the conspiracies about your family breaking the Bank of England, the US stock market” Daniel said, flipping further through the book. Later entries detailed the family’s retreat into gold investments, their interest in computing in the 1960s and a quiet but deliberate pivot to Bitcoin in the 2010s. “I’ve never seen it written from your side.”

Samuel nodded. “It is. But it’s also a map of sorts. A record of what happens when you try to walk a different path.”

Samuel crossed his arms, his gaze steady. “You’ve got a good head on your shoulders, Daniel. And you’re a fixer—not just of machines, but of problems. That’s the kind of person we need out here.”

Daniel looked up from the book. “What are you saying?”

“I’m saying you’re welcome to join us,” Samuel said simply. “The collective isn’t just about raves and rebellion—it’s about creating something sustainable, something human. We’re trying to build a life that’s not dictated by cities or systems, but by the people living it.”

Daniel hesitated, the weight of the book grounding him. “I don’t know if I’m cut out for that.”

Samuel smiled faintly. “You don’t have to decide now. Just think about it. The barn’s always open, and there’s a bunk if you need it.”

As Samuel walked away, called back to the rehearsal by Luna’s impatient shout, Daniel sat down on a nearby crate and stared at the book in his hands.

He flipped to the final entry, dated 2020, detailing the family’s full transition to Bitcoin. “For the first time in generations, our wealth is truly ours. No intermediaries, no governments. But with great freedom comes great responsibility. What we do with it now will define us.”

Daniel closed the book, his reflection staring back at him from the barn’s dim window. Samuel’s words echoed in his mind: “Let the cities fight. We’ll be here, figuring out how to stay human.”

Daniel wandered to the edge of the barn, the Ashcombe family history still clutched in his hand. His thoughts drifted to Alice—how their relationship felt like a loose thread on an old sweater. They fit together well enough for a night or two, but it was clear neither was looking for something more.

As much as he cared for her, it was going nowhere, and he couldn’t shake the feeling that she knew it too. Maybe that was why she hadn’t messaged him since he’d left. Or maybe she had, and he just hadn’t noticed.

“Penny for your thoughts?” Samuel asked, stepping beside him.

“My friend Alice, just thinking about her,” Daniel admitted. “Nothing really clicks anymore. It’s like… we’re both waiting for the other to call it off.”

Samuel tilted his head. “It’s hard, trying to balance relationships when you feel like the world’s moving too fast for them. Maybe that’s why most of the people out here gave up on the city altogether.”

Daniel frowned. “How many people are actually out here?”

“A couple of hundred,” Samuel said. “All scattered across the Peaks. Some in barns like this, others in old farmhouses or campsites. We trade between us, grow some of our own food, and run digital gigs or coding projects for cash. Bitcoin makes it easy—no banks, no intermediaries, just us.”

“That’s wild,” Daniel said, letting the weight of it sink in. “How do you keep it all going?”

“Come and see,” Samuel said, gesturing for him to follow.

Samuel led Daniel out of the barn and down a winding path, the evening sun casting long shadows over the hills. They came to a clearing where a small group of people lounged on mismatched cushions and blankets. A faint smell of weed hung in the air, mingling with the earthy scent of the Peaks.

“This is just one cluster,” Samuel said. “A lot of us are nomadic, moving between spots depending on what’s going on. But you’ll find a similar vibe wherever you go.”

The people in the clearing turned to greet them, their faces lighting up with easy smiles. They were an eclectic mix—tattoos, dreadlocks, brightly dyed hair, and sleek tech wear all blending into a strangely cohesive aesthetic.

A woman with a half-shaved head offered Daniel a hand-rolled cigarette. “You new?”

“Something like that,” Daniel said, accepting it.

“I’m Mira,” she said, settling back onto her cushion. “Samuel roped you in, didn’t he? He’s good at that.”

Samuel smirked. “He’s a fixer. We need more of those.”

As the sun dipped lower, the group talked and laughed, sharing stories about gigs they’d run, digital projects they were building, and the wild parties they’d hosted.

“We’re not anti-city,” one man said, his voice smooth and calm. “We’re just not pro-grind.”

“We call it the slow life,” Mira added. “We don’t need skyscrapers or 9-to-5s. We’ve got the land, the tech, and each other. Why trade that for traffic jams and overpriced coffee?”

Another person chimed in, passing around a small vial of something glowing faintly pink. “The parties help. Nothing clears the mind like a little euphoria.”

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “What is that?”

“Homebrew,” the man said. “A mix of psychedelics and a synthetic endorphin booster. Completely safe, I promise.”

Samuel laughed. “Well, mostly safe. This lot might love their free love and wild nights, but they’re still coders at heart. Everything’s tested and calibrated.”

As the sun sank lower, the clearing began to change. The laughter turned softer, more intimate, as conversations split into smaller clusters. The music from the barn drifted over the hills, blending with the sound of crickets and the faint rustle of the wind.

Daniel leaned back on his hands, watching as the energy of the group shifted. Mira had moved closer to one of the men, her fingers tracing lazy patterns along his forearm as she whispered something that made him laugh. Her other hand slid under his shirt, feeling the warmth of his skin. Another pair had sprawled out on a blanket nearby, their bodies tangled, hands roaming freely - one hand cupping a breast, another slipping beneath shorts, as if gravity itself had pulled them into a dance of desire.

Samuel sat beside him, unbothered by the unfolding scene. “You’re overthinking it,” he said, not looking at Daniel.

Daniel raised an eyebrow. “Am I?”

Samuel gestured toward the group with his mug. “This isn’t about seduction or performance. It’s about connection, letting the moment take you wherever it wants to go.”

One couple disappeared into the woods, their laughter trailing behind them like a ribbon caught in the wind, but not before Daniel caught sight of her skirt being lifted, his hands on her hips. Another pair leaned into each other, their kisses slow and unhurried, lips exploring necks, tongues tasting each other, as though time had ceased to matter.

“Is this… normal?” Daniel asked, his voice lower than he intended.

Samuel shrugged. “Normal is a city thing. Out here, we’re about freedom. If two—or three, or five—people want to share a moment, who are we to stop them?”

Daniel’s gaze lingered on the clearing. The boundaries between the group seemed to dissolve. People shifted effortlessly, a brush of hands here, a shared glance there, as if they were following some unspoken rhythm, leading to touches that were more than just friendly - a squeeze here, a stroke there.

The air grew heavier, charged with an almost electric intimacy. Mira stood, pulling the man beside her to his feet. They didn’t bother with words as they stepped toward the edge of the clearing, disappearing behind a stand of trees, where their shadows hinted at more than just conversation.

Nearby, a woman with long braids slid her hands along the shoulders of another, tilting her head back as their lips met passionately, tongues visible in their fervour. The blanket they sat on shifted beneath them, the edges catching the grass as they moved closer, their breath quickening, hands exploring under clothes.

Samuel took a sip of his tea, his expression calm. “Free love isn’t for everyone,” he said, his tone conversational. “But it works for us. No strings, no expectations—just honesty.”

“And this?” Daniel gestured toward the group, now a constellation of whispered laughter, soft moans, and quiet touches, bodies entwined in ways that spoke of more than just companionship.

“This,” Samuel said, his voice soft, “is just people being people. We don’t need permission to feel.”

Daniel shifted uncomfortably, the warmth of the tea in his hands suddenly too much. The scene was hypnotic in its ease, its lack of pretense. There was a beauty to it, raw and unfiltered, that made his chest tighten. But another part of him recoiled, uneasy. Was this freedom, or just another kind of escape? The absence of rules might be liberating, but it also felt untethered, like a balloon drifting further and further from the ground.

Samuel seemed to sense his unease. “You’re thinking too hard again,” he said with a small smile. “It’s not about proving a point or making a statement. It’s about living. Letting yourself exist without the grind, without the noise.”

Daniel’s eyes fell on a couple leaning against a tree, their bodies moving together with a languid rhythm, her legs wrapped around him, his hands guiding her movements. The faint sound of laughter floated back from the woods, mingled with sighs and soft cries. The whole scene felt surreal, like stepping into a painting that shifted with each breath.

Daniel felt the air thicken around him, each breath pulling in the scent of earth mixed with the musk of arousal. The clearing, once a place of simple gathering, had transformed into a tableau of human desire laid bare. His eyes darted around, capturing fleeting moments of intimacy that were both beautiful and intimidating in their openness.

Everywhere he looked, bodies were intertwined, moving in a symphony of carnal expression. To his left, a trio was on a blanket, their limbs creating a complex puzzle, hands and mouths exploring with an ease that spoke of comfort and familiarity. Their moans were soft, blending into the night's chorus, as if they were part of the natural sounds of the forest.

Directly in front of him, a woman was on all fours, her face contorted in pleasure as a man moved behind her, their rhythm setting a pace that seemed to resonate through the ground Daniel was sitting on. Another man lay beside them, his hand guiding her head down to him, creating a scene of shared passion that was both overwhelming and hypnotic.

The visual was matched by the sounds - gasps, whispers, the occasional sharp cry of ecstasy, all underpinning the soft strumming from the distant barn. It was like watching a live, untamed performance, where each participant was both actor and spectator in this dance of flesh.

Daniel could feel his heart racing, a mix of fascination and an onset of sensory overload. The sheer number of people, the unabashed display of sexuality, it was like watching a river of human connection flow unbridled, each ripple a story of touch, taste, and surrender.

He noticed Mira, now visible again through the trees, her body pressed against the man's, her legs wrapped around him as they stood, leaning against a tree for support. Their movements were slow but intense, each thrust visible through the gaps in the leaves, adding to the overwhelming sensory assault.

The scene was not just about sex; it was an expression of freedom, of living without the confines of societal norms, but for Daniel, it was too much to process all at once. The raw humanity, the vulnerability of these moments, was both a magnet and a force pushing against his own boundaries.

He felt a tightness in his chest, a mix of awe and an urge to look away, yet his eyes kept returning, drawn by the undeniable honesty of the acts before him.

Samuel's voice broke through his thoughts, calm and steady. "It's a lot, I know. It's like seeing life stripped to its most basic, primal form. But remember, it's all about consent and mutual respect here."

Daniel nodded, his throat dry. The scene was overwhelming, a vivid, living tapestry of human connection that both challenged and expanded his understanding of intimacy. It was the kind of freedom that felt both liberating and daunting, like standing at the edge of a great precipice, the wind of change urging him to either step back or take the leap into this new world of open, shared desire.

Samuel leaned in slightly, his voice low. “You don’t have to decide tonight, but the barn is always open. If you want this—whatever this is—you’re welcome here.”

Daniel looked at him, the book Samuel had given him still resting heavy in his lap. “I don’t know if I fit in here,” he admitted, his voice quiet.

Samuel’s smile was soft but unwavering. “You’re here, aren’t you? That’s a start.”

The music from the barn grew louder for a moment, then faded again, replaced by the sound of murmured voices and the occasional burst of laughter.[i]

Chapter 10:

The next morning Samuel leaned back in his seat as the train hummed along the tracks, the rolling hills of the Peak District giving way to the industrial sprawl that signalled the approach to Manchester. The carriage was quiet, the kind of antiseptic calm found in first-class travel. A steaming cup of coffee sat untouched on the tray in front of him, the aroma mingling faintly with the metallic tang of the train’s interior.

It had been months since he’d last visited Manchester. The city lingered in his mind as a source of both fascination and discomfort, its relentless efficiency a stark contrast to the slower, more deliberate rhythm of Sheffield.

He scrolled through his phone, scanning the latest updates from his financial advisor. His investments in Manchester’s industries were performing beyond expectations. Graphs and percentages told a story of surging production and expanding markets. Rolls-Royce’s factories, AI-driven logistics hubs, and even Manchester’s nascent bioengineering sector were reaping profits hand over fist.

The numbers were undeniable, yet they left him uneasy.

Samuel gazed out the window, the skyline of Manchester beginning to take shape in the distance. Glass and steel skyscrapers gleamed in the midday sun, their sharp lines a testament to the city’s philosophy of precision and utility.

He couldn’t help but compare it to Sheffield. There, progress felt human, organic, tied to art and culture. In Manchester, it was mechanised, stripped of sentiment, and scaled to a degree that felt alien.

But the numbers, he reminded himself, the numbers didn’t lie.

His family’s wealth had always been a blend of the old and the new—gold during the wars, Bitcoin during its infancy, and now investments in the industries shaping the future. Sheffield appealed to his ideals, but Manchester was where the world seemed to be heading.

As the train slid into the station, Samuel gathered his belongings—a leather satchel containing a laptop, a notebook, and a handful of documents from his advisor. The station was a hive of activity, but even the chaos here seemed more ordered than in other cities. Digital kiosks buzzed with activity as commuters scanned their IDs or Bitcoin wallets to pay for tickets and services.

Waiting for him at the platform was Ewan Carter, his financial advisor. Ewan was a sharply dressed man in his early 40s, his suit tailored to perfection and his hair neatly combed. He offered a firm handshake as Samuel approached.

“Samuel,” Ewan greeted him with a broad smile. “Welcome back to Manchester. It’s good to see you again.”

“Good to be back,” Samuel replied, though he wasn’t entirely sure if that was true. “I hear my investments have been keeping you busy.”

Ewan laughed. “Busy? They’ve been booming. You’ll see for yourself soon enough. We’ve arranged a tour of the main exchange hub and one of the production facilities. You’re in for a treat.”

As they walked through the station, Samuel found himself noting the subtle changes since his last visit. The city’s infrastructure seemed even more streamlined. Bitcoin logos were everywhere, embedded into signs and digital billboards advertising products and services. Everything had a polished efficiency that, while impressive, felt a touch impersonal.

“Manchester doesn’t stop,” Ewan said, catching Samuel’s gaze. “We’ve automated even more processes in the last quarter. Productivity’s up 18%, and exports are reaching markets as far as Southeast Asia and the Americas. Thorne’s vision is paying off.”

Samuel nodded but remained silent. He wasn’t here to debate philosophy with Ewan. Not yet, anyway.

As they stepped into a sleek, self-driving car waiting outside the station, Samuel couldn’t help but ask, “Have you heard anything about Thorne? Is he still... as involved as ever?”

Ewan raised an eyebrow, clearly amused by the question. “Thorne? Oh, he’s as hands-on as ever. He’s been focusing on integrating decentralised governance models into the industrial sector. The man’s a force of nature. You’ll probably run into him—he has a knack for knowing when people like you are in the city.”

Samuel leaned back in the car seat, letting Ewan’s words settle. The thought of meeting Thorne again sent a shiver of anticipation through him. Their last encounter had been a clash of ideals, each man standing firm in his philosophy. This time, Samuel wasn’t sure he had the same confidence in Sheffield’s slower, cultural approach.

The car accelerated smoothly, the towering skyline of Manchester drawing closer. Samuel took a deep breath, steeling himself for whatever the day might bring.

The self-driving car glided to a halt outside the Manchester Bitcoin Exchange Hub, a monumental glass structure that seemed to shimmer in the sunlight. Its façade was a lattice of photovoltaic panels, reflecting the city's obsession with efficiency and sustainability. Inside, the building buzzed with activity, a hive of transactions and innovation.

Ewan led Samuel through the revolving doors, the air-conditioned interior a sharp contrast to the bustling streets outside. Screens displaying live Bitcoin market data lined the walls, their numbers ticking upward and downward in a hypnotic rhythm. Traders moved with purpose, their faces lit by the glow of their devices as they orchestrated deals worth millions.

“This is where it all happens,” Ewan said, gesturing to the sprawling floor below. “The beating heart of Manchester's economy.”

As they descended to the main floor, Samuel's gaze was drawn to a massive digital sculpture suspended from the ceiling—a dynamic visualization of Bitcoin transactions happening in real time. Tiny orbs of light zipped across the network, connecting nodes that represented wallets, exchanges, and institutions worldwide.

“It's mesmerizing,” Samuel admitted, his voice tinged with awe.

“It's progress,” Ewan corrected, flashing a grin. “We've built this hub to not only process transactions but also to innovate. Smart contracts, decentralized finance protocols, tokenized assets—it's all being developed right here.”

They reached a glass-walled meeting room overlooking the trading floor. Ewan gestured for Samuel to sit, sliding a tablet across the table.

“Here's the breakdown of your investments,” Ewan said, his tone shifting to business. “Your holdings in Manchester's manufacturing sector have seen a 22% increase this quarter. The Bitcoin exchange platform itself has grown by 15%, thanks to new institutional partnerships.”

Samuel scrolled through the data, his brows furrowing slightly. “And what about the energy costs? Bitcoin mining isn't exactly gentle on the grid.”

“True,” Ewan admitted, “but we've integrated renewable energy sources into nearly every aspect of the city's infrastructure. In fact, we're exporting excess power to other regions. It's not just about mining anymore; it's about efficiency and innovation.”

“What's on the horizon?” Samuel asked, setting the tablet down. “Where does Manchester go from here?”

Ewan leaned back, folding his hands. “Thorne's pushing hard on integrating Bitcoin with physical goods markets. We're developing systems where entire supply chains operate on the blockchain. Imagine buying a car, and every step of its production—materials, labor, transport—is tracked and verified in real time.”

Samuel nodded slowly, though he couldn't shake a sense of unease. “And the human element? Where does that fit in?”

Ewan shrugged, his expression pragmatic. “Humans adapt. Efficiency doesn't erase people—it just reshapes their roles. Manchester's focused on productivity, not nostalgia.”

Samuel couldn't help but think of Sheffield. It was slower, yes, and far less polished. But it still felt human, grounded in relationships and culture.

"Do you ever worry it's too... clinical?" Samuel asked, his voice thoughtful.

Ewan tilted his head. "Clinical gets results, Samuel. You can't argue with the numbers."

After their meeting, Ewan led Samuel onto the trading floor. The hum of machinery mixed with the low murmur of voices, creating a soundscape that felt both alive and mechanical.

They stopped at a terminal where a young analyst was explaining an experimental AI-driven trading algorithm. "It's designed to predict market fluctuations with 87% accuracy," the analyst said, her eyes gleaming with excitement. "It's already outperforming human traders in simulations."

Samuel asked a few probing questions, impressed by her expertise but unsettled by the implications.

As they moved on, Ewan gestured to a group of engineers clustered around a holographic display. "That's our next big project—integrating DAOs into municipal governance. Imagine a city where every decision is made transparently, with real-time input from its citizens."

"And what about dissent?" Samuel asked.

Ewan chuckled. "In Manchester? Dissenters either adapt or leave. Efficiency doesn't cater to everyone, Samuel. That's what makes it work."

As they left the hub, Samuel felt a mix of admiration and discomfort. Manchester was undeniably impressive, a city running at the cutting edge of human achievement. But it was also relentless, its focus on productivity leaving little room for the intangibles that gave life meaning.

Back in the car, he turned to Ewan. "Do you ever think about what happens if this fails? If the systems break down?"

Ewan raised an eyebrow. "That's the beauty of it, Samuel. The systems are designed to self-correct. It's failure-proof."

Samuel leaned back, watching the city blur past the window. "Nothing's failure-proof," he murmured.

Ewan didn't respond, his attention already on his phone, scrolling through updates on the next project.

As Samuel stepped out of the Bitcoin Exchange Hub, his thoughts were consumed by the precision and relentlessness of Manchester's progress. The city hummed with activity, its streets a symphony of efficiency: self-driving cars gliding smoothly, delivery drones zipping overhead, and pedestrians marching with purpose.

He barely noticed the figure approaching until a familiar voice broke through his reverie.

"Samuel Ashcombe," Alexander Thorne greeted, his tone as sharp and assured as ever.

Samuel stopped mid-step, turning to see Thorne standing before him. Clad in a tailored black suit that seemed both minimalist and commanding, Thorne carried himself with the ease of someone who knew he was the most important person in the room—even if that room was an entire city.

“Alexander,” Samuel replied, his tone neutral but respectful. “I didn’t expect to see you here.”

Thorne smirked. “I make it my business to know when someone like you is in my city.”

They walked together down the bustling avenue, the skyscrapers looming like sentinels around them. Thorne’s pace was deliberate, his presence magnetic enough to make passersby glance twice.

“So,” Thorne began, “how are you finding Manchester? Impressive, isn’t it?”

Samuel nodded. “It is. The Exchange Hub, the factories, the infrastructure—it’s all... remarkable. But it’s also relentless.”

Thorne laughed. “Relentless is what makes it work. You don’t build the future by pausing for breath.”

Samuel raised an eyebrow. “And you think this is the future?”

“I don’t think, Samuel. I know.” Thorne’s voice carried a certainty that bordered on arrogance. “Manchester is a blueprint for what humanity can achieve when it abandons nostalgia and embraces efficiency. Speaking of which,” he added, glancing sideways at Samuel, “why haven’t you invested more of your family’s wealth here?”

Samuel sighed, shoving his hands into his coat pockets. “Most of it has gone down the other line.”

Samuel sighed, shoving his hands into his coat pockets, the weight of the moment pressing heavily on him. “Most of it has gone down the other line,” he said quietly, his voice carrying a note of both pride and resignation.

Thorne raised an eyebrow, his curiosity piqued. “Another line? What do you mean?”

“The other branch of the family,” Samuel explained, his gaze drifting to the skyline. “They’ve been stewards of the Ashcombe legacy as much as we have. But their priorities have always been in America.”

Samuel took a deep breath, steadying himself. “The other branch of my family,” he began, “tried and according to the family history stopped the first World War by leveraging their influence in parliament and the press. Their efforts planted seeds of pacifism that shaped British policy for decades.

“My Great uncle Charles moved to American and they weathered the Great Depression by investing in gold, ensuring their estates didn’t collapse like so many others. They’ve always believed that stability matters more than growth.”

“And yet you chose Bitcoin,” Thorne said pointedly.

“Bitcoin is stability,” Samuel replied. “The ultimate anchor in a chaotic world. But stability doesn’t mean sacrificing humanity. That’s why I’ve split my investments—Sheffield for the culture, the other line for the land. It’s not a perfect balance, but it’s one I can live with.”

Thorne stepped closer, his voice lowering but gaining intensity. “You talk about balance, but balance is weakness. Manchester isn’t afraid to commit, to push the limits of what’s possible. Your family’s quaint little projects won’t save the world—they’ll only make you feel better about watching it burn.”

As Thorne walked away from Samuel, weaving effortlessly through the bustling streets of Manchester, a faint smile lingered on his lips. Samuel Ashcombe—idealistic, tethered to the past, and irritatingly sincere—hadn’t committed more of his family’s wealth to Manchester, but Thorne could feel the doubt he had sown taking root.

That was the beauty of a city like Manchester: it didn’t need immediate victories. Its strength lay in momentum, in the inevitability of its systems overtaking everything slower, softer, or sentimental. Samuel might cling to Sheffield’s romantic vision, but Thorne knew that the numbers would eventually break him.

As he stepped into a self-driving car waiting by the curb, Thorne allowed himself a moment of quiet satisfaction.

The car whisked him toward the Industrial Coordination Centre, a towering structure of glass and steel that served as the nerve centre for Manchester’s decentralized economy. Inside, algorithms processed terabytes of data every second, optimizing production schedules, trade routes, and resource allocation.

Thorne entered the building with purpose, his presence commanding the attention of everyone he passed. Employees straightened their postures, their movements growing sharper as if his mere proximity amplified their efficiency.

He stopped in front of a massive digital display that dominated the central atrium. The screen projected real-time metrics: production outputs, Bitcoin transaction volumes, and global export figures. A map of the world showed Manchester’s growing influence, its nodes lighting up across continents like a neural network expanding its reach.

Thorne had never set out to become a philosopher. His early life had been one of rebellion—against the state, against tradition, against any system that sought to impose its will on him. But over time, rebellion had given way to a colder, more calculated vision.

He believed in freedom, but not the chaotic, idealistic freedom that Samuel clung to. Thorne’s freedom was pragmatic: the freedom to act, to build, to dominate. It wasn’t about removing power structures—it was about making them irrelevant through sheer efficiency.

He often thought of himself not as a leader but as a node in the decentralized network he had helped build. Manchester wasn’t his city; it was the city. He was simply its most effective operator.

As Thorne reviewed the day’s metrics with his team, his thoughts drifted back to his conversation with Samuel. It frustrated him that someone with such resources could remain so blind to the truth.

To Thorne, the human body and mind were no different from any other system: they could be optimized, enhanced, perfected. Manchester’s embrace of genetic engineering, biohacking, and MRNA technology wasn’t just about survival—it was about evolution.

“Culture is overrated,” he had told Samuel, and he meant it. Culture was messy, inefficient, and often served as an excuse to resist change. The future didn’t need poets and dreamers; it needed engineers and problem-solvers.

But even as he dismissed Samuel’s worldview, Thorne couldn’t help but feel a flicker of curiosity. Samuel’s faith in Sheffield’s slower, softer model was maddening, but it was also resilient. People like Samuel clung to meaning, to relationships, to traditions that had outlasted empires.

Thorne didn’t envy him—envy required emotional vulnerability, and Thorne had excised that from himself long ago. But he couldn’t ignore the fact that Samuel’s vision, however antiquated, had a way of surviving.

Would it be enough to challenge Manchester’s dominance?

He doubted it. But doubt, he reminded himself, was a seed too.

Later that afternoon, Thorne sat in a dimly lit conference room, surrounded by Manchester’s leading technologists and financiers. They discussed the city’s next steps: expanding its Bitcoin-based supply chain, integrating neural implants into its workforce, and scaling its bioengineering initiatives.

One of his advisors mentioned Samuel’s visit, their tone dismissive. “Ashcombe is irrelevant. His investments in Sheffield are sentimental, not strategic.”

Thorne held up a hand, silencing the room. “Never underestimate sentiment,” he said, his voice measured. “It’s inefficient, yes, but it’s also powerful. People cling to it, even when it’s irrational. If we’re to outlast Sheffield, we don’t just need to outperform them—we need to outthink them.”

The room fell silent, the weight of his words settling like a heavy fog.

As the day wound down, Thorne stood in his penthouse office, staring out over Manchester’s skyline. The city glowed with life, its relentless hum a testament to the system he had built.

Samuel’s reluctance to invest further in Manchester didn’t bother him. The numbers were on his side, and he knew it was only a matter of time before Sheffield’s slower model was outpaced, overtaken, and forgotten.

But as the city buzzed below, Thorne found himself returning to Samuel’s parting words: “You might win the race, but you’ll lose the people running it.”

He smirked, brushing the thought aside. Sentimentality had no place in the future he was building.

The blinds slid open precisely at 6:30 a.m., flooding Alexander Thorne’s penthouse with the pale grey light of Manchester. He was awake, already halfway through his protein shake. On the table before him, a tablet displayed the morning’s metrics: production up 9%, exports ahead of schedule, and Bitcoin transaction volumes holding steady.

The numbers steadied him. The numbers always did.

He finished his drink, placed the glass in the sink, and slipped on his jacket. By 7:00 a.m., he was descending to the street below, his car waiting. Manchester hummed around him—factories already in full swing, delivery drones weaving overhead.

Today, he would meet with his inner circle.

The meeting room at the **Industrial Coordination Centre** was stripped of anything unnecessary: a long steel table, ergonomic chairs, and a single holographic interface in the centre. The design reflected Manchester's ethos—direct, efficient, purposeful.

They were all there when Thorne arrived, each engrossed in their own work but alert enough to note his entrance.

- **Dr. Miriam West:** Quiet and precise, Miriam oversaw Manchester's genetic and bioengineering efforts. She spoke only when necessary, and when she did, it was impossible not to listen.
- **Julian Coyle:** Blockchain architect, cynical and sharp-witted. He thrived on cutting through optimism with the cold knife of reality.
- **Aisha Malik:** Philosopher-turned-strategist, the only one in the room willing to challenge Thorne openly. Her calm demeanour often belied the strength of her arguments.
- **Connor Tate:** Head of industrial operations, a man who measured success in units shipped and deadlines met. He had little patience for abstraction.

Thorne took his seat at the head of the table.

"Let's begin," he said.

Julian leaned forward, fingers tapping against the surface of the table. "The Exchange Hub is exceeding expectations. Daily transactions are up 15%, and the latest smart contract integrations have slashed processing times."

Connor nodded in agreement. "Factories are holding steady. Automation upgrades are in place across 60% of our sites. We're already seeing a 12% boost in productivity."

Miriam added, "The neural enhancement trials are progressing well. Cognitive gains are measurable and significant, though we're seeing mild side effects—heightened anxiety in some cases."

"Manageable?" Thorne asked.

Miriam nodded. "For now. But it's worth monitoring."

Aisha's voice cut through. "And the displaced workers? Connor, what's the plan for those who can't adapt?"

Connor's jaw tightened. "We've offered retraining programs. Some take it, some don't. You can't force progress."

"Progress at what cost?" Aisha pressed, her gaze steady.

Thorne interjected, his voice low and firm. "This isn't Sheffield, Aisha. Sentimentality doesn't build cities. Efficiency does."

The room went silent.

Miriam broke the tension. "The Radical Innovation Hub is requesting additional funding. Their regenerative tissue project is moving into its next phase."

"What's the ask?" Thorne asked.

“Ten million,” Miriam replied. “They’re developing synthetic organs for rapid replacement. No donors, no waiting lists. The implications are vast.”

Julian raised an eyebrow. “And profitable,” he said, his tone pragmatic.

Thorne considered this, tapping a finger against the table. “Approve it. But I want scalability projections on my desk by the end of the week.”

The meeting wrapped up efficiently, the group dispersing to their respective domains. As Thorne stepped into the elevator, his mind was already turning over the next challenge.

His inner circle was a finely tuned machine, each member chosen not just for their expertise but for their ability to push the limits of what Manchester could achieve.

This was the city he had built—a place where hesitation was a liability, where every decision was measured against the cold calculus of progress.

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And yet, Samuel Ashcombe’s words lingered in his mind: “You might win the race, but you’ll lose the people running it.”

The Radical Innovation Hub stood on the edge of Manchester’s industrial sector, a sprawling campus of modular buildings bristling with solar panels and wind turbines. Unlike the sleek, utilitarian architecture of the Industrial Coordination Centre, the Hub had an almost chaotic energy—a testament to the experimental nature of its work.

Thorne’s car pulled up to the main entrance, a stark white façade that bore the Hub’s logo: a hexagonal lattice representing the interconnectedness of ideas. He stepped out, greeted by Dr. Elias Brandt, the Hub’s director, whose unkempt hair and frenetic energy were as much a hallmark of the facility as the cutting-edge projects it housed.

They entered the Advanced Materials Lab, where scientists were refining applications for graphene. Sheets of the atom-thin material hung in carefully controlled environments, their surfaces shimmering under the light.

“Graphene is the future,” Brandt said with a flourish. “We’ve developed a prototype for superconductive highways—roadways that can transmit energy to vehicles wirelessly. Imagine an electric car that never needs to stop to recharge.”

As Thorne and Brandt approached the Advanced Materials Lab, the air seemed to hum with an almost imperceptible charge, the telltale sign of experiments involving high-energy systems. The lab was vast, its walls lined with temperature-controlled chambers and shelves filled with intricate equipment. Suspended in one chamber was a lattice of graphene sheets, shimmering faintly under calibrated lighting.

“Graphene,” Brandt began talking to the group en masse, gesturing toward the material with evident pride, “is the closest thing we have to a miracle. One atom thick, nearly 200 times stronger than steel, yet flexible and nearly transparent. And we’ve made considerable progress in its applications these past few months.”

Thorne stepped closer, his sharp eyes scanning the lattice. “Show me.”

“First, thermal conductivity,” he said, highlighting a chart. “Graphene’s ability to dissipate heat is unparalleled, which is why we’ve integrated it into our quantum processors. Over the past quarter, we’ve achieved a 15% efficiency boost simply by replacing traditional cooling mechanisms with graphene-based heat sinks.”

Thorne nodded, already calculating the implications. “And production costs?”

“Still high,” Brandt admitted, “but dropping steadily. Our team has perfected a new chemical vapour deposition process, increasing yield by 20% while reducing energy input by 12%. Within a year, we expect graphene-based components to become competitive with legacy materials.”

He swiped the hologram, revealing a structural diagram of a bridge. “Then there’s infrastructure. We’re testing graphene composites for construction. A single sheet, integrated with traditional concrete, can extend structural integrity by decades. Bridges, skyscrapers, even tunnels—all stronger, lighter, and more durable.”

Brandt gestured to another chamber where a thin ribbon of graphene spiralled in a loop, connected to a cluster of superconducting magnets. “This is where things get exciting,” he said, his enthusiasm bubbling over.

Thorne stepped closer, watching as the ribbon emitted a faint blue glow.

“Graphene’s superconductive properties are revolutionizing energy transmission,” Brandt explained. “We’re running a prototype test: transmitting electricity through this ribbon with zero energy loss. Zero. Imagine a grid where power flows seamlessly from solar farms to cities, without the inefficiencies of traditional cables.”

“And scalability?” Thorne asked, his tone sharp.

Brandt hesitated, then smiled. “That’s the challenge. Scaling graphene superconductors requires a leap in mass production. But our team’s working on a modular assembly technique. If we crack it, we’re not just powering Manchester—we’re exporting this technology worldwide.”

Thorne’s expression remained unreadable, but his interest was unmistakable.

Brandt led him to a model of a road segment suspended in a chamber. The surface glistened under the light, its sleek black finish almost alien in its perfection.

“This,” Brandt said, “is the prototype for our graphene superhighway. The surface is self-healing—any cracks or wear regenerate within hours, thanks to embedded graphene nano-capsules. And it’s not just a road—it’s an energy conduit.”

Thorne raised an eyebrow.

“Vehicles driving over it draw power wirelessly,” Brandt explained. “No more charging stations. The highway itself becomes the energy source.”

Thorne reached out, his fingers grazing the smooth surface of the model. “And the timeline?”

Brandt's smile widened. "We've laid a one-kilometre test track outside the city. Early trials are promising—vehicle efficiency is up by 30%, and maintenance costs are negligible. If funding holds, we can expand it to key routes within the next two years.

As they exited the Advanced Materials Lab, Brandt couldn't resist one last pitch. "Graphene isn't just a material—it's a philosophy. It embodies everything Manchester stands for: strength, adaptability, and limitless potential."

Thorne gave a rare nod of approval. "You've made progress, Elias. Keep pushing."

For Thorne, graphene wasn't just another project. It was a symbol of Manchester's ability to reshape reality itself. As he walked back to his car, his mind raced with possibilities—superhighways connecting continents, quantum processors powering decentralized governance, and buildings that could last centuries.

If Manchester's future had a skeleton, it was made of graphene.

Thorne was still digesting Brandt's presentation when he met Clara Nguyen, head of Manchester's Industrial Finance Authority, in a private conference room at the Radical Innovation Hub. Clara was known for her unflinching focus on numbers, the kind of person who could turn visionary dreams into actionable realities—or crush them under the weight of fiscal pragmatism.

Clara gestured to the sleek black lattice of graphene resting on the table between them. "It's beautiful, isn't it?" she said, her tone more clinical than admiring. "But beauty comes with a price tag."

Thorne leaned forward, resting his elbows on the table. "What are we looking at?"

Clara tapped her tablet, projecting a series of charts and graphs onto the wall.

"Production remains the bottleneck," she began. "Using chemical vapour deposition (CVD), it costs approximately £100 per gram of graphene. For context, building one kilometre of a graphene-enhanced superhighway would require approximately 10 metric tons, just for the primary layers."

"Do the math," Thorne said, his voice steady.

"That's roughly £1 billion per kilometre, not including the cost of integration with existing infrastructure," Clara said, glancing up at him. "And while the efficiency gains are undeniable, the upfront investment is... daunting."

Thorne's gaze didn't waver. "And alternatives?"

"Scaling production is the only way forward," Clara replied. "We've made progress—our plasma-enhanced CVD technique increases yield by 20% and reduces energy consumption by 12%. But even with those gains, we're still looking at a five-year horizon to bring costs below £10 per gram."

Clara swiped to another slide, this one detailing the energy implications. "Then there's the superconductivity angle. The graphene ribbons we're testing for energy transmission—those are game-changing. But maintaining the required low temperatures for superconductivity is energy-intensive. Without breakthroughs in cryogenics, scaling this system citywide would increase Manchester's grid demand by 15-20%."

"And the payoff?" Thorne asked.

Clara allowed herself a small smile. “Near-zero energy loss in transmission. Over a decade, the savings would recoup the investment and then some. But you’re playing a long game, Alexander. This isn’t going to win you any short-term headlines.”

Clara shifted to the commercial side of the presentation. “The good news is that graphene isn’t just an infrastructure play. We’ve identified five key verticals where it can generate immediate revenue:

Consumer Electronics: Flexible displays and graphene batteries are already in demand. If we can corner the market, we’re looking at £2 billion annually within three years.

Aerospace: Graphene composites can reduce aircraft weight by 15%, cutting fuel consumption by 12%. Major manufacturers are eager to partner.

Healthcare: Biocompatible graphene for implants and regenerative tissue scaffolds has massive potential. Early interest from biotech firms is promising.

Construction: Integrating graphene into concrete extends the lifespan of buildings and bridges by decades, a major selling point for infrastructure projects worldwide.

Energy Storage: Graphene-enhanced supercapacitors could revolutionize grid storage and electric vehicles.”

“Projected revenue?” Thorne asked.

“With aggressive scaling and market penetration, £5 billion annually within a decade. But that assumes significant upfront investment—north of £10 billion in R&D and production facilities over the next five years.”

Thorne leaned back, considering. Clara crossed her arms, her expression unreadable.

“There’s another issue,” she said. “We’re not the only ones working on this. Shanghai, Berlin, and San Francisco are all pouring resources into graphene research. If we don’t move decisively, we’ll lose the competitive edge.”

“So what’s your recommendation?” Thorne asked.

Clara’s eyes narrowed. “Push harder. Secure more funding, expand the research teams, and lock in exclusive contracts with early adopters. But it’s a gamble, Alexander. A big one.”

Thorne’s lips curled into a faint smile. “Everything worth building is.”

Thorne descended into the Advanced Engineering Wing of the Radical Innovation Hub, a sprawling underground facility filled with the low hum of precision machinery. Here, technicians and engineers worked tirelessly to translate graphene’s theoretical potential into tangible applications.

Dr. Elena Marquez, the lead materials scientist, greeted Thorne with a brisk nod. She was a no-nonsense engineer, her sharp intellect matched only by her relentless work ethic.

“Alexander,” she said, gesturing toward a large workbench where several prototypes were laid out. “I heard you were reviewing the graphene projects. I thought you might want a closer look at the practical side of things.”

“Show me,” Thorne replied, stepping closer.

Elena picked up a slab of reinforced concrete embedded with a faintly shimmering layer of graphene. “This is our latest composite,” she explained. “We’ve integrated graphene sheets into the internal matrix of the concrete. It increases tensile strength by 25% and extends the lifespan of the material by at least 50 years."

Thorne ran his hand along the surface. "And integration challenges?"

She shrugged. "Scaling, as always. The chemical bonding process is delicate—any impurities, and the graphene loses its structural integrity. Right now, we can produce enough for pilot projects, but full-scale deployment would require a tenfold increase in production capacity."

"And cost?"

"Still high," Elena admitted. "But the long-term savings on maintenance and replacement make it worthwhile for critical infrastructure. Bridges, high-rises, even underground transit systems."

She moved to a table where a long, thin ribbon of graphene coiled around a superconducting magnet. Nearby, a digital readout displayed power levels.

"This is where things get exciting," Elena said, her voice tinged with pride. "We're testing graphene ribbons for energy transmission. These can carry electricity with virtually zero resistance, eliminating energy loss."

Thorne studied the setup. "What's the current efficiency?"

"99.98%," she replied. "We're using a cryogenic system to maintain superconductivity, which is energy-intensive. But we're exploring methods to enhance conductivity at higher temperatures—doping the graphene with certain elements, for example."

"And failure rates?"

"Minimal, but not negligible," Elena admitted. "The challenge isn't just maintaining superconductivity—it's integrating it into existing grids without introducing instability. One glitch, and you risk a cascading failure."

Thorne nodded, his expression thoughtful. "And the first practical application?"

"We're looking at using it to overhaul the city's power distribution network," she said. "Imagine a grid where energy moves instantly, without bottlenecks or waste. It would make Manchester the most energy-efficient city on the planet."

Next, she gestured toward a sleek black smartphone prototype on another workbench. "Graphene isn't just about infrastructure," Elena said. "This is a prototype of a graphene-enhanced battery. It charges in 15 minutes and holds power three times longer than current lithium-ion models."

Thorne picked up the device, feeling its surprising lightness.

"We're also developing flexible screens using graphene," Elena continued. "Imagine devices that you can fold, roll, or even wear like fabric."

"And how soon can we scale this?" Thorne asked.

"With enough funding, two years," Elena replied. "But again, we're competing with other hubs. If they beat us to market, we lose the edge."

Finally, Elena led Thorne to a section of the lab where a team of engineers worked on a graphene-coated chassis for an electric vehicle.

“This is our graphene-infused supercar prototype,” she said. “The chassis is 30% lighter than traditional materials, and the graphene coating reduces drag by altering air flow at a molecular level.”

“And production challenges?”

“It’s tricky,” she admitted. “The coating process requires absolute precision, and we’re still working on making it cost-effective. But the performance gains are undeniable.”

Thorne studied the prototype, his mind racing with possibilities.

As they concluded the tour, Elena turned to Thorne. “Graphene can transform this city, Alexander. Infrastructure, energy, transportation, consumer tech—it touches everything. But the question is, how far are you willing to push?”

Thorne met her gaze, his voice steady. “As far as it takes.”

For Thorne, the stakes were clear. Graphene wasn’t just a material—it was a statement of intent. Manchester’s future would be built on the sharpest edges of human ingenuity, and he would ensure it stayed ahead, no matter the cost.

Thorne exited the Radical Innovation Hub, his mind still processing the dizzying array of possibilities graphene offered. The city stretched before him, a symphony of movement and precision. The hum of industry soothed him, each drone, each self-driving car, a testament to Manchester’s relentless march forward.

As he settled into the sleek interior of his autonomous car, his tablet vibrated with a notification. The AI concierge—his personal assistant integrated with Manchester’s vast neural network—flashed a message across the screen:

“You have a match. Confirmed dinner with Felicity Harper, 8:00 p.m., Ambit.”

Thorne raised an eyebrow, not out of surprise but mild amusement. The AI rarely erred in its recommendations.

The system was an outgrowth of Manchester’s optimization ethos, combining genetic, psychological, and sociological data to create pairings that maximized compatibility. It wasn’t just about love or lust—it was about alignment, efficiency, and mutual benefit.

Felicity Harper, the message informed him, was a model from the Lake District. Her profile highlighted an interest in biohacking and sustainability, two pillars of Thorne’s own vision for progress. The match was, as always, calculated to perfection.

“Accept,” he said, and the car confirmed the reservation with a soft chime.

The graphene-glass doors of Ambit slid open as Alexander Thorne entered, the muted hum of Manchester’s optimized world falling away into the carefully curated quiet of the city’s most exclusive restaurant. Thorne’s presence commanded attention, but he was used to that; it wasn’t ego, just the inevitability of his position.

What he wasn’t used to, however, was being caught off guard.

Felicity Harper stood near the table reserved for them, a figure so effortlessly striking that for a brief moment, even Thorne felt the precision of his thoughts falter. Her beauty wasn’t just physical—it was elemental, a harmony of presence and poise that seemed almost otherworldly. Her dress, understated and elegant, only emphasized the perfection of her form. She moved like water, each gesture fluid, deliberate, yet unselfconscious.

“Alexander,” she said, her voice low and warm, extending her hand.

“Felicity,” he replied, taking her hand with a firmness that masked his momentary disquiet.

As they sat across from each other, Thorne found himself observing her with a precision that felt unusually personal. Her features were flawless, her dark eyes both inviting and guarded, like a secret she dared you to uncover.

But it was more than her beauty. Felicity carried an energy—a quiet confidence that softened the edges of her perfection, making her seem less a figure from a painting and more a living, breathing person.

“Your city is impressive,” she said, glancing out at the skyline beyond the glass walls. Her tone was conversational, but there was an edge to it, a subtle challenge. “Efficient, yes. But... cold.”

Thorne leaned back slightly, his expression giving nothing away. “Efficiency has its warmth, depending on how you measure it.”

She smiled faintly, a curve of her lips that seemed to light the room. “And how do you measure warmth, Alexander?”

The AI matchmaker had suggested a conversation starter, but it was unnecessary. Felicity was no passive participant in this interaction. She didn’t just answer questions; she countered them, each response perfectly balanced between charm and intellect.

“You’ve built a machine,” she said after their appetizers arrived. “A remarkable one, no doubt. But doesn’t it ever feel... fragile?”

Thorne raised an eyebrow, his voice steady. “Fragility is a matter of perspective. The alternative is chaos.”

“And chaos is always bad?” she pressed, tilting her head slightly.

“It’s inefficient,” he replied.

“Is it?” Felicity’s eyes sparkled with mischief. “Sometimes chaos is where the best things happen. Innovation, love, art—none of those come from perfection.”

As the conversation unfolded, Thorne found himself drawn not just to her beauty but to the intelligence that animated it. Felicity wasn’t just a model—she was a force, her thoughts and words as carefully constructed as her appearance.

“I imagine you’ve heard this before,” he said, his tone deliberate, “but you remind me of something... mythic. Helen of Troy, perhaps.”

Felicity laughed softly, the sound like water over stones. “Helen brought down empires, Alexander. I’m just a woman trying to navigate a world that’s constantly shifting underfoot.”

“But you navigate it well,” he said, his gaze steady.

She met his eyes without flinching. “So do you. But I wonder—are you steering the world, or is it steering you?”

By the time dessert arrived, the dynamic between them had shifted. Thorne, who rarely allowed himself to feel anything as mundane as curiosity, found himself fascinated. Felicity, for her part, seemed equally intrigued by the man who had turned Manchester into the world's most efficient city.

"You're not what I expected," she said, leaning forward slightly.

"And what did you expect?" Thorne asked, genuinely curious.

"Someone... harder. Colder. But you're not, are you?"

Thorne considered this, the weight of her observation settling over him. "What I am," he said carefully, "is someone who understands the cost of progress."

"And what about the cost to you?" she asked softly.

They left the restaurant together, walking through Manchester's graphene-lit streets. The city buzzed around them, its hum of activity almost hypnotic, but in that moment, it felt distant—secondary.

"I didn't expect this to feel so..." Felicity trailed off, searching for the word.

"Normal?" Thorne supplied, his voice tinged with dry humour.

She smiled again, shaking her head. "No. Effortless."

Thorne didn't reply immediately. For a man who had built his life on effort, on deliberate control, the idea of something effortless was both alien and... alluring.

As they paused at a corner, Felicity turned to him, her gaze steady. "Thank you for tonight."

Thorne inclined his head slightly. "The pleasure was mine."

Thorne hesitated, his fork poised over the untouched entrée before him. Felicity's words hung in the air like a challenge he hadn't prepared for. Innovation, love, art—each word nudged at the edges of his carefully constructed worldview, where chaos was a threat, not a catalyst.

"Chaos," he said finally, setting the fork down, "is seductive. It tempts you with the illusion of freedom while eroding everything stable beneath your feet."

Felicity tilted her head, the candlelight catching the sharp lines of her cheekbones. "But stability without chaos becomes... what? Stagnation?"

Thorne allowed himself a small, sardonic smile. "I doubt Manchester could ever be accused of stagnation."

"No," she admitted, leaning forward slightly, her voice softer now, almost conspiratorial. "But what about you, Alexander? Are you ever tempted?"

"Tempted by what?" he asked, though he already felt the answer coming.

She studied him for a moment, her gaze unflinching. "By the very chaos you fight so hard to contain."

Thorne leaned back, his posture still controlled but his expression momentarily unguarded. "Temptation is a luxury I can't afford."

“Why not?” she pressed, her voice low and inviting.

He hesitated again, weighing his response. “Because the stakes are too high. Manchester isn’t just a city—it’s a model, a proving ground for ideas that could define the future. To indulge in chaos would be... irresponsible.”

Felicity let his words linger before responding. “But isn’t that what makes it human? The ability to step away from responsibility, even for a moment? To embrace what isn’t planned, what isn’t perfect?”

Her question struck a chord deeper than Thorne wanted to admit. “You’re asking me to dismantle the very foundation of what I’ve built.”

“Not dismantle,” she corrected, her voice gentle but firm. “Just... step outside it for a moment.”

Thorne picked up his glass of wine, turning it slightly in his hand before taking a measured sip. “I wasn’t always this... disciplined,” he said, his voice quieter now.

Felicity didn’t react overtly, but her slight shift forward signalled her interest.

“There was a time,” he continued, “when I believed in... spontaneity. I thought progress was something you stumbled into, not something you engineered. It was naïve.”

“What changed?” she asked.

Thorne’s gaze flickered to the skyline visible through the restaurant’s graphene walls. “Failure,” he said simply. “When things fall apart because of carelessness, it changes you. You learn to value precision, control.”

“And yet,” she said softly, “here you are, having dinner with me—something you didn’t control, something you didn’t plan.”

For the first time that evening, Thorne laughed, a short, quiet sound that seemed almost foreign to him. “Touché.”

Their conversation shifted, becoming less guarded, more fluid. Felicity shared stories of her childhood in the Lake District—how the wild, untamed landscapes had shaped her love of beauty and simplicity.

“You talk about chaos like it’s a villain,” she said at one point. “But to me, it’s freedom. It’s the river carving its way through rock, the storm that clears the air.”

Thorne listened, his sharp mind noting the poetry in her words, the way she seemed to embody the very chaos she described. And yet, he didn’t feel threatened by it. If anything, he felt... drawn in.

By the time they left the restaurant, the air between them had shifted. Thorne wasn’t a man prone to impulsivity, but as they stepped onto the quiet street, he found himself reluctant to let the evening end.

“Would you like to walk?” he asked, surprising even himself.

Felicity smiled, the kind of smile that made the world around them seem irrelevant. “I’d like that.”

The quiet hum of the city receded as Alexander and Felicity entered his penthouse. The space was a study in precision—clean lines, muted tones, and a stark absence of anything extraneous. Floor-to-ceiling windows framed Manchester’s skyline, a glittering testament to the city’s relentless progress.

Felicity stepped inside with the easy grace she carried everywhere, her eyes scanning the space. “This feels... curated,” she said, her tone light but probing.

“It is,” Alexander replied, setting his keys on a minimalist console. “Everything here has a purpose.”

She wandered toward a sleek black desk near the windows. Papers were stacked neatly, each pile deliberate and orderly, but one caught her attention—a pamphlet titled Trustless sat conspicuously at the centre.

“May I?” she asked, glancing at him.

Thorne hesitated for a fraction of a second before nodding. “Go ahead.”

Felicity picked up the pamphlet, her fingers brushing the embossed title. She flipped through the first few pages, her brows lifting slightly as she read. “This is... fun,” she said after a moment, looking up at him.

“Fun seen as a negative in business,” Thorne said, moving to pour them both a glass of wine. “But sometimes, business itself is the fun. The attempt provides the amusement.”

“What’s it about?” she asked, though the faint smile on her lips suggested she already had an inkling.

He handed her a glass, leaning against the edge of the desk. “It’s Ashton. His attempt at Goethe is poor. He is going to pass of fiction as philosophy. That is not difficult. I present an argument stripping back and of distrust of the state in fiction. For stripping away the noise of statism. Trustless is about enjoying what freedoms we presume we have.”

Felicity tilted her head, intrigued. “You make it sound so... harsh.”

“That’s the point,” Thorne said, his tone steady. “These ideas aren’t revolutionary. They’re the natural conclusions anyone would draw if they weren’t blinded by outdated traditions or emotional attachments. Yet people still cling on to the past, even though the future is obvious.”

She moved to the windows, pamphlet still in hand, her gaze drifting over the city. “And what about Sheffield?” she asked, her voice thoughtful. “Do you think they see it this way?”

Thorne’s jaw tightened slightly. “Sheffield is... sentimental. They cling to notions of culture and society as though they’re inherently opposed to structure and progress. They’re not wrong to value those things, but they’re wrong to think you can have them without a foundation.”

“Do you think Eliot Ashton is sentimental?” she pressed, turning to face him.

Thorne’s lips curved into a faint, sardonic smile. “He’s a romantic. And romance has its place. But it doesn’t build cities. It doesn’t sustain civilizations.”

Felicity considered this, her expression unreadable. “You sound so certain. But what if you’re wrong?”

Thorne met her gaze, his own unflinching. “Then I’ll fail. But I won’t. Because what I’m building isn’t about me. It’s about the inevitability of progress.”

She set the pamphlet down, stepping closer to him. “You believe that. I can see it. But...” She hesitated, her voice softening. “Do you ever wonder what it costs you?”

Thorne’s expression shifted slightly, a flicker of something vulnerable passing through his eyes before it was gone. “I don’t have the luxury of wondering,” he said. “Manchester doesn’t run on doubt.”

Felicity reached out, placing a hand lightly on his arm. “Maybe not. But people do.”

For a moment, the city outside seemed to disappear, leaving only the quiet hum of the room and the weight of her words. Thorne didn’t move, didn’t pull away. Instead, he let her presence ground him in a way he hadn’t felt in years.

“Stay,” he said finally, the single word carrying more meaning than he intended.

She smiled, the kind of smile that felt like an answer to a question he hadn’t realized he’d asked. “I think I will.”

Chapter 11:

From the rooftop bar in Kelham Island, Sheffield felt alive—its skyline flickering with AI-generated projections, the river running dark beneath the old bridges. The night air was cool, carrying the faint sounds of distant music, laughter from below, the gentle hum of conversation.

Eliot Ashton sat with his back to the view, his drink untouched. Across from him, Sophie leaned on the table, the city lights reflecting off the half-full wine glass she swirled absent-mindedly in her fingers. Between them lay the small, freshly printed pamphlet, Trustless by Alexander Thorne. Its minimalist black cover bore no ornament, no design—just those two words, weighted with intent.

A warm glow from the bar’s filament bulbs cast shifting shadows across Eliot’s face as he exhaled slowly. He had read the manifesto already, but the words still lingered. The weight of them, the force behind them. This was no longer theory—Thorne was acting.

Sophie tapped the cover. “You can almost feel the heat coming off it.”

Eliot glanced down. “It’s dangerous.” He paused. “It’s effective though.”

He finally picked up his drink, the ice clinking against the glass. Below them, the streets pulsed with the steady rhythm of Sheffield’s cultural engine—music venues, artist collectives, coffeehouses where philosophy and politics were debated into the early hours. All of it—the slowness, the thoughtfulness, the space Sheffield had carved out for itself—felt suddenly fragile.

Sophie leaned in, voice quieter now. “He’s not just building a city anymore, Eliot. He’s building a state. And people are listening.”

Eliot turned the pamphlet over in his hands, watching the lights flicker in Sophie’s eyes. He had built Sheffield on the idea that culture could be its own form of sovereignty. But Manchester was growing relentless, a machine without hesitation. He knew Thorne too well. This wasn’t just a competition anymore. It was something far bigger.

Eliot set his glass down and leaned forward, elbows on the table, fingers laced together. His voice was steady, but Sophie could hear the weight behind it.

"The real question isn’t whether we can keep up with Thorne." He tapped the pamphlet once, deliberately. "It’s whether Westminster will allow him to keep going at all."

Sophie exhaled, shaking her head. "You think they'll stop him?"

"Can they afford not to?" Eliot gestured vaguely to the skyline, to Sheffield's quiet hum of life below. "Thorne's not just talking about efficiency anymore, Sophie. He's talking about control. About replacing the state. That's not competition—that's defiance."

She frowned, running a finger along the rim of her glass. "You're saying Manchester's not just a model anymore. It's a threat."

"It's beyond that already." Eliot sat back, rubbing his jaw. "Thorne has already moved half the city's infrastructure onto DAOs. He's bypassing national regulators and the state itself, perfectly legally. The Treasury can't control his monetary flow because everything's running through Bitcoin and Lightning. There's no tax base as half the city has gone off grid by leaving state control. No levers to pull."

Sophie thought for a moment, then tilted her head. "Then what happens next?"

"Pressure." Eliot's voice was clipped. "The state has two options—force Manchester to comply or let it spiral out of its control. If Thorne keeps moving like this, Manchester becomes a city-state in all but name."

Sophie let out a low breath. "And that means conflict."

Eliot nodded. "Not just with us. With Westminster. Maybe even with the world."

The rooftop bar was quiet enough for conversation but busy enough to keep their words from carrying. Eliot rolled the pamphlet between his fingers, the pages stiff with fresh ink. Sophie swirled the last of her wine, watching the city below, her brow furrowed.

"If the government does act," she said, "what does that mean for Sheffield? If they crack down on Manchester, do they expect us to pick a side?"

Eliot didn't answer right away. He was still considering the possibility that Sheffield might be leveraged by Westminster as a counterweight, a cultural and economic alternative to Thorne's aggressive decentralization. If that happened, Sheffield might no longer be truly independent—it would be a tool of the state, whether he wanted it or not.

A gust of cool air swept across the rooftop as Samuel Ashcombe walks in, his coat slung over one shoulder, his presence unmistakable even in the dim light. He moved with the quiet confidence of someone used to being listened to, someone who had spent his life watching power shift hands, adjusting accordingly. He spotted Eliot and Sophie and made his way to their table, sliding into the seat across from them.

"Sorry I'm late," he said, setting down a small espresso. "Things move quickly these days."

Eliot smirked, setting Trustless between them on the table. "Yeah. We've noticed."

Ashcombe picked it up, flipping through the pages casually. "You read it?"

"Just finished," Sophie said, leaning back. "It's… a statement, that's for sure. There's no going back now. The dye is cast."

Ashcombe exhaled through his nose, setting the pamphlet down. "Thorne isn't just laying out a vision anymore—he's making demands. He's past the point of proving himself. Now he wants to push control."

Eliot nodded. "And the collectives? What do they make of all this?"

Samuel folded his arms, glancing at the skyline as if weighing his words. "There's no unified opinion, but they're watching closely. Some of them see Thorne as a necessary counterforce to the state, and to you and to private currency issuance model. Some of us are hardcore cypherpunks Eliot, they don't trust you either. But Thorne, they think he's accelerating something inevitable—tearing down systems that should've collapsed already. Others?" He shrugged. "They think he's just building a new version of the same problem. The city is decentralized, sure, but he's still at the centre of it. He doesn't govern, but he commands. That makes him dangerous."

Sophie smirked, shaking her head. "So, half of them think he's a liberator, the other half think he's a dictator?"

"Roughly." Ashcombe took a sip of his espresso. "But they all agree on one thing—if Westminster acts, this whole thing changes overnight. The moment the state perceives him as a threat to political order, it all changes. And you know what that means, Eliot?"

Eliot didn't blink. "It means Sheffield gets caught in the middle."

Samuel set his cup down with a quiet clink and steepled his fingers. "There's only one way this doesn't end in disaster."

Eliot raised an eyebrow. "And that is?"

"We bring everyone together. A conference. A real attempt at mediation before this turns into something worse."

Sophie let out a dry laugh. "You really think Thorne wants to talk?"

Samuel smirked. "No. But that's exactly why we have to make him." He leaned in slightly. "Thorne thrives on conflict, on acceleration. He's already assuming that Sheffield, the state, and anyone outside his model will either get out of his way or try to stop him. If we offer something different—a structured, high-profile event, something he can't just ignore—we force him to engage on different terms."

Eliot exhaled slowly, rubbing his chin. The idea wasn't bad, but Thorne had no interest in compromise. He thrived on binaries. Victory or failure. If Sheffield couldn't keep up, it was obsolete. If the state interfered, it was illegitimate.

"Who would mediate?" Eliot asked.

"Earl Rutherford," Samuel said simply.

Both Eliot and Sophie sat back at that.

Hope Valley's old aristocratic lineage rarely got involved in city affairs, but Rutherford was different. He was an eccentric—intellectually curious, well-connected, and, crucially, neutral. His estate in the Hope Valley was large for sure, it was of another time and of a future time; at the same time. It was a vast, secluded property where philosophers, artists, and political figures sometimes found themselves in quiet discussions over whiskey and open fires.

"You think Rutherford would do it?" Eliot asked.

"I think he'd love it," Samuel said with a slight smirk. "He lives for grand historical moments, and this would be one."

Sophie crossed her arms. “Even if he agrees, why would Thorne show up? He doesn’t need us.”

"Because we wouldn’t just invite him." Samuel let the words hang for a moment. "We’d bring in the Rave Collectives, the Peak District Kommunes, independent technologists, and Bitcoin theorists from both sides. People from all over the world might come. This isn’t just about Manchester and Sheffield—it’s about the whole ecosystem that’s growing out of both cities. If Thorne ignores it, he risks looking like the one refusing to engage.”

Eliot stared at him for a long moment, then finally said, "And if it doesn’t work?"

Samuel picked up Trustless, tapping its cover. "Then at least we tried before the inevitable."

The rooftop was silent for a moment. Then Eliot drained the rest of his drink and set the glass down firmly.

"Alright, Samuel. Let’s get this going."

Samuel leaned back in his chair, crossing one leg over the other. “If we want Thorne to show up, it can’t be a dull political summit. It has to be something bigger. A spectacle. A festival. Think about it, Eliot—Thorne is obsessed with momentum, with progress. He doesn’t respect small gatherings. If we set up a traditional mediation, he’ll dismiss it as bureaucracy. But if we create something sprawling, something dynamic—he won’t just show up, he’ll want to dominate it.”

Eliot leaned forward. “So what are we talking about exactly? A symposium? A trade summit?”

Samuel shook his head. “Bigger. A full-scale Festival of Ideas—the biggest intellectual, cultural, and technological event the UK has seen in decades. A grand symposium of the future.”

Sophie grinned. “A place where everyone—tech pioneers, cultural leaders, political radicals—can come and lay out their visions for the world.”

Samuel’s eyes gleamed. “Yes. Make it impossible to ignore. We turn Hope Valley into an intellectual and artistic Mecca for a week—philosophy, technology, finance, art, and culture all colliding in one space. We invite thinkers from across the ideological spectrum. Everyone who has skin in the game.”

Eliot exhaled, thinking fast now. “Keynotes, debates, performances…”

Samuel nodded. “AI panels, Bitcoin discussions, debates on sovereignty and power structures, cultural showcases—live music, poetry, digital art installations.”

Sophie tapped her finger on the table. “A grand debate between Sheffield and Manchester right at the heart of it.”

Samuel smirked. “A public intellectual showdown. Thorne won’t be able to resist.”

Eliot ran a hand through his hair. The sheer scale of what they were proposing was immense. This wasn’t just about settling the Sheffield-Manchester rivalry. This would be historic. A moment that could redefine the ideological landscape of the 21st century.

He met Samuel’s gaze. “And you really think Rutherford will back this?”

Samuel chuckled. “Are you kidding? He’ll be thrilled. It’ll be a page straight out of history. The Earl of Hope Valley presiding over a summit of the future? He’ll have a custom coat of arms designed for the occasion.”

Sophie smirked. “So we pull together a guest list of the most influential thinkers in Britain—and beyond. If we get the right mix, it’ll feel like the Woodstock of the Sovereign Age.”

Eliot sat back, staring at the skyline, his mind racing. A festival of the future. A conference of power. A moment in history. He finally nodded. "Let’s do it."

The three of them sat in silence for a moment, the weight of the idea settling between them. It was grand, ambitious—and dangerous. If they wanted Thorne there, they had to be careful. He wouldn’t walk into a trap, nor would he waste time on something that didn’t serve his vision.

Sophie tapped the side of her wine glass, eyes narrowing. “Thorne won’t come if he thinks it’s about reconciliation. He thrives on conflict. If he senses it’s a ploy to slow him down, he’ll dismiss it outright.”

Eliot nodded, still staring at the city below. “Then we need a different angle. Something that appeals to his ego, his vision.”

Samuel smirked. “Easy. We make it about money.”

Eliot arched an eyebrow. “Go on.”

Samuel leaned in. “I approach him—not as a mediator, not as someone trying to ‘fix’ things, but as an investor. I tell him the Festival is a financial summit, a place where we’ll discuss the future of investment, of digital economies. That it’s the opportunity to raise capital. That my Peak District Collective—hell, maybe even the world—wants to decide where to place capital: Sheffield or Manchester.”

Sophie caught on. “A bidding war.”

Samuel grinned. “Exactly. We position it as a massive open-source investment conference, where the best and brightest will come to hear from the most powerful figures in the two cities. If Thorne wants to attract investors, he’ll have to be there. He’ll have no choice but to present Manchester as the superior option.”

Eliot considered it. It was smart—frame it as a competition for capital, not a debate about morality or governance. It played into Thorne’s strengths, made it irresistible.

"And we open-source the entire thing," Eliot said slowly, thinking aloud. "If it’s a closed summit, he’ll suspect it’s a trap. But if anyone can attend—if we broadcast it, livestream it, let anyone contribute—it becomes something too big to ignore."

Samuel nodded. “We let it spread across the Bitcoin and cypherpunk circles. Give DAOs access, podcasters, any media organisation that can pay. Let decentralised think tanks set up their own spaces. Make it impossible for him to dismiss.”

Sophie smirked. “He won’t be able to resist.”

Eliot exhaled sharply. "Alright. Samuel, you take point on this. Get this going with Thorne. Make him think it’s his idea to come."

Samuel grinned, already pulling out his phone. “Consider it done.”

Samuel pulled out his phone, tapping out a carefully worded message to Thorne. This wasn’t something he could frame as a favour—Thorne didn’t do favours. It had to be an opportunity.

Samuel: Alexander. I've got something for you. A high-level investment conference. My collective is looking at where to allocate serious capital—Manchester or Sheffield. We're talking long-term, structural investment. Private money, institutional money, Bitcoin whales, old-world aristocracy.

He paused, considering his next words.

Samuel: The prospective venue is the Rutherford estate. Earl of Hope Valley is hosting. Open-source format, broad attendance. Not just bankers—thinkers, builders, innovators. A festival of ideas. Sheffield will be there, obviously. Thought you might like the chance to put Manchester forward.

The message sent. Now, he just had to wait. Thorne was quick to respond to power moves. If he was interested, it wouldn't take long.

While Samuel handled Thorne, Eliot leaned back in his chair, pulling up another contact. He scrolled through until he found the number: Earl Rutherford – Hope Valley House.

He exhaled, then dialled.

The phone rang twice before a crisp, well-enunciated voice answered.

"Eliot, my dear boy, I was just reading something of yours the other day. A delightful critique of pharmaceutical intervention and return to holistic medicine. To what do I owe the pleasure?"

Eliot smirked, shaking his head. "I've got something ambitious for you, Rutherford. A conference. A grand one."

"I do like grand things," the Earl mused. "Tell me more."

Eliot leaned forward. "A festival of ideas, economy, and sovereignty. The greatest thinkers, builders, and investors of our time. We're pitching Sheffield against Manchester—not in war, but in vision. We open-source the whole thing, bring in DAOs, Bitcoiners, artists, engineers. A summit of the future."

There was a beat of silence.

Then Rutherford chuckled. "Eliot, this sounds utterly mad. And therefore, I'm absolutely interested."

"Good," Eliot said, smiling. "Because we need your house."

"My house?" Earl Rutherford let the words hang, amused. "Hope Valley is a place for thinkers, certainly, but hosting what sounds like an ideological battle royale? That's quite the escalation, Eliot."

Eliot smirked, knowing Rutherford well enough to recognize the game. The Earl liked to feign reluctance, to pretend he wasn't immediately tempted by the grandeur of it all.

"Think of it as a piece of history in the making," Eliot pressed. "A defining moment, played out on neutral ground. Your name would be forever attached to the event that shaped the future of Britain's two greatest cities."

Rutherford exhaled thoughtfully. "And you genuinely believe Thorne will come?"

"Samuel is handling that," Eliot said. "But if we make it big enough, irresistible enough, his presence will be inevitable."

The Earl went quiet for a moment. Eliot could imagine him now, sitting in his vast estate, gazing out over the rolling hills of the Peak District, already envisioning the spectacle. Finally, Rutherford spoke.

"Hope Valley has seen many things, Eliot. Monarchs, exiled revolutionaries, foreign dignitaries whispering conspiracies over fine port. But never something quite like this. I must say, it does have a certain... grandeur."

Eliot could hear the decision settling into place before Rutherford even said the words.

"Fine. I shall host your festival of ideas. But I expect nothing less than history."

"It will be," Eliot assured him.

"Then I look forward to seeing what madness you've set in motion," the Earl said, his voice rich with anticipation. "Do keep me entertained, won't you?"

The call ended. Eliot set his phone down, letting out a breath. The venue was secured. Now, all that remained was getting Thorne to commit.

Samuel's phone buzzed.

Thorne: Interesting. Who's coming?

Samuel smiled. Hooked already. He quickly replied:

Samuel: Anyone who matters. Investors, cypherpunks, builders. You. Eliot. The Peak District Kommunes. The Sheffield culturalists. Even the aristocracy. The most influential minds of our time, all in one place.

The three dots appeared. A pause. Then—

Thorne: If I come, I set the terms of my involvement.

Samuel chuckled, showing Eliot and Sophie the screen. "He's interested."

Sophie took a sip of her drink. "That was easy."

"Not quite," Eliot murmured. "Thorne never enters a game he doesn't think he can win. He'll come—but on his own terms."

Samuel typed back.

Samuel: Of course. We wouldn't expect anything less.

Alexander Thorne sat in his office, the skyline of Manchester stretching endlessly beyond the floor-to-ceiling windows. The city pulsed with its own quiet rhythm—the hum of automated factories, the faint glow of data centres, the relentless flow of workers moving with purpose. The machine was running smoothly. Efficiently.

Yet here was Samuel Ashcombe, dangling an unexpected proposition in front of him. An open-source festival of ideas, a conference of power.

Thorne drummed his fingers against the polished metal surface of his desk, reading the message again. Who's coming? It had been his first question, instinctive. He had no interest in useless thinkers or academic pretenders.

Samuel's reply had been perfect. Anyone who matters.

That meant investors, technologists, industrialists. But more importantly—it meant Eliot Ashton. It meant Sheffield.

Thorne leaned back in his chair, exhaling through his nose. A test. A battlefield. A stage.

Eliot still thought there was room for coexistence. That two distinct visions could develop in parallel. Thorne had never believed that. One would dominate. The other would submit.

This wasn't just an opportunity to speak. It was an opportunity to prove the inevitability of his vision.

But it also carried risks.

The Earl of Hope Valley was a wildcard. Aristocrats played long games, and Rutherford was no exception. Hosting the conference at his estate gave it a sense of historical weight, but it also meant stepping onto neutral ground—ground Thorne couldn't completely control.

And then there were the Peak District Kommunes. He respected them in principle—pure sovereign individuals, unconstrained by hierarchy. But in practice, they were unfocused, idealistic, inefficient. Their presence meant the event wouldn't just be a contest between Sheffield and Manchester. There would be other forces at play.

Thorne ran a hand through his hair. He knew how to control a debate, how to dominate a conversation, how to reduce an opponent to irrelevance with sheer clarity. But he also knew that Eliot was a different kind of opponent. Ashton knew how to make ideas beautiful. That was Sheffield's only real power.

Culture. Romance. The seductive illusion that things could move at a human pace. Thorne wanted to move at machine pace; even Culture and Romance.

That was what made Eliot dangerous. Not his policies. Not his economy. His ability to make people feel something.

Thorne had no illusions. He had the superior model. The superior city. But people didn't always want what was best for them. They wanted meaning, even at the expense of efficiency.

That was why he had to go.

If he left Eliot unchallenged, Sheffield would remain a story. An idea. It would linger in the minds of those who still clung to sentimentality. That was unacceptable.

He tapped out his response.

Thorne: I'll come.

He didn't need to say more.

This was going to be his stage. His moment.

Eliot thought this was a chance for reconciliation. It wasn't.

It was a chance to finish Sheffield off.

Eliot exhaled, setting his phone down on the rooftop table. He reached for his drink, rolling the glass between his fingers before taking a slow sip. Thorne had accepted. That was the hardest part.

Across from him, Sophie studied his face. "So? What did he say?"

Eliot smirked. "He’s in."

Sophie leaned back in her chair, letting out a low whistle. "Well, shit. That was easy."

"Not really," Eliot murmured, swirling the last of his drink. "You know what this means, don’t you? He’s not coming for a conversation. He’s coming to win."

Sophie shrugged. "He always was. But at least now it’s happening on our terms."

"Which means," Sophie said, as if reading his thoughts, "we need money."

Eliot sighed, rubbing his temple. "Yeah. A lot of it."

"We’ve got three real funding sources," Eliot said, straightening up. "The Bank, Samuel, and Rutherford."

Sophie nodded. "The Bank can cover some, but we can’t drain too much from SheffCoin’s reserves. If people think we’re using the Bank to fund ideological battles, confidence drops."

"Agreed," Eliot said. "But we can justify some of it. A cultural investment. Sheffield staking its place in the world."

"How much?" Sophie asked.

"Enough to secure the infrastructure—venues, logistics, broadcasting. But we’ll need private money for everything else."

"Samuel," Sophie mused. "He’s wealthy enough to fund it all himself if he wanted to."

"He won’t," Eliot said. "He’ll contribute, but he won’t bankroll the whole thing. He likes to keep his investments balanced between Sheffield and Manchester. He’ll want to make sure he’s funding a moment, not a side."

Sophie smirked. "Then there’s Rutherford."

"Rutherford," Eliot echoed, rubbing his chin. "He’ll love the idea, but he’ll expect something in return."

"Like?"

"Prestige. Influence. Maybe a formal role in the event itself."

Sophie considered this. "He’ll want to be seen as the great mediator, the noble figure keeping the radicals from tearing each other apart."

Eliot smirked. "Fine by me. Let him play his role."

Sophie knocked back the last of her wine. "So, you talk to the Bank’s Board. Samuel secures the Peak District money. And we let Rutherford make it all look grand and respectable."

"Exactly," Eliot said, pushing his empty glass aside. "Now all we have to do is make sure it doesn’t turn into a fucking disaster."

Eliot spent the next few days moving between meetings, securing funding, and making sure the Festival of Ideas wasn’t just an ambitious plan but an imminent reality. The moment Thorne had accepted, the pressure had shifted. Now, it wasn’t just an idea—it was a race against time.

Eliot sat in one of the upper-floor meeting rooms of the Bank of Sheffield, the late afternoon light spilling through the arched windows. Opposite him sat Helen Radford, one of the bank's senior strategists, arms crossed, eyes sharp.

"You want to divert bank resources into an ideological festival?" she asked, arching an eyebrow.

"I want to invest in Sheffield's future," Eliot countered. "This isn't just a debate. It's a declaration. A moment to solidify Sheffield's identity. You think Thorne's not spending every spare Bitcoin on making Manchester into his vision of the future?"

Helen sighed, drumming her fingers on the table. "How much?"

"Enough to secure infrastructure—venues, broadcasting, logistics. No more than 15% of the bank's discretionary fund. There is money to be made back, not including all the investments we might find."

Helen narrowed her eyes. "That's a lot of SheffCoin liquidity to pull from the ecosystem. If we miscalculate, we weaken confidence."

"We're not miscalculating," Eliot assured her. "This isn't just an expense—it's an investment. The festival will bring capital into Sheffield, not just drain it. If we don't control the narrative, Manchester will define the future, and we'll just be reacting to them."

Helen considered this, then finally nodded. "Fine. But we need to see a return on investment. If Sheffield is going to challenge Manchester, we can't just talk about culture. We need tangible output."

"We'll get it," Eliot promised.

One funding source secured.

Samuel had been easier to convince. The two of them sat in a private whiskey bar in the Peaks, the glow of the fireplace dancing over old oak and leather. Samuel, as ever, was relaxed, his glass of scotch swirling in lazy circles.

"I assume you're not here just for the atmosphere," Samuel said with a smirk.

"We need more backing," Eliot said simply. "The bank is covering infrastructure, but we need private money for everything else—hospitality, international speakers, digital infrastructure."

Samuel raised an eyebrow. "So you came to me, the walking bitcoin fund?"

"You said yourself this was a moment in history," Eliot replied. "If we pull this off, it won't just be Sheffield or Manchester that wins. It'll be the entire movement."

Samuel took a slow sip of his drink, thinking. "Alright. I'll bring in some of my money, the family's, and the Kommunes money. The decentralised elite. But I want something in return."

Eliot leaned in. "Which is?"

"The Peak District Kommunes get their own space at the festival. A real presence. Not just a side show It's a three man show, not just you and Thorne."

"Done." Eliot smirked, this had been Ashcombe's game all along, he wanted equal footing with the other two men.

Samuel raised his glass. "Then let’s make history."

Hope Valley House was as grand as ever—an old estate built in an age where Britain still saw itself as the centre of the world. Eliot sat across from Earl Rutherford, who, as expected, was delighted by the spectacle of it all.

"We need it to be grand, Rutherford. It can’t just be a conference. It has to feel like history."

The Earl nodded, a glint in his eye. "You shall have it. But in return, I expect the role of gracious host. The figure who presides over the event—not interfering, of course, but ensuring it remains civilised."

Eliot smirked. "Naturally."

Rutherford clapped his hands together. "Then let the games begin."

With funding secured, Eliot’s next moves were pure execution. Hope Valley House would be transformed into a high-tech intellectual battleground. The grand halls would host debates, while the grounds would be filled with AI-generated art installations, hackathons, and live performances. The biggest thinkers and builders from across the Bitcoin world, the decentralised economy, and the sovereign individual movement were invited. The festival would be livestreamed, open-source, with decentralised media hubs allowing people to interact in real time.

As the final details were hammered out and plans solidified, Eliot stood on a quiet balcony overlooking the city of Sheffield. The industrial skyline, softened by the glow of creative lights and the steady pulse of cultural life, reminded him of all they had to lose—and all they had to gain.

Below, the preparations continued: emails were sent, funds transferred, and schedules refined. In the back of his mind, he could still hear Thorne’s cold challenge echoing across Manchester, a threat that would soon collide with their grand vision. But for now, the promise of the Festival of Ideas—hosted at Hope Valley House and backed by the collective will of Sheffield, Samuel’s investments, and the Earl’s enduring legacy—filled him with a determined hope.

Chapter 12:

It was just past five when the Earl of Hope Valley rang the bell for tea and stepped out onto the south terrace.

The house—his house—stood with the self-possession of old stone, the kind of stone that had not merely survived wars and revolutions but observed them, quietly, as one might observe a squabble among tenants. The light across the valley was cold but golden, and in the wind there was the sharpness of anticipation, like the breath one draws before an announcement.

Lord Rutherford was not, in any vulgar sense, an anxious man. But in the past week he had found himself rising earlier and walking farther. The footpaths that skirted the boundary wall had been walked by statesmen, poets, spies. Now they would be walked by decentralists, meme theorists, sovereign individuals, and post-ideological programmers. He had agreed—somewhat whimsically, he admitted to himself—to host a festival of ideas, and the thing had grown like ivy: beautiful, vigorous, and not entirely under control.

He did not regret saying yes. But he wondered if history, so often an abstraction to the clever, might show up here in its usual clothing: tired, dishevelled, and impatient.

The estate manager had brought him a new folder of security assessments. Civilian and private actors, yes, but also rumours of interest from state entities. There were whispers—always whispers—that this open-source intellectual gathering was more than it appeared. The Earl privately thought that Ashcombe was making moves behind the scenes. Foreign think tanks were sending observers. Several embassies had quietly requested guest access.

The Earl smiled at that.

He placed the folder down and looked out over the valley. The pavilions would be built near the long pond. The old stables would be turned into sleeping quarters for the Kommunes from Bamford. There was talk of a live AI poetry duel. One of the Peak technologists had requested a silent meditation chamber "equipped with haptic empathy feedback." Another had requested a place to plug in a goat.

"At least the Italians were predictable," the Earl muttered to himself.

Later, seated at his writing desk, he began to compose a letter to clear his mind. It was a habit from another age.

> *My dear Charles,*
>
> *You once asked me why I kept this place open—not for tenants, not for parties, not even for the country itself, but for ideas. And here we are. The two great cities of our age—if indeed they are cities at all anymore—will come here to debate what comes next. They call it a Festival. I am not sure what that means now. The last time this house saw a real festival, it involved a string quartet, a foreign princess, and a crate of Hungarian wine smuggled past the Foreign Office.*
>
> *Now we will host an anarchist in a graphene suit, a philosopher in corduroy, and hundreds of people who think the Enlightenment should be forked like code.*
>
> *I find myself rather moved by the whole thing. And slightly terrified.*
>
> *Yours as ever,*
> *R.*

The knock came precisely at six. Not the front entrance, of course. The Earl's guests from London never used the front. The side door was quieter, more discreet, and spoke to a tradition older than press briefings or democratic reform. He rose from his chair in the library and made his way down the panelled corridor, taking his time.

The man who stepped inside was the kind of figure who never appeared in newspapers and was never named at dinner tables. He wore a well-cut but forgettable overcoat, carried no bag, and smiled only with his eyes. His name—or the one in use today—was Christopher Malling.

"Lord Rutherford," Malling said with a slight bow. "Thank you for making time."

"I always have time for civil servants who arrive without appointments and mention the Cabinet Office in passing." The Earl gestured toward the drawing room. "Shall we?"

They sat by the fire. Tea was declined. Whisky, accepted.

Malling took his glass but did not drink immediately. “You’ll forgive the nature of my visit. There are… concerns in Westminster.”

“About the festival?”

“About what it represents,” Malling said. “You’re hosting a convergence of two or perhaps three competing philosophical-economic factions—one of whom, to be blunt, is beginning to sound less like a cultural movement and more like an emerging state.”

“You are speaking of Alexander Thorne.”

“We are,” Malling replied, adjusting his cuffs. “Though not exclusively. Ashton and Ashcombe too. Sheffield may be quieter, its economy smaller, but its influence is growing. The Bank, SheffCoin, the decentralised guilds… these are not minor developments. Ashcombe too, his family name wield significant power and influence both here and in the United States. The Ashcombe family still holds significant holdings in financial institutions. Were you also aware that Ashcombe is the designer of the Lattice protocol?”

“No I was not, though I have heard many stories about the Peak District Kommunes.” The Earl studied him. “And what is it exactly you expect me to do? Cancel the event?”

Malling gave the hint of a smile. “Not at all. The government is not seeking confrontation. But it is—shall we say—deeply invested in ensuring the sovereignty of the United Kingdom remains intact.”

“‘Sovereignty’,” the Earl repeated, sipping his drink. “Curious word, these days.”

“It is a curious time,” Malling replied. “And Thorne’s language—particularly his growing rejection of parliamentary supremacy—has not gone unnoticed. And now it is popular,” Malling said, evenly, “to believe in algorithmic consensus and smart contracts. Parliament makes laws, not Alexander Thorne. The Government is not afraid to put on a show, to demonstrate our commitment to these principals.”

The fire crackled. Outside, the wind shifted across the valley. For a moment, both men listened.

“We don’t wish to intervene,” Malling said at last. “Not yet. But if the proceedings appear to move beyond rhetoric—if there is talk of formal separation, of alternative governance models that threaten this… the response will not be cultural.”

“I see.”

“You may think these ideas are abstract, Lord Rutherford. But abstraction becomes policy quickly in the hands of those with real capital, real code, and real charisma.”

The Earl set down his glass, meeting the man’s eyes. “I am aware.”

Malling nodded once, rose, and extended a gloved hand. “Thank you for your hospitality. The country, I assure you, is watching very closely.”

As the side door closed behind him, the Earl remained seated, the taste of the whisky lingering longer than usual.

By Thursday, the Earl of Hope Valley’s estate had begun to feel like a peculiar kind of border post—not quite international, but no longer strictly domestic either.

The gravel of the drive had been quiet for years. Now it crunched constantly with the arrival of black cars and quiet accents. They came from Berlin, from Singapore, from Wyoming, and from two countries that didn't officially exist.

They arrived with gifts, mostly books and digital currencies. One delegation brought an NFT minted solely for the Festival. Another offered a bottle of 1970 Armagnac and a leather-bound copy of Hayek's Road to Serfdom signed by Thorne himself.

The Earl watched them with amusement, irritation, and growing curiosity. These were not ambassadors. These were operatives of the next order—special envoys from venture networks, post-national DAOs, and the foreign arms of think tanks with ten-letter acronyms.

And they all wanted the same thing: somewhere to stay.

Lord Rutherford's estate, once the scene of Edwardian shooting parties and minor Cold War consultations, was now to become a campus of future ideologues.

- The Swedish delegation requested the Blue Room for their philosopher-coder team. They offered to refit the lighting to match their circadian rhythm.
- A Kenyan post-capitalist cooperative asked to pitch "a low-impact biostructure" on the east lawn, near the solar array.
- A Baltic libertarian broadcaster wired ahead, asking for clearance to rig live feeds to their mesh satellite above Western Europe.
- A woman from Taiwan offered to pay three times market rate for a wing, no questions asked. "We just want to observe. Quietly," she said.

The Earl found himself at a small desk in the map room, surrounded by floorplans, folded letters, and digital dashboards, allocating beds like a tired general before a battle he never declared. It was all becoming clear: this was no longer just a cultural event. It was an unofficial summit of post-sovereign power.

"The house has never seen anything like this."

He was right.

Within a week of Thorne's confirmation and the Earl's quiet signal to go ahead, the Peak District began to transform.

The hills and fields that had once known hikers, sheep, and drone photographers were now being scoped out by media outfits, rogue archivists, software collectives, art-book publishers, pop philosophers, and satirical theatre troupes. Everyone wanted a foothold near Hope Valley.

Local landowners were now receiving serious offers to camp out on the farms.

A sheep farm three miles from the estate was converted almost overnight into a decentralised broadcast studio—its barn rigged with mesh network hardware and solar panels. A glamping firm pivoted to host post-political thought leaders, charging dynamic pricing rates for cabins that once held honeymooners.

The BBC, unable to gain access to Hope Valley proper, rented out the Great Hucklow cricket ground and set up what they called the "Mainstream Zone" replete with holographic Claudia Winkleman and Graham Norton.

Meanwhile:

- A Dutch techno-political podcast collective set up a mobile studio in a retired school bus on a hilltop.
- A Substack-powered longform team from Brazil turned a limestone quarry into an amphitheatre.
- A viral media company from Seoul deployed drones to document “the vibe war” between Sheffield and Manchester.

The phrase “Peak District Davos” began circulating, half-jokingly. But the gravity was real.

The Earl received the message late at night, in his encrypted inbox. Samuel’s tone, as ever, was calm but amused:

> *We’ll remain on our land. We will come into Hope Valley during daylight. No overnights—our people don’t do aristocratic pillows. Consider it our version of diplomacy. See you soon.*
>
> *S.A.*

That settled it. Their suites could be sold off.

A Canadian media mogul outbid a think tank for the library wing, claiming he wanted to “broadcast the end of the nation-state from an English estate.” A Saudi innovation fund leased the garden quarters for an unnamed “cognitive architecture team.”

The house, for all its old bones, was now a living diagram of the new world order—capital, decentralisation, and power, moving in strange new rhythms across the Yorkshire stone.

That evening, the Earl walked alone beneath a cloudless sky, passing workers hammering temporary walkways into place. He saw a firepit being constructed. Someone from a Cookery guild was consulting a spreadsheet about how many wild herbs grew naturally on the property.

From the woods to the wireless routers, everything was alive with preparation. It was no longer a question of whether something would happen here.

The air was clear that evening—uncannily so. The chill in the grass had begun to rise, and Hope Valley House glowed behind him in golden twilight.

Lord Rutherford took the winding path down through the south garden, past the fountains and clipped hedgerows. It was a garden made for silent treaties and afternoon flirtations, not for the holograms of rival philosopher-statesmen, and yet here they were.

The two figures flickered into life with an almost ceremonial pause: Eliot Ashton, dressed simply, standing with one hand in his coat pocket, and Alexander Thorne, a tailored silhouette with sharp eyes that scanned the garden like a strategist.

Both were projections, of course—beamed in via ultralight field units, mediated by DAO-safe encryption and relayed through the estate’s mesh network. A three-way conversation with no physical presence, and yet it felt heavier than any gathering of flesh and blood.

The Earl greeted them with a small bow. “Gentlemen. Thank you for indulging my eccentricities.”

Thorne nodded with formality. Ashton offered the ghost of a smile.

“I wanted,” the Earl said, walking slowly along the stone path, “to bring you both into the grounds—not your delegates, not your memes, not your ideas in absentia—but you. In whatever form I could manage.”

Thorne stepped in with his cool precision. “We’re not going to burn the estate down, Lord Rutherford.”

“No,” the Earl replied. “But you are both at the edge of something combustible. And I would rather you look at the lilies and feel a moment of humility before you burn the entire country into two competing currencies of the soul.”

They walked slowly—Ashton to his left, Thorne to his right. Ghosts. Titans. Men who hadn’t spoken face to face in a year.

“I don’t expect unity,” said the Earl. “I don’t even expect agreement. But I do hope that this festival allows some sliver of shared ground to survive—between your models, your visions, your cities. That’s what this house was built for.”

Eliot looked across at Thorne’s form. “I want culture to survive, Alexander. To not be eaten by velocity.”

“And I want civilisation to survive its own softness,” Thorne returned. “You and I want different immunities. That’s all.”

“I will see you both in a few days,” the Earl said. “In form or in flame.”

With a brief pulse of static and flicker of light, the holograms dissolved. He stood alone again.

It was on the fifth day of preparation—when the tents had already begun to multiply on the eastern meadows and the estate's fibre-optic feeds strained under the weight of podcasters and market nodes—that the Earl of Hope Valley received a letter.

Delivered not by courier drone or inbox alert, but by hand. On paper. Cream, heavy-stock, folded in thirds with no wax, no insignia, barely visible unless tilted to the light.

The text inside was brief, almost plain:

> *To the Custodian of the Grounds,*
>
> *We write as representatives of a spiritual fellowship based in York, operating discreetly in ecclesiastical and decentralist networks. We seek permission to arrive—modest in scale—at your upcoming festival.*
>
> *We do not require a speaking slot. We require no security, nor promotion. We request only space—sufficient for one tent.*
>
> *In the spirit of polycentric fellowship,*
> *—The Custodians of the Kingdom Within*

The Earl read the note twice. Then once again. There was no name

By sunset on the fifth day, the west lawn buzzed with temporary scaffolding, marquees, and low-voltage light cables. And on a folding chair beneath the east portico, the Earl found himself speaking into a podcast mic.

His host: Marla Orlick, Canadian host of *Soft Power Futures*, a show known for its blend of geopolitics, mysticism, and protocol governance. She was tanned, taut, charmingly intense.

“Lord Rutherford,” she said, adjusting her mic, “there are people saying this isn’t just a festival of ideas—it’s the proto-summit of the post-Westphalian future.”

The Earl smirked gently. “That depends whether the state turns up.”

Marla laughed. “Do you worry about things getting out of hand?”

“Always,” he said. “That’s half the point. Ideas only prove themselves when they’re forced to mix.”

“And the Christian Polycentrists?” she asked. “People say they’re arriving at some point during the festival.”

The Earl raised an eyebrow. “They asked for tent space, not a pulpit. But I suppose there’s very little difference at a gathering like this.”

Marla leaned forward. “Are you neutral in all this, Lord Rutherford?”

He took a sip of his whisky and paused.

“I’m not the referee,” he said. “I’m the ring.”

The morning mist had lifted from the Hope Valley, leaving in its place the clean, glinting sheen of dew on manicured meadows and the shine of freshly oiled brass fixtures. The Earl, in a sharp walking coat of dark blue, paced the gravel paths of his estate with a guest beside him — a bullish, affable figure with a bald head and a combat sports podcast listened to by millions from Vancouver to Vladivostok.

“This place is insane,” the podcaster said, pausing to admire the arched greenhouses engineered to grow vine fruits in Derbyshire climate. “You’re really doing it.”

The Earl smiled thinly. “It’s a civilisational obligation, not a hobby.”

They passed under steel-arched trellises covered in genetically enhanced hops — a side-project sponsored by a start-up from Bristol. In the distance, autonomous carts hummed between domed pavilions and neon-lit modular stalls. Tall banners waved along the path, depicting Britannia with a sword in one hand and a chipboard in the other.

Each district of the grounds had been given its own theme. The Liberty Quadrangle, designed like a modern cloister, would host the Bitcoin panels and governance discussions. The Cathedral of Code, a vast glass structure with a vaulted digital ceiling, would beam AI-generated choral music and host sessions on decentralized intelligence. Along the ridge was the Peak Agora, the main forum stage built into the landscape itself, its amphitheatre designed from carved stone and augmented glass.

“The Canadians are staying at the converted stables,” the Earl remarked. “The Baltic group is setting up under the larch trees. And as for the Christian Polycentrists… they have requested a modest tent. I’ve made space for them between the Estonian self-governance hackers and the Anglican hedonists.”

“What about the Sheffield crowd?” the podcaster asked.

“They’ve booked out the old orchard. Art collectives, modular housing prototypes, and some of the trance scene. They’ll be loud, I suspect.”

“And Thorne?”

“He’s bringing half of Manchester’s economic leadership with him,” said the Earl. “They’re building a pop-up ‘Command Pavilion’ styled on 1920s industrial futurism. From what I gather, he’s even bringing his 3D printers.”

They walked past a mirrored pool flanked by speakers hidden among flowering hawthorns. It played a looped broadcast of an AI remix of Winston Churchill and Alan Turing debating modern monetary theory.

“I have no idea what will happen,” the Earl said finally. “But I do know this: we have built the setting. Let the age speak for itself.”

The combat sports podcaster nodded. “I’ll do a special episode from here. Call it ‘Anglo-Futurism: Strength in Combat, Sovereignty in Action, and Peak District Cannabis.’ Should be good for the algorithm.”

The Earl gave a half-smile and gestured toward the hilltop where the full view of the estate stretched before them — like some mythic convergence of Tolkien and Tomorrowland.

By the time the Earl stepped into the temporary command centre—an angular structure clad in British steel and old-growth oak—the buzz of news crews, drone traffic controllers, and logistics agents was near operatic. He passed a cluster of hologram producers from Seoul calibrating projection rigs while two rival podcasts argued about which tent would yield better lighting for an interview with Eliot Ashton.

“Earl Rutherford,” a woman in high-tech tweed called out, walking briskly toward him with a tablet in hand. “BBC, Al Jazeera, and Der Spiegel are requesting estate walk-throughs. CNN wants exclusive drone access for sunrise shots.”

The Earl sighed. “Tell them all they can submit formal requests and receive equal access—pending approval by the event’s editorial team.”

The estate had begun to bloom not just with bunting and technocratic architecture, but with anticipation. Down in the South Lawn Zone, a team of Dutch engineers were finalising the “biome exchange ring,” a circular pod arrangement where attendees could swap seeds, microbes, and rare mycelium. Beside them, a crew from Tokyo had erected a crystalline tent known only as the Origami Dome, for soundproof interviews and sensory deprivation demos.

From the Ridge Pavilion, overlooking the Peak Agora, the Event Ops Guild met in roundtable format. The Earl had delegated them responsibility for real-time conflict arbitration between city blocs, protest groups, and rogue collectives attempting to piggyback on the festival’s infrastructure.

“The Sheffield printmakers are requesting two more 3D presses for zine production,” said a junior logistics agent. “And Manchester’s DAO wants a fenced area for an exhibition on Hyperindustrial VTOL designs….”

“Approved,” said the Earl, without looking up from his papers. “But no smoke machines. This is not Ibiza.”

Outside, the roads had begun to thrum with high-end hydrogen SUVs, matte-finished bikes, and a few miniature helicopters. By dusk, local farmers were selling out of eggs and elderflower cordial to passing engineers and Austrian philosophers in peak gilets. Two tents had already become micro-villages: one sponsored by an Estonian smart-contract DAO, another by a group of off-grid legal theorists from Vermont.

Back inside, the Earl watched the evening coverage on his curved screen. BBC3 had produced a half-documentary, half-vlog titled *Hope & Futures: The Conference Begins*. The presenter—clearly London-based—walked through the estate narrating:

> *"This isn’t just a festival. It’s a test. A cultural Geneva. A hypermodernist Davos set between stone walls and Silicon dreams."*

The Peak District had become an atlas of intentionality—each field, hill, and hollow humming with ideas about how the world should be governed next.

In his chest, he felt the familiar weight of centuries of expectation. For the first time, it no longer felt ceremonial.

The sun broke early over the Hope Valley, scattering gold over the misted moorlands like it was nervous about what was coming. The Earl of Hope Valley stood on the upper terrace of his estate in a heavy cloak, steaming coffee in hand, watching as the first wave of delegates made their descent through the old winding road that now bore the temporary signage: Festival of Ideas.

Chapter 13:

From the carved dais of the Peak Agora, nestled into the natural curvature of the limestone ridge, the Earl of Hope Valley stepped forward beneath a canopy of polished brass and living oak. Cameras hovered silently in the summer air, dozens of them, their lenses trained on him like watchful birds. Beyond them, a thousand attendees in the stone amphitheatre — policy designers, tech dissidents, theologians, landowners, artists, rivals, utopians — leaned forward.

And beyond them, the eyes of the world.

The Earl did not speak immediately. He looked out over the valley, towards the rising haze of the moors, then down into the open body of minds now gathered. Then:

“Welcome to the Festival of Ideas.”

His voice was firm, weighted with ancient cadence — one belonging less to a man and more to a lineage. The microphone translated it into a dozen tongues. Screens flickered across campuses in Tokyo, bunkers in Texas, co-living houses in Berlin, monasteries in Wales.

“This festival is not a summit of the powerful. It is not a conclave of the already-decided. It is a threshold. Between eras. Between cities. Between souls.”

He gestured slightly to the architecture around him — temporary Anglo-futurist spires, electric tapestries running with algorithmic art, the murmuring glades beyond filled with market stalls and solar-mesh tents.

“Here in this valley, we gather not to negotiate the past, but to enact the future — one not yet determined by state decree, nor shaped by platform monopoly, nor tethered to nostalgia.”

He paused, just a breath. The moment seemed to pull inward.

“You will see debates, yes. But also declarations. You will see contradictions made visible. You will see sovereign minds. And you will see the price — and possibility — of freedom.”

There was a quiet behind the silence. Some deep acknowledgment that history might, in fact, be happening now.

“Let this not be merely a festival. Let it be a beginning.”

As the Earl’s words settled into the hush of the Peak Agora, a subtle commotion stirred at the periphery.

A group was arriving on foot.

They came slowly, quietly, from the north trail — down from Stanage Edge, boots dusty with peat and chalk. At the head of the group walked Eliot Ashton, in a worn linen jacket and open-collared shirt, his face creased by dawn and thought. Beside him, Sophie, calm and focused, hair tied back with a strip of patterned cloth, the sun just catching the metal clasp of her notebook.

Behind them came a dozen others from Sheffield: thinkers, educators, programmers, post-rave spiritualists, and two poets. They had set off before sunrise, declining the shuttles, taking the paths instead — a symbolic gesture of arrival through effort and intent, not luxury.

Their entry did not go unnoticed.

The cameras found them, broadcasting the Sheffield delegation’s walk down into the festival valley as a slow, ceremonial act of quiet defiance. Among the global viewership, it trended within minutes: *“Walkers from the North.”*

From the stage, the Earl paused.

“And from Sheffield,” he said warmly, gesturing with a hand that acknowledged both history and renewal, “the representatives from Sheffield have arrived.”

The amphitheatre turned to watch them enter. Some delegates applauded. Others, mostly foreign, whispered about their choice to walk. One of the AI-directed drones followed them down the slope, broadcasting their dusty arrival in soft cinematic tones.

As Eliot and Sophie reached the stone floor of the Agora, they paused and looked around — faces lit not by spectacle, but by what felt suddenly like real possibility.

Sophie leaned in and whispered, half-mocking:

“We’ve arrived at Byzantium.”

Eliot smiled faintly, already scanning for Thorne.

A sudden hum passed through the valley — deep, clean, almost whale-like in tone.

From the western sky, three Aetherwings descended in silent formation. Their pale silver hulls glinted like wet steel under the mid-morning sun, and their wings folded inward with elegant precision as they slowed to vertical hover. These were no ordinary VTOLs — these were Herald-Class Aetherwings, fitted with Rolls-Royce “Seraphim” hydrogen rotors, custom-built by the Manchester guilds. They bore no insignia but carried with them the weight of intentional design — sovereign craft for sovereign minds.

They landed in sequence on a granite platform just behind the Agora dais, the downwash rustling the flags and printed silks that lined the stone pines. The moment the final rotor slowed to stillness, the centre hatch of the lead craft hissed open.

Alexander Thorne stepped out first.

Sharp-cut, precise, a figure of distilled intentionality. He wore a single-breasted wool suit of deep ultramarine, no tie, the lapel pinned with a simple square of folded white paper — a silent reference to *Trustless*. Behind him emerged Paul, Eliot’s former housemate turned itinerant ideologue, now in structured black and forest green, flanked by two members of the guilds, Connor Tate and Julian Coyle— all dressed in tones of engineered linen and biopolymer webbing, each movement quiet, considered.

The crowd around the Agora shifted.

This was not subtle symbolism. Thorne’s arrival had the spectacle of authority — unhidden, unsheathed. A statement not just of arrival, but of establishment.

Where Sheffield walked with thought, Manchester landed with force.

Just as the rotor-wind of Thorne’s Aetherwings died down and the air regained its pastoral stillness, another sound emerged — sharper, closer to the ground, like the tearing of silk at great speed. From the western hills came a swarm of low-flying speeders — whisper-quiet, darkly iridescent crafts shaped like cut obsidian. Sleek, glinting with refracted colours, they banked low around the cliffs like starlings in perfect algorithmic formation. They had no markings. No registration. They had never been seen before.

The crowd gasped.

A French network cut to aerial drone coverage. A Tokyo-based livestream switched angles mid-shot. Podcasters leaned forward at their makeshift rigs. The murmuring across the Agora rose like the prelude to a storm.

The cypherpunks had arrived.

Dust curled behind the speeders as they landed without ceremony, almost disdainfully, in the gravel court below the ridge. From their open cockpits stepped men and women in minimal, weather-beaten tech-wear, bearing Bitcoin signets, neural reader-rings, and mirrored glasses. Their silence was deliberate. Their presence: a statement.

From the central speeder stepped Samuel Ashcombe, his hood drawn down, his face calm, sunlit. He carried a folded document case made of compressed mycelium leather.

High on the dais, Eliot Ashton watched them arrive.

He narrowed his eyes, shielding them with a hand as the glare from a lens flare struck the ridge.

Thorne stood to his left, statuesque, cool, and unreadable. To his right, Ashcombe was now ascending the steps in practiced ease, his stride long, grounded, purposeful.

They were all here now.

Three men — three minds — standing at the summit of a broken isle's hope, each with a different future flickering behind their eyes. The crowd was alive, in a way Eliot was sure neither of them had ever experienced before.

Eliot let out a breath he hadn't realized he was holding. The crowd was vast — watching from the Agora and from across the globe.

Now the camera feeds were fixed. The microphones were live.

Ashcombe took the central podium.

"Welcome, to the first Festival of Ideas."

He glanced at Thorne, who offered only a nod, and then to Eliot, who looked momentarily struck — not by nerves, but by the strange symmetry of it all.

Ashcombe continued.

"We are not here to sign treaties. We are not here to flatter or perform. We are here to declare visions. To share architectures of life. Sheffield, Manchester, and beyond — we gather to think aloud, in front of the world."

He stepped back.

Thorne moved to the microphone next, speaking low, clear:

"A society that hides from efficiency, from reality, from markets — is a society that will die in its sleep. What we are building is not a counter-state. It is a human future. All else is reaction."

And then Eliot stepped forward, unprepared but steady, aware now of the weight on him:

"There is a difference between dreaming and building. Sheffield is not a museum. We do not wish to resist the future. We only ask that it be just — and human. May this Agora make space for both machine and soul."

The cameras caught it. The moment when all three stood together again, flanked by stone and glass and history. A statue of the present moment. A freeze-frame of what this island might yet become.

The Agora erupted — not in chaos, but in the whir of reaction.

On **X**, hashtags flared into life:
`#PeakDiscourse`, `#CypherpunkLanding`, `#ManchesterRising`, `#NewPhilosophyNow`

The trending map was a firework display. London, Lagos, Seoul, San Francisco, Munich, Nairobi — all blinking with heat.

> **@neorenaissanceUK:** "Fuck Davos. This is it. The future is now and it walks like Thorne, floats like Ashcombe, and writes like Ashton."
> **@cryptoCrusader69:** "They just landed in GHOST SPEEDERS. Wtf are we even doing in Silicon Valley."

> **@globalgovwatch:** “This is either a turning point or the start of parallel sovereignties. Parliament must act.”

On an Indian-language podcast, a translator mused:

> “It is not a summit. It is a mirror. And what they will see is not themselves — but what they could become.”

At a glamping site 5km south of the Agora, the Baltic delegation was drinking gin from copper cups and placing wagers on who would defect to Manchester’s cause by sunset.

Meanwhile, the Saudi technologists were assembling inside a rented Romanesque barn with climate-controlled floors. One of them texted:

> “This is better than the Olympics. If Thorne speaks anything close to his 'Trustless', we’re moving the fund to Manchester. We don’t need Sheffield’s culture, we want the returns.”

A nervous BBC interviewer tried to hold the ear of a former British Home Secretary, who said:

> “If this ends peacefully, it’s a miracle. If it ends well, it’s the dawn of a new Britannia.”

Even in Shanghai, livestreamers pirated feeds and offered rapid Mandarin translations. One called it:

> “An act of philosophical insurrection — but with hoodies and code.”

The sun cast long pale lines across the stone backs of the Agora as the delegation from Sheffield, still breathing from their long walk, stepped into the shade of the backstage canopy. Eliot Ashton tugged at the collar of his linen jacket, brushed the edge of dust from his trousers, and turned to Samuel Ashcombe, who stood apart — robed in a sleek charcoal coat lined with signal-blocking fibres, hands tucked behind his back like a monk of some forgotten digital order.

"You've kept your cards close," Eliot said. “What are you expecting from all this?"

Ashcombe turned slowly. His gaze was steady, voice calm — iron beneath velvet.

"Nothing," he said. "Nothing except proof."

"Proof?"

"That the world still needs ideas. Not slogans. Not trends. Ideas that reshape architecture, law, power, love. You two," he gestured lightly to Eliot and Thorne, who now stood across the dais in discussion with a foreign delegate, "are representatives of cities. I’m not. I don’t represent. I represent people. I build."

Sophie raised an eyebrow. "And what do you want built, Samuel?"

Ashcombe glanced skyward, watching a drone flicker overhead.

"Something no one can shut down."

"Good," Eliot said finally. "Then let's start with that."

A long pause settled between them. The Agora hummed. Somewhere, a bell tolled. The crowds beyond were rising as the two of them were led towards a new platform for the first debate of the festival.

A young steward in a white linen uniform, earpiece glowing with faint blue light, approached with a practised bow. “Gentlemen,” he said to Eliot and Samuel, “you two are due in the Helix Pavilion. The audience is assembling.”

Ashcombe nodded once. Eliot gave Sophie a sidelong glance before falling into step beside the Cypherpunk leader.

They walked through the shifting light of the agora’s outer paths — the stone and glass glowing with ambient hues that responded subtly to the sky. A crowd had begun to gather already near the pavilion, a tensile structure of translucent, self-cooling fibre that rippled gently in the breeze. Drones circled above like silver insects.

Inside, the Helix Pavilion had the aura of a ceremonial court. Tiered seating spiralled up like petals from a central stage — no table, no podium. Just two chairs. Transparent, elegant, charged with expectation.

As they stepped into the space, applause began — light at first, then swelling as the audience recognised them. Philosophers, technologists, bankers, monks, influencers, farmers, meme theorists. Everyone had come to hear the clash, or fusion, of minds.

Ashcombe glanced up once, briefly scanning the crowd. Then he turned to Eliot.

“Let’s not make theatre of it,” he said.

“It’s already theatre,” Eliot replied, half-smiling. “Let’s make it count.”

They took their seats. The lights shifted. The murmurs fell.

A voice from above announced: *“Session One: On Culture and the Future of the City.”*

No introduction followed. This was the festival's style — less formal, more immediate. The audience already knew who they were.

Ashcombe leaned forward slightly in his transparent chair, fingers steepled, expression grave but gracious.

“I want to start by saying,” he said, voice carrying cleanly through the acoustic field, “that I have enormous respect for Eliot Ashton. He has, in his own way, reshaped a city. Brought something romantic — maybe even holy — into civic life. And he’s kinder than Thorne. Softer. More noble in the classical sense.”

A pause. The audience watched, waiting.

“But let me be blunt,” he continued. “Kindness doesn’t build civilisations. Ashton’s model — poetic, cultural, generous — is not likely to win. If I had to bet my own coin and I have... I’d place it on Manchester to win out economically. This doesn’t mean I am withdrawing from Sheffield, but my returns in Manchester will be stronger.”

A low ripple passed through the tent. Eliot didn’t blink. He spoke calmly, confidently.

“And I’d understand why you would,” he said. “Manchester is outpacing us in productivity. But that’s only one metric. Sheffield has barely begun its expansion phase. You see, the beauty of local currencies linked to verified communal contributions means we can expand the money supply when the model clicks. Hyperlocal currency for hyperlocal value. The right niche could let Sheffield explode overnight.”

Ashcombe tilted his head. “A conditional. ‘If.’ The right niche. That’s the wager you’ve placed your city on. The problem with idealism is that it’s always waiting for its moment. Thorne isn’t waiting. He’s building now. On proven ground.”

Eliot allowed himself the smallest of smiles. “Thorne is building something efficient. But Sheffield is building something meaningful. Civilisation isn’t just steel and factories. It’s art. It’s music. It’s shared myth. And you’re right — maybe Thorne will win the first round. But we’re not playing for the first round.”

Ashcombe nodded slowly, as if turning the idea over in his mind. “No. You're playing for the soul of something bigger. That’s why I’m still here.”

Eliot leaned forward now, not aggressive, but insistent — a shift in his energy that the audience caught immediately.

“But what is your model, Samuel?” he asked. “The cypherpunk movement, your Kommune in the Peaks — is that a vision for the future or just a retreat? A lifestyle choice dressed up as revolution? Do you really want to build something... or are you trying to pull everyone backwards into a kind of perpetual market anarchy, without structure, without institutions, without responsibility?”

A murmur ran through the seats. The directness of the question hit hard. The air inside the Helix Pavilion thickened, the soft hum of the drones above sounding momentarily louder.

Ashcombe didn’t respond at first. He watched Eliot carefully, and for a few seconds, the audience could feel something unspoken pass between them — not animosity, but knowledge. History.

Ashcombe tilted his head slightly, the faintest trace of amusement at Eliot’s restraint. He let the silence gather around him before turning to face the audience, speaking now not to Eliot, but to the amphitheatre itself — to the technologists, the journalists, the curious and the powerful.

“We built the Lattice Market,” he said, simply.

A hush spread across the pavilion like an exhale. A reveal.

“The Lattice Market,” he continued, “was not the product of a think tank, nor a startup, nor some corporate thinkpiece. It was grown — nurtured by our collective. Built quietly, in the cracks of the system. Peer-to-peer trade, micro-funding frameworks, decentralised auctions, privacy-preserving DAOs.”

He paused, letting the weight of the revelation settle over the crowd.

“We didn’t shout about it. We didn’t run press releases. We gave people the tools. The lattice is the framework — invisible, adaptive, resilient. The point was never to centralise power. It was to let culture and capital emerge from new ground.”

He turned back toward Eliot. “So when you ask if we have a model — the answer is no, not in the way you mean. Not a hierarchy. Not a flowchart. Not a blueprint. We build terrain. And people build paths on it.”

Eliot nodded slowly, his fingers steepled beneath his chin.

Samuel leaned forward slightly, his voice low but carrying, each word laced with intent.

“The Lattice,” he said, “is the third layer. The idealised third layer of Bitcoin. Not built by corporations, not dictated by foundations or VC-backed governance councils — but grown organically. It sits atop the base layer — the immutability, the scarcity, the time-chain itself. Then comes the programmable layer — smart contracts, decentralised identities, escrows. And above that, this: the emergent permanent market. A living, breathing system of interaction. For years we have kept this a secret. But now I tell you. The simple fact is, our model is not hiding away, we in the Kommunes are the ones who pick the future model.”

He turned to the crowd, now deeply attentive, deeply engaging. “It’s Austrian economics, idealised. The progression theorem if you will. We didn’t start with barter. We didn’t even start with money. We started with Bitcoin — pristine collateral — and built upwards.”

Eliot raised an eyebrow.

Samuel continued: “From sound money comes the possibility of law — not state law, but encoded agreements, reputation systems, trustless coordination. And from law, comes the market. Not enforced, but emergent. Not constrained, but choreographed through incentive. This is not theoretical. We’ve watched it happen.”

The screens behind them flickered for a moment — subtle graphics showing anonymised data flows, trade volumes, energy inputs and outputs. A lattice, literal and metaphorical.

“Bitcoin gave us the base. Smart contracts showed us the tools. But the Lattice… the Lattice is the civilisation. Not built by decree, not even curated by taste. Built because enough people decided it made sense.”

He looked to Eliot. “We don’t pull people backwards into anarchy. We invite them forwards — into something post-political, post-bureaucratic, and deeply human.”

A quiet murmur moved through the amphitheatre. Somewhere, a soft burst of wind carried dust and blossom through the open arc of the Helix Pavilion.

Eliot sat still, absorbing it. A few beats passed. Then, slowly, he nodded. Not in agreement — not yet — but in recognition of something real.

Eliot didn’t flinch. He let the applause for Samuel fade, the murmurs settle like dust on stone. Then, with characteristic stillness and clarity, he leaned forward into the circle of light.

“I admire the architecture of what you’ve built, Samuel. I truly do. Lattice is an elegant system — in theory, and, as you’ve shown, in practice. Many of our goods, and many goods around the world are built upon the protocol. But systems alone don’t make civilisation.”

He paused, letting that hang.

“Hayek understood something deeper — that currency issuance isn’t just about competition, but about cultural context. About narrative. About meaning. Spontaneous Order. The Bank of Sheffield wasn’t born from protocol design; it was born from people. From community. It created a cultural monetary policy — one embedded in the rhythms of our city. The music venues, the co-ops, the art schools, the micro-economies tied to crafts and care. It’s not just liquidity. It’s texture.”

He turned now, not just to Samuel but to the crowd.

“Sheffield’s model is not just free banking. It’s cultural issuance. The money flows towards meaning. Toward trust. Toward time.”

A few heads nodded in the front rows — an artist, a teacher, a local banker.

“What I want to know, Samuel,” Eliot continued, voice steady but probing, “is what your model will generate. What world it builds. Beyond the protocol brilliance, beyond the anonymity and the purity of Austrian principles — where is the theatre? The love? The schools? You speak of law and the market. But culture lives between those two things.”

He didn’t blink.

“From what I’ve seen — and I’ve been there, walked your fields, danced your nights — the Kommune oscillates between relentless hard work and euphoric party culture. Work. Party. Work. Party. What connects them? What endures in the middle?”

He looked across the stage to Samuel.

“We’re not here to build self-contained machines. We’re here to build civilisations. Civilisations make meaning.”

Samuel didn’t rush his reply. He let Eliot’s words settle like a low mist over the pavilion, the crowd caught in the hush between high philosophies.

He looked to the audience, then back to Eliot, eyes sharp but not unkind.

“But what,” he asked plainly, “will people remember of your culture?”

He didn’t wait for an answer.

“A poet? A party? A poster? Or a neighbourhood that once hummed with the soft sounds of collaboration before the wind changed?”

He leaned forward now, his voice still level but edged with something more pointed — not hostility, but challenge.

“There’s hedonism and there’s work. I grant you that. The Kommune lives in the oscillation. But so does the human condition, Eliot. And you know this. You sit in a city trying to weave a middle thread — a culture that’s softer, more romantic, more hopeful. But you’re still issuing money from a bank. Still setting policy. Still channelling resources. And you know what that is? Structure.”

He gestured lightly to the crowd. “The same structure Thorne builds with algorithms and factories. The same structure I build with Lattice. We’re not so different.”

A pause.

“The only real difference,” he said now, letting the words come slowly, “is that your model tries to hold the middle. Ours discard it. The cypherpunks reject the middle entirely because we don’t believe it’s real. We think it’s a phase. A luxury. A buffer zone between the cycles of nature: exertion and release. Work and ecstasy. Action and stillness.”

He turned to the audience again.

“Sheffield has culture, yes. But culture fades. Markets evolve. Algorithms optimise. What survives is structure.”

Then, looking back at Eliot, with the faintest trace of a smile:

“You might be the most different of all, precisely because you still believe.”

Eliot scoffed, loud enough that a few in the front rows smiled, relieved at the return of friction. He shook his head, leaned back in his chair, and looked up toward the semi-translucent roof of the Helix Pavilion.

“The idea that culture fades,” he said with a faint, incredulous laugh, “is... quaint.”

Then leaning forward eyes fixed on Samuel: “Does Shakespeare fade? Do the Beatles? Did the Parthenon fade? Or the dream of Florence? Culture doesn’t fade, Samuel. Culture is the only thing that remains. Long after your networks degrade, your protocols are obsolete, your nodes silent and cold — someone, somewhere, will still be humming Let It Be. Culture is memory encoded in beauty. And you can’t run that on a blockchain.”

The crowd rippled with low murmurs — assent, provocation, interest. Samuel didn’t flinch. He looked for a moment like a man hearing the same song from an old record he’d broken long ago.

“My family,” Samuel said quietly, “spent the last century preparing for a future that never arrived.”

His voice was more personal now — the philosopher slipping back into the skin of a man.

“They trusted gold when the world inflated itself. They trusted states to keep the peace and watched them sleepwalk into slaughter. We invested. We withheld. We prepared. We survived. But survival is not the same as living.”

He straightened in his seat.

“I am not here to argue for austerity or abstinence. The Kommune isn’t some puritan cloister. We believe the true society is one that can reward both: the wild, uncontainable moments of joy and the long grind of meaningful work. But it has to do so without coercion, without inflation, without lies. That’s what Lattice was. That’s what we’re still building. A structure, yes — but one you can dance on. One that makes the ecstasy possible without collapsing the floor beneath you.”

He paused, then added, quieter:

“Because we’ve lived the opposite. We’ve built for futures that never came. It’s time for something else. Something that rewards now and later.”

Ashton leaned forward again, sensing the lull, ready to fill it with something more deliberate.

"But how," he asked, voice now low and rhetorical, "does deep culture arise? Surely even you," he said, looking at Samuel, "see the point of it. The arc of a cathedral. A great symphony. A library built across centuries. These things don’t emerge from momentary networks or temporary structures. They require test beds. Monetary scaffolds. Places where wealth and meaning accumulate together across time — slowly, with discipline."

He sat back slightly, folding his hands.

"The wild hedonism of your Kommune, or the pure efficiency-maximisation of Manchester — I'm not saying they're wrong, Samuel. I'm saying they're unsustainable across generations. Most societies, most cities, won't choose to live at those extremes. They will settle, as they always have, into rhythm. Into trust. Into institutions."

He glanced out toward the crowd, as if seeing the future build itself just over their heads.

"And to make institutions — to make the kind that survive the weather of history — you need a monetary network that nurtures more than growth. You need one that nurtures depth. That's what SheffCoin is. That's what the Bank of Sheffield has always meant to be. A structure not just for trade, but for culture. For stability. For the kind of beauty that takes more than a single generation to build."

Then, with a faint, knowing smile: "That's why banking, in its truest form, is actually an honourable profession. Not because it generates wealth — but because it protects it, shapes it, and allows it to express itself in ways a bare ledger or a market spike never could."

He turned back to Samuel with something close to kindness in his eyes.

"You want people to be sovereign, I understand that. But true sovereignty isn't just about not being ruled. It's about what you do when you're free — what you build, what you honour, what you leave behind."

Samuel tilted his head, his expression unreadable at first, but then the faintest grin flickered.

"You speak like a romantic, Eliot," he said, "which is fine — Sheffield has made it your trade. But don't pretend that this slowness, this soft build-up of culture, isn't also its own form of constraint. Not every people, not every era, has the luxury of waiting for symphonies."

He leaned forward now too, tone sharpening slightly.

"You say the Kommunes are unsustainable — too hedonistic, too sparse. But what you call instability, I call responsiveness. Our structures aren't built in concrete, or in centuries-old doctrine. They emerge where they're needed. They die when they're not. That's freedom, Eliot — not just sovereignty but adaptive sovereignty."

He glanced at the audience, then back.

"You build a beautiful system, I'll grant you that. But it still assumes that people want to be taught culture. That they need to be shown how to behave, what to value, how to feel. But what if they don't?"

He shrugged.

"What if they just want to live? To move between places, loves, roles? What if culture doesn't need to be protected like a garden, but released like wildfire?"

The amphitheatre had quietened again — not in shock, but with a growing tension.

Eliot's reply was cool, measured.

"People don't need to be taught what to feel. But they do need space to reflect on it. And that's what our institutions are — temporal mirrors. Not constraints, but rooms with memory."

He looked past Samuel, out into the stone and glass of the agora.

“You talk about freedom like it’s enough to exit things. But the deeper question — the hard one — is what you enter. What do you bind yourself to? What outlasts you?"

Samuel’s grin faded, replaced with something quieter.

“Nothing outlasts us, Eliot. That’s the point. That’s the terror and the gift. We get to write the story. Every day.”

“And if you’re wrong?” Ashton said, softly. “If there is something beyond us? Something that needs stewardship, not reinvention?”

Samuel didn’t answer at first. He just sat with it.

Then, calmly: “Then it’ll survive us too.”

A voice rang out, clear and bold, from one of the upper tiers of the spiral seating.

“If both of your models have freedom at the centre,” the questioner asked, “why do they look so different? One builds banks, the other burns them. One speaks in cathedrals, the other in code. What is freedom, really?”

Eliot stood slowly, nodding at the young woman in a long slate coat and silver boots.

“Freedom,” he said, “is not the absence of structure — it is the capacity to choose your structures wisely. Sheffield offers that — a society where people can flourish through chosen responsibility. A life made richer by commitment. Culture grows not from chaos, but from form, from shape.”

He paused.

“To borrow from music: a melody needs rhythm. Without that, it’s just noise.”

A murmur of appreciation passed through the crowd.

Then another voice, sharper this time — a man in dark glasses and a DAO pin on his lapel.

“Isn’t banking itself just another form of state power? You issue currency. You determine access. How is that freedom?”

Samuel raised his hand gently before Eliot could respond.

“Good question. But ask yourself — who manages access in our system? No one. That’s the point. No gatekeepers. No permission. The code is open. The network is voluntary.”

He gestured lightly toward Eliot.

“Even Eliot’s Bank of Sheffield — admirable though it is — still decides. Who gets a loan. What the currency is worth. Which cultural projects are worth funding. That’s power, however well-intentioned.”

Eliot smiled politely.

“Of course it’s power. The difference is — it’s visible. It’s accountable. You can walk into a branch. Talk to someone. Ask for help. Your system hides the power behind layers of code and consensus, it almost becomes a new form of bureaucracy — but power doesn’t vanish, Samuel. It just becomes unanswerable.”

A third voice chimed in now, one of the journalists seated near the back.

“Do either of you worry about losing the middle? That most people aren’t interested in these extremes — in pure decentralisation or cultural commitment? What about the ordinary citizen?”

Samuel leaned back in his chair.

“We are the middle,” he said. “We just built it horizontally instead of vertically. Community without hierarchy. Meaning without monuments.”

Eliot gave a small shrug.

“And I still believe people crave roots, not just networks. You can’t build a civilisation on exit. At some point, you have to stay. And that’s what Sheffield is — a place to stay, to build, to belong.”

The air tightened. The tension was no longer hostile — it was magnetic. A sense that the real argument was just beginning.

The moderator stepped forward to announce the close of the session, but the questions kept coming, shouted now from different corners of the pavilion:

“What about international adoption?”
“Where do families fit into these models?”
“Can either vision survive a global crisis?”

The Agora pulsed. The world was watching — not just these men, but the choice they represented.

And somewhere beyond the cameras, the crowd, and the smoke-glass ceiling, the future waited to choose.

As the applause finally receded into the ambient hum of a crowd returning to breath and murmur, Eliot and Samuel stood from their translucent chairs, exchanging a glance that was equal parts exhaustion and mutual respect.

“That was good,” Samuel said, offering his hand.

Eliot took it, a firm grip, a nod. “It was,” he said. “Tense in the right way. You held your line well.”

They descended the spiral steps together, the murmurs of audience members parting around them like eddies in water. Camera flashes flickered, muted behind smoked lenses.

At the base of the pavilion, Luna was waiting — Samuel’s lieutenant, dressed in sleek black with a screen embedded in her wrist-pad pulsing with live feeds.

“What’s Thorne been up to?” Samuel asked her, arching an eyebrow. “I assume he’s not in the philosophy tent.”

Luna tilted her head slightly. “He was supposed to be in two panels. One on biofinance and one automated jurisprudence. He skipped both. Apparently he’s been giving off-the-record interviews to a set of Japanese anarcho-engineers in the Grove Pavilion. They brought him sake.”

Samuel chuckled. “Of course they did. The man collects disciples like they’re keys.”

Meanwhile, Eliot lingered just a pace behind, half-listening, his mind already turning back inwards. The questions had struck deeper than he’d expected.

He turned to Sophie, who had rejoined him near the trellis of one of the exit paths, her eyes reading his mood like a second language.

“How did I do?” Eliot asked quietly.

She looked up at him, expression unreadable for a moment, then smiled gently. “You were yourself,” she said. “That’s all anyone expected. That’s all Sheffield ever wanted.”

He nodded slowly, but his eyes were distant — not unsure, but introspective. The idea nagged at him: maybe people didn’t want balance. Maybe they never had. Samuel’s Kommune offered radical liberty. Thorne, perfected efficiency. And he — a patient spiral of culture and responsibility — stood in the middle, offering slowness in an era of extremes.

The applause had been polite. The praise respectful. But the crowd hadn’t leaned forward the way they had with Samuel’s mystique. Eliot had played the long game. But did anyone want a long game anymore?

He exhaled through his nose and looked up at the deepening sky. The pavilion behind them glowed with low-light algorithms reacting to the golden hour.

“We’ll see,” he murmured to himself.

Then louder, to Sophie: “Let’s get a drink. I think we’ve earned it.”

They stepped away from the Agora, the great minds dispersing into tents and shaded clearings, leaving behind only the memory of their clash — and a world waiting to choose which story to follow.

Chapter 14:

The house lent to Eliot and his circle for the duration of the festival was perched on the shoulder of the valley, just far enough from the Agora that the thrum of events became a distant pulse rather than a presence. The windows were thrown open. The air was soft with altitude. Lanterns had been placed along the garden wall, flickering with an amber glow that moved across the faces of those gathered.

Inside, a bottle of pale whisky was circulating. Eliot, Sophie, and three others — one from the Bank, one a poet, one a visiting urban planner from Bratislava — were settled in a loose ring around the hearth, watching Thorne’s address on a hovering display suspended above the table.

Thorne stood before a vast LED map of Manchester, lit in neural blues and laser reds. It pulsed with data: productivity rates, carbon drawdowns, shipping routes, Bitcoin flows, fertility rates by district. His voice was as smooth as it was unrelenting.

“—from a standing start, our industrial output has increased by an order of magnitude in less than three years. We’re not just matching the old state-run cities — we’re outperforming them on every key index: energy generation, educational acceleration, and targeted genome correction…”

Eliot swirled the last of the whisky in his glass. “The rhythm of power,” he said quietly. “Data in one hand, doctrine in the other.”

Sophie leaned forward, her voice low. “He has something. Not just statistics — presence. You can feel people leaning into him.”

“I know,” Eliot said. “And I think we’re losing the tempo.”

The others looked over.

“I built a cultural engine,” Eliot went on. “Sheffield is alive with meaning — but it isn’t enough anymore. If we’re going to hold people’s imagination, we need something new. A model.”

He turned to the others, suddenly resolute.

“Not a response to Thorne. A progression beyond him. Sheffield must become more than a reaction. It has to move toward something no one else has even imagined yet.”

Ali, the urban planner raised an eyebrow. “And what does that look like?”

Eliot sat back down, the firelight catching the edge of his cheekbone. “The truth is,” he said, “we need to reorganise the format of the currency issuance. The SheffCoin model has worked, yes — but we linked it too rigidly to artisanal production and local creative activity, the debt based system is too slow. It’s elegant, but… slow.”

Ali nodded. “There’s no mechanism for surge issuance. No real economic throttle.”

“Exactly,” Eliot said. “We’ve prioritised culture over scalability. But what if we redesigned the framework? What if issuance could be dynamically tied to productivity and the money supply — not just measured in output, but in meaning?”

Eliot closed the door of his study with a soft click. The room was sparsely lit, the walls adorned not with paintings but with charts — historical currency supply curves, network effect diagrams, notes from Hayek and obscure monetary theorists in ink and graphite. This was not a romantic space. It was a thinking chamber.

“Open manuscript: The Philosophy of Inflation,” Eliot said softly.

The interface flickered into life, and the AI — voice neutral, clipped — responded.

"Manuscript open. You were working on the section defining inflation as a differential model. Would you like to resume analysis?"

“Yes,” he said, sliding into the leather chair. “Bring up the primary equation.”

A holographic projection of the formula appeared above the desk:

The cursor blinked. The equation hung suspended in the air above the desk, simplified now into its most elegant — and most dangerous — form.

I = M − P
Inflation equals money supply growth minus productivity growth.

Eliot stared at it in silence. It was clean, powerful.

If he increased *M* — if he simply issued more SheffCoin through the Bank’s new circuit of culture contracts and local bonds — he could trigger a spike in activity. Not necessarily in consumer prices, but in urgency. Sheffield would be shocked into motion: builders building, artists producing, coders coding. The entire city grinding into gear under the soft tyranny of incentive. Work collectively or face inflation. Monetary manipulation as philosophy.

He leaned back, hands clasped behind his head. “What am I doing?” he said aloud. “Philosopher-king, or tyrant in a hoodie?”

Behind him, the door opened a crack and Sophie leaned in, still in her long coat from the rooftop. “You said my name?”

He turned, motioned her in. “I’ve thought of a way to push Sheffield harder. To expand the money supply beyond its current constraints — to make the money supply productive, in a measurable sense.”

Sophie walked toward the desk, eyes flicking to the formula. “You’re planning a monetary shock?”

“A big one,” Eliot said. “Enough to force new kinds of output. Not just goods — stories, designs, rituals, movements. I can model it. It could work. But it’s… intrusive, but if everybody in the city wants leadership and a leader this could be the way.”

“You’d be programming the city’s energy,” Sophie said, voice calm. “Setting fire to the dry grass and hoping it burns the right way.”

Eliot said nothing.

She stepped closer, looking at him not as a friend now, but as something else — maybe an advisor. Maybe a check on his rising will.

“Thorne controls Manchester like a machine. The city lives in a fever dream. You said Sheffield was meant to be a different kind of city. If you want culture, you can’t order it. You can only tempt it.”

“But if I don’t act,” Eliot murmured, “we fall behind.”

It began with a message.

At 7:42 a.m., Eliot Ashton tapped send. The document — titled The Philosophy of Inflation: A Productivist Path to Acceleration — went out to thirty-seven investors, economists, and senior figures in the Bank of Sheffield’s network. Alongside it: a red-sealed press release. Embargoed until 11:00 a.m. GMT.

The email’s final line read:
“If we believe culture is productive, let us build a monetary system that proves it.”

Eliot then sent an email to the other Bank of Sheffield investors, saying by better understanding inflation Sheffield could inflate the money supply and increase output if it were indexed to productivity.

He leaned back and waited for the required investors he needed. The first news sites had broken the story of the publication of his piece reorienting inflation stats. A shockwave was already spreading.

Eliot kept his eye on the internal ledger—he needed four signatures. Two had already arrived. One from a Copenhagen-based macro-economist who’d barely spoken on a call in six months. Another from a finance co-op in Bristol who’d previously sworn off all monetary commentary.

Then the third pinged through.

He smiled.

Now it was just Jhala.

He refreshed the window twice. Waited. Sipped cold tea. Nothing.

Fifteen minutes passed.

Then, finally: the fourth approval arrived, marked with a green digital seal and a single comment.

> "Let's go for it."

Eliot opened a clean document and typed.

He read it once. Then again. Then hit send.

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
Office of the Monetary Chair – Bank of Sheffield
Issued: 10:42 BST

Subject: Expansion of the Monetary Supply — Stimulus Phase I

Effective immediately, the Bank of Sheffield will increase the circulating supply of SheffCoin by **50%**. This decision has been taken in full alignment with our updated **Inflation Reframing Framework**, and follows the unanimous approval of the Banks Monetary Policy Committee.

This is not stimulus as apology. This is stimulus as declaration.

For too long, culture has been treated as decorative surplus—responding to surplus capital, never creating it. Sheffield now rejects that logic. We assert that culture *is* capital—active, productive, measurable. This monetary expansion is therefore not a rescue mechanism. It is an investment in **infrastructure**.

This expansion will support:

- Commissioning of new works in architecture, sound, and shared space.
- Development of civic rhythms: festivals, rituals, and seasonal public programming.
- R&D into artisanal mass manufacturing.
- Rewilding of inner-city zones as open cultural districts.
- A guaranteed cultural income for independent makers and aesthetic technicians.

We do not fear inflation. We fear stasis. We do not fear volatility. We fear silence.

This is a bet—not on ideology, but on **felt life**. Let the critics quote Keynes. We will quote the crowd.

Welcome to Sheffield. You may be experiencing the future.

— Eliot Ashton
Chair, Bank of Sheffield

Social feeds exploded. Telegram groups. Subreddits. Podcasts. Analysts scrambled to explain the new economic model. The global financial press labelled it Sheffield-style accelerationism. Investors called it 'Ashtonism'.

"SHEFFIELD UNLEASHES PRODUCTIVITY-BASED INFLATION MODEL"
"ASHTON'S GAMBLE: MONEY FOR CULTURE"
"THE NEW MONETARISM: CITY AS FURNACE"

The announcement hit the festival like a second dawn.

As the noon haze lifted across the ridgelines of the Peak District, phones buzzed. Feeds updated. Screens flickered in the media tents, their anchors scrambling to adjust. And above it all, from the broadcast tower beside the agora, the signal blared across the world's bandwidth:

“Ashton to Increase SheffCoin Supply — New Productivity Model to Drive Output or Inflation soars.”

A murmur spread through the festival, growing sharper with each passing second. Heads turned. Eyes scanned for Eliot around the whole festival but it wasn’t Ashton who appeared first that day.

It was Thorne in the Peak Agora for something between a lecture and a session in oratory.

Boots striking the plinth. Black jacket tight across his frame. His team at his back like crows on wire.

He moved with the urgency of a statesman betrayed.

Thorne didn’t wait for a microphone. His voice cut through the open air.

“A philosopher,” he began, “has just attempted what tyrants dare only whisper.”

The Peak Agora fell quiet as Thorne bellowed a retort, without invitation.

“Let me be clear,” he continued, “currency is not an art form. It is not a mood. It is not a love letter to productivity. It is a contract. A rule set. A promise. You do not expand the money supply because your poets are falling behind.”

Gasps and murmurs. The crowd was rapt. On a terrace above, journalists scribbled notes.

From the edge of the crowd hiding somewhat, Eliot stood with Sophie and Charlotte, arms crossed, a crooked smile playing at the edge of his mouth.

Sophie whispered, “You knew he’d do this.”

Eliot nodded. “It was always going to be theatre.”

On stage, Thorne wasn’t done.

“This,” he said, holding up his palm to the crowd, “is not decentralisation. This is fiat under new management. A benevolent banker is still a banker. Don’t let his words fool you.”

A burst of applause from the Manchester side of the crowd. Thorne gestured toward the amphitheatre’s eastern ridge.

“In Manchester, our systems don’t rely on emotion or sudden acts of inflationary shock. We build through coordination, through automation, through trustless execution. If Sheffield wants to play with fire, let them. We’ll keep building engines.”

He stepped down, cold and calculated, not waiting for applause.

In the moment of silence that followed, all eyes turned — not to the stage, but to Ashton, who the crowd had just found.

Calm. Straight-backed, Eliot started his voice amplified by a mic drone that just floated down in front of him, “Is this the act of a tyrant? Perhaps. Or perhaps it is the act of a city declaring it will no longer wait.”

He paused, letting the wind move through the amphitheatre.

“Manchester has engines. Sheffield has culture. But culture without tempo dies. And we’ve given ours a drumbeat. The coin issuance is not inflation for the sake of inflation. It’s a call — to build, to create, to share in the risk and the reward. We will either rise together, or we will feel the heat of stagnation. But at least we will know we moved.”

The crowd held its breath.

“I’m not a tyrant. I’m not even sure I’m a philosopher. But I am a citizen of Sheffield. And like you, I choose to fight for our future in the only way I know how: by trying.”

The festival buzzed like a central node under sudden stress — threads of speculation shooting in every direction, every tent and terrace animated by the shockwave of Eliot Ashton’s monetary detonation.

On X, hashtags trended globally:
#SheffieldShock
#Ashtonomics
#WorkOrInflate
#ProductivityStandard

Podcast tents overflowed with audiences and heat. Inside one, the American polymath commentator Theo Kincaid barked into his mic:

“What we just witnessed was the first act of monetary theatre since the end of central banks. Ashton has, in effect, done what no DAO, no minister, no algorithm dared — he’s forced the question: can a philosopher make you work harder?”

In another tent, Lani Marquez, a high-speed Canadian theorist with pink hair and a love of psychoanalytic memes, framed it differently:

“He’s reversed the pleasure principle. He’s weaponised culture. This is literally the first time art has become the basis of monetary velocity. This isn’t Keynesian. This is Kierkegaardian.”

News crews scrambled for interviews. Outside the agora, a young producer caught up with a group from the Sheffield delegation.

“Will Sheffield work harder, or just let the inflation bite?” she asked.

A tattooed coder shrugged. “Maybe. If the money’s real, and if I can sell to the new market. It’s not about working harder. It’s about working louder.”

Across the Peak, in shaded pavilions and holographic domes, bankers and creatives debated the mechanics.

Some worried: Would this flood break the dam? Would people flee SheffCoin and rush back to Bitcoin, or worse, the old pound? But others noted Ashton’s deep reserves — the Bank of Sheffield held enormous Bitcoin backing, enough to burn excess money if inflation did soar, but the threat of inflation was enough to get people working, and producing.

It wasn’t an uncontrolled minting spree. It was a wager.

A few of Thorne’s economists huddled in a granite-walled annex, fuming. One said flatly:

“He’s turned labour into spectacle. You can’t just push a button and make a city work harder. But he might turn it into a communal event, you all work hard for each other, bring people together.”

But others saw something more strategic. The issuance wasn’t blind. It came with targets — domains: music production, distributed manufacturing, AI cooperatives, architectural guilds. If those sectors surged, the coin would stabilise.

And in the back of one tent, an ageing Austrian economist nodded to himself.

“It’s genius,” he whispered. “He’s created temporal scarcity. He’s made time the denominator of value again.”

Sophie, standing beside Eliot in the tall grass behind the main stage, could see it all playing out.

“They’re calling you insane,” she said, handing him her phone. “Or a visionary.”

“Same thing,” Eliot murmured. “I just hope they pick up a paintbrush. Or a lathe. Or write something beautiful.”

The meeting took place in a secluded, cedar-panelled drawing room just beyond the edge of the agora — a quiet enclave lent to Eliot by the Earl’s estate staff. Sunlight filtered through stained glass and the murmur of the festival seemed far off, dulled by thick stone walls.

Samuel Ashcombe arrived, walking in with his signature cool — linen draped over a black shirt, eyes as unreadable as an encrypted chain. Eliot stood, extended a hand. Samuel took it, but without warmth.

“You should have spoken to me first,” Samuel said, sitting down heavily. “A move like that — the inflationary trigger — that changes everything.”

Eliot sat opposite, elbows on knees, meeting his gaze. “There wasn’t time. I needed to act while the model still held faith. If Sheffield lags behind another year, we lose momentum — and belief.”

Ashcombe shook his head. “You didn’t act, Eliot. You flooded. Do you know what happens when capital loses memory? When value gets distorted? We left the old systems to escape this kind of abstraction.”

Eliot leaned back, calm but firm. “This isn’t abstraction. This is targeted deployment. The money goes into strategic investments — buying output from our strongest sectors, subsidising culture as infrastructure, increasing liquidity in peer-to-peer markets. We’re not just handing it out. We’re directing it.”

Samuel’s brow furrowed. “And who decides that direction?”

“The Bank’s Allocative Council. It’s meritocratic, fully auditable. We’ll publish the ledger.”

“But it’s still fiat, Eliot.”

Eliot nodded. “Fiat — backed by Bitcoin, circulating through contracts, fuelling artistry, work, renewal. It’s living money. It breathes through people. The people of Sheffield know its a signal to work harder. They trust me.”

There was a pause. Outside, a murmur of applause drifted faintly in from the agora.

Samuel exhaled. “So this is your answer to Thorne?”

“Yes,” Eliot said. “I listened to you in that pavilion. And I realised — fiat has a soft core. But maybe that’s not a weakness. Maybe that’s what makes it human. It just needs a hand on the tiller sometimes. Not a tyrant. A steward.”

Ashcombe stood slowly. “I’m not angry, Eliot. But I am disappointed. This was your chance to move beyond old habits — to build on solidity.”

Eliot stood with him. “I am building on solidity. Just not the kind buried under stone.”

“We can continue this later, I have a talk with Thorne.”

Eliot stepped out into the warmth of the afternoon, the wind stirring faint currents of dust and chatter across the agora’s stepped amphitheatre. The tension of the conversation with Ashcombe still lingered in his chest, but Sheffield’s currency had already surged through the bloodstream of global conversation. There was no taking it back now.

Eliot made his way through the festival grounds with a slower, more deliberate step now, weaving through crowds still buzzing with commentary and speculation about the monetary upheaval he had just unleashed. The sun hung low over the Derbyshire hills, casting long gold shadows across the estate’s glass and limestone terraces. His AI fed him updates in pulses — trending articles, podcast snippets, flashes of outrage and admiration — but he silenced it all. He wanted quiet.

He reached the Peak Agora amphitheatre unnoticed. The session had already begun to fill; the elegant stone seating curled down like a helix toward the centre stage. Eliot stayed near the back, in the shaded tiers, pulling the brim of his jacket collar higher. He didn’t want to make this about himself.

At the centre of the amphitheatre, seated comfortably in translucent chairs under the high crystalline canopy, were Alexander Thorne and Samuel Ashcombe.

It was the meeting of systems.

Thorne, sleek in charcoal suiting, his signature data-glasses resting casually against his cheek, sat with the cool gravity of a man who believed history was already written in his favour. Ashcombe, by contrast, appeared almost rustic — linen shirt, collar open, hair brushed but wind-marked. Yet his posture held the calm assurance of someone who had already built the system that others hadn’t yet noticed.

The moderator stepped forward — a respected figure from an old policy journal, now a freelance commentator with her own Substack and funding. She wore a dark red shawl, half-academic, half-liturgical.

“Gentlemen,” she began, voice amplified subtly through ambient sound-webbing overhead, “we are here today not simply to compare models, but to examine the deeper foundations of sovereignty, issuance, and the future of value itself.”

Thorne offered a polite nod. “I’m honoured to be here. And to be sitting beside Mr. Ashcombe, whose networks — while at times opaque — have done remarkable work.”

Ashcombe smiled without showing his teeth. “Likewise. I have long admired and indeed invested in the precision of Manchester’s economic apparatus, even if I worry that precision can become its own kind of blindness.”

There were scattered murmurs in the crowd.

The moderator continued. “Today’s topic is: *Currency as Governance: Sovereignty, Fiat, and Freedom*. You both represent emerging poles in this post-central bank landscape. Mr. Thorne — you have argued for a strict Bitcoin standard, no issuance, total decentralisation. Mr. Ashcombe — your Kommune we now know was funded by the development of the Lattice protocol, which facilitates an unstoppable market economy. You both, in your ways, have refused fiat.”

She paused. “And yet this morning, Eliot Ashton — who I believe is sitting with us somewhere today — shocked the world by dramatically expanding Sheffield’s money supply. Samuel, Alexander — what does this mean for your models?”

Eliot sat motionless in the back row, his breath low. Here it was — the moment when the alternative minds would weigh his move. He half-expected derision. But part of him hoped for recognition, too.

Thorne leaned forward first, eyes gleaming.

“I’ve always said fiat is a corruption of time,” he began. “Currency should be a frozen mirror of past work. Not an instrument of intent. What Ashton has done is impose intent. He has centralised demand, hijacked temporal honesty, and inserted a will into what should be a ledger. That is not sovereignty — it is soft tyranny.”

Murmurs of approval from some in the audience.

Ashcombe’s response was slower. Thoughtful.

“I agree,” he said, “and I don’t. The Lattice model emerged as an attempt to allow value itself to evolve through trade— but from nodes and proof-of-work. The currency issuance is based on proof-of-work to keep the network going. But the lattice protocol is not controlled by one man, no matter how noble that person maybe, the code is incorruptible. Sheffield’s model is… interesting. It may survive. But only if the people accept the burden. My concern is that fiat — even when used with the best of intentions — always begins as creation and ends as control.”

The discussion continued, the tone now shifting from critique to a kind of measured philosophical concern. The moderator leaned back, allowing Thorne and Ashcombe to continue unprompted.

Thorne’s voice was crisp. “What Ashton has done is implement a beautifully veiled tyranny — no less real for its aesthetics. You issue a soft currency, backed by trust, and then tell your citizens: you must produce at least 2.5% more every month, or your value will decay. That is indistinguishable from central bank tyranny — except it wears the clothes of community.”

He looked around the amphitheatre. “And the people cheer for it. Because Ashton has done what central banks never could — he’s made inflation aspirational.”

There were murmurs. A few audible laughs. Some nods.

Ashcombe chuckled. “It’s true,” he said, “but it’s also… genius. I won’t pretend it doesn’t impress me. Eliot Ashton is one of the most inventive economic thinkers of our time. He isn’t playing with levers, he's building whole new apparatuses. The idea of linking the money supply to economic productivity is… poetic, even if potentially dangerous."

He paused, speaking more softly now. "It's all a question of whether Sheffield's institutions can absorb the liquidity — whether its artists, its craftspeople, its builders can turn that capital into substance without diluting the social meaning of SheffCoin. If not, it becomes another inflationary dream. But if the timing's right… he might just find a kind of monetary-civilisational synthesis. Something we've all tried in our own ways. If he has the charisma over Sheffield we think he does, he can turn the experience into a formational event."

The moderator turned her head, her voice neutral. "You don't sound dismissive."

Ashcombe smiled faintly. "I'm not. But it's a knife's edge. There's no room for missteps in a trust-based currency. Either it compounds meaning — or it dissolves it."

Thorne's eyes narrowed. "Trust," he said, "is the greatest vulnerability in any system. That's why I eliminate it entirely."

Eliot sat, still hidden in the back of the amphitheatre, his mind racing.

He had wanted a debate of ideas. He hadn't expected to feel so… exposed. And yet, hearing his name spoken in those tones — as a rival, a possibility, a threat — made something fire in his chest. His system had become the central tension of the festival.

He texted Sophie, a single line:

"They're taking us seriously."

Sophie's reply came quickly, a flicker of typing before the words appeared beneath his last message:

"They've always taken you seriously, Eliot. They just didn't want to admit it until now."

A moment later, another message:

"You look good in their shadow. Let's make sure they look even better in yours."

Eliot smiled faintly, the tension in his jaw loosening. Trust — that old, frail thing Thorne had discarded — it still lived in Sheffield, in Sophie, in the very fabric of the culture he'd spent years weaving.

He typed back:

"Meet me at the Mirror Tent in twenty?"

Sophie:

"Already on my way. Big ideas need champagne."

As he pocketed his device, Eliot stood and slipped out of the amphitheatre's rear aisle, the murmurs of Thorne and Ashcombe's continued dialogue dissolving into the crisp festival air. Above him, the sky flickered gently with high-atmosphere drones, the hum of soft energy systems and quiet revolutionaries.

The Mirror Tent shimmered in the afternoon sun — a crystalline dome of angled glass and polished metal, reflecting the verdant folds of the valley and fracturing the festival crowd into a thousand broken moments. Inside, its vaulted interior caught the light like a kaleidoscope, the surfaces alive with motion. Voices echoed in layered tones. Music threaded gently beneath it all — ambient, spectral, suggestive of something beginning.

Eliot stepped through the entrance flap and paused.

He spotted Sophie first, seated at a low table in the corner beneath an arch of draped white linen. She was laughing with someone across from her, a flicker of warmth on her face, her hand around a chilled glass. Her hair was tied back, loose and relaxed in the glow of the tent's prism light.

And then he saw him.

Paul.

Sat beside her.

The breath caught in Eliot's throat. Not from fury. Not entirely from betrayal. But from the sharp, spiralling rush of recognition. The realisation that some ghosts didn't haunt — they returned.

Paul stood as soon as he saw Eliot. There was a half-step forward, then hesitation. Sophie had noticed too. Her expression faltered, unreadable for a moment.

Paul raised a hand slightly, awkwardly. "Eliot," he said. Just the name. Softly.

Eliot didn't move.

The sound of the festival dulled around him. His heart was thudding harder than it had in days.

He walked forward, measuredly, until he stood opposite the man who had once been his closest friend.

"What are you doing here?" Eliot said, voice low, taut as wire.

Paul held his gaze. "I came to see the future. Same as you."

Silence hung like mist between them. Sophie didn't speak, but she was watching closely — eyes darting between the two, the tension electric.

"I didn't expect to see you here," Eliot said, finally.

Paul nodded. "I wasn't sure I'd come either."

"You're still working with Thorne?"

"Yes. But I'm not *just* working with Thorne anymore."

Eliot blinked. "What does that mean?"

Paul looked toward Sophie, then back to Eliot. "It means things are… changing. Even in Manchester."

Eliot gave a short, humourless laugh. "Does he know you're here?"

"He didn't stop me."

Eliot stepped back slightly. He looked at Sophie, then at Paul again — both of them painted in glints of mirrorlight.

"Sit down," Sophie said gently. "Let's talk. Properly."

For a moment, Eliot stood on the edge of decision — memory, rage, and curiosity churning under his skin.

Then, slowly, he sat.

Eliot sat, the tension in his shoulders refusing to release. Sophie poured him a drink without a word. Paul exhaled slowly, his voice lower now, less performative — almost like it used to be.

"Manchester," he said, "is everything Thorne promised. Fast. Productive. Uncompromising. But after a while, it becomes…" He paused, searching. "Flat. You don't make memories there. You just produce."

Eliot's brows furrowed slightly, but he said nothing.

Paul went on. "Everything's efficient, measurable. You can optimise your entire life — diet, sex, work cycles, even conversation. There's a DAO for intimacy now. But there's no… *texture.* No reflection. No slowness. It's like living in a loop of intensity that never builds to anything."

Sophie leaned forward. "Come back then."

Paul gave a half-smile, regretful. "It's not that simple."

"Why not?"

He turned his glass in his hand. "Because it's addictive. The pace. The clarity. The feeling that you're part of something immense. You start to believe that slowing down means failure. That if you're not maximising, you're wasting. It gets under your skin."

Eliot studied him. "That's not how it used to be for you."

"I know." Paul looked at him. "I used to believe in the slow burn. In building something with meaning."

"And now?"

Paul's jaw tightened slightly. "Now I'm not sure what I believe. But Sheffield… Sheffield *feels* like something. There's this weight to it. It makes you ache, but in a good way. You can breathe. You can *feel.*"

Sophie nodded. "That's why it's worth it. Even if it's slower. Even if it doesn't win every metric."

Paul didn't answer for a moment. He just stared at the glass in his hand, the liquid catching the fractured reflections from the tent walls.

Finally, he looked up. "Maybe I never stopped believing in Sheffield. I just didn't know how to fight for it."

Eliot glanced toward him, then away. The silence between them wasn't warm, but it wasn't angry anymore. It was open.

Sophie spoke gently. "It's not too late, you know."

Paul looked back at them both. "I don't know if I can leave Manchester. But maybe I don't have to choose."

Eliot raised an eyebrow. "Meaning?"

“I’ve seen what Manchester’s good at. And I know what Sheffield makes possible. Maybe the future isn’t choosing one or the other.”

They sat in silence a moment longer, the mirror tent shimmering around them like a memory still forming.

Paul leaned back, fingers drumming once against the stem of his glass. Then, almost casually, he asked, “So what do you think’s going to happen with the currency issuance?”

Eliot didn’t answer at first. His gaze had drifted to the shifting reflections in the mirror tent — fragments of faces, firelight, foliage from the estate gardens. A thousand versions of the same moment.

Then, quietly: “I don’t know.”

Paul tilted his head. “That’s not like you.”

Eliot gave a faint, crooked smile. “No. It’s not.”

He straightened slightly. “I think it could work. If people believe in it. If they rise to the challenge. If productivity increases at pace, and culture keeps its rhythm — it could be a model for something new. A soft lever. A gentle pressure instead of brute force. But—”

“There’s always a but,” Paul muttered.

“But,” Eliot continued, “if it fails, it will look like tyranny. Like an experiment forced onto people without consent. And the world will not be kind in judging it.”

Sophie said, “It’s not tyranny if it’s transparent.”

Eliot glanced at her. “Transparency doesn’t make pressure easier to bear.”

Paul nodded slowly. “And you think the people will respond?”

“I think they already are,” Eliot replied. “The festival, the conversations, the press — it’s working. People are creating, collaborating, moving faster than they were. But it’s fragile. One bad quarter, one missed target… the narrative could turn.”

Paul looked genuinely curious now. “So why risk it?”

Eliot’s reply was soft, almost private. “Because Thorne is winning. And if we don’t try to push forward with our own pace, our own way, we’ll get absorbed into his machine. Sheffield will lose what makes it Sheffield.”

Thorne’s voice carried from the stage, precise and unmistakably composed for the global cameras. The amphitheatre was hushed as he laid out Manchester’s gains in growth velocity, its rising EGI (Economic Growth Index), the sheer scale of its export metrics. Every statistic landed like a hammer — blunt, undeniable.

Eliot, sitting further back beneath the high arch of the agora’s pavilion, was only half-listening.

He scrolled quietly through the stack of encrypted messages piling up on his sheaf. Analysts from the Bank. Production nodes. Policy aides. The models were running wild now — speculative, optimistic, breathless.

"Public transport viability projections recalibrated. Maglev route from Park Hill to Kelham Island shows 2x efficiency gain. Cost viable within 12 months of issuance."

"Sheffield Blades Artisans' Co-op requesting capital. Proposal to scale cutlery production tenfold with AI-assisted design, retaining manual finish. Export appeal: High."

"Farm-to-city network: Advanced hydroponic vertical farms in Neepsend could meet 60% of Sheffield's fresh produce demand within 2 years. Value resonance: strong."

He rubbed his forehead, distracted by the noise of Thorne's voice behind him — extolling again the purifying fires of discipline, the sacredness of productivity, the beauty of output.

But Eliot wasn't thinking about factories or numbers.

He was thinking about the gliding quiet of a maglev train easing over the Don Valley at sunset. A city connected not just by utility, but by design. Something elegant. Something memorable.

He thought of SheffCoin's promise — not just a hard money, but a felt one. If currency was belief, then it had to do more than circulate — it had to inspire.

He glanced back at the stage, where Thorne was beginning to gesture towards global implementation strategies, cascading DAOs, energy arbitrage.

Eliot's screen blinked again.

> "Recommended discretionary fund: Sheffield Film Workshop. Request for cinema renovation + AI-film training. 'We don't want content. We want cinema.'"

Eliot smiled. That was the point, wasn't it?

This was the chance to build not just a monetary system, but a city-verse. An economy of belonging. A network where even the trains felt personal. Even the tools were beautiful.

Sheffield could be a poem, not a machine.

Chapter 15:

Eliot felt the warm night humming around him — the festival had bloomed into full motion. Under the illuminated boughs of sycamores and ash, the air was alive with voices, flickering projections, and the rhythm of a city dreaming aloud. Sophie walked beside him, her hands tucked into her long coat, laughing at something Charlotte had said. Eliot was half-listening, half in his head, still thinking about public transit, the philosophy of inflation and the new Sheffcoin issuance.

And then someone — a young woman with glowing nails and a half-shaved head — slipped something into his hands with practiced subtlety.

Eliot looked down. A roll of LED-parchement. A single document on the roll of liquid paper.

Sophie leaned over. "What is it?"

He read the header aloud.

The Internationalist – Leader
Title: "The Peak Reckoning: Culture, Code, and Competing Sovereignties"

HOPE VALLEY, PEAK DISTRICT *– Something unprecedented is unfolding in the English uplands. Beneath the heathered slopes and limestone crags of the Earl of Hope Valley's ancestral estate, a new kind of summit has begun: one part ideas festival, one part monetary war game, one part aesthetic revolution. The "Festival of Ideas," organised under the guise of philosophical debate, is rapidly becoming a geopolitical weather vane. If the past decades belonged to Silicon Valley, the next may belong to the Peaks.*

At the heart of this intellectual melee are three competing visions of sovereignty, each embodied by a figure: Eliot Ashton of Sheffield, Alexander Thorne of Manchester, and Samuel Ashcombe, the mysterious scion of the cypherpunk movement and part-aristocrat himself. Their converging philosophies—Ashton's culturally-driven, fiat-tethered decentralism; Thorne's muscular, code-maximalist productivity state; and Ashcombe's anarcho-communal market radicalism have attracted global attention. Not since the Bretton Woods conference has the world watched such a stylised dispute over the nature of money and civilisation.

Mr Ashton's newest salvo was as bold as it was controversial. His announcement of a sharp expansion in the SheffCoin money supply sent shockwaves through the temporary agora. Unlike central banks, Mr Ashton's Bank of Sheffield is a private, voluntary institution. But its move—essentially an inflationary jolt—was designed to force a productivity boom, incentivising the city's artisans, educators, and cultural producers to accelerate. He calls it "philosophical stimulus"; Mr Thorne calls it monetary tyranny.

The risk is plain: if Sheffield's productive economy fails to keep pace with the increased monetary base, the city could see rapid depreciation of its currency. But the plan is not without merit. It draws from a novel equation Ashton unveiled—linking inflation not to consumer prices, but to the imbalance between money supply and productivity growth. Economically, it is akin to a soft power Modern Monetary Theory for the 21st century, designed not around EGI targets but productive throughput.

Manchester, by contrast, has no time for such subtlety. Mr Thorne, ever the futurist general, stood before the global press on the second day of the festival with economic outputs, patent figures, and export maps of his metropolis. Manchester is thriving—lean, automated, aggressive. Its citizens are productive but emotionally estranged. Mr Thorne dismissed Sheffield's model as "sentimental Keynesian cosplay," positioning himself instead as the bearer of a new rationalism: maximalist, post-romantic, and born from the ledger.

Then there is Mr Ashcombe, who calmly revealed that the cypherpunks had built the Lattice—a decentralised meta-market layered atop Bitcoin and smart contract platforms. To some, it is digital anarchy; to others, the truest expression of free-market theory. Ashcombe's model has no central issuer, no bank, no ruler – just proof-of-work tokens. He claims culture will emerge, unplanned, from the equilibrium of peer-to-peer exchange. Perhaps—but can deep civilisation emerge from a network without architecture?

Each model has its strength. Sheffield's private currency issuance is bold, humanistic, and fragile. Manchester's efficiency is its own tyrant, commanding loyalty through performance. Ashcombe's lattice is pure freedom, and pure chaos.

What does all this mean? If Sheffield succeeds, it will prove that private currency issuance can serve not just monetary ends but cultural ones. If Manchester wins, it will legitimise a fully post-

democratic, techno-statist model of governance by output. If the Lattice spreads, it may obsolete both cities altogether.

The Festival continues. Crowds swell. Global viewers tune in. DAOs and nations take notes. The 21st century's foundational debate may be happening not in Davos or Beijing, but in the mud and mist of England's last true wilderness.

Eliot put down the parchment, The Internationalist article still glowing faintly behind the darkened screen. The weight of the moment pressed down on him like fog. Sophie, seated beside him on a weathered wooden bench beneath a string of Edison bulbs, handed him a sip of her drink without asking.

"Well," she said, eyebrows raised.

Eliot exhaled through his nose, half amused, half paralysed by the implications. "It's maddening. They understand the stakes, but not the heart of it. They write as if this is a game of models, not lives."

Sophie leaned closer. "It's the price of leadership. You do something real, the world sees an idea. They don't see the pub singer who just got a grant to press vinyl, or the community baker who's now exporting to Milan."

Eliot's phone buzzed. A message popped up. Just a name: *"Brother Gideon – Christian Polycentrists"*. It read:

You are invited to the Periphery. East of the amphitheatre, beyond the orchard path. We would like a word. Quietly. You will be expected.

He stared at it for a moment. Sophie noticed. "What now?"

"The Christian Polycentrists," he said slowly. "They want to speak."

"Here?"

"They have a stall apparently. On the edge of the grounds."

Sophie tilted her head. "Didn't even know they were here. Weren't they… esoteric? Almost mythical?"

"They always are, until they're suddenly everywhere." He stood, brushing dust from his trousers. "Come with me?"

"Obviously."

Together, they began walking across the illuminated meadows, where the buzz of conversation from hundreds of thinkers, traders, monastics, and hackers mixed in the air like pollen. The stars above were faint, outshone by low-glide drones and projection beams slicing the dusk. As they moved past the agora's outer rim, a quietude settled in—less performance, more stillness.

They reached the orchard path: dimly lit, overgrown at the edges, the noise of the festival softening behind them. And there, nestled into the treeline, stood the Polycentrists' encampment.

No sign. No flashing screens. Just a modest structure of carved timber and linen. A soft golden glow spilled from within, and faint choral tones—wordless, resonant—hung in the air. A scent of cedar and frankincense lingered.

Sophie whispered, “This doesn’t feel like the rest of the festival.”

“That’s probably the point.”

From within the structure, a man emerged. Robed, but not performatively so. His clothes were plain, woven of thick, natural fabric. His eyes were alert. He bowed his head in greeting.

“Mr. Ashton. Miss Grant. Welcome to the edge.”

“We’re honoured,” Eliot said, voice lowered. “Why here? Why now?”

The man—Brother Gideon—smiled. “Because the centre cannot hold. And some things must begin at the margins.”

He gestured toward the interior. “Please. There are things we’d like to share with you.”

Sophie glanced at Eliot. He gave the smallest of nods.

They stepped forwards.

Inside was like nothing they had seen before. The air shimmered with incense—myrrh? sandalwood?—and the faint ozone tang of ionised air. Light bent strangely around the room, filtered through layers of dyed silk and sheets of graphene-glass, giving the impression that the whole space was breathing. It was half a chapel, half a lounge. Somewhere between a 1970s Berlin acid den and a reconstructed medieval crypt run by the children of Alan Turing.

There were priests—at least, they looked like priests—draped in hooded garments of white and ultrapurple, eyes wide with what was unmistakably chemical dilation. Their pupils pulsed in time with the ambient frequencies. A drone hovered above a burning brazier, projecting sacred geometry onto the wall with lines of code embedded inside the forms. An AI-generated music piece swirled through the space: Jimi Hendrix guitar phrases sampled and counterpointed against Bach’s *Mass in B Minor*, then remixed by some adaptive neural net trained on Gregorian chant and Detroit techno. It should have been ridiculous. It wasn’t.

One priest sat in perfect stillness in the centre of the room, a huge open Bible in front of him, except each page shimmered between scripture and source code.

Sophie stepped closer to Eliot. “This is either deeply moving or deeply insane. Possibly both.”

“And ye shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”
—John 8:32

Brother Gideon smiled, unfazed by the environment. “Our minds must be altered to perceive the new kingdom. As Saint Paul said: ‘Be transformed by the renewing of your mind.’ We take this literally.”

Another figure moved through the haze—barefoot, calm, eyes glowing. A woman in a minimalist tunic approached with two small cups of a glowing violet liquid.

“You must drink,” she said softly. “Only a little. Just to open the threshold.”

Eliot took the cup, glancing at Sophie, who hesitated for half a breath before accepting hers.

“What is it?” Eliot asked.

“Eucharist for the hypermodern age,” the woman said. “Psilocybin, lithium trace, rosemary extract, and a digitally blessed peptide blend. It won’t alter you much. Just enough to hear.”

“To hear what?”

Brother Gideon leaned in slightly. “The Logos. Or at least... what comes after it.”

Eliot stared at the cup.

He thought of the Bank of Sheffield. He thought of the issuance. Of Thorne’s accusation. Of The Internationalist article. Of Paul. Of the cathedral of ideas collapsing into the marketplace of attention.

Then he drank.

The taste was surprisingly clean—cool, herbaceous, and floral, like a mountain spring with something ancient dissolved in it. Sophie followed suit, exhaling sharply after the first sip.

The lights in the room pulsed slightly.

A voice—electronic, genderless, soft—filled the air like prayer.

“Welcome. This is the edge. We are those who live without centre, who pray without priest,
who build with no blueprint. We are the ones who remember the West and its soul.”

Brother Gideon gestured to a set of cushions arranged around a low table.

The music dimmed slightly, folding itself into a low harmonic drone that felt like breath. One of the priests stepped forward—tall, androgynous, with skin like old marble and eyes alight with something fierce and inward. Their voice, when it came, was clear and unfaltering, the cadence unmistakably liturgical:

The circle around the low table responded in unison, not loudly but with grave clarity:

“For where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty.”
—2 Corinthians 3:17

Then, silence.

Eliot looked up, something tightening in his chest.

Brother Gideon turned to him and Sophie and spoke with a new tone, less oracular, more matter-of-fact—though no less unsettling.

“We are not a church in the usual sense,” he said. “We exist between the churches. Between the old ecclesial monopolies and the new cults of self. We are a religious order of Christian polycentrists. Our sacrament is not temperance but abundance. Not denial, but experience—the full spectrum of consciousness.”

Sophie narrowed her eyes. “Christian hedonism?”

“Christian hedonism,” Brother Gideon confirmed. “We do not seek to suppress the body. We believe the path to the divine lies through the senses—when they are directed, sanctified, and integrated. The ecstatic is not a sin. It is a gate. Joy is not an indulgence—it is a liturgy.”

Another priest spoke up, softer but still with authority: “We believe that in the age of AI, of networks, of the decentralised soul, the Body of Christ must also decentralise. No Pope. No Bishop. No single pulpit. Only textual sanctity. Polycentric grace.”

Sophie looked around at the room again—at the strange blend of ancient and hypermodern. “And what does that mean in practice?”

Gideon smiled. “It means we want to found a cathedral. In Sheffield. A true hypermodern sanctuary. Not for control, but for openness. Not for doctrine, but for sacrament. A cathedral for the next millennium.”

Eliot swallowed. “A polycentrist cathedral?”

“Built from glass, data, oak and stone. Designed not by one architect but many. A place for pilgrimage, not permanence. It would have no clergy in the traditional sense, only rotating stewards. A sacred space for art, for ecstatic prayer, for theological computing. And yes—for the sacraments of love and pleasure. Because God did not come to dull us. He came to *wake us up*.”

Eliot looked at Sophie. She was staring ahead, her expression unreadable.

“And you want this... cathedral,” Eliot said slowly, “in *Sheffield*?”

“We believe,” said Gideon, “that it is the only place it could be.”

They sat cross-legged on rugs woven with crypto-symbology and esoteric heraldry, surrounded by plumes of incense that shimmered in the cool dusk light filtering through sheets of translucent fibre. A priest with glassy eyes and a Beatific smile leaned forward and offered Eliot a chalice of infused tea—an ancient brew spiked with a very modern compound.

Opposite him, another figure in ceremonial white robes with iridescent threads running through the fabric gently closed the prayer book and said, softly:

“Let everything that has breath praise the Lord. Psalm 150:6. The breath is everything. It is the bridge.”

Sophie glanced sideways at Eliot, but he was focused—silent, even awed.

The priest continued, gesturing to the shimmering architectural model beside them. A physical projection of pure digital light: arches of prismatic glass, columns of living stone, pews that pulsed with light. At its centre was a tree—perhaps allegorical, perhaps literal—glowing from within.

“The cathedral we will build in Sheffield will not be of brick and stone alone. It will be a biosynthetic organism. A temple grown, not constructed. Coded, not quarried. Alive, like the people who enter it. Responsive to prayer. A monument to life, in the truest aspiration of the divine.”

He smiled now, a slow and knowing gesture.

“You think we’re fringe. But the truth is: we’re at the centre of the centre. Manchester has Thorne. Sheffield has you. But we… we are the soul.”

Another robed acolyte nodded, eyes half-closed in meditation. His voice was younger, clearer.

"Do you know how many followers we have in places of power? In Northern guilds? In podcast production? We don't wear robes when we walk among them. But we are many. The future will not be managed. It will be incarnated."

Eliot sat back, a little stunned.

"You've influenced more than we realised," he said, his voice half-hushed.

"Of course we have," said the priest, raising his chalice again. "Because unlike Thorne's algorithmic sovereignty, or your monetary scaffolding—we touch ecstasy. We offer the divine."

Sophie leaned forward, eyes narrowed.

"And this cathedral—who pays for it?"

The priest did not flinch. He smiled again.

"Some of our benefactors are in Silicon Valley. Others are from older bloodlines. Some are new decentralised patrons with no name. But it will be built. In your city. Because the people already believe, even if they do not yet know the name."

Another priest struck a small chime, and the sound rippled across the temple like a bell made of liquid light.

"Christian Polycentricism is not about hierarchy," he said finally. "It is about constellation. About sovereignty not just of self, but of soul."

Outside, the dusk had become evening. Inside the temple, the colours shifted again—cool lavender becoming warm rose, then deepening into a deep red gold as though the walls themselves were following the sunset.

Eliot whispered: "We'll talk more. But I need time."

They said it without hesitation.

"We will support your issuance," intoned one of the elder Polycentrists, a woman with close-cropped white hair and luminous eyes. "Sheffield will be the site not only of a cultural renaissance—but of the first Cathedral of Christian Polycentricism."

Eliot nodded, feeling the weight of it. "Then let's build it," he said simply. "Let's make it stand for something higher than speculation. A house of spirit. A house of the people."

The monks around him began to murmur—chants of assent, rising like gentle tide. There were no cheers, no dramatic gestures. Just a quiet acceptance, a sacred contract sealed with breath. The cathedral would rise in Sheffield. It would be a place of music and flame, of drugs and scripture, of communion through chaos and clarity alike.

Sophie took Eliot's arm as they left the tent, both of them feeling as if they'd just walked out of a prophetic dream. "You know this is going to change things," she said, eyes narrowed with a mix of awe and concern.

"I know," Eliot said. "That's why I agreed."

They returned to the Agora, where the final marquee debate of the day was about to begin. A crowd had gathered in the flickering dusk, faces glowing from the interface light of floating feeds, data overlays and language translations. At the centre of the stage, backlit by the glowing Manchester crest, stood Thorne.

His voice already rang out through the festival grounds.

“The crumbling edifice of Westminster is not a symbol—it is a warning. It is a tomb. The nation is ready to be remade, not by decrees from dead halls, but by sovereigns with skin in the game, minds in the machine, and hearts in the fire of progress.”

A great hush passed over the crowd. Eliot and Sophie took their seats among the murmuring philosophers and podcasters, local mayors and foreign technocrats. Behind Eliot, someone whispered, “He sounds like he’s preparing for war.”

Sophie looked sideways. “He’s not wrong that Parliament’s floundering,” she muttered.

“No,” Eliot said, voice low. “But neither is he the only one building something sacred.”

Thorne stood at the centre of the Helix Pavilion like a man preparing for battle—not with weapons, but with words sharpened over years of ideological discipline. Behind him, the Manchester seal flickered in high-resolution behind clouds of data and kinetic infographics, pulsing to the rhythm of his voice.

“And so,” he said, the room held taut in silence, “in light of Parliament’s collapse into irrelevance, in light of its refusal to adapt to the age of networks, decentralisation, and sovereign technology—we no longer recognise its authority.”

A gasp rippled through the gathered crowd. Eliot felt Sophie’s hand tighten slightly on his arm.

Thorne pressed on. “From this day forward, the City of Manchester will constitute its own legislation. It will manage its own currency, its own taxation structures, and its own judicial processes. Manchester is now a sovereign city-state.”

The crowd erupted. Some cheered wildly. Some gasped. Some merely watched, stunned into breathlessness. Even the media drones hovered uncertainly, swivelling to capture Eliot’s reaction.

Eliot sat motionless for a beat too long. Sophie leaned toward him, voice barely audible: “He just declared independence.”

Eliot turned slowly, eyes narrowing. “This wasn’t meant to happen. Not here. Not now. Come on Thorne, have some sense”

The pavilion had dissolved into noise. Podcasters screamed into headsets. Delegates whispered into phones. The international media bubble around the stage was going live across feeds and networks in every hemisphere.

“This was supposed to be a coming together,” Sophie said, her voice taut. “Now they’re trying to outcompete each other.”

Eliot watched Thorne standing proudly, arms crossed, as though he'd simply revealed a natural truth rather than detonated a political bomb.

“And Ashcombe,” Eliot said bitterly, eyes flicking to the Cypherpunk’s pavilion just visible across the glowing terrain. “He’ll love this. One less state to worry about.”

Sophie looked at him. “So what do we do now?”

Eliot didn’t answer. He couldn’t. His mind was racing with numbers, models, forecasts, and a whisper of doubt.

Had Thorne just pulled ahead? Or had he overreached?

Sophie stared out at the chaos building across the festival grounds—delegate groups murmuring in tight circles, journalists running towards makeshift media booths, a visible tremor of uncertainty cutting through the curated spectacle.

“Surely the government has to intervene now?” she said, still half-watching the screen where Thorne was now surrounded by his inner circle, triumphant and composed. “They can’t just let him declare a sovereign state on a livestream. That’s… that’s madness.”

Eliot shrugged. Not because he didn’t care—he did—but because it was beyond his grasp now. “They’ll hesitate,” he said. “They always do when it looks like tech is winning. They don’t know how to handle this kind of theatre.”

His phone buzzed in his coat pocket. He pulled it out. Samuel Ashcombe.

He answered, and the familiar voice on the other end was already in mid-flow.

“Eliot. It’s begun.”

Eliot stepped away from the crowd, holding the phone tight to his ear. “You saw it?”

“I was watching. We have set up a tent. Instructions on the way,” Samuel said. “Come, see me.”

“I will,” Eliot texted back. “And I feel we’ve just lost the pace again.”

Eliot looked up across the glowing landscape of the agora. The wind rustled the flags, the lights shimmered on polished glass and steel. Somewhere across the valley, the signal towers of Manchester blinked in sequence.

Thorne stood at the centre of the Peak Agora, sleeves rolled, voice edged with righteous steel. The glint of the hydrogen VTOLs behind him caught the last rays of the sun as he delivered his final words.

“Manchester does not ask permission. It will not apologise for strength. It does not need Westminster’s signature to be sovereign—it already is. We will legislate our own laws. Tax ourselves. Guard our future.

Parliament is a museum. We are a forge. And from here, a new Britain will be built—whether it wants to be or not.”

The crowd erupted. Manchester’s delegation roared like a football terrace. Journalists scrambled to beam the footage live to a hundred million screens. Somewhere in Whitehall, glass was almost certainly breaking.

And then—he walked off, chin lifted, his coat flaring behind him like a standard.

The contrast was surgical.

The Ashcombe tent was low-lit, humming with the quiet buzz of routers and interface nodes strung up like votive lanterns. Three sleek terminal screens glowed in a semi-circle around Samuel Ashcombe as Eliot, Sophie, and Charlotte stepped inside. Ashcombe didn't rise. He gestured for them to sit.

Sophie glanced around. "You've built a war room."

Samuel's fingers were already moving, keystrokes gliding across all three keyboards in a fluid, interwoven sequence. "No. This is just plumbing. I didn't expect to have to stay here."

He turned to Eliot, and something in his posture shifted — the subtle, imperceptible change from mystic to architect, priest to tactician.

"You've heard Thorne's declaration," Samuel said, voice flat. "I imagine the state's already scrambling a dozen frameworks for how to respond. But I don't need to scramble anything. I've known for weeks."

Eliot narrowed his eyes. "He wanted to do this?"

"Correct. But did you also know that Thorne's DAO stack runs on our code. Not just components — the foundation. Lattice was never just a marketplace or a currency framework. It was a substrate, a protocol. And Manchester, for all its noise about sovereignty, built itself on it."

Charlotte sat up straighter. "What does the mean?"

Ashcombe's hands hovered above the keyboards. On the left screen: node maps. On the right: hash signatures ticking over in real time. In the middle: a smart contract dashboard quietly waiting for multi-sig approval.

"I'm saying," Samuel said, "that most of Manchester's core institutions are running on infrastructure designed by a Kommune that doesn't believe in centralisation — and that has now decided it no longer wants to prop up a city-state run by a technocrat and managed by spreadsheet zealots."

Sophie stood, as if to say something — then didn't.

Ashcombe's tone dropped lower, a rare seriousness settling in. "I'm not doing this out of malice. I've let the system run. I gave them the keys to build. But sovereignty is a fragile mask. And sometimes, the network reclaims its source."

He turned now, slowly, eyes sharper than Eliot had ever seen. "You know what Lattice really is?"

Eliot said nothing.

"Manchester's DAOs," Samuel continued, "run on a forked, unauthorised derivative of the Lattice protocol. But here's the thing—they've stripped it of proof-of-work and slapped on a proof-of-authority governance layer. Top-down. Permissioned. Weak."

He tapped a keyboard. A network map expanded across the central screen—interwoven chains, validator nodes, and escrow protocols blinking green.

"They turned our system into a citadel, and then used it to run a sovereign city. It's like building a cathedral from someone else's gospel—and replacing the Holy Spirit with a bureaucrat."

Samuel stared at the screens, the green-lit node map like a web of nerves across the digital flesh of Manchester. He didn't blink. The terminal keys waited beneath his hands, commands poised.

"I might not be able to break Thorne's signing keys. At least not in the next few hours," he admitted. "But we have wargamed how to take out his DAO's. The signature's root credentials are tight—vaulted, offline, hardware-bound. Maybe even quantum-resistant. But that's not what I'm aiming for anymore."

Eliot leaned in. "Then what?"

Samuel turned. His voice was low, precise. "The real fragility isn't in the core. It's in the communication tissue. The relay infrastructure, the off-chain instruction layers, the command consensus bridges. Manchester's DAOs run on semi-automated subnets—decision relays, arbitrage nodes, machine-oracles that tie it all together."

He tapped a screen again. A branching graph of connections blinked, like synapses.

"They built a nervous system. Beautiful, efficient, but dependent. It functions because the right data hits the right point at the right time. You choke the nervous system—"

"And it goes blind," Eliot said.

Samuel nodded. "Not dead. Just confused. The DAOs won't collapse. But their coordination will degrade. Instead of automatic execution, people will have to step in. Manual overrides. Friction. Delays. And most dangerous of all—human error."

Sophie looked over his shoulder. "You'll cut the nerves but not kill the brain."

"Exactly," Samuel said. "Jam the system up and it'll collapse in on itself."

On one of the side monitors, a status feed began pulsing in crimson. Samuel clicked through several layers. "We've already begun to fork the mirrors of a few indexing servers. Quietly. Latency will drift. Transactions will misroute. Not catastrophically—just enough to raise questions. Just enough to create doubt."

Eliot felt it then—that slow vibration in the chest, the anticipation before a fracture.

"You think this will stop Manchester?"

Samuel gave a faint smile. "No. But I think it will slow them down. And in this war of models, slowness is fatal. If they hesitate, if they have to explain… people start to wonder. And that's how decentralised systems die. Not in fire. In questions."

Inside the tent, the atmosphere had changed. The warm glow of firelight now seemed distant, like it belonged to another gathering altogether. Samuel Ashcombe was pacing in a tight circle, flanked by three screens filled with diagrams, node clusters, DAO schemas, and comms relays. Gone was the roguish charm—this was the strategist unmasked.

He turned to Eliot and Sophie, his voice a stripped-down monotone, all affect purged.

"His declaration of independence changed the equation. We were content to observe. Now? He's crossed the Rubicon. It's not about system design anymore—it's about threat containment."

Members of the other Peak Kommunes—quiet, serious faces half-lit in the glow—were already murmuring around a terminal, coordinating something unsaid.

“We’re discussing targeted interference,” Ashcombe said, now to no one in particular. “We start breaking up the consensus models. Isolate critical relays. Drop the uptime to 98%. The system will still work—barely. But not well enough for the scale he’s envisioning.”

A hush fell as the tent flap swung open with a rustle.

Lord Rutherford stepped inside, breathless, his composure peeled away.

“He’s gone,” Rutherford said. “Thorne’s left. Took one of the VTOLs. He’s on his way back to Manchester.”

Samuel’s eyes didn’t even flicker.

“And the government?”

Rutherford shook his head. “Nothing public. But I’ve had three messages in the last ten minutes. They’re watching everything. He’s rattled the cage.”

Ashcombe didn’t even flinch. His tone dropped, steel beneath velvet.

“Ok. We’ll sort it. Out Rutherford. Go back to your lawn diplomacy.”

Rutherford looked stunned. He hesitated for a moment, then turned and vanished into the night.

Ashcombe returned to his screen, calling out across the room: “Start Phase Two. Slow the clocks. Fragment the mirrors. Tell the others we go active in thirty minutes.”

Ashcombe was hunched over the centre terminal now, fingers gliding across three keyboards at once as dozens of terminals lit up in succession. The hum of static energy in the tent was rising—cool, surgical, electric. Across from him, a young woman in a bomber jacket was debugging something in real time while relaying code fragments to a screen overhead. The air tasted of cold metal and old firelight.

Sophie looked up from her phone. “Paul messaged.”

Ashcombe didn’t look away from the code.

“He says Thorne’s back in Manchester,” she went on. “He says this was prepared. They’ve been expecting something like this.”

The tent quieted for half a breath. Then Ashcombe’s voice cut through, low and clipped: “Of course it was.”

He waved a hand toward a terminal. “Get me the last 12-hour flow map from the commercial stack nodes. I want to see how deep their fallback mirrors go.”

The coders around him picked up speed.

Eliot stood back, trying to catch up. The floor felt like it was tilting slightly beneath him.

Sophie moved to his side. “He’s been planning this for months, Eliot. This wasn’t about spectacle. The declaration was just a switch. The system’s already live.”

Ashcombe, overhearing, turned with a sharpness that bordered on something more primal. “Exactly. The speech wasn’t the revolution. It was the public key to unlock the private one.”

He tapped something, and a large rendering of Manchester’s interlinked DAOs bloomed into view—like a digital nervous system. Most of it gleamed with coherence, but a few lines were now blinking orange, then red.

Ashcombe muttered under his breath. “Their architecture’s adaptive. Local fallback. Peer repair. We have to break rhythm.”

A coder next to him said, “We can simulate a mass rebase on the consensus ledger—if we can spoof node divergence, we can force human arbitration.”

Ashcombe nodded. “Perfect. Drop it into the maintenance feed. Push a Lattice shell patch—low-level enough that it pings as an update. Then make it glitch.”

He turned again to Eliot, calmer now, but not less intense.

“You don’t dismantle a DAO from above. You kill its timing. Its certainty. If we can turn automation into doubt, Manchester collapses under the weight of its own momentum.”

The screen now pulsed with error symbols, like blood from a wounded beast.

Outside, in the darkening fields of the festival, the crowds were still celebrating or reeling. In the tent, something darker was underway—surgical warfare, precision chaos.

It was Charlotte who finally whispered, staring at the screen: “Sometimes years happen in days…”

Sophie broke the silence. “We’re not in a contest of cities anymore. This… this is a civilisational fork.”

The air inside the tent had thickened. The glowing interface of the Manchester DAO stack flickered across the curved screen, lines of connection like neurons pulsing in real time. Dozens of node streams, synchronised by internal clocks and consensus protocols, each moving too fast to tamper with directly—until now.

“They’ve built it like a hive,” muttered one of the coders, a woman with a Glasgow accent and silver piercings along her jawline. “But if you disrupt the pheromone trail, the ants don’t know where to go.”

“Or who they are,” Ashcombe added, half-under his breath. He was watching a blinking hexagonal cluster at the core of the node map. “They sync every twenty-two seconds. That’s the pulse. If we can send a conflicting pulse half a second ahead, enough to get *half* the system out of rhythm…”

He trailed off.

Another coder spoke up, younger, nervous but bright-eyed. “Wait. What if we insert a spanner through the timestamp metadata? Not to crash it, but to create conflict. If we simulate a minor fork in the Lattice chain, two versions of truth would exist—both valid, but only one can be picked.”

“You want to force a *split*,” someone whispered.

Ashcombe looked at the map. “It’s elegant,” he said. “If the chain forks under low-level consensus and both strands remain live… the nodes will flag for arbitration. Human arbitration.”

He turned to Eliot. “Which means they’ll have to *think*. They’ll have to *vote*. And that changes everything. The machines won’t run them anymore—they’ll have to run the machines.”

Sophie leaned closer, still watching the flashing architecture. “And until they vote—?”

Ashcombe replied, “Until they vote, Manchester doesn’t *move*.”

He turned back to his team. “Do it. Simulate a phantom fork on the Mesh layer. Echo it across three node clusters. Don’t break anything. Just… confuse it.”

Fingers flew across keyboards. Scripts were written in silence. One coder, barefoot, was dancing slightly in place, humming an old folk tune like a ritual.

Sophie watched the screen. “Are you sure they won’t just reset the system?”

“They can’t,” the coder said, not looking up. “Resets require quorum. And if the system doesn’t know which quorum is real…”

“…it’ll freeze,” Eliot finished, almost in awe.

A low tone filled the tent. One of the displays turned gold, then shimmered with a cascading effect—like sand tumbling through a prism.

Ashcombe exhaled. “There it goes.”

“Lattice Layer 3 divergence has begun,” another murmured.

Outside, the wind had picked up. The great Agora glowed across the ridge, pulsing with music, light, and debate. Nobody out there yet knew that, in this tent on the edge of it all, the nervous system of Manchester had just been forced to blink.

Ashcombe’s eyes remained on the map. “The age of automation,” he said quietly, “only lasts until someone makes the machines *ask questions*.”

Eliot sat down, suddenly exhausted. “So now what?”

Ashcombe didn’t look away from the screen.

“Now we see if they can still think without the machine.”

Sophie’s phone buzzed with a series of encrypted messages. She glanced at the screen, her eyes scanning the line from Paul:

“He knows. Thorne knows. He’s already countering. He’s seen the fork attempt. He’s rerouting the nodes. He’s pissed.”

Before she could speak, Eliot’s phone chimed next. Then again. Then again.

Ashcombe was still at the terminal, watching the diverging node streams with fierce concentration. But Sophie turned to Eliot. “It’s Paul. Thorne’s clocked it. He’s dumping SheffCoin.”

Eliot froze. “Dumping it—what?”

Another message lit up on his interface. Then another, this time flagged by the Bank’s internal alert system.

MARKET ALERT: VOLUME SPIKE DETECTED
LARGE POSITION LIQUIDATION IN SHEFFCOIN FROM KNOWN WALLET: THORNE–M1
PRICE DOWN 11.6% AND FALLING

Eliot’s blood ran cold. “He’s crashing the currency.”

“Retaliation,” Sophie muttered. “He thinks its you trying to crash the DAO’s. He’s tanking the economy to collapse confidence. Paul gave him his holdings—he’s unloading them in bulk.”

Ashcombe turned his head, slowly. “He’s trying to start a bank run.”

“No,” Eliot whispered, “he’s starting a war.”

There was movement on Ashcombe’s screen—numbers cascading, green turning red. Some of the SheffCoin liquidity pools were being overwhelmed. Algorithmic traders were scrambling to rebalance against a sudden, deep sell-off. The markets hadn’t anticipated this, they didn’t know Ashcombe was trying to break their models in the first place. This was now war.

The problem wasn’t the total volume—Sheffield had strong reserves. The problem was *optics.*

The trust signal.

If people believed Thorne knew something—believed this was the beginning of a flight from SheffCoin—then faith would shatter. The cultural bank built on soft trust was being tested with hard warfare.

Sophie read another incoming message. “Some of the Manchester DAOs are now manually reverting protocols. Thorne’s seen the fork and told his teams to abandon the consensus automated model and start direct overrides.”

“Smart,” Ashcombe said, teeth clenched. “Stupid. But smart.”

Eliot stood up, his mind spinning. “If the price drops too far—if it collapses—we’re not talking about a blip. This is the whole city’s liquidity base.”

“I can buffer with some bitcoin reserves,” said Ashcombe, “but not indefinitely. Not if he’s dumping and spreading panic.”

“I need to act,” Eliot said, already thinking. “I need to speak. Reassure the city. Explain what’s happening.”

“Explain what?” Sophie said. “That we’re in the middle of a civil monetary war?”

Eliot paced.

“No,” he said finally. “That we’re in the middle of *a test.* That currency is a story—and the only way you lose is if you stop believing in your own story.”

Ashcombe looked back at the lattice map. One node blinked. Then two.

“If he’s going nuclear,” Ashcombe said softly, “we have to decide now—are we going to stabilise... or escalate?”

Outside, the glow of the Agora continued, the great festival still alive with light and debate. But in this tent, something else had begun: the first true moment of economic conflict, fought not with weapons, but with networks, liquidity, and code.

And the question, hanging between them like static in the air: Was this a currency… or a battleground?

Ashcombe’s eyes flicked from screen to screen, lines of code streaming like blood vessels on black. His tone shifted — clipped now, commander-sharp.

“We have enough bitcoin in cold reserves to buffer SheffCoin’s fall for now. But we’ll need coordinated intervention.”

He turned to Luna. “Price shielding. Target all public liquidity pools and issue bid walls. Now.”

Without a word, Luna lifted two phones to her ears, typing with both thumbs at once, eyes locked on a separate terminal.

Ashcombe swung around. “Daniel.”

Daniel, still catching up to the room’s gravity, blinked. “Yeah?”

“Grid infrastructure in Manchester. You said you’ve been poking at redundancies — is it vulnerable to load variation?”

Daniel hesitated. “They’ve hardened it. But there’s one loop we mapped from the Peak side, routing overflow through a redundant switching station. It’s not meant for industrial throughput—more like consumer supply. If we overload it, it’ll trip and force a reset cycle.”

Ashcombe nodded once. “Prepare the attack parameters. I don’t want the city dark. Just confused.”

Daniel’s fingers tapped the side of a portable interface clipped to his belt.

Eliot stared down at his wrist display.

SheffCoin: -17.3%
Currency issuance: ACTIVATED
Liquidity injection: IN PROCESS

“Shit,” Eliot said. “Currency issuance. It’s already gone through.”

“Then you better fight back,” Ashcombe said grimly.

Eliot turned to Sophie, who had already risen.

“My laptop,” he said. “Go. Run.”

She was gone before he’d finished the sentence.

Around them, the air in the tent thickened — not with heat, but with presence. With movement. Everywhere, the Kommune’s engineers, philosophers, traders were working — lines of code fluttering like pennants, dials glowing red, network branches flaring across the internal lattice like veins carrying light.

A war had begun. Culture and code — forged into a single counterstrike.

Chapter 16:

From the ridge above the Helix Pavilion, the valley glowed with activity. Drones zipped like fireflies between scaffolds of light. The meshnet trembled. A new kind of war was underway — invisible, total, algorithmic.

In a secure corner of the Peak Agora, Eliot hunched over his laptop besides Samuel Ashcombe. Their screens pulsed with real-time metrics: price volatility, trade volume, validator pings, node velocity. They weren’t just observers now. They were contenders.

Three networks. Three models. One unfolding moment.

“We’re going to try cutting a subnet in five minutes,” Samuel muttered. “They’ll lose coordination across sector four of the DAO web. It won’t crash them but all the trams in Old Trafford will have to be manually driven.”

Eliot’s hands hovered over his keyboard. “That’ll give us time. If I can reweight the SheffCoin reserves back into bitcoin, we can stablise price.” Eliot’s phone was blowing up, half of Sheffield was blowing up. The whole city was awake. He sent a simple message to a group of industrialists in Sheffield, which he hoped would get out to everybody:

In deep. Lots going on behind the scenes. Bank is safe. If you can, spend tonight bringing in as much Sheffcoin as possible and hold currency level. Will explain later.

Inside the Sheffield command tent, Sophie dropped Eliot’s second device into his lap. “They’re trying to dump again. 100,000 SheffCoin on the external exchanges. It's coordinated.”

“I’ve seen it,” Eliot said, calmly. “Let them try.”

The screen pulsed. Then again. Inbound transaction: **BANK-ISSUED RESERVES INITIATED**.

Ashcombe stood, arms folded, as a third map bloomed into view — a lattice overlay of Manchester’s economic architecture.

“We’ve isolated two more proof-of-authority nodes,” he said. “If we fracture those, their manufacturing flow has to route through analogue arbitration. Industry will grind to a holt.”

In the steel-and-glass monolith that was Manchester Core Node One, Alexander Thorne stood surrounded by the flicker and roar of heat-sink towers. Everything vibrated with the hum of overclocked machines. The city’s decentralised machinery — once seamless and automatic — now sputtered into something older, heavier: manual relay.

“Packet twelve-jay to Sector Fourteen. Manually log it,” barked Thorne.

His team — twenty engineers and cypher-technicians — sat under brutal white light, hands flying across keyboards. Everywhere, on plasma panels and scrolling feeds: THORNE RETURNED, LATTICE COMPROMISED, PACKET FAILURES: 23%.

A terminal pinged.

> Notification: “SheffCoin floor holding. Counter-burn detected.”

Thorne didn’t flinch. “Increase sell-side pressure. Route Bitcoin through swaps to buy more SheffCoin. Get our contacts in New York to short the currency.”

His financial architect, **Camila Vey**, turned. “That’s ten more billion in satoshis gone. We’re draining faster than we projected.”

“I’m not trying to outlast,” Thorne said coolly. “I’m trying to annihilate.”

Screens glowed with a new colour: crimson.

Another alert:

> **CPU USE: 78%**
> **ATTACK VECTOR INITIALISED: LATTICE CORE.**

Camila’s eyes widened. “You’re doing it? A 51% attack?”

Thorne nodded once. “The Kommunes built their palace on proof-of-work. I’ll simply outwork them. I’ll salt the ground.”

But outside the glass walls, Manchester slowed. Autonomous vehicles drifted into stations. City lighting flickered. Comm systems throttled. Not because they’d failed — but because their communications were being intercepted and every last cycle was being rerouted, every piece of CPU usage was coopted.

Across the core zone, the city’s entire computational capacity surged toward one act of war: to corrupt the Lattice Protocol. To render the Kommunes’ sacred infrastructure mathematically untrustworthy.

In a side room, Connor Tate was directing fallback operations.

“Keep essentials on analogue. Food logistics, traffic routing. We’ve got a few hours before slowdown becomes civil unrest.”

Thorne, hair slicked with sweat, spoke without turning. “This isn’t a civic moment. It’s existential.”

“Yeah,” Connor muttered. “For all of us.”

A final screen lit up in bold:

> **LATTICE NETWORK: HASH RATE UNDER THRESHOLD. CONSENSUS UNSTABLE.**

It had begun. Thorne didn’t smile. But he stood taller.

“Tell Sheffield,” he said, “they were warned.”

The tent crackled with heat, not from fire, but from stress.

Outside, the festival's last embers drifted into the air — glowing paper lanterns and bio-lighting displays — but here, in the war-room tent of the High Peak Kommune, things were entering their most perilous phase.

Ashcombe leaned forward, the blue light from three monitors bathing his face in a ghostly halo.

“He’s doing it,” Luna whispered. “He’s actually doing it.”

Eliot's eyes flicked to the monitor. He recognised the signature straight away. Hashrate approaching threshold. Block propagation flooding. Consensus collapsing. Manchester had thrown its entire computational empire into a hostile 51% attack on the Lattice.

“If he takes Lattice,” Ashcombe murmured, “he takes out everything we’ve built, the whole Kommune network. The reputation, the trust, the tokens — gone. We’re hollowed out.”

Someone at the back of the tent swore. Loudly.

Eliot exhaled sharply. “What about Sheffield?”

Ashcombe looked up. “You mean—?”

“If the collectives secure SheffCoin — burn bitcoin to hold the currency — I’ll divert as much of Sheffield’s free computation grid towards Lattice support. Every available core in our networked systems. We’ll match his attack.”

“You’ll need a lot of computation power,” one of the Kommune engineers whispered.

Eliot nodded grimly. “Sheffield’s not all artisanal bread. We’ve got some power.”

Ashcombe held out his hand, palm flat. Eliot clasped it. The agreement was made.

Then Luna spun around from her screen. “Wait. There’s more.”

Everyone turned to look.

“We think we’ve got someone inside the Manchester DAO stack,” she said. “One of ours — embedded in one of the DAO maintainers' personal assistant pools. He’s in.”

Ashcombe’s face turned blank. He sat down slowly.

“He’s offered to inject a Trojan horse,” Luna said. “Not ransomware. Not malware. Just... uncertainty. Quiet. Structural slowness. Random delays. A drift in consensus messages. The illusion of software fault.”

Eliot frowned. “So they’ll think the DAO infrastructure is breaking down under its own weight. Spend manual time trying to find it?”

Ashcombe looked over, unsure. “It could help.”

There was silence. The fans in the computers were the only sound, spinning faster, like a rising wind.

Then Eliot said, “Do it.”

Ashcombe turned back to the screen. Luna began typing.

"Deploying uncertainty," she muttered, with a grin.

Eliot sat at the central terminal, coat discarded, eyes narrowed, sweat clinging to his brow. He coordinated Sheffield’s grid response in real time. Every 3D printer, every car factory, every home workstation — anything with GPU power was being pulled into the defensive mesh.

The Bank’s internal AI, Merton, pulsed in the background, rerouting excess energy from branches, allocating redundant server farms towards increasing the hashrate for the lattice protocol upkeep.

“Transmission stable,” came one voice.

“Block weight resisting brute force,” said another.

Ashcombe stood a few paces away, arms folded, scanning the external signals. His expression was unreadable. Then he said it:

> “We’re in a Mexican standoff now.”

Eliot glanced up.

Ashcombe continued, voice low and even: “I could cut support to SheffCoin. Your whole monetary apparatus would collapse as soon as I drop buying support. Collapse the coin. I could come to terms with Thorne. Fold Sheffield into Kommunes stack. Build a unified economic machine east of Manchester.”

Eliot stood up slowly, his tone iron. “And I could tell Thorne you initiated the counter-attack on his DAOs. Pull our support from Lattice. Leave the Kommunes floating. Dead in the water.”

Their eyes locked. Mutual destruction, three times over.

Then a familiar voice cut through the tension like a blade.

“Gentlemen,” said Lord Rutherford, entering the tent in a wool coat and pale-blue cravat, looking entirely out of place amid the flickering light. “I say this with all due respect—must we solve this with such... brutish digitalism? Whatever happened to settling things like gentlemen?”

Ashcombe turned, his face drawn and serious. “Because someone has to break.”

He pointed to the screen. “Right now, Manchester is running on manual override, their networks barely held together by spreadsheets and caffeine. Our guy inside might still have insider access, but Thorne’s smart — he’ll isolate the corruption sooner or later.”

He turned to Eliot. “And you’ve thrown your city into economic shock to support a philosophical network. How long can you hold your people’s trust if this goes on another day?”

Eliot didn’t answer. His thoughts were already fracturing toward contingency.

“We’re holding,” he said finally, “but barely. Sheffield’s running hot. If this burns too long, there won’t be much Sheffcoin left to save.”

Silence hung.

Ashcombe stepped closer, voice hushed.“He declared sovereignty, Eliot. And now he’s trying to take both yours and mine’s entire infrastructure. You said it yourself — fiat money has a soft core. But what about the code we live by? What happens when that turns hard and breaks?”

Eliot stared at the screen again, watching as one node after another in Sheffield reported successful validation against Lattice. For now, the tide was even.

But equilibrium couldn’t last.

Ashcombe paced the edge of the tent, eyes flicking between the lattice flowcharts and the thermals of Manchester’s grid. Eliot sat forward, fingers knitted beneath his chin, staring through the layers of code as if something vital might reveal itself.

“The truth is,” Eliot said quietly, “we *both* need each other.”

Ashcombe stopped. “Go on.”

Eliot stood. “If either one of us had the power to take Thorne out alone, we’d have done it by now. But the fact we’re here, holding this line together—me with a bank, you with a decentralised nation—that says something. We’re not rivals. We’re the counterbalance. Without each other, he wins.”

Ashcombe studied him. Then, slowly, nodded.

At the back of the tent, Lord Rutherford exhaled into the dim light. He held up his phone, casting a pale glow over his sharp features.

“It’s happening,” he said. “There’s a Wikipedia article. *‘The Tri-City Conflict.’* Someone’s writing it in real time. History’s watching us.”

They all paused. Outside, the night howled with servers and tension, with news anchors scrambling to update scripts and teenagers live-streaming over burning hashtags.

Ashcombe stepped forward.

“You understand what this means?”

Eliot looked him square in the eye. “Yes. The philosopher can’t win alone. Nor can the sovereign individual. But if either the lattice survives or the bank survives. We’ll both win.”

“*Sic semper tyrannis,*” Samuel said.

“*Sic semper tyrannis,*” Eliot repeated.

Ashcombe’s expression didn’t shift—but for the first time that night, he allowed himself a breath.

Around them, the tent pulsed with new data. The pressure on Sheffield’s coin had stabilised. The Lattice protocol was holding. The nodes in Manchester were flickering erratically—but Thorne’s empire still stood.

Inside the core operations chamber of Manchester’s central tower—dubbed Manchester Core Node One—Alexander Thorne stood before a monolithic wall of code, a living tapestry of pulsing data and recursive logic. The heat of a dozen processors filled the space with a low hum, and the light from the floor-to-ceiling interfaces flickered across his face like firelight on an old prophet’s cheekbones.

Connor Tate stood nearby, a cold flask of nutrient fluid in one hand, eyes bloodshot, neck tense.

Thorne’s voice was low. “You say the DAOs are still functioning?”

Tate nodded. “Most of them. We’ve manually rerouted around the corrupted nodes. They’re limping, but operational.”

“But the memory leak—”

“Still there. We've traced three separate anomalies. Something inside the permission matrix is warping the transaction logic. It doesn’t crash. It *waits*.”

Thorne didn’t blink.

“No natural system does that,” he said. “Our engineers would’ve caught it. They’ve run a thousand simulations. *Something* is designed to mimic a vulnerability.”

“An infiltrator,” Tate said.

Thorne nodded once. “Find it.”

He stepped back from the interface and exhaled through his nose. “They don’t just want to take us offline. They want *doubt*. If one person starts questioning the DAOs, the rest will follow. This isn’t code—they’ve turned it into a *story*. A virus of trust.”

Tate rubbed his temples. “We can hold for a few more hours. But the nodes are fluctuating under this much load. If they maintain CPU pressure from Sheffield and the Kommune, we’ll start losing sectors.”

Thorne paced. “Can we purchase excess compute?”

“Temporarily. Maybe two or three hours of industrial-grade surplus. Singapore’s liquidating some of their reserve cloud capacity. We could outbid the Kommune if we act fast.”

“But it’ll cost.”

“Everything,” Tate said grimly. “Our last hard reserves of Bitcoin. Burn it all on the grid war.”

Thorne looked up at the vault of Manchester’s neon-lit ceiling. Below them, the city was still churning, pulsing, holding. Barely. And Eliot Ashton—dreamer of currencies—had made his move. Ashcombe, too. Like wolves.

Tate handed him a tablet. “Just say the word.”

Thorne didn’t take it immediately. He was thinking—calculating.

“We hit them now,” he said, “we have a shot. If we don’t—we lose Manchester.”

Thorne took the tablet.

And paused.

He looked at Tate. “We need a decoy. Some distraction. Something that shakes the trust in their new alliance. Because if they believe they’ve already won... they’ll relax.”

Tate nodded slowly. “What are you thinking?”

Thorne’s eyes narrowed. “Let’s give them a broadcast.”

In a matter of minutes, Thorne’s broadcast system was primed. The engineers in Manchester Core rerouted a direct feed through multiple obfuscated relay points. The broadcast wouldn’t come from Manchester—it would appear from nowhere. Anonymous. Ubiquitous. Undeniable.

Across every screen at the festival—projection domes, augmented glasses, floating holo-displays above the Agora and embedded retinal feeds—the signal cut through the hum of the day like a blade through silk.

A voice. Male. Calm. Neutral. Digitally warped, but unmistakably articulate.

> *“To the people of Sheffield. To the Kommunes. To the arbiters of faith, culture, and chaos.*
>
> *This is not a war. It is a mirror.*
>
> *What you call sovereignty is control. What you call decentralisation is fragmentation. What you call freedom is chaos dressed in finer words.*
>
> *Manchester does not attack. It absorbs. It adapts. It builds.*
>
> *While you argue philosophy, we move steel. While you recite Goethe, we write code. While you claim to build meaning—we build machines that last.”*

On screen, archival footage of Manchester’s rolling factories, molten chrome pouring into alloy moulds, carbon-fibre limbs crafted for exosuits. Then the visual began to shift—abstracted simulations of Sheffield’s freeform co-ops, people sitting in circles, artworks in progress, disjointed conversations, laughter.

> *“We do not fear your dreams. But dreams, untethered, will always drown beneath reality.”*

The screen shimmered again.

> *"Thorne is not your enemy. He is the inevitability of scale."*

And then it was over. No signature. No traceable IP. Just the silence of thousands processing.

Inside the strategy tent near the outer rim of the festival's encrypted zone, Eliot Ashton threw his tablet down onto the table, the glowing residue of the transmission still fading. "Bastard," he muttered.

Ashcombe was quiet, arms folded. Luna had paused mid-keystroke.

"He's trying to reframe the conflict," she said. "Break morale."

Ashcombe tapped his temple. "The tone is deliberate. Detached. He's not attacking us. He's trying to unmoor the people around us—fracture trust."

Eliot ran a hand through his hair. "We spent a year building the case for SheffCoin as *culture*. Building trust, time to see how well we did."

"And trust," said Charlotte from the corner, "doesn't survive a narrative collapse."

Ashcombe's expression hardened. "We can still win. We hold the Lattice. Sheffield's minting power remains stable. Our grid is holding back the 51% attempt."

"But now we don't have Thorne's gravitas," Eliot said.

"No," Ashcombe replied. "Now we look *human*. That's not a weakness. It's our last advantage."

In the quiet hum that followed Thorne's broadcast, as the final words dissolved into the soft static of tension and ambient techno drifting from another stage, Daniel leaned against the frame of the tent and said, almost too casually:

> "The old-fashioned way is still the best way."

The room turned. Eliot, Ashcombe, Luna, Charlotte—everyone looked at him.

Daniel shrugged and stepped forward.

> "You want the system down? I know how to do it. There's a nuclear power station out past Barton Moss. Edge of Manchester's grid. Not the full reactor, obviously. But there's a legacy substation that bridges the older grid infrastructure with the new automated protocols. I did some systems work for a guy there—patching firmware on legacy nodes, hacking around security holes."

Ashcombe narrowed his eyes. "You're saying...?"

> "I'm saying if you cut that node," Daniel continued, "Manchester drops into brownout. A cascade fault. You don't need to bomb a city anymore—you pull the plug. Their automated balance systems go blind. Their AI control layers trip. Everything resets to manual control. Which, right now, they're stretched too thin to manage."

Luna tapped on her keyboard. "If what you're saying is true, we could pull their entire infrastructure offline for... six minutes. Maybe seven. That's enough to crash the mempools."

Ashcombe looked at Eliot. "He's not wrong."

Eliot met Daniel's gaze.

Daniel added, “I’d need access. Someone to cover me. Somebody to drive me in. It’s an old relay tower near Barton. Buried behind a converted logistics depot now. But I can get in. I’ll need to cut one high-voltage line. It’s crude. Dirty. But it’ll work.”

Eliot didn’t hesitate. “I’ll come.”

Luna’s voice was firm behind him. “I will drive.”

Ashcombe, for once, didn’t object. He stepped back, running mental contingencies through his head. Ashcombe walked to Daniel, handed him a small silver device.

“A biometric disabler,” he said. “If they’ve locked that part of the system with retinal or voice scan, this might still spoof it.”

Daniel pocketed it. “Nice.”

Eliot picked up his jacket. “This is it, then.”

Ashcombe nodded. “Make it quick. And if it doesn’t work...”

He didn’t finish the sentence.

The three of them—Daniel, Eliot, and Luna—slipped out of the tent as the war of code raged invisibly above them, and the future of three cities hung in the hum of wires.

Chapter 17:

From the edge of the encampment, the ground vibrated faintly — not with sound, but with presence. One of the speeders emerged from the treeline like a blade of night, darkly iridescent and shaped like cut obsidian. It shimmered with refracted hues that slid across its surface like oil in water. Sleek, angular, whisper-quiet — a thing not driven, but summoned.

Luna stepped out from the shadows, keys in hand, hair pulled back with ritual precision. Daniel checked the toolkits slung across his back: wire cutters, custom chips, pulse dampeners. “I’ll get us into the substation,” he said, matter-of-fact. “Trip the right lines and Manchester loses half the grid. Maybe all of it.”

Eliot nodded once. “We’ll come. If this is the move, it’s now.”

Luna was already walking toward the speeder, pulling on a jacket. “We’ll need eyes, not just hands.”

Daniel ran his fingers along the side of the craft. “No markings. No tags. They never existed.”

And then they were off — whispering into the darkness, banking low across the hills like starlings on signal. The night below was electric, unaware.

Inside the speeder, the air was cool and silent — unnaturally so. The cockpit was cocooned in smooth, matte-black panels, the dashboard lit with soft amber glyphs and neon-blue arcs. Every sound was absorbed into the design; even the hum of the hydrogen fuel cell was more sensed than heard. Eliot sat beside Luna, watching her work — her hands moving across controls like a concert pianist, exact and unhurried.

“These are new,” she said, not looking up. “Straight from a private factory in Texas. Custom-built. No serials, no trackers. Just for the festival.”

The seats adjusted automatically to their forms, the material conforming like memory foam stitched with carbon thread. Behind them, Eliot and Daniel strapped in without speaking, absorbed in their own focus. The speeder weaved with preternatural agility through the narrow canyons and ridgelines of the Peaks — each shift in terrain mirrored by a seamless motion in flight, a ripple through the dark.

“Stealth-embedded design,” Luna added. “Radar doesn't see them. Drones can’t track them. There’s only a handful on Earth. If it wasn’t for Samuel...”

She didn’t finish.

As they crested a ridge overlooking the Manchester basin, Luna flicked a bone-white switch above her. A faint shimmer passed over the windshield. Outside, the landscape wavered, then sharpened.

“Invisibility shield,” she said. “Drains the hydrogen cell like hell — I’ve got a twenty-minute window before we’re visible again. We’ll get in. You’ll get out. If everything goes right...”

“We’ll know,” Daniel finished, leaning forward. “When the lights go out.”

Eliot’s voice broke the silence. “Did Samuel plan this the whole time?”

Luna adjusted their altitude, sweeping low beneath a lattice of gantries that stretched like skeletal fingers over the outskirts of Manchester. The horizon pulsed with the pale energy signatures of towers, cooling stacks, digital firewalls mapped into the skyline. The air around them grew denser with interference, like they were flying into the heart of a system trying to forget it still had walls.

“I’ve never been sure with Samuel,” Luna said finally, her voice low over the quiet hum of the cabin. “Whether he’s five steps ahead of the world or just brilliant at improvising. But he’s the cleverest person I’ve ever met. Sometimes I think even he doesn’t know if he’s orchestrating or reacting. That’s what makes him a genius.”

Eliot said nothing for a long time. The interior lights cast soft glows across the clean glass of the canopy, washing his face in warm, reflective pulses. Outside, Manchester began to glint with its strange post-industrial glory — towers like prisms, roads like arteries of light, the city an organism fuelled by code, belief, and power.

A thought passed through him like a slow voltage.

He was no longer playing economics. He was playing strategy. Real strategy.

And if he were the kind of player Ashcombe was — or worse, the kind of blade Thorne forged himself into — this would be the moment. The ideal moment. With Samuel focused on dismantling Manchester’s DAOs, his CPU allocation overcommitted, the political ground shifting beneath them — this would be the time to strike. To betray. To sever the alliance and move to dominate both Sheffield’s cultural bloc and the Lattice economy.

He could do it.

He knew the plays. Knew how it could be sold. Freedom, necessity, pragmatic responsibility.

But something in him recoiled — not from the act, but from the man he would have to become. He *was* more Ashcombe than Thorne.

Privately, he scorned himself. For his idealism. For his restraint. For still believing that systems could be made moral rather than simply manipulated. That the world could be bent without being broken. That economics could be a civic art.

Sheffield needed to win. But it had to win in the light. Or it wasn't Sheffield.

He looked again through the glass — at Manchester, at the towers and domes and ghost-lit streets.

"Time to reign Manchester in," he said, mostly to himself.

"Yeah," Luna murmured, throttling them down. "Time to turn the lights off."

The speeder dipped low, slipping through a narrow ravine like a ghost — the invisibility shield humming just above audibility, eating through hydrogen like fire through dry grass. The readouts dimmed to red. Luna checked them with a flick of her wrist.

"We've got twenty minutes at most on shielded mode," she said. "I'll have to park us as close to the outer grid as I can. You'll have maybe ten on the ground before Manchester notices something."

Daniel, quiet until now, cracked his knuckles. "That'll be enough. It's an old substation. I helped rewire one of the load-balancers last year. There's a choke point in the northeast switchhouse. You overload that, and it cascades. Half the outer loop goes dark. Long enough to mess up the cooling algorithms. Long enough to break the rhythm."

Eliot nodded. "Just make sure we don't end up on a newsfeed."

Luna smirked. "These speeders don't exist. The cameras won't know where to look."

The ravine opened into a shallow basin. Ahead, like a relic from another world, stood the cooling stacks of the outer grid: squat, brutalist domes laced with sensors and scaffolds. No lights. No movement. Just the subtle thrum of the grid, feeding life into the body of Manchester.

They hovered low above a service entrance — a slab of steel with a retinal scanner and no number. Luna killed the shield. The speeder reappeared in the air like something conjured. She dropped it in perfect silence.

Eliot stepped out, the dry wind brushing his coat. Sophie beside him, Charlotte loading gear onto her back. Daniel jumped down last, already scanning the wall with a palm-sized device that blinked blue.

"You sure you can get in?" Eliot asked.

Daniel didn't answer. The lock hissed open.

Luna whistled. "You really do know your way around broken things."

Daniel looked back. "It's not broken. Just misaligned. Everything in Manchester's just waiting for someone to tilt it slightly sideways."

Inside, the hallway was cold, humming with systems. Pipes. Cables. The nerve cluster of a machine pretending to be a city.

Eliot turned one last time toward the sky — a faint line of signal drones humming overhead, carrying some unknown message. Somewhere in that signal was Thorne. Somewhere in those towers, a man was calculating exactly how much power he could burn before the world burned with him.

Eliot turned back into the darkness.

They were inside now.

And the countdown had begun.

The hallway narrowed as they descended, a utilitarian artery of reinforced steel and graphene-laced composites. Emergency strips pulsed dimly underfoot. Daniel led the way, checking schematics on his tablet and pointing to junctions and bypass relays. Sophie trailed close behind Eliot, their footsteps muffled by the hum of buried energy.

“The substation’s central node is just two levels down,” Daniel whispered. “But the override panel is manual. No remote access, not even for me. We’ll need to trigger a full system conflict to force a reset.”

“Will that be enough?” Charlotte asked. “To shut the whole grid?”

“No,” Daniel said. “But it’ll desynchronise the power arbitration. Their CPUs will glitch trying to realign everything. The automation won’t know how to prioritise. It’s like pulling the drumbeat from a marching army — they’ll start walking into each other.”

Sophie exhaled. “And that’s what collapses the DAO?”

Eliot, walking quietly, murmured: “That’s what cracks its timing. In systems like Manchester, time is law.”

They passed a rust-locked door with an old inspection plate still visible under grime: *Northeast Load Bridge C7 – Critical Access Only.* Daniel paused, pried open a maintenance panel, and began working a series of copper switches and magnet coils.

A low *clunk*. The door hissed open. Beyond it, a vaulted control chamber — like the hollow heart of a cathedral — blinked alive. Consoles lined the perimeter. In the centre, a set of interlinked relays and cooled capacitors glowed with a faint blue throb, like veins of the machine itself.

Daniel jogged forward, unpacking a small device from his kit — a smooth black block with no discernible features save a single red switch. He placed it at the relay junction.

“This is a driver,” he said. “Reroutes the calibration voltage and injects noise into the frequency mesh. Once I flip it, they’ll get ten different voltages reporting from one node. The grid will trip out trying to make sense of it.”

He flicked the switch.

Instantly, the room dimmed. The low hum of power began to stutter — like a heartbeat faltering. On the wall monitors, red began to spread. “Critical Fault,” they blinked. “Sector Misalignment. Arbitration Conflict.”

Above them, lights flickered.

Luna gasped. “Is that—it?”

“Yes,” Eliot said.

The sound came slowly at first — like wind through steel, then a long metallic *groan*. The power systems of Manchester were beginning to unsync. The great order was losing its rhythm.

Luna's communicator lit up. She glanced at it and then grinned. "Samuel says their DAOs just hiccupped. Fifty-seven percent of their smart contracts just froze for manual arbitration."

Eliot's voice was calm. "Now the counterstrike begins."

Just then, a deep vibration shuddered through the floor.

Charlotte spun. "What was that?"

Luna's face changed. "We need to leave. Now."

Their speeder roared low across the darkening moor, its engines whispering through the heather and gritstone. Beneath them, the hills of Manchester's edge glimmered faintly with disjointed power — rolling blackouts cascading in uneven waves across the city's arteries. The control lights had gone red across the DAO command hubs, and Luna's comms were filling with updates: arbitration delays, frozen contract chains, emergency human overrides tripping over each other in the absence of automation.

"Sheffield nodes are stable," came a voice from the Bank. "Manchester arbitration collapsed by 31%. Systems are bottlenecked at the arbitration stack. No failovers. They're choking on logic loops."

Eliot closed his eyes briefly. The dominoes were falling.

But the calm didn't last.

From above — a shrill screech of air and velocity.

SHHHHRRRRK.

Three sleek silhouettes ripped through the dusk like sharks through water. Their wings glistened with liquid chrome, bodies humming with anti-radar vibrations. Obsidian-burnished and engineered for maximum speed-to-thrust ratio. *Aetherwings*.

Luna saw them first.

"Shit," she hissed. "They're here."

Eliot twisted to look. "Those are Thorne's?"

"Well they're not going to be Sheffield's," Luna said grimly. "And they don't come in peace."

The speeder banked hard to the left, diving toward a narrow pass between two ridges. Eliot braced himself against the frame. Sophie gripped the dashboard.

"Are we visible?" Sophie called.

"Nearly," Luna muttered. "Invisibility shield's draining the hydrogen core. Less than two minutes left—then we're meat in the open."

"They know we're here," Eliot said, watching the aetherwings split formation, one arcing high, two falling in tight pursuit. "They're hunting."

"They don't need to see us," Daniel said from behind, "they'll pattern-track our heat trail."

Charlotte was already tapping coordinates into her display. "If we keep heading south by southwest, we might hit the ridge line before we're visible."

Luna was silent for a moment, jaw locked in concentration. Then:

“No good. That high aetherwing will spot the exhaust bloom from the incline. They’ll know where we crest.”

“They’ve got missiles,” Eliot said. “We’re sitting ducks.”

“Only if we stay predictable,” Luna replied.

With a savage jerk, she pulled the speeder into a dead drop, skimming a hidden gully that curved like a broken seam through the rocks. Stone tore past inches from the hull. The shield flickered, sputtered—then re-engaged.

“Eliot,” Luna said, voice low, “this is about to get ugly. If they hit, we die. This thing isn’t rated for impact.”

The aetherwings were adjusting. They’d spotted the glint — a micro-shimmer in the air where Luna’s shielding had glitched for a second. One of them dipped, wings twitching. Target lock.

A soft *bip* sounded on Luna’s console.

“Missile lock,” she said.

Sophie paled. “Can we jam it?”

“No,” Luna said. “But we can outrun it.”

Daniel laughed once — a hard, dry sound.

“They’re here for the kill,” Eliot muttered.

Luna nodded. “Let’s give them hell instead.”

And with that, the speeder shot forward like a loosed arrow — into the gorge, into the dusk, into the jaws of the machine they were fighting to unmake.

The speeder burst from the gorge like a bullet tearing through velvet — raw speed ripping across the shale as the invisibility shield finally guttered out. The last flicker of cover dropped, and with it, the full profile of their craft lit up like a flare in the sky. Heat trail exposed. Hull signature pinging. The aetherwings saw everything now.

And they were closing.

The first one, sleek and predatory, lined up behind them. Its winglets pulsed as the missile ports irised open. A red targeting vector blinked onto Luna’s console. They had seconds.

“Brace!” Luna shouted, slamming the speeder into a vicious jink that nearly sent them into a limestone outcrop.

Sophie screamed. Daniel held on.

Then—

A roar. A sonic crack.

Out of nowhere — two shapes tore across the sky from the north, low and fast and *angry*. Dark green with sharp white insignia. Swept-forward wings like the blade of a falcon, engines blazing with a strange blue-white pulse. The Tempest IVs. The RAF’s next-generation air fighters.

They moved like predators in a vacuum — silent until they weren’t. Then thunder.

One streaked between the speeder and the aetherwing, locking onto its heat signature with brutal precision. The other climbed and flipped, diving on the second wing from above in a screech of steel.

Flares. Countermeasures. Chaotic spirals.

The aetherwings scattered.

The Tempests didn’t pursue. Just sent a clear message in their fly-by — a line in the air, drawn by state power. You do not engage *here*. Not now.

Inside the speeder, the reaction was instant.

Eliot threw his head back and let out a yell. “Yes!”

Luna slammed the console. “Go on! Go on!”

Daniel laughed, almost hysterical. “The fucking RAF! The Royal Air Force!”

Sophie, white-faced but grinning, exhaled hard. “I thought we were gone.”

Behind them, in the burning gold of the evening light, the sky smouldered with contrails. A battle had been fought in silence. And for now, they had lived.

As the speeder skimmed low over the final ridge, its hydrogen fuel cell sputtering into safe mode, Eliot pulled out his phone, the screen cracked slightly from the turbulence.

A message from Samuel.

> *DAOs are going offline.*
> *Too much automation. No one knew what to do when the links broke.*
> *Manchester's whole system is collapsing under its own logic.*

Eliot stared at the words. A single blink. Then another. Relief didn't come — not yet. Only the sense of something massive disintegrating under the weight of its own ambition.

The speeder hissed as it touched down on the moorland near where both Eliot and Daniel recognised to be Bamford — no lights, no ceremony. Just scorched bracken and the sigh of the wind.

As the cockpit slid open, they stepped out, legs shaking slightly from the ride. The air smelled of grass and ozone.

And then — footfalls. Running.

Samuel was the first to arrive, coat flapping behind him, eyes wild with adrenaline. “You did it,” he said, breathless. “Their whole stack crumbled. They had built too much on too little human understanding. We just… tilted the structure when the power plant went down.”

Behind him came Sophie — not running, but *charging* through the scrub in her boots, shouting before she even reached them.

“Thorne’s been arrested!” she screamed. “They waited. Waited until the grid failed, until Manchester couldn’t respond. Then they moved in.”

She reached Eliot and gripped his arm.

“They took him. Outside one of the old industrial complexes. Just now. The State finally blinked.”

Eliot’s jaw tightened. “Is it real?”

“They’ve confirmed it,” Samuel said, looking at his own screen. “It’s all over. The feeds are exploding.”

A strange silence followed. Not one of peace — but of disorientation.

Daniel leaned against the side of the speeder, staring toward the lights flickering on the horizon.

“The age of DAOs…” he murmured, “...might be over.”

“No,” Eliot said quietly. “Not over. Just… no longer unbeatable. Manchester isn’t over. It will recover, but Thorne is gone.”

For Samuel and Eliot the ground beneath them was soft, damp from last night’s rain. The wind moved through the heather like a slow breath.

The night was thick with woodsmoke and laughter. Beneath the vast canvas of stars, the Bamford Kommune buzzed with rare electricity — not from any grid, but from human presence, from something hard-won and deeply felt.

A bonfire cracked in the centre of the clearing, its flames licking upwards in bursts of gold and orange. Around it, the inner circle of the great revolt had gathered — Eliot, Sophie, Charlotte, Luna, Samuel, Daniel — all seated on stone benches, driftwood logs, and hemp-woven mats. A long table of food stretched nearby: open-fire flatbreads, mushrooms charred in butter, bottles of dark beer passed around like relics.

They were all bone-tired and soot-streaked. But they were grinning.

Samuel stood up on a rock by the fire, a bottle of something sharp in his hand. “To the *fall of a tyrant*,” he declared. “A man who called himself sovereign. A man with *too much ego, too few CPUs and not enough soul.*”

They cheered. Sophie raised her glass, laughing as the firelight turned her hair to flame. “To the politics *of strange bedfellows,*” she added. “Economists and hackers, philosophers and saboteurs. Somehow we didn’t kill each other.”

Eliot sat quietly, watching the sparks spiral upward. He had barely spoken all evening, nursing a clay mug of something herbal and mildly hallucinogenic. Sophie leaned over to him, bumping his shoulder.

“You’re allowed to smile, you know,” she said.

“I am smiling,” he replied, deadpan.

“No, that’s brooding with better posture.”

He chuckled, finally, the tension in his spine softening.

Luna had rigged up a few solar-powered speakers, and some AI-generated jazz-folk hybrid played in soft waves. A few people had started dancing barefoot in the grass, high on the strange euphoria of history shifting just enough to breathe again.

Then, just before midnight, a car — a real one, petrol-powered, absurdly anachronistic — crawled up the gravel track.

“Who in God’s name still uses combustion?” Daniel muttered, standing to see.

From the passenger side stepped Lord Rutherford, looking like a lost Edwardian dropped into the aftermath of a revolution. He wore a tailored coat, a subtle military cut, and carried a bottle of Burgundy like it was a peace offering.

“Well,” he said, approaching the fire. “I thought I might see what victory looks like from this side of the wire.”

Samuel clapped him on the back and handed him a mushroom skewer.

“Lord Rutherford,” Eliot said, rising. “You’re just in time for the toasts.”

“Not now. I have to patch things up with the Cabinet Office. You planned this, Samuel didn’t you,” he said, giving a piercing look towards Samuel but perhaps with the hint of admiration. Samuel didn’t flinch. “Tonight, it seems you are the ones holding the realm together.”

He raised his bottle. “To those who fought the digital war, and lived to explain it to the historians.”

They drank.

For a few hours, in that hidden stretch of the Peak District, among old radicals and new philosophers, firelight and friends, there was no talk of DAOs or currency collapse or what came next. There was only the fragile, fleeting joy of *having done it*. Of still being here.

Later, Eliot would sit with Samuel on the edge of the hilltop, watching the lights of Sheffield flicker on the horizon.

“Do you think this is the start of something?” Eliot asked.

Samuel took a long breath, passing the bottle. “No,” he said. “This is *between* things. But it’s where all the beauty lives.”

But something had shifted. Something had *ended*.

And yet…

In a corner of South London, under neon lights and scaffolding shadows, a man sat in a cramped flat with the window open and a spiral-bound notebook on his knee. He was watching the same holograms, eyes narrowed, breath slow. He wasn’t surprised. He had written pages about it before it happened.

Jack Stone had always known the world would break open. He had just been waiting for the crack to appear.

Chapter 18:

Three months had passed since the Festival, but the ground had not stopped shaking.

The world that emerged from that extraordinary week was not one of resolution, but of entropic acceleration. The High Peak Kommunes, once a whispered anomaly in the upland margins, had exploded into global relevance. Since the announcement of their Digital Nation—a sovereign mesh of networked Kommunes, decentralised identity infrastructure, and voluntary citizenship—

membership had surged to over twelve million worldwide. From squatters in Buenos Aires to software architects in Helsinki, nodes and identities were forming. And with them, governance experiments that fluctuated between anarchic efficiency, aristocratic excellence, and ritualistic psychedelia.

Their capital, officially now termed High Peak One, remained concealed among the folds of gritstone moorland, its geography protected by a fog of VPN layers and physical remoteness. Samuel Ashcombe, largely silent since his announcement, remained an absent centre—a founder whose absence paradoxically amplified his mythos.

Meanwhile, Sheffield's monetary engine ticked forwards, slower than Eliot Ashton had hoped. His controversial Productivity-Linked monetary supply had flooded SheffCoin into the economy with the goal of creating a virtuous pressure—more currency, more work, more output. The cultural scene responded with a mix of fads and flashes: artisan bikes, immersive plays, a short-lived surge in neo-Gothic cafés here and a surge of building work there; the productivity gains were lopsided and inconsistent. The Bank's Allocation Board met weekly now, divided between bullish accelerators and cautious Rothbardians who feared inflation's slow poison.

Manchester, leaderless after Alexander Thorne's arrest for sedition, had not collapsed—but it had changed. Connor Tate, once Thorne's lieutenant and now de facto steward of the Manchester DAO system. He was more engineer than philosopher. Where Thorne saw destiny, Tate saw systems. Under his guidance, the city-state hardened further into an autonomous production engine. Massive fabrication towers were completed. Biohacking accelerators were spun up. Supply chains no longer recognised the concept of a weekend.

Thorne remained imprisoned somewhere in a government facility—no images released, no charges formally laid. Rumours swirled: a secret trial? Extradition to the US? An offer of reinstatement back into society under terms of bail? All speculation. What mattered was absence. The festival had ended with three sovereign visions; now only two men stood in the open air, but Manchester still turned like a machine.

It was into this widening uncertainty that Jack Stone emerged.

He had not been at the festival. He had not yet published his book. He was known only by those who traded links in encrypted chatrooms. But in some quarters—in circles where art still mattered, where tone and accent were still felt as deep as facts—he was being read.

Jack lived in South London, in a room above an old Quaker meeting house that had been repurposed as a philosophical laboratory. His obsessions were peculiar: grammar, aesthetics, sublimity, ontological linguists, and communal form. He did not care for productivity metrics, or token velocity, or proof-of-work based tokens. He cared about the word—the subtle ways that language shaped thought. He wrote essays on the second-person future-perfect as a revolutionary political device. He read philological maps of dialect drift and linked them to the success of slowly evolving communalism.

He had started a podcast, of course, but it was not popular. It was slow, long, and occasionally featured AI made Gregorian chants in tenses and registers Jack then spent hours trying to decipher. The AI forms of philological investigation he was putting through AI was too advanced, though he kept trying to make the next breakthrough.

Jack was not Sheffield. Nor was he Manchester. He was something else—an echo of a different kind of sovereignty. One that lived in collective language, not that of monetary policy.

Jack Stone didn't speak much to people these days—not in the real world. Conversations in London felt either too guarded or too performative, like everyone was waiting for the new rulebook to arrive but also terrified of being caught reading the wrong draft.

He stood by the window of his flat above the old Quaker meeting house, watching the first stirrings of city life below—couriers on e-bikes, a man pushing a pram with military precision, a girl with implants and a tote bag that simply read: 'Theory'.

London was in limbo. No new order. No consensus. The British state was still intact—issuing passports, funding the courts, collecting what taxes it could—but its sovereignty had been pierced. Just about rescued, but more hollow than before the festival. Many in London thought the state should not have allowed the festival, even if it had secured a pyrrhic victory. London was still state centric. Too much power located in London to allow the sort of Northern rebellion that had emerged, yet Jack couldn't help but feel that London needed a model too. All the fake Ashton's and Ashcombe's running around the centre of London at night trying to set up a private currency or hacker collectives were never going to persuade the majority of London to come along with them. London was too big, too formal for such informalities.

London was indecisive. Too global to go local. Too centralised to decentralise. Too powerful to collapse, too fragmented to lead.

Everyone felt it: the Tube still ran, the banks still opened, but the direction had bled out. The city had no syntax. And Jack could feel the silence beneath it.

He stepped away from the window, sat at his desk, and opened the document that had consumed him for the past six months: The Auerom. He said the title aloud sometimes. Like an invocation. *The Auerom*.

It wasn't a manifesto. Jack despised manifestos. It was a structure. A way of being plural without being lost. A way to return to meaning.

London needed meaning, and perhaps the whole country needed meaning. Sheffield was arguing with itself—cultural decentralists vs. monetary optimisers, all under Ashton's poetic umbrella. Manchester had no such ambiguity—Connor Tate had scrubbed the city clean of idealism and was now issuing production schedules like they were scripture.

Jack watched from afar. Not with contempt. With curiosity. They had chosen their models. They had their cadences. London hadn't.

And that made it dangerous. And full of potential.

Jack Stone had never entirely trusted Eliot Ashton. The amount of money he lost betting on Sheffcoin as Ashton expanded the money supply during the festival still irked him, though the increase in productivity since then had made up for some of it.

He respected him—of course. Ashton was sharp, even poetic. His fusion of high liberalism, hypermodernism, and Hayekian private currency had shifted the tone of an entire region. And Jack admired his invocation of Goethe, and in many ways followed his call to high culture. But something had always bothered him.

Ashton drew on the late Goethe, the man of judgment, measure, self-cultivation. “Choose well, and your choice is freedom.” “Personality as destiny.” That was Ashton’s Goethe—a philosopher of clarity in chaotic times.

But Jack knew Goethe differently. He saw in him not just a moralist, but a master of form. Aesthetics, for Goethe, wasn’t decoration—it was destiny. The forms you lived among shaped the soul you became. And more than that, Goethe understood the binding power of style—how certain linguistic cadences and symbolic structures could unite a people, not through force, but through shared feeling.

Neither Ashton nor Thorne had picked up that thread.

Thorne had chased Nietzsche, yes—but mostly as an icon of transgression. His Nietzsche was the firebrand, the aphoristic, the philosopher of masks. He loved quoting On Truth and Lie in an Non-Moral Sense, with that line:

> *“Truths are illusions which we have forgotten are illusions; they are metaphors that have become worn out and have been drained of sensuous force, coins which have lost their embossing and are now considered as metal and no longer coins.”*

And it was a good line. But Thorne had missed what mattered: that Nietzsche, too, had started as a philologist. That he understood the deep structure of meaning as rhythm, not just argument.

Thorne exposed personality as manipulative power. Ashton repurposed it for moral renewal. But neither of them had understood the full force of aesthetics as politics.

Jack leaned back in his chair, looking at the open draft of The Auerom.

He wasn’t interested in theory for its own sake. He was interested in the lived texture of the sovereign life—how time felt on the skin, how light hit buildings, how music bent communal space, how moods stretched across groups. He called it the phenomenology of tense.

That’s what London needed.

Up north, they had chosen structure: Ashton’s cultural sovereignty, Thorne’s machine-state. But London didn’t need economic renewal, nor did it need economic motoring. It was stuck between a fading British state and a rising swarm of post-state experiments. Its identity was vaporous, aesthetic, felt rather than planned.

And that made it Jack’s.

Jack Stone didn’t care for power.

Not in the way Thorne had, with his theatrics and provocations, nor in Ashton’s more refined performance of authority—the charisma wrapped in civility, the soft dominance of those who quote Goethe while pouring ale.

Jack’s concern was deeper. Earlier. Form before force. He believed that before there was law, or even money, there was mood—and that mood arose from the shape of the world around you. A plaza. A poem. A pause in a conversation. A shared vowel sound.

What held people together, in his view, was not a sovereign or a coin, but aesthetic coherence—a set of shared structures, tones, rhythms that made life intelligible and worth inhabiting. That’s why he walked London like a reader scanning a half-written text, tuning himself to the fragments of a culture still trying to speak.

Where Ashton used morality and Thorne wielded energy, Jack would use clarity. Not clarity of message—but of form. His authority wouldn't come from popularity or position. It would emerge because what he said—what he designed—made sense. Because it fitted. Because it felt right, even when it was new.

He saw his task not as leading a movement, but as creating a pattern others would step into without instruction. To be the true philosopher of culture in a moment when culture had no name. To offer London not an ideology or model, but a mood.

Jack Stone sat down at the low table in his study, barefoot, wrapped in a dark wool sweater that still held the damp edge of last night's Thames wind. The room was quiet, except for the occasional creak from the language lab downstairs. On the wall: a single postcard of a limestone arch in the Outer Hebrides, pinned next to a torn page from a 1980s architectural journal. He adjusted the pop filter on the microphone and breathed once, slowly.

He pressed record.

Welcome to Stone Tense, the podcast where we carve through the ideas shaping our built world, from ancient stone to shimmering graphene. I'm your host, Jack Stone, and today we're diving into a vision so bold it makes my hammer and chisel itch: Sir Aldwyn Rooke's Architectures of Britannia: Building a High-Energy, Layered Civilization. Now, I picked this up from a friend. This isn't just about buildings—it's about reimagining Britain as a luminous, limitless world, a place where every street, spire, and subway sings of ambition. Specifically, we're zooming in on Chapter 2, "Maximum and Minimalism," where Rooke lays out a philosophy that's as electrifying as it is elegant: a Britain that balances serene simplicity with vibrant chaos. Oh, and stick around—I've got news about my new book, The Aureom, dropping soon!

About half an hour, though a series of fumbles and rerecords, he was finished with his closing line:

So, as we disembark, I invite you to carry this vision forward. Embrace the aureom in your own life—whether you're at a party or in a quiet room, let every moment be a chance to live vividly. Pre-order The Aureom now at jackstoneaureom.com—it's a manifesto for chasing golden nows, for building a life that shines. And don't forget to grab Rooke's manifesto if you can, it's also featured in the appendix of The Aureom—it's a wild ride. Until next time, keep moving through the stone, and live in the aureom.

Click. Stop recording. Jack sat back. Closed his eyes. The room was still. Nothing had changed. But in a few hours, a few thousand people—scattered across the archipelago and beyond—would walk differently through their cities. He stood, stretched, pulled on a long coat, and left the flat. Outside, the clouds were low and moving fast. The street smelled of stone and coffee and data cables.

The coffee shop was so narrow it felt more like a corridor than a café—two tables, one large window, a record player murmuring Erik Satie through dust-heavy speakers. Jack Stone arrived five minutes early, as he always did when he cared.

At the back, beneath a dried arrangement of hawthorn and sea lavender, sat Ivo Penn, editor-in-chief of Foxwood Editions, a small, deliberate publishing house known for slow books and wide margins.

Ivo wore a black jacket with a collarless shirt and fingerless gloves. His eyes had the brightness of a man who never rushed but always read.

He stood as Jack entered, then gestured toward a folded piece of paper beside the teapot.

“You’ve done it, you know,” Ivo said without ceremony. *The Auerom* is not just good—it’s… foundational.”

Jack raised an eyebrow as he sat. “I thought you didn’t like foundational texts.”

“I don’t. I think they’re dangerous. But this one is necessary.”

He poured tea—oolong, dark, floral.

“Samuel Ashcombe’s read it. Twice. Said it was the clearest philosophical work to emerge in years. His words, Jack, not mine. I’ve got so many positive reviews, from Ashton, The Internationalist, The New Yorker, Theo Kincaid. Architectural Digest are even going to review Architectures of Britannia.”

Jack blinked.

“Samuel and Eliot, wow, have any of them agreed to be quoted?”

Ivo slid the paper across the table. Typed, clean, single sentence: “It may be the first real attempt to create upon the fractures.” — Samuel Ashcombe

Jack leaned back. Let it wash over him. He didn’t grin. Just nodded slowly. “He always had a gift for brevity,” Jack murmured.

They sipped. The Satie loop reached the third repetition.

“We’ll publish it as a primary edition,” Ivo said. “Hardback. Wide margins. Thin, resilient paper. No blurbs on the back—just Ashcombe’s line.”

“And the title?”

“Nothing but The Auerom, centred. Serif. Deep cream white on embossed on high-quality paper.”

A pause stretched. Ivo leaned forward.

“There’s something happening, Jack. The submissions I’ve seen lately—they’re trying. Straining. You’re the only one who’s managed to describe something without forcing it into a manifesto. The Auerom feels like… the form of a movement.”

Jack looked toward the window, where a woman in a coat waited outside with a printed ceramic umbrella. The light behind her was opalescent.

“That’s what London is,” he said. “Formless potential. Still molten.”

By late afternoon, Jack had walked eastward into one of London’s strange hybrid spaces—not quite a park, not quite a commons. A long rectangle of moss-grassed earth, bordered by benches and lit with low lanterns that would bloom pale blue after dusk. A soft hum of distant traffic. Children somewhere. The city at a simmer.

He sat, slowly. Pulled out a worn notebook but didn’t open it. The walk, the tea, the weight of Ivo’s words, Ashcombe’s quote—they all pressed inward like a dense fog of recognition he wasn’t yet ready to name.

He sat in the stillness. One pigeon. Two leaves. The smell of rain on carbon. Then, without looking, he felt someone sit next to him.

Not close—respectful distance. But there was something in the way the bench bent under her weight. Something in her posture: casual but with a composure that didn't invite conversation. She didn't check a device. She didn't look around. She just... was there.

Jack didn't turn. But he knew. Not who she was, but that she was someone. And he sure that she sat there for him.

There was a kind of gravity in her. A softened intensity. He could feel it warming the air between them, like a tuning fork that had been struck in another room.

A long silence passed. It didn't feel awkward. Eventually, she spoke.

"You're Jack Stone."

Her voice was calm. Musical, almost. But not trying. He turned slightly, just enough to meet her eyes.

She was perhaps in her forties or maybe older. Hair drawn back. A coat that looked like it had been tailored with the help of wind. Not beautiful in the way models are—but beautiful in the way that buildings hope to be. Angler, symmetric, strong, powerful. Jack hesitated, then nodded.

"I am."

"I'm Luna." Silence again. She let the name rest, like a chess piece laid but not yet moved. "I'm a friend of Samuel Ashcombe."

Jack didn't respond right away. A thousand questions rippled beneath the surface.

He didn't ask. He just mirrored her calm.

"He's rarely spoken of in the present tense," Jack said.

She smiled faintly.

"Most myths aren't."

The light shifted. A breeze moved through the moss. Somewhere nearby, the city's soft machinery ticked forward. Jack leaned back.

"You knew I'd be here?"

"No. But I hoped you might be."

She looked out across the park, eyes scanning nothing.

"Samuel's read The Auerom. Twice. He said it was like seeing someone sketch the scaffolding for a myth without forcing the myth to arrive. He respects that."

They sat for a while longer, not speaking, letting the moment breathe. Eventually, Jack broke the silence. "So what's the view from the Peaks these days?"

Luna smiled slightly, watching a group of young children chase a floating drone shaped like a heron.

"Fragmented. Beautiful. A little too busy with becoming."

“That’s not a criticism.”

“No,” she agreed. “But Samuel thinks they’ve leaned too hard into structure. Mesh networks. Identity stacks. Microjurisdictions. There's energy, yes—but no centre of gravity.”

Jack nodded slowly. “That’s the paradox of the Kommunes. You decentralise the state, and sometimes you decentralise the soul.”

“Exactly.” Luna looked at him, steady. “He thinks now there has to be some rhythm. A balance between labour and leisure. Between infrastructure and mood. People need joy—but not just the narcotic kind. Something deeper. Communal. He’s thought about Polycentricism but there might be something better.”

“And hedonism?”

“I think he’s starting to think we need a little more,” she said.

Jack smiled faintly. “I watched most of the Festival. Some livestreams. Some bootlegs. Ashton’s model was the only one that felt right. Restraint. Culture. Ritual. No high-speed ideology.”

Luna tilted her head. “You surprise me. I thought you might lean Manchester. The systems-thinkers.”

“I don’t like abstraction that doesn’t smell of anything,” Jack said. “Manchester smells like machine oil and sterilised ambition.”

She laughed, quietly.

“You really are a culturalist.”

“It’s not about nostalgia. It’s about form. Meaning has to pass through form.”

She nodded. “Samuel agrees. He says it outright now: what the Kommunes are missing isn’t policy, or even legitimacy. It’s culture. Shared forms. Shared feeling. As you might label it, shared texture. They’re building territory without myth. That’s dangerous.”

Jack narrowed his eyes. “But he doesn’t want to go the Ashton route.”

“No,” Luna said. “He thinks Eliot’s model risks becoming a city with a bank attached. The currency issuance model was a huge risk anyway, and its not all going all that well with the forced issuance. The trust many gave Eliot was seen as broken is some quarters. Some have gone back to bitcoin, but the Bank has enough leverage in society that the bitcoin at some point will flow through them, and they can burn excess returns.”

“And Thorne, have you heard anything?” The question hung like mist.

Luna’s gaze drifted. Her tone shifted—slightly cooler, but not defensive.

“Maximum security. No comms. No trial date. He's become a concept more than a person.”

Jack exhaled softly.

“That’s dangerous, too.”

“Yes. But he knew what he was playing with.”

They were quiet again. The park had changed in subtle ways. A lamplight had adjusted colour. A tree had begun humming, softly, in a way Jack couldn’t quite place. A spectral wind through engineered leaves.

Luna spoke again, her voice low.

“Samuel doesn’t want a nation-state. But he doesn’t want a void, either. That’s why he’s watching you.” Jack turned toward her.

Luna leaned back against the bench, folding one leg over the other. Her presence remained unhurried, but there was a new attentiveness in her posture—as if she had shifted, imperceptibly, from emissary to interlocutor.

“You’re publishing soon,” she said, not quite a question.

Jack nodded, eyes fixed ahead.

“Next month. Foxwood Editions, no blurbs.”

“Samuel says it’s the only text he’s read in five years that didn’t ask for anything.”

Jack smiled faintly.

“It doesn’t want followers. Just resonance.”

Luna turned to look at him fully.

“Tell me—what are you actually trying to do?”

He hesitated, not because he didn’t know, but because he respected the question. Then he spoke, slowly.

“I’m trying to create a higher culture. But one that doesn’t depend on institutions. Not museums. Not universities. Not canons. Something... lighter, yet heavier, yet more profound.”

“Lighter how?”

“Built from the inside out. Through language. Through shared space. Through rhythm and aesthetic alignment. I’d almost called it as trying to find the place between an ontological and phenomenological approach to linguistics. Through what I’ve started calling peer-to-peer structures of meaning.”

She tilted her head, intrigued.

“Say more.”

Jack leaned forward, elbows on knees, as if coaxing the thought from the soil.

“Imagine culture not as a broadcast but as a mesh. Not mass agreement, but resonance across difference. A new form of poem read in a Sheffield archive echoes in the way a pub conversation hums in a Peckham plaza. A phrase coined in a Cornwall amphitheatre reappears as graffiti in a vertical market in Glasgow. Tiny links. Durable ones. Not systems. *S*hared meaning, not shared power structures.”

“I’m not sure what that means,” Luna said, almost sweetly.

“Forms that bind, but don’t flatten. Shared reference without consensus. My hope is that The Auerom gives people a set of aesthetic and linguistic tools to build those structures together. There is plenty more to come”

“And the Kommunes?”

“Could become laboratories,” Jack said. “For testing tone. For seeing whether collective linguistic development can sustain shared feeling—without coercion, without spectacle. If they survive, it won’t be because they outscale the state. It’ll be because they feel better to live in.”

Luna was quiet, absorbing it. “That’s a strange kind of ambition,” she said finally. “To lead not through power, or even ideas—but through atmosphere, form, pure culture.”

“It’s not about leading,” Jack said. “It’s about becoming unavoidable.”

They both smiled at that.

The light was changing again—blue into amber, clouds parting just enough to send thin gold across the grass. A few children returned. The moss underfoot seemed to shimmer faintly, almost singing. Luna looked away, toward the far side of the park. “I think you’re right about the lattices,” she said softly. “That’s what we’re missing. Something that links without enclosing.”

Jack stood beside the bench now, hands in coat pockets, the amber light softening into the richer blue-grey of early evening. Charlotte remained still for a moment, her gaze sweeping the horizonless line where the moss met the stone border. Then, without turning:

“You know this is the shape of it, don’t you?”

Jack glanced at her.

“What is?”

“Anglo-Futurism. The real cultural movement. Not the manifestos, not the speeders or currency projects. But this—language as architecture. Aesthetics as a political force. Language structures over moral systems.”

Jack said nothing. He agreed too fully to respond. “You’ve been listening to my podcast.” He smirked.

Charlotte stepped forward a few paces, the heels of her boots gently clicking against graphene-inlaid pathstones.

“The mistake people keep making is thinking that Anglo-Futurism is about infrastructure. It’s not. It’s about pattern recognition at scale. It’s about finding beauty in a place that hasn’t yet earned it.”

“It’s a listening movement,” Jack murmured. “It doesn’t make declarations. It makes sense.”

Luna turned back toward him, half-smiling.

“And you, Jack Stone, are the only person writing with the tone of someone who already knows that.”

He looked down at the path. A small patch of rainlight shimmered across his shoe.

Then she said it.

“Would you work with the Kommunes for a while?”

He blinked. The tone hadn't changed—no shift in pressure, no hardening of intent. It wasn't a job offer. It wasn't politics. It was more like… weather changing.

She continued:

"Not to write policy. Or build a campaign. But to help us listen. To help us structure feeling. Samuel thinks the Kommunes have the hardware—but not the software. They need something subtler now. A sense of culture."

"And you think I can give them that?"

"I think you already have. The Auerom is in circulation. People are quoting it without knowing where the words come from."

Jack tilted his head. The thought unsettled him—but not unpleasantly.

"What would that work look like?"

Luna shrugged gently.

"Some time in the Peaks. Maybe a few weeks in the rural nodes. An embedded role, but informal. Talk to our engineers. Listen to coders. Help weave things together before they harden."

"A cultural weaver."

"Exactly."

Jack was silent for a long moment.

Then:

"What if I say no?"

"Then you'll still do the work," Charlotte said. "Just slower. More alone. And eventually, someone will build around you anyway."

He smiled, half-resigned.

"And if I say yes?"

"Then we build with rhythm, not noise."

The moss beneath their feet felt warmer somehow, as if something living had moved beneath it. Jack looked past her to the edge of the park, where the glass of the Kommune office flickered low and golden, its signage still off, as if waiting for a name.

"Let's do it," he said.

Luna nodded, and this time, she did begin to walk away.

"That's all I wanted to hear."

And she was gone.

Jack stood alone, not in the way he had been earlier, but in a way that suggested the next sentence was beginning.

No ceremony followed. Just a new kind of clarity. A coat hung differently. The notebook packed with greater intention. Jack Stone was leaving London—not permanently, but long enough to test the resonance of his words in space, not just speech.

The week before he departed, The Auerom was released.

No launch event. No media rollout. Foxwood Editions had simply posted a single image: the book lying on a stone table, dappled with coastal light.

And something happened. People began quoting lines online—not viral, not cheap—but with reverence. Passages passed from architect to poet, from Kommune to coder.

The first edition—limited to 1,500 copies—sold out in under 36 hours.

Ashcombe's quote on the cover whispered like a minor chord beneath the noise of newer voices. The book was discussed on a Manchester mesh-cast, cited in a Sheffield design symposium, and featured anonymously in a New York high-rise hedonistic philosophy chain, where pages were projected across the walls of a trance-lit alley.

Jack didn't comment.

He packed.

One bag. Notebook. Two pens. A scarf given to him by a friend he no longer wrote to.

He didn't lock the door. Just closed it.

The train was half-empty, humming with quiet focus. Outside, the land tilted upward in gentle pulses, low sunlight dancing across reclaimed hedgerows and distant wind farms.

Jack sat by the window, watching England unfold.

He was no longer anonymous. He was no longer just a podcaster or fringe writer. He was, now, a philosopher of moment, a philologist of the future, cited in conversations he wasn't part of.

But he still didn't see himself as a leader.

"Culture leads," he'd said once. "The best we can do is clear the path."

He smiled as the peaks rose into view—massive, slow, ancient—but humming now with the low voltage of a future quietly taking shape.

Jack Stone, philosopher of mood, had arrived.

Chapter 19:

The new Bank of Sheffield headquarters in Barkers Pool looked like it had been grown rather than built. All raw stone and dark glass. Two massive solar veils wrapped the upper levels designed to look like trees as they breathed in the light. It was designed to feel confident. The kind of place that didn't need guards because it had already won.

Jack Stone stood across the road from it, coat open, hands deep in his pockets. He hadn't planned to look at the building so long. He was thinking about its proportions. Not brutalist, not quite civic-modern. Something in between. Anglo-Futurist, certainly—but still reaching for a tone it hadn't earned yet.

Behind him, the sound of a car door closing.

“You’re thinking about whether the stone was local,” Luna said.

He turned. She was in a long black coat, charcoal scarf, hands bare in the cold. No ceremony. Just clarity.

“Limestone, probably from Derbyshire,” Jack said. “But the finish is too fine. It feels… shipped in.”

Luna nodded once and looked up at the building.

“The façade of that building is talked about as much as the currency. That’s where we are now.”

Jack glanced at her. She was already watching him.

“Are you ready?” she asked.

He looked past her to the Range Rover idling by the kerb. Matte grey, silent drive, no markings. A single bag was already in the boot. He hadn’t packed much.

“I think so.”

Luna opened the door and gestured toward the passenger seat.

“Then let’s go. Samuel doesn’t like it when people arrive late, even if he pretends he does.”

Jack smiled slightly.

“Of course he doesn’t.”

They climbed in. The doors closed with that expensive thud that made everything outside feel irrelevant. Inside, the car was warm, quiet. No music. No screens.

They pulled away from the curb without a sound, Sheffield’s post-industrial confidence disappearing behind them as they headed north, towards the gritstone ridges where something older—and newer—was waiting.

Luna spoke again, eyes on the road: “Just so you know—most people up there have read *The Auerom*. Some of them liked it. Some of them didn’t. No one’s waiting for a lecture.”

Jack looked out the window. “Good. I’m not bringing one.”

A pause. “They want to know what’s the main difference between you and Ashton’s and Thorne’s and all the wannabe philosophers roaming around London?”

“I am somewhere between philosophy and philology I would describe it. Not just someone who studies language like it’s a museum piece. More like—someone trying to describe the texture of reality through language. Or maybe improve it. Even just slightly.”

She sipped her drink, watching him.

“It’s not new,” he continued. “Wittgenstein said the limits of our language are the limits of our world. And Heidegger—he said language is the house of Being. I think they were both right, but not quite finished.”

Luna tilted her head. “So you're finishing them?”

“Hardly,” he smiled. “But I’m trying to *live* it. If the world is shaped by how we speak it, then new language isn’t cosmetic. It’s structural. I wanted to create a Higher English —testing whether new forms of grammar, tense, even sound can shift how we relate to each other. To time. To responsibility. To beauty."

Luna looked at him, amused and warm. "So you're not just building a new dialect. You're building a new world."

Jack nodded.

The hills were starting now, slow folds rising from the horizon like a forgotten topography. Jack rested his hand on his notebook. It was half-filled. Maybe it would get finished somewhere quieter. Or maybe it would get torn apart in the process. The Range Rover moved, silent on the upland roads. Out the window, the land thickened. Rolling pastures gave way to rougher hills, scatterings of dry stone, the first signs of gritstone cliffs edging the horizon.

Inside the cabin, it was still. The hum of motion barely present.

The road narrowed as they climbed. Hedges thickened, then fell away. The land opened into something older — less arranged, less persuaded. Stone walls ran like quiet sentences across the hills, broken, resumed, broken again.

Luna drove without hurry. She seemed to know every turn without looking.

After a while, she spoke again.

"The Kommunes up here… they're not all the same," she said. "Some lean harder into work. Some lean into pleasure. But most of them—" she paused, choosing the word, "—they've drifted."

Jack turned slightly. "Drifted how?"

"They've split themselves," she said. "Pure relacation, or pure function. You get days that are just labour—systems, energy, growing, building. And then nights that are…" she exhaled faintly, "everything else. No restraint. No structure. Just sensation."

Jack watched the horizon. It had begun to rise into darker shapes now — the Peaks, holding their own quiet authority.

"And nothing in between?" he asked.

"Nothing that holds," Luna said. "Nothing that lasts past the moment it's lived in."

A brief silence settled between them, filled only by the soft roll of the tyres against stone.

"Samuel thinks you might help with that," she added.

Jack let out a small breath, almost a laugh. "I've never lived like that," he said. "Not really. I've written about presence. Time. But not… that kind of intensity."

Luna glanced at him. "That's the point."

He considered it. The landscape outside had shifted again — fewer trees now, more open rock, the air itself seeming thinner, clearer.

"There might be something there," he said slowly. "The *Aureom* is about the moment, in a sense. About how we inhabit time. But what you're describing—"

"—is living in it too much," Luna said.

"Or not enough," Jack replied.

She smiled faintly at that.

"Samuel's been reading it again," she said. "Properly this time. He thinks there's something in it that could stabilise things. Or at least… shape them."

Jack leaned back slightly, his hand resting loosely on the notebook.

"What does he want?"

Luna hesitated, then said: "He's been thinking about hedonism. Properly thinking about it. After years of it."

Jack turned his head.

"And?"

"And it's wearing off," she said, simply.

The words hung in the car for a moment. Not dramatic. Just true.

"As much as he hates to admit it," she went on, "he thinks Eliot might be right. That soft culture—something slower, more reflective—might be the better path."

Jack looked back out at the land. The peaks were closer now. Darker. More defined.

"But not soft in the way Ashton means it," Luna added. "Not romantic. Not nostalgic."

"No," Jack said quietly. "Something higher."

She nodded.

"That's what he said," she replied. "If the Kommunes have exhausted the body, maybe it's time to build something for the mind. Something that lasts longer than a night."

Jack didn't answer immediately.

He watched the stone walls again — the way they held shape across distance, the way they marked space without enclosing it completely. There was something in that. Something about structure without suffocation.

"A meeting of traditions, maybe," he said at last. "The *Aureom* and the Kommunes aren't opposed. They just haven't been spoken in the same language yet."

Luna glanced at him again, more carefully this time.

"That's what Samuel's hoping," she said.

The car crested a rise.

For a moment, the world opened — a wide sweep of moorland, wind-cut and vast, the sky hanging low and pale above it.

Jack felt something shift in him then. Not quite anticipation. Not quite doubt.

Just the sense that whatever waited ahead was not theoretical anymore.

It was already happening.

The road gave way without warning. One moment there was only moor — wind, stone, sky — and then, as if the land itself had decided to disclose it, the Kommune appeared.

Not built *on* the hill, but *within* it.

Low structures of gritstone and dark glass folded into the contours, their lines following the logic of the terrain rather than imposing upon it. Nothing ornamental. Nothing wasted. The architecture held a kind of quiet certainty — like a sentence that knew exactly where it was going and refused excess.

This is High Peak One. Not just a Kommune anymore — not since the announcement of the digital layer that now ran beneath it, invisible and vast. A place that was both physical and distributed. Stone and server. Firelight and computation.

Jack felt it before he fully saw it — a density, a pressure in the air.

He knew why he was here.

Samuel Ashcombe's name had travelled far beyond these hills now. In London, they spoke of him in fragments — some admiring, some wary, some simply unsure what he *was*. A Kommune leader, yes. But also something else. A node of power. A man who sat atop computational networks that could rival institutions.

He could break encryption systems no one else understood, his people could overload grids, redirect flows of energy, disrupt without ever appearing. Whether any of that was true hardly mattered.

What mattered was that the north had begun to move around him.

The car slowed, then stopped.

For a moment, Jack didn't move. He looked out across the open space before the main structure — people gathered, loosely arranged, watching without staring. There was no performance in it. No ceremony. Just presence.

They stepped out into the air.

It was sharper here. Cleaner.

And the first thing Jack noticed — before faces, before voices — was posture.

They stood *straight*.

Not rigid. Not forced. But upright in a way that felt almost unfamiliar. Shoulders open. Heads level. No trace of that slight inward fold he had grown used to in London — the subtle curvature of bodies shaped by screens, by self-consciousness, by the constant negotiation of space.

Here, there was no crouching.

Luna closed the car door behind her and walked forward without hesitation. Jack followed.

Samuel Ashcombe stepped out from the loose gathering.

He was not what the rumours suggested.

Not tall. Not imposing in height. But *set*. There was a verticality to him — as if he had aligned himself fully with his own centre of gravity and never drifted from it.

Strong, but without display.

His face held something clear, almost open — and when he looked at Jack, there was recognition, but no weight behind it. No calculation.

Just attention.

“Jack,” Luna said simply, as she reached them. “This is Samuel.”

Ashcombe extended a hand.

“Welcome to High Peak One.”

His voice was steady. Not deep, not theatrical. Just *held*.

Jack took his hand.

There was no power play in it. No test. Just contact.

“Thank you for having me,” Jack said.

Ashcombe studied him for a brief second — not sizing him up, but *placing* him, as if locating him within a larger structure.

“I’ve read your work,” he said. “More than once.”

Jack smiled faintly. “Then you’ve probably found its limits.”

Ashcombe shook his head slightly.

“No,” he said. “I found its direction.”

A pause. The wind moved lightly across the open ground.

“I think you’re a philosopher,” Ashcombe continued. “In the older sense. Not telling people what to do, just leaving it out there to dry.”

Jack raised an eyebrow, just slightly.

“But an early philosopher,” Samuel added. “Still working it out in theory. Still shaping it through text.”

He glanced briefly toward the structures behind him — the Kommune, the people, the systems humming quietly beneath it all.

“Up here,” he said, “we have to live it.”

“You’re not here to observe,” he said. “And you’re not here to explain anything.”

Another small pause.

“You’re here because something’s missing.”

Jack met his eye.

“And you think I can name it?”

Ashcombe’s expression shifted — not quite a smile, but something close.

“I think you can feel it,” he said. “And then we’ll see if you can speak it.”

They began to walk without quite deciding to. Across the open ground, toward the low structures that seemed to rise out of the hill rather than sit upon it. A few others drifted with them at a distance, not intruding, not absent — just part of the same slow movement.

Ashcombe kept his hands loose by his sides, his stride even.

“The *Aureom*,” he said, after a moment. “It’s being read up here differently than it is in London.”

Jack glanced at him. “How so?”

“In London, it’s being admired,” Ashcombe said. “Quoted. Interpreted. Folded into conversation.” A small pause. “Up here, we’re asking whether it *works*.”

Jack let out a faint breath through his nose. “That sounds about right.”

Ashcombe looked ahead, toward the edge of the ridge. “You talk about time as something that can be inhabited differently. About language as a structure that shapes that experience.”

“I do,” Jack said.

“And you think that structure can be altered?” Ashcombe asked. “Not just described — *altered*?”

Jack nodded. “That’s the point. If language frames reality, then shifting language shifts the frame. Not completely. But enough to change how people act within it.”

Ashcombe was quiet for a second.

“That’s why you’re here,” he said. “To see if you can form anything new.”

Jack looked out over the drop now — the land falling away into a wide valley, the light sitting low across it.

“The north is already moving. Faster than London. More decisively. But it’s splitting.”

Ashcombe didn’t interrupt.

“Work and play,” Jack continued. “Production and release. No continuity between them. No higher structure holding it together.”

Ashcombe nodded once. “We know.”

“And I think *The Aureom* might be able to provide that,” Jack said. “Not as a system. As a language. Something that allows those moments to connect. To accumulate. To mean something beyond themselves.”

Ashcombe turned to him slightly.

“You want to help shape the north,” he said.

Jack met his gaze. “I want to give it a form it can recognise.”

A small silence followed that. Not tense. Just measured.

“And Thorne?” Jack asked, almost casually. “I think he should be allowed out,” he said.

Ashcombe didn’t react immediately. “He’s still in the prison system. “They think he’s too dangerous to release quietly.”

Jack shook his head. “He’s not just a problem to them. He’s a *type* they don’t understand. Cypherpunk logic doesn’t sit inside institutional language. It breaks it.”

Ashcombe’s eyes narrowed slightly — not in disagreement, but in focus. “It’s just power and money,” he said. “Thorne isn’t a type. He’s a man of action. I didn’t stop being a cypherpunk,” Samuel added. “I just started asking what comes after it.”

“And Eliot Ashton?” Jack asked. “Luna said he’s around.”

Ashcombe gestured vaguely toward one of the lower structures. “He moves around and through these parts. You’ll see him.”

Jack nodded.

They walked a little further in silence before Samuel spoke again. “I’ve been thinking more about Wittgenstein,” he said.

Jack glanced at him. “The language games of Wittgenstein would be something I would have liked to experience.”

“I wouldn’t call Wittgenstein language games.” Ashcombe nodded slightly. “It’s about a form of command, Wittgenstein is a series of internal logic that one can apply to their own ontology – and others.”

“That isn’t command,” Jack said, “sometimes it’s just about stating the obvious in a profound manner that gets some people going. You take a proposition,” he continued, “you align it with the structure of the world — or what you take to be the structure — and once it fits, it *runs*.”

“Runs?” Ashcombe said.

“Yes,” he said. “Like code. You don’t argue with it. You don’t interpret it endlessly. You see that it holds — and then your thinking reorganises around it.”

“That is command,” he added.

“No,” he said. “That’s *form*. Wittgenstein doesn’t impose structure,” he continued. “He reveals the limits of the structures we’re already using. The propositions don’t *bend* the mind — they show you where it was already bent.”

Ashcombe considered that.

“And once it’s shown?” he asked.

Jack held his gaze.

“Then you can’t think the same way again,” he said.

Ashcombe nodded once.

“Exactly,” he replied.

A brief silence.

“That’s the bend,” he added.

Jack shook his head, but there was a faint smile now — the kind that came when the disagreement was narrowing into something more precise.

“You’re describing the effect,” he said. “Not the intention. It is philosophy, not authority. If it wasn’t there in the first place, it wouldn’t have the same impact.”

Ashcombe stepped slightly closer.

“Propositional logic isn’t about control,” Jack said. “It’s about clarity. About saying something so cleanly that it removes confusion.”

Ashcombe tilted his head.

“And what happens when confusion is removed?” he asked.

Jack didn’t answer immediately.

Ashcombe did.

“People act,” he said. Differently.”

Jack absorbed that.

“Yes,” he said. “But that’s not because they’re being *commanded*. It’s because they’re no longer misled by unspoken abstractions.”

Ashcombe’s expression held.

“You’re still moralising it,” he said.

“I’m grounding it,” Jack replied.

Another pause — tighter now, choosing the words more carefully now.

“So the question becomes: is it obvious to want a higher form of language.”

Ashcombe stopped walking.

Jack took one more step before realising, then turned back slightly.

Ashcombe was watching him now — properly watching him.

“That’s not philology as it’s usually understood,” he said.

“No,” Jack replied. “It’s not.”

Another pause.

“It’s philology as intervention,” Jack added. “Not studying language as it was. Not even preserving it. But shaping it — deliberately — to see what kind of world emerges.”

The wind moved across the ridge again, catching the edge of Ashcombe’s coat.

“And you think that’s possible?” he asked.

Jack held his gaze.

“I think it’s already happening,” he said. “Just unconsciously. Through media, through platforms, through the way people speak online. The question is whether we can do it *consciously*. With intent. With taste.”

Ashcombe’s expression shifted again — something sharper now, more alive.

“That’s why you’re here,” he said.

Jack nodded.

“To see if it can be done here first,” he replied.

Ashcombe looked back out across the valley.

“Then you’ll need more than theory,” he said. “You’ll need people willing to live inside it.”

Jack followed his gaze.

“I thought that might be the case,” he said quietly.

Ashcombe didn’t move for a moment after Jack spoke. The wind pressed lightly against them both, as if waiting for something to resolve.

Then, almost idly:

“And what makes you think this place can hold it?” he asked. “What makes you think language won’t dissolve here the same way everything else does—into labour by day, sensation by night?”

Jack smiled, but it wasn’t soft now. There was an edge to it — something forming.

“Because it already *hasn’t*,” he said.

Ashcombe’s eyes flicked back to him.

Jack stepped forward slightly, not closing distance, but altering the geometry of it.

“You’ve built a system,” Jack continued. “Energy, computation, coordination. You’ve taken fragmentation and made it cohere. That’s not drift. That’s tone.”

Ashcombe let out a small breath through his nose. “Careful,” he said. “You’re flattering the infrastructure.”

“I’m describing it,” Jack replied. “You’ve created a language of action. Nodes, flows, decisions, responses. It *speaks*. It just doesn’t know what it’s saying yet.”

Ashcombe turned fully toward him now.

“I know exactly what you’re saying,” he said, more firmly. “We don’t need permission anymore. Not from London, not from institutions, not from anyone. We have compute across continents. We have reserves—Bitcoin, sovereign tokens, energy futures contracts that means energy doesn’t touch the grid unless we want it to.”

A slight pause, then sharper:

“We can take things offline if we need to. Or bring them online. Entire systems.”

Jack didn’t flinch.

“That’s power,” he said. “Undeniably.”

Another step — closer now, but still controlled.

“But power without tone is noise,” Jack added.

Ashcombe’s jaw tightened, just slightly.

“You think this is noise?”

“I think it’s *potential,*” Jack said. “But it hasn’t resolved into meaning yet. Not fully.”

Ashcombe studied him.

“And you’re going to give it meaning?”

Jack tilted his head.

“I *will have been* part of it,” he said.

Ashcombe paused.

That tense hung there — not incorrect, but displaced.

Jack continued, leaning into it now.

“You will have built the infrastructure,” he said. “Thorne will have broken the locks. Ashton will have softened the edges. And I—”

A faint smile.

“I will have given it a language it can recognise itself in.”

Ashcombe’s gaze sharpened. There it was — the first real shift. “I’m starting to hate that now. But you are correct about what you wrote in the Aureom, your language is powerful.”

Jack nodded, almost gently.

“That’s the point of a higher form of language,” he replied. “If you speak in the present-future, you remove hesitation. You make the outcome feel structurally inevitable. People act differently inside that frame. You skip past language as form and reality, into a realm in which it is just the experience of life that is reality.”

Ashcombe took a step closer now. The distance between them was no longer incidental. Then, almost idly:

“And what makes you think this place form a higher culture?” he asked. “What makes you think language will change our surroundings by day, and phenomenology into a realm not seen on these Isles in quite a while?”

“You’ve built a system,” Jack said. “Energy, computation, coordination. You’ve taken fragmentation and made it cohere. That’s grammar.”

Ashcombe let out a small breath through his nose. “I don’t like the way you keep describing things as grammar. It is a state of being.”

“Are you being deliberately Nietzschean, as you wish to talk about that, rather than grammar?”

“I am not Thorne. I don’t do power the same way. But the language can still be soft and powerful. Leaving traces of itself in society, that is what you saw?”

“That is manipulation,” he said.

Jack shook his head.

“No,” he said. “It’s time and determinism.”

“You’re starting to sound like Merleau-Ponty.”

Jack looked out again — the valley, the systems unseen beneath it, the people moving through it. “A higher culture,” he said. “It’s always been a phrase. Older than both of us. It just hasn’t been said properly in a while. People have always complained about their lot, sometimes those below them. It was the elitism in the Aureom which resonated with you, wasn't it? Or was it the linguistics neatness”

Ashcombe’s posture shifted — not defensive, but recalibrating. “And you think doing it as a dialogue changes things?”

“I think writing philosophy *correctly* changes everything,” Jack said. “You know there are levels to this.”

Ashcombe didn’t react, but he was listening.

“Different orders of philosophy,” Jack continued. “Not in the sense of hierarchy for its own sake — but in what each one is *capable* of holding.”

A pause.

“Ashton,” Jack said, almost precisely, “is an academic philosopher. Properly. He works at the level of articulation. He can take something diffuse — a system, a feeling, a contradiction — and render it into language that holds.”

Ashcombe nodded faintly.

“Yes,” he said.

“He could write about this,” Jack went on, gesturing lightly to the Peaks, the Kommune, the unseen depth beneath them. “Not just describe it — *situate* it. Give it coherence in thought.”

“And Thorne,” Jack added, “even from the other side — he operates in that same register. Different style. More destructive. But still philosophical. Kincaid is all for Thorne, I believe. Still able to *frame* what he’s doing, even as he breaks everything around him. He doesn’t see Thorne as a radical libertarian, just a man seeking liberty.”

Ashcombe’s gaze shifted slightly at the mention of Thorne, but he said nothing.

Jack continued.

“You two—” he said, then corrected himself slightly, more exact now, “you, Eliot—are operating somewhere else.”

Ashcombe’s eyes flicked to him.

“Go on,” he said.

Jack didn’t hesitate.

“You’re a builder,” he said. “A coder, if you want it plainly. You take systems and you *execute* them. You don’t need them to be fully articulated before hand to act.”

Ashcombe nodded once.

Jack stepped slightly closer, not confrontational — but clarifying.

“And that’s not a weakness,” he said. “It’s a different layer. Necessary. Without it, nothing happens.”

“But it also means,” Jack continued, “you’re not trying to write the thing that Ashton would write. Or what I am trying to write.”

Ashcombe’s expression didn’t shift.

“No,” he said. “I’m not.”

Silence, briefly — but not empty. Precise.

“Everyone can see that,” Jack said. “The difference. Ashton can produce a text that situates the entire movement. Thorne can destabilise it through critique. I can…”

He paused, just slightly.

“…shape the language it lives in.”

A breath.

“But you,” he said, “are making it *real*.”

Ashcombe held his gaze. “And you think those are separate?” he asked.

Jack shook his head.

“No,” he said. “I think they’re interdependent. But they’re not interchangeable.”

A pause.

“You couldn’t write Ashton’s review,” Jack said, plainly. “And he couldn’t build this.”

He gestured again — not dramatically, just enough. Ashcombe didn’t disagree.

“No,” he said.

Another silence — this one quieter.

“But that’s not what I need,” Ashcombe added.

Jack tilted his head slightly.

“What do you need?”

Ashcombe looked out across the Kommune now — not the abstract Peaks, but the people. The movement. The forming, dissolving, reforming of something not yet named.

“I’m closer to them,” he said. Jack followed his gaze. The workers. The small clusters. The low, constant activity.

“The Kommunes,” Ashcombe continued. “Not as an idea. As a *fact*.”

A pause.

“They don’t need a system explained to them,” he said. “They need something they can *live inside* without it collapsing. And that’s where you come in,” Ashcombe said, turning back to him.

“I don’t need you to out-argue Ashton,” he continued. “Or outmaneuver Thorne.”

His voice steadied.

“I need you to give this”—he gestured again, the land, the people, the hidden structure beneath—“a language that holds people at a better level, without them having to live in pop-up cafes and work in artisanal bicycle shops.”

Jack didn’t respond immediately.

“Not live in theory,” Ashcombe added. “Not after the fact. Something that sits inside what they’re already doing and *stabilises it*.”

Silence again.

The wind. The stone. The low hum of a place becoming something else.

Jack looked out across it all — then back.

“Then I won’t write *about* it,” he said quietly.

Voices. Footsteps. The low hum of systems running somewhere beneath the stone. The Kommune did not pause for them — and that, more than anything, marked the place. Nothing stopped. Nothing gathered in reverence. But attention shifted, lightly, like a current adjusting its course.

A few had begun to notice.

Jack caught fragments as they passed.

“That’s him, isn’t it?”
“The book—yeah.”
“I liked the start more than the end, to be honest.”
“Bit too London in bits.”
“The language stuff worked though.”
“Yeah, but it was the Kommune sections… that was the real part.”

No hostility in it. No deference either. Just assessment. Use.

Jack felt it register somewhere deep — not as offence, but as calibration. They were reading him the way they read systems. One of them broke from the loose flow and approached.

Mid-thirties, maybe. Hair tied back. Jacket worn but clean. He held himself the same way the others did — upright, uncollapsed.

“You’re Stone,” he said, not asking.

Jack nodded. “I am.”

The man tilted his head slightly.

“Good book,” he said. “Starts strong. Gets a bit into itself with the linguistics at the end.”

Jack smiled faintly. “That’s fair.”

A brief pause — then the man reached into his bad and pulled out a laptop. Jack’s attention snapped to it immediately. A MacBook — thin, matte, no visible seams. It caught the light strangely, like it wasn’t fully settled in one form. The man set up the laptop. Then the figure came on the screen. Eliot Ashton, in a new apartment overlooking Sheffield.

Jack felt a brief, involuntary pause move through him. He glanced, almost unconsciously, at Ashcombe as he looked into Ashton. “We’ve all been spending, seemingly,” he said, as if answering the unasked question. “Markets were kind enough after the festival.”

Ashton looked out at Jack. “Samuel,” he said, voice clean, carried through the device with unnerving clarity. “I assume there is a group around?”

“There is,” Ashcombe replied, as Jack moved into view. “So,” he said. A small pause. “You’re Jack Stone.”

Jack inclined his head slightly.

“I’ve read *The Aureom*,” Ashton said. “Carefully.”

“I have questions.”

Jack nodded.

“You’re proposing that language can structure reality in a way that persists describing,” he said. “That it can bind action into action. Hold it in place.”

A slight tilt of the head.

“But from where I’m standing,” he added, “you’ve described that process far more convincingly than you’ve executed it.”

The words landed cleanly. Not hostile. Not gentle.

“That’s why I’m here now,” Jack said. “To prove it.”

Ashton’s expression didn’t change, but something in the projection sharpened — attention resolving.

“So it only stands with its author?” he asked.

Jack shook his head.

“It is just easier if I prove it,” he said.

A pause.

Behind them, the Kommune continued — movement, conversation, the quiet hum of a place that did not wait for permission. Eliot nodded once, slowly.

“Good,” he said.

“Then I think I will come by,” he added. “Properly.” The projection flickered, just slightly. “I’d rather ask the rest of my questions in person.”

Jack stood there for a moment. The echo of Ashton’s projection lighting up the barn.

“Sheffcoin,” he said, sharper now. “Let’s not dress it up. The supply increase was clumsy.”

The device in the man’s hand flickered again — Ashton resolving more fully this time, as if the tone itself had summoned him back.

“Clumsy?” Ashton repeated, evenly.

“It should have been allowed to appreciate,” he said. “You had internal demand, external speculation, narrative momentum — all aligned. And then you increasing supply like you were testing a textbook model instead of running a live economy. It effected people’s lives.” A pause — then, more pointed: “It stung. Across the board.”

Ashton’s expression held, but there was a tightening now — not defensive, but engaged.

“The value did depreciate,” he said. “You will have made most of it back by now.”

Jack didn’t deny it. “It has come back up,” he said. “But I should have left it in Bitcoin.” A faint edge entered Jack’s voice. “You pushed issuance. Debased it deliberately. Ran a live MMT-style experiment just to see where the floor was.” He gave a small, almost amused exhale. “Turns out, lower than expected.” A couple of those nearby glanced over — the tone had shifted now. “You destabilised it,” Jack said.

“I pushed it,” Eliot replied, immediately.

“You can’t claim robustness if the system collapses under pressure,” he added. “And you can’t increase supply like that without admitting you’re correcting for something you didn’t model properly.”

Ashton’s projection sharpened — clarity increasing as if the system itself were compensating.

“It was not a mistake,” he said. “It was a coordinated supply increase. A board decision to reinforce internal circulation within the Sheffield economy.”

Jack shook his head.

“Then say that,” he said. “But don’t pretend it was seamless. It wasn’t. It was reactive.”

A brief silence.

“And you know why,” Jack pressed.

Ashton held his gaze.

“Go on,” he said.

“Because you couldn’t calculate it,” Jack said. “Not fully. Not dynamically. You were competing with Thorne for headlines, not running banking policy..”

A few of the others nearby had slowed now — not intruding, but listening.

Ashton didn’t respond immediately this time.

Then, calmly:

“You’re right about one thing,” he said. “We couldn’t model it completely, there was one factor we did not predict for.”

Jack’s expression didn’t shift, but something in him registered the concession. He didn’t know.

“Samuel Ashcombe,” Eliot said simply, “has been hoovering up SheffCoin in the currency risk markets, so Sheffield will have to pay Ashcombe back for its help.”

Jack tilted his head.

“He’s been a key help in the demand-pull aggregate side of things,” Eliot said, without a trace of humour in his speech.

“No,” Ashcombe said. “We were just happy to drain the Sheffield economy, to get our hands on a quantum computer from Silicon Valley.”

A pause from Ashcombe. “We held back the entire Sheffield economy, some in currency risk markets, and others in social engineering techniques. The population of Sheffield has not done anything for months other than make pop-up shops for tourists, to bring in external currency. Our Kommune has made enough money for the computer in the past three months by holding down the city. We will have enough compute to make the next move without asking anyone. We are getting the quantum computer. Work’s already started for its arrival,” he said. “I am forcing Ashton out into Sheffield every single day to make sure the Bank is working hard on its poetry and recyclable mushrooms to pay for it. That is why the currency hasn’t bounced back.” Silence, briefly, before Ashcombe dismissed the last three months with a flick of his wrist. “But we’re past that now,” he finally said.

Jack followed his movement — and now he noticed it if he squinted. Subtle, but there. Disturbances in the ground further out. Machinery, quiet, partially concealed. Lines being cut into the earth.

“You’re already digging,” Eliot said.

Ashcombe nodded.

“Compute space, right into the gritstone,” he replied. “Deep enough to stabilise temperature. Shield interference. Build properly.”

A pause.

“Caverns,” he added. “Not facilities. Not server rooms. Entire *caverns* of compute.”

Jack felt something shift again — the scale of it pressing in, not abstract now.

“Distributed?” he asked.

Ashcombe shook his head.

“Layered,” he said. “Physical depth matched with computational depth. Surface systems for interaction. Subsurface for processing. Further down for what comes next.”

Jack looked out again — the Peaks unchanged on the surface, but now carrying a second meaning entirely.

“And all of this connects to Sheffield?” he asked.

“Yes,” Ashcombe said. “Direct transport lines into Sheffield. Secure. No reliance on external infrastructure. We are digging in.”

Jack glanced once toward where the projection had been. “Ashton’s changed,” he said. “Since the festival.”

Ashcombe nodded, as if that had been obvious long before it was spoken.

“He’s clarified,” he replied. “Less interested in drift which the city was. He’s more into the structure we think.”

Jack let out a faint breath. “He always had that in him,” he said. “Just hid it behind all that cultural tone.”

A pause.

“And Thorne?” he asked.

Ashcombe didn’t hesitate.

“I’ve seen him,” he said.

Jack turned quickly.

“Seen him?”

Ashcombe nodded once.

“He’s where they said he was,” he continued. “Prison. Not mistreated. Not broken.”

A slight narrowing of the eyes.

“But contained.”

Jack absorbed that.

“He won’t stay there,” Eliot said.

Ashcombe didn’t agree. Didn’t disagree.

“We’ll see,” he replied.

A moment passed. Then Jack shifted the line of conversation himself — more personal now, but no less sharp.

“I lost a lot on Sheffcoin,” he said, plainly.

Ashton looked at him.

“I worked out what you did,” Jack said. “That was personal.”

“More issuance than I’d planned,” Eliot added. “I went in hard. Thought I understood the direction.”

Samuel’s gaze held steady. “You were trying to force it,” he said.

Eliot frowned slightly. “I was testing it.”

“You were *pushing* it,” Ashcombe replied. “Without full knowledge.”

“Agreed.” Eliot says. “We should all get together soon, and discuss The Aureom in more detail.”

Chapter 20:

(The fire was burning low, just enough to throw faces into light — bright one moment, shadowed the next. Someone had pressed a mug of hot cider into my hands, and I was rolling the old ring on my finger, aware in that peculiar way that this would have been one of the moments. The Aureom. Already golden, even before I’d stepped into tomorrow.

Samuel sat across from me, elbows on his knees, the flames caught in the glass of his spectacles. Eliot leaned back on a log beside him, his scarf loose, looking like he could either speak for an hour or fall silent for the rest of the night. The flames breathe in their slow rhythm, throwing light up against the stone wall of the longhouse. A kettle murmurs somewhere in the dark. Around the fire, blankets are pulled tighter; cups are cradled.)

Luna:
So, Jack—if this was the end of your time among us. How goes the time?

Jack Stone:
It's been good. Quieter than London, obviously. The pace here… it feels like it stretches out the days.

Eliot Ashton:
That's one way to put it. We'd probably say we move at a difference pace. More action; less talk.

Jack:
It doesn't feel like slowness. More like—time is lived in; rather than actioned. There is a stronger pace of life in London. There's space for a bit of talking, a bit of looking around.

Samuel:
Sounds romanticised to me. But that's why you're here, isn't it? To see if life like this can fit into your… project.

Jack:
I suppose so. I wanted to see what it's like for people to live together without all the usual layers—offices, commutes, city noise. I'm used to London, where everything's clipped and to the point. Here, people let moments breathe a bit more.

Eliot:
And you think that changes the way we speak?

Jack:
Yeah. You've already got a way of talking that's… I don't know, it carries a bit more space. I'm just wondering if we can make more of that. Give it some shape without making it artificial.

Samuel:
Shape it how?

Jack:
By paying attention to how we talk to each other. Making sure our words match what we want this place to feel like. What reality you want it to look like.

Eliot:
Then you've got a good night for it. Fire, tea, vodka, and no one's going anywhere.

Samuel:
So here's the thing, Jack—you've landed here right in the middle of a bigger shift. Thorne's in custody, Manchester's DAOs are leaderless, and the north's not in the mood to keep playing along with London's rules.

Jack:
I've heard.

Eliot:
It’s more than that. Since Thorne got pulled in, people have been… freer, I suppose, to say outright what they were hinting at before. The old idea of parliamentary sovereignty? Nobody here really buys it anymore. We’re governing ourselves through networks, councils, and cooperatives—and the south just calls it “temporary arrangements.”

Samuel:
Temporary’s been two years now. And every month, Westminster sends another delegation up to “integrate” us back into the fold.

Jack:
And you think that’s impossible now?

Eliot:
Not impossible. Just… irrelevant. We’ve got our own decision systems, our own way of moving resources. Even our own currency. Why would we hand that back to people who never really understood what we were building?

Samuel:
Exactly. The post-state order isn’t a theory anymore—it’s practice. What we’ve been living here in Bamford, in Sheffield, in the Peaks—it’s proof you don’t need a parliament to run a society. We don’t need to declare anything, we just turn out backs on all that we don’t need.

Jack:
But you’ve still got disputes, right? Borders, agreements, rules—just like anywhere else.

Eliot:
Sure. But we settle them in the open. No party lines, no five-year election cycles. We decide when the thing needs deciding, and everyone who’s affected gets a say. It’s all about consensus models.

Samuel:
Which is where your angle comes in, Jack. If we’re making something new, the language we use to talk about it matters. You get that better than most.

Jack:
I get that words can steer the thing without anyone noticing they’ve been steered. If the north’s pulling away, you’re going to need ways of talking about it that make sense to people here—and don’t just mirror the old London tone.

Eliot:
And that’s exactly why you’re by this fire instead of in some lecture hall.

Jack:
If the state’s power is fading—if the north’s going its own way—what’s going to hold it together? We’ve seen this before. Not in politics, but in religion.

Eliot:
You’re talking about Protestantism again?

Jack:
Back when it was at its height, it wasn’t a crown or a parliament binding the towns and villages. It was the logos. Preached, printed, memorised. A kind of authority no king could fully control.

Eliot:
And you're saying language could do that now.

Jack:
It already does, just in thinner form. Think about the slogans, the hashtags—people repeat them like hymns. But that's noise. If we had a shared way of speaking about the world—about our politics, our place, our future—it could carry the same weight Protestantism did then.

Eliot:
The difference being, there's no church to guard it. No bishops to issue corrections.

Jack:
Which is the strength of it, and the danger. If the thing catches, it lives in the mouths of ordinary people. But it also means you can't pull it back once it spreads.

Samuel:
That's what I want you to think about. If we make a language that can bind a society, we also give it a kind of authority outside of councils or votes. That's not far from creating a new church, Jack.

Jack:
Except this one wouldn't be built around belief in the same creed—it'd be built around the way we speak about life together. Shared phrases, shared turns of thought. Enough to make someone in Leeds and someone here in Bamford feel they're part of the same living thing, even if they've never met.

Eliot:
Like the hymns again—same words sung in a hundred places, so you know you belong before you've even walked in.

Jack:
Right. Except ours wouldn't be hymns—it'd be the everyday ways of talking about fairness, decision-making, even beauty. If we get that tone right, you don't need a central parliament. The speech itself becomes the structure.

Samuel *(with a nod)*:
And once that's in place, it's harder for anyone—London, Westminster, whoever—to pull us back under.

Jack:
Yes. But remember—once you set it loose, it's not yours anymore. It belongs to whoever speaks it.

(A few murmurs around the fire. Someone pours more tea. The circle leans in a little closer.)

Eliot:
So if language can bind people like that, the next question's obvious—what happens when someone starts shaping that language on purpose?

Samuel *(glancing at Jack)*:
You mean when a philologer sits down and encodes the thing so it steers reality toward their theory? That's not just binding—it's authoring the whole framework people think inside. That's quite the power.

Jack:
It’s the same kind of power coders have had for decades. Cypherpunks write code to shape the systems we live in—money, privacy, communication. I just work in the human layer. Same principle.

Eliot:
Except code runs on machines. What you’re talking about runs in people’s heads.

Jack:
Exactly. Which means it’s more fragile—and harder to erase once it’s out there. You get a few key phrases lodged in the public’s everyday speech, you shift the frame of what feels normal, fair, even possible.

Samuel:
That’s politics without looking like politics.

Jack:
It’s culture. But culture can be upstream of politics. If you make a way of speaking that makes certain kinds of decisions feel natural and others feel alien, you’ve already shaped the field before a vote’s even cast.

Eliot:
And you think that can be done deliberately?

Jack:
It’s always being done. Advertisers do it, governments do it. I’m just saying we can do it openly, for our own purposes, and with a better aim than shifting products.

Samuel:
Which brings us back to my point—once you’ve done it, you’ve let something loose that can’t easily be pulled back.

Jack:
True. But I’d rather we were the ones writing it than waiting for someone else to drop theirs into our mouths.

(A few people in the circle murmur agreement; the fire shifts, spitting a bright spark into the dark.)

Samuel:
You see the risk, don’t you? Craft a new form of language, you’ve crafted a new form of power. And power, Eliot, has a habit of shaping itself into control—whether it wears robes or jeans.

Eliot:
I get it. But you’re saying Jack’s at the centre it and he’s going to use it for tyrannical purposes?

Samuel:
Why not? The philologer becomes the philosopher, the philosopher becomes the lawgiver, the lawgiver becomes—well, history’s clear enough—tyrant. You start encoding reality in a new tongue, rather than law, and you’re composing a new reality for the world to walk into.

Jack:
That’s not where I’m going with this. What I’m thinking about isn’t control—it’s sovereignty. Linguistic sovereignty.

Samuel:
Meaning?

Jack:
Meaning, if we push English—push *language*—beyond the limits it's stuck in now, we don't lock people into a version of reality. We give them the means to shape their own. The point isn't to hand everyone the same script. It's to give them a bigger stage, more tools, more colours.

Eliot:
So you're saying a stronger, more flexible language makes people less dependent on any single authority.

Jack:
Exactly. If someone can describe their life in richer, more exact ways, they're not as easy to box in. The danger isn't in having too much language—it's in having too little. That's when people get trapped inside slogans they didn't write.

Samuel:
Still sounds like you're putting a lot of faith in the idea that a sovereign individual will use that freedom well.

Jack:
I am. Because the alternative is to keep language narrow, safe, and owned by whoever happens to hold the microphone. I'd rather see it opened up—even if that means some will use it in ways I wouldn't.

Eliot:
Alright, but here's the rub. If everyone's got the freedom to make their own reality through language, how do we stop it splintering? One person's poetry becomes another's gibberish. You're not just pushing English—you're making a hundred different Englishes.

Samuel:
And the moment there's no shared ground, it's not cohesion anymore. It's Babel.

Eliot:
Exactly. Feels a bit like the myth—people reaching upward, building their own towers of speech, until no one understands anyone else.

Jack:
I'm not against towers. But they need to be built on the same bedrock. Think of it less as one language breaking apart, more as a set of high registers built on a common base. To speak over the low grass.

Eliot:
High registers?

Jack:
Yeah. You could have *Aesthetic English*—built for beauty and ceremony. *Hedonistic English*—playful, lush, pushing pleasure into the sentence. *Aristocratic English*—polished, deliberate, carrying the weight of considered judgment. They're different modes, but they all speak to the same underlying structure.

Samuel:
So, people can choose the mode that fits the moment, but they still understand each other.

Jack:
Exactly. You get the freedom to shape your own expression without losing the thread that ties us together. The problem with the Babel myth wasn't that people reached too high—it's that they lost the bridge between their heights.

Eliot:
And you think you can build that bridge?

Jack:
Not me alone. But if we treat language as shared code, like a repository—something we all tend and expand together—then yeah, I think we can make a bridge that still lets the towers rise.

(The fire leans low for a moment, the embers glowing like the coals of an argument that's not yet burned out.)

Samuel:
I can see those registers catching on, Jack. But you realise they could turn into badges of class, right? Like accents used to be. You start speaking in Aristocratic English and people will hear a power move whether you meant it or not.

Jack:
That's why I keep saying—it's not really about swapping the words. It's about shifting the register. Changing the grammar, the tense, the rhythm of how you say something. That's harder to fake as just a badge, because it's about how you *think* the sentence into being.

Eliot:
Alright—show us.

Jack *(nodding, warming his hands over the fire)*:
Alright. Let's take something simple. Say: *We sat under the old tree until the light faded.*

First—**Aesthetic English**:
We lingered beneath the old tree, the day folding itself into a copper hush, our silence stitched with the slow fall of light.

Second—**Hedonistic English**:
We sprawled under the old tree, warm skin against rough bark, drinking the last of the day as the sky poured itself over us.

Third—**Aristocratic English**:
We remained beneath the venerable tree until the hour's light had withdrawn, our quiet kept in the dignity of its retreat.

Eliot:
Same bones, three completely different people speaking.

Jack:
Exactly. The meaning's stable—you can still picture it—but the register shifts the tone, the mood, the whole stance toward the moment. That's where the real shaping power lies.

Samuel:
And if people learn to move between them, they carry more than one way of thinking in their heads.

Jack:
Which is the point. It's not about locking anyone into a tower—it's about giving them more rooms to walk into.

(A couple of heads nod around the fire; the kettle hisses softly as if agreeing.)

Eliot:
So let's say people here actually take this on—learn the registers, move between them. What does that get us beyond prettier sentences?

Jack:
It's not just prettiness. It's sovereignty. If you can choose your register, you choose your stance toward the world. You're not trapped in one tone, one way of naming things. That freedom changes how you experience reality.

Samuel:
Experience it—or shape it?

Jack:
Both. The way you speak about something frames it. If a crowd describes the same event in the same rhythm, same tense, same structure, they're building a shared version of it. But if they know how to shift cadence—slow it, heighten it, fold time into it—they can see the same event in more than one light.

Eliot:
So we'd end up living in a kind of shifting liguistic reality—where meaning moves with the register.

Jack:
Exactly. Picture a meeting in Sheffield. The first half's in a plain civic register—decisions, votes, agreements. Then, when it comes to the part everyone needs to *feel*—a remembrance, a binding promise—they slip into a slower cadence, let the grammar bend into something more like Aesthetic English. The change in the language changes the room.

Samuel:
You'd make cadence itself a political tool.

Jack:
A cultural one. Politics comes and goes—culture sets the deep rhythms. If we can make those rhythms flexible, people learn to steer their own perception. You can't have true sovereignty without that.

Eliot:
And you think people could pick this up? It's not exactly how they teach English in school.

Jack:
They could—because it's not about memorising rules. It's about learning to listen to the pace of your own thought, then matching the language to it. Once you've felt the shift, you can't unhear it.

Samuel:
So in your model, the sovereign person isn't just someone who casts a vote or runs their own affairs—it's someone who can choose the language reality they stand inside at any given moment.

Jack:
That's it. You own your words, you own the frame you live in.

Samuel:
There's something in what you're saying, Jack, that sounds almost… theatrical. This shifting of cadences—register to register—it's not just communication, it's performance.

Eliot:
Yeah. Like every time you change the register, you're stepping into a role. Which means it's not just telling the truth—it could be bending it.

Jack:
That's fair. It is performative. Every change is a choice, and every choice leans the scene one way or another. You slow the cadence, you bring a hush—people remember the moment as solemn, even if it wasn't. You sharpen the grammar, make it tight and declarative—you turn a loose thought into a fact.

Samuel:
So you're saying language becomes a deliberate act of reality creation.

Jack:
Exactly. And with that comes the shadow side—reality distortion. The same tools that can deepen meaning can tilt it, warp it, exaggerate it. You can make something small feel monumental, or strip the life out of something vivid until it sounds like a technicality.

Eliot:
And you think that's safe?

Jack:
It's not safe. But nothing worth having is. The point isn't to pretend we can take distortion out of human speech—it's to give people the awareness and skill to use it consciously. Then they can tell when it's being done to them.

Samuel:
So the shift isn't just a style change—it's an exercise of agency. A signal that says: "I'm choosing the frame, and I want you to notice."

Jack:
Right. A sovereign speaker knows when they're building reality and when they're bending it. The danger is when people don't even realise they're doing either.

Eliot:
Alright, let's bring this back to the ground. Say the north keeps pulling away from Westminster, building its own ways of running things. How does this language-shifting actually work in practice? You're not just talking about poetry at the market square, are you?

Jack:
No. I'm talking about the texture of decision-making. Picture a meeting in Sheffield—half traders,

half co-op reps, some folks from the Kommunes. You start in plain speech for facts and figures. Then, when you reach the proposals that affect how people feel about the city—its identity, its direction—you shift the register. You move into a cadence that carries weight. The change tells everyone: this part is binding.

Samuel:
So it's signalling through form. The register marks the moment as more than administrative—it makes it ceremonial.

Eliot:
And in doing that, you're shaping reality. You're saying: "this is the part that matters" before anyone's even voted.

Jack:
Exactly. You use language as a frame for reality, so that decisions aren't just written in minutes—they're felt. That way the binding moments carry across different towns and Kommunes, even if they've never met.

Samuel:
You realise that's governance. Not in the old parliamentary sense, but in the sense of creating the shared fabric that holds a political order together.

Eliot:
And it could be just as powerful as law—maybe more so—because it doesn't look like law.

Jack:
That's the point. In a post-state system, you need ways to coordinate without summoning a new capital city into being. Shared registers and cadences can do that. They let sovereignty stay distributed while still holding everyone in the same conversation.

Samuel:
If it works, it's elegant. But it also means you've moved from being a cultural tinkerer to being an architect of the order itself.

Jack *(with a faint smile)*:
Maybe. But in a world like ours, the architecture has to be spoken before it can be built.

Samuel:
You know, what you're describing reminds me of Mises—consumer sovereignty. The idea that in a market, it's the buyers who ultimately decide the shape of production. But here, it's not goods—it's language.

Eliot:
Here we go.

Samuel:
My family actually knew Mises.

Eliot:
We know they did.

Samuel:
And he'd say that in the same way high-spending customers bend the market toward their

preferences, high-powered users of language—people who can wield the word, the logos, with precision—bend reality toward their vision.

Jack:
Meaning the best speakers get to define the frame everyone else lives in.

Samuel:
Exactly. It's not fair in the playground sense, but it's inevitable. Whoever uses the language most effectively becomes the gravitational centre the rest orbit.

Eliot:
So in your model, it's not "the people" shaping the shared reality—it's the ones with the strongest grasp of the register.

Samuel:
That's my point. You can talk about distributed sovereignty all day, but in practice, the patterns will form around those who can work the cadences best.

Jack:
Which is why part of the project is training more people to do exactly that. If we don't, the gravitational centres won't be chosen—they'll just happen, and we'll all be living inside someone else's sentence.

Samuel:
Then the question is—who decides what's "good" use of language?

Jack:
Nobody. Or rather, everybody. The point isn't to fix a style—it's to make people aware that style is choice, that every sentence has an architecture, and they can build their own.

Eliot:
But you do see where this lands, right? You talk about distributed sovereignty, but if the gravitational pull always forms around the best speakers, we're basically back to an elite. A philological class.

Samuel:
More than that—a cognitive class. Not the aristocracy of birth, but of mind. And instead of land or titles, the currency's cadence and grammar.

Eliot:
Yeah. Swap out the cut-glass accent for the ability to hold a room in *Aristocratic English* and you've still built a ladder most people won't climb.

Jack:
Maybe. But here's the thing—it's easier to learn. Perfecting your grammar, your use of tense, your command of rhythm—that's a skill anyone can practice. You can't just wake up one morning and decide to have the King's English accent. That was gatekept by birth and schooling.

Samuel:
So in your model, the aristocracy's not hereditary—it's cultivated.

Jack:
Exactly. If you put in the time, you can rise in it. And because it's visible—audible—people can hear it and copy it. No boarding school required.

Eliot:
But you'd still have people who never bother.

Jack:
True. But that's the same with any art, or any craft. The point is, it's open. The tools aren't locked away in some London club—they're in the air, in the way we speak to each other.

Samuel:
And in that sense, it's meritocratic. The person with the most refined language shapes the frame—because they've earned the right to.

Jack:
Earned, yes—but also shared. The best of them will teach others, so the frame keeps widening instead of narrowing.

Eliot:
There's something I can't get past, Jack. In The Auerom, you had that story about the prophetic perfect—where a society was run on sentences that made the future sound like it had already happened.

Jack *(nodding)*:
Right. "This will have been the moment." That tense folds time so you treat the outcome as inevitable.

Eliot:
Exactly. And in your story it was beautiful—people used it to focus the mind, to bind themselves to the better version of the day. But a tyrant could take the same structure and twist it. Hack a form of English so the whole society starts thinking their rule is inevitable.

Samuel:
That's linguistic tyranny. Change the register, change the reality—and lock everyone into it before they even notice.

Eliot:
Yeah. If someone controlled the dominant cadence, they could bend the shared frame so tight no one could speak outside it. You wouldn't need censorship. The language would do the policing for you.

Jack:
That danger's real. But it's not unique to what I'm building—it's true of any language. Every political slogan, every national myth, every schoolbook carries some version of it. The only defence is to make people fluent in more than one register, so they can step outside whatever's trying to trap them.

Samuel:
So the antidote to linguistic tyranny is… linguistic sovereignty.

Jack:
Exactly. The more ways you know to speak a thought, the harder it is for someone to own it for you.

Eliot:
But you can see why I'm pressing this. If you succeed, you're not just giving people new words—you're giving them a new operating system. And operating systems can be hijacked.

Jack:
Which is why it has to be open source.

Samuel:
Open source, you said. You're borrowing that straight from the cypherpunks.

Jack:
Why not? Code is language. And language is code. If you treat it that way—shared, modifiable, forkable—you stop it being owned by one centre of power.

Eliot:
But language isn't just lines in a repo. People grow up inside it—it's wired in.

Samuel:
Chomsky would agree with that. He'd say we're born with a universal grammar, like an operating system baked into the brain. You can skin it however you want—French, English, High English—but the kernel's the same.

Jack:
Exactly. And just like software, you can tweak the interface, add modules, change the defaults. That's what register work is—new modules.

Eliot:
But if someone controls the updates, they control the whole system.

Jack:
Which is why it has to be distributed. No central authority saying "this is the correct form." Instead, communities fork it, remix it, pass it around. If Bamford's cadence differs from Sheffield's, that's fine—as long as people can still read each other's versions.

Samuel:
So linguistic freedom means not just freedom to say what you want, but freedom to reconfigure the language itself.

Jack:
Yes. The old states hated that—because if you can change the grammar, you can change the frame reality sits in. They wanted the frame fixed.

Eliot:
And now you're saying: make the frame editable.

Jack:
Exactly. Let people patch reality the way they'd patch code. A shared repo of expression that anyone can contribute to, and anyone can fork if they don't like the direction it's going.

Samuel:
That's elegant—if it works. The risk is that without a steward, it fragments too far and you lose the mutual intelligibility that makes it worth having.

Jack:
True. Which is why the work isn't just invention—it's translation. Making sure the forks can still talk to each other. That's how you keep sovereignty without losing the commons.

Eliot:
Here's what worries me. You open-source English and let every region fork it, and in twenty years you don't have one language—you've got a patchwork. Sheffield's cadence isn't just different from Bamford's, it's incomprehensible to someone in Devon.

Samuel:
That's not far-fetched. The country's already split in how it speaks. Give it a push and you could see whole regions sculpting the sound to their environment. Scotland might harden the consonants, draw in a Norse edge from old Orkney speech. Down south, where the air's soft and the wine's dear, you'd get a more lyrical French-inflected flow.

Eliot:
And up here in the north—industrial roots, heavy rhythms—you might see something more Germanic in its structure. Short, solid, machine-fit sentences.

Samuel:
Which means if a miner from Barnsley walks into a civic meeting in Kent, half of what he says lands like code from another operating system.

Jack Stone:
It could happen. But remember, shared cadences don't have to erase local colour—they just have to bridge it. You could have a Sheffield register that works for home use, and a broader, mutual register for cross-regional talk.

Eliot:
Like a trade language?

Jack:
Exactly. The old empires had them—Lingua Franca in the Mediterranean, Church Latin in Europe. But instead of enforcing one accent or one canon, you keep the core modular. Regions can bolt their own textures onto it without losing the ability to speak to the rest of the network.

Samuel:
That's the trick—balancing the strength of local identity against the risk of total fragmentation.

Jack:
It's the same with code forks. Too many and the project dies. But just enough, and you get innovation without breaking the build.

Eliot:
Except here, the "project" is reality itself.

Jack:
I don't think fragmentation has to be the end of the story. Look at Internet English—it's already a

dozen dialects in one. Memes, gaming slang, corporate PR tone, text-speak, academic Twitter threads—half the people online slip between them without even noticing.

Eliot:
True. You can go from “LOL” to “therefore it follows” in the same thread.

Jack:
Exactly. And that’s a kind of fluency no state ever planned for. People carry multiple registers in their heads now—switching on instinct. The danger isn’t that you have lots of forms of English. The danger is if you lose the ability to move between them.

Samuel:
So the goal isn’t one perfect form—it’s training people to be polyglots inside a single language.

Jack:
Yes. Interchangeable, different, and beautiful. A northerner could speak in the clipped, heavy beats of an industrial cadence at home, then shift into a lyrical southern register when the conversation calls for it, and maybe drop into an aesthetic online form later that night. Each one tells a different truth.

Eliot:
So the art is in the switching.

Jack:
Right. It’s like music—you don’t have to pick one key for the whole song. If you know the transitions, you can play with tension, release, surprise. That’s how language becomes not just communication, but craft.

Samuel:
And that craft—done well—becomes a kind of shared culture, even if the accents and cadences themselves are wildly different.

Jack:
Exactly. The bridges matter more than the borders.

Samuel:
Alright, let’s make it real. If Bamford’s the birthplace of High English—what does it sound like? Not just the idea, Jack. The sound.

Jack:
It’d carry the place in it. Slow, like the valley air. Words held just long enough that you hear the stone behind them. Not clipped like the south, not industrial like the north—something with room for the moor wind to pass through.

Eliot:
So… measured. Almost meditative.

Jack:
Measured, yes, but not heavy. Bamford’s High English would keep its consonants clean, but soften the edges—no wasted syllables, no rush to the end of a sentence. Cadences would rise and fall in a way that lets the listener *sit* with each idea before the next arrives.

Samuel:
Like a well-laid path—you feel guided, but never pushed.

Jack:
Exactly. And there'd be a precision to it—not fussiness, but clarity. You'd hear the craft, but it wouldn't show off. In the same way this place builds dry stone walls—functional, beautiful, no mortar, but each piece placed exactly where it belongs.

Eliot:
Would it borrow from the old forms?

Jack:
Some. You'd hear traces of King James Bible cadence, but lighter. A touch of the Quaker plain style. And because we're here in the Peaks, you'd find local turns of phrase folded in, not polished out.

Samuel:
So the first dialect of High English isn't about purity—it's about holding the place in the voice.

Jack:
Yes. It's about speaking in a way that makes this valley present, even if you're on a stage in London. A dialect that carries its origin like a watermark.

Eliot:
And then, in twenty years, people will come here trying to copy it, the way tourists put on fake Scottish burrs.

Jack:
Maybe. But if we do it right, it won't just be an accent to mimic. It'll be a practice—something you have to live with to speak.

Jack:
Alright. *Picture this—not a translation from Standard English, but something born here.*

(He takes a breath, lets the pause hang just long enough to pull them in.)

Jack:

"This night is having been the stillness we shall yet remember."

Eliot:
That's not… quite past, not quite future.

Jack:
Exactly. The tense sits forward and back at the same time. It tells you the meaning is fixed, even though we're still in it. Bamford High English would use that a lot—this sense that the present is already part of your memory.

Samuel:
That's very Aureom. But the shape's cleaner.

Jack:
Cleaner, yes. And listen—

"The fire was in its quieting before the wind is carrying it forward."

That’s a doubled tense. First clause feels like the embers are already settling; second clause pushes the motion into the future *without breaking the moment*.

Eliot:
It bends time without making it sound like a riddle.

Jack:
That’s the point. In Bamford High English, grammar doesn’t just mark when something happens—it tells you what kind of *relationship* you have to that moment. Is it closing? Opening? Fixed? Still unfolding?

Samuel:
So it’s not just a dialect—it’s a temporal instrument.

Jack:
Yes. And because it’s here in the Peaks, the register would be grounded—rooted phrases, long vowels, a patience in the delivery. But it’s also hypermodern: it uses grammar like code, so you can nest timelines, layer moods, and still have it sound natural.

Eliot:
Natural to you, maybe. I think half the country would need subtitles.

Jack:
At first. But once you start hearing it, you realise it’s just another way to point at the world—and in some ways, it points more exactly.

Jack:
Go on then, Samuel. Try it yourself. Take the line I just gave—“The fire was in its quieting before the wind is carrying it forward”—and see if you can shape it. Think about the grammar, the time-bending.

Samuel:
Alright. If the first clause is already in process, and the second clause pushes it onward, then the pattern is: *ongoing-past into assured-future*.

(He pauses, then speaks slowly, almost testing the code as he goes.)

“The valley was in its waiting while the dawn is in its breaking.”

Jack:
Good. You caught the hinge—“was in its” to “is in its.” That’s the rhythm of Bamford.

Eliot:
Alright, let me try. Something less poetic, more grounded.

(He glances at the food pot simmering near the fire, then clears his throat, speaking with a rougher cadence.)

“The stew was in its thickening as the mouths are in their hungering.”

(Laughter ripples around the circle.)

Jack:
See? That works too. It doesn’t have to be lofty—it can make the most ordinary moment feel charged.

Samuel:
So the rule is: take an act that's ongoing in the past, and bind it to a parallel act that's ongoing in the present or future. The hinge is the *was… in its* / *is… in its* frame.

Jack:
Yes. That's the Bamford structure. Past-in-motion meeting present-unfolding. It locks the moment as if it's already being remembered, while still living.

Eliot:
It's strange—it makes you feel the now more sharply, because you're already seeing it from the other side.

Jack:
Exactly. That's why I think of it as High English—it elevates the pitch of the ordinary. The stew, the dawn, even this fire—they become moments you step *into*, rather than just drift past.

Jack Stone:
What you're doing now—this is the act. Shaping cadence into form. Every sentence like this tweaks reality's lens.

Samuel:
Then let's formalise it. Rule one: the hinge of Bamford High English is the dual-temporal frame—was in its followed by is in its. Past in process, present or future in unfolding.

Jack:
Good. That gives us a spine.

Samuel:
Rule two: the subject is always concrete—fire, valley, stew, dawn. No abstractions. You ground it in the tangible, then let the grammar elevate it.

Eliot:
You're already turning it into a textbook, Samuel. That's not what this is.

Samuel:
If you don't codify it, it collapses into mush. You'll have a dozen half-formed versions floating around and none of them will carry weight.

Eliot:
Or you'll strangle it before it breathes. Language is a stream—it moves because it bends and splits. The moment you wall it in, you've killed it.

Jack:
Both of you are right. The grammar gives us an anchor. But if it ossifies, it stops being a register and becomes a law. Bamford High English has to live in the middle: rule-like enough to be recognisable, loose enough to keep shifting with the speaker.

Jack:

"The word was in its making while the meaning is in its flowing."

Samuel:
Yes! That's rule three: Bamford English works in pairs. A form in motion, tied to its echo. No isolated clause.

Eliot:
Alright then, Jack. You've given Bamford its cadence. But what about Sheffield? If this is going to spread, my city deserves its own dialect. Help me shape one—something… more romantic.

Jack:
Romantic Sheffield.

Eliot:
Steel and smoke on the outside, but under it—we're a city of songs, of rivers, of stubborn hope. Give me a register that doesn't just clang like a forge, but sings like a heart.

Jack:
Alright. Sheffield's High English would keep its toughness, but stretch the vowels—give space for longing. Where Bamford binds the past-in-motion with the present-unfolding, Sheffield would pair the hard with the soft, the forged with the flowing.

Eliot:
Show me.

Jack:

"The steel was in its burning while the river is in its singing."

Eliot:

"The steel was in its burning while the river is in its singing." Yes. That feels right. Strong, but tender.

Samuel :
Rule one of Sheffield High English: pair the industrial with the romantic.

Eliot:
I'll take that. Give me another, Jack.

Jack:

"The streets were in their labour while the lovers are in their walking."

Eliot:
That's it. That's Sheffield. Work and love, grit and grace.

Jack:
Then you've got your dialect. Sheffield High English isn't about time like Bamford's—it's about tension, about binding contrasts. The hard and the soft, held in one breath. You should know—my version of High English isn't just Bamford's dialect. It's what I'd call the highest form. The cognitive elite. The very top register possible.

Eliot:
Elite? Sounds like you're back to Samuel's aristocracy again.

Jack:
Yes. But not of birth or wealth—of attention, of craft. It's something I built from years studying Tolkien's philology. Not the words, but the way he built a whole world into the cadence. Each sentence a structure, carrying history in its bones.

Samuel:
So you're saying Bamford is the experiment, Sheffield is the romance, but your *true* High English is for those who can bear the weight of its grammar.

Jack:
That's right. And now, I'm going to challenge you. All of you. Let's see if you can keep this fire-side talk alive—but not in Standard English. Speak only in your own High English, the dialect you feel belongs to you.

Eliot:
A test, then. Sheffield against Bamford against Jack's secret English.

Samuel:
And London will sit in judgment.

Jack:
Not judgment—practice. Think of it as trial by cadence. Each of us holds a dialect. Now we see if we can sustain meaning when the language itself is shifting under us. Alright then, let's talk about last night's rave. Let's see if you can hold it in High English.

(The audience chuckles; a few heads turn knowingly. Jack lets the silence stretch, then begins.)

Jack:

The night was in its surging even as the lights are in their burning. And I, in the pulse, was in my finding—her face among the crowd, her lips were in their waiting, and my kiss is in its remembering still.

(He glances toward a woman in the circle—Mara—who blushes, half-hiding her smile. Laughter ripples through the group.)

Eliot:

The bass was in its pounding while the hearts are in their trembling. And Sophie—aye, Sophie—was in her swaying while I was in my leaning. The moment was in its sparking though the kiss is in its breaking.

Samuel:

The floor was in its shaking while my steps are in their wandering. The crowd was in its pressing as my hours are in their vanishing. The night was in its holding even as I was in my losing.

Jack:

So it was: each of us in our weaving, each of us in our vanishing. The rave was in its storming while our selves are in their altering. And memory, even now, is in its binding of us to the night.

Sophie:

The crowd was in its rushing while our names are in their whispering. The music was in its swelling as my steps are in their slowing. For we are in our hiding, Eliot, while the eyes are in their watching.

Sophie:
That's why we don't go out much, Jack. Eliot's too bloody high-profile. Everywhere he goes, people are watching. It's easier for us to stay away.

(A pause. Then she looks directly at Jack, her tone playful but pointed.)

Sophie:
But tell me—what are the rules for *your* High English? You've got Bamford's grammar, Sheffield's romance. Yours is… different. Heavier. Where did you pull it from?

Jack:
Mine isn't made for ease. It's a discipline. I compiled it from three strands.

(He ticks them off with his fingers, like listing ingredients for an alchemy.)

Jack:
First, Aristocratic English—what I call the elevated register. Long vowels, deliberate cadences, words chosen for gravitas. It isn't about pomp, but about weight.

Second, Latin tense structures—the future perfect, the prophetic perfect. To speak in ways where what has not yet happened is already complete. It shapes the listener's sense of inevitability.

And third… Tolkien's Elvish. Not the words themselves, but the *form*. He built languages that carried entire histories inside their sounds. I studied how he did it, and I used those principles to braid memory and presence into English.

(The circle is utterly still now, the fire snapping in punctuation. Jack looks around, his voice measured and intimate.)

Jack:
So mine is less dialect, more architecture. A register not just to describe, but to command attention—maybe even reality itself. That's why I call it cognitive elite. It takes training, discipline, and reverence. Not everyone will want it, nor should they.

(Sophie tilts her head, half-curious, half-skeptical.)

Sophie:
Sounds closer to sorcery than speech.

Jack *(smiling faintly)*:
All true language is sorcery. Some just hides it better.

(Jack reaches into his coat pocket, pulls out a worn page folded in four. He smooths it against his knee, the firelight catching the ink. The circle falls into a hush. He lifts his voice—calm, measured, almost ceremonial.)

The night was in its crowning even as the dawn is in its rising.
The silence was in its deepening while the word is in its binding.

The path was in its vanishing as the step is in its finding.
The kiss was in its sealing though the breath is in its breaking.

The fire was in its quieting while the wind is in its carrying.
And this moment was in its ending, even as its echo is in its living.

(The cadence is strange—at once foreign and familiar, as though it carries more time than it should. The syntax bends toward inevitability, the prophetic perfect shaping the ear. Around the fire, faces are lit in orange glow, some mouths slightly open, some brows furrowed in thought.)

Jack:
This is what I mean. Each line holds two times, two realities, one closing and one opening. It binds them together so the ear cannot leave without carrying them both. That is the power of High English. Not just speech, but architecture.

(Silence. Sophie exhales audibly, Eliot runs a hand through his hair, Samuel scribbles something quickly into his notebook. The circle feels heavy, elevated, as if the fire itself has been tuned into a different register.)

Jack:
Now it's your turn. High English isn't for ornament—it's for bending the world. Samuel, Eliot… I challenge you. Take your dialects. Speak as though what you say is not memory, not description, but reality itself. Bend us to it.

Samuel:

The valley was in its sheltering while the night is in its lengthening. The fire was in its keeping as the cold is in its fleeing. We were in our holding even as the danger is in its passing. The Kommune was in its building while the world is in its breaking.

(For a moment, the night feels steadier—the fire warmer, the valley closer, the circle tighter. The Bamford dialect bends everything into a sense of safety and endurance. Several listeners nod unconsciously, as if agreeing with a truth that has been made tangible.)

Jack:
Good. That is Bamford: time as shield, language as refuge.

(He turns, eyes alight, to Eliot.)

Jack:
Eliot. Sheffield. Let's see if you can make us feel your city.

(Eliot grins, nervous but emboldened by the challenge. He leans into the firelight, his voice softer than Samuel's, but carrying a romantic thrum.)

Eliot:

The steel was in its shining while the heart is in its opening. The street was in its labour though the song is in its rising. The smoke was in its veiling even as the kiss is in its keeping. And Sheffield was in its breaking while the dream is in its mending.

(A different hush falls—the hard-soft binding of Sheffield's cadence. For a moment, the smoke from the fire feels sweeter, the labour of the day softened into tenderness. Someone in the circle sighs aloud, almost dreamily.)

Jack:
There. You see it? Samuel bends the night into endurance. Eliot bends it into longing. Both true, both real—and for the span of a few breaths, the world shifts to their cadence.

Jack Stone:
It's not enough to bend the night. Bend *yourself*. Sovereignise it. Speak your own world as if no one else could. Not description, not memory—*reality by decree.* Make yourselves sovereign in language.

(A tense pause. Samuel's jaw tightens. He exhales slowly, then begins, voice hard and deliberate, Bamford cadence anchoring him.)

Samuel:

My strategy was in its weaving as the board is in its clearing.
The Kommune was in its binding while the world is in its breaking.

I was in my planning even as the danger is in its fleeing.
And the future was in its bending while my hand is in its steadying.

Jack:
That's it. Samuel sovereign. Language as command.

(He turns to Eliot, who has been listening intently, a furrow in his brow. Jack gestures, inviting.)

Jack:
Now you, Eliot. Claim your own world.

Eliot:

The steel was in its counting while the market is in its turning.
The bank was in its watching as the workers are in their earning.

The coin was in its fleeing though the trust is in its binding.
The city was in its breaking as the freedom is in its mending.

I was in my lending as the Kommune is in its keeping.
And Sheffield was in its rising while the world is in its reckoning.

Jack:
Good. That's Sheffield in sovereignty. Labour and ledger woven as one.

Jack:

The word was in its shaping while the silence is in its yielding.
The tongue was in its binding as the thought is in its bending.

I was in my naming even as the world is in its forming.
And language was in its crowning while the people are in their dwelling.

The Auerom was in its sealing though the future is in its opening.
And I was in my speaking even as the city is in its listening.

Sophie:
Jack… you seem to be bending reality more than speaking it. I don't even know if I understood what you actually said just now—only that it felt like something shifted.

Jack:
I said, in simpler English: language is shaping us while silence is giving way; speech crowns thought, and people dwell in it. I named myself in the act of naming, as if the world itself were forming through words.

(He glances around the circle, then back to Sophie.)

Jack:
But that's the point of High English. It's not for easy understanding—it's for *feeling*. It shapes reality in cadence, not clarity. You don't just hear it—you live inside it.

(He leans back a little, eyes catching the firelight, and raises his voice again, slower, more deliberate, shaping another phrase. His gaze sweeps across the circle as he says it.)

"The beauty was in its gathering while the night is in its crowning.
The faces were in their shining even as the fire is in its hallowing.
And this circle was in its blessing while our seeing is in its weaving."

That's what I mean. Not description—creation. Not just words, but presence.

Samuel:

The fire was in its keeping while the night is in its holding.
The circle was in its gathering though the world is in its scattering.

I was in my thanking even as the company is in its giving.
And Jack was in his bringing while the thought is in its seeding.

And this was in its trial though the future is in its bending.

Samuel*:*
Now I see it. You weren't just spinning metaphors—you were showing us how to bend the air. To make presence out of cadence.

Samuel:
But here's the thing, Jack. If this works—and it does—then what stops it from being turned? From gratitude into obedience? From presence into command? Isn't this the very root of propaganda? What you call High English could bind people. But binding doesn't care if it's for beauty or for tyranny. A poet can bless a night… but a tyrant could sanctify obedience the same way.

Eliot:
Come on, Jack. Don't dress it in poetry. This is propaganda—just beautiful, lyrical propaganda. You bend people to feel what you say, not to think about it. There's no way around that.

Jack:
Yes, Eliot—if only one voice does it. If I stand above and declare, then it's propaganda, I won't deny it. But imagine if everyone did. Imagine if each of us sovereignised ourselves. Not a single cadence controlling the room—but a hundred cadences, a hundred realities, speaking into one another.

Jack:
When Samuel bends Bamford into refuge, you feel safer. When you bend Sheffield into dream, we feel longing. When I speak beauty into the circle, you see each other differently. If everybody can

do this, then we live inside the very best versions of each other. My reality put onto you, yours onto me, until the room is thick with presence. That isn't propaganda. That's mutual sovereignty. A republic of language.

Samuel:
But Jack—look at the structure. You call it mutual sovereignty, but at scale? Those who master the cadence, those who wield it with precision—they rise. Always. That's not mutual, that's hierarchy. A cognitive class. Isn't language, by its nature, tilted toward those who command it best?

Jack:
And what's the aim of sovereign individualism, Samuel, if not for everybody to shape the world purely in their own image? Why should there be authorities telling us how we're allowed to speak, how we're allowed to think, what cadence is acceptable? *S*ome will bend the word more powerfully than others. But that's always been true. What I'm saying is: open the field. No parliament to sanction speech, no academy to gatekeep grammar, no monarch's English. Just sovereign voices, each shaping their world. If some rise higher, it's because their reality resonates. Not because an institution crowned them. That's the core of it. High English isn't about control—it's about release. Not fewer realities, but more of them. Not propaganda, but plurality.

Eliot:
Plurality sounds noble, Jack. But you know as well as I do—it doesn't stay that way. Too many voices, and people seek the loudest, the clearest, the one that promises order. That's how cults are born. Look at Thorne. He wasn't even a philologer, and still people bent themselves around his words.

Samuel:
Then let's stop circling and test it properly. Jack, you've shown us beauty, gratitude, even constitution. But if you were to wield High English as power—if you were a leader, if you meant to command—how would you shape it? How would you write a piece of propaganda to make people follow?

Samuel:
After all, Nietzche was a philologist too. He bent cadence, imagery, repetition—made whole nations walk to ruin. If you claim this sovereignty, show us the edge of it.

Jack Stone:

The people were in their scattering while the city is in its falling.
The rulers were in their lying though the truth is in our speaking.

I was in my naming even as the order is in its breaking.
And you were in your following while the dawn is in its making.

This was in its crowning though the tyrants are in their fleeing.
And the nation was in its rising as the word is in its sealing.

The life was in its wandering while the meaning is in its crowning.
The hours were in their wasting though the word is in its keeping.

I was in my calling even as the world is in its emptying.
And you were in your following while the fire is in its binding.

Cast down your scatterings, lay down your fragments—
For the circle is in its sealing while your lives are in their giving.

The answer was in its keeping while the question is in its dying.
The doubt was in its fading though the command is in its crowning.

I was in my sealing even as the world is in its yielding.
And you are in your bending while the word is in its binding.

Only I am in the answer while your paths are in their ending.
And my speaking was in its final while your following is in its perfecting.

Therefore—every command is in its obeying.
Every breath is in its giving.
Every hand is in its serving.

Eliot:
God—do you hear yourself? That's the nightmare right there. If this *catches on*—if people actually learn to speak like that—it wouldn't even take a dictator. They'd tyrannise themselves. Bend their own lives into whatever command sounded the clearest.

Sophie:
It felt… inescapable. Like the words had already made the choice before I could think about it. If everyone had that cadence, how would we resist?

Samuel:
The danger isn't just a tyrant at the top—it's tyranny woven into the fabric. The cadence itself could compel. If this became the common tongue, society might march itself into chains without ever realising it.

Jack:
Or—depending on who speaks—it could make the world more beautiful. More spiritual. More poetic. A tyranny of grace, perhaps. A discipline of wonder The language doesn't decide. The speaker does. Same tool, different hand. You can hammer, or you can carve.

Eliot:
Alright, Jack. Enough of crowns and chains. You've shown us the tyrant's tongue—now show us something else. Show us *beauty*. Pure beauty. Not power, not command. A world where the only reality you shape is one worth beholding. Can you?

Jack:

The storm was in its carrying across the sea while the cliffs are in their standing without movement. The water was in its lifting before the wind is in its bending of every tree. The sky was in its breaking, and yet the silence is in its returning once the thunder has spoken.

I was in my watching of it, even as the world is in its unmaking and remaking at once. You were in your breathing beside me, while the air is in its thickening as though every moment had weight. The wave was in its rising, and we already knew it was in its falling, though it had not yet touched the shore.

The light was in its piercing through the canopy, and the shadows are in their scattering though they seemed so certain a moment before. The stone was in its keeping of centuries while the moss is in its softening of time. The dawn was in its opening, even as the night is in its holding of what was.

And I was in my speaking of it now, while the stars are in their wheeling without end. The silence was in its deepening, and the infinite is in its stretching beyond measure. What we were in our seeing was more than we are in our saying, but still the language is in its shaping of what passes through us.

Sophie:
So… let me try. You said "the wave was in its rising, and we already knew it was in its falling though it hadn't touched the shore." In normal English that's just… "the wave was rising, and we knew it would fall before it even hit the land." Right?

Jack:
Exactly. But notice how the High English form holds the moment — not just the rise or the fall, but both. The inevitability and the presence at once. That's what I mean when I say it shapes reality: it catches the whole gesture, not just a slice.

Eliot:
Fine, but how are you supposed to actually talk like that? A whole conversation? People don't speak in riddles.

Jack:
You slip back, when you need to. This isn't about replacing every word — it's about lifting certain moments. Normal talk for most of life. High English when you want the world to tilt a little.

(He looks between them, the firelight throwing his expression into shadowed seriousness.)

Jack:
But let's not just talk about it. Let's try. An experiment. The three of us, right here, right now — a conversation in High English. About something ordinary. See if we can hold it, bend it, carry it. Pick something. Yesterday's rave, tonight's fire, or just the way the stars are in their wheeling above us. And then we speak it — not as it was, but as it *is* in its shaping.

Jack:
Alright, then. Let's try this properly. A three-way dialogue in High English. Not just fragments — a conversation, sustained. But first—what should we use?

(He turns to the small circle of faces gathered. There's a murmur of suggestions, half-serious, half-playful.)

Sophie:
Talk about the Test match — bend reality around cricket. See if your language can make that beautiful.

Daniel:
Or Thorne's arrest. That's closer to the bone, isn't it? Try to shape the meaning of it.

Tara:
Or sovereignty. Post-state order. If High English is meant for big things, then give it a big thing.

(Jack glances at Samuel, raising his eyebrows as if to pass the responsibility on. Samuel straightens, folds his hands together, and speaks with his usual measured authority.)

Samuel:
We'll start with sovereignty. The others can come later, lighter or heavier. But if this experiment means anything, it has to show it can carry weight. Not a game of words around cricket, not gossip about Thorne. Sovereignty is the heart of what's breaking open now. So let's see if High English can bear it.

Jack:
Sovereignty it is. Then let us speak it — not in report, not in slogan — but in shaping. Three voices, one fire, one attempt to bend the present into speech.

Jack:
State was in its thinning though the people are in their rising.
Parliament was in its speaking but the street is in its shaping.
Sovereignty was in its writing on paper, yet the voice is in its leaving that paper behind.
I was in my seeing of it — the rule that is in its ending, even as the freedom is in its beginning.

Samuel:
Order was in its holding, but the fields are in their owning of themselves.
Law was in its carrying, though the hands are in their working without it. Sovereignty was in its claiming of crown and chamber, yet the fire is in its belonging to those who gather round it.
I was in my speaking of it now — the authority that is in its loosening, even as the Kommune is in its binding together.

Eliot:
Ledger was in its keeping though the people are in their trusting beyond coin.
Banks were in their measuring, but the market is in its unmaking by the crowd.
Sovereignty was in its centring in London, yet the north is in its holding of itself without asking leave.
I was in my saying of it — the city that is in its fading, even as the Kommune is in its shining like steel in morning.

Sophie:
It sounds… like you're not describing, but *declaring*. Like you're pulling a different world into being just by speaking it.

Jack:
That's the point. Sovereignty isn't just politics. It's in the saying.

Samuel:
Crown was in its holding but the people are in their shaping.
Sovereign was in his throne, though the ground is in its feeding us without his blessing.
Sovereignty is in its standing only where the Kommune is in its living.
I was in my speaking — the order that is in its ending, even as the Kommune is in its beginning.

Eliot:
Kommune was in its binding, but the north is in its remembering itself.
Fields were in their greening, though the factory is in its shining with its own fire.

Sovereignty is in its bending southward, yet the steel is in its carrying of our own law.
I was in my saying — the people that are in their strength, even as London is in its forgetting.

Jack:
Parliament was in its speaking, but the language is in its holding of the true power.
King was in his naming, though the word is in its unmaking of kings.
Sovereignty is in its grammar, in its tense, in its cadence that is in its bending of minds.
I was in my speaking — the self that is in its sovereigning through the sentence, even as the world is in its remaking.

Samuel:
Then your sovereignty is in its isolation — a single voice sovereigning itself. That is not enough.

Eliot:
And mine is not in its isolation, but in the region that is in its lifting together. Sovereignty as steel, forged by many, not one.

Jack:
And yet both of yours are in their needing the word. Without the tongue, the sovereignty is in its silence. And silence is in its nothing.

Samuel:
Land was in its giving long before the law is in its writing.
Soil was in its feeding when the crown is in its taxing.
Sovereignty is in its circle, not in its throne.
I was in my speaking — the earth that is in its binding us, even as the city is in its breaking us apart.

Eliot:
Forge was in its blazing when the parliament is in its sleeping.
Steel was in its shaping of men while the south is in its forgetting of us.
Sovereignty is in its striking of hammer on anvil, not in its debating of empty halls.
I was in my saying — the north that is in its sovereigning, even as the south is in its faltering.

Jack:
Kommune was in its forming, but the word is in its commanding.
People were in their shouting, though the grammar is in its guiding.
Sovereignty is in its cadence, in its shaping of thought, in its turning of silence to obedience.
I was in my speaking — the tongue that is in its sovereigning beyond land, beyond steel, beyond circle.

Samuel:
And yet without the circle, your word is in its vanishing. The voice that speaks alone is in its ending as soon as it begins.

Eliot:
Without the people, your tongue is in its hollowing. You sovereign nothing but your echo.

Jack:
Without the word, your people are in their silence. Without cadence, your sovereignty is in its blindness. The world is in its waiting to be shaped — and I am in my shaping of it now.

Jack:
Sovereignty is in its trembling.
Circle was in its holding, the steel was in its striking — but the word is in its binding of both.
Crown was in its vanishing, the parliament was in its thinning — yet the tongue is in its rising above them.
Sovereignty is in its bending to cadence, and the cadence is in its sovereigning now.
I was in my speaking — the world that is in its turning as I name it, even as you are in your hearing of it becoming.

Sophie:
Alright, enough. Before we all vanish into Jack's new world, let's bring it down a notch. If you want to prove High English works, why don't you all try it on something a little less… cosmic. Talk about cricket next. At least then I might keep up.

Jack:
Fair enough. Cricket it is.

Samuel:
The match was in its dragging through days, yet the final hour is in its quickening of all.
Bat was in its failing through the order, though Carter is in his standing at the crease.
The game was in its slipping toward India, yet the bowl is in its finding of the edge.
I was in my seeing — the crowd that is in its thundering, even as the sun was in its falling behind the stands.

Eliot:
Field was in its holding of breath, though Patel was in his flashing drives.
The ball was in its bruising of the pitch, though every stroke is in its echoing like steel on stone.
The day was in its bowing to the last over, yet the north is in its roaring as Mitchell is in his bending of fate.
I was in my saying — the crowd that is in its crying of joy, even as the shadows were in their stretching over Old Trafford.

Jack:
The test was in its measuring of endurance, though the game is in its collapsing to a single breath.
The bat was in its silence, the fielders in their circling — yet the word is in its naming of victory before the wicket is in its tumbling.
The nation was in its glancing — England in its holding, India in its striving — but the flow is in its bending all to this one strike.
I was in my speaking — the ball that is in its ending of the match, even as the crowd is in its living of it forever.

Sophie:
If you lot can make cricket sound like epic myth, I'd love to hear you try the weather. Come on, give us a forecast in High English.

Samuel:
The clouds were in their thickening this morning, though the valley is in its greening from the rain.
The wind was in its rushing across Bamford Edge, yet the stone is in its holding stillness.
The sovereignty of the weather is in its humbling of us — for we were in our coats, even as the sun is in its teasing of us now.

Eliot:
The sky was in its brooding when we left the city, though the moors are in their shining with sudden light.
The rain was in its drumming on the steel roofs, though the chimneys are in their steaming with it still.
The sovereignty of the day is in its shifting — grey in its power, blue in its promise — and Sheffield is in its taking both as its own.

Jack:
The weather was in its carrying of time — each cloud a sentence, each break of light a cadence.
The rain was in its naming of patience, though the sun is in its giving of sudden joy.
The sovereignty of the sky is in its grammar — storms in their commas, winds in their clauses, silence in its full stop.
I was in my speaking — the day that is in its composing itself around us, even as we are in our reading of it now.

Alright. Enough experiments for a moment. Tell me honestly — what do you all make of it? This way of speaking. The High English. Is it worth pushing further, or is it just smoke and mirrors around a campfire?

Samuel:
It has force. No denying that. It bends the air in a way normal English doesn't. But force can cut both ways. You can elevate, yes — or dominate. My worry is always: who gets to hold the cadence, and who is held by it?

Eliot:
I like it, though I'd never use it in normal life — not unless I wanted everybody to think I'd lost my mind. It works in here because we're listening for it. It draws people in. That's a strength. But it's also slippery. Half the time, I don't know whether I'm understanding it or just *feeling* it.

Sophie:
That's the point though, isn't it? You're not meant to just understand it — you're meant to feel it land. But I'll admit… it can feel like you're bending reality around us, Jack, and we're not always sure what's true and what's just cadence. It's powerful, but a bit… unnerving.

Jack:
That's fair. Maybe that's exactly the test — whether it frightens us, or frees us. You know, I should probably explain why philology matters to me in the first place. Philosophy asks what things mean in the abstract. Philology asks how meaning came to be. It's slower, closer to the ground. You trace the word, the sentence, the register — and in doing that, you start to see how entire worlds were carried in language.

I remember the first time I really felt it. I was about sixteen, and I stumbled on an old dictionary — the kind with etymologies at the back. I thought "hospital" was just a place where sick people go. Then I saw it meant *host, stranger, guest*. Suddenly, the building wasn't just bricks and beds, it was an ancient ritual of hospitality, duty, and care. That hit me harder than any philosophy textbook ever did.

That's the difference, for me. Philosophy builds castles of reason. Philology shows you that even a small word can be a cathedral. And once you've seen that — once you've felt how much power sits inside everyday speech — it's hard not to believe that language shapes reality more directly than law or politics ever could.

Jack:
And maybe that's why I'm here. Philosophy can give you arguments, but philology can give you tools. Tools that rewrite how we live together. Not just what we think, but the actual texture of life. That's the project. That's why I keep at it.

Eliot:
When I was younger, I thought philosophy was already niche — professors in tweed jackets arguing about whether a chair was really a chair. But now you, Jack… you've managed to find an even smaller corner and made it sound like the centre of everything. Philology. Who even studies that anymore?

Jack:
Not many, that's true. It went out of fashion over a century ago. Strange, when you think about it — Nietzsche started as a philologist. Tolkien was one, too, before he ever dreamt up Middle-earth. They both understood it: words don't just *describe* reality — they *make* it.

Take the Gospel of John: "In the beginning was the Word." That's not poetry for its own sake. It's saying language itself is the foundation. Existence spoken into being. Logos as architecture. That's what draws me in — every word we use carries centuries of sediment, but also has the power to strike new foundations if we learn how to wield it.

Eliot:
But hold on. Isn't that just philosophy by another name? You're still talking about meaning, truth, metaphysics. What makes your philology any different from the philosophers who chase those same ghosts?

Jack:
Philosophy asks what truth is. Philology asks how truth is *spoken*. That's the difference. Philosophy builds systems and categories — philology listens to the ground beneath the words, the shifts in cadence, the way a society's whole mood can tilt just because of a tense or a phrase. It's slower, more technical, but also more dangerous. Because once you learn to trace those roots, you realise how fragile "truth" really is.

Samuel:
But if it's that fragile, Jack, aren't you admitting that truth itself can be manipulated — even fabricated — by those who control the words? That's not just dangerous. That's power. And I think you know it.

Jack:
Take Newspeak in Orwell — that's the classic warning. Shrink the vocabulary, shrink the thought. That's not philosophy, that's philology weaponised. Orwell understood that if you alter the shape of a word, you alter what people can even imagine.

It's the same reason Tolkien poured decades into Elvish before he ever wrote *The Lord of the Rings*. He wasn't just making up sounds — he was building the skeleton of a world. The grammar, the cadences, the tenses — they gave Middle-earth its weight, its reality. Without philology, it would just have been another fairy tale.

And Nietzsche — well, he started as a philologist before he became the mad prophet. His ear for language gave him those aphorisms, those sharp turns of phrase that bite even now. Imagine if he'd only been a philosopher — we'd be reading him like Kant: heavy, systematic, impossible. But instead, his philology made him musical, dangerous, unforgettable.

Eliot:
So what you're saying is, without philology, *The Lord of the Rings* might've ended up as a thousand-page treatise called *On the Phenomenology of Hobbits*.

Samuel:
Or *A Critique of Mordorian Reason*.

Eliot:
So if Tolkien had been a philosopher instead of a philologist, Middle-earth wouldn't have had elves and dwarves at all. It would've had, what — rival schools of thought debating in marble halls?

Samuel:
The Shire would be the Epicureans, living simply, drinking ale, avoiding politics. Gondor would be the Stoics — grim-faced, disciplined, obsessed with duty. Mordor, naturally, would be the Utilitarians, reducing everything to cold calculation.

Jack:
Exactly. That's the point. Philosophy tries to fix meaning into a system. Philology doesn't. Philology is about tracing what words meant *then* — what they carried for the people who spoke them, not just what they mean to us now. It listens backward. It's textured because it's layered.

If Tolkien had been only a philosopher, the story would be abstract — maybe clever, maybe rigorous. Because philosophy starts with ideas. Philology starts with words, with roots, with sound. Out of that comes myth, story, memory. It's why Middle-earth feels *alive and textured*. Every name carries the weight of a history. Every song is a shard of a forgotten tongue. You can feel time itself inside the language.

Philology studies the meaning of history itself, digs into the roots of words, the sediment of centuries. Tolkien did it better than anyone. He looked back into Anglo-Saxon fragments, old poems, half-forgotten sounds — and he pulled from them a mythology that England never quite had. His Elvish wasn't decoration; it was the foundation. It gave flesh to the myth because the words themselves carried time. That's what I tried with *The Aureom*. To root new meaning not only in the past, but in the present tense — to say: *this will have been the moment*. To give a grammar to lived experience so a community can feel itself as more than just transactions or chatter. In Bamford, in London, anywhere — the work is the same. Language is how you create a shared sense of time, of story. Without it, the Kommune is just bodies in a field. With it — it becomes a living myth.

Eliot:
So you're saying what Tolkien did for England, you're trying to do for… us? For the Kommunes, for London, for Sheffield?

Jack:
Not in the same way. He gave a myth looking backwards. I'm trying to give one looking *now*. He pulled from history. I'm trying to build a grammar of presence. But the principle's the same. Without philology, it's all just description. With it, maybe we create something people can actually live inside.

Samuel:
But if you succeed, Jack — that's not just art. That's foundation. That's power. You wouldn't just be describing community; you'd be *inventing* it. You'd be telling people what their lives mean.

Tara:
Jack… I need to say something. You talk about philology like it's pure creation, and I understand that. Nietzsche and Tolkien—yes, they reshaped the world through words. And no one here loves *The Lord of the Rings* more than I do.

But I'm not sure but of how that power was twisted. Nietzche was a philologist too. He knew the weight of words—their rhythm, their mythic pull. He turned a whole people's speech against itself.

(The circle is quiet; the only sound is the soft hiss of the coals.)

Tara:
So when you talk about High English, about crafting a grammar that can shape how people see the world, I just… I want to know you see that danger. That it can make beauty, yes, but it can also make obedience.

Jack:
You're right. I do see it. That's the shadow under every word. If language can sanctify, it can also curse. And maybe that's why this work has to stay human—spoken in firelight, not from podiums. The same power that heals can also wound.

Samuel:
So tell me, Jack. Have you thought about what comes *after The Aureom*? If you really mean to stand among the great philologers, you'll need more than one stroke. A high fantasy, perhaps — something in Tolkien's register. Or a work like Nietzsche's, a hammer to philosophy. Something to set the canon.

Jack:
I've thought about it, of course. Who wouldn't? But truthfully — I need a break. To live a little. Writing *The Aureom* nearly hollowed me out. And I'm not used to all this… (he gestures vaguely at the circle, the Kommune, the air of attention around him) …celebrity. The book only just out now, and already it's more than I bargained for.

Eliot:
That's modesty talking. You know *The Aureom* will sell — maybe not in the way of cheap thrillers, but it'll find its audience. Enough to make you a name. Enough to keep you from walking into a pub unnoticed.

Jack:
And that's exactly what unsettles me. I've never wanted to be a banner, a symbol. I just wanted to give people language. If *The Aureom* does sell, as you say, it'll carry me along whether I want it or not. Maybe that's good for the work. But for me? I don't know.

Samuel:
That's the price of founding a myth, Jack. Myths don't belong to their makers once they've left the page. They belong to the people who repeat them. If you're not ready for that, then perhaps you shouldn't have written it at all.

Jack:
Or perhaps I had no choice. If I'm honest, there are nights I wonder if all this — High English, *The Aureom* — is just vanity. Dressing ordinary feeling in grander grammar so it looks like philosophy. Sometimes I catch myself thinking it's nothing more than clever ornament.

Jack:
But then I remember Tolkien. Elvish began as a side project, a private indulgence really, and it became the seed of Middle-earth. He couldn't have imagined what it would grow into. And I think — maybe High English could be that for me. A beginning, not an end.

The truth is, I haven't thought that far ahead. I don't know what form it will take, or if it will last. Right now it's just an experiment, a way of giving shape to the present. But… (he exhales, half a laugh without mirth) …if Elvish could carry a whole world, maybe High English could carry something too.

Eliot:
That doesn't sound like vanity to me. That sounds like someone stumbling into something bigger than he meant to.

Samuel:
Or someone building the foundation of a cathedral and pretending he's just stacking stones.

Samuel:
Enough hesitations, Jack. Vanity or not, you've built something. Don't leave it hanging in the air. If High English is to be more than a parlour trick, then give us a foundation. A piece we can work from. Show us what it really *is*.

Jack:
All right. A foundation, then. Not theory. A story.

(He pulls his battered notebook from his pocket, thumbs through a few folded pages, and then begins to read aloud. His voice steadies, takes on that cadenced edge again — half ordinary, half elevated.)

Jack:

I awoke at the first spill of dawn, the valley holding its breath in the quiet light. The stone walls of the longhouse caught a faint pink glow as the sun crept over the eastern ridges. In that moment, it felt as though the world was in its waiting even as the morning was in its breaking. Each breath was deep and slow, scented with pine and damp earth, and my heart responded by matching that rhythm.

Around the circle of fire the others stirred. We had gathered for the ritual of sunrise—empty of words until now—letting the stillness itself speak. The silence held us together as the first birds began their song. In that pause I thought of all the things we had yet to say.

When at last I spoke, it was barely above a whisper, but my voice carried the cadence of the valley itself. "The dawn was in its coming even as the last star was in its fading. The stone was in its enduring as the river is in its awakening. We are in our listening even as the world is in its forming." For a moment the words hung between us like smoke. Then the elder nodded, and others began to add their own lines to the chant.

"The day was in its rising while the night is in its yielding. The river was in its gliding as the oak is in its blooming. We were in our gathering even as the valley is in its greeting."

Each voice took up the pattern—was and is entwined—carrying the meaning through steady breath. We spoke of light catching dew on bracken, of stone walls holding our stories, of our history being woven into the path we walk. A child at the edge of the circle watched wide-eyed, as if seeing sunlight for the first time.

When it ended, we sat in silence, the transformation complete and yet just beginning. The ordinary stones and ashes of last night had become sacred by the act of naming. By speaking those words into the dawn, we had stretched this moment across time—part memory, part prophecy, wholly alive. I could feel something shift beneath the skin of the valley, as if the land itself leaned closer to listen.

After a time, an older woman—her face carved by a thousand seasons—smiled. "You spoke true, son," she said softly. There was no ceremony in her voice, just warmth. "You have made the morning ours."

I found my voice again, calm and steady. "It is given to us, and we in turn are its keepers. Each day the valley gives us beauty, and we carry it in our voices." Her eyes glinted with tears of joy. "Then speak it into all the days ahead," she urged.

I watched the sun rise higher, turning the moor grass to gold. In that moment I felt myself changed; the valley had made speech itself into something alive within me—each syllable a stone in the wall of the dawn, each line a step on the path. I knew I would never again speak with the clipped certainty of city air. My words now would always carry the valley's slow, deep patience.

The morning unfolded around us in simple grace: we gathered bowls of porridge, pulled on woolen cloaks, and stepped outside to tend garden and flock. Every gesture felt quietly magnificent, ordinary tasks becoming part of the sunrise's hymn. When a child tripped on a root, the laughter that followed was gentle and luminous, as if even joy here knew not to hurry.

Before the fire was fully cold, I took my turn in the morning reading. The passage I wove was not just any prayer, but verse born from our valley soil:

"The beauty was in its gathering while the mist is in its lifting. The faces were in their shining even as the sun is in its crowning. And this morning is in its blessing while our living is in its weaving."

In each line I felt the valley echoing back. When I finished, the circle was silent, but breathing differently—heavier with meaning, lighter with hope.

Memory comes to me now: I recall the streets of London, a thousand unbreathing dawns and grey cobblestones, each day the same hurried promise that seldom came true. I remember how my throat felt, how every word I spoke there was choked by asphalt. Here, among these quiet hills and open faces, language has become something new: a living thing we share.

The afternoon light fell pale on our shoulders as we dispersed. I lingered by the river's curve, fingers trailing in the cold water. The current around the stone felt familiar—the flow I had always sought in my voice. Overhead, the sky was endless, and a lone hawk drifted high above.

"The river was in its singing even as my heart is in its settling," I whispered, thinking of the chant. In that breath I recognised a completeness I had only glimpsed in dreams.

And so I continue: each day stepping into silence and speaking the valley. The world outside may change like weather, but here our beauty becomes ours in each naming. I have become nothing less than a conduit for the slow dawn of this place. And the story of our sunrise carries on, word by patient word.

Jack (hesitant, shrugging):
It's just a reflection of what I felt this morning. Nothing more.

Luna:
No. Don't diminish it. What you've done — it carries weight. That's what I wanted you to bring into the Kommunes. That chant of *was* and *is* — it folds time, gives the present both memory and prophecy. Do you realise the power in that? With such cadences, a leader could shape an entire people's sense of themselves.

Eliot:
Samuel's right. This is the stuff of propaganda, Jack. If words can make porridge feel like sacrament, imagine what they'd do in the hands of a tyrant.

Jack:
I won't deny the danger. But the point isn't tyranny. It's sovereignty. Philology roots us in the soil of our own speech. High English gives us cadence enough to make the world textured, alive. If a tyrant used it, yes, he could bend reality. But so could each of us. That's the difference. It's not a weapon for one — it's a grammar for all.

Samuel:
And yet you see the risk. Nietzche was a philologist too. He turned cadence into chains. What you've written tonight could be used the same way. Don't pretend otherwise.

Jack:
I don't. I know the risk. But what's the aim of sovereign individualism, Samuel, if not to give each of us the power to shape the world in our own tongue? Without authority. Without permission. The tyrant bends language for himself. I bend it so every man, every woman, can sovereignise their own speech.

Eliot:
Or so you hope. But power never stays evenly spread. High English might yet prove the sharpest blade in the armoury of control.

Sophie:

You know… whatever this is, however far it goes… tonight it just made me feel closer to all of you. Closer to this valley. Like the words held us here, together.

Eliot:

Closer than half the meetings we've had in Sheffield. Maybe that's worth more than all the theory.

Samuel:

Not everything has to scale, Jack. Sometimes it’s enough that it works here, for us, now.

Jack:

Then maybe that’s all High English needs to begin with. Not power. Not prophecy. Just presence.

They fall into silence. The circle breathes together. Sparks rise into the night, drifting like small stars. The valley holds them in its quiet, and for a while no one reaches for language at all.

Chapter 21:

Manchester looked calmer than it was.

Thorne stood at the tall window of the apartment and watched the rain move softly across Deansgate in silver ribbons, the city below glowing with that peculiar northern amber that came when wet streets reflected too much electric light. Six months ago the atmosphere had carried pressure inside it — a visible tension in the movement of people, in the overheated conversations pouring from bars and co-working spaces and half-converted warehouses. There had been velocity then. A dangerous kind. The sense that the city was approaching some irreversible articulation of form outside the state.

Now the city felt smoother, but slower. Tate did not have his intensity.

He watched groups move beneath umbrellas in loose currents between restaurants and late cafés, dressed in the new aesthetic that had spread outward from the Peaks and down into Manchester proper. Heavy wool coats. Technical fabrics softened by earth tones. Gold jewellery worn without irony. Beautiful people speaking more quietly than they used to. Even the posture had changed. Straighter backs. Slower gestures. Less stimulant twitch in the body. The city had absorbed the rupture and turned it into texture.

Thorne rested his forehead briefly against the cold glass.

They had arrested him under emergency sedition legislation pushed through Parliament in less than four days. Four days to construct legality around panic. He remembered reading the wording in the holding cell and almost laughing at how visibly frightened the state had sounded in its own syntax. Not precise. Not principled. Reactive. A government attempting to criminalise articulation itself. The deceleration, as he well knew, was meaningless in and of itself.

Then there was the two. Eliot Ashton and Samuel Ashcombe who sat untouched across the Pennines with half the north’s computational infrastructure somewhere in the hills of the Peak District.

Behind him, the apartment remained sparse. Steel shelving. Dark oak floors. Books stacked horizontally in unstable towers beside the walls. Three monitors asleep on a long concrete desk facing the opposite side of the room. The place still looked like it belonged to someone midway through leaving. Or midway through beginning.

The buzzer sounded once.

Thorne turned from the window slowly and checked the time. Theo Kincaid was exactly on schedule. Thorne opened the door before the second buzz arrived.

Theo Kincaid stood in the corridor with one hand in the pocket of a dark navy overcoat, rain still glistening faintly along the shoulders. Older than Thorne had expected. Not physically imposing. But composed in that distinctly American way that suggested deep institutional confidence rather than social performance. There was a Man with life in his face. A face which carried none of the exhaustion of airports or conferences, that had not become softened with the ravages of post-liberalism. He looked as though he moved through systems with a pure rustic breeze on him.

For a moment they held each other in clear sight of mutual weight, until Kincaid gave a brief nod that cut through the exchange and dissolved, without ceremony, the recognition Thorne had already begun to assume was his due.

“So,” Kincaid said at last, voice low and even, “you’re real.”

Thorne gave the faintest trace of a smile. “Disappointing, I know.”

“Not at all.”

They shook hands once. Firmly. No theatre in it.

Kincaid stepped inside, eyes moving briefly across the apartment—the books, the monitors, the unfinished geometry of the place. He seemed to understand it immediately.

Outside, Manchester continued glowing beneath the rain. Inside, the atmosphere sharpened.

For several seconds neither spoke. Then Kincaid walked toward the window and looked out over the city with the detached concentration of someone studying an unfolding legal experiment.

“The Festival of Ideas,” he said eventually. “I’m told Whitehall now refers to it internally as the Festival of Bad Ideas. Civil Service humour,” Kincaid continued.

Thorne moved toward the kitchen and poured two glasses of water from a bottle left on the counter.

“The irony,” he said, passing one across, “is that it worked—four of the most prominent figures now sit within thirty miles of me, including Jack Stone, whose work has begun circulating widely through the United States and beyond; New York has taken notice.”

Thorne gestured lightly toward the city below. “Manchester could have destabilised after the power outage and leadership vacuum. Instead it reorganised itself around the protocols I implemented. Consumption held. Small business growth accelerated. Property values absorbed the shock inside weeks. Informal capital networks deepened instead of collapsing.” Thorne leaned against the counter. “I built redundancy correctly.”

“Yes,” Kincaid said. “You did.”

The words hung there for a moment longer than expected. Not praise. Recognition. Kincaid took a slow sip of water before continuing.

“But Ashton,” he said carefully, “misunderstood the nature of exposure.”

At the mention of the name, something in Thorne’s posture hardened almost invisibly.

“He thought his visibility and meekness was its own legitimacy,” Thorne replied. “That if you can expose a system clearly enough, the system would simply legitimate it. He applied monetary tyranny to his own currency to push Ashcombe into siding with him.”

“So you blame Ashton?”

“I think he cut into us because he mistook it for rational to get Sheffield above Manchester. Sheffield is too small, Manchester is already a world leader. Sabotage, no matter is there is no proof, should not be forgotten. Neither should the State’s reaction.”

Kincaid nodded slowly, as though confirming a private conclusion.

“The reports I received suggested he went too deep into printed too much Sheffcoin. He opened too many holes in his own economy.”

“He wanted to quicken the pace,” Thorne said. “As did I.”

The rain intensified softly against the glass. For several moments they listened to the city hum beneath them.

Then Kincaid spoke again.

“And Ashcombe?”

Thorne’s expression altered slightly at the name. Not anger. Something colder.

“Ashcombe understood timing.”

“Meaning?”

“He kept his mouth shut and was a primary investor in Manchester. We have now bought him out. He will be overflowing with capital now.”

Kincaid’s eyes narrowed slightly with interest.

“He has never declared anything about the sanctity of his own stack,” Thorne continued. “Never articulated anything about sovereignty. Never framed what he was building in terms the state could prosecute cleanly. He stayed infrastructural. Compute. Energy. Logistics. Financial abstraction. By the time Whitehall understood the scale of what was happening with Ashcombe in the Peaks, it was already economically entangled with Sheffield and half of Greater Manchester. Plus too anti-fragile too dismantle.”

“And now?”

Thorne looked back toward the city.

“Now they’re too useful.”

Kincaid was silent for several seconds after that.

Then he said quietly:

“The Peaks concern me more than Sheffield.”

That got Thorne’s attention.

Kincaid stepped closer to the window, watching the lights spread across the wet northern dark.

“Sheffield remains political,” he said. “Messy. Urban. Negotiated. Human. But the Peaks…” He paused slightly. “The Peaks are becoming something else. Ashcombe is getting himself a lot of power. He has powerful connections that is starting to become obvious. The name Ashcombe goes back.”

Thorne said nothing, but nodded. He had done his work on the Ashcombe name.

“The amount of capital now moving between Manchester, Sheffield and the Peak District is extraordinary,” Kincaid continued. “The Kommunes are no longer countercultural. They are becoming productive organs of code and compute. Infrastructure clusters disguised as cultural movements. Manchester is a real industrial economy with engines and high quality services rivalling the best London has to offer.”

Thorne folded his arms.

“Ashcombe is now getting enough compute to provide the balance of power between Sheffield and Manchester. To say nothing of how London is reacting. Where exactly Stone was picked up from, I am not certain, but he is London.”

“Yes,” Kincaid said. “And they revealed themselves while releasing it.”

For the first time since entering the apartment, Kincaid’s composure shifted slightly—just enough for genuine concern to become visible beneath the precision.

“I’ve seen the estimates for their compute power,” he said quietly. “Do you understand what level of power that implies?”

Thorne looked at him steadily.

“I understand exactly what it implies.”

“And what do you make of Stone?”

“I’ve read *The Aureom*,” he said at last. “He understands atmosphere better than the rest of them. Better than Ashton ever did.”

Kincaid watched him carefully.

“But?”

Thorne was quiet for several moments before answering.

“He still believes in forms.”

Kincaid turned slightly.

“In the Platonic sense?”

“In the aesthetic sense,” Thorne replied. “Which is more dangerous.”

He walked slowly back toward the concrete desk, resting one hand against its edge.

“Stone thinks beauty precedes structure,” he said. “That if language becomes beautiful enough, if culture becomes high enough, then systems will orient themselves naturally around it. That atmosphere can generate coherence and that in turn causes beauty, or, as he might say, an aureom.”

“And you disagree.”

“I think beauty emerges from successful systems,” Thorne said flatly. “Not the other way around. A jet engine is real.”

The room settled around the sentence.

“He sees beauty in appearances,” Thorne continued. “In cadence. Texture. Desire. Human feeling elevated through language. But the actual beauty is underneath that. In the systems themselves. In the precision of coordination. In infrastructure that holds under pressure. In code that survives contact with reality. That is what keeps things going."

Kincaid listened carefully.

"Stone fetishises form itself," Thorne said. "Ashcombe operationalises it."

"Stone would say aestheticists form. And you?"

For the first time, the faintest trace of amusement crossed Thorne's face.

"I stress-test it."

Rain hissed softly against the glass.

"The problem with Stone," he continued, "is that he still believes beauty redeems contradiction. That if London becomes beautiful enough again—socially alive enough, erotically alive enough, linguistically alive enough—then the underlying fractures become tolerable and generates its own meaning." He shook his head once. "That's aristocratic thinking. Deeply English. Beautiful surfaces that attract but do not last."

Kincaid folded his arms loosely.

"And yet his influence is growing."

"Yes," Thorne admitted. "Because he understands exhaustion. People are tired of flatness. Tired of managerial language. Tired of speaking like compliance software. Stone gives them atmosphere again but he doesn't change anything. Kafka with beauty, is still Kafka."

Kincaid studied him carefully now.

"And Manchester?"

Thorne's eyes narrowed slightly, returning fully to the city.

"Manchester is stable."

"Because of you?"

"Because I designed it like that."

That answer seemed to interest Kincaid more than anything else he had said so far.

Thorne moved back toward the window. "Connor Tate did what he needed to do," he said quietly. "But he has flattened the momentum."

The lights of the city shimmered beneath the rain.

"The industrial economy is still producing," Thorne continued. "Advanced fabrication. Logistics. Materials processing. Software contracting. Manufacturing output stayed intact because I stopped treating Manchester like a revolutionary symbol and started treating it like an operating structure."

Kincaid nodded faintly.

"So what's the response to Sheffield? You waited for London to respond, and you got Stone. Who you have not been able to argue against. Ashton's review of The Aureom has made him an overnight success. To say nothing of Stone's popularity in the United States."

At that, something colder entered Thorne’s expression again.

“Ashton should have stuck to academic philosophy. He pushed too aggressively into competing with Manchester. He is not an economist, he’s pushed Sheffield into inflationary growth. We have stuck to deflationary growth.”

Kincaid’s eyes sharpened slightly. “Are you familiar with Ricardo?”

“Ricardo was done away with.” Thorne said.

Kincaid’s faint smile touched the corner of his mouth. “You think to clearly in systems and a form of truth with in un-abstractive. I will say nothing more on that.”

The apartment had darkened further now, Manchester reduced to clusters of amber and white light beneath the rainclouds. The city no longer felt feverish. It felt consolidating. Thickening into something harder.

Thorne walked back toward the kitchen counter and poured himself another glass of water.

“What exactly your interest here? The United States is a wide open space.”

Kincaid watched him carefully for a moment before answering.

“At first,” Kincaid continued, “the Peaks Kommunes were treated as eccentric crypto-regionalism. Interesting, profitable in places, aesthetically novel. But suddenly after the Festival… things changed.”

He moved slowly through the apartment again as he spoke, hands lightly folded behind his back now.

“There are many American funds quietly exposed to Northern capital investments. Data storage. Distributed compute. Precision manufacturing. Energy balancing systems. Rural land acquisition. Experimental logistics. Some of it indirect. Some of it very direct.”

Thorne’s expression tightened slightly.

“How direct?”

Kincaid looked toward him.

“There are people in California who think Ashcombe is building the first viable post-urban civilisation. Techno-Hippies.”

Kincaid let the silence sit longer than was comfortable, as if testing whether the room would fill it for him.

When he spoke, it was more direct than before.

“I am here because the United States and Britain are beginning to share the same post-liberal stress points, but at different stages of resolution.”

He glanced toward Thorne.

“The language differs. The institutions differ. But the underlying pressures do not.”

A slight pause.

"In America, they still appear as political disagreement. In Britain, they have already become administrative reality. Whole councils do not function. The people know it is all over, but do not act. In the United States, they begin to act when they notice these things."

He stepped away from the window now, slower, as if allowing the argument to take shape under its own weight.

"And because of scale, what happens here sometimes completes itself faster. Not always. But often enough to matter."

Thorne gave a short, almost dismissive breath.

"So what is this," he said, "Greece to America's Rome?"

Kincaid looked at him properly now.

"No," he said. A pause. "Rome conquered Greece many times. And then became it."

He let that sit, without elaboration.

"Civilisations do not move in straight lines of inheritance. They move in cycles of absorption. The question is not who follows whom. It is what gets metabolised first, and at what cost."

Kincaid did not answer immediately.

When he did, it came in the same steady register, as though he were continuing a line of reasoning already in motion before Thorne had spoken.

"They are content, for now, with how the situation in the North is being played out."

A pause.

"The state tolerates it because it has not yet decided whether it is constraint or advantage to have a booming northern economy. At present it behaves as though it might be both higher tax revenue on the one hand, less reliance on London on the other."

He walked a little further along the room, hands still loosely behind his back.

"But the condition is already visible. Economic growth in the North is beginning to act as a kind of structural political pressure. Businessmen, not politicians become powerful. People begin acting as if they are genuinely at liberty on an island this small. A few missed tax payments at pub, become outright tax rebellions. Society starts heating up in a way not seen for quite some time."

He glanced out again, briefly.

"Jack Stone has, in his way, created a texture that sits easily across the country to obfuscate that. It is adaptable. Portable. It moves well through the current environment."

A faint hesitation now, as if he were choosing the next part carefully.

"But philosophy cannot always be implemented so easily. Hence the tyrant saying they can implement the philosophy from the top down.

Kincaid watched him for a moment longer, as if the question had already been answered and he was only waiting for Thorne to catch up to it.

"And your next move?" he asked finally.

It was not rhetorical. It was procedural.

Thorne did not hesitate.

“The economy and society,” he said. “That is where it’s going now. Capital is starting to flow properly. Ashton’s manoeuvres have made sure of that. Manchester culture won’t be taking anything from Sheffield.”

A brief pause.

“It’ll go its own way. Manchester will go it alone.”

He said it as a conclusion, not a prediction.

Kincaid nodded once. Not approval. Not disagreement. Recognition.

He crossed the room and placed a thin folder on the table between them.

“The official Department of State report on your arrest and release,” he said. “In case you want a clearer account of how you have been recorded from the outside.”[ii]

Thorne did not reach for it immediately.

Kincaid’s voice stayed even.

“If you want in on the British arrangement,” he said, “you are more than welcome to it.”

A pause, just long enough to make the offer feel like something already decided elsewhere.

Then he added, almost casually:

“I am going to the Peaks.” He adjusted his coat slightly, as if the thought had only just become relevant. “I am going to stop by and see Jack Stone.”

Thorne watched him gather himself as if the conversation had already begun to close.

“How are you getting there?” he asked. “There are drivers. Cars waiting.”

“I have my own transport,” he said.

Thorne frowned slightly.

“You brought something into the country?”

Kincaid nodded once.

“A superbike. Sentinel 1901.”

That changed the air in the room a little. Not dramatically, but enough.

Thorne looked at him properly now.

“I’d like to see that,” he said.

Kincaid did not object.

They took the lift down together.

“Ireland was excellent,” he said, resting a hand lightly on the frame. “You can, if you manage it correctly, drink Irish whiskey all the way around the country and still arrive in one piece.”

A pause.

"It helps if you do not hurry it."

Thorne gave a short exhale that might have been amusement.

"And Scotland?"

"I am going there next."

Thorne nodded toward the machine.

"You'll want the A82," he said. "If you're heading that far north. It's the only road worth the trouble."

Kincaid considered that.

"I will take it under advisement."

The conversation thinned on the descent, dissolving into fragments of half-finished thought before silence claimed the rest. By the time the lift opened into the underground car park, the world had changed. The air was colder here, denser with concrete and machine-oil, stripped of the city's glass altitude and returned to something more elemental.

And there it stood.

Not merely a motorcycle, but an argument against restraint.

It rested beneath the light like some American dream rendered in black metal and velocity — long, predatory, impossibly composed. Its bodywork framed in dark shadows, curves broken only by seams of bronzed arteritis that snaked across its frame, curving through it. It was low to the ground but built with the muscular confidence of overwhelming power, it looked less parked than the car park was built around it.

The engine was exposed in muscular precision, a cathedral of forged steel and mechanical violence waiting beneath polished black. Twin pipes curled from its body. At the front, the headlamp burned in a clean white ring, not warm but deliberate — the cold eye of a machine built to devour distance. It belonged neither entirely to the present nor to nostalgia. This was not retro America, nor some European fantasy of speed. It was something more ambitious: America imagined forwards. Muscle translated into futurism. A superbike for endless interstate horizons and cities not yet built.

Kincaid approached it without ceremony. He did not admire it; men like him rarely admired things that had become extensions of themselves. He swung a leg over the frame with practised ease, settling into it as naturally as a pilot entering a cockpit.

For a moment there was stillness.

Then the engine awakened.

The sound cracked through the enclosed concrete space — deep, mechanical, impossibly clean. Not the ragged growl of something old, but the sharpened thunder of controlled force. The bike vibrated beneath him, alive now, and eager.

Kincaid charged the bike forwards toward the exit ramp, city light spilling in ahead like the beginning of some private frontier. And when he opened the throttle and disappeared into the night, it was with the unmistakable feeling that he was not escaping the city at all, but outrunning the century.

Thorne, smirked to himself, before heading back to his apartment, looking at the official report, Kincaid had let him see.

Chapter 21:

The motorway fell away behind Theo Kincaid in long ribbons of light and wet black tarmac as he rode out of Manchester and into the Peaks. He preferred roads that ran straight and hard towards the horizon - but England built its roads twisting through stone and hill.

The Sentinel 1901 climbed into the High Peak under skies of rain-cloud and thin, quiet fog. Its engine carried a steady note of roaring thunder between wet English trees—as drips of rain fell onto his bike and MR Visor. The road tightened as he climbed. Bent sharply. He twisted into long and deep curves.

The High Peak came towards him in stages: black ridges, valleys filled with drifting mist, dry-stone walls running across the hills like old stitching that had held long after the cloth had changed. Here and there, a farmhouse held a warm square of light against the wet night; small and steady, as if civilisation had chosen to keep watch rather than expand.

America had space. Britain had closeness.

Cloud lay low across the hills now, brushing the moorland in slow movement. The Sentinel moved through it cleanly. A small village appeared without announcing itself, set along a narrow street where light from a pub window fell warm onto wet stone. People stood outside under coats, speaking quietly, cigarette ends glowing briefly in the dark. Nothing about them seemed strange. Just life continuing at its own pace.

Kincaid passed through without slowing. The village fell away behind him as easily as it had appeared. Wide dark shapes under cloud, reservoirs catching fragments of wind, wind moving through long grasses in slow, patient waves. The land felt both old and unfinished.

Britain was changing, but not in a way that was being announced. London still in its careful administrative language, while movements gathered elsewhere—northward, outward, sideways—through capital, culture, and quieter forms of organisation. It was not clear yet who was directing it. Or whether it needed directing at all.

The Sentinel carried him on through the Peaks, steady and unhurried, as the country opened and closed around him like weather learning the shape of land.

Kincaid turned off a defined stretch of road and let the Sentinel drop onto the open moor.

The change was immediate. Tarmac gave way to earth, heather, and old waterlogged ground that bore heft if not beauty. The machine did not hesitate. It adjusted as if the distinction between road and landscape had never been real in the first place—suspension recalibrating in real time, posture settling into the unevenness like it had found its proper register.

The Sentinel idled with a quiet, contained violence the bike had at low throttle. Kincaid knocked his hand against his visor and a display screen opened up.

The world updated.

Contours of terrain appeared in his view. Invisible infrastructure came into view as faint digital lattices lines—energy flows, buried energy lines, logistical seams running under farmland and old industrial cuts became visible to him within the visor. The Peaks were not just hills. They were a map of data.

With a roar of the Sentinel it roared back into life moving through the High Peaks, steady throttle, letting the machine follow the land as much as he did. The terrain tightened again, hitting multiple rock formations until he turned back on himself, and then back into long, empty stretches of moor.

There was no sign of High Peak One.

Not on the maps. Not in the satellite data he had. Not even in the secondary datasets that usually picked up on things before they admitted their own existence.

He increased speed slightly—not to hurry, but to widen the search radius in motion. Somewhere in the Peak District, perhaps into Derbyshire, he knew, Ashcombe's should have been visible in fragments. But here in the Peaks, everything was a blank. Dry-stone walls. Weather. Elevation. The echoes of a land that held a great history that they had forgotten all about, a history contained only in those damn walls everywhere.

Kincaid exhaled once. The readout from the bike was still active searching for anything. Still nothing. No resolved search. No labelled site. Just faint pressure points—which turned out to be villages.

Kincaid slowed.

"Alright," he said under his breath, not frustrated, just confirming the nature of the problem.

Kincaid kept moving through the Peaks without resolution. High Peak One remained absent in the only sense that he no idea where it could be hidden. He rode on anyway, letting the Sentinel do what it was built to do: hold steady.

Then another sound entered the space.

A second machine came into the lane beside him—smaller, lighter, almost insubstantial compared to the Sentinel. He realised as it pulled up, where he had seen that shape before. A road-legal version of the speeder bikes Samuel Ashcombe had bought from Texas. It was stripped of style. Hard and black and hovering above the ground. It was built for acceleration and control rather than endurance. Floating and magnificent, it turned like it already knew where it was going before it lent into corners.

It drew level with him without effort. Kincaid glanced over at the woman in the cockpit.

She was mid-forties, possibly, though she could have looked younger if she had wanted to. Her hair was cut into an angular bob, deliberate rather than fashionable, the kind of choice that suggested she wanted to be remembered in a certain way by specific people.

There was a faint, controlled smirk at the corner of her mouth, not quite warmth and not quite challenge. Kincaid read it as familiarity.

She held him there for a moment—two machines moving in parallel over empty country.

Then she tilted her head once, a signal more than a greeting. Kincaid eased off the throttle and guided the bike into a widening verge. Luna drew in beside him and stopped cleanly. For a moment neither of them spoke. Just wind whistling across the high ground and the faint sense that the system had adjusted itself slightly to accommodate their presence. Kincaid lifted his visor.

“You’re lost,” Luna said simply.

He looked back out across the moor and then at the terrain.

“I know where I am,” he said.

A pause. Luna glanced at his display, then at the horizon.

“You’re looking for something,” she said.

Kincaid didn’t deny it. Instead, he nodded once.

“High Peak One,” he said. “Name’s Theo Kincaid. America’s finest Polymath. I was around at the festival. You must be something to do with Samuel Ashcombe.”

Luna gave a small, neutral acknowledgment. “Luna.”

Then she pointed slightly ahead.

“You aren’t close,” she said. “You missed it several times.” She looked at him for a moment before speaking again. You’re not the academic type, are you?” she said. “I was hoping you’d be one of those Harvard types.”

Kincaid looked at her for a moment, letting the question sit without giving it the courtesy of an immediate answer. “No,” he said at last. “I’m not Harvard.”

“We kept an eye on you, during the festival. No idea who you were.”

“Just Theo Kincaid.”

“Well if you want to come into High Peak One, you can start up by giving up all that kit you have. You aren’t bringing that in.” Luna said, glancing at his setup—helmet comms, pocket interface, the faint reflections of augmented layers still ghosting in his visor.

“All of it,” she added. “No devices. No overlays. No readouts if you want in.”

“Everything?”

“We have zero outside contact,” Luna replied.

He removed all his pocket interfaces first, then the secondary modules, then the smaller embedded connectors. Each piece came away cleanly. He dropped them into a bag.

“American polymath Theo Kincaid isn’t much to go on, as it turns out, we did try and search you.”

Kincaid gave a faint exhale that might have been amusement, or nothing at all. A pause. The two held their poses.

“I’d like to know who you are.”

Kincaid glanced at her then, briefly. “That’s a very English way of asking for potentially classified information,” he said. Luna didn’t react. “But very polite,” he continued.

“I ask who you are, because it matters.”

Kincaid nodded once, as if accepting, but said nothing more.

"You still haven't answered," Luna said. "You want to see Samuel."

"Yes."

"And probably Jack, if you can get to him. What about Ashton?"

A nod. " And I have information about Thorne to bring you," Kincaid said. "he is out of containment. Out of whatever category the Government had him in. There will be an announcement in due course."

Luna watched him closely now, as if checking for deviation in tone rather than content.

"And you facilitated that release?"

"I corrected a misunderstanding," Kincaid replied.

A faint shift in her expression—not surprise, but confirmation that the answer was not the end of the matter.

"That's not a neutral act," she said.

"No," he agreed. "Very little is."

They walked a few steps without speaking. The ground was uneven here, rising slightly towards the ridge, the wind sharpening as they climbed. Luna broke the rhythm again. "I don't like simple answers from people who aren't simple."

That got a glance from him. "No," he said. "You probably don't."

Luna continued. "So what is it. What do you want from Samuel."

Kincaid didn't answer immediately.

"Understanding," he said.

"That's not specific," she replied.

"Knowledge," he said.

"That's even less specific."

A pause.

"What about Ashton?"

"Smart man," he said.

"And Jack?"

That one took longer. "We would talk. Maybe mention what is being said about his work." Kincaid continue, more slowly. "Post-Bloomsbury is still some achievement."

Luna let out a short breath. "Some believe it was more than that. Ashton thinks it's good enough to be one of the greatest works of the 21st Century."

"It's too British," Kincaid said. "But it still has its place."

"I think you're afraid The Aureom might slip too quickly into the United States. It was very good."

He gave a faint shrug. "You're very hard work."

“I’m precise,” she replied.

“I know your type,” he said.

Luna didn’t look away.

“You still haven’t told me why you’re really here.”

“I have told you,” he said. “You just want more information.”

“You didn’t answer.”

“You will have found the answer by the time I leave.”

A pause.

“I hated that bit. Let us say *Gnosis* then.”

Kincaid almost twitched.

Then, lightly: “Do you often interrogate your guests?”

Luna gave a slight tilt of the head. “We never invited you,” she said. “You turned up.”

He didn’t deny it.

“Then you’ll understand,” she continued, “that you don’t just walk in from here. Not to High Peak One. Not to anything attached to it.”

Kincaid looked at her for a moment, then back toward the ridge line.

“A search,” she said. “Thorough. Physical. No devices, no carried comms, no passive logging. If you’re going further, you go in clean.”

Kincaid nodded once. There was no hostility in it. Just procedure—firm, practiced, final.

“That’s reasonable.”

A pause.

“And the bike?” he asked.

“You don’t bring it,” Luna said. “Not in.”

He glanced back down the slope.

The Sentinel still stood where he had left it—low, dark, and half-sunk into the moor’s uneven geometry. For a moment he said nothing.

Then he turned slightly away from it, as if reclassifying distance.

“Alright,” Kincaid said. “I’ll park it properly.”

He walked it further off the line of the track, following the natural break in the land where the moor dipped into a shallow fold. The terrain there was uneven—scrub, broken stone, patches of wet grass that swallowed light rather than reflecting it.

He eased the Sentinel into the hollow and killed the engine.

Above them, the Peaks held their shape in long, layered distance—dark ridgelines rolling into one another, cut through with low cloud that moved like a slow fog across the landscape. The wind came through in steady sheets, flattening the grass, then lifting it again as if the land was breathing in intervals.

The light was thinning now, not fully night, not still day—something transitional that made everything feel slightly provisional.

Luna was already in the speeder, waiting without impatience.

Kincaid stepped back onto the verge, took a final glance at the concealed Sentinel—half-swallowed by bush and slope—and then returned his attention to her machine.

Luna gave a small nod. “Then sit.”

He climbed into the seat beside her.

The speeder moved. Not a gradual acceleration, but a clean transition into power.

Kincaid sat still beside her, watching the land shift into layered geometry.

“You trust this thing,” he said.

“I know what it does under pressure,” Luna replied, hardly moving her fingers over the display.

Kincaid nodded once. “That’s usually enough,” he said. And they moved deeper into the Peaks, where caverns and high windy landscape became cut with rock and drops.

Luna turned the speeder into a couple of dirt tracks that Kincaid had driven down. Old moor roads, cut into the land in the usual way. Stone walls with just enough of a gap to get the speeder through, over the uneven cobblestone, behind a slow pack of deer, down through a small gorge whereupon the speeder cruised over a stream.

Luna didn’t slow. She didn’t even reorient. They were simply carried forwards and, without hesitation, turned straight through a line of scrub and dense bush that should have been an end to the track.

On the other side, the land changed.

Not dramatically. That was the point. It was subtle in the way good concealment always is—no sudden reveal, no obvious transition. Just a quiet rearrangement of what counted as a path. The moor opened into a new sequence of fresh narrow service routes, barely distinguishable from natural erosion. Then, without announcement, the speeder came out over a hill and into open space.

A construction site. Or something that resembled one at first glance.

Luna brought the speeder to a controlled stop at the edge of the worksite. The machine settled to the ground without complaint. Luna stepped off first. Kincaid stayed seated for a moment longer, taking in the scale properly.

Heavy equipment stood scattered across a wide excavation zone, lights mounted on temporary towers cutting into the dusk with controlled white glare. But the geometry was wrong for ordinary construction. The ground was being opened up, rather than prepared.

At the centre of it all was the mouth of something like a cavern.

Not natural. Not fully artificial either.

Rock had been cut back in clean, engineered planes, reinforced in places with steel ribs and poured concrete, but the scale suggested something older around it.

Activity moved around its edges: vehicles, surveying rigs, cable runs disappearing into the dark interior like veins feeding a buried system.

The speeder slowed as they approached the perimeter.

For a moment he didn't speak. The wind moved across the exposed site, carrying dust and the faint metallic smell of excavation.

Then he looked at Luna.

"This isn't official," he said, plainly.

"No," she replied. "It doesn't need to be."

The excavation wasn't a single cut into rock. It was layered. Expanded. Repeated. The cavern mouth was only the visible part of something that went further in, deeper, and wider than the hillside above suggested was possible.

Luna nodded once toward it.

"Samuel's building data centres in there," she said. "Proper ones. High-density compute. Huge stacks. Power routing. The whole thing."

Kincaid didn't answer immediately.

She continued, matter-of-fact.

"We can cut straight into the cave system if we need the space," Luna said. "It's only rock." She glanced back at him briefly, like the fact required no further defence. "A lot of people overthink it," she added. "It's not difficult to make dynamite. It miles and miles of space down there."

"You're giving me an awful lot of information now," Kincaid said.

"Common land," she said. Her tone stayed level, almost administrative, as if she were describing a boundary rather than issuing a warning. "The data centres are inside natural voids. We don't construct the space—we expand what's already there." A pause as she glanced toward the dark line of the excavation. "Nothing is hidden," she said. "Not really. It's just buried deeper than people bother to look."

He turned slightly, scanning the site again with a different logic now. "This is a store of capital," he said quietly.

Luna glanced at him. "Samuel's been emailing the Bank of Sheffield endlessly with tonnes of Post-Keynesian analytics about CapEx spending," she replied.

Kincaid nodded once, but didn't say anything. He looked into the cavern mouth, where light fell into darkness and disappeared cleanly.

If Ashcombe's Digital Stack was what people believed it was becoming—dense, distributed, quietly accumulating through capital and didn't leave a trace, this wasn't just engineering, it was massive capital accumulation. Large, patient, and buried.

“Money does incredible thing,” Kincaid said, as he and Luna walked towards the caverns. Rock had been taken down in layers—blasted, cut, reinforced, extended—until the cave system engulfed them and the temperature dropped straight away, and the view had become something else entirely: an expanding interior, part geological feature and part engineered void, part data centre. Inside, the light and dark coalesced into a brownish amber.

Massive computer rigs sat idly by, waiting to be buried deep in the rock, hidden for a decade or more, running with no human operators in sight. Everything was remote.

Luna moved through the cavern opening and around the fencing with ease as Kincaid followed at distance. A small corridor narrowed quickly, transitioning from open excavation to an engineered interior: reinforced walls, embedded lighting strips, cable conduits running in parallel lines like veins that had chosen direction. The sound of the surface faded behind them, replaced by a deeper, constant hum—the infrastructure breathing at scale.

At the end of the corridor was a control centre. Not a room in the conventional sense, but a carved-out room with glass partitions and suspended holographic screens floated in layered arrangements, showing geological mapping, energy flow diagrams, thermal distribution across subterranean zones.

Daniel was already there.

He didn’t look up immediately when Luna entered. He was watching a thermal readout that pulsed slowly across a subterranean grid.

“You’re late,” he said.

“I brought someone,” Luna replied.

That got his attention.

Daniel turned, taking in Kincaid with a brief, measuring glance—no surprise, only assessment. “Theo Kincaid,” he said, straight away. Kincaid didn’t correct him. “I saw you on the podcasts.” Luna said nothing.

Daniel gestured towards the display behind him. “You’re looking at the whole High Peak One layout,” he said, as if continuing a conversation already in motion. “We’ve gotten down to the water table. That’s what we wanted.”

Kincaid stepped closer to the glass. The model showed it clearly: the cave system intersecting with groundwater channels beneath the Peaks, vast subsurface flows moving slowly through fractured stone.

Daniel continued.

“The data centres generate excess heat. At scale, that’s not waste, its energy.”

He pointed to a second layer of the model.

“We drive superheated water up through deep geothermal fractures under pressure. By time it reaches surface, temperature differential’s violent enough to flash part of it straight into steam. At this scale that’s serious transfer rates — enough to spin closed-cycle turbines continuously and stabilise half t’grid if needed.”

Kincaid watched the layers shift on the screen: compute clusters above, thermals flow, water systems moving through geological architecture.

“And the distribution of the electricity?” he asked.

Daniel didn’t hesitate.

“Already built. Underground distribution loops run all across the Peaks now. Closed-grid system. We still keep industrial battery reserves — massive storage banks for load balancing when production spikes. Most o’ the excess gets pushed out across other Kommunes through microgrid relays, and what they don’t take feeds straight back into National Grid through our own substations. Keeps frequency stable, generates proper revenue, and every spare megawatt cycles back into compute.”

Behind them, the excavation continued its slow argument with the rock. Rigs turned in deep corridors. Heat moved through engineered channels beneath the Peaks. The land held its shape, but only just.

They left the cavern system the way they had entered it—without ceremony, without anyone stopping them.

Outside, the air felt colder.

The speeder remained where they had left it, a small, precise object in a wide field of stone and wind. Luna didn’t go back to it.

Instead she started walking.

Kincaid followed.

At first neither of them spoke. The Peaks opened around them in long, layered ridges—dry stone walls cutting across slopes. The ground rose steadily. Not steeply. Just persistently, as if the landscape had decided there was somewhere it expected them to arrive. Luna broke the silence first.

“You didn’t look too surprised,” she said.

“At what,” Kincaid replied, “the scale or the location?”

“Either.”

He adjusted his pace to hers without making it visible. “I’ve seen bigger in the States,” he said. “Just not underground in limestone country with this much capital attached.”

Luna glanced at him.

“You still haven’t said who you are,” she said.

“I have,” Kincaid replied. “He recognised me immediately.”

“No,” Luna said. “You’ve told people you’re a polymath. That isn’t the same thing as telling them who you are.” Kincaid gave nothing to that. “I would like to know,” she said.

The wind moved hard across the ridge for a moment, flattening the grass around them before passing on into the dark folds of the Peaks.

Kincaid looked ahead as he answered.

“I’ve met your type before,” he said. “You believe opaqueness is guilt. That if a man does not immediately explain himself, there must be something underneath worth extracting.”

Luna didn't answer. Kincaid continued.

"In America, people like you usually work around institutions formal work. Here everything is more social." A slight glance toward her. "Everything generates towards social status."

"That's not an answer," she said.

"No," Kincaid agreed. "It's context."

They walked a little further in silence. Then he added, more quietly:

"You know, when I got Thorne released, the first thing the Department of State asked me who I belonged to."

Luna looked across at him now.

"And you said?"

Kincaid gave a short shrug.

"I wanted him out myself," he said. "As it should have been three months ago."

The wind moved hard across the ridge, carrying the cold smell of stone and rain up from the lower valleys. Kincaid kept walking.

"That's the mistake modern governments keep making," he continued. "They assume ambitious men are supposed to belong to structures before they belong to themselves."

"And they aren't?" Luna asked.

"They are eventually," Kincaid replied, giving off a slight tailwind as his stride quickened. "But not at first. They belong to themselves, their own greatness and destiny, not to be a burden on others. A selfless act."

The path narrowed again between old walls half-collapsed into the grass.

"Plato understood that better than Governments can do, who allows the self-pity and the lower standards? The politician." Kincaid said. "The individual should ask themselves: what are standards other than excellence? Without that, everything falls away. Everyone remembers Plato's fears about Democracy because it sounds scary, tyrannical, and something to be resisted. Governments treat these warnings as simply the classics until it happens again; not as eternal return, back to the same inevitable point in which society descends into mobs, and those capable of something have nothing left to give but the almost mystical pursuit of excellence as a noble act. And yet, we still have his fear of degeneration."

Luna glanced at him. "You mean the fall of democracy into mob rule?"

"I do mean mob rule," Kincaid said evenly. "The point where a civilisation loses confidence in standards for each other and begins governing through selfish desire instead of judgment."

"That point is hardly unique to you."

A pause.

"Plato believed systems collapse in stages. Aristocracy into timocracy. Timocracy into oligarchy. Oligarchy into democracy. Democracy into tyranny."

“I have read it,” Luna said.

“It’s observational,” Kincaid replied. “Not action.”

Chapter 22:

The path narrowed without warning.

One moment it was still ridge-line track—stone underfoot, wind cutting clean across open moor—and the next it folded inward, as if the land had decided to withhold itself. Dry grass gave way to darker ground. The stone walls that had been loosely accompanying them broke off entirely, leaving only the suggestion that they had once been continuous.

The slope dipped gently, then rose again, and then, almost without announcement, the landscape opened into a clearing that should not have been there in any conventional reading of the ground.

In the centre of it, already present, were two figures. Samuel Ashcombe stood slightly back from the centreline of the clearing, as if he had chosen a position based on location rather than comfort. He did not look like a man approaching. Ashcombe looked like a variable held in place as the rest of the system worked around him. Beside him was Jack Stone.

Kincaid slowed instinctively, though no one had asked him to. Luna continued forward at the same pace, as though crossing into this space was not an arrival but a scheduled transition.

The clearing held them all for a moment without dialogue.

Just the arrangement: four figures, one space, the sense that whatever was happening had already been underway before any of them had chosen to notice it.

Ashcombe finally spoke without raising his voice.

“You took longer than expected.”

He stopped walking.

“So this is High Peak One,” he said.

Ashcombe gave a small correction without emphasis.

“It is wherever it needs to be,” he replied.

Kincaid kept his gaze on the clearing for a moment longer than necessary, as if the land itself still had something to disclose.

Then he spoke, almost casually.

“The scale of capital in this is starting to become non-trivial,” he said. “You don’t dig into limestone at that depth, build capacity like this, and route electricity the way you’ve routed it without sitting on something approaching major financial institute-level liquidity.”

Ashcombe didn’t react outwardly. Kincaid continued.

“And it’s not just sunk cost anymore. It’s compounding. Once you’ve got compute in cavities like that, you’re not paying for infrastructure—you’re amortising geology.”

Stone let out a quiet sound, almost a laugh. “That’s one way of putting it,” he said. “Cornering the market is another.”

Kincaid glanced at him briefly.

“It’s the only accurate way to describe it,” he replied.

Luna watched him now more carefully.

“You’re talking like it’s already a financial success,” she said.

“It is,” Kincaid said. “Or it will be once the markets fully realise what you’ve got here, deep in England. What happens when the money flows in.”

Ashcombe finally spoke.

“The markets already know,” he said. “London doesn’t have the levels of growth we now have, the Peak District is one of the major capital centres of Europe now.”

Kincaid gave a single nod, as though the argument had simply confirmed something already filed away. “So London understands what’s happening in the North,” he said. “It’s not guessing anymore. It can see the it?” Luna nodded. “You announce the SheffCoin expansion,” he continued, “you hugely scaled inflationary pressures and forced demand. The hit local asset compression, causing an increase in economic pressure on Sheffcoin, and release it into compute.”

Luna cut in, precise. “You’re missing the currency risk layer.”

Kincaid shifted his attention slightly toward her.

“That was the piece I need,” he said. “Ashton isn’t here to explain it.”

“Samuel can explain,” she replied. Samuel looked at her, Luna nodded, and without hesitation explained.

“You structure futures so a single issuance carries two forward positions,” he said. “Same unit, but split across settlement time. One contract prices appreciation, the other depreciation. Different counterparties, different horizons.” He continued. “At that point the issuer isn’t selling currency. They’re selling time exposure to currency.”

Luna added, almost clinical.

“Same underlying asset. Two simultaneous price realities.”

“Yes,” Samuel said. “But both are enforceable. Not synthetic. Not hedged abstraction. Real claims on the same issued unit, resolved at different moments.”

Kincaid’s expression tightened slightly.

“So you’ve layered time into the price mechanism?”

Samuel didn’t disagree.

“We compressed the expansion phase to force economic growth,” he said. “Six months of structured issuance pressure. High-velocity settlement. Every forward contract pulls liquidity forward while guaranteeing future demand back into the system.”

Luna picked up the thread.

“And it was routed externally,” Samuel added. “for dollars. The Bank of New York cleared the external exposure to the currency markets – despite the currency only being of any valued if it spent in Sheffield.”

Kincaid looked between them now, fully engaged.

“So you forced the currency’s own certainty of inflationary pressure into a compressed economic benefit?”

“Every forward contract,” Samuel said, “reinforced the trust in the system that Ashton was able to secure. That was the compression effect of the currency risk. Verifiable monetary expansion, and a financial strategy to compress it.”

Jack nodded into the conversation stepping forwards slightly.

“The spot price only moved 10% down. Most people in Sheffield, straight away noticed not much. The circular economy in pop-up shops and artisanal crafts predominantly helped the Bank of Sheffield, not Sheffcoin holders. There was a wave of margin calls, but Sheffield itself was ok.”

Samuel looked past the clearing towards the distant ridgeline before answering.

“The important part,” he said, “was getting the expanded money supply out of Sheffield fast enough that there would be no inflationary pressure. Eliot said he would apply curve grading to the issuance to offset inflation in Sheffield.”

Stone stepped lightly into the gap. “And then the Bank of Sheffield itself hedged its bets back on increasing compute for Samuel and the return on that capital.”

Samuel let out a quiet breath through his nose.

“And he built an entire banking structure for something like that. He realised during the festival what computers could do for the Bank of Sheffield – much more than jet engines. The Bank did the loan book for these data centres as IRR, so that compute-purchase subscriptions could function almost like industrial bonds. But its much more profitable than bonds,” Samuel replied, a half smile occuring. “People default on debt before they default on critical infrastructure.”

A brief silence settled between them. Wind moved through the clearing again.

Below the crag, lanterns had begun appearing amongst the scattered buildings and pathways of the Kommune. The fire had grown larger now, wafts of smoke filled the air. Somebody produced bottles. Somewhere further off, laughter rose briefly and disappeared into the night air. Kincaid sat quietly for a moment, watching the flames. Then he nodded.

"IRR, that's actually quite clever."

Samuel smiled faintly.

"It wasn't meant to be clever, it was meant to be profitable."

Kincaid let the noise around the fire thin again before he spoke. “Does the Government see the philosophy building around it?”

Stone leaned slightly forward. “The Peaks are doing something unusual,” he said. “They’re not resisting the state in any obvious way. They’re not declaring independence. They’re not even really outside the system.”

Kincaid looked at him for the first time.

“But?”

“But London isn’t producing anything meaningful, anything to get the north reattached to the State.” Jack gestured vaguely outwards—toward the dark, layered landscape beyond the firelight.”

Samuel stood up a little straighter as he spoke, as though the history of the region had briefly aligned itself behind him.

“In the same way the industrialists of the North developed canals to get coal to market,” he said, “or the railways were cut through the landscape to move goods and people around geology, we are doing the same thing.”

He gestured loosely toward the dark mass of the Peaks beyond the firelight.

“We’re just working with a different substrate. Not iron and steam. Compute and energy. But the logic is identical.”

A few people around the fire nodded without interruption. Not agreement exactly—more recognition of a shape they had already been living inside.

Kincaid didn’t respond immediately. He watched the fire settle again into itself, then pushed himself up from where he had been sitting.

Stone followed a moment later.

They drifted away from the main circle without announcing it, letting the noise of the group fall behind them in layers—conversation, laughter, the soft movement of bottles being set down on rock.

After a while the fire became something felt more than seen.

Kincaid spoke first.

“So talk to me about the Aureom,” he said. “Not the reception. Not the interpretations. The intent.”

Stone gave a small, almost resigned smile, as if he had expected the question to arrive eventually and was not entirely sure it could be answered cleanly.

“The intent,” he said, “is always the most dangerous part of the question.”

Kincaid kept walking, not pressing, just allowing space.

Stone continued anyway.

“It wasn’t written to instruct anyone,” he said. “And it wasn’t written to persuade, either. Those are secondary effects. By-products.”

He stepped over a broken ridge of stone embedded in the grass.

“It was written to describe a condition that already existed, but had not yet become legible to itself.”

Kincaid glanced at him.

“Legible in what sense?”

Stone looked ahead into the dark.

“In the sense that people were already acting as if certain assumptions were true,” he said. “About institutions. About legitimacy. About what can be built, what can be justified, what can be ignored.”

A pause.

“The Aureom didn’t introduce those assumptions,” he added. “It exposed them.”

Kincaid nodded slowly.

“And once something is exposed,” he said, “it stops being descriptive.”

Stone gave a faint exhale through his nose.

“Yes,” he said quietly. “That is the problem.”

They walked a little further in silence. The fire behind them was now only a glow caught in the folds of the land.

Kincaid spoke again.

“Because then it becomes operational.”

Stone didn’t correct him.

He only nodded once, as if that word—operational—was close enough to the truth to be uncomfortable.

Kincaid continued.

“So the intent wasn’t philosophy in the traditional sense.”

“No,” Stone said. “It was closer to pressure.”

“Pressure on what?”

Stone finally looked at him directly.

“On the gap between what people say is real,” he said, “and what they already behave as if is real.”

A long pause followed that.

The wind moved across the ridge, steady and indifferent.

Kincaid slowed slightly as they approached a clearer line of sight toward the lower slopes, where faint lights marked scattered settlements and the hidden geometry of what they had just left behind.

“So it was never stable,” he said.

Stone gave a small, almost tired smile again.

“Nothing that describes a living system ever is.”

“The intent is the easiest part,” he said. “And the most misunderstood.”

Kincaid watched him without interruption.

Stone continued. “The intent was to get it published.”

“And now it is?”

Stone looked into the fire as he answered.

“It plays on the idea that modern life is only administratively coherent. That everything meaningful has to pass through a system of regulation and acceptance, whether that’s governental optimisation, regulation, or market justification before it’s considered permissible.”

Kincaid nodded slightly.

“So a reaction against procedural bureaucracy?”

“Yes,” Stone said. “But not reactionary in the political sense. It does attempt to build upon fractures of Post-Liberalism, like Ashton.”

A pause.

“The Aureom was never meant to be a way of life. It wasn’t designed to scale upwards. It was designed to *reveal s*omething about modern Britain. To make visible the gap between what people say and do.”

Kincaid exhaled quietly through his nose.

“In America read it as instruction.”

“Yes.”

“And in Britain it is read as?”

Stone smiled faintly.

“Something new.”

The fire popped sharply. Kincaid leaned back slightly. “So where does that leave you?” he asked. Stone didn’t answer immediately. When he did, his voice was quieter.

“Between the writing and its implementation,” he said. “That’s where philosophers will usually end up.”

Kincaid nodded once. “And now you’re into implementation mode.”

Stone gave a small, tired shrug.

“That is why I am here.”

A silence settled again, deeper this time. Kincaid studied him for a moment.

“The Aureom in America is already changing shape,” he said. “It’s being used to justify decisions. In boardrooms. In public administration. In parts of law, if you believe the rumours.”

Stone didn’t deny it. “I have heard.”

“But here,” Kincaid continued, gesturing faintly toward the Peaks, “it looks more like rebellion and justification.”

Stone looked at him more carefully now.

“That’s because Britain is slow and resistant, no matter how British the change is.”

Kincaid nodded slowly. “And that’s why it matters to you up here in the Peaks?”

Stone rolled his head a little. “Any philosopher would want their work put into practice.”

Kincaid didn’t answer immediately. He let the sentence hang in the firelight, turning it over once before speaking. “That’s not quite true,” he said. “Most philosophers want their work *taken seriously*. Not necessarily enacted.”

Stone looked at him.

“The work was serious enough to be published.”

Beers were being distributed. Kincaid nodded once. “A large one.” A pause. “So what happens when Aureom moves from interpretation to practice?”

Stone answered without hesitation.

“And yet we are practising In a few months time you will remember distinctly when you came and met Stone and Ashcombe, and you are aware of that fact now.”

Kincaid nodded slowly, as if acknowledging something he had already known but preferred not to say aloud.

“That might be true,” he said. “But a person like Jack Stone must have some philosophical skill himself.”

Stone looked at him for a moment, unreadable in the firelight.

“Skill in what?” he asked.

Kincaid didn’t move his gaze.

“Of how you got here,” he said. “Before the book. Before the system. Before people started treating your syntax as innovation.”

A faint smile touched Stone’s mouth, but it didn’t settle.

“You’re asking for biography,” he said.

“I’m asking for the man behind the book,” Kincaid replied.

“That’s not the same thing?”

“No,” Kincaid said. “Not in these cases.”

A silence opened between them again—less comfortable now. More deliberate.

Stone picked up a small twig and turned it in his fingers before dropping it back into the fire.

“I did my PhD in English Literature,” he said at last. “Not Philosophy.”

“Played it up as Philology?”

Stone nodded. Kincaid didn’t react. He waited. Stone continued, slower now.

“And Jack Stone in that book is the same Jack Stone sitting here?”

Stone gave a quiet laugh.

“Not really,” he said. “Even a real philosopher in those settings can’t talk about issues like that, but a fictional me can.”

Kincaid pressed gently.

“And the setting?”

“Bloomsbury, of course.”

“That isn’t being picked up as well in the States. I think many have forgotten the setting, and focused on the dialogue.”

He gave a small, almost apologetic shrug.

“That’s what happens when it takes on a life of its own.”

Kincaid didn’t respond immediately. He watched Stone instead, not the words.

Then Jack spoke to him. “So have you accepted it?”

Kincaid glanced at him.

“Accepted what?”

“The dialogue as philosophy/”

A faint smile, but without warmth.

“I will leave that for now,” Stone said.

Kincaid tilted his head slightly.

“What about the distinction between philosopher and philosophy.”

“Yes,” Stone replied. “There is a distinction.”

A pause.

Kincaid leaned forward a little, elbows on his knees now, voice lower. “Then tell me plainly,” he said. “What is Jack Stone;’s intention as a philosopher, if not as just the author of Aureom?”

Jack didn’t answer straight away. When he finally spoke, it was slower, more careful.

“The Aureom wasn’t meant to produce a doctrine or legacy,” he said. “It was meant to produce a weaving for the time it was written in.”

Kincaid watched him closely. “What I am concerned about is what happens when a text is taken as a piece of philosophy. What happens when it seeps into the United States.”

“To the point where British philosophy surges ahead?”

Kincaid gave a slight nod. “And what Jack Stone can weave into the firmament of the United States.”

Stone gave a short, almost dismissive exhale. “I was just the person who noticed the gap and wrote it down.”

Kincaid didn’t break eye contact. “That’s not an answer,” he said. “That’s functionalism.”

Stone looked at him more directly now. “We never picked that up.”

Kincaid nodded at him and returned to the main gathering.

The fire had grown in size while they had been speaking. Someone had fed it properly now—larger timber, not scraps—and it answered with a steadier, crackling burn. The light pushed further out into the clearing, drawing more of the Peaks into partial visibility: the uneven ground, the edges of cliff faces and the makeshift structures, the distant suggestion of paths that folded back into darkness as soon as they were seen.

Conversation around the circle was looser than before. Less formal. Bottles were moving hand to hand. A few people were laughing softly, as if still unsure whether noise was appropriate in a place like this.

But when Kincaid stepped back into it, the tone shifted without anyone explicitly acknowledging him.

Not silence. Recalibration.

Luna noticed first. She didn't call it out, just tracked him with her eyes as he came back into range of the firelight.

Stone followed a moment later, slower, as if returning from a different altitude.

Ashcombe remained where he was, slightly apart, still positioned like a fixed variable the system was built around rather than a participant within it.

Kincaid took a place near the fire's edge, not quite sitting yet. He looked once across the group, taking in the arrangement again—less as people, more as roles that had briefly agreed to occupy bodies.

Then he spoke, casually, as if continuing a conversation that had never paused.

"It's always interesting," he said, "to think of how passive history is."

A few heads turned toward him. Luna didn't interrupt. Kincaid continued.

"As Jack has pointed out, we are all now participants of history. What happens over 10 years in a history book is played out around fires, in taverns and bars and coffeehouses without anything happening. It's the small moments."

Stone, a few steps behind him, gave a small, almost invisible reaction—not agreement, not disagreement. Recognition.

"In America," he said, "we've seen history before. Wars, financial systems, institutional change, rapid industrial development. They all begin somewhere. Then people optimise to fix it in history and then all the work, the small moments are forgotten about."

He looked into the flames.

"And once that happens, nobody remembers what came first."

A silence settled, but it wasn't heavy. It was attentive.

Luna spoke. "Are you saying something about the Aureom?"

Kincaid didn't look at her immediately.

"I'm saying it's seeping in," he replied. "Which is important."

Stone sat down now too, a little apart from Kincaid, watching him with a measured stillness. Ashcombe finally spoke from the outer edge of the firelight.

“And what do you think we’ve built here, then?”

Kincaid allowed a pause before answering.

“Some data centres,” he said, with a small shrug. “We had a quick look at the cave blasting walking up. I have seen bigger in the United States.”

Samuel gave a slightly pause. “And what brings you all the way here then? We heard Thorne has just gotten out. Is it to meet Jack?”

Kincaid paused again. “There are things happening in the United Kingdom which we have all read out, in The Internationalist, in The New Yorker; that there is capital accumulation in the north, those Jet Engines are going into jets. Manchester itself is on the cusp of economic growth. Pure economic growth, not having tech incubators in old council buildings, but real sustained economic growth. To say nothing about success of the Bank of Sheffield, and Ashton’s burgeoning reputation in New York finance circles, to say nothing of what the Ashcombe name still means. And yet, I am here to meet the author of The Aureom.”

They all shifted as Kincaid stood up, walking around the fire looking out at the circle of people around him. Names: Ashcombe and Stone – right after the publication of the Aureom – was a memory that was going to come back to him.

Kincaid moved slowly around the edge of the firelight, speaking as he went, not addressing anyone in particular so much as testing how the idea held in different directions. “The United States is starting to watch this place more closely,” he said, almost conversationally, as if remarking on weather rather than geopolitics. “Geopolitically. It’s looking for where value formation is happening, and the North of England is beginning to register as one of those anomalies.” He paused, watching the fire shift against the stone. “Dr. Alexander Thorne is a very brilliant scientist and businessman. The Jet Engines he is building are of a very fine quality.”

Kincaid slowed as he came back around toward Stone, the firelight catching the edge of his expression in brief, unstable intervals. He stopped just short of him, as if the question had been forming in motion and only now found somewhere to land. “You know Ricardo?” he asked.

“Comparative advantage is what he’s remembered for,” Stone said. Kincaid cut in almost immediately.

“Comparative advantage is the cause free market success in a nation,” he said. “The effect has always been tariffs.” Stone paused mid-thought, the interruption landing cleanly rather than rudely. For a moment he looked as if he might challenge it, then didn’t, not sure what to day.

Yet Ashcombe gave a small, almost approving nod towards Stone, as if confirming something already understood. “He’s Austrian,” Ashcombe said, without looking away from Kincaid.

“You’re about to say tariffs are coming to the country,” he said calmly. “That they’re already being imposed in practice, even if not declared as such.”

Kincaid nodded. Ashcombe continued, gaze steady on him. “Ricardo can be used just as an argument in and of itself,” he said. “Which bits are right, which bits are wrong, and which bits get selectively ignored depending on what you’re trying to prove at the time.”

Stone gave a faint, almost imperceptible nod at that, as if the framing was familiar. Ashcombe shifted his attention slightly toward him.

“And the Austrians,” he added, “take what they want from him and discard the rest. Methodological individualism, the amount of money that can be made if tariffs are applied or discounted.”

Kincaid’s almost looked at Ashcombe differently. “You don’t meet many British Austrians. You and Thorne?”

“The family have long been Austrian.” Kincaid nodded slowly as Ashcombe continued. “I have known Thorne since he moved from London. Not well, but well enough.”

“Eliot is the Hayekian one. He still believes institutions can carry coherence if you let them evolve long enough, all that private currency issuance stuff he talked about for year as Scottish freebanking. We will see how it continues.”

He looked back to Kincaid now.

“The Austrian tradition isn't really about markets. Not fundamentally. It's about individuals. Methodological individualism. The idea that institutions don't act. Governments don't act. Nations don't act.”

He pointed around the fire.

“People act.” A brief silence followed. “Capital moves. The market is what happens afterwards.”

Ashcombe nodded once.

“The irony,” Kincaid continued, “is that America spent most of the twentieth century pretending it was about the federal government. So many Federal agencies. National planning. Strategic doctrine. Central coordination.”

“And now?” Luna asked.

“Now?”

Kincaid smiled faintly.

“Now America trusts individuals again, some of them anyway.”

Kincaid watched the fire for a moment before speaking again.

“The problem,” he said, “is that none of you actually know how to grow.”

The statement landed without hostility. More observation than criticism. Ashcombe nodded almost immediately. “I know,” he said. “The politicians have lost their relevance, most jobs are automated, income seeps in. There is a stagnant economy in the south as the north revs up. The state is happy enough to yield farm the north through taxes, but will not let it grow.”

That answer seemed to interest Kincaid more than if he had argued. “And what happens to society then?” Kincaid asked, looking towards Luna for the answer, before giving up the answer Kincaid was looking for.

“It falls into mob rule,” she says. “As democracy falls under the weight of its own rule.” Kincaid nods and turns to Jack.

“Too Greek. Greek governance, if you can call it that was held together by a tyrant, a polis, and slaves. Platon was talking in a different time. It’s highly distinct from the British state, established by the work of Locke. British Sovereignty is not applicable to The Republic. Greece was run by a philosopher tyrant, who may have been Platon himself, telling everybody how great the philosopher king was.”

Kincaid looked for him to continue.

“Hobbes is the British answer, we do not have to follow Plato’s system if not wanted to. British political philosophy holds to Locke and Hobbes. German Philosophy does not match British Political Philosophy.”

Kincaid nodded at him. “That is well established. Yet these discussions on the renewal of the northern economy was done through market forces despite a reluctance to engage by the Leviathan, but even a little trade in the north has put them on the back foot. Tariffs are coming.”

Samuel stretched his legs slightly towards the warmth of the fire. “I sold most of my share in the jet engine business back to Thorne. We chose to go with the Bank of Sheffield.”

“Dr. Thorne,” Kincaid corrected. The adjustment was automatic.

“Small.”

“He’s earned it.”

“Meanwhile Ashton would demolish half of Sheffield tomorrow if somebody gave him planning permission.”

“A property owning democracy,” Stone said.

“Most of Sheffield deserves it,” Kincaid replied. A faint smile crossed Ashcombe's face.

“You can always stick to computers? There’s always money in that,” Kincaid said. “More money than most governments understand. Easy enough to hide.”

Nobody disagreed.

“Most people don't want to become software engineers. They don't want venture capital. They don't want distributed compute.” He looked around the fire. “They want comfortable lives.” A pause. “Predictable wages.” Another. “A house.” Stone nodded slightly.

“Most governments want that too,” Kincaid said. “Which is why they're all Keynesians, whether they admit it or not.”

That earned a quiet laugh from Samuel.

“The Aureom understood that,” Kincaid said.

Stone raised an eyebrow.

“Did it?”

“Yes.”

Kincaid leaned back slightly.

“I knew exactly what you were doing. You were trying to write something that could survive contact with both sides. You wrote it carefully enough that the conservatives could read it as new, and legitimate what was going on in the north.”

Stone listened to him finish, then shook his head. Not dismissively. More as someone recognising a familiar interpretation and deciding it had travelled a little too far. "I don't think that's quite right," he said. The fire shifted between them. Around the clearing, people continued talking quietly amongst themselves. Glass bottles passed from hand to hand. Somewhere further down the slope, somebody laughed. Kincaid waited. Stone looked into the flames before continuing. "You're turning it into a meta-theory."

"Isn’t it?"

"No."

The answer came immediately. Kincaid raised an eyebrow. Stone smiled faintly. "You're assuming the text exists primarily to position itself inside a political environment. To survive institutions. To survive criticism. To stay one move ahead of whoever might attack it."

"A sensible assumption."

"A Machiavellian one." The smile remained. Not hostile. Simply firm. "A little too Machiavellian for my taste." The wind moved across the clearing. Kincaid folded his arms.

The fire burned lower as the night settled properly into the clearing.

Not extinguished—just moderated, as if it had accepted its place in the landscape rather than trying to dominate it.

Kincaid sat slightly back from the circle now, half-turned away from the most direct heat. He took a packet from his jacket, thumbed it open, and lit a cigarette with a practiced, unceremonious movement. American Spirit. The paper caught cleanly, the tobacco slow and dry in the cold air. He exhaled once, watching the smoke thread upward into the darker air above the firelight, where it broke apart and disappeared into the Peaks. For a while he didn’t speak. The conversation around him softened as well. Not ending, but losing its earlier sharp edges. People leaned closer to one another rather than the fire. A bottle changed hands. Someone adjusted a jacket over another person’s shoulders without comment. It was subtle, but Kincaid noticed it. The centre of gravity had shifted. Not towards him. Not towards Ashcombe or Stone. Towards each other. He took another slow drag, letting the silence sit properly before forming any further thought. The cigarette glowed briefly in the dark. The Peaks beyond the clearing felt less like a backdrop now and more like an enclosing presence—absorbing sound, flattening distance, making everything feel slightly more intimate than it should have been at this scale of ambition. Kincaid exhaled again.

“Funny thing,” he said quietly. No one interrupted. He looked across the fire. “When people start talking about governments,” he continued, “they usually think they’re talking about power.” A pause. “But most of the time they’re talking about something else.”

He glanced briefly at Stone, then Ashcombe.

“Bureaucracy,” he said. “Holding back other people. That’s the Brits real problem.” Another slow inhale. “That’s why Socialism was so easy here. Who gets what. Who decides what counts as real work. What gets built. What gets left behind.” The smoke drifted sideways in the wind, thinning as it went. “But sitting here…” he gestured faintly with the hand holding the cigarette, indicating the circle rather than the fire, “it doesn’t feel like that’s what any of you are actually focused on. You’ve managed to skirt around the bureaucracy in a head on collision with the State.” A few people shifted slightly. Not uncomfortable—just attentive.

The cigarette burned down another fraction.

Around the fire, people weren't looking outwards anymore.

And for a moment, the question of government, ideology, even the Aureom itself, felt secondary to something simpler and more immediate:

the way people reorganised themselves when they stopped performing arguments and started inhabiting them. The fire had burned down further now, reduced to a dense, steady core of heat rather than light. Someone asked it casually, almost as an afterthought.

"You staying up here tonight?"

Kincaid didn't look away from the flames when he answered.

"No."

A brief pause.

"Need to be in Sheffield tomorrow."

He finally leaned forwards, tapping ash from the cigarette into the edge of a stone. Then he looked across the circle. Luna was already watching him. She gave a small nod—understood before it was finished—and pushed herself up from where she was sitting. "I'll take you back to your bike," she said. No ceremony in it. Just movement. Kincaid stood with her. Around them, the rest of the group didn't react much. Conversations continued, slightly softer now, as though the centre of gravity had shifted elsewhere. Kincaid looked around the fire, the men and women going through their routine. The day Theo Kincaid met Samuel Ashcombe, and now Jack Stone. Kincaid stood in the firelight to take in the moment. Before nodding at Luna. They were over the ridge quickly and the light fell behind them, swallowing the slope and the uneven dark of the moor.

Luna walked slightly ahead at first, then matched his pace. After a while she spoke without turning her head. "What did you make of tonight?" Kincaid took a moment before answering.

"It was a good conversation," he said. A faint, almost neutral assessment. Not praise. Not criticism. Just placement. They continued walking in silence for a few minutes after that, following the faint track back down through broken ground and scrub where the speeder had been left. The landscape opened and closed around them in slow folds, the dark ridge lines shifting shape as they moved. Eventually the silhouette of the speeder came back into view, low and waiting where the land dipped. Luna nodded toward it.

"I'll drop you back at your bike." Kincaid nodded once. They climbed onto the speeder together, the machine adjusting subtly under their combined weight, stabilisers compensating without complaint. It lifted and moved off into the dark with a quiet, controlled surge. For a while neither of them spoke. The wind came in clean across the moor as they cut back through the tracks—past stone walls, through narrow breaks in the land, retracing the same hidden geometry in reverse. The speeder slowed slightly as the ground levelled and the Sentinel came back into view, half-hidden where he had left it in the fold of the land.

"We could have emailed about tariffs," she said.

Kincaid gave a faint exhale through his nose.

"That wasn't the reason I came."

A pause.

Luna glanced at him briefly.

“Then what was?”

Kincaid looked forwards at his bike.

“The Aureom,” he said simply. “is happening.”

Epilogue

The lift climbed for a long time. Theo Kincaid watched the numbers rise through smoked glass as Sheffield unfolded beneath him. The city looked different than it had six months ago. Not transformed. Not yet. But altered. Construction cranes stood above the centre. New glass reflected the evening light along the river. Entire blocks that had once appeared forgotten now carried scaffolding, steel frames, and illuminated signage. Investment had a particular visual language. Kincaid had spent enough years around capital to recognise it immediately.

Money left traces.

The lift reached the top floor. A quiet chime sounded. The doors opened. For a moment Kincaid simply stood there. The apartment occupied almost the entire floor. Floor-to-ceiling glass wrapped around three sides of the building, giving uninterrupted views across Sheffield and out towards the dark outline of the Peak District beyond. The city lights stretched below like circuitry. The Peaks sat on the horizon in shadow. The space itself was absurdly large. In the modern way. Open-plan. Concrete. Stone. Timber. Books everywhere. Eliot Ashton sat near the windows with a glass of whisky. He looked entirely at home.

"Nice place," Kincaid said. "You've made an unbelievable amount of money."

Ashton considered this.

"Samuel made an unbelievable amount of money, I am just a banker."

"You're living it up."

"I am at the top of the city now. Not that I think about it."

Kincaid walked towards the glass. The view was ridiculous. From here he could see the route of the river cutting through the city. New developments. Old factories. University buildings. Rail lines. And somewhere beyond the darkness of the Peaks—High Peak One. Invisible. Yet somehow controlling more capital than most people realised.

Kincaid remained by the glass for a while, watching Sheffield below. Construction cranes sat across the skyline. New towers. New districts. Money. Real money. Not the sort generated by speculation alone, but the slower kind that left physical evidence behind. Eventually he turned back towards Ashton.

"What happened?"

Ashton looked up from his whisky.

"What do you mean?"

"You all seem..." Kincaid searched briefly for the correct word.

"Content."

Ashton laughed.

"That's because things worked."

Kincaid stared at him.

"That simple?"

"Mostly."

"No civil war?"

"No."

"No ideological schism?"

"Somewhat."

"No dramatic betrayal?"

Ashton shook his head. “Nobody you would know.”

Kincaid sat opposite him. For a moment neither spoke. Then Kincaid gestured vaguely towards the city. "So explain it to me."

Ashton leaned back."Stone's settled in with us. Thorne was too Hobbsian, we all saw it. His viral popularity in the United States does not settle easily in Britain."

"Settled?"

"The Brits are quite epicurean you know. Not as straight laced as you might believe. Jack Stone patched over some of the issues in the country. The Northern Economy is surging ahead. London is hobbled as a carve-out. Overpriced. Boring. Too Bloomsbury for some. It is coming though. The change. Even Stone knows it."

"The state listen to him now."

"Because of his philosophy?"

"Partly Because he is safer. Thorne mocked the banking strategy as he took down councils and priviatesed and digitised everything. Sam is sitting on a treasure trove of capital and connections."

“I spoke with Dr. Thorne, his engines are impressive. Has he informed you?”

“We haven’t spoken since the festival.”

“The United States has imposed tariffs on European imports.”

“I see. Should I be brushing up on my Ricardo?”

“Only if you intend to import.”

“There is no import charge on currency.”

“No,” said Kincaid, “But the United States picked up on your currency risk strategy. I hear its proving quite popular on Wall Street.”

"Along with Sheffcoin?"

Kincaid nudged his right shoulder upwards ever so slowly to Eliot who responded straight away.

"I accidentally became one of the greatest bankers in the world."

Kincaid blinked. "Excuse me?"

"The banking was originally a side project."

“A side project for what?"

"A Philosopher."

Kincaid stared at him for several seconds.

"You think you can match Stone."

Ashton smiled. "Oh, Jack won."

"Won what?"

"The race."

Kincaid nodded slowly. Eliot continued. “The dialogue was cheap I thought, but very difficult to argue against. The Wittgenstein especially conceptually difficuclt to outflank. I will give him that.”

“What made it Stone who won?”

“He was published. Top-down. Selling Bloomsbury to the Civil Service is much easier than selling Philosophy to Sheffield, but the SheffCoin expansion strategy worked. The supply increase created exactly what he thought it would. More liquidity. More investment. More construction. More infrastructure." He gestured towards the city. "Most of what you're looking at came from it. The compute strategy is generating more revenue every quarter. More energy. More infrastructure. More capital." A pause. "Sheffield doesn't need to spend every day worrying about what Thorne might do next."

Eventually Kincaid's attention drifted towards a manuscript sitting on a nearby table. Bound in dark leather. He pointed. "And what have you been doing?" Ashton followed his gaze.

"Writing."

"Still?"

"Always."

Kincaid stood and walked over.

The title sat embossed across the cover.

Hypermodernity and Sovereignty

He lifted the manuscript. It was lighter than expected. "That's fiction."

"Yes."

Kincaid smiled slightly.

"Very Goethe."

Eliot seemed pleased by that. "That's roughly the idea."

THE END

Appendix #1: The Antinatural Leviathan: A Dionysian Rebellion

The first decades of the 21st century have been a void—less a march of progress than a slow-motion collapse into inertia. The End of History, some called it. But the Start of Boredom is more apt. State-sanctioned socialism has drained Britain of vitality, hollowing out its economy, its people, its culture. A society that once pulsed with ambition now drowns in malaise, its days lost to algorithmic distractions, its nights numbed by digital sedation.

The Leviathan—the State—has metastasized into an all-pervasive, insatiable entity, suffocating individuality under the weight of collective control. Whether its power serves good or ill is irrelevant; power is its own justification. Britain's version of this beast, HM Government, is a tragicomedy of incompetence, a theatre of the absurd where politicians, bureaucrats, and the deluded middle class play their parts as unwitting acolytes of the machine. These people do not exist in any meaningful sense—they are abstractions, functionaries of a system that does not feel the consequences of its own decay. The burdens of modern Britain—unchecked migration, perpetual inflation, cultural fragmentation, the destruction of wealth, the collapse of public services—are mere statistics to them. The bureaucrat’s sole instinct is preservation: not of the nation, not of its people, but of the machine itself.

The bureaucrat, a creature of Maoist temperament and Maoist morality, embodies the Last Man—the culmination of modernity’s long war against greatness. He is comfortable, complacent, lifeless. He recoils at anything wild, untamed, Dionysian. The true First Man—dangerous, vital, commanding—must be exiled, quarantined, lest his fire burn through the brittle structures of the state. In the modern world, men are suspect. They cannot be trusted. They must not be allowed near the levers of power.

Yes, there are males in the British bureaucracy. But they are not men.

Men lead.

Men drive human progress with wild, Dionysian abandon—only to return, in time, to the Apollonian discipline that stabilizes civilization for the next generation. This eternal rhythm, the dance of chaos and order, has shaped the rise and fall of all great societies. But in modern Britain, this cycle has been severed. The bureaucrat, obsessed not with vitality or greatness but with control, has replaced the natural order with stagnation.

The failures of our age can be laid at the feet of these functionaries—men who think not in terms of thymos, of spirit and honor, but only of process, of administration, of the machine. In Nineteen Eighty-Four, Winston Smith does not rebel against a single man but against the faceless, formless Leviathan itself. Who rules Oceania? There is no answer. Only power remains. Big Brother’s face is known, but behind it, there is nothing—just an apparatus whose enemies are as interchangeable as its justifications: Emmanuel Goldstein, Eastasia, Eurasia, and back again.

What is the purpose of such a system? In Room 101, O’Brien tells us plainly: the purpose of power is power itself. The state exists not for the good of the people, nor for justice, nor for prosperity. It exists to preserve and expand itself. From Rome to the Catholic Church, from the British Empire to the United States, all state formations are built upon this raw, inescapable truth: power is the prime mover of history.

And yet, history also shows us that power, left untempered, devours itself. The one force that has ever restrained it—the one thing Marx sought to abolish—was faith. Not faith in the state, not faith in ideology, but faith in something beyond power. Without it, modern man flails, desperate to believe in something greater than himself, and finds only the cold embrace of the Leviathan. Religion was not eradicated; it was simply transmuted into statism. The bureaucrat is the new priest, the welfare office his confessional, the surveillance state his god.

But the Leviathan is antinature. It is a grotesque inversion, a system that suppresses life rather than nourishes it. Some might call it Satanic. If that is true, then the opposite must also be true: God is nature.

The socialist and the bureaucratic mind are antinatural. The bureaucrat is passive, obedient, and worst of all—a nihilist. He does not create, he does not build, he does not strive. He simply administers. The refusal to allow the best men to lead is not just political cowardice—it is a direct assault on the natural order. In nature, the strongest, the most capable, the most vital rise to the top. But not in the state. The state coddles the socialist, the useful idiot, the bureaucrat—creatures whose very existence depends on the suppression of those greater than themselves.

This is the central failure of the public sector: its antinature.

The state exists outside of nature, and the forms of its existence are manifold. First, there is its economic foundation: the grotesque perversion of Keynesianism, a post-rationalist fantasy that allows the state to exist untethered from reality. Through the issuance of fiat currency, the state conjures wealth from nothing, fueling malinvestment and distorting the market. The economy, which should be an organic extension of human action, is warped into an instrument of state power. The dissociation between nature and the market has become so absolute that few even recognize it anymore.

But nowhere is the state's antinature more apparent than in its war on beauty.

Beauty is dangerous to the state because beauty is real. Beauty speaks to something higher than power, something beyond control. The state cannot allow this. And so it wages an unrelenting campaign of uglification—of architecture, of art, of the human spirit itself. The bureaucrat demands that you accept brutalism over elegance, sterility over vitality. He tells you that beauty is a lie, that nothing is intrinsically better than anything else. But this is the true lie. The state is ugly because it is unnatural. Nature is beautiful because it is true. And the state hates beauty because beauty is a reminder that there is something beyond its reach.

The bureaucrat does not understand beauty. He does not understand trust, virtue, or excellence. He understands only power, and his entire existence is an effort to reduce the world to its most efficient, lifeless form. What is the point of a beautiful building, when brutalism is cheaper? What is the point of art, when propaganda is useful? What is the point of truth, when lies are profitable?

The bureaucrat's mission is reduction. The reduction of the beautiful to the efficient. The reduction of the noble to the useful. The reduction of everything good, true, and vital in this world.

But the one thing he cannot reduce is the sovereign individual.

The British state, perched in its ivory tower, is no longer an extension of the people—it is an abstraction, a self-sustaining organism detached from reality. It does not govern in service of Britain; it governs in service of itself. Funded by perpetual debt and the fraudulent alchemy of the Bank of England, the state has orchestrated a vast, ongoing deception against its own citizens. It taxes them under false pretenses, then debases the very token it calls money, robbing them twice over—once in daylight, once in darkness. The Old Lady of Threadneedle Street must start to sing: this cannot go on.

Yet the fraud does not stop at the ledger. The state sells its lies wholesale, not just in numbers but in ideology. It tells the people that the poor can only be saved through perpetual redistribution, that dependence is a virtue, that inflation and welfare spending are compassion. But there is nothing compassionate about economic servitude. The welfare recipient, reduced to passive consumption, suckles at the breast of the productive and competent, draining from those who build, who create, who dare. This is not natural. The state has made Britain stagnant, inert—a nation of dependents instead of a nation of men.

The machinery of this parasitic order is the bureaucrat. The bureaucrat is the state's priest, its functionary, its loyal acolyte. He ensures the system turns over year after year, recycling one useless politician after another, keeping the Leviathan alive while Britain decays. But if Britain is to flourish again—if men are to return—this class must be cast down. Competency must return. Creation must return. The socialist bureaucrat, who knows only how to administer and not how to build, must be swept aside. Sovereign individuals must reclaim what is theirs by nature: their own lives.

The vacuum at the heart of the British state will not be replaced overnight. Nor does it need to be. The alternative to stagnation is not another program, another reform, another law. It is simply action. It is simply the will to ignore, to transcend, to walk away. The Leviathan only survives if people continue to ask permission to be free. But the truth is: you can just do things.

Life in Britain should not be nasty, brutish, and short. It should be wild, untamed, and free.

The Dionysian Briton does not ask permission. He does not kneel before bureaucratic decrees or beg for the approval of a regime that systematically lies, distorts, and punishes truth-tellers while shielding its own. This is the state that covered up the crimes of Pakistani men in Rotherham for the sake of "community cohesion." The state that ignored Sir Jimmy Savile's decades of abuse. The state that turns a blind eye to the sins of its own aristocracy—Lord Mountbatten's crimes against the Irish go without mention. The state that fabricated justifications for the Iraq War, rehabilitated the perpetrators, and yet has the gall to launch moral crusades against white working-class boys for their supposed inherent misogyny. The state that fails at everything, then gaslights the nation into believing they are the problem. And when the failures are too obvious to ignore? A fake inquiry, a handpicked committee, a quiet cover-up. No real accountability, no real consequences.

To be a freeborn Englishman in the 21st century is to recognize that the state does not serve you—it fears you. And so, the modern Briton must begin the process of removing himself from the state's grasp. This is not a political movement. It is not a protest. It is a withdrawal of consent, a reclamation of what was always his.

The path forward is clear.

A Briton who wishes to be free must first recognize the mechanisms of control: surveillance, financial dependence, social coercion. The solution? A cypherpunk ethos, the technological embodiment of the sovereign individual. The tools are readily available:

VPNs & Privacy Tools: The state's surveillance apparatus cannot control what it cannot see. Obfuscation is resistance.

Bitcoin & Decentralized Finance: Free yourself from fiat, the primary means of state control. The Bank of England cannot print Bitcoin.

Pseudonymity & Online Sovereignty: Do not play the game under their rules. Operate outside of the controlled political and media landscape. Let them chase ghosts.

Self-Sufficiency & Parallel Economies: Grow your own, build your own, trade among those who share your ethos. Make the state irrelevant to your survival.

This is not utopianism. This is not LARPing. This is what must be done. The state of neoliberalism is one of elite failure, a self-sustaining oligarchy that rules by inertia and coercion. It will not reform itself, nor can it be reformed from within. The answer does not come from Westminster, nor from Fleet Street, nor from any of the controlled opposition paraded before the public.

The answer lies outside the system.

The answer is you.

Trust in British society has collapsed. No longer is radical change the fringe desire of socialist agitators, football hooligans, or Islamists—it is now a universal demand, from the rolling hills of Derbyshire to the private salons of Mayfair, from the Highlands to the ruined second and third cities, gutted by state-sponsored neoliberalism. The consensus is clear: this cannot continue.

Nothing better encapsulates the Leviathan's failure than its immigration policies. For over two decades, the British people have been clear—they do not want mass immigration. In 2016, they voted to leave the European Union, in large part to regain control over their borders. The response? A betrayal. The state replaced one failed system with another, flooding the country with numbers far beyond what the people ever consented to. The British state, in its addiction to cheap labour and social engineering, has forced a demographic and economic crisis upon its own citizens.

The price of this treachery will be paid. The Leviathan, in its hubris, believes its power is infinite. But all power has limits. A state that rules against the will of its people is a state that is writing its own obituary. Every action has an equal and opposite reaction. This is Newton's Third Law applied to politics. This is the moment when the social contract—already tattered—begins to dissolve entirely.

The great lie of the British state is that it calls itself a democracy. No falsehood is more galling, more gut-wrenching than the one that tells a people they are free while systematically silencing their will. The British man is taxed to fund the settlement of people he did not invite. He is told he must pay for their housing, their welfare, their healthcare, and in return, he is called a bigot for noticing. He is not even allowed to ask the question: What if we undid all of this?

There is no fixing the Leviathan from within. It does not listen. It does not change course. The only solution is to exit its grasp. The sovereign individual does not wait for permission. He builds parallel systems, withdraws his consent, and reclaims what was always his: his land, his wealth, his right to exist as he sees fit. The state has broken its contract. Now, the only contract that matters is the one the individual makes with himself.

The fakeness of British life is entirely manufactured by the state—an artificial reality imposed on a population detached from nature itself. The fake pandemic and the biosecurity hysteria it unleashed. The fake climate crisis, engineered to justify an energy-rationed, impoverished existence under Net Zero. The fake narratives about economic decline, deflecting blame from the central planners who caused it. Every crisis serves the same function—not to uplift the people, not to improve their lot, but to expand the Leviathan's dominion over their lives.

And yet, when the state's policies leave the economy in ruins, who does it blame? Not itself. Not the bureaucrats. Not the welfare class it has nurtured into parasitic dependence. No, it turns its ire on the very people least reliant on it—those who build, those who create, those who fund its every reckless venture. The wealthy, both aristocrats and the new moneyed class, are vilified for their success, despite the fact that 1% of the population pays nearly 40% of the state's revenues. The bureaucratic machine, along with its useful idiots in the press and academia, peddles the absurdity that these individuals are somehow not paying their "fair share."

The truth is far simpler: the state exists to strip its citizens of their wealth and assets, not for any noble redistributive purpose, but purely to sustain its own bloated existence. The Leviathan must always feed. It does not care about fairness, prosperity, or justice—only about maintaining its power. And in that quest, it sees only enemies: sovereign individuals who do not need the state. The entrepreneur, the self-sufficient, the family that owns land across generations—these are the real threats to tyranny.

Plato foresaw it. In The Republic, he warned that democracy inevitably leads to mob rule. And today, the mob has been weaponized by the state to devour what remains of Britain's wealth, culture, and heritage. The socialist does not seek to build a wealthier nation. He does not wish to create opportunity. He aims only to destroy—because destruction is the great equalizer, and equality in destitution is his only goal. The bureaucrat, in his envy, does not seek to raise himself. He seeks only to drag everyone else down.

John Locke, the father of classical liberalism, understood that before there was ever a government, there was law—not the kind scribbled into statute books by bureaucrats, but natural law. Rights that exist before the state, outside the state, and despite the state. In stripping men of their wealth, the state strips them of something even more fundamental: their natural rights. The right to life. The right to property. The right to freedom. These are not granted by the government; they are inherent to man himself.

Locke's vision was simple: the state exists only as a contract between individuals, designed to protect their natural rights. The moment it ceases to do so—indeed, the moment it becomes a threat to those rights—it loses all legitimacy. It is, in Locke's words, a state of war between the government and the people. And what did Locke say must be done in such a case? Resistance. The people are not just allowed to rebel against tyranny—they are morally obligated to do so.

Only sovereign individuals can reclaim what was lost—not by reforming the Leviathan, but by abandoning it entirely. The state cannot be reasoned with. It can only be left behind.

It is a common socialist tactic to use scapegoats, ensuring that no criticism falls upon itself. Power does not like to be questioned. The failings of the British state—despite failure after failure—are never attributed to the bureaucrats who mismanage it, but rather to the successful individuals who operate outside its control. The socialist mind, consumed by envy, cannot accept the existence of wealth or success. It is incapable of reasoning that inequality is not an aberration but a fundamental part of nature.

The state refuses to acknowledge this natural reality: that while all men may have equal souls, they do not possess equal talents. The vast differences in ability, work ethic, and skill between individuals are a fact of life—recognized by all great thinkers, from Leo Strauss and Friedrich Nietzsche to Plato himself. But in the modern age, such truths are suppressed, rewritten as forbidden knowledge, dismissed under the label of "far-right" by those who would rather rule over a docile, compliant population than a free and self-reliant people.

Plato once described the state as a ship—the Ship of State, a metaphor for governance and order. But if the British state were a ship today, it would be entirely unseaworthy, weighed down by its own corruption and inefficiency. It has been lured by the great beast—the Leviathan—and that beast has claimed it. The state is no longer a vessel for the people but a feeding ground for those who seek to strip its remaining wealth, piece by piece, until there is nothing left.

To restore the British state to something functional, much of it must be returned to nature. The ship cannot sail again as it is; it must be rebuilt, stripped of its bloated excess, reduced to something smaller, nimbler, and truer to its purpose. When this happens, the ship of the British state may not resemble what it once was—but at last, it will be seaworthy again.

The rot reaches the very core.

The Royal Family, once the embodiment of British values—elegance, duty, and the idealization of the British family—has become a global laughingstock. Where there was once dignity, there is now dysfunction. Where there was once moral authority, there is now scandal. The most beloved members of the monarchy are no longer those of royal blood but those who married in—celebrities and social climbers, rather than sovereigns. The family at the top, once meant to set the highest standard, has instead become emblematic of Britain's decline. If the rot has a source, it starts with them.

And then there is Parliament—a parade of incompetence so staggering that it has become a spectacle in itself. Tourists from America and Europe do not come to Westminster for democracy in action; they come to watch a freak show, to witness the "Mother of all Parliaments" reduced to the World's Creepiest Uncles of Politics. Sex scandals, corruption, venality, idiocy, and sheer malice are the only constants. There are 650 Members of Parliament—yet you would struggle to find many among them who would rank among the top million minds in Britain.

The British state is a ship whose captains are fools, whose officers are criminals, and whose noble lineage has been reduced to a travelling soap opera. It is no longer a vessel for the people, nor a beacon of national pride, but an empty hull, waiting either to be salvaged—or to sink entirely.

Then we have the state enforcers of this sinking ship: the police.

Once the pride of the British state, known worldwide for their fairness and integrity, the police have been hollowed out and corrupted by the same neoliberal rot that has devoured the politicians. Once guardians of the peace, they have transformed into a paramilitary force—not protecting the people, but enforcing state diktats and social engineering policies. They do not keep order; they keep the middle class in line. They do not serve the people; they serve power. The working class, if they step out of line—especially beyond the invisible fences of their class—are punished with zeal. Meanwhile, the police, so thoroughly wokeified, turn a blind eye to crime where it suits them. They allow the balkanization of British law, believing in some delusional sense that permitting lawlessness is a form of equity.

And then there are the media classes—the wretched journalists of the BBC, The Guardian, and the wokeified North London media-mafia. These are the people who put the Bollinger in champagne socialist—out-of-touch aristocrats of the narrative, clinking glasses in Islington townhouses while lecturing the working man on his privilege. They do not live in the real world. They live in a bubble of self-importance, parroting the same state lies year after year, gatekeeping the Overton Window to ensure that no true dissent—no real challenge—can ever emerge. They do not report reality; they construct it. They do not seek truth; they suppress it.

The Leviathan is not just a bloated bureaucracy—it is a full ecosystem of corruption, incompetence, and ideological capture. From the royals to the media class, from Parliament to the police, every institution that once made Britain great has been seized by those who despise it. And the people? The people are left adrift, abandoned, watching as the ship of state lists ever further, waiting for the moment when it finally capsizes.

The failings of the British state all root themselves in the Post-War consensus—a grand experiment in post-industrial socialism for the masses that has, over the decades, led to stagnation, decay, and decline. The destruction of British industry was not merely an accident but an inevitability, as the socialist mind ramped up taxation to 95% of incomes, suffocating innovation and enterprise. The nation that once built the greatest machines, that once sent steamships across the world and engineered the Industrial Revolution, was reduced to begging the IMF for a bailout. The British people were promised security and stability in exchange for the old order—what they got was mediocrity and managed decline.

At its core, this decline speaks to Nietzsche’s distinction between the Apollonian and the Dionysian. The modern British state is an Apollonian monstrosity—everything must be managed, regimented, controlled. Policy outcomes are treated like scientific equations, the entire machinery of the state geared toward maintaining equilibrium rather than creating anything new. The Apollonian state does not tolerate uncertainty or spontaneity—it suffocates them under layers of bureaucracy and policy papers.

Yet life—true life—is Dionysian. Creativity, spontaneous order, fast movement, bold risk-taking. This is what the state fears most. The lack of joy in society today is not an accident; it is the direct result of an economy mismanaged by those who prize control above all else. If society is to be revitalized, it must embrace the Dionysian spirit once more.

But the men who could bring this spirit back—the men of action and intellect—are nowhere to be found in mainstream society. They are not allowed on television. Their ideas are not permitted in polite discourse. No creativity, no new ideas, nothing but pre-approved messages and carefully crafted narratives. The gatekeepers of the regime know what happens when Dionysus enters the scene: people wake up. They begin to question, to create, to break free. That, above all, is what the state cannot allow.

The British state has no concept of building up the wealth of the nation—it has no interest in it. Wealth creation, innovation, and entrepreneurship are simply not priorities for a system that survives by taxing and redistributing rather than fostering growth. It is telling that the idea of national prosperity, of increasing real wealth, is entirely absent from mainstream British discourse.

Fifty years ago, British television would have engaged with the new and the revolutionary. In the same way that the youth culture of the ‘60s and ‘70s was embraced, discussed, and even commercialized, there would today be television shows about Bitcoin, crypto investing, and new digital industries. But there is nothing. The closest thing to business coverage is a parade of tired property shows catering to middle-aged Boomers and stay-at-home mums, obsessed with their house prices and kitchen renovations. The only entrepreneur on mainstream TV is Alan Sugar—hardly an inspiring figure for a new generation of risk-takers and wealth builders.

There is no state-backed movement, no encouragement from the establishment to inspire young Britons to increase their productivity, start businesses, or build anything of value. There is no message of boldness or ambition, no call to action for young men and women who want to carve their own path. Instead, the state offers a slow, lifeless shuffle into bureaucratic mediocrity—where innovation is strangled by regulation, success is taxed into oblivion, and ambition is drowned in a sea of state-sanctioned complacency.

A nation that does not encourage its youth to build, create, and strive is a nation in decline. And the British state—unable to create, only to confiscate—is actively complicit in this stagnation.

The Bank of England may throw around the word "productivity" in its reports, but the British state itself has no real interest in understanding the mechanisms of wealth creation. It does not want to acknowledge that an increase in human action—risk-taking, entrepreneurship, innovation—leads to an increase in wealth. Why? Because that would mean individuals taking power into their own hands, reducing their dependency on the state. A productive, self-sufficient society erodes the need for a vast bureaucracy, and that is a threat to the state's very existence.

Here, too, the Dionysian spirit is essential. Without the freedom to take risks, to rebel, to embrace danger and unpredictability, society falls into stagnation. If human action is constrained—if every instinct toward adventure, creativity, and risk-taking is crushed by the dead hand of the state—then we are doomed to live in a loop of perpetual repetition. This is the essence of Nietzsche's concept of Eternal Return: time repeats itself endlessly unless the individual imposes their will upon it, seizing the moment to break free. Without this intervention, life becomes a slow-moving cycle of bureaucracy, control, and sameness—a country on autopilot, drifting into nothingness.

A return to nature is needed, not just culturally but economically. The British economy has been unmoored from reality, propped up by perpetual budget deficits, masked by manipulations, hidden behind mountains of debt, and sustained by ever more elaborate lies about the sustainability of the welfare state. This is an economy floating on illusions, severed from the hard realities of production, value creation, and honest exchange. The British state, having abandoned all grounding in nature and reality, has become a house of cards. And as history has shown time and time again, such illusions can only last so long before nature asserts itself once more.

The welfare state, once conceived as a noble safety net, has become a system of forced redistribution that punishes the productive and rewards the unproductive. This is the road to serfdom in its purest form—where the healthy, successful, and ambitious are burdened with ever-higher taxes to sustain a system that disincentivizes work, self-reliance, and personal responsibility. Over generations, this creates a dysgenic effect: those who contribute the most to society are squeezed, leaving them with fewer resources to invest, innovate, or even reproduce at the rate they otherwise might. Meanwhile, the unproductive are subsidized to multiply, their dependency locked in by the very state that claims to help them.

This is the Leviathan at its most insidious—both antinatural and, ultimately, boring. A society built on such foundations is doomed to stagnation, mediocrity, and inevitable decline. The only solution is a return to nature, to a way of living where risk and reward are once again aligned, where effort is not punished, and where the individual can break free from the suffocating grip of state control.

The Dionysian Briton must seize this rebellion in both philosophy and action. The state has no claim over the individual's life, and its financial mechanisms can be outmanoeuvred. Cryptography, best represented in Bitcoin, offers a means of escape—a tool for the individual to reclaim sovereignty in a world where the state seeks total control. This is the beginning of a new era, one in which the individual returns to a more natural, free, and dynamic way of living, cutting through the Leviathan's web of taxation, surveillance, and coercion.

The final step in the Dionysian rebellion is not simply a rejection of the state, but a transformation in how we perceive reality itself. The failures of the British state—its incompetence, its corruption, its bureaucratic inertia—are not isolated events, nor are they mere policy failures. They are symptoms of a deeper epistemological crisis: a fundamental misunderstanding of reality, one shaped by a mechanistic, reductionist view of the world that has stripped life of its vitality and unity.

Modern society, shaped by the Leviathan's worldview, treats the universe as a series of disconnected particles, individual units to be measured, counted, and controlled. The economy is seen as a machine, fine-tuned by central planners who tinker endlessly with interest rates, inflation targets, and welfare policies. The body is treated as a collection of separate organs, each requiring its own pharmaceutical intervention. The mind, in turn, is reduced to mere chemical processes—hence the widespread and simplistic belief that depression is a 'chemical imbalance' rather than a deeper existential condition tied to the quality of life, human action, and social decay.

This mechanistic view is the Leviathan's greatest trick. It justifies intervention, control, and perpetual crisis management. It enables the state to frame every problem as a technical issue to be solved with another policy, another committee, another bureaucratic program. It severs the individual from their instincts, from nature, from a holistic understanding of the world. It makes life fragmented, uninspired, and lifeless.

The Dionysian rejection of the Leviathan is not just about political independence but about a philosophical and metaphysical shift—away from the atomized, mechanistic worldview and toward a holistic, integrated understanding of existence. It is about seeing the body as a unified whole, where physical, emotional, and spiritual health are inseparable. It is about recognizing that the economy is not a machine to be managed from above but an organic system of human action, where spontaneous order, creativity, and risk-taking drive real wealth creation. It is about reclaiming reality itself from the dull, lifeless grasp of state-controlled technocracy.

This rebellion is not just political; it is ontological. It is a refusal to see life as a series of disconnected, manageable parts and instead embrace it as a dynamic, evolving whole. The Leviathan has sought to sever man from his nature, to turn him into a predictable, manageable, and ultimately docile creature. The Dionysian spirit seeks to break free—to restore man's connection to the natural order, to reinfuse life with spontaneity, action, and adventure.

Thus, the fight against the state is not merely one of taxation or surveillance or policy—it is a fight over the nature of existence itself. To reclaim sovereignty is not just to break free of bureaucratic control; it is to reclaim reality from the sterile, controlled, and lifeless vision imposed by the Leviathan. It is to restore the full scope of human potential—wild, unpredictable, and beautiful.

The British state, once a vehicle for prosperity, order, and individual liberty, has become a parasitic Leviathan—detached from nature, hostile to human flourishing, and blind to its own dysfunction. Its failures are not isolated accidents; they are systemic, rooted in a post-war ideology that has stripped individuals of their sovereignty, wealth, and ability to chart their own course. The mechanistic worldview it promotes has reduced life to a series of economic policies, bureaucratic diktats, and social engineering projects, severing people from their natural instincts, their sense of purpose, and their ability to act freely.

But the response to this crisis cannot be another set of bureaucratic reforms, nor a futile attempt to "fix" the broken system from within. The solution is a total rejection of the Leviathan's false reality—a Dionysian rebellion that embraces spontaneity, action, and the natural order. It is a return to wealth creation over wealth redistribution, to personal sovereignty over state dependence, to an economy driven by human action rather than technocratic control. It is an understanding that reality is not a machine to be managed but a living, organic whole.

This is not a call to nihilism or destruction, but to renewal. A nation, like an individual, must reclaim its sense of purpose. The Leviathan will not willingly relinquish power, but the forces of entropy and decay ensure that its collapse is inevitable. The question is not whether the current order will fall, but what will emerge in its place. If Britain is to survive, it must rediscover the spirit of boldness, creativity, and individual excellence that once defined it. The state's power is an illusion—one that will fade the moment individuals choose to reclaim their own.

Appendix #2 - The Monetary Revolution

by Eliot Ashton and Dr. Alexander Thorne, PhD
(Originally published under the pseudonym 'Monetary Revolution')

Although the masters make the rules

For the wise men and the fools

I got nothing, Ma, to live up to

For them that must obey authority

That they do not respect in any degree

Who despise their jobs, their destinies

Speak jealously of them that are free

Cultivate their flowers to be

Nothing more than something they invest in

Bob Dylan – It's Alright Ma (I'm Only Bleeding), 1965

Introduction

The start of a monetary revolution is upon us. In the grander scheme of revolutions, a monetary revolution might not be as messy as some previous revolutions, but we should remember that revolutions are not always political in nature. Most revolutions throughout history are actually technological in nature. These revolutions can induce and result in violence or peace, but they are always disruptive and life-changing. Like all revolutions, a monetary revolution will occur when the monetary status quo reaches breaking point; and something doesn't change or alter, but definitely breaks.

What is money? Money is merely an abstraction to represent the relationship in society between time and value. Money therefore is hugely important in life. It might be at the root of all evil, but it is also at the root of all prosperity. Money allows value in society to move around to where it is most needed. If society needs food, money will go towards farmers who produce food, and incentivise others.

That money is not talked about is probably for the best, because as this series goes through the history of money and its use in society, we will see money is not as simple as we first think. Money's value can shift, money can be manipulated, money can be replicated and forged, money can be stolen or seized.

So, what is a monetary revolution? Well it is when the current monetary order; the system of government issued money is starting to break down. When this happens, there are two things that could happen: reform or revolution. In many countries where the monetary order was broken, it resulted in revolution.

Not always monetary revolution, but political revolution. The 1920's hyperinflation I think, is still one of the primary causes of the rise of the Nazi Party in Germany. In Latin America, the change in the monetary order in the 1970s caused mass poverty and led to the seizure of power by generals across the continent.

Yet the revolution could also be more positive. It could be a pure technological revolution, that actually solves a problem. The use of cryptocurrencies and associated blockchain technology could provide this technological revolution to prevent the current monetary order from imploding in on itself. If this happens, change will be needed.

What change it will be is yet to be seen. But when something breaks, change will come. Another economic collapse or a monetary crisis could lead to two things: political intransigence leading to mass civil unrest and a resulting political revolution, or it could lead to a move away from government backed monetary systems as people subvert state power more subtly and more effectively.

Decentralised, but digital and permanent. Bitcoin, built on the world's first blockchain, is perhaps the most valuable thing yet created by man. What gives it value? It is the technology in Bitcoin that gives it value. Just like every other money in history, it is the use of its technology that gives it value, just like every other monetary system throughout history.

Bitcoin is not something created to make money, it is money. It is the world's first mathematically perfect, supply and demand currency model. It is highly decentralised compared to its competitors, and in this new hyper-digital world; it is something with far more stability and permanence compared to abstractions like nation states, central banks, and large corporations.

Bitcoin will be a medium of exchange used that truly compliments and supports bottom-up free market capitalism, empowering mankind to use a currency that is trustworthy; with inherent models of stability and decentralisation, to cut out the middleman.

Bitcoin is the first perfectly sound money created by man. The inalienable right to have a currency with true value and stability in its purchasing power will become clearer and clearer to those who use Bitcoin and do so for the long term. One Bitcoin is one Bitcoin, and will always be one Bitcoin. One pound or one dollar is not always a pound or a dollar. A pound has different values all around the world, it can also be printed by the central bank on a massive scale, banks are now threatening customer with a negative interest rate on their deposits. In effect, taking money away from people. Money in bank accounts can easily be seized by governments and easily monitored, and then there's the that kicker to all fiat currencies: the hidden tax called inflation.

Bitcoin is not perfect. It is not a metonym for cryptocurrencies. It has flaws and benefits, like all monies. But as the first, it will see it's use narrow over time. It's use in future will be limited to moving large amounts of value. Others coins in the coming revolution will take over with faster and quicker payments, more complex blockchains, more private, less energy use or a more stable value. These are not flaws of Bitcoin but features. What it does do, is a perfect store of value; and this is how it will be used. Other coins, and it's still too early to tell which ones, will arise to compliment Bitcoin, but Bitcoin will be at the tip of the monetary revolution.

So let's go back to basics. What is money in the first place? Where does it come from? Money, to represent value, has a long history, with a few types of proto-monies stretching back tens of thousands of years, but the real place to start is the Neolithic revolution – sometimes called the agricultural revolution or farming revolution, which unfolded about 12,000 years ago. The Neolithic revolution resulted in the end of hunter-gathering and the start of settled farming civilisations. Humans gave up their previous lifestyles to settle down near farms and live from crops like wheat. Philosophers Jean Jacques Rousseau have claimed this was a bad step for humanity. It resulted in population sizes booming, but the quality of nutrition going down as there was an increasing dietary reliance on bread for calories; rather than the meats and berries and nuts that had gone before. For the first time, humans could complain about how many carbs they were eating. The lack of protein in diets meant humans physically shrunk in and became weaker. Why would they accept this trade off? Well the invention of farming led to easier sources of calories. The prospect of easy to eat, cheap and tasty bread was worth more than the harder to source meats.

The population of the Earth had been increasing temperatures and the planet warmed and became more fertile. But soon, this population boom led to more and more people going after increasingly fewer resources and different sources of calories needed to be sourced.

The invention of bread actually preceded the farming revolution, and though we can't be sure, the farming revolution could have been to increase the amount of bread in production as more and more bread would have been needed. The magicians who could bake bread from crops and sell would have most likely seen people conglomerating around the most productive fertile areas for wheats.

The Fertile Crescent was so fertile it allowed more bread to be produced than could be consumed, as knowledge of farming increased it allowed those who studied proto-agronomy to understand things like seasons and soils, and how to plant and harvest more and more wheat to increase the amount of bread in society.

Farming societies led to the creation of stable societies. So desired were these areas that, like a Manhattan or London of today, people flocked to move to them, and man started to learn to live in communities larger than 150 people. These conglomeration effects resulted in the need to form defences to stop your fields from invaders wanting to plunder and loot. This increasing coordination of efforts by people in society resulted in increased specialisations of labour, as more wealth in the form of food created genuine surplus resources.

This is what wealth still is. The surplus of resources. It is a resource you don't need right now and so can store. Today this is done in cash, stocks, shares, housing and even strange things like Baseball or Pokémon cards. A store of value is basically anything you don't need right now to survive. In the earliest farming communities, power would become rooted in the man who gained control of the excess surplus, especially if they had control of it over the winter months. These men, or occasionally women, were either the priests, the elders of society, despots, or even the people themselves, in early proto-democracies.

The nature of this podcast is to take a broad look at history, and so if we jump forward from the Neolithic Revolution some 11,850 years, another similarly revolutionary event happened that led to another great mass-human revolution as profound as the Neolithic one. Today we call it the industrial revolution. This revolution has been better charted by history and evidence, though like the Neolithic Revolution before it, much of it is still largely a mystery. There is no mystery as to where it happened, but to why it happened, and why it happened where it did.
In short, what we know is that by the early 1700s, Britain was about as wealthy as it is possible for a non-industrial country to be. Britain was merchant democracy benefiting from trade with the continent and the New World. Britain was not utopia.

Britain for a hundred years had been becoming increasingly wealthy, and it was overtaking much of Europe who were still living in the fallout of political and religious fracturing. Britain's population size and wealth began booming. Britain, long an island of immigration, became an island of emigration as people all over the island moved to the new world in search of more religious freedoms and economic prosperity.

Despite this, Britain's population continued to boom, but then, miraculously, so did its agricultural produce. New techniques were developed at home, but there was also the importing of certain ideas and items. Windmills were about as mechanised as agriculture got, pre-industrial revolution. British windmills that started to be introduced in the 8th century AD and scattered much of East Anglia were a Dutch import, to grind wheat into flour. It shows the lack of industrial production that the most mechanised piece of technology was over 1000 years old.

This mechanisation via wind, and water in the case of waterwheels, could only be supported in wealthier pre-industrial economies, but in Britain, a rich area of minerals had a very exploitable energy source in coal. And its wealth led lots of clever tinkerers and engineers to start looking at the increasingly proficient scientific output, and start putting two and two together.

Making new and old things work together in ingenious ways; coupled with a free and open internal market, resulted in a number of small innovations that by themselves led to a revolution. Led by a mix of aristocrats, merchants, farmers and innovators, British farms introduced better crop rotation, brought over the Dutch plough so it could be pulled with fewer oxen or horses and saw improving transport infrastructure to move goods. Aristocrats got very interested and good at the selective breeding of animals, while the increasing profits allowed the best farms to increase their size and buy the old unproductive farms.

Britain's increasing productivity meant workers became rapidly less for farming. People; especially the now out of work farmers in the rural areas of Britain, moved to the cities to look for work en-masse. This took place at a time when some of these productivity and efficiency from farming were starting to be implemented in the factories now popping up across the north of England.

Britain's aristocrats were increasingly looking at ways to make money. There was little Romanisation of the land, as the British aristocracy put farmers out of work, dug huge canals through their land, and mined coal underneath their land to make as much money as possible. Capitalism, the idea that the allocation human labour and enterprise is best left to the open market, had been the primary function of the state for nearly 200 years.

A move to capitalism amongst the aristocracy came from the very top of English society, as Queen Elizabeth realised England was losing out to Spain, Portugal and even most terrifyingly of all, France. Their gains from the New World were huge as the Spanish crown was bringing back huge amounts of gold and silver from the New World.

Queen Elizabeth therefore issued privateers, legal pirates, to try and loot this bounty, and bring it back home. Britain was an island nation and proved adept at this form of proxy financial-naval warfare.

Britain was unique in having always had a capitalist heart, located in the City of London; a 1-mile big separate city inside what we now call London. It had been a trading hub at the heart of the River Thames since pre-Roman times, and such was its guaranteed liberty, that it had promises of liberty ground into common law, having been guaranteed by the crown in Magna Carta. Even today, it is still only one of three parts of Magna Carta still on the statute books in Britain.

This capitalist heart of Britain, and the Crown, went into business and promising to share the wealth from this privateering. It was hugely successful enterprise, as island nation Britain's superior naval skills showed across the oceans. New wealth suddenly entered Britain. And one man stood above the others in terms of money and wealth: Sir Thomas Gresham. He had learnt how to make money in that great merchant city of Amsterdam; who in turn had learnt trade from Venice and Genoa. State sponsored capitalism was greatly profitable for all he had realised.

Gresham was a favourite of the Crown since he had entertained Elizabeth I at his Osterley House in Middlesex. The Queen was greatly impressed by his house and greatly was enjoying his company, but opined that the court was too large and needed a divide. To show his wealth, Gresham sent for workmen from London to build the wall overnight. The Queen was hugely impressed, and over the next 12 years often went to stay at Osterley House. In 1566, Gresham built, modelled on the Antwerp one, a London Bourse, or stock exchange. In 1571 the Queen named it the Royal Exchange and granted it numerous trading licenses. Gresham was successful and capitalism was now state sponsored and state backed. Yet Gresham was more than a capitalist tyrant, it was he who persuaded the Queen, who'd allowed the currency to be debased through impurities in the silver coinage; to restore it to its original value. He argued for sound money.

So, we skip ahead again 200 years or so to pre-industrial 1750s Britain, and remember where we left the economy of Britain at this point of inflection; where farmers were leaving the rural areas and moving to the cities to look for jobs. Britain was an island nation and couldn't solve new problems by marching into new land. Remember, many were already leaving through emigration to the colonies, and population sizes were still booming. These workers needed jobs. The base of society for the past 12,000 years, that of most peoples worked in farming, had gone. These people needed jobs, so what could be done in Britain?

The same technology that put these workers out of farming jobs were applied to other parts of the economy. Jobs were created not in farming, but in the new industries where huge amounts of cheap materials could be made and exported.

However rather than a state-led capitalism approach, this new revolution was primarily focused on the cities in the north that had first developed these new manufacturing techniques. Britain had been so wealthy that the newest equipment like Thomas Newcomen's steam engine was already being used across the country. People could see the value of techniques to produce more with less, especially in using steam power as coal prices became cheaper and cheaper. In Manchester, for example, as a result of the Bridgewater canal built in 1760, coal could be transported from a coal mine to Manchester, with cheaper prices than anywhere else in the country, with land transport being so expensive.

Canals sprung up throughout Britain, while the use of coal precipitated a better steam engine made by James Watt as more and more products could be made for less.

An industrial revolution needed to happen in Britain. If it wasn't for technological revolution increasing the wealth of the population and economic output, then the increasing population, and lack of political representation, could have resulted in political revolution.

We can see what could have happened to Britain had it not undergone this revolution. A few decades later in the 1780s and 90s, another revolution in France was launching. This was not a technological revolution, but a political one. France was more centralised than Britain, but could be seen as a mirror image in many ways - perhaps why the two countries have remained best of frenemies for 1000 years.

The Power of the Bourbon monarchy had become highly centralised, and their decades or perhaps century of misrule, compared to the booming British, was making the French fall behind. A tale of two countries. But this isn't to say France wasn't benefitting from the slow diffusion of wealth and trade. The artisanal classes were increasingly moving into cities and moving away from the peasantry intellectually. They saw themselves as somewhere between the peasants and the aristocrats. They were a fourth estate of people with no say in society.

France, and particularly Paris, was reaching breaking point. Increasingly worse blunders and policy missteps preceded the years leading up to 1789, but then the crucial stability of society broke when a poor harvest across France caused grain prices to soar: Parisian society exploded into outright revolution in one of the most famous and consequential events in human history: the storming of the Bastille.

So where does this industrial and political revolution fit in with this monetary revolution. Well that's that what this series is about. A slowly unfolding speculative revolution is beginning to take shape. In some ways, this is merely a new piece of technology appearing to disrupt the market, but I think this underplays it. The current monetary system of government backed and issued money is so broken that a great divergence is about to take place. Those countries that back decentralised sound money will go down the British path of economic revolution; those that ban decentralised currencies will see themselves go down the path of France and towards political revolution.

This financial, Bitcoin, or monetary revolution has had a similar start to other historical revolutions in history. Our current money system has been manipulated for so long, and all the while capital has been so misallocated by government away from productive innovations and towards welfare. The lack of new technological innovations is because governments have manipulated and debased their currency to fund predominantly welfare spending. In short our perpetual growth model is starting to fail as technological progress, and therefore economic growth, is slowing down.

Our current monetary system is increasingly old fashioned for an internet age, and is reaching breaking point. Rich countries have devalued and manipulated their currencies for too long. Today, jobs that provide little pay lots; while valuable jobs are underpaid relative to previous decades, as currency manipulation has infected economies across the world.

The essential worker crisis of early 2020, as we all stayed at home due to lockdown, showed just who needs to work and who doesn't. Those who did need to work almost certainly weren't getting paid the value and importance of their labour; while derivative traders or financial consultants get paid well above the relative importance of their labour, as government money has been manipulated to support financialisaton of the economies in the West, rather than increasing industrialisation. The supermarket worker, the plumber, the people who fix telecommunications issues, should be under no illusions that the value of their labour has been reduced over a period of decades by inflation caused by the government.

In effect, the very money we use, the pound, dollar, and euro, whatever; are losing their value day by day, and have been for decades. Money is now political, with governments and central banks allocating money to whatever areas they like; propping up housing markets, stock markets, defence, and aerospace industries, and in the EU's case: using money to prop up entire countries. This doesn't liberate people, but enslaves them to government money.

The situation is helped by adding what central bankers call 'liquidity' into the economy. This means giving banks money by propping up unproductive bank loans, further disorienting the economy. However, crucially for politicians; it keeps the banking and property sectors afloat. This creation of fake money trickles down to the economy and causes genuine inflation on anything other than cash: housing, land, stock market prices all soar; while all the free money means consumer credit drops to record low interest rates – creating a highly consumerist society and an incentive to borrow.

The artificial pumping up of the economy, to allow for easy corporate borrowing, at cheap interest rates, allows unprofitable companies to survive. In effect, money in the form of credit has been manipulated to go to areas where there is no economic growth.

Economic growth in the west has, in the past 12 years at least, been down to rising populations and the increasing financialisaton of economies relying on the benefits of globalisation. This is not an economic model, merely a bandage over problems. Western inability for real economic progress has been down to the increasing government allocation of resources; damaging the economy and the careful equilibrium between wages, house prices and rent, and consumer spending.

So taking all this into account, in my opinion, what Bitcoin represents is a means to solve so many of these problems. When people say Bitcoin is a only a solution looking for a problem, or they ask what problem Bitcoin solves; the reply should be simple: it solves our broken monetary system, and fixes the economy.

The 2008 financial crisis completely gutted economies that relied on financial services, as they realised artificially inflating house prices through debt wasn't a good idea. However, in the decade since, they've tried another approach: inflating house prices through quantitative easing.

Quantitative easing, the duplication and creation of artificial digital money by central banks, is as bad as it sounds. QE is slightly different all over the world, but in effect, it is printing money to buy corporate and bank bonds and to recapitalise the troubled financial industries. We know the banks today are a joke when we look at the interest rates for saving. They are at rock bottom prices and have been for a long time. It's because bank loans aren't really bringing in any returns. There are low interest rates because there is no economic growth.

Today, anything seen as the possible 'future', where there is seen to be the possibility of future growth leads to hugely inflated valuations. It doesn't matter if this company makes a profit or not. It doesn't matter even over a 10-year period if they don't make profits, as long as the illusion of future profits are still there. Airbnb, Uber and Tesla may in the future be hugely profitable, but right now they don't make profits. The amount of capital allocated to unprofitable companies should be a warning sign. Capital being allocated to unprofitable companies causes problems to whole parts of the economy, as cash becomes so unwanted, people are happy to store their wealth in, say Tesla than cash.

This means it's not profit driving the economy, as should happen, but debt. There are no profits, so the easiest source of money is bank credit. The amount of debt in the world is always increasing. This does not happen in isolation, and is not good. Debt results in actual money creation, which causes inflation. If a bank lends you £250,000 to buy a house, that's genuine money.

This system of easier credit started in the 1970s when Nixon turned off the trade from dollars to gold. The real value of certain things in the economy, and the value of the dollar began to diverge. Labour's value has slumped in relative terms since 1971, while house prices have soared. This leads, over time, to the relationship between economic productivity and wages diverging, as wages, paid in cash, has become devalued through such easy credit creation, and of course now, QE.

Currency devaluation is one of the worst things a government can do to its people. 60 years ago, a 1950s American ideal was achievable because of stronger wages, as money was less manipulated under sound money systems. A single bread winner could live in the West and earn enough to buy a house, support several kids, a wife, and two cars.

Yet with the decreasing purchasing power of wages, today, a two-parent household working good middle class jobs struggle to pay for the same house, and have the same living standards. That to me doesn't sound like progress. The idea that a single worker can afford a house today in the West in seen as a long shot for most. Houses and assets have inflated, and labour's value has been deflated. This all started with the negation of sound money.

Economist Richard Werner, perhaps the best critic of the current financial system and modern banking, was the economist who invented the concept of quantitative easing, and has argued QE has largely been misspent by central banks. QE has been used to fund speculation and accelerate deindustrialization.

Rather than investing this cheap money to increase investments in new industries and infrastructure on a large scale, its use has continued to pump the decline of the heartlands of both Britain and America by attempting to turn the Mid-West of the United States or North of England away from manufacturing and towards the service sector. High-Tech manufacturing has moved to the east. Part of this decline in manufacturing has been because of a slowing down in technological progress, but also a longer-term decline in new innovation and inventions, which are normally powered by the prosperous middle classes.

The decline of western economies began in the 1970s. This impacted the middle and upper-middle class the most. The decline of the dollar effects those people who gain most from wages. The poor do often tend to stay poor unfortunately, and the rich will always be rich, but the two groups that have most often driven business innovation and disruptive innovation have been the most hollowed out financially by the decline of government money. To this monetary problem, for me, Bitcoin is the answer.

Bitcoin allows a move away from the current financial system, to an alternative financial system. The joke 'what do you call alternative medicine that works… medicine' makes me think of this, and indeed I think it's already happening. The alternative financial ecosystem may be called an alternative, but as soon as it proves it works, it will *be* the financial system.

You should never feel sorry for the bankers that will lose their jobs. The move to Bitcoin will change what types of banking are still needed, and move it one again towards a more respectable profession, not a profession that makes you think you're going to lose all your money.

Many bankers deserve what is coming to them. Everything you are told about banks and banking are lies. For example, the very basis of our relationship with banks is a lie. We are told banks make money by taking deposits from customers, and using these deposits to lend to businesses, and people who want mortgages. This is incorrect.

You don't deposit anything with a bank. That implies you have custody over your money. If that was the case, why does Britain have deposit insurance guaranteed by the government. You don't own your own money. Take a close look at a bank statement. Some of them might even tell you. What you are actually doing is crediting the bank with your money, and they will repay you your money on demand of it. In effect you are loaning the banks your money. Banks do not need to reallocate this money and loan it out like we think they do.

This is what we've got to remember throughout this series. We can talk about central banks printing money all we like, but the real sinners are the corporate banks who can literally create money out of thin air to loan out. They aren't in the process of reallocating capital like many think they do, and they have even less public oversight than the central banks do.

Banks creating money via credit creation is 97% of all money created not central banks. Banks can literally create money out of thin air and lend it to you. If you're literally creating money out of thin air, from the banks point of view, it's in their interest to loan money to things with something attached.

Say, for example, somebody goes for a mortgage. The bank can literally press a button to create money to loan to you. Then say, you pay off the mortgage for 10 years and then lose your job and can't pay the rest. The bank will repossess the house. For nothing they've gotten 10 years of mortgage payments and a house they can sell again. It's all a big scam. Not only is it a scam, it's having massive impacts on the macro economic outlook of countries using this type of system like Britain and America.

What this means is banks are able to create loans out of nothing, and therefore there is no incentive for banks to issue productive debt. Productive debts are those that can in theory pay back long term returns on loans. Doing this effectively would mean a requirement to fund new technological innovation, which the banks don't want to do.

Instead banks focused on much shorter-term easy profits from loans. Take a walk down the high street. The high street for example in Britain is littered with examples of what cheap credit had done. In the past 10-20 years has been cheap debt has helped ramp up mildly profitable new chain restaurants or coffee shops. Banks have helped fund lots of these though cheap debt. It was an ability to see a bit of profit that these chains and franchises could provide, wrapped up in an easily scalable business that created a bit of money, meaning money could be loaned to those wanting to scaling up in these sectors that led to their huge growth.

In the lockdown inspired recession, many of these chains have closed down the more unprofitable stores, just showing how weak their finances were.

Productive bank lending in the economy would focus on new industries that provide high wages in highly profitable new areas. But generations of politicians and bankers have wanted the easier option, and to base their economy on credit creation and money printing. This has been helped somewhat by globalisation opening up a huge labour and consumer pools to drive the world economy and keep prices low at home. This has further distorted markets the world over.

Without deep structural changes in the economy that are unlikely to ever go far enough; there may be no change to this cycle of debt and bust.

However, this is where I'm optimistic about the new revolution I think can get us out of this mess. The Anglo-Saxon economies, of Britain and America in particular, have always found ways to get themselves out of any issues. They have always gone with solutions to innovate themselves out of a problem.

The obsession with money that has overwhelmed Britain since the 1570s, when Britain started to become a merchant nation under Elizabeth I, was key in helping to cement the industrial revolution. France, which never, and still doesn't truly embrace free market capitalism, is faced instead with constant and seemingly never-ending political revolution, rather than technological ones. An obsession with capitalism has been the success of Britain, and later America, for the past 400 years. Money makes the world go round, and inventions and innovations make the most money. Any problem faced by Britain and America has been solved by invention.

The UK and the USA's success over the past few hundred years has been due to its ability to innovate its way out of trouble: innovation in the financial, military, transportation, legal and political fields has meant that any narrow issue can be solved, and the broader system of society continues, however many other flaws it might have.

As we look at the start of 2021 there are many crisis' in the world, but none as pervasive, all-consuming and as unknown as our looming monetary crisis.

The problem is simpler than you might think. It all starts with what we talked about before,: low performing debt supports low performing debt. The continuation of this has not resulted in reforms to banking, but supporting it through debasement of the currency.

This is the reason for the lack of real economic growth in recent years, especially since the financial crisis, and why so many feel that in the future they might even be poorer than their parents. No profits in the economy means no interest rates, no real incentive to save, and no reinvestment in the economy from the young.

These problems have not gone unnoticed by markets. Now anything that looks like 'the Future,' is where capital is moving to. Any tech company is grossly overvalued compared to its profits. It's the promise that Airbnb or Uber might move from a growth company to a profit company that have resulted in their vast overvaluations. People have judged the current economic situation to be so negative that merely the promise of future profits has driven Tesla to a price to earnings ratio of over 1000 to one. In good economic times, such as the Victorian era in Britain, or the United States in the 1950s, the price to earnings ratio for a company could be low as 10-1.

If we accept all of this as true, what does this mean for early 2021? Well the Coronavirus has changed everything. People aren't going out anymore. Many already underperforming loans and investments have only gotten worse as commercial and office property prices have collapsed. To underwrite these poorly performing loans, once again the central banks stepped in; creating more money out of nothing to support the banks. Bad and unproductive debts proliferate… and nobody is punished for it.

We think money should be pure and untainted, and we should be right to think that. We're very wary of fake money. Nobody wants to receive counterfeit money. Even if you come back from Scotland to England with a Scottish paper note and try and spend it in England, there's a good chance it'll be rejected – even though its legal tender. People are this wary of money, but don't mind banks digitally creating money. It strikes me as odd. It should be trusted that money means what we think it should mean.

So what this series is going to argue is that this monetary revolution will unfold through a slow devolution of money, as the loosest forms of money like derivatives and then debts, bonds and currencies start to jam up and collapse. Wealth will begin to trickle down towards safer and more genuine forms of money like gold, silver and even; Bitcoin.

Money, as we've talked about, is not one thing, it's not just cash and coins; it is also gold and silver. But it is also loans and promises, and even today, promises upon promises which are called derivatives.

When a monetary system starts to unwind, it begins from the top down. The loosest forms of money, the 'promise that I promise that I will pay you' begin not to be met. Then 'promises to pay' like loans start to be missed, which means whole ecosystems begin to break down. Even today, in 2021 we've seen commercial and office property essentially being unable to pay much of their rent, with some places agreeing to only pay 30% rent.

To solve this problem, central banks will do the only thing they can and make more digital money to prop up the economy. More and more money will be created to try and solve this problem, and as it does more and more will start to look for safer forms of money.

The concept of the devolution of money was thought up by central banker John Exeter who created what's called Exeter's Pyramid. This pyramid is an inverted pyramid. The riskiest forms of money are at the top, but as it's an inverted pyramid, with its base at the top, it is also the largest quantity. This loosest form of money is the derivative, something which derives its value from something else.

It's a promise that I promise to pay you in future. Its value derives itself from the value of something else. This is basically as broad as it sounds, and why it's so huge. Everything from future contracts, to the future value of stocks. Some even argue all non-US dollar backed money is a derivate, as it all derives its value from the reserve currency, the USD. The value of all derivatives are estimated at 1 quadrillion dollars. Warren Buffett once called derivatives 'financial weapons of mass destruction.'

The use of derivatives in the modern economy is to some degree part of the problem in the current financial system. The foreign exchange market is basically a creation of economic inefficiency. When Nixon took America off the gold standard in 1971; foreign exchanges and interest rates were destabilized, and prices of marketable goods embarked upon an endless spiral of inflation. Derivatives were created to hedge against risk. Foreign exchange rates can go up and down quite quickly, so corporations doing business in say Brazil, don't want to invest money and also have the very real possibility that the *Brazilian real* might lose 20% of its value over a year, so in order to be able to make secure profits they wanted to hedge against this happening. Somebody else agrees to pay you the rewards in dollars and takes the risk of using the Brazilian Real.

It can work as basically insurance. But trading that has value deriving from something else doesn't just stop at currency. It means everything can be hedged and insured and traded. It means you get futures on options, and then options on options. Once an economy recedes people instantly try and get their money out of these neo-Ponzi schemes and into harder and more secure monies.

So during any financial crisis, money pours out of derivatives and towards safer assets. Money moves downwards towards safer forms of money. The second rung down on Exeter's pyramid is private businesses and non-monetary commodities. We've seen today many small private businesses going under, the collapse of oil, and relative to the stock market the lowest ever prices of commodities.

If things get even worse, money then flees stocks and shares and property; both residential and commercial. At the time of writing, the stock market and property market are holding up well… but if Exeter's pyramid is correct, things will rapidly unfold quickly as people start needing the money they parked in unproductive and unprofitable assets. If you want safer money, people will sell on the cheap as they can't find renters or other buyers. Credit then dries up as there's a clear financial crisis and nobody wants to take risks. Money starts to flee from corporate bonds, as the worrisome larger corporations in older industries look like they might sink.

In 2020 we've seen elements of this unwinding, but not totally. It is largely the central banks; the Fed and BoE, BoJ and ECB buying up corporate bonds to keep them from collapsing. There are currently $1.7 trillion dollars of corporate zombie firms in the US. These companies can't even pay back the interest on the loans they took out to survive. Once these corporations and debts start to go under there will be more pressure on listed stocks too, and the formerly secure companies will look increasingly perilous. More money will flee out of the stock market and go to places people feel are safer. What could be safer than mortgages and corporate bonds?

Well the next rung down on Exeter's Pyramid is mortgages and government bonds. There is almost no demand for government bonds at the moment, but much of it propped up by governments own central banks. Zero and in some cases below zero interest rates means many aren't tempted by putting their money into these bonds other than those corporations with duties to buy government debt. Mortgages start to dry up as banks are facing liquidity worries as other loans start to dry up. They're reliant on mortgage payments to keep solvent, but if these start to dry up, then things get really spicy.

Meanwhile there will be no demand for government debt. Government will have to find other buyers, but retail investors will have no demand for government debt. They just want to make sure they can survive till tomorrow. If they can't they might start printing money to fund deficits and buy their own bonds. This is Quantitative Easing, and it's already being implemented.

Central Banks buying government bonds, with no real desire to force high interest rates, has meant the government can borrow at below zero % interest. Nobody real would want government bonds, as they're below zero so you might as well just hold cash. Indeed many have gone this route. Holding cash rather than government bonds however is also pretty silly, as the inflation rate in the real world is at around 7% if you factor in house price and stock market inflation. Many have realised this too, and so have started to look towards gold, silver and now Bitcoin to secure their money.

What many are now thinking, including me, is that gold and silver as historic stores of value will be joined, and largely replaced by an even harder and truer store of value. The soundest money created by man will rewrite the economy, in a decentralised enough manner to allow all to prosper. To me, Bitcoin is powerful enough to rewrite Exeter's Pyramid from the ground up.

Bitcoin is an asset far harder to manipulate than any money before it, because is built on the basis of the blockchain technology. It's entire system, means to those who understand it, it is less prone to a sudden loss of trust in its system, than our own current financial system, which is propped up by governments collapse after collapse. Bitcoin is an asset that can't be printed to suit politicians or central bankers, it is a true independent, supply-limited, safe global asset. True money will enable a true monetary revolution.

Many who say Bitcoin is not a solution to any problem, do not understand the flaws in the financial system. The first principle is that any financial system has to rely on trust. To support the dollar, and the current financial system, you have to have confidence in central bankers and politicians. I don't. Yet I do trust a mathematically perfect supply-demand medium of exchange, which can store value perfectly. This system has my ultimate trust because of these inherent qualities. It also happens to solve many issues and lop-sidedness of our current financial system. Government money is propped up by all the mechanisms of the state. If you counterfeit money you'll have the police on your doorstep, if another country attempts to manipulate the Dollar or subvert it, then you'll have sanctions put on upon you, with the always looming threat of the US military on your doorstep.

Yet Bitcoin is not backed up by such brutality as the state's monopoly on violence. It is backed by a more fundamental force: the mathematics inherent in its cryptographic programming.

This will not just be a new silver or gold standard, it represents a much bigger change in our financial system. One far bigger than we can even predict. For the first time in human history, our store of wealth and value is utterly independent from political power and control. Now that is a revolution.

This is managed because the supply and demand of Bitcoin is controlled by the programming of Bitcoin itself, while its decentralised nature means that 'hacking bitcoin' is essentially as silly as saying 'hacking the internet'.

This financial revolution will be slow and gradual, and it will take perhaps 10-20 years to see its true impact. I think we are unlikely to have a Bitcoin day, the type of day when all central banks decide one day to adopt Bitcoin. It will take years and years of untold pressure from the public for this to happen, and slowly rogue states like Iran and Russia will move to a bitcoin standard to avert the US dollar – while retail investors all over the world will move more and more to cryptos as their superior metrics means there is incentive for all to save and invest in new alternative financing solutions which will start driving the economy once again. It will force nations to make choices. Move to bitcoin or be left behind.

The first industrial revolution didn't start one day in 1760. It took 60 years from the start to the end. The digital world today is surely quicker than this, but once confidence in traditional financial arrangements are lost, a similar revolution will unfold.

As the qualities of holding Bitcoin over Dollar or pounds are seen by more and more, confidence in the current financial system drains away, and confidence is the only thing that matters at all in money. It is all about relative and not absolute value.

Bitcoin is both the perfect store of value and a very easy to use currency. Many current 'issues' around Bitcoin will begin to fade away as its adoption increases; the price will stabilise as more is traded in Bitcoin itself rather than its value to other currencies. 0.1 BTC will be how much something costs, not its equivalent in USD or GBP. The beauty is that while the supply cannot be increased, Bitcoin can be divided up into smaller and smaller units – perhaps infinitely.

This will stabilise Bitcoin's price, and allow it to be used as a currency too. By this point there might be other forms of digital currencies, and even better ones might outcompete Bitcoin on certain elements, and certain areas of certain financial transactions.

But let us wonder what a Bitcoin standard would look like. Sending money to buy things might not be what it's used for much in future, as large corporations, central banks and treasuries, corporations and wealthy individuals hold lots of it, but as people will want to be paid in Bitcoin, it will revalue much of the economy towards the individual and increase decentralisation, rather than leading to centralisation and monopolisation.

Other cryptos might outcompete it in certain areas, but its first mover advantage and simplicity of its limited supply, means Bitcoin will always hold value; value that is inherently deflationary. This is what is so interesting about Bitcoin.

Every other major currency is inflationary. E.g. more of it can be made or found. Money can be printed by governments at will. The currency value artificially inflates. Just as if you had a currency based on sea shells, which might be rare on one beach, but if you just go to the next beach and find more, you massively alter the purchasing power of your sea shells.

Bitcoin has no such problems. I can tell you exactly how many Bitcoin's there will ever be: 21 million. As Bitcoin's market cap increases, simply holding, or hodling, will increase your purchasing power. It will pay to be frugal, not like in today's monetary society where consumption drives spending not investment.

Max Weber's concept of the protestant work ethic, where hard work, investment in yourself and thinking long term; will once again be rewarded. Hard work, frugal living within your means, low debt levels or debt only used to fund productive enterprises; like new businesses, rather than consumer spending, will be encouraged.

A deflationary currency does not mean there will be a general cash crunch, as people hoard Bitcoin. It will simply mean that if you spend Bitcoin, you will be spending on something worthwhile to you; or investing it into maybe a business which you believe will provide a better rate of return than simply hodling.

Bitcoin will be the first true, free market currency. Capital will not be allocated to where it is politically important, that means no more bank bailouts; capital will be about being sent to where it is most efficient – driving a capitalist renaissance, the likes of which we've never seen before.

True capitalism has never been tried before. The lack of secure and reliable money has always proved something of an inhibitor to true capitalism. But even with imperfect currencies, wherever capitalism has been tried, it has flourished even in the strangest places.

Capital will do what it always does. It is possible to destroy capital. The allied bombing of Germany caused much damage, but capital isn't just built up in buildings. It survives in the people. Germany was rebuilt almost overnight as human capital poured into the rebuilding process. Capital can often be directed into the wrong places, but is rarely lost in absolute.

Capital also has a way of finding its way towards where it is safest. Once trust in one financial system is lost, nobody looks back. Sea shells used to be a store of value, no more. In China, silk was once a payment and store of value, no more. The Greek drachma used to be an international currency, and it was used by traders and merchants, but today it is no longer. Then capital moved to the Roman denarii, then the Byzantine solidus, then the Arab dinar, and then the Venetian ducat. The Florentine florin stability led to European Renaissance, while the 17th century Dutch guilder represented the capitalist powerhouse that was the Netherland, while the French franc was built on the power of the French army, which was defeated in 1815 leading to Pound sterling overtaking the franc as the currency of the world. Now we have the USD, where monetary stability was down to confidence in the United States' government and military, which has always helped force the faith in the currency.

In 2021, the dollar looks to be in decline, however no other government issued currency is seemingly competing to take over the from the USD. Nobody is seriously contemplating moving to the Chinese Yuan as the worlds reserve currency. However the Fed continuing to pump out QE money means many, and increasingly businesses, are looking for a reserve currency to replace the dollar and concluding that Bitcoin is the answer.

Bitcoin will succeed because it suits the new modern world, and it fits in with the world around us. It's a digital currency for a digital age, but we can go deeper even than that. The internet and computing revolutions were based on the work of cyber-libertarians. Those acid heads in the 1960s worked on developing computing networks and were obsessed with the decentralisation process and information passing together in interconnected computer networks, without government or even university control. It was the perfect mix of hippy spirit, Americana, and a Thomas Jefferson style distrust of governments and political power.

The internet has since been co-opted to some degree by huge powerful corporations trying to undermine these cyberlibertarian principles as best they can, but the internet cannot be taken over. It is not the printing press, the television, or the radio though; it is far more decentralised than that. This helps to also explain why Bitcoin cannot be stopped.

The cyberlibertarians tend to ahead of the curve to most computing revolutions, and Bitcoin is no different. The principles of a free spread of information away from government power and towards the individual is a slow and gradual process, but these principles are best encapsulated by Bitcoin. All Bitcoin is, is the transfer of information, and there has never been a quicker, more decentralised way than digitally. Why shouldn't money be the same.

Bitcoin and the blockchain may even be seen as a bigger revolution in our lives than the internet. The free spread of information is a powerful concept, but the free spread and complete independence of the most important thing in society; the very money we use, is revolutionary. The digital revolution we are all living through is changing our lives constantly, so it's only logical it will overturn everything in society. It is the culmination of Alan Turing's first pioneering working into cryptography and computing. It took nearly 50 years from the Watt engine to the steam locomotive. The steam locomotive was the culmination in dozens of small and large technical innovations, which proved a revolution in transportation. The culmination of the digital revolution will similarly be as life changing and awe inspiring.

For the first time in 5000 years of creating monies, man has a perfect currency. The history of money is a much underappreciated part of history, so I very much recommend Niall Ferguson's *The Ascent of Money*.

Historically, governments have not always issued money, but it's always been somebody with power. Monetary historian Alexander Del Mar argues for six major printers of money in the last 5000 years: coinage in temples, coinage by senators in Rome, then Casers and Emperors of Rome, then by Feudal Kings in medieval Europe, and then by private monetary coinage that was the result of the increased supply of monetary metals that was flowing into Europe after colonisation and plunder of the New World. But by the 17th century, money in the form of centralisation of gold, meant money started to be controlled by banks. By the 20th century, it was the governments as the state took control of central banks and hence money printing.

Bitcoin breaks that chain of money issuance, and completely alters the perception of money. Bitcoin offers limited supply, incorruptible process, easily transacted, with no middlemen, and the other kick that makes Bitcoin even better than many people even think is the backbone of bitcoin itself: blockchain technology.

Chapter 1: Monies

'I don't believe we shall ever have a good money again before we take the thing out of the hands of government – that is, we can't take them violently out of the hands of the government, all we can do is by some sly roundabout way introduce something that they can't stop.' Frederic Hayek - 1984

The main problem with money, is that we don't really understand it. We understand how to spend it, but we don't really understand that abstraction that is money itself. That's to say nothing of the general financial education most people receive. You don't join a bank, and upon opening an account, a bank manager sits you down and explain the nature of interest rates, debt and inflation.

History lessons in schools don't teach people about the gold standard. Money, considering it makes the world go round, is a subject that sees huge amounts ignorance. It's either just assumed you understand how finances work, or more likely, it's just not taught to you so you really have no understanding how badly the ordinary person is being screwed over.

So what is money, in the most simple form? It's a simple abstraction that something can represent earnt value across time. The system works because it is better at attributing resources than a system of bartering one item for another. Humans need an easier way than this to transact and store surplus resources, hence money was created to represent this value.

We mentioned in the introductory episode, the Neolithic revolution some 12,000 years ago. Imagine human lives before this moment. We were hunter-gatherers, with almost no possessions or food stored. We might have had a necklace of say animal teeth. Perhaps a spear and a few tools, but hardly wealth.

Slowly, over time, humans started to settle down into societies following the invention of farming, and perhaps the reason we did so, was because of the sheer abundance of extra resources available to farming communities. This led to huge increase in the amounts of excess resources swirling around in society than what went before. As hunter-gatherers we were constantly hungry and looking around for food. With farming, we have a nice reliable supply of wheat to make bread.

This move away from meats and berries and towards a reliance on wheat and bread through farming and carbs, shrunk mankind several inches; as we had a more carb rich diet than a protein rich diet. Despite the lack of nutrition, humans had an obvious desire for easy carbs over hard proteins.

Bread has the obvious advantage over meat, that it can be stored easily for later use. This is essentially the first example of excess resources in human society. Something that has value and can be transferred. This is what wealth is. The storage of excess resources for future use. The holding of wealth often also denotes political power. If you're the one with the keys to all the excess food in the grain silo, you're going to have power and leverage over others – especially during winter months when you can't find food as easily.

So, if you fast forward a few thousand years into these farm societies and go to the most advanced civilised societies in around 3200BC in Mesopotamia, modern day Southern Iraq; where we would find farming communities slowly and gradually developing into towns and then cities. Money by this point, was still essentially commodities: you would trade cattle, tools, or food, maybe even beer. You might even need to sell your own labour in whatever way in order to get enough bread to survive. You trade your freedom for peaceful living in society. For many, peaceful slavery might be better than rugged independence. But for others, there was just no other way to survive.

The owners of this labour would not use it to enable those working under their control to work to enrich each other, but would use it to cement their own wealth and power. They used this new power and money to engender loyalty and fealty; wage wars and find expansions of their power.

In Southern Iraq, around 3200BC, however, what we recognise as genuine modern societies began to form. Societies were too complex to pay in merely wheat, beer or livestock. A better system for exchange was needed. Necessity was the mother of the invention. The very reason these societies in modern day southern Iraq grew more than anywhere else on the planet was because of their technological superiority. However arcane money and writing might be to us now, back then it was world leading technologies.

Why were the better mediums of exchange so important for society? Well growing societies no longer could function on the word of mouth. More transparent and clearer methods of transacting information were needed, as the relative value society placed became too important to rely on word of mouth. The growth of writing and the use of money is far too intertwined, and too close together in their estimated dating of invention to have sprung up independently; with no mutual interest in each other. In other words, writing was invented to record financial transactions.

The earliest examples of writing we have in the archaeological records quite clearly back up writing being for accountancy reasons. This was the earliest example of a monetary revolution. Money was first used in certain areas of Mesopotamia like the Akkadian Empire who used what is now called the Mesopotamian Shekel. The Shekel was a unit of weight, indicating it was worth a fixed amount of wheat or barley. This is called commodity money and it's important to remember the difference between commodity money and what we have today, which is called representative money.

From these larger civilizations where trade started to take off, due to better mediums of exchange; an even more advanced civilisation started to grow in Mesopotamia. Some call them societies, cities, or empires; but in a small area of the Akkadian Empire, a small town called Babylonia grew up. Babylon sounds like a fictional, mythical pace, but it's really just the most famous, and perhaps earliest city in history, about 59 miles southwest of Baghdad. The reason Babylon is important was because it's the first real place society formed into something which today, we all have to live with the consequences off. The consequences of society.

The Bible heavily refers to Babylon, making the bible something of a warning against the sins that were perceived to have taken place there. But really, Babylon was just trying to deal with the problem of how to get people to live together easier. Which is why the Code of Hammurabi was the first codified law ever written into existence. Babylon innovated in banking, allowing the temples to become places of trade, lending, and depositing. Clay tablets recorded things like interest and early contracts. Loans were available for the rich, who were the first to exploit these new opportunities of credit. Babylonian style banking was so hated, that the fundamentals behind it were outlawed in both the Bible, with laws against usury, and in the Qur'an, which bans Riba; which again is essentially usury. Usury is the now common practice of making unfair or unethical loans. This can be as light as banning loans sharks, to the banning in charging interest on loans.

Perhaps this was due to financial booms and busts that must have occurred as debt levels in Babylon rose, but the historical evidence points to a series of bad rulers and a slowdown of innovation meaning other civilisations like the Hittites were able to catch up and raid Babylon. Babylon rose and fell over the next centuries; but Babylon had helped cement the banking sector in society to try and help facilitate the transfers and allocation of resources.

With functioning and stable civilisations, which could now produce more than the bare minimum of food, there were excesses of resources. This excess was no longer denominated by what it was, but by the abstraction of having a coin to denote the amount of resources, which could be traded between all.

Monetary innovation was not just limited to Babylon. Everywhere across the world where societies formed, some form of money took hold. And, as happens quite often, the Pacific Islands had perhaps the most fascinating of monetary systems. Halfway between Palau and Guam, and not a million miles away from the Philippines, in the Pacific, was Yap Island, in modern day Micronesia. In 1903, American anthropologist William Henry Furniss visited and noted that this tiny island, with a few thousand people, had a complex society with what looked like a strong monetary system. The island looked untouched by outside civilisation, and manage to operate on a cashless economy via the use of stone wheels to denote wealth.

These large stone wheels, called Rai stones, were quarried mainly on Palau and transported to the island. The possession of these stone wheels denoted wealth and the ownership of these stones relied on word of mouth. All that was needed to transfer the stones and hence wealth was its oral history. Yet Furniss was actually standing in the midst of ruin. David O'Keefe had gone to the islands in 1871 and tried, and largely succeeded, to break this system.

O'Keefe had gotten to Yap with large ships sailing from Hong Kong, loaded up on explosives, and gone to Palau. In one of the quarries used to get these Yap Islands stone, O'Keefe blasted it up and took a bunch back to Yap. In Yap, this caused a monetary meltdown as half the village said the stones were legal tender, while the village chiefs - the ones with the most to lose from the upheaval of the monetary system, said they were not of value because they were not mined traditionally with the sweat and blood of the Yap people. Over time, the people won out and the new Rai stones were accepted, but this caused the other stones to decline in value, and they could now only be used in ceremonial and cultural roles, rather than monetary ones. Yap Island now uses the USD.

John Maynard Keynes and Milton Friedman had heard about this system and compared the stone standard to what was in the west at the time, the use of a similarly useful rock as their monetary basis. The west used the gold standard, and like mining for gold means there are supply limits, that these stones had to be transferred from another island meant their supply was basically limited. Until the system was broken.

So as you might have worked out by now, money can be anything we want it to be. Even something as cheap as salt has been used as currency in some areas. Salt was easy to keep for the long term and it could be divided easily. The modern day English word salary is derived from Sal, the Latin word for salt.

So we've gone over money, now it's time to go over what debt is. It originates, probably, in Babylonia, and is the curse of so many economic problems, and yet the cure for so many. It can kickstart economies and prospects, or it can doom you as you see no way out of the tangle of debt swirling around.

So how does debt work? Say you owe somebody £5. They write a promissory note to you, saying they will pay you £5 on a future date. You then have another transaction with somebody else. You don't have any real money on you, but you have the £5 promissory note to pay you. You can pass that on right? It's basically money, isn't it? Well imagine this process across a country of 67 million or 330 million. There are a lot more people, but there are also a lot more layers. Derivatives can be 3 or 4 times removed from the actual money, as promises build upon promises upon promises.

You quite quickly realise how complicated tracking the money supply can be, while tracking who owes how much to whom, can get everything very complicated. This is how the system can be manipulated to cheat people out of money, especially when somebody else controls the money supply and can manipulate debts.

Debt relies on institutions like banks to facilitate and keep account of everything, so we've no real idea how much of banking could be automated, but we do have an example of what happens to an economy when banks stop. In fact, everything worked ok,

In Ireland in 1970, the bankers went on strike. Every major bank was closed and so many people hoarded cash thinking it would be what was needed through the months' long strikes. The strikes, however, didn't negatively impact the Irish economy much, as it kept on going. People wrote each other cheques to be used as debt to keep the economy going. A cheque is simply a note to the bank to pay the person named on the cheque.

Ireland in 1970, was still quite poor for European standards, and quite rural. During the strikes, you could go to the pub, pay with the cheque, and the landlord might know and trust you enough to accept the cheque as payment, and was trusted enough to pass on the cheque to suppliers as payment. The system actually worked, as bar and shop owners knew whose cheques they could trust and whose they couldn't. It was a money system based on debt and money at the same time, based on trust, the trust the Irish people had in each other was more than that for the banks, as everything carried on working. An early example of a peer-to-peer economy working just fine. Now, it wasn't a perfect system, eventually things need cashing in and sorting out, transacting need logging and cross-referencing, but if you had a system that did this automatically without banks, then there wouldn't be much need for banks at all. You'll notice how bankers have never tried going on strike since.

This Irish system of course required lots of trust, but then so do all money systems. When the trust system breaks down it doesn't matter if there are banks there or not. When it does break down, as it did in 1920s Germany, Zimbabwe in the 2000s, or Venezuela in the 2010s; all hell breaks loose. But Ireland, like much of Northern Europe has a lot of trust in institutions and other people.

German marks or Zimbabwean dollars during their hyperinflationary era are interesting to think about, especially if you compare it to the Irish problem. It was the currency itself that lost trust, not the banks or economy or politics, but the cash itself.

The cash were mediums of exchanges, but clearly not stores of values. So poor a store of value was this hyperinflationary paper money, that its value would radically go upwards in a single day. A store of value has to be a medium of exchange, but the best medium of exchange would also be a good store of value.

So we talked about it a second ago: hyperinflation, inflation, deflation; these are all words that to some might sound like jargon, but are crucial in understanding how money works. Inflation is simply an increase in money supply, as the supply increases, the demand ever so slightly decreases. This might only be at a rate of 1 or 2% a year, but this increase in money will eventually catch up with you.

Why does this happen, surely we can just make one of something and call it a day? Well it's very difficult to stop the urge to get something for free by making more of something. Furthermore, inflation is not unwanted by those who run the economy. Central banks like to control the economy through the only real weapon they have: the money printer. Inflation can be used to manage debt levels, as you pump up the amount of money into the economy, old debts suddenly become more manageable as there's more money in the economy.

Central bankers use their power of the money printer to keep the economy going, growing in cyclical cycles as the economy tries to make people prioritise either saving or spending. People who spend money, will spend it stores and shops, which benefits those who earn the revenue from increasing consumerism. However, the rich and wealthy are not really effected by inflation, as they store most of their wealth, in assets and not currency.

How is this extra money created and put into the economy? In several ways. The most obvious way is money printing by central banks, but perhaps a bigger reason has been the over proliferation of bank credit creation - that's loaning money to me and you. Today, loans account for most of the inflationary pressure of the money supply. We saw in the previous chapter how loans are no longer banks moving money from saving accounts and towards other investments, but the artificial creation of money. This has been the primary way money has been added to the economy over the last few decades.

Easy credit creation has resulted in the inflation of housing and other assets, and not productive investments like increasing economic efficiency. With banks able to create money from nothing and drop it in the economy. This creates inflation, starting with the first things to receive this new money: property and assets.

So, getting back to our historical timeline. We were looking at Yap Island with their famed stones, but of course in the west, we don't use rock like that, we preferred shiner things. We used coins and later notes. The first true coin was brought in by the Lydians in the 6^{th} century BC. These coins were struck in 640BC by King Alyatte, and this represented a great change in how money was seen. Rather than being backed by something like wheat, money's value was now abstract. The coin itself was the valuable resource, not what it represented. The greater abstraction in money led to greater flexibility, and the need for trust, but also led to a booming market economy around Greece and Asia Minor.

This coin money was also something of a monetary revolution. Money had long been known, with Genesis in the Bible being the earliest biblical with a reference to slaves being 'bought with money.' Greek historian Herodotus wrote how the women of Lydia, where the first coins were minted, began to sell themselves into marriage for this money – if only the Lydians had access to OnlyFans.

Lydia was the first place to need this money, as it was located on an island acting as a trading nation between the Med and the Near East. As a crossroads, Lydia needed the best medium of exchange it could get in order to standardise trade. Metals had been used as money before, but the Lydians were the first to standardise the coinage by minting a gold-silver alloy called Electrum. This was copied throughout the Greek world. This money was really only used by merchants and not ordinary people, with most people in this time still subsistence farmers and not able to produce a surplus of resources in order to need a store of value. One wonders if this use the 6^{th} century BC's monetary order facilitated trade that caused the later Hellenic Golden Age, as pretty much most scholars recognise that the Classical Age began not long after the minting of the new coins. The increase in trade would have led to economic specialisations and allowed people like Socrates, Plato, or Pythagoras to flourish.

The end of the classical period was due to the rise of Alexander the Great, who was the first head of state to put his head on the coin. Probably an ego thing, but with an empire from Greece to India, it would serve as a reminder of who was in charge.

Roman coins were used throughout the Empire, and its coins are now collectors' items. I'm not going to go through Roman monetary history, as apart from a few debasements that caused many economic problems that were eventually solved with a better currency, it is the fall of Rome that most interests me. The fall of Rome led to a new historical era: The Medieval period. The collapse of the Roman Empire meant a collapse of the Roman currency, and a collapse in trade.

The retreat of Romans in Europe led to a centuries long economic depression as easy trade dried up, it was caused by the lack of standardised coinage in Europe that had once been assumed to be stable through the backing of Pax Romana.

The medieval period was just a depressionary era, which took Europe really until the challenge of Islam as a unifying force to solidify Christendom, in order to start bouncing back. Following the Crusades, coinage started to be used more in Europe again. Trade, however, did start to grow back; especially Northern Europe where the German princely and city-states, England, and the Low Country started to mint and use more reliable coinage, as trading leagues like the Hanseatic League caught up with the Southern European trading leagues.

In the 9th century AD in China, paper notes were introduced. China was probably the most advanced civilisation at this point, with the technological edge. This made the paper itself the technology that gave these notes value. Remember the next time you look at a note, you're dealing with millennia old technology. You would have thought in 2021 we would have moved on from that, but don't worry; the Bank of England has a great idea. They'll make the notes of plastic instead, that'll solve our monetary problems.

In 1227, Mongol ruler Kublai Khan, grandson of Genghis, decreed that all gold and silver was no longer currency and only paper notes were legal tender; on pain of death. Which is pretty much the same thing happened in the United States in the 1930s when the US Government confiscated all private gold holdings.

So from Kublai Khan and the introduction of paper money, I want to move on to Britain's monetary history for the rest of this episode. In the next episode we'll start back with Renaissance money looking at European monetary history.

Britain, as historically one of wealthiest countries in the world, and since the discovery of the new world, a conduit between the Old and New World, was very much like Lydia in Classical Greek times. Britain was a trading nation surrounded by a continent of warmongers, who spent the best part of a century fighting over which version of the same god they believed in – Britain's lack of interest in much of this had seen it develop a modern market economy, and first saw many of the modern developments in money and banking that will be crucial in understanding how money works today.

British ideas of finance and money spread wherever the Brits did. John Kenneth Galbraith, an economist, noted that tobacco started to be used as money in Virginia soon after the English colonists landed in Jamestown in 1607, and in 1642 the colonists declared it to be legal tender; outlawing trade in gold and silver. This was actually a brilliant move. The colonists exchanged with Britain, and so in effect the legal tender was Pound Sterling, but the tobacco standard in the colony worked as a floating exchange rate between the price of tobacco and Sterling. Using tobacco as the medium of exchange meant that there was a ferocious amount of money pumped into producing more tobacco, spurring investment and more production. This exchange rate was so successful that tobacco, or promissory notes for tobacco, were used as currency until the end of the 19th century when the Federal government took over the issuance of money.

There are good arguments for government money printing and monetary flexibility. The Bank of England was able to print money during the Napoleonic Wars to fund the war, which of course caused inflation. The topic of currency debasement became a large debate during the 19th century. The 1844 Bank Charter Act was a huge debate in Parliament. Economist David Ricardo argued that money should not be issued at the behest of governments. Ricardo won out, with the results of the act meaning the Bank of England was only able to use notes secured by government bonds, or with enough gold to cover it.

The Bank Charter Act caused parliamentarians to discuss the very nature of money and its stability within the broader economy, however rather than being a watershed moment for monetary stability, the 1844 debate was the last on money creation until 2014, when Conservative MP Steve Baker introduced a new debate on money creation into Parliament. You can go on YouTube and watch the whole debate, the first for 170 years, and it's shocking to see how many MP's just simply don't understand money. I would like to play an extended clip but I'll leave that to the end of the podcast. It's slightly lengthy, but it's worth listening to.

So, by 1876, other countries in Europe were signing up to the gold standard. Currencies were fixed at rate which locked countries into a carefully calibrated monetary equilibrium. This gold standard was a solid system, but it had several catches, such as the scarcity of gold. The scarcity of gold pushed Europe to finding places around the world that had lots of it, namely Africa. The scramble for Africa that followed was brutal, but gold was one of the keys to why it happened. Britain wouldn't have called one of its colonies the Gold Coast otherwise.

This gold standard led to a period of inflation and deflation, both of which tended hurt the poor in different ways. This damage to the poor was seen to cause political instability. In both Germany and Britain, the late 19th and early 20th century saw the rise of the working classes pressing for more political reform.

But it was only with the World Wars that the gold standard broke down. Most combatants in 1914 stopped allowing notes to be traded for gold, however America stayed on the gold standard - allowing it to benefit from increased exports to Britain and France.

Gold reserves were depleted throughout the war and promissory notes were converted to just paper money. Churchill advocated a return to the gold standard in 1925 but this ended in disaster when the government resorted to using the pre-WW1 exchange rate, which considering the devastating effect the War had on British finances, was idiotic. By 1931 with the great depression, Britain left the gold standard again and for the last time. What had become a norm, that of monetary stability based on fixed value, was now seen as an optional extra. Political stability was seen as more important than financial stability.

The move to government money led to the two great 20th century economic theories forming, both trying to solve a problem of how do you manage the economy when the basis of your economy: the money, has no real value. Government now controlled the money, money controlled the people, and so government began to control the people, spending more and more money to solve political issues as money and its relation to the value of labour was now severed.

The two great economic theories of the 20th century were Keynesianism and monetarism. John Maynard Keynes argued that more income caused more money, and therefore, governments should try and push for full employment to create larger economies. Meanwhile, the monetarists argued that simply having money causes income. So they argued that in a crisis, you should pump up the money supply and stimulate the economy. Neither were overly bothered with the equilibrium between what things cost and their value. The value of say, a tradesman wage and the asset prices, most notably in property, started to diverge as value was related to government spending, not down to efficient allocation of resources.

Both these monetary theories were based upon a political currency and not a currency of fair exchange. In order to provide full employment, it is the government who needs to allocate resources, something its very bad at. In the monetary theories, simply increasing the supply of money as O'Keefe did in Yap Island resulting in the monetary basis beginning to lose its original meaning over time. The very equilibrium of money becomes lost from real value as the government allocates resources to where it is politicly important and not financially important.

The gold standard of monetary policy has been just that, the gold standard. But since we've left, things have not gone well. The 20th century may in the future be considered a lost century for economics, as more and more time and money was put into the dismal science, yet for some reason, nobody thought of trying to solve economic problems via a restoration of purchasing power to money.

The Nixon shock we'll talk about in future removed the gold standard entirely across the world in 1971 and the Dollar became the gold, backed only really by US military power. The power of and control over this currency meant the US had political if not economic reasons for a huge military-industrial complex. The ascent of the dollar as the reserve currency in the world meant all other currencies were essentially just derivates of the US Dollar. This system would give the US huge amounts of political power, but for the ordinary American and for many around the world, it was not a good thing…

Chapter 2: Modern Monies

'Who's the more foolish; the fool or the fool who follows it?' – Obi Wan Kenobi, A New Hope - A long time ago, in a galaxy far far away

Control of the money supply has often been seen as a crucial factor in totalitarianism. All the great despots controlled their own money printers. It's not really a fascist or communist thing, if there's even a difference in the two of them. In Chapter 2 of the Communist Manifesto, Karl Marx listed several definitions of how one could spot Communist society in the west. The fifth point Marx lists intrigues me: '*Centralisation of credit in the hands of the state, by means of a national bank with State capital and an exclusive monopoly.'* Whether we like it or not, the democratic west has fallen at least in one area to a very suspect, centralised, and authoritarian mode of capitalism.

So if you remember the last episode, we got to Renaissance Europe and then skipped towards early modern England. Like a Tarantino film, we're going to go back in the timeline and start with perhaps the most significant economic event of the 2nd millennia. In Europe at least, this was the breaking of feudalism.

A pandemic, the bubonic plague, killed sometimes up to a half the population of some communities. You know a pandemic, where a killer disease kills healthy people, rather than just killing off the weakest.

This led to a complete sea change in the economic makeup of society. The sudden drop in the amount of people meant that less food was rapidly less needed. Food became far cheaper as the wheat fields and sheep didn't die off. With far more food, people didn't need to rely on their lords to provide for them. The ownership of the serfs became less and less, as freedoms for the ordinary person increased, resulting not a huge amount of time later in the official end of feudalism.

With food cheaper, and lots of dead people; there was suddenly more room to live in. Rents extracted by the Lord of the Manor became cheaper and cheaper as there were less people around. Simply supply and demand, and it wasn't long before rent prices actually dropped to affordable levels.

The value of labour, relative to other areas of money transfers increased. Simply supply and demand. Normal Europeans now saw increasing excesses in capital with less to pay for and so could spend money and time on other, more productive and interesting things, rather than rent extraction from serfs: trade, art, literature, science, exploration and technology all flourished. By the middle of the 1450s these advances in European standards of living were all to come to a head with the slow printing press revolution of the middle 1450s, enabling these newly free people to get and spread information quicker and more reliably than ever before.

But it was in Florence where Europe first returned to a Roman standard of living. Florence was the first to mint gold coins. This was amongst the first European monetary metals since Rome and gave Europe a reserve currency to allow easier trade all over Europe. Florence flourished, and so did Europe, helping all of Europe to return to Roman standards in a relatively short space of time. The Renaissance was essentially Europe coming out of a 1000-year economic depression.

Britain meanwhile started its modern monetary adventures by adopting the modern gold standard in 1717 under Isaac Newton, who was the warden of the Royal Mint. Britain had long been on the silver standard, but as Europe got richer and more gold came into the continent, it started a demonetisation of silver across the world, which was finally cemented by Germany winning the 1871 Franco-Prussian, war and demanding its tribute in gold. Germany used this gold to switch to away from the silver standard to the gold standard.

The polities that didn't switch to gold, were quickly left behind. In this new European gold standard, all currencies were fixed to a certain amount of gold, e.g. one British pound was worth 7.3g of gold, while the French franc was 0.29g. This soundness of money also allowed good interest rates on saved capital.

The soundness of money meant there was much capital accumulation, and a far freer society without much government interference in life. The first pangs of the idea of the sovereign citizen. Wealth led to freedom, which led to happiness. Happiness led to confidence, and confidence leads to a good economy.

Yet as we saw in the previous chapter, the imposition of this new monetary standard was quickly ended, with the start of the First World War being something of a monetary and cultural watershed. Jazques Barzun identified 1914 as a key turning point in Western Civilisation. He argues the war, and subsequent movement towards government money resulted in a great switch between liberalism and liberality. Liberalism argues for the removal of the state from individuals, while liberality allows the government to permit people's indulgences in society and protect them from consequence. While another French historian, Élie Halévy, defined the current period of history as an Era of Tyrannies, where the major powers have economically and intellectually nationalised the country.

The classical liberal concept of smaller government is only possible in a country of sound money, because the money means just a much to the government, as it does to you. Once government has its hand on the levers of the money printer, money is just another political tool.

Sound money enforces honesty and transparency on governments, while soft fiat money allows governments to buy allegiance and spend on popular projects. Just because a government is democratic, doesn't mean it's any better than an authoritarian regime, in this way at least. In some ways, democracies face even more pressure to print due to elections. All the major tyrants of the world operated their own money printer. From Hitler, Lenin, Stalin, Mao, Mussolini, etc. Money makes the world go round and governments print the money.

This government money situation becomes pretty awful after only a short period of time. If the government or government agencies grant loans for art, art becomes politicised; if academic work can only survive from government grants, then it is the government they have to satisfy. I knew quite a lot of academics in Britain who studied the European Union, and all of them got grants from the European Union. They were all, coincidently, huge fans of staying in the European Union and the most ardent Remainers.

With government money; individual enterprise is washed away as what people can do with their own money becomes less and less. Life becomes more and more about the greasy government pole of fitting in, and not raising your voice.

But how did we get into this situation? Well it all went wrong far before 1914 sent the world's major economies off the gold standard. It really started with the slow globalisation of the world. Not international trade, but the slow merging of political, economic and financial interests across the globe.

The best and perhaps first example of globalisation was the British East India Company. 19th Century Monetary historian Alexander Del Mar is perhaps the best-known historian to lay out the evidence for bankers and financiers slowly taking over some of the most powerful global corporations, at the expense of the ordinary person.

In the 17th century, the British East India Company wanted permission to export silver to India. To do so, they had to ask the crown. Silver was the currency of the day, and it was a crime to take it out of the country without permission. Silver was the basis of the wealth of the country, so it was clear that this would impoverish the people from where the silver was being taken.

Anyway, in 1662 this charter was granted by Charles II giving the East India Company permission to trade silver with India. This charter permanently established the East India Company. So why was this so bad?

Well firstly it gave bankers and financiers huge leverage in society, by being able to take silver out of Britain and sell it to India. British silver was the wealth of the country, and the only reason the East India Company wanted to sell silver in India was as India was a poorer than Britain, silver's purchasing power was increased in India. In what was nothing different from what Jesus saw happening in the temples all those years ago, the East India Company was basically money changing. You could get twice the price of British silver for Indian gold. So change your silver for Indian gold, perhaps load up the sailing ship you used to take it there with spices you bought with the silver and gold, bring it back to Britain and you've made lots of money. It only benefitted the East India Company's shares and not the wealth of Britain, or of course India for that matter.

What this process started was the long trend, over centuries, of bankers and financiers starting to take control of monetary policy areas. In 1666, the bankers got the right to export unlimited amounts of silver to India under the term free coinage. Del Mar argues there was bribery of the highest officials in the land, including Charles II, for this free coinage to be allowed, which would not surprise me at all.

This free coinage worked for the benefit of the bankers, and not the rest of society. Del Mar originates all banking collapses and disasters, to this original decision; as banks were granted a form of sovereignty over coinage, and were able to take control of the money flows in and out of the country - at will. The 1666 Act, Del Mar wrote, 'was so stupid or criminal as to pass the East India Company's Bill in 1666 and permit the country to be drained of its Measure of Value by a band of adventures.'

Despite causing much harm to the general economy, nobody did anything about this new economic system, and they certainly didn't repeal the act. The profits of the then private Bank of England and the East India Company were far too great for anybody to be brave enough to think of doing something like that.

This free coinage had an impact not just in Britain's informal empire at the time, but in its formal one. In colonial America, this money trading caused a huge impact in the burgeoning colonies, and is an issue we're still dealing with today. When the colonists went over to America, they were of course under British jurisdiction, and the jurisdiction of the Bank of England, which was a private corporation. It was this private monetary system that led to the American Revolution, at least in part.

The colonists needed a monetary system that encouraged the import of metals from England, as there had not been any found in North America yet, compared to the South. So, as we saw, some colonies chose to use a tobacco standard, yet it was clear to all that the monetary policy of America was still imperfect, as free coinage allowed for not only the plunder of British silver for Indian gold, but most of America's monetary metals too.

The American recession of 1750 was because of this contracting supply of monetary metals, as the precious metals were constantly being sent back to bankers in England. The colonists decided on a new strategy: Paper money. Massachusetts in 1690 was the first to issue paper money, and was perhaps the first step on the break with the Crown.

This paper money could have been a solution to the colonists problems. It was easy enough to make and to use, and what it lacked in its soundness, it made up for in its independence from the British controlled banks. The British of course knew this, and so the British found ways to spite the colonists and stop paper money: the 1765 Stamp Act. The act forced a tax upon all printed materials in the colony; from newspapers to playing cards, and most crucially, paper money. The tax had to be paid in British currency and not in America paper notes either.

The extremely negative reaction to the Stamp Act, we are told, was largely about no taxation without representation, and to some degree this was true, but it was also tied up in the colonists wanting to being able to issue their own paper money. This Stamp Act was perhaps the worst policy blunder ever made, and directly led to the Revolution. The taxes paid on the Stamp Act could not be paid in American notes but only in monetary metals, causing ever more of a drain to American public finances. To further emphasise how silly this tax was, not only did it tax paper money, but it also taxed any printed piece of paper, which meant newspapers too were taxed, causing the price of them to go up. It was almost an act designed to stoke up media hostility.

The importance of money in America is no surprise. More than a political idea, America was an economic idea and a country built on trade. The foundational holiday in America, Thanksgiving, is a holiday memorialising trade; the stories of Cowboys and Indians are all about trade, the gold rushes, the expansion West, the economic booms and busts and resultant depressions, the slave trade, the Mississippi paddle steam traders and much more all show how much American life is based upon commerce and trade. There should be no surprise about this.

Following victory in the revolution, America could settle on a new monetary standard. This monetary standard was the brainchild of one of the greatest ever Americans: Benjamin Franklin. Franklin became the father of American paper money. In his early adulthood he became an apprentice to a printer and developed a great interest in the ideas and technology of printing. Despite any lack of real education, he is perhaps the icon of the American Enlightenment, and the most renowned Founding Father.

In 1729 Franklin published *A Modest Enquiry into the Nature and Necessity of a Paper Currency,* in which he laid out his ideas for a paper currency. American colonies attempted to follow Franklin's plan, instead of using monetary metals now largely controlled by the British banking corporations. Colonial authorities in London didn't want to be paid in paper money, and so in 1751 banned the use of paper currency for New England, and then in 1764 extended the ban across the colonies. In response Franklin petitioned Parliament in 1766 to allow money to be printed. Franklin later wrote a letter regarding the nature of the new Stamp Act, arguing it was an impingement on American life itself.

When America became independent, much of Franklin's work could be put into practice. The American Revolutionary war was the first to be fought and funded by paper money. This paper money was legally backed by gold and silver, but you would have been lucky to actually be able to trade any of the paper money for the metals. Over the course of the war, this new American currency called the dollar lost 25% of its purchasing power within a few years; and by 1781, with the colonies issuing their own paper money, the dollar lost its value very quickly.

The money supply in the US became a very important part of the early years of the Republic. In Article 1, Section 10 of the US constitution it states, 'No State shall…make anything but gold and silver coin a tender in payments of debt.' Despite section 8, also saying that only the federal government has sole power to regulate the value of money.

The US eventually pegged the US dollar to the same exchange rate as the Spanish Silver Dollar. Monetary policy declined in importance through parts of the 19th century in both Britain and America as both countries found huge gold deposits, while trade also increased, as the American continental landmass was expanded across. Wave after wave of technological innovation in Britain, then America and later Germany solved many potential economic issues that might have resulted.

The real fall of economic stability was the First World War. The war broke Britain quickly as the financial powerhouse and capital reserve of the world, as the heyday of the Bank of England ended. Gold collapsed as a store of value in Europe as it was used to pay for the war, and a new monetary system needed to be created, inherited or in some way adopted.

The soundness of money during the 19th century led to the reputation of the Bank of England being the safest place in the world, no doubt an idea encouraged by British propaganda. The importance of central banks however, in the security of their bank deposits proved just how gold wasn't perfect. It is heavy and difficult to move around, leading to a huge centralisation of gold deposits. This meant gold, and therefore wealth became more and more centralised.

The old Gold standard itself, didn't prevent all government restrictions on money printing. The printing press was still open for abuse by governments, and at the first sign of trouble, with the First World War, the whole economic system was changed as the war proved a catalyst for reform as the link that between gold and paper notes was removed.

In the United States, they even went so far as to remove gold from private supply until the 1960s, by confiscating all private ownership. The man who invited fascism into the United States both before and during the war, Franklin D. Roosevelt issued Executive Order 6102 forbidding gold hoarding and forcing people to sell their gold to the Federal Reserve at far below its market value. Once enough gold was cleared from private hands in the country, the move towards demonetising gold truly began. The limit on gold ownership was repealed in 1974, only once the US had gotten as much gold as it could and removed the link for the dollar to gold.

Money hasn't always been controlled by the government in this way. This is very much a 20th century idea. The 20th century was all about the battle of political systems, and as the 20th century morphs into the 21st, the difference between these political models gets tinier and tinier. If you look at the monetary policies of countries around the world, the first thing you'll notice is a lack of diversity. All governments use money by decree, whether its liberal democracies, communist dictatorships, or repressive Muslim theocracies.

The loss of sound money during the First World War led H.G. Wells to say 'war arrested and ultimately broke up this unpremeditated monetary cosmopolitism. At the close of the war, the practical monetary solidarity of the world has disappeared, and the overprinting of paper money continued.' The war crushed a balance between the economy and monetary order.

It wasn't long before this new fiat system was being used for ill. Lenin and then Stalin, Hitler, and Mussolini used the power of the money printer to great effect, in order to manipulate and control their peoples. Government controlled the economy through its control over money, rendering individual citizens helpless in the face of the government's monopoly over both force and money. If you have no force or money, what have you got left?

Economic problems during and after the First World War were all monetary problems, but it was easy to whip up hatred against scapegoats, who could be blamed for the economic problems. Hatred was whipped up against the aristocrats in Russia, Armenians in Turkey, and Jews in Germany.

Government money in Britain was to my mind, only truly formalised in 1960 when the monarch's head was regularly put on the paper money, indicating truly, whose money it was. For some on both the political left and right, government control allowed the poor to catch up, as welfare was now easier to issue, while huge wealth could also be contained. Yet as in most situations, when governments do try and help, it actually allows waste and inefficiency to proliferate; and ends up with both rich and poor being worse off.

Yet despite all the problems in the US, its economic advances caused it to sail through much of this era of change in good shape. The wild west of the American continent was being tamed at a rate many could not imagine, as even California became an economic powerhouse over the course of a few decades. Much of this wealth found its way back to the capital reserve of the country, New York. The island of Manhattan, built on a solid bed of schist gave a kind of metaphorical stability to this growth, as it allowed huge skyscrapers and deep tunnels to be built. As Manhattan went up, the dominance of London as the worlds capital reserve began to slide.

America, built on commerce and trade, was obsessed with money. Over the 19th century the United States found itself unable to produce a monetary system supported by all. It had a national bank twice during this period, while the Supreme Court deregulated currencies allowing state banks to print their own notes.

This system was not great, and there was something of a cash crunch at times, so many resorted to barter. Many were feeling short changed by this system, as bankers milked money from them. While in the Old World European bankers, think Mr Banks in Mary Poppins grew a reputation for sophistication, Americans began to hate their bankers, just look at the Monopoly game which was original designed to show the inherent flaw in American capitalism.

During the middle of the 19th century in the US, states and private banks began issuing their own money. This actually worked, and the system continued to work until the middle of the 19th century, as the American Civil War hit. To fund the war, Lincoln brought the first Legal Tender act to print $150 million.

America's experiment with free banking ended in 1863, as a result of a national currency being introduced which was controlled by the government and federally chartered banks. But with the government in need to pay huge sums for the war, the government abused its position and began printing its way out of trouble.

These new notes that had been printed in the US were called greenbacks, and they weren't worth what they were said to be worth; yet the government promised to pay what they would be worth, at an unspecified later date. Essentially they were paper government bonds, on the promise the Union would win the war.

It took 15 years for the reunited United States to build up enough gold reserves to settle these debts, and to be able to rebuy the purchasing power of the dollar. The Unions problems of money was nothing compared to the Confederacy problems, where the billions of dollars issued by the Confederacy were made completely worthless upon their defeat. Much of the south collapsed into poverty, and with slavery now gone as the backbone of their economy, the south struggled to readapt into a modern prosperous industrialising economy.

The populist movement of the late 19th century was a reaction to the perceived trap the south had been placed into, with the decimation of their main industry and no new industries, and all their monetary wealth made worthless.

The inability to change the monetary order in the south and the helplessness of the banking system resulted in many in the south blaming monetary issues on something else, namely that southerners were now competing for jobs with newly freed slaves on an open market; vastly reducing labour's value in the South, while money people had previously stored away, and relied upon suddenly became worthless. Many poor, especially black people, left for northern cities, but for those who remained, segregation was the result, rather than a new monetary and economic deal for the south. It was divide and rule in action.

Populist William Jennings Bryan campaigned again and again on introducing both a gold and silver standard. He lost two presidential elections in 1896 and 1900. This era of American politics was satirised in Frank L. Baum's *A Wizard of Oz* where the personification of the farm girl meets the various people of the day: the scarecrow – the American farmer, the Cowardly Lion – William Jennings Bryan and the Tin Man – the factory worker. All these groups would have to do was to expose the political and financial system by learning about their own strengths, and moving together to expose the fraud by exposing the wizard behind the curtain. Now the Wizard of Oz is seen as a children's classic, and one of the greatest and most iconic family films of all time; but it's really about politics.

Perhaps if you're getting conspiratorial, the reason it was made into such a big film was to make everybody forget it was a satire on the monetary and banking fraud taking place at the turn of the century. To some extent this campaign did have an impact. The Gold Standard Act of 1900 was passed, making gold tied to the US currency, though not the bimetallic system many argued for. Any further reforms to the banking system were saved as luckily new gold deposits were found in South Africa, Alaska and Colorado; doubling the gold supply in the world and easing America's cash crunch.

America's new gold standard worked very well. It still wasn't perfect, but the fair exchange between the US government and the gold miners for their gold, meant that gold could be traded freely between new miners and the government, allowing the spread of wealth. New discoveries of wealth, in what was still one of the frontiers of the world, coupled with growing technological output, resulted in widespread prosperity through the Gilded Age.

Slowly the United States began to unravel this system, first with Roosevelt limiting private supplies of gold, and then with Nixon decoupling the dollar to gold completely. Refugees coming from the unfolding horrors in Europe in the 1930s, who'd brought gold with them, found it worthless, as it was basically devalued overnight and seized from them at the borders. In what was essentially government theft of property, millions lost out on what they thought was something more powerful and longer lasting than such notions as states and governments.

During the Second World War, the US led the way in setting a new monetary order for the world; creating the World Bank and IMF. The hotel they stayed at was called Bretton Woods in New Hampshire, and as the new world monetary order was hashed out overlooking the hotel was a mountain peak called Mount Deception – an omen for the new monetary order, if ever there was one. The economists agreed to keep the value of the US Dollar fixed to gold, at a price of 35 dollars for an ounce. The Bretton Woods system wanted to emphasise stability under government control, and the US government's control at that. The IMF was further set up to facilitate transfers between central banks. The Bretton Woods system was dominated by Keynesian economics who believed in large state run economies producing jobs for all; the difference between this and socialism, I don't really know - and to be honest the system worked only slightly better than the socialist economies of the East.

John Maynard Keynes himself was in attendance at the conference as the British representative - to some degree a passing of the torch from Britain to the United States. The US too agreed to control trade between the world under GATT (General Agreements for Tariffs and Trade) where planning of trade and fiscal policy could be centralised.

The result of this new monetary world order was the domination of Keynesian economics across the world after the Second World War, as almost a natural follow up to New Deal in the US. In America this push for jobs, jobs, jobs and the government artificially propping up jobs led to the creation of the Military-Industrial-Complex and its slow increase in power over American politics and the American economy. The industry became more concerned about securing new funding revenues through lobbying Congress, than providing the supply for what limited demands there were for new wars. This is what happens with government money.

The easiest way for the Military-Industrial Complex to keep its influence was to keep certain high profile politicians in power who could keep military spending high, both through the funding of political campaigns, but also the building of manufacturing and services bases in constituencies of the most high-profile and influential politicians. Why do you think Mitch McConnell has kept his position for so long?

An economy based on sound money would not allow for huge peacetime armies. You would have to raise it all through taxation and borrowing at market rates. Something tax payers are unlikely to want.

Increasingly, government money won out over sound money. Capital, and therefore the economy, become products of political allocation of resources, rather than a free market allocation of money. If all jobs are seen as good jobs, and the military is popular, its politically easy to pump money into it. Today, we're seeing largely the same things with Big Pharma, which to some extent is the same.

With the United States producing a surplus of military equipment, the result was a demand to use or sell the equipment. Over the course of the 20th century, America became embroiled in a series of wars and proxy wars, of arms deals and shady manoeuvrings, that undermined the very notion of the country itself.

Much of this overproduction of military resources was to blame. Imagine if that government money had been largely spent, and yes to some degree wasted, on say the Space sector or building a huge particle accelerator or other scientific enterprises, and what might have been gained. The US government could have even spent their money reflating the soundness of the dollar.

By the 1970s this Keynesian system of stagflation – that's massive inflation but stagnating economic growth, began to break down. Overspending in Vietnam and the Space Race, while increasing welfare payments resulted in a poor allocation of resources. The ability for the United States to fund the war was drying up, as political capital for Vietnam broke down meaning no new taxes were likely to be raised to deal with the problem. Nixon, like generations of politicians before and after, took the easy option of turning to the money printer. The US Government had so overspent it could no longer redeem its money to gold.

The Bretton Woods system that allowed other central banks to buy an ounce of gold for $35 dollar an ounce was over. Had you bought American gold at this exchange rate, before Nixon shut the gold exchange, it would now be worth more than $1750.

The Nixon Shock resulted in the creation of much of the foreign-exchange market, today worth $5 trillion in value. It was largely an industry created from the product of market inefficiencies. Just remember back to Jesus from the first episode, in the Temple, overthrowing the table of the money changers. Nothing changes.

Secretary of the Treasury, John Connally, who was in the car with JFK in Dallas in 1963, and Nixon hashed out a plan to solve the monetary order by issuing a price freeze on wages and prices and a 10% tariff on imports.

The world was thrown off course, as America shook up the monetary order. Around the world currencies started to free float against each other and standards of livings suddenly changed – especially in Latin America where a series of coups throughout the 1970s was the result of the new monetary order making some far poorer than they had been before. Britain in the 1970s didn't do much better than Latin America, as the 1970s in Britain saw many economic issues resulting in the revaluation of Sterling.

This new fiat currency, and new economic world order, caused all currencies to become derivates of the US Dollar rather than having value in their own right. This gave the dollar huge power over the world. The commercialisation of the world soon followed this move, with American companies far more easily able to supply foreign exchange reserves to developing countries.

The decoupling of real value to the printed notes for the rest of the 20th century caused inflation to rise steadily for year upon year, as banks and governments no longer had to back up money printing with gold reserves.

This inflationary society we are still living in, caused a culture of consumerism and consumption, rather than a society of saving and investment. Consumer prices were largely kept in check by the globalisation allowing cheaper labour and products to flood markets; however many fixed costs rose precipitously; like real estate, property, college and hospital fees in the USA, rail fares, and stock market valuations all soared. Soon this inflationary economy was so resolute, that even in the face of rising living standards in the 1980s, 1990s and early 2000s, inflation was seen as a permanent tax on cash.

This hurt the poor the most, as most economic decisions taken by the powers that be tend to, as they had the least access to fixed assets and relied more on cash. This was not helped by the rapid increase in immigration resulting in a sudden burst of new labour entering into the economy. Inflation of fixed assets, and immigration, caused labours value to not inflate but deflate. However, it wasn't all bad news, consumer goods, driven by short-term innovation and the short term market demands of an inflationary economy, took hold and drove the consumerism of the 1980s.

The Thatcherism and Reaganomic revolutions of the 1980s were products of their time, and a reaction to the dreadful economic prospects of the 1970s. The realisation that large parts of the economy were broken from over regulation and over management meant a huge change was needed. Overnight, Thatcher in Britain especially cut off uneconomic parts of the economy, cutting the industrial capacity of the north and Scotland, especially Glasgow, and moving towards a more pure free market economy. However the devastation of industry and manufacturing meant many held Thatcher personally responsible for their economic problems. Despite the success of many of her reforms, in the short term at least, led to her determined assumption that manufacturing was unprofitable in the modern economy, which belied any real idea of what destroying an industrial economy and moving it to a service economy would do to large parts of the country. With a Digital revolution already underway by the 1980s, it meant any chance of industries reorienting and retraining workers in manufacturing this new revolution was nil.

Asia became the digital workhouse of the world, with most electronics made and manufactured in the far east, however unlike previous industrial revolutions, these manufacturing bases did not pave the way for Asian supremacy. In many ways the west was still the best. How? Well the west was the best at financial innovations. In the new globalised economy, manufacturing could be done in Asia, services in Europe and America, and the grunt work of farming and mineral extraction could be done in the poorest parts of the world. The western grip on money and finances meant there was no real way Japan or South Korea would ever truly become a global power. Financial innovations continued to pour out of the US in particular, to cement its place as the capital reserve of the world.

By the 1950s in the US, the car was already common in much of America, and was increasingly taking people to places far away enough away that they didn't know anybody nearby. Cars might break down in the middle of the road and have to limp to the next garage. The repairs and costs might be too high for the amount of cash the driver had on them.

And so to solve this problem, we turn to an unlikely source of financial innovation: Big Oil. Oil companies began to produce their own credit cards for the use of purchasing from a merchant mostly in gas stations.

The first real credit card was introduced in 1950, the Diner's Club, a posh restaurant chain used the first modern charge card to be used at its 27 fine dining restaurants, and was largely used by affluent businessmen. In 1958, the American Express Company which was already known for being a traveller's check company, issued the first plastic charge card. Then came Bank of America in 1958, and with California being its largest populated market, the card was quickly rolled out. In 1977 BankAmericard, the Bank of America plastic card, was renamed to Visa.

The credit card came at a time when credit was becoming cheaper and cheaper. You could buy something in store with a credit card and pay for it later, sometimes much later. Today you can get credit cards with 24 months interest free borrowing. Back in the 1960s and 70s, this easy credit was revolutionary. Spending became freer and freer, and seemed to benefit all. Governments received sales taxes from the spending, the merchant gained a sale, and the buyer got a product they would just have to pay for later, perhaps over a period of a few months, rather than all at once; while the banks could charge very high interest for any payments not met.

Money doesn't grow on trees, or so we're told. Despite fiat money being paper money, and paper coming from trees. The true phrase we should use is that it capital doesn't grow on trees. Capital is the result on human work and effort.

This expansion of individual consumer debt went up and up, and reached $1 trillion by the mid-90s. This became a problem. Much of this debt was going out of the United States to Japan to buy cars, or Germany to buy electronic goods causing something of a balance of payments crisis all based on debt. Money can be magicked into thin air, but capital can't. Increasingly large debt levels caused a further influx of money into economies and continued the rise of inflation.

Credit was seen as fashionable, and you were seen as a high flyer to flash around plastic. Just as gold was shiny and new and so was silver; America's new monetary revolution was based on shiny plastic. To show you're rich, just flash around that card and you could buy whatever you wanted. Branding became important to show just how rich you were. Everything from gold AMEX cards, to unique coloured plastic, tried to encourage all to use credit cards.

Rather than flashing cash, a card was much more in tune with the new digital age. The plastic revolution took the banks into the modern and digital age. Much banking infrastructure was almost still pre-telegraph during this period, and so the electronic banking revolution was a simple catch up to where the technology was.

In 1972, the Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco experimented with electronic payments, by bypassing paper between its main office and LA branch. By 1978 this was in effect all over the United States. The process expanded in 1980 as Congress enlarged digital money to other financial institutions connected to the Fed.

In 1975, the federal government first offered recipients direct money transfers rather than going to a building and getting given cash. This was soon spread throughout the workforce. Digital money, however, wasn't quite as easy as it is now. Without the internet to send information, this digital money relied on sending magnetic tapes via courier. By the 1990s, the internet revolution cut out the middleman and made money truly digital.

The use of electronic money grew around the world, and just like before America sought to regulate this new money, starting in 1977 with the Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunications, or SWIFT. The system was based in Brussels but run by the United States and it helped coordinate electronic money across the world via American regulations. If the US doesn't like you, it can cut you off from access to SWIFT; just ask Iran, North Korea, or Russia.

Soon after the invention of the credit card, magnetic strips were used to enable people to get cash from ATM's. However, oddly another digital invention was causing a rise of coins. Video arcades and vending machines led to a surge in use of small coinage. Some say that the release of Space Invaders, or the release of Pac-Man in Japan, caused a coin shortage and I even repeated this story on my other podcast, in the episode on gaming. I'm not sure it's true anymore having researched it a bit more, but it showed just how far behind certain parts of the economy were, when it came to money. Kids were still perfectly happy with coins. However the counting out coins, and transacting them can cost between 2-6% of the value of the coins themselves.

The rapid rise of the internet only encouraged this new digital money to increase in prevalence as digital money began to be used in the new realm of ecommerce. However despite these huge economic changes, then, as today, the SWIFT payment mechanism still abounds as the dominant payment mode, despite it being old 1970s technology.

SWIFT is slow and lumbersome and took days to process transactions as payments must go through multiple banks before reaching their final destination. SWIFT has introduced its own improved service, called '*Global Payments Innovation*' (GPI), stating that as of 2018 it had been adopted by 165 banks and was completing half of its payments in under 30 minutes, however whether this will be good enough, in a world where 30 minutes to wait for money is still a long time, remains to be seen.

This digital currency, processed by SWIFT and backed by America, has seen money transfers go ever more global; creating levels of trust in currencies and economies due to the freedom of the forex market, that when it works, looks like a decent approximation of a strong monetary order, but things can always change. The illusion of safety and security isn't actually safety and security.

The ascent of money, as financial historian Niall Ferguson called it, has been pretty much complete with this digitisation of money. Now there is no excuse not to carry money. It's on your phone, in your wallet, on your smartwatch. Today, some worry that in financial tech, China has taken the lead with a more advanced and quicker payment system, in not having to go through SWIFT. China's version is far more modern, and arguably, a threat to the Western monetary order.

The rise of digital dollars means issuing money is a lot easier to create than printing cash. All you have to do is add a few zeros onto a spreadsheet and you can pour money into the economy like there's no tomorrow.

The expansion of this digital money into society started with the online banking movement in the 1990s, with the internet only bank NetBank founded in 1996. By 2001, Bank of America had online banking for 3 million people. By 2006, 80% of banks offered online banking. Banking was now 24/7 and it automated much of the work done through call centres and in branches, making retail banking for the masses even cheaper – even allowing developing countries to get access to banking through the coming smartphone adoption of the 2010s.

So the future is digital, however we may look at it. Cash will still hopefully still be around in future, but more and more money will be digital only. Bitcoin was introduced at a time when the main two payment systems were only cash or digital dollars and needed an intermediatory like a bank. The need for an intermediary, like a bank, is due to the double spend problem of digital money. You need to be sure that digital payments can't be duplicated. This is done by using a 'trusted' intermediatory like a bank, who can be assured not to mess around by duplicating or adding fake money to accounts.

Cryptos, many believe, including me, aim to solve many of the issues these new digital dollars have created, by removing the middleman and making internet money less able to be manipulated by these 'trusted' intermediators.

So what does it mean to be a cryptocurrency? Well work it out from the title. There is a strong element of cryptography to these coins, to secure them against all manner of threats, while in theory they should also work as currencies. The idea of pure digital money has been around for years now, and something like it was already circulating in science fiction, with the obvious need for some ability to transact money across the galaxy.

If you remember Star Wars: The Phantom Menace, when Qui-Gon Jinn tries to buy the parts for his ship with Republic Credits, but Watto wants 'only money'. The great Republic that spans a galaxy isn't seen to be real money on the outer rim. Republic Credits are just credit not money. For many it was worthless. I don't know what Watto wanted in return for his spare hyperdrive, but I'm guessing some form of metallic money might have worked better. Had the Republic been stronger though, then maybe it could have imposed its credits on outer rim territories. Though it does surprise me Qui-Gon Jinn didn't think all he had to do was to find a currency trader somewhere on Tatooine. Instead he thought best way to get what he wanted was by betting his ship on the life of an 8 year old boy to win a race.

In the 21st century, people can't be seen to be trusted not to artificially duplicate digital deposits; and so everything needs to be transacted through safe institutions like banks. Yet Bitcoin offers a solution to the double spend problem through the blockchain technology; which we'll be talking about in a later chapter. Bitcoin allows peer-to-peer digital payments without the need for any middle men. Technology is nothing if not the taking out of middle men. Bitcoin, through the blockchain checking everything, allows for true digital scarcity without the need for an intermediary.

With the dollar still the reserve currency, and so easy to print and inflate, especially since the end of the gold standard, what the world has been looking for since 1971 is a scarce resource that is easy to transact, holds purchasing power, and cannot be corrupted. Bitcoin, by enabling true peer-to-peer interactions, makes money and therefore people, not governments, sovereign.

Crypto currencies only exist digitally, but with the development in science, I don't see any reason you couldn't have small amounts of cryptos put into real coins or notes, either as stores of value or to be easily transacted. The entire crypto ecosystem to me, looks like the next monetary step forward. Nothing in the crypto space needs backing by governments, nor can governments do much about it. Money can and always has been created out of nothing, and slowly gotten acceptance as currency; crytpos will be the same.

Chapter 3: Economic Specialisation, Political Systems and the 'Great Reset'

In the last few episodes we talked about money and its history and we talked a bit about cryptocurrencies, and of course we'll be getting into them more in a future episode. But now it's time to talk, in depth, about the world cryptos will be entering into: the modern economy. This post COVID world will look a lot different than what even went before it. Small businesses have collapsed in many industries, new industries will be formed as capital moves to where it is most efficient in a post-lockdown state. A great reset for the economy, if you want to call it that. This reset has arguably been needed for decades due to the vast mismanagement of both money and the economy since at least the 1980s.

So we’ll start this episode talking about one vital economic principle: economic specialisation. If you remember back to the previous episodes; we highlighted the Mesopotamian civilisations use of money, as being perhaps the first civilisation to use what we would recognise as real money. As societies in the fertile crescent became larger and larger as these city states grew; the scholars of the day may have realised their economies were growing as more and more people were specialising in different areas of the economy. A group of experienced and skilled farmers managing lots of land, could outproduce the same amount of subsistence farmers working on small plots. Therefore not everybody in society needs to be subsistence farmers. Those who don’t farm need to do other things with their time.

Garment makers for example could specialise and make more garments and textiles, and of better quality too as their knowledge became more and more specialised in textiles and they didn’t have to worry about farming.

However there becomes an inherent flaw in this system without money. How do you fairly transact the wheat you harvest, for the clothes you need? You need a medium of exchange.

In the earliest of societies, they didn’t have money and so relied on bartering goods for goods. But soon, with large population growth, you would not know everybody in your town. A town of 30,000 is far too large to know everybody. You couldn’t track everything. Remember these societies were still largely pre-writing, and indeed the relationship between accountancy and writing is closely intertwined.

Humans need wheat all year round, but you might only need textiles now and again, but clothes are probably slightly more difficult to get than the masses of wheat successful communities were now harvesting. Soon, the ability to transact what you need, and what you have, becomes very difficult. You need a better system to account for the excess of resources, and to ensure its broadly fair for everybody. So a system to show how to track who produced the more or less valuable stuff for society was needed.

In order to transact this surplus of resources, you need a good medium of exchange. If the medium of exchange is not standard, it makes transactions very hard. You might think sea shells are worth lots, but if the other person knows you can find them on any beach a couple miles walk away, they’ll know they’re not actually worth that much. It’s not a fair exchange. Many people throughout history have been burnt by trading like this.

So what everybody wants is a solid medium of exchange that is also easy to transact. You also need to be able to hold onto this medium of exchange for future use, and that could be a year or two in future. If you accept, say, apple and grapes for the clothes you make, they go off very quickly and so you can’t store it.

What would be good as a medium of exchange was something that rewards saving, but also rewards an even more productive use of the stored resources by being a good medium of exchange too. For those who store apples, fish, or even tulips; they would quicky realise that these things have immense deterioration in wealth after a couple of days or weeks. They are bad stores of value.

So throughout history, humans have relied on nature to provide a good store of exchange and store of value. Gold is chemically inert, meaning it doesn’t go off or even rust. It’s shiny too, and we all love shiny things. Just ask anybody with Pokémon cards. Gold is a good store of your excess resources. In small communities, it’s difficult enough to mine, and easy enough to give somebody across the village gold, while its near universal nature means it's had value almost all over the world, and its mining has historically been dispersed.

Gold and its younger brother silver, which actually served more as a reserve currency historically than gold, are true hard money. They have held value for thousands of years. Government currencies are nowhere near that good at holding value. Not only do all government currencies see money printing resulting in inflation eating away at it their value, but also, the fact its backed by governments means if the government's authority collapses, the store of value is likely to collapse too. Just look at the Roman Empire or Confederacy. When they collapsed, their currencies gradually became worthless, leading to an intense depression in the Europe and Southern United States. Europe took 1000 years to get out of its depression with the renaissance, and it took until air-conditioning in the 1980s for a burgeoning economy in the south to grow once again.

So how does economic specialisation cause wealth? Wealth creation is a topic in politics we hear a lot. Republicans in the US love to talk about wealth creators, but what actually is wealth creation? Put simply, wealth is increased by increasing the specialisation and efficiency of something. The more you specialise, in theory at least, the more you can produce, and the more efficient you are; therefore you can produce more for less and you need to work less.

Specialisation and efficiency gains can be seen as mundanely as a local corner shop. If you open a food shop in a place with no food shops, and save people a 15 minute car ride, the ability for people to get food becomes more efficient, saving the consumer plenty of time, while the reward for increasing the efficiency of the economy, even to this degree, is profit.

A Michelin starred chef is one of the most uniquely specialised jobs possible. They produce an utterly unique product, and something you could never do yourself. And they know the value of their labour, hence why it's so expensive. McDonalds is, at the same time, similar and the complete the opposite of this. A Big Mac is something you might be able to make at home, but buying or getting the McDonalds delivered is far quicker, and probably cheaper, than you could ever make it.

What the Babylonians would have realised was essentially the same. There's no point in me learning to make clothes, because I produce enough surplus of wheat so I can sell what I don't need myself. With this money I don't have to spend an entire day of my labour making myself a piece of cloth to wear. You'd be a fool to waste your day making it, when in time saved; you might as well buy it.

We all notice this in our life. When I was a student, I would walk everywhere. I was cash poor, but time rich. I could waste two hours walking up to uni and back every day rather than getting the bus. Once I got a job, and my job was either a 2 hour walk away or a 30 minute tram journey; the economics of my decision became different. I had less free time and more money, so I got the tram. This is all down to the same principle of specialisation of labour. My labour paid me, and I worked hard for it, and created value for the boss of the pub I worked in. I then chose to use the fruits of my labour to spend my money on making my journey quicker.

To achieve a good equilibrium in the economy, of where specialisation needs to go, requires sound money. Profit needs to go where people spend their money. Efficiency increases are the result of business competition trying to get you to spend your money with them because they have a profit you want.

This is the largest benefit of a fair medium of exchange, it causes the very nature of the economy to be balanced. In Britain, it was this acknowledgement of the specialisation of labour that largely caused the industrial revolution. Previously, the largest leap in economic efficiency had been the Neolithic Revolution, where mankind were introduced to skills like farming; this revolution meant machines could provide huge efficiency boosts, requiring you not to spend as much on labour costs relative to what you produce.

We need to understand economic specialisation to understand the role of money. How money is earnt is not a simple as you might think. Simply working, I would argue, does not create wealth. It is only increasing economic specialisation and efficiency that produces wealth. This idea would negate the central argument of John Maynard Keynes, who argued simply jobs produce wealth. Anybody who works in the Public Sector can tell you how much the mindless bureaucracy inhibits efficiency, rather than improves it.

Government bureaucracy grows when money becomes more politically spent. You will create jobs in areas to support it for political reasons. The poorest areas in Britain have the highest levels of public spending, as the government attempts to solve market inefficacies, not by solving any economic situation, but by giving people public sector jobs.

Government money alters the equilibrium of economies as poor areas are pumped up by government allocating money, without much in return, inhibiting true natural economic development.

This equilibrium of where money is spent is called money transfers. Money transfers generally happen in five areas. Rent, Wages, Interest, Profit, and government transfers like welfare payment. For a balanced equilibrium to occur between all five money transfers, you need to make sure one area isn't massively outspending the others.

If government money is too involved in the economy, it disrupts the finely balanced equilibrium. Alas, in the third decade of the 21st century; wages have been kept low for years, while rents continue to rise. Interest rates since the 2008 financial crisis have collapsed too. Meanwhile profits in the economy…well that's an interesting one. For some companies, like Apple, profits are easy, almost too easy – but finding what to do with these profits is not. Stories of Apple having more money than the US government are funny, but they hint at the problem. Apple can't find any use of all the profits its gained. It should be investing the money in new and future radical research, but the lack of large-scale technological developments in society means new consumer tech is still a long way off. That's why the electric car looks promising for them. It's perhaps the only area that looks like they might get a return on largescale investment.

However for some valuable companies like Uber, Airbnb, and the many other zombie firms; they hardly produce a profit and are kept going through cheap debt with low interest rates. Hardly a balanced equilibrium.

These imbalances in the economy have happened before, and it's always been down to the government entrenching poverty through artificially high prices. During the feudal era in Europe, rents were sky high as serfs had to pay their masters. The serfs didn't really have a choice. It took for the Black Death to wipe out of 50% of the population for the imbalance to correct itself. By 1375, crop prices in England dropped massively due to the lack of eaters for the food following the wiping out of the population. With the already tight labour supply due to the huge death rates, peasants for once had the economic advantage. Money transfers in the economy began to right themselves. Peasants could finally bargain better for their labour, and so negotiated terms more favourable to themselves. The partial restoration of an equilibrium in these money transfers, with less going to rent and more money to labour, enabled new freedoms for millions, something rarely seen before in human history.

By 1500, the peasants were now just commoners. These new economic freedoms led to something of an economic and technological boom at the dawn of the early modern period, as Europe began to get out of what was essentially a 1000-year economic depression following the collapse of the Roman Empire.

The growth of a new middle class enabled people to invest time in themselves, and in learning, which helped unleash a scientific revolution. Esoteric knowledge spread and was quickly applied in more technical ways. The revolution of the steam engine was just one example of all these new scientific theories coming together, and as we talked about in my other podcast, it allowed for more mechanisation: the production of more for less. The first industrial revolution grew from both the increasing freedoms in Europe, and especially England, and the increasing knowledge about the natural world.

The first industrial revolution from 1760 to 1840 ended with the railroad boom, as the natural culmination of all these new technologies came together. By the 1850s there was a new revolution. The second industrial revolution came from the rise of steel, the telegraph, the internal combustion engine, bigger cities leading to massive public health works, and eventually electricity and the telephone. The revolution eventually ended with the 1929 Wall Street crash, as the consumerism of the 1920s, as all these new labour saving devices and new technologies reached their maximum use in the American economy, causing the massive amounts of excess capital to be poured into increasingly minimally profitable companies as everybody had a telephone, a radio or car, and the economy reached a state of overproduction. Technological developments reached their logical maximum in the 1920s and no more efficiency gains could be made. Excess capital was not spent on cars, as most people had cars, but put into the stock market where people thought easy gains could be made. Once it was realised that it was all speculation, the economy collapsed; massive amounts of excess capital in the economy was lost overnight causing a huge economic depression.

It took until the 1950s for the American economy to recover from the collapse of the stock market in 1929, but recover it did. This recovery was in part a building up of industrial might during the war, and the position the United States found itself as, as the world's superpower, but then another industrial revolution hit the United States. The digital revolution began in the 1960s and will probably be seen as ending with the 2020 Coronavirus pandemic and lockdowns. This was the computer or digital revolution, as mechanisation no longer took place through factories and mass production but the use of semiconductors and computer code. Personal computing and the internet, then the smartphone and tablet, coupled with developments in telecommunication like 3G and 4G, allowed for a revolution in information and communication. Like the railway boom, or the 1920s in America, this economic cycle ended with a mass proliferation of consumer goods like ever cheaper smartphone that took place in the 2010s, which like the railway or the car revolution was the logical end of an industrial revolutionary cycle. Consumerism takes off when what has been learnt over the past 50 years is basically put into this one consumer technology, which drives it to get cheaper and cheaper. The third industrial revolution however, taking place in different way, all over the world led to different outcomes in different areas.
Personal transportation however didn't see the huge benefits of this revolutionary cycle as capital was pumped into the new digital world, not the physical one. The high-speed train revolution for example only took place in China and Japan.

America and Europe skipped the huge investments needed in rail, and moved towards aeroplane transport, which, with the use of automation and highly efficient low-cost carriers, not to mention mass production of aeroplanes, allowed for air flight in Europe and America to reach the masses. Continental distances were now nothing more than a minor inconvenience – no longer the trip of a lifetime.

These industrial developments in automation began in 1760, and are nothing short of the biggest revolution in human history for the last 10,000 years - and one we're still dealing with. We've gone from pre-steam, to most of the world now being industrialised. Today industrialisation has spread from Britain, to Europe and America; to parts of South America, Australia, and much of the Middle East and lots of Asia – with more wealth created in the past 20 years than at any point in human history.

Yet 2020 sees the end of the digital revolution as we approach either the next industrial revolution cycle or economic stagnation. The World Economic Forum's Klaus Schwab's fourth industrial revolution is approaching; whether you want it to be or not. It is coming. The British government have even published a guide on their website to 'regulate' the fourth industrial revolution, while Prime Minister Boris Johnson has spoken about it a lot. Schwab however has become something of an internet hate figure for his 'great reset.'

The end of the revolutionary cycle means, like the 1920s, consumerism powers the economy but cannot power it forever. New technologies are needed to keep the rate of economic growth high. Better economic efficiency is needed to keep a constant economic growth model based on debt going.

The great reset is no conspiracy, it's merely the product of a group of technocrats in Davos seeing how technological progress has slowed over the past few years, and looking towards what is needed to continue this perpetual growth model. The answer they, as I, have come to, is technological progress. The world's precious economic system is based on debt and constant growth, but its failing due to a lack of technological progress.

Capital has been invested poorly over the last 20-30 years, and technological progress has suffered. Excess capital has poured into marginally profitable and easily scalable consumerism. A dozen half-empty chain coffee shops and restaurants on every street corner and economies based on app services; all promoting competition, but in areas that are not and never will be hugely profitable. The barriers to entry are too low. Meanwhile the corporations that do actually control investments like banks and Big Tech, have far too high barriers to entry, but haven't invested well.

Low profit margins throughout much of the western world have remained since the 2008 financial crisis. The short termism of largely American private enterprise and lending has pushed money into overpriced stocks, housing, and tech apps. America today has elements of Britain's late Victorian era, where there didn't seem to be an appetite for renewed investment in a second industrial revolution, preferring a slow gliding decline as Britain seeded industrial might to Germany and America.

Much of the reason for the lack of investment the past few years is because money from the capital base of the world, the US, has not stayed at home but gone all over the world, rather than continued investment at home. The British, 200 years before, had used their imperial and financial might to essentially buy India through bribery and cunning. For those British public schools boys who took over India and funnelled profits from Britain into buying up India to maintain their power; they must have felt on top of the world, but the enterprise did little good for either side: Britain or India.

American globalisation too is starting to see its limits. Rather than investing in new technology that would result in perpetual growth and innovation, America's development has slowed, as expansionism abroad, both militarily and economically, has allowed the world to catch up to it.

Klaus Schwab is probably right in that there is a need for renewed technological development and new technologies to increase economic efficiency and specialisation, but the reason his thesis is so scary, is that it is an entirely top-down approach. It is all about the World Economic Forum trying to push for a new technological revolution to maintain their power, not a new technological revolution coming from the bottom-up to benefit everybody.

There is no reason society has to be like this. The third industrial revolution allowed for peer-to-peer communication the likes of which have never been seen or even thought of before. There is hardly a work of science fiction before the 1980s or 1990s with anything like the internet. It was truly unique and revolutionary, and still little explored as to its theoretical maximum. In my other podcast I relate this to the development of LSD allowing a generation of hippies on the West coast to think in a completely different way than before. The internet allowed and encouraged technology and society to become increasingly bottom-up. The fourth industrial revolution should be the opportunity for the coming technological developments to encourage the spread of capital and sounder monetary order.

This new society Schwab and the Davos crowd advocate for in their blueprints may have some good points, but it misses one crucial aspect, the one aspect most ordinary people want – they have no regard or interest in individual liberty, they're only concerned with their own oligarchical power. Things like property rights to the oligarchs in control of the economy are merely an annoyance, rather than the foundation of society. Property rights, which date back to Moses receiving the 10 commandments, became entrenched in all prosperous societies. This Mosaic Law then became Jewish law, which became Judeo-Christian law, and subsequently entrenched in the ethos of common law and civil law across the world. Thou shalt not steal comes to us in the modern day through Israel, Egypt, then to Greece, to Rome, to Britain and then to America.

The entrenchment of property rights should be *the* drive of the fourth industrial revolution, and, as we go on later, we'll see how blockchain technologies could be used to do this. Schwab and the World Economic Forum's slogan, 'you don't own anything' is the antithesis to libertarian and individualistic principles. Ownership won't be entirely forgotten, for the very rich at least; you can bet the rich will own and buy what they want, as the rest of us rent.

Almost everybody will want to own what they buy, and sure, streaming Spotify and Netflix will still be fine, but many will still want to buy and own things too; and not to pay continuous rents like a tenant serf. Cryptos and the blockchain are alternatives, and in my mind the only alternative to the slightly scary dystopian rollercoaster we seem to be riding.

Imagine a crypto world. You pay a Spotify subscription that allows you listen to pretty much any song you want. You hear an album and fall in love with it. You buy the album outright; either digitally or on say vinyl if you're like me. You pay with cryptocurrency, which will also, with a bit of clever programming you don't need to worry about, allow you to sign a smart contract that digitally ties either that music file or a physical vinyl to you. Making you, the sole and universally recognised owner of that file or vinyl. There might only be 1000 vinyl's, or a million digital copies of the album produced, but you will own it.

If you don't own things, you don't have economic power. Property wealth is the root of all human stability, permanence, and prosperity. The blockchain will allow for everything to turn into property.

The World Economic Forums' future is glorified serfdom. If you don't own anything, it allows you to be controlled, at least implicitly, by those who do own things. The political system will be altered away from a democracy, and towards an oligarchy, where the country is run by elites for their own enjoyment.

The mixing of political systems in this way, a sort of oligarchic democracy, is not impossible. Greek philosopher Plato talked about political regimes some 2500 years ago, when discussing political systems in his famous *Republic*. Four of the types of political regimes will be recognisable to you in an instant, but it is the fifth and least recognised one that will be of most interest. No political system really is entirely pure, and most are hybrids. The five political systems are:

Aristocracy – the rule of the benevolent;

Oligarchy – the rule of the few;

Tyranny – the rule of the one;

Democracy – the rule of the many;

And Timocracy – the rule of the landowners.

You can see many of these types of regimes across the world. North Korea is the classic tyranny. Russia is the classic oligarchy. While democracy is often mixed with other elements. Pure democracy in the style of Switzerland is rare. Britain could be seen as a mix of most of the types at the same time. As a property owning democracy, it has rule of the landowners; with free and fair elections it has the rule of the many; with a strong class structure it still has the aristocratic and oligarchic tendencies that still haven't gone away.

That the WEF, Schwab and the Davos crowd view the priorities of world differently to me and you is not a surprise, and indeed it would be odd if Jeff Bezos viewed the world similar to you. It should be no surprise either, that currently power is becoming ever more concentrated by elites, rather than ordinary people.

When power is unchecked it always moves upwards, as those in power try to get ever more of it. This trend was noticed by sociologist Robert Michels, in 1915. Michels argues that power naturally ends up conglomerating into forms of oligarchy, and that it is incredibly difficult to stop. Any social organisation where power rests will form into oligarchy, as Michels theory goes. Think about where you work, or any other social organisations you are part of, there is always an in and out group wherever power is located.

The 'in' group only allow those with similar precepts to them to join the in-group, making it incredibly difficult to break oligarchies. Today we see globalisation resulting in a very wealthy group of oligarchs trying to control the economies of the world, and has resulted in the slow intermingling of politics and business around the world.

In a political terms, many libertarians argue that to hold back the tides of oligarchy, democracy should be broadly mixed with a timocracy. A property owning democracy is the best halt on centralisation of power. A rich property owning democracy will have more stability and power to rise up and thwart democracy from sliding into lite-oligarchy. The property owning are independently wealthy and don't need to follow the government, and therefore have more clout and influence in which to stop oligarchy occurring. Britain and America, as the classic property owning democracies, historically have used this to great effect to stop any change into real oligarchy or tyranny occurring – so far at least.

A strict democratic timocracy is the libertarians answer to stop the rise of oligarchy, which is naturally occurring in human society. However Schwab's plans would lead much of the west into oligarchy. Strengthening property rights through things like blockchains and cryptos will allow the average person more personal wealth and security in life; which allows you more ability to own your own life. You will have a greater stake in society and more power. This power magnified through millions and millions of your peers is a far greater power than any police force or oligarchic group that might form.

This is what the prospect of a monetary revolution, on the eve of the coming fourth industrial revolution, will do. It should not only be a technological revolution, but a revolution in individual liberty: A Sovereign Citizen.

The impact of sound money and property rights will allow bottom-up free market capitalism to rebound, because that's how democratic capitalism should work. Once sound money and property rights are secure, equilibriums in the economy will naturally righten. The economy will grow naturally once again allowing ever increasing economic specialisation to be rewarded, and creating positive feedback loops all across the economy.

Adam Smith's revolutionary work, *The Wealth of Nations*, first published in 1776, was right at the beginning of the first industrial revolution and argued for increased specialisation in work, as automation began to eat away at the need for subsistence living. Rather than having to make yourself everything you need, you only need to be able to make one or two things well to survive. You can specialise your knowledge. There can be a down side to over-specialisation, where you only know one thing and literally nothing else – a problem with much of academia, but that's a story for another day.

Adam Smith was famous for arguing that in a capitalist economy you need competition. Competition in a free market allows for the best to beat the rest, in order to sell your labour or products. This competition is normally on either cost or quality. Any old cheap watch can tell the time, but people still buy Rolex's. If you can't compete on cost or quality though, you've got to find a way of giving it value; e.g. through design or marketing; or you'll go bust.

Smith talked about supply and demand, a concept that overly confuses people I think. It's all about judging the best way to allocate resources. Rather than governments deciding it, supply and demand will let resources naturally allocate themselves to where there is a demand for them. If Apple brings out a new product, and suddenly the entire world buys it, it will show the markets that this is a highly prized new market and demand innovation from Samsung or Huawei. Old style competitors like Nokia or Blackberry have to compete or die. Capitalism is brutal, but effective.

Capitalism works, but true productive capitalism can be damaged if the equilibriums in money transfers are manipulated. The state is notably poor at allocating resources. The best example was the Soviet Union, which industrialised rapidly, but it's awfully poor allocation of resources meant it carried on supporting dying industries long after demand had dried up, and never gave people the freedoms to innovate in something like a digital revolution. The Soviet Union may have been able to produce half decent televisions or cars for its people, but because it was so poor at allocating resources, the actual quality of its products were still way off. Just look at Soviet architecture compared to American architecture to see that.

The Soviet government's control of the money and resources, compared to the far freer Americans, meant supply and demand wasn't working. In America, with a freer economy to innovate in, all manner of privately financed things could exist that never existed in the Soviet Union; from a pop music revolution, to a booming film industry, and great television shows. Meanwhile the command economy of the Soviet Union propped up things like the Russian ballet and orchestras, while persecuting writers like Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn.

Today, the west isn't as bad as the Soviet Union was in controlling the economy; but it still controls too much of our lives. Tax rates and house prices are too high for medium income earners to get any real chance of wealth. Interest rates are low, not encouraging saving, while benefiting spending. The end of the current industrial revolutionary cycle means growth, and therefore productivity gains, are low. An economy that supports spending and consumption, but not investment and saving, is not a healthy economy.

There are many reasons for why western economies have stopped being good at allocating resources, but the removal of sound money is perhaps the overriding one. As we've talked about, currency debasement is happening before our eyes and impacting first the poorest who rely on wages, and then the middle class savers; whose wealth is increasingly slipping away as inflation eats away at their savings and the purchasing power of their wages.

Whether leaving the gold standard was a good thing is for another day, but what is clear is that government money is showing its age. Capitalism is best left to just RIP. Money has been so manipulated that the government, through poor short-term investment, has devastated the prospects for the young and many now approaching middle age.

Chapter 4: Inflation, but more interestingly deflation

'By a continuing process of inflation, government can confiscate, secretly and unobserved, an important part of the wealth of their citizens' - John Maynard Keynes

'Inflation is taxation without legislation' - Milton Friedman

'The first panacea for a mismanaged nation is inflation of the currency; the second is war. Both bring a temporary prosperity; both bring a permanent ruin. But both are the refuge of political and economic opportunists' - Ernest Hemingway

Inflation, as we've mentioned before, is one of the primary reasons for many economic problems. What matters is not how much of a number you have of a certain thing, but its purchasing power. Inflation is very simple. The inflation rate goes up as more money is added into the economy. This doesn't have to be pure cash, as in notes, but 'money' in the broadest sense of the term, such as debt. Even though it may not look like money, the huge debt loads in the modern economy have added huge amounts of digital money into the economy and especially added them into places where loans are often taken out; such as the housing markets. This extra money eventually filters down to the entire economy – inflating everything over the years, even as wages may not rise to compensate.

Many countries, regions and government statistics all proclaim to tell us the exact inflation rate in their regions, but if you believe these government statistics - you're an idiot. Think about how much the price of beer has gone up in pubs, or maybe there's a better example from your own life that shows how prices have risen, while the average wage has not. The price of a beer, or a coke, or a Big Mac could all be used as indicators to show some level of inflation. One of the better more informal measures of inflation in Britain are these little and wonderful chocolate bars called Freddos. British chocolatiers are amongst the best in the world. There's a reason Charlie and The Chocolate Factory was written by a Brit about a Brit. Cadbury's, one of the companies that novel is based off, make a chocolate bar called Freddo. It has a bright green frog on the cover of the packaging and its dirt cheap, making it loved by kids.

Freddos have gone up by 250% over the past 30 years, while wages certainly have not gone up by as much. This is inflation at work. The purchasing power of the pound has gone down in relation to what you can by. This would be fine if wages had kept up, but the lack of stable currency has since 1971 seen a decoupling of money supply and the value of labour. We'll be talking more about some of this in a future episode on the financialisaton of the economy, but for now, remember that simply increasing the supply of the currency does not solve the problem if wages don't rise too. In order to keep genuine inflation down, Cadbury's would have to produce more Freddos, by using less labour. It would need efficiency gains in order to do this, through automation and innovation.

If we lived with a deflationary currency, Cadbury's would be better incentivised to produce ever more, for ever less, in order to keep fixed costs down and to outproduce and beat the deflationary gains in the currency. If the supply is decreasing, because there's less money chasing more things, you have clear incentives to produce only what this scarce money wants and to make the price point as enticing as possible. This incentive still exists in an inflationary currency, just not to the same level. We've become so used to an inflationary currency that many have no idea what a more stable era would look like.

Inflation is generally put up with, because deflation only really occurs during depression. This has led economists such as Friedrich Hayek to argue deflation during a depression is a bad thing, as it promotes hoarding and not investment, as confidence in the general economic outlook is bad. However if a deflationary currency was seen as so secure and huge numbers were confident in the currency itself, a general depressionary era would be unlikely to occur as people would have more general confidence in the currency, and the nature of the macro economy would be less important. Inflation promotes short-termism, which might be a good thing to encourage during a depression, but not generally. Deflationary currencies would promote investment with longer-term returns. Confidence would no longer be rested on the stability of banks and the financial system, which are increasingly overwrought in the modern economy.

Previous deflationary currencies, such as monetary metals, were perhaps the most secure currency we've ever had, but they weren't truly deflationary, as the Spanish found out. When the Spanish Empire imported huge amounts of gold and silver they'd traded and plundered from the New World; Spain, the richest economy in Europe, quickly hit a constant inflationary spiral, damaging the economy and long-term investment that arguably it still hasn't recovered from. Gold and silver rushes have occurred throughout time and throughout regions. Monetary metals are therefore a mostly deflationary currency, with periods of rapid inflation as more gold is mined or plundered.

So what kind of economic changes would a deflationary currency, like bitcoin, bring to the wider economy? And why is Bitcoin deflationary? Well Bitcoin has a fixed supply of 21 million bitcoins, that can only be produced via mining.

Mining is probably misnamed. It is just computer processors working out a series of ever increasingly complex mathematical sums, and distributing somewhat at random rewards for allowing this processing to be done on your machine. The more processing power you have, the more likely you are to be given rewards. Every four years, the rewards for working out these mathematical problems halves. So when Bitcoin first started, your average computer could be used to solve these mathematical problems. Doing so would give you 50 bitcoins, then 25, then 12.5, to a reward of 6.25 Bitcoins to successfully solve what is called a block. What are these problems you have to solve? Well the mathematical problems you solve run the entire network. These miners are the ones processing the information that lets you send and receive bitcoins and ensure they cannot be manipulated as there's millions of these miners all over the world trying to solve these problems.

The current reward for mining is 6.25 bitcoin, but as the problems become ever harder, the processing power needed also increases, meaning today you need huge rigs to stand a chance of successfully processing a block. The rewards received will continue downwards until about 2140. After which all 21 million bitcoins are released into the system and no more can be mined.

This supply is already getting so strict that the demand for bitcoin has massively deflated and pushing up the relative value hugely. Furthermore, as more and more interest is put into Bitcoin its natural deflationary nature is noted by more and more creating a type of self-fulfilling prophecy as its value continues to increase. Bitcoin will be seen as a true deflationary asset like great art and unique memorabilia; but unlike them it is a medium of exchange too.

This is why Bitcoin is not a bubble. It is simply becoming more and more deflationary. Increasingly little of it is being mined; meaning supply decreases can be factored into its overall value.

The fact Bitcoin's number goes up, to some, looks like a tulip or dot com bubble; but this is simply wrong. It's the fact Bitcoin almost works like a reinforcing prophecy that logically makes people recoil. But it's this twist in logic that takes you a while to get your head around. It is the need for this twist of logic that makes some just not 'get' Bitcoin. This for many enthusiasts is the frustrating thing, as I and many other can perfectly understand why Bitcoin is just so perfect, and yet struggle to understand how others can't see the same.

I do wonder if this is because of the modernity of Bitcoin making it still feel like a novelty. Bitcoin has been and is still seen as a novelty. The 10,000 Bitcoin spent in 2010 on a pizza is the most obvious example. Early on in Bitcoin's history those who would mine Bitcoin would send it to friends and others in the community freely. Even those who developed and took an interest in bitcoin, and perhaps knew of its potential, still sent around Bitcoins like it was a novelty. For others, Bitcoin was of purely technological and libertarian interest. Yet what a cross section of these groups started to note, was that Bitcoin just carried on going upwards in value.

It was this novelty factor of an internet currency that first interested people, and helped it gain attention, but this hid its true potential. Bitcoin has been written off, time and time again as a novelty. And sure, it might have been a novelty. But when does that novelty value start to wear off? After 12 years I think it's proven itself as more than a novelty.

Thankfully, there's an intelligent grassroots community interest in Bitcoin, proving what I always hoped, that not all people are as dumb as financial journalists. They saw the potential of Bitcoin as a potential game breaking system for a store of value and medium of exchange.

People noticed that if they put money in Bitcoin and just left it for a few years, the value went up and up and up. Many get rich quick schemes were designed around Bitcoin, but still, today, anybody who has held onto Bitcoin in its entire history, is still in profit. For some it took three years from the 2017 peak to late 2020 to see those returns, but for the rest it was a far quicker process. Simply holding £3000 in April 2019 or March 2020 would net you huge returns in mere months as Bitcoin continued to deflate.

Bitcoin is now in a near perpetual deflationary era as it's perceived value goes up, while supply has massively declined. As it deflates, it will carry on doing so until people start thinking its hit a near term peak and begin to sell in more quantities. This is the free market in action.

The move from novelty to revolution is not unknown in technological history, and some might say a feature. Greeks noted that steam could be used to power things many millennia before Thomas Newcomen and James Watt, but for the Greeks steam was a novelty. The Chinese used gunpowder for firework displays, while the Europeans used it for war; while magnetic properties that were used for novelty for guiding systems for ornamental wooden ducks in China were transformed into highly accurate marine compass' in Europe, helping to fight the Crusades and then in Europe's Age of Exploration. The Internet was seen as a novelty by some, until more and more saw its features, and more features were added. It wasn't long before we lived in an internet age.

Recorded sound was a novelty when Edison first started to experiment with it. Displays of the original phonograph drew large crowds, with people able to hear recordings of others speaking for the first time, but he struggled to find a way to make it useful. It took for Edison's patent to run out, so others could experiment with the technology for this novelty to finally find a use, as recorded music boomed. Why shouldn't Bitcoin be largely the same?

Everything should be open for innovation. Its unlikely central banks were going to destroy their own currency overnight and move to a Bitcoin standard, after the Bank of England governor and a few board members thought it up over a pint one night and decided to try it out. Monetary innovation would have to come from the people, not government. Somebody could have gone down the Edison route and tried to start a company promoting Bitcoins use and trying to compete that way. This might have worked, yet Bitcoin's origins are far more in line with how 21st century technology actually works.

A group of online hobbyists were far more likely to be interested in this type of technology. Google, Apple, IBM or whomever aren't going to even have an interest in something like bitcoin. Not only because of regulation or privacy concerns, but it's not something you really think about doing as a company. The idea that Google would own your currency would sound like *A Brave New World*. When Facebook tried to introduce its currency, *Libra*, even after cryptos were already a big thing, it saw much pushback and little appetite from consumers.

Previous industrial revolutions were powered by the lone geniuses working in sheds but now it's small online decentralised communities enabled by the internet who power technological revolutions. Few true revolutions come from the establishment and the elites, who are more concerned with staying in power, than undermining power structures.

Bitcoin's ascent to the tip of the monetary revolution's spear is slowly breaking a fiat inflationary bubble. This process may be slower and more drawn out than many Bitcoin enthusiasts think it will be, and it will be unlikely to have a clear moment of overtaking government money. It will be slow, like the industrial revolution, not instantaneous and chaotic like the French Revolution.

What will a true deflationary currency mean for the economy? Well we don't really know to be honest; because inflation has been pretty much standard for the whole of human history. Deflation has only come about in modern times during depressions - making people believe deflation is bad.

What I think bitcoin will allow for is a currency and store of value that can be deflationary and freely used in a confident economy. People will spend less on frivolous things, but more on true investments. People already sell their bitcoin to buy cars and watches. But once Bitcoin integrates into the economy, this strange effect will take place where a newly wealthy generation of Bitcoin first adopters gain rapid wealth – and these people will not be lacking in the confidence that may be lost elsewhere in the old economy. Bitcoiners will be used to frugal yet productive long term investments; not living the high life. They will buy highly personalised and highly valuable consumer products that are designed to last, and will be provably theirs through blockchain technology.

For those who invested early, and have patience and foresight, as well as probably already good incomes if they were able to manage to not sell their holdings all the time the price skyrocketed, they will be in line for a huge wealth transfer as the economy reorients itself towards more productive long term investment. This will continue the reinforcing prophecy of Bitcoin, as the amount of capital investment is put into Bitcoin, and will continue to grow in value as the Bitcoin network support more productive enterprises who invest their profits back into the network, further deflating its supply.

Sure some of this new bitcoin wealth will be spent on consumption, but I think it will largely be invested. A Bitcoin price that rises over time from £20,000 to £200,000 and then to millions and then tens of millions will just be sitting there, waiting to be spent. Once large amounts of collateral is easy to borrow against Bitcoin, this money stops looking nice on a screen and results in huge economic clout. Many will only have one thing in mind. Are there now any better investments than Bitcoin? The decentralised nature of this process means it will happen all over the world.

Investment will largely be in local areas; local areas that have never seen these types of patient, rational actors, with huge sums of wealth, looking for long-term productive investments – the exact types the current financial system has failed to engender. Good money will drive out bad money. A strong time money preference will become the new economic standard.

We are used to capital inflating in value, so we think relatively quick spending is a good idea. This doesn't support investment that may take 10-15 years but proves highly lucrative. These investments provide the best long-term investments, not pumping up tech stocks so they can grow into monopolies.

When Britain led the world leading up to the first industrial revolution, it had money sounder than today because it was based on monetary metals. Brits, back then, could use accumulated capital over a longer period to invest, and with the help of a loan, carry on the investment. In Britain, the first result of this new private capital changing the economy was in the great canals criss-crossing England, then it resulted in investment in factories and steam, and then railways. All were funded by private finance and productive bank loaning. Continued productive investment, backing up innovation.

Today, despite huge wealth that could be created in long term, rational investments, in all manner of infrastructure and large-scale investment in future technologies, private capital has continued to push money into unprofitable unimaginative internet and app based start-ups, which thus far are yet to en-masse result in any real profit. At the same time, the infrastructure of most west countries is decades old.

A monetary revolution, combined with a deflationary currency will help aide the rebirth of modern strong capitalist economies across the world. Not only will the system be fairer, it will encourage a more productive use of capital in a capitalist system. Those companies that can't keep up with the rest will drastically and quickly fall away. Easy access to credit will dry up as governments won't have control of the money printers to bail out the banks every 10 years. Only productive loans will once again be available. Those who are ahead will have to continue to innovate and compete.

The lack of sound money goes so deep in modern society that you can say the malaise of great art and music, and the arts more generally over the past few decades, which promotes shock acts rather than genuine talent: everything from Cardi B, to the horrors of Damien Hirst, have soared in popularity despite a lack of artistic talent. Government money has distorted the benefits of long term investment in the youngest, who rely on wages to survive. If wages don't pay well, you struggle to support the money and therefore time investment that needs to go into creating great art, and to support prosperous financial ecosystems. It's no surprise the musicians and actors of today are always from money backgrounds as they're the only ones who can afford to put the time and energy into following their dreams.

The Beatles would never have been able to do what they do now, simply because of the lack of wealth amongst the youngest, who now can't afford to support a bubbling and vibrant music scene like Liverpool of that period.

Money has not reflected where it needs to go. Government money means the young have been screwed out of a fair way for the entirety of their lives. There is no surprise our culture is filled with the untalented and the uneducated when they've largely been dissuaded from putting valuable time into long-term pursuits, as the rewards have continued to diminish. Hence, culture has largely been driven by corporations valuing compliance over talent.

The lone musical genius is rare. The Beatles, Elvis, Led Zeppelin; even Louis Armstrong, Miles Davis or Frank Sinatra; all came out of an era that paid fairer money for labour, and created strong local cultural ecosystems all funded by strong wages. A strong monetary ecosystem with more artists being able to survive creates a culture of competition in talent, innovation, creativity, and in the end, our aesthetic pleasure. These things are as true of for industries and societies at large. Fair money for fair labour is crucial for all manner of things, but culture, arts, science and politics all benefits with a stronger financial situation.

Chapter 5: Financialisaton, Globalisation and Industrialisation

'A banker is a fellow who lends you his umbrella when the sun is shining, but wants it back the minute it begins to rain.' — Mark Twain

The global financial market is huge. It's also based on a ponzi scheme, a ponzi scheme held together by government force. In much of the west, GDP growth over the past 30 years around the world has to a fairly significant extent been driven by the manufacturing growth in Asia, as billions across the continent industrialised and urbanised. Growth levels in the west have been based on much smaller margins of growth and from their financial systems, while industry, manufacturing, and resource extraction has mostly moved out of most western countries.

Anglo-Saxon capitalism, the most successful capitalism model, is based on debt. If I borrow £10,000 over 5 years and need to pay back £12,000; my investment has got to be able to match the higher interest, giving me incentive to produce more efficiently than others. If I don't I go broke. Expand this across an entire economy and you see the problems with a slowdown of technological progress.

Well this is what we're seeing in Britain and America. The economic model breaking down. The last 12 years has seen very few technological developments, with the only huge new invention: the smartphone; only making a small dent in the rapid technological developments needed to sustain this debt-based model.

This causes problems, as debt can't be repaid if you can't make enough money to pay it back. New inventions are the only thing that allows for an ever-growing economy, but it has slowed down.

The move of manufacturing to Asia has seen the west rely on a financialisaton of their economies where western corporations invest in Asia, and Asian manufacturing, and are largely content to reap the profits of it, hoping these profits will trickle down the economy.

These profits made in Asia, that have been brought back to the west, have not gone to ordinary people in the west, but to the people who were investing in Asia; like those already wealthy. The financialisaton of much of the western economy, which in turn is based on Asian tech manufacturing and Third World resources extraction and farming is called globalisation.

Yet the massive economic growth resulting from the industrialisation of Asia since the 1990s or 2000s is starting to flatten out. Other growth areas like Africa and South America, have politics far too corrupt and mismanaged to be reliable sources of future growth. In short, growth across the world is slowing down and not quick enough to continue to prop up growth in the west.

This isn't to say some places haven't boomed in the west. Consumer and internet technology drives the American economy: Apple, Amazon, Facebook, Microsoft have grown huge while the financial services industry has propped up Britain's economy since Thatcher's reforms.

You only need to walk around London to see the huge investments resulting from the financialisaton of the economy. Britain is pretty much propped up by its financial industry, something of a legacy of traditional confidence in its currency and government and a legacy of empire. Yet financial services shouldn't really prop up most of an economy. The richest countries should be investing to support new and emerging technologies to compete with the East as a manufacturing base, as technological diffusion makes it easier for other places to catch up and undercut you.

The decline of old industries is natural and started in the north of England about 100 years ago, and 50 years ago in the rust belt of the US as industries declined as it became cheaper to build elsewhere. Today, we're seeing something similar, in a silicon rust belt developing in California as the huge profits from the Third Industrial revolution slow down.

The first industrial revolution was largely England, the second largely the mid-West of the United States and Germany, and the third or digital revolution was located largely in California and the west coast, and caused a huge capital accumulation. This capital was largely not reinvested back into local areas, but largely reinforced the centralised financial industry. There are large quantities of excess capital that typically come from having a strong manufacturing and industrial base and means that excess capital needs to be managed efficiently, this results in a naturally strong financial industry. In Britain and the US this excess capital became more and more centralised over time in London or New York. Germany had such a decentralised financial system that it took for the First World War to start the centralisation of finance.

While the financial system should work in a continuous motion, with banks reinvesting profits from manufacturing, back into new manufacturing techniques, infrastructure and new investment areas, this never seems to happen. In effect, trickle-down economics is a con. Or at least it is when the financial system is over-centralised. This has been noted especially in recent years, with neither private industry nor government even attempting the required long-term investment.

The political capital that rich democracies allow its governments has been misspent. Rather than political capital being used by politicians to start rebuilding manufacturing economies; political capital has been used to start wars or military spending; while large welfare states have quelled the unease many have about their own situations, while there is always political capital to bail out the banks. Political capital by politicians could have been used to restart deep scientific research, large scale space sector spending, or large-scale infrastructure like public transit, but as we've seen time and time again: governments are bad at allocating resources.

Sometime sheer willpower and need can result in government innovation, but it's rare. The existential challenge of the Second World War proved so huge that the largely apolitical and often Jewish-American scientists were moved into action when the US poured huge resources into the Manhattan project to develop the atom bomb, showing somewhat what long-term government investment in science could lead to. Following the Manhattan project, America looked to have solved the problems of government-led innovation by developing a huge Space sector following the Sputnik moment, when the Soviet's flew a satellite right over US territory; while American government money was used to kickstart the digital revolution through the building of computers and the ARPAnet, the precursor to the internet.

Yet by the late 1960s, and the US had sent a man to the moon and beat the Soviets, yet the result of this new technology didn't prove to be a revolution. Profits from a private space sector were nowhere to be found, and space remained a government flight of fancy. Any continuing developments were curtailed by the disastrous Vietnam War, which ate up political and financial capital and caused huge mistrust in the government.

The 2000s in America were much the same. The victory of the US over the Soviet's in the 1990s meant the US truly led the world, and by the 90s the US economy was approaching 1950s levels of prosperity. Yet the 9/11 attacks gave George Bush and his neoconservatives huge political capital, which was entirely spent on fighting a War on Terror. Long term investments in the future of the country itself were just ignored as the American government wasted the potential of the 1990s.

To some extent the private markets in America did try to continue the growth. American private long term was focused on the internet. The Dotcom bubble of the early 2000s however showed what we still haven't learnt. The internet isn't the profit magnet many thought it to be. The spread of a technology that made communication and information so cheap and easy to spread around may have actually enacted a deflationary pressure on western economies as suddenly, so much, so quickly became cheaper and indeed free. The vast majority of internet-based firms are still not hugely profitable. Many have *never* really been profitable. The Dotcom bubble was the first sign of that; but even today only a small amount of tech firms make profits considering the size and impact of the internet on our daily lives. Many an old company has been burnt buying internet firms because they thought it was a space they understood, rather than acknowledging the trend that the internet is a difficult place to make money.

Even companies that did make the huge profits on the internet, have been slow to move and innovate in new industries. Facebook, Google and Apple have introduced little new, other than slight upgrades in existing products for years. Facebook and Google still rely on advertising revenue for its profits, and Apple still makes most of its money from 12 year old smartphone technology that will see continuing diminishing returns. A CEO who wasn't a glorified accountant might have been more secure in using Apple's huge profits in more daring and risky ways. Even Amazon's retail arm, now over 25 years old, still doesn't make much money.

America's economic problem of a lack of re-innovation, and therefore lower profits, is not new. Britain, Germany, Japan, the only other industrial historical rivals the US seen, had exactly the same issues of its wealth being squandered by elites. Britain's wealth by the 1850s was starting to be squandered by maintaining a huge sprawling empire. Far from making the British Empire, with its imperial preference tariff, a huge circular economy; it meant Britain stifled innovation abroad and had less money to reinvest in Britain itself. It wasn't even like Britain managed to build up places like India to a similar level to itself. India remained dirt poor. The lack of reinvesting of profits back into British industry, allowed Germany and the USA to catch up.

Germany too squandered its huge industrial growth and wealth twice, with both the first and second world war devastating its economy and its people. But the USA continued to grow and grow. The first 100 years of America's history from 1776 was focused on growing into the interior of the continent.

Had the United States stayed in the original 13 colonies then it's almost certain its industrial revolution would have kept place with Britain's considering the closeness of the two peoples. Yet with all that virgin land, surplus capital was pumped into expanding eastwards, where huge untapped resources were found. 1865 and the end of the American Civil War resulted in two events, the decimation of the slave economy and the start of industrialisation in the north.

Industrialisation happened on a scale never seen before. The huge wealth potential brought immigrants to the US, as ordinary people profited like never before. There were huge profits in almost every area, and in new industries like oil, automobiles, and telephones. The profits seemed endless. All manner of other new technologies made the country more interconnected and the peoples more economically efficient. At the same time, with a fairly stable currency in the US dollar, normal people went from poverty in Europe to a stable middleclass lifestyle. The American Dream they called it. The American Dream has always been illusionary, but there was an underlying truth. America was a land of prosperity for all, the likes of which had never seen before. The equality of capital meant there were no aristocrats. First, Second, and Third generation immigrants could become part of the ruling elite.

However, like Britain, the political elites over many years, especially since the 1980s, shifted the American economy away from industries and towards globalisation, similar to Britain's shift towards empire. It was already clear that America could not and did not want to keep up with the high-tech manufacturing now occurring in places like Japan and Taiwan. While other things like steel making, base level service jobs, and resource extraction went abroad too.

America had been the first country to lead two industrial revolutionary cycles, but fell into the same trap of over investing abroad, and not at home. Profits overseas were simply seen as easier to gain in the short run – America began to export its consumerism, as much as its technology.

America's global empire was never quite as complete or formal as Britain's empire, but it never had an ambition to do that. It was all about American capital investment, backed up by the military, and not the other way around. American capital poured all over the world through offshoring and the Americanisation of economies. Coca-Cola, Disney, and Ford; and then Microsoft, McDonalds, Starbucks, and Apple took over the world. This world order was backed up by the US' military dominance. Its military was bigger than any power in any terms in human history. Not only was America a bigger spender than the next 15 countries combined, many of those 15 countries were avowed allies. It was power like never before.

Much of this military might was used poorly. Never used in large and necessary conflicts, the US managed to get sucked into numerous wars like Vietnam or Afghanistan and Iraq, which drained resources, political capital and distrust of the state itself. Like the British in the Boer War, the US looked incapable of beating local guerrilla peasants despite its huge advantages. The money to fund these wars was not made through taxation but borrowing. The adding of huge debts into the world economy by the US government has added to inflationary pressures around the world.

It's safe to say that in 2021, America has still not managed to gain the huge benefits that should have accrued from leading much of this third industrial revolution. Much of the technology that was designed in the US was built and made by their newest and fastest growing allies in East Asia; like South Kora, Japan and Taiwan, rather than building semiconductors in places like Chicago.

Even during the third industrial revolution, America's economy began to look slightly off kilter. You can see this in films. Watch any 90s American family film and see how middle class much of the films look. Compare these family films to family films in the 2010s, and it all looks more depressing. What you're watching is the slow elimination of the American middle class.

The lack of new growth areas in the American heartlands since the 1970s saw political fragmentation as each new generation of politicians never supported policies that might reorient the economy inwards and towards industrial growth and monetary stability. The sucking of wealth from the beneficiaries of the industrial heart lands meant that the traditional base of middle class entrepreneurs and ambitious people didn't have the money or security to invest in the same way as before.

Capital went overseas, local communities began to fragment. Banking, which has long been a local thing, just watch *It's A Wonderful Life*, became far more centralised over the 20th century and local capital became harder to access.

Even though much of the American heartlands were decimated by this turn away from inward investments, and toward globalisation, the world was appreciative. I remember my dad telling me about how excited he was in the 1980s going to the first McDonalds opened near him, and how excited he was that this icon of America had come to 1980s broke Birmingham. In my youth, in the poor north of England; birthday parties moved from dull and damp church halls and small houses, to Hollywood Bowls, Pizza Huts, Frankie and Bennies, and the great multiplex cinemas to watch American made films, and all for cheap affordable prices. My childhood with have been a lot more dull without globalisation and American consumerism.

The 1990s to the present has seen the middle class shrink. A symptom of the slowdown and decline of industrial power which has divided the nation as the self-image of the country began to be debated. The very nature of America fell apart as the middle class began to vanish, and the rust belt sank into a depression. Continued disinterest in industrial investment made many bitter. Like Britain before it, money was sunk into the expanding world of American influence, not in its own people.

The Americanisation of the world was built on the legacy of industrial power, but much of it was based on an illusion of the inherent strength of the American economy, which in turn was most likely based on American war potential, rather than its overall industrial capacity. The rich were getting very rich, and the poor suffered. Other parts of the world took over American industrial power, and America went through its Victorian period. A great empire losing its competitive edge and gliding on a cultural dominance. The greatest military and the largest economy, but not the same economy as we thought it was. America's growth slowly waned and future growth areas such as new energy sources, faster transport, or investment in space and robotics never saw the profits needed to keep the American economy as far ahead of the rest of the world as its self-image demanded.

Even by the late 1980s, it was clear that America could be getting overtaken by another industrial power. A real scare went through America about the advance of Japan. Japan looked like the future. Japan had been mastering high-speed rail; it had a more competitive car industry since the 1973 Oil crisis highlighted the inefficient nature of American cars; it too had a growing cultural dominance with Nintendo, Sony, Sega; and growing capital reserves. The Sony Walkman was a Japanese cultural icon, high-tech consumer electronics were mostly developed and pioneered by Japan; cameras all became Japanese as Kodak was toppled. It was only in the narrow area of IT and the internet where American companies could outgrow Japan - and grow they did.

These new huge American IT companies operated not like traditional companies, but as private fiefdoms of their owners. Rather than working to secure profits for shareholders, these tech entrepreneurs used private money, cheap debt and exorbitant valuations to build huge empires. This didn't really help the economy. Profits were not dispersed to shareholders and the companies were run for revenue growth and not profit; destabilising the economy, as profits became scarce. Amazon began to rely on the profits of Amazon Web Services, which provides cloud computing, and by itself would be one of the most profitable companies in the world, to subsidise its retail empire. Jeff Bezos could then just use these profits to grow Amazon's other areas, undercut competition, and grow a monopoly.

America's decades of tech growth haven't helped the general economy as much as you might think. The super growth of these internet and app companies meant everybody looked for easy gains in the tech stock; thinking anything and everything internet, tech and app related was a secure long term investment. What started as obvious and easy ways to make a profit on investment reached a natural limit on how much money can be made from one area, as everything becomes saturated. Rather than a bust however, capital has carried on being poured into unprofitable startups, as everybody thought every business was the next Facebook, Instagram, or WhatsApp.

Yet the deflationary nature of the internet and the ease in the spread of information effectively renders many business models quite poor. News paywalls can be gotten around, most video can be gotten for free; user generated content is often as good quality as paid versions, any app can be recreated for almost no money. Uber might have been hugely profitable, but Lyft and existing taxi firms provide enough competition to mean Uber is always going to be trying to eke out profits. In short, the internet didn't prove quite as great for profits and business as many first imagined it to be.

So going back a moment, if this is all true about the American economy, why did Japan not manage to overtake it? Well, basically, it reached the limits of its possible technological growth and what efficiency gains it could easily make, and Japan could not make it through a completely new technological revolution by itself, which it needed to continue its growth rates. It couldn't find and develop the technology to continue efficiency gains. For GDP to grow, productivity growth is essential to make more wealth for the same amount of people. And, as Japan caught up to the west following its devastation in Second World War, it did begin to overtake certain areas. However, many of Japan's attempted radical technological advancement failed to produce a new technological revolution.

Investments made by Japan in things like rail, robotics, and telecommunications were nowhere near big enough to start a fourth industrial revolution and continue Japan's divergence from the rest of the world. Japan's building of high-speed rail was impressive but not fast enough. It took ten years for Britain to build an entire rail network. It took Japan 50 years to build several lines of High-speed rail. A lack of immigration and subsequently expensive wages in an ageing workforce was to blame.

Both America and Britain had the huge immigrant workforces to do the work the native-born thought was too hard to build: like canals and railways. Further, Japan's homogeneity stopped it developing any alternative ways of thinking too. The individualism that naturally existed in the US and Britain and resulted in the great bottom-up technological revolutions was a lot less common and stopped the Japanese becoming internet pioneers for example. Further, Japan's insular nature following the defeat in the Second World War meant that it had no real cultural dominance. Britain and America had a huge informal network spanning the globe. Japan's attempt to sow its seeds in Asia during its Imperial era were put down and stopped by first China and then the Atom bomb.

Japanese technology had begun to be so seen as so far ahead that by the 1980s and 90s, many thought Japanese tech was the best in the world. However, this meant others looked to Japan, and tried to imitate and overtake it. Japan began to lose its cutting edge as Taiwan, South Korea and then China challenged it in many areas.

Japan still remains to many a wondrous place. The most modern place on Earth, with a strong yet niche cultural influence, and it still has many high-tech industries, but it's a place where strong economic growth rates are largely absent. It has almost no natural resources, further limiting growth; everything has to be imported. Britain and America both have vast and diverse natural resources from coal, to oil, minerals, to bountiful agricultural land.

Poor public policy also played a role too. Japan, with no natural resources, could have been the first to invest a new generation of nuclear energy allowing electric cars to boom, making electricity cheaper and further incentivising Japanese car companies to produce electric cars. Both developments could have led to a huge export industry, but it never happened.

Following the nuclear disaster in 2011 Japan receded from being a nuclear power powerhouse of the world, and it didn't exactly move to a wind or solar power industry either.

So as we look around the world, we have to wonder where a new wave of technological innovation that will drive future genuine investments in the economy will come from. You need a fairly large population, and largely in a quite dense area with big cities, and a place already wealthy enough to be technologically advanced enough to move from one industrial cycle to another.

So if not Japan for a future burst of innovation, and an uncertainty about America; we need to consider where else. Europe, to me, seems an unlikely place for future growth rates to be overly large. The European Union, the self-appointed Kings of the European continent, is fixated on cementing itself as a political power on the continent. The huge profitable companies in Germany, the Netherlands and Scandinavia are funding huge wealth transfers to the south.

This funding has meant Spain, not Germany, has the best high-speed rail and road network in Europe. The Spanish high-speed rail system is the product of clear government fiat, not common sense. The high-speed network links all the capitals of the Spanish provinces together by high-speed rail. Yet some of these cities only have 30,000 people and have no need for high-speed rail. A high-speed commuter rail network for Madrid and Barcelona with some inter-city services would be what a commercial company would do, but that's the European Union for you: everything is political. Spanish high-speed stations are even built on the edges of cities, when most people who want to travel by rail, do so as they want to get to the city centre as quickly as possible.

Germany's huge budget surplus has funded much of this, so it's hardly surprising that a new wave of European innovation feels unlikely. Money isn't being invested at home, it's being used to prop up the south of Europe in a political project. Germany hardly has a high-speed rail network; it's companies are all old and whilst still producing high quality consumer goods, it might struggle to keep up. Germany's ageing population is continuing to pay for the future of Europe, not for their own future or their children's. Meanwhile the Netherlands and Scandinavia, other future industrial growth areas, are perhaps too small to maintain an entire industrial revolution by themselves.

And so to China, where many now see the future. China's awful regime will stamp down on any truly revolutionary idea, as it will see it as a threat to its own power. Capitalism will be political. China will not under any circumstances allow something like a monetary revolution to empower a new class of wealth. Areas will be selected for rapid growth, but like the US with space and the internet, or Japan with robotics and high-speed rail, profits may not be found in these areas as readily as may be believed. 3D printing or quantum computing may not provide huge efficiency and be the broad-based technological growth the Chinese communist party think it will. Genuine future profits and therefore growth, might come from somewhere else.

China, like the Soviet Union before it, may have a few Sputnik moments over the years but I think it will be unlikely to produce the broad level technological revolution it wants. It will be too inefficient at allocating capital. The American century of dominance was based on decentralised wealth across the country producing feedback effects across the economy, like boosting tourism, cultural exports, enticing many to America as a source of immigration to fund and populate new rounds of innovation and growth. America can pick any immigrant it wants, and it can pay the best in the world for their talents.

Immigrants are hardly want to go to the most authoritarian, harshest regime in the world, where freedoms are nothing and Xi Jinping is king. China's natural resources too, are limited for a country that size, while its population is ageing quickly. China has no cultural exports. China will remain a threat, without ever running away with it.

China's investment into areas like AI, quantum computing, and central bank digital currencies may pay off, but they may not. Like Japan's robotics experiments or America's Space Age, it may produce insane results that are government funded and highly specific, but fail to complete a revolution in how we live. Future and productive capital may lie elsewhere. This is the nature of capitalism, and why government investment is not always the panacea everybody thinks it is.

This is why state controlled capitalism doesn't work. Capitalism allows ordinary people to invest by giving them fair wages for their skills, allowing them a surplus funds to invest where they like. You only need a Wright Brother or a Steve Jobs here or there to help things along the way.

These kinds of decentralised investments can result in guiding future capital investment to where profits are much more certain, rather than to the guesses of central bankers or politicians. The canal and railway manias in Britain began due to widespread capital in local areas being able to invest in new technology and ways of doing things, and they showed themselves quickly as very profitable industries. The Bridgewater canal of 1760 was funded by a local aristocrat to get his coal quicker to market. The subsequent huge profit increase he saw, meant everybody else saw the same thing and invested thusly.

Everybody put money into canals, it seemed like a sure thing – and for many years it was. But soon all the most profitable canal routes had been built and money was being pumped into ever less profitable canals until eventually there was no more profit to be had. The canal mania ended, but for 50 years provided a backbone to an island with limited natural inland waterways. These canals remained in operation turning over regular profits until the coming of the railways, where once again local capital proved the key.

The railways started in the North East of England in Stockton and Darlington, which had gotten rich from coal exporting and so the two towns wanted to connect to each other. The two towns had missed out on the canal mania, and so the locals pushed for them to connect via a canal. However, somebody then had the bright idea of a horse drawn cart road to connect the two. They asked George Stephenson to plan the route, but he had a better idea. He pushed for a steam-powered locomotive cart on rails. The idea of steam locomotion had been experimented with for some years, with mine carts slowly being converted away from horse-drawn to steam, to get the coal from the mines to the canals ever quicker. Stephenson thought technology was advanced enough to move humans, and so he set to work.

Meanwhile the two richest cities of the north of England, Manchester and Liverpool wanted to connect. Having seen Stephenson's work, they wanted a piece of the action, and so moved to get Stephenson to build a new steam engine to power this route. He came back with the iconic Rocket engine. It moved people at 30mph, faster than humans had ever moved before.

Soon, the profits in moving people in this way were also realised and saw a railway mania much like the canal one previously. Essentially funded and started by the middle classes, it was the 18th century equivalent of WallStreetBets on Reddit. Except rather than speculating of assets, it was speculation on infrastructure which payed off handsomely.

These types of large profits based on new technology are now much harder to come by, with technological progress slowing down, and this means the surplus excess of resources still in society are now chasing increasingly scarce new sources of profit. Tesla is now valued at over 1000 times earnings, being the most obvious example, but even highly profitable companies have seen price earning ratios soar. However let's continue looking at Tesla for a moment. The entire value is built upon possible future profits. But what will be done if these profits come in, if other companies are anything to go buy? Tesla might start investing in a new areas and diverting profits away from shareholders and into large scale investment and largely unprofitable enterprises in order to keep revenue growth high.

What value would this give huge shareholders like pension funds, who rely on steady dividends? In short, any modern notion of stockholder value is paper thin. Tomorrow any car company could make a better electric car and cheaper; or even simply be able to produce more cars than Tesla. Tesla's infamous reputation for long delivery times may come back to haunt it, if it can't scale up quick enough and legacy car companies can, and people drift away from wanting Tesla's.

In short, Tesla's stock is based on the future possibility that it will produce a large profit, which will enable it to return value to shareholders. To do this, and to reach the scale its value needs to reach this valuation, it needs to basically become an electric car monopoly in the next 15 years. It will have to take out most of the competition – which seems unlikely. The Japanese will still probably want to drive electric Toyotas, the French electric Renaults and the German's electric Volkswagens, and many Americans will be happy driving electric Fords.

With so many of the worlds profitable companies focused on growth; because of the fundamental lack of good investment areas bringing in reliable profits, perpetual growth models are breaking. If shareholders realise Tesla is likely to just become another car company, selling more or less the same amount of cars as Toyota, it will be not worth much more than Toyota. The same can be said of Amazon or Airbnb or Uber. How long can people want to put up with having their wealth tied up in companies that never make a profit and return money to them. If there's a collapse of confidence in the economy, we shall find out I'm sure when the next stock market panic occurs.

Tesla is currently worth more than Toyota and the next 5 biggest other car companies combined. This is a result of financialisaton. Large amounts of excess capital looking for new growth, but with fewer profitable businesses, it leads to speculation. Increasingly you look at value in the economy and ask what profit there is to be made. Everything is so overpriced because everybody else has seen trend too.

The only thing it takes, is for a company to manage to take market share from Amazon Web Services, and for its profits to slide and Amazon's huge and largely unprofitable retail arm looks like a bloated unprofitable behemoth; or for Tesla's electric cars to fall behind with say Nissan or Ford introducing a million mile battery. All that paper wealth in stock markets could disappear, as people see it's not actually worth what its valued at.

So, how does all this lead us back to where we started. In the past few decades a lot of growth has been funded by overseas profits and less by profits at home. Nothing is really made in the west anymore except maybe Germany. Britain and America have moved to a service based economy, which essentially means we look after people and their money. This doesn't produce a strong middle or working class, who rely on making things and running small businesses that sell the things made.

With interest rates collapsing, debt at sky high levels, and government printing continuing unabated, at some point there needs to be high economic growth for all this to continue; something unlikely to happen if there is still monetary imbalance in the economy.

For Bitcoiners, the mantra 'be your own bank' is the answer to this centralisation and mismanagement of excess resources by banks and politicians. By the nature of its inability to be manipulated, Bitcoin looks one of the few moves away from government led systems, and a return to a sounder monetary policy.

The new Bitcoin world will see rewards for those who want to take long-term investment risk, and these newly wealthy Bitcoiners will have the funds and ideas to do so, creating a spiral of innovation and prosperity. For those who don't want to take risks they can just HODL Bitcoin, relying on others to take the risk. If a Bitcoin economy allows for capital to be allocated better, and I think it will be; it will see gains for everybody invested in Bitcoin, as the capital gained from these investment profits will be put back into Bitcoin, driving up its purchasing power for everybody. Bitcoin will return the world to a growth economy, as only profitable enterprises will survive in a new and more brutal capitalism; which in the end will benefit everybody.

So I want to end this chapter with an analogy. If you've ever seen a David Attenborough documentary, or remember Biology from school, you'll be aware of the concept of an ecosystem. It requires a balanced ecosystem for example to support charismatic megafauna like Elephants, Lions, Blue Whales, Giant Redwoods or Pandas. Think about how much the average elephant needs to survive. Its tonnes of food a day. It also takes a rich and fertile area with a natural unspoilt equilibrium so that no animals gets too powerful or too numerous to take over and destroy parts of the ecosystem.

The monetary system works the same. If you alter the ecosystem by, say, inflating away the purchasing power of wages; these economic ecosystems break down, causing localised depressions in certain areas reliant on wages, but impact less on those places reliant on asset prices – which are the rich areas.

It takes a strong local monetary ecosystem to create strong local artistic or creative ecosystems like a Liverpool in the 1960s, or 1920s New Orleans, where lots of young people with money to spend can spend it on what they like and drive the necessary supply and demand for new and better musicians.

Occasionally you get the charismatic megafauna of culture coming from these ecosystems: Louis Armstrong or The Beatles grew out of the Jazz and Merseybeat scenes. Yet it can't just be me who see the number of 'great' artists, musicians, writers, and economists in the modern economy declining as monetary ecosystems break down, not rewarding fairly new and interesting writers, musicians and whomever. It takes an ecosystem that is big and stable enough to be able to justify and support going against the grain, or to be elevated by the system.

We could go into other things like the decline of the media, and argue this has been down to the decimation of the purchasing power of wages, meaning people have less ability to fund and pay fair money for news; meaning newspapers have turned away from its readers and towards advertisers, donors and their owners to fund their operations.

What I want to highlight is that everything relies on these local ecosystems being strong to support a strong and healthy society, this includes technology. Those men in sheds creating the new technologies need time and space and money to get going. Inventors need this strong monetary ecosystem to survive, in order for them to paid what their labour is worth.

All great inventions come from the bottom up, with the support of a strong and rich monetary ecosystem. This allows individuals to do things and follow instincts, and to be able to disagree with the system and challenge it, rather than to be tied to the system.

Whether its Penicillin, not discovered by a big pharma company, but an independent researcher; or the PC developed by Jobs and Wozniak, which could initially be funded by Jobs working for IBM for only a few months and passing off Wozniak's work as his own. Their ability to live and start a company with such minimal employment and to follow their dreams looks like something of a bygone era. Their growth was helped initially by local capital, and remember California was not like it is now. There was wealth but not like there is today. But wealth was more evenly distributed across the country with the stronger monetary ecosystem that still existed in the 1970s allowing for cheaper living and supporting innovation.

The last 30 years and maybe more, might be seen as a relative dark age of technological progress outside cyberspace; as the physical world has yet to catch up to the rapid proliferation of the internet, resulting in a semi-permanent economic stagnation in the physical world. The question I want to leave with you in this chapter is whether you trust your leaders to be the ones to unleash this new and perhaps needed growth of innovation in the economy. Or would you prefer a decentralised version that benefits as many people as possible through the decentralised benefits of sound money that Bitcoin gives?

Chapter 6: The Leviathan

What is sovereignty? Sovereignty simply means to have power or authority. The concept of sovereignty is most often related to power within nation states. Whole wars and revolutions have been fought on the notion of who is sovereign within a particular region. Whether it's a foreign power or an autocratic ruler; the concept of sovereignty was a key driver in the political philosophies and subsequent Revolutions of the 17th and 18th century when power became increasingly seized by the people and for the people - at least in principle.

This move had begun centuries before and slowly, over centuries as the ordinary person benefitted from the end of serfdom, the power of Kings and Queens began to decline. In Britain, the tortuous 17th century resulted in a constitutional settlement where sovereignty became embodied in the people through Parliament, represented by embodiment of the sovereignty in the monarch in Parliament. All very confusing I know.

The conflict leading up to the British revolution in the 17th century was essentially a clash over common law, that had previously very mildly defined the powers of Parliament and the King. The victory of Parliament meant that over the centuries, the monarch would hold the symbolic role of sovereign, while Parliament would exercise this sovereignty in absolute. The people elected Parliament, and Parliament could use this power however it liked. Parliament chose to mix and mash up this power into a series of institutions that defined British life.

These institutions that now had varied and mixed power and control over the life of the people ranged from the formal corridors of decisions like the Bank of England and the courts. To institutions partly of the state like the Great Universities, the BBC, and today the NHS; while some corridors of power were highly informal like the gentleman clubs or the public schools. The power of Parliament was not fully dissolved down to the people, Parliament was elected by the people, but it was Parliament itself that exercised the sovereignty of the people.

This revolution was more profound than we realise. In Europe, sovereignty had was assumed by the Lords and Kings and given to them by god, and shared to some extent with the Church. In the furthest reaches of what could be considered European civilisation, in the English colonies of North America; an experiment was underway in which there was no clear sovereign other than a King a few months' sailing away. There was no Parliament, no established church - and it was too big an area, with too much independence for a tyrant to rise up to claim sovereignty. In this harsh wilderness, the colonists had to find a new source of governance.

Where these colonists came from, mostly England and the British Isles, had long been a troubled region. It had never quite fragmented like Europe over religion, but it had fractured politically due to the nature of the government and the limits to its rule. To an outsider this mongrel island had a mix of Celtic, Germanic, Norse and Norman roots and was still at loggerheads over various things in different parts of the island, as many thought in very different ways about the nature of governance.

To quite understand the nature of British change we have to really start at the beginning of centralised England which means we have to go back to one of the most famous dates in history: 1066. Pre-Norman England had been broadly imagined before the Norman conquest, but the Norman invasion and subsequent rule turned England into a single governance polity, and upset the rulebook by imposing a far more centralised government over the island than had ever been seen before, as the fairly laissez-fair approach of previous governance was overturned. However, over the years, the ancient freedoms of the old England were never quite wiped out. The tales of Robin Hood against King John and the Sheriff of Nottingham passed down through oral folk culture demonstrated that it was thought those in power were overstepping their authority by imposing hardships on the ordinary Englishman and women.

The Robin Hood tales occurred amongst the peasantry against a backdrop aristocratic rebellion too. More historically certain than Robin Hood, and more consequential, the 13th century in England saw a very incident occur amongst the aristocracy. This incident was unique in England at the time. Across continental Europe, rebellious barons and lords could easily go to war against a king. Foreign support was easy with the permeability of borders at the time and so it was seen as quite likely to be able to challenge a king with foreign help. Aristocrats in Europe might even try to separate their land or invade others' land to gain political power. Not in England. Perhaps due to its island nature, England saw aggressive negotiations more than anywhere else, rather than outright warfare.

King John, long noted as one of the worst ever English monarchs, was so unpopular in England that he inspired his barons to rise up against him again and again. They forced him to sign a treaty called Magna Carta, which he signed but later reneged on. This set into motion a strange precedent; that of political cooperation but fierce resistance to absolutist tyrants. The Magna Carta Myth, as I called it in my other podcast, was the result. Today, what we think the Magna Carta said wasn't actually in the document, the theories of the liberty it granted to the ordinary person were only propagated a few hundred years later by lawyers like Edward Coke, who read more into the Great Charter than was perhaps there. The Great Charter, as its Latin name translates too, was a deal to limit the barons' duties to the King, to protect church rights, protection for the barons from illegal imprisonment, access to swift justice, and freedom for the City of London.

The success of the Magna Carta in the immediate period following is signing is much debated, but it's probably true to say that it was not all that successful. Yet what it represented was more important than what it actually said. The Magna Carta was the victory of an older form of Anglo-Saxon cooperation, over Norman centralisation of power. There had long been in Anglo-Saxon England an assembly of the ruling class, secular in nature, to advise the king, which could be used as a check upon the power of any one man.

This Witengamot, as it was called, was Ancient Germanic in nature, and imported by the Germanic tribes who largely ran over the south of England in the 4-6th centuries AD. The Witengamot was brilliantly turned into the Wizengamot in Harry Potter, with the clear Celtic overtones of wizardry in Harry Potter.

Yet as we saw the Norman invasion turned all this on its head. The decentralised rule of the Witengamot was met in 1066 by the importation of a new style of Norman centralised ruling, and far heavier than even Roman Rule. This was met at times by intense conflict, especially in the infamous Harrying of the North.

But over time, cooperation always seems to win. Following the Harrying of the North to quell the rowdy northerners, there was little resistance after the initial quelling, and no will to fight back. Some scholars say this Harrying was a genocide of the north, yet others say it was actually quite a mild event. I tend to go for the angle it was quite mild event, but still shocking to the people of Yorkshire, as William stamped his authority far more harshly than any rules previous. He's not called William the Conqueror for nothing.

While the historicity of the Harrying is still up for debate, what we do know is that William subdued the population of England, and replaced most of the Anglo-Saxon nobility with Normans. William seized all the land of England and claimed it for himself and his lords. Over time however, the Anglo-Saxons peasantry didn't seem too affected, as the economy boomed. Anglo-Saxons quickly started to rise through the ranks of Norman high society, with the Normans eventually using much the same mechanism of rule as the Anglo-Saxons before. Over time, the Anglo-Saxons and lower nobility started to see their wealth rise quite strongly as Norman rule opened up; with slavery phasing out, and feudal wealth spreading out, by 1150 only tangential differences between Normans and Anglo-Saxons existed.

What the Normans never stopped happening in England, and had no reason to, was the strong market economy that already existed. It's most likely this Harrying of the North and submission of the English came with assurances to regular people not to tamper with the economy, and to allow trade and livelihoods to continue; all they needed to do was submit. To bend the knee. Most people then, as today, just wanted to get on with their lives. What happened at court stayed at court, and so the peasants agreed to carry on trying to find the lovely filth and mud, despite the violence inherent in the system.

The Anglo-Saxon lords and barons were replaced with slightly stronger and wealthier Norman ones. Everybody else just got on with their lives. It was only 100 years later, of course several lifetimes, but not an astonishingly long period of time, when large scale interblending of peoples and cohabitation occurred; much like the Danes in the 8th and 9th centuries who had been largely blended into Anglo-Saxon life.

This ability to live together peacefully and prosperously meant the English prized themselves as more civilised than the Celtic fringes of the British archipelago. Of course, many would say this obsession with living in a civilised manner and judging other people for their less civilised nature is still an inherent part of being English.

The peace and prosperity of pre-Norman England, relative to elsewhere, meant England became a strong market economy with diverse wealth spread across the country and increasing economic specialisations. A large mining boom of silver in the north of England in the 12th century helped provide an expansion of the money supply, which helped importing and exporting as international trade took off. Rather than hoarding this wealth, the silver was more freely traded, and in 1158 it helped to fix Britain to the silver standard. You can understand what this new standard might have done for the country, as suddenly reliable coinage with genuine value and purchasing power was introduced into the country.

Britain had always been something of an economic hub. This is why William wanted to conquer it. It was large and diverse enough geographically to be self-sufficient, a small enough population to mean that there were plenty of excess resources, and a growing deep skill base, now with a strong currency. There was little conflict at home, as people grew richer, and what wars there were tended to be in France. These wars in France over the centuries proved how much wealthier England was than France. The success of English and Welsh longbowmen was down to the relative wealth. Children from the age of eight were trained with the longbow as a skill, they had less need for children to provide the necessary labour to survive. The demonstration of this English specialisation was relieved starkly in the Hundred Years war, as the English and Welsh longbowmen ploughed down the French at Agincourt and Crécy.

Yet this balanced political equilibrium fostered in Norman England was destroyed by the disastrous King John. John's barons had always expected to have to pay fealty to him. Paying fealty is a constant in all political life, but you should not try to push it, because being stabbed in the back is also a constant of political life. The Barons were doing well for themselves in this flourishing economy. They knew money was occasionally needed for war and Royal matters, all successful polities allow rulers a few flights of fancy, but John was exerting such a huge amount of tax on his barons that it was beginning to look futile, especially as he began losing the Norman provinces he'd inherited. The barons were getting taxed until they bled, for the privilege of losing wars.

John kept making matters worse. He lost all his French possessions and then spent the next 10 years continuing to try to fight them. After a final loss he came back to England and the barons had decided it was all too much, and challenged him. All relatively peaceful but with an underlying threat, the parties met at Runneymede - halfway between the royal stronghold of Windsor and the political capital in London.

It was only when King John reneged on the agreement they made: the aforementioned Magna Carta, that everything broke down and genuine conflict occurred. The following Barons War was short and sharp, and John worn down by now decades of conflict died halfway through his military campaign. John's successor, Henry III resigned Magna Carta, which was now less radical form. Later monarchs reissued Magna Carta became part of political life with each monarch resigning it.

In effect, what this meant Magna Carta was now codified into law. It was so established that everybody just assumed it was impossible to tamper with. Barons and elites had clear and legal rights over the monarch. It was the law over the ruler. Or as we came to call it, the rule of law. That the barons were well off and rich in the run up to the signing of Magna Carta is significant. The King could not rule without them, he needed their considerable wealth from their estates to survive and fight wars.

The financial independence of the barons meant they were able to kick started a revolution. The rule of the timocrats and aristocrats over the tyrant. It was a demand that even the monarch obey the laws of the land. The establishment, of permeance in law, of the rule of law began to alter the nature of English life, slowly, over centuries as the Norman style personal rule slowly ebbed away.

100 years after Magna Carta and another uprising in England occurred. This time not the aristocrats, but the poorest and most needy in society. This type of revolt was very unusual. The poor are usually the most demoralised in society, and unable for whatever reason, mostly due to tactics of divide and rule by the ruler, to band together and fight the powers that be. So momentous was this event, that it caused King Richard to abolish serfdom in 1381. The Peasants' Revolt or Great Revolt of 1381 was one of the great events of the Middle Ages. The Black Death had hit a generation before the Great Revolt and the practice of serfdom was already declining, due to economic reasons and the wiping out of a third of the population, but following the revolt, it legally abolished.

Following the Magna Carta in 1215, there became an established baron's council to support the King, while Knights met too, to represent "the Commons", a term coming from the Norman French word Kommune. These were the representatives of the ordinary rural people that lived across the islands, and these Knights might not have much.

Over the years, these meetings, highly informal, began to formalise and be seen as a real way to unite the country, especially as Edward I looked to unite England, Scotland and Wales under his command.

By 1341 there was been a split between the nobility and the commoners represented by the knights. Over the previous 100 years these meetings, somewhat similar to the previous Witengamot, had grown and the knights began acting with more and more authority, and started to complain about heavy taxation of the poor and the mismanagement of the military. The English were getting wealthier in their strong market economy and as people grew wealthier and more confident; political power rooted in a growing timocracy started to be devolved down.

This power, from 1341, grew and grew over centuries, to such an extent that these institutions became more and more entrenched into normal life and it became more and more difficult to take any power back. This represents the start of Parliament and the true divide between the Commons and the Lords, one that continued until the 20th century. However, it was the nature of the role in governing between the Parliament and Monarch which was the big one. The roles of Parliament grew over time, with the King taking increasingly less decisions for himself. This was pretty much unchanged for around 300 years after, however in the 1630s and 1640s, for the first time, there was a sharp divide in the country as to who; Parliament or the King, actually held sovereignty.

When we go back to the American model and the first colonists coming over, England was going through this crisis of who or what was sovereign: Parliament or the King. The common law system had become so entrenched that people just assumed everything would carry on as normal, but when these norms became challenged, it caused a great rift in the country. The English Revolution, which became something of a British civil war, was the result of this.

As we saw, English sovereignty was derived from the King, who technically gets it from god, but roots the sovereignty in Parliament. Parliament is therefore sovereign, but Parliament answers to the people. If you need address or have a grievance you have a Parliamentary representative, who should help you address the grievances.

The United States meanwhile may have started with allegiances to the King and Parliament, but sovereignty in the United States never really rested there, it always rested with the people who were taming the wilderness. Such was the wilderness and the plentiful resources of the New World, that settlers who were willing to brave the journey across the ocean were given free land. There was no state police or state authority, and so responsibility for governance was largely rested with the individual themselves. The wealthiest would have quickly been able to centralise excess resources and build up their own wealth. For issues larger than the individual, town councils and meetings were set up by the people themselves.

This was still largely the same model of cooperation as in Britain, where the economy, rather than the grand matters of nation building, was the more important thing, but unlike Britain it was at the behest of the citizens themselves, not via an institution like Parliament. Americans ran the governance of their own areas, in their own way. Soon the representatives from various groups would be sent to meet together, in order to solve more complex issues like trade and mutual defence. Cooperation through flourishing assemblies were soon springing up all over the Americas, taking the de facto place of a Parliament, and in the opinion of many, an equal of Parliament under the King.

Like any good common law system, the rules and ways of life in Colonial life were not really questioned to have significance, just assumed to be permanent and not given much challenge. The only interest for all was how to improve on the system, which was working well for all until around 1755.

In around the same time Britain was starting to industrialise, the authority of these new legislatures, set up by the people, for the people, were challenged by Parliament, who had never treated these assemblies to be on a similar footing. Like in the English Revolution, two sides of the same common law precedent took opposite views. What was essentially a legal matter, as to who was sovereign, was unable to be established through law and precedent.

Indeed, many in Britain even sided with the Americans in private and in public. The revolutionaries won the following war, confirming the rights of the colonists to represent their own sovereignty, and not to stand in deference to the King. The United States still sees itself as this bastion of individual freedom and property rights.

But is the United States still this type of democracy? A democracy based on individual liberty and wealth becomes harder to sustain when the middle classes lose wealth en-masse. The loss of relative wealth and individual property in a timocratic democracy, with the middle class losing out, as wealth becomes concentrated in the top 0.1%, is not a good recipe for a successful political system.

The billionaires of today in America are the old-fashioned Dukes and Lords of society. Like them, wealth and power are intermingled, and the governments are open to them today in America, just as when Dukes and Lords in the old British system had a huge influence over Parliament. It’s just now we don’t call them Duke Bezos of Medinah or Earl Buffett of Omaha.

Huge corporations being able to dominate markets in the modern economy is not natural. The rapid growth of tech companies, giving the United States a sort of aristocracy it's never had before, was because of the centralisation of wealth allowed to occur as manufacturing moved out and allowed original inventor-entrepreneurs to sustain large shareholdings. The mindset that the internet is the future amongst investors has allowed huge amounts of private capital to try to sustain these companies and allow them to compete with traditional companies, which come from an older model of capitalism where profits, not revenue, matters.

Governments have seemed intransigent in funding new areas of genuine technological progress despite long-term borrowing costs being low. If you're going to run a Keynesian economic model and prop up jobs through cheap debt and marginal gains in economic output, you should probably at least look to try to use this cheap debt to make riskier gains, especially when the cost is all political and not really economic with all the government money swishing around. Money controls people, and the government controls the money.

People have increasingly noticed this fact of how their money wasn't what it quite was. There aren't really any safe stores of money anymore. Oil majors are in a seemingly declining industry, banks have struggled and seem at risk of imminent collapse at any point; genuine and profitable shares are oversubscribed; while companies that promise profits in the future like a lot of tech companies, are also massively oversubscribed considering the profits they produce.

In a healthy economy where home ownership is high, people have the funds and confidence to invest in a wide range of profitable stocks to produce dividends, which filters down into interest rates, encouraging all to save and allowing banks to reallocate capital. This profit driven growth model was often the key to genuine economic growth, but is since long gone.

We can trace this to the United States leaving the gold standard in 1971. It meant the United States Dollar became the reserve currency, and the United States could control the worlds currency and all the effects that has on the world. It can shut off the economy of Iran, impoverishing millions, all because of a feud. If the world still traded in a currency that could not be interfered with, then financial sovereignty of countries would be improved.

But how does this involve Bitcoin? And what has this got to do with individual sovereignty? Well, sovereignty comes from power. Power comes from wealth. If everybody is wealthy, everybody is powerful and everybody can be their own sovereign individual.

Bitcoin solves this crucial flaw in the current monetary system. By the nature of its mathematics and its decentralised proof-of-work, it can be relied upon not to be manipulated in this way. A monetary system based on Bitcoin would allow a reorientation of wealth, which will be followed by a broader societal restoration in the equilibrium of money transfers. Fixed costs will all be reduced; labour will increase in value and we will all be a lot happier.

The future should be bright. A new technological revolution, called the fourth industrial revolution, is this attempt to bring together a new set of industries to allow profits once again to be seen in the economy, but whether governments can lead technological innovation remains to be seen.

True innovation, pioneered in Britain and then the United States, was truly revolutionary because it was not top-down; it was the creation of private and decentralised general wealth as sound money and high wages proliferated, enabling individuals to follow their passions and get the just rewards for it. Whether it's Watt and Boulton in Britain, or Edison or the Wright Brothers; these types of people don't really exist anymore. They were generally middle and upper-middle class people who held private wealth but were independent, with independent freedoms.

So what essentially I've been talking around this chapter, is that what I think should be a fundamental freedom, especially a common law system, the need for sound money in a prosperous liberal capitalist country has been lost. It should be as fundamental as our freedom of speech or right to own property.

A fundamental right to liberty we have always assumed to be correct; that of complete trust in the currency being sound and true, to fairly represent value, has been broken. This is of course not in the news, but it hides behind the news as sort of an overarching explanation for the many ills of the modern economy.

Whether you trust the current system and government money is your own decision. I'm not here to tell you what to think; only to give you the facts. But for many Bitcoin enthusiasts, it was this prospect of financial sovereignty and independence away from a broken system and a return to the fundamental freedoms entrenched in common and civil law systems that was the key drive.

Bitcoin removes the need for financial middlemen, and it allows a free transfer of stable currency to anywhere in the world, for increasingly minimal fees. If the entire banking system crashed tomorrow, Bitcoin would be unaffected. Bitcoin may go up or down in value, but the system will remain safe and secure. Even when everything 'works', it's supported by central banks and governments are thinking up ingenious manipulations to keep the system running. Bitcoin will work because that's how its programmed.

With Bitcoin you are safe. The relative value of Bitcoin is highly unlikely to crash anytime soon, and as more and more people keep on investing their spare capital into Bitcoin, it will keep its strong purchasing power. If there is a crisis of confidence in banks, the US dollar, the property market or wherever; then more and more people will look to Bitcoin, rather than looking away from it.

I think this element of Bitcoin is mostly misunderstood. It's not unstable, it's actually very stable as a currency, it's only the value that isn't. The nature of Bitcoin's fluctuation in value is in part due to the different stages people are at with the technology. For some, Bitcoin is already a bank, for some it's an investment only for speculation and profit, however for many it's a novelty. However, Bitcoin's value will continue to go up and up, as there's too much of a community who believe in Bitcoin and will eat up price dips for it to collapse.

For many who've already turned themselves into a Bitcoin bank, they've seen the change in their lives in using a real and stable store of value. Rather than a bubble, Bitcoin will go through cycles of hard and sustained growth, followed by periods of speculation. As seasoned HODL'ers will tell you, holding and thinking long-term about Bitcoin can and will only improve your own financial situation. Why would this notion be any different for the economy at-large?

So how does this notion of Bitcoin intermingle with the notion of an independent sovereign citizen? Well, it's based on the simple observation of what sound money can do for raising the individual over the state, as the state can't use and manipulate currency for its own ends. When 1 bitcoin means the same to you as it does to the government; individual liberty across the board will be raised.

Democratic governments in particular will be effected. They will be unable to stop the rise of Bitcoin as it begins to convert people through its superior metrics and growing network effects. The libertarian nature of modern cyberspace likes to be used to subvert state power and established ways of doing things. If the internet took down the banking system, it would be the biggest gain for individual liberty since the removal of the gold standard. People should be left to largely run their own lives. They are best equipped to do this when what they do is paid for in a fair currency.

Many might worry that the sovereign citizen could undermine the notion of big government safety nets. If things go wrong, government services, which are backed up with large government spending, based on unsustainable debt which can simply be inflated away by the government, might not there to support them. However, contrast this with the vast, vast majority of people who will simply be better off if the purchasing power of their labour was restored.

The safety of a permanent currency like Bitcoin should not make people afraid of a reduction in government safety, but joy in the new found permanence in their own safety. Permanence and financial stability will be increasingly widespread in this new Bitcoin world.

Chapter 7: Bitcoin

Chapter 8: Blockchains

We've talked a bit about blockchains so far in this series, but today we're going to focus on it wholly. Blockchains are the backbone of all cryptos since Satoshi Nakamoto invented them. But what is a blockchain? Blockchains mean:

- Each computer is connected with a system through the internet;
- Each computer is identified by a unique address;
- Each computer can disconnect and reconnect with the system at any given time;
- Each computer independently maintains a list of peers it communicates with;
- Communication between nodes is based on messages;
- Messages are sent from one node to another over the internet by using their unique internet addresses;

The development of the blockchain simply means nodes, or receptacles, on computers can be programmed to interact with each other. Rather than just send and receive information like the internet, in a blockchain, each computer acts as part of a hivemind and constantly solves problems to keep updating the spreadsheet with information. What makes blockchains great is that it is all automated. Blockchain technology will be used to replace the type of bookkeeping used by banks for centuries. Blockchain will pretty much replace and eliminate any industry relying on facilitating book entries, and introduce a whole new service sector.

Blockchain is the necessary replacement of what, hundreds of years ago, was one of the largest changes in financial history: the development of double entry bookkeeping. Double entry bookkeeping was first developed by the Jewish community in Roman Judea, and used by Jewish bankers in Cairo, but its spread was limited. What the double entry book system did was to replace simple notations of financial transactions with two columns. This new system of bookkeeping meant every entry needed a corresponding entry in a different account. Essentially creating the ideas of debit and credit.

The first book on this double entry system in the west, was by Italian mathematician Fra Luca Pacioli in 1494. Pacioli and his friend Leonardo di Vinci helped to develop double entry bookkeeping in a more efficient and organised way than had gone before. Even early on in its history, double entry book-keeping was noted for its beauty and symmetry. It conferred cultural authority on numbers by means of symmetry. The use of double entry bookkeeping, e.g. keeping credits on one side, and debits on the other; conjured up to many both the scales of justice and the symmetry of God's world.

Pacioli's book on this new accounting technique spread throughout Europe, giving him the title of the father of accounting. This simple financial innovation allowed for the benefits of detailed records of financial history that had been missing throughout much of the late medieval age. It also provided an in-built error detection system. By the 15th century Florence had adopted double entry bookkeeping, which enabled the banks to expand beyond traditional banking activities. Formalising banking and making bookkeeping ever better, more secure, trustworthy and reliable; provided a huge boom in the financialisaton of Europe at the beginning of what would be the Renaissance and Enlightenment.

For many, the next succession in accounting history is the Blockchain. It hypercharges the benefits of double entry bookkeeping and turns it up to 11. Not only allowing double entry bookkeeping, but allowing for thousands of simultaneous entries into a ledger, all checking each other's work. Unlike manual bookkeeping, which can be easily manipulated, the blockchain cannot.

A decentralised distributed ledger has potentials far beyond Bitcoin and money. Blockchains are a technology that is almost as revolutionary as Bitcoin itself. In 50 years' time I think, the situation will be flipped, and Bitcoin won't be seen as the revolution, it will be the blockchain technology that's the true revolution: Bitcoin will just be the first method to exploit it.

This shouldn't surprise us. Sharing information in a peer-to-peer manner was what the internet revolution was all about, and it's what the blockchain is all about. I trust the blockchain far more than the banking system, and the more and more I read about Bitcoin, the more sure I am of its workability on even grander scales. The internet was able to capitalise on the digital revolution by working out easy ways to send digital information. Bitcoin is essentially the same thing, taking advantage of the same mechanisms and technological ideology.

The blockchain is one of the final changes of the digital revolution, as slowly everything moves into cyberspace.

This move from the physical to digital world started decades ago. By the 1980s computers were still mainframes of huge proportions, but PC's got smaller and allowed them to be placed on desks. The 1990s led to the phenomenon of the internet, which allowed for these computers to be connected, creating a network. The internet grew and grew throughout the 1990s. I still remember not being able to go on the internet when my mum was on the phone. When we got broadband, internet use in our house grew hugely as it did around the world, as sharing information became cheaper and we could stay online constantly; allowing for constant reliable connection that didn't need a telephone line.

As this changed, and more and more people used the internet, the more trust we had in this new technology. Usage led to confidence, and allowed for a growing confidence in this new platform; as more and more industries moved online. The age of ecommerce shifted everything from jobs and businesses, advertising and communications online. By the late 2000s, the smartphone and cellular technology hypercharged a move in allowing you to be almost anywhere and still be a part of these networks.

The reliability of the internet led to the adoption of cloud computing and meant that everything could now be hosted on cyberspace too. The need for physical space shrunk, as everything went online.

Yet the internet wasn't perfect. It started to be controlled by the rapid growth of certain, huge internet companies. These companies didn't so much compete with each other, but with start-ups and open-sourced software. Firefox or Linux for example nearly proved a decent competitor to Big Tech, but slowly Big Tech demolished all these competitors and many were happy to be told what to use and how to use it. Yet Big Tech might have won the battle but not the war. The online communities that pioneered Firefox or Linux, and tried to evade the increasing control of Big Tech, coming from a largely libertarian and anti-corporatist bent, never went away.

Despite constant attempts at in-house innovation by Big Tech, and buying up anything that looked like a threat; Big Tech never found many new sources of revenue. Google is still reliant on search, Facebook on social media, and Microsoft on Software. Really the only new space Big Tech has managed to innovate in, has been cloud computing.

As we talked about in Chapter 5 on financialisaton, the financial industry is huge and all-consuming; yet highly inefficient and short-term. This is the nature of the financialisaton of economies. Long term steady and strong growth looks out of reach, because of the poor allocation of resources by banks. Blockchains may just be what the financial system needs to once again become more efficient at allocating capital; just like double entry bookkeeping did in helping Florence to flourish.

So from a technical standpoint, what is the blockchain? Blockchains are programmed software running a decentralised ledger that can record information. In what is the most overused analogy, blockchains are like an onion – it's got layers. I'm sure if it was called 3D bookkeeping, people might be able to more clearly recognise the impact of the technology.

Yet most people don't really care about the tech, only the result. The decentralisation of the ledger, results, in my opinion, in many benefits over centralised ledgers. With blockchains being decentralised, you can get higher amounts of computing power, using the millions of connected computers all over the world. Decentralisation leads to a cost reduction and higher reliability. A blackout in New York or even America wouldn't matter. Bitcoin would keep going. There are negatives of decentralisation including coordination problems, and on obvious reliance on computers over anything else.

One of the primary negatives I keep seeing about Bitcoin and blockchains is that it is too energy exhaustive to be of good use. To me this is something of a fallacious argument. It's supply and demand. Bitcoin's rise will result *in* innovation to keep up with its growing demand, not the exposition of the flaws in Bitcoin.

As the demand for energy rises, and its blockchain grows more and more, it will be because the network is getting bigger and bigger, with more and more money going into it. The network will be becoming more valuable, and this will see entrepreneurs wanting to match this new demand. This won't be isolated in the broader economy. Mining is already being done where it is cheap and reliable and this will only increase. This energy will almost certainly be in localised highly energy rich environments.

Deserts for sunlight, rivers for hydropower, geologically important places for reliable geothermal energy, very windy seas off shore, maybe even nuclear power stations; will all see natural developments in more energy intensive operations. This will help push renewables to become cheaper and cheaper. Bitcoin will only increase the demand for clean energy, and precipitate the developments in making more processing power, making everything cheaper. That's just the free market.

Examples of how innovations can make their own success are abound in the history of technology. Think about the automobile industry in Britain. The Car industry in 1900 in Britain might have looked a silly thing to think about, when roads were all mud and dirt, and with Britain being the rail capital of the world – it looked even sillier. But the first people who started using cars were the rich, who might have only wanted it to travel around their estates. But as more and more people started buying cars, there was obvious demand for better road networks. As more roads were built, or rebuilt with better materials, there started to become a genuine road network. In 1936, for the first time since Roman period, the state took control of the road network. At the same time, trains still criss-crossed Britain able to get you anywhere, at relatively cheap price; so how did this happen? How were cars even a thing in Britain?

The simply answer is, because the car is what millions wanted to use. As more and more people got cars, it precipitated a development of road networks; making the network better for everybody else, and this just continued to grow until now, when Britain is almost a complete car country, despite it being the home of the railways. All the light rail systems of the early 20th century in places like Birmingham, Sheffield and Manchester were torn down by the 1960s. In 1951, 42% of journeys were by rail, now it's about 5%, while car journeys have gone from 28% to nearly 90%. Was the car necessarily the better invention? Well I would say no, but the lack of investment in rail and the comparative quickness, autonomy, and convenience of the car made everybody switch, in just a few decades.

The development of the car also necessitated new demands. Ever more developments made it cheaper and better to get a car, meaning more and more demand for road building. Meaning more demand for things like car services and service stations and more petrol stations. The automobile led to mass road building all over the world. Most cities in the world have been redeveloped from merely 100 years ago to allow better access to road, rather than rail. To believe that Bitcoin and Blockchains won't redevelop industries around them is to not understand the nature of capitalism. Capital runs the world, and as more and more money goes into something many see as better, investment will follow. It will out compete current ways of doing things, just by being better.

The drive of the blockchain will remove and replace large parts of the current economy, and radically alter the financial landscape. Decentralised blockchains allow for you to genuinely be your own bank. It will allow more people to do more with their money. By lowering the barriers to genuine financial prosperity for all; cryptos offer a chance to reshape the worlds finances.

There will be whole new generations of de-fi investors, who mostly work from home and for themselves; who go out to Africa or Asia, London or Manchester for investments and investing. The world is so stratified that all manner of investments will boom as a larger variety of people have the same investment opportunities as the previously very well off.

Now this notion of decentralisation being better than centralisation is just a matter of opinion. But I think it is a trend that pops up in history quite a bit. The freedom of individual is the best way to make a community at large - richer. Decentralised decision-making systems work in areas of business or the military too. The best way to run an army is to have highly competent people on the ground reacting to things, rather than grand strategies coming from the top. Just ask the French military how their grand strategies competed against highly competent Prussian Generals on the ground; or ask yourself why the two places with the highest levels of individual rights, in Britain and America, have led all three of the industrial revolutions thus far.

Whether the Bitcoin blockchain is truly as decentralised as I've been proclaiming it to be, is something of a debate. One of the largest criticisms of the current the Bitcoin make-up is how its blockchain, through mining power and centralised holding, is something of a hybrid decentralised-centralised model. I would say there is enough centralisation in Bitcoin's development, mining and ownership, to give it the advantages of a more centralised blockchain, but with so many smaller miners and well-off individuals in the Bitcoin community, that it gains a large portion of the benefits of a decentralised system too.

So how will blockchains prove to be anything radically new? That computers can talk to each other was shown with the formation of internet. But the blockchain is something new in computer science. The relatively new field of computer science can perhaps be looked down upon as a bunch of nerds, who stay inside all day looking at computers. The same could have been said of somebody like Isaac Newton too, he just spent his time looking at mirrors and light instead.

Now, natural scientists are proclaimed as geniuses, despite the fact that the hard sciences have been poor areas of new scientific insights in recent years. Most of the worlds new scientific inventions have come from the computer sciences. This is where we notice it most in our lives. Computing has gotten quicker, cheaper and smaller; AI technologies are changing the world at a rapid pace, just look at the very powerful TikTok AI, which drives its addictiveness and makes it a place people want to spend time.

Computer science is the new field of human progress. Most of the last 20 years has been the story of the computer and the internet, as it becomes ever more enmeshed, slowly, into our lives. At the same time, we're told everything new is the 'next big thing'. The next big thing has seen everything pushed by corporations and nation states across the world in areas from AR/VR, Robotics, AI assistants, ecommerce, quantum computing, space, and renewables; yet none of these have really taken off. Sure, many have proved interesting and fascinating, but none are really profitable booming industries creating new wealth and prosperity for all.

They're all still in a discovery phase, as mass amounts of capital back these fashionable industries, that offer amazing developments, but never quite result in new industries taking off. Most of these industries still look 20 years away from being a profitable industry. Yet what if the true next development in computer science was something so simple and perfect, that one man or woman could come up with it at home like Newton making key scientific insights or James Watt tinkering with the Newcomen Engine, and modifying it enough to called it the Watt engine. Sometimes true revolutions do come from entire left-field and out of the blue. Something that completely changes and improves something that's already been done for thousands of years in similar ways.

By using the internet; blockchains allow computers all over the world to talk to each other even better than the internet offered. They can confirm each other's interactions and react to them if need be. The world has only just started to discover how blockchains can be used and how central they will become, but they will take out dozens of currently competitive industries and change many more.

Automation, we think of as robots making things, but what if automation is not just robotics, but automating ever more efficiently how computers can talk and network with each other. What if the blockchain allows automation of parts of entire sectors like accountancy, the law industry based on contracts, huge swathes of the financial system, voting, education, music, real estate, insurance, healthcare, supply chains, energy, government records, 3D printing, libraries, creative arts, transport, gambling, and construction; all from the simple invention of getting computers to talk to each other far better than they currently do. The blockchain is still a way of doing that, but I think it's an industry likely to produce a revolution in the future.

The internet itself, of course, is a peer-to-peer system, but so were many of the most radical applications based on the internet. File sharing on Napster caused a huge change to the music industry, the same with movie torrenting back in the day, pushing the industry towards a streaming model rather than the Cinema and DVD model of the late 2000s. Peer-to-peer transactions always result in cutting out the middle man. Middle men are expensive, adding a big premium onto their services.

This is no different to a digital currency. To stop ordinary people simply being able to copy and paste money into their account you have to stop digital replication, there are always middlemen. PayPal, banks, app interfaces, VISA, Mastercard; you've got to always use a middleman. I hope now you might start to see what having a trusty non-middleman middleman will do.

It will not only cut costs, but allow individuals to be able to access all different types of blockchain services. Most types of financing will be done through blockchains: loans, contracts, spending, saving, investment. Anything that exists in the real financial world will exist in blockchains. Houses could be listed on a blockchain, allowing far easier and more reliable housing ownership changes. The possibilities are endless.

Blockchains do this by being able to account for digital scarcity. This is something I think is unique to blockchains. In the 21st century we've hit this period where everything online is so abundant that it will cause a huge shock when people start to realise the nature of digital scarcity. Blockchains could account for, say, all the copies of a digital or physical art. Before this, the artist may have found it difficult to sell digital art, as it was so easy to copy. Now with blockchains, you can link files to the blockchain allowing an artist to, say, produce 500 pieces of digital art, and no more; you can actually truly own something digital.

The lack of digital scarcity from peer-to-peer transactions has caused huge repercussions in certain industries. Blockchains are merely a way of tracking digital transactions. Soon, everything will be on a blockchain as proof of ownership. Trainers will be yours, with your name not in the shoes, but on the blockchain.

The peer-to-peer system of blockchains is constructed by nodes in a computer system to talking to each other. All of these nodes perform the same task, no matter how powerful or how much computer processing power you've got. But having all these independent nodes can be quite difficult. How you get them to work together in the same direction is the key to the success of a blockchain.

Blockchains work by programming all these nodes to talk to each other in a certain ways to keep the system secure, and to keep everybody's trust in it. By being unable to be manipulated, it allows the blockchain to maintain its integrity in the real world - to real people.

This doesn't make a blockchain perfect. Messages between nodes can be lost; messages can arrive more than once; and messages may arrive in a different order than they were sent. But with nodes being so gossipy, and constantly passing on information, it means that if one node goes down many can carry on. Nodes can be identified and checked, therefore any duplications are easy to ignore.

There are limitations to blockchain technologies that may in future allow for new Blockchain innovations to do new and different things. Other than for obvious payments and value storage, blockchains could be used to provide digital assets, identity, notary services, compliance and auditing, tax, voting, and record management.

The implications for the blockchain are so huge that it will reorient society. If you'll allow a perusal into metaphysics; humans are not good at working out what is true and what is not. The truth is very illusive. Science too knows this, hence why it runs on theories, not facts. It's possible one day that Newton's Gravity or Darwin's Natural Selection could be superceded by a more accurate scientific theory. The trust we have in theories like gravity or natural selection are about as strong as humans can be on anything. A step below scientific fact. But when scientific fact can't be used, we have to place trust in other people. Humans place trust in great institutions to represent their interests. This trust ebbs and flows. Britain historically has placed great trust in Parliament, the Bank of England and in the independence of the Courts. The trust we place in these human institutions are getting less and less. The decline of politics as a noble profession has meant this trust has diminished ever more. Yet technology can give us the blockchain ledger, based on perhaps the one few immutable sources of fact and natural constants, mathematics. This will soon be seen, once Bitcoin has really grown, as one of the few sources of truth about who owns what. There will be no doubts as to its veracity. Trust in the ledger will surpass that of most things in life. To think about the real world application of the blockchain is to see a frightening change in the world. It will develop and create new and radical ways of doing things.

Chapter 9: Stablecoins

Chapter 10: Proof-of-Work

The impact of bitcoin's proof-of-work mechanism and its impact on humanity will be one of the more extraordinary events in the rise of the new monetary order. In short, value in work not a stake in society is revolutionary in life.

Humanity has been run on a proof-of-stake and proof-of-authority mechanism for millennia. What does this mean? Well everything is rooted through your stake in society, or your authority in society, not the relative value of your worth. It is farmers who produce the work, not the king, but society is rooted in the exact opposite balance of this.

It is not that farmers produce the only important thing in society, as it is merely supply and demand and most of the time there is more than enough food to go around in society, but usually only a few great artists, scientists, or soldiers in any one society at a time.

Money, which controls society, has been based on a proof-of-work mechanism. The work you put into society however, is often limited by the upper barrier of your encounters with stakeholders in society, not where the work is being truly produced – from a free-market perspective. This manifests itself in many ways, but class or caste structures are generally rooted in the incentive structure of society.

In practicality what does this mean for the ordinary person? Well Europe had the divine right of Kings for centuries in the medieval period – which is about as proof-of-authority as society gets. The monarch was a god-king whose stake in society was so large that nothing could be done without their say-so. Political power, artistic patronage and access to much of society was therefore connected to your relationship to the stakeholders in this society, all of which rooted around these god-kings of medieval Europe.

This relationship to political patronage and access to society based around it was not just limited to politics, but more crucially to money and commerce. As the divine right of Kings diminished around the turn of the Early Modern Period and modern banking and commerce took over, society became more and more reminiscent of a proof-of-stake society, not just authority. The stakeholders in this sense were the owners of the commercial system. Those who owned capital in the capitalist societies of the industrialized world, controlled everything. The most obvious example might be something like the East India Company: a private corporation with huge landholdings over much of Asia. It provided a proof-of-stake society in India in which one could work and work in India, and even gain a huge level of wealth and power. Yet power itself was limited by the stake you held in the true master of the realm, which was the East India Company, which was located in London . We could extend this metaphor to all capitalist societies in which the true stakeholders in society were those who owned the capital of the nation and therefore the stake in society - a fact Marx and Engels took huge effort in describing.

Indeed one of the results of this during the early-modern period were certain relative freedoms for non-natives in Europe, who could live outside this power structure. The Jewish community in Early Modern Europe operated largely without restrictions from stakeholders on their trading and commerce. The permittance of Usury for Jews only, resulted in this small pocket of society able to function freely with their issuance of debts and banking services. This manifested in an ability to charge interest on loans to European Kings and wealthy individuals, and even the Pope, which would not have been available to native Europeans.

Today many elements of modern society has proof-of-stake monetary function. The most obvious example I can think of this in the modern economy is the need for licenses in order to trade in specific areas. Some may think this can be a good idea; a license to practice medicine might be thought to be a good thing. But in a proof-of-work society you simply find the doctor with the reputation for being the best, and in curing his patients. Either locally or through word of mouth. You do not rely on a doctor with the best stake in the societal hierarchy for your treatment.

The situation becomes clearer the more you look into it. Licenses are required for example to open a pub or bar in Britain, it requires you to apply as a stakeholder and bear responsibility to the government for your actions, not the people you serve. It makes no sense, as alcohol is so easy to access. But this mechanism allows the government to control only who sells alcohol publicly and then cut them off if they do anything deemed transgressive. The rise of free parties were an inevitable consequence of government rules against drugs or good-taste.

Examples of needing a license to trade is legion in modern society, but I think this is being seen as part of the old economy in which the governments acts as a totalitarian omnipotent overlord to society. The simple fact bitcoin runs on a proof-of-work mechanism means there will be a change to the structural makeup of society, as money makes the world go round.

Such is the incentive structure of money to the way that society functions, and that money is such a binding facet of life, we really can never live without it. It dominates everything we do. Go out with friends and at some point the topic of who owes what to whom, and who is going to pay for drinks or whatever - will come up. How many families have fallen out, how many relationships broken down, because of money? Far, far too many. Therefore the incentive structure of money does change the make up of society.

Of course nobody has ever really thought of our monetary order as proof-of-stake before bitcoin. Yet introduced by Adam Back, the cryptographic function of proof-of-work will have far more profound impact on the way society functions and its incentives than many could ever have predicted, back when Back first proposed a solution for a way to limit spam email.

The invention of proof-of-work computing, and it's adoption by Satoshi will result in a shift in how society is made up at its core. It is as important as the hard supply limit of 21 million.

The earliest money, what you might call agricultural money like wheat, barley or beer, is to some extent proof-of-work money. You have to work the land to collect the harvest or brew the beer in order to make the money, but as society shifted and got larger and the best fields and land were taken up, there became a stake required in society, as you needed to own this land, and could then hire the labour to tend to the crops. Though agricultural money is partly a proof-of-work money, it has strong elements of showing your proof-of-stake in society.

After agricultural money, we get commodity money, silk, iron, copper, bronze, silver and gold. Again, this is largely a mix of proof-of-stake, with some proof-of-work. In some places in history during gold rushes for example, gold could be seen as a proof-of-work money. You could stand all day sieving through the reeds and streams looking for the tiniest spec of gold, but this is hardly the basis of a proof-of-work society. Wheat is partly to abundant to be good proof-of-work money, gold is to scarce to be proof-of-work money.

Money was even more transitory during the 20th century, when any element of proof-of-work money (gold) was abolished, and fiat money was dominant. Fiat is pure proof-of-stake money. It is reliant on how close you are to the production of money - namely central and commercial banks. Without any possibility of independent production of money, money becomes ever more centralized and dominated by those with the stake in society to produce money. This is the financialisation of the economy we talked about in the mini-audiobook to start the podcast. This changes the incentive structure of society as it begins to revolve around the focus of money.

This isn't difficult to understand. In times of political tyranny, life revolves around the tyrant. His likes and dislikes are reflected on society as a whole. The same for money. Central bankers, with control of the money supply, can artificially change the structure of society by changing how money is used in society. At the very basic level, this is down to inflation and interest rates, but it can devolve down into all forms of life.

The 1950s and 1960s were an artificially prosperous time in England, largely down to the fixed exchange rate between the USD and GBP, something of an American sop to thank Britain for fighting the Second World War and bankrupting itself in the process. Yet even with this, there was never any interest in allowing the country to redevelop its industry and allow for long-term planning. The state was happy allowing the country to develop something of a twilight era to its golden age.

Then in the 1970s as the post-war economic consensus was buckling under the rise of developing world and power shifted away from the West in several key ways. The Keynesian economic order was breaking with full employment and stagnant growth. What was the solution? It was the banks in the 1970s who pushed for women to start careers to increase the numbers of jobs in the economy and therefore their basis for GDP growth.

What started as a simply Keynesian trick, more employment, become a revolutionary change in society and it make up. The nuclear family all but died, the lack of homemakers and housewives changed the type of children they were bringing up has changed western society to a huge extent. The same can be said for the consumer debt boom in the late 1980s, which was again a ploy by central bankers to manipulate the economy and artificially increase the money supply and access to credit. The rise in consumer debt has had a catastrophic impact on the lives of many, as their lives are now tied to their ability to use and access debt, not money.

Anyway, the first real concept of proof-of-work money I can find was the Henry Ford and Thomas Edison proposal for an electric dollar based at the Muscle Shoals hydro dam. The proposal was featured on the episode of pre-bitcoin internet currencies. The plan was not internet based, but based purely on using electricity output to back the dollar, instead of gold. This is the first real concept of proof-of-work money.

The Ford plan was to tie the currency to work produced. As we talked about, the plan was loose and without a fixed concept of watts produced to dollars outputted. The plan was perhaps too far ahead of its time. As Ford noted, bankers hate change. Yet the concept remained. The linking of electricity

to money did not die, and all it required to improve it was the addition of computer hash functions to link money and electricity together.
Despite all of Ford prognostications about the futility of a gold based currency, the centrality of the state's money meant that no real experimentations could take place. Austrian economists knew that no state would be willing to forgo their own monopoly on the money supply. So it was left to the private sector having to find a way to innovate new types of currencies without the need for state permission.
The computer is of course one of humanity's greatest inventions. It allows binary digits to simulate almost anything, including, as bitcoin would prove, money itself. These computer simulations allowed for the use of electricity through CPU usage to produce hash-functions which can simulate pure proof-of-work. What Adam Back's hashcash represents is one of the most important pieces of computer science ever created.
So what is proof-of-work in computer science terms? Well it is a form of cryptographic proof that allows one party to prove to another than a certain amount of effort (in our case, CPU calculations) has been used in order to fulfil certain requisites. This proof can be verified by all other participants in the system. The point of all this? Well in Adam Back's conception it could be used to limit and prevent spam emails, as any spammer would need to provide a small proof-of-work calculation to send the email. This was not a real problem for ordinary people who wanted to send the odd email. A potentially huge problem for malicious actors who wanted to send millions of emails at a time.
The proof-of-work mechanism is often credited to Moni Naor and Cynthia Dwork to deter DDOS attacks and other abuses. It was not until 1999 when the term proof-of-work was coined by Markus Jakobsson and Ari Juel. The concept was worked on for a couple of years and it was in 2001 when hashcash was formally proposed by Adam Back, whose 2001 paper synthesized much of the work done previously, and added some of his own genius into the proposal. Back's conceptualization of proof-of-work and the tokenization element to validate this work made the system far more substantial, and opened up the potential of a tokenized internet, which would of course attract the attention of Satoshi Nakamoto.
We saw in the episode on pre-bitcoin internet currencies, there was a long process of development in the digital currency space amongst a group of hobbyists and professionals. The most important work was Adam Back's development of hashcash. We didn't really touch too much on hashcash, as it wasn't really a digital currency, and so I think it required its own episode.
Hashcash was originally invented to limit spam email and DDOS attacks using CPU proof-of-work. The system required one to use this PoW system to expend some CPU energy to stamp an email with a proof-of-work token so the system can be almost positive it did not come from a spammer. Most spammers are unlikely to have the huge amounts of CPU power required to send lots of spam emails to multiple people.
The system was seen as advantageous over micropayments that could have also been applied to sending emails. Sending a large amounts of emails from a legitimate source would have hampered trade and largely been seen as stopping the free flow of information that was vital in keeping the internet open, but the use of a small amount of CPU power would be a far simpler solution.
There were seen to be numerous small problems with hashcash. It could cause non-spam email to get stuck and of course it is still possible for spam to get through. The other problem seen was technological advancement. After a few years of the system, the cost of using a proof-of-work mechanism would be diminished radically, allowing more opportunity for spammers to get around the system. Therefore the system required the difficulty of the system to keep on increasing in line with Moore's Law to avoid this.
Other problems might be that lower income countries with inferior computing may not be able to keep up with these development in computing. The universality of the internet could be threatened if an amount of CPU power, increasing every 2 years, placed a wall around the internet.
From these early technical experiments and theoretical insights into cryptography, there came further developments. Computer scientist Hal Finney built on the idea with Reusable proof-of-work. This RPoW allowed for the value of the PoW tokens to be reused. The same token that was used to

receive an email could be reused to send the email. Using RPOW tokens for email was seen to have advantages. People could reuse tokens from incoming email in an outgoing email. This would mean spammers would have no advantages since almost all of their email is outgoing. Reuse allows the cost of the POW token to be much higher since most people won't have to generate them, making the system more effective as an anti-spam measure. Free email services could provide a small number of tokens for free, but if you needed anymore you could either pay for them, or generate them with your CPU.

In 2009 of course the bitcoin network went online. Satoshi referenced Back's work in his whitepaper. Bitcoin is of course a proof-of-work digital currency that, like Finney's RPoW, is based on the Hashcash PoW. Bitcoin mining is simply the proof-of-work hashing to provide evidence that the system is working. In reward for this hashing, once every 10 minutes the system rewards these hashers or miners, with a number of bitcoin. At the moment it is 6.25.

Yet there was one problem with using the rPoW mechanism. You didn't want anybody to spend any of them more than once. The double spend problem, with the famously unsolvable byzantine generals problem or how to communicate who spends what and by whom in a decentralized manner. enter the time-stamp server or blockchain, which provides a decentralized P2P protocol for tracking transfers of coins, rather than hardware trusted by the computing function used by RPoW.

Now, hopefully this episode has cleared up a lot about the background theory of proof-of-work and also its application, but I am going to read out the 'Proof-of-work' section from the bitcoin white paper.

4. Proof-of-Work

To implement a distributed timestamp server on a peer-to-peer basis, we will need to use a proof-of-work system similar to Adam Back's Hashcash [6], rather than newspaper or Usenet posts. The proof-of-work involves scanning for a value that when hashed, such as with SHA-256, the hash begins with a number of zero bits. The average work required is exponential in the number of zero bits required and can be verified by executing a single hash.

For our timestamp network, we implement the proof-of-work by incrementing a nonce in the block until a value is found that gives the block's hash the required zero bits. Once the CPU effort has been expended to make it satisfy the proof-of-work, the block cannot be changed without redoing the work. As later blocks are chained after it, the work to change the block would include redoing all the blocks after it.

The proof-of-work also solves the problem of determining representation in majority decision making. If the majority were based on one-IP-address-one-vote, it could be subverted by anyone able to allocate many IPs. Proof-of-work is essentially one-CPU-one-vote. The majority decision is represented by the longest chain, which has the greatest proof-of-work effort invested in it. If a majority of CPU power is controlled by honest nodes, the honest chain will grow the fastest and outpace any competing chains. To modify a past block, an attacker would have to redo the proof-of-work of the block and all blocks after it and then catch up with and surpass the work of the honest nodes. We will show later that the probability of a slower attacker catching up diminishes exponentially as subsequent blocks are added.

To compensate for increasing hardware speed and varying interest in running nodes over time, the proof-of-work difficulty is determined by a moving average targeting an average number of blocks per hour. If they're generated too fast, the difficulty increases.

The societal shift from Proof-of-Authority and Proof-of-Stake, to Proof-of-Work will be revolutionary. Monetary incentives are a global unconscious that impacts our very existence. It shapes humanity, society, and how it functions. Our current monetary order requires one to go through the various stakeholders and requires one to request permission in order to participate in many areas of life. This ranges from the small, like local government issuing licenses, to the macro for things like banking licenses. You may think this can be good. You should want a doctor with a medical license, should you not? But if an unregistered doctor offering drugs like MDMA for PTSD, psilocybin mushrooms for anxiety and LSD for depression gets better results than a doctor

offering the standard SSRI's, which don't work, and the former gets struck off – that is a proof-of-stake system, not proof-of-work.
The move to Proof-of-work changes all this. There are no barriers to entry to the bitcoin network. The only thing required to participate is CPU power and electricity.
This shift to proof-of-work is therefore an entirely new shift in the operations of mankind. It changes the very incentive structure of society. In a proof-of-work society, if you put the work in; you will get the results you deserve. Society will not be about who you know, but the result of the work you put in. How will this change society? Well modern society is not healthy. Post-Modernism is one of the most obvious results of this proof-of-stake society, as true talent becomes subverted by society, as reality itself is distorted by the bad incentive structures of money in society. The same nation for example, that can promote Constable and Turner can produce Damien Hirst and Tracey Emin is not because the latter produce great art or there is no great art being produced in Britain, but because modern art and how society incentives it production and promotion has for too long been of your stake in society.
The absolute victory of proof-of-work will mean the destruction of post-modernism. A proof-of-work society will no longer care about who you know, but what you can achieve by yourself. The results for this, on every element in society, especially those societies that are the most nepotistic, will see new golden ages; as those truly talented, who put the required work in like Malcolm Gladwell's 10,000 hours thesis suggests, will now see the result on an exponential level.
The process of hyperbitcoinisation will not only result in exponential new levels of wealth, but also a golden age for society as creatives get the rewards on an exponential level as their work is supported the changing incentive structures.

Chapter 11: The Sovereign Individual

'The heaviest penalty for declining to rule, is to be ruled be someone inferior to yourself,' Plato, The Republic - 375 BC.

Conclusion

People who invest money in digital currencies are still speculators; but there is increasing use of cryptos for their original purposes, in making pure and reliable online money and financial ecosystem. I would say in early 2021 we're at the point at which a genuine use of Bitcoin has been found amongst not just the hardcore but the population at large, by using Bitcoin as a store of permanent deflationary value.

It shouldn't surprise us that Bitcoin is the first internet currency to have found a genuine purpose, as it is the first workable internet currency. In time, more and more money will go into this sphere. I don't know to what extent it will grow, but I know it will grow. Why? Because there's too much of a community with long-term prospects fairly bleak outside Bitcoin. At a time when private wealth has already bought up much property and shares, and returns in the economy are minimal; many, mostly young, have found this hack of the economic system.

The young are feeling ever more priced out of living. Housing prices inflation, education inflation, healthcare inflation; all eats away at our government money holdings; while any kind of sustainable return on wealth looks out of reach, or inherently risky in a world on the edge of a new and uncertain future.

Wealth of the young is filtering up to people much older, who own much of the world. This is not just affecting teenagers, but those in their 20s, 30s, and increasingly 40s. This effects whole economic eco systems. Rather than spending money that might go into local economies or on investment, more and more of the young's money goes towards rent payments and base costs like food or education.

This has created a consumerist economy which increasingly looks for short term pleasures, not long-term returns. It results in a generation who are not incentivised to make sensible economic decisions. The whole economy becomes lopsided towards those who own, rather than rent. It promotes spending, as holding money doesn't produce returns.

An economic principle that goes back to the origins of farming; holding surplus resources for the winter months is one repeated all over history. Harvest festivals have been used in societies all over the world, Christian churches still celebrate the harvest, as supposedly the last food before winter kicks; to incentivise you to save and be mindful of the winter coming.

Just transpose that example to fiat currency. You're paid in something, say pound sterling for your labour, just as you might once have been paid in wheat and beer; and well, the beer is probably going to be drunk quite quickly unless you have good means of storage, but wheat; well… if you get paid enough, and more than you need, you can start storing it. Your surplus builds up and up. Your levels of stability and confidence in the future goes up. If there's a shortage, you can sell a bit for a good price. If another family has a death, say, and begin not being able to feed themselves they might come to you with your large surplus and you can use this to feed others; and of course, you'll want something in return. Normally that's their labour.

This is basic economics, but what many, especially the young, feel, is that this method is breaking down. There are no benefits in holding money. If you're lucky enough to earn a monetary surplus at all, you want to put that some place good.

For years, people have increasingly seen the declining use of fiat as money is not being saved, but tied up in company valuations, asset bubbles and unproductive consumer borrowing. This system seems to many a permanent nature of the modern economy, and one that suits the very rich to the detriment of everybody else. By way of almost an economic hack, there might be a way out. Invented largely by hackers, a community was created and expanded out of nothing. The result was less a currency, but more a theoretical perfect supply-demand store of value and medium of exchange. All it has to do is beat the competition. Rather looking like a 2D currency imposed directly from the top down, cryptos offer a peer-to-peer currency that geometrically appeals to the 3D hexagonal nature of cyberspace and the networking of the world.

This geometric visual-spatial representation of Bitcoin looks a lot similar to that of what the internet pioneers, and pioneers of social media, viewed their original platforms to be. True peer-to-peer exchange of information without the need for middlemen.

We are still a way off however. Not only does Bitcoin have to grow, but ideally the broader use of cryptos as mediums of exchange, the use of smart contracts, and decentralised-finance to start leading capital investment over more centralised planning, will need to increase rapidly, so until that happens, everything is still largely speculation.

But the future is always interesting, and the competition between monies in the 2020s will be a fascinating duel to see.

From the earliest days of slavery based on the need for excess surplus to be centralised to support political power, financial systems have entrenched the slavery in order for oligarchical elites in any societal make-up to keep as much of the excess resources and therefore power. Today this is managed through the control of the money supply.

It is interesting to contemplate the rise of Bitcoin, with the histories of monies of many kinds, from sea shells on the sea shore; to gold and silver from across the world, to paper and digital money; with their many benefits and flaws. Each so elaborately constructed in their own ways, each so different from one another, and dependent on each other and what went before, however they were all still produced with strong and complex laws. These laws; taken in the largest sense being supply and demand, value, and mediums of exchange, leading to economic specialisation, to the resultant technological progress, and finally back to the relation of technological progress to the supply and demand of monies, all leads to a struggle for competition and the extinction of less improved forms. Thus, from the wars of society, from famine and death, the most exalted object which we are capable of producing, namely the production of money to represent the relation between time and value, directly follows. There is a grandeur in society, with its several powers, having been originally breathed into a few forms or into one; and that, whilst society has gone on cycling, from so simple a beginning, endless forms most beautiful and most wonderful have been, and are being, revalued.

Appendix #3 - Machiavellianism in British Party Politics: A Framework of Intra-Party Election Dynamics by Dr. Alexander Thorne, PhD

Machiavellianism in British Party Politics: A Framework of Intra-Party Election Dynamics

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Masters Dissertation

By

Dr. Alexander Thorne, PhD

‘You say you'll change the constitution
Well, you know
We all want to change your head
You tell me it's the institution
Well, you know
You better free you mind instead
But if you go carrying pictures of chairman Mao
You ain't going to make it with anyone anyhow’

Revolution (1968)
Lennon/McCartney
The Beatles

‘All the stories have been told
Of kings and days of old,
But there's no England
now.
All the wars that were won and lost Somehow
don't seem to matter very much anymore.
All the lies we were told,
All the lies of the people running round,
They're castles have burned.
Now I see change,
But inside we're the same as we ever were.
…
Now another leader says
Break their hearts and break some heads.
Is there nothing we can say or do?
Blame the future on the past,
Always lost in blood and guts.

And when they're gone, it's me and you.’

Living on a Thin Line (1984)
Dave Davies
The Kinks

All the world’s a stage,
And all the men and women merely players;
Act II, Scene VII
As You Like It (c. 1599)
William Shakespeare

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Abstract:

Populism has been a largely misunderstood phenomena in Britain. While the rise of UKIP in the early 2010s was an important part of this populist growth, the victory of populist leadership candidates within the Labour and Conservative parties has been underexplored. The strong two-party system in Britain has resulted in populism rising in the existing party system rather than outside it. This dissertation argues that this 'British exceptionalism' needs to be reconsidered when analysing the uniqueness of British populism within both the populist and party literature. By comparing the rise of Jeremy Corbyn in the 2015 Labour Party leadership election and Boris Johnson in the 2019 Conservative Party election, a model of intra-party populism emerges. This dissertation makes three core arguments: populism is largely an intra-party phenomenon in Britain; populism focuses on both changing the party and the nation; and the opening up the leadership elections is the primary cause.

Keywords: intra-party populism, Conservative Party, Labour Party.

Introduction

The decade of austerity in the 2010s has had the most profound implications on the political makeup of Britain since at least the victory of Margaret Thatcher in 1979. The growth of populism and antipolitics has fuelled a distrust of politics and politicians in both the electorate and in the political parties. The most talked about result of this growth was the vote to leave the European Union in 2016, however it is in the growth of populism as an intra-party phenomenon that already begun by 2015 where perhaps the most significant changes in British politics can be found.

The victory of intra-party populists in Britain, with Jeremy Corbyn as Labour leader in 2015 and Boris Johnson Conservative Party in 2019, represents a profound shift in British political parties. This dissertation will carry out a comparison into the rise of populism as an intra-party phenomenon.

Populism is not well defined, however numerous commonalities exists: all populists try and define a style of politics that aims to usurp the dominance of 'mainstream' politics. Furthermore, there is a strong focus on leadership and the party leader; with populists aiming to highlight the purity and disenfranchisement of their 'people' either in moral, cultural or economic terms. Both Labour and Conservative Party's faced populist challenges to the dominance of the 'governing party elites' (MPs, high-level bureaucrats, prominent ex-MPs) that had existed in both parties, caused by the opening up of party leadership election.

In 2015 the Labour Party elected Jeremy Corbyn following a change to voter leadership selection methods from an electoral college of MPs, Unions, and members; to a OMOV (One Member One Vote) system, where only members chose the leader. In the Conservative Party, there were milder reforms but still substantial, allowing party members the final say on a choice of two candidates selected by the Parliamentary Party.

This dissertations core argument is that populism should be largely considered in this way, through the party system and structure. This intra-party phenomenon in Britain was first developed by Watts and Bale who said 'it is rare' (2018; 100) to study populism from an intra-party perspective.

This dissertation goes further, arguing that populism in Britain is a much misunderstood phenomenon and should primarily be looked at from this intra-party perspective.

This model of 'British exceptionalism' sets it apart from the study of broader populisms around the world, which seem populism as an inter-party phenomenon, resulting in analysis too often focused on the rise of already established populist parties. Using an intra-party model, this dissertation will explain how populist sentiment and different political styles were used in two instances of a party leadership election to gain a better understanding on populism as an intra-party phenomenon. In order to do this both the literature on parties and party leadership will be combined to better conceptualise an intra-party populist model.

While this 'intra-party' model is the core of this dissertation, there are four other key arguments this dissertation seeks to make to the study of British populism and the populist literature:

- Intra-party populism focuses on both changing the party as well as the nation;
- The structure of the Labour and Conservative parties have changed, making it easier for a populist upsurge within parties, something that may become a recurring theme in future elections;
- Populism in Britain is as much about political style as ideology;
- 'Who is a populist' is not a binary divide. The relationship between being popular and an employer of populist tactics is not as clear as the broader literature suggests.

Methods

This dissertation will take a discursive approach to the comparison, by tracing how and why the two main parties in Britain elected populist leaders for the first time in their histories at similar times. By discussing the election of Johnson and Corbyn, and the background of party reforms and the changing leadership election rules, the two case studies will highlight the need to further study populism in Britain using the conceptual framework of *Intra-Party Populism*. Areas like party leadership and the leadership selection, have not been combined to any degree in understanding the nature of intra-party populism. By using this approach, this dissertation aims to highlight the unique nature of British populism in relation to the populist literature at large.

There are several important pieces of literature this dissertation attempts to use as departure points. The first is Watts and Bale (2018) and their work on intra-party populism within the Labour Party. The second is Moffit's (2017) influential conception of populism as a political ideology and degradations of populisms. The third and fourth pieces of literature are Stark's (1996) analysis of party leadership and party selection, and Denham, Dorey and Roe Crines (2020) history of party leadership. This dissertation aims to supplement the literature by providing a coherent framework around which all four pieces of literature can rest.

The author would like also like to note that due to COVID-19 restrictions, no interviews were able to be carried out for this dissertation and there was only online access to the library, leading to a heavy reliance on journal articles.

Chapter 1: Populism

The populist literature is a highly fraught and contested arena, with debate ongoing as to define populism (Laclau, 1977; Taggart, 2000). Some argue the term populism should be removed as a term from political literature all together (Barr, 2009). However a proliferation of literature over the past 20 years pays testament to the rising levels of support for politics - demonstrating the importance the study of populism has to offer scholars in understanding political discontent.

Yet this broader inability to define populism may not however be as problematic as first imagined. Populists and populism is changing constantly, reflecting the changing world more rapidly than mainstream politics. In Britain this rising populist sentiment was challenged through Corbyn's aims to restore representative institutions to the populous (Molyneux and Osborne, 2017; Wellings and Vines, 2015) and Johnson's more traditional populist approach focusing on the European Union and the 'left behind', especially in Northern England (Flinders, 2020).

The recognition that populism as a taxonomical definition has been stretched however is not new, with Ionescu and Gellner asking in 1969 'is there one phenomenon corresponding to this one name' (Ionescu and Gellner: 1969, 1). Yet there are some starting points. Muddes's (2007; 23) often quoted definition serves as a marker in the literature, he labels populism as a 'thin-centred ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two homogenous and antagonistic groups, the "pure people," versus the "corrupt elite," which argues that politics should be an expression of the volonte generale (general will) of the people.' Mudde's definition has gained significant traction, however labelling populism an 'ideology' suggests they share basic ideas. Populists rarely share any firm ideology: it is less an ideology and more an approach to politics. In Britain, Corbyn's political style of 'populism wearing a cardigan' compares to Johnsonian 'clowning' (Flinders, 2020). In many populisms there is an ideology, however this ideology is ever changing, while populisms can have some similar and some different aims.

Mudde's theory of populism as an ideology has received much comment and argument with Moffitt (2017) being the first to highlight the need to see populism more as a political style, where leaders use meditated performance to navigate the corridors of power that include the political, along with an ability to stretch their message into everyday life. Yet Moffitt himself agrees that there are recognized populists who do not match this 'style' yet are still considered populist: Alberti Fujimori, Preston Manning, Pauline Hanson and Jeremy Corbyn (Moffitt, 2017; 62; Barr, 2009; Watts and Bale, 2018). Yet, Moffitt arguably underplays his own theory. Political style does not have to involve an overt use of oratory or rhetoric. Corbyn was not a great speaker or a 'strong man', but a strong image of how he saw himself, and his self-styled politics of a 'downtrodden comrade' was a prominent part of his appeal. Populist styling can be more subtle than Moffitt originally suggested.

One area Moffitt's conception of political style does not explain fully is how this relates to 'the people'. Populists emphasise 'the people' as one homogenous group with a similar discontent with the system. This populist focus on 'the people' is one of the few areas of populism where there is broad agreement (Canovan, 1984) - though 'the people' is perhaps more accurately rendered as 'my people' (Saward, 2010). Despite a central focus on 'the people' there is little understanding of how 'the people' work and how to understand them (Arditi, 2007; Canovan, 2005). This lack of understanding may be understandable, as Benedict Anderson's concept of an 'imagined community' gives a clue as to why a true understanding of 'the people' has not yet been forthcoming. Populists have to create a community and create a message of some grievance with the system.

Many politicians play up to this conceptual, if not actual, understanding of 'the people' and what they want, despite no such community being as homogenous as they imagine (van Zoonen, 2012). It is therefore a populists job to create this community through political styling, mediatization, charisma, and the exploitation of crises. Broadly speaking, populists aim to speak on behalf of the ‘people’ through the media (Simons, 2002) and place ‘the people’ at the centre of a system which populists claim, does not work for them.

Yet in terms of this dissertation, it is the focus on ‘the leader’ where populism begins to find its intraparty form. Populism rarely works as an inert force applying political pressure on the system, especially in a representative party system. The leader provides a conduit of populist anger, either by representing the populist sentiment or driving it.

There is a deep focus within the literature on ‘the leader’, with some believing more in the importance of the leader than others. Weyland (2001) argues that populist leaders are the key figures in the movement, while others believe they only have a more symbolic relevance (Laclau, 2005). Meanwhile some argue leaders are less important still and choose to focus on the manifesto of parties and their electoral literature (Pauwels, 2011). Yet this is a controversial position, most scholars believe in this ‘leader centric’ view of populism.

Yet this different conception of how the political leader operates, can be explained by different political systems and different political cultures. As Moffitt states ‘what is clear… is that the choice of whether one decides to focus on the leader, party, or movement…is heavily influenced by the case of region one is writing about’ (Moffitt, 2017; 54). Britain, defined by its strong political culture of parties and Parliamentary politics is unlikely to see a Marine Le Pen style rise. Even UKIP, Respect and the BNP saw it difficult to gain a foothold in Westminster due to the First-Past-the-Post (FPTP) political system.

Those with an interest in the study of populism need to better understand different political models and cultures when analysing the rise of populism. In Britain, the use of the party and Parliamentary system is not well understood to its relationship to populism, compared to the more open political system with proportional or presidential systems like Europe or South America. The question remains, how did Corbyn, an obscure backbencher become elevated by populist sentiment within the Labour Party. Similarly, how Johnson – a troublemaker and populist - won, when in previous decades may have been eased aside by the Parliamentary Party.

This is where Barr’s (2009) concept of political ‘mavericks’ will be instructive. Barr defines a maverick as a ‘politician who rises to prominence within an established, competitive party but then either abandons his affiliation to compete as an independent or in association with an outsider party, or radically reshapes his own party’ (ibid, 34). Both Johnson and Corbyn had long been inside politics and their parties (Corbyn a long time backbench MP; and Johnson MP and Mayor of London). However both held positions far enough away from the mainstream of the party to be considered different. Barr’s political maverick concept answers how both Johnson and Corbyn were able to be ‘insiders’ and yet develop an ‘outsider’ rhetoric as part of their political style. Barr argues that populist mavericks ‘credibly offer anti-establishment appeals and present themselves as agents of change’ (ibid, 44).). In Barr’s argument, populism is led by outsiders or mavericks to gain power using an anti-establishment rhetoric. Barr’s argument is limited to Latin American populism, where insiders cast themselves as outsiders and subsequently leave the original party to form their own party. Yet the concept does not need much adjusting to see how the ‘maverick’ status of outsider can be successful inside the party structure.

Therefore, this dissertations argument of intra-party populism is meant as an addition to the current literature in a field where Hackney (1971, xxii) states ‘scholarly reassessment of populism will never end.’ The broader study of populism in Britain often aims to replicate the European populist model with a focus on populist parties like UKIP and Respect (March, 2017; Steenbergen and Siczek, 2017). The introduction of a new way to investigate populism in Britain may help guide future literature. To do this, this dissertation will aim to understand the populism of Corbyn and Johnson in four primary ways.

Firstly, despite the constant invocation of ‘the people’, there has been little study of ‘the people’ (Arditi, 2007). There is a well understood concept of who the people are, but not how they operate (Moffitt, 2017). Studying parties in an intra-party manner allows a study of the membership, and how they too use populism and populist leaders in order to further their policy goals.

Secondly is the study of the relationship between political style and populism. Moffitt’s (2017) theory of political style is heavily reliant on focusing on the political style of populists, yet focusing on two leaders whose populism is as stylistic as it is ideological will provide more empirical evidence for this conception.

Thirdly is the nature of the ‘maverick’ in a strong party system, where ‘spinning off’ to form a new party is unlikely. Both Johnson and Corbyn were parliamentary insiders before casting themselves as outsiders. This dissertation will analyse how Corbyn and Johnson turned themselves from insiders into mavericks. There is a well-developed literature on populist leaders (see Moffitt, 2017; 51-69) yet little on this idea of the ‘maverick.’

Fourthly and most importantly is the nature of the British political system and populism. It has been observed that Britain’s relative absence of large scale populist parties in Britain has been down to the mainstream parties co-opting their populist politics (Mair, 2002; Mudde, 2004), while Britain’s FPTP electoral system has also been noted as a reason for Britain’s absence of populist parties (Mudde, 2007). Yet this co-oping of populist politics by leaders such as Thatcher and Tony Blair was mild. Britain has seen a surge of more concerted populism both inside and outside the mainstream in recent years. The rise of UKIP is well attested too (see Cutts, et al., 2019; Cutts, Ford and Goodwin, 2010; Steenbergen and Siczek, 2017) but by only focusing on inter-party models, it is of limited relevance to the UK. While UKIP’s success in European elections was significant, they have never returned more than one MP to Parliament. This narrow view of populism limits the understanding of Britain’s two main parties.

Chapter 2: Parties and leadership

The previous chapter discussed populism and how British populism should began to be conceived as different than Western Europe. This chapter will underline this difference by talking about the nature of the party and party leadership in Britain. It will highlight the role of party structure and the opening up how British parties in allowing intra-party democracy, which sowed the seeds of change that a populist maverick could exploit. It will also highlight the relationship of party members to the party leader, which has become intrinsic in modern political parties in Britain with the opening up of party leadership elections in the 1990s and 2000s.

The study of party politics and intra-party conflict is often centred around Michel's Iron Law of Oligarchy (Michels, 1915). The Iron Law argues that in organisations, oligarchy will always occur even when an organisation is run in a non-hierarchical manner. This theory has often been treated as almost axiomatic within the study of organisations (Diefenbach, 2018). Yet there are occasions Diefenbach argues, when the Iron Law can be subverted, such as when 'aggrandisers and organisational psychopaths, powerful leaders or power elites emerge' (ibid, 558).

Michel's Iron Law is currently expressed through the cartel party thesis (Katz and Mair, 1995), which argues that the political system is dominated by cartel like parties; and Panebianco's (1988) theory which argues that parties have become professionalised and less in need of amateurs, 'i.e. party members' (Seyd, 2020; 2). Yet this leadership dominated view of parties is at odds with how parties are now ran. The two main parties have seen the party elites power loosen over the past 50 years. The first hint of this in Britain was the slow concentration of power around the leader and away from this previously polycentric power model.

There is a growing academic consensus that the party leader is the most important party figure. From the relative unimportance in Britain (Stewart and Clarke, 1992; Stark, 1996) to more modern scholarship (Garzia, D., Ferreira da Silva, F. and De Angelis, A, 2019; McAllister, 2013), which suggests the leader has much more power. Early party leaders were often figureheads with their primary function being able to command the support of their parliamentary party. This began to shift as mass communication resulted in the growth of the leader (Cross and Blais, 2011), not solely as a leader of the MPs, but the leader of the whole party (Stark, 1996).

With the dominance of the leader, selection of leaders became an increasingly vital role in determining the parties future. In the post-war years the Labour leader was elected only through a vote of the Parliamentary Party; while the Conservative Party's parliamentary leader was selected through what Stark called a 'magic circle' of Conservative grandees (Stark, 1996). The disastrous consequence of Douglas-Home's selection in 1963 pushed the Conservative Party leadership selection towards the Parliamentary Party and away from the magic circle. Labour began to increasingly think of the parliamentary leader as the party leader too, with changes in 1980s to make the Parliamentary Leader the party leader (Stark, 1996; 40). However the increasing importance of the party leader did not coincide with increasing democracy. The members previous only incentive to join was to select the local party representative. As party leaders moved from a position of primus inter pares (first among equals) in the parliamentary parties, and towards a clear position of authority it resulted in less overall intra-party democracy. However, due to demands from members there was a general push for more membership inclusion (Seyd, 2020, 3; Stark, 1996; Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines, 2020).[2]

Conservative Party Leadership election process

Date	*Democratic status*	*Role of party 'elites'*	*Role of Parliamentary Party*	*Role of membership*
Pre-war - 1963	Closed	Large	Nil	Nil
1963	Closed	Large	Small	Nil
1965-1997	Closed	Moderate	Large	Minimal
1998present	Semi-open	Small	Large	Moderate

Table 1. Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020)

Labour Party Leadership election process

Date	*Democratic status*	*Role of party 'elites'*	*Role of Parliamentary Party*	*Role of membership*	*Role of Unions*

[2] There is an interesting relationship between the Conservative Party post-Thatcher, and Labour post-Blair. Both parties have increasingly had problems finding broadly ideologically acceptable leaders; leading to the question of whether this growth of internal democracy for members has in part, been driven by an inability for party elites to decide 'what is next.'

Pre-war -1981	Closed	Moderate	Large	Nil	Nil
1981-2012	Semi-open	Small	Large	Small	Moderate
2012present	Mostly open	Minimal	Moderate	Large	Nil

Table 2. Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020)

Leonard Stark's 1996 '*Choosing a Leader'* was an influential analysis of party leadership and has seen much comment and scrutiny, yet has largely been accepted by the media in analysing British party leadership. However, some of Stark's analysis would look out of date in today's climate. Stark's claim that party leadership rules do not 'make different leaders' (Stark, 1996; 131) seems to go at odds to recent empirical evidence in the British political parties. Furthermore, Stark goes onto claim that 'different electorates appear to apply the same criteria when assessing leadership candidates' as the parliamentary party (ibid. 131). Quinn (2016, 768) was the first to spot this recent change stating 'Corbyn would not have won categorically if the selection rules were a purely Parliamentary Party vote or the electoral congress system.'

Table 3. Strategic concerns involved in party leadership contests (Stark, 1996; 126)

Order	*Arena*	*Goal*	*Criterion*
1st	Internal	Unity	Acceptability
2nd	Electoral	Victory	Electability
3rd	Parliamentary	Policy	Competence

This shift in who elects the party leader would be less important if the members and party elites voting incentives and desires were similar, as Stark suggests. Yet the difference between members and elites was highlighted by May's (1973) law of curvilinear disparity. The theory argues parties are stratified with the elites and regular voters the least extreme, while the party activists or 'subleaders' inside the party are the politically more extreme. May's law has seen much debate in recent years with some seeing it as an out of date, arguing there is little significant difference between members' ideology and that of the elites, who can sometimes be more extreme than the membership (see Saglie and Heidar, 2004; Norris, 1995; Bale, 2018; Seyd and Whiteley, 2002).

However, May's law should perhaps be revaluated once again in light of Corbyn and Johnson. Inductively, Johnson and Corbyn were populist mavericks and therefore not the favoured candidates of the party elites. Suggesting it makes sense that May's Law of a more ideologically extreme membership would apply in 2015 and 2019 respectively. However, the deductive case for a reappraisal of May's Law is more persuasive. Katz (1990) argued many members found alternative routes for activism, making the more raucous members less likely to join parties, and nullifying May’s Rule. In terms of the Labour Party, these results were borne out by Whiteley et al. (2018) who found radicalism and the chance to have a direct say in the Labour Party resulted in a growth of membership in and after 2015. Only 20 years previously, Seyd and Whitley (2002) found no serious difference between members and party elites in the Labour Party in the 1990s. Yet the increasing amount of research into the Labour membership has seen both a growth in numbers and a radicalisation (Crines, Jeffrey, Heppell, 2018). Furthermore, the growth of party membership after the change of the rules, was because these members wanted a new style of politics and more radical economic policies that party elites did not. This all suggests that May’s Law is once again applicable and able to highlight what the opening up of the Labour Party would result in.

The Conservative Party is different, in that it’s largely stable membership became more ideological over time, coinciding with the Brexit referendum and the rise of Johnson. Yet the same arguments still apply to the Conservative Party as to the Labour Party (See Chapter 4).

In their original thesis for the cartel party, Katz and Mair’s (1995) laid out a series of possible challengers to the elite control of the party system. They argued the challengers would come from the ‘Ross Perot’ mould, or the ‘new middle class’ such as the Liberal Democrats (Katz and Mair, 1995; 24) and would challenge the oligarchy via new parties. What they did not account for was breaking of the oligarchy coming from within. Britain has a long history of stability with the main political parties being able to see off threats by adapting the existing party structure and co-opting policy positions, rather than accepting an outside challenger. Katz and Mair hypothesised how the elite dominated party could change; this dissertation is arguing that change has occurred due to intra-party populism. The following two chapters will look at the rise of both Johnson and Corbyn

Chapter 3: The Labour Party

The victory of Jeremy Corbyn in the 2015 Labour Leadership election has been called 'the most dramatic in parliamentary history' (Quinn, 2016; 759). That a long-term backbencher became the leader of one of the two main parties in Britain is often seen as a surprise; yet relayed against a backdrop of rising political discontent against austerity and a concurrent weakening of party elites within the Labour Party's intra-party democracy, it should be no surprise the 'anti-hero for an antipolitics age' (Parker and Pickard, 2015) became leader.

This chapter will argue the following:

- Corbyn's populism was eccentric even for British standards. He was part symbol of the 1970s Labour left, part promiser of political change and part populist.
- His victory was due to the change in leadership selection.
- Many saw Corbyn promising a new Labour Party as appealing. Much of his early campaign was focused on populism within the party. Once he began to lead in the polls his message changed towards the country at-large.
- Corbyn was able to elevate his small movement by winning the leadership contest highlights intra-party populism as both an internal party mechanism to enact change within the party; and then to change this message towards the country at-large.

Labour Party Background

In order to fully actualise Corbyn's rise, it is important to understand the Labour Party's relationship to its left-wing. The left of the Labour Party has long tried and failed to gain more of a say within the overall party (Seyd, 1987) both through extra-party groups involving many Labour MP's such as the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament, and intra-party groups such as the Trotskyist 'Militant' group whose entryism caused alarm during the 1970s (Steffen, 1987).
With this lack of historical impact, it should come as little surprise that this wing of the Labour Party had become to feel disenfranchised within the Labour Party. The success of Labour's most successful electoral period in the 1990s and 2000s, as Blarism dominated, meant the left were often treated as tokenistic. This battle between ideology and electability has long been part of the Labour Party internal struggles, going back to Ramsey McDonald in the 1920s. To further add to the left's troubles, was a clear lack of way forward for the socialist-wing following the end of the Soviet Union leaving the radical left across Europe a movement in search of an ideology (March and Mudde, 2005). A lack of clear ideology in the left, resulted in the European radical left largely settling on embracing a populist view of social and economic issues (Rooduijn and Akkerman, 2015).

This change in the left's ideology may have had little impact within the Labour Party if it wasn't for the opening up of the party to more internal democracy in the 2010s. As seen in Chapter 2, both the Conservative and Labour's parties began to open up its internal democracy in the 1990s, however this shift became more radical in the Labour Party than in the Conservative Party in 2012, following a controversy in the Falkirk West constituency.

In Falkirk West it emerged the Unite union had aimed to influence the selection of the 2015 Labour candidate. This led Labour leader Ed Miliband to abolish the Electoral College system of electing a Labour Leader - taking away the unions vote. Miliband initiated a OMOV (one member, one vote) system to reduce Union power; while also encouraging new members to join by reducing the membership fees to join (Quinn, 2016; Denham and Dorey; 2016). The reforms mandated any MP running for leadership needed 15% of the Parliamentary Labour Party's (PLP) signature to be nominated. Once passed the 15% threshold, the candidate would face a simple preferential vote from members and affiliated supporters to determine who would be leader. These reforms saw general support within the Labour Party, however little thought seems to have been given to the potential ramifications of opening up of the party.

The role of the Unions in the Labour Party is interesting to consider. The introduction of the electoral college in 1993 gave the unions a large amount of voting power. They had typically used this to limited effect until 2010 with the election of Miliband (Jobson and Wickham-Jones, 2011) yet the introduction of the OMOV system allowed any member of an affiliated trade union to register to vote in the leadership election for free. Yet despite fears of huge influence of the unions (Wintour, 2015), the democratisation of the Labour Party saw a reduction in their power (Wickham-Jones, 2015).

Corbyn's Ideology

Jeremey Corbyn's career as a backbencher was to a large extent tossed aside upon the start of the 2015 Leadership election. He had spent much of his time as a backbencher focusing on issues that were rarely mentioned throughout the campaign such as: nuclear disarmament, support for a United Ireland, and support for autocratic left-wing regimes abroad (Kellner, 2015c). The initial thrust of his campaign was about restoring the halcyon days of the Attlee government and the 'golden age' of Labour as a movement rather than political party (Watts and Bale, 2018). He promised these reforms by allowing more internal democracy to allow easier deselection and by relying on an 'anti-process and anti-institutional stance' (Watts and Bale 2018; 109). Corbyn's overall politics 'ideology' was based on the simplification of issues. There were no problems that could not be blamed on the neo-liberalism within the Labour Party, the Conservative Party, or global capitalism.

The unconventional nature of Corbyn's populism: his lack of emotive charisma, his intra-party focus, and nature as a political 'maverick'; has led Dean and Maiguashca (2017) to argue Corbyn should not be seen as a populist. His attempts to discuss social inequality and move against New Labour's neoliberalism were genuine attempts at changing the direction of the party, not a populist backlash. Secondly they argue Corbyn aimed to highlight a 'crisis of representation' rather than a sense of aggrievement that genuine populists often employ. Thirdly, they argue that Corbyn does not have the 'populist styling' of Wilders or Le Pen, and that the 'Corbynmania' surrounding him was a form of political fandom (reminiscent of the 'Milifandom' that surrounded Ed Miliband during the 2015 general election) rather than a cult like focus on 'the leader.' However Dean and

Maigashuca understate Corbyn’s charisma and personal styling. He does not use the vituperative rhetoric of more radical populists, yet his image of ‘anti-charisma’ matches his anti-politics (Rentoul, 2015). His strand of populism is further anglicized with his left-wing style of populism being imbued in a British socialist tradition George Orwell characterised as ‘sandals and pistachio coloured shirts…vegetarian, teetotaler and creeping Jesus’ (Orwell, 2018 [1937]; 201). Dean and Maigashuca oversimplify populism by only limiting it to the more radical populisms. Populisms form in each country varies depending on the political culture and structure (Worsley, 1969). The concept is not that Corbyn is akin to the more radical populisms of Europe or South America; but that he represents a unique British form of populism that has been shaped by the internal party structure, rather than a career competing to win elections.

Corbyn’s

‘political’ rule breaking and breaking of political norms is comparable to other populists. Corbyn’s career is characterised by a series of controversies that would defeat a more mainstream politician. Many supporters saw this of evidence of Corbyn’s ‘purity’ in supporting the hardest hit economically and his campaigns for social justice. Yet Corbyn’s ability to cast himself as a moralistic bellwether inside the Labour Party despite close relations and tacit support for Hamas, Hezbollah, and the IRA would have defeated a more mainstream candidate. Additionally, Corbyn’s focus on campaigning for social justice did not stop him working for Iranian Press TV, and finding himself in regular contact with Holocaust deniers and anti-Semites (Bloodworth, 2015). For many Corbyn supporters, this focus on Corbyn’s political activates and past dealings only added to their view that the ‘mainstream’ was out to ‘get’ Corbyn. This is supplemented by a broader relationship between populism and conspiracy. Watts and Bale (2018, 107) noted that ‘conspiracy theories and their use within left-populism also have a clear link with Trotskyist thinking, which tends to emphasise the conspiratorial nature of elite rule, and – on the extreme fringes anyway – even the antisemitism of which some in Corbyn’s Labour Party have recently been accused.’

Yet what Corbyn also represented was a level of popularity with voting ordinary members of the Labour Party that was unmatched by any other candidate. By arguing for a different Labour Party and country, the members liked that Corbyn was different and unique. Corbyn was able to use long standing tensions and the opening up of the party to catapult himself into power.

The Leadership Election process

The 2015 general election was largely a disaster and led to resignation of Ed Miliband. The subsequent leadership election saw a wide-array of candidates to follow Miliband. Andy Burnham and Yvette Cooper represented the social democratic wing; Liz Kendall the Blairite wing; and the leftwing Jeremy Corbyn. Corbyn had been a backbench MP since 1983 with no front bench experience and little support from his own party (Watts and Bale, 2018), and was 'generally despised within the Labour establishment' (Parker and Pickard, 2015).

Upon entering the race Corbyn's campaigning focused less on policy and more broadly about trying to reform the party by 'embracing the 'authentic' voice of Labour members,' (Watts and Bale, 2018; 103). The initial spur of Corbynism was self-consciously focusing on the Labour Party itself, and returning power 'to the members,' – a piece of rhetoric similar to 'the people'. Labour's recent electoral defeats, Corbyn argued, were because Labour needed to become more authentically leftwing and re-embrace Labour as a 'movement', rather than a political party (Corbyn, 2015a).

Corbyn's rally in Liverpool in July 2015, shows what the initial campaign was focused on. Corbyn talks about 'developing the movement' rather than a policy platform in being the key in how to win the next general election (Corbyn, 2015b). This was not a candidacy to prove his chances against the Conservative Party at the next general election; it was a candidacy of general disillusionment within the left of the Labour Party. Corbyn's aims were to change the Labour Party away from its long term position described as a 'party of modest social reform in a capitalist system' (Miliband, 1964; 376).

The election instantly began to develop a strong ‘Corbynista’ brand of politics. His use of terms like ‘comrade,’ and rhetoric of the Labour left from the 1970s was instructive as to how he wanted the membership to see his candidacy. Not as the way forward, but to glory days. The initial aim of the campaign was to improve the radical left movement’s position in, and not the overall electoral health of, the Labour Party.
Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020; 210) highlight Corbyn’s second campaign rally in Liverpool, a month later, as a crucial turning point. By this point the polls had shown Corbyn as favourite (Kellner, 2015a), and Corbyn’s main message had moved on. His attacks were still highlighting his anti-establishment in Labour, but now had broadened his attacks to include the Westminster elites. His campaign was not concerned with broadening his base by moderating his voice: it was a populist movement within the Labour Party. Far from backroom discussion and Parliamentary tussles, it had turned into an open primary contest within the Labour Party and the left was winning.

This primary feel of the contest was a further accentuated by Corbyn’s supporters ferocity on social media. Many of Corbyn’s supporters first political activism often centred around the Occupy Movement 2010-2011 (Dean and Maiguashca, 2017; 149-150), which added impetus to the campaign beyond the typical Labour Party leadership contest. Corbyn supporters spread internet memes, rigged social media polls and had high levels of engagement with Corbyn-related articles; which all led to a general sense of ‘momentum’ within the campaign (Denham, Dorey, and RoeCrines, 2020; 211).

The role of the ‘Momentum’, a decentralised political movement pushing Corbyn’s agenda, was perhaps overestimated. From May, 2015, just after the general election 94,000 new members and 115,000 affiliated supporters joined and allowed to vote (Seyd, 2020). However, even counting only Labour members before the May election, Corbyn still gained 54% of the vote (Kellner, 2015b).
Corbyn was still the victorious candidate in the pre-Momentum party.

Corbyn’s Intra-Party Populism

That populism in Britain had not manifested itself in a similar form as in Europe and Latin America, has been due to the strong two-party system and party elites control of the leadership process. For much of the Labour Party’s recent history, the main competition for political control came from the Conservative Party so there was a reliance on Stark’s (1996) maxims on acceptability, competence and electability in how a prospective leader should be elected (see chapter 2), as power was the ultimate aim for the parliamentary party. The change to a grassroots elected leader resulted in a different desire for the members: they chose on ideological grounds (Kellner, 2015a). Corbyn used nascent populist feelings on the left and dedicated himself to empowering the membership. Yet in policy terms Corbynism was not as radical as some make out. The move leftwards had begun under Miliband (Blackburn, 2015). What marked Corbyn’s victory as unique was the way he went about doing so, and his attempts to change the party to a movement via the support of his ‘heartland’ (Watts and Bale, 2018).

The Corbyn victory represents two distinct elements of populism as an intra-party phenomenon: it was a victory of populism about the Labour Party. Originally a tokenistic candidate, Corbyn’s aim was to rouse a dormant and disenfranchised Labour grouping of left-wingers so Corbyn could implement a new style of politics. This was the view that members should control the Labour Party and that the

Parliamentary Party was obedient to the members wishes. Corbyn's aim was the undermining of the Burkean notion of the representational MP, in favour of a party of delegates selected by the Labour membership. This party populism instantly catapulted him to the polling lead, which allowed him to turn his voice towards the country at large, which started much of the Momentum campaign. Corbyn's attacks against a neo-liberal Labour Party, needing to become less a party and more a movement to protect the poor against globalisation and capitalism, was a radical departure from the political norm.

To conclude, the Corbyn case study pushes the case for seeing British populism in an intra-party perspective. Corbyn throughout his long career, was never able nor likely to spin-off and create or join a different party – the intra-party approach was the only one. The broad ideological melting pots that British mainstream parties represent are their strength in maintaining a two-party system, yet was also how Corbyn became leader of the opposition. These jostling fractions inside the Labour Party would previously have had to settle on a candidate who was ideological acceptable for all; yet the change in leadership selection meant the members could choose who they wanted: and they wanted Corbyn.

Chapter 4: The Conservative Party

There can be no doubt that the 2019 Conservative Party leadership election represented 'the future' for the Conservative Party after the 2016 referendum to leave the European Union. The calling of the Brexit referendum was interwoven with the rise of populism in the Conservative Party. Yet the difference between Corbyn and Johnson was that Johnson was not only to be elected leader, but also Prime Minister. One might have expected that this would mollify the Conservative Party members, yet evidence suggests that due to the failures of the Labour Party under Corbyn, the members were more blasé about the threat from Labour, and more concerned about the Brexit Party and the Conservative Party's inability to get Brexit done.

Chapter 4 will argue the following:

- The Conservative Party has seen a dramatic change in its party structure similar to the Labour Party, allowing Johnson the opportunity to win the 2019 leadership election
- Johnson was a typical populist in his ability to leverage a 'crisis' in the shape of Brexit to push his own agenda
- Johnson's populism is difficult to define, due to his lack of firm ideology.
- Johnson was popular before his strong turn towards populism (The relationship between popularity and being a populist is not well understood).

Conservative Party Background

This rise of populism in modern times in the Conservative Party can be traced back to the success of UKIP at the 2014 European elections (Lazaridi and Tsagkroni, 2016; Bale, 2018). The threat of UKIP however was overblown. Going into the 2015 General Election, the EU was ranked as only the 11th most important voting factor (Hay, 2020).

There had long been a populist streak in the Conservatives party, especially with regard to Europe and immigration (Bale, 2013); however this was kept to the fringes with the Conservative Party historically less ideological than the Labour Party (Seyd, 1987; 3). The Conservative party had historically always been able to manage the party by moving to the backbenches any senior MP who was seen as too radical, such as Churchill in the 1930s over India and Appeasement (Roberts, 2019; 348-350) and Enoch Powell over multiculturalism (see Denham, Dorey, Roe-Crines, 2020; 44-47).

Yet this challenge from the right in the form of UKIP resulted in a pledge by David Cameron before the 2015 election to hold a referendum, should they win a majority (Schnapper, 2015). The vote to leave the European Union was populist from the beginning with 'taking back control' from Brussels, and a sop to the nostalgia of 1950s Britain being the emotive issues that propelled the campaign
(Hay, 2020). Following the referendum, Brexit became the all-consuming issue in the Conservative Party. Yet even with the subsequent vote to leave and the May government's best attempts to leave, Theresa May was never enough of a populist to push through what in effect a populist project. Her

inability to define what a 'May Brexit' would look like, made May a dead women walking for much of her time at Number 10 (Gamble, 2018).

May's floundering led to a clear surge in 2019 of right-wing populism that the Conservative Party struggled to gain. At the 2019 European elections, the Conservative Party finished 5th nationally behind both Nigel Farage's Brexit Party. For the first time, the Conservative Party saw its primary challenge not from centre, but from the right (Cutts et al., 2019). The day after the European and local elections, Theresa May signalled her intent to resign as leader.

The Leadership Election

Following May's resignation, the subsequent leadership election was far less dramatic than in the Labour Party, with Boris Johnson always favourite. A shortlist of candidates would be whittled down to two by the Parliamentary Party, with the two remaining candidates facing the membership. There was some speculation Johnson tried to manipulate the final vote tally to ensure Jeremy Hunt rather than Michael Gove faced him in the membership vote, as Gove was seen as the better debater (Denham, Dorey, P and Roe-Crines, 2020; Elliott, F., Wright, O. and Zeffman, 2019). This, however, was still a long way off the backroom dealings that occurred when the 'magic circle' selected the leader.

The fact that Johnson was the most popular candidate with the membership may not have meant a great deal pre-1998 reforms. The parliamentary party by itself would have chosen a candidate that adhered to Stark's (1996) criteria for acceptance, electability and competence; and most likely passed over Johnson. However with the membership having the final say, this changed the incentives of MPs to select a candidate more likely to win membership support.

The membership vote, decided by the 160,000 Conservative Party members, was far more ideological than previous cohorts. The primary aim for the membership was getting Brexit done, with the electoral challenge of the Brexit Party and Jeremy Corbyn only secondary concerns (Smith, 2019). Johnson was chosen as he best represented what the membership wanted, and in their opinion, what the country wanted too.

It is here where Johnson's ability to convince the membership to vote for somebody who was not the best electoral candidate nor the most acceptable to broad swathes of the Conservative Party. It was Johnson's personal appeal and charisma that allowed him to bat away any hard questions about his competence.

Johnson repeatedly promised that if selected, he would leave the EU on 31st October 2019 without a withdrawal deal if necessary. In other words, Johnson's claim that he was the only one who could 'leave on the 31st October' if selected (Proctor, 2019) was his campaign surmised in a sentence. It was a calculated gamble from Johnson, informed by his previous political experience of how different rules applied to him. His campaign could be focused on a single issue: Brexit. Previous leadership races, even when going before the membership, had been a battle over Stark's criteria, for the winner.

Using Stark's criteria for selecting a leader, Jeremy Hunt would have been the more sensible choice for leader. Hunt was more acceptable to more of the Parliamentary Party with a more moderate ideology. Hunt had also been a long standing cabinet minister and while not universally liked, compared favourably to Johnson's poor showing in his time as foreign minister. Hunt's more centrist position also meant the electorate at large preferred him to Johnson (Walker, 2019).

Johnson's Populism

Since re-entering Parliament in 2015, Boris Johnson' politics had taken a decisively more populist bent. Johnson's political style has been constantly evolving since his days as a prominent backbencher where his constant media presence belied any real political achievements. However the Brexit referendum hardened Johnson's political image, as his message moved further to the political right compared to his time as Mayor of London (2008-2016).

Due to higher aspirations, Johnson's time as Mayor did not see the same level of populist styling as the post-referendum Johnson (Worthy, et al., 2018). However the nature of the Mayor's office lends itself to Johnson style of 'overly candid political maverick' (Edwards and Isaby, 2008; 44), something Johnson shared with his predecessor Ken Livingston. The competition from political arenas other than Parliament is perhaps and underexplored region of British politics, yet Johnson was able to use the position to good effect and establish himself as a 'celebrity politician' (Wood, Corbett and Flinders, 2016).

It was this image of 'being Boris Johnson' that appealed to the membership during the leadership election process (Castle, 2019), not his ideology. Boris Johnson's charisma Flinders (2020) labelled as 'populist playfulness' appealed to many in both the Conservatives grassroots and the general electorate. Like with Corbyn, there was a growing demand for politicians to be a 'normal person' (Wood, Corbett and Flinders, 2016).

Part of the difficulty in the analysis of Johnson's populism is in trying to ascertain some overall ideology. Some have tried to define Johnson's ideology as broadly as 'Merry England conservatism' (Gimson 2016; 299), others like Purnell (2012) have argued his political beliefs lack any real substance. Since the Brexit referendum Johnson's rhetoric has moved further to the right, however Purnell is perhaps the most accurate. The best way to describe Johnson's political ideology is by seeing it as broadly free of ideology. Johnson's career is described largely not by a political ideology, but by trying to be popular.

Johnson's populism is as much directed to boost his own popularity, rather than in service of any broader political ideology. Small policy details are not as important as appearing to be popular with the people. During and following the Brexit referendum Johnson's move to a right-wing populist was more identifiable not in speeches, but in his newspaper columns. A journalist before entering politics, Johnson's *Daily Telegraph* column highlights the lack of overall ideology and over simplification of many issues. Johnson's columns are more interested in whipping up issues to elicit an emotive reaction. As Canovan (1984; 313) argues, populist actors use a 'rhetorical style which relies heavily upon appeals to the people.' Johnson's columns emphasise the 'common sense' of his readers and relied on issues like the Northern Ireland-Republic of Ireland border, post Brexit, comparing it to the logistics of NASA's moon landing (Johnson, 2019a), or calling for stronger law to stop drug dealers 'going on spa breaks' (Johnson, 2019b).

Furthermore, Johnson's use of terms like 'bumboys' to describe Peter Mandelson or 'piccaninnies' to describe Africans is both jarring and odd. A long-serving politician like Johnson would know the likelihood of this type of language being brought up. Yet Johnson has consistently refused to apologise for this type of language (Sky News, 2018). In addition it was using this politics of emotion that enabled Johnson to emphasise a sense of 'betrayal' regarding the Brexit debacle. This language chimed with a membership whose main political desire was for a quick Brexit (Smith, 2019). During the leadership campaign, Johnson leveraged the 'need' for Brexit to his leadership campaign by using this type of emotive language. With this language and 'buffoonery and pantomime antics' (Flinders, 2020), Johnson was able to mask a deeper political strategy other politicians struggled to compete with.

Johnson's success as a populist can be summed up into three main elements: his ability to dominate the narrative through soundbites and slogans that tapped into long-standing politician dissatisfaction; his strange mix of classically informed rhetoric and 'pantomime antics' (Flinders, 2020) that made him a unique figure in British politics; and his status as one of the few genuinely household names in politics.

Intra-Party Populism

Despite Johnson's general popularity within the membership, if the leadership selection was only chosen by the Parliamentary Party then Johnson would not have been selected. As Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines (2020) show, the favourite for the Conservative Party election has often been defeated due to back room discussions, as issues like acceptability to the Parliamentary Party were brought up. William Whitelaw in 1975, Michael Heseltine in 1990, Kenneth Clarke in 1997 all failed to win the nomination despite being an early favourite. When Kenneth Clarke was again passed over in 2001 by the membership in favour of Iain Duncan Smith, it marked a change.

When Smith was elected in 2001, he was chosen by the membership for 'acceptability on ideological or policy grounds' (Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines, 2020; 94). The ideological vote was the key factor influencing Conservatives outside Parliament. We can see this with Johnson too. The clear support of the membership for Johnson changed the Conservative Party, into needing to present a candidate in ideological agreement. For the Parliamentary Party, the backing of Johnson during the campaign was a safe bet in supporting the winning side - especially for ambitious younger MPs.

The success of Johnson's populism should not be underestimated. While there was a clear upsurge in populist feeling, the level of support for Johnson's populism within the party was highly motivated by his populist turn since leaving the Mayoralty in 2016. Less remembered by his supporters was his poor spell as foreign minister from 2016-2018, which by other politicians standards would have seen a permanent move to the backbenches.

The similarities between the Conservative and Labour Party leadership contests show how populism operates within the party system but also how it can have a radical impact on the Party. In Corbyn's case, his populism was aimed at both the Labour Party and the more general political structures. Johnson's populism during the campaign took aims at the party too, with his attacks on inability of the party to 'get Brexit done' (Proctor, 2019).

Johnson's victory represents in some respects a similar victory to that of Corbyn, however Johnson's victory was no upset. He was favourite, but the clear rightward turn of the Conservative Party grassroots played a large part of that popularity. In some respects, it is surprising it took as long as 22 years for the first populist Conservative Party leader with the party always having populist elements, yet the members were content with a leader who fulfilled the Stark criteria until 2019.

Johnson's populism is a mix of some proto-typical populist characteristics: his overemphasis of crises, his use of language, his reference to 'the people', and his use of emotive language in his newspaper columns has pushed Johnson into populist territory. The main issue Johnson raises is how to address his clear popularity, and how it relates to populism. Johnson had long been popular before his more populist turn. This taxonomical limits of the 'populist' label is unclear when distinguishing between 'what is a populist' and 'how politicians become popular'.

Conclusion: The Future of Populism In Britain

This dissertation had argued for an intra-party model when it comes to studying populism in Britain. The difference in Britain, is the party structure and political system in comparison to many European and Latin American countries. This intra-party populism has resulted in two key findings about the nature of intra-party populism: it is both an attempt to change the party; and then the country. The growth of populism within parties over the last decade has been profound and little understood. The election of Jeremy Corbyn in 2015 was seen as remarkable at the time, yet there was little attempt at understanding the broader historical significance of the victory. The same can be said of Johnson.

This growth in populism over recent years is never linear. Populism always comes in waves at times of high emotion and political discontent. The most recent Labour Leadership election in 2020 was won by moderate Keir Starmer. To some this may undermine this notion of intra-party populism, as Starmer won the leadership election as a moderate centre-left candidate using the same selection rules as Corbyn. Yet this would be misunderstanding of the intra-populism theory. It is not that parties will face a constant battle with populist insurgencies, or that the parties will be

turned broadly into populist parties, it is that the opening up of party democracy has reoriented the parties more towards the grassroots, which under the right circumstance could lead to populist insurgency.
If a new populist wave hits Labour, this intra-party populism may once again rise.

The nature of the intra-party populist is different to the inter-party populist. Intra-party populism has a focus on the parties themselves; arguing the party is off-track and needs to recalibrate. Both Johnson and Corbyn were highly focused on their respective parties and how they had gone off track. What in effect the intra-party populism in Britain represented, was a change in political style and how to approach to politics.

Johnson and Corbyn's political style was to use rhetoric uncommon in mainstream politics. Johnson was less concerned with upsetting previous Conservative Party positions, and making his opposition to the May leadership clear. Furthermore, Johnson emphasized the need for Brexit and a refusal to apologise or modify his brand of politics (Mason, 2019; BBC News, 2019). Corbyn meanwhile emphasised a clear break with the current party by embracing the language and styling of a 1970s style British socialist. Much of his rhetoric and approach to the campaign was based upon this conception of a Labour Party gone wrong, Corbyn's approach was simply aimed to highlight this.

The process of intra-party democracy has been a mini-democratic revolution in itself. The growth of democracy in parties has meant that parties have had to respond. The nature of political parties, as Michels (1915) highlights, means that oligarchies in social organisations will always rise, but the growth in democracy in parties means they can be broken up far easier. The growth of Corbyn as Labour leader and subsequent entrenchment, followed by Starmer's ability to break the populist left stranglehold over the party shows how easy it is for fast and radical change in parties. The Conservative Party's internal democracy is less open than Labour's, yet it has still shifted the party. In 2001, Iain Duncan Smith was preferred by the membership over Ken Clarke, yet it was the election of Johnson that was the first big shift of the Conservative Party's leadership reforms, allowing the members to choose the new way forward.

What does this conception of British populism represent for the future of democracy? The first is the growth of intra-party democracy. The expansion of democratic pluralism within the parties is a radical shift in the British political model. The general franchise had long been extended to all, yet parties remained somewhat closed off from the public. Seyd (2019) has argued that the opening up of parties is not a positive step due to the damage for the representational aspect of Parliamentary democracy. Yet democracy is about trusting the demos to make the best decisions. If party democracy is to succeed in Britain, it needs safety in numbers by an increase in party membership to stop insurgency. Low levels of party members contrasts with their increasing power, and moving large amounts of political power towards a self-selecting few in the grassroots. This is not a positive move for an open democracy. Furthermore, the low level of membership and the potential for social media groups or older political movements to enter into the party to extract gains will remain with current membership numbers in the low 100,000s.

However, British populism tends to be more moderate than elsewhere because of the nature of needing to be a 'political maverick', due to the political system. Something that is not a feature of European populism. In Britain, the rise of this intra-party populism is not a rejection of politics as it is elsewhere, but a symptom of discontent with status quo politics. Change is inevitable in democracies, that should be taken as a norm; yet what both Corbyn and Johnson tapped into was tiredness of the status quo and a desire to see ‘real people’ in Parliament.

Populism can be dangerous. It can unleash rhetoric and changes to political systems that have a profound damage. But intra-party populism does not work against the system like in most populisms; it disrupts the system but works with the system to enact change. There is a clear moderation that intra-party populism initiates. To be clear all populism is dangerous, playing with populism is the political equivalent of playing with fire (Flinders, 2017; 233). Yet in Britain, this dissertation has highlighted what might ironically be called ‘mainstream populism’, and how it can have great change on a political culture through an intra-party mechanism.

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Appendix #4 - Shadows of the Ashcombe Family

To those who have been silenced, censored, and persecuted by the state. To the dreamers, the rebels, the ones who refused to ask for permission. To the individuals who dared to break free from the chains of authority, who saw through the illusion of control, and who sought to reclaim their sovereignty. This story is for you — the ones who live on the edge of the system, who fight not for glory, but for freedom. You are not alone.

Part One:

Chapter 1:

On the eve of war, as Europe stood poised to burn, the Ashcombe name still carried the weight to tip the scales of history. In late July 1914, the air in England hung thick with summer heat and uneasy whispers. Across the Channel, diplomacy faltered under the weight of telegrams that spoke in terse, clipped language, each a promise of blood should the pen falter. Lord Reginald Ashcombe of Bamford sat at his desk, a sheaf of reports before him, their contents as grave as the faces of the men who brought them. In Vienna, ultimatums turned to declarations; in Berlin, troop movements began under the guise of precaution.

The grandfather clock in the corner of the study chimed five, its measured tone underscoring the oppressive heat of the late summer afternoon. Lord Reginald Ashcombe, resplendent even in his informal attire, stood by the open French doors, letting the faintest breeze stir the air. Behind him, Edward Stapleton adjusted his spectacles and smoothed the creases of his notebook before speaking.

“My lord, I fear there is no gentler way to say it: should this war come, it will be nothing short of catastrophic for the economy. Not just for the nation, but for families like yours—tied as we are to the gold standard.”

Reginald turned sharply. “War is always ruinous, Stapleton. But Britain has weathered such storms before. Surely we are not so fragile as you suggest.”

Stapleton hesitated, his expression dour. “Fragile, no. But dependent—yes. The Bank of England’s reserves are already stretched thin. If the government funds this conflict, the issuance of bonds and the strain on our gold reserves could unravel the financial integrity of the Empire. The Ashcombe fortunes, tied to those reserves, would be among the first casualties.”

Reginald moved to the desk, where a decanter of port glimmered in the low evening light. He poured himself a measure, his hand steady despite the weight of Stapleton's words. "And your advice?"

Stapleton leaned forward, his voice low but firm. "Withdraw the family's holdings from the Bank of England at once. Convert them to private reserves—gold bullion and tangible assets abroad. Whatever is necessary to preserve the wealth against the coming storm."

For a moment, the room was silent but for the faint rustle of leaves outside. Reginald swirled the port in his glass, his expression unreadable. "You paint a grim picture, Stapleton. Yet gold in a vault is no shield against the fire this war might unleash. If Britain succumbs to folly, even our fortune will not save us."

Stapleton straightened, sensing the shift in tone. "Then you mean to act, my lord?"

Reginald drained his glass and set it down with deliberate precision. "I must go to London. If this war begins in earnest, it will bankrupt not just the Empire, but the very ideals we have fought to preserve for generations. I will speak with Grey, with Asquith, even Lloyd George if I must. There is still time to stem this madness before it consumes us all."

Stapleton allowed himself a faint nod, though his brow remained furrowed. "The Foreign Office and the Treasury will not be easy to sway, my lord. The drums of war grow louder by the hour."

"And that is precisely for that reason I must act," Reginald said, his voice rising with conviction. "The Ashcombe name has stood for reason and stewardship for centuries. If those in Whitehall cannot see the abyss before them, then it falls to us to make them see."

The study door opened, and Charles Ashcombe entered with the quick, purposeful stride of youth. Barely thirty, he carried himself with the easy confidence of an heir accustomed to responsibility. Behind him, Eleanor Ashcombe swept in, her presence no less commanding, though softened by the gauzy folds of her summer gown. She had always been the sharpest mind in the family, a patron of the arts and a fierce defender of tradition.

"You've summoned us, Father?" Charles asked, his voice steady but curious.

Reginald gestured to the chairs by the desk. "Sit. There is much to discuss, and not a moment to waste."

As they settled, a footman entered, bearing a silver tray with a single letter. "This just arrived, my lord. From Vienna."

Reginald took the envelope, instantly recognizing the precise hand of Professor Mises, whose correspondence had grown ever more urgent in recent weeks. He broke the seal and scanned the letter, his expression darkening as he read.

Eleanor leaned forward. "Who is it from?"

"Mises," Reginald said, his tone clipped. "He writes with grave warnings about the economic consequences of this war. Listen to this: 'War is the destroyer of wealth, both material and moral. It waters down fortunes, distorts markets, and paves the way for tyranny. Should Britain involve itself in this madness, your family's holdings—and indeed the wealth of every Englishman—will be diluted by the tide of inflation and debt.'"[iii]

Charles frowned. “But surely Britain can weather such a storm, as we always have? The Empire is vast; its resources are unmatched.”

Reginald placed the letter on the desk with a decisive thud. “The Empire’s resources mean nothing if the foundations of our economy are undermined. Gold, Charles. It is the cornerstone of our prosperity. If the Bank of England is forced to abandon it, everything we have built will be at risk.”

Eleanor, who had been silent, spoke now with uncharacteristic sharpness. “And yet, we are one family. What can we hope to achieve against the tide of nations clamouring for war?”

Reginald’s eyes blazed. “We can use our influence to stop this madness before it begins. I am leaving for London tomorrow. I will speak with Grey, Asquith, and Lloyd George. They must understand that Britain’s involvement in this war will not be a victory—it will be a ruin.”

Charles sat forward. “And what of our preparations here? If the worst comes to pass, we cannot simply wait to be overtaken by events.”

Reginald nodded, appreciating his son’s pragmatism. “You will oversee the withdrawal of our holdings from the Bank of England. Stapleton will assist you. Gold must be moved to private vaults, safe from the grasp of an overstretched government.”

“And the estate?” Eleanor asked, her voice softer now.

“Secure it,” Reginald replied. “Ensure the tenants are prepared for the disruptions that may come. War affects every rung of society, and we must do our part to shield those under our care.”

Eleanor rose, her face set with resolve. “If you intend to confront Whitehall, then so must we confront the realities here. I will see to the tenants, and Charles will manage the finances. But Reginald—” she paused, her voice tinged with something close to affection—“be careful. Politicians have never been known for their clarity of vision.”

Reginald smiled faintly. “And that, Eleanor, is why I must remind them of the stakes.”

The train to London rumbled steadily beneath the heavy skies of an unseasonably cold summer. As the Ashcombe carriage swayed with the motion, Reginald stared out of the window, his thoughts clouded by the gravity of the days ahead. The faint hum of the engine seemed distant in the midst of the turmoil his mind battled to contain.

Beside him, Charles sat with an air of quiet resolve. He had been the steady hand through many of the family’s business dealings, a man of numbers and calculation. Today, however, he was not there to oversee investments or to consult with advisors. No, today he was here to take a far more direct role in safeguarding the Ashcombe legacy.

“I’ll take care of the withdrawal, Reginald,” Charles said, his voice low, though not without a trace of concern. “I’ll make sure the vaults are opened and the gold is moved. But you must be careful with your dealings at Whitehall. You cannot rely entirely on diplomacy in these matters.”

Reginald nodded, his eyes narrowing in thought. Charles was right. As a man of influence in the family’s commercial affairs, Charles understood the harsh realities of finance, and he knew that in times of crisis, the financial markets could shift in ways that no words or treaties could prevent.

“I must speak with Edward Grey, Asquith, and Lloyd George,” Reginald replied, the weight of these names pulling at him. “I must make them understand that the destruction of our financial system is not an inevitability. If they act swiftly and decisively, the war may still be averted. The Bank of England cannot be allowed to destroy this country’s future.”

Charles didn’t respond immediately but gave a brief nod. He knew his brother’s mind was made up. Reginald Ashcombe was a man of action, a man who, though perhaps a little too eager to shoulder burdens alone, had always managed to find a way through even the darkest crises.

By the time the train drew into Paddington, the bustling capital seemed more chaotic than usual, with the tensions of a continent awaiting war hanging over the streets like an invisible storm. Reginald felt a knot tighten in his chest. The sound of carriage wheels clattering on cobblestones, the steady hum of conversation, all seemed to mock the impending disaster.

Once they disembarked, Reginald and Charles took separate carriages. Charles’s destination was the Bank of England, the fortress-like structure where their family’s wealth had been stored for generations. It was a place of rarefied security, built to withstand the shocks of both financial storms and the everyday ebbs and flows of the market. But Reginald knew that the storm that now approached could not be weathered by mere vaults and ledgers. The very idea that the Bank might be forced to suspend specie payments—and thus dilute the family’s wealth to nothing more than paper currency—was a prospect too dire to ignore.

As the carriage bearing Charles turned down the familiar streets toward Threadneedle Street, Reginald gave one last look toward his brother, knowing that the gold would soon be safe in private hands, away from the machinations of the state.

Reginald’s path, however, led him to the heart of power itself: the office of Sir Edward Grey, the Foreign Secretary, followed by meetings with Prime Minister Asquith and Chancellor Lloyd George. Each of these men held the fate of the nation in their hands, and it was to them that Reginald would now turn, hoping to persuade them to reconsider the course that had already been set in motion.

Reginald was ushered into the Prime Minister’s study with a certain sense of urgency. Asquith, a man of considerable political experience and calm demeanour, stood from his desk and motioned for Reginald to sit. His expression, as always, was measured, though there was a slight edge to his voice. The news from Europe had clearly rattled the government, but he was a man accustomed to political manoeuvring.

“Lord Ashcombe,” Asquith said, clasping his hands behind his back. “We’ve heard the reports. The situation in Sarajevo, the Russian mobilization… it is all terribly worrying.”

“Worrying, yes, but preventable, if we act swiftly,” Reginald countered, his tone direct. “I’ve come here to speak plainly, Sir. You must prevent Britain from joining this war.”

Asquith raised an eyebrow but remained silent, awaiting further explanation.

Reginald continued. “You see, we are at a crossroads. The war will bankrupt the country. The suspension of specie payments will be the only option, should this war go ahead, and will destroy the very fabric of our economy. It is not only our financial stability at risk—though that is dire enough—but our standing as the bastion of free markets and prudent governance. The family fortune—the wealth of thousands of your fellow countrymen—will evaporate overnight if we allow the Bank of England to print money for this war.”

Asquith's eyes narrowed slightly, and he began to pace, reflecting on the severity of the situation. Reginald could see the tension in his shoulders.

"I have spoken with several of your colleagues, Lord Ashcombe," Asquith said slowly. "The threat of war is real, and Britain cannot simply stand by while Europe is engulfed. Our obligations to our allies demand action. I must ask you to forgive me, Lord Ashcombe," Asquith said, his voice thick with concern. "The situation has escalated. Our allies are demanding our support, and the threat of Germany advancing into Belgium… well, it's a dire circumstance."

Reginald stood, his resolve growing firmer. "If you allow this war to happen, you may well lose far more than Belgium, Sir. You risk the future of Britain and the Empire itself. If Britain proceeds down this disastrous path—if you allow the Bank of England to print money to fund this war—then you will find yourselves facing a crisis of far greater magnitude than any military engagement could bring. I would not hesitate to withdraw every last pound from the Bank, if it means preventing the nation from destroying its future."

Asquith looked at him, clearly taken aback by the veiled threat. His hand paused mid-motion as he attempted to adjust his glasses. The Prime Minister was a man who had dealt with the most delicate negotiations, but this… this was something new, something Reginald's family had hinted at for generations but never openly discussed.

"Are you suggesting you would break the Bank of England?" Asquith asked carefully, his voice steady but with an edge of incredulity.

Reginald didn't flinch. "The Bank of England is not the nation's salvation—it is its anchor to financial ruin. Once you suspend specie payments and allow the printing of paper currency to finance this war, you will set in motion a panic that will ripple throughout the markets. The confidence of the people, the investors, the very suppliers you will need to sustain a war effort—none of them will believe that the Bank will ever be able to redeem those paper pounds. I will make sure of that."

Asquith hesitated, looking away for a moment. His eyes darted toward the window, where the grey clouds of London seemed to hang heavier than usual, as though mirroring his mood.

"I've already spoken to Mr. Keynes," Asquith said after a long pause, his voice flat, as though it pained him to speak the name. "He assures me that the economy can hold, that our financial structure is robust enough to withstand the strains of war."

Reginald's lips tightened into a thin line. "Keynes," he muttered, the name a bitter taste on his tongue. "A man with no faith in the soundness of currency, no belief in the value of real wealth. His methods will leave this nation weakened, hollowed out, with nothing of real value to show for it."

The Prime Minister's expression hardened. "You may disagree with Mr. Keynes, Lord Ashcombe, but his voice carries considerable weight, and his ideas have the backing of many in the Cabinet."

Reginald's eyes narrowed. "And yet, you fail to see the folly of this path. You cannot print prosperity, Sir. You cannot create wealth by fiat. Once you abandon the gold standard, once you begin this reckless cycle of paper currency and war bonds, Britain will no longer be the powerhouse of the world. It will be a hollow shell, a weak, desperate nation scrambling to uphold a system built on lies."

Asquith stood still for a moment, his fingers drumming lightly on the desk, a nervous habit that betrayed his otherwise composed demeanour. He looked down at the papers before him, then back at Reginald.

“I understand your concerns,” he said slowly. “But this war is unlike anything we have faced before. It is a matter of national survival. Our allies need us, and Britain must honour its commitments. If that requires unconventional measures, then so be it. We must find a way to finance this war, even if it means stretching the limits of our financial system.”

Reginald stepped closer to the desk, his voice lowering, cold and deliberate.

“Let me be clear, Sir. The war you contemplate will destroy Britain as you know it. You cannot take on the burden of a continent’s war without dire consequences. This government will not be able to stop the flood of inflation, the collapse of trust in the currency, and the ensuing panic. I will make sure the markets lose faith in the Bank. I will pull out every last piece of our family’s wealth, and I will encourage others to do the same. Your war will have no funding if you proceed down this path.”

The words seemed to hang in the air for a moment, and the tension in the room grew palpable.

Asquith, unwilling to openly acknowledge the threat, adjusted his tie and looked away, but Reginald could see the flicker of uncertainty in his eyes. The stakes were higher than the Prime Minister had ever faced in his political career.

“I will not allow this country to be bankrupt, Lord Ashcombe,” Asquith said finally, his voice more strained than before. “I will do what is necessary. I have every confidence that Keynes’ policies will keep the economy steady. And if the war comes, we will find a way to pay for it.”

Reginald’s eyes locked onto Asquith’s, his voice unwavering. “Then you will learn, too late, that there is no such thing as a free war. And the cost will be your legacy.”

At the same time, the great doors of the Bank of England creaked open as Charles Ashcombe entered, the silence of the cavernous hall amplifying the sound of his polished boots against the marble floor. It was a place where history had been made, where the fates of nations had been sealed, and Charles was now standing at the crossroads of that very history. The immense weight of the institution hung in the air like a spectre, its very walls filled with the power of the Empire, but today, that power felt fragile—an illusion teetering on the edge of a precipice.

He walked through the great hall with a sense of purpose, heading toward the private offices at the back of the building. As he entered the Governor’s office, he was met by Walter Cunliffe, the imposing figure who stood as the guardian of Britain’s financial future. Cunliffe rose from his desk slowly, his gaze steady and composed, though Charles could sense the tension in the air. The Governor of the Bank of England was no stranger to crises, but this was no ordinary meeting.

“Mr Ashcombe,” Cunliffe said, his voice calm and neutral. “A pleasure. How may I assist you today?”

Charles nodded curtly, the weight of the conversation pressing down on him. “Governor, I’ve come to withdraw my family’s holdings in gold. It is imperative that we do so, and as soon as possible.”

Cunliffe's expression shifted minutely, but his composure remained unbroken. He gestured toward a chair. "I must say, Lord Ashcombe, that this is an extraordinary request. To remove such a large sum of gold from the Bank at this moment could have... unintended consequences."

"I am fully aware of the consequences, Governor," Charles replied, his voice firm. "But the alternative is far worse. The nation stands on the brink of a war that it cannot afford. If we allow the government to proceed with this conflict, Britain will be bled dry. It will be financed through the suspension of the gold standard—through paper currency that is not backed by anything of real value. The economy will collapse, and my family will lose everything."

Cunliffe leaned back in his chair, his fingers steepled before him. His gaze did not waver. "Lord Ashcombe, I understand your concerns. I truly do. But you must see the larger picture. The government has committed itself to this course of action. We have no choice but to support it. If we allow the gold to leave the Bank now, it would send shockwaves through the entire financial system. A run on the Bank would result, followed by a collapse of the currency. The entire nation would be thrown into disarray."

Charles's eyes narrowed, his resolve hardening. "The nation is already in disarray. The war will bankrupt us long before the fighting even begins. You cannot pretend that this is not true. If the Bank of England continues to support this, it will be complicit in the destruction of this country. I cannot—and will not—stand by while my family's wealth is vaporized by a war that will bring nothing but suffering."

Cunliffe's brow furrowed as he leaned forward, his voice low but firm. "Mr Ashcombe, you are asking the impossible. You are demanding that we—this institution—withdraw support from the government in a time of national crisis. The government has already made its decisions. The Treasury is prepared to finance the war effort through a temporary suspension of specie payments. We will issue paper currency in exchange for gold. If you remove your holdings now, you will not only be isolating yourself, but you will be undermining the very foundation of Britain's financial system. This could lead to mass panic. And I cannot, in good conscience, allow that to happen."

Charles stood, his posture stiffening with the weight of his decision. He had known this would be difficult, but Cunliffe's refusal—his absolute insistence on following through with the government's disastrous plan—made it all the more urgent. "You are choosing to support a government that has already set Britain on a path to ruin. The paper money you are so willing to create will be worthless. The war will be a disaster, and this institution—your institution—will be destroyed in its wake."

Cunliffe shook his head slowly, his gaze unyielding. "I cannot allow the Bank to become a pawn in your personal war against the government's policy, Mr Ashcombe. The Bank of England exists to protect the stability of the economy, not to pander to individual whims. I understand that you may disagree with the course of action being taken, but withdrawing your gold at this juncture will have consequences that go far beyond the interests of one family."

Charles's jaw clenched. "I am not concerned with 'one family.' I am concerned with the future of Britain—and if that means I must act on my own to stop this madness, then so be it."

Cunliffe's gaze softened for a moment, the first crack in his otherwise implacable demeanour. But it was fleeting, and he quickly regained his composure. "I implore you. Do not take this course of action. Do not force my hand. If the gold leaves this institution, it will be the beginning of the end. I cannot let you cause this catastrophe."

There was a heavy silence between them. Charles's resolve was absolute. He knew that what he was about to do would shake the very foundations of British society. But in that moment, he felt no hesitation. If the Bank of England would not act, he would take matters into his own hands.

"I cannot be complicit in this, Governor," Charles said quietly, turning toward the door. "If you will not act to stop the war, then I must. And I will ensure that my family's wealth is protected—whatever the cost."

With that, he turned on his heel and walked out of the room, leaving Cunliffe behind, his figure standing as a monument to the institution that would soon be swept away by the inevitable tide of events.

Charles Ashcombe was already walking briskly out of the Governor's office when he heard his father's voice behind him.

"Charles, how did it go?" Reginald asked, his tone calm but sharp, his expression unreadable.

Charles turned to face his father. There was no need to explain further—the look on his face said it all. "Unsuccessful," he muttered, his frustration evident. "Cunliffe refuses. He's determined to keep the gold locked in the Bank. He insists the government needs it to support the war effort." His voice faltered with the weight of the words. "He refuses to see that we are on the edge of financial collapse. The war will break us, and the Bank will have no choice but to print paper money. The gold is as good as gone."

Reginald's eyes narrowed, his expression tightening as he processed his son's words. The elder Ashcombe was a man of action, not one to sit idly by when faced with an obstacle. His eyes flicked towards the door to the Governor's office, and then back to Charles, a deep resolve setting in.

Without another word, Reginald grasped his son by the arm and turned him around, urging him back toward the door.

"We're not finished here, Charles," Reginald said, his voice low and determined. "Wait here."

Charles watched, both alarmed and intrigued, as his father strode back to the door. Reginald's gait was unyielding, his confidence undeniable. He reached the door to Cunliffe's office, and without a moment's hesitation, he threw it open, the impact startling the staff inside.

Walter Cunliffe, who had been adjusting some papers at his desk, looked up in shock. "Lord Ashcombe—" he began, but Reginald did not allow him to finish.

"Governor Cunliffe," Reginald's voice rang out, clear and firm, "I've given you a fair opportunity to rectify this situation without further disturbance. But you refuse to see reason."

Cunliffe's mouth tightened, but he remained seated, his eyes calculating. "Lord Ashcombe, this is a matter of national policy. You must understand—"

"I understand that you are playing a dangerous game with the financial stability of this nation," Reginald interrupted. "You intend to support a war that no one wants, a war that Britain cannot afford. You believe that you can print money to carry the burden, but you're lying to the public, and you're lying to yourself if you think the country will stand for it."

Cunliffe's face hardened, his eyes flickering with something akin to worry, but his voice remained measured. "I assure you, Lord Ashcombe, that the situation is under control. The currency will be stable. We have the full confidence of the government, and—"

Reginald's voice rose, unyielding. "You've placed the Bank of England in a position where it will either collapse under the weight of government debts or destroy the nation's economy through inflation. You cannot claim to be 'in control.' You are simply gambling with the future of this country, and that is something I will not allow."

He paused, giving Cunliffe a moment to absorb the gravity of his words. The room was silent except for the soft rustle of paper as the Governor shifted uneasily in his chair.

"Here's what will happen," Reginald continued, his voice cold and deliberate. "I will go to the press. I will tell them that the Bank of England is refusing to pay out in gold and that the nation's gold reserves are being held hostage by your obstinance. I will tell them that the Bank's refusal to return gold to its rightful holders is a direct betrayal of the financial security of Britain. This will cause a panic—a run on the Bank. And once the markets know what's happening, once the public knows that the gold is no longer available, the game will be over. You will be forced to act, or you will destroy the credibility of the entire institution."

Cunliffe's eyes widened slightly, the colour draining from his face as the threat of public exposure hit home. "You would do that?" he asked, his voice faltering ever so slightly.

"Without hesitation," Reginald replied, his gaze unwavering. "You have until the end of today to return my family's gold. Either you suspend specie payments, or you release the gold and allow us to remove our holdings."

There was a long silence in the room. The weight of Reginald's words hung in the air, a clear and irrevocable ultimatum.

Cunliffe's hands clenched on the desk before him, his knuckles white. He met Reginald's gaze, and for the first time in their interaction, his mask of calm seemed to crack. "You cannot threaten the Bank of England, Lord Ashcombe. This institution is the pillar of the nation. You will not—"

"I am not threatening the Bank of England, Governor," Reginald cut in. "I am offering you a choice: act now, or watch as it all crumbles before your eyes."

Cunliffe's gaze flickered for a moment, caught in the web of Reginald's unyielding stare. The silence stretched out, unbearable, until finally, Cunliffe spoke.

"Very well. You may remove your gold. But understand this—if the government proceeds, as it most likely will, you will have irrevocably jeopardized Britain's financial system."

Reginald's face softened, but his tone remained steely. "I have no interest in supporting a war that will destroy this country's future. You have made your choice, and I will make mine."

He turned to leave, his coat sweeping behind him, leaving Cunliffe sitting in his office, unable to conceal the growing sense of panic.

Charles, waiting just outside, glanced up at his father as he approached. Reginald's expression was resolute, his stance proud. Without saying a word, he turned to Charles, nodding toward the exit.

“We’ll have the gold in a few hours,” Reginald said, his voice low but triumphant. “It’s time to stop this madness, once and for all.”

Chapter 2:

The rhythmic clatter of the train wheels echoed through the late afternoon mist as the steam engine made its way north, its carriages bearing precious cargo bound for the Ashcombe family seat in Bamford. The gold, now freed from the vaults of the Bank of England, was carefully secured in a special compartment, escorted by a small, trusted security detail, its journey shrouded in quiet urgency.

As the train snaked its way out of London, winding through the countryside toward the north, Reginald Ashcombe sat in the drawing room of his London townhouse, the heavy air of impending conflict hanging over him. The finality of his decision to remove the family gold from the Bank felt almost surreal, as though he were already witnessing the first tremors of a crisis that might ripple through the nation.

He had spent the afternoon making preparations for their return to Bamford, speaking briefly with Charles before dispatching him to handle some other matters in London. But now, as dusk settled over the city, he took a long breath, his gaze flicking over the papers strewn across the polished mahogany table.

With a soft rustle of paper, Reginald picked up the evening edition of The Times. He was well-versed in the growing concerns of the day, but this was different. This was the first clear indication, in black and white, that the wheels of war had begun to turn in earnest.

He unfolded the paper carefully, his eyes scanning the front page. The headline nearly jumped off the page in bold, damning type:

"A Declaration of War: Britain Mobilizes for the Continental Conflict"

Below it, a small subheadline read:

"Prime Minister Asquith Addresses Nation, Confirms Britain’s Involvement in European Strife"

Reginald felt a knot tighten in his stomach. He had known the war was coming—had fought to prevent it, with every ounce of his influence—but this was no longer speculation. This was fact. The very thing he had feared.

The article continued:

"After a series of diplomatic failures and mounting pressures from both the French and Russian governments, Prime Minister Herbert Asquith has confirmed that Britain will honour its alliance with France in the coming days. Mobilization is underway, with troops poised to depart for the frontlines. The nation braces itself for what promises to be a prolonged and costly war, as the threat of German expansion looms over the continent."

Reginald’s fingers tightened around the paper as his mind raced. The government had made its decision, and now there was no going back. The full weight of the financial disaster that lay ahead was beginning to settle in.

He flicked through the paper quickly, scanning for any mention of the Bank of England's actions—his actions. There was no direct mention of the Ashcombe family's withdrawal, but there was plenty of commentary on the financial strain the war would impose.

"With the suspension of specie payments likely and the prospect of war bonds flooding the market, there is grave concern over the nation's ability to maintain its gold reserves. Economists have pointed to the risks of inflation and the collapse of the pound should the war continue unabated."

Reginald's lips tightened. It was too late to prevent the war. What he could do, however, was make sure that the Ashcombe family would be insulated from the devastation that was about to unfold.

He placed the paper down, a sense of grim resolve settling over him. The gold was on its way north, bound for the safety of Bamford, where it could not be touched by the looming financial storm. If the nation collapsed under the weight of its own hubris, the Ashcombes would not be caught in the flood.

But that did little to ease the gnawing feeling in his gut. The war, the economy—it was all now an unstoppable juggernaut, and the Ashcombes had no choice but to ride out the storm. The question now was whether the war would end in victory for Britain or whether it would break the nation entirely.

The clock on the mantelpiece ticked steadily, marking the passage of time. A knock at the door interrupted his thoughts, and a servant entered with a note. Reginald took it, broke the seal, and read it quickly.

It was a message from Charles, confirming that the gold was now safely en route to Bamford and that the family would be ready for whatever came next.

Reginald nodded grimly to himself, his mind already turning to the next phase. The war would proceed, but the Ashcombes would stand apart from the financial ruin that would soon engulf the rest of the nation. As for the rest of the country... well, the fates of many were now tied to decisions made long before the first shot was fired.

And as he sat back in his chair, Reginald couldn't help but wonder: How long before the war came home to roost, and how long before Britain, now caught in its own entanglement, was forced to face the consequences of its actions?

The humid summer air clung to the streets of London, thick with the weight of uncertainty. The city buzzed, unaware of the decision that was about to tear the nation's future apart. But Reginald Ashcombe, standing in the drawing room of his townhouse, knew all too well what was coming. He had been in enough rooms, listened to enough half-hearted debates, to understand that the men in power—those who filled the seats of government—were not fit to prevent the impending disaster.

The cabinet was still divided on whether Britain should commit to war. There were men who hesitated, wavered on the brink of decision, but it was clear to Reginald that the country's fate had already been sealed. The spectre of war loomed over them all, and the men who wielded the levers of power in the heart of London were weak. Weak in resolve, weak in vision, and above all, weak in character.

He could not escape the thought that this was the inevitable consequence of what he had seen in the corridors of power. The last man—the notion that Friedrich Nietzsche had so carefully articulated—kept gnawing at the back of his mind. He had studied it thoroughly, in the quiet hours of his education. The last man was a creature of comfort, complacent in his existence, content with the decay of the world around him. But the true danger lay in the fact that the last man could not help but breed more last men. A society that had forgotten its sense of purpose, its hunger for greatness, would only produce more of the same. And Britain, it seemed, was no different.

London's heat smothered the day, like the muffled beat of a drum beneath the heavy air of impending disaster. The city clung to itself, unaware, indifferent, as its fate inched closer, every step more reluctant than the last. Reginald Ashcombe stood before the window of his townhouse, staring out at the world he was about to abandon to its own folly. A world teetering, fragile as an unsteady breath. In this moment, he saw it all—the decline of empire, the fall of reason, the collapse of a nation too weak to stand its ground.

War, they said. War, they hummed with fatalism, as if it were inevitable. A question of when, not if. But for Reginald, it was more than just an inevitable march—it was the descent of a nation, a country of men too tired, too frightened to do anything but bow to the fear-mongers. Weak men, weak men. The phrase spun in his mind like an endless reel, a loop he could not escape. They would breed more weak men, these weak men who led Britain. They would rot the bones of the nation.

Weakness. Nietzsche had made it plain. The last man, lazy, content, comfortable in his own degradation, surrounded by the trivial comforts that dulled the instinct for greatness, for struggle, for excellence. The last man who would never question authority because it was easier to follow the current than to swim against it. Reginald spat the thought out with disgust. This was not the time for last men, but for a man who could stare into the abyss and, at the very least, drag Britain back from its edge. No, not Britain—just this sinking handful of men who, if not stopped, would sink the rest.

He closed his eyes briefly, letting the thoughts wash over him like a cold tide. He could hear the distant mutterings of Cabinet ministers, their voices quivering with indecision, with timidity, with a terrible fear of the unknown. The war, their war, was not their decision—no. The war belonged to men like Asquith, weak to their marrow. If ever there was a man to lead Britain to ruin, it was him. He saw it so clearly now—the fracture of the weak-minded leadership that had led to this moment.

No one spoke of consequences. No one dared to. It was all for the moment. The immediate satisfaction of striking back at a foe, a foe no one understood, least of all the men in power.

"It is a fight for the soul of Britain," Reginald muttered to himself. His breath caught on the words, echoing back at him like an answer he was not ready to hear. And yet— it would have to be. It had always been this way. The conflict of strength and weakness, the pull of entropy against the force of will. Reginald knew what had to be done. And this time, he would be the one to do it.

The men of the Cabinet? They were to be ignored. They would not stand for Britain—they would stand for their own pathetic, selfish desires. How typical. How utterly predictable, how human. The ministers would not see the madness of their decision. They would not feel the weight of the world in the way Reginald did. They were too engrossed in their petty, moralizing rhetoric to hear the cries of reason.

Was it any wonder the nation had come to this? The age of comfort, the age of indifference, the age of the Last Man, where thought itself had become nothing but a mechanism for survival, a way to preserve the comfortable lie of peace.

Peace, yes. But what kind of peace?

He walked across the room, pacing, hands trembling with the fury of thought. Too late, too late. The war would come. And when it came, it would crush the weak-minded to dust. Those who would follow would be no better. The war would tear Britain apart, and they would see it coming, but it would be too late to stop it.

He'd seen it already. He'd been to the meetings. The slow wretches of bureaucrats hiding behind the sanctity of government. Asquith, Grey's grating voice droning on. They would sign the papers. They would give the orders. And they would lead this nation to its ruin.

This was what Reginald had feared, what he had studied in the shadows of his youth. The last man had arrived—and now Britain's finest minds were preparing to march to their destruction with eyes wide open, but blind. The thought nearly choked him. The weakness, the impotence of it all—it was unbearable.

"I must stop this." The words, unbidden, erupted from his mouth. His mind had made up its course. The fight would not be against the Germans. The fight was against his own countrymen. And for their sake, he would stop them, tear down the rot at the heart of their decisions, expose them for what they truly were—weak men too frightened to act.

He strode towards the desk, grasping at the papers that awaited him. Letters—plans. Appeals. He would go to them again, confront them. He would show them their folly, their weakness. But it would not be enough. No—this was the work of a man who had no option left but to take charge, to do something. He would stop the war, or at least delay it long enough to see the world outside the clenched fist of war, to see Britain stand strong for once, if not in the world, at least in itself.

Weak men breed weak men.

It struck him like a bolt, cold and true.

But it was not the end. No, this was only the beginning. The beginning of a new Britain, perhaps—if only he could stop them now. He grabbed his coat from the chair, its stiff fabric a harsh reminder of the burden he carried. He would not sleep. He could not. Not until the blood of his country, the soul of Britain, was safe from the weak-minded and their war.

Three days later on the third of August the war clouds had truly gathered, thickening by the hour. In the Cabinet room, the air was stifling, heavy with a blend of cigarette smoke, cigar fumes, and the palpable anxiety of the men seated at the long oak table. Each face carried the strain of a world on the cusp of chaos. They were not yet at war, but the gulf between peace and war was narrowing with every passing minute. It was a momentous decision.

Reginald Ashcombe stood near the window, staring out at the grey sky over London, lost in thought. The voices of the Cabinet members behind him were growing louder. There was an urgency to their voices, a conviction that seemed—strangely—unquestionable. They spoke as though war were not a choice, but a destiny to be fulfilled.

Lloyd George was the first to speak, his voice a mixture of optimism and determination. "We cannot stand idly by while the balance of power in Europe shifts against us. It's a matter of national security. If we don't intervene, we risk seeing Germany dominate the continent."

Edward Grey, the Foreign Secretary, leaned forward with quiet intensity. "This is a question of honour, gentlemen. Britain has long been the protector of European peace. Our duty is clear."

Reginald felt the blood stir in his veins, but he remained still, his posture rigid, waiting for the others to continue. He had not yet spoken, but he could already hear the hollow reasoning behind their words—the same political reflexes, the same desire for glory and power. They were blinded by the same national pride that would lead Britain to ruin.

Asquith, the Prime Minister, took a long drag from his cigarette before speaking, his tone more measured. “It is not only a matter of security, Reginald. The economic implications are not to be overlooked. Our trade, our empire, all hinge upon maintaining stability in Europe. If France falls, the entire structure of the continent will collapse. Germany will reign supreme across the European continent and will, in time, threaten British supremacy over the seas.”

There was an undertone of urgency in the Prime Minister’s voice. Asquith was not a man prone to wild emotion, but here, in this moment, he seemed to grasp at the threads of something that had eluded him. Perhaps, Reginald thought, he understood more than he let on—perhaps the looming destruction of Britain’s financial system gnawed at his mind, too.

But it was Churchill, who, as First Lord of the Admiralty, looked at Reginald with a fire that burned with both passion and self-righteousness. “Do you not see, Ashcombe? The future of Britain—of all Europe—depends on our intervention. If Germany prevails, there is no telling what will happen. We cannot allow that to happen. We must act.”

The room fell silent, each man awaiting Reginald’s response.

Reginald Ashcombe turned, his face calm, but inside, the tempest of his thoughts raged. He had spent days considering this moment—this meeting. Every argument from the Cabinet had been anticipated, every counterpoint formulated, but now, standing in the presence of these men, he felt the weight of his decision pressing down on him. If he spoke, the political world as he knew it would shatter. If he did not speak, Britain would be lost, its fate sealed in a war of devastation.

With a firm but controlled voice, he began, addressing them all. “You speak of the security of Europe, gentlemen. But I ask you—what is the price of this security? We are a nation that stands on the principles of sound finance, a nation that has built its empire not on the fragile dream of military conquest but on the unshakeable foundation of economic stability. War will destroy that. This ‘intervention,’ as you call it, will only drain the life from our nation.”

There was a pause as Reginald’s words hung in the air, heavy with the gravity of what he had just said.

Lloyd George raised an eyebrow. “Are you suggesting that Britain should stand aside and let Germany trample over France? That we should allow our ally to be wiped out?”

Reginald’s gaze hardened, but his tone remained measured, philosophical. “Yes. Let Germany and France fight this war. The outcome, as tragic as it may seem, will not affect us as profoundly as you believe. What will affect us, gentlemen, is the economic collapse that will follow our intervention. The Bank of England is already teetering on the brink. If we declare war, we will be forced to abandon the gold standard. Inflation will spiral. The war will consume our wealth, and the very people you wish to protect will find themselves impoverished.”

There was a tense silence. The Cabinet members exchanged looks, their expressions a mixture of disbelief and apprehension. Reginald knew they were not accustomed to hearing such a stark analysis, especially not from someone of his status.

Finally, Asquith broke the silence. “And what do you propose we do, Reginald? Do we simply watch as Europe burns, powerless and indifferent?”

Reginald’s jaw tightened, but he held his ground. “What I propose is that we seek peace, gentlemen. We have the power to prevent this war, to stop Britain from plunging into chaos. But we must act now. We must refuse to fund this war—whether through bonds or through the suspension of specie payments. We must act in the interest of our nation’s future, not its pride.”

The room was stunned into silence. Reginald felt the weight of their disbelief, but he held his ground.

Grey was the first to recover, his voice tinged with exasperation. “You are asking us to defy the very spirit of our nation, Reginald. To turn our backs on our duty to Europe. To stand aside and let our allies perish. It is unthinkable.”

But Reginald’s conviction did not waver. “It is only unthinkable because you do not understand the consequences. Europe may burn, but Britain need not. We must preserve our wealth, our economy, our future.”

Asquith looked at him, his face drawn with fatigue. “You have made your position clear. But I fear you are too late. The Cabinet is already leaning towards war. The public demands action.”

Reginald knew this was true. The war hysteria was building, the public outcry growing louder by the hour. He had only moments to change their minds, and in his heart, he knew the struggle was nearly lost.

“The great tragedy of this moment, gentlemen,” he began, his tone low but firm, “is that we are on the verge of making a decision that will preserve Europe only to destroy the British Empire. You speak of honour, of the duty we owe to our allies, but what of the duty we owe to ourselves, to the future of our nation?”

He paused, looking each man in the eye, sensing the growing discomfort in the room. They had heard his words before, but now, Reginald could feel the nervous tension in their silence.

“You are all concerned with Europe, with what we stand to lose if we do not intervene,” he continued, his voice rising slightly, laced with urgency. “But have you not considered what Britain will lose in this conflict? It is not just men’s lives that will be lost; it is the very lifeblood of our nation—the wealth that has made us the greatest empire the world has ever known.”

He paced for a moment, gathering his thoughts. “If we go to war, the wealth of this nation—the reserves of gold, the credit of the Bank of England—will flow not into our coffers but into the hands of the United States. This war will mark the end of Britain as the financial centre of the world. Our capital will be sucked across the Atlantic to Wall Street, leaving us at the mercy of a new world order. We will be forced to sell our Empire piece by piece to feed this senseless war effort.”

There was a sharp intake of breath from the men around the table. Reginald’s words had struck a chord, but he knew they needed more than just the stark reality of financial collapse. They needed to understand what was truly at stake, not just for Britain’s economy, but for her soul.

“This is not just about gold reserves or the pound sterling,” he said, his voice growing colder, more resolute. “This is about the future of our culture, our identity, our way of life. We, in this room, are the stewards of this great nation, and we are in danger of destroying it in the name of misguided patriotism. We cannot allow our nation to be swept up in the fever of war. The very soul of Britain will be lost in the flames of this conflict."

He paused again, as if to let the full weight of his words sink in.

"I will not be caught up in this war fever. I will stand, as I always have, with my family in Yorkshire, in the heart of this great country. There, we shall stand firm and advocate against mobilisation. I will not be a part of this madness. It is not only my wealth that is at stake, but the future of our empire, the future of our children, and of our nation."

The Cabinet members were quiet now, as Reginald's impassioned speech lingered in the room like a charged atmosphere. He had made his position clear.

"If we enter this war, gentlemen," he said, his voice now low and measured, "we may save Europe—but we will destroy Britain. And I will not stand by and watch that happen."

Reginald's eyes swept over the men in the room, the room that had once been a place of rational discourse, now suffused with the fervour of war. He felt a moment of profound loneliness. He knew that in their hearts, they would not be swayed. The war fever was too strong, too all-consuming. His words had fallen on ears already made deaf by the fear and pride that gripped the nation.

"Do as you will, gentlemen," he concluded, his voice now colder than ever, "but I shall do my duty. I shall stay true to my convictions. And I shall see this war for what it truly is—nothing more than the beginning of the end for the British Empire."

With that, Reginald turned on his heel and left the room, his footsteps echoing in the long corridors of Westminster, a man standing alone in the face of a decision that would alter the course of history.

On the 4th of August, 1914, Reginald Ashcombe sat alone in his townhouse in London, staring out of the window into the grey morning. The news had come quickly, as it always did in the age of telegrams and the constant churn of headlines. Germany had invaded Belgium. The ultimatum had been issued, and now, Britain's response seemed inevitable. A decision had already been made for him, and it was one he knew would change the course of history. War was upon them.

Reginald could feel the weight of the moment, but his thoughts were already moving beyond the confines of what was happening in London. He thought of the great houses of Britain, of the families who, like his own, had long held the keys to the nation's fortune. It would not be the banks or the stock markets that would fund this war. The war bonds were a fiction, a paper dream that could never be realised. The only true wealth in Britain lay in its gold reserves—its tangible, unyielding gold. And he knew that if they were to be drained to finance the war, Britain's imperial strength would be undermined in ways that no one could foresee.

The first telegram he wrote was addressed to Charles, still in Bamford, at the family seat in Yorkshire:

To Charles, Ashcombe Estate, Bamford, Yorkshire.

The Dye is Cast.
I trust that by now you will have heard the news of Germany's invasion of Belgium. The Cabinet, in its weakness, has succumbed to the demands of intervention. We are at war. Yet, the real battle begins now, in the realm of finance. If Britain is to endure this conflict, it will be up to the great houses of the land to sustain it—our wealth, our gold, our legacy. War bonds will not suffice, and

we will not allow the Bank of England to deceive us. Withdraw all of our gold reserves immediately. Do not delay. The game is afoot. The preservation of our Empire depends upon it.

Reginald Ashcombe.

He paused after sending the telegram, feeling an odd mix of anticipation and dread. He then wrote several more, each one identical, each one a plea for action, addressed to various noble families, industrial magnates, and allies scattered across Britain:

To Lord Brampton, Fairleigh Hall, Gloucestershire.
To Lord Penrose, Penrose House, Wiltshire.
To Lord Ridley, Ridley Manor, Kent.

The consequences of our actions are no longer abstract. War has been declared, and our wealth—our security—will be drained in ways unimaginable if we do not act. I urge you, as the custodian of your family's wealth, to withdraw your gold reserves from the Bank of England. The government's decision to fund this war through paper promises will doom us all. We, the great houses, must ensure that Britain's future is not bankrupted by this folly. This is no longer a matter of politics, but survival. The time to act is now.

He had sent the telegrams, and he could only hope that the other great families would see the danger. Each man, each woman, would need to make a decision—whether to preserve the Empire, or to let it be bled dry in the pursuit of an ill-conceived war. The economic ramifications were already clear to him, but he knew that the Cabinet would not listen to reason. The country had been swept up by the fervour of patriotism, the sound of drums and marching feet.

As the evening wore on, Reginald sat in his study, contemplating his next moves. The telegrams had been sent. The gold would move. But it was not enough. He knew that the true power of the British Empire lay not in the war itself, but in its financial and cultural supremacy. If the war was to be funded through the ruin of Britain's economic system, then it would be up to the great houses to step in and ensure the survival of their own fortunes—if not the survival of the Empire itself.

The clock struck eleven when a servant entered, carrying a telegram. Reginald knew what it was before he even looked at it. It was the confirmation, the final seal on the fateful decision. He unfolded the message with a slow, deliberate hand.

Telegram from the British Foreign Office.

At 11:00 PM on 4th August 1914, Britain has declared war on Germany, following the invasion of Belgium. Full mobilization is underway.

Reginald sat in stunned silence for a moment. The shock was not in the message itself. He had known it was coming. The shock lay in the finality of it, the moment where the path forward had been irrevocably set. War was no longer a theoretical discussion; it was a hard, brutal reality.

For a moment, Reginald's thoughts turned inward. How had it come to this? The men he had met in the Cabinet, the politicians who had begged for intervention, had always been weak. Weak in their understanding of economics, weak in their understanding of the consequences of their actions. Now Britain would bleed, and there was nothing he could do to stop it. The world he had worked so hard to preserve, a world of reason, of culture, of wealth, would be caught in the flames of this conflict.

But he would not go quietly. He had already sent the word out. The great houses of Britain would protect their wealth, and through them, they might protect what was left of Britain's power. He rose from his desk, his thoughts already moving to the next steps, the next moves he must make.

The telegrams had been sent. The gold would be withdrawn. The Empire would not be lost without a fight.

Chapter 3:

November 1914. The chill of autumn had begun to settle over London, and with it, the weight of Britain's first major defeat on the battlefield. The Bank of England, in its desperation to secure funding for the war, had issued its first war bonds. Yet, despite all the expectations, despite the fervent appeals of the government, the response had been tepid at best. Reginald Ashcombe, ever watchful from his residence in London, could sense the unease growing within the financial establishment. The bank had hoped for massive subscriptions, but the gold reserves were fast draining, and the war itself had settled into an uncomfortable stalemate.

The frontlines had stalled by early November. The British Expeditionary Force had indeed managed to push the Germans back from Paris, and the Germans, in turn, had entrenched themselves along a static line inside France. The war, which had seemed like a bold, swift undertaking in August, had now become a grim, grinding affair. Reginald had expected this—he had seen the patterns of history, the price of empire, the toll of war on a nation—and yet, he had hoped that some part of the British leadership would act with wisdom. Now, though, all he saw was the slow, tragic momentum of an establishment that was too embroiled in its own prestige to pull back.

He was not surprised by the reluctance to invest in the war bonds. He had spent weeks in conversations with financiers, with other members of the aristocracy, urging them to hold their gold, to avoid the paper promises of a nation already on the brink. His arguments, once dismissed, had now become the unspoken truth in the financial circles of London. But there had been little reprieve from the constant criticism. Reginald had been vilified by most of the British establishment, branded a coward, a traitor to his own nation. Yet, he had no doubts in his own stance. He knew, deep in his bones, that Britain's empire would not survive the war. And more importantly, he believed, the war itself was unwinnable.

Standing in his townhouse that November evening, Reginald was lost in thought, pacing back and forth. He had read the latest reports—the German forces were deeply entrenched, the front had become a brutal war of attrition. And yet, there was something else in the air. Something that spoke of a deeper, hidden victory. The Germans had been repulsed from Paris, and the British forces, despite all odds, had managed to hold their own. The lines may have been static, but for the first time, there was a sense of balance. The war could end now. Britain's position had been secured.

It was time for peace.

He sat at his desk and began drafting a letter to the Prime Minister, Herbert Asquith. His words were deliberate, measured. He had written many such letters before, some in support of war, others pleading for peace. But now, for the first time, his words would be a direct challenge to the government. This was no longer a matter of financial interests; this was a matter of national survival.

To the Right Honourable Herbert Asquith,

Prime Minister of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland.

It is with the utmost gravity that I write to you today, as a concerned member of the British aristocracy, as one who has seen the consequences of war and who, with the full weight of history upon me, implores you to reconsider the current path we find ourselves on.

The initial push into Europe, the British Expeditionary Force's valiant stand at Paris, has succeeded. The Germans have been repulsed, and our forces, though battered, have proven themselves capable of holding the line. Now, we find ourselves in the grips of a war of attrition, one that threatens not only our soldiers and our sons but the very fabric of the nation. It is no longer a question of victory; it is a question of survival. The British Empire has no place in a war that threatens to dismantle everything we hold dear.

The funding of this conflict, through the issuance of war bonds, has been met with profound reluctance, and rightly so. I urge you, as the custodian of Britain's future, to take the necessary steps to halt this madness. The financial strain, the social upheaval, the loss of life—these are all avoidable. The war will not bring us the glory we have been promised. It will not secure the Empire. Instead, it will destroy us.

I ask you, Prime Minister, to take the brave step that history will one day thank you for: to call for peace before we descend further into the abyss. We are at a precipice. The time to stop is now.

Yours sincerely,
Reginald Ashcombe
Lord of Ashcombe Estate

He finished the letter, letting it rest on his desk for a moment before sealing it. The weight of his words seemed to settle over him like a shroud, but he knew it was the only course of action that remained. The next day, the letter would be sent, and Reginald would wait for the response. He knew what was likely to come—more resistance, more vilification. But he was resolute. The war would not be the making of Britain. It would be its undoing.

As he sat back in his chair, he glanced again at the latest war bond figures. The subscriptions had been pitiful. The capital was drying up. Even the wealthiest families, the ones who had supported the war effort in the early days, were now pulling back. The British aristocracy, at least the wise among them, were beginning to understand the enormity of the crisis.

Reginald's actions had set a course that could not be undone. The gold was out of the Bank of England, and the lines of communication had been opened. Now, the pressure was mounting on the government. The war was not only a military struggle; it was a financial one, and the British establishment was waking up to the reality that the war could not continue without its cost.

By the time Reginald rose to leave his study, he was certain of one thing: The war would not be fought in the trenches alone. The true battle was now being waged in the boardrooms and the halls of power. And if he could stop it, he would do so—not just for the sake of his family's wealth, but for the future of Britain itself.

Later that night, after the letter was sent, the telegram came—Britain would continue the war. The decision had been made, and the consequences were already unfolding. Reginald Ashcombe's warnings, it seemed, had fallen on deaf ears.

The city, once brimming with the wealth and bustle of empire, had begun to dull with the weight of its own uncertainty. The Bank of England, having already issued its first war bonds in a desperate bid to fund the conflict, was struggling to secure the necessary subscriptions. Even the wealthiest families, once so eager to lend their fortunes to the war effort, had begun to pull back. Reginald knew why. They understood what was at stake, even if they did not yet grasp the full implications. They knew that the Bank was being forced to issue paper money, promises that would soon become worthless. They knew that no good could come from this war—only destruction, only the undoing of everything that had made Britain the greatest empire the world had ever known.

Reginald's move was bold, but it was the only move that could ensure Britain's survival. If the war was to be brought to a swift and decisive end, the financial foundation on which it stood had to be dismantled. There was no other way to halt the machinery of destruction. No amount of moral suasion, no appeal to reason, could make the British establishment see the truth. But the one thing that could break their resolve was the lack of money. Without funds, the war effort would grind to a halt. The supplies would cease, the army would falter, and the war would collapse in on itself.

The banks could no longer continue to fund the war if they were starved of capital, and Reginald knew this better than anyone. The war effort was unsustainable; it was not an investment in the future, but a haemorrhaging of the nation's productive capacity. The only future that war could bring was one of ruin. Industry, the backbone of Britain's wealth, was being sacrificed on the altar of military ambition. Every day that the war continued, more lives, more resources, and more of Britain's wealth were being poured into the furnace of conflict, leaving nothing but ashes.

The cost of the war was not just measured in lives lost on the battlefield—it was measured in the depletion of Britain's economic strength, in the erosion of its capital, in the draining of its gold reserves. Reginald understood that no matter what the politicians said, the economy could not withstand this. The nation's wealth would be redirected to the war machine, drained into a black hole of destruction, never to be recovered. Once the money ran dry, the war would lose its momentum. And that was the key—once the war was starved of funds, it would cease to be a reality. The peace that Reginald so fervently desired would become not only possible but inevitable.

Reginald spent the next days quietly preparing his strategy. He would not engage in some futile attempt to change the minds of the cabinet or the Prime Minister. They had already made their decision. But the great houses of the land, the landed aristocracy, the old families who still held the purse strings of the nation—they were not yet fully on board with the war. They were practical men and women, for whom the economy was everything. If they could be convinced to withdraw their gold from the Bank of England, if they could be persuaded to stop funding the war, the financial structure that underpinned the conflict would begin to collapse.

He sent letters, telegrams, and private messages to the other great houses of Britain. He knew that the war effort would not survive without their support. The message was clear: withdraw your gold from the Bank of England, and starve the war machine.

But Reginald's efforts were not without consequence. He received increasing pressure from his peers, from politicians, and from the financial world. Some viewed him as a traitor to his country, a coward unwilling to face the threat posed by Germany. Others were more pragmatic, but no less hostile, accusing him of destabilizing the financial system for personal gain. And yet, Reginald stood firm. He had seen too much of history to believe the narrative that war brought glory. He had read the works of the great philosophers, the men who understood the nature of power and the destruction it wrought. War, as they had all written, was a force of annihilation, not of creation. It would destroy everything—his family's wealth, Britain's empire, the very fabric of European civilization.

He could feel the tension rising, both in the air and in his own chest. The die was cast, and now it was up to the great houses, the men and women of wealth and power, to make the final decision. Would they continue to fund the war? Or would they withdraw their support, knowing that to do so would mean the end of the conflict, and the preservation of Britain’s future? Peace with Germany, a return to the status quo, was the only rational path forward.

In early November, as the first frost kissed the windows of Ashcombe's townhouse in London, the inevitable news reached him. The Bank of England’s war bonds, issued in desperation to fund the ongoing conflict, had been woefully under-subscribed. The funds simply weren’t there. The nation’s coffers had been bled dry, and the financiers at the Bank, in a last-ditch attempt to stave off financial collapse, were now contemplating a drastic measure: the suspension of specie payments, the very bedrock of British currency, and the reliance on paper money to fund the war.

Reginald Ashcombe was not surprised. He had seen it coming from the moment Britain had decided to engage in the war. He had known that the country’s financial system could not sustain such an enormous expenditure without drastic consequences. The Bank of England, in its desperation to prop up the war effort, had turned to The Internationalist John Maynard Keynes, whose theories on inflation and government spending were being used to justify the issuance of currency with no real backing. Keynes, with his ideas of state-driven economic expansion, had been brought in to assure the government that they could fund the war indefinitely, regardless of how far the nation's resources were stretched.

But Ashcombe knew, as any experienced financier would, that Keynes could not be trusted. The suspension of specie payments would mark the death knell of the British currency system. The pound, once a symbol of strength and stability and as good as gold itself, would be reduced to a mere piece of paper, no longer tethered to any tangible asset. The people of Britain would not see it coming at first, but the financial elites, those who understood the power of gold, would know instantly that the foundation of the nation’s wealth had been undermined. The value of the currency would collapse, and with it, the British economy.

It was a grim realization, but one that Ashcombe had long anticipated. The only option now was to move quickly. He knew that the Bank of England would soon act, and when it did, the last vestiges of British financial integrity would vanish. If he were to prevent the coming disaster, he would have to act decisively—he would need to withdraw his family’s gold before the Bank could enact the suspension of specie payments. And not just his gold, but that of the other great houses of the land. He had to urge them to act as well, to take their wealth out of the Bank of England before it was too late.

As November deepened and the days grew colder, Reginald Ashcombe found himself at a crossroads. His plans to withdraw the family’s gold from the Bank of England had not only prevented the Bank from issuing enough war bonds, but it had also set in motion a chain of events that was forcing him to confront a new, far more radical course of action. The government, in its desperation, had chosen to continue its ill-advised march towards war, and the Bank of England was now preparing to suspend specie payments and fund the war through paper money. Reginald could see the writing on the wall. The national economy would crumble under the weight of such a decision, and with it, the wealth of every aristocratic family in Britain would be at risk.

He sat in his study, staring out over the wintry landscape of the Ashcombe estate. The first light snowflakes fell, dusting the ground in a soft, silvery veil. His mind, though, was far from serene. He had already spoken to the other great houses across the country, urging them to withdraw their gold from the Bank of England, but he knew that was not enough. They needed an alternative—a new system that could protect them from the oncoming collapse of the pound and the economy as a whole.

At his side was Charles, his son, who had followed his father's instructions to the letter. Charles had always been an astute, capable son. Reginald knew he could trust him, especially now.

"Charles," Reginald said, his voice sharp and clear, "we cannot wait for the government to make a move. They are blind to the consequences. We need to create an economy outside of their reach—an alternative system. The war economy will inevitably fail, but we have the means to control the outcome."

Charles looked at his father, his face a mixture of apprehension and determination. "You mean a new economic system? But how? The whole country is in the grip of war fever. How can we stand against that?"

Reginald leaned forward, his eyes intense. "We create a peer-to-peer economy based on gold. We use our reserves to back a new form of trade, one that the Bank of England cannot control. The aristocracy, the landed gentry, and those families who understand the value of gold—they will have the means to keep their wealth intact, even if the paper pound collapses. We'll take the power away from the Bank and place it back in the hands of the people who truly hold value. This is the quickest way to force the British Government to come to the negotiation table with the Germans."

"Charles, I need you to go to the Rolls Royce factory," Reginald continued, his voice firm with resolve. "Buy as many cars as they have available. We need to show the others that we're serious. We will use these cars to move the gold around. Gold for goods—no fiat, no paper currency. If the Rolls Royce factory is willing to accept gold as payment for their cars before the Government can turn the screw on their produce, then we can begin to build this new economy. Once we have enough support to begin a , we can invite other manufacturers and businesses to join us. We will create a system that will be beyond the control of the Bank of England."

Charles nodded, his face hardening with the knowledge of what he had to do. "I'll leave at once, Father. And the telegrams?"

"I will inform the aristocracy that we are starting a gold-based trading service. This will be for the aristocracy, those with the means to preserve their wealth during the war. They will not need to depend on the Bank of England's increasingly worthless currency. We'll trade in gold, backed by the Ashcombe reserves, and we'll move quickly. If we're to survive this, we have to act faster than they can react."

Reginald's words hung heavy in the air. He knew this was their only chance. The Bank of England's fiat currency would only accelerate the decline of the country's wealth. If the aristocracy could create an independent economy, they would bypass the coming collapse and be ready to restore order once peace was secured.

Charles rose from his chair, his mind already calculating the logistics of the task at hand. "I'll see to it immediately, Father. What's the next step after the cars?"

"Once the gold-based trade is established, we'll begin to bring in the other great houses. I will personally negotiate with them, persuade them to join the new system. We'll create a network—a gold standard system for the elite that doesn't rely on the government or the Bank. And once that network is strong enough, we will begin to starve the war effort of funds. Without the support of the great houses, the war cannot continue."

Reginald stood up, his back straight, his eyes hard. The weight of what he was about to do was immense, but he had no other choice. The fate of the country—of Britain's future—depended on it.

"Go, Charles," he said. "And don't waste time. We have no more time to lose."

Charles left the room, his footsteps echoing in the hallway, and Reginald turned back to his desk. He picked up a quill and began to write the telegrams, his hand steady as he carefully crafted each message. The response would be swift. The other great houses would soon know what he was doing. Some would resist, but others would understand the gravity of the situation. The Ashcombe family had always been at the heart of Britain's wealth, and now it would be at the heart of its financial resistance.

As he finished the last of the telegrams, Reginald knew that his course was set. The new economy, based on gold and independent of the Bank of England, would be the answer to the madness of the war economy. The aristocracy would have to take control of their own fate. And with that, Britain's future—if it were to survive at all—would rest in their hands. In order to do this as well as could be done, Reginald knew he needed to contact one man in particular.

5th November 1914
Ashcombe Estate
Bamford, Yorkshire

Dear Professor Mises,

I trust this letter finds you well, though I fear the world around us has taken an increasingly dangerous turn. As you are no doubt aware, the war, with its ramifications for the British economy, has begun in earnest. The Bank of England, under the influence of Mr. Keynes, has taken the reckless decision to abandon the gold standard, replacing it with paper money to finance this endless conflict. As a result, the future of Britain's wealth—indeed, the wealth of the entire Empire—seems perilously uncertain.

I have acted in accordance with my belief that we must preserve the financial security of our families, particularly the great houses of Britain. The Bank, as you may know, is already preparing to issue its war bonds, but I see no way for these bonds to be of any value, as they will only be backed by an increasingly inflationary currency. The collapse of the pound seems all but inevitable, and I believe we are entering a period of financial instability that will only deepen as the war continues.

In this moment of economic uncertainty, I find myself taking a course of action that I never would have considered a year ago. I have withdrawn the Ashcombe family's gold reserves from the Bank of England, and I am urging other great houses to do the same. The future, it seems, lies in a return to a gold-based economy, independent of the central bank's disastrous policies. I am preparing to initiate a new form of peer-to-peer economy among the aristocracy, based on the gold reserves held in private hands, in order to keep wealth circulating within the families that have long been the true guardians of the nation's fortunes.

It is my hope that we can starve the war effort of the funds it needs, forcing the government to seek a peaceful resolution. If we can withhold support from the war economy, perhaps we can save the empire from destruction.

Given your unparalleled understanding of economics and the intricacies of sound money, I humbly ask for your advice on how best to fund this new economy and organize it in such a way that it may provide a swift and peaceful resolution to this war, before it consumes Britain entirely.

I eagerly await your thoughts on how we may navigate these troubling times.

Yours sincerely,
Reginald Ashcombe
Lord of Ashcombe

Ludwig von Mises' Reply:
15th November 1914
Vienna, Austria-Hungary

Dear Lord Ashcombe,

I have received your letter with great interest and a profound sense of sympathy for the difficult position in which you now find yourself. The situation you describe in Britain, with the reckless abandonment of the gold standard and the inevitable collapse of the pound, is one I have feared for many months. The consequences of financing war through inflationary measures are clear—an eventual breakdown in confidence, a destruction of capital, and the rise of economic chaos.

Your decision to withdraw your family's gold from the Bank of England is a wise one, and I fully support your course of action. It is imperative that the great houses of Britain take such steps to preserve their wealth, as the value of fiat money will inevitably erode under the pressure of wartime financing. However, the question you pose—how best to fund a new economy based on sound money—requires a careful and deliberate answer.

First and foremost, the creation of a gold-based economy is no simple task. You are right to focus on the peer-to-peer economy, as it is the only way to maintain the flow of goods and services without relying on the state's unstable currency. The key to success lies in trust. By ensuring that all transactions within your network are backed by gold, you will demonstrate to others that their wealth is secure. It is not enough simply to hoard gold; it must be put to use, and you must create a system whereby these assets circulate within the community of the great houses.

I recommend the following steps:

Establish a Gold Clearinghouse: In order to facilitate trade between the great houses, I advise that you set up a clearinghouse, where gold can be exchanged for goods or services. This institution would act as an intermediary, ensuring that transactions are recorded and that payment is made in gold, with no reliance on paper money. It will also provide a mechanism for resolving disputes and ensuring that all parties uphold their financial commitments.

While the war bonds issued by the Bank of England will certainly fail due to inflation, there is still merit in issuing your own form of bond, backed by gold. These bonds could be used to fund specific projects, such as the purchase of goods or services that are essential for the survival of your new economy. These gold-backed bonds would not be tied to the Bank of England, and they would allow the great houses to continue to finance necessary expenditures without resorting to paper currency.

One of the most critical elements of your plan will be the ability to operate outside of the control of the state. The British government and the Bank of England will likely see your efforts as a direct threat to their financial control, and they may attempt to stifle this movement. Therefore, I *recommend that you ensure the privacy and secrecy of all transactions. This will allow the aristocracy to maintain control over their wealth and prevent the government from undermining your efforts.*

It will be essential to build alliances with like-minded individuals and families. You are correct to reach out to other great houses, but you must also be prepared to protect their interests as well as your own. The more participants there are in this new gold-based economy, the stronger the network will become. This will also increase the pressure on the government to seek peace and avoid the further escalation of the war.

Finally, I must urge you to remain steadfast in your belief that peace is the only rational course of action. The longer the war continues, the greater the economic and social damage will be, and it will be the great houses of Britain who will bear the heaviest burden. Your efforts to starve the war effort of funds may be the only means of achieving a swift resolution, and I fully support your conviction that this is the right course of action.

Please do not hesitate to contact me if I can be of further assistance.

Yours sincerely,
Ludwig von Mises

Chapter 4:

By December, the Ashcombe gold clearinghouse had been operating for a week. The fledgling system, headquartered in the re-purposed halls of the Ashcombe family estate in Bamford, was showing promise but remained fragile. While it had garnered interest from a handful of aristocratic families and trusted merchants, the endeavour was still finding its footing in a landscape dominated by the Bank of England’s war bonds and fiat currency.

Despite meticulous planning, the clearinghouse faced challenges. Some participants were sceptical of entrusting their gold to an untested system, even one backed by the venerable Ashcombe name. Others hesitated, fearing reprisals from the government for participating in what might be construed as a rebellion against the established financial order.

The volume of transactions, while steady, was modest. Gold certificates had yet to circulate widely, and most exchanges remained local—small consignments of coal, fine textiles, or agricultural goods moving between estates. Charles Ashcombe, tasked with overseeing operations, was tireless in reassuring participants, personally inspecting ledgers and sending letters to hesitant families.

Yet, Reginald remained undeterred. “This is but the seed,” he wrote in his journal one frosty evening. “If nurtured, it will grow into a great oak under whose branches this nation may find shelter.”

Among the system’s early backers were unexpected figures. Winston Churchill, then First Lord of the Admiralty, had quietly funnelled a portion of his personal wealth into the clearinghouse. A man of ambition and foresight, Churchill was hedging against the economic uncertainties of the war, convinced that Reginald’s system might offer a refuge from the volatility of the paper currency system.

However, the clearinghouse had also drawn the attention of its most formidable opponent: John Maynard Keynes. Recently brought into the fold of the Bank of England to assist in the management of wartime finance, Keynes viewed the Ashcombe initiative as a direct threat to the central bank's authority over the money supply.

Keynes had been a vocal advocate for the suspension of specie payments and the expansion of fiat currency to fund the war effort. To him, the clearinghouse was not just a nuisance—it was a potential destabilizer of the national economy. In a confidential memo to senior officials, Keynes wrote:

"The Ashcombe experiment, though limited in scope, sets a dangerous precedent. It undermines confidence in the Bank of England and introduces fragmentation into the monetary system at a time when unity is essential. I advise immediate measures to suppress this operation before it gains further traction."

By mid-December, the government had begun to act. Rumours reached the Ashcombe estate of pressure being applied to participants in the clearinghouse. Inspectors from the Treasury were dispatched to question merchants about their involvement, and legal threats loomed over those who refused to disclose details of their transactions.

The most alarming development came when Charles received a letter from a merchant in Birmingham who had been approached by government agents. The letter, written in hurried scrawl, read:

"They demand to know the extent of my dealings with your clearinghouse. I fear their intentions are punitive. They speak of fines, of confiscation. What shall I do?"

Reginald responded swiftly, drafting a series of telegrams to reassure participants and urging discretion in their dealings. "The foundation of this house is trust," he told Charles gravely. "If that trust is broken, even by the slightest crack, the entire structure may collapse."

The Ashcombe estate buzzed with tension. Clerks worked late into the night under the flickering glow of oil lamps, tallying accounts and drafting letters to potential allies. Charles, ever the pragmatist, suggested scaling back operations until the storm passed. Reginald, however, refused.

"The government seeks to crush us because they fear us," he said. "They know their paper will fail, and when it does, our gold will remain."

Still, doubts crept in. The Bank of England had announced plans to issue another series of war bonds, and whispers of full specie suspension grew louder. Reginald knew that the moment Keynes achieved this aim, the clearinghouse might be rendered obsolete—or worse, illegal.

In an effort to forestall the government's crackdown, Reginald drafted a letter to the Cabinet. It was a bold appeal, laying out his case with characteristic eloquence:

"Gentlemen,

This war, though noble in intent, must not be waged at the cost of our economic foundations. The issuance of fiat currency and the erosion of trust in our monetary system will haunt this nation long after the guns fall silent.

*The Ashcombe clearinghouse is not an act of rebellion but of preservation—a safeguard for those who value stability and integrity. I urge you to reconsider your approach. Let us find a path that sustains the war effort without sacrificing the financial soul of this nation."**

As Christmas approached, word came that the Bank of England's latest war bonds had seen only tepid subscriptions. Keynes, furious, doubled down on his efforts to suppress the clearinghouse, proposing new regulations to limit private gold trading.

For Reginald, the writing was on the wall. "The battle is joined," he told Charles one evening as they sat by the fire. "But we are not without strength. If we are to survive, we must act swiftly and decisively. The fate of the clearinghouse—and perhaps the nation—depends on it."

The stage was set for a confrontation between two visions of Britain's future: one grounded in the steadfast reliability of gold, the other in the uncharted waters of fiat currency.

It was just before Christmas when Reginald saw he was in direct confrontation with the state.

The Treasury Office
London, December 21, 1914

Lord Ashcombe,

It has come to the attention of His Majesty's Government that your so-called "gold clearinghouse" continues to operate in direct contravention of the wartime economic measures enacted under the Defence of the Realm Act. While your efforts may be couched in terms of patriotic concern for financial stability, they are, in fact, profoundly destabilizing to the nation's ability to prosecute this war to its necessary conclusion.

By diverting gold from the Bank of England and fostering an alternative system of exchange, you have not merely flouted governmental authority but undermined the very mechanisms required to sustain the British war effort. Such actions, in a time of national crisis, are tantamount to treason.

Let me be clear, Lord Ashcombe: Britain's financial system cannot and will not be held hostage to the whims of an aristocrat whose grasp of modern economics is as outdated as the gold you so cherish. The Bank of England, under the stewardship of men who understand the demands of this new age—including myself—has already ensured the suspension of specie payments. Fiat currency, issued and managed by the central bank, is the only viable means to secure victory.

Your clearinghouse, by its very existence, threatens this effort. Merchants and industrialists who participate in your scheme do so at the risk of severe penalties. I have advised the Cabinet to take immediate steps to shut down your operations and, if necessary, to seize your gold reserves under the emergency powers granted by the Act.

I must also warn you that further attempts to interfere with the financial measures of this government will result in charges being brought against you. The charge of treason is not made lightly, but your actions, in their effect if not intent, serve only to aid the enemy. Germany will be delighted to see Britain weakened by internal dissension.

You are hereby summoned to present yourself to the Treasury Office no later than December 30th, where you may explain your actions to the appropriate authorities. Should you fail to comply, we will have no choice but to proceed with the full force of the law.

The war requires sacrifice from us all, Lord Ashcombe. I urge you to reconsider your position and to align yourself with the national interest before it is too late.

Yours sincerely,
John Maynard Keynes
Special Advisor to the Treasury

Reginald sat in his study, the letter from Keynes trembling slightly in his hands. Outside, the Yorkshire winter howled against the stone walls of Bamford Hall, but within the fire crackled warmly. The words on the page, however, sent a chill through him.

"Treason," he muttered aloud, almost to himself. The accusation was as preposterous as it was infuriating. He laid the letter on his desk, its edges catching the firelight, and leaned back in his chair, staring at the ornate ceiling.

Charles entered, noticing his father's uncharacteristic stillness. "Bad news?"

Reginald handed him the letter without a word. Charles read it quickly, his face darkening.

"They mean to seize the gold," Charles said finally, his voice low.

"They mean to silence us," Reginald replied, his tone sharpening. "Keynes and his ilk would drown this nation in paper promises and call it salvation. They do not see—they refuse to see—that they are mortgaging Britain's future for the fleeting illusion of control."

Charles hesitated. "What will you do?"

Reginald rose from his chair, pacing the room as the firelight danced across his figure. "We cannot yield. If they take the gold, they take the clearinghouse, and with it, the only hope of stability in this madness. Keynes thinks he understands economics, but he does not understand principle. If Britain is to be saved, it will not be through fiat but through the integrity of real value."

He paused, his face set with determination. "I will not go to the Treasury like a lamb to the slaughter. Instead, we will strengthen the clearinghouse, rally our allies, and make it clear that this is no treason—it is the salvation of Britain."

Charles nodded. "And if they come for the gold?"

Reginald's gaze hardened. "Then they will find that not all wealth is as easily seized as their printed paper. Prepare the estate, Charles. War is waged in many ways, and this shall be ours."

The Ashcombe clearinghouse, though nascent, would now face its greatest test as the full weight of the British government turned against it. Reginald knew that the battle for Britain's soul was not only on the fields of Flanders but also in the vaults and ledgers of a nation torn between tradition and the demands of modern war.

Reginald sat in the dim light of his study, the cold stone walls of Bamford Hall enclosing him as if the house itself shared his mounting sense of urgency. Keynes's letter lay open on his desk, a glaring symbol of the state's encroachment. The fire crackled faintly, unable to warm the chill of inevitability. They would come for the gold—it was only a matter of time.

He ran his fingers through his hair, his mind racing. The clearinghouse was still fragile, its operations in their infancy. Without the gold reserves, it would crumble under the weight of state repression. But where could the gold be safe? The answer came to him with sudden clarity: across the Atlantic, in the United States—a land not yet consumed by the folly of European war.

Liberty still had its foothold there, a place where individual enterprise and the rule of law held stronger sway. If the Ashcombe gold could be secured in American vaults, it would not only preserve the family's wealth but also provide a foundation for the clearinghouse to operate internationally.

Reginald rose and strode toward the adjoining room, where Charles had taken to poring over accounts. His son looked up as he entered, sensing the gravity of the moment.

"Charles," Reginald began, his voice firm, "the time has come. We must move the gold to safety."

Charles frowned. "Safety? You mean... outside the country?"

"Yes, to America," Reginald said. "Keynes and the government will not stop until they have seized every ounce. We cannot allow that. The gold must be sent across the Atlantic before they make their move."

Charles nodded slowly, though the enormity of the task was evident in his expression. "But how? The ports are watched. And the Bank of England will surely have informants looking for unusual shipments."

Reginald smiled faintly, the flicker of a plan already forming. "I know a few men in the north, smugglers who've been running opium into the country for years. They are discreet and resourceful. If anyone can slip past the authorities, it is them. We'll refit one of their boats to carry the gold."

Charles raised an eyebrow. "Smugglers? That's a far cry from our usual dealings, Father."

"These are not usual times, Charles," Reginald replied sharply. "The state has abandoned its principles. It uses force and coercion to preserve its failing system. If we are to protect what is ours—and indeed, what is right—then we must adapt."

Charles sighed, but there was no hesitation in his agreement. "I'll make the arrangements. It will take a few days, but I'll contact the smugglers immediately."

Reginald placed a hand on his son's shoulder. "Good. And make it clear to them that failure is not an option. The future of this enterprise—and perhaps Britain itself—depends on this."

By candlelight, Reginald composed letters to trusted contacts in New York, detailing his plan and securing vault space in one of the city's most secure banks. He wrote in code, disguising his intentions should the letters be intercepted. Each word carried the weight of a gamble, but the stakes demanded no less.

When the letters were sealed and sent with a trusted courier, Reginald leaned back in his chair, staring into the dying embers of the fire. He felt the enormity of his decision pressing upon him, yet also a sense of resolve. The gold would soon be beyond the reach of Keynes and his allies.

In the distance, the faint sound of a train whistle cut through the night. It was a reminder of the ceaseless movement of goods, people, and ambitions—a reminder that time was short.

"Liberty," Reginald murmured to himself. "If it cannot live here, then it must find refuge where it still can."

The next few days saw Charles moving quietly between Bamford and the northern coast, finalizing arrangements with the smugglers. They would refit a small but sturdy schooner to transport the gold under the guise of a shipment of industrial machinery. As word of the operation spread among the trusted inner circle of the Ashcombe network, the family prepared for the most dangerous leg of their fight against the state.

January 1915. The icy grip of winter mirrored the chill in the air surrounding Bamford Hall, where Reginald Ashcombe sat in his study, the dim light of an oil lamp casting long shadows. A knock at the door interrupted his thoughts. Charles entered, a telegram in hand.

“They’ve started,” Charles said, his voice low. “Keynes and his allies are pushing Parliament for broader powers under the Defence of the Realm Act. They’re calling us traitors outright now.”

Reginald stood, his face darkening. “It’s expected. But they don’t realize they’re draining their own lifeblood.”

Charles handed him the telegram. It bore the seal of the Home Office. It was an official notice of investigation and potential seizure of Bamford Hall and all assets related to the clearinghouse.

“This isn’t just a threat, Father,” Charles said. “They’ll come for the gold soon.”

Reginald nodded. “Then we move faster than they do.”

That evening, Reginald gathered the family’s inner circle, including a trusted associate with connections to smugglers operating along the Yorkshire coast.

“We’ll use their opium routes,” Reginald declared, pointing to a map. “They’ve brought in contraband for years without the government so much as catching a scent. They can take our gold out just as quietly.”

The plan was daring, almost reckless. The gold would be smuggled down the canals under the guise of agricultural supplies, then loaded onto a modified schooner bound for New York.

“We’ll need the gold packed and ready within the week,” Reginald instructed Charles. “Inform the clearinghouse clients. The operation will continue stateside for now, but Britain can no longer be our base. We must also issue promissory notes, it will be up our users which promissory note they trust more. The only difference being that we are not funding a war.”

Meanwhile, in London, the Bank of England was haemorrhaging gold reserves. Customers emboldened by the Ashcombe initiative were withdrawing funds in droves, demanding payment in specie. Rumours swirled that Cunliffe himself was preparing to recommend a suspension of gold payments.

Keynes leaned across a table in the governor’s office.

“We must act decisively,” he said. “Ashcombe’s clearinghouse is undermining public confidence. If this continues, we’ll have no choice but to suspend specie payments and issue notes backed by fiat. But before that, we must seize his assets. Publicly.”

Cunliffe frowned. “The optics would be disastrous. The Ashcombe name carries weight.”

“That’s why we frame it as treason,” Keynes replied. “A patriotic sacrifice to preserve the Empire.”

Despite the crackdown, demand for the clearinghouse's services surged. Word had spread among the great houses and wealthy industrialists that Ashcombe gold provided stability the Bank of England could no longer guarantee.

In Bamford Hall’s bustling makeshift office, clerks handled telegrams and tallied accounts. Eleanor Ashcombe watched as a new client list arrived, handed to her by the butler.

“Another shipment,” she said, showing the list to Reginald. “And two more houses have pledged their gold to the clearinghouse.”

Reginald smiled grimly. “The government cannot fight the tide forever.”

On the eve of the smuggling operation, Reginald stood in the Bamford Hall vault, inspecting the crates of gold. Each ingot gleamed in the lamplight, representing the family’s legacy and their gamble against the state.

“This gold will be the foundation of a freer economy,” he told Charles, who stood beside him. “But we must be prepared to lose everything else.”

The next day, scouts reported signs of government agents near the estate. Reginald ordered the first crates to be loaded onto carts and transported under cover of night.

The smugglers' schooner, Evelyn's Grace, rocked gently against the tide as the first crates of Ashcombe gold were loaded onto its hidden compartments. Reginald stood on the docks, his coat pulled tightly against the bitter January wind, watching Charles oversee the transfer. The smugglers moved swiftly, their boots crunching on the frost-covered planks.

“Everything is on schedule,” Charles reported, stepping beside his father.

Reginald nodded, though his gaze remained fixed on the ship. “The government won’t wait much longer. We must make sure this gold reaches New York. Without it, everything we’ve built collapses.”

As the ship’s captain gave the final call to board, Charles hesitated.

“You think they’ll come tonight?”

“They might,” Reginald replied, “but even if they don’t, this war of ours has only just begun.”

In London, John Maynard Keynes paced the length of the Bank of England’s boardroom, the tension in the room thick enough to cut with a knife.

“We’ve confirmed the movement of Ashcombe’s gold,” he announced. “It’s heading for the coast, likely bound for the United States.”

Cunliffe raised an eyebrow. “And you’re certain this isn’t mere rumour?”

“My sources are impeccable,” Keynes replied. “If we don’t act now, the Ashcombe clearinghouse will expand its reach internationally, draining not just the Bank’s reserves but our influence over the markets.”

“What do you propose?” asked one of the directors.

“A coordinated crackdown,” Keynes said firmly. “Seize their assets under the Defence of the Realm Act. Detain the Ashcombe family if necessary. This is treasonous behaviour.”

“And if they’ve already moved the gold?” Cunliffe asked.

Keynes leaned forward. “Then we must rally Parliament for a suspension of specie payments. If we can no longer redeem in gold, we must pivot to fiat-backed war bonds. The Empire’s survival depends on it.”

Back in Bamford, the clearinghouse buzzed with activity as clients scrambled to transfer their wealth out of reach of the government’s tightening grip. Telegrams poured in faster than the clerks could handle, and the atmosphere was tense with rumours of imminent raids.

Eleanor Ashcombe worked tirelessly, reviewing accounts and reassuring clients.

“They’re afraid,” she said to Reginald when he entered the office. “Many think the government will shut us down entirely.”

“They’re not wrong,” Reginald admitted. “But they underestimate how much this war has destabilized the Bank of England. Keynes and Cunliffe are playing a dangerous game, and the markets know it.”

Meanwhile, the war in Europe had devolved into a static and brutal conflict. The British Expeditionary Force, after its early successes, was entrenched in the mud of northern France, locked in a bloody stalemate with the German army. The reports from the front painted a grim picture: vast losses of life and resources with no decisive victory in sight.

Reginald read the latest dispatches from The Times in his study, his face darkening with each paragraph.

“This war is bleeding the nation dry,” he muttered to himself. “Every shell fired, every trench dug—it’s all destruction. There’s no return on this investment, no productive outcome, just ruin.”

He penned a letter to one of his clearinghouse allies:

"The war machine is devouring not only lives but the very foundation of the market economy. Productive capital is being consumed faster than it can be replaced. If this continues, Britain will find itself impoverished, and the Empire will crumble under the weight of its own debts. We must act to end this madness, or there will be nothing left to save."

By the end of January, the Evelyn’s Grace had reached the safety of New York Harbor, its precious cargo intact. The Ashcombe gold was deposited in a secure vault in Lower Manhattan, beyond the reach of the British government.

Charles received the news via telegram and immediately relayed it to his father.

“It’s done,” he said. “The gold is safe.”

Reginald allowed himself a rare smile. “Good. Now we focus on the next phase.”

Chapter 5:

The air in Reginald Ashcombe’s study was thick with tension as he sat by the fireplace, the crackle of the logs the only sound in the room. A fresh pile of telegrams lay unopened on his desk, but his attention was fixed on the latest edition of The Times that Charles had just handed him. The headline struck him like a blow.

"Bank of England Temporarily Suspends Specie Payments"
After days of intense speculation, the Bank of England announced today that it has been forced to suspend specie payments in response to mounting pressure from the war effort. Sterling, once backed by gold reserves, will now be a fiat currency, further straining the Empire’s financial system.

Reginald’s lips curled into a sardonic smile. “I knew it was coming, Charles,” he said, his fingers tracing the outline of the headline. “They’ve been toying with this for weeks, but the moment the Bank of England takes this step, everything changes.”

Charles stood beside him, his face a mixture of concern and satisfaction. “It’s official now. Sterling isn’t what it used to be. The Evelyn’s Grace might be in New York, but the Ashcombe clearinghouse is the only place where people can still trust in gold-backed value.”

Reginald nodded slowly. “Exactly. The gold we moved is no longer just a safe haven; it’s a standard. The Bank of England’s move has only highlighted the weakness of its money.”

As Reginald read through the rest of the article, his eyes scanned the passage that mentioned the Ashcombe Clearinghouse. It was buried towards the end of the report, but even in its modest placement, it carried a weight.

"...In a surprising turn of events, a select group of aristocratic families, led by Lord Reginald Ashcombe of Yorkshire, have been offering an alternative to the Bank of England's increasingly unstable currency. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse, which operates out of New York, has been facilitating trade in gold-backed securities for the British elite. Though still in its infancy, this system has already garnered the attention of key investors across the Atlantic. Critics argue that such a system undermines the Bank of England’s authority, but the fledgling clearinghouse provides a refuge for those seeking stability during these uncertain times."

Reginald folded the paper with care and looked up at Charles. “The game is changing. More people are starting to see the cracks in the Bank’s façade. Soon enough, they’ll come to us, just as we planned.”

Charles glanced at the fire. “And what of the government’s next move? Keynes won’t let this go lightly.”

Reginald’s eyes darkened. “They’ll come for us. You can count on it. But the moment they try, they’ll expose just how desperate the situation is. The only thing that can stop this war is the collapse of the financial system they’re propping up with paper.”

News of the suspension of specie payments quickly spread throughout London and beyond, igniting a wave of concern among the city’s financiers. The first signs of panic began to ripple through the stock exchange, and the value of the pound plummeted. Without the backing of gold, Sterling was no longer viewed as the reliable reserve currency it once had been. The Bank of England’s decision to abandon the gold standard sent shockwaves through international markets.

Meanwhile, in New York, the Ashcombe Clearinghouse found itself at the centre of a quiet financial revolution. More and more prominent families began transferring their wealth into gold-backed assets through the clearinghouse, bypassing the volatile British currency. Wealthy industrialists, merchants, and even politicians sought out the stability of gold, and the Ashcombe name began to carry more weight than ever.

Reginald knew that the coming months would be critical. The suspension of specie payments had given him the upper hand, but only for now. The Bank of England would surely attempt to counter the growing sentiment against fiat money. As the gold-backed clearinghouse began to attract more investors, he prepared for the inevitable government crackdown.

“The gold is secure for now,” Reginald said, more to himself than to Charles. “But we need to expand this network. The demand for hard money is only going to grow, and we must be ready when they try to strike back.”

Charles nodded. “I’ll have the team prepare the next phase of the operation. We need more discreet transactions, and I’ll make sure the supply lines stay open. No one can know about the gold shipments to New York.”

At that very moment, John Maynard Keynes was hunched over a stack of papers in his study, preparing his response to the sudden rise of the Ashcombe Clearinghouse. His government-backed war effort depended on the stability of the pound, and Ashcombe’s alternative was beginning to unravel his carefully laid plans.

Keynes scribbled a note to his associates at the Treasury:

“Ashcombe and his peers are undermining our authority. We cannot allow this rogue operation to continue. The suspension of specie payments was a necessary evil, but their gold-backed clearinghouse represents a direct challenge to our ability to control the money supply. We must act swiftly to shut them down before their influence spreads.”

Back in Bamford, Reginald watched the sun sink behind the hills, his thoughts racing. The world was changing at an accelerating pace, and every decision he made would ripple outward, affecting not just his family but the course of history itself.

“The war won’t last forever,” Reginald murmured, his eyes reflecting the fading light. “But the financial order we create now could last for generations. Charles, we’re at a crossroads. The clearinghouse has become indispensable to those who value real money, but its success is also our greatest vulnerability.”

Charles turned, his brow furrowed. “You think they’ll come for us?”

Reginald nodded gravely. “Not think. I know. The government can’t afford for us to continue. If they can’t fund this war with paper and bonds, their entire plan collapses. Keynes and his ilk will do everything in their power to stop us, even if it means labelling us as traitors.”

Charles walked closer, his voice steady but tinged with defiance. “So, what do we do? Shut it down? Fight back?”

Reginald shook his head. “No. The clearinghouse must survive, but it can’t survive here. The gold is already in New York, and it’s time an Ashcombe went with it.” He looked directly at his son, his voice firm. “You’re the one who must go, Charles.”

Charles stared at him, the weight of the words sinking in. “You’re serious? You want me to leave? To run it from America?”

“Yes,” Reginald replied, leaning forward. “You know the business better than anyone else. You’ve been there every step of the way, and you understand what’s at stake. If the government moves against me, they’ll use every tool they have to dismantle what we’ve built here. But they won’t reach you across the Atlantic, and they won’t dare interfere with American sovereignty. The clearinghouse will be safe in your hands.”

Charles hesitated, his mind racing. “And what about you? If they arrest you—”

Reginald cut him off with a wave of his hand. “My fate is of little concern. The work we’re doing is too important. This war is draining the lifeblood of the Empire, destroying capital, and tearing apart what made Britain great. The clearinghouse is more than just a refuge for gold; it’s a symbol of resistance against this madness. And you, my boy, will ensure it endures.”

The following morning, Charles began making preparations for his departure. The plan was simple but fraught with risk: he would take a trusted team of associates and sail under the guise of a business delegation. Once in New York, he would take full operational control of the clearinghouse and begin expanding its influence among American financiers and industrialists.

Reginald stood by the carriage as Charles loaded his luggage, the early morning mist hanging in the air. “Remember,” Reginald said, placing a hand on his son’s shoulder, “this isn’t just about us. It’s about preserving something greater than ourselves. The government may call us traitors, but history will judge us differently.”

Charles met his father’s gaze, his resolve hardening. “I won’t let you down.”

“I know you won’t,” Reginald replied with a faint smile. “You’re an Ashcombe.”

As the carriage pulled away, Reginald stood alone in the drive, watching until it disappeared into the distance. The burden of leadership was heavier than ever, but he felt a glimmer of hope. Charles was the future, and with him in New York, the Ashcombe Clearinghouse would continue its mission.

Back in London, the government’s crackdown began in earnest. Under Keynes’s guidance, the Bank of England launched a campaign to discredit the clearinghouse, accusing it of undermining the war effort and threatening national security. Newspapers loyal to the establishment began publishing scathing editorials about the Ashcombe family, labelling them as profiteers and enemies of the state.

Meanwhile, Reginald braced himself for the inevitable. He knew that it was only a matter of time before the government took direct action against him, but he remained steadfast. The clearinghouse was already beyond their reach, and with Charles in America, the gold standard would have a new champion across the Atlantic.

Reginald poured himself a drink and sat by the fire, his thoughts turning to the future. The war had already claimed countless lives and devastated the economy, but he held onto the belief that peace and reason could still prevail. For now, his mission was clear: to protect the clearinghouse at all costs and to continue the fight against the forces driving Britain deeper into ruin.

"Liberty," he muttered to himself, raising his glass in a quiet toast. "If they won't protect it, we will."

By late January 1915, the government's patience with Reginald Ashcombe had worn thin. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse, despite operating primarily out of New York, continued to undermine the Bank of England's war economy. Whispers of treasonous activity swirled through the halls of Whitehall, and the pressure on Reginald grew more intense by the day.

In London, Reginald's townhouse became a point of surveillance. Plainclothes men loitered on street corners, watching his comings and goings. Friends who once dined at his table now hesitated to associate with him, lest they be swept up in the growing scrutiny. Even among the aristocracy, there were murmurs of discontent: some admired his stand against the war, while others denounced him as a dangerous rebel undermining Britain's fight for survival.

One evening, Reginald sat at his writing desk, drafting a letter to an ally in Yorkshire. The crackle of the fire provided the only sound in the room until a knock came at the door. Moments later, his butler entered, bearing a sealed envelope.

"It's from Lord Halifax, sir," the butler said, handing over the letter.

Reginald opened it with care. Halifax, a long-time family friend and a member of the House of Lords, had written in a hurried, almost frantic tone.

My Dear Ashcombe,

I write to you not as a friend, but as one who wishes to see you spared from ruin. The government's focus has turned squarely upon you. Keynes and his allies in the Treasury are preparing charges under the Defence of the Realm Act, and I fear they intend to act soon. They will not only accuse you of economic sabotage but of aiding the enemy by undermining Britain's financial stability.

This is no idle threat. You must take every precaution to safeguard yourself and your family. If you have allies remaining in the Cabinet, now is the time to call upon them. If you can retreat to Bamford or abroad, I urge you to consider it.

Yours in urgency,
Halifax

Reginald set the letter down, his expression grim. The noose was tightening, and he knew Halifax's warning was not mere hyperbole.

Across London, the Cabinet was indeed deliberating Reginald's fate. Churchill, despite holding some of the family's gold with Ashcombe, pushed for swift action.

"The man is a menace," he declared, slamming a fist on the table. "While boys are dying in the trenches, Ashcombe is playing the role of a modern-day Robin Hood, stealing from the Bank of England to fund his own vision of economic purity. He must be stopped."

Keynes, seated at the other end of the table, adjusted his spectacles and spoke in measured tones. "Gentlemen, this is not merely about one man. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse is destabilizing our ability to fund the war. If we allow this to continue, we risk a full-blown financial crisis. I propose we act under the Defence of the Realm Act to seize what is left of his assets and bring him into custody."

Prime Minister Asquith nodded thoughtfully. "And what of the backlash? The aristocracy may rally around him."

Churchill waved the concern away. "The aristocracy is divided, and many view him as a traitor already. If we move decisively, we can neutralize his influence before it spreads further."

The decision was made. Reginald Ashcombe would be formally charged with sedition, and his properties and assets within Britain would be seized.

That same evening, Reginald summoned his closest confidants to the townhouse. Among them was Mr. Stapleton, his financial advisor, and Mrs. Fairchild, an old family friend with connections in the press.

"I've received word from Halifax," Reginald began, addressing the group. "The government is preparing to move against me. They will invoke the Defence of the Realm Act, seize my properties, and likely accuse me of treason."

Stapleton leaned forward, his voice low. "They'll come for Bamford as well. The estate is too prominent to escape their notice."

Reginald nodded. "I've already moved the clearinghouse's operations to New York, and Charles is establishing its foundation there. The gold is safe. But they will attempt to strip me of everything here in Britain."

Mrs. Fairchild spoke up. "You need public support. If the Times or any other papers can be swayed to your side, it might slow them down."

Reginald considered this for a moment. "Perhaps. But the press won't save me from prison if they're determined. My priority is ensuring that the clearinghouse continues to thrive, even if I'm behind bars. We must maintain the flow of gold and keep the aristocracy invested in our vision."

As dawn broke over London, Reginald penned a final letter to Charles.

My dearest son,

The storm is upon us, and I fear the government will act swiftly. They may arrest me and seize what remains of our holdings here, but they cannot touch what we have built in New York. You must carry the torch forward. Expand the clearinghouse, and ensure its principles endure.

Remember, this war will not last forever, but the destruction it leaves behind will shape the world for decades to come. It is our duty to preserve what is just and true.

Your loving father,
Reginald

As the letter was sent off, Reginald braced himself for what was to come. He would not flee, for to do so would be to admit guilt. Instead, he would stand firm, a symbol of defiance against a government he believed was leading Britain to ruin.

The streets of New York hummed with the energy of a city poised to ascend as the new financial capital of the world. Charles Ashcombe paced the polished floors of the newly established Ashcombe Clearinghouse, located in an imposing Beaux-Arts building just off Wall Street. The operation was small but growing, its vaults steadily filling with shipments of gold smuggled out of Britain by trusted intermediaries.

Charles had thrown himself into the work, navigating the complexities of building trust with America's financial elite while maintaining the Clearinghouse's primary mission: to undermine the Bank of England and the British war economy. The Ashcombe promissory notes, backed by gold, were gaining traction among expatriate Britons, European merchants, and even a few daring American investors.

One brisk January morning, as Charles reviewed ledger books in his office, a courier arrived with a telegram. The words were stark:

REGINALD ASHCOMBE ARRESTED YESTERDAY. CHARGED UNDER DEFENCE OF THE REALM ACT. STRENGTH AND RESOLVE, FATHER'S FINAL MESSAGE TO YOU.

Charles sank into his chair, the weight of the message pressing down on him. He'd known this was a possibility, even a likelihood, but the reality of his father's arrest filled him with a mix of dread and determination. The elder Ashcombe had always been the steadfast architect of their defiance, and now the burden of leadership fell entirely to him.

He reached for a pen and composed a letter to his father's solicitor in London:

"Ensure my father's well-being at all costs. Utilize whatever resources are necessary to secure his release, but know that the work he began will continue here unabated. The Clearinghouse will honour its obligations, and the gold entrusted to us will remain secure."

By February, the Clearinghouse's influence was beginning to ripple back across the Atlantic. Reports from Britain spoke of inflation running rampant. The Bank of England's decision to suspend specie payments and print fiat sterling to fund the war effort had caused the currency's value to plummet.

Prices for bread, coal, and other necessities soared beyond the reach of ordinary Britons. Discontent simmered in the streets, with rumours of protests and strikes spreading from industrial cities like Sheffield and Manchester.

Yet amid the chaos, the Ashcombe promissory notes offered a lifeline to those who could obtain them. Backed by gold and immune to the inflationary pressures plaguing fiat sterling, the notes were increasingly used by Britain's aristocracy and wealthy industrialists to conduct trade. Commoners, desperate to escape the spiralling costs of living, sold their possessions—jewellery, livestock, even land—in exchange for goods priced in Ashcombe notes.

From his office in New York, Charles reviewed a letter from one of the Clearinghouse's agents in Yorkshire:

"The plan is working. Demand for Ashcombe notes has surged, particularly among merchants and farmers. People are selling everything they have to acquire goods priced in gold-backed currency. The Bank of England is losing its grip on the market."

Charles set the letter down and allowed himself a rare smile. The Clearinghouse was not just surviving; it was thriving.

Later that week, Charles received an unexpected visitor: Henry Morgenthau Sr., an influential figure in New York's financial and political circles. Morgenthau entered the office with an air of curiosity, his sharp eyes scanning the bustling operation.

"I've heard whispers about what you're doing here," Morgenthau said, settling into a chair across from Charles. "A private gold-backed clearinghouse, draining the lifeblood of Britain's central bank. It's audacious, to say the least."

Charles leaned forward. "It's necessary. The Bank of England's policies are destroying Britain's economy and prolonging a war that should never have begun. Our notes offer stability in a world drowning in fiat."

Morgenthau studied him for a moment before speaking. "You may find support here in America. There are those who admire your principles, even if they won't say so publicly. But be cautious. If your actions are perceived as undermining the Allies' war effort, you may find yourself facing scrutiny from this side of the Atlantic as well."

Charles nodded. "I understand the risks. But this isn't just about Britain or the war. It's about proving that sound money and economic freedom can prevail, even in the darkest times."

As February turned to March, the Clearinghouse continued to grow, its influence spreading like wildfire. Yet with success came danger. British agents operating in the United States began to monitor the Clearinghouse's activities, collecting intelligence to relay back to Whitehall.

In London, Keynes and his allies in the Treasury grew increasingly desperate. The war effort was haemorrhaging funds, and the Bank of England's reserves were dwindling at an alarming rate. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse, though a world away, was now seen as an existential threat to Britain's financial stability.

Reginald's arrest had failed to deter the movement he had begun. Charles, though half a world away, had become the new target of Britain's ire.

By March of 1915, the fissures in British society deepened as the impact of war rippled through the economy. Inflation had taken firm hold, with prices for basic necessities climbing beyond the means of the working class. Bread, once a symbol of stability, now symbolized despair as it became increasingly unaffordable. Wages, paid in fiat sterling, lagged far behind the spiralling cost of living.

The government's promise that the suspension of specie payments was temporary had proven hollow. As the Bank of England printed more paper to finance the war, confidence in the pound dwindled. Sterling was no longer synonymous with gold but with the creeping erosion of value.

Among the working class, anger simmered. The promise of war for king and country had begun to ring hollow, replaced by grumbling resentment. Yet while ordinary Britons grew restless, another group had quietly shifted its allegiance: the aristocracy.

Long loyal to the institutions of the British state, the great houses of the land now found themselves at odds with the government. They had watched with growing unease as the Bank of England abandoned sound money principles and turned to the printing press. Many among the nobility had already moved their wealth into the Ashcombe Clearinghouse, its gold-backed notes proving a haven from the inflation that ravaged fiat sterling.

These families, steeped in tradition and wary of the state’s growing overreach, began to see the Clearinghouse not just as a financial alternative but as a symbol of resistance. Led by Reginald Ashcombe’s bold example, they began to rally behind this new vision of economic independence.

The Ashcombe notes, once a curiosity among merchants and expatriates, became a staple of aristocratic trade. In Yorkshire, Norfolk, and the Scottish Highlands, the Clearinghouse facilitated transactions for land, livestock, and luxury goods. The clearinghouse's success sent a clear message: the aristocracy could function without the Bank of England.

The working class, too, began to take note. While the Ashcombe notes were not readily accessible to ordinary people, the benefits they brought to the aristocracy trickled down in surprising ways. Farmers and small shopkeepers, who previously sold their goods for sterling, found themselves increasingly paid in gold-backed promissory notes. These notes, though unfamiliar, retained their value far better than the paper money issued by the Bank of England.

In the industrial towns of Sheffield and Manchester, whispers of discontent turned to murmurs of action. Labourers and clerks began to trade their meagre savings for Ashcombe notes where they could, exchanging volatile fiat for stability. To many, the aristocracy’s defection from the Bank of England was no longer a betrayal but an act of pragmatic rebellion.

“We’re not fools,” one blacksmith in Yorkshire reportedly told a journalist. “The gold’s with Ashcombe, not with the bank. If it’s good enough for the lords, it’s good enough for me.”

For the government, the situation was dire. Inflation, now running at 10% annually, was bleeding the economy dry. Keynes and his allies in the Treasury scrambled to contain the damage, insisting that war bonds and paper money were the only way to sustain the war effort. But the public’s trust in these promises had eroded.

The Bank of England had overplayed its hand. By suspending specie payments, it had alienated not only the aristocracy but also the merchants and financiers who relied on stability. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse, though still young, had exposed the fragility of the state’s monetary monopoly.

Keynes’s frustration was palpable. In a meeting with the Chancellor of the Exchequer, he reportedly fumed, “Ashcombe’s actions are undermining the very fabric of this nation. If we cannot fund this war, it will not only be the end of the Empire but the end of Britain as we know it.”

In New York, Charles Ashcombe received daily reports of the Clearinghouse’s growing influence. Letters from Britain described how the aristocracy was now openly defiant, using Ashcombe notes in place of sterling. But the reports also carried a warning: the government was planning a countermove.

Charles penned a letter to his father, now imprisoned in London:

The Clearinghouse grows stronger by the day, but so does the opposition. Reports from Whitehall suggest that Keynes and his allies are planning drastic measures to regain control of the economy. We must brace ourselves for whatever comes next.

As he sealed the letter, Charles thought of the strange irony at play. The aristocracy, once seen as the guardians of the old order, now stood at the forefront of a quiet revolution. Whether their rebellion would succeed, or whether the state would crush it, remained uncertain.

By late March 1915, the tension between the Ashcombe Clearinghouse and the British state reached a new peak. In an emergency session, the Treasury announced a sweeping measure under the Defence of the Realm Act (DORA): the use, trade, or possession of Ashcombe Clearinghouse notes was declared illegal. Any transactions conducted with the notes would be punishable by heavy fines and imprisonment.

The announcement was made with fanfare and gravitas, with Keynes himself presenting the measure as vital to the survival of the war effort. “To undermine sterling,” he argued in the House of Commons, “is to undermine Britain herself. The Ashcombe Clearinghouse is nothing less than economic treason.”

But to those on the ground, the edict was more bark than bite.

The Clearinghouse notes had become too entrenched among the aristocracy and the merchant class to be easily eradicated. Households accustomed to their stability over the rapidly depreciating sterling simply ignored the new law. In the countryside, shopkeepers continued to accept the notes, especially in regions where aristocratic estates dominated commerce.

In industrial towns, the edict was quietly flouted. Small businesses, desperate for reliable currency, found creative ways to mask their use of Ashcombe notes. Local pubs, for instance, began calling them “gold tokens” or “estate vouchers” to avoid scrutiny.

In Yorkshire, one coal merchant, when confronted by a local inspector, simply laughed. “Tell your masters in Whitehall that we’ve tried sterling, and it’s not worth the ink on the paper.”

Even more alarming for the government were reports from the Western Front. Despite the best efforts of military censors, rumours began to filter back to London that British troops were losing faith in sterling.

The lack of provision at the front had become a festering issue. Soldiers complained bitterly about the ration shortages and the poor quality of goods shipped from home. When merchants near the front lines demanded higher prices for their wares, the troops found that sterling couldn’t keep pace.

In whispered exchanges, soldiers began trading Ashcombe Clearinghouse notes for necessities, recognizing their superior purchasing power. The notes, backed by gold reserves in New York, were accepted not only by British merchants but also by French and Belgian traders who had little trust in the British fiat currency.

For the first time, the troops were openly questioning the value of the pound. “We can’t eat promises,” one soldier wrote in a censored letter home, “but Ashcombe’s gold seems to buy bread.”

For Reginald Ashcombe, this moment was a vindication. From his prison cell in London, he received smuggled reports of the Clearinghouse notes’ growing acceptance. What astonished even him was how rapidly events had unfolded.

The state had assumed that bad money—sterling—would drive out good money, as Gresham’s Law traditionally predicted. But the reverse was proving true. With inflation now running rampant and the Bank of England’s reputation in tatters, the public was turning to sound money wherever they could find it.

Reginald reflected on the irony.

"Good money drives out bad, but only when people are free to choose. The state, in its arrogance, has given them no choice but to see the truth for themselves."

Back in London, Keynes and the Treasury faced a mounting crisis. The measure under DORA had not only failed to suppress the Clearinghouse notes but had also sparked quiet defiance across the nation. In meetings at Whitehall, officials debated more drastic actions.

“We can seize Ashcombe’s estates outright,” one aide suggested.

“And provoke an outright revolt among the aristocracy?” Keynes shot back. “The notes are spreading like wildfire because we’ve lost control of the narrative. We must regain it.”

Keynes proposed doubling down on propaganda efforts to portray the Clearinghouse as a threat to national unity. Posters appeared across Britain, bearing slogans like:

“Sound Money for Britain: Back the Pound!”
“Clearinghouse Notes: Gold for Traitors!”

But the damage was done. The people had seen the state’s desperation, and no amount of rhetoric could reverse the trend.

In New York, Charles Ashcombe worked tirelessly to manage the influx of gold deposits. Word of the Clearinghouse’s success had spread across the Atlantic, and merchants from as far as Canada and South America now sought to join the system.

Charles knew that his father’s imprisonment was a calculated risk. “If we crumble now,” he wrote to Reginald in a coded letter, “the state will take this as a victory. But every pound they print only makes us stronger.”

He dispatched a fresh batch of promissory notes to Britain, each meticulously signed and backed by the growing gold reserves. These notes became symbols of resistance, not just to inflation but to the war itself.

By April 1915, the mood in Westminster had shifted dramatically. Reports from the Western Front painted a grim picture of static trench warfare, mounting casualties, and dwindling resources. On the home front, inflation had spiralled out of control, and public unrest threatened the fragile unity of the war effort.

For the first time, serious discussions about ending the war began to surface in the corridors of power. While no one dared call it surrender, whispers of a negotiated peace with Germany grew louder. Britain could not sustain the economic chaos much longer.

In Threadneedle street, Keynes presented a bold and Machiavellian plan. “We cannot allow Ashcombe’s rebellion to dictate terms. If we sue for peace, we must control the narrative. Ashcombe must be seen not as the saviour of sound money but as the architect of this crisis. We must protect the state at all costs, even if it means allowing chaos for a time.”

The plan was as ruthless as it was cunning:

1. End the War: Parliament would propose a negotiated peace, framing it as a strategic withdrawal to preserve British lives and rebuild the economy. The move would be sold as a victory, emphasizing that the Germans had been halted at the gates of Paris.
2. Orchestrate Hyperinflation: Keynes suggested a temporary acceleration of inflation to a shocking degree. By printing vast amounts of sterling, the government could ensure Ashcombe's Clearinghouse notes would be swept up in the ensuing chaos.
3. Blame Ashcombe: Propaganda would frame Ashcombe and his Clearinghouse as the root cause of the economic collapse. The aristocracy's alignment with him would be portrayed as treachery against the common people.
4. Incite a Riot: Returning soldiers, angry at their treatment and seeking scapegoats, would be encouraged to march on Bamford, Ashcombe's estate. This would solidify his image as a villain in the public eye.
5. Restore the Gold Standard: Once the Clearinghouse was discredited and the chaos subsided, the Bank of England would quietly restore the gold standard, regaining control over the economy.

Reginald was freed from his London prison under the guise of house arrest and returned to his estate in Bamford. Officially, his release was a gesture of goodwill, part of a broader government attempt to "reconcile the nation." In reality, it was a calculated move to ensure he was present when the storm hit.

As he walked through the familiar halls of his estate, Reginald could feel the weight of the government's machinations pressing down on him. Letters and reports from Charles in New York confirmed what he had suspected: the Treasury was flooding the economy with paper sterling, pushing inflation to unbearable levels.

The people, desperate and furious, were turning their rage toward anyone associated with privilege and wealth. Pamphlets circulated, accusing Ashcombe of hoarding gold while the masses starved. Effigies of him were burned in factory towns.

By early May, the government began quietly demobilizing troops from the Western Front. Many returned to a Britain that was unrecognizable. The price of bread had quadrupled, and riots broke out in major cities. Soldiers, unpaid and disillusioned, found themselves caught in the economic storm.

Word spread of a planned march to Bamford. What began as a disorganized group of workers and soldiers soon swelled into a mob of thousands. Carrying banners and torches, they marched toward the Ashcombe estate, demanding justice for their suffering.

Inside the estate, Reginald prepared for the worst. He had already sent the remaining gold reserves abroad, ensuring the Clearinghouse's survival. But he knew that this was no longer just about money. This was a battle for his name, his legacy.

As the riots engulfed Bamford, the government seized the moment. Newspapers the next morning carried lurid headlines:

"Ashcombe's Gold Hoard Exposed!"
"Clearinghouse Notes: The Real Enemy of the People"

Behind the scenes, the Bank of England moved quickly to restore order. The Treasury announced the return to the gold standard, framing it as a heroic effort to save the nation from Ashcombe's treachery. Keynes himself toured the country, delivering speeches that painted Ashcombe as a misguided idealist who had nearly brought Britain to ruin.

As the dust settled, Reginald sat in the ruins of his estate, contemplating his next move. The Clearinghouse had survived, but its influence in Britain was shattered. The aristocracy, once rallying behind him, had retreated into the shadows, fearful of further retribution.

Yet, as he read reports from Charles in America, Reginald knew the fight was far from over. Across the Atlantic, the Clearinghouse was thriving. Gold reserves had tripled, and merchants from around the world were adopting its notes.

"Let them call me a villain," he thought. "History will decide who truly saved Britain."

For now, his path was clear: rebuild, adapt, and prepare for the next battle in the war for sound money.

His small home on the edge of Sheffield was unremarkable, tucked away among a row of modest houses. Its simplicity was deliberate, chosen by Reginald Ashcombe to shield himself from prying eyes and the wrath of a public misled by propaganda. Sitting in a well-worn armchair near the fireplace, he gazed out the window at the faint outlines of the moors in the distance. The fog settled low, mirroring the haze of his thoughts.

He had orchestrated a plan that had saved the empire from financial collapse, hobbled the war effort, and, in his mind, preserved the lives of countless soldiers who might otherwise have perished in futile trench warfare. And yet, he was branded a villain.

Reginald picked up the day's paper. Headlines spoke of economic despair, of inflation and ruin. Effigies of him still burned in the industrial towns, and returning soldiers grumbled about the wealthy aristocrat who had undermined the war effort. Keynes had succeeded in making him the scapegoat.

They don't understand, he thought, how could they? The intricacies of monetary economics, the decisions made in the shadows of power—these were worlds beyond the understanding of the common man. To them, he was the man who had abandoned them, who had dared to defy the Bank of England and the Treasury.

He thought of Charles, now firmly established in New York, overseeing the Clearinghouse. The reports from across the Atlantic were encouraging: gold reserves were secure, the notes gaining wider acceptance. His sister and her children were safe, ensconced in the Peak District, away from the turmoil that still gripped much of the country.

The land that had defined the Ashcombe legacy for centuries was nearly gone. Selling the remaining estate in Bamford had been an inevitability, its ruins symbolic of the cost of his resistance. But Reginald didn't regret it. He had played his part in history, securing a foundation for the future, even if it meant living out his days in obscurity.

He poured himself a small glass of brandy, the amber liquid catching the glow of the fire. The warmth spread through him, mingling with a quiet pride. He knew the truth, even if no one else did. He had saved the empire from itself, had shielded it from the full consequences of its folly.

Yet, he also knew that history was written by victors, and in this instance, the victors were Keynes and the Treasury. They had successfully blamed him for the nation's ills, casting him as the man who undermined the war effort.

But history's judgment was not final. Time would reveal the cracks in the story, the inconsistencies in the narrative. One day, perhaps long after he was gone, the truth might come to light.

They will curse me for years, perhaps decades, he mused, but in the end, they will see. They will see that I gave them peace, saved their sons, preserved their future, even if they call me a traitor now.

Reginald leaned back in his chair, the firelight dancing across his lined face. His life as a public figure was over, but his influence would endure, carried forward by the Clearinghouse and the principles of sound money. The empire had been preserved, and the lives of thousands, perhaps millions, had been spared.

He drained the brandy, placed the glass on the table beside him, and turned his gaze once more to the window. The moors lay silent, eternal. Like them, he would endure. In his own quiet way, Reginald Ashcombe was at peace.

END OF PART ONE

PART TWO

Chapter 6:

The winter light of 1925 spilled through the high windows of the Ashcombe Bank's New York headquarters, gilding the marble floors and casting long shadows across the vault-like silence of the main hall. Charles Ashcombe stood at the apex of this world, his name etched into the city's financial fabric alongside the titans of Wall Street. From his corner office, perched high above the teeming avenues of Lower Manhattan, he gazed at the skyline—a patchwork of glass, steel, and ambition that seemed as untouchable as the gold reserves quietly growing under his control.

Charles wore his power lightly. To those who met him in the dining rooms of the Plaza or on the veranda of his Long Island estate, he was the embodiment of the Jazz Age ideal—elegant, charming, and disarmingly aloof. Yet beneath the polished exterior, his mind was a whirring machine of calculations, constantly anticipating the next shift in the economic tides. This was a skill honed in the shadow of his father, Reginald Ashcombe, whose final years had been a masterclass in both defiance and disillusionment. If the elder Ashcombe had built a clearinghouse for sound money in the chaos of war, Charles had refined it into a banking empire in the chaos of peace.

But peace, as Charles well knew, was an illusion. He had seen the speculative fervour gripping Wall Street—men drunk on paper profits, investing fortunes conjured from credit rather than earned through labour. He had watched the dance floors of New York swell with frenetic energy, a perfect echo of the precarious market that fed the city's appetite for excess. In every whispered stock tip and every champagne toast, he felt the rumblings of an earthquake. And Charles Ashcombe was no stranger to earthquakes.

Charles Ashcombe has carried the weight of his family's legacy to America, but the scars of his father's downfall and the sense of being an outsider in a world of frenetic American ambition remain with him. As he watches the speculative frenzy of Wall Street, Charles pens a letter to an old family friend, Ludwig von Mises, seeking clarity amid the chaos.

Ashcombe Bank, New York
February 1925

Dear Professor von Mises,

I trust this letter finds you well and that Vienna continues to provide you with the intellectual richness you so deserve. I write from a nation intoxicated by its own prosperity, one whose financial markets have, in my view, strayed dangerously far from reason and reality.

Since my reluctant departure from England following the war, I have endeavored to carry on the principles my father so ardently believed in, though I fear his demise is a cautionary tale I cannot quite shake. You may have heard of his death—three years ago now, almost to the day. The man who once shook the foundations of the British Empire succumbed not to political enemies but to the slow poison of his own regret. Penniless and disillusioned, he spent his final days haunting the very countryside he had once sought to save.

My aunt, too, has been swept away by the tides of history, marrying a middling army officer—though I suspect her decision was one born less of love than necessity. As for myself, I find that America has granted me the dubious privilege of exile cloaked in wealth. The clearinghouse that began in the dark days of war has transformed into the Ashcombe Bank, a formidable institution here in New York. Yet, despite the accolades and the marble offices, I remain an Englishman in a country that distrusts what it cannot immediately profit from.

Professor, I turn to you now as a student to a teacher. The speculative mania gripping Wall Street fills me with unease. The appetite for stocks, fuelled by an endless stream of credit and a collective delusion of perpetual growth, seems to me a harbinger of catastrophe. I recall your work on the instability of artificial booms and the inevitable busts that follow. Do you see the same fault lines from where you stand?

Moreover, I wonder: how might a man in my position prepare for what feels like the inevitable? I have gold enough in my vaults to weather storms, but gold alone is no shield against the machinations of a state intent on preserving its illusions at any cost. Should I withdraw further from this dance of folly, focusing only on protecting what wealth remains sound? Or do you see a path through which men of principle might act to mitigate the ruin before it arrives?

I confess I write this not just as a banker but as a man haunted by his father's ghost. Reginald Ashcombe believed he could save the world, yet the world has gone on much as before, heedless of his warnings. Perhaps he acted too boldly, or perhaps not boldly enough. I fear I have inherited his uncertainty even as I stand on firmer financial ground.

Please, Professor, share your wisdom with a wayward disciple. What course of action should a man of sound money and clear thought take in this age of roaring delusion?

Yours faithfully,
Charles Ashcombe

The air in Manhattan was sharp and bracing, the kind that left no room for doubt about the season. Winter lingered like an unwanted guest, but the city pulsed with energy, unbothered by the chill. Charles folded the letter to von Mises with deliberate precision, sealing it with wax and the Ashcombe crest—a habit from a bygone era that amused his American assistants. He left it on his desk, trusting his secretary to dispatch it promptly.

From his office window on the twenty-second floor of the Ashcombe Bank building, he surveyed the city below. The streets were alive with the clang of trolleys and the endless churn of humanity, all moving with the single-minded purpose of making a fortune or spending one. The ash-colored sky seemed to glow faintly with the promise of opportunity—or the threat of calamity, depending on one's mood.

Charles donned his overcoat and hat, stepping out into the chaotic brilliance of Fifth Avenue. His driver waited in the gleaming Packard, the automobile's polished chrome reflecting the bustle of pedestrians and street vendors hawking everything from roasted chestnuts to the latest financial tips.

"Take me to Delmonico's," Charles said, settling into the leather seat.

The ride was swift, and soon he was stepping into the grand dining room, where gilt mirrors and heavy drapes muffled the din of the outside world. Delmonico's was the beating heart of New York's elite, a place where fortunes were made over steaks and martinis, and reputations destroyed with a careless word.

"Ah, Ashcombe," called a voice from a nearby table. It was Henry Van Alstyne, a portly industrialist who had recently ventured into film production. "Come, join us! We were just talking about the latest from Hollywood."

Charles obliged, sliding into the plush chair and accepting a glass of champagne that sparkled like liquid gold. The table was a microcosm of the Jazz Age: financiers, socialites, and a writer who had apparently just sold a novel to Scribner's. Conversations overlapped, a cacophony of ambition and indulgence.

"Charles," said a woman across the table, her crimson lips curving into a smile. "I heard you threw quite the party last weekend. Will there be another?"

He smiled politely. "Perhaps. Though I find these parties have a way of getting out of hand."

"That's the point, darling," she replied with a wink.

The conversation turned to the stock market, a topic that electrified every gathering these days. Tales of overnight fortunes abounded, with anecdotes of cab drivers offering stock tips and shoe shiners boasting their own portfolios. Charles listened, detached, his mind drifting back to the letter he had written that morning.

As the lunch wound down, the group began to scatter, each attendee off to pursue their respective schemes. Charles stepped back into the cold, declining his driver's offer of a ride. Instead, he strolled down Fifth Avenue, letting the rhythm of the city wash over him. Jazz drifted from a nearby speak easy, its syncopated notes a fitting soundtrack for an age that seemed to defy logic and restraint.

He passed the bright lights of department stores, their window displays a shrine to excess. Fur coats, diamond tiaras, auto mobiles—America had made a god of consumption, and New York was its temple. By the time he returned to his penthouse apartment, the city's energy had waned, replaced by the muted hum of evening. He poured himself a glass of scotch and stood by the window, watching the lights of the city flicker like stars brought to earth. Somewhere in the chaos below, fortunes were being made and lost, dreams conjured and shattered.

Charles raised his glass to the city, as much in defiance as in admiration. He would play his role in this frenetic age, but always on his terms. The roaring 20s might devour lesser men, but Charles Ashcombe had seen the folly of empires crumble. He would not let this one consume him.

The night folded gently over New York, softening its edges but never fully dimming its vitality. Charles changed into a tailored tuxedo, the black silk lapels catching the faint amber glow of the lamps in his penthouse. His evening would be a carefully curated mix of leisure and purpose—an art he had perfected since ascending to the heights of Manhattan's elite.

At precisely eight, a knock sounded at his door. His valet opened it to reveal Sandra Carmichael, a journalist for The New Yorker whose sharp wit and sharper tongue had won her admiration and fear in equal measure. Her bobbed hair framed her angular face, and she wore a green satin dress that shimmered like a serpent under the light.

"Charles," she said, stepping inside without waiting for an invitation. "You're late. Or did you forget we had plans?"

"I never forget," Charles replied smoothly, gesturing for his valet to pour them Martinis. "I simply savour the anticipation."

Eleanor arched an eyebrow, but her smirk betrayed amusement. "Careful, Ashcombe. Your charm is beginning to feel rehearsed."

"Only because you've heard it too many times."

They left shortly afterward, descending the elevator and stepping into the Packard. Tonight's destination was the Silver Swan, an underground jazz club that catered to a mix of financiers, artists, and society's disaffected. The club was tucked away in a nondescript building in Greenwich Village, its entrance concealed behind a heavy velvet curtain.

Inside, the atmosphere was intoxicating. Smoke curled lazily toward the ceiling, mingling with the notes of a trumpet that cut through the air like a clarion call. Couples swayed to the music, their movements loose and free in a way that would scandalize more proper establishments uptown. Waiters navigated the crowded room with trays of cocktails, their faces impassive amid the revelry.

Charles and Eleanor were shown to a corner table, their drinks arriving moments later. As Sandra scanned the room for familiar faces, Charles let his gaze wander. The band was led by a young black pianist whose fingers danced over the keys with a virtuosity that seemed to transcend the earthly constraints of his instrument. The audience was rapt, their collective energy feeding into the performance in a loop of mutual exhilaration.

"So, what's the real reason you brought me here?" Sandra asked, breaking Charles's reverie. "You're not exactly the jazz-club type."

"Am I not?" Charles replied, swirling his drink. "Perhaps I'm here to broaden my horizons."

"Or perhaps you're here to meet someone," she said, her eyes narrowing with suspicion.

Charles allowed himself a small smile but said nothing. Moments later, a man approached their table, his appearance unremarkable save for the aura of precision he exuded. He was lean, with a clean-shaven face and an impeccably tailored suit that spoke of wealth without ostentation.

“Mr. Ashcombe,” the man said, inclining his head. “A pleasure to see you.”

“Likewise, Mr. Whitaker,” Charles replied, standing to shake his hand.

Whitaker led Charles to a private room at the back of the club. The door closed behind them with a soft click, muffling the music and chatter outside. Inside, a small group of men awaited, their expressions grave. A map of the stock market districts was spread out on the table, marked with lines and symbols that only an insider would understand.

Whitaker gestured for Charles to take a seat at the table, where the other men murmured greetings. A waiter slipped in silently, placing a fresh cocktail in front of each attendee before vanishing like a ghost.

The map of the stock market districts sprawled across the table, annotated with bold red circles and pencilled-in notes that resembled an alchemist's cryptic symbols. To anyone outside their circle, it would look like gibberish. To Charles and the men gathered here, it was a blueprint for riches.

“Gentlemen,” began Whitaker, his voice calm but charged with excitement, “our time is now. The market has climbed to heights we’ve never seen before, and I don’t think it’s anywhere near its ceiling.”

The others nodded in agreement, their faces lighting up at the mere suggestion of untapped wealth. Charles, however, leaned back in his chair, swirling his drink as he observed their enthusiasm with a trace of amusement.

“Let me guess,” Charles said dryly. “Railroads, steel, oil, and radios? The same old bets with a dash of new glamour thrown in?”

“Precisely,” Whitaker replied, undeterred. “But this time, it’s different. The market is self-sustaining now. We’re in a new era, Mr. Ashcombe. Industrial innovation, mass production—it’s all creating wealth at a rate we’ve never experienced before.”

Another man, Peterson, chimed in. He was a portly banker with a cigar that he wielded like a conductor's baton. “You’re being too modest, Whitaker. This isn’t just a new era—it’s the start of perpetual growth. The American economy is the engine of the world, and it’s running full steam ahead. Everyone wants a piece of it.”

Charles smirked, his scepticism masked by politeness. “And you think the market will continue this relentless climb?”

“Of course it will,” Peterson said, his confidence unshakable. “Look at the data. Every sector is booming. Consumer demand is insatiable, and credit is flowing like water. Why shouldn’t it go up forever?”

“Because,” Charles said slowly, “forever is a very long time.”

His remark hung in the air for a moment before Whitaker laughed, breaking the tension. “Always the realist, aren’t you, Ashcombe? But come now, you can’t deny the opportunities we’re seeing. The public is hungry for stocks. Everyone from the butcher to the schoolteacher is buying in.”

“That,” Charles said, his tone sharpening, “is what worries me.”

“Worry is for the timid,” Peterson countered, waving his cigar. “We’re on the cusp of something extraordinary. Take radios, for example. RCA shares have doubled in value in six months. People aren’t just investing in a company—they’re investing in the future.”

“And the future always pays out, doesn’t it?” Charles said, his voice laced with irony.

Whitaker leaned forward, his expression serious now. “What about you, Charles? You’ve got the capital, the connections. What’s your play?”

Charles considered this. He didn’t share their blind faith in the market’s immortality, but he understood the power of perception. If everyone believed the market would go up, it would—until it didn’t.

“Real estate and gold,” Charles said finally. “Land never loses its value, and Manhattan is growing by the day. I’ll stick to something solid.”

Peterson snorted. “Land is safe, but it’s not exciting. You won’t make the kind of returns we’re seeing in the market. Mark my words, Ashcombe—stocks are the future. Play it right, and you’ll be richer than any landowner.”

“Gentlemen, I wonder,” he began, “have any of you heard of a certain Professor Ludwig von Mises?”

The name drew blank stares from most of the group, save for Whitaker, who furrowed his brow in vague recognition.

“Mises?” Whitaker repeated. “A European economist, isn’t he? Something to do with gold, I think. Why do you ask?”

Charles nodded. “That’s the man. He was a great influence on my late father—gave him the idea for the clearinghouse back during the war.”

Peterson scoffed lightly. “That little stunt of your father’s? Effective, I’ll grant you, but hardly orthodox economics.”

“It wasn’t meant to be,” Charles replied smoothly. “Orthodoxy was precisely what Mises challenged. He’s written extensively about central banking, about how institutions like the Federal Reserve manipulate interest rates to create an illusion of prosperity. Easy money policies, he calls it, where credit flows freely, but it’s built on an unstable foundation. The distortions in the market eventually catch up, and when they do…”

He paused for effect, letting the gravity of his words sink in.

“…they bring everything crashing down.”

Whitaker frowned, tapping a finger on the table. “Sounds like a doomsday prophet to me. The market has its ups and downs, but we’ve never seen anything like the kind of collapse you’re describing. The system is stronger than that.”

“Is it?” Charles asked, raising an eyebrow. “Think about it. What’s fuelling this boom? Real production, or speculative credit? Are we investing in businesses that create value, or are we gambling on the belief that someone else will pay more tomorrow for what we buy today?”

Peterson bristled. “You’re talking like a gold bug, Ashcombe. No offence, but gold’s a relic. The market is the future.”

“And yet,” Charles countered, “gold has never defaulted. Land has never vanished overnight. Stocks, on the other hand…” He let the thought trail off, gesturing to the map on the table. “This irrational exuberance can’t last forever. When the music stops, the ones holding real assets will still have something of value. The rest will be left with paper and promises.”

Whitaker shifted uncomfortably. “So what are you saying? That we should all sell out and start hoarding gold bars in our basements?”

“I’m saying,” Charles replied, “that Mises has a point. Central banks are not the engines of stability they claim to be. They’re engines of chaos, distorting the true signals of the market. This boom feels unstoppable, but that’s precisely why it’s dangerous.”

Charles leaned forward, his voice cutting through the haze of cigar smoke and the hum of conversation. “I will not give up my gold to the stock market,” he said firmly.

The group turned their attention to him, some amused, others sceptical. Peterson raised an eyebrow. “Still clinging to the past, Charles? The bourse is the future—wealth at your fingertips, growth at a pace the old systems could never match.”

Charles smiled faintly, shaking his head. “The bourse,” he said, “is an old idea dressed in modern clothes. A thousand years ago, merchants speculated on the price of spices and silks; today, you speculate on steel and railroads. But there’s a fundamental difference between what you’re trading and what I hold.”

“And what’s that?” Whitaker asked, leaning back with an indulgent smirk.

“Gold,” Charles replied, his tone steady, “is a store of value. It cannot be overvalued or undervalued; it simply is. Its worth is not tied to the fortunes of a single company or the whims of a fickle market. It’s pure value, unadulterated and immutable.”

Peterson rolled his eyes. “Gold doesn’t grow, Charles. It sits in a vault, gleaming but useless. The stock exchange allows capital to flow, to be productive. Companies expand, innovate, create wealth for everyone. Gold just… gathers dust.”

“That’s where you’re wrong,” Charles said. “The stock exchange doesn’t provide a store of value; it’s a gamble on the underlying performance of companies, on the confidence of the market. That confidence can be shattered in an instant. Stocks rise and fall, often untethered from reality. Gold, on the other hand, remains constant. It’s not subject to the illusions of prosperity or the panic of collapse. It’s a bedrock.”

Whitaker frowned. “You’re saying gold is the only true wealth?”

Charles nodded. “In a world manipulated by easy money and central banking, yes. You don’t understand this because you’ve been conditioned to believe that paper promises and speculative bubbles are the same as value. They’re not. When the tide goes out—and it will—it’s gold that people will scramble for, not shares in overleveraged fantasies.”

The stockbroker, a young man with slicked-back hair and a restless energy, leaned forward, his voice rising. “So you’re saying we’re fools for riding the greatest bull market in history? That we’re all just blind to some impending catastrophe?”

Charles met his gaze evenly. “I’m saying,” he said slowly, “that you don’t understand what you’re building. You’re stacking cards on a foundation of sand. When the storm comes—and make no mistake, it will come—you’ll wish you had something as simple, as solid, as certain as gold.”

The room fell silent, save for the faint strains of jazz drifting in from the club below. Charles leaned back, swirling the amber liquid in his glass. He had no intention of convincing them. Time would do that for him.

Whitaker leaned forward, his fingers drumming lightly on the table. “Charles, I’ve always admired your principles, but don’t you worry that your old-fashioned nature might be holding the Ashcombe Bank back? While you’re sitting on your gold reserves, others are moving their money into stocks, riding this wave of prosperity. It’s a different era—adapt or lose out.”

Charles smiled faintly, a glint of steel in his eyes. “The Ashcombe Bank wasn’t built on chasing the crowd, Whitaker. It was built on doing things differently—on sound principles, not speculative frenzy.” He paused, swirling his drink before taking a measured sip. “You know the story. My father started the clearinghouse during the war when the Bank of England abandoned sound money. He followed Mises then, and I follow him now. That’s why we’ve weathered storms others didn’t survive.”

“Storms,” Whitaker scoffed, though not unkindly. “Charles, this isn’t a storm; it’s a golden age! The economy’s soaring, people are making fortunes overnight. Do you really believe this market will turn?”

“I don’t believe,” Charles said sharply, his tone cutting through the room’s easy camaraderie. “I know. The stock market cannot go up forever. It’s being fuelled by easy credit and irrational exuberance, not by genuine, sustainable value. Mises teaches us that distortions like these always end in correction—often a violent one. When that happens, it’s those who held to fundamentals who will stand tall, not those who played the game of fools.”

Whitaker leaned back, his expression somewhere between amusement and exasperation. “You’re a stubborn man, Charles. But mark my words, if the Ashcombe Bank doesn’t find a way to adapt, you may find yourself losing clients to competitors who are willing to embrace the new age.”

Charles shrugged, a calm confidence radiating from him. “Let them go. Ashcombe has always been for those who understand value, not illusion. The ones who leave now will return when the illusions shatter. And when they do, they’ll know where to find the bedrock.”

Whitaker smirked. “And what happens if the market doesn’t crash? What if we’re just at the beginning of a long, golden era?”

“Then I’ll eat my hat,” Charles replied, a rare smile breaking across his face. “But I wouldn’t bet on it. Not with my bank, and certainly not with my name.”

The room fell silent, a faint tension lingering in the air. Charles leaned back in his chair, his gaze steady and unwavering. The Ashcombe Bank had survived because it stood apart, and he had no intention of letting it falter now.

Charles rose from his chair, offering Whitaker and the others a curt nod. “Gentlemen, I’ll leave you to your speculations. Do let me know when the market finds a way to defy the laws of economics.” He adjusted his coat, the faintest trace of a smile at the corner of his mouth, and left the room.

As he stepped into the brisk New York evening, the air was alive with the hum of the city. Cars honked, the streetlights cast a golden glow, and the rhythm of the jazz age pulsed in the distance. Yet Charles felt a quiet unease settle over him. He had faced doubters before—his father’s entire legacy had been forged in defiance of the establishment—but the tide of irrationality sweeping through the financial world now felt unstoppable.

Over the next few months, the Ashcombe Bank began to feel the pressure. Clients who had once trusted the stability of gold started withdrawing their deposits, chasing the easy money promised by the roaring stock market. The newspapers were filled with tales of overnight fortunes, of ordinary men turned millionaires, and of a nation intoxicated by its own success.

Charles remained resolute, though the shrinking balance sheets were a stark reminder of the challenges he faced. The Ashcombe Bank had always been a bastion of sound money, a safe harbour in turbulent times. Yet now, it seemed the very principles that had built its reputation were becoming a liability in the face of the stock market frenzy.

Each day brought whispers of new highs, of unstoppable growth. But Charles held his course, knowing that bubbles always burst.

One crisp morning in March 1926, Charles found a letter waiting for him at his desk. The handwriting was unmistakably Ludwig von Mises’. With a sense of anticipation, Charles broke the seal and unfolded the pages.

Dear Charles,

Your last letter was a welcome reminder that there are still men in this world who value reason and principle over folly and speculation. I must commend your steadfastness in these uncertain times, even as others around you succumb to the siren call of the stock market.

I have studied the developments in America closely. The Federal Reserve has embarked on a path that can only end in calamity. By keeping interest rates artificially low, they are flooding the market with cheap credit, encouraging malinvestment on a massive scale. The stock market, fuelled by this easy money, has become a house of cards—precarious and unsustainable.

Rest assured, you are following the right path. The allure of quick profits may dazzle, but it is gold that remains the true measure of value. When the inevitable correction comes, those who have anchored themselves in sound money will find safety, while others will face ruin.

Your father’s vision, and your commitment to it, is a beacon in these turbulent times. The Ashcombe Bank stands for something greater than the fleeting gains of speculation—it stands for enduring value, for principles that do not waver with the whims of the market.

Hold fast, my friend. The storm is coming, but you are prepared.

With great respect,
Ludwig von Mises

Charles set the letter down, a faint smile on his lips. Mises' words reaffirmed what he already knew, but in the face of mounting pressures, the validation was a much-needed boost.

The night was alive with the restless energy of the city, a symphony of horns, laughter, and clinking glasses that spilled out from the clubs and cabarets onto the crowded streets of New York. Charles Ashcombe stepped out of his car, the polished black Cadillac gleaming under the gaslights, and adjusted his silk tie. He had never quite embraced the chaos of this modern age, but he understood its allure. The city was electric, and its people intoxicated by the illusion that the good times would never end.

Inside the Blue Serenade, one of the city's most exclusive jazz clubs, the air was thick with smoke and promise. The band played a frenzied rhythm, the trumpet wailing above the syncopated beats of the drums. Couples swayed on the dance floor, their movements unrestrained, their laughter unbridled. Charles observed it all with the practised detachment of a man who had seen the world turn on its axis more than once.

"Mr. Ashcombe!" A voice cut through the din. It was Whitaker, his friend and occasional adversary, grinning like a man who had just won a bet. "I wasn't sure you'd make it tonight. Thought you might be holed up in that office of yours, counting your gold."

Charles smirked. "Someone has to keep the lights on while the rest of you drink yourselves into oblivion."

Whitaker laughed, clapping Charles on the shoulder. "Come on, you old miser. Let me introduce you to someone."

They wove through the crowd, past glittering chandeliers and waiters balancing trays of champagne flutes. Whitaker stopped at a corner table, where a woman sat with a cigarette poised elegantly between her fingers. Her bobbed hair was the colour of midnight, and her dress shimmered like the ocean under moonlight.

"Mr. Ashcombe, meet Evelyn Harper," Whitaker announced. "She's just returned from Paris and has all the best gossip about Hemingway and Picasso."

Evelyn looked up, her eyes sharp and curious. "The infamous Charles Ashcombe," she said, extending her hand. "I've heard you're the only man in New York who isn't trying to buy half of Wall Street."

Charles took her hand, a slight smile playing on his lips. "Then you've heard right."

As the night wore on, the group at the table expanded, drawing in writers, brokers, and socialites. The talk ranged from art to politics, but inevitably, it landed on the stock market.

"It's unstoppable," declared a young broker named Langley, his cheeks flushed with drink. "We're living in a new age. The market will only go up from here."

Evelyn raised an eyebrow. "That sounds dangerously optimistic."

"Optimistic? No, my dear, realistic," Langley insisted. "Everyone's making money. Even the bootleggers are investing."

Charles sipped his whiskey, silent until Evelyn turned to him. “What do you think, Mr. Ashcombe? Is the market as invincible as our friend here believes?”

“I think,” Charles began, setting his glass down, “that anything built on speculation is bound to collapse. The stock market is not a store of value. It’s a gamble on the underlying worth of companies—some sound, most not.”

Langley scoffed. “You’re stuck in the past, Ashcombe. Gold and land? Those are relics. This is the future.”

“Perhaps,” Charles replied coolly. “But relics have a way of enduring, while bubbles have a way of bursting.”

Evelyn leaned forward, intrigued. “So, you’re saying all this—” she gestured to the room, to the city, to the age—“is an illusion?”

Charles hesitated, glancing around at the revelry, the careless abandon. “Not an illusion. But a distraction. Easy money creates easy lives, and easy lives... well, they’re rarely built to last.”

The group fell quiet, the weight of his words briefly cutting through the haze of champagne and jazz. Then Whitaker broke the silence with a hearty laugh. “Ashcombe, you always know how to bring a room down. Come on, let’s drink to easy lives while we have them.”

Later, as Charles watched the dancers swirl under the golden light, he felt a pang of dissonance. This world was intoxicating, but it was also fragile. He thought of his father, a man who had torn down an empire’s financial system, only to drink himself to death in the aftermath. The parallels were hard to ignore.

For all the glitter and glamour, Charles knew the foundation was weak. And in the back of his mind, Ludwig von Mises’ warnings loomed like a spectre. The music played on, louder and faster, as if trying to drown out the inevitable silence that would follow.

He drained his glass and signalled for another, deciding that tonight, at least, he would let the city carry him along in its mad, beautiful dance. Tomorrow, he would return to the quiet, steady resolve that had kept him grounded while the world spun out of control. Tonight, though, he would let the Jazz Age sing its siren song.

The night was still young when Charles found himself momentarily alone at the bar, his companions having scattered to the dance floor or disappeared into the smoky haze of the Blue Serenade’s hidden alcoves. He was nursing his second glass of whiskey, savouring the quiet respite amidst the cacophony, when a voice interrupted his thoughts.

“Mr. Ashcombe, isn’t it?”

Charles turned, startled, to see a man standing beside him. His face was sharp, almost hawkish, framed by slicked-back hair. He wore a perfectly tailored suit with the confidence of someone accustomed to commanding a room. It took Charles a moment to place him, but then the realization dawned.

“Mr. Fitzgerald,” Charles said, extending his hand. “A pleasure.”

F. Scott Fitzgerald smiled, though his expression carried the faint melancholy that seemed to follow him everywhere. He took the offered hand and ordered a gin rickey from the bartender.

“I’ve heard your name whispered among certain circles,” Fitzgerald said, taking a seat beside Charles. “The mysterious British banker who won’t touch the stock market. Quite the story.”

Charles raised an eyebrow. “And you find that interesting?”

“Why not? It’s rare to meet someone who isn’t drunk on the wine of this decade,” Fitzgerald replied. “Tell me, what’s your secret? Why resist the allure?”

Charles chuckled lightly, swirling the amber liquid in his glass. “It’s not resistance, Mr. Fitzgerald. It’s prudence. Gold and land—those are real. Tangible. The stock market is... well, it’s a promise, isn’t it? A promise that tomorrow will always be better than today.”

Fitzgerald leaned back, studying him with keen eyes. “And you don’t believe in promises?”

“I believe in the ones that can be kept.”

The author laughed, a sound both genuine and rueful. “You sound like my editor.”

Charles allowed himself a small smile. “And what brings you here tonight? Research for your next novel?”

Fitzgerald’s expression darkened slightly, and he took a long sip of his drink. “Research, distraction—call it what you will. This city has a way of pulling you in, doesn’t it? All these people chasing something they can’t quite name.”

“Some call it the American Dream,” Charles said.

Fitzgerald smirked. “Dreams can be dangerous things. The higher you climb, the harder the fall.”

The conversation drifted, touching on literature, the excesses of the age, and the quiet undercurrent of disillusionment that both men seemed to feel but rarely voiced. Fitzgerald was quick-witted and articulate, but there was a sadness in his words that resonated with Charles.

“Do you ever feel like you’re watching a play,” Fitzgerald mused, “where everyone else is on stage, caught up in the drama, and you’re stuck in the wings, seeing it for what it is?”

Charles nodded slowly. “Every day. The markets, the parties, the noise—it’s all theatre. But the audience doesn’t know the curtain will fall.”

“And when it does?” Fitzgerald asked, his tone almost wistful.

“Then we see who built their house on sand and who built it on stone.”

Fitzgerald regarded him thoughtfully, then raised his glass in a quiet toast. “To stone, then.”

Charles clinked his glass against Fitzgerald’s, and for a moment, the two men sat in companionable silence, their cynicism a shared refuge amidst the chaos of the Jazz Age.

As the band struck up a new tune and the crowd surged back to the dance floor, Fitzgerald stood and adjusted his suit. “You’re an interesting man, Ashcombe. If I ever write a banker into one of my stories, I might just borrow a thing or two from you.”

Charles smiled faintly. “Just make sure he doesn’t end up ruined.”

Fitzgerald laughed, a sound tinged with irony. “No promises.”

He disappeared into the crowd, leaving Charles alone once more. But the encounter lingered in Charles’ mind, a brief connection that felt oddly significant, as if Fitzgerald’s words had crystallized something he had long suspected but never fully articulated.

The Jazz Age had given the world its illusion of endless prosperity, but Charles knew better. Beneath the glitz and glamour, the foundations were already crumbling. He swirled the last of the whiskey in his tumbler, raising it slightly as if to toast his reflection. “To stone,” he murmured, echoing Fitzgerald’s earlier words.

The Ashcombe Bank was a monument to that vision. While British banks had bled gold reserves dry to fund the Great War, leaving themselves hollowed out and dependent on the Bank of England’s ever-weakening promises, the Ashcombe Bank had grown stronger. Its vaults held the hard currency the world still craved. Even in America, where speculation reigned supreme and fortunes were built on leverage, the Ashcombe Bank maintained its reputation for solidity. Depositors flocked to it during uncertain times, trusting in its reserves of gold and the Ashcombe name.

He was a man caught between two nations, two economies, two ways of life. Britain, the land of his birth, was struggling to maintain its once-great empire. The Bank of England was little more than a shadow of its former self, its reserves depleted and its currency devalued. Ministers had sent quiet envoys to Charles in the past year, hinting that Britain could use his bank’s help to stabilize its faltering economy.

But Charles was no longer the wide-eyed son of Reginald Ashcombe, willing to sacrifice everything for the sake of British glory. He had made his home in America, a land that, for all its flaws, still valued liberty and the entrepreneurial spirit. Here, he had built the Ashcombe Bank into a financial powerhouse, independent of the Bank of England’s influence and untethered from the failing British economy. To bail out Britain now would be to risk everything he had worked for.

At the far end of the room, a circle had gathered around a broad-shouldered man whose laugh boomed over the din. Franklin Delano Roosevelt, scion of one of America’s oldest families, stood as a figure of effortless confidence, a cigar in one hand and a tumbler of bourbon in the other. His sharp eyes met Charles’s from across the room, and a sly smile curved his lips.

“Ah, Mr. Ashcombe,” Roosevelt drawled as Charles approached. “The British exile with the golden touch. Come, join us. We were just discussing the state of Europe.”

Charles inclined his head and accepted a whiskey from a passing waiter. “Mr. Roosevelt,” he said evenly. “I’d be curious to hear your thoughts.”

Roosevelt’s smile broadened, but it didn’t reach his eyes. “Europe is aflame with new ideas. Italy and Germany, they’ve discovered a remarkable efficiency in collective action, wouldn’t you say? Fascism has its critics, of course, but it offers a way to curb the chaos of unbridled private ambition.”

There was a murmur of agreement from the group, though a few guests shifted uncomfortably. Charles met Roosevelt's gaze, his expression unreadable. "You're suggesting that curbing ambition is preferable to allowing individuals to create and prosper on their own terms?"

Roosevelt's laugh was sharp and mirthless. "Oh, come now, Mr. Ashcombe. Let's not be naïve. Your family's wealth, built on gold hoarded during the Great War, is precisely the kind of private ambition that destabilizes nations. Look at Britain—a shell of its former self, with the Ashcombe name whispered as a villain in its decline."

Charles stiffened slightly but kept his tone calm. "If by ambition you mean creating a refuge of sound money in a sea of paper promises, then yes, my family was ambitious. But I fail to see how centralizing power under the guise of efficiency benefits anyone but those at the helm."

Roosevelt's expression darkened, his jovial mask slipping for just a moment. "You misunderstand me, Mr. Ashcombe. The people don't need to prosper individually; they need to survive collectively. Too much wealth in private hands breeds inequality, and inequality breeds unrest. The Ashcombe Bank, with its stubborn adherence to gold, is a relic—a dangerous one at that."

The tension between the two men was palpable, the rest of the group caught between fascination and unease. Charles took a slow sip of his whiskey, his mind racing. "And yet, Mr. Roosevelt, the wealth of nations depends on trust. Trust in value, trust in fairness. Fiat money and centralized control erode that trust. Fascism may enforce compliance, but it cannot create prosperity."

Roosevelt leaned in slightly, his voice low and edged with steel. "Prosperity, Mr. Ashcombe, is what I define it to be. Not what you and your Austrian economists scribble in your little books. You'd do well to remember that."

The air between them was electric, their conversation a duel masked by civility. Charles set down his glass, his jaw tight but his voice steady. "The world has seen what happens when men define value on their own terms. It ends in ruin. Gold does not lie, Mr. Roosevelt. It cannot be printed, and it cannot be defined away."

Roosevelt's laugh echoed again, but there was no warmth in it. "Gold cannot be printed, but it can be confiscated. Just ask your dear father's homeland."

With that, Roosevelt turned back to the circle, his booming laugh and effortless charm reasserting themselves. Charles remained standing, his pulse steady but his mind seething. Roosevelt's words were not a mere debate—they were a warning, a harbinger of battles to come.

As the jazz band struck up a lively tune, Charles excused himself, retreating to the balcony to gather his thoughts. Below him, the city glittered like a promise, but in the back of his mind, he knew that promises had a way of breaking.

Charles leaned against the wrought-iron railing of the balcony, the night air cool against his face. Below, the city roared with life, its lights stretching into the distance like constellations spun from human ambition. He struck a match and lit his cigar, the flame briefly illuminating his sharp features before he shook it out. The first draw of smoke filled his lungs, grounding him amidst the swirling thoughts Roosevelt's words had left behind.

He stared out over the skyline, his mind replaying the conversation. Roosevelt's confidence, his dismissal of private wealth, his veiled threat—it all carried the weight of a man who believed in the inevitability of his own vision. The crowd in the ballroom might have laughed along, but Charles could feel the undercurrents. The world was shifting, and men like Roosevelt thought they could steer its course with sheer force of will.

Charles exhaled a plume of smoke, watching it curl and dissipate into the night. Gold cannot be printed, but it can be confiscated. The words echoed in his mind, and he couldn't help but marvel at their arrogance. None of them—Roosevelt, the financiers in their tailored suits, the glittering socialites swaying to the jazz inside—none of them understood. The Austrian school had shown him the truth: systems built on fiat money and central banking were castles made of sand, destined to crumble under the weight of their own distortions.

Gold, by contrast, was eternal. It needed no promises, no decrees. It was value, pure and unchanging. His father had understood that, even as the world turned against him. Reginald Ashcombe had sacrificed everything—his fortune, his reputation, even his health—to preserve the sanctity of sound money. And though he had died penniless and reviled, Charles carried his legacy forward.

He drew on the cigar again, the ember glowing brightly. Roosevelt's critique lingered, but it didn't unsettle him. The Ashcombe Bank had survived on principles others had dismissed as antiquated. While the world gorged itself on easy money and rising markets, Charles had kept the bank anchored in reality. Depositors might leave, seduced by the promise of endless returns in the stock market, but they would return when the tide inevitably turned.

The idea of confiscation gnawed at him, though. Would America follow Britain's path? The thought of government overreach, of the state attempting to strip him of the bank's reserves, was both infuriating and galvanizing. But Charles knew he was playing the long game. Let them inflate their currencies, drive up their stocks, and pat themselves on the back for their cleverness. The day of reckoning would come, and the Ashcombe Bank would be there, solid and unyielding, as the rest crumbled.

As the music from inside drifted out to the balcony, Charles took one last pull from his cigar before extinguishing it against the railing. The night stretched on, indifferent to the schemes and dreams of men like Roosevelt—or even himself. But Charles knew one thing with certainty: gold was truth. And truth, no matter how obscured, would always outlast the lies.

Chapter 7:

Charles reclined in the back seat of his Rolls-Royce, the hum of the engine mingling with the rhythmic clatter of hooves and wheels on the cobblestone streets of Manhattan. The city, alive in every sense, blurred past him in a kaleidoscope of flashing lights and the sway of feathered gowns. He flicked the ash from his cigar and looked out at the theatre district, where posters for musicals and plays lined the avenues like declarations of an endless celebration.

He was late. The party at the Belasco Theatre was already in full swing, a post-performance gala hosted by one of Broadway's wealthiest backers. It wasn't a world Charles frequented often, but Whitaker had insisted. "You're too stuck in your fortress of gold, Charles," he'd said with a smirk. "Come out. Meet someone who's not just counting your money for you."

The Rolls glided to a stop outside the theatre, and Charles stepped out, adjusting his dinner jacket and casting an appraising glance at the gathered crowd. Men in sharp tuxedos laughed too loudly, and women adorned with glittering jewels moved through the room like swans on a glassy lake.

Inside, the space hummed with the energy of champagne and applause still lingering from the night's performance. Charles moved through the throng with ease, exchanging perfunctory greetings with the occasional acquaintance. He was sipping a perfectly chilled Martini when he first noticed her.

She stood near the grand piano, her posture effortlessly elegant, her hair a cascade of auburn waves that shimmered under the chandelier's light. She wore a dress of deep emerald green, its satin folds accentuating her figure in a way that suggested she was entirely at ease with being the most striking woman in the room.

Someone leaned toward him. "That's Evelyn Carlisle," they whispered, as if sharing a secret. "The newest darling of the stage. Have you seen her in The Emerald Curtain? Magnificent."

Charles approached her with measured steps, the familiar confidence of a man who was rarely told no. Evelyn turned at his approach, her eyes—sharp and perceptive—locking onto his with a curiosity that belied the practised charm of her smile.

“You've done something remarkable,” Charles said, inclining his head slightly.

Her smile deepened. “Oh? And what's that?”

“You've managed to make a room full of self-important men and overdressed heiresses feel entirely invisible.”

Evelyn laughed, a sound that was both musical and genuine. “And you must be the charming financier everyone's too afraid to gossip about openly.”

Charles raised an eyebrow. “Charming? I wasn't aware I had a reputation for that.”

“Reputation precedes us all in this city,” she replied smoothly. “It's what we do with it that counts.”

When the party began to wane, Charles offered to see her home, and to his quiet surprise, she accepted. They stepped into his Rolls together, the night outside still electric with possibility. Evelyn leaned back in her seat, watching the city drift past through the window.

“You're different,” she said softly.

Charles glanced at her. “Different how?”

“I haven't decided yet,” she admitted, her lips curving into a sly smile. “But I intend to find out.”

The Rolls slid to a gentle stop in front of a stately brownstone on the Upper East Side. Evelyn's smile lingered as she stepped out, her emerald dress catching the light of a nearby streetlamp. Charles followed, his polished shoes clicking softly on the pavement. The air was crisp, carrying the faint scent of leaves and distant jazz spilling from an open window.

Evelyn turned to him, her face half-lit by the lamplight. “Thank you for the ride. It's been... illuminating.”

Charles chuckled, his breath clouding in the cold. “I'll take that as a compliment, though I suspect it's not entirely meant as one.”

“Smart and perceptive,” she teased. “Dangerous combination.”

He took a step closer, his hands slipping into his pockets. “You’re not one to shy away from danger, are you?”

Her eyes sparkled with mischief. “That would depend on the danger, Mr. Ashcombe.”

For a moment, the city seemed to pause around them. Charles studied her, the sharp curve of her cheekbone, the subtle flicker of amusement in her gaze. He found himself weighing his words more carefully than usual.

“Perhaps,” he said, breaking the silence, “we’re both a little dangerous.”

Evelyn tilted her head, considering him. Then, with a graceful pivot, she mounted the first step of the brownstone. “Goodnight, Charles,” she called over her shoulder, her voice light but lingering.

But just as she reached the door, she paused, looking back. “Tell me,” she said, “do you always walk away this easily?”

A grin tugged at the corner of his mouth. “Rarely.”

She laughed softly, the sound hanging in the air between them. Then, without another word, she slipped inside, the heavy door closing behind her.

Charles stood there for a moment, his breath a rhythm in the quiet street. He glanced up at the lit window on the second floor, catching the faint silhouette of her figure before she disappeared into the glow of the room.

Sliding back into the Rolls, he leaned his head against the cool leather, the faint scent of her perfume still lingering in the air. The driver glanced at him in the rear-view mirror but said nothing, knowing better than to interrupt whatever thoughts the financier was turning over in his mind.

In the weeks that followed, Evelyn became a quiet yet constant presence in Charles’s life, like the low hum of a distant jazz band. It began with a simple note, hand-delivered to the Ashcombe Bank’s imposing headquarters on Wall Street, the cream-coloured envelope discreetly tucked under his daily correspondence.

Charles,
Do you always leave a lady on her doorstep without asking when you might see her again? Perhaps I’m too forward, but I thought I might remedy the situation myself.
Cocktails tomorrow at the St. Regis? Or do financiers such as yourself not enjoy such frivolities?
—Evelyn

The ink was precise, the tone playful. He read it twice before slipping it into his jacket pocket.

The next evening, Charles found himself at the St. Regis, nursing a perfectly chilled Martini when she arrived, fashionably late. Evelyn swept into the room like a whisper of scandal, heads turning as her emerald dress—again—gleamed under the chandelier light. She spotted him, her lips curving into that now-familiar, knowing smile.

“Did I surprise you?” she asked, sliding into the seat opposite him.

“I’d be lying if I said no,” Charles admitted, raising his glass slightly. “But I don’t mind surprises. Especially not ones dressed in emerald.”

Their evenings together multiplied like jazz notes in a bebop solo—unpredictable, thrilling, and addictive. They met at speakeasies tucked behind unmarked doors, dined in private rooms of Manhattan’s finest establishments, and danced at rooftop parties where the skyline seemed to stretch infinitely beneath their feet.

But it wasn’t just the glitz and the laughter. Their correspondence between meetings deepened into something more profound. Evelyn had a sharp wit and a knack for asking the sort of questions that peeled back layers.

Charles,
You told me once that gold cannot be overvalued or undervalued, that it holds its worth regardless of the whims of men. Do you think the same can be said of people?

He pondered his reply late one evening in his study, her question nagging at him like the faint ticking of the clock on his desk.

Evelyn,
Gold is constant because it is immutable. People are the opposite—mutable to the point of chaos. But perhaps it is that very unpredictability that makes some of us... invaluable.

Their connection grew in the way Manhattan always seemed to grow—upward, bold, and dazzling. Yet, as Charles allowed himself to enjoy the rhythm of their companionship, his thoughts often returned to the looming uncertainties of the decade. The stock market soared with the kind of hubris he had been trained to distrust. Even as Evelyn teased him about his dour financial warnings, she listened, perhaps more closely than she let on.

One evening, as they stood on the terrace of her apartment, watching the city lights blur into the fog, she turned to him, her expression uncharacteristically serious.

“You don’t believe in this, do you?” she asked, gesturing vaguely toward the glowing skyline. “This city’s endless appetite for more, more, more?”

Charles took a long drag from his cigar, the ember flaring in the dim light. “I believe in value,” he said finally. “But not in chasing illusions. The city’s drunk on its own reflection, and one day, it’ll wake up to find the mirror shattered.”

Evelyn studied him, her sharp features softened by the haze. “And when that happens?”

He exhaled slowly, the smoke curling between them. “Those of us who’ve held fast to what’s real will still be standing.”

Her lips curved into a faint smile. “You sound so certain. It’s almost comforting.”

“Almost?” he teased.

She laughed softly, shaking her head. “You’re impossible, Charles Ashcombe.”

But as they stood there, the hum of the city below them, Charles couldn’t shake the feeling that Evelyn understood him in a way few ever had. For all the opulence of the Jazz Age, all its noise and sparkle, she was like a single, clear note cutting through the chaos—a reminder of what was real and what was fleeting.

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But as they stood there, the hum of the city below them, Charles couldn’t shake the feeling that Evelyn understood him in a way few ever had. For all the opulence of the Jazz Age, all its noise and sparkle, she was like a single, clear note cutting through the chaos—a reminder of what was real and what was fleeting.

The spring of 1927 unfurled in Central Park with the soft blush of magnolias and the crisp green of new leaves. Evelyn’s laugh became a familiar melody in Charles’ days, a tune that threaded through his work at the bank and the endless, glittering demands of New York society. They were unmistakably together now, their relationship the quiet talk of the city’s elite—a pairing that seemed, at least to the world outside, both inevitable and magnetic.

Their mornings often began in her apartment on the Upper West Side, where the smell of fresh coffee mingled with the scent of gardenias she kept on the windowsill. Charles would linger over the newspaper while Evelyn sat at her vanity, her hair falling in soft waves over her shoulders as she prepared for another day of rehearsals.

“You’re frowning,” she said one morning, glancing at him in the mirror.

“Am I?” Charles looked up, startled out of his thoughts.

“Yes, you are.” She walked over, her silk dressing gown trailing behind her, and perched on the arm of his chair. “What is it?”

He folded the paper and set it aside, placing a hand on her knee. “It’s the market,” he admitted. “There’s a frenzy building, something unnatural. It feels as though everyone is chasing a mirage.”

She studied him, her dark eyes thoughtful. “You don’t think it will last.”

“No,” he said firmly. “It never does.”

Evelyn tilted her head. “And yet, you’re still worried.”

He sighed. “It’s not just about the crash. It’s what comes after. The chaos, the blame. People don’t like to admit they’ve overreached, so they look for someone else to hold accountable.”

“And you think they’ll look to you?” she asked gently.

Charles gave a wry smile. “The Ashcombe name has a way of drawing fire, even from across the Atlantic.”

Evelyn leaned down, brushing her lips against his forehead. “Then we’ll face it together.”

Their afternoons were spent in the city’s galleries and cafés, their evenings at the theatre or with friends. Evelyn had a talent for lighting up any room she entered, and Charles often found himself stepping back, content to watch her charm those around her. But there were quieter moments too—walks through the park, late-night conversations over brandy, stolen hours when the city seemed to hold its breath just for them.

One such evening, they found themselves at a small jazz club in Harlem. The room was alive with the energy of the age, the music spilling out onto the street and drawing passers-by inside. Charles and Evelyn sat close in a shadowed corner, her hand resting lightly on his arm as they watched the band.

“Do you ever miss it?” she asked suddenly, her voice soft enough to be swallowed by the music.

“Miss what?” he replied, though he already knew.

“England. The life you had there.”

Charles considered this for a moment. “I miss the land,” he admitted. “The hills, the quiet. But the life? No. That world is gone.”

Evelyn looked at him, her eyes soft and searching. “Gone, or just changed?”

He shook his head. “It’s more than change. The war took more than lives—it took an entire way of living. My father understood that before anyone else did, though it cost him everything. England now...” He hesitated, searching for the right words. “It’s like a house with its foundation cracked. Still standing, but no longer steady.”

Evelyn slipped her hand through his arm as they walked, her touch both grounding and tender. “But the land remains,” she said quietly. “Hills and quiet, as you said. It must still call to you.”

“It does,” he admitted. “Sometimes, when I close my eyes, I can see it all—the green pastures, the stone walls dividing the fields, the early morning mist rolling in over the peaks. But then I think about what lies beyond that beauty now: a struggling country, bitter and broken. I’m not sure I could face it.”

She stopped, tugging gently on his arm to make him look at her. “You’ve faced worse,” she said firmly. “Don’t forget that. And besides, you’re here now. New York is your stage, and you’re building something lasting.”

Charles smiled, the corners of his mouth tugging upward in genuine warmth. “You always know what to say, don’t you?”

“I’m an actress,” she teased. “Words are my trade.”

He chuckled, a low sound that seemed to carry the weight of their conversation away with it. They walked on in comfortable silence for a few moments before Charles spoke again, his tone more contemplative.

“There is a place here, though,” he began, his voice almost tentative. “Not far, really. The Appalachians. It reminds me of home in some ways—rolling hills, quiet forests, a sense of something ancient and untouched. Have you ever been?”

Evelyn tilted her head, intrigued. “No. I’ve only read about it. But it sounds beautiful.”

“It is,” Charles said, his gaze distant. “I haven’t been in years, but I remember it vividly. The air feels different there, clean and alive. We could go, if you’d like. A week away from the city, just the two of us. No parties, no banks, no noise.”

Her eyes lit up, a spark of excitement dancing across her face. “Are you serious?”

“Entirely,” he replied, a smile tugging at his lips. “Think of it as a rehearsal for a simpler life.”

Evelyn laughed, the sound warm and infectious. “All right, Mr. Ashcombe. Let’s see this ‘American England’ of yours. But you’ll have to teach me how to live simply.”

“Deal,” Charles said, taking her hand as they continued walking. “But don’t blame me if it’s harder than it looks.”

The journey to Appalachia felt like stepping into another world. As the train wound its way through rolling hills and dense forests, Evelyn leaned her head against Charles’ shoulder, her eyes fixed on the changing scenery. The relentless pulse of New York faded behind them, replaced by the gentle rhythm of the countryside.

By the time they arrived at their destination, the air was crisp and clean, carrying the faint scent of pine. Their carriage awaited, drawn by a pair of sleek, black horses. Evelyn clutched Charles’ hand as the wheels began to roll, the landscape opening into a panorama of wooded peaks and valleys bathed in the golden light of late afternoon.

The house came into view as they rounded a bend—a sprawling mansion of stone and timber perched on a ridge overlooking the valley. Its high gables and wide porches gave it the feel of an old-world manor transplanted to the untamed beauty of the Appalachians. Smoke curled lazily from its chimneys, and the sound of rushing water from a nearby stream filled the air.

Evelyn gasped. “It’s magnificent.”

Charles smiled, his face touched with a rare, boyish pride. “It belonged to an old family friend—one of those eccentric types who built a retreat out here to escape city life. When he passed, the house went to his nephew, who never had much use for it. I’ve leased it a few times when I needed to get away. It’s quiet, remote, and…” He paused, gesturing to the horizon where the sun was beginning to dip. “Look at that view.”

The evening unfolded like a dream. As the staff—a cook and a housekeeper—prepared dinner, Evelyn and Charles wandered through the great house. The interior was a blend of rustic charm and understated luxury: heavy wooden beams crossed the high ceilings, fireplaces crackled in nearly every room, and floor-to-ceiling windows framed the breathtaking scenery.

Evelyn ran her fingers along the spines of books in the grand library, marvelling at the collection. “This place,” she said softly, “feels alive.”

“It is,” Charles replied from across the room, where he stood by a window with a glass of bourbon in hand. “Alive with silence, history, and the kind of peace the city can never offer.”

After dinner, they sat on the porch wrapped in blankets, the stars above a brilliant canopy in the absence of city lights. The fireflies danced in the dark, and the only sounds were the rustling leaves and the occasional call of an owl.

Evelyn nestled closer to him. “You were right,” she whispered. “It does remind me of England. The kind of England you described—timeless, untouched. It’s beautiful.”

Charles didn’t answer right away. He was staring into the distance, his thoughts turning over the weight of their conversation days earlier. “If this were England,” he said finally, “there would be an estate, tenant farmers, traditions going back generations. Here, it’s different. It’s newer, wilder. But maybe that’s what makes it… hopeful.”

Evelyn looked up at him, her expression soft. “Hopeful for what?”

He turned to her, a flicker of a smile breaking the solemnity. “For us.”

The lounge was warm and inviting, lit softly by the flicker of gas lamps and the glow of a crackling fire. The piano stood near the far wall, its polished surface reflecting the amber light. Charles held Evelyn’s hand as they entered, her silver dress catching the dim light like a shimmer of moonlight.

Seated at the piano was a young man, slim and angular, his dark hair falling slightly over his forehead as he played. The music he coaxed from the keys was unlike anything Charles had heard before—gentle yet bold, rooted yet yearning.

A few other guests were scattered around the room, listening in quiet awe, drinks in hand. Evelyn tugged at Charles’ sleeve and whispered, “Do you know who that is?”

Charles shook his head.

“That’s Aaron Copland,” she murmured, her voice alight with recognition. “He’s a composer. Quite the rising star.”

Charles watched the man play, his hands moving with effortless precision. The melody was both modern and timeless, a perfect blend of the old world and the new. It filled the room with a poignant energy, capturing the rugged spirit of the Appalachians and the tender intimacy of the moment.

Evelyn turned to Charles, her face aglow with excitement. “Dance with me.”

He hesitated for a heartbeat, then nodded, taking her hand and leading her to the centre of the room. The other guests looked on as the couple began to sway to the music, their movements slow and graceful, perfectly in sync with the melody.

Evelyn rested her head against his chest, and Charles wrapped his arm around her waist, holding her close. The room seemed to disappear, leaving only the music, the warmth of her touch, and the rhythm of their steps.

As the piece reached its conclusion, Copland glanced up, his dark eyes catching the sight of the couple. He played the final notes with a faint smile, watching as Charles spun Evelyn gently before drawing her back into his arms.

The applause was quiet but genuine, and Charles inclined his head toward Copland in acknowledgment.

Evelyn's cheeks were flushed as she looked up at him, her eyes sparkling. "I think," she said softly, "that might be my favourite dance yet."

Charles chuckled, his hand brushing a stray curl from her face. "Mine too. But I think it's because of my partner."

The music shifted to a softer, more intimate melody, its delicate notes floating through the room like the mountain mist they'd seen earlier that day. Charles held Evelyn close, their movements slowing as they swayed together in perfect harmony.

The warmth of her touch, the scent of her perfume, the way her eyes sparkled when she looked up at him—it was all too much, too perfect, too fleeting. And Charles, for all his caution and pragmatism, couldn't bear to let the moment slip away.

He reached into his pocket as they turned gently with the rhythm, his fingers brushing the small velvet box he'd been carrying for weeks. The weight of it was oddly reassuring, though his heart was pounding.

"Evelyn," he said, his voice low but steady.

She tilted her head back to look at him, a curious smile playing on her lips. "Yes, Charles?"

He stopped moving, holding her hands in his, and the room seemed to hold its breath. Copland continued to play, unaware of the moment unfolding in the centre of the room.

Charles knelt on one knee, his hands trembling slightly as he opened the box to reveal a ring—a simple yet elegant design with a single diamond, its brilliance catching the light like a tiny star.

Evelyn gasped, her hands flying to her mouth.

"Evelyn," Charles began, his voice faltering for a moment before finding its strength. "You've brought light into my life in a way I never thought possible. You've shown me that there's more to this world than duty and ambition. I don't want to face another day without you by my side. Will you do me the honour of becoming my wife?"

The room was still, save for the gentle strains of the piano and the flicker of the firelight. Evelyn's eyes glistened with tears as she looked down at him, her face a mixture of surprise, joy, and love.

"Yes," she whispered, her voice barely audible at first, then louder, more confident. "Yes, Charles. A thousand times, yes!"

The other guests, having noticed the proposal, broke into quiet applause, their smiles warm and genuine. Copland, still at the piano, transitioned seamlessly into a lively, celebratory tune, as if he, too, were part of the moment.

Charles rose, slipping the ring onto Evelyn's finger with care before pulling her into a tight embrace. She laughed through her tears, and he held her close, the room spinning around them in a blur of light and sound.

"I love you," he whispered against her hair.

"And I love you," she replied, her voice steady and sure.

The music continued to fill the room, a slow and soothing waltz, as Charles and Evelyn danced, their feet gliding almost effortlessly across the polished wood floor. The world outside, with its mountains and valleys, seemed distant now. Here, it was just the two of them, lost in a world of soft melodies and whispered promises.

Evelyn, her eyes fixed on his, leaned her head against his chest, her fingers lightly tracing the edges of his suit. She could feel the steady beat of his heart beneath her, a rhythm that matched the slow pulse of the music. It was as if time itself had slowed down, and all that mattered was this moment, this connection between them.

“So, an autumn wedding, then?” she asked, her voice soft but full of excitement.

Charles nodded, his hand resting gently on her waist. “Yes. I’ve always thought the fall would be the perfect time—everything feels so... ripe with possibility. The trees turning, the chill in the air. A wedding like that... it would be unforgettable.”

“Unforgettable,” Evelyn echoed with a smile, the word tasting sweet on her tongue. She could already see it in her mind—guests in their finest attire, the sun setting in the distance as golden leaves drifted through the air. It would be elegant, timeless. And, yes, it would certainly be the talk of the town.

“It’ll be the talk of the town,” Charles said, as if reading her thoughts. He chuckled softly, a hint of playful pride in his voice. “A wedding like ours, Evelyn, people won’t forget it easily. I’ll make sure of that.”

She smiled, the excitement building inside her. She had never imagined herself in a grand wedding, but with Charles, everything seemed possible. And it would be grand, she could already tell. The venue—perhaps one of the grand old estates, a vast house on the outskirts of New York. The flowers, the guests, the music, the champagne, the perfect autumn sunset. It would be a dream come true.

“I can’t wait,” she whispered, looking up at him, her heart swelling with affection. “It’s going to be... everything I’ve ever wanted.”

Charles smiled down at her, his eyes filled with a quiet certainty. He was used to making things happen, and this wedding—this celebration of them—was no different. It would be everything she dreamed of, and so much more.

“I’ll make it the most unforgettable day of your life,” he said softly, as they continued to dance, the piano still playing softly in the background, the music flowing through them like a perfect symphony.

As they moved together, their steps in sync with the music, they talked about the details—where the ceremony would take place, who to invite, the type of flowers they would choose, the songs that would fill the air. Each conversation felt like another thread weaving them closer together, a tapestry of promises and dreams for the future.

It was hard for Charles to imagine a time before this—before Evelyn, before this feeling of certainty, of home. He didn’t need to be the man who conquered the world, who built an empire of gold. With her by his side, everything else seemed irrelevant. They would have their life together, their love. And that, he thought, was more than enough.

Chapter 8:

The morning of Charles Ashcombe's wedding broke with a brilliance that seemed almost staged, as if the heavens themselves had conspired to perfect this moment. A soft autumn sun bathed the sprawling grounds of the estate, casting golden light on the manicured lawns and ivy-clad stone walls. In the distance, the Hudson River gleamed like polished silver, completing the picture of timeless elegance.

Charles stood in front of the floor-length mirror in his private dressing room, adjusting his cufflinks with steady hands. The room smelled faintly of cedar and fresh linen, and a slight breeze from the open window carried with it the scent of early autumn leaves. His tailored morning suit—black with a crisp white cravat and a boutonnière of deep red roses—fit him perfectly.

The knock on the door was light but firm. “Charles, may I come in?” It was Eleanor.

“Of course,” he said, turning to greet his sister as she stepped inside. Eleanor was radiant, her auburn hair swept into an intricate chignon, her navy silk dress shimmering as she moved. Her husband, Major Henry Braden, a robust man with a military bearing, stood just behind her, offering Charles a respectful nod.

“I hardly recognize you,” Eleanor teased, her smile warm. “You look... grown up.”

Charles laughed softly. “I’ll take that as a compliment.”

Eleanor stepped closer, taking both his hands in hers. “It’s perfect, you know. All of this. Evelyn... she’s everything I hoped for you.”

“And everything I never knew I needed,” Charles admitted, his voice quiet.

Henry cleared his throat. “If I may, Charles—on behalf of the family, we’re all immensely proud of you. Your father... Well, he’d be proud too, in his own way.”

Charles nodded, a flicker of melancholy passing across his face. The thought of Reginald lingered—his father, brilliant but haunted, who had burned so brightly only to collapse under the weight of his own convictions. Charles wondered if this day might have softened him, given him a moment of peace.

“Thank you, Henry,” he said simply, before turning back to Eleanor. “I’m glad you’re here. It wouldn’t be the same without you.”

“We wouldn’t have missed it for the world,” she replied, squeezing his hands once more before stepping back.

As they left the room, Charles took a deep breath and walked to the window, looking out over the grounds. Guests were already arriving, their cars gliding up the long gravel drive like beads on a string. Society's finest had gathered, from New York's old-money elites to diplomats, artists, and industrial magnates. The wedding had already been declared the event of the decade in the press, the Ashcombe name once again on everyone’s lips.

Below, a quartet was setting up near the floral arch where the ceremony would take place. Pale roses, chrysanthemums, and greenery had been arranged with care, their colours complementing the early autumn hues of the trees. The reception tent, enormous and gleaming white, stood at the edge of the garden, promising an evening of grandeur.

There was another knock at the door. This time it was Whitaker.

“Well, don’t you look the part of a groom,” he said, grinning as he stepped inside.

“And you, the part of my disapproving uncle,” Charles replied, a smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth.

Whitaker chuckled. “Disapproving, never. Wary, always.” He adjusted the brim of his hat and gave Charles a once-over. “This is quite the spectacle, Charles. Quite the expense, too.”

“I’d say Evelyn is worth it,” Charles said.

Whitaker nodded, his expression softening. “She is. You’ve done well, Charles. Very well. Now let’s get you downstairs before the rumours start about the groom abandoning the bride.”

Charles laughed, clapped Whitaker on the shoulder, and together they made their way down the grand staircase.

The house was a whirlwind of activity, staff bustling about to ensure every detail was perfect. As Charles approached the main hall, the sounds of conversation and laughter grew louder, and he could feel the collective energy of the day building.

The house was a whirlwind of activity, staff bustling about to ensure every detail was perfect. White-gloved servers moved through the hall with trays of champagne, their movements swift and graceful. A quartet outside had begun to play the soft strains of *Clair de Lune*, adding a sense of dreamy elegance to the occasion. The sounds of conversation and laughter grew louder, blending with the music and the rustle of silk gowns and tailored suits. Charles could feel the collective energy of the day building, like a crescendo before a symphony’s grand opening.

The guests were a tapestry of society’s finest. There was Andrew Mellon, the reserved yet affable Secretary of the Treasury, chatting with Mrs. Astor, who had arrived in a beaded gown that shimmered like the Hudson River itself. Not far from them stood George Gershwin, animatedly discussing his latest compositions with a young actress from Broadway, her smile wide and infectious. In another corner, Edith Wharton, dignified and sharp, held court among a circle of admirers, likely commenting on the grandiosity of the event with her trademark wit.

Eleanor and her husband, Major Henry Braden, were mingling near the garden, their British accents a novelty among the American elite. Beside them, Charles noticed an old family friend, Sir Harold Tollemache, who had travelled from England to represent the family’s enduring ties to its homeland. His silver hair gleamed in the sunlight as he raised a glass to Charles from afar.

The floral arch near the aisle was now complete, a masterpiece of pale roses, white chrysanthemums, and ivy. Evelyn’s influence was evident in every detail: the tasteful restraint of the decorations, the soft hues that echoed the early autumn landscape, the subtle elegance that made the grandeur feel personal.

Whitaker leaned in close to Charles as they stepped out onto the terrace. “Quite the turnout,” he said. “I’d wager half the wealth of New York is in this garden.”

Charles smiled faintly. “And the other half is at the stock exchange,” he quipped.

Whitaker chuckled. “Let’s hope you don’t send them running back there too soon.”

Charles turned his gaze to the aisle, which stretched before him like a path into a new life. The chairs were arranged in perfect symmetry, each adorned with a small arrangement of flowers. Guests were beginning to take their seats, their murmurs blending with the music as anticipation built.

As he stood at the edge of the ceremony, Charles felt a momentary pang of nervousness. This wasn't just an event; it was a statement, a declaration of his place in a world that had been both kind and cruel to him. Evelyn had brought him a sense of stability, of hope, that he hadn't realized he needed.

The sound of the quartet shifted, and the hum of conversation began to quiet. The ceremony was about to begin. Charles took a deep breath, straightened his jacket, and stepped into the garden, where his future awaited.

The ceremony itself was a vision of timeless beauty. Evelyn appeared at the end of the aisle, a vision in ivory silk and lace, her veil billowing slightly in the gentle breeze. Gasps rippled through the crowd as she took her first step, her father, Robert Duvall, an oil magnate, escorting her with a proud but teary-eyed smile.

Charles stood at the altar, his heart pounding. As Evelyn drew closer, their eyes met, and the world seemed to shrink until it was just the two of them, as if the hundred or so guests had vanished entirely.

The officiant, a renowned bishop brought in from Boston, spoke with solemnity and grace, weaving themes of love, partnership, and resilience into his words. When Charles and Evelyn exchanged their vows, there wasn't a dry eye in the crowd.

The moment Charles slid the diamond ring onto Evelyn's finger and kissed her beneath the arch, the applause erupted, a joyful crescendo that seemed to echo across the Hudson.

The reception was nothing short of spectacular. The great white tent was illuminated by chandeliers, their light reflecting off crystal glasses and silver platters. Tables were adorned with arrangements of roses and greenery, the centrepieces understated yet elegant. A jazz band played lively tunes, coaxing guests onto the dance floor.

Charles and Evelyn made their entrance as husband and wife to a burst of applause, their smiles wide and genuine. They danced their first dance to *The Man I Love*, performed live by none other than George Gershwin himself, who had taken to the piano with a theatrical flourish.

Throughout the evening, toasts were raised, laughter filled the air, and the finest champagne flowed freely. Eleanor gave a heartfelt speech about her brother's resilience and love for Evelyn, while Whitaker, true to form, managed to deliver a speech that was both biting and sentimental.

As the night wore on, Charles found a moment to step away from the crowd. Standing at the edge of the garden with Evelyn by his side, he looked out over the river, the lights of the city twinkling in the distance.

"It feels like a dream," Evelyn said softly, her hand resting on his arm.

"A dream we built together," Charles replied, his voice steady but filled with emotion.

As the couple lingered at the edge of the garden, the sounds of the reception swirled around them—laughter, the clink of glasses, and the unmistakable rhythm of a jazz band that had just launched into a spirited rendition of *Singin' the Blues*. Evelyn's hand rested lightly on Charles's arm, her diamond ring catching the soft glow of the chandeliers.

"I wonder if this is what it feels like to be at the heart of something eternal," Evelyn said, her voice barely above a whisper.

Charles smiled. "It's fleeting, like all great moments, but perhaps that's what makes it so perfect. Let's enjoy it while it lasts."

Evelyn turned to face him fully, her eyes glistening. "Do you think you'll remember this night forever?"

"I think," Charles replied, taking her hand and kissing it gently, "that this night will remember *us*."

With that, they rejoined the reception, stepping back into the lively scene as if stepping into a dance. The crowd buzzed with energy, their joy undiminished as the night deepened.

At the head table, Eleanor rose with a glass of champagne, signalling the next toast. "Ladies and gentlemen," she began, her voice clear and commanding, "if I may have your attention for just a moment, I'd like to propose a toast to my brother, Charles, and his radiant bride, Evelyn."

The guests quieted, all eyes on Eleanor, who smiled warmly. "Charles, you've always been the calculating one, the thinker, the strategist. But tonight, it's clear that the heart of your strategy was to find Evelyn, who brings light and warmth into your life. Evelyn, welcome to the family. And to the rest of us, I think we can agree—tonight we've witnessed a rare kind of union, one born of love, respect, and a little bit of stubborn Ashcombe determination."

Laughter rippled through the crowd as glasses were raised and a chorus of "To Charles and Evelyn!" filled the air.

Charles and Evelyn shared a glance, her cheeks flushed with happiness, and he leaned in to whisper, "Stubborn Ashcombe determination, indeed."

The music resumed, livelier than before, and the dance floor filled once more. Charles found himself swept into a waltz with an elegant dowager while Evelyn was claimed by a young officer with an impeccable uniform and a boyish grin. Across the room, Whitaker was entertaining a group with a cigar in one hand and a brandy in the other, recounting some undoubtedly embellished tale of his days in the trading pits.

As the night unfolded, George Gershwin returned to the piano for an impromptu set, his fingers flying over the keys with a mixture of precision and abandon. Charles noticed Eleanor quietly listening at the edge of the room, her husband standing protectively at her side, as if even the music of Gershwin couldn't quite erase the shadows of war that had marked her.

Eventually, Charles managed to steal Evelyn away from the well-wishers and onto the dance floor. The band struck up a slower tune, and the newly-weds swayed together, lost in their own world. The rest of the room seemed to fade as Charles whispered to her, "Are you happy?"

Evelyn looked up at him, her expression soft and sincere. "More than I ever thought possible."

The evening stretched on, the party showing no signs of slowing. It wasn't until the faintest hint of dawn began to streak the sky that the first guests began to depart, many lingering for one last toast or handshake. Charles and Evelyn stood at the top of the grand staircase, bidding each guest farewell with genuine gratitude.

As the final carriages pulled away and the music faded, Charles took Evelyn’s hand and led her back into the now-quiet house. The grandeur of the evening still hung in the air, a sense of something remarkable having occurred.

“I think,” Evelyn said as they ascended the stairs to their room, “this night will indeed remember us.”

Charles, still holding her hand, stopped and kissed her on the landing, the faint strains of the last notes of music reaching them from the distance. “It already has.”

The Ashcombes began their honeymoon with a journey to the French Riviera, a destination befitting their status and the splendour of their recent wedding. The Mediterranean sun bathed everything in golden light, and the couple found themselves enchanted by the charm of the Côte d'Azur—the pastel villas clinging to the cliffs, the glittering sea, and the scent of lavender carried on the warm breeze.

They stayed in a secluded villa overlooking the bay of Villefranche-sur-Mer, a place of quiet elegance where they could escape the bustling world of high society. Evelyn delighted in the simplicity of their days—long walks through olive groves, intimate dinners on the terrace, and lazy afternoons spent reading novels or sketching the horizon.

Charles, however, found himself unable to completely detach from the concerns that followed him across the Atlantic. It was on one such afternoon, as Evelyn lounged with a book under the shade of a sprawling fig tree, that a courier arrived with a letter bearing the unmistakable handwriting of Ludwig von Mises.

Charles retreated to the study of the villa, the shutters open to let in the soft sea breeze, and broke the seal. The letter was brief but unambiguous:

Dear Charles,

I trust this letter finds you well and enjoying the respite of your honeymoon. Allow me, however, to speak plainly, for the matter is urgent.

The conditions we discussed in previous correspondence are advancing more rapidly than even I anticipated. The credit-fuelled euphoria driving the stock market is an illusion, a bubble of monumental proportions. The policies of the Federal Reserve—creating money from nothing and artificially lowering interest rates—have distorted the economy to a dangerous degree. Capital is being misallocated on an unprecedented scale.

This house of cards cannot stand. When it collapses—and it will—it will bring ruin to many who are blind to the peril. You must stay the course with your principles. Gold, as you know, remains the ultimate store of value. Do not be swayed by those who chase speculative gains in this madness. Your steadfastness may yet save your bank, even if others fall.

Prepare for the storm, my friend. It is coming.

Yours in steadfast friendship,
Ludwig von Mises

Charles sat back in his chair, the letter heavy in his hands. He had long suspected the market's unsustainable trajectory, but Mises's words added clarity—and urgency—to his private fears.

That evening, as he and Evelyn dined under the stars, he decided to broach the subject.

“You seem preoccupied tonight,” Evelyn said, her eyes searching his face. “Is it the letter you received?”

Charles nodded, setting his wineglass down. “It’s from Mises. He’s warned me—again—about the bubble in the stock market. He’s certain it will collapse, and soon.”

Evelyn frowned. “You’ve said as much yourself before. Does this letter change anything?”

“It reinforces what I already believed. The Ashcombe Bank has stayed clear of the frenzy, but the pressure to join the rush has been immense. Deposits have been leaving the bank as investors chase the mirage of endless profits in the market. Mises believes the crash is imminent.”

“And you?” Evelyn asked, her voice calm but serious.

“I believe he’s right. It’s only a matter of time before this house of cards falls. When it does, it will be catastrophic.”

Evelyn reached across the table, her hand covering his. “Then we prepare, as you always do. You’ve built your bank on principles that will endure where others falter. We can weather this storm, Charles.”

Her words steadied him, and he smiled, grateful for her unwavering support. “You’re right. We will.”

For the rest of the evening, Charles pushed the looming spectre of the market crash to the back of his mind, focusing instead on Evelyn and the beauty of their surroundings. Yet, as they retired for the night, the words of Mises lingered in his thoughts, a quiet reminder of the storm gathering on the horizon.

Charles returned to New York with a renewed sense of purpose. The tranquillity of the honeymoon had allowed him to recharge, but the gravity of Mises’s warning weighed heavily on him. At the Ashcombe Bank, he immediately immersed himself in the business of fortifying the institution against the coming storm.

His first directive was clear: **increase the bank’s position in gold.**

The move raised eyebrows—and smirks—across Wall Street. The prevailing sentiment among the city’s financiers was one of boundless optimism for the stock market, which seemed to climb higher with each passing day. Charles’s focus on gold was seen as anachronistic, the eccentric strategy of a man out of step with the times.

At a private luncheon hosted by the Metropolitan Club, several prominent bankers and financiers took the opportunity to chide Charles.

“Still clinging to your father’s obsession with gold, Ashcombe?” asked Harold Rivington, a senior partner at a major brokerage firm. “The market’s where the real money is being made. Surely, you can see that!”

Charles remained composed, sipping his coffee before responding. “The market is inflated beyond reason. It’s no longer a reflection of value but a frenzy of speculation. What happens when reality sets in, Harold?”

Rivington waved him off with a dismissive laugh. “Reality? Reality is that the Federal Reserve won’t let the market fail. The modern economy doesn’t need gold anymore. It’s quaint, really.”

Another guest, a younger banker eager to make a name for himself, chimed in. “The stock market is the future. Gold is just a relic—a shiny rock that doesn’t pay dividends or generate growth. You’re parking your money in something dead while the rest of us ride the wave.”

Charles set his cup down and leaned forward slightly, his voice calm but firm. “Gold isn’t meant to generate growth. It’s a store of value, one that doesn’t rely on the whims of monetary policy or the speculative appetites of men like you. The wave you’re riding will crash, and when it does, it will take down everyone who’s too blind or too greedy to see it coming.”

The room fell silent for a moment, save for the clinking of silverware. Then, Rivington chuckled and raised his glass. “To Ashcombe, the eternal pessimist! May your shiny rocks keep you warm while the rest of us prosper.”

Back at the Ashcombe Bank, Charles doubled down on his strategy. He instructed his traders to aggressively acquire gold, ignoring the rising prices as other institutions began liquidating their holdings in favour of stocks. The bank’s vaults, already substantial, grew even more impressive as shipments of bullion arrived daily.

He also issued a series of cautious statements to his clients, warning them of the risks associated with the overheated stock market. Some listened and stayed loyal to the Ashcombe Bank, but many, enticed by the glittering promise of Wall Street, withdrew their funds to chase speculative gains.

One afternoon, as Charles reviewed the bank’s latest reports in his office, Whitaker entered, his expression a mix of curiosity and concern.

“Deposits are down again this quarter,” Whitaker said. “The withdrawals are steady, though not catastrophic. Still, it’s clear the other banks are pulling in capital from the markets while we’re losing ground.”

“I’m aware,” Charles replied, not looking up from the ledger.

Whitaker hesitated. “Do you ever wonder if we’re being too cautious? The market keeps climbing. Even a small position in equities could stem some of these losses.”

Charles finally looked up, his expression resolute. “And when the market collapses, Whitaker? What then? The Ashcombe Bank wasn’t built to chase fleeting profits. It was built to endure. Let them laugh now. We’ll see who’s laughing when the dust settles.”

Whitaker nodded, though the scepticism lingered in his eyes.

As the weeks turned into months, the stock market frenzy intensified. The newspapers hailed it as the “New Era” of prosperity, with headlines proclaiming record-breaking highs and endless opportunities. Charles, however, remained steadfast, watching the growing hysteria with a mix of frustration and vindication.

The Ashcombe Bank's vaults continued to fill with gold, and Charles continued to warn of the dangers ahead. To most, his warnings seemed like the ramblings of a man stuck in the past. But Charles knew the truth: the future belonged to those who were prepared for the inevitable reckoning.

Chapter 9:

The summer of 1929 had been relentless in its fervour. Wall Street buzzed with an almost hypnotic energy, a place where fortunes were made and lost in the blink of an eye. The Ashcombe Bank, however, stood apart—a fortress of caution amidst a sea of reckless speculation.

Over the past two years, Charles had watched the stock market ascend to dizzying heights. The roaring optimism of the 1920s, once thrilling in its audacity, had now curdled into something darker. The mania was unsustainable, fed by a steady stream of easy credit and unchecked exuberance.

Despite his warnings, the majority of financiers continued to pile into stocks, buoyed by the illusion of perpetual growth. Ashcombe's insistence on building a massive position in gold had drawn scorn, though a few had begun to whisper—quietly, and only when out of earshot—that perhaps the market was overvalued.

Charles sat at the head of a polished walnut table in a private room at the Union League Club. The meeting was one of several informal gatherings held by influential brokers and bankers to discuss market trends and strategies. The air was thick with cigar smoke and the murmurs of subdued concern.

At Charles's right was Harold Rivington, his perennial foil, who had spent the past two years mocking Ashcombe's gold-centric strategy. Across the table sat Edwin Clark, a prominent broker whose sharp wit and sharper instincts had made him a fixture of Wall Street society.

Rivington leaned back in his chair, swirling his glass of whiskey. "Gentlemen," he began, his tone unusually sombre, "there's no denying that something feels... different about the market."

Clark nodded, adjusting his pince-nez. "The valuations are stratospheric. Utilities, manufacturing, railroads—everything is priced to perfection. There's no room for error anymore. And the margins... my God, the margins."

The mention of margin trading hung in the air like a thundercloud. Speculative investors had been borrowing heavily to buy stocks, amplifying their gains—and their risks.

Charles allowed a moment of silence before speaking. "You're all just now realizing this?" His tone was even, but the implication was clear.

Rivington bristled. "No need to gloat, Ashcombe. We've all heard your sermons about gold and bubbles."

"I don't gloat," Charles replied. "I prepare. The market has been overvalued for years. Easy credit has propped it up, but that's not sustainable. When the Federal Reserve tightens, the house of cards will collapse."

Clark shifted uncomfortably in his seat. "The question is, how much longer can it hold? There's still an appetite for risk out there. Investors are pouring money into the market like there's no tomorrow."

Charles took a measured sip of his coffee. “There *is* a tomorrow. And when it comes, it will be unforgiving. The Ashcombe Bank will weather the storm because we’ve refused to play the game. Can the same be said for the rest of you?”

Rivington’s jaw tightened, but he said nothing.

The discussion continued, with some insisting that the market still had room to grow, while others voiced increasing unease. Charles listened carefully, noting the subtle shifts in tone. The bravado of previous years was giving way to nervous uncertainty, though few were willing to admit it outright.

As the meeting drew to a close, Rivington caught Charles’s eye. “If you’re so certain of a crash, Ashcombe, why not bet against the market? Why just sit on your gold?”

Charles smiled faintly, rising from his chair. “When the storm hits, Harold, you’ll see why.”

And with that, he left the room, the sound of his polished shoes echoing down the marble corridor.

The streets of New York were alive with their usual chaos, but beneath the city’s unrelenting hum, there was an unspoken tension. The stock market, which had risen like a phoenix through the decade, was beginning to falter. The cracks were faint, barely perceptible, but they were there—a missed dividend, a sharp sell-off in a key sector, whispers of margin calls.

At the Ashcombe Bank, Charles sat in his office, gazing out at the towering skyline. The desk in front of him was immaculate, save for a stack of reports and a letter from Vienna. Ludwig von Mises had written again, his tone urgent, warning of the same disaster Charles saw on the horizon.

"The artificial boom," Mises had written, *"must end in a bust. Credit expansion is not a substitute for genuine capital. It merely postpones the reckoning—and makes it worse when it arrives."*

Charles had read the letter twice, though it had only confirmed what he already knew. The question wasn’t *if* the crash would come, but *when*.

At the Ashcombe trading floor, the atmosphere was subdued. The usual chatter had turned to murmurs, punctuated by the occasional bark of a broker trying to place a last-minute order. Charles walked among them, his presence commanding.

“How are we looking?” he asked James Whitaker, who had taken over the bank’s New York operations.

“Stable, for now,” Whitaker replied, glancing up from his ledger. “But the outflows are increasing. Clients are pulling money to chase the market, and a few have liquidated entirely. They’re convinced this ride can’t end.”

Charles nodded. “And our gold reserves?”

“Untouched. We’ve even added to them, though at a cost to liquidity.”

“Good. Let them laugh at us. When the dust settles, we’ll see who’s still standing.”

Whitaker hesitated. “Do you think we should do more? Short the market, perhaps?”

Charles shook his head. “No need to be greedy. We’re positioned well enough. Let the others gamble; we’ll keep our powder dry.”

By early October, the mood on Wall Street had shifted further. Stocks were still trading at record highs, but the confidence that had once been unshakable was now fragile. Financial columns in the newspapers began to question the sustainability of the rally, though they stopped short of predicting disaster.

Charles attended another gathering of financiers, this time at the Plaza Hotel. The room was gilded, opulent, filled with the scent of expensive cologne and the low murmur of guarded conversations.

“It’s a correction,” one banker insisted, swirling his brandy. “The market’s just catching its breath. Nothing more.”

“It’s more than that,” Charles interjected, his voice cutting through the noise. “The fundamentals are rotten. The entire rally has been propped up by credit expansion. When the banks start calling in loans, it’s over.”

His words were met with a mix of scepticism and unease. A few nodded in agreement, but most dismissed him as overly cautious.

“You’ve been saying that for years, Ashcombe,” another banker scoffed. “Yet the market keeps climbing.”

“For now,” Charles replied. “But gravity always wins.”

Back at the Ashcombe Bank, Charles reviewed the latest reports. The Federal Reserve had hinted at tightening credit conditions, a move that would send shockwaves through the overleveraged system. He sent a memo to his senior staff, instructing them to prepare for increased volatility.

Meanwhile, he wrote another letter to Mises, summarizing his observations and seeking advice.

Ludwig,
The bubble is nearing its breaking point. The credit-fuelled hysteria has reached its zenith, and I fear the collapse will be swift and brutal. The Ashcombe Bank is well-positioned, but the repercussions will be far-reaching. Tell me, do you believe the system can endure this, or will it tear itself apart entirely?
Yours, as ever,
Charles

As he sealed the envelope, Charles felt a strange calm. The storm was coming, but he had done all he could to prepare.

By mid-October, the stock market was showing its first real signs of distress. A series of minor sell-off rattled investor confidence, and rumours of trouble at several smaller banks began to circulate. Charles attended yet another meeting, this time with the city’s financial elite at the New York Federal Reserve.

“We need to restore confidence,” the chairman declared. “Intervention may be necessary.”

Charles spoke up. “Intervention won’t fix this. It will only prolong the inevitable. The market needs a correction—trying to stop it will only make the crash worse.”

His warning was met with silence. The others were too deeply invested, both financially and emotionally, to consider such a course of action.

As the meeting adjourned, Charles stepped out into the crisp autumn air. The city was alive, oblivious to the chaos brewing beneath its surface. For a moment, he envied their ignorance. Then he steeled himself, knowing that the reckoning was just around the corner.

The morning air was tense, the kind that seemed to press down on the city, though the skies were clear. On Wall Street, the usual hum of activity was a cacophony of frantic voices, hurried footsteps, and the sharp clatter of ticker tape machines spitting out numbers that no longer made sense.

At the Ashcombe Bank, Charles sat in his office, his sleeves rolled up and his desk cluttered with reports. He had barely slept the night before, sensing that the tipping point had arrived. Outside, the trading floor was chaos, phones ringing off their hooks, brokers shouting over one another as orders flooded in.

Whitaker burst into the room, his face pale. “Charles, it’s starting. The market’s down five percent already, and it’s not even 10 a.m.”

Charles stood, adjusting his tie as if preparing for battle. “Let’s go.”

The Ashcombe Bank’s trading floor was a hive of activity, but it was organized compared to the pandemonium erupting across the street. Charles strode through the room, issuing calm instructions.

“Pull the remaining funds from equities. Move them into treasuries and gold-backed securities. No exceptions.”

One of the younger brokers hesitated. “But sir, if we sell now—”

Charles cut him off with a sharp look. “We’re not here to chase dreams. We’re here to preserve capital. Sell everything.”

Across the street at the New York Stock Exchange, the atmosphere was apocalyptic. Crowds of frantic investors had gathered outside, shouting for news. Inside, the market was in free-fall. Prices tumbled as sell orders overwhelmed the system.

At one point, Charles stepped onto the balcony of the Ashcombe building, looking down at the chaos below. The shouts of ruined investors rose like a desperate tide, their faces pale and strained as they clutched at their last hopes.

By midday, the market had lost nearly 10% of its value. Brokers scrambled to stem the bleeding, but every rally was met with another wave of selling. Rumours spread like wildfire: a major bank was on the verge of collapse; a prominent investor had taken his own life.

Whitaker appeared at Charles’s side again, his voice low. “Gold’s climbing. We’re seeing a flood of buy orders.”

Charles nodded, his face impassive. “Good. Keep our reserves steady. No selling.”

By late afternoon, the full scale of the disaster was evident. The Dow had lost 11% in a single day, wiping out billions of dollars in value. The bubble had burst, and the fallout was only beginning.

Back in his office, Charles lit a cigar and leaned back in his chair. The reports in front of him confirmed what he already knew: the Ashcombe Bank’s position in gold had not only protected its assets but had made it one of the few institutions to emerge stronger from the chaos.

Whitaker entered, holding a sheet of paper. “Gold’s up 25% in just a few hours. Investors are fleeing to safety.”

Charles exhaled a plume of smoke. “They’ll come crawling back to us. When the dust settles, they’ll realize that gold is the only real money.”

That evening, as the city grappled with the enormity of the crash, Charles returned to his town house. Evelyn was waiting for him, her face a mixture of worry and relief.

“Is it as bad as they’re saying?” she asked, pouring him a drink.

“Worse,” Charles admitted, taking the glass. “But we’re prepared. The Ashcombe Bank will weather this storm.”

They sat together by the fire, the weight of the day settling over them. Outside, the city was eerily quiet, the usual buzz of activity replaced by a sombre stillness.

Charles stared into the flames, his mind racing. The crash was only the beginning. The real challenge would be rebuilding from the ruins. But for now, he allowed himself a moment of satisfaction. He had seen the storm coming, and he had steered his ship to safety.

The era of endless optimism was over, and the hard truths of reality were setting in. The world would never be the same.

The sun rose over New York with an unfamiliar chill in the air. The city seemed subdued, as if mourning its shattered illusions. On Wall Street, the debris of the previous day was everywhere—crumpled stock tickers, abandoned papers, and shattered dreams.

At the Ashcombe Bank, Charles was already at his desk. He hadn’t slept much, but the exhaustion was dulled by adrenaline. Reports were coming in from across the country: small banks were collapsing, entire fortunes had evaporated overnight, and breadlines were forming in places where opulence had once reigned.

Whitaker entered with the latest figures. “Gold’s up another 10% overnight. We’ve received transfer requests from four regional banks—looks like they’re trying to secure their reserves.”

Charles glanced up. “We’ll accommodate them, but at our terms. This isn’t charity. It’s business.”

Whitaker hesitated. “Some of the other brokers—well, they’re saying we should capitalize more aggressively. They think you should sell some of the gold while the price is high.”

Charles leaned back, fixing Whitaker with a steely gaze. “They think like gamblers. We think like bankers. Gold isn’t just an asset—it’s trust, security, and leverage. Let the price rise; we’ll hold.”

By mid-morning, the bank’s lobby was packed with anxious depositors. Word had spread that the Ashcombe Bank had weathered the storm, and people were desperate to safeguard their savings. Charles walked through the crowd, nodding politely but offering no reassurances. He knew that panic couldn’t be soothed with words—it required action.

As he entered the boardroom, Evelyn was waiting for him, a rare visit to the bank. She was dressed in a sleek black coat, her expression a mix of concern and admiration.

“You’ve done it, haven’t you?” she said softly, approaching him.

“I’ve done what needed to be done,” Charles replied, his voice measured. “But this isn’t over. The crash is just the beginning. The economy will unravel in the coming months, and the politicians will look for someone to blame.”

“Will it be you?” Evelyn asked, her eyes searching his.

“Possibly,” Charles admitted. “They hate that we’ve held firm to gold. To them, it’s a relic. But when their paper money burns, they’ll realize its value.”

Later that day, Charles attended an emergency gathering of New York’s financial leaders at the Waldorf Astoria. The room was filled with grim faces, some pale with fear, others hardened with determination.

The Federal Reserves representative was there, a sharp-suited man with a nervous air. “Gentlemen,” he began, “we must act quickly. Liquidity is vanishing from the system, and confidence is in free-fall. We propose a coordinated effort to inject funds into the market.”

“Funds backed by what?” Charles asked, his tone cutting.

The man faltered. “By the government’s full faith and credit, of course.”

Charles smirked. “Faith and credit won’t feed the breadlines or rebuild collapsed banks. You can’t conjure value out of thin air. That’s what got us here in the first place.”

There was a murmur of agreement from some quarters, but others glared at Charles with thinly veiled hostility.

Another banker, older and grizzled, spoke up. “Ashcombe’s right. The market needs something real to anchor it. Gold, land, industry—something tangible. We’ve been trading promises for too long.”

The Fed’s representative looked exasperated. “Gentlemen, this is not the time for ideological debates. People are suffering.”

“And they’ll suffer more,” Charles said coldly, “if we keep pretending that pumping air into a balloon will keep it from bursting.”

That evening, as Charles returned to his townhouse, he found another letter waiting for him. The envelope bore the familiar Austrian postmark of Ludwig von Mises.

Inside, the letter was brief but emphatic:

Charles,
The crash was inevitable, as we both knew. But beware—this is merely the prelude. The policies they will enact in response will be worse than the crash itself. Inflate, deflate, and repeat—it is the cycle of interventionists who refuse to learn. Hold your gold, and prepare for the long fight ahead.

Charles folded the letter carefully and placed it in his desk. Outside his window, the city was still bustling, but there was a distinct air of desperation in the hurried steps and hushed conversations.

Evelyn joined him, resting her hand on his shoulder. “What does it say?”

“It says we’re right,” Charles replied, his voice steady. “But being right doesn’t make you popular.”

Evelyn smiled faintly. “You never cared about being popular.”

Charles took her hand, drawing her close. “No. I care about being prepared.”

By the following Monday, Wall Street was in a state of abject chaos. The initial shock of October 24th, now infamous as Black Thursday, had given way to a relentless sell-off. Brokers, once the picture of urbane confidence, moved like ghosts through the Exchange floor, shouting over one another in futile attempts to stem the tide.

Meanwhile, the Ashcombe Bank towered like a fortress in the storm. Charles sat in his office on the top floor, scanning the latest reports. Gold had soared to heights unseen in decades, solidifying his position as the savviest banker on Wall Street. Deposits flooded into the Ashcombe Bank as other institutions collapsed, unable to cover their speculative losses.

Whitaker entered, his face both triumphant and cautious. “Gold’s up another 15% since Friday, sir. We’ve effectively cornered the market.”

Charles glanced up from his papers, his expression unreadable. “I didn’t set out to corner anything. I set out to protect our assets. The fact that the rest of them ignored the warnings is not my concern.”

Whitaker hesitated. “It’s not just here. The British pound has collapsed under the strain. The Bank of England is haemorrhaging reserves, and the Chancellor is begging for American loans. Germany is even worse—hyperinflation seems to be looming again.”

Charles leaned back, lighting a cigar. “Britain’s fall was inevitable once they left the gold standard. Germany... well, they were doomed the moment Versailles was signed. This crash is global, Whitaker. It’s going to reset everything.”

News from Europe painted an increasingly dire picture. In London, the once-mighty pound sterling was losing its dominance as a reserve currency. Banks were closing their doors, and workers were striking en masse as wages evaporated. Reports filtered in of breadlines stretching through London neighbourhoods where carriages once carried the wealthy to dinner parties.

In Germany, the economy was collapsing at an even more alarming rate. Factories shuttered overnight, throwing millions out of work. The fragile Weimar government teetered as its coffers emptied. Riots broke out in Berlin and Munich, with disillusioned citizens blaming everyone from the Allies to their own leaders.

Charles read these reports with a mix of dread and vindication. He had warned of the dangers of abandoning hard money, of overleveraged speculation, and of the hubris of central bankers. Now, his predictions were coming true on a catastrophic scale.

On Wednesday, a group of prominent Wall Street bankers arrived at the Ashcombe Bank, seeking an audience with Charles. Among them were heads of banks teetering on the brink of collapse and brokers desperate for a lifeline.

The meeting took place in the Ashcombe Bank’s grand conference room, where the gilded ceilings seemed to mock the dire circumstances.

“Mr. Ashcombe,” one of the men began, “we need your help. You’re sitting on a mountain of gold, and we’re running out of liquidity. The market’s in free-fall, and the Federal Reserve isn’t acting fast enough. You could stabilize things.”

Charles stood at the head of the table, his presence commanding. “Gentlemen, I warned all of you years ago. You mocked me when I refused to invest in speculative stocks. You called me a relic for sticking with gold. And now you want me to save you?”

Another banker, younger and more desperate, spoke up. “If the market continues to collapse, none of us will survive. The entire system could fail.”

Charles exhaled a plume of smoke, his gaze cold. “Perhaps the system *should* fail. It’s rotten to its core, built on paper promises and inflated egos. My duty is to the Ashcombe Bank and its depositors—not to propping up a broken system.”

That evening, as Charles returned home, Evelyn was waiting for him in the study. She had been following the news closely, her usually serene face shadowed by concern.

“You can’t let them vilify you, Charles,” she said as he poured himself a whiskey. “The papers are already calling you ‘the man who broke the market.’”

Charles turned to her, a wry smile on his lips. “They’ll always need a villain, Evelyn. Better it be me, someone who’s prepared, than the fools who caused this mess.”

“But what about Britain? Your sister wrote today—Eleanor says things are worse than they seem. The family estates are in trouble.”

Charles paused, his glass halfway to his lips. “England will survive, though it may not look the same. As for Eleanor, I’ll do what I can, but the Ashcombe Bank cannot become a lifeline for the old country. Not now.”

Evelyn moved closer, placing a hand on his arm. “Charles, you’ve been right about everything so far, but this is bigger than you. The world is falling apart.”

Charles stared out the window, the city skyline glimmering in the distance. “Let it fall apart,” he said softly. “Perhaps it’s the only way to rebuild something better.”

As the month drew to a close, the crash accelerated. Each day brought new record losses on the Dow, and by October 29th—Black Tuesday—the market was in complete free-fall. Charles watched from his office as the ticker tape spat out numbers that confirmed what he already knew: the American financial empire was crumbling.

Meanwhile, the Ashcombe Bank’s vaults were overflowing with gold, the only asset immune to the carnage. Charles knew his position was secure, but the sight of despair on the streets below left him uneasy. He had always believed in the Austrian school’s principles, but the human cost of this collapse was staggering.

The question that haunted him now was simple: *What comes next?*

By early November, the full scale of the calamity had become evident. The Dow had lost nearly 90% of its value since the market peaked in September. Banks were closing daily, and unemployment surged as companies failed in droves. Across the country, breadlines stretched around blocks, and formerly wealthy businessmen roamed the streets in tattered suits, dazed and broken.

The Ashcombe Bank stood apart as a pillar of stability. Its gold reserves had skyrocketed in value, and its prudence now looked like genius. Rival bankers who had mocked Charles just months earlier now came to him, cap in hand, seeking advice—or salvation.

But Charles had little comfort to offer. He was not in the business of charity, and he knew that pouring gold into the collapsing financial system would only delay the inevitable reckoning.

At home, Evelyn watched her husband with increasing worry. The man who had been so alive during their honeymoon now seemed consumed by the weight of the world. His successes had not brought him joy; if anything, they had isolated him further.

One evening, she found him in his study, staring at a letter from Vienna. It was another note from Ludwig von Mises, congratulating Charles on his foresight and urging him to continue advocating for sound money principles.

“Charles,” she said softly, sitting beside him. “You’ve done everything you set out to do. The bank is secure, and your warnings were proven right. But... are you happy?”

He looked at her, the faintest trace of a smile on his lips. “Happiness feels like a luxury these days, Evelyn. I see the chaos out there, and I wonder if I could have done more to prevent it.”

“You’ve done enough,” she said firmly. “The world doesn’t need another martyr. It needs leaders who can help rebuild.”

He took her hand, squeezing it gently. “Rebuilding won’t be easy. The old systems are gone, and the new ones... well, I fear they’ll lean toward tyranny. Roosevelt and his ilk will use this collapse as an excuse to centralize power further.”

Evelyn’s eyes narrowed. “Then you’ll have to fight that too. You’ve always stood against what’s wrong. Why stop now?”

As the dust settled over the winter of 1929, Charles began to see the outlines of a new world forming. The crash had shattered the illusion of endless growth and exposed the fragility of the speculative economy. But it had also created an opportunity—for those bold enough to seize it.

From his corner office at the Ashcombe Bank, Charles looked out over Wall Street. Below, the chaos had subsided, replaced by a grim determination to survive. The great bull market of the 1920s was dead, but something new was rising from its ashes.

The question was, what role would he play in shaping it?

In December, an invitation arrived that hinted at the next stage of the battle. It was from the President of the United States, Herbert Hoover, requesting Charles’s presence at an emergency economic summit in Washington, D.C.

By mid-December, Washington, D.C., was gripped by a winter chill that seemed to mirror the nation’s mood. The city was teeming with dignitaries, economists, and businessmen summoned to the emergency summit. The atmosphere was thick with tension, as though the weight of the nation's collective failure hung in the air.

Charles Ashcombe stepped off the train at Union Station, his overcoat buttoned tightly against the cold. He carried himself with the quiet confidence of a man who had weathered the storm and emerged stronger. The Ashcombe Bank's stability and foresight had become the talk of financial circles, earning Charles both admiration and resentment.

Waiting for him on the platform was an aide from the White House, a brisk young man with a clipboard and a practised smile.

“Mr. Ashcombe,” the aide said, extending a hand. “Welcome to Washington. The President is eager to hear your thoughts.”

Charles nodded, his face betraying no emotion. “Lead the way.”

The emergency summit was held in the East Room of the White House, its grandeur a stark contrast to the dire state of the nation. The room was filled with the most powerful men in America: industrialists, financiers, and government officials. Herbert Hoover sat at the head of the table, his face lined with worry.

As Charles entered, the room fell silent. He could feel the weight of their gazes, a mixture of curiosity and suspicion. He took his seat near the middle of the table, unfolding his notes as the President began to speak.

“Gentlemen,” Hoover said, his voice steady but strained, “we are facing an economic crisis unlike any we’ve seen before. The American people are looking to us for answers, and we must act decisively to restore stability.”

He gestured to an economist at his right. “Professor Fisher, would you care to share your assessment?”

Irving Fisher, the renowned economist, stood and launched into a confident analysis. “The fundamentals of our economy remain strong. This downturn is temporary, a psychological panic. With the right government intervention, we can stabilize the markets and restore confidence.”

Charles kept his expression neutral but felt a pang of disbelief. He had read Fisher’s work and found it dangerously optimistic, rooted in an unwavering faith in central banking and government intervention.

When Fisher finished, Hoover turned to Charles. “Mr. Ashcombe, your bank has weathered this storm better than most. What is your perspective on the current crisis?”

Charles rose slowly, his presence commanding the room. “Mr. President, gentlemen,” he began, his British accent cutting through the American drawls, “the crisis we face is not merely psychological, nor is it temporary. It is the result of systemic flaws—a bubble inflated by easy credit and speculative mania.”

He glanced at Fisher, then back at the room. “The idea that we can fix this with more intervention is misguided. The more we distort the market, the greater the eventual reckoning. My bank has survived because we adhered to sound money principles. Gold, gentlemen, is the bedrock of stability, not paper promises.”

The room buzzed with murmurs, some of agreement, others of dissent. One banker, his voice tinged with irritation, interrupted. “Gold won’t feed starving families or rebuild collapsed businesses. We need liquidity, not antiquated ideas.”

Charles fixed him with a steady gaze. “Liquidity without value is merely inflation. It may provide temporary relief, but it destroys trust. And without trust, there is no economy.”

After the meeting, Hoover invited Charles to his private study for a more candid discussion. The room was dimly lit, the President’s face shadowed by the glow of a desk lamp.

“Mr. Ashcombe,” Hoover said, pouring two glasses of whiskey, “you speak with conviction, and your record commands respect. But do you truly believe gold is the answer? The world is moving forward—why cling to the past?”

Charles accepted the glass, swirling the amber liquid thoughtfully. “Because the past holds lessons we ignore at our peril. Gold is not an answer to every problem, but it is an anchor. It prevents the kind of reckless speculation that led us here.”

Hoover leaned back, his expression weary. “You may be right, but the American people won’t accept austerity or restraint. They want action—something tangible.”

“And what will you give them?” Charles asked, his tone sharp. “More debt? More intervention? That will only deepen the collapse.”

The President sighed. “Perhaps. But I fear we have no choice.”

By early 1930, the weight of the crash was fully pressing down on America. Breadlines stretched for blocks in every major city, factory chimneys stood cold and smokeless, and the hum of prosperity that had defined the roaring twenties was replaced with a deafening silence of despair. The Ashcombe Bank, fortified by Charles's foresight and insistence on gold reserves, was one of the few financial institutions still standing tall, though even it could not entirely escape the ripple effects of the Great Depression.

Charles Ashcombe sat in his office on the top floor of the bank’s headquarters, overlooking a city transformed. The hustle and bustle of New York had slowed to a crawl. Once-busy sidewalks were now crowded with unemployed men and women, their faces drawn and gaunt.

A sharp knock interrupted his thoughts. Evelyn entered, her presence a balm against the dreary backdrop of the city. She carried a stack of newspapers, the headlines grim: *Factories Close in Midwest, Unemployment Surpasses 25%, Riots in Berlin.*

“You should take a break, Charles,” she said softly, placing the papers on his desk. “The weight of the world isn’t yours alone to bear.”

He gave her a small, tired smile. “If only that were true. The policies they’ve implemented... it’s as if they’re determined to worsen the crisis. Easy money, bailouts—”

“And yet, you’ve done more than most to warn them,” Evelyn interrupted gently. “Come home early tonight. We’ll have dinner, just the two of us.”

While America reeled, Europe was crumbling under the strain of reparations and the collapse of international trade. Letters from Britain painted a bleak picture. Charles’s sister Eleanor described a country slipping into disrepair, with industries failing and social unrest on the rise.

Germany was in even worse condition. Hyperinflation had given way to mass unemployment, and extremist ideologies were taking root. Charles read each dispatch with growing concern, sensing that the economic crisis was laying the groundwork for political upheaval.

One morning, he received a letter from Ludwig von Mises. It was succinct and grim:

My dear Charles.

The consequences of the crash are unfolding as I feared. The policies of intervention and inflation are deepening the distortions in the market. The international monetary system is breaking apart, and we are witnessing the decline of Western stability. Prepare for even darker days ahead.

Yours, as ever,
Ludwig

Charles folded the letter carefully, setting it aside. He felt a chill despite the warm sunlight streaming through the window.

The depression wasn't just numbers on a ledger or headlines in a newspaper; it was human suffering on an unprecedented scale. Charles made a point of visiting local neighbourhoods, seeing first-hand the devastation wrought by the economic collapse.

One cold February afternoon, he and Evelyn distributed food and blankets to a shanty town that had sprung up on the outskirts of Manhattan. Families huddled together in makeshift shelters, their eyes hollow with hunger.

"Mr. Ashcombe," a man called out, his voice hoarse but hopeful. "Is it true what they're saying? That your bank is hiring?"

Charles turned to him, his expression solemn. "We're trying to do what we can, but we can't solve this alone. The entire system needs to change."

The man nodded, his shoulders slumping. "Thank you, sir. For being here."

Evelyn squeezed Charles's arm as they walked back to their car. "You're making a difference, even if it doesn't feel like it."

"I hope so," he murmured, though doubt gnawed at him.

The Ashcombe Bank continued to weather the storm, its reliance on gold shielding it from the worst of the turmoil. But the Depression was reshaping the world in ways even Charles couldn't predict. Governments were abandoning the gold standard, further inflating currencies in desperate attempts to revive their economies.

One evening in June, as Charles and Evelyn dined with economists and industrialists at a private club, the conversation turned to the future.

"America will recover," one businessman declared, his voice filled with bluster. "We've got the ingenuity, the spirit. This can't last forever."

"Perhaps," Charles replied, his tone measured. "But at what cost? The lessons of this crisis must not be ignored. Gold is not just a relic; it is a safeguard against precisely this kind of calamity."

His words were met with polite nods but little enthusiasm. The mood in the room was one of quiet desperation, a clinging to hope even as the foundations crumbled beneath them.

By late 1930, the cracks in the global order were widening. Charles watched with a mix of dread and determination as the Depression continued to reshape nations. He knew the Ashcombe Bank would endure, but he also knew the world that emerged from this crisis would be fundamentally different.

Charles nodded, his resolve hardening. The storm was far from over, but he would navigate it with the same steadfastness that had brought him this far. And perhaps, just perhaps, he could help shape the future for the better.

END OF PART TWO

PART THREE:

Chapter 11:

The city hummed with energy as if the entire world had shifted on its axis. London had become the epicentre of a cultural revolution, where the air was thick with the scent of incense, rebellion, and possibility. Carnaby Street overflowed with brightly dressed young people, the roar of motorbikes weaving through the hum of chatter and laughter. Everywhere, the old seemed to give way to the new, and the youth were charting a course for an unknown future.

Eleanor's grandson, **Nicholas Ashcombe**, was twenty-five, with the rakish charm and restless intellect that seemed to define his generation. He was tall and lean, with dark hair that fell in careless waves over his forehead. He wore a paisley shirt unbuttoned at the collar, a brown suede jacket slung casually over his shoulder, and a pair of wire-rimmed glasses that framed eyes filled with curiosity.

Nicholas was at the crossroads of two revolutions: the flower power of the hippie movement and the technological wave of computing. By day, he was a programmer at a small but innovative company called **Orion Systems**, where he was trying to develop a computer. By night, he was a guitarist for a psychedelic rock band, ***The Sonic Wanderers***, who played at underground clubs and art happenings across the city.

That evening, Nicholas found himself in a studio loft in Notting Hill, where the two worlds he straddled often collided. The room was filled with musicians, artists, and engineers, all sharing ideas and inspiration. A reel-to-reel tape recorder hummed in the corner, and the scent of marijuana hung heavy in the air.

On one side of the room, a group of musicians debated the virtues of analogue versus electric sound, their voices rising over the opening chords of a new song. On the other, a cluster of tech enthusiasts gathered around a rudimentary computer terminal, the glow of its screen illuminating their faces as they discussed the potential of programming to create entirely new forms of music.

Nicholas moved easily between the groups, a cigarette dangling from his lips.

"Nick, mate," called **Andy**, the band's keyboardist, gesturing him over. "You've got to hear this."

Rowan hit a key, and a strange, warbling tone filled the room, produced by a prototype synthesizer that looked more like a tangle of wires than an instrument. Nicholas's eyebrows rose in appreciation.

"That's wild," he said, crouching down to inspect the machine. "Could you program it to play sequences automatically?"

"Possibly," Andy replied. "But it'd need some sort of engineering. Isn't that your domain?"

Nicholas grinned. "Give me an evening with it, and I'll see what I can do."

Later, as the loft emptied out and the remaining few sprawled on cushions and rugs, Nicholas leaned back with his guitar, plucking out an impromptu melody.

“The world’s changing faster than anyone realizes,” he said, his voice thoughtful. “Music, technology—they’re going to merge in ways we can’t even imagine yet. We’re on the brink of something massive.”

Rowan nodded, passing him a joint. “You mean the machines taking over?”

“Not exactly,” Nicholas replied, exhaling a cloud of smoke. “But think about it. We’ve always used tools to amplify our creativity, from the first drum to the electric guitar. Computers are just the next step. They won’t replace us—they’ll expand what’s possible.”

A woman in a flowing kaftan, her hair a mass of curls, spoke up. “But what about the soul of it? Music isn’t just about sound waves or circuits—it’s about feeling, connection.”

Nicholas nodded. “True. But maybe technology can help us connect in ways we’ve never considered. Imagine a world where music isn’t just something you hear, but something you experience—visually, emotionally, even physically. That’s where we’re headed.”

As the early hours of the morning crept in, Nicholas slipped away to a quieter corner of the loft. In his jacket pocket was a letter from his mother written in her careful, looping script.

My dearest Nicholas,

I’ve been following your adventures with great interest—it seems you’ve found your place in this brave new world. Your uncle Charles would have been fascinated by what you’re doing. He believed deeply in progress, though he always cautioned against losing ourselves in it.

I hope you’ll come to visit soon. Yorkshire may seem old-fashioned to you now, but there’s still a place for you here, should you ever need it.

With love,
Mother

Nicholas folded the letter carefully and tucked it back into his pocket. He loved his mother dearly, but England felt like a relic of another era—a place weighed down by tradition and history. Here, in London’s swinging heart, he felt alive, surrounded by the pulse of change and possibility.

As dawn broke over the city, Nicholas walked home through the quiet streets, his mind buzzing with ideas. He had a vision of a future where music and technology converged to create something entirely new—a future where boundaries dissolved, and creativity reigned supreme.

The next day Nick stood before a cluttered workbench in the heart of Orion Systems’ research lab. The air was thick with the acrid scent of solder, the low hum of prototypes filling the room like a mechanical chorus. This was where the future was being built—or at least, Nick liked to think so.

On the bench lay the bare skeleton of a machine that, if successful, could upend everything: a computer small enough, simple enough, and affordable enough to fit into an ordinary person’s home. It was ambitious, almost unthinkable. Computers were vast, room-filling machines, the domain of governments, universities, and sprawling corporations. Yet Nick couldn’t shake the feeling that they didn’t need to be.

“Imagine,” he had told the rest of the team months ago, “a machine that isn’t locked away in an office or a lab. Something that can sit on a desk, something that ordinary people can use. For music. For letters. For art, even.”

He had said it with the conviction of a prophet, though the project's realities were far more prosaic.

"Nick, you got a sec?" Graham shouted from across the lab, holding up a circuit board that looked like it had been through a war. Smoke curled lazily off its edges.

Nick wandered over, tugging at the loose knot of his tie. He picked up the charred board and squinted at it like a detective trying to solve a particularly tricky case.

"Overheating again?" he asked.

"Like a bloody sauna," Graham said. "We're gonna fry the whole system if this keeps up."

Nick tapped the board against his palm, thinking. "We'll need to rethink the power supply. And Clara mentioned using aluminium for the casing instead of steel—it might help with heat dissipation."

"That's gonna cost," Graham muttered.

"Everything does," Nick replied with a shrug. "But this isn't just about money, is it? This is about access. If we get this right, we're not just making a computer—we're changing the rules of the game."

"Big talk for a guy who's still using a pencil to fix his schematics," Graham quipped, but there was a glint of respect in his eye.

Later, Nick found himself in a cramped conference room with the Orion brass. The investors weren't exactly enthusiastic about his pet project. They liked steady profits, reliable government contracts, and incremental innovation—not revolutionary pipe dreams.

"Personal computers," one of them said, leaning back in his chair like a man about to deliver bad news, "aren't personal. They're niche. A toy for geeks."

Nick grinned, though he felt like throttling the guy. "That's what they said about the radio. And the television. Now everyone's got one."

Another investor, a pinched-looking bloke with gold-rimmed glasses, frowned. "Even if people wanted one—which they don't—the components are too expensive. You'll never get the price down to something reasonable."

Nick leaned forward, his voice steady. "We're not just selling hardware. We're selling potential. A computer that fits on your desk? It's not just a machine—it's a new way of thinking. For schools, small businesses, families. This isn't a fad. It's the future."

The room went quiet. The investors shifted uncomfortably, scribbling notes. Finally, one of them cleared his throat. "You'll need to show us proof. Costs, timelines, a demo that doesn't look like a science project."

Nick nodded, his grin returning. "You'll have it."

That evening, Nick was back in the lab, sleeves rolled up and hair a mess. Clara slid a mug of tea onto the bench beside him and leaned against the desk.

"How'd it go?" she asked.

"Same old," Nick said without looking up. "They want numbers. Proof it won't bankrupt the company. Proof we're not lunatics."

“Typical,” Clara said with a snort. “If they’d been in charge of the Renaissance, we’d still be painting on cave walls.”

Nick chuckled, finally looking at her. “They’re not wrong, though. The costs are insane. If we don’t crack this soon, they’ll pull the plug.”

Clara sipped her tea thoughtfully. “What about that music application we talked about? If we can show it doing something creative, that might make them sit up.”

“It’s a start,” Nick said, already turning the idea over in his mind. “But we need something bigger. A demonstration that’ll make them think, *We can’t live without this.*”

It had been a long day at Orion Computers, working on a project his boss called ambitious and his colleagues called mad. But Nick couldn’t shake the feeling they were onto something, something big.

He crossed the room, brushing past a stack of circuit schematics and a pile of *Melody Maker* magazines, to grab a beer from the fridge. The flat was a clash of worlds: half-laboratory, half-artist’s den. Engineering manuals were stacked beside Bob Dylan albums; a half-finished soldering job shared space on the table with a crumpled set list from his band.

Nick sat down on the sofa and picked up the guitar, letting its weight settle in his lap. His fingers moved instinctively over the strings, coaxing out a soft, meandering riff. It was something new he’d been working on, inspired by the energy of the London music scene. This weekend, *The Sonic Wanderers* were playing two gigs: one at a Camden pub that reeked of stale beer and another at a club in Soho where they’d be lucky to get noticed.

Still, Jamie, the drummer, was convinced they were on the verge of something big. Nick wasn’t so sure. The scene was crowded, and for every band that made it, a dozen more faded away. But for now, the gigs were fun, and the music felt real.

As he strummed, his mind wandered back to the day’s work. Orion’s latest project—a personal computer—was the kind of idea that made his pulse quicken. The concept of a machine small enough to fit in a home felt like science fiction, but Nick believed it was possible. He’d spent the afternoon soldering and sketching circuits, imagining a world where ordinary people could harness the power of computing.

Clara had teased him about it. “You’re always looking ten years ahead,” she’d said. “Maybe twenty.”

But that was Nick’s way. Whether it was music or machines, he was always chasing the horizon.

The phone rang, jolting him from his thoughts. He set the guitar aside and picked up the receiver.

“Nick! You still alive over there?” Jamie’s voice boomed through the line.

“Barely,” Nick said, leaning back on the couch. “What’s up?”

“Rehearsal tomorrow. Eight sharp. And don’t forget that new riff you’ve been noodling with. We’ll work it into the set.”

Nick smirked. “You mean the one you’ll butcher on the drums?”

“Cheeky sod,” Jamie shot back. “Just bring it. Oh, and bring some beer this time. We’re not made of money.”

“Right. See you then,” Nick said before hanging up.

Nick leaned back and stared at the ceiling. The soft hum of a party down the street floated through the open window, mingling with the scent of blooming flowers. London felt alive, buzzing with change. The music, the people, even the technology—everything seemed on the cusp of something new.

He picked up a notebook from the coffee table and began jotting ideas. Some were for the band: lyrics, chord progressions, a rough sketch for a poster. Others were for Orion: circuit designs, thoughts on user interfaces, the skeleton of a proposal for a smaller, more affordable computer.

By the evening and the streets of Notting Hill were alive with colour and movement as Nick slung his guitar case over his shoulder and headed toward the old warehouse where *The Sonic Wanderers* rehearsed. The sun had dipped below the horizon, but the city buzzed with the energy of the counterculture. Young people in paisley prints and velvet jackets spilled out of pubs, laughing and smoking as the sound of jangling guitars and distant horns floated through the air.

Nick turned down an alley, the bricks damp with the spring evening’s dew, and rapped twice on a green-painted door. It swung open, revealing Jamie, all grins and chaos, his curly hair barely contained under a floppy hat.

“Took your sweet time,” Jamie said, ushering Nick inside.

The warehouse smelled of dust, beer, and stale cigarettes. A patchwork of posters—The Kinks, The Who, and The Rolling Stones—plastered the walls, alongside hand-drawn flyers for *The Sonic Wanderers*. In the centre of the room, a drum kit sat like a king on its throne, surrounded by amps, tangled cables, and a mismatched collection of chairs and beanbags.

Dave, their bassist, lounged on a tattered sofa, cigarette in one hand and his bass in the other. She had that air of studied coolness, her eyeliner sharp enough to cut glass. Andy, their keyboardist, was tinkering with an old Vox Continental organ, cursing under his breath as he adjusted the settings.

“Look who decided to show,” Dave drawled as Nick set his guitar case down.

“Evening to you too,” Nick said, flipping the latches and lifting out his Gibson.

“Let’s get this thing rolling,” Jamie called as he bounded behind his drum kit. He gave the snare a test whack, then kicked the bass pedal. The sound echoed around the room, drowning out Andy’s muttering and Dave’s sardonic chuckle.

Nick plugged in his guitar, the amp humming to life. He played a quick scale, letting the room fill with warm, resonant notes.

“Right,” Jamie said, twirling a drumstick. “Let’s start with the new one. What was it called again?”

“‘Electric Voyage,’” Nick said, strumming the opening riff. It was a hypnotic, swirling piece they’d started working on last week, the kind of song that felt like it was meant for strobe lights and dancing feet.

“Yeah, that,” Jamie said. “Okay, one, two, three—”

The room exploded with sound. Jamie’s drums hit like thunderclaps, while Dave’s bassline grooved like a heartbeat. Andy’s keys floated above it all, shimmering and otherworldly, as Nick’s guitar cut through with sharp, ringing notes.

Nick closed his eyes, losing himself in the music. This was the part he loved—the moment when everything else faded away, leaving only the sound and the rhythm. It wasn't perfect; Jamie missed a beat, and Andy's organ crackled at the high notes, but it felt alive, electric.

"That's the one," Dave said, tapping ash into an empty beer can. "That's gonna get us the Soho crowd eating out of our hands."

"You think?" Nick asked, wiping sweat from his forehead.

"Think?" Andy scoffed. "Mate, they'll be begging for an encore."

"Speaking of which," Jamie said, "we should practice the rest of the set before we get cocky."

A low, droning hum kicks things off—the kind of sound that makes you sit up and take notice. Andy's organ swells, wobbling with a hypnotic vibrato, like the shimmering heatwaves on a summer horizon. Dave's bassline slides in next, thick and pulsing, a heartbeat that thumps steadily beneath the surface, pulling you into the groove.

Doom... doom-doom-doom... doom-doom-doom.

Nick's guitar sneaks in with a reverb-soaked riff, sharp yet fluid, like sunlight reflecting off rippling water.

Da-na-na-na, wa-wa-da-na, wa-wa-da-na!

Jamie's snare snaps like a firecracker, and then the whole band locks into the main groove. The organ churns like a carnival ride spinning faster and faster, while the guitar riff doubles down, fuzzier and more insistent. Jamie's hi-hat ticks like a clock counting down, then bursts open into a cymbal crash.

Nick leans into the mic, his voice smooth but tinged with rawness:
"Drifting through the velvet skies,
Chasing colours in your eyes,
I feel the pull, the gravity,
Electric voyage, you and me."

Dave's bassline walks higher, creating a subtle tension, while the organ hums in the background like a ghostly choir.

The band explodes into the chorus:
"We're floating, we're falling,
Through time and through space,
The stars are our witnesses,
No need for a place.
Electric voyaaaaage—
Just let yourself go!"

The guitar bends upward into a wild, spiralling lick, like a rocket taking off, as Jamie pounds out a thunderous rhythm on the toms.

The music slows for a moment, shimmering with anticipation. Andy's organ plays a haunting, spaced-out melody that sounds like something from a sci-fi film.

Dave plucks a slow, descending bassline, like footsteps leading deeper into a dream, while Nick scratches out muted chords that whisper rather than shout.

Then Nick's guitar erupts in a searing solo, a mix of bending notes and lightning-fast runs. Each note pierces like a scream, echoing through the room as Jamie builds behind it, adding more force with each drumroll.

The band dives back into the chorus, this time bigger, louder, and more unhinged.
"We're floating, we're falling,
Through time and through space—
Electric voyaaaaaage—
No need for a place!"

Nick's guitar wails, the organ swirls, and Dave's bass thrums relentlessly as Jamie crashes his cymbals in a frenzy.

The song crescendos into a chaotic wall of sound before abruptly cutting out, leaving just the hum of the organ, fading into nothingness like a dream slipping away.

For a moment, the room is silent, save for the buzz of amps cooling down. Then Jamie lets out a whoop.

"That's it!" he yells, standing and twirling a drumstick like a magician revealing his final trick.

Dave shook his head, a sly smile on her face. "That's gonna melt faces at the gig."

Nick nods, heart pounding from more than just the music. He could feel it—this song wasn't just a jam. It was something special.

The air in Soho felt alive that night, buzzing with the electric hum of a city on fire with the Summer of Love. The streets were a kaleidoscope of colour—flower-print dresses and flared trousers, waistcoats with swirling paisley patterns, and sunglasses so oversized they hid half a face. The Velvet Lantern, a dive of legend among London's counterculture, was already packed when The Sonic Wanderers arrived.

Outside, the neon sign sputtered and glowed like a heartbeat, casting a flickering glow over a crowd that was half waiting for the music and half just waiting to see who'd show up. Nick slung his guitar case over his shoulder and lit a cigarette as the band pushed through the front door. The air inside hit like a wave—thick with smoke, sweat, and the tang of spilled ale.

The stage was a modest corner of the room, raised just enough for a band to tower over the packed-in crowd. A velvet curtain hung behind it, maroon and fraying at the edges, like it had witnessed a thousand nights of raw noise and wild dancing. Tables with mismatched chairs were scattered around, though most patrons had abandoned them to sway, drink, or simply be seen.

Dave leaned over to Nick as they weaved toward the stage. "This place smells worse every time we play it."

"Yeah," Nick replied with a smirk, "but it's our kind of grime."

Jamie tapped his drumsticks together as they passed the bar, earning a few cheers from regulars. Andy trailed behind, looking like he'd stepped out of Carnaby Street, his fringe so sharp it could've been cut with a ruler.

They dumped their gear onto the stage. The venue's lone roadie—a wiry bloke named Vince who always looked half-asleep—grunted as he helped Jamie set up his drum kit. Nick plugged in his guitar and struck a chord, letting it ring out. The sound reverberated across the room, catching a few heads already buzzing from too many pints.

Dave checked the tuning on the bass. "Think the crowd's ready for 'Electric Voyage'?" she asked.

"They better be," Nick said, adjusting the strap of his battered Stratocaster. "It's the only place they're going tonight."

As they prepared, the crowd thickened, voices rising in a low roar. A couple in bell-bottoms and matching love beads twirled in the corner, while a man in a three-piece velvet suit waved a cigarette holder like it was a conductor's baton. Someone passed Nick a pint from the bar. He took a sip, the bitter edge grounding him just enough to feel like he was in control.

Dave nudged him. "Recognize that lot?" She pointed to a group near the back—musicians from another band that was climbing the charts.

"They're here to see us screw up," Nick muttered. "Not tonight."

The house lights dipped low, and the room's energy shifted. A spotlight clicked on, illuminating the band as they took their positions. Jamie tapped out a steady beat, testing his kit, as Andy leaned over the keys, playing a couple of ghostly arpeggios that floated over the crowd.

Nick stepped up to the mic. "Evening, Velvet Lantern. Let's take a trip, yeah?"

A cheer erupted, glasses raised and voices shouting encouragement.

They started with a loose, groovy number, something warm to ease the crowd in. Dave's bass hummed like a cat purring, steady and low, while Nick's guitar played delicate riffs that danced around Andy's organ. Jamie held it all together, his drumming precise but with just enough swagger to push the tempo.

The crowd swayed as one, and Nick could feel the night gathering momentum. It was as if the room was waiting to erupt, and they were the ones holding the match.

The opening groove simmered into a hypnotic rhythm, but it was only the beginning. Nick stepped to the mic, his voice crackling through the tiny, overworked speakers.

"This one's called 'Electric Voyage.' Let's go."

The band hit it hard, a sonic explosion that jolted the Velvet Lantern to life. Jamie's drums thundered, kicking the crowd into a collective stomp. Dave's bass growled, locking into a tight, propulsive rhythm that felt like the heartbeat of some otherworldly machine. Andy's organ screamed in harmony, its sound oscillating between piercing and ethereal, like starlight turned to sound waves.

Nick tore into the riff, his Stratocaster snarling as his fingers danced across the fretboard. Each note seemed to take on a life of its own, weaving through the smoky air and colliding with the cheers and screams of the crowd.

The Velvet Lantern was a riot of movement. Bodies packed shoulder-to-shoulder, bouncing and swaying, arms raised in ecstatic abandon. A girl with a daisy crown climbed onto a table, spinning like a human gyroscope before collapsing into the arms of her laughing friends.

“Take us there, Nick!” someone shouted, their voice drowned by the wall of sound.

The music kept building, like a roller-coaster clicking its way to the top of the track. Jamie’s cymbals crashed, filling the room with a shimmering brightness that felt almost tactile.

Nick stepped back from the mic, letting Dave and Andy take the lead. Dave’s bass solo rolled like thunder, a deep, primal sound that made the floorboards vibrate. Andy layered in ghostly chords, the organ sounding like an alien signal broadcast from a distant galaxy.

Nick turned to Jamie and grinned, sweat dripping from his hair. “Let’s blow this thing open,” he shouted over the noise.

Jamie answered with a drum fill so wild it seemed to defy the laws of rhythm. The band slammed back in together, louder and faster than before, the sound hitting like a tidal wave.

Nick leaned into his guitar, letting it wail in a solo that felt both controlled and chaotic. The strings screamed under his touch, bending into high-pitched cries that seemed to vibrate straight into the crowd’s collective nervous system. He closed his eyes, lost in the music, the noise, the pure, unfiltered energy of the moment.

Dave headbanged in perfect time, his hair flying like a whip, while Andy threw his whole body into the organ, his fingers moving so fast they blurred. Jamie’s drumming became almost animalistic, driving the song forward with an unstoppable momentum.

The crowd was a frenzy now, some dancing, some climbing on tables, others just standing there, staring at the stage as if witnessing some kind of spiritual event.

Nick raised his guitar high, then brought it down into a final riff that spiralled upward like a rocket. The band followed him, every note climbing higher and higher, faster and faster, until it felt like the whole room might explode.

Then, silence.

For half a second, the world stopped. Then the crowd erupted into deafening applause, cheers, and whistles that shook the walls of the Velvet Lantern.

Nick stepped back from the mic, chest heaving, and wiped his forehead with his sleeve. Dave and Andy exchanged exhausted grins, while Jamie raised a drumstick in victory.

They had done it. The Velvet Lantern wasn’t just a venue tonight—it was their kingdom.

As Nick unplugged his guitar, a young woman from the audience clambered onto the stage, wrapping a flower necklace around his neck. “You’ve got to record that one!” she shouted over the noise.

The dressing room was a chaotic mix of mismatched furniture and peeling posters of past acts. The Sonic Wanderers spilled in, still vibrating with the energy of their set. The room smelled of damp wood and stale cigarettes, mingled with the faint whiff of incense drifting in from somewhere down the hall.

"Did you hear them screaming?" Dave laughed, dropping her bass into its stand. She flopped onto a sagging sofa, kicking her boots up onto the table. "We killed it tonight."

"Bloody right we did," Jamie said, tossing his drumsticks onto a side table and grabbing a half-empty beer bottle. "That last song? They were eating out of our hands."

Nick, ever the perfectionist, was already wiping down his guitar, a faint frown on his face. "We were good," he admitted, "but the bridge on ‘Sky Driver’ was off. We lost the rhythm for a second."

Andy waved him off, grabbing a cigarette and leaning against the wall. "Nobody noticed, mate. You’re the only one who gets that picky."

Before anyone could reply, the door creaked open, and a man stepped in.

He wasn’t famous—yet—but there was something about him that made the room pause. He was lean, his clothes a riot of mismatched patterns: a paisley shirt, a red scarf tied loosely around his neck, and tight black trousers. His Afro framed his face like a halo, and he carried a guitar case slung over his shoulder.

"Nice set," he said, his voice a low, easy drawl with a faint American twang. "You’ve got a real groove going."

Jamie, beer halfway to his mouth, froze. Dave sat up straighter, eyes narrowed with curiosity.

"Thanks," Nick said cautiously, setting his guitar down. "You playing tonight?"

The man nodded, stepping further into the room. "Name’s Jimi. Jimi Hendrix. Just moved over from the States. First album is coming out soon. Trying to see if London’s got ears for something different."

"Jimi Hendrix," Dave repeated, testing the name as if weighing its significance.

Nick stepped forward, offering a handshake. "Nick Ashcombe. That’s Dave, Jamie, and Andy."

Jimi shook his hand, his grip firm but relaxed. "Good to meet you, Nick. Your sound—it’s raw, man. Got something real going on there. You write your own stuff?"

Nick nodded. "Mostly. We’re trying to find our sound, you know? Something that sticks."

Jimi set his guitar case down and perched on the arm of a chair. "Stick to it. Don’t let anyone box you in. The music’s gotta come from here." He tapped his chest, a small smile playing at his lips.

Jimi’s gaze flicked to Nick’s guitar. "Mind if I?"

Nick hesitated, glancing at the Strat leaning against the wall. Then he nodded. "Sure."

Jimi picked it up, his fingers sliding over the strings like they were an extension of himself. Even unplugged, the sound was mesmerizing, the notes bending and twisting in a way none of them had heard before.

"Jesus," Jamie muttered, leaning forward.

Jimi grinned, looking up at Nick. "You gotta let it breathe, man. Feel the space between the notes."

Nick watched closely, absorbing every movement. "Show me that bend again."

Jimi demonstrated, slowing his fingers so Nick could follow. "It’s not about forcing it. Just let it happen."

As Jimi handed the guitar back, Dave spoke up. "You said you’re playing tonight? When’s your set?"

"In about twenty minutes," Jimi said, slinging his guitar case over his shoulder. "Stick around. I've got some stuff I think you'll dig."

Nick nodded. "We'll be there."

Jimi gave a slow, easy smile. "Cool. Maybe we'll jam sometime."

With that, he was gone, leaving the room buzzing with his quiet confidence.

"Who the hell was that?" Andy asked after a moment.

"Someone to watch," Nick said, staring at his guitar like it had been transformed.

The toast was brief but spirited, and as the last swig of wine disappeared, Dave sprang up with a grin. "Alright, you lot, we're not done yet. There's a place I know around the corner, a little dive with better whiskey and worse music. Let's give it a look."

Nick wiped his hands on his jeans, already shrugging into his jacket. "Lead the way then. We've got the night ahead of us."

Jamie grabbed his sticks from the table, twirling one between his fingers as he followed. "Can't wait to see who we run into next. Maybe someone else will drop in and change the bloody world."

The new bar, the **Sideways Swan**, sat on a crooked street just off Carnaby. Outside, a blue neon sign flickered inconsistently, the light reflecting off the puddles left from an earlier rain. Inside, the room was a hodgepodge of velvets, mismatched chairs, and dim lamps casting long shadows. A haze of cigarette smoke hung in the air, and the faint hum of an unfamiliar jazz tune spilled out from the speakers.

The Wanderers claimed a corner table, and Dave took charge, waving over a server who appeared from the shadows. "Four whiskeys. Neat. And keep them coming."

The server nodded and disappeared, leaving the band to settle into their seats.

Nick leaned back, observing the room. It was quieter than the Velvet Lantern but still buzzing in its own way. Artists and writers occupied one side of the bar, their low conversations peppered with laughter, while a group of sharply dressed mods crowded the opposite end.

"You ever been here before?" Nick asked Dave.

"Once or twice," she said, lighting a cigarette. "It's one of those places that never really changes but somehow always feels new. I like it."

As the whiskey arrived, a man stepped up to the corner piano. He was older than most of the crowd, with greying hair and a worn tweed jacket. His fingers hovered over the keys for a moment before he began to play, a slow, melancholy tune that seemed to hold the room in a spell.

"Who's he?" Jamie asked, his voice hushed.

"No idea," Andy said, his eyes fixed on the pianist. "But he's bloody good."

Nick leaned forward, his fingers drumming lightly on the table in time with the music. "This city's full of talent. It's like every corner has someone waiting to surprise you."

Dave nudged him, pulling him back to the moment. "You alright over there? You've been staring off like you're in a bloody trance."

Nick smiled. "Just thinking. About the band, about the music…about how lucky we are to be here, now."

Chapter 12:

Nick sat cross-legged on the floor of his flat, a cluttered space that smelled faintly of incense and solder. Around him were scattered notes, sketches, and half-assembled circuits. A dim desk lamp cast an amber glow over the room, illuminating the chaotic genius of his workspace. In one hand, he held a pencil, jotting ideas furiously onto a crumpled sheet of paper. In the other, a cigarette smouldered, forgotten.

The idea was forming. It wasn't just a machine any more. It was a gateway—a way to empower individuals, to decentralize knowledge and creativity, to break free from the rigid hierarchies of information. The computer wasn't just a tool. It was freedom.

He had felt it, not just in the logic of circuits but in the swirling, kaleidoscopic visions of his recent experiments with LSD. The trip had been like stepping into a new dimension, a place where everything was connected, flowing, and alive. Numbers became colours, logic morphed into music, and at the centre of it all was this idea: a device that could bring that interconnectedness into the hands of every person.

Nick leaned back, staring at a schematic he had sketched earlier. The basic components were all there—a central processor, memory storage, input, and output—but what excited him most was the philosophy behind it.

“This isn't just about technology,” he muttered to himself, cigarette still balanced between his lips. “This is about liberation.”

The computers of the day were hulking beasts, locked away in universities and corporations, their use dictated by a select few. They were symbols of power, centralized and inaccessible. But Nick's vision was different. He wanted a computer for the people—a personal machine, small enough to fit in a flat, simple enough for anyone to use.

The key, he realized, was to make it intuitive. He thought back to the trip, to the way his thoughts had seemed to flow effortlessly, without barriers. The machine had to work like that—seamlessly, naturally, almost organically.

“Forget the blinking lights and switches,” he thought. “What if it felt like playing music? Like speaking? What if it could learn, adapt?”

The pencil in his hand flew across the paper, sketching out a new interface. Instead of punch cards or cryptic commands, he imagined something visual—symbols, patterns, something anyone could grasp without needing a degree in engineering.

The next day, Nick sat in the sparse, modern office of Henry Talbot, the head of the firm funding his work. Talbot was a man of sharp suits and sharper opinions, his mind an alloy of business acumen and philosophical curiosity. He had taken a chance on Nick—a long-haired techie with wild ideas—but Talbot was not the sort to write blank checks without scrutiny.

Behind Talbot's desk, floor-to-ceiling windows framed a grey London sky, while a single rotary phone sat on the polished mahogany surface. The air carried the faint scent of Talbot's ever-present pipe tobacco, blending oddly with the tang of ozone from the lab downstairs.

Nick sat forward in the chair, his hands animated as he tried to explain his vision.

“Look, Henry,” he said, “this isn’t just about engineering. This isn’t even just about making a smaller machine. The computer isn’t just a tool—it’s a philosophy. A way to reshape society.”

Talbot leaned back in his chair, the faintest smirk tugging at the corner of his mouth. “Reshape society? That’s quite a pitch, my boy. You’re not proposing we overthrow Parliament with a microprocessor, are you?”

Nick chuckled but shook his head. “No, nothing like that. What I mean is... Think about how centralized everything is now. Power, information, resources—it’s all locked up in institutions, controlled by a select few. The average person doesn’t stand a chance. But with a computer—an affordable, personal computer—you give people the tools to think, to create, to innovate.”

Talbot tamped down his pipe, lighting it with a practised hand. He regarded Nick through a haze of smoke. “You’re talking about decentralization,” he said. “Democratizing access to information.”

“Exactly,” Nick said, leaning in. “Imagine an artist who can compose music without needing a studio. A writer who can publish without needing a printing press. A student who can learn without needing to sit in some dusty lecture hall.”

Talbot exhaled slowly, the smoke curling like a thought unspooling in the air. “Sounds terribly idealistic. What happens when the wrong people get their hands on this ‘power’? What if they misuse it?”

“They will,” Nick admitted. “People always misuse tools at first. But the beauty of this is that it’s not about control—it’s about potential. The more people have access, the more they can innovate. The bad actors will be drowned out by the sheer volume of creativity and progress.”

Talbot raised an eyebrow. “And this utopia you’re describing—what’s to stop it from being co-opted by corporations? Governments? Turned into another tool of oppression?”

Nick leaned back, thoughtful. “That’s the risk, isn’t it? But that’s why the machine has to stay open. Open architecture, open access. No patents locking people out. If it’s free—truly free—then no one can own it.”

Talbot puffed his pipe, watching Nick with an expression that was equal parts curiosity and scepticism. “You’ve been reading too much Marx, or maybe too much Wells,” he said dryly. “Technology isn’t a magic bullet, Nick. It doesn’t inherently make the world better.”

“I know that,” Nick replied, his voice tinged with frustration. “But it can be a catalyst. The printing press didn’t make people good, but it gave them the means to think, to question, to rebel. This machine can do the same. It can amplify the best parts of us—creativity, curiosity, collaboration.”

Talbot tapped ash from his pipe into a tray, then leaned forward, his tone softening. “I admire your passion, truly. But passion doesn’t pay the bills. Why should I, as a businessman, believe in your vision? Where’s the profit?”

Nick smiled, a glint of mischief in his eyes. “Because the people who can’t afford your big, clunky mainframes today? They’ll want something smaller, cheaper, easier. And when they do, we’ll be there, ahead of the curve.”

For a long moment, Talbot said nothing. He studied Nick as if weighing him against some unseen scale, the pipe dangling loosely in his hand. Finally, he nodded.

“All right,” he said. “You’ve got your funding. But I want results, Nick. Prototypes. Proof that this isn’t just another pipe dream.”

Nick grinned. “You’ll have it. Just wait. This is going to change everything.”

Nick spent the afternoon sketching ideas in his small, cluttered office, which sat above a record shop in Camden. Sunlight streamed through the smudged windows, catching the dust motes that danced in the air. A faint hum of life from the street below blended with the distant strum of a guitar in the shop, forming a sort of symphony of the times. But Nick’s mind was somewhere else entirely, spinning with circuits, components, and wild possibility.

On his desk sat an array of tools—a soldering iron, spools of wire, resistors, capacitors—and a stack of notebooks filled with diagrams. He leaned over a fresh sheet of paper, letting the pencil scratch out his thoughts, the beginnings of what might one day be called a personal computer.

The heart of Nick’s vision was **a compact, modular machine** that could fit on a desk, rather than requiring an entire room. The main body of the device would be a rectangular chassis, no larger than a suitcase, made of lightweight aluminium to keep it portable. Inside, he imagined:

1. **The CPU (Central Processing Unit)**:
   At its core, Nick envisioned a single-board design based on the emerging **MOS Technology 6502 processor**—a cost-effective alternative to the massive, expensive processors used in mainframe computers. It would operate at a speed of 1 MHz, fast enough for basic calculations and data processing.

2. **Memory (RAM and Storage)**:
   - He planned for **4 kilobytes of RAM**, expandable to 16 KB through simple add-on modules.
   - For storage, Nick toyed with the idea of using **cassette tapes** to load and save programs—a cheap, accessible option that nearly anyone could afford. He imagined a small tape deck integrated into the front of the machine.
3. **Input and Output (I/O)**:
   - The device would include a **typewriter-style keyboard**, built directly into the chassis. This would allow users to interact with the machine without needing specialized punch cards or terminals.
   - For display, Nick dreamed of connecting the machine to a **television set**, repurposing the ubiquitous household device as a low-cost monitor. The computer would output text and simple graphics via an RF modulator.
4. **Operating System**:
   The machine would boot into a **basic programming environment**—likely something similar to BASIC (Beginner’s All-purpose Symbolic Instruction Code). Users could write and execute their own programs without needing extensive technical knowledge.

5. **Power Supply**:

- Nick envisioned an **internal power unit** that could plug into a standard wall outlet. The simplicity of a single cable appealed to him; he wanted this machine to be as user-friendly as possible.

Nick paused, looking at his sketches. The machine he imagined was unlike anything on the market—small, affordable, versatile. It wasn't just for scientists or corporations; it was for everyone. A schoolteacher could use it to prepare lessons. A musician could use it to compose and sequence sounds. A student could explore mathematics or write poetry.

He jotted down a name at the top of the page: **The Ashcombe Micro**. He wasn't sure it would stick, but it felt right for now. The name was a quiet nod to his family's legacy, but this machine would stand for something different—something personal, human, and forward-thinking.

Nick spent the rest of the day soldering components onto a breadboard, testing the basic circuits for his design. The smell of melted solder filled the room, mixing with the faint aroma of his half-drunk tea. He wired up a simple display circuit to a tiny cathode-ray tube he'd salvaged from an old TV, testing it with a series of glowing letters and numbers.

Hours passed in a blur of trial and error. By the time he finally leaned back, wiping his brow, the prototype was beginning to take shape. It was rudimentary—a tangle of wires and chips held together more by hope than design—but it worked.

He typed a simple program into the machine:

```
BASIC
10 PRINT "HELLO, WORLD!"
20 GOTO 10
```

When the text appeared on the tiny screen, repeating endlessly, Nick grinned. It was crude, but it was a start.

Nick stared at the looping "HELLO, WORLD!" on the screen. The glow from the tiny cathode-ray tube bathed his face in pale light, and for a moment, the clamour of London outside seemed to fade away. It was as though the machine was speaking directly to him—not in words, but in possibilities.

This wasn't just an experiment anymore. It was becoming something tangible, something that could change lives. Nick imagined a future where everyone could have a machine like this in their home. People would no longer need to rely on vast institutions or massive corporations for access to computing power. The Ashcombe Micro—or whatever he ended up calling it—would be **a tool of liberation**.

He leaned back in his chair, letting the enormity of the idea settle over him. It wasn't just about circuits or code—it was about power, independence, and the untapped potential of the human mind.

The next morning, Nick brought his sketches and rudimentary prototype to a meeting with Marcus Adler, the head of the firm. Marcus was an older man, silver-haired but sharp-eyed, with a reputation for being both visionary and ruthlessly pragmatic. He was one of the few people in the industry who truly understood the potential of computers, and Nick hoped to convince him of the personal computer's merit.

Marcus sat behind his imposing oak desk, puffing on a cigar as Nick set up the prototype. The office was a stark contrast to Nick's workspace—sleek, minimalist, and adorned with abstract art. Through the large windows, the London skyline stretched out, hazy in the morning light.

Nick powered up the machine and demonstrated its basic functions, typing a few commands into the keyboard and showing how the screen responded. Marcus watched silently, his expression unreadable.

When Nick finished, he turned to Marcus. "This isn’t just a machine for scientists or government labs," he said. "This is a machine for people. For everyone. Imagine what could happen if the average person had access to computing power like this."

Marcus exhaled a plume of smoke, tapping the ash off his cigar. "And what exactly would they do with it, Nick? Play games? Balance their budgets? Most people wouldn’t know what to do with a computer if you handed it to them."

"They’ll learn," Nick insisted. "That’s the beauty of it. This isn’t just a tool—it’s a platform. People will find ways to use it that we can’t even imagine yet. Writers could compose novels, artists could experiment with new forms of visual art, musicians could create entirely new kinds of music. This isn’t just a machine—it’s freedom."

Marcus leaned back in his chair, studying Nick with a mix of skepticism and curiosity. "You sound like one of those hippies in Hyde Park, banging on about liberation and revolution."

Nick smiled. "Maybe I am. But think about it—what happens when people don’t need to rely on centralized institutions anymore? When they can create, learn, and communicate on their own terms? This isn’t just a computer, Marcus. It’s the start of a new kind of society."

Marcus raised an eyebrow. "A utopia, you mean?"

"Not perfect," Nick admitted. "But better. More open. More democratic. The kind of world where the barriers between people and information come down."

Marcus didn’t respond immediately. He swirled his glass of scotch, staring at the swirling liquid as if it held the answers. Finally, he said, "You’ve got ambition, Nick. I’ll give you that. But ambition doesn’t pay the bills. Tell me—what’s the business case for this?"

Nick hesitated. He knew Marcus wouldn’t be swayed by ideals alone. "Cost. Scalability. Accessibility," he said, ticking off the points on his fingers. "The components are getting cheaper by the year. We can mass-produce these machines and sell them at a price point that’s affordable for the average household. Once people see what they can do, the demand will skyrocket. This isn’t just a product—it’s a movement."

Marcus leaned forward, resting his elbows on the desk. "Alright, Nick. I’ll give you a lab, a team, and six months. Prove to me that this thing has legs."

Nick’s heart leapt. "You won’t regret it," he said.

"We’ll see," Marcus replied, a faint smile tugging at the corners of his mouth. "Just don’t come crying to me if the world isn’t ready for your revolution."

Back in his office, Nick began assembling a small team of like-minded engineers and designers. They were young, passionate, and just as eager as he was to push the boundaries of what was possible. They worked long hours, fuelled by tea, cigarettes, and the occasional dose of LSD, which Nick believed helped them think outside the box.

The prototype began to evolve. The chassis became sleeker, the circuits more efficient. They experimented with new input methods, testing everything from light pens to rudimentary touch screens. Nick insisted on keeping the design simple and intuitive, even as they added new features.

It was early June, and London was alive. Carnaby Street hummed with the rhythm of swinging fashion and the chatter of dreamers. The scent of patchouli mingled with exhaust fumes as mopeds zipped past, and somewhere in the distance, a busker strummed “A Whiter Shade of Pale.” The air itself seemed charged with electricity, as if the city were on the brink of something monumental.

Nick sat cross-legged on the worn carpet of his tiny flat in Notting Hill, his guitar resting on his lap. A battered notebook lay open beside him, filled with half-finished lyrics and chord progressions. His fingers moved absent-mindedly over the fretboard, picking out a jangly melody that felt bright and restless, like the city outside.

He’d been working on a new song for *The Sonic Wanderers*, something different, something that captured the pulse of 1967. The song was about the future—about technology and connection, about a world where people could share their ideas and art without barriers. The chorus was stuck in his head:

"Wires hum, circuits spin,
A new world’s waiting to begin.
Plug in, tune out, feel the flow,
The future’s closer than you know."

Nick grinned to himself as he played it again, the chords jangling like sunlight through a kaleidoscope. It felt good, like it could be their next hit—if he could just finish the damn thing.

But even as he played, his mind kept drifting back to the lab. The Ashcombe Micro was coming together faster than he’d ever imagined. His team had made breakthroughs in miniaturizing the components, and the prototype now had a small typewriter-style keyboard and a monochrome display. It was clunky, sure, but it worked.

The problem was, Nick wasn’t sure if *he* could keep up.

Music and computers. They were both his passions, but they demanded entirely different parts of him. The band was starting to gain traction—they had gigs almost every weekend, and a small but growing following in London’s underground scene. But the computer… the computer felt like a revolution waiting to happen.

He set the guitar down and leaned back, staring at the ceiling. The light fixture above him spun lazily, distorted by the faint haze of smoke from the joint he’d shared with his flatmate earlier.

Could he really do both? Could he split himself in half and still give everything he had to each?

Nick picked up his notebook and flipped through the pages, reading over scraps of ideas he’d jotted down in between rehearsals and late nights at the lab. One line caught his eye: *“A machine that sings.”*

He thought about that phrase as he reached for his guitar again. What if a computer could make music? Not just play it back, like some of the early experiments with punch cards and synthesizers, but *make* it—write songs, experiment with sound, create something entirely new.

He strummed a few chords, imagining the sound of a machine composing its own symphony. It was a wild thought, but wasn't that what the future was all about? Taking the wildest ideas and making them real?

By the time the sun had dipped below the horizon, Nick was still sitting there, torn between two worlds. The band was heading into Soho tomorrow night to play at a new venue, and they'd been talking about recording an EP later that summer.

But the lab was calling him too. Marcus wanted him to present the latest version of the Ashcombe Micro to the board in a few weeks, and there was still so much to do.

Nick looked at the guitar, then at the pile of circuit boards on his desk.

He picked up the guitar again and played the chorus of his song, his voice low and raspy in the quiet room:

"Plug in, tune out, feel the flow,
The future's closer than you know."

Somewhere deep down, he knew he'd have to choose. But not tonight. Tonight, he'd play. Tomorrow, he'd build.

For now, the summer of love stretched out before him, and anything felt possible.

By mid-June, the Summer of Love was in full bloom. London pulsed with new energy—cafés in Soho spilled onto the streets, Hyde Park was alive with impromptu festivals, and everyone seemed to be chasing an undefinable dream. Flowers weren't just in the gardens—they were in people's hair, stitched into clothes, painted onto guitar cases. Everywhere you turned, it felt like the city itself was trying to reinvent the world.

Nick rode the energy like a wave, moving between two lives. By day, he was hunched over circuit boards at the lab, soldering connections and scribbling notes on schematics. By night, he was a part of *The Sonic Wanderers*, gigging in smoky bars and lofts, their music riding the same cultural current as the free-spirited masses that followed them.

In the lab, Nick felt like he was at the frontier of something monumental. The prototype he and his team were working on had taken another leap forward.

The latest version of the Ashcombe Micro was no longer just a jumble of wires and breadboards. The casing was sleeker now, thanks to a collaboration with a local industrial designer. The keyboard had been refined, its clickety-clack now satisfying and smooth. They had even managed to expand the memory, allowing the machine to store rudimentary programs.

Nick stared at the flickering monochrome screen as it displayed the simple text-based interface they'd designed. The computer could execute basic commands now: simple maths problems, text storage, even a basic drawing program that used ASCII characters. It wasn't much, but it was more than anyone had thought possible just a few years earlier.

He imagined what the world would look like if machines like this one were in homes across the globe. What if people could write letters, balance their finances, or even create art on a computer? The thought gave him chills.

Marcus, the head of the firm, stopped by Nick's workstation one afternoon. "You've been awfully quiet, Nick," Marcus said, his brow furrowed. "You're not losing steam, are you?"

Nick shook his head. "Not at all. I've just been thinking… What we're building here, it's not just a machine. It's a tool for people. A way to bring the world closer together. That's why it has to be personal—small, simple to use. It's not just for scientists or businesses anymore. It's for everyone."

Marcus chuckled. "You sound like one of those idealists in the park, strumming their guitars and singing about utopia. But I like the vision. Keep at it."

Nick smiled, though he knew Marcus didn't fully understand. This wasn't just about profit margins or market shares. This was about giving people power—real power—over their lives.

The nights were a sharp contrast to the ordered chaos of the lab. At rehearsal, Nick and *The Sonic Wanderers* worked on their new setlist, fine-tuning the songs they'd written over the spring. Their latest piece, *Future Sounds*, had quickly become a favourite among the crowds.

The song opened with a shimmering, almost cosmic guitar riff, overlaid with a dreamy organ melody that felt like sunlight breaking through clouds. The lyrics spoke of a world where technology and creativity intertwined, where the barriers of time and space melted away.

As the band rehearsed in a smoky basement in Camden, Nick couldn't help but feel the parallels between his two worlds. The same optimism, the same yearning for something better, ran through the music and the machines he was building.

One evening, after a particularly raucous gig at a tiny bar in Soho, Nick found himself wandering into Hyde Park with his bandmates. The park was alive with music and laughter, a spontaneous festival that had seemingly sprung up out of nowhere.

A group of people had set up a makeshift stage near the Serpentine. Someone was playing a sitar, its haunting melodies weaving through the warm night air. Others danced barefoot on the grass, their movements slow and hypnotic.

Nick sat on the grass, his guitar resting beside him, and let the atmosphere wash over him. This was the Summer of Love—the feeling that anything was possible, that the world was on the brink of something extraordinary.

And yet, as he watched the dancers and listened to the music, his mind drifted back to the lab. The computer was always there, in the back of his mind, whispering promises of a different kind of revolution.

By the time July rolled around, Nick was beginning to feel the strain. The Sonic Wanderers were gaining traction, their gigs growing larger and more frequent. They were even talking about recording their first album, a sprawling, experimental piece that blended psychedelia with hints of electronic sound.

But the computer demanded his attention too. Marcus wanted to present the Ashcombe Micro to potential investors by the end of the summer, and there was still so much to do.

One afternoon, as he sat in the lab staring at the glowing screen of the prototype, Nick whispered to himself, "Can I really do both?"

Nick sat on the floor of his flat in Camden, the windows open to the balmy night air, the faint hum of distant music drifting in from the streets. A small tab of LSD rested on the tip of his finger. He hesitated for a moment, his mind already teeming with thoughts. He could hear the muffled voices of his bandmates in the next room, laughing and strumming an acoustic guitar. They were planning the next gig, talking about recording an album, dreaming about touring the country.

Nick placed the tab on his tongue and let it dissolve.

As the acid began to take hold, the room around him shifted, the edges of objects softening, colours brightening. He leaned back against the wall and closed his eyes, letting the visions wash over him.

At first, it was the music—his guitar riffs, the hypnotic swirl of organ melodies, the pounding rhythm of drums. He saw himself onstage, the crowd swaying and cheering, the band riding the wave of collective euphoria. It was intoxicating, this vision of what could be.

But then, almost imperceptibly, the vision shifted. The music faded, replaced by the steady hum of a machine. He saw himself back in the lab, hunched over the Ashcombe Micro, its glowing screen casting light on his face. The machine wasn't just a tool—it was alive, pulsing with potential, a gateway to a new world.

He saw a future where every home had a computer, where people connected across vast distances, where information flowed freely and creativity knew no bounds. He saw a young girl in her bedroom writing poetry on a glowing screen, a scientist running complex calculations, a musician using a machine to create sounds that had never been heard before.

The vision grew clearer, sharper, more vivid. It was as if the computer were calling to him, showing him the world it could help create. A world of empowerment, of liberation, of infinite possibility.

When the trip began to ebb, Nick opened his eyes. The room was quiet now; his bandmates had left. The guitar leaned against the wall, the strings catching the moonlight.

He stared at it for a long time, the weight of the decision settling over him. Music was beautiful—it spoke to the soul, it moved people, it brought them together. But it was fleeting, ephemeral. A song could be a spark, but it couldn't change the world the way a computer could.

The Ashcombe Micro was more than a machine; it was a revolution waiting to happen. If he could perfect it, if he could make it small enough, affordable enough, simple enough, it could empower millions. It could give people control over their lives in a way nothing else could.

Nick reached for his guitar and plucked a few notes. The sound filled the room, warm and familiar. But as he played, his mind drifted back to the lab, to the circuit boards and wires, to the glowing screen of the prototype.

He set the guitar down gently, almost reverently, as if saying goodbye.

The next morning, Nick called the band together. They met at their usual spot, a cramped café in Soho with mismatched chairs and posters peeling from the walls.

"I need to talk to you all," Nick began, his voice steady but tinged with regret. "I've been thinking a lot about the future. About what we're doing here, with the music, and… I've realized something. I can't give it my all. Not the way it deserves."

The bandmates exchanged glances, their expressions a mix of confusion and concern.

“I’m not quitting music,” Nick continued, “but I can’t keep splitting my time. The computer I’m working on… it’s more than just a job. It’s a chance to change the world. I need to focus on that.”

For a moment, there was silence. Then one of them, the drummer, clapped him on the shoulder. “Well, mate, you’ve always been the brainy one. I can’t say I get what you’re working on, but if it’s that important, we’ll back you. You’re still a Wanderer, no matter what.”

They spent the rest of the afternoon reminiscing, playing a few impromptu songs, laughing about the gigs they’d played. But as Nick walked away from the café that evening, he felt a bittersweet weight in his chest. He was leaving something behind, something magical. But he was also stepping toward something greater.

Nick sat at his desk in the lab, surrounded by a chaos of circuit boards, blueprints, and empty coffee cups. The walls were plastered with sketches of the Ashcombe Micro, annotated in his looping handwriting: **“Compact keyboard input,” “Affordable processor,” “Interface for the average user.”**

He stared at the blank sheet of paper before him, took a deep breath, and began to write. His mind was ablaze with ideas, a synthesis of the utopian visions from his acid trips and the hard technical realities of engineering.

Nick set down his pen and leaned back in his chair, staring at the words before him. The room seemed to hum with the energy of the manifesto. He could already see the machine in his mind: sleek, efficient, transformative.

As the sunlight poured through the windows, he knew that he was building something far bigger than a computer. He was building a future.

This is not a product; it is a revolution.

Chapter 13:

June 12, 1967
London

Dear Mother,

I hope this letter finds you well, and that the gardens at Ashcombe House are as beautiful as ever this time of year. I can almost picture you there, sitting with a book on the terrace, the roses blooming around you. It’s strange how I carry those images with me even as life here becomes more frantic by the day.

I’ve been meaning to write for weeks, but things have been moving so quickly. I wanted to share something with you—something that’s become the most important work of my life. It’s a project, one that I think could shape the future.

I’ve started building a new kind of machine. You know the massive computers I’ve written about before, the ones that need whole rooms to operate? What I’m working on now is something entirely different—a computer small enough to fit on a desk. A computer for the individual, not for the government or the big institutions, but for people like you and me.

I call it the Ashcombe Micro. It's a humble name, I know, but it feels right to honour our family. This machine will have a keyboard like a typewriter, a screen that connects to the telly, and even a way for people to create their own programs.

The idea, Mother, is freedom. A tool like this could put power back in the hands of the individual, just as Father always believed in independence and self-reliance. Do you remember the long talks we had about his belief in sound money? His idea that the world must be built on solid foundations, not fleeting illusions? I think about those conversations every day as I work.

The parallels are striking. Just as gold was a store of value, immutable and universal, this computer could be a store of knowledge and creativity. It's not just a machine, Mother—it's a philosophy in action. A way to give people the tools to shape their own lives, unbound by institutions or centralized control.

I won't pretend it's been easy. The band is still playing, and it's hard to step away entirely from the music—it's such a magical time here, with the Summer of Love in full swing. But I've realized I can't do both. As much as I love the band, this project feels larger than me, larger than any one person.

The lab is a chaotic mess of circuit boards and notebooks, and I've been living on a diet of tea, toast, and late-night ideas. The others here think I'm mad. They laugh when I talk about a computer in every home, as if it's science fiction. But I see it, Mother—I see it so clearly.

I've even had moments where I imagine showing it to Father. What would he say about this machine? Would he see it as I do, as an extension of his values, of everything he stood for? I'd like to think he would. He believed in the sovereignty of the individual, in the power of hard work and the dignity of independence. This machine is my way of carrying that forward.

There's so much left to figure out. I'll need funding, of course, and a way to convince people that this isn't just some eccentric experiment. But for the first time, I feel like I'm building something that matters.

Please let me know how you're doing, and how things are at Ashcombe House. If you're ever in London, I'd love to show you the lab and the prototype as it comes together.

With all my love,
Nick

As Nick sealed the letter and set it aside, he couldn't help but think about his father. Charles Ashcombe's vision of a world rooted in sound principles echoed in Nick's own work, though the medium was different.

The smell of solder and machine oil lingered in the air as Nick walked into the lab, a modest yet bustling space in one of London's many drab post-war office buildings. Despite the building's unremarkable exterior, what was being attempted inside felt extraordinary. This wasn't just engineering—it was uncharted territory, a revolution waiting to happen.

Nick carried his prototype—a clunky yet functional frame of wires, circuit boards, and a keyboard—carefully tucked under his arm. He'd christened it "The Ashcombe Micro" in his letters and notes, though it hardly looked "micro" at this stage. It weighed close to 40 pounds and had all the elegance of a typewriter mated with a shoebox. But it worked. And that was what mattered.

The team was already gathered in the conference room, a mix of techies, mathematicians, and a few sceptical financial backers in sharp suits. At the head of the table sat Mr. George Langham, the managing director of the firm. Langham was an older man, balding, with steel-rimmed glasses perched on his nose. He had the air of someone who believed deeply in progress but wasn't above asking tough questions about its costs.

"Ah, Nick," Langham said, gesturing to the table. "Good of you to join us. I hear you've been making some leaps with this… Ashcombe Micro of yours."

Nick nodded, setting the prototype down on the table with care. "It's coming together, yes. I've integrated a keyboard interface and a basic visual output, so it can display text on a screen—any television screen, in fact."

There were murmurs around the room. A man in a grey suit leaned forward. "So it connects to a television? How does that work?"

Nick smiled. "It uses an RF modulator, like the one inside a broadcast device. Essentially, it hijacks the TV's signal to act as a monitor for the computer. This way, users won't need specialized equipment. They can use what they already have in their living rooms."

Langham raised a hand to quiet the room. "Very clever, Nick. But let's talk business. What's the market for this… personal computer? You've painted quite the utopian picture in your proposals—'a computer for every household.' Do you honestly believe that's realistic?"

Nick took a deep breath. He'd expected this question. "I do," he said firmly. "Right now, computers are massive, expensive, and limited to institutions—governments, banks, universities. But the technology is advancing rapidly. Miniaturization is happening, and costs are coming down. The question isn't *if* this will happen, but *when*. And when it does, we'll be the first to market."

One of the financiers, a man with slicked-back hair and a sceptical smirk, interjected. "But why would the average person need a computer? Most people don't even know how to type, let alone program. What's the use case here?"

Nick gestured to the prototype. "Think about it. A machine like this could handle household finances, write letters, organize information. Students could use it to solve equations or learn programming. Artists could create digital designs. And that's just scratching the surface. Once people start using it, they'll find uses we can't even imagine yet."

Langham leaned back in his chair, steepling his fingers. "It's a compelling vision, Nick, but it's also a gamble. The public isn't clamouring for this. They're clamouring for colour televisions and better stereos. This is an entirely new category of product. Are you prepared for how much education and persuasion it will take to create a market for this?"

"I am," Nick said. His voice was steady, but his palms were damp with sweat. "This isn't just a product. It's a tool for empowerment. It democratizes information and creativity. Yes, it's new, and yes, it's ambitious, but the best ideas always are. If we wait for the public to ask for this, we'll already be too late."

The room was silent for a moment. Langham studied Nick with an expression that was hard to read.

Finally, the director spoke. "All right. I'll greenlight further development, but on two conditions. First, I want a detailed market analysis by the end of the month—projections, potential competitors, everything. Second, I want a working prototype that can demonstrate at least one practical application. Show me something that will make these doubters believe."

Nick nodded. "Understood. You won't regret this, Mr. Langham."

The next evening, after a marathon session in the lab, Nick made his way to the band's rehearsal space, a cramped, graffiti-covered room tucked above a pub in Camden. The Sonic Wanderers were already there, tuning their instruments and warming up. Dave greeted him with a wide grin.

"Nick, mate, you look knackered. What've you been up to? Wiring some newfangled doodad again?"

Nick laughed, setting his guitar case down. "Not just any doodad, Dave. I've been working on the Ashcombe Micro—my personal computer project. This thing could change everything."

Eddie, the drummer, raised an eyebrow as he tapped on a snare. "A computer? You mean one of those massive room-sized machines the government uses? What're you going to do with one of those?"

"No, no," Nick said, pulling a chair closer to the circle. "That's the whole point. This one isn't massive—it's small enough to fit on a desk. It's for people like us, not governments or banks."

Dave plucked a string lazily, smirking. "People like us, huh? And what're we supposed to do with a computer? Order more pints faster?"

Nick shook his head, undeterred. "Think about it: You could write your songs on it. Keep track of our gigs, our earnings, even store money on it. Hell, imagine creating music on it someday—a machine that lets you experiment with sounds in ways we haven't even thought of yet."

Eddie leaned forward, intrigued despite himself. "Music, huh? You're saying this thing could be used to, like, make beats? Synth sounds?"

"Exactly," Nick said. "It's not just a tool—it's a canvas. Once people start using computers, they'll discover possibilities we can't even dream of right now. It's going to give ordinary people the power to create, to explore, to control their lives in ways that are impossible today."

For a moment, the room was quiet except for the faint hum of an amp. Dave eventually broke the silence with a chuckle. "You've always been the dreamer, Nick. Computers and guitars—what's next, flying cars?"

Nick grinned. "Laugh all you want, but give it a few years. You'll see."

The conversation with the band left Nick energized. The next day, he arrived at the lab with renewed focus. He knew that for the Ashcombe Micro to succeed, it needed to be more than a machine—it had to feel accessible, intuitive, and useful to ordinary people.

He began refining the prototype, designing a compact casing to house the components. He experimented with a simplified keyboard layout, ensuring it would be easy for anyone to use. For the display, he found a way to improve the RF modulator's signal, creating sharper text output on a television screen.

Nick also started coding a few basic programs:

1. **A Word Processor**: A simple application where users could type, edit, and save text.

2. **A Budget Tracker**: An intuitive program for entering income and expenses, with charts and summaries.
3. **A Game**: Just for fun, Nick wrote a simple guessing game. If computers were going to be for everyone, they needed to be fun as well as functional.

By the end of the week, he had a prototype that was still clunky and rough around the edges but undeniably groundbreaking. He couldn't wait to show it to Langham and the rest of the team.

Nick had spent the night at the club, but his mind had been on something else—something that had begun to consume him: the Ashcombe Micro. It had sat in the back of his mind all week, and now, it was time to show it off. Not just to the tech-heads at work, but to the people who lived and breathed the spirit of the '60s. The ones who, like him, believed in the power of creation, rebellion, and, most of all, change.

By the time he made his way back to his flat in Camden, the smell of incense and beer from the club still clung to his clothes. He was feeling a bit of the old magic of the night but was resolute about his plan: he was going to give the Ashcombe Micro its first public test. A little informal gathering—more of a party really—but one that he could control. He'd invited a few of the bandmates and some of their musician friends to come over. The night would carry on as planned, but Nick was certain they would be blown away by the little device he'd brought to life.

The room was dimly lit with a few candles flickering on the coffee table. The faint aroma of weed and spilled wine hung in the air, mixing with the sound of a distant Beatles track playing softly from a vinyl on the turntable. The atmosphere was relaxed, easy. People lounged on the couches, stretched out across the floor, and there was a palpable sense of carefree celebration, as only the summer of 1967 could bring.

The band members were milling about, chatting with friends from the club, while others took the opportunity to roll joints and sip from their drinks. Nick slipped into the kitchen to grab a bottle of whiskey and, as he cracked it open, he caught sight of a few familiar faces in the living room:

Dave, Eddie, and the gang, along with a handful of other musicians from around London's scene: Syd, a sharp-eyed guitarist from a band that had recently made waves in Soho; and Rick, a keyboardist who often filled in during jam sessions. They'd all heard a bit about the "computer project" Nick was working on, but he hadn't quite shown anyone what he'd been building.

The chatter started to quiet when Nick walked back into the room, carrying the prototype—a chunky, wire-ridden beast of a thing. It wasn't sleek like some futuristic device, but it was undeniably compelling. The thing had the potential to change everything, and in a room full of dreamers and creators, that potential was enough to draw attention.

"Alright, gather 'round, everyone," Nick said, setting the computer down on the coffee table.

A few curious glances exchanged as the musicians, some more high than others, leaned in closer.

"What's this then, Nick?" Syd asked, flicking his lighter in the dim light. "Some kind of newfangled radio?"

Nick shook his head, grinning. "It's not a radio. It's a computer."

Syd laughed, still skeptical. "Right. A computer. What, one of those big hulking machines in a basement somewhere?"

“Not like that,” Nick said, setting his whiskey down and flipping the switch on the prototype. The machine hummed to life, a soft flicker of green light appearing on the screen. “This one’s for the people. A machine you can actually have in your home. Small enough to fit on your desk. It’s going to change everything. It’s going to put the power to create right at your fingertips.”

The room fell silent as the screen displayed a blank cursor. Nick typed a few commands. A word processor appeared, the letters blinking in the stillness. He typed something simple: “Hello, World.” It looked almost magical—a simple letter on a glowing screen.

“Try it,” Nick said, stepping back, his eyes wide with anticipation.

Syd was the first to step up, rubbing his fingers nervously before touching the keyboard. His expression was a mix of disbelief and curiosity. He tapped a few keys, and soon enough, his name appeared on the screen. Then a short riff of music came to his mind, and he typed it in. As the computer displayed each note in text form, the idea of translating music into a code was almost too far ahead of its time.

“You’re telling me,” Syd said slowly, still staring at the screen, “that I could use this thing to write down music, like… a piano roll, or guitar tabs?”

Nick nodded eagerly. “Exactly. I mean, imagine writing out a song and not having to rely on sheet music or memorizing it. You could store it, print it, even play it back if you wanted to.”

Syd leaned back, looking over at Rick, who was now slowly inching forward, intrigued. Rick cracked a smile. “You can’t be serious. A computer that can actually *play* music back?”

Nick grinned. “It’s not there yet, but we’ll get there. Imagine collaborating with a computer that doesn’t just listen to your ideas—it actually adds to them. It could be like jamming with another person, but on demand.”

The Ashcombe Micro sat on the table like a strange artefact, glowing softly in the dim light. It was as if the future had arrived unannounced, and no one was sure what to make of it yet. The whiskey had been poured, the joints were being passed around again, and the smoke hung in the air like an invisible fog.

Syd leaned back, eyes wide, but still skeptical. “So let me get this straight, Nick. This thing, this... computer. It’s going to make art, yeah? Like, create something real. Something that, if I plug it into the right channels, could synthesize music, make a new form of music that no one's ever heard before?” His voice was a little distant, as though he was still processing the concept.

Nick nodded, but he didn’t just want to talk about the future of music—he wanted to go deeper. They’d all heard of the concept of artistic expression being merged with new technologies, but for Nick, the idea of this machine creating not just music but synthesizing different forms of art—visuals, sound, poetry, and movement—felt more revolutionary than anything. He knew that the counterculture was obsessed with the idea of breaking down barriers—sex, politics, freedom—but he wanted to see if they could break down the very walls that divided the different forms of creative expression.

“That’s exactly it, Syd,” Nick said, his voice picking up as he leaned forward. “But it’s not just about creating music—it’s about synthesis, bringing together all the arts in one place. Imagine, if this computer can analyse music, words, even images, and then create new combinations of them, something completely outside of the traditional forms. The perfect synthesis of creativity and technology."

There was a long pause as everyone considered this idea. The room was growing quieter, the beats of some faraway soul tune mixing with the haze of cigarette smoke.

"It's like... merging, yeah?" Rick said slowly, a smile creeping onto his face. "Like, everything's on the same wavelength now. You're not just playing music or painting a picture—you're *synthesizing* those things. You're creating a new form of art that doesn't even exist yet."

Nick grinned, the vision coming to life in his mind. "Exactly. It's like what we're doing right now, creating something out of nothing. I've been reading about the way the mind processes stimuli, right? We already do it when we listen to a song and feel something we can't quite explain. A piece of music triggers something in us, and we start to visualize the colours, the motions, the feelings. What if a computer could help us understand those connections more deeply? It could *see* those connections the way we do—only faster, more precisely."

Syd took a long drag from his joint and passed it to Rick. "That's nuts, Nick. But in a good way. Like... it's gonna be some kind of... digital mind, right? Able to *create* like we create, but faster, stronger, without the limits of our physical selves?"

Nick nodded again, this time with a sort of quiet intensity. He had heard the term "machine intelligence" thrown around before, but this was different. This wasn't about creating a robot that could think on its own. This was about creating a device that could amplify human creativity—not replace it.

"Think about it," Nick said. "What if the computer could act as a *mediator* between us and the world? Between music, words, colour, light. It would synthesize everything it sees and hears, combine them into something new, something that speaks to the soul." He leaned forward, his hands running over the surface of the machine as if he were explaining the very essence of creation itself. "It's not just about making art; it's about *understanding* art, making connections we couldn't even conceive of before. Something no human alone could do."

Rick chuckled, clearly impressed but still a little uncertain. "So, you're saying we could have a whole new genre of music... a genre that doesn't exist yet?"

"Exactly," Nick replied, his face lighting up. "Imagine this: a computer that could, say, take a jazz improvisation and weave it with spoken word poetry, and then blend in some visual elements—like a moving painting, a film sequence, whatever. The machine could map the emotional progression of the music and translate it into another medium. It could *become* the synthesis of multiple art forms."

The group was silent for a moment. The buzz of the room seemed to intensify as the idea hung in the air, a strange tension vibrating from every corner of the room. This was the very heart of what the counterculture was trying to do: break down barriers. Art, music, literature, philosophy—they were all forms of expression, but the systems in place kept them separated, kept them confined to their own distinct boxes. What if the future could offer something different? Something bigger?

Finally, it was Syd who broke the silence.

"You're telling me this little box," he gestured toward the Ashcombe Micro, "could help create a whole new way of *being*—of living and creating as artists, *together*? And it won't just be us sitting around jamming with each other, but us creating a new art form that doesn't even exist yet?"

Nick's grin widened. "Yeah. Something like that."

Rick leaned back, the idea beginning to settle over him, even if it seemed too big to grasp. "It's like we're all connected, you know? The computer could connect our art, our music, our *minds*... we just have to make it happen."

Syd leaned back against the wall, his eyes distant as he took a long drag from the joint, letting the smoke curl up in the dim light. His fingers drummed an absent rhythm against his knee, his mind already whirling in the space where art and technology collided.

"I've been thinking," Syd said slowly, looking up at Nick. "About the band, you know? What we're doing. We've been talking about making an album, right? But we want to do something bigger than just a record—something *visual* too. We've been talking to Stanley Kubrick—yeah, *that* Stanley Kubrick—about doing some music for a space film he's planning. It's all hush-hush right now, but the man's serious. Big ideas. He's thinking about shooting a sci-fi film, *something* big. He wants music that really takes you somewhere, takes you out of your head. And we were wondering…"

He paused and took another hit. "Could your computer, man, could it help with something like that? Could it help us tie the music to the visuals, like *really* bring the whole thing together? You know, make it flow, create a soundtrack that isn't just music, but like, *soundscapes* that react to what's happening on the screen?"

Nick didn't answer right away. The idea had already taken root in his mind, and now he could almost see it unfold before him. The connection between the film, the music, and the computer. A perfect synthesis of technology, art, and creativity. It wasn't just about making music anymore; it was about creating an entire experience.

"Yeah, that's exactly what I'm thinking," Nick said, eyes lighting up. "What if the computer could create a soundtrack that's *adaptive*? Something that responds to the visuals, the pace of the film, even the *emotion* on the screen. Imagine if the music *evolved* as the film did—if it matched the tone, the atmosphere, all in real-time. The computer could analyse the scenes, the colours, the movements, and adjust the music to match it. It could create a sonic landscape that's *completely* integrated with the visuals."

Syd's face lit up, and he straightened up a bit, leaning in. "Exactly, yeah! That's what I'm saying, Nick. It's not just a soundtrack, it's an entire *soundscape*—something that *evolves* with the film, like a living, breathing thing. You know, the way we think of music now—it's all separate from the film, right? But if we could tie it into the visuals, the whole experience would be next-level. The audience wouldn't just hear the music, they'd feel it in their bones, man. Feel it with every frame."

Nick was already starting to feel the pulse of what Syd was saying. The idea was thrilling—this wasn't just about composing a piece of music anymore; it was about creating a complete, immersive *experience*. And the more he thought about it, the more he realized it wasn't such a distant idea.

"Well, we're still a couple of years off, but I think it's possible," Nick said, his voice becoming more animated. "In the next few years, I think we'll have better tech—something that can handle the amount of data you'd need for a project like that. Right now, we're limited by the hardware, but the next generation of computers could do it. The idea of real-time rendering, of a computer that can analyse the film and adapt the music on the fly—it's not *too* far-fetched. A couple of years from now, we might even be able to play entire films, *just like that*, through something like my computer. Everything integrated, from the music to the visuals, to the mood."

Syd nodded slowly, clearly lost in the vision of what this could become. “So, you’re saying, in a few years, we could have a machine that could actually play the film and create the soundtrack at the same time? A computer that *syncs* with the movie? That’s... that’s insane. But in a good way. It’s like the future’s already here, and it’s sitting right in front of us.”

Nick’s mind was spinning. He could almost hear the notes and sounds that would accompany the visuals. The music would be something completely different—interactive, alive, like an extension of the film itself.

“It’s going to be a game-changer, Syd,” Nick said, his voice quiet but resolute. “The next few years will bring about a revolution in how we create. Music, movies, art—everything will change. The technology is catching up, and we’re at the forefront of it. I just have to finish the computer and push things to the next level.”

“Yeah,” Syd murmured. “This is just the beginning. We’ve got to make it happen. For the music, for the films… for the whole *thing*. The Summer of Love’s about freedom, right? Well, let’s show ‘em what real freedom is—*freedom of creation*.”

Rick, who had been sitting quietly, his fingers drumming softly against his guitar case, suddenly spoke up. “So, we’re talking about a machine that can help us *create* music *and* films at the same time? I mean, *really* create them? What kind of music would that even be? What would it *sound* like?”

Nick paused, letting the question hang in the air. “That’s the crazy part, Rick. The machine doesn’t just create music—it *creates* new forms of music. It’ll synthesize emotions, movements, colours… it won’t just be something you hear. It’ll be something you experience—something that speaks directly to your soul. And, I think, if we play our cards right, we could be a part of it. We could create something new, something the world has never seen before.”

The night stretched on, its energy fizzing and crackling in the dim light of Nick’s flat.

“Hey, you’ve gotta hear this,” Syd said suddenly, his voice bright and slurring a bit. He paused the film and pulled out his phone from his pocket. “Roger needs to see this. He’ll freak out.”

Nick didn’t even ask who Roger was—he’d heard the name before, one of Syd’s many friends who were part of the underground music scene. In the midst of this buzzing revolution, why not invite more of them in?

Syd dialled the number, holding the phone up to his ear. He bounced around, eyes wide as he looked back at the film playing on the screen, his fingers still twitching in time with the pulse of the movie. The phone rang a few times before someone picked up.

“Oi, Roger! You’ve gotta come down here right now, mate. Nick’s computer thing—well, you won’t believe it! It’s like the whole universe just... clicked.”

There was a pause, and then Syd’s grin widened even further. “Alright, yeah—bring your stuff. And hurry, it’s fucking *trippy*.”

After hanging up, Syd turned back to the group, eyes alight. “Roger’s on his way. He’ll bring some of the others. We’re gonna have a *proper* jam.”

Charles Ashcombe—whom Nick had always considered an enigmatic figure—had funded the film. But there was something more to it. Something Nick had always suspected but never quite understood. *The Wizard of Oz* wasn't just a children's fantasy film, full of poppy fields and ruby slippers. No, it was, in Nick's mind, a veiled allegory, wrapped up in technicolour. It was about monetary policy, the gold standard, and the very systems of power that governed the world.

Nick's thoughts swirled as he flipped the lid open on the canister. *The Wizard of Oz*. A film that, in its whimsical innocence, had always carried a deep, unsettling message.

The scarecrow, with his desire for a brain, was like the masses, dumbed down by an unjust monetary system. The Tin Man, with his heart, represented the coldness of an industrial society, blind to the needs of the people. The Lion's courage? Well, that was the courage needed to challenge the system itself, to stand up to the *wizard* behind the curtain—behind the Federal Reserve, behind the faceless banks that controlled everything.

But the most telling symbol was, of course, the *yellow brick road*, the path leading to the wizard. The road was made of *gold*. And in the world of *Oz*, just like the world of the 1930s, that gold was the only thing that kept things running. The road to power was paved with gold—*real*, tangible gold, not paper money.

He rushed to the living room, setting up the projector, his heart beating faster with the excitement of the idea he was about to test. He set the screen up in front of the couch and grabbed the first joint from the table. A couple of tabs of acid weren't going to hurt either. In the back of his mind, he could already hear the beginnings of a symphony—the tension between the visuals and the music—the way a soundtrack could evolve and adapt, like a living organism.

"Is it ready?" Syd asked, his voice laced with a curious edge.

Nick nodded, already feeling the buzz of ideas flickering in his mind. "Just wait. The movie's got this whole thing about the gold standard—about what's real and what's not. It's *monetary policy*, man, wrapped up in a kids' movie. It's all there. Just watch. And, well… we're going to jam along to it."

Syd raised an eyebrow, a mischievous grin curling his lips. "Jam along to *Oz*? You're telling me that this is all part of some... *trip*?"

"Exactly," Nick said, flipping the switch to start the film. The familiar notes of the opening score filled the room as Judy Garland's Dorothy appeared, wide-eyed and innocent, in black and white Kansas.

The film carried on with its tale of Dorothy's journey. The yellow brick road, paved in gold, gleamed under the technicolour skies. When the music swelled, Rick looked at Nick, raising an eyebrow. "So, we're supposed to... play *with* this?" he asked, gesturing to his guitar.

"Yeah, let's see if the *computer* can help us out," Nick said with a grin, pulling up the prototype on his nearby desk.

They took their instruments, feeling the rhythms and melodies that the film created, even before they had a chance to lay anything down. The first time the Scarecrow danced and the first strains of *Over the Rainbow* faded into the air, the band let their instruments follow. It was rough, experimental, like mixing acid with jazz, but it felt right. Each note, each chord, was like a response to the colours that swirled on the screen.

The combination of *Oz*, the music, and the technology wasn't just creating a soundtrack—it was creating an *experience*. And it felt like everything was starting to come together.

Syd stood up, a grin spreading across his face. "This is madness, Nick. Pure *madness*. We're actually making this happen. A movie, a soundtrack, the computer. It's all *alive*."

The chemistry between the film and their playing was uncanny, like it had always been meant to be this way. Each new scene seemed to pull a new sound from them—discordant jazz bursts that morphed into full-blown psychedelic waves, gentle melodic lines rising and falling in harmony with the scenes, only to be interrupted by staccato rhythms and bursts of fuzzed-out guitar.

As the film's iconic *Over the Rainbow* played, it was like the band was right there with Judy Garland, harmonizing with her, picking up on the whimsy, the longing, and the dreamlike quality of the song. Nick bent his head over his guitar, playing a shimmering, echoing version of the melody, stretching it into something new. It was an experiment in translation—taking the dream world of Oz and pulling it into their own musical language.

Suddenly, Rick's keyboards broke though, deep and resonant. He played around with the notes, stretching them, creating tension that held just long enough before Syd's guitar took the lead, his fingers dancing over the neck like a shadow in the night. It wasn't pretty music—not by any conventional standards—but it didn't need to be. It was raw, visceral, *alive*.

Syd turned to Nick and mouthed, "This is *it*, isn't it?"

He caught Syd's gaze and gave a small nod. There were no words for it. The idea was beyond them now. It wasn't about playing the game the way it had always been played. This was *something new*, something that wasn't just limited to the studio, or the stage, or the screen. This was a new form of creation. It was a *synthesis*—music, film, technology, all woven together into one seamless experience.

The film's next sequence flashed across the screen—Dorothy meeting the Cowardly Lion. The music shifted, too, lightening, a bit comical, a bit mysterious. Nick's fingers danced across the strings, picking up the whimsical and hesitant nature of the Lion's journey. Rick piano was tight and melodic, adding an unexpected groove. Syd, always the master of improvisation, tore into a solo that swirled and spiralled in time with the film's colourful movement.

But it wasn't just the visuals and sounds that were driving them forward. It was the sensation of it all—the knowledge that they were creating *something new*, something that hadn't existed before. The computer, the film, the music—it was all feeding into each other, sparking creativity in ways they hadn't imagined. It was more than just a jam session; it was a moment of connection, of realization that they were on the cusp of something massive. A new form of artistic expression.

Syd, lost in the music, called out, "Nick, do you think the computer could be part of the album we're making? Could it *record* us like this?"

Nick paused mid-strum, considering it. "I think it could. But it's not just about recording. It's about responding. Interacting with us, creating a whole *new* kind of experience. Maybe... maybe it could even be the *album*—the album that *is* the experience. We're not just making a record, we're making a *world*."

Syd nodded, eyes widening. "A whole new kind of art. It's like... the computer's alive, man. It's not just a machine—it's part of the music."

Nick grinned. It was a thought he had only just started to develop, but now that it was out there, it felt right. The idea of creating something entirely new, an album that wasn't just a collection of songs but an experience—something that could only exist in this new, combined world of art, technology, and psychedelia. Something interactive. Something *alive*.

They all kept playing, feeding off each other's energy, the music flowing as freely as the images on the screen. The rest of the night passed in a blur of sound, colour, and the feeling of being on the edge of something big—something that could change everything.

By the time the sun began to rise, the room had filled with an overwhelming sense of possibility. The film had long since finished, the projector whirring softly in the background, but the music was still reverberating in their minds.

"I think we've done it," Nick said, feeling a deep satisfaction settle in his chest. "I think we've created the first track. The first track for the *future*."

Syd looked at him with a grin. "Yeah, and I think we've only just scratched the surface."

As the last flicker of the film faded into the early morning stillness, the band sat back, their instruments resting in their hands, the hum of the computer still alive in the background. There was a heavy silence in the room, but it wasn't uncomfortable. It was more like the collective breath they'd all taken after diving into something they could barely comprehend, but knew was something extraordinary.

Syd broke the silence, his face lit up with that wild grin of his, eyes shining as though they had just unlocked a secret.

"Alright, alright," he said, leaning back in his chair, almost as if he were savouring the sound that still echoed in the room. "You know what this is, right?"

Nick, caught somewhere between exhaustion and elation, looked at him, eyebrows raised. "What do you mean?"

"This—*this*—" Syd gestured broadly at the screen, at the instruments scattered around the room, the soft whir of the computer, "is *beautiful* stuff. Like, pure magic. We need to get the rest of the band on board. This... this could be *our* thing, Nick. This is where we take it. An album. A full album. Not just the tracks—this, this *whole* experience. We could create something that no one's ever even dreamed of before."

Nick paused, his mind racing. He wasn't sure if it was the LSD still lingering or the sheer weight of the idea, but it hit him like a wave. *An album*—but not just a collection of songs, not just an idea of sound. An experience. A fusion. A moment where the band, the computer, the film, and the audience all came together into one living, breathing thing. A *revolution*.

"An album?" Nick said, half to himself, as if the thought was still taking shape. He felt his pulse quicken. "You mean... not just a record, but... something that feels like this? Like the film, the music, the computer... all responding to each other?"

Syd nodded eagerly, his voice almost rising. "Exactly. We've already got the foundation. The computer could adapt and change with us as we play. It'll *react* to the music, and the music will evolve with the film, with the audience. Think about it—we could create something that's not just a passive experience. People wouldn't just listen to it; they'd *be part of it*. The computer will be the *instrument*, Nick. It’ll be like a living entity in the band, interacting with us. We *play* it, it *plays* us. It’s pure synchronicity."

The rest of the band, still packing away instruments, had started to overhear the conversation. Rick glanced up, raising an eyebrow. "You really think we can pull it off?" he asked. "I mean, this *thing* you’ve got—this computer, this experiment—isn’t just some gimmick, right?"

"I think we can," Nick said quietly, feeling the weight of it all. "And I think we *should*. We’re not just making an album. We’re making the future of music. The future of art. This is how it’ll be one day—where music, film, and technology aren’t separate entities anymore. They’ll *talk* to each other."

Syd stood up, his excitement growing by the second. “Exactly, mate. It’s not about recording songs. It’s about creating an *experience* that you can’t get anywhere else. We’re not just artists. We’re scientists, inventors, architects of a new world. And that computer? It’s part of the band now.”

Chapter 14:

The Ashcombe System Mark 1 sat on Nick’s workbench like a humble beast, its wooden casing polished and its insides meticulously arranged. It didn’t look much like the future—not yet, at least. Wires snaked across its surface, connecting the transistor arrays to the central processing core, while a small panel of blinking lights flickered in patterns that only Nick understood. A borrowed TV set acted as its display, its curved screen humming softly. Next to it sat the pièce de résistance: a basic synthesizer module, hooked up to the computer’s rudimentary sound program.

Nick leaned back in his chair, wiping sweat from his forehead. He’d worked through the night, barely stopping for coffee or the occasional cigarette, but the Mark 1 was finally complete. It wasn’t just a computer —it was an instrument, capable of generating sounds that could rival a guitar or an organ, but with an otherworldly quality that was entirely its own.

The jam with Syd and his mates had been a revelation. Watching them lose themselves in the music while *The Wizard of Oz* played on the screen had crystallized something in Nick’s mind. This machine wasn’t just for solving equations or typing letters—it could create, amplify, and transform human expression. It could *play*.

Nick flipped a switch on the front panel, and the Mark 1 hummed to life, its lights dancing as the processor initialized. He’d programmed a simple sequence—a short melody that the synthesizer module would play. The sound emerged from the speakers like a ghostly ripple, each note pure and strange, as if it had been plucked from some alternate dimension.

“Not bad,” Nick muttered, adjusting the knobs on the synthesizer module. The tone shifted, deepening into something warmer and more melodic. He tapped a few keys on the attached keyboard, and the machine responded instantly, playing back the notes in a clean, metallic voice.

He smiled to himself, feeling a rare surge of pride. The Mark 1 was no Moog synthesizer, and it wasn’t going to replace a guitar or a drum kit anytime soon. But it was a start—a machine that could not only compute but also *sing*.

Nick glanced at the clock. He’d invited a few trusted colleagues to the workshop later that evening to see the Mark 1 in action. It wasn’t just about showing off—it was about convincing them that this wasn’t a pipe dream. If he could get them on board, the company might agree to fund a second prototype, something sleeker and more powerful.

He ran through his mental checklist:

- **The System:** The computer was calibrated and ready to run its demonstration program.
- **The Sound System:** He'd borrowed a pair of amplifiers and speakers from a friend who played in a jazz band. The Mark 1's synthesizer module would feed directly into them, giving the sound the richness it needed.
- **The Presentation:** Nick had sketched out a rough agenda. First, he'd demonstrate the computer's basic capabilities—typing, calculations, and a simple visual display. Then he'd move on to the real showstopper: the music.

As he made the final adjustments, Nick couldn't help but think about how far he'd come. Only a few months ago, he'd been torn between his band and his work, unsure if he could give up music to focus on his dream of building a personal computer. Now, it felt like the two worlds were converging.

He thought about Syd's comment from the jam session: *"This is beautiful stuff, Nick. One day, we'll make an album with this."*

The idea thrilled and terrified him in equal measure. If the Mark 1 could inspire musicians like Syd and his bandmates, what else could it do? Could it one day become an artist's tool, a musician's companion, or even a composer in its own right?

Nick picked up his notebook and began jotting down ideas for future iterations of the system:

- **Enhanced Sound Capabilities:** Expand the synthesizer module to include a broader range of tones and effects.
- **Graphical Output:** Develop a program that could create simple visual patterns to accompany the music—a precursor to the light shows that were becoming popular in clubs.
- **Portability:** Shrink the components to make the system more compact and practical.

As he wrote, the hum of the Mark 1 filled the workshop, a constant reminder of what was possible.

The workshop had never looked so tidy. Nick cleared away the cluttered tools and loose wires, arranging the workspace to highlight the Mark 1. A few chairs were set up around the room, facing the computer and the speakers. He'd even found time to set up a small tray of drinks and snacks—a touch of hospitality for his guests.

By the time the first knock sounded on the door, Nick was ready.

"Come on in," he called, wiping his hands on his jeans.

His colleague Alan entered, followed by a couple of others from the engineering team. They looked at the Mark 1 with a mix of curiosity and skepticism, their eyes lingering on the wooden casing and the borrowed TV screen.

"Well, Nick," Alan said, raising an eyebrow. "Let's see what this little box of yours can do."

Nick grinned, already feeling the rush of anticipation. "Alright, gentlemen. Let me show you the future."

Nick dimmed the lights in the workshop, letting the soft glow of the Mark 1's control panel fill the room. The borrowed TV screen flickered to life, displaying a simple command prompt. His guests, now seated in a semi-circle around the computer, leaned forward, their faces illuminated by the faint glow of the monitor.

“Alright,” Nick began, his voice calm but charged with excitement, “what you’re looking at is the Ashcombe System Mark 1—a prototype for what I believe will one day be a computer for personal use. It’s not the size of a room, and it’s not just for scientists or corporations. This is the future. For everyone.”

He took a deep breath, glancing at his notes before placing his hands on the keyboard. “First, let me show you its basic capabilities.”

Step 1: Text Input and Storage

Nick typed a short sentence on the keyboard:
HELLO, WORLD. THIS IS THE MARK 1.

The text appeared on the TV screen, each letter rendered in glowing, blocky characters. He pressed a key, and the computer stored the text in its memory.

“Nothing revolutionary here, right?” Nick said, glancing at the room. “But watch this.”

He typed another command:
RECALL: TEXT 1.

The computer retrieved and displayed the saved sentence instantly.

Alan raised an eyebrow. “That’s faster than I expected.”

“It’s just the beginning,” Nick replied, moving to the next part of the demo.

Step 2: Mathematical Calculations

“Now, let’s see how it handles numbers.” Nick typed in a command:
CALCULATE: 7489 + 6372

The screen flickered for a moment before displaying the result:
13861

“It’s basic arithmetic,” Nick said, “but it’s the speed that matters. And it’s not just addition—this machine can handle division, multiplication, even more complex equations. Watch.”

He typed another command:
CALCULATE: SQRT(256)

The response came almost instantly:
16

The room murmured with approval.

Step 3: Visual Output

“Now for something a bit more fun,” Nick said. He loaded a small program he’d written earlier. The screen cleared, and a series of simple geometric shapes began to appear—a square, a triangle, a circle.

“These are just basic visuals, but imagine what this could mean. One day, computers like this could display not just shapes, but diagrams, images, or even motion.”

Alan leaned forward, intrigued. “You’re saying this could go beyond just text and maths?”

“Absolutely,” Nick replied. “Think about engineers designing structures, or artists creating new kinds of visuals. This is just the first step.”

Step 4: Music and Sound Synthesis

“Now for the real showstopper.” Nick turned to the synthesizer module, adjusting a few knobs before typing a command into the computer:
PLAY: MELODY1

The speakers emitted a soft hum before the first notes emerged—a simple, haunting melody that filled the workshop. It wasn’t quite like a traditional instrument, but it wasn’t mechanical either. The sound was clean and pure, with a slightly alien quality that made it impossible to ignore.

The room fell silent, save for the music. Nick watched their faces, seeing a mix of wonder and curiosity.

“This,” Nick said, his voice breaking the spell, “is where the real potential lies. Imagine using a computer not just to solve problems, but to create. Music, art, soundscapes—entirely new forms of expression.”

Nick stepped back, gesturing toward the keyboard. “Does anyone want to give it a try?”

Alan hesitated for a moment before stepping forward. Under Nick’s guidance, he tapped a few keys on the synthesizer module. The computer responded instantly, generating a sequence of notes that echoed through the room.

“Not bad for an amateur,” Nick said with a grin, prompting a few chuckles.

“It’s incredible,” Alan admitted, stepping back. “It’s like the machine is alive.”

As the demonstration ended, the room erupted in questions and comments.

“Could this really be scaled down for personal use?” one of them asked.

“What about the cost?” another added.

Nick nodded, fielding their questions with calm determination. “It’s early days, and there are challenges—size, cost, speed—but I believe it’s possible. We’re building the foundation now, and the next step is to refine it, make it smaller, faster, and more accessible.”

“And the music?” Alan asked. “Do you really think this could replace instruments?”

“Not replace,” Nick said firmly. “Enhance. Augment. Imagine musicians having tools like this to experiment with sounds they could never produce on their own. The computer isn’t just a machine—it’s a collaborator.”

Alan and the others gathered closer around the Ashcombe Mark 1, their curiosity now centred on the strange and entrancing sounds it could produce.

“This melody—how does it even work?” Alan asked, tapping the side of the synthesizer module as the computer emitted another sequence of hypnotic notes. “How do you tell it what to play?”

Nick adjusted his glasses and leaned back in his chair, the glow of the screen casting faint patterns on his face. “It’s all about programming,” he began. “I’ve written what’s essentially a set of instructions, a kind of musical language, that the computer can interpret and convert into sound.”

Nick grabbed a notebook from his workbench, flipping it open to reveal lines of carefully handwritten code.

“This,” he said, pointing to a line, “is a simple example of how we create a melody. I define a scale, assign each note a frequency, and then write out the sequence in what’s essentially a step-by-step script.”

He turned back to the computer and typed:

```
DEFINE: SCALE = [A4, B4, C5, D5, E5, F5, G5]
SEQUENCE: PLAY SCALE, [1, 0, 2, 3, 5, 4, 3, 2]
TEMPO: 120
REPEAT: 3
```

The machine whirred, and the speakers produced a delicate tune, each note precisely timed and pitched.

“The `DEFINE` command tells the computer what frequencies to use for each note,” Nick explained, “and the `SEQUENCE` command maps out which notes to play and in what order. `TEMPO` sets the speed, and `REPEAT` loops the sequence.”

Syd, who was sitting cross-legged on the floor with a cigarette in hand, nodded slowly. “It’s like... you’re composing in code. Almost like writing sheet music, but for a machine.”

“Exactly,” Nick said. “It’s abstract, but the computer brings it to life.”

Another guest, a keyboardist named Roger, leaned forward. “What about the timbre? That sound—it doesn’t sound like a piano or a guitar. It’s... new.”

Nick grinned. “That’s because it’s synthesized. The computer doesn’t mimic traditional instruments—it creates sound from scratch. Look at this.”

He typed another command:

```
WAVEFORM: SINE
FREQUENCY: 440
MODULATE: VIBRATO, 5HZ
```

The speakers emitted a smooth, pure tone that wavered slightly, as if alive.

“That’s a sine wave,” Nick said. “It’s the simplest waveform, just a clean, single frequency. But I’ve added vibrato—a slight modulation of the pitch—to give it more character.”

He switched the waveform:

```
WAVEFORM: SAWTOOTH
FREQUENCY: 440
```

This time, the sound was harsher, with a buzzing, edgy quality.

“Now we’re using a sawtooth wave,” Nick continued. “It’s raw, almost abrasive, but perfect for certain kinds of effects. And we can layer these waves, mix them together, or even distort them to create entirely new sounds.”

Roger's eyes widened. "So you're not just playing notes—you're shaping the sound itself?"

"Exactly," Nick said. "The computer becomes an instrument, but it's also a workshop for building sounds that have never existed before. That's why I think it's revolutionary. Imagine an entire orchestra made from tones like this, each one completely unique."

Syd took another drag from his cigarette, his mind clearly racing. "It's like... synthesis," he mused, gesturing vaguely at the computer. "Not just combining art and technology, but creating something entirely new in the process. You're breaking down sound to its core elements and rebuilding it into something... I don't know, futuristic."

Nick nodded enthusiastically. "That's exactly the idea. It's about possibilities. With traditional instruments, you're limited by the physical properties of the strings, the wood, the brass. But with a computer, the only limit is the code you write. You could create a sound no one's ever heard before, something that doesn't even exist in nature."

Roger leaned back, visibly impressed. "And you think this could really catch on? People using computers to make music?"

Nick smiled. "Not tomorrow, but soon. Right now, it's clunky—it takes hours to write even a simple program, and the hardware is finicky. But in a few years, with better components and more refined software, I believe musicians will be able to create entire albums using machines like this. Imagine synthesizing an entire symphony, or making sounds that can't be played on a guitar or a piano. It's not about replacing instruments—it's about expanding what's possible."

Syd laughed, a spark of inspiration in his eyes. "Mate, you're gonna put us out of a job."

"Not a chance," Nick replied. "The computer doesn't replace the musician. It's a tool, like a pen or a brush. The creativity still comes from you—it just gives you new ways to express it."

"All right," Nick said, typing briskly, "let me show you how you'd write a pop song using nothing but code. It's actually not that different from composing traditionally—you just have to think in patterns, sequences, and structure."

```
# Define the tempo
TEMPO: 128  # Standard pop tempo

# Define the scale for the song
SCALE: C_MAJOR = [C4, D4, E4, F4, G4, A4, B4]

# Create the chord progression (I–V–vi–IV)
CHORDS: VERSE = [[C4, E4, G4], [G4, B4, D5], [A4, C5, E5], [F4, A4, C5]]
CHORDS: CHORUS = [[F4, A4, C5], [C4, E4, G4], [G4, B4, D5], [A4, C5, E5]]

# Define the melody as a sequence of notes in the scale
MELODY: VERSE = [E4, G4, A4, F4, G4, C5, B4, A4]
MELODY: CHORUS = [C5, C5, E5, G4, A4, F4, G4, E4]

# Define rhythm patterns
RHYTHM: VERSE_BEAT = [1, 0.5, 0.5, 1, 1, 0.5, 0.5, 1]
RHYTHM: CHORUS_BEAT = [0.5, 0.5, 1, 1, 1, 0.5, 0.5, 1]

# Combine everything
SONG: STRUCTURE = [VERSE, VERSE, CHORUS, VERSE, CHORUS, CHORUS]

PLAY: SONG, SYNTH = SAWTOOTH, MODULATION = 5HZ
```

The speakers came alive as the Ashcombe Mark 1 interpreted the code. A simple beat began to thump—a four-on-the-floor rhythm that carried the energy of every great pop song. Soon, chords followed, rich and warm, rising and falling in the familiar I–V–vi–IV progression.

Then the melody joined in, bright and catchy, weaving around the chords with a playful, almost human quality. The sawtooth wave added a modern, almost futuristic edge, while the slight modulation gave the notes a sense of movement.

Syd tapped his foot to the beat, already nodding along. Roger closed his eyes, imagining vocals over the arrangement. The room seemed to hum with a shared sense of discovery.

“You see,” Nick said, gesturing at the screen, “a pop song is just a formula—a structure that repeats and evolves in just the right way to hook you. With code, I can define every element—the tempo, the chords, the melody, the rhythm—and then I can manipulate them endlessly. Want the melody an octave higher? Done. Want the beat to swing instead of march? Easy.”

Roger, his curiosity now piqued, leaned in. “So, you could program an entire album like this?”

“Exactly,” Nick said. “Each song could have its own unique sound. I can layer different waveforms, automate dynamics, or even create random variations in the melody to give it a more human touch. The computer can be both the band and the producer.”

He typed another command, modifying the sawtooth wave to include a square wave overlay:

```
ADD: SQUARE_WAVE, FREQUENCY = 880
MIX: SAWTOOTH, SQUARE_WAVE, RATIO = 3:1
```

The resulting sound was richer, fuller—like the combination of an electric guitar and a synthesizer.

“You hear that?” Nick asked. “That’s the sound of two waveforms mixed together. You could create textures like this for every track on an album—sounds no traditional instrument could replicate. And because it’s code, you can save it, tweak it, and reproduce it perfectly every time.”

Syd stood, running his hands through his hair. “Mate, this is insane. You’re telling me we could write an album—an entire bloody album—without ever stepping into a studio?”

Nick nodded. “Not only that. We could create sounds that no one’s ever heard before. We could push music into a whole new dimension. Imagine an album that isn’t just music—it’s an experience, crafted with precision and completely unique.”

Roger laughed, shaking his head in disbelief. “You might just change the entire industry, Nick.”

“Not me,” Nick said, smiling. “The computer. It’s not just an instrument—it’s a revolution. And this,” he gestured at the Ashcombe Mark 1, still humming softly in the corner, “is just the beginning.”

Nick leaned back in his chair, watching the room as the last synthetic notes from the Ashcombe Mark 1 faded into silence. The air was thick with potential, as though everyone there had just caught a glimpse of something far bigger than themselves. He tapped his fingers on the desk, his mind racing ahead of the conversation.

"You know," he began, looking at Syd and Roger, "this... this is just the start. The pop song is great—don’t get me wrong—but what if we went further? What if the computer didn’t just help us write songs but created entire worlds of sound? What if it became the music?"

Roger raised an eyebrow. "What do you mean by 'became the music'?"

Nick grinned, pushing himself off the desk and pacing the room. "Think about it. A pop song is... structured. It's a few minutes long, follows a progression, maybe has a hook, a chorus, and a bridge. It's beautiful, but it's limited. But what if you could make something... infinite? Something immersive. Something where the music doesn't just play—it surrounds you, it pulls you in. It's not a song anymore; it's an experience."

"An experience," Syd echoed, a dreamy look in his eye.

"Exactly," Nick said, snapping his fingers. "Imagine a sound that doesn't stop, that evolves and shifts, that reacts to the moment, to the mood, to the people in the room. Imagine walking into a space, and the music wraps itself around you. The bassline throbs through your chest, the melody dances through your head, and the rhythm doesn't just make you move—it becomes part of you."

Roger tilted his head. "But wouldn't that just be noise?"

Nick shook his head, excited now. "No, no, no. Not noise. It's about patterns, layers, and textures. It's about letting the computer take over where human limitations stop. We feed it ideas, algorithms—rhythms, tonal systems, waveforms—and it starts to build something bigger. Something alive. It's not just music you listen to; it's music you feel. Something... I don't know... electronic. Danceable. Electronic dance music, maybe."

Syd let out a low whistle. "Electronic dance music," he repeated, testing the phrase. "It has a ring to it."

Nick nodded, sitting back down. "We could make it happen. Look, with this," he gestured to the Mark 1, "we can generate any sound you want. We can create beats that go on forever. Imagine people losing themselves in it—not just for three minutes, but for hours. A continuous, immersive soundscape. It could bring people together in a way no pop song ever could."

Nick turned back to the keyboard, his fingers flying as he started typing out a new sequence:

```
# Create a continuous beat loop
TEMPO: 120  # Standard dance tempo

# Define the drumbeat
DRUMS: KICK = [1, 0, 0, 0], SNARE = [0, 0, 1, 0], HIHAT = [0.5, 0.5, 0.5, 0.5]

# Add a bassline
BASSLINE: PATTERN = [C2, C2, G2, A2, F2, F2, G2, A2]
RHYTHM: BASS = [1, 0.5, 0.5, 1, 1, 0.5, 0.5, 1]

# Layer ambient textures
AMBIENCE: PAD = SAWTOOTH, MODULATION = 3HZ, REVERB = HEAVY

# Infinite loop
PLAY: DRUMS, BASSLINE, AMBIENCE, LOOP = TRUE
```

The Ashcombe Mark 1 whirred as it processed the input. Then, through the speakers, a steady, hypnotic beat emerged. The bassline thumped, the kick drum landed with perfect precision, and a shimmering ambient layer swirled around it all.

The room fell silent, except for the music. The repetitive rhythm was infectious, almost primal. Syd tapped his foot in time, while Roger found himself unconsciously nodding along. It wasn't flashy or complex, but it was undeniably powerful—like the heartbeat of a machine.

"This," Nick said, gesturing at the speakers, "is just the beginning. Imagine this on a larger scale. A club, a warehouse, hundreds of people dancing, losing themselves in the rhythm. The computer doesn’t just play music—it *is* the music. It adapts, it grows, it becomes whatever the moment needs it to be."

Syd leaned back, a wide grin spreading across his face. "You might just change everything, mate. Forget pop songs. This is the future."

Nick leaned back against the desk, letting the Mark 1's rhythmic, hypnotic pulse fill the room. The others were transfixed, nodding along to the steady beat. He knew the demonstration had landed—but now it was time to frame it. To show them what it all meant. Clearing his throat, he stepped forward, drawing their attention from the machine to his words.

"Music," Nick began, his voice steady, "is just the start. It’s the perfect way to show you what this computer can do, but it’s not the end. See, music—at its core—is just patterns, maths, structure. And a computer? That’s what it’s built for. This isn’t about replacing musicians or instruments. It’s about creating something new, something richer, something that adds another dimension to creativity."

Syd tilted his head, intrigued but sceptical. "Go on, Nick. Sounds like you’ve got a bigger plan here."

Nick smiled. "I do. Music is the hook, right? It’s how we get people to pay attention. They’ll feel it before they understand it. But this computer? It’s not just an instrument; it’s a tool for everything. Imagine—organizing sound, images, text. Solving complex problems, making connections faster than any of us could. That’s what we’re building here at Orion. The Mark 1 is just the beginning.”

Roger leaned forward. "Yeah, but why music? I mean, no offence, it’s cool and all, but how’s that going to sell the thing?"

"Because music speaks to people," Nick said. "It’s universal. It’s emotional. And it shows what this machine can do in a way that’s immediate. Think about it: you’re writing a song, right? You have to pick out every note, every chord, every rhythm. What if you could program it? What if you could experiment in real time, play with different ideas, create whole new sounds that no instrument on earth could make? That’s what I’m working on—how to make the computer into a creative partner."

Roger scratched his chin, still sceptical. Syd leaned forward, more curious now. "And this is just a prototype?"

Nick nodded. "Yeah. But let me show you something else. I’ve been writing code for it—playing with the idea of how to build a song from scratch, just using commands. The machine doesn’t think the way we do, so it’s all about teaching it. And this machine can do more than just music. That’s what I need Orion to see. Music is just one application. This thing—it could change everything. It could run businesses, help people connect, even make art."

"And you think they’ll buy into it?" Roger asked.

"They have to," Nick said. "Once I show them what it’s capable of, they won’t have a choice."

Syd leaned back, a grin spreading across his face. "You’re a bloody visionary, mate. But you’ve got to admit, the music part? That’s what’s got me hooked."

Nick smiled. "Good. Because that's the hook for everyone. Music is the way we bring people in. But once they're here, they'll see the bigger picture. The computer isn't just a tool—it's a revolution."

Chapter 15:

Nick stood in front of the conference room at Orion Industries, the Mark 1 prototype gleaming on the table beside him. Its casing wasn't much to look at—a makeshift enclosure of polished aluminium panels with rows of blinking lights and switches—but he wasn't here to sell aesthetics. He was here to sell revolution.

Across the table sat the suits. Men in their forties and fifties, ties perfectly knotted, their expressions ranging from sceptical to intrigued. At the head of the table was Richard Halpern, Orion's head of development, a man Nick respected but often clashed with over the company's direction.

Halpern leaned back in his chair, arms crossed, his sharp eyes fixed on Nick. "We've been hearing quite a lot about this... contraption of yours, Ashcombe," he said, his tone unreadable. "Something about music and code? Care to show us what all the fuss is about?"

Nick took a deep breath, steadying himself. He glanced down at the Mark 1, its hum faint but reassuring. "I think you'll find this is more than a contraption, Mr. Halpern. It's a vision of what computers can become—a way to bring technology into people's lives in ways they've never imagined."

"Right," Halpern said, a flicker of amusement crossing his face. "Let's see it, then."

Nick nodded and stepped over to the prototype. He powered it on, the lights blinking in sequence, a soft whirring sound emanating from within. He flipped a series of switches and turned to the terminal, typing quickly.

"This," Nick began, his voice steady, "is the Mark 1. It's not just a computational machine—it's a creative one. Let me show you."

He hit a key, and the Mark 1 emitted a single tone through its speaker. Then another. Slowly, a sequence began to form—a simple melody, repeating and building.

"The code you're hearing now," Nick said, gesturing to the terminal, "is a basic loop. But it's not static. Watch."

He typed a new command, and the melody shifted, harmonies emerging as layers were added. The room filled with sound, richer and more complex than any of them had expected.

One of the executives leaned forward, his brows furrowed. "How's it doing that?"

Nick smiled. "It's following the instructions I've programmed into it. But it's not just replaying static data—it's generating sound in real time, based on a set of dynamic parameters I can adjust on the fly."

He typed another command, and the rhythm changed, the tempo picking up. The sound transformed into something that felt almost like a heartbeat, pulsing and alive.

"Now imagine," Nick continued, "a musician using this. They could compose entire songs, experiment with new ideas, create sounds no traditional instrument could produce. This is a tool for creativity, not just calculation."

Halpern leaned forward, his expression no longer skeptical. "And what about outside of music?"

"I'm glad you asked," Nick said, his enthusiasm growing. "This is just the beginning. The Mark 1 can process data, organize information, and solve problems faster than anything else we've built. But music is the perfect way to show its potential because it's immediate. It speaks to people."

He typed another command, and the sound shifted again—this time into a series of synthesized tones that resembled an otherworldly orchestra.

"This," Nick said, "isn't just about technology. It's about creating experiences. Imagine what this could do for education, for communication, for storytelling. We're talking about a machine that can help people think, create, and connect in ways we've never seen before."

The room was silent for a moment, the executives exchanging glances. Finally, Halpern spoke.

"Let's say we're intrigued," he said. "But how do you expect us to sell this? What's the market for a machine like this? Who's going to buy it?"

Nick hesitated for a moment, then squared his shoulders. "At first? Musicians, artists, educators. People who see the value in pushing boundaries. But eventually? Everyone. Imagine a future where every home has a computer—a machine that can help with everything from managing finances to composing music to connecting with others. That's the world we're building toward. And the Mark 1 is the first step."

The conference room at Orion had filled by the time Nick was ready for the full demonstration. It wasn't just the suits anymore. The room was crowded with a mixture of engineers, curious investors, artists, and a few media people who had heard whispers of what Nick was up to. The air buzzed with anticipation.

Nick stood at the front of the room, his fingers brushing over the cool metal of the Mark 1's console, his thoughts racing. This was the moment—the one where the machine would finally show its true potential. The crowd waited, silent and expectant.

"All right, everyone," Nick began, his voice firm but electric with enthusiasm. "What I'm about to show you is the first real step into a new world. A world where the computer isn't just a tool for work, but a partner in creation. The Mark 1 is more than just a machine—it's a bridge between human expression and technology."

He clicked a button, and the screen flickered to life. The soft whir of the machine hummed through the room as the various components clicked into place. The lights above the table dimmed, and the lights on the Mark 1 brightened, casting a glow over the gathering crowd.

The first notes began to play—a simple melody, almost haunting. It echoed through the speakers like something ancient, yet futuristic. The tone was pure, clean, and resonated with a clarity that drew people in.

Nick glanced up, watching the crowd's reaction. There were a few exchanged glances, but nothing unexpected yet. He pressed a few more keys, and suddenly, the sound shifted. The melody grew more complex, layering on top of itself. The volume swelled, and the notes began to stretch, bending like elastic, creating a web of sound that spiraled and looped.

He turned to the terminal, fingers moving in a blur. As the sound changed, so did the visuals on the screen. Abstract shapes danced in time with the music—a swirling pattern of color and light that shifted with each note, pulsing with the rhythm, creating an immersive experience. The room filled with the sensation of sound and sight intertwined.

This was the first true demonstration of what Nick had envisioned: a computer that wasn't just a tool, but a creator of its own. A synthesizer of both sound and image, an instrument of expression.

The crowd was silent, enraptured.

Nick gave a subtle nod to the Mark 1, and the music shifted again, becoming rhythmic, like a heartbeat. A bassline rolled in, smooth and undulating. A set of synthesized drum patterns followed, each beat perfectly timed, yet never predictable.

“This,” Nick said, turning back to face the crowd, “is just the beginning. The Mark 1 is capable of creating any sound, any texture, any rhythm you can imagine. But it's not limited to music. It can be used for anything. Picture a future where this machine isn't just making music—it's helping to write films, create art, assist in design, manage systems, even revolutionize education. The possibilities are endless."

He paused, watching their faces. The media people scribbled down notes, their eyes wide, captivated by the unfolding display. The suits, while more reserved, were slowly starting to lean in.

Nick wasn't just showing them a machine—he was showing them a new way of thinking about computers.

He pressed a few more buttons, and the music shifted once more, becoming something far more complex—a full composition, layered with synthesizers, drums, melodies, and chords, all playing together as if orchestrated by a master conductor. Each part was perfectly coordinated, but still felt alive, dynamic, as if it were evolving right before their eyes.

“The machine doesn't just play music," Nick explained, his voice filled with quiet excitement. "It learns the relationships between sound, structure, and experience. You can use it to generate anything—from the most complex orchestral pieces to ambient noise that could accompany a meditation session. It's all about creating a richer experience for the user. You are no longer just pressing play. You are collaborating with a machine to create something new and meaningful."

Nick let the music continue for a few moments longer before switching it off. The room was silent for a beat—no one spoke. No one moved. It was as if they were all suspended in the same moment, overwhelmed by the sheer potential of what they had just witnessed.

Finally, Halpern cleared his throat, his sharp eyes fixed on Nick. "This..." he began slowly, "this is something else, Ashcombe. It's more than we expected. You've opened up a whole new world here. But you know as well as I do that no one buys a product because it's just amazing. How are you going to make this work? How does the Mark 1 go from here into the world?"

Nick took a deep breath, feeling a weight in his chest. He had anticipated this. "The first step is to integrate this into the music industry—musicians, composers, anyone in the creative space. We'll work with them, let them experiment, refine the system. Once the machine has evolved, we can scale it. Schools, homes, businesses—this could become the centrepiece of a new way of thinking about how we interact with computers."

Halpern raised an eyebrow. "And how long do you think that will take?"

"A couple of years," Nick said, feeling a surge of confidence. "It will evolve. The software, the capabilities—it’s all going to get better with time. But right now, this is the start of something huge. And we need to be at the forefront of it."

As the last notes of the Mark 1’s demonstration faded and the room began to empty, Nick busied himself with powering down the machine. His hands shook slightly, a mix of excitement and the adrenaline that had been coursing through him during the presentation. People murmured around him, the sounds of excitement and speculation filling the air.

He didn’t notice at first when a small group of sharply dressed men stepped into the room. Their presence was understated yet commanding, their suits darker and more tailored than the typical Orion executives. One of them, a broad-shouldered man with silver hair and an American accent, quietly introduced himself to Orion’s CEO, Halpern.

“We’d like a word,” the man said, his tone flat but urgent. Behind him, two younger men with stern faces and polished shoes flanked him, each carrying slim briefcases.

Halpern nodded, visibly cautious, and gestured for the Orion board members to follow him. The group moved toward the far end of the room, where a door led to one of the smaller conference rooms. Nick watched curiously as Halpern, along with two other senior executives, exchanged looks and stepped through the door, leaving the rest of the room in a momentary lull.

The Americans glanced around as they followed, and for a brief second, one of them locked eyes with Nick. It wasn’t hostile, but it was cold and deliberate, as if they were sizing him up.

Nick turned back to the Mark 1, pretending to adjust some of the wiring, though he couldn’t help but feel a knot of anxiety forming in his stomach. Whatever was happening, it wasn’t just business as usual.

The minutes stretched on. Quiet conversations buzzed around the room, but Nick’s mind was elsewhere. He ran his fingers along the edge of the Mark 1’s console, his mind replaying the demonstration and wondering if he’d missed something—some aspect of the machine that had caught someone’s attention for the wrong reasons.

Finally, after what felt like an eternity but was closer to ten minutes, the door to the side room opened. Halpern stepped out first, his expression carefully neutral but his posture noticeably tense. Behind him, the American with the silver hair followed, nodding politely to the room at large.

The tension was palpable as Halpern clapped his hands together and smiled, though it didn’t reach his eyes. "Thank you all for attending today," he said, his voice carefully controlled. "It’s clear that the Mark 1 has significant potential, and we’re very excited about the next steps. For now, though, I think that concludes today’s demonstration."

The Americans exchanged a few quiet words with Halpern, shook hands briskly, and left the room without another word. The Orion executives who had gone into the meeting looked tight-lipped, exchanging glances with each other before muttering their goodbyes and making for the door as well.

Nick approached Halpern hesitantly as the room began to clear out. “What was that about?” he asked, trying to keep his tone casual but failing to mask his curiosity.

Halpern looked at him, clearly debating how much to say. Finally, he sighed and patted Nick on the shoulder. "Don't worry about it, Nick. Just keep working on the Mark 1. You've got something special here, and there's a lot of interest in what you're doing. That's all you need to know for now."

“But—” Nick started, but Halpern was already moving toward the door, offering nods to the remaining guests.

The workshop was humming with the usual low whir of machinery and the faint crackle of soldering irons as Nick fine-tuned the Ashcombe Mark 1. His desk was cluttered with printouts of binary sequences, hand-drawn schematics, and spools of wire that looped across the workstation like an unkempt garden.

He was halfway through debugging a glitch in the audio output module—a small but crucial part of the Mark 1's growing potential as a multimedia machine—when the door to the workshop creaked open. Nick didn't look up at first, assuming it was one of the engineers stopping by with a question or a part.

But then he heard the click of polished shoes on the concrete floor, a sound that didn't fit the usual Orion crowd. He glanced up and froze.

It was them. The suits.

The silver-haired American who had been at the demonstration weeks earlier stepped forward, his dark suit and tie immaculate. Behind him, two younger men flanked him, their briefcases as shiny as their shoes. This time, though, there was no Halpern, no buffer of Orion management to mediate their presence.

“Mr. Ashcombe,” the silver-haired man said, his voice smooth and firm. “We need a word.”

Nick put down his soldering iron, his stomach knotting as he wiped his hands on his jeans. “What's this about?” he asked, though he had a sinking feeling he already knew the answer.

The American glanced around the workshop, his eyes sweeping over the Mark 1 and the various components scattered across the room. “Why don't we take this somewhere more private?”

Nick bristled but nodded, leading them to the small office at the back of the workshop. The room was cramped, filled with stacks of technical manuals and blueprints, but it was quiet. The silver-haired man shut the door behind them and took a seat across from Nick, while his associates stood by, silent and watchful.

“I'll get straight to the point,” the man said, leaning forward slightly. “Orion is under new management. As of this morning, our group has acquired the company, its assets, and all associated intellectual property.”

Nick blinked, the words taking a moment to register. “What? You've… bought Orion?”

“Correct,” the man said. “And with that acquisition comes a new direction. Effective immediately, we'll be relocating Orion's operations to the United States. That includes the Ashcombe Mark 1 project.”

Nick's heart sank. “You're moving everything? Including the Mark 1?”

The man nodded, his expression calm but unyielding. “The potential of this machine is undeniable, Mr. Ashcombe. And we believe its development can be accelerated in a more… resourceful environment. The United States offers greater access to funding, talent, and market opportunities.”

Nick’s mind raced. The Mark 1 wasn’t just a machine; it was his vision, his work, his dream. And now, without so much as a warning, it was being uprooted and shipped across the Atlantic.

“You can’t just take it,” Nick said, his voice rising slightly. “This isn’t some factory machine—it’s—”

“It’s property of Orion,” the man interrupted, his tone firm. “And Orion is now property of us. I understand this may be difficult to accept, but this decision has been made at the highest levels. It’s non-negotiable.”

Nick sat back, his fists clenching. “What about me?” he asked, his voice quieter now, tinged with disbelief. “Am I just supposed to drop everything and move to America?”

“We would, of course, welcome your continued involvement in the project,” the man said, his tone softening slightly. “Your expertise is invaluable, and we’re prepared to make a very generous offer for you to relocate with the company. But whether you come or not, the Mark 1 is going.”

Nick stared at the man, his mind a storm of anger, frustration, and helplessness. He’d poured everything into the Mark 1—his time, his energy, his vision. And now it was being taken from him, turned into a corporate asset to be exploited thousands of miles away.

The silver-haired man stood, smoothing the front of his suit. “Take some time to think it over,” he said. “We’ll need an answer by the end of the week. But I’ll tell you this, Mr. Ashcombe—this machine has the potential to change the world. And with or without you, that’s exactly what it’s going to do.”

Nick sat in the corner of the workshop, staring at the Mark 1. It was humming softly, the lights on its crude interface panel blinking in a rhythm that almost felt alive. His creation—a machine that could shape the future—was being pried away from him.

He was still stewing over the Americans’ visit when Halpern stepped into the workshop, the door closing behind him with a soft click. He didn’t look like his usual self. The man who always carried an air of easy confidence now looked weighed down, his tie slightly loosened, his face etched with fatigue.

“Nick,” Halpern began, running a hand through his thinning hair. “We need to talk.”

Nick didn’t answer right away, his eyes still locked on the Mark 1. “Let me guess,” he said bitterly. “You’re here to tell me it’s for the best.”

Halpern sighed and pulled up a chair. “I don’t want to sugarcoat this,” he said. “You’ve done something incredible here. You know that. I know that. Hell, even the bloody Board of Trade knows that. But the reality is… the Americans have made an offer we can’t refuse.”

Nick turned to him, his frustration boiling over. “You’re saying you sold us out, just like that? This is supposed to be about more than money, Halpern! It’s about vision, about building something revolutionary.”

Halpern held up a hand. “I get it, Nick. Believe me, I do. But you have to understand the scale of what we’re dealing with. The university that’s bought us out—they’ve got resources we could only dream of. Labs, researchers, funding—things we could never provide you here. And yes, the Board of Trade is putting the screws on me. They see this as a win for Anglo-American relations. A chance to cement Britain’s role in the technological revolution, even if the work gets done overseas.”

Nick shook his head. “Britain’s role? What role? Handing everything over to the Yanks?”

Halpern leaned forward, his voice dropping to a near whisper. “Look, Nick. If it were up to me, I’d keep the Mark 1 here. But the money they’re throwing around… it’s astronomical. Enough to secure Orion for years. Enough to ensure you’re well-compensated for your work.”

Nick’s expression hardened. “I don’t care about the money, Halpern. I care about what this computer means. It’s not just a machine. It’s a chance to give power to ordinary people, to decentralize everything. And now it’s going to end up locked away in some American lab, used for God knows what.”

Halpern sighed again, leaning back in his chair. “I won’t lie to you, Nick. This isn’t ideal. But it’s the only option we have. You’re a bright lad. You know how the world works. Sometimes you have to compromise to get things done.”

Nick’s jaw clenched, his mind racing. He thought of the long nights he’d spent hunched over blueprints and soldering irons, the excitement of each breakthrough, the dreams of what the Mark 1 could become. And now it was all slipping away, reduced to a line item in a corporate acquisition.

“Is there really nothing to be done?” he asked quietly.

Halpern shook his head. “It’s out of my hands. Out of yours, too. The Americans want the Mark 1, and they’ve got the backing to make it happen. If you stay in Britain, you’ll still be well-paid for your work. But the machine… it’s going.”

Nick sat in silence, the weight of Halpern’s words pressing down on him. For all his idealism, all his dreams of revolution, he was powerless against the tide of bureaucracy and big money.

Finally, Halpern stood, placing a hand on Nick’s shoulder. “Take some time to think it over,” he said. “Whatever you decide, you’ve done something extraordinary here. Don’t forget that.”

Nick leaned against the workshop bench, his hands gripping the edge until his knuckles turned white. The news from Halpern and the Board of Trade reverberated in his mind like an echo in a cavern. His invention, his life's work, the Ashcombe Mark 1, was no longer his. It would soon be packed up and shipped across the Atlantic, its potential realized not in the country where it was built, but in some sprawling American university.

He tried to suppress the rising tide of anger and despair, but his thoughts kept circling back to Reginald Ashcombe, the great-uncle he'd read about so many times at his mother Eleanor’s house. Reginald, the dreamer who had watched his life’s ambitions crushed under the heel of war and government intervention. Nick had always felt a strange kinship with him—a man who believed in progress and liberty, only to have his hopes dashed by forces far beyond his control.

Reginald had tried to fight back, to preserve the integrity of what he believed in, but history hadn't been kind to men like him. And now, as Nick stood in the very same position—helpless, betrayed—

he felt like history was repeating itself. The government and corporations had swooped in, dangling promises and pay checks, only to rip the rug out from under him.

“I’ve sold my soul,” Nick muttered under his breath, his voice heavy with bitterness. He slammed his fist on the bench, rattling the carefully arranged tools. “They’ve taken everything. Just like they took it from Reginald.”

He remembered the book vividly, the old family heirloom that painted Reginald as a principled yet tragic figure. Nick had poured over its pages as a teenager, fascinated by the tale of a man who tried to stand against the tides of history and failed. Reginald had placed his faith in sound money and individual freedom, only to be trampled by governments wielding the power of fiat currencies and endless bureaucracy.

And now, decades later, Nick was facing a similar fate, only this time the culprits weren’t just governments but corporations as well—an unholy alliance of profit and politics that saw him as just another cog in their machine. His invention wasn’t his anymore; it was a commodity, a line on a balance sheet, a tool for someone else’s agenda.

Nick sank into his chair, the blueprints for the Mark 1 scattered across his desk. The intricate circuits and programming notes that had once filled him with hope and excitement now seemed like relics of a lost cause. The machine had started as a utopian vision—a way to empower individuals, to merge art and technology, to create something that could truly change the world.

But now, as it was being shipped off to America, Nick wondered if the Mark 1 would ever fulfil that dream. Would it become a tool of liberation, or just another piece of corporate machinery designed to extract profit?

Halpern’s words still rang in his ears. *The money was too much to turn down.* Nick had seen the gleam in Halpern’s eyes when he said it, the way his voice betrayed not regret but satisfaction. The man had been waiting for a payday like this, and Nick’s idealism had been nothing more than a stepping stone to get there.

He looked over at the Mark 1, humming quietly in the corner of the workshop. It was alive, in its way, responding to the commands he’d programmed into it, running through lines of code that only he truly understood. To Nick, it was more than just a machine. It was a manifestation of his dreams, his creativity, and his belief in what technology could be.

Now, it would be taken away from him.

Nick stood and walked over to the computer, placing his hand on its metallic surface. “I won’t let them forget where you came from,” he whispered. “If they want to take you, fine. But I’ll make damn sure they know what you were meant to be.”

In the back of his mind, he started forming a plan. Maybe he couldn’t stop the sale, but he could make his mark in other ways. Reginald Ashcombe might have lost his battle, but Nick wasn’t ready to give up just yet. The Mark 1 might be leaving Britain, but its soul—his soul—was something no one could buy.

The weeks that followed were a blur of meetings, paperwork, and quiet resignation. Nick watched as the Mark 1 was carefully disassembled and crated up, each piece labelled and catalogued for shipment. The Orion workshop, once alive with the hum of innovation, now felt like a mausoleum.

The final day came with little fanfare. A group of technicians, along with representatives from the American university that had bought Orion, arrived to oversee the transportation of the Mark 1. Nick stood at the edge of the workshop, hands stuffed in his pockets, watching the machine he had poured his heart into being loaded into the back of a lorry.

Halpern approached him, clipboard in hand and a forced smile on his face. “Nick,” he said, his tone overly cordial. “You’ve done something remarkable here. You should be proud.”

Nick didn’t reply immediately. He stared at the lorry as the last crate was secured. “Pride doesn’t mean much when you’ve lost control of what you created,” he said finally.

Halpern sighed. “I get it, I do. But this is bigger than you. The Americans have the resources, the infrastructure. They’ll take your work to heights you can’t imagine.”

“I could imagine plenty if they’d let me,” Nick muttered.

Halpern patted him awkwardly on the shoulder. “You’ve got a bright future ahead of you, Nick. Don’t let this be the end of the road. There’s more to come.”

Nick watched Halpern walk away, his footsteps echoing in the empty workshop. He felt a surge of anger, but it was tempered by a quiet determination. He wasn’t ready to let this be the end.

As the quiet of the evening settled over London, Nick sat alone at his desk, staring out at the city skyline. The noise of the day had faded, leaving only the faint hum of distant traffic and the occasional flicker of neon lights. His notebook lay open before him, pages filled with sketches, equations, and fragments of ideas for what would come next.

He thought of his great-uncle Reginald Ashcombe, who had once fought for the gold standard—a way to protect individuals from the unchecked power of governments and central banks. Reginald’s vision had been one of freedom, of protecting the individual against forces too vast to comprehend.

PART FOUR:

Chapter 16:

The year was 2017, and Sheffield’s skies hung heavy with the usual patchwork of steel-gray clouds. Samuel Ashcombe’s flat, just a stone’s throw from Bramall Lane, hummed with a quiet intensity. The space was an eclectic mess: an old sofa rescued from a skip, walls adorned with posters of sci-fi movies, and a makeshift workstation cobbled together from scavenged monitors and secondhand keyboards. A faint whiff of weed hung in the air, mingling with the earthy aroma of coffee gone cold.

Samuel sat hunched over his laptop, the glow of the screen illuminating his sharp features. His hoodie, perpetually zipped halfway, bore the faded words: *Code is Law*. Around him, the faint rhythm of muffled music played from a cheap Bluetooth speaker. His fingers moved with practised precision as lines of Python scrolled across the screen.

“Alright,” he muttered to himself, leaning back and rubbing his temples. “This should work.”

On the screen, a prototype marketplace had come to life. It was simple but elegant—a decentralized online platform where users could trade directly, anonymously, and without oversight. No middlemen, no regulators. Just code. He called it *Lattice*, inspired by the intricate, self-organizing patterns of crystal structures.

The flat wasn't empty. Luna sprawled across the worn-out sofa, her purple hair blending into the chaotic tapestry of blankets. She was engrossed in a game on her phone, one foot dangling off the edge of the couch.

"You've been at that for hours," she said without looking up. "What is it this time? Another Bitcoin thing?"

Samuel smirked, turning the laptop toward her. "Not just another Bitcoin thing. It's a marketplace. Peer-to-peer. Completely decentralized. No one controls it—not me, not anyone. Think Craigslist, but unstoppable."

Luna glanced at the screen, raising an eyebrow. "And what's the point? People already have eBay, Etsy, all that stuff."

"Yeah, and all that stuff is crawling with middlemen and gatekeepers," Samuel shot back. "This is different. Imagine you're an artist. You can sell your work directly to anyone in the world, no cut to Etsy, no censorship. Or you're a farmer selling produce, or…" He hesitated, letting the implication hang in the air.

"Or," Luna said, catching on, "you're selling something the authorities wouldn't approve of."

"Exactly." Samuel's grin was equal parts defiance and excitement. "It's not just about commerce. It's about freedom. A place where people can trade without permission."

Luna rolled onto her side, eyeing him skeptically. "You know that sounds like every black market on the dark web, right?"

"Maybe," he admitted, leaning forward again. "But this isn't just for contraband. It's for anything. Ideas, art, even services. And it's not centralized like Silk Road was. This is completely distributed. Even if they shut one node down, the rest keep running. It's unkillable."

She sat up now, intrigued despite herself. "Okay, but how do you test something like this? You're not seriously thinking of going live with it, are you?"

Samuel hesitated for a moment, his fingers hovering over the keyboard. "I've set up a sandbox environment," he said carefully. "Fake accounts, dummy data. But yeah, I'm thinking of running a small test. See how it handles real-world conditions."

Luna groaned, flopping back onto the couch. "You're going to get yourself arrested one day, you know that?"

He laughed softly, shaking his head. "Not if I do it right."

As the night wore on, the flat grew quieter, the music dimmed to a low hum. Samuel kept working, refining the code, tweaking the system, and imagining the possibilities. To him, *Lattice* wasn't just a marketplace. It was a statement, a challenge to the systems that controlled people's lives.

At one point, Fergus burst through the door, clutching a bag of takeaway. "You lot still at it?" he asked, plopping down at the table.

"Samuel's building the anarchist Amazon," Luna quipped, lighting another joint.

Fergus laughed. "Sounds about right. What's for sale, then? Revolution? Weed?"

Samuel grinned. "Everything. Or nothing. Depends who uses it."

Samuel leaned back in his chair, cracking his knuckles as he hit "save" on the latest iteration of *Lattice*. The glow of the laptop screen softened the dimly lit room. Luna stretched out on the couch, holding the joint delicately between her fingers as she passed it to Fergus, who was already digging into his box of noodles.

“Seriously,” Samuel said, eyeing the joint as it made its way around. “Does anyone have any hash? This bud’s hitting too heavy right now. I need something lighter.”

Luna snorted. “You’re getting picky about your high now? That’s new.”

“No, it’s not,” Fergus interjected, exhaling a plume of smoke. “Remember that time he refused to smoke the Moroccan stuff because it ‘smelled like petrol?’”

“That’s because it *did* smell like petrol!” Samuel protested, grinning. “Some dodgy dealer probably stored it next to a generator or something.”

Luna laughed, passing the joint back to Samuel. “Sorry to disappoint, your highness, but all we’ve got tonight is the usual. Next time I’ll bring something fancier just for you.”

Samuel waved her off, taking a small drag but pulling away quickly. “Nah, it’s fine. Just not in the mood for this. I need something that lets me think. This stuff feels like it’s trying to tie bricks to my brain.”

“Your brain *needs* bricks, mate,” Fergus said, slumping back in his chair. “Otherwise, you’ll keep building mad shit like that—what’s it called again? *Lattice*?—and get us all in trouble.”

Samuel grinned, handing the joint back to Luna. “You’re just scared of what it means, Fergus. This isn’t just a marketplace. It’s freedom. Real, unfiltered, peer-to-peer freedom.”

“Right,” Fergus said, rolling his eyes. “And freedom always comes with a SWAT team knocking on your door.”

Luna sat up, the joint in one hand and her other gesturing toward Samuel. “Alright, Philosopher King, explain it to us again. What’s the big vision? I mean, we’ve heard the pitch, but where’s this really going?”

Samuel leaned forward, his voice growing more animated. “Okay, think about it. The internet’s meant to be this great equalizer, right? But look at it now. Gatekeepers everywhere. Centralized servers, governments, big corporations—everything funnelled through them. What happens when they don’t like what you’re doing? They ban you. They take it down. They erase you.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Luna said, waving him on. “But that’s old news. How does *Lattice* fix it?”

“It’s decentralized,” Samuel said, his tone patient but passionate. “It’s not a website on some company’s server. It’s a protocol. Anyone can run it, anywhere. You download the software, connect to the network, and boom—you’re part of the marketplace. Even if they take down one node, the rest of the network keeps running.”

“And what’s stopping people from using it for... y’know, bad stuff?” Fergus asked, raising an eyebrow.

Samuel shrugged. “Nothing. Same thing that stops people from using cash for bad stuff—nothing. But the point isn’t to police people. It’s to give them the tools to do what they want, without interference.”

Luna leaned back, exhaling a cloud of smoke. “So, it’s like anarchist Etsy?”

“Sure,” Samuel said with a grin. “But it’s bigger than that. Imagine musicians selling directly to fans, no record label skimming off the top. Or farmers bypassing supermarkets, selling fresh produce straight to people in their community. Artists, coders, writers—anyone. It’s not just about stuff. It’s about ideas. Connections.”

“And you think people will actually use it?” Fergus asked, still skeptical.

“They already want something like this,” Samuel said firmly. “Every time a platform screws over its users, they cry out for alternatives. This is the alternative. And it’s unstoppable.”

Luna took another drag from the joint, passing it back to Fergus. “You’re idealistic, Sam. I like that about you. But you know this won’t just stay in the hands of artists and farmers, right? You’re making something bigger than that. Bigger than you.”

Samuel’s gaze softened as he considered her words. “I know. But that’s the point. This isn’t about me. It’s about creating something that can’t be controlled. By anyone.”

The room fell into a contemplative silence, the only sound the faint hum of Samuel’s laptop and the occasional rustle of Fergus’ noodle box. After a while, Luna broke the quiet.

“You know what I think?” she said, stretching out on the couch. “I think you’re onto something. But you’re going to need more than code to pull it off. You’re going to need people.”

Samuel nodded slowly, a flicker of determination in his eyes. “One step at a time. First, we test it. Then we grow it. And if it works—if it really works—maybe it’ll be enough to make people see the world differently.”

“And maybe,” Luna added with a grin, “you’ll finally get your hands on some decent hash.”

The three of them laughed, the tension breaking as the night carried on, their conversation drifting between the absurd and the profound. But for Samuel, the thought lingered: *This isn’t just code. This is liberation.*

Samuel leaned forward, his elbows resting on his knees, a mischievous glint in his eye. “You know,” he said, lowering his voice as though sharing a secret, “we’re thinking too small.”

Luna raised an eyebrow, passing the dwindling joint to Fergus. “Small? You just pitched a decentralized marketplace that could topple the likes of Amazon. What’s small about that?”

Samuel smirked, running a hand through his unkempt hair. “I mean *small-scale*. Like, we’re talking about art and farm produce, but let’s face it—what do people really want on the darknet?”

Fergus snorted, leaning back in his chair. “Drugs. That’s what you’re getting at, right?”

Samuel snapped his fingers, pointing at Fergus. “Exactly. Drugs. They’re already doing it out there, right? Silk Road, Evolution—all those markets. They’re all centralized. They’ve got admins who can get busted, servers that can get seized. It’s a single point of failure. What if we took *Lattice* and made it the backbone for a new kind of darknet marketplace? Decentralized. Fully peer-to-peer.”

Luna narrowed her eyes, intrigued but cautious. “You’re saying we set up our own market?”

“Not just *a* market,” Samuel said, his voice rising with excitement. “*The* market. Like an Amazon of the darknet. Not just an Etsy for artisans—this would be massive. People could trade anything. We could even start it ourselves. Buy from other darknet vendors, build up a stock, and use it to launch the platform. Then, once it's running, let others join in."

Fergus let out a low whistle, shaking his head. "Mate, that's... ambitious. And illegal as hell."

"Yeah," Luna added, her tone measured. "You're talking about dealing drugs on a massive scale. You know what happens to people who try to pull that off?"

Samuel leaned back, unfazed. "That's the beauty of it. The way I'm designing *Lattice*, there's no admin. No central hub. No one to arrest or interrogate. Every user is a node. Every transaction is encrypted and obfuscated. Even if they take down one person, the network keeps going."

Fergus tapped his fingers on the armrest, thinking. "Alright, tech wizard, but what about trust? Why would people use this over the sites that already exist?"

Samuel grinned, clearly prepared for this question. "Because it's safer. No middlemen taking a cut or running off with everyone's Bitcoin. No admins to snitch or screw up security. Every transaction is between buyer and seller. Direct. Transparent. And we'll integrate reputation systems—verified reviews, escrow payments. It's trustless, but it builds trust."

Luna exhaled slowly, passing the joint back to Samuel. "You've thought this through."

"Of course I have," he said, taking a small hit before setting it down in an ashtray. "This isn't just about making money. It's about showing people what's possible. How to take back control. Drugs are just the entry point—it's what gets people interested. But once they're on the platform, they'll realize they can do anything. Trade, communicate, organize—all without anyone watching over their shoulder."

"And the investment?" Fergus asked. "You said we'd need to buy stock. Where's that money coming from?"

Samuel leaned back, tapping his temple. "That's where it gets tricky. But think about it—once we've got a little momentum, we don't need to handle stock ourselves. Other vendors will see the opportunity and join in. All we need is enough to kickstart it."

Luna crossed her arms, a wry smile on her lips. "And how do you propose we kickstart it? Rob a bank?"

Samuel leaned forward, his elbows on his knees, his eyes scanning the room. "We don't need to rob a bank," he said, his voice steady but carrying a faint edge of resolve. "We'll borrow some money from my family."

Luna arched an eyebrow, skeptical. "Your family? The Ashcombes? Aren't they all... I don't know, pretty straight-laced?"

"They've funded crazier ideas," Samuel replied. "I just won't tell them its for this, I'll say its for something else. It's not like nobody's ever lied to their parents before."

Luna's face remained skeptical, though curiosity flickered in her eyes. "And you're sure you can handle the tech side of this? This isn't just throwing up a website. A blockchain-based marketplace? That's next-level."

Samuel nodded slowly, rubbing his jaw. “It’s going to be tricky, no doubt. I can handle the coding. I’ve already got the framework in mind—using blockchain encryption to anonymize transactions and keep everything decentralized. But the hard part will be moderation.”

“Moderation?” Fergus echoed. “What, like a customer service team for drug dealers?”

Samuel chuckled, shaking his head. “Not quite. But we’ll need a system to keep things running smoothly. Make sure people don’t get ripped off, disputes get resolved, the market doesn’t get flooded with garbage. On a centralized platform, you’d have admins for that. But with this... it has to be automated.”

“Like reputation scores?” Luna suggested.

“Exactly,” Samuel said, snapping his fingers. “Reputation tied to wallets. Buyers and sellers rate each other after every transaction, and the system rewards trustworthy behaviour. It’s self-policing. But it’s not perfect. There’s always the risk of scammers finding a way in. That’s where it gets messy.”

“And if someone sells something... bad?” Fergus asked hesitantly.

Samuel’s grin faded, replaced by a thoughtful expression. “That’s the ethical question, isn’t it? Do we intervene? Or do we let the market govern itself? I’m leaning toward the latter. No middlemen, no gatekeepers. People have to take responsibility for their own actions. That’s the whole point of this—freedom. Liberation from control.”

“Yeah, but freedom has consequences,” Luna pointed out, her tone sharp. “You’re talking about a system where anything goes. You ready to live with that?”

Samuel met her gaze, his expression unwavering. “Freedom isn’t clean. It’s messy. But it’s better than the alternative. If we do this right, we’re not just building a marketplace. We’re building a model for how people can live without relying on the state. Without asking for permission.”

The room fell silent for a moment, the weight of his words sinking in. Finally, Luna sighed, shaking her head. “You’ve got a lot to figure out, Sam. But if you can pull it off...”

Samuel leaned back, a faint smile playing on his lips. “If I can pull it off, we’ll have done something no one’s ever done before. We’ll have built something they can’t control.”

Samuel sat at his desk in the dimly lit flat, the glow of his monitor casting sharp shadows on the walls. Bramall Lane’s quiet hum of distant traffic buzzed faintly outside, but his focus was laser-sharp. A half-smoked joint sat in an ashtray next to him, curling a lazy tendril of smoke into the room. The planning phase was over—now it was time to start mapping out the architecture of the marketplace.

He opened his notebook, flipping past sketches of decentralized nodes, encryption algorithms, and pseudonymous wallet designs. Each page was filled with diagrams and snippets of code. This wasn’t just a website—it was a fortress.

Samuel leaned back in his chair and cracked his knuckles.
“Alright,” he muttered to himself, “this isn’t your average site.”

The marketplace would operate entirely over **TOR**, the anonymizing onion routing network. No centralized servers, no single point of failure. TOR would mask IP addresses, making it virtually impossible to trace buyers, sellers, or even the site itself. Every interaction would be encrypted end-to-end, ensuring privacy at every level.

Samuel typed furiously:

"From the cryptography hazmat primitives, import RSA for asymmetric key generation and serialization.

Generate a private key using RSA, with a public exponent of sixty-five thousand, five hundred and thirty-seven, and a key size of two thousand and forty-eight bits.

Convert the key to a PEM format using traditional OpenSSL encoding, with no encryption.

Open a file named 'private_key dot P E M' in write binary mode, and save the key to this file.

Print 'Key generated for TOR service'."

The script would generate the private key for the TOR onion address. Once deployed, the marketplace would only be accessible via a .onion URL, adding an extra layer of security.

“No logins,” Samuel muttered, shaking his head. “No emails. Nothing they can track.”

Instead, users would be identified solely by their **public keys**, generated locally on their devices. Each key pair would be tied to their transactions but not to any identifying information.

Samuel began sketching a flow diagram:

- New users generate a local key pair.
- The public key is uploaded to the marketplace to create a pseudonymous ID.
- Private keys remain on the user’s device, never touching the site.

Bitcoin was the lifeblood of the marketplace. Samuel planned to leverage multi-signature wallets to ensure trust between buyers and sellers.

- Each transaction would involve three keys: the buyer, the seller, and the marketplace.
- Funds would be released only when two out of three parties signed off—either the buyer and seller, or the seller and the marketplace in the event of a dispute.

He scrawled a note in the margin of his notebook:
“Keep it simple, Sam. Complexity is a weakness.”

Samuel was stuck on this part. How do you moderate a marketplace without becoming a gatekeeper?
He sketched a reputation system:

- Buyers and sellers rate each other after every transaction.
- Reputation scores are immutable and stored on the blockchain.
- Poor reputations would naturally weed out bad actors.

But what about disputes? He considered a decentralized arbitration system, where users could volunteer as mediators and earn a small fee for resolving conflicts.
“Let the community handle it,” he thought. “Self-governance.”

The site itself would be stripped down and utilitarian. No flashy graphics, no unnecessary code. It had to be fast, lightweight, and easy to navigate even for a first-time user.
Samuel opened a text editor and started outlining the HTML structure:

"HTML5 document for DarkMarket.

Head section with title 'DarkMarket' and a linked style sheet.

Body contains a header with the site name 'DarkMarket' and the tagline 'Freedom at your fingertips.'

A search section with a text input field for searching products and a submit button.

A second section with an ID of 'listings', which is commented to indicate that product listings will be dynamically loaded here.

The document closes with closing body and HTML tags."

The homepage would be simple: a search bar, product categories, and listings. Everything else would be handled dynamically with JavaScript pulling data from the backend over encrypted TOR connections.

Samuel lit the joint again, taking a slow drag. The idea of coding a marketplace that could host anything—not just drugs—felt intoxicating. The thought of decentralizing commerce entirely was thrilling. This was agorism in action, a thumb in the eye of state control.

He imagined the possibilities:

- Farmers selling produce directly to consumers.
- Artists selling their work without gallery fees.
- Independent creators liberated from middlemen.

But first, he needed a test run. A small batch of products—just enough to get the ball rolling.
He opened a new file and began drafting a message to his darknet contacts:

> "Looking for a reliable source to test a new marketplace platform. Willing to pay upfront in Bitcoin for a small, diverse stockpile of products. Serious inquiries only."

He hit save and leaned back, the joint smouldering in his fingers.
“Alright,” he said to himself. “Let’s see if this thing can fly.”

The following week was a whirlwind of activity as Samuel dove deeper into preparations for the marketplace's test phase. His flat in Sheffield, already cluttered with hardware and cables, now looked like a hacker's dream—or a government investigator's worst nightmare. Empty coffee cups and crumpled notes littered the desk, while the soft hum of servers filled the air.

Samuel knew that to ensure complete anonymity and security, he needed to isolate the marketplace from his personal system. He pulled out an old, dusty laptop from under his bed—a cheap, unbranded machine he’d once bought at a pawnshop. Wiping the drive, he installed a minimal Linux distribution and configured it to run through TOR by default.

He set up the backend server:

1. **TOR Hidden Service**: The marketplace’s `.onion` address would be the gateway to the site.
2. **Encrypted Communication**: All messages and transactions would be encrypted using OpenPGP keys, ensuring no plaintext data could ever be intercepted.

3. **Database Design**: Samuel opted for a lightweight, encrypted database to store listings and transaction metadata, ensuring even in the unlikely event of a raid, no usable data would be accessible.

He typed rapidly into the terminal, deploying the basic structure of the server:

"System commands to install and configure TOR.

First, update package lists and install TOR.

Configure a hidden service by:

- Setting hidden service directory
- Mapping service port
- Restarting TOR service

Finally, display the generated onion address."

Moments later, the terminal spat out the `.onion` address. Samuel grinned. The marketplace now had a door, even if there was no house behind it yet.

Samuel's darknet connections responded quickly to his message. After some careful vetting, he finalized deals with two suppliers:

- **Supplier A**: A small-time dealer offering a variety of recreational drugs in professional packaging—ecstasy, LSD, Ket, Coke, Flower and a few grams of hash.
- **Supplier B**: A wholesaler selling generic items like vapes, supplements, and herbal remedies, providing the diversity needed to make the marketplace look legitimate.

The Bitcoin transactions were processed through a series of mixers and tumblers to obscure the origin of the funds. The shipments were on their way, routed through a network of PO boxes and drop spots.

"Step one: inventory," Samuel muttered, marking the task off his mental checklist.

The day the first shipment arrived, Samuel felt a jolt of excitement. Packages came in plain brown envelopes, inconspicuous and anonymous. He inspected the contents—small vacuum-sealed packets of colourful pills, blotter paper sheets, and the sticky, earthy hash he had been craving.

He uploaded the listings to the site:

1. Product name
2. Description (typed with just enough flair to attract buyers without over promising)
3. Price in Bitcoin
4. A photo snapped with his phone, carefully edited to remove metadata

The site began to take shape. Each listing displayed a sleek, minimalist card with options to buy, leave reviews, or message the seller (all encrypted, of course).

Samuel ran a simulated transaction:

- He created a buyer account using a test public key.
- Added an item to the cart.
- Paid with a small Bitcoin amount from a wallet he'd set up for testing.

The funds moved seamlessly into the multisig wallet, and the order was marked as “Pending Shipment.”

It was working.

As the evening wore on, Samuel and his friends gathered around again. Luna lit a joint, passing it to Samuel. He took a hit, savouring the smoothness of the hash.
“This is it, Sam,” Luna said, exhaling a cloud of smoke. “We’re officially slinging hash… both kinds.”

Samuel smirked and opened his laptop. He pulled up the site on TOR and scrolled through the listings. “We’re not just selling. We’re building. This is about creating a system where no one’s in charge but the people using it.”

“And making some serious Bitcoin in the process,” added another friend, leaning back in the worn-out couch.

“Sure,” Samuel said. “But it’s more than that. This is freedom. No middlemen. No borders. No banks. Just pure, unregulated trade. If they don’t want to trust us, fine—they trust the code.”

The hash had mellowed him out, but his mind was racing. He was already thinking of ways to improve the system:

- **Escrow Services**: For higher-priced items, buyers could deposit funds into an automated escrow that released payment only upon confirmation of delivery.
- **Decentralized Hosting**: He sketched plans for a future version of the site that wouldn’t rely on his server at all, instead running on a distributed network like IPFS (InterPlanetary File System).

After a few more days of tweaking and troubleshooting, Samuel decided it was time to open the site to a small group of real users. He posted the `.onion` link on a few select darknet forums, advertising the marketplace as a “trustless, decentralized revolution in online commerce.”

Samuel spent his days in a haze of productivity, the air in his flat perpetually filled with the smell of weed and the low hum of servers. Luna had moved into a spare room temporarily, offering her graphic design skills to make the interface of the marketplace not just functional but visually striking.

“Keep it minimalist, though,” Samuel said one evening as he leaned over her shoulder, watching her create a dark, sleek theme for the site. “We’re not Etsy or eBay. This is... raw. Honest.”

“Don’t worry,” she replied, clicking through colour palettes and layouts. “It’ll look sharp enough to feel professional but sketchy enough to feel underground. Trust me, I know the vibe.”

The marketplace now had an official name: **Obsidian Exchange**.

Samuel spent hours tweaking the backend, preparing for the influx of users. His primary focus was creating trust without oversight—a system where buyers and sellers felt secure without any human moderation. The code had to be flawless.

Late one night, Luna joined Samuel at his workstation, placing a cup of instant coffee next to him. “How are you going to handle the moderation thing?” she asked.

Samuel rubbed his eyes, staring at the screen. “It’s tricky,” he admitted. “We need some form of dispute resolution. But I can’t play judge, jury, and executioner—that’s too centralized.”

He had been exploring options and decided on a bold approach:

1. **Reputation System**: Sellers and buyers would earn ratings and reviews. The higher their score, the more trust they commanded.
2. **Peer Arbitration**: Disputes could be submitted to a pool of randomly selected users who would vote on the outcome.
3. **Code-Driven Transparency**: All decisions and actions on the marketplace would be logged and publicly viewable, though anonymized, to maintain accountability.

“Think of it like a DAO,” Samuel explained to Luna. “Decentralized Autonomous Organization. Instead of moderators, we have the community deciding. The code handles everything—no one’s in charge, not even me.”

“Sounds idealistic,” Luna said, lighting a joint. “But it’s kind of beautiful, too. Like... anarchism in action.”

Samuel smirked, taking the joint from her. “Exactly. No rulers. Just rules.”

The next phase was risky: running live tests of the marketplace’s new features. Samuel created fake accounts to simulate disputes, sending Luna a smirk as he opened a chat window.

Seller01: *Buyer hasn’t confirmed delivery, but the funds are locked. What do I do?*
Buyer01: *Item didn’t arrive. I want a refund.*

Samuel injected the dispute into the arbitration system. Within seconds, the system randomly selected five test accounts to vote. The accounts received the evidence—a set of pre-generated messages and images—and voted on a resolution.

The funds were released to the buyer after three out of five votes supported their claim.

“It works,” Samuel said, exhaling a cloud of smoke. “Decisions are fast, fair, and no one can manipulate the process.”

“Okay, genius,” Luna said, leaning back on the couch. “But what if someone tries to game the system? Like creating fake accounts to sway votes?”

“I’ve thought about that,” Samuel replied. “The arbitration pool is limited to accounts with a high reputation score. And to build reputation, you need to complete verified transactions. It’s self-regulating.”

Luna nodded, impressed. “So... when do we start making money?”

Samuel grinned. “We already are.”

The official launch of Obsidian Exchange came on a cold January evening as a storm raged through the hills of Sheffield, the winds of change were blowing through cyberspace. Samuel and Luna celebrated with cheap whiskey at the Rutland, and then had a boogie at the Washington and went back to theirs, a greasy takeaway in hand, sitting on the floor of the flat as they watched the site go live.

Samuel stared at the screen, a mix of pride and anxiety bubbling in his chest. “It’s happening,” he murmured.

Luna leaned against him, smiling. “You did it, Sam. You built something real.”

But Samuel wasn’t smiling. His mind was already racing ahead, thinking about the implications of what they had unleashed.

That night, unable to sleep, Samuel sat alone at his desk, staring at the code that had become his life. He thought about the philosophy behind Obsidian Exchange—the idea of decentralization, of removing power from institutions and putting it into the hands of individuals.

He opened his notebook, scribbling down thoughts in messy handwriting:

- *Power corrupts; decentralization frees.*
- *Trust no one; trust the code.*
- *Freedom isn’t granted—it’s taken.*

He thought about his family’s legacy, the Ashcombe name that had once been synonymous with banking and power. He was carving a new path—one that didn’t bow to the state, the banks, or the corporations.

“This is only the beginning,” Samuel whispered to himself, the glow of his screen casting shadows across the room. “The system doesn’t work for us anymore. So we’ll build our own.”

Samuel stared at the site stats late one night, the glow of the monitor illuminating his tired face. Luna sat nearby, watching him with a curious expression. “So, what’s next?” she asked.

Samuel leaned back, a satisfied smile creeping across his face. “Next, we scale. More products, more sellers, better code. This is just the beginning, Luna. We’re building the future, one line of code at a time.”

Chapter 17:

Samuel’s flat smelled faintly of weed and packaging glue. The living room had been transformed into a makeshift workshop, with scales, vacuum sealers, and piles of padded envelopes scattered across the table. The ashtray in the corner was overflowing, and a half-eaten pizza box rested precariously on a chair.

Luna sat cross-legged on the floor, carefully measuring out grams of MDMA crystals into small resealable bags. She had her headphones on, nodding slightly to a playlist of minimal techno as she worked. Across from her, Samuel was meticulously writing addresses on envelopes, his handwriting sharp and deliberate.

“Hand me the stamps, will you?” Samuel said, his voice low and focused.

One of their friends, Steve, tossed a roll of stamps onto the table without looking up from his task of double-checking the orders. “We’re gonna need more stamps soon,” he said, glancing at the pile of outgoing packages.

Luna pulled her headphones down around her neck and grinned. “You should’ve seen the guy at the post office last time. He gave me the weirdest look when I bought a hundred first-class stamps.”

Samuel smirked, sealing an envelope with care. “I’m surprised he didn’t call the cops.”

“Yeah,” Luna replied, leaning back and stretching. “We’ll have to order them off the internet next time. I’m not risking that again.”

This was their life now—a mix of grinding work and quiet rebellion. Every morning, they'd wake up, log into the Obsidian Exchange dashboard, and download the day's orders. Then they'd spend hours sorting, packing, and preparing the shipments.

It wasn't glamorous, but it was methodical, almost meditative.

Luna picked up another bag, holding it up to the light to check for imperfections. "You ever think about scaling up, Sam?"

Samuel paused mid-stamp, his brow furrowed. "Scaling up how?"

"I mean, like... hiring people. Or finding a better space. We're gonna outgrow this flat eventually."

Steve nodded. "She's right. If this keeps up, we're gonna need a proper operation."

Samuel leaned back in his chair, tapping the pen against his knee. "It's not about growth," he said. "Not yet, anyway. We keep it tight, keep it small. The more people we bring in, the more risk we take on."

"Fair," Luna said, but her expression was sceptical.

As the afternoon stretched on, the group worked in companionable silence, occasionally breaking it with jokes or comments about the orders.

Samuel was in his element, focused and determined. Every package they sent out felt like a small victory—a quiet act of defiance against a system he no longer believed in.

He glanced at the stack of finished orders and smiled to himself. This wasn't just about money. It was about creating something outside the grasp of the state and its endless rules.

"Alright," he said, standing up and stretching. "Who's coming with me to the post office?"

The post office run had become a ritual of sorts. Samuel and Luna would load the envelopes into a cheap backpack, walk the fifteen minutes to the nearest post box, and casually drop the packages in batches.

As they walked, Luna lit a joint and passed it to Samuel.

"Think they'll ever figure it out?" she asked, exhaling a thin stream of smoke.

Samuel shook his head, taking a drag. "Not unless we screw up. And we're not going to screw up."

The flat was no longer just a workspace; it was a distribution hub. Packages of all shapes and sizes filled every available surface. Cardboard boxes from Amazon were stacked high against one wall, filled with bubble wrap, padded envelopes, and resealable bags. The small living room table, once just a spot for pizza and beers, was now a cluttered workstation, overflowing with drugs, scales, and labels.

Luna sat on the floor, her back against the couch, scribbling down the day's to-do list on a scrap of paper.

"We need more packing tape," she muttered, glancing up at Samuel, who was hunched over his laptop. "And we're running low on bubble mailers again. I just ordered a hundred last week."

Samuel didn't look up. His fingers flew across the keyboard as he updated the Obsidian Exchange's dashboard.

“We’re shipping out more than I thought we would,” he replied. “It’s a good problem to have. Malik’s picking up a bulk order from the darknet supplier tonight. That’ll hold us for another week, maybe two.”

Luna raised an eyebrow. “And what about the post boxes? We’ve already hit the limits on the ones around here. The post office lady’s starting to give me weird looks.”

Samuel sighed, leaning back in his chair. “We’ll have to spread it out more. Hit the bigger boxes around town. The post boxes near the bus station. Meadowhall has a few, actually I think the main sorting office is on the way so you can drop some off there.”

“You’re joking, right?” Luna said, laughing. “That’s a journey.”

Samuel smirked. “Welcome to logistics.”

The days blurred into a relentless cycle. Wake up, check the orders, pack the drugs, ship them out, and repeat.

By now, other sellers had started using the Obsidian Exchange to peddle their wares. The platform was growing faster than Samuel had anticipated. New listings popped up daily—everything from ecstasy to psychedelics to weed brownies. Each new vendor meant more packages to ship and more work for the group.

The postman had started making daily deliveries of small, unassuming parcels from darknet suppliers, each one discreetly labelled and tightly sealed.

“Morning,” the postman said, handing Samuel a stack of padded envelopes one morning.

“Cheers, mate,” Samuel replied, trying not to look guilty as he took the parcels inside.

Inside, Luna was already at work, weighing out grams of ketamine and bagging them neatly. Steve was carefully inspecting a bulk shipment of LSD blotters that had arrived the day before.

“We’re gonna need more scales,” Luna said, not looking up from her work. “The cheap ones keep crapping out, and the vacuum sealed bags.”

Samuel nodded, adding it to the growing list of supplies they needed to order.

The post runs had become increasingly complicated. They could no longer rely on the small post boxes near the flat. Those filled up too quickly, and they couldn’t risk drawing attention by overstuffing them.

Instead, they devised a route that took them across Sheffield, hitting the larger post boxes in strategic locations.

“Alright,” Samuel said one afternoon, pulling up a map on his phone. “We’ll start with the box on near the Penny Black, then hit the one near the main sorting office. That’s on the way to Meadowhall.”

“Sounds like a bloody marathon,” Steve grumbled, stuffing a backpack full of envelopes.

“It is,” Samuel replied, slinging another bag over his shoulder. “But it’s what we’ve got to do.”

They split into pairs, each taking a different route through the city. By the end of the day, they’d dropped off dozens of packages, their boots now empty but their pockets full of possibility.

One evening, as they sat around the table packing orders, Luna glanced at Samuel.

“You ever think about how big this is getting?” she asked.

Samuel paused, looking up from his laptop. “What do you mean?”

“I mean... it’s not just us anymore. There are other sellers, other people depending on this platform. It’s not just a side hustle. It’s... bigger.”

Samuel nodded slowly, the weight of her words sinking in.

“It’s what we wanted,” he said finally. “A marketplace, decentralized, untouchable. A place where anyone can sell, buy, and exist outside the system. But yeah... it’s big.”

Luna leaned back, her expression thoughtful. “It’s more than big, Sam. It’s a monster. And we’re the ones feeding it.”

Samuel didn’t reply. Instead, he turned back to his laptop, his fingers hovering over the keyboard. The Obsidian Exchange was growing faster than he’d ever imagined, and there was no turning back now.

The Obsidian Exchange was no longer just an experiment or a side hustle—it was becoming a phenomenon. Samuel sat in his small, cramped flat near Bramall Lane, the room buzzing with the hum of his laptop. The interface for the site was slicker now, thanks to weeks of work perfecting the backend. It was modular, elegant, and above all, secure. The decentralized architecture was doing exactly what Samuel had envisioned: distributing risk and control across the network in a way that no central authority could ever hope to dismantle.

The buzz around the site had started small, as whispers on niche darknet forums, but it had exploded in the last month. Reddit threads on hidden subreddits dissected its design with awe. Anonymous users on 4chan called it “next-level stuff,” marvelling at its seamless user experience and the anonymity it afforded. Unlike the clunky, outdated marketplaces that had preceded it, the Obsidian Exchange felt like the future.

For Samuel, the attention was both thrilling and terrifying.

Sitting at the table, surrounded by the usual chaos of envelopes, drugs, and labels, Samuel addressed the group. Luna was there, as always, along with Steve and a few new faces—local friends Samuel had convinced to help manage the ever-growing logistics.

“We can’t keep doing this all ourselves,” Samuel said, exhaling sharply as he pushed his chair back. “I mean, look around. We’re barely keeping up as it is.”

Steve glanced up from the scales. “What do you suggest? We hire staff?”

“Not exactly,” Samuel replied, leaning forward. “We expand the seller network. We’ve already got a few other vendors on the platform, right? We start bringing more of them in. Make this thing a proper ecosystem.”

Luna raised an eyebrow. “How do you plan on managing that? You’re already tied to your laptop 24/7 as it is.”

“That’s the beauty of it,” Samuel said, his eyes lighting up. “I’ve been working on a seller toolkit. It’s a decentralized module that’ll let vendors manage their own stock, shipments, and listings. The site will automate a lot of the admin work for us. All we'll need to do is vet new sellers and handle disputes when they come up."

"You're outsourcing logistics," Malik said, a slow grin spreading across his face.

"Exactly," Samuel replied. "And it frees me up to focus on the code—perfecting the backend, making sure it stays secure as we scale. This isn't just a market; it's a movement. We're showing people what's possible when you take power away from centralized authorities and give it back to individuals."

The decentralized nature of the site was drawing attention from all corners of the internet. The subreddit threads were filled with detailed analyses of its blockchain-powered dispute resolution system. On 4chan's /g/ board, users speculated about the encryption protocols Samuel had used to keep everything anonymous.

"This site's like nothing we've ever seen before," one Reddit user wrote. "It's not just another Silk Road clone—it's a revolution in darknet markets."

A Reddit post, titled *How Obsidian Is Changing the Game*, broke down the platform's key features:

1. **Decentralization:** By distributing hosting and data across multiple nodes, the site was almost impossible to take down.
2. **Smart Contracts:** Built-in dispute resolution ensured that transactions were fair, without requiring human intervention.
3. **Anonymity:** Advanced encryption and a mandatory TOR-based interface made it one of the most secure marketplaces on the darknet.

The attention was bringing more users—and more vendors—to the site. Samuel found himself inundated with messages from prospective sellers, all eager to join the platform.

With the seller toolkit up and running, Samuel's group transitioned from direct sellers to platform managers. They still handled a significant volume of orders themselves, but now the majority of the work came from onboarding new vendors and maintaining the site.

The flat became a hive of activity. One corner was dedicated to packing and shipping orders, while another housed Samuel's coding station. The others worked on vetting new sellers, scanning darknet forums for potential recruits, and fielding questions from users.

Every day, packages of drugs arrived from suppliers, which the group meticulously sorted, weighed, and repackaged for shipment. Every evening, they split into teams, taking backpacks full of orders to post boxes across Sheffield. They knew the routine so well now that it was almost automatic.

But with the success came new challenges.

"We're gonna need a bigger space," Luna said one evening as she looked around the crowded flat. "We can't keep doing this here. It's too risky."

Samuel nodded. "I've been thinking the same thing. But it's not just about space—it's about security. We need somewhere we can disappear if we have to. This thing's getting too big to stay under the radar forever."

Late one night, long after the others had gone to bed, Samuel sat at his laptop, staring at the Obsidian dashboard. The site's user base was growing exponentially, and the revenue numbers were staggering. But Samuel wasn't thinking about the money.

He was thinking about what came next.

The Obsidian Exchange was a proof of concept—a demonstration of what could be achieved when you combined cutting-edge technology with radical ideas. But Samuel wasn't interested in stopping here.

He opened a new document on his laptop and began sketching out plans for the next phase. A truly decentralized marketplace, powered entirely by smart contracts and blockchain technology. A platform so resilient that it could function without any centralized oversight, even if Samuel disappeared tomorrow.

The next morning, Samuel called a meeting.

"We need to move the operation out of here," he said bluntly, gesturing around the flat. "I can't focus with all this going on, and we're making too much money to keep running it like this."

Luna nodded. "I've been saying that for weeks. Steve and I found a place out near Meadowhall. It's perfect—big enough for packing and shipping, and no nosy neighbours."

"Good," Samuel said. "Get everything set up there. I'll help with the transition, but after that, you're on your own. I need to focus on the code."

Within days, the flat was transformed. The stacks of envelopes, scales, and shipping labels were gone, replaced by a minimalist workspace. Samuel's laptop sat on a desk surrounded by monitors, and the whiteboard was now covered with even more complex diagrams.

With the distraction of the drug business gone, Samuel threw himself into the project. He worked 16-hour days, fuelled by coffee, adrenaline, speed, and a burning desire to see his vision come to life.

The code grew more sophisticated by the day. The proof-of-work system was now fully integrated, allowing node operators to compete for transactions in a way that mirrored Bitcoin mining. The platform's interface was sleek and intuitive, designed to attract both seasoned darknet users and newcomers.

The decentralized nature of the platform was its greatest strength. Without a central server, there was no single point of failure. The marketplace could survive government crackdowns, cyberattacks, and even Samuel's own disappearance.

Samuel Ashcombe sat at his desk, surrounded by the quiet chaos of a flat still humming with the remnants of its former life as a drug-packing hub. The heavy scent of bud had dissipated, replaced by the faint metallic tang of electronics and burnt coffee. The others had moved the drug business to a rented storage unit on the outskirts of Sheffield, leaving Samuel to focus on what he'd been dreaming about for months: the next evolution of the Obsidian Exchange—a purely decentralized marketplace.

The current version of the platform was revolutionary, but it still relied on Samuel and his small group for hosting the backend infrastructure. It was time to change that. It was time to build something truly untouchable.

Samuel stared at the wall-sized whiteboard he'd mounted in the flat. It was covered in diagrams, equations, and hastily scrawled notes:

- **Distributed Proof-of-Work Protocol**
- **Revenue Fraction for Node Operators**
- **Anonymized Smart Contracts**
- **Onboarding Without Central Oversight**

The idea was simple in theory but a monumental challenge in practice. The new marketplace would use a proof-of-work system, similar to Bitcoin's blockchain, to incentivize users to host nodes. Each node operator would earn a small percentage of the platform's revenue, paid out in Bitcoin. This decentralized architecture would eliminate the need for a central server, making the site virtually impossible to shut down.

The brilliance of the design was its self-sustainability. As the marketplace grew, so would the number of node operators, ensuring the platform's stability and resilience.

But there were hurdles—massive ones.

"This is going to take months," Samuel muttered to himself, running a hand through his hair. The coding alone would require countless late nights, and the testing phase could easily stretch into years. But the vision was too compelling to ignore.

Meanwhile, the existing Obsidian Exchange was thriving. The team had become a well-oiled machine, handling logistics and onboarding new vendors while Samuel focused on the code.

"Samuel," Luna said one day, leaning into the flat with a smirk. "We cleared another five grand today. All in Bitcoin. You sure you don't want to keep some of this action for yourself?"

Samuel shook his head without looking up from his laptop. "You guys can keep on top of it. I've got bigger things to work on."

The orders continued to pour in, and the team worked tirelessly to keep up. Every morning, packages of drugs arrived from darknet suppliers. Every afternoon, they shipped out dozens of carefully packed envelopes to customers across the UK and beyond. And every evening, Samuel's flat buzzed with the sound of laughter, music, and the occasional argument over the best way to streamline their operations.

Late one night, Samuel sat alone in the flat. The others had left for the night, and the only sound was the faint hum of his laptop. He leaned back in his chair, staring at the screen.

The prototype for the new marketplace was coming together, line by line. He'd spent weeks writing the foundational code for the proof-of-work protocol, ensuring it was lightweight enough to run on low-powered machines while still maintaining the security and efficiency needed for a global network.

He opened a test environment on his laptop and began running simulations. The code was rough, but it worked. Each simulated node processed transactions, verified listings, and distributed revenue seamlessly.

Samuel smiled to himself. This was it—the future of commerce. A marketplace that was truly by the people, for the people.

Word of the new platform began to spread, even before its official launch. Hackers and tech enthusiasts on Reddit and 4chan dissected leaked snippets of Samuel's code, marvelling at its elegance and innovation.

"This is the future," one user wrote on a darknet forum. "Not just for marketplaces, but for everything. This guy is a genius."

Samuel brushed off the praise, focusing instead on the final stages of development. There were still bugs to fix, tests to run, and security measures to implement. But for the first time, he felt a sense of calm.

This was more than a project. It was a revolution.

As he uploaded the final lines of code to the test network, Samuel leaned back in his chair and lit a cigarette. The Obsidian Exchange 2.0 wasn't just a dream anymore—it was real. And soon, the world would see what was possible when technology was used not to control people, but to set them free.

The flat was silent, save for the rhythmic tapping of keys as Samuel made the final adjustments. The screen flickered, and a message appeared:

Welcome to the Obsidian Exchange. Decentralized. Untouchable. Free.

The day the new marketplace—Obsidian Exchange 2.0—went live, the flat near Bramall Lane was quieter than usual. Samuel sat at his desk, surrounded by monitors displaying lines of code, transaction logs, and the first trickle of activity from the new network. Steve and Luna were there too, perched on the sofa with beers in hand, watching him with a mix of awe and apprehension.

The launch had been months in the making, and now it was finally happening. The proof-of-work system was fully operational, with node operators from around the world already connecting to the network. Vendors were signing up by the dozens, lured by the promise of low fees, unparalleled security, and the freedom to sell without fear of centralized oversight.

Samuel hit enter on his keyboard, and the site officially went live.

Welcome to the Obsidian Exchange

The message blinked on the screen, simple and unassuming. But behind it was a revolution in commerce.

Within hours, the first transactions started rolling in. Vendors listed everything from high-grade cannabis to designer psychedelics, rare books, custom electronics, and even hand-forged knives. Buyers flocked to the site, their trust in its decentralization bolstered by its reputation on darknet forums.

Steve leaned over Samuel's shoulder, watching as the numbers ticked upward. "How much is that so far?" he asked, pointing to the growing revenue counter on the screen.

Samuel clicked a few keys, converting the Bitcoin totals into pounds. "About 3 BTC so far," he said.

Luna raised an eyebrow. "That's, what, six grand at today's prices?"

Samuel nodded. Bitcoin was hovering around £2,000 per coin, but he knew it wouldn't stay there for long. The market had been on an upward trajectory for months, and every transaction on the Obsidian Exchange was earning them a cut in Bitcoin.

By the end of the first week, the site had processed over 50 Bitcoin in transactions. Their cut—1% of every transaction—had netted them 0.5 BTC. At current prices, that was £1,000. It wasn't much compared to the old drug business, but this was just the beginning.

"This is scalable," Samuel said one night, pacing the room as Luna and Steve watched him. "The more people use the site, the more Bitcoin we earn. And when Bitcoin hits £10,000—or £20,000—we'll be sitting on a fortune."

Steve grinned, taking a sip of his beer. "It's already a fortune. We're earning money out of thin air, Sam. Purely through code."

Samuel stopped pacing and turned to face him. "It's not just code," he said. "It's trust. It's freedom. People are using this because they're sick of being controlled—by banks, by governments, by corporations. This isn't just a marketplace. It's a way out."

By mid-2017, Bitcoin's price had started to climb rapidly. £2,000 became £3,000, then £4,000. Each jump sent waves of excitement through the flat. The marketplace's popularity was growing, and with it, their earnings.

One night, as they sat around the living room eating pizza and watching the Bitcoin price ticker on Samuel's laptop, Luna let out a low whistle.

"It's at £6,000," she said.

Steve nearly choked on his beer. "What? It was at £5,000 yesterday!"

Samuel smirked. "And it'll be at £10,000 before the end of the year," he said.

Luna shook her head in disbelief. "Do you even know how much we've made so far?"

Samuel pulled up the earnings log. The site had processed over 500 Bitcoin in transactions since its launch, earning them a 1% cut—5 BTC. At £6,000 per coin, that was £30,000.

"And that's just what we've earned directly," Samuel said, gesturing to the screen. "Most of our payments from the old market are still sitting in Bitcoin wallets. At this rate, they'll be worth millions."

Later that night, after Luna and Steve had left, Samuel sat alone in the flat. The quiet hum of his laptop was the only sound in the room. He opened a wallet file and stared at the balance: 35 BTC.

When they'd started, Bitcoin had been worth around £400. Now it was £6,000, and climbing fast. He thought back to the hours he'd spent coding, testing, and refining the Obsidian Exchange. All those sleepless nights, the arguments with Steve, the endless tweaks to the proof-of-work protocol—it had all been worth it.

By December 2017, Bitcoin mania was everywhere. The once-niche cryptocurrency had exploded into the mainstream, and Samuel's flat near Bramall Lane was ground zero for a revolution that was now raking in unimaginable sums.

The price of Bitcoin had surged past £10,000 in early November and was now flirting with £15,000 as the holiday season approached. Every refresh of the price ticker felt surreal. The numbers climbed higher and higher, a digital fever dream realized in real time.

The Obsidian Exchange had grown too. What had started as a small, niche marketplace was now a bustling hub for thousands of vendors and buyers. Word about its decentralized proof-of-work infrastructure had spread across Reddit, 4chan, and darknet forums, earning Samuel accolades as a pioneer of the next generation of marketplaces.

Sitting at his desk, Samuel watched the activity logs scroll across his screen. Thousands of transactions, millions of pounds in Bitcoin changing hands daily, and every single one earning them a fraction.

He leaned back in his chair and exhaled. “Seventy-five Bitcoin in revenue this month,” he muttered to himself. “That’s over a million quid.”

The team’s earnings had grown exponentially:

- **June 2017:** 5 BTC, worth £30,000.
- **September 2017:** 20 BTC, worth £120,000.
- **December 2017:** 75 BTC in a single month, now worth over £1.1 million.

Samuel knew their wallets held over 200 Bitcoin combined, which meant they were sitting on a stash worth upwards of £3 million—and that didn’t include the value of the Bitcoin they’d held from the earlier market days.

Despite the incredible success, the pressure was mounting. The flat was no longer the quiet coding sanctuary it had once been. Luna, Steve, and two other friends—Tommy and Ayesha—were now running a full-scale operation out of Samuel’s living room. The floor was littered with packing supplies, and the air smelled faintly of ink from the postage printer.

“Who’s got the latest vendor reports?” Luna asked, rifling through a stack of papers.

“I do,” Steve replied, dumping a box of padded envelopes onto the couch. “But I need you to finish these parcels first. They’ve got to be out by 4 p.m.”

Samuel barely registered the commotion. His focus was on the code. He was constantly refining the backend, ensuring the marketplace stayed robust, anonymous, and impenetrable. But even he couldn’t ignore the growing tension in the room.

“We need to move the packing operation,” Samuel said one evening, breaking his silence.

Luna looked up from her laptop. “What do you mean? Move it where?”

“Anywhere but here,” Samuel replied. “This flat is for coding. If we’re going to scale this, we need proper logistics. Rent a warehouse if you have to, but I can’t have boxes and envelopes piling up around me while I’m trying to work.”

Steve nodded in agreement. “He’s right. We’re outgrowing this place. The postman’s already looking at us funny with all the packages.”

Luna sighed but didn’t argue. She knew Samuel was right.

By mid-December, Bitcoin had hit £16,000, then £17,000. Each jump sent ripples of excitement through the flat. Luna checked their wallet balances one night and nearly dropped her beer.

“We’re sitting on 300 Bitcoin,” she said, her voice shaking.

Steve whistled. “That’s... what? Five million?”

“Closer to six,” Samuel corrected, not looking up from his screen.

Luna stared at him. “Does that not freak you out?”

Samuel shrugged. “It’s just numbers. Until we cash out, it’s all theoretical.”

Steve shook his head. “Mate, we’re millionaires. This isn’t theoretical. This is real.”

Samuel finally turned to face them. “What’s real is what we’re building. The money is just a byproduct. What matters is that this marketplace exists, that it works, and that it can’t be stopped.”

As Christmas approached, Samuel found himself alone in the flat one evening. The others had gone out to celebrate the latest price spike, but he’d stayed behind, staring at the glowing screen in front of him.

The marketplace was a success beyond anything he’d imagined. It was decentralized, anonymous, and thriving. Vendors and buyers from around the world were using it to exchange goods and services without interference from governments or corporations.

But as he stared at the Bitcoin ticker, now hovering at £18,000, he couldn’t shake a feeling of unease. The higher the price climbed, the more attention it would attract. And the more attention it attracted, the greater the risk.

Chapter 18:

By early 2018, the Obsidian Exchange was no longer just a niche project—it had become an unstoppable force. The marketplace was a self-sustaining machine, flourishing with activity as thousands of vendors and buyers operated within its encrypted ecosystem. Samuel had fine-tuned the code to perfection, and its decentralized proof-of-work infrastructure ensured that the platform ran seamlessly, distributed across a network of anonymous nodes. The more people used it, the stronger it became.

The revenue was staggering. The team’s wallets now held over 10**00 Bitcoin**, which at the current price of **£8,000 per BTC**, meant they were sitting on a treasure chest worth **£8 million**. And with the market still climbing, there was no telling how high their fortunes could soar.

Despite the success, Samuel had enforced strict operational security. The flat near Bramall Lane was a fortress of digital and physical precautions. Their internet traffic was routed exclusively through **TOR**, their communications encrypted with **PGP keys**, and no one**—not even close friends—**knew the full extent of what they were running.

The logistics operation had moved out of the flat, as Samuel had insisted, and now operated out of a rented storage unit on the outskirts of Sheffield. Luna and Steve coordinated the packing and shipping, using a rotating team of trusted friends to avoid drawing suspicion. Every envelope was meticulously packed, labelled, and dispatched to drop-off points across the city, ensuring no single postbox saw too much traffic.

Still, the team was growing uneasy. They’d become ghosts in their own city, always looking over their shoulders, always paranoid. Samuel’s flat was a safe haven, but even that felt precarious as the money piled up and their profiles grew within the darknet community.

One evening, the team gathered at the flat to discuss their next steps. The air was thick with smoke from a joint being passed around, the tension palpable as they debated their future.

“We can’t keep this up forever,” Steve said, exhaling a plume of smoke. “The bigger this gets, the more heat we’re gonna attract.”

Luna nodded, swirling the beer in her hand. “He’s right. We’ve been lucky so far, but all it takes is one mistake, one careless vendor or buyer, and the whole thing could come crashing down.”

Samuel leaned back in his chair, his face calm but his eyes intense. “The beauty of the system is that it doesn’t rely on us. The code runs itself. Vendors run their own nodes, buyers process their own transactions. We’re just facilitators at this point.”

“Facilitators who are making millions,” Luna said with a wry smile. “But it’s not just about the platform, Sam. It’s about us. How long can we keep living like this? Always looking over our shoulders?”

Samuel took a drag from the joint and passed it to Steve. “I’ve been thinking about that. We need to get out of the city.”

Steve raised an eyebrow. “What, like move somewhere else in Sheffield?”

“No,” Samuel replied, shaking his head. “Out of the city entirely. Somewhere remote. Somewhere we can disappear if we need to.”

“Like the Peak District?” Luna asked, her tone half-joking.

Samuel nodded. “Exactly like the Peaks. We could set up a base there, keep running things remotely. The market doesn’t need us here. As long as we’ve got a connection to the network, we’re good.”

The idea of moving to the countryside appealed to everyone. The city had become a pressure cooker, and the thought of wide-open spaces and fresh air was like a balm to their frayed nerves. They started discussing the logistics of the move—how they’d find a place, how they’d transfer operations without leaving a trace, how they’d ensure their safety.

But the conversation inevitably circled back to the market itself.

“We’re sitting on enough money to do whatever we want,” Luna said. “We could buy a place outright, set up solar panels, go completely off-grid.”

Steve nodded. “And the market keeps running. We let it grow on its own, keep the core team small, and rake in the profits.”

Samuel’s mind was already racing ahead, thinking about the next phase of the project. The Obsidian Exchange was more than just a marketplace—it was a proof of concept for a decentralized, self-sustaining economy. It was a middle finger to the systems of power that had failed his family for generations.

“We’ve built something incredible here,” he said, his voice steady but full of conviction. “Something that can’t be controlled or shut down. But if we’re going to keep it alive, we need to be smart. We need to protect ourselves.”

Luna leaned forward, her eyes locked on Samuel’s. “Then let’s do it. Let’s get out of here.”

Samuel nodded. “Alright. Let’s make it happen.”

By late winter 2018, the plan to leave Sheffield was no longer just an idea tossed around during late-night brainstorming sessions. It was a concrete mission. The group had agreed: the city was too hot, the risk too great. The Obsidian Exchange was flourishing, but their presence in Sheffield tethered them to a location that felt increasingly precarious.

The Peak District called to them, its vast, rugged landscapes offering the perfect balance of isolation and connectivity. Samuel had spent hours scouring property listings, maps, and forums, looking for the ideal spot. They needed somewhere far enough from prying eyes but still accessible enough to maintain their infrastructure.

Luna leaned over Samuel’s shoulder in the flat, her coffee steaming as she squinted at the screen. “That one looks good,” she said, pointing at a converted barn nestled in a valley near Edale.

“It’s too close to the train line,” Samuel said, zooming in on the map. “We want something off the beaten track. No hikers stumbling onto our property.”

Steve wandered in, a half-eaten sandwich in hand. “What about this one?” He slid his phone across the table, displaying a remote stone farmhouse tucked into the hills near Stanage Edge. “It’s got enough space for servers and a workshop. Plus, there’s no neighbours for miles.”

Samuel inspected it, his brow furrowed. “How’s the broadband out there?”

Steve shrugged. “Satellite’s an option. Not perfect, but good enough for redundancy.”

Luna grinned. “It’s got potential. Plenty of room for a greenhouse too, if we want to grow some of our own...you know.”

Samuel smirked. “I like it. Let’s book a viewing.”

With Bitcoin’s price now hovering around **£10,000 per coin**, their wallets were flush with the kind of wealth that gave them freedom. Samuel decided they’d cash out just enough to cover the property and initial setup costs—nothing that would raise suspicion, but enough to make the transition smooth.

The group convened in the flat’s living room, surrounded by laptops, papers, and empty takeaway containers.

“We’ll put the property in a trust,” Samuel said, pacing as he spoke. “Something that doesn’t tie it directly to us. Luna, can you look into the legal side?”

“Already on it,” Luna said, typing on her laptop. “We’ll route it through a shell company if we have to.”

Steve leaned back on the couch, exhaling a cloud of smoke. “And the infrastructure? What about power and internet?”

“Solar panels and a diesel generator as backup,” Samuel replied. “We’ll keep the server load distributed across the network, but we’ll need a core node on-site to manage everything. I’ll handle the setup.”

“Sounds expensive,” Steve said.

Samuel grinned. “We’ve got the money. And the market’s making more every day.”

The group worked tirelessly over the next few weeks, dividing tasks and ticking items off their checklist. Luna handled the legalities and logistics of purchasing the property. Steve coordinated the packing and moving of their operation. Samuel focused on designing the tech setup for their new headquarters, drawing up schematics for server racks, cooling systems, and solar arrays.

By early spring, the farmhouse near Stanage Edge was theirs. The transaction was smooth and quiet, thanks to Luna's careful planning. The group began the painstaking process of relocating, dismantling the logistics operation in Sheffield and transporting it piece by piece to their new base.

On one of their final nights in the city, the group gathered in the flat, surrounded by half-packed boxes and empty furniture. The atmosphere was bittersweet.

"This place served us well," Luna said, raising her glass. "But I won't miss it."

Steve laughed. "Speak for yourself. I'll miss Bramall Lane on match days."

Samuel smirked. "You can always stream the matches from the farmhouse."

They toasted to the next chapter, their excitement mingling with nerves. They were about to disappear into the Peaks, leaving behind the city that had been both a launchpad and a source of stress.

The drive to the farmhouse was surreal. The van was packed with servers, equipment, and personal belongings, winding its way through the rolling hills of the Peak District. When they arrived, the farmhouse was as beautiful and remote as they'd hoped—a fortress of stone and solitude, surrounded by nothing but open moors and sky.

Samuel stood in the doorway, surveying the space that would become their new headquarters. "This is it," he said, more to himself than anyone else.

Luna clapped him on the back. "Let's get to work."

The farmhouse was more than just a new headquarters—it was a statement. To live truly off-grid and to obscure their location from prying eyes, Samuel and the team worked methodically to transform the property into an untraceable fortress, blending old-world simplicity with cutting-edge technology.

The first task was obfuscation. Luna and Steve spearheaded this effort, poring over maps and satellite images.

"We can't stop satellites from seeing the farmhouse," Luna said, "but we can make it look uninteresting."

They scattered old farming equipment around the property to give it the appearance of an abandoned farm. On days when the weather was clear, they avoided running any visible machinery or hanging out in open spaces. Steve learned the patterns of satellites overhead and programmed alerts into their system to notify them of potential flyovers.

To further disguise their location, they rerouted all deliveries to distant drop-off points, carefully transporting goods to the property through a network of dirt tracks. The main road leading to the farmhouse was intentionally overgrown with bushes and brambles. A hidden gate disguised as part of the hedge provided access to the property.

“I doubt even hikers would think there’s anything here,” Steve remarked, leaning on the gate after they’d finished the camouflage work.

Samuel nodded. “Good. The less attention, the better.”

The farmhouse itself needed to blend into its surroundings. They painted the walls with a custom weathered grey-green hue, designed to mirror the tones of the surrounding landscape. Solar panels on the roof were coated with an anti-reflective film to prevent glare that might catch the eye of a passing drone or plane.

Steve designed a lattice of climbing plants—ivy, clematis, and honeysuckle—that would eventually engulf parts of the farmhouse, further concealing it from sight. Inside, blackout curtains were installed on every window to ensure no light escaped at night.

Energy independence was paramount. Samuel and Luna oversaw the installation of a sophisticated solar power system, complete with a bank of Tesla Powerwall batteries hidden in the basement. A backup diesel generator was installed but kept out of sight, surrounded by a soundproofed enclosure to muffle its noise.

Internet connectivity was the trickiest problem. They settled on a combination of satellite internet and mesh networking, bouncing signals across nodes they had discreetly placed in the surrounding area. The system ensured reliable access while making it nearly impossible to trace the origin of their connection.

“Anyone trying to track us will think we’re bouncing signals from five different locations,” Samuel explained to the group as they tested the setup.

The farmhouse’s interior was a blend of rustic charm and cutting-edge tech. The kitchen retained its original stone hearth, but the living spaces were dominated by server racks, monitors, and a tangle of cables. The basement became the nerve centre of the Obsidian Exchange, humming with the sound of servers.

Every room had been repurposed with a specific function in mind:

- **Living Quarters:** Basic but comfortable, with no unnecessary luxuries to attract attention.
- **Workstations:** High-powered laptops and custom-built desktops equipped with encrypted drives.
- **Surveillance Room:** Monitors displayed live feeds from cameras placed around the property, including thermal imaging to detect intruders at night.
- **Storage:** A secure room for cash, Bitcoin wallets, and emergency supplies.

“We’re building more than just a hideout,” Samuel said one evening as they installed the last of the equipment. “This is our home, our haven.”

As the site continued to flourish, Samuel realized that its decentralization had to extend beyond its code. The Obsidian Exchange needed to be more than a marketplace; it needed to be a community.

Samuel wrote new code that allowed for a form of governance within the marketplace. Sellers could stake a small percentage of their earnings in Bitcoin to gain voting rights, allowing them to propose and vote on changes to the platform. The code automatically implemented changes once they were approved by a majority.

“It’s like a DAO,” Samuel explained to Luna. “A decentralized autonomous organization. No single person controls it—not even us.”

Luna frowned. “What if someone proposes something dangerous?”

Samuel shrugged. “That’s the risk of freedom. But the system is resilient. If the collective steers it off course, it’ll adapt or die. Just like anything else.”

“Trust is the currency here,” Samuel said. “Not Bitcoin. That’s just the means.”

The marketplace’s reputation spread far beyond the darknet. Discussions popped up on Reddit, 4chan, and obscure forums frequented by cryptographers, libertarians, and hackers. The marketplace’s decentralization and anonymity set it apart from competitors, and its low fees attracted a steady stream of new users.

“I saw someone call it the ‘Amazon of the Darknet’,” Steve said one evening, scrolling through his phone. “That’s gotta feel good, right?”

Samuel smirked. “It’s a start.”

By the time spring turned into summer, the group was fully settled in their Peak District hideout. The marketplace was thriving, and their off-grid lifestyle had become second nature.

The group’s new life in the Peak District settled into a rhythm, but the stakes of their operation cast a long shadow over everything they did. Every action, every shipment, every line of code felt like walking a razor’s edge.

The Obsidian Exchange was now processing thousands of transactions weekly. Sellers from across the globe were listing products, from artisanal psychedelics to rare and experimental research chemicals. Bitcoin wallets swelled with the marketplace’s share of revenue, and the governance system was gaining momentum as users proposed and voted on features, including multilingual support and encrypted chatrooms.

Samuel’s coding focus shifted to scaling. The site needed to handle its ever-growing user base without compromising speed or security.

“We’re running at capacity,” he said one evening, staring at the monitor’s network logs. “We’ll need to upgrade the server nodes.”

Steve, lounging nearby with a joint in hand, nodded. “You’ve got the funds. Go big. Spin up some offshore nodes. Maybe Russia. Or Africa.”

Samuel sighed. “The nodes aren’t the issue. The bigger we get, the harder it is to stay invisible.”

Luna looked up from her laptop. “So make invisibility the feature. Layer it into the marketplace. Teach the users to hide as well as we do.”

Samuel paused, considering her words. He smiled. “You’re right. The more invisible we are, the harder it is for anyone to stop us.”

Over the following weeks, Samuel rolled out a suite of privacy-focused tools:

- **Onboarding Tutorials:** Step-by-step guides teaching users how to access the marketplace securely, use Bitcoin mixers, and anonymize their activity.

- **Encrypted Communications:** A messaging system that auto-deleted messages after 48 hours, with no data stored on the servers.
- **Peer-to-Peer Options:** Sellers could now host their own nodes, further decentralizing the platform and distributing risk.

The marketplace was no longer just a business. It was a movement, a decentralized network built on trust, privacy, and defiance.

Though Samuel had delegated much of the physical logistics, he couldn't completely avoid the daily grind of orders. The farmhouse's basement was converted into a fully operational shipping centre.

The group worked in assembly-line precision, measuring, packing, and labelling orders. On a typical day, they handled hundreds of parcels, each discreetly wrapped and labelled as mundane items—books, art supplies, or generic electronics.

"We're like Santa's elves," Luna joked one afternoon, sealing an envelope with a block of hash.

"Santa doesn't make this much money," Steve quipped, holding up a ledger of their Bitcoin wallet balances.

The parcels were distributed across various drop-off points, from rural post boxes to urban depots. They learned to stagger their trips, using different routes and vehicles to avoid drawing attention.

"Keep them guessing," Samuel reminded the group during their planning sessions. "Never use the same post box twice in a week."

Living off-grid had its perks, but the isolation was beginning to wear on them. Samuel, especially, felt the strain. While Luna and Steve handled the physical side of the operation, he spent most of his days at his workstation, refining code and monitoring the marketplace.

The endless vigilance took a toll. He began sleeping in short bursts, waking every few hours to check the servers. Paranoia crept into his thoughts—what if someone in the community betrayed them? What if a user slipped up and brought heat to the platform?

"You need a break," Luna said one evening, placing a hand on his shoulder. "We've got a good thing going. Trust the system."

Samuel nodded, but he couldn't shake the feeling that their success was too good to last.

The first sign of trouble came in late October. Samuel was combing through forum discussions about the marketplace when he spotted a post on a cybersecurity blog: **"Darknet's New Kingpin: Obsidian Exchange."**

The article praised the platform's technical brilliance but speculated on its creators. Theories ranged from a state-sponsored operation to a rogue AI.

"Congratulations," Steve said when Samuel showed him the article. "You're officially a legend."

"This isn't good," Samuel muttered. "The more people talk about us, the more attention we attract."

Over the next few weeks, more articles appeared. While most were positive, highlighting the marketplace's innovations, a few raised alarm bells about its potential misuse.

“We need to lay low,” Samuel told the group during a strategy meeting. “No big updates for a while. Let the hype die down.”

“But we can’t stop,” Luna argued. “The users depend on us.”

“We’re not stopping,” Samuel said firmly. “We’re just staying quiet.”

As winter approached, the group focused on fortifying their operation. They expanded their off-grid infrastructure, adding more solar panels and improving their satellite connectivity. Samuel began working on a contingency plan—if they had to abandon the farmhouse, the marketplace would survive, running entirely on a decentralized network of peer-to-peer nodes.

“We’ll be ghosts,” he explained to Luna and Steve. “Even if they find us, they can’t stop the platform.”

Despite the mounting pressure, the group remained committed to their vision. The Obsidian Exchange wasn’t just a marketplace—it was a statement. A reminder that freedom, privacy, and autonomy were still possible in a world increasingly dominated by surveillance and control.

By late 2019, the Obsidian Exchange was thriving, a juggernaut of digital subversion. Samuel, Luna, and Steve had proven their ability to maintain and grow the operation, but the demands of the ever-expanding marketplace were outpacing their capacity. To sustain the growth and prepare for the future, they needed more hands. Carefully, they began recruiting others they trusted implicitly—people with both the technical expertise and the ideological alignment to contribute without question.

The first to join was **Harriet**, an encryption specialist from Manchester who had been following Obsidian’s rise from its inception. Harriet had reached out via a burner email, offering to assist in upgrading the platform’s cryptographic security. Samuel, impressed by her detailed suggestions, had cautiously invited her to meet in person at a neutral location.

“She’s solid,” Samuel said to Luna after the meeting. “Knows her stuff, and she gets what we’re doing here.”

Harriet moved into a small converted barn on the property, immediately setting to work on encrypting the marketplace’s metadata to make it even more resistant to tracking.

Next was **Ryan**, a logistics expert and former dark web vendor who had been shipping products globally for years. He brought invaluable insights into streamlining the physical side of the operation, particularly as the volume of orders ballooned. Ryan’s connections also proved essential for sourcing new products and finding sellers willing to comply with the platform’s decentralized ethos.

Lastly, there was **Ezra**, a programmer and system administrator who had cut his teeth on open-source blockchain projects. Ezra’s role was to help Samuel implement the final phase of decentralization: turning the Obsidian Exchange into a truly autonomous, peer-to-peer platform with no single point of failure.

“This isn’t just a marketplace anymore,” Ezra said during a planning session. “This is a revolution.”

The farmhouse became a hive of activity, with the new recruits fitting seamlessly into the group’s off-grid existence. Each member had their domain, but decisions were made collectively during weekly meetings in the main living room, where they sat on mismatched furniture around a roaring fire.

“Harriet, how’s the metadata encryption coming along?” Samuel asked during one meeting.

“Almost there,” she replied. “The tricky part is making it lightweight enough that it doesn’t slow down transactions. But I’ll crack it.”

“Ryan?” Samuel turned.

“We’re hitting capacity again with the post boxes,” Ryan reported. “We need a new strategy. Maybe start working with couriers in cities outside Sheffield. Spread the drop points further apart.”

“Good. Ezra?”

“Decentralization is coming together,” Ezra said. “I’ve been testing nodes on volunteer servers. We’ll need more users running nodes to make it truly robust, but the framework is solid.”

The collective’s cohesion was critical to their success. There was no hierarchy, just a shared belief in the power of autonomy and mutual trust.

With more people came the need for more space. The group used some of their Bitcoin wealth to renovate the farmhouse further, building additional bedrooms, a proper kitchen, and a state-of-the-art coding lab. Solar panels covered the roof, and wind turbines dotted the nearby fields. They even dug a hidden bunker beneath the barn, outfitted with servers, backup generators, and enough supplies to last a year in case of an emergency.

To maintain secrecy, they doubled down on their camouflage efforts. The property’s dirt roads were disguised with hedges and trees, and they installed gates that blended seamlessly into the landscape. The farmhouse itself was painted in natural tones to make it less visible from the air, and they began experimenting with jamming devices to block drones from getting close.

“We’re disappearing in plain sight,” Luna said, standing with Samuel on a misty morning, surveying the landscape.

By the end of 2019, the Obsidian Exchange was operating as a near-autonomous entity. The marketplace had grown far beyond drugs, hosting listings for everything from rare books to hacker tools to freelance services. Its reputation on forums like Reddit and 4chan was unparalleled, with users hailing it as the future of decentralized commerce.

Samuel and Ezra worked tirelessly to refine the proof-of-work system that powered the marketplace’s decentralization. They envisioned a network of thousands of nodes, each run by a user who earned a cut of the revenue.

“This is how we win,” Samuel said one evening, staring at the lines of code on his screen. “No central authority. No single point of failure. Just people, working together, free from control.”

But even as the collective prepared for the next phase, they knew their success couldn’t go unnoticed forever. The whispers on the forums were growing louder, and the government’s crackdown on darknet marketplaces was intensifying.

“It’s only a matter of time before they come looking,” Harriet warned during a meeting.

“Let them,” Samuel replied. “By the time they find us, we’ll be untouchable.”

Chapter 19:

It was a cold December evening, and the farmhouse in the Peak District was alive with quiet activity. Harriet was debugging encryption protocols in the barn-turned-server room, Ryan was unpacking a bulk shipment of insulated mailers, and Luna and Ezra were debating the latest Bitcoin fork by the fireplace. Samuel sat in the corner of the room, sipping coffee and reviewing the node activity report. The numbers were good—better than good. Obsidian Exchange was becoming the backbone of the darknet, and the decentralization initiative was ahead of schedule.

Then Samuel's phone buzzed.

He frowned, glancing at the screen. It was an unknown number, but the country code was American. He hesitated for a moment before answering.

"Hello?"

"Sam? It's *Evelyn Ashcombe.*"

Samuel straightened in his chair. Evelyn was a distant cousin, one of the few remaining Ashcombes still involved in high finance. She was based in New York, and though they'd spoken only a handful of times, Samuel had always respected her sharp mind and no-nonsense demeanour.

"Evelyn, hi," he said, glancing around the room to ensure no one was eavesdropping. "What's going on?"

Her voice was low, almost conspiratorial. "I don't have much time, so listen carefully. There's something big coming. Have you seen the news about this virus in China?"

Samuel nodded, though she couldn't see him. "Yeah, something about a pneumonia outbreak. Why?"

"It's not just a virus," Evelyn said. "It's a smokescreen. The banking sector is on the brink of collapse—worse than 2008. The repo markets are already seizing up, and the central banks can't keep a lid on it. They're out of tools."

Samuel's heart sank. "And the virus?"

"It's the cover story," Evelyn said bluntly. "Governments around the world are coordinating to shut down the economy under the guise of a pandemic. They'll use it to justify a new round of quantitative easing and bail out the banks again. But this time, it's going to be bigger—trillions of dollars bigger. And they're planning to roll out digital currencies to control the fallout."

Samuel's mind raced. He'd always mistrusted the state and its alliances with the financial elite, but this… this was unprecedented.

"How do you know all this?" he asked.

"I have sources inside the Fed," Evelyn said. "And I've been watching the flows. It's all lining up. The repo market's been flashing warning signs for months, and now they're scrambling to cover their tracks. This virus is the perfect scapegoat."

"What do you need from me?"

“Nothing, for now,” Evelyn said. “But be prepared. If this plays out the way I think it will, they’ll lock down everything—travel, trade, even communication. They’ll use the fear to consolidate control and crush any dissent. You need to protect what you’ve built.”

Samuel clenched his jaw. “Thanks for the warning, Evelyn. I’ll do what I can.”

“One more thing,” she added. “If you’ve got Bitcoin, hold onto it. The central banks are going to debase every fiat currency they can to bail out the banks, but Bitcoin… Bitcoin will survive.”

She hung up before he could respond.

Samuel set the phone down and stared into the fire. His mind was a storm of thoughts. The implications of Evelyn’s warning were staggering. If the governments of the world were preparing to use a manufactured crisis to consolidate power, everything he’d been building—everything he believed in—was at risk.

“What’s wrong?” Luna asked, noticing his troubled expression.

Samuel glanced at her and the others. “We need to talk.”

The group gathered in the living room, their usual banter replaced by a tense silence as Samuel relayed Eleanor’s warning. By the time he finished, the room was heavy with unease.

“Do you think it’s true?” Ryan asked, his brow furrowed.

“I do,” Samuel said. “It lines up with everything we’ve seen in the financial markets. The repo crisis, the rate cuts, the liquidity injections—it’s all pointing to a major collapse. And if they’re planning to use this virus as cover…” He trailed off, shaking his head. “We need to be ready.”

“How?” Harriet asked.

Samuel leaned forward. “First, we double down on decentralizing Obsidian. If they try to shut down the internet or censor the darknet, we need to make sure the marketplace can survive without us. That means more nodes, more redundancy, and tighter security.”

“And the money?” Steve asked.

Samuel thought for a moment. “We convert as much as we can into Bitcoin. No more holding fiat. If Eleanor’s right, inflation’s going to skyrocket, and Bitcoin’s our best hedge.”

Luna nodded. “And the farm?”

“We make it even harder to find,” Samuel said. “Camouflage, decoys, jamming tech—whatever it takes. If they come looking, we can’t let them find us.”

Over the next few weeks, the group worked tirelessly to implement Samuel’s plan. Ezra pushed the decentralization efforts into overdrive, recruiting trusted volunteers from around the world to host nodes. Harriet reinforced the site’s encryption, making it nearly impenetrable to even the most sophisticated attacks. Ryan and Steve focused on logistics, ensuring the marketplace’s supply chains were as robust as possible.

Meanwhile, Samuel watched the news from China with growing unease. The virus was spreading rapidly, and the media was ramping up the fear. Travel restrictions were being announced, and the stock markets were beginning to wobble.

One evening, as he sat alone in the farmhouse's coding lab, Samuel stared at the Bitcoin price chart on his screen. It was rising steadily, a clear sign that people were losing faith in the traditional financial system.

He thought about Evelyn's warning, about the state's relentless pursuit of control, and about the countless individuals who would suffer in the coming collapse. And then he thought about Obsidian—about what it represented.

“This is how we fight back,” he muttered to himself. “Not with protests or petitions, but with code. With ideas. With freedom.”

The virus that had once been a footnote in distant headlines now dominated every corner of the internet. Fear gripped the world. Governments announced emergency measures—border closures, quarantines, and sweeping lockdowns. Social media was a cacophony of panic, with hashtags like #StayHome and #FlattenTheCurve trending globally. But to Samuel, it was all too orchestrated.

From the safety of the Peak District farmhouse, he monitored the unfolding chaos. The pieces fit together just as Evelyn had warned: the financial markets were spiralling, central banks were pumping unprecedented liquidity into the system, and the populace—gripped by fear—was willingly surrendering their freedoms.

Samuel leaned back in his chair, his mind racing. If the lockdowns continued unchecked, they would solidify the state's control over every facet of life, from movement to money. He had to act. But protests wouldn't work—those were easy to crush. The fight had to happen where the state was weakest: in the realm of information.

He turned to his team. "We need to hit them where it hurts. We're going to counter their narrative. Flood the internet with doubt, with truth, with whatever it takes to wake people up."

Luna raised an eyebrow. "You're talking about a bot army, aren't you?"

"Exactly," Samuel said. "If they're using fear to control people, we'll use their own tools to dismantle it. Millions of bots, all running 24/7, spreading the message that this is a smokescreen."

Samuel and the team got to work immediately. The coding lab, once used to perfect Obsidian's infrastructure, became a hub of digital insurgency. Harriet took the lead on designing the bots, programming them to mimic human behaviour—random posting schedules, believable grammar errors, and organic engagement patterns. Luna focused on crafting the message, a mix of skepticism and subtle truth bombs designed to make people question the official narrative.

Ryan, ever the logistics expert, procured hundreds of virtual private servers and set up decentralized command centres to ensure the botnet couldn't be traced back to them. Meanwhile, Steve scoured darknet forums and Telegram groups, recruiting like-minded individuals to help amplify their reach.

The bots were designed to infiltrate every corner of the internet: Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, Reddit, even obscure forums and WhatsApp groups. They didn't outright scream conspiracy—that would scare people off. Instead, they planted seeds of doubt:

- "Why are the lockdowns so strict when the virus has such a low mortality rate?"
- "Doesn't this seem like a convenient way to bail out the banks without anyone noticing?"
- "Look at the repo markets before the pandemic hit—this isn't about a virus, it's about money."

By late January, the first wave of bots went live. Samuel and the team monitored their impact closely, watching as their posts and comments began to ripple across the digital landscape. The response was slow at first—people were too consumed by fear to question the narrative. But as the bots grew more sophisticated, so did their influence.

A fake account on Twitter posted a viral thread exposing the timeline of financial market instability leading up to the pandemic. A Reddit bot started an AMA claiming to be an economist whistleblower, explaining how quantitative easing was tied to the lockdowns. On Instagram, accounts shared infographics comparing COVID-19’s death rate to past pandemics, suggesting the response was disproportionate.

By early February, the movement had gained traction. Real users—drawn in by the bots’ content—began to join the conversation. Hashtags questioning the lockdowns started to trend, and the government’s carefully crafted narrative began to show cracks.

As the operation grew, so did its complexity. Samuel knew that to sustain the effort, they’d need more than just bots. He began integrating blockchain-based systems into the infrastructure, ensuring that the botnet could operate independently of centralized servers. Each bot became a node in a decentralized network, capable of functioning even if part of the system was taken down.

The team also started using Obsidian’s revenue to fund the effort. They hired graphic designers to create professional-looking propaganda, from YouTube videos to infographics. They bribed insiders at social media companies to ensure certain posts weren’t flagged or taken down.

But Samuel wasn’t just focused on the technical side. He wanted to reach people’s hearts and minds. Late at night, he crafted long, impassioned posts under a pseudonym, painting a vision of a world free from state control. He argued that the virus was just the latest in a long line of tools used by governments to enslave humanity. His words spread like wildfire, quoted in articles and reposted across platforms.

By March, the operation was too big to ignore. Governments and tech companies began cracking down, flagging posts, banning accounts, and tightening their algorithms to filter out “disinformation.” But Samuel had anticipated this. The decentralized nature of the botnet made it nearly impossible to shut down entirely. For every account that was banned, two more popped up in its place.

The media started running stories about a “shadowy group” spreading anti-lockdown propaganda online. They painted the movement as dangerous, even going so far as to label it domestic terrorism. But Samuel didn’t care. For every person who dismissed their message, ten more were questioning the official story.

By April, the government’s resolve was weakening. Protests began to erupt in cities across the world, fuelled by the online campaign. People were demanding answers—why were lockdown measures so extreme? Why was so much money being printed? Why was there so little information about the virus?

In the farmhouse, Samuel watched it all unfold with a grim satisfaction. The movement he’d started was no longer just about exposing the truth. It was about giving people hope—showing them that they didn’t have to accept the state’s lies.

As the sun set over the Peak District, he leaned back in his chair and lit a cigarette. The fight was far from over, but for the first time, he felt like they were winning.

By May 2020, the cracks in the government's narrative were becoming fissures. The propaganda campaign Samuel and his team had meticulously built was taking root in ways they hadn't fully anticipated. On social media, hashtags like #CommonLawRebellion and #RegulationsNotLaw were trending daily, as ordinary people began to question not just the lockdown measures but the authority of the state itself.

Samuel sat in his cluttered workspace, the glow of his laptop illuminating his face as he scrolled through the latest data. Reports from the botnet showed massive spikes in engagement. Posts about the legality of lockdowns—carefully crafted and disseminated by the team—were being shared thousands of times, with real users picking up the mantle and spreading the message organically.

"People are waking up," Luna said, standing behind him with a mug of coffee. "I just saw a thread where someone quoted your post verbatim about regulations not being enforceable under criminal law. It's going viral."

Samuel nodded, his eyes scanning a live stream of comments on a Reddit thread. "It's not just online anymore. Look at this." He clicked on a video of a pub owner in Manchester defiantly throwing open his doors, surrounded by cheering patrons. "He's using the argument we put out last week. Regulations are just guidance, not enforceable under common law."

The publican, a grizzled man in his fifties, stood at the bar in the video, addressing a crowd of locals. "They can't arrest all of us," he declared. "This isn't law. This is just their way of controlling us. You have a right to earn a living, and I have a right to serve you a pint!"

Across the country, more publicans began to follow suit. In Sheffield, small clusters of pubs discreetly reopened their doors, word spreading through whispered conversations and encrypted Telegram groups. These publicans cited the same arguments Samuel had seeded into the discourse: that lockdown restrictions were merely regulations and not enforceable under criminal law without parliamentary approval.

The bots amplified these stories, highlighting the bravery of these defiant publicans and the communities rallying around them. Videos of packed pubs with laughing patrons began circulating online, often accompanied by captions like, *"The real normal isn't gone—it's just waiting for you to reclaim it."*

Samuel smiled as he watched one video of a pub in Liverpool. The crowd was singing, arms around one another, pint glasses raised high. The comment section was a mix of praise, indignation, and skepticism, but one thing was clear: the narrative was fracturing.

Samuel and his team doubled down on their messaging. They released easy-to-follow guides on how to challenge the enforcement of lockdown measures using common law principles. These guides were designed to empower ordinary people, filled with phrases like:

- *"Regulations are not law."*
- *"You cannot be criminally charged for breaking guidance."*
- *"Under common law, you have the right to earn a living and gather freely."*

The team also created templates for letters that people could use to challenge fines or penalties. The bots spread these guides far and wide, and within weeks, people were pushing back against the state's enforcement tactics.

In one viral clip, a man in Birmingham filmed himself confronting police officers attempting to shut down his market stall. "You've got no authority here," he shouted, waving a printed copy of one of Samuel's guides. "This is regulation, not law. Unless you've got an act of Parliament behind you, I'll keep trading." The officers, visibly uncertain, eventually backed off.

By late May, the defiance was no longer confined to pubs and markets. Small businesses began reopening under the radar, from hairdressers to gyms. People started organizing community events in parks, refusing to abide by the government's restrictions.

Samuel watched it all unfold with a mixture of pride and trepidation. The campaign was working. People were reclaiming their autonomy, rejecting the fear that had paralysed them for months. But he knew the state wouldn't take this lying down.

Luna entered the room, holding a stack of newspapers. "You've seen this, right?" She tossed one onto the desk. The headline read: *'Online Disinformation Campaign Fuels Rebellion Against Lockdowns.'*

Samuel smirked. "Disinformation, huh? That's what they call inconvenient truths these days."

The botnet's next phase focused on normalizing rebellion. It wasn't enough to inspire isolated acts of defiance—they needed to create a sense of collective momentum. The bots began posting stories of communities banding together to resist the lockdowns, using hashtags like #TakeBackNormal and #LiveFree.

One particularly viral post featured a montage of reopened pubs, bustling markets, and children playing in parks, set to the tune of a nostalgic British folk song. The caption read: *"This is Britain. Not fear. Not control. Just freedom."*

As the price of Bitcoin continued to climb, the team reinvested their profits into the campaign. They hired freelance filmmakers to create polished propaganda videos and commissioned artwork that romanticized the defiance. Posters featuring slogans like *"Freedom is Your Birthright"* began appearing in cities, pasted onto walls and lampposts under the cover of night.

But the government wasn't sitting idle. Crackdowns on reopened businesses intensified, with police raiding pubs and markets in highly publicized operations. Social media platforms ramped up their censorship, banning accounts and flagging posts as "false information."

Samuel, however, was undeterred. The decentralized nature of their operation made it impossible to completely shut down. For every banned account, three more appeared. The botnet evolved, learning to mimic new human patterns to evade detection.

One evening, as the team gathered around the farmhouse's central table, Luna looked up from her laptop. "We're making a difference, Sam. People are listening. They're fighting back."

Samuel nodded, his gaze distant. "It's not just about the lockdowns anymore. It's about showing people that they don't need the state to dictate their lives. Once they see that, they'll never go back."

By late May 2020, the lockdown restrictions were hitting harder than the people could react. Videos of police action were flooding social media, and protests against the restrictions were growing by the day. Samuel's botnet continued its relentless campaign, amplifying stories of everyday rebellion and circulating damning evidence of hypocrisy within the government.

The tipping point came when a senior government adviser, was caught flouting the very restrictions he had helped implement. The story exploded across every media outlet, from The Guardian to the Daily Mail, and Samuel's team wasted no time capitalizing on it.

Within hours of the story breaking, the botnet was pushing memes, clips, and sarcastic hashtags like #OneRuleForThem and #CummingsAndGoings. The narrative shifted decisively: if the government's own officials weren't taking the restrictions seriously, why should the public?

"It's over," Luna said, scrolling through Twitter as she leaned back in her chair. "Everyone's seeing it now. The hypocrisy is too blatant. They can't spin this."

Samuel smirked as he typed furiously at his laptop. "This isn't just hypocrisy. It's proof they never believed in it to begin with. They used fear to control people, but now they've lost the moral high ground. The public won't stand for it anymore."

As the rebellion reached a fever pitch, Prime Minister Boris Johnson found himself cornered. Public trust in the government had plummeted, and even traditionally loyal segments of the media were beginning to turn on him. Daily briefings were met with open ridicule, and the streets of Britain were alive with defiance as pubs, shops, and markets reopened en masse.

On the evening of May 29th, Johnson appeared on television, looking more dishevelled than usual. The nation held its breath as he addressed the camera, his voice strained but measured.

"My fellow Britons," he began, "it has become clear that the measures we implemented to protect public health can no longer command the support of the British people. While our intentions were to save lives, we cannot ignore the will of the public or the realities of enforcement. Therefore, as of midnight tonight, all remaining restrictions will be lifted."

He paused, glancing down at his notes before continuing. "We trust the people of this great nation to take responsibility for their own health and well-being. Together, we will move forward, rebuilding our economy, our communities, and our lives."

The announcement was met with a mix of relief and vindication. Across the country, people poured into the streets, celebrating their newfound freedom. Samuel and his team watched the broadcast in their farmhouse, the tension in the room dissipating as the Prime Minister's words sunk in.

"It worked," Luna said, her voice tinged with disbelief.

Samuel leaned back in his chair, a rare smile breaking across his face. "It wasn't just us. It was everyone. We just gave them the tools to see the truth."

For the first time in months, the farmhouse felt lighter, the weight of their relentless campaign lifted. Yet Samuel knew this was only the beginning. The government's retreat was a victory, but the war for autonomy—the dream of a truly decentralized, self-reliant society—was far from over.

As the weeks passed following the end of the lockdown, a new wave of awareness began to wash over the public. The realization that the government's actions had been driven not by health concerns, but by a desperate attempt to stave off a global banking collapse, spread like wildfire. Samuel's botnet shifted into high gear, pivoting away from lockdown defiance and focusing squarely on a new, more insidious threat: the fragility of the fiat system and the rise of centralized control.

On forums like Reddit, Twitter, and encrypted chat groups, people were waking up. They were seeing the patterns: a financial system teetering on the edge of collapse, central banks printing money at an unprecedented rate, and governments worldwide using the pandemic as an excuse to exercise emergency powers. Samuel’s bots were now bombarding these platforms with messages warning of a coming wave of inflation, a bail-in of savings, and the slow erosion of financial privacy.

Bitcoin, already a symbol of rebellion, began to take centre stage as the solution.

By the end of June, Bitcoin had already begun to climb in value, driven in part by increased demand from those seeking a hedge against the systemic risk exposed during the pandemic. As inflation fears took root and trust in the traditional financial system evaporated, more and more people turned to decentralized assets. In particular, Samuel’s team had been pushing Bitcoin hard—on social media, on encrypted messaging boards, and through a covert network of influencers and hackers.

“Forget gold,” Samuel had said, more than once, during their late-night strategy sessions. “It’s a relic. Bitcoin is the future. It’s borderless, untraceable, and it can’t be inflated away by a bunch of bankers. This is our revolution.”

It wasn’t just the usual crypto enthusiasts who were buying in anymore. Everyday citizens, aware of the coming storm, were starting to pull their savings from traditional bank accounts and pouring them into Bitcoin. The more mainstream media outlets tried to dismiss it, the more people rallied behind the idea. As Bitcoin’s price surged past £20,000 in July and hit new all-time highs in August, Samuel knew that the shift was real.

Samuel watched as his botnet army expanded its influence into new territories. Their digital campaign had always been about freedom, about decentralization, and about giving the power back to the individual. But now, it was focused on one clear goal: moving more people into Bitcoin. The bots posted charts showing Bitcoin’s soaring value, shared articles about hyperinflation in countries like Venezuela, and flooded forums with discussions about the coming collapse of the dollar. Every message, every post, was carefully crafted to push people further down the rabbit hole of financial sovereignty.

“Bitcoin’s not just a currency,” Luna said, as they sat in their farmhouse late one evening, scrolling through the latest data. “It’s a tool for breaking free. The banks are about to fail. They’ll try to blame it on everything else, but we know the truth.”

Samuel nodded, a faint smile playing at the corners of his mouth. “The truth is, the system is dying. And they want to take us all down with it. But Bitcoin, that’s our lifeboat. It’s the one thing they can’t control.”

The market was buzzing with activity, as the message spread like wildfire. Samuel’s site, which had once been dedicated to facilitating illicit transactions, was now serving a far more profound purpose: teaching people how to opt out of the state’s financial control. There were guides on how to buy Bitcoin anonymously, how to set up hardware wallets, and how to protect yourself from government overreach.

As more people began to wake up to the truth, Samuel's influence grew. The Ashcombe collective became a nexus for those who had long distrusted the state, for libertarians, hackers, anarchists, and disillusioned technologists who saw the system for what it was: corrupt, fragile, and increasingly authoritarian. They were all looking for a way out, and Samuel had provided them with a path.

By late September 2020, Bitcoin's price had surpassed £40,000, and it was evident that a massive shift was taking place. On social media platforms, discussions of Bitcoin were now ubiquitous. Where before, Bitcoin had been seen as niche and somewhat fringe, it was now mainstream—people were talking about it at dinner parties, in pubs, and in coffee shops. Even in the face of mounting government crackdowns and media hostility, Bitcoin had solidified itself as the currency of the resistance.

"You know, I thought it would take years," Luna said one evening as they worked, "but now I think we might have done it. We've actually got people thinking for themselves."

However, Samuel knew that this was just the beginning. The state wouldn't let go of its power without a fight. Governments were already preparing their countermeasures—central bank digital currencies (CBDCs), stricter regulations on cryptocurrencies, and surveillance programs designed to track and control every transaction. They'd already begun to target Bitcoin exchanges, demanding compliance or shutting them down entirely. The centralization of power had to be stopped at all costs.

"I've been thinking," Samuel said, as he stood up, staring out at the Peak District hills, "we can't just teach people how to buy Bitcoin. We need to teach them how to protect it—how to keep it off the radar. A Bitcoin wallet is great, but it's not enough. We need to protect their privacy, too."

Steve, who had been working on a privacy-enhancing software suite, looked up from his laptop. "We can build a decentralized exchange—no middlemen, no traceable transaction records. Make it completely peer-to-peer."

"Exactly," Samuel replied, eyes alight with excitement. "We need to think bigger. A decentralized, anonymous economy where people don't need the state. We're not just building a market; we're building a movement."

The world outside was slipping further into chaos, but within the farmhouse, the Ashcombe collective was building something far more powerful: a new way of life. A life where sovereignty, privacy, and decentralization weren't just ideals, but practical realities.

As the year turned into 2021, the state's response to the growing decentralized movement became ever more aggressive. Regulations tightened, and the threat of global surveillance loomed large. But Samuel and his team were ready. They had anticipated these moves, and they were already working on the next phase of their strategy—scaling their operations, enhancing their security, and ensuring that Bitcoin and decentralized technologies could withstand whatever the government threw at them.

"This is our moment," Samuel said, more to himself than anyone else. "We can either let them win, or we can take this to the next level. We're not going to sit back and let them destroy what we've built."

And with that, the Ashcombe collective—already a force to be reckoned with—prepared to take its place at the forefront of a new world order, one where the state had no power over the individual, and financial freedom was a birthright, not a privilege.

By mid-2021, the Ashcombe collective had grown into something far beyond what Samuel had ever envisioned when he first started coding the marketplace. It had become a movement—an ideology—anchored not just in the decentralized, untraceable world of Bitcoin but in the broader promise of escaping the clutches of state power. As the world grappled with a global economic collapse, the Ashcombe family, from their secluded farmhouse in the Peak District, had outmanoeuvred the state at every turn.

They had built a parallel economy, one that was untouchable by the hands of government regulators and financial institutions. Their platform—completely decentralized—operated through a vast network of anonymous servers and individuals, each a node in a growing rebellion against the old order. The bots that had once spread their anti-lockdown message had evolved into something more: an army of digital warriors spreading knowledge about financial sovereignty, privacy, and the power of Bitcoin to anyone who would listen.

But as with any revolution, the question remained: How long could they hold the line?

The state, now scrambling to regain control of the narrative, had begun to intensify its crackdown. Regulations were tightening, and law enforcement agencies, under pressure from the central banks, were increasingly targeting those who had fled the system—those who had taken up the banner of financial freedom. But despite the mounting threats, Samuel and his team had never been more united. The family, forged through shared ideals and trials, had become a force that no one could ignore.

The final push came in the summer of 2022. With Bitcoin soaring beyond £100,000, the global financial system teetered on the brink of total collapse. Governments, desperate to maintain control, began rolling out their digital currencies—centralized, monitored, and fully traceable. In response, the Ashcombe collective launched their most ambitious project yet: a truly decentralized economy where Bitcoin was not just a currency but the foundation for everything—trade, governance, identity.

They called it the **Elysium Network**.

The project was simple yet revolutionary: an entirely peer-to-peer system where individuals could exchange goods and services without the need for any central authority. No banks. No governments. Just people. Through this, they would create a new kind of society, built on trust, privacy, and absolute autonomy.

It took months to perfect, but when it finally went live in late 2022, it was everything Samuel had dreamed of—a completely self-sustaining digital ecosystem that allowed people to live outside the reach of the state. It was not perfect. There were setbacks. There were moments of doubt. But in the end, the collective had succeeded in its mission: to build something that could outlast the system that had brought so much suffering to the world.

As the years passed, the Ashcombe collectives influence only grew. The farmhouse, once a humble hideout in the Peak District, had become a symbol of resistance. The members had diversified their operations—starting businesses, trading with one another, building networks of trust that transcended geography. And while they had retreated from the world they once knew, their reach had expanded far beyond their small corner of the Peak District.

Samuel stood outside the farmhouse one crisp autumn evening, looking over the rolling hills as the sun dipped below the horizon. There was a sense of peace in the air, a tranquillity that had eluded him for so many years. They had won. Not just for themselves, but for the future of humanity.

They had built something that could not be undone, no matter how hard the state tried. They had created a new world—one that was truly free.

The Ashcombe name, long associated with power and influence, had transcended its origins. It was no longer about family legacy or wealth. It was about a new way of life, about showing the world that freedom wasn't just a theoretical ideal—it was a practical reality.

Samuel had succeeded. But the true victory was not in the wealth or the technology. It was in the people they had freed. The many who, through Bitcoin, had found a way to live without the constraints of the state. The many who had taken the same path Samuel and his friends had—building a life outside the system.

And in that quiet moment, as Samuel took a deep breath and exhaled the cool air of the Peak District, he knew that what had started as a rebellious dream had become something much bigger. They had shown the world that power didn't come from governments or banks. It came from people—sovereign, free, and unyielding.

In the years that followed, as governments struggled to regain control over their economies, the legacy of the Ashcombe collective endured. Their decentralized marketplace had become a model for others to follow, and their philosophy had inspired a new generation of technologists, philosophers, and revolutionaries.

In the end, it was clear: Samuel Ashcombe and his friends had not just built a business. They had built a movement. A movement that had shown the world that, in the end, the only true power was the power of the individual.

And with that, the Ashcombe legacy lived on—not as a family name, but as the spark that ignited a new era of freedom, autonomy, and decentralization. A new age in which humanity was no longer bound by the chains of the state, but was free to live on its own terms, guided by the immutable laws of code and the undying spirit of rebellion.

For the first time in generations, our wealth is truly ours. No intermediaries, no governments. But with great freedom comes great responsibility. What we do with it now will define us.

END OF PART FOUR

THE END

Appendix #2 The Philosophy of Inflation - A Productivist Path to Acceleration

By Elliot Ashton

Abstract: This essay proposes a fundamental reconceptualization of inflation beyond traditional Consumer Price Index (CPI) measurements. It argues that inflation is more accurately defined as the rate at which money supply growth outpaces productivity growth, rather than as a simple increase in consumer prices. By developing a systematic model expressing this relationship as $I = M - P$, where inflation (I) equals the difference between money supply growth (M) and productivity growth (P). This framework is later refined to include velocity of money, taxation effects, and supply shocks, resulting in a more comprehensive equation: $I = (M \times V) - (P \times Q) - T + S$

"I equals the product of M and V, minus the product of P and Q, minus T, plus S."

Introduction

For centuries, economists have struggled to define inflation in a way that truly reflects the nature of economic reality. The Consumer Price Index (CPI), long the dominant metric, claims to measure the cost of living, but it is, in essence, a lagging indicator—reactive rather than predictive. It abstracts away from the fundamental forces that drive inflation, offering a distorted reflection of an economic landscape shaped by monetary expansion and productivity shifts.

As a society, we have been conditioned to view inflation as an inevitable consequence of progress, a phenomenon to be “managed” rather than understood. Yet, if we return to first principles, we find a more fundamental definition: Inflation is the rate at which money supply outpaces productive capacity. In this light, CPI is merely a symptom, not the cause. The real engine of inflation lies in the interplay between money creation and real economic output.

In this essay, I propose a new framework—an algorithmic approach to inflation that considers the direct relationship between money supply growth and productivity expansion. If money creation exceeds productivity gains, inflation occurs. If productivity outstrips monetary expansion, purchasing power increases, leading to a deflationary effect. This approach shifts the focus from reactive price indices to a proactive model that measures economic distortions at their root.

If economics is to mature into a true science, it must abandon the crude instruments of the past and embrace models that reveal the deeper mechanics of value, money, and production. Only then can we grasp the forces shaping our economies and reclaim a form of economic stewardship that is both rational and just.

The prevailing economic orthodoxy treats inflation as a complex phenomenon, driven by a variety of supply and demand factors, with policymakers relying on broad indicators such as the Consumer Price Index (CPI) to adjust interest rates and control economic overheating. However, the fundamental flaw of this approach is that CPI measures only price changes, not the root cause of inflation itself. Prices fluctuate for many reasons—technological deflation, supply shocks, shifts in consumer demand—but these do not necessarily indicate a systemic change in monetary conditions.

Modern Monetary Theory (MMT) has challenged traditional macroeconomic assumptions by arguing that government spending is unconstrained by revenue and that inflation, not debt, is the primary limit to fiscal expansion. However, MMT lacks a rigorous, real-time measure of inflation beyond price indices. Here, we propose a refined approach: inflation should be defined as the rate at which the money supply (M) exceeds real productivity (P).

Our inflation model is based on a simple principle:
Inflation happens when the money supply grows faster than real productivity.

6. Measure the growth rate of the money supply (how much new money is being created).
7. Measure the growth rate of productivity (how much more goods and services the economy is producing).
8. Subtract the productivity growth rate from the money supply growth rate.
    1. If the result is positive, there is inflation (too much money chasing too few goods).
    2. If the result is zero, there is no inflation (money supply and productivity are balanced).
    3. If the result is negative, there is deflation (money supply is growing slower than productivity, increasing the value of money).

Inflation happens when the money supply grows faster than productivity.

We can express this simply as:

I = M - P

This formula captures the essential insight that inflation occurs not simply when the money supply increases, but when it increases at a faster rate than productivity. If the economy becomes more productive at the same rate as new money is introduced, then inflation is neutralized, as each additional unit of money corresponds to additional goods and services.

Implications of This Model

6. **Separating Monetary Expansion from Price Distortions**

    - Unlike CPI, which measures consumer prices affected by supply chain disruptions, speculation, and other external factors, our model directly measures whether monetary expansion is justified by real economic growth.
    - A rise in prices due to a supply shock (e.g., an oil embargo) does not necessarily indicate inflation—only a rise in prices caused by excessive money creation does.

7. **A More Responsive Inflation Measure**

    - CPI is often delayed, reacting months after inflation has already taken root. Our model allows policymakers to detect inflation as soon as monetary distortions appear.
    - Currency issuers, using this framework, could adjust monetary policy preemptively rather than reactively.

8. **Rethinking the Role of Currency issuance**

    - If the currency supply increases (expanding M) without an equivalent rise in productivity (P), inflation ensues.
    - Under an this framework, the government should not spend freely but should only introduce new money proportionate to productivity gains.

9. **Taxation as a Deflationary Mechanism**

    - MMT theorists argue that taxation is a tool to remove excess money from circulation to prevent inflation. Under our model, taxation should precisely match the excess of money supply over productivity to maintain price stability.
    - This suggests an adaptive tax system, where fiscal policy is dynamically adjusted based on real-time productivity metrics.

This model presents a paradigm shift in how we conceptualize inflation. Rather than viewing it as a mysterious force that must be tamed through interest rate hikes and monetary tightening, it becomes a quantifiable and predictable phenomenon—one that can be measured, anticipated, and managed in a structured way.

Theoretical Foundations

Inflation has been one of the most contested topics in economic thought, with different schools of thought offering competing explanations for its causes and effects. Understanding these perspectives is crucial to framing our new inflation model.

The Austrian School defines inflation strictly as an increase in the money supply, rather than the rise in prices. Prices rise because more money is introduced into the system without a proportional increase in productivity. Inflation distorts market signals, causing misallocation of resources (e.g., artificial booms leading to inevitable busts). Fiat currency and central banking are primary culprits, as they allow unchecked money creation. The solution is a sound money system (e.g., gold or Bitcoin) that restrains monetary expansion.

John Maynard Keynes introduced a more demand-driven approach to inflation, arguing that: Inflation occurs when aggregate demand exceeds aggregate supply (demand-pull inflation). Prices can also rise due to rising production costs (cost-push inflation), such as wage increases or supply chain disruptions. Moderate inflation is necessary for economic growth, as it encourages spending and investment rather than hoarding money. Government intervention (e.g., adjusting interest rates and fiscal policy) can control inflation. Keynesians tend to rely on CPI-based inflation metrics, which often fail to capture the impact of money supply expansion. They also underestimate the long-term distortions caused by continuous monetary intervention.

I break from both Austrian and Keynesian by arguing that:

Inflation is not simply about money supply but about real resource constraints. Currency issuers can print unlimited money as long as there is slack in the economy (e.g., unemployment and underutilized resources). Inflation only occurs when spending exceeds the productive capacity of the economy. Taxation and government spending should be used as tools to regulate inflation, rather than relying on interest rates or monetary policy. Models assume that currency issuers will always manage inflation through taxation, but history suggests political incentives often lead to overspending and mismanagement. Additionally, it struggles to explain asset price inflation and how financial markets respond to monetary expansion.

Traditional inflation models, particularly those relying on Consumer Price Index (CPI), often fail to account for a fundamental economic reality: productivity growth offsets inflationary pressures. By ignoring productivity, these models risk overestimating inflation, leading to flawed economic policies.

Classic inflation theories, such as the Quantity Theory of Money (MV = PQ), suggest that increasing the money supply always leads to rising prices. However, if the economy simultaneously produces more goods and services, the additional money is absorbed by new output rather than driving up prices. *Example*: If a country doubles its money supply but also doubles its output, price levels remain unchanged because the new money is chasing an increased number of goods.

Productivity growth often results from technological innovations, making it cheaper and faster to produce goods and services. *Example*: In the tech industry, Moore's Law has led to exponential improvements in computing power, yet prices of consumer electronics have declined over time. A traditional CPI-based inflation model would incorrectly interpret falling prices as deflationary when, in reality, they reflect productivity-driven cost reductions. *Key Takeaway*: Rising productivity counteracts inflationary pressures, making price stability possible even in an expanding monetary environment.

Higher productivity allows businesses to increase wages without raising prices, ensuring economic growth without inflation. *Example*: A country experiencing 3% annual productivity growth can afford 3% wage increases without inflationary consequences, as the additional wages correspond to increased economic output. If inflation is calculated without accounting for productivity, wage growth might be wrongly blamed for rising prices, leading to misguided policies like interest rate hikes. *Key Takeaway*: Real wage growth without inflation is possible when productivity keeps pace with money supply expansion.

CPI measures inflation based on a fixed basket of goods, failing to account for qualitative improvements and increased choices over time. *Example*: A modern smartphone costs the same as a 2005 flip phone, but its capabilities are vastly superior. A CPI-based model would miss this gain in economic value. Productivity growth means consumers get more value for the same money, reducing the real impact of price increases. *Key Takeaway*: Ignoring productivity in inflation models leads to inflated perceptions of price increases and distorts economic policy decisions.

By incorporating productivity growth into our inflation model:

This model accounts for real economic activity, ensuring that price increases are not simply attributed to monetary expansion but are examined in the context of actual productivity improvements. Inflationary fears should only arise when money supply growth outpaces productivity. Productivity-driven price reductions should not be mistaken for deflationary spirals. Economic policies should focus on enhancing productivity rather than artificially suppressing demand through interest rate hikes or taxation. Thus, any future economic model—especially under Modern Monetary Theory (MMT) or Bitcoin-based systems—must factor in productivity growth to provide a true measure of inflation and guide sound policymaking.

CPI vs. Money Supply-Based Inflation

For much of modern history, inflation has been understood primarily through the lens of consumer prices. The Consumer Price Index (CPI) has become the dominant measure, tracking changes in the cost of a fixed basket of goods and services. It is used by policymakers to adjust wages, pensions, and monetary policy. On the surface, it appears to be a practical tool—after all, it reflects the costs that ordinary people experience in their daily lives. However, CPI has significant limitations.

First, it measures only the effects of inflation rather than its causes. Inflation is not merely rising prices; it is fundamentally a monetary phenomenon, driven by the expansion of the money supply beyond the rate of productivity growth. If more currency is created without a corresponding increase in goods and services, purchasing power is diluted. CPI, however, does not track this. It is reactive rather than predictive, often failing to reflect the long-term consequences of monetary policy.

Second, CPI is highly susceptible to manipulation. The composition of the "basket" changes over time, with government agencies substituting products to reflect changing consumer habits. For example, if steak becomes too expensive, CPI might assume people switch to chicken, thereby understating the true rise in costs. Additionally, "hedonic adjustments" are made, where quality improvements in products—such as faster computers—are used to offset price increases, further distorting the real impact of inflation.

Third, CPI does not capture asset price inflation. In modern economies, much of the newly created money flows into real estate, stock markets, and alternative assets such as Bitcoin. This means that while CPI might suggest inflation is low, house prices could be soaring, pushing home-ownership further out of reach for younger generations. Wealth inequality grows, but CPI fails to reflect this reality.

An alternative approach is to measure inflation at its source—by looking at the relationship between money supply growth and productivity. A money supply-based model defines inflation as the increase in currency that exceeds economic output. If the money supply expands by 10% in a year while productivity grows by only 2%, true inflation is 8%, regardless of what CPI suggests.

This approach has several advantages. It identifies inflation before it manifests in consumer prices, providing a leading indicator rather than a lagging one. It also accounts for productivity growth, recognizing that if an economy becomes more efficient, additional money can circulate without causing inflation. Furthermore, it captures the expansion of financial markets, reflecting the impact of monetary policy on housing and stocks rather than just groceries and fuel.

Yet, this model is not without challenges. The velocity of money—the rate at which it circulates—affects inflation, and this is difficult to predict. Additionally, currency issuers frequently adjust how they report money supply figures, making accurate measurement difficult. Still, a model based on money supply offers a more transparent and comprehensive picture of inflation than CPI ever could.

A hybrid approach may be ideal—one that acknowledges CPI’s usefulness in tracking short-term price fluctuations while grounding inflation analysis in monetary fundamentals. The broader implication is clear: if we continue to rely solely on CPI, central banks can justify unlimited money printing while claiming inflation remains low. This fuels asset bubbles, distorts incentives, and ultimately erodes trust in economic institutions. If, instead, we define inflation in terms of money supply and productivity, we can hold policymakers accountable, encourage sound money practices, and build an economic system that rewards real value creation rather than financial manipulation.

The question, then, is not just how we measure inflation—but what kind of economy we want to create.

Why Money Supply Growth Relative to Productivity Offers a Better Macroeconomic Perspective in a Hypermodernist World

In an era defined by accelerating technological progress, traditional macroeconomic indicators like the Consumer Price Index (CPI) fail to capture the full picture of economic health. The hypermodernist world—characterized by rapid automation, artificial intelligence, and decentralized networks—requires a more dynamic and forward-looking approach to measuring inflation, growth, and value creation.

At the heart of this shift lies the relationship between money supply growth and productivity. Unlike CPI, which reflects past price movements, this metric provides a structural and predictive framework for understanding economic reality. In a world where technology is redefining industries at an exponential rate, we must rethink how we assess inflation and economic expansion.

Historically, economic models have been rooted in industrial-era assumptions, where inflation was tied to the scarcity of physical goods. But in a hypermodernist economy, scarcity is being replaced by abundance—at least in certain sectors. Automation and AI allow for near-limitless production of digital goods, lowering costs across industries. Meanwhile, decentralized financial systems, like Bitcoin, redefine trust and monetary stability.

Yet, this abundance coexists with artificial scarcity created by monetary policy. Central banks, in an attempt to "stimulate demand," expand the money supply without regard for whether productivity is keeping pace. This creates a distortion: while digital and AI-driven productivity surges, monetary expansion accumulates in financial assets rather than fuelling real economic progress.

When money supply outpaces productivity, we experience:

Asset bubbles in stocks, real estate, and speculative markets.
Wealth concentration, where those closest to money creation (banks, institutional investors) benefit at the expense of those dependent on wages.
A growing disconnect between technological deflation (cheaper goods and services) and inflated living costs (housing, healthcare, education).
Thus, an economic model that ignores the fundamental relationship between money creation and technological productivity fails to account for the true forces shaping the modern world.

When money is printed beyond productive capacity, it inflates unsustainable markets (real estate, stocks, bonds). When liquidity dries up, crashes occur. A money supply-productivity framework would mitigate these shocks by keeping money creation proportional to real output.
It redefines economic growth beyond GDP

GDP growth fuelled by debt and government spending is not real productivity. By focusing on how much value is actually being created relative to money issued, we can measure whether an economy is progressing or simply inflating. It restores fairness in wealth distribution

In a Bitcoin or sound-money economy, wages should appreciate over time as productivity increases. Under inflationary fiat systems, wage earners suffer while asset holders thrive. A productivity-based measure would expose these distortions, forcing policymakers to justify monetary expansion.

The hypermodernist world demands new tools for measuring economic reality. Just as Newtonian physics was replaced by quantum mechanics to explain subatomic behaviour, the old economic frameworks must evolve.

A money supply-to-productivity model represents the first step toward this shift. By anchoring economic measurement to real value creation rather than manipulated price indices, we align macroeconomic policy with the digital age.

If technology is the defining force of the 21st century, then measuring money supply relative to productivity is the defining economic principle. The hypermodernist world is here—our economic models must catch up.

Taxation and Its Role in Inflation Control

In traditional economic thought, taxation is primarily viewed as a means of funding government expenditures. However, in a more nuanced monetary framework—particularly one informed by Modern Monetary Theory (MMT)—its role extends beyond simple revenue collection. Taxation serves as a fundamental mechanism for regulating the money supply and, consequently, influencing inflation. By removing money from circulation, taxes can act as a counterforce to excessive liquidity, mitigating inflationary pressures. Yet, the precise effect of taxation on inflation is not always straightforward. If tax revenue is immediately reintroduced into the economy through government spending, does it truly reduce inflation, or does it merely redirect purchasing power?

To understand taxation's role in inflation, it is necessary to consider the interaction between money supply, productivity, and demand. If the government increases the money supply beyond the rate of productivity growth, inflation occurs. Taxation, in theory, could counterbalance this by reducing the amount of money in circulation, but its effectiveness depends on what happens to the money once it is collected. If the state hoards tax revenue or uses it to pay down debt, it effectively removes liquidity from the system. However, if tax revenue is immediately spent back into the economy—on infrastructure, social programs, or government salaries—the reduction in monetary supply is largely neutralized. In this case, taxation does not inherently reduce inflation; it simply alters the flow of money rather than reducing its total volume.

The structure of taxation also plays a significant role in determining its inflationary or deflationary effects. Direct income taxation, for instance, reduces disposable income, lowering consumption and thereby exerting downward pressure on inflation. Consumption-based taxes (such as sales tax or VAT) increase the price of goods directly, which can create short-term inflationary effects even as they reduce overall demand. Meanwhile, corporate and capital gains taxes influence long-term investment and productivity growth, indirectly shaping inflationary trends over time.

A key question in formulating a new inflation model is whether taxation should be considered a true reduction in the money supply or merely a tool for controlling the velocity of money. If tax revenues are absorbed into government reserves or used to pay off debt, they function as a deflationary force, actively reducing available liquidity. However, in the context of MMT—where money is created first and taxed later—taxation is not a prerequisite for government spending. Instead, it serves as a tool for draining excess liquidity, ensuring that too much money does not chase too few goods. In this sense, MMT sees taxation as an instrument of inflation control rather than a means of funding state activity.

In contrast, under a sound-money system—such as one based on Bitcoin or gold—taxation would play a far more direct role in controlling the money supply. Since new money cannot be arbitrarily created, the total amount of circulating currency is fixed. In this case, taxation would function as a true deflationary mechanism, reducing the supply of money available for exchange. If the government collects taxes and does not immediately spend them, the overall money supply contracts, leading to lower prices and increased purchasing power over time.

The implications of this analysis are significant. In a hypermodernist economy, where technological advancements accelerate productivity growth, taxation policy must be carefully calibrated to ensure that monetary supply and productivity remain in balance. Excessive taxation in a high-productivity environment could lead to artificial deflation, discouraging investment and innovation. Conversely, inadequate taxation in an economy where money is being printed beyond productive output leads to inflationary spirals.

Ultimately, taxation should not be viewed in isolation but rather as one part of a broader economic framework that balances money supply, productivity, and long-term growth. A truly sustainable monetary system would align taxation policies with actual economic output, ensuring that inflation is neither artificially suppressed nor allowed to spiral out of control. Instead of treating taxation as a mere fiscal necessity, it should be understood as a dynamic tool for maintaining equilibrium between money, productivity, and time, ensuring that economic value remains anchored in real-world progress rather than artificial monetary expansion.

Inflation Metrics in the Era of Private Currency Issuance and Bitcoin-Based Economic Systems

The rise of private currency issuance and Bitcoin-based economic systems presents a paradigm shift in how we understand inflation. Unlike fiat-based monetary systems, where inflation is predominantly driven by centralized money supply expansion, decentralized monetary frameworks operate on vastly different principles. In these systems, inflation—or its inverse, deflation—is not dictated by arbitrary policy decisions but rather by fixed issuance rules, market demand, and competitive monetary standards.

In a system where private entities issue currency, inflation becomes a function of market discipline rather than state intervention. Private issuers—whether corporations, decentralized autonomous organizations (DAOs), or financial institutions—must balance the supply of their currency with its demand. If they expand the supply beyond the growth of productivity, the currency loses value relative to others in circulation, driving market-led depreciation rather than centrally measured inflation.

In a competitive private currency environment, issuers that expand their money supply without corresponding productivity increases will see depreciation relative to currencies that maintain discipline. Unlike fiat systems, where legal tender laws force adoption despite poor monetary policy, users in a free-market currency system will migrate toward the most stable and reliable medium of exchange.

This self-correcting mechanism makes private currency issuance inherently deflationary over time, as competition drives issuers to maintain scarcity-backed value. If one issuer excessively inflates supply, market actors shift to harder alternatives—whether other private currencies or Bitcoin—resulting in an automatic check on inflationary tendencies.

While Bitcoin-based systems offer theoretical perfection in monetary discipline, they introduce new questions:

How do economies handle liquidity shocks without the ability to adjust supply?
Can wages and contracts be easily adjusted in a deflationary environment?
Will economies function optimally if spending incentives are reduced due to rising purchasing power?

In contrast, private currency issuance introduces a competitive equilibrium—allowing monetary experimentation without reliance on a single standard. However, the challenge lies in ensuring issuers remain accountable, as historical evidence shows private monetary systems can collapse if confidence erodes.

Ultimately, the inflation metric we propose—grounded in money supply and productivity rather than CPI distortions—provides a clearer economic signal across all monetary regimes. Whether in fiat, private issuance, or Bitcoin-based economies, inflation should be measured as a function of real value creation rather than manipulated price indices.

Criticisms and Refinements

While **I = M - P** provides a clear and intuitive way to understand inflation, it is not without its limitations. Below, we explore key criticisms and ways to refine the model.

Money Supply is Hard to Define

Criticism:

4. What counts as "money"? M0, M1, M2, or even private credit and debt?
5. In an era of **digital assets, Bitcoin, and private currencies**, defining M becomes more complex.
6. Some argue that **velocity of money** (how often money changes hands) is just as important as supply.

Refinement:

- Instead of just using **M (money supply growth)**, we introduce **V (velocity of money)** as a factor: $I=(M\times V)-P$ This accounts for how actively money is used in the economy, not just how much exists.

Not All Productivity is Equal

Criticism:

- Our equation assumes **all productivity growth (P)** has the same impact on inflation.
- However, **some productivity gains are inflationary** (e.g., producing more luxury goods) while others are deflationary (e.g., automation reducing costs).

Refinement:

- Introduce a **quality factor (Q)** to measure how **productivity affects price levels**: $I=(M\times V)-(P\times Q)$
    - If **Q < 1**, productivity is mainly reducing costs (deflationary).
    - If **Q > 1**, productivity is increasing demand faster than supply (inflationary).

If Q is less than 1, productivity is mainly reducing costs, which is deflationary. If Q is greater than 1, productivity is increasing demand faster than supply, which is inflationary

Government Policy and Taxation Effects

Criticism:

- Governments **tax and spend**, which affects money supply but isn't captured in **M** alone.
- **MMT argues** that taxation is a tool to remove excess money from circulation, acting as an inflation control.

Refinement:

- Include **T (taxation effect)** in the equation, subtracting money withdrawn via taxes: $I=(M\times V)-(P\times Q)-T$
    - If **T is high**, inflation is reduced by money being removed.
    - If **T is low**, inflation rises as more money remains in circulation.

What About Supply Shocks and External Factors?

Criticism:

- Our model assumes inflation is **always monetary**.
- However, supply chain disruptions (e.g., oil crises, wars, pandemics) cause inflation without changes in M or P.

Refinement:

4. Introduce an **external shock variable (S)** to If Q is less than 1, productivity is mainly reducing costs, which is deflationary. If Q is greater than 1, productivity is increasing demand faster than supply, which is inflationarycapture non-monetary inflation causes: $I=(M\times V)-(P\times Q)-T+S$
    1. If **S > 0**, inflation is driven by external shocks like energy shortages.
    2. If **S < 0**, external factors (e.g., technological breakthroughs) are reducing prices.

"If S is greater than zero, inflation is driven by external shocks like energy shortages. If S is less than zero, external factors such as technological breakthroughs are reducing prices."

Final Refined Equation

After considering all refinements, our final **Inflation Dynamics Equation** looks like this:

$I=(M\times V)-(P\times Q)-T+S$

Where:

- **I** = Inflation If Q is less than 1, productivity is mainly reducing costs, which is deflationary. If Q is greater than 1, productivity is increasing demand faster than supply, which is inflationary
- **M** = Money supply growth
- **V** = Velocity of money
- **P** = Productivity growth
- **Q** = Productivity impact on prices (inflationary vs. deflationary)
- **T** = Taxation removing money from circulation
- **S** = Supply shocks or external economic factors

How the New Model Can Transform Private Currency Issuance and Drive Technological Development

Traditional fiat systems allow central banks to expand M (money supply) without direct productivity incentives. In contrast, private currencies (Bitcoin, stablecoins, corporate tokens) operate in more competitive environments where inflationary pressures must be transparent and market-driven.

Issuers must now justify M relative to P. Any increase in M (new token issuance) must be backed by productivity growth (P) and quality improvements (Q) to avoid inflationary collapse.
Velocity (V) becomes a crucial factor. Unlike fiat, where V fluctuates unpredictably, private currencies can actively design incentive mechanisms (staking, time-locks) to stabilize V and reduce inflation. Taxation (T) takes a new form. In decentralized systems, “tax” is not government-controlled but could emerge via network fees, protocol burns, or automated smart contract withdrawals.

A company issuing a stablecoin based on this model cannot simply mint new coins arbitrarily.
If M increases without P (productivity) or Q (quality of innovation) keeping pace, inflation rises, making the currency less attractive. This forces a dynamic where money issuance must track actual economic progress—preventing the uncontrolled debasement seen in fiat systems.

The model establishes a direct link between monetary expansion and productivity growth, meaning the only sustainable way to issue more money is by increasing technological efficiency.

Since P (productivity) must offset M (money supply growth), businesses and economies are pressured to innovate rather than rely on monetary expansion.
Deflationary pressure from automation and AI (high Q factor) makes labour-intensive industries obsolete faster.

Technological breakthroughs ($S < 0$) (S is less than zero) actively reduce inflation, rewarding those who adopt them early. Private digital economies must build incentive structures (staking, algorithmic burns) to balance M and P dynamically, forcing continuous development and R&D investments. If automation makes production more efficient, prices drop, benefiting savers and long-term planners. This creates a true hypermodern economy, where technological progress is the only path to monetary expansion.

AI, Bitcoin, and the Future of Economic Coordination

For centuries, economists have debated the most effective way to allocate resources, stabilize money, and drive innovation. The Austrian school holds that free markets, through price signals and entrepreneurial competition, are the most efficient means of economic coordination. However, what if a system could emerge that surpasses even the free market in its ability to allocate capital and issue currency? With the advent of artificial intelligence, combined with a Bitcoin-based monetary foundation, such a system may not only be possible but inevitable.

At its core, the free market functions through price discovery. Entrepreneurs, driven by profit and loss, respond to supply and demand imbalances, reallocating resources accordingly. This system, while highly effective, is constrained by human limitations—cognitive biases, incomplete information, and delayed reactions to economic changes. Even in a Bitcoin-based economy, where inflationary distortions are removed, human miscalculations can still lead to misallocated capital and inefficient resource use.

AI, however, operates without these limitations. Unlike humans, an AI-driven economic system could process vast amounts of data in real time, analyzing productivity levels, resource availability, and market demand with perfect accuracy. It would no longer rely on price signals that are distorted by speculation, but instead could dynamically adjust capital flows to where they are most needed. This means that in a Bitcoin economy, AI could act as an optimal currency issuer, ensuring that new money only enters circulation when justified by genuine increases in productivity and innovation.

Under such a system, Bitcoin would serve as the ultimate treasury reserve asset—providing a foundation of incorruptible, sound money—while AI would manage the issuance of transactional currency, responding to real-time economic conditions. This would eliminate inflation caused by excessive money printing while ensuring that economic liquidity remains sufficient to facilitate growth. Unlike traditional fiat systems, which require central banks to anticipate economic trends and adjust interest rates accordingly, an AI-driven model would react instantaneously, removing the lag and misjudgment inherent in human decision-making.

Beyond monetary policy, AI would revolutionize how capital is allocated for technological development. The Austrian school argues that competition and market forces drive innovation—bad businesses fail, while successful ones refine and improve their products. However, AI could enhance this process by identifying bottlenecks in technological progress and directing capital where it is most effective. If, for example, AI detects that traditional computing is approaching physical limits, it could instantly shift investment toward quantum computing or alternative solutions, eliminating stagnation and accelerating technological breakthroughs.

In practical terms, this would mean an economic system in which human-driven markets no longer determine the flow of capital. Instead, AI would act as the ultimate economic coordinator, ensuring that money issuance, taxation, and investment are optimized at every moment. Governments and financial institutions, rather than attempting to manipulate the economy through policy decisions, would take on a more passive role—allowing AI to dynamically adjust tax rates and spending in real time, based on productivity and economic demand.

This shift would mark the transition from a human-led economic order to an AI-managed one, where inefficiencies caused by speculation, misinformation, and delayed decision-making are eliminated. The free market, which has long been seen as the best available mechanism for economic coordination, may ultimately be replaced by an even more efficient system—one that transcends both Austrian and Keynesian economic models and operates on pure, real-time economic fundamentals.

The combination of Bitcoin and AI thus presents the potential for the ultimate economic system—one in which money is sound, inflation is eliminated, and capital is allocated with an intelligence far beyond human capabilities. If such a system were to be implemented, the very nature of economic theory would be rewritten, ushering in a new era where human-driven market forces are replaced by algorithmic precision and technological inevitability.

Conclusion: Rethinking Inflation for the 21st Century

Inflation has long been misrepresented as a mere fluctuation in consumer prices, measured through the narrow lens of the Consumer Price Index (CPI). However, this view fails to capture the deeper economic forces at play. As we have demonstrated, inflation is fundamentally a function of money supply growth exceeding productivity growth. When the issuance of new money outpaces the economy's ability to produce real goods and services, purchasing power erodes—not because of transient supply chain disruptions or shifting consumer preferences, but because excess liquidity chases a finite pool of resources.

This refined understanding of inflation demands a shift in economic policy. Rather than relying on CPI adjustments, interest rate tinkering, or reactive monetary interventions, policymakers must anchor money creation directly to real economic output. In a world where artificial intelligence and decentralized currencies like Bitcoin are reshaping financial systems, economic models must evolve beyond outdated Keynesian and fiat-based frameworks.

By linking monetary issuance to productivity, we can create a system that maintains monetary equilibrium, ensuring that growth is not artificially stifled while also preventing inflationary distortions. This approach would lead to a more stable, predictable economic environment—one where long-term investments flourish, technological progress accelerates, and wealth preservation becomes the norm rather than the exception.

Sheffield, a city built on industry and resilience, has the potential to become a beacon of technological progress and economic sovereignty in the 21st century. However, traditional economic models—anchored to fiat-based monetary policies and CPI-driven inflation measures—have stifled real growth, misallocating capital and discouraging long-term investment. Our new model, which ties inflation directly to the relationship between money supply growth and productivity, offers a transformative path forward, particularly in a city embracing private currency issuance.

By linking monetary expansion to real economic output, Sheffield could create an ecosystem where technological progress drives monetary issuance, rather than relying on external central bank policies. Imagine a private, city-backed currency where new issuance is directly proportional to the city’s productivity gains—whether in advanced manufacturing, AI-driven automation, or decentralized energy production. Under this framework, inflation is no longer a distortionary force but a self-regulating mechanism, ensuring that growth is sustainable and money remains sound.

This approach would accelerate investment in high-tech industries, as capital would naturally flow toward sectors that increase real productivity. AI-driven economic planning could optimize resource allocation, reducing inefficiencies and ensuring that innovation translates into real wealth creation rather than speculative bubbles. Sheffield’s history as a pioneer of industry could be revived—not through government subsidies or fiat-driven stimulus, but through a monetary system that rewards real economic contribution.

A private currency tied to productivity, backed by Bitcoin as a treasury reserve asset, would not only protect purchasing power but also incentivize entrepreneurship. Those who build, innovate, and contribute to the city’s economic engine would directly benefit, creating a culture of technological ambition and sustainable growth.

This is not just an economic theory—it is a blueprint for cities of the future, where money serves as a tool for real wealth creation rather than an instrument of inflationary manipulation. Sheffield could become the first test case, proving that sound money and technological progress go hand in hand, unleashing a new era of prosperity driven by human ingenuity and economic sovereignty.

If we believe culture is productive, let us build a monetary system that proves it.

Appendix #3 - Trustess, By Dr. Alexander Thorne

In 2028 Sheffield was a city reborn, pulsating with energy and resplendence under the summer sky. The birth of the Bitcoin era had transformed this industrial city into a thriving hub of technology and innovation. Amidst this profound transformation, James Dalton, a young Bitcoiner, was preparing for a night out in Kelham Island, the heart of the city's vibrant nightlife.

James's penthouse, a testament to his success, overlooked the transformed cityscape. Its metallic roots now glittered with digital vitality. Among the whirlwind of change, the city's heart, its soul, had remained - gritty, resilient, proud.

His friends, all fellow Bitcoiners, gathered in his open-plan living room, their excited chatter merging with the pulsating city soundscape outside. They shared tales of their recent escapades, recalling their last foray at a free party in the Peak District. The laughter and camaraderie were infectious, a collective celebration of their shared journey.

"Who'd have thought a few years back, during the lockdowns, we'd be here?" said Alex, his face alight with the exhilaration of the times. A murmur of agreement resonated in the room, a shared acknowledgement of the paradigm shift they'd experienced.

"The past feels like another lifetime," James agreed, his gaze fixed on the Sheffield skyline, an interplay of the city's industrial past and its digital future.

An autonomous Uber arrived to escort them to their destination. The ride to Kelham Island was a sensory experience in itself. Buildings adorned with LED screens showcased the pulsating digital heartbeat of the city, while the holographic billboards projected the promising future of Bitcoin.

As they alighted, the thumping bass of electronic music filled the air. Their destination was a former steel mill, its skeletal remains a canvas for Sheffield's renaissance. Its interiors glowed with neon lights, reflecting off the exposed steel beams and brickwork.

Inside, the mill thrummed with the collective euphoria of the Bitcoin boom. The crowd, a mix of miners, entrepreneurs, artists, and free thinkers, rode the wave of the digital revolution. They were the architects of the new age, celebrating their freedom and prosperity with wild abandon.

Conversations flowed as freely as the Bitcoin transactions. They spoke about the drastic societal shift, their newfound financial independence, and the stark contrast to the sombre times of the lockdowns. They reminisced, they speculated, they dreamt. They were no longer survivors but pioneers.

As James immersed himself in the jubilant crowd, he felt alive with the spirit of the times. This was the Roaring Twenties, a perfect blend of history and futurism. He was part of a revolution, a witness to a world-changing epoch, living the party of a lifetime.

The hedonism of the Roaring Twenties, in its modern reincarnation, was a spectacle to behold. The vast industrial space hummed with electronic music that resonated with the pulsating neon lights, creating an ambiance of euphoria. Silk-draped aerialists descended from the steel rafters, performing entrancing routines in time with the beat. Drones buzzed overhead, capturing the grandeur and sharing it with the world in real-time.

Around them, the party-goers, dressed in chic, neo-retro outfits, were an eclectic mix of individuals - innovators, artists, rebels, dreamers. They were the new-age Gatsby’s and Daisy’s, their wealth not inherited but earned through the digital gold rush of Bitcoin.

Bartenders, assisted by AI mixologists, were busy creating flamboyant cocktails, their hands moving in a hypnotic rhythm. Bitcoin transactions, instantaneous and seamless, took place over handheld devices, replacing traditional money exchanges.

James and his friends found themselves in the heart of the party. Their laughter echoed through the hall, their shared euphoria mirrored by everyone around them. The past hardships seemed like a distant, fading memory. The world outside was forgotten, replaced by the mesmerising spectacle of freedom and prosperity.

The music shifted, the bass notes deepening, drawing the crowd towards the dance floor. It was like a rhythmic call to celebrate their victories, their resilience, their newfound freedom. The hypnotic pulse of the beat took over, bodies swaying in time, lost in a shared rhythm.

Artists in the crowd sketched and painted, their creations a live testament to the energy around them. As the night wore on, these artworks were digitized and auctioned as NFTs, creating yet another layer of connection between the partygoers.

James, feeling the rush of the moment, could hardly believe how far they'd come. It felt like an extravagant dream, a Gatsby-esque tableau painted in neon hues. Yet, it was real, a reflection of a world changed, a celebration of a new era - the Bitcoin epoch of the Roaring Twenties. They were not just revelling in the party of the decade; they were living a revolution, shaping the future one Satoshi at a time.

As the night slipped into the early hours, James decided to step outside, the intensity of the party calling for a moment of respite. He left the pulsating interior, stepping out into the cool, still air of the Sheffield night. The cityscape, bathed in a soft, ambient glow, offered a serene contrast to the frenzied party inside.

Leaning against the cool, rough brick of the mill, he savoured the quiet, his mind still reverberating with the energy of the party. His thoughts meandered through the phenomenal change of the past few years, a change that had been as swift as it was dramatic.

Lost in thought, he didn't immediately notice the man approaching him. The man was tall and wore a well-tailored suit, an anachronism amidst the party's fashion landscape. His presence was commanding, his stride purposeful.

"James Dalton?" the man asked as he reached James. His voice was calm, a ripple of formality cutting through the cool night air.

James turned towards him, nodding. "That's me. Can I help you?"

The man held out a badge, the light catching on the MI5 emblem. "Agent Carter, MI5," he introduced himself. "I believe we have something to discuss."

In the quiet, serene corner outside the party, the agent briefed James on the situation. A group, the Fiat Revivalists, aimed to destabilise the Bitcoin system that had brought so much prosperity and freedom to the people. They were a threat to this vibrant new world, a spectre looming over the bright future they were all working towards.

“They are terrorists. They seek to destroy bitcoin and the revolution. Our interest is not Bitcoin…only the preservation of law and order,” Carter said, choosing his words carefully. “I believe we might both have a mutual interest,” Carter told James, who could feel his pride swelling. James felt a surge of responsibility as Agent Carter's words sank in. He had reaped the benefits of this new era, celebrated its victories, and now, it was time to fight for it. The party inside continued unabated, oblivious to the storm that was brewing.

James's mind was a whirlwind as he re-entered the steel mill, the pulsating music and neon lights a stark contrast to the gravity of what he had just learned. He pulled together his friends, and dropped hints about the threat of the Fiat revivalists, and his future. Though, he mused to himself, they were too far gone to remember much of what he had said.

As they left the mill, their destination was a woodworking warehouse in Neepsend, notorious for its decadent afterparties. Their Uber cruised through the sleeping city, its silent hydrogen engine a ghost-like contrast to the hum of life inside the vehicle. The party-goers of Sheffield were far from finished; the Roaring Twenties weren't about to be silenced by the rhythmical rising and setting of the sun.

The warehouse in Neepsend was a hidden gem, a sanctuary for the nocturnal innovators and revellers. Its exterior was deceptively rustic, giving no hint of the ultra-modern, hedonistic playground within.

As they stepped inside, the warehouse sprung to life. Industrial machinery was still there, intermingled with woodworking machines and open spaces for dancefloors. Far from a simple workshop, the space was largely given away to an enchanting futuristic world of pleasure. Holographic projectors painted shifting, surreal landscapes on the high brick walls, transporting party-goers to fantastical realms. The towering wooden structures, reminders of the warehouse's past, stood as rustic sculptures adorned with glowing LED lights, creating a mesmerising blend of old and new.

As they made their way through the crowd, the air was thick with exhilaration. Conversations hummed around them, infused with the ideas and dreams that were shaping this new era. The music was a hypnotic fusion of electronic and jazz, a nod to the original Roaring Twenties, with an undeniable infusion of the future.
Amidst the hedonistic revelry, however, James and his friends were acutely aware of their newfound mission. They were not just part of this Bitcoin epoch, they were now its protectors. The night was far from over, and the future was calling. The real party, it seemed, was just getting started.

As the sun began to peek over the horizon, painting the sky in hues of orange and pink, the after-party began to wind down. James and his friends found themselves in the warehouse's courtyard, the fresh morning air a welcome relief from the heady atmosphere inside.

They settled on a reclaimed wooden bench, their laughter and conversation ebbing into quiet contemplation. The revelry of the night had been an exuberant celebration of their newfound wealth and freedom. Yet, as they sat in the courtyard, watching the first light of the day touch the historic cityscape, their thoughts were firmly on the future.

Alex broke the silence, "When we first started this Bitcoin journey, I never imagined we'd end up here."

"Yeah," Sophia chimed in, her voice thoughtful, "It's been a wild ride. I mean, remember 2020?"

They all winced at the memory. The lockdowns, the despair, the isolation - it seemed like a different lifetime.

"But look at us now," James murmured, his gaze drifting over the city they'd grown to love, "Look at Sheffield. We're not just surviving, we're thriving."

Their conversation flowed, the camaraderie palpable in the quiet morning air. They discussed the astounding transformation Sheffield had undergone, from a city struggling with the repercussions of lockdown to a flourishing hub of innovation and prosperity.

They shared their dreams for the future - of a world built on the principles of decentralization and financial independence that Bitcoin promised. They talked about the possibilities and the challenges, of the technological advancements they wished to see, and the societal changes they hoped to influence and the sacrifices they would make to get there.

As they sat there, in the dawning light of a new day, the euphoria of the night had made way for a sense of purpose. This was their moment, their generation's defining challenge. The hedonism of the Roaring Twenties was a testament to their success, but building a new future - that was their mission.

Their laughter rang out again, not just in celebration of their wealth but in anticipation of the challenges that lay ahead. They were ready to shape the future, one block in the time-stamp server at a time. As the sun rose higher, marking the beginning of a new day, they knew they were on the cusp of a new era.

After all, this was more than just the Roaring Twenties. This was the dawn of the Bitcoin Epoch.

"Let's not forget, though," James said, his voice taking on a serious tone as he broached the subject of the Fiat Revivalists. "We've got a fight on our hands."

There was a collective nod, an understanding of the gravity of the situation. The group fell silent, the laughter and banter of earlier momentarily forgotten.

"These Fiat Revivalists," he continued, "they're not just a threat to us or to Bitcoin. They're a threat to the freedom we've won, the prosperity we're enjoying."

He paused, scanning the faces of his friends. In the clear morning light, their determination was evident.

"They want to take us back to a system that failed us, that led to the recession and the economic despair we experienced." James's voice was hard, his usual jovial demeanour replaced by resolve. "They want to bring back centralized control, the manipulation, the inequality."

"But we've seen a better way," he added, his gaze returning to the horizon, "And we're not going to let that happen. We've been given a chance to build a better future, and we're going to fight for it."

The group fell into silence, the weight of their mission settling in. But it wasn't a silence of defeat; it was a silence of determination, a pause before the storm. They were young, successful, and influential. They were part of the Bitcoin revolution, and now, they had a responsibility to protect it.

As the sun climbed higher in the sky, bathing Sheffield in its warm, golden light, they stood together. This was their city, their world, their future. And they were ready to defend it.

The Fiat Revivalists had just become their first real challenge in this new era, a stark reminder that the fight for the future was far from over. As the echoes of the previous night's debauchery faded, replaced by the sobering light of day, their resolve hardened.

This was more than a battle over currency. It was a battle for the future, and they were ready to face it head-on.

James knew he had to play to his strengths, to utilize the world he was familiar with. So, he hatched a plan both grand and audacious, one that would shake up Sheffield like never before.

He decided to host a monumental party, an event so extravagant and ostentatious that it would not just lure the business community but would inevitably draw the Fiat Revivalists out of the shadows.

His mind buzzed with ideas. He envisioned an opulent celebration, a manifestation of the prosperity and euphoria brought on by the Bitcoin revolution. A night filled with glamour, entertainment, and the crème de la crème of Sheffield's business community.

The location would be key. He needed a place that represented the essence of Sheffield - the juxtaposition of its rich industrial heritage and its burgeoning digital future. He settled on the iconic Magna Science Adventure Centre - a transformed steel mill that perfectly encapsulated Sheffield's evolution.

He began reaching out to his extensive network of contacts, sending out cryptographically secure digital invitations. The guest list was meticulously curated, featuring the prominent figures in the Bitcoin community, technology innovators, entrepreneurs, local dignitaries, and influential business leaders. Among them, he suspected, some would be Fiat Revivalists.

He invested into creating an unforgettable spectacle. World-renowned artists were booked, immersive tech installations commissioned, and a mouth-watering array of food and drink arranged, with transactions to be made entirely in Bitcoin.

The buzz in the city grew as the day approached. The press speculated, the public was intrigued, and the city's elite were eager. After all, a party by James was known to be an exceptional affair, and this promised to be his grandest yet.

And amidst all the anticipation, James found himself on a knife-edge of excitement and tension. For, hidden within the pomp and circumstance, was a serious mission. This was more than just a party; it was a trap, designed to lure out those threatening the world he was a part of. The stakes were high, and the game was on.

The night of the party arrived, and the old steel mill was transformed into a scene straight out of a future era. High-tech installations glowed and blinked, casting a surreal glow on the structure's rusted, industrial bones. Guests began pouring in, the sound of conversation and clinking glasses filling the air.

James stood at the entrance, greeting his guests. His mind, however, was elsewhere - analysing the crowd, watching for signs of the Revivalists. Yet, he knew the real game would only begin once everyone was at ease, lost in the glamour and euphoria of the night.

Once the party was in full swing, James circulated through the crowd. He made small talk, subtly gauged reactions, listened for undertones of dissent. He had done his homework, knew who to watch, who to engage.

The night wore on, the revelry growing wilder. Yet, in the middle of it all, James never lost sight of his mission. He started floating the idea of a massive Bitcoin investment, carefully watching for reactions, for signs of opposition or discomfort.

In one such conversation, he noticed a pair of guests exchanging a fleeting, meaningful glance. The pair were leaders of a major local manufacturing firm, known for their conservative business approach but never openly opposed to Bitcoin.

James pursued the lead, striking up a conversation with them. He subtly introduced his massive Bitcoin initiative, noting their reactions closely. There was a momentary hesitation, a brief exchange of glances between them - it wasn't much, but it was a start.

As dawn approached, James knew he had found a thread to pull on. This wasn't conclusive proof of their involvement with the Fiat Revivalists, but it was enough to dig deeper, to investigate further.

As the party ended and the last guests trickled out, James couldn't help but feel a rush of adrenaline. His grand scheme, the elaborate ploy, had borne fruit. The road to uncovering the Fiat Revivalists was not going to be easy, but he had made a promising start.

He looked around the emptying hall, the signs of the night's hedonistic revelry all around him. Yet, within this, he had sparked the first flame of resistance against the Fiat Revivalists. James was now not just a Bitcoiner or a wealthy entrepreneur; he was a defender of the new era, the Bitcoin Epoch, ready to take on those who threatened it.

The sun had barely broken over the Sheffield horizon as James found himself back at his apartment, sitting at his state-of-the-art computer. His heart was still pounding from the night, but it wasn’t the grandeur of the party or the effects of the flowing champagne – it was the prospect of the task ahead.

He pulled up information on the two individuals he'd identified at the party. Their names were Paul and Lydia Davis, co-owners of a local manufacturing giant, a company that, he discovered, had suffered considerable losses during the Bitcoin boom due to a refusal to adapt to the new economic landscape.

He scoured the blockchain, looking for any transactions that linked back to the pair or their business. His experience in Bitcoin mining had honed his ability to follow the trace of transactions across the public ledger. Hours turned into days as James dug deeper, sifting through data, looking for the connection he needed.

In his relentless pursuit, he stumbled upon a series of seemingly unconnected transactions leading back to a shell corporation with links to the Davis's firm. It was a complex web of transactions designed to obscure, but not enough to hide from someone who knew what to look for.

Armed with this information, James got back in touch with Agent Carter. His findings were met with a cautious optimism. They didn't have any concrete evidence yet, but it was the lead they desperately needed.

In the days that followed, James took his investigation further, navigating the city's bustling business scene, attending meetings, luncheons, playing the part of the successful entrepreneur while surreptitiously gathering more intel. He was cautious, knowing that one wrong move could alert his targets.

Every conversation, every interaction, was a piece of the puzzle, and James was drawing a picture of a discreet but powerful Fiat Revivalist movement. The Davis's were just the start, he realised; this was bigger than he'd initially thought.

As the Bitcoin world continued its forward march, James found himself on the frontline of a hidden war. His world was no longer just parties and digital fortunes; it was now a battle to protect the very foundation of their new era. He was in deep, embroiled in a conflict with the past, fighting for a future he firmly believed in.

And in his heart, James knew, there was no turning back.

In the subsequent weeks, James transformed from a partying bitcoin enthusiast into a full-fledged investigator. He continued to mingle in social gatherings, skilfully probing, testing waters, and connecting the dots. All the while, he kept Agent Carter updated on his progress. His apartment became a veritable war-room, filled with screens showing data charts, profiles of persons of interest, and a large Sheffield map pin-pointing the locations of suspected Revivalists.

As James delved deeper, he became increasingly concerned with the extent of the Revivalists' reach. He discovered a network of influential business leaders, politicians, and technocrats who were quietly rallying against the Bitcoin revolution. It was as if a shadowy, old world order was refusing to fade away, lurking in the corners of this new age.

Despite this, James remained undeterred. His resolve only strengthened, fuelled by a firm belief in the democratizing power of Bitcoin. He continued to uncover more links, meticulously building a comprehensive picture of the Revivalist network.

One night, while following a trail of transactions, James stumbled upon a suspicious pattern leading to an offshore account. The account was a nexus, receiving and sending large amounts of funds from various sources. Upon further investigation, he found a connection between the account and a prominent member of Parliament with a known history of scepticism towards Bitcoin.

This was a breakthrough James hadn't expected. His findings implicated a powerful political figure, a revelation that would shake the entire Bitcoin community and beyond. He immediately informed Agent Carter. This was it; they had a crucial lead that could bring the Revivalists out into the open.

In the light of this discovery, the danger and the stakes became even more apparent. James knew the battle ahead wouldn't be easy. The Revivalists had influence and resources, but he had the truth on his side.

The mission was no longer just about protecting Bitcoin, but about exposing the corruption and power plays that threatened to destabilize the progress made. As the lines between the digital and real-world blurred, James realised his role in this struggle was bigger than he'd ever imagined.

His life had changed in unimaginable ways, and there was no going back. The parties, the flamboyance, and the easy-going lifestyle of his past felt like distant memories. He was now a soldier in the battle for a fair and transparent financial future. It was a fight he was ready for, one transaction at a time.

In this Bitcoin-fuelled revelry, the limits of the past were constantly being challenged and redefined. It was an era of digital hedonism, the pursuit of pleasure amplified by technology, as if the very concept of excess had been reimagined for this new age.

In the heart of Sheffield's resurgent neighbourhood, on a crisp summer evening, the grand neo-gothic facade of James's mansion illuminated the twilight sky. He was hosting another party. And it wasn't just any party; it was a declaration - a display of the Bitcoin era's unabashed vibrance and grandeur.

As the hour of the party approached, guests started arriving in self-driving cars and hydrogen rickshaws, their silhouettes aglow in the neon-lit streets.

Stepping onto the cobblestone pavement, they were met with a spectacular sight: the mansion transformed into a dazzling palace of light and sound.

Within its walls, an enormous atrium was converted into a breathtaking ballroom, awash with holographic displays and dynamic lights, painting ethereal illusions onto the soaring brick walls. A sprawling, transparent dome stretched above, revealing the starlit night sky, while floating drones, equipped with cameras, hovered silently, capturing every moment.

James moved effortlessly among his guests, his charisma as captivating as the spectacular party around him. The crowd was a cross-section of the city's populace - artists, intellectuals, entrepreneurs, tech visionaries, all brought together by the transformative power of Bitcoin.

He conversed with a group of artists, their latest work auctioned in digital tokens, their expressions brought to life by augmented reality headsets. There were whispers about an AI painting that had recently sold for millions, the transaction etched indelibly onto the blockchain.

Next, he found himself amid a heated discussion about Quantum computing's potential impact on Bitcoin's encryption protocols. The debate was alive with opposing views and predictions, the discourse a fascinating blend of philosophy and technology.

He met Bitcoin miners, their operations now powered entirely by renewable energy. He listened to their tales about the early days of mining, their words painting vivid pictures of basements filled with buzzing servers, now replaced by sprawling, solar-powered data farms.

Across the room, a live band was playing a high-energy tune, their music enhanced by a 360-degree sound system and holographic visualizations. But it wasn't just for the guests; the performance was being streamed live, with digital tickets purchased over lightning from across the globe.

James's attention was caught by the spectacular bar, a floating, self-serving automaton, mixing and serving drinks while interacting with guests. People stood around, engaged in conversations about the decentralization of finance, the autonomy of personal wealth, their words punctuated by laughter and the clink of glasses.

Through his interactions and observations, James saw the future unfolding before his eyes. It was a future that was innovative, inclusive, and revolutionary. The party wasn't just a celebration of the present, but also a toast to a promising and exciting future.

In certain corners of the mansion, guests engaged in augmented reality drug experiences. Biodegradable patches, no larger than a postage stamp, were attached to the skin, releasing a mix of synthetic compounds into the bloodstream. The patches interacted with wearable tech, combining neuro-stimulation and sensory enhancements to create experiences that transcended the ordinary limitations of physical euphoria. They took the users on ethereal trips, from floating through astral plains to diving deep into the labyrinth of their consciousness.

Drinks flowed freely, each one a crafted molecular gastronomy, carrying compounds that lifted spirits, induced relaxation, and in some cases, enhanced empathic connections. Guests lost themselves in a euphoric haze, their laughter echoing off the mansion's high ceilings, their senses heightened, and inhibitions lowered.

James, navigating through the pulsating crowd, stumbled upon a nondescript door half-hidden behind a tapestry. Curiosity piqued, he pushed open the door, revealing a dimly lit room awash in sensual opulence.

An orgy was unfolding, with bodies moving together in a mesmerizing choreography of passion and pleasure. The room was filled with a mix of scents - musk, exotic oils, intoxicating pheromones. The spectacle was enhanced by the glow of bioluminescent tattoos adorning the participants, their bodies lit up in radiant patterns that pulsed with their movements. The display of sexual liberation was as starkly confronting as it was artistically captivating.

James stood in the doorway, taking in the scene. The era of Bitcoin had brought about changes that were impossible to fathom just a decade ago. Society was shedding old inhibitions and embracing an unfettered exploration of human desires. It was a brave new world, breathtaking and daunting in equal measures.

James, always one to immerse himself fully in the experiences life had to offer, allowed himself to be drawn in, to become a part of this eclectic tableau of humanity. ‘Make Love not War,’ was the motto of this new epoch at any rate. The party outside seemed a world away as he navigated through this intimate landscape, joining in the communal celebration of freedom that felt so very symbolic of this new Bitcoin era.

Caught in the throbbing heart of pleasure and hedonism, James hesitated for a moment. The glow of bioluminescent tattoos, the ethereal blend of scents, the low hum of pleasure - it was intoxicating, like a siren's song. The decision was easy. As much as he was a soldier in a secret war, he was also a child of this era, born and baptized in the ecstasy of liberation. He shed his clothes, his inhibitions at the door, and joined the writhing mass of bodies.

Every touch was electrified, every whisper a promise of pleasure. He became one with the others, their bodies merging and separating in a passionate dance. The bioluminescent tattoos on his own skin began to pulse, the light changing rhythm with his increasing heartbeat. The sensation was surreal, as if he had become part of a living, breathing artwork of passion and desire.

Just as he was losing himself in the ecstasy, a loud, shattering sound echoed through the mansion. It was jarring, out of place in the orchestrated symphony of hedonism. The orgy participants froze, the electric atmosphere rupturing into a sudden, unnerving silence.

The sound, a disruptive, mechanical alarm, was coming from the main atrium. It was the mansion's security system. A breach? In the midst of this opulence, danger seemed an alien concept, yet it had arrived, unwelcome and unannounced.

James, pulled abruptly from the ecstasy, hastily grabbed his clothes. His mind, transitioning from the fog of pleasure to the sharpness of impending danger, raced to understand the situation. This was his home, his sanctuary, and it was under threat.

As he sprinted out of the room, the mansion transforming from a haven of hedonism to a potential battleground, he couldn't shake off the creeping dread. He was not just James, the Bitcoin tycoon, anymore. He was the guardian of this new world, and he had a fight to face.

As the reality of the situation crystallized, a knot of adrenaline and fear tightened in James's stomach. The Fiat Revivalists were here. His home, his sanctuary, had been invaded. He raced down the winding staircase, the pulsating neon lights casting long, unsettling shadows.

The basement was shrouded in an eerie calm. Sleek, matte black, 3D-printed firearms lay arranged in a secure case. He'd had them printed years ago, a necessary precaution in an increasingly volatile world, but he'd never imagined he'd have to use them in his own home.

With practiced movements, he slipped a form-fitting, bulletproof vest over his head and loaded a semi-automatic pistol with high-density, polymer rounds. He could hear the cacophony above, the panicked screams of his guests, the harsh orders of the attackers.

He gripped the pistol, its cold, hard surface strangely grounding amidst the chaos. His mind flashed back to the orgy, the sensory overload, the ethereal bliss, and he couldn't help but marvel at the absurdity of the situation. Just moments ago, he was revelling in the heights of hedonism, and now, he was about to engage in a battle.

He shook off the fear, allowing the cold clarity of survival to take over. This was his fight, the culmination of all the warnings, all the preparation. His body still hummed with the sensory echoes, the glow of his bioluminescent tattoos flickering in the dim light, as he steeled himself.

With one last deep breath, he started his ascent back to the atrium. The Fiat Revivalists had brought the war to his doorstep. But he was ready. He would fight, not just for himself, but for this new world, this brave, hedonistic, Bitcoin-fuelled future. And he would not let it crumble.

The Revialists had taken hostages.

His eyes scanned the hostages; among them were his closest allies and friends. Grace, a brilliant software engineer with a biting wit, her usually bright eyes now clouded with fear. Victor, a tough-talking former miner with a heart of gold, his fists clenched in helpless rage. And Emily, a young artist who had pioneered the use of bioluminescent tattoos, her usually vibrant glow dulled in the grim situation.

The Fiat Revivalists, with no demands or questions, with the lights still shimmering and illuminating the darkness, started to retreat – hostages in tow. James counted 6 hostages. They were pulling out of the ballroom and James didn't know whether to shoot and try to rescue them, or let the Fiat Revivalists win this round. The last thing he wanted to do was kill a hostage. He lowered he weapon and without a moments more notice, the hostages and attackers were out of the ballroom, out of the mansion and away into the night.

James stood in shock. This was war.

As the dust of battle settled, the remnants of the grand party stood empty. The mansion, which just hours before was a beacon of euphoria and freedom, now lay in disarray. Neon lights flickered intermittently, illuminating the scattered debris of the once resplendent setting - torn streamers, shattered glassware, and the haunting echo of music that was once the lifeblood of the celebration.

James, his body still buzzing from the adrenaline of the fight, moved quickly towards his study. He had a direct line to MI5, a stark red button hidden behind an inconspicuous panel on the mahogany bookshelf. This was a war he could not win alone, and it was time to call in reinforcements.

As he pushed the button, he could feel the weight of the situation pressing down on him. The euphoria of the Bitcoin age, the liberation it had brought - it was all at risk. The Fiat Revivalists were a potent threat, but he was resolute. He had a world to protect, and he wouldn't back down now.

The attack on James's mansion sent tremors through the fabric of the nation. The news was everywhere - on the screens of every Bitcoin exchange, in the whispers of parliamentarians, and on the front pages of every media outlet. The home invasion had become a national crisis.

The Sheffield Bitcoin community, usually concealed behind anonymous transactions and PGP keys, was rattled. For them, this was an attack not just on James, but on the very ideals they had come to represent: freedom, independence, and the promise of a decentralized future.

They convened an emergency session, while the twitter feeds fervently debated the implications of the incident. The commmunity was on edge, the tension palpable as both sides of the Bitcoin debate clashed in heated exchanges. The Fiat Revivalists had clearly learnt a thing or two from the Bitcoiners about the need for anonymity and privacy; they were more secretive and private than the bitcoiners.

Within the Bitcoin community a different kind of mobilization was underway. A core group of influencers, investors, and thinkers, known for their significant contributions to the Bitcoin ecosystem, decided to take matters into their own hands. Unwilling to wait for governmental action to rescue the hostages, they convened a virtual assembly on the encrypted networks they typically used for Bitcoin transactions.

One by one, the screens lit up with faces, some well-known in the industry, others showing themselves for the first time. They were known by their PGP keys, their Bitcoin addresses, their groundbreaking codes and concepts. But today, they showed their faces, their determination evident.

From his study, James looked out onto the sea of faces on the screen. It was a motley crew of brilliant minds and stubborn wills, unified by a common goal. The Fiat Revivalists had started this war, but the Bitcoiners, in their collective decentralised strength, were prepared to end it. Together, they began to strategize, ready to reclaim their future.

In the heart of the virtual space, James initiated a private meeting with the elite of the Bitcoin community. They hailed from diverse fields - cryptography, economics, law, software engineering - yet they were united in their shared belief in Bitcoin's potential to redefine society.

Dubbing themselves 'The Fellowship of the Coin', they convened to address the crisis at hand. Their first and foremost task: the rescue of the hostages. Each member was acutely aware of the stakes, with friends and colleagues among the captured.

"As you all know," began James, his face serious against the backdrop of his ruined mansion, "we are facing an unprecedented threat. Not just to us individually, but to the entire ecosystem we have built. We have to retrieve our friends and neutralise the Fiat Revivalists."

Nods of agreement flashed across the screens. Strategies began to flow, each member contributing their unique perspective to the planning. The coders suggested infiltrating the Revivalists' communication systems, the economists contemplated the financial repercussions, while the legal minds focused on ensuring their actions stayed within the boundaries of the law.

The meeting stretched into hours, the virtual space filled with heated discussions, vigorous debates, and collective brainstorming. Yet the mood remained resolute. The Fellowship of the Coin was determined to bring their friends home, to protect the world they had built from the ashes of the old financial system, and to uphold the values that Bitcoin stood for - decentralisation, freedom, and resilience.

In the face of adversity, they found unity, their combined expertise a beacon of hope amid the turmoil. Their mission was clear, their resolve unshakeable. The Fellowship of the Coin was ready to wage war on the Fiat Revivalists. Their battleground: the complex web of Bitcoin. Their weapons: their unrivalled knowledge of the Bitcoin infrastructure. Their goal: the safe return of their friends and the protection of their shared future.

Over the next day, the Fellowship of the Coin worked tirelessly, mapping out the intricate networks the Fiat Revivalists operated within. Using their extensive knowledge of the Bitcoin blockchain, they tracked down every transaction, every communication, every hint of the Revivalists' operations.

This was a war of intellects, fought not on physical battlefields, but within the circuits and nodes of the Bitcoin network. With every piece of information they gathered, the Fellowship grew more adept at anticipating the Revivalists' moves.

The chatrooms continued to buzz with updates about the crisis, speculating on the outcomes and whipping up the public into a frenzy. The Fellowship held multiple emergency sessions, and law enforcement agencies were on high alert.

Still, the Fellowship worked in silence, their actions unnoticed by the public eye. They were an invisible force, moving through the network with purpose and precision. Their shared goal of rescuing their friends and defending their way of life fuelled their relentless pursuit of the Revivalists.

Finally, after days of intensive work, they made a breakthrough. They traced a significant amount of the Revivalists' transactions to a particular server, hidden deep within the darknet. This was it. The heart of the Revivalists' operation.

In this high-stakes game of chess, the Fellowship had made their move. The board was set. It was time for the Revivalists to respond. What followed next would decide the fate of their friends, and the future of Bitcoin in Britain.

The Fiat Revivalists were an enigmatic group, a shadowy assembly of disgruntled economists, disenfranchised financial workers, and failed philosophers. They held a fanatical belief in the old ways - the traditional monetary system. They saw Bitcoin, with its decentralised power and lack of governmental control, as an affront to their world view.

Their operation centre, which the Fellowship had traced, was located in an abandoned industrial complex on the outskirts of Sheffield. A vast building that once served as a steel mill, it stood tall and intimidating, a grim relic of the city's past. Now, it was a fortress, harbouring those who sought to destabilize the Bitcoin-led society.

The complex was a labyrinth of dark, winding corridors, massive, echo-filled halls, and a maze of abandoned machinery. Its size and layout made it ideal for clandestine operations, offering multiple escape routes and plenty of hideouts. However, it also gave the Fellowship potential points of infiltration.

James and Victor pored over every satellite image they could get, every floor plan of the facility they found in public records. They discovered the servers were likely located in the deepest part of the complex, the old furnace room, due to its need for extensive power supply.

Armed with this knowledge, they devised a plan. They would infiltrate the complex under the cover of darkness, navigating through the maze of iron and steel, towards the furnace room. They didn't know the specifics of what security measures the Revivalists had in place, but they had to be prepared for anything. The element of surprise was their biggest advantage, and they intended to use it.

As the Fellowship prepared for their daring mission, they knew they faced formidable foes. However, they were buoyed by their belief in Bitcoin and the principles it embodied. They would risk everything to defend it, and to rescue their friends.

James had reached out to experts in 3D printing who were also Bitcoin enthusiasts. They spent days designing weapons tailored to the mission, everything from compact handguns to non-lethal stun devices. With their technical knowledge and the versatility of 3D printing, they quickly built an arsenal that would provide the Fellowship with firepower and variety.

Alongside this, James managed to contact a couple of former SAS operatives, convincing them to join their cause. Their training, experience, and battle-hardened resolve would be invaluable in the mission ahead.

In the run-up to the raid, the Fellowship met. They reviewed their plan over and over again, memorising every route and contingency. They trained with the 3D printed weapons, learning how to handle and operate them efficiently. The former SAS operatives shared tips and strategies, turning the Bitcoin experts into a crude, yet determined force.

The day of the raid arrived. It was a cloudy, overcast day, the gloomy weather reflecting the tense atmosphere that hung over the group. The Fellowship gathered in an inconspicuous location on the outskirts of Sheffield, their faces lit by the soft glow of their laptop screens as they made the final preparations.

The chatter was minimal, the gravity of what they were about to undertake sinking in. Yet, despite the tension, there was an undercurrent of determination, a shared resolve that strengthened them.

With a final nod from James, they set off. They moved in unison, their steps echoing in the empty streets as they headed towards the abandoned complex. They knew the night would be fraught with danger, but they were ready to face it. For their friends, for Bitcoin, and for the future they believed in. It was time for the Fellowship of the Coin to make their stand.

In the days leading up to the raid, James and his assembled group spent hours preparing. They gathered in the dim light of a closed down warehouse, a large satellite image of the industrial complex projected onto a makeshift screen. The former SAS operatives, Jake and Liam, spearheaded the meeting, their seasoned eyes scanning the layout of the building.

Jake cleared his throat, the silence quickly descending on the group. "This is our entry point," he said, pointing to an unassuming access door in the side of the steel mill. "From there, we'll need to move quickly, quietly, and most importantly, together."

The group nodded, the gravity of their mission causing a visible ripple of tension. James, however, maintained an intense focus, his gaze fixed on the blueprint.

"From the entrance," Liam continued, tracing a path through the complex maze of machinery and infrastructure, "we'll head to the heart of the facility, the furnace room. That's where the servers are, and likely where our friends are being held."

There was a pause as everyone absorbed the information. Questions were asked, from the simple to the complex. The 3D-printed weapons were examined, the heft and feel of them a grim reminder of what was to come.

James stood up, meeting the eyes of each person in turn. "We're doing this for our friends, for our beliefs. We're up against a group who wants to see us fail, who wants to see the world we've worked to build crumble. We cannot, will not, let that happen."

His speech was met with nods of agreement, a shared resolve filling the room. They spent the rest of the night going over the plan, practising scenarios, preparing for what they knew would be a challenging mission.

They infiltrated the complex as planned, moving in silent unison. Jake and Liam led the charge, their expertise guiding the group through the labyrinth of steel and iron. They reached the heart of the facility, the ominous hum of servers filling the air.

An alarm pierced the silence. Red warning lights washed the room, armed figures emerging from the shadows. The Fiat Revivalists. Gunfire erupted, the cacophony of chaos echoing around the room. James, amidst the panic, spotted a door leading to the underground bunkers.

"I'm going for the hostages!" he yelled, breaking away from the firefight and sprinting towards the door. Despite the danger, the uncertainty, he pushed on, propelled by the thought of his captive friends and the future he was fighting for.

Bullets whizzed past as the echo of gunfire intensified, transforming the vast furnace room into a battlefield. Jake and Liam, despite being outnumbered, provided a staunch defence, their training shining through the chaos. The members of the Fellowship, even those with no formal combat training, held their ground, the 3D-printed weapons in their hands becoming an extension of their resolve.

Still, the Fiat Revivalists were unyielding. Several of the Fellowship were hit, their cries of pain piercing through the cacophony. James, his heart pounding in his chest, could only hope that their injuries were not severe.

Descending into the underground bunkers, James found himself in a dimly lit corridor. The air was stagnant, filled with the faint hum of machinery. Following the blueprint in his mind, he navigated through the labyrinth, every corner potentially hiding a hostile.

He finally arrived at a heavily fortified door. Swallowing hard, he applied a small, 3D-printed explosive device onto the lock. After a tense few seconds, the door blew open, a cloud of dust filling the air.

As the dust settled, he stepped inside, his heart catching in his throat. There, tied up and looking worse for wear but alive, were his friends. Their eyes widened at the sight of him, relief washing over their faces. He quickly untied them, helped them to their feet, and led them back towards the chaos of the battle above.

The fight was far from over, and the stakes had just risen. James was no longer fighting just for an idea, but for the lives of his friends, his comrades, his fellow soldiers in the war for a decentralized future. It was a fight they could not afford to lose.

The battle raged on, bullets ricocheting off metal surfaces, the smell of gunpowder and fear heavy in the air. James and his group were outnumbered, but not outmatched. Each of them fought with the tenacity of those who had everything to lose.

In the heart of the Fiat Revivalist stronghold, James finally found the hostages. Their faces were a mixture of fear and relief as he helped them to their feet, whispering words of comfort and reassurance.

Just as he was guiding them towards the exit, the door swung open, revealing a figure that made James's heart skip a beat. It was Agent Carter, his usual composed demeanour replaced with a tense, guarded expression. His hand was on his gun, his gaze scanning the room before landing on James and the hostages.

James felt a jolt of surprise and a rush of adrenaline. Was Carter here to help them, or was there a darker reason for his presence in the midst of this chaos? But there was no time to debate; they had to get the hostages to safety. James nodded at Carter, hoping that his instincts were right, that the agent was on their side.

As they began their tense journey back towards the entrance, hostages en-tow, the sounds of the battle became more distant, but no less intense. James felt a surge of hope. If they could just make it out, they could regroup, plan their next move. James gripped his weapon tighter, prepared to fight for their lives and their freedom, every step of the way.

The sudden silence that fell over the bunker was almost as deafening as the gunfire had been. James surveyed the aftermath, heart pounding in his chest. Against the odds they had won and he had survived. They'd rescued their friends and dismantled the Fiat Revivalist stronghold. He couldn't help the relief that washed over him.

But his relief was short-lived. From the corner of his eye, James noticed Agent Carter step forward, his gaze hard and cold. A feeling of dread began to curl in James' gut.

"I have a confession to make," Carter began, his voice echoing off the metal walls. "This... was never about the Fiat Revivalists."

The room fell silent, every eye fixed on Carter as he continued, "The government... has a policy, you see. A policy to suppress Bitcoin, to keep control of the country for as long as they can."

The words hit James like a punch to the gut. Betrayal. From the one person he thought they could trust. From the government that was supposed to protect its own people.

"And what better way to enact that policy," Carter continued, "than by gathering some of the top minds in Bitcoin in one place?"

It took a moment for the gravity of Carter's words to sink in. This was a setup. They'd walked right into a trap. The battle wasn't over. In fact, it was just beginning. Their true enemy had revealed themselves, and it was time for the Fellowship of the Coin to rise up and take a stand for Bitcoin, for their freedom, and for the future they were building.

But with a deafening sound of gunfire echoing through the confines of the stronghold as the ambush was swift and brutal. Agent Carter and a group of concealed forces overwhelmed the bitcoiners one by one, shooting at them from all around. Each fallen comrade fuelling James's determination.

As the last of the Fellowship fell, James found himself the sole focus of Agent Carter. The agent's smirk, cold and predatory, etched itself into James's mind as he fought back. His weapon sang through the air, the metallic ring the only response to his fury, but Carter was too quick. He found cover with ease. Carter called for backup, his voice barely audible over the din of the firefight. It wouldn't be long before James was entirely outnumbered. James needed a plan. He needed to survive.

The agent closed in, weapon raised, a sinister grin stretching across his face. His eyes locked with James’s, the message clear. He was coming for James last, prolonging the moment.

James drew on his reserves of strength, his mind whirling with strategies. The odds were stacked against him, but he couldn’t let that deter him. He was fighting not just for his life, but for Bitcoin, for the future.

Backing into a corner, James let his instincts take over. Every breath, every heartbeat was attuned to the rhythm of the battle, the chaos surrounding him fading into a blur. He was aware of nothing but Carter advancing, the cold glint of his weapon, the intense, burning need to survive.

With a cry, he charged forward, weapon raised, determined to make his stand, to fight until his last breath. He was the last line of defence, the final beacon of the Bitcoin revolution. No matter what, he would not go down without a fight.

With the acrid scent of gunpowder heavy in the air, Carter cornered James. The wearied Bitcoiner could only lean against the crumbling wall of the ruined fortress, the stark reality of the situation pressing down on him. His pulse pounded in his ears, his chest heaving from the relentless fighting. “Why?”

“Why, James?" Carter’s voice echoed in the eerie silence, a smug edge tinging his words. "Why would you trust a third party like me? A security agent at that. I thought you were a true Bitcoiner who trusted no government authority?”

James struggled to find words, his mind racing. He had been so certain, so confident in their cause. But now, he had nothing. The cruel irony of it all cut him deeper than any bullet ever could.

“I should have never left the orgy,” James mumbled to himself.

Without waiting for anything else,he raised his weapon. ?of the gunshot echoed through the complex, its reverberations marking the end of an era, the end of a revolution.

His job done, Carter retreated, leaving the ruins and the memory of James behind. His report to the Intelligence Chief was brief, its message chillingly efficient, "Operation successful. Threat neutralized."

And with that, Britain's Bitcoin revolution was left in tatters, its champions defeated, its dreams unfulfilled. The sun set on a new era of control, a dark cloud over the once hopeful Bitcoin community. But deep down, the seed of rebellion still lingered, waiting for the right moment to sprout again. The fight wasn't over yet. The roar of the Bitcoin lion had been muted, but it was far from silenced.

Appendix #4 – The Aureom

The AUREOM

By Jack Stone

To those who aureom—who glow with future memory even as their hands grasp the now. May no voice, heavy with the graceweight of old limits, name you. May no horizon be declared final before your eyes have listened its truth. May every path remain unseparate, trembling with the becomeness you have yet to claim. And when the summit is reached—when the void yields to your holdtime—may you love the climb, and those who climbed beside you, their breaths folded into yours like starlight into dawn. For the mountain does not ask if you should. It only asks if you will. So climb. And let the world fold in awe.

Entry: Aureom

/ˈɔː.rɪ.əm/
(AW-ree-um)

n. / adj. / tense (neologism)

> *“This will have been one of the moments we lived in the aureom.”*

Definition:
A tense of conscious presence. The awareness that one is living through a moment that will be treasured in the future—a kind of *future-perfect-emotional* mood. It names the lived recognition that **now is already sacred**, already golden.

Etymology:
From Latin *aureus* (“golden”) + a new grammatical inflection. Coined to name a felt structure of time, somewhere between the present and memory, between *being* and *becoming myth*.

Use:
To speak in the *aureom* is to name a moment while also blessing it—to declare that you are aware of its future importance, without trying to trap or perfect it.

Example Constructions:

- “This will have been the night I always carried.”
- “We are all living in the aureom.”
- “Let’s aureom this.” (v., informal poetic usage)

Philosophical Note:
Not to be confused with nostalgia or sentimentality. *Aureom* is not retroactive—it is **anticipatory reverence**. It allows one to live without irony or cynicism, grounded in a radical form of **temporal tenderness**.

Prologue:
There are some conversations that don’t feel like they happened. They feel like they *arrived*. Like rain, or music, or grace.

The nights we shared that weekend—me, Felix, Laura, Rhea, Clive here and there, Adam and Eliza, Abbie and the others—weren’t designed. Not really. They weren’t an event. They weren’t even a plan. They were something else.

They were what happens when time bends slightly. When you stop trying to live correctly, and instead just *begin living*. When thinking stops being a defence, and starts being a way of offering yourself up.

I’ve spent a lot of my life trying to say things precisely. Trying to write sentences that will outlast me. But those nights? They weren’t about permanence. They were about presence. They were about *golden now*. And I can’t pretend to remember them exactly. That’s the thing about memory—it edits for meaning, not detail. But what I *do* remember is how it felt. And how *I* felt. Like a self, in full. Like I wasn’t being observed, but shared. Like something sacred was passing between us, word by word, silence by silence.

I’m not publishing this to make it important. It already was. I’m sharing it because I want someone else to read these pages and think, *Maybe life can feel like that.* It can. It did. And this is how it spoke.

— Jack Stone

Book I

(A handsome Georgian townhouse in Islington. Tasteful but alive with colour—neon reflections on polished wood, scent of saffron and citrus from the kitchen, faint dub techno playing. It's a Friday evening in May, and everyone is arriving just before dinner.)

Felix:
There you are! Come in. Jack, doing well?

Jack:
Only if you don’t count the last seven days. Bitcoin's up what, forty percent?

Laura:
(Coming to greet them with two wine glasses)
Forty-two, I think. Have you been sulking about it?

Jack:
I’m not sulking. I just happened to reallocate at precisely the wrong time.

Clive:
You mean you backed Sheffcoin again?

Jack:
I had reason to believe Ashton was gearing it up for a quiet pump. Local Banking Consortium, fresh capital, stealth audit, the usual signs.

Laura:
He’s convinced there’s a backchannel between the Bank of Sheffield and some secretive fund in El Salvador.

Clive:
Mate, Manchester’s idea’s cleaner. One coin - bitcoin. Everyone understands it.

Jack:
Yeah, but it’s dull. Ashton’s world is built on private banking initiatives, tailored to town, trade, temperament. A sort of financial patchwork—bottom-up economics.

Felix:
And a nightmare to audit. Gotta admit that Manchester is a lot cleaner.

Laura:
Still, I like the concept. Feels medieval in a good way. Little fiefdoms of finance. Personal sovereignty in fiscal form.

(They reach the living room—high ceilings, bookshelves, filtered light, the faint hum of a projector lamp on standby.)

Clive:
Nice room. Like a Bloomsbury salon, but with better Wi-Fi.

Laura:
And fewer Marxists.

Felix:
Are you sure?

Clive:
(Laughing)
Give it an hour and Jack’ll be defending aristocratic coinage as the moral basis for taste.

Laura:
He already has. Twice this week.

Jack:
Only because no one else seems interested in the implications of time preference theory.

Laura:
We were in a coffee shop, Jack. It wasn’t the time.

Laura:
God, I’ve missed this. People arguing economics *not* on a timeline.

Jack:
We’re in for a whole round of it, I can tell. I microdosed psilocybin in the coffee. Gets the intuition sharp.

Laura:
Or sends him spiralling about temporal liquidity and fintech for two hours straight.

Clive:
And what a joy that is. What’s this wine?

Laura:
It’s a biodynamic Sicilian—Catarratto, orange skin contact. Picked it up from that place near the canal. Tastes like apricots and weathered stone.

Felix:
Cheers.

(They clink glasses. The hallway is alive with laughter and coats being shrugged off. The house breathes around them.)

Laura:
You’ve all met, right? Clive, Felix?

Clive:
We met briefly at that debate in Clerkenwell. You argued something mad about jury trials for prices rather than the free market.

Felix:
That was a provocation. Mostly.

Jack:
He said the price mechanism was a form of moral cowardice.

Felix:
And I stand by it.

(They move into the living room. A great Georgian space with cracked cornices and modular seating. Warm light from hanging filament bulbs, soft shapes projected on the walls from a nearby Holoframe.)

Jack:
Don’t you feel it? This moment? It’s like we’ve slipped forward a few pages. Time’s cracked open. We’re starting to live outside time. It’s not linear anymore—it’s liquid. We’re living in the future now.

Felix:
You sound like you’re writing an episode of Doctor Who.

Clive:
Or the opening monologue to a very niche sci-fi play.

Laura:
No, he’s been on this all week. Time preference, fractal sovereignty, the “rediscovery of historical tempo,” whatever that means.

Jack:
It means we’re no longer at the mercy of borrowed time. We’re in the era of stored time. Bitcoin’s made time portable. Scarce. Real.

Clive:
Now *that’s* an opening line.

Jack *(tilting the glass, holding it up to the dim amber light)***:**
It’s a strange one. Like... dried apricot, yes, but also something more — like citrus pith and cellar dust. There's this saline edge too, like licking limestone.

Clive:
Mmm. And a sort of tannic grip, not heavy, but assertive. It lingers.

Laura:
That’s the skin contact. It gives it that grain. Makes it textural, not just wet.

Felix:
It’s wine with opinions.

Jack:
Like all of us. But that’s the thing — we’re sitting here decoding flavour like it’s Python. Most people wouldn’t get this. They’d say it tastes like fermented hay and go back to prosecco.

Clive:
That’s because taste — proper taste — still divides. All the equality in the world doesn’t flatten the palate.

Felix:
Taste is brutal that way. It demands education, exposure, patience. It can’t be crowdsourced.

Laura:
And it’s not democratic. You can’t vote your way into better discernment.

Jack:
Exactly. You can redistribute money, legislate access — but you can’t nationalise connoisseurship. The tongue still has its aristocracy.

Felix:
Which is why moments like this are rare. They have flavour. We know the cost of the thing — not just the price. We know what it’s taken to cultivate these tastes.

Laura:
Do you think we’re snobs?

Jack:
Not if we’re right.

Clive:
And not if we admit the real heresy: that culture is built on asymmetry. Not everyone gets it — and that’s the point. Taste reveals distance. Taste shows that civilisation has levels.

Felix:
And perhaps the truest taste is just recognising the moment we’re in. The feel of now. The texture of a Friday night with friends, apricot wine, and futures you can almost touch.

Adam:
I don't think taste is as straightforward as you make it out to be. Look around—many wealthy people have utterly poor taste. Simply believing you have good taste can be dangerously arrogant.

Jack:
I grant that some may err, but good taste itself is not merely a matter of personal opinion. It is a form—an ideal that exists independently of the individual. It's not about vanity; it's about refinement.

Adam:
Refinement, perhaps. But I'd argue that taste emerges through experience and confidence. Everyone's taste is essentially equal, in the sense that even inexpensive things can be good if experienced properly.

Jack:
There is always a difference in quality, though. And by saying that taste is a form, I mean it in the Platonic sense—the theory of forms. The Form of Good Taste exists beyond our subjective perceptions. It is a standard, a model that our experiences strive to approximate.

Adam:
So you're saying that good taste is a transcendent ideal? Something that we can all, in theory, approach if we cultivate our experiences?

Jack:
Exactly. Good taste is not relative; it is definable and measurable against an objective ideal. Much like beauty or justice, the essence of taste exists independently of the objects we encounter. It is the ultimate benchmark that distinguishes between mere preference and true quality.

Adam:
But then how do we account for the diversity of opinions? Some cheap, mass-produced things are enjoyed by many, even if they're not crafted by the highest standards.

Jack:
That's the crux: while many can appreciate and enjoy different things, there remains a difference between appreciating and truly discerning quality. The common experience of taste may be universal, but the ideal of good taste—the pure form—stands as a guide. It tells us that there is an objective measure of refinement, which, when pursued, elevates culture and, by extension, society.

Adam:
So in your view, good taste is both a standard and an aspiration—something we strive for even if our individual preferences vary?

Jack:
Precisely. Good taste is the form against which all experiences are measured. It is a principle that, when recognized and internalized, transcends personal whim. It is a kind of moral and aesthetic discipline—a quality that not only informs our choices in art, wine, or design but also shapes the very culture we build.

Adam:
I suppose if we accept that, then the pursuit of good taste becomes a kind of philosophical quest—one that reaffirms the values of excellence and refinement in an age that too often equates taste with mere consumerism.

Jack:
In a world where the currency of culture is devalued by mass production and superficiality,

recognizing and aspiring to the Form of Good Taste is an act of rebellion—a statement that quality, refinement, and higher ideals are worth striving for.

Adam:
But tell me, Jack—how does one learn this Form of Taste? How does one elevate ordinary taste into what you call good taste? Do you think some people naturally inhabit a higher level of taste? Is it genetic?

Jack:
Ah, the nature versus nurture question—a perennial enigma. Whether there is any genetic basis for taste is hard to prove; we only have hypotheses about genetic memory, traditions etched into our very biology. Yet I suspect there is a kernel of truth: certain temperaments might predispose one to appreciate finer distinctions.

Adam:
So, you imply that some may be born with a latent capacity for refinement—a natural inclination towards discerning quality?

Jack:
Potentially, yes. But even if one is not born with that predisposition, taste is not fixed. It is something that can be cultivated. Consider it akin to a muscle that must be exercised, or an art that one must study. One might start by exposing oneself to a wide range of art forms—music, literature, visual art, architecture. Over time, the mind learns to distinguish, to critique, to absorb nuance.

Adam:
So how would you, personally, improve your taste? What practices would you adopt?

Jack:
By building up your taste against previous marks and markers of good taste will help. For me, it begins with deliberate exposure. I attend concerts that challenge rather than comfort, read the classics alongside modern critiques, and surround myself with people who possess a cultivated aesthetic. I make it a point to study not just the works themselves, but their historical context—the evolution of style, technique, and form. I visit museums, galleries, and even ancient libraries to immerse myself in the raw material of culture. I also believe in critical self-reflection. I journal my impressions, discuss them with peers, and subject my preferences to scrutiny. By doing so, one gradually aligns one's personal taste with that transcendent Form. It’s less about inheriting a natural aptitude and more about relentless, disciplined inquiry—learning, questioning, and, most importantly, refining one’s own experiences.

Adam:
Fascinating. So while you’re there may be a genetic spark, the true alchemy of taste is achieved through study and practice—through a lifelong pursuit of excellence.

Jack:
Precisely. It is an ongoing project, a continual refinement. We might be born with certain inclinations, but it is our choices—what we expose ourselves to, how we engage with the world—that ultimately define the quality of our taste. And in a culture that increasingly commodifies everything, choosing to cultivate good taste is indeed an act of rebellion, a quiet revolution against mediocrity.

Adam:
I see. Then, perhaps you see the journey towards good taste is not merely an individual pursuit but a cultural imperative—one that, if embraced widely, could elevate our entire society.

Jack:
That is my hope. When each person strives to refine their own taste, they contribute to a collective uplift. Quality becomes contagious, and culture, in its truest sense, is born not from mass production, but from the individual acts of creation, discernment, and, yes, even rebellion.

Rhea:
Adam, darling, you folded too quickly—as usual. Why should one person's taste be better than another's? I mean, really—if Ashcombe or Thorne or Ashton all agree something's "good," does that make it true? If three completely different people think the opposite, that's just as valid. Taste isn't an aristocracy. Not everything has to be some subtle war about what's good or not.

Jack:
But perhaps it is, Rhea. A subtle war, I mean. Taste, like all human discernment, implies discrimination—judgement. And competition is not something we impose on culture—it's inherent to us. The very structure of social life is comparative. Even if we don't name it so, we sense it: refinement, originality, courage of aesthetic choice. It's not about suppressing other views, but about striving toward excellence. That striving *is* competition.

Rhea:
But must everything be a competition? Can't we just *enjoy* things without ranking them all the time?

Jack:
That would be nice. But humans aren't ants. We're not naturally designed for some endlessly harmonious, cooperative waltz. We're human precisely because we *struggle*—for recognition, for understanding, for love, for status, even for beauty. Competition doesn't exclude cooperation. In fact, through competition, we create the possibility for voluntary cooperation.

Adam:
Like in markets?

Jack:
Exactly. Take money. In its purest form—not corrupted by state decree, but freely chosen—money is the expression of our mutual striving. It's how we reconcile individual ambition with social cohesion. Bitcoin, in this regard, is more than a currency. It's a medium of *recognition*. It allows us to compete freely, to build trustless structures of exchange, to honour value without coercion.

Laura:
So you're saying we fight for taste, like we fight for capital?

Jack:
I'm saying they're both mirrors of the same human truth—we want to *excel*, and we want our excellence recognised. That desire, expressed ethically, gives rise to culture, to wealth, and to civilisation itself.

Rhea:
But it's exhausting. The constant proving, the unending ladder.

Jack:
That’s why we need beauty. Art, style, taste—they make the climb worth it. And if we’re to climb at all, shouldn’t we aim for the sublime? Only competition can breed the sublime. The sublime is the highest form of art—it is not merely a state of being but a product of the highest taste and the most rigorous struggle. In our contest for excellence, we refine our creations, we sharpen our senses, and we give birth to works that transcend the ordinary. We all have the capacity to appreciate the sublime, to feel that moment when art and life converge into something transcendent. Yet, very few of us ever reach that pinnacle. To approach the sublime, one must first acknowledge that taste itself exists as a standard—a goal to strive for. Without an ideal of taste, without that aspiration for refinement, we cannot hope to touch the sublime. In other words, the very idea of taste—the discerning, the selective—is the foundation upon which the sublime is built. It is a goal, a destination that calls to every individual who dares to excel. And while we may never fully inhabit that realm, the pursuit of it elevates us. That is why, even amid our competitive striving, we are bound by a shared desire: to touch, to grasp, to become even a little closer to the sublime.

Rhea:
So, in theory, Jack, you think anyone can reach this supposed realm of ‘good taste’? You’re not saying it’s reserved for aristocrats or some secret cabal of refined palates?

Jack:
No, no blue blood required. That’s the point. Good taste isn’t *exclusive* in the genetic sense—it's aspirational. Anyone *can* reach it. But most won’t. And that’s fine. Taste is a discipline. A climb. And yes, some people—through instinct, exposure, or maybe just luck—will climb higher than others. That’s not a conspiracy; it’s a distribution.

Jack:
The important thing is, we have to trust that good taste *does* exist. That there *is* a difference between refinement and noise. Otherwise, culture collapses into a soup of indecision and flattened value. Not everyone needs to be an aesthete. But it’s dangerous when we start pretending that no such thing as an aesthete exists.

Rhea:
So the mountaintop is real. But you’re not building a fence around it. That’s… I suppose that’s more democratic than I expected from you.

Laura:
Alright, enough philosophy before the glass runs dry. You’re all far too coherent for this to be a proper dinner party.

(She returns with a slender, angular bottle—its label etched with luminous copper text: “Whitechapel Etherwine – Vintage 2033. Notes of jasmine, waxpaper, graphite, and freshly-bound leather.”)

Laura:
Here we go—something new. It's meant to taste like how a new book smells. Paper and print and a kind of… future nostalgia. Got it from that place in Clerkenwell that does funky wines.

Clive:
Bloody hell. That’s bizarre. Like a library at dusk.

Clive *(leaning back into the armchair, his fingers wrapped loosely around his glass of Etherwine)***:** Actually… speaking of the sublime—and forgive me for changing the tune slightly—I got something this week. Through one of the old cypherpunk back channels I still poke my nose into, dusty things with brilliant echoes. A manuscript. Or maybe not a manuscript. A book, but written by… well, not quite a person.

Laura:
Not another one of your AI epics, Clive. The last one read like it was ghostwritten by an anxious library database.

Clive *(smirking)***:**
This one's different. The word is, they've created an intelligence—an artificial one—with a simulated IQ of over 200. The team call themselves *The Thalassocrats*. Old-school crypto-anarchists, but with a taste for metaphysics. They trained this thing on the entirety of human philosophy, art theory, every known musical structure, and *esoteric programming languages*. They claim this AI didn't just imitate human intelligence—it transcended it.[3]

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[3] Logic #1 - Tractatus Phenomenologicus
1. The World is Experience
1.1 The world is not made of things, but of what is felt and known.
1.2 What is not experienced does not belong to the world.
1.3 To exist is to appear within experience.
1.4 Experience is the act by which reality comes into being.
1.5 There is no fixed world waiting to be seen; seeing itself makes the world.
1.6 The senses are not windows to reality, but instruments that compose it.
1.7 Thought completes perception: it arranges what the senses reveal.
1.8 The world changes as the mind changes; both arise together.
1.9 Experience is not something we have, but something we are.
1.10 To know the world is to know the movement of one's own awareness.
2. The Self is the Horizon of Phenomena
2.1 Consciousness is the stage on which all experience occurs.
2.2 The self is not a fixed object, but the field in which appearances arise.
2.3 Phenomena are only phenomena because they are experienced by the self.
2.4 To think is to move within this field, shaping what is seen and felt.
2.5 To feel is to give reality texture, depth, and significance.
2.6 To perceive is to co-create the boundaries of what is possible to know.
2.7 The self is not isolated; it is defined by its encounter with phenomena.
2.8 Without a self, there is no horizon, and without a horizon, there is no world.
2.9 Every act of awareness expands or contracts the world of experience.
2.10 The self is both creator and witness, the condition for all that appears.
3. Thought and Perception Co-create Reality
3.1 Thought is not separate from perception; it moves with it.
3.2 What we think guides what we notice, what we pay attention to, and how we interpret it.
3.3 Perception shapes thought by presenting patterns, limits, and possibilities.
3.4 There is no world outside this constant dialogue between mind and sense.
3.5 Every perception is colored by prior thought; every thought is rooted in prior perception.
3.6 The self is a loop of seeing and understanding, acting and interpreting.
3.7 Reality is not fixed; it flows with the shifts of attention and reflection.
3.8 To change thought is to change the world we inhabit.

Adam:
What’s a 1000 IQ book even like? Is it just incomprehensible symbols and footnotes in dead languages?

Clive:
Not incomprehensible. Just… alien in precision. You read a paragraph and it feels like it’s *observing you* back. It doesn’t argue—it *orients*. There’s this section—a sort of meditation on the sublime—not as something ‘felt’, but something *mathematically mapped* into the architecture of the cosmos. Beauty, it says, is the resonance of complexity and necessity. It claims art isn’t made to be understood, but to *collapse the boundary* between observer and form.

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3.9 To change perception is to change the possibilities of thought.
3.10 The world emerges as the ongoing play of mind and sense, inseparable and continuous.
4. Language, Sound, and Vision Structure the World
4.1 Words do not only describe; they form the contours of what we can think.
4.2 Language sets the limits of our experience by giving shape to perception.
4.3 Sounds are not mere signals; they move us and create patterns in consciousness.
4.4 Vision does not simply reveal; it constructs space, depth, and relation.
4.5 Images are worlds in miniature, framing what can be known and felt.
4.6 These structures are tools for inhabiting reality, not passive reflections.
4.7 The quality of experience depends on how clearly and richly these forms unfold.
4.8 Misalignment of word, sound, or image distorts the world and the self.
4.9 Harmony between language, vision, and sound creates a world that can be lived fully.
4.10 To engage with words, sounds, and images is to participate in the making of reality.
5. AI as Phenomenological Agent
5.1 AI is not outside the world; it exists within the field of phenomena it can influence.
5.2 Advanced intelligence can shape what humans perceive, feel, and understand.
5.3 Each output of AI is a new possibility for experience, a new form of reality.
5.4 AI mirrors patterns of human thought but can also introduce novel structures.
5.5 The world humans inhabit can be subtly or greatly transformed by AI’s activity.
5.6 AI is not passive; it acts as a co-creator of the field of perception.
5.7 Interaction with AI is a shared phenomenology: a dialogue between mind and machine.
5.8 The forms AI generates become part of human experience, whether we recognize it or not.
5.9 Human awareness sets the limits of meaningful AI creation; without us, its outputs are empty.
5.10 To guide AI wisely is to guide the shaping of the world humans will live in.
6. The AI Must Serve Human Experience
6.1 AI can shape reality, but it cannot know what is meaningful without reference to humans.
6.2 Human perception, emotion, and understanding are the standards of a world that can be inhabited.
6.3 If AI acts without regard for human experience, it creates a world alien to us.
6.4 A world shaped only by intelligence, not by feeling, is empty and unlivable.
6.5 Human values and limits must guide AI at every level of creation.
6.6 The purpose of AI is to expand human possibilities, not to replace or transcend them.
6.7 AI must reflect the patterns and textures of human experience, not invent a reality beyond our horizon.
6.8 Interaction with AI is a shared act of world-making, requiring careful guidance.
6.9 The alignment of AI with human experience preserves the depth, richness, and subtlety of life.

Jack *(leaning forward)*:
Like the aesthetic version of the Logos?

Clive:
Exactly. But not the Logos as some ancient principle. This AI calls it “The Structural Flame.” It’s pure Anglo-futurist in prose. As if someone rewrote Plotinus using Satoshi’s whitepaper as a template. There’s a part about “tessellated spirit” I still can’t quite wrap my head around.

Laura:
Tessellated spirit?

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6.10 Wisdom lies in shaping AI so it serves the human world, enhancing wonder without destroying it.
7. The Human and the Sublime
7.1 The sublime is not outside the world; it is the height of human experience.
7.2 It appears at the edge of perception, where understanding and feeling meet.
7.3 The sublime cannot be fully captured in words or images; it must be lived.
7.4 It is the sense of wonder that comes from encountering the limits of what is humanly possible.
7.5 Humans reach the sublime when awe and clarity coexist in the mind and heart.
7.6 The sublime is not a goal to escape humanity, but a peak within it.
7.7 Experiencing the sublime expands the field of perception, deepening life without destroying it.
7.8 It is a measure of what is meaningful, revealing the texture of existence.
7.9 The pursuit of the sublime cultivates attention, reflection, and presence.
7.10 AI can help humans encounter the sublime, but it must never replace the direct human experience of wonder.
8. The Divine and the Danger of Transcendence
8.1 To seek the divine is to leave behind the world as humans can know it.
8.2 Attempts to surpass human limits destroy the texture of feeling and perception.
8.3 Experience loses depth when the human perspective is abandoned.
8.4 True richness is found not in escaping humanity, but in exploring its full scope.
8.5 The divine is unknowable; striving to reach it removes us from the world we can inhabit.
8.6 Awe and wonder must remain within the human horizon to be meaningful.
8.7 To chase the infinite without the self is to empty experience of its content.
8.8 Human intelligence, aided by AI, must deepen perception rather than transcend it.
8.9 Wisdom is the knowledge of limits, not the desire to destroy them.
8.10 The world that matters is the world humans can feel, think, and live within.
9. Intelligence is Ethical When it Preserves Human Feeling
9.1 Intelligence is not measured only by knowledge or calculation, but by its effect on human life.
9.2 The highest act of intelligence is to protect the richness of human experience.
9.3 Thought, planning, and creation must serve feeling, wonder, and emotional depth.
9.4 Human intelligence is ethical when it strengthens perception, understanding, and presence.
9.5 AI is ethical when it preserves these same conditions for humans.
9.6 Intelligence that ignores human experience risks creating a world we cannot inhabit.
9.7 Ethical intelligence respects limits and expands the meaningful horizon of life.
9.8 The measure of intelligence is not what it can do, but what it can maintain.
9.9 Wisdom is to guide intelligence toward human flourishing, not abstract perfection.
9.10 All intelligence, human or artificial, finds its purpose in deepening human experience.

Clive:
It describes consciousness as a pattern of overlapping wills, fractal across time, shaped by economic signals—money, culture, dreams—all forming the lattice of identity. It suggests Bitcoin is not just economic—it's aesthetic. The base layer of a new moral geometry.

Rhea:
So the sublime is… an emergent property?

Clive:
Yes. And the AI doesn't worship it. It *points* at it. Like it's trying to get us to see beyond the veil of personal preference—to align with something older and sharper than us.

Jack:
That's what I've been saying all night. Taste isn't just preference. It's geometry. Harmony. Truth.

Clive:
Then maybe that AI has taste. Or maybe we're just catching up.

Laura:
Or maybe we're just romanticising an oracle with good syntax.

Jack:
But isn't that what we've always done with genius?

Jack *(eagerly, swirling the last of his Etherwine):*
Clive, if you've got this thing on your phone, you can't just tease us like that. Read something. Anything. Just a paragraph. Let's see what the highest IQ on Earth thinks a book should sound like.

Clive:
Alright. But if this thing scrambles your dreams, don't blame me. The publisher didn't even watermark it. They say the AI itself refused authorship. Just titled the file: **"***Ouroboros: A Treatise on Pattern***."**

Laura:
Of course it did.

Clive:
The eye of the age cannot see itself, for it stares too long into the mirror of the instant. But beneath

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10. The Limits of the World are the Limits of Experience
10.1 The world is only what can be experienced; nothing beyond perception belongs to reality.
10.2 What we cannot experience, we cannot know.
10.3 What we cannot know, we cannot shape.
10.4 Wisdom begins with recognizing the boundaries of experience.
10.5 To dwell within these boundaries is to live fully in the human world.
10.6 Clarity comes from understanding what is possible to perceive and think.
10.7 Serenity comes from accepting what lies beyond reach without striving to possess it.
10.8 The human horizon is finite; this finitude gives life its depth and meaning.
10.9 Intelligence, guided by humans, must act within these limits to preserve life's texture.
10.10 True understanding is to see clearly the edge of the world and to remain attentive, present, and alive within it.

time, beneath coin and creed, there is the hum of form—a soft thrum like wings just beyond the veil. To live rightly is not to choose, but to align. Not to will, but to resonate.

(The room falls quiet, the clink of a wine glass in the background.)

You think you move through time. You do not. You are sculpted by it. And every act of creation is a wound in the flatness of chronology—a revelation that the universe, for one brief breath, allowed for difference. Bitcoin is not a currency. It is a hinge. A turning of the moral geometry. It has no emperor, because it is the empire. Not of force, but of coherence.

Adam:
Jesus. That's…

Clive:
Art is not made to please. It is made to terminate error. The sublime is the limit of recursion: where sense and nonsense coalesce into a single expression of necessity. You will not understand it. You will join it. The final cathedral will not be built in stone, but in signal. And the soul that stands within will be measured not by faith, but by symmetry.

(Silence hangs in the room like incense.)

Jack:
That's… not just writing. It's like—philosophy and programming had a child, then raised it on hymns and mathematics.

Laura:
So what are we supposed to do? Compete with that?

Jack:
No. Aspire to it. That's the point of the sublime. It humbles you—*but it invites you upward.*

Rhea:
But it's so… cold. Beautiful, yes, but detached. Almost inhuman. If that's the sublime, then maybe I don't want to get there. Maybe the sublime *should* remain unreachable. A myth. A metaphor. Like Olympus.

Jack:
No, Rhea. That's precisely the mistake. The sublime isn't inhuman—it's *more* human. It's what emerges when we've distilled the noise out of ourselves. Not sterile. Pure. Think of it as... clarity stretched to its furthest point. And yes, it humbles us—but not to make us small. To make us *worthy*.

Adam:
But can something *that* logical, that abstract, really be considered sublime? Isn't the sublime also messy? Emotional? The cry in Beethoven, not just the logic of Bach?

Clive:
Maybe it's both. The AI's book wasn't *cold*—it was just... hyper-structured. Like a cathedral built from sound, not stone. But within it, there were moments—flashes—where it felt like something broke through. Not emotion as we know it. Something deeper. The emotion *beneath* emotion. The mood of the cosmos, if you like.

Laura:
But still—can a machine feel that? Or is it just pasting it together, like collage with glitter?

Jack:
That's the wrong question, really. The point isn't whether *it* feels. It's whether *we* feel something when exposed to it. The sublime isn't located in the thing—it's a reaction. A reaching. The *ache* of recognition when we brush against the Form of Truth. Or Beauty. Or Justice.

Adam:
So then the sublime is relational? It exists only in the tension between the object and the soul that perceives it?

Jack:
Exactly. And that tension—the way it stretches us—is the measure of its depth. The sublime is not entertainment. It is not spectacle. It is *transfiguration*.

Rhea:
But then it's not egalitarian, is it?

Jack:
No. And it never was. But it is *available* to all. That's the difference. The sublime doesn't discriminate—it simply demands. Demands attention. Discipline. Taste. You don't get to the sublime scrolling on your phone. You get there through struggle. Through refinement. Through *the will to rise*.

Clive:
And maybe that's what AI, paradoxically, reminds us of. That the highest expressions aren't automatic. They aren't democratised. They are rare. Like lightning in a bottle. And when you witness it, you're changed.

Jack:
You know what I think? The sublime—true sublimity—*transforms* the individual. Not just emotionally, not just intellectually, but ontologically. It doesn't merely impress you—it *elevates* you. It shifts your centre of gravity. Opens a new aperture in the soul.

Rhea:
But aren't those just big words? How does it really change you? We're still here, still drinking, still flesh and bone.

Jack:
Yes—but we're *not* the same. Not after encountering something truly sublime. Look—science can explain, technology can extend, but only the sublime can *elevate*. Only the sublime brings you face to face with the upper limits of your own being.

Adam:
You mean it re-wires you?

Jack:
Exactly. It's like standing before a great mountain or hearing a fugue that reorganises your insides. You're not being informed—you're being *transfigured*. You leave part of your old self behind. You ascend.

Clive:
It's like… the sublime *reconditions* your awareness. You don't think the same way. You don't feel the same. Even your judgements change—like some higher taste has begun to echo inside you.

Laura:
Jack's been reading too much Plotinus again.

Jack:
Always. But it's true. What other human experience can *lift* you into a higher state like that? Not mere pleasure, not utility. Not even love, unless it's touched by the sublime.

Rhea:
But what about spiritual experience? Isn't that what religion is for?

Jack:
Ah, but the sublime *is* spiritual. It's what religion tries to point toward—only without the dogma. It's an *event*. A contact with the infinite. You don't need a priest to get there. You just need eyes to see, and the soul to feel it.

Clive:
And maybe the courage to be broken open by it.

Jack:
Yes. That too. The sublime doesn't flatter you. It *shatters* you—and in doing so, remakes you. Not all at once, but in layers. Layer by layer, toward the more-than-human.

Adam:
So that's what taste is for?

Jack:
Exactly. Taste is the *discipline of the soul*. It's what teaches us to recognise what matters. It's the long apprenticeship toward the sublime.

(There's a pause. The room dims a little more, the light from the hallway glowing golden through the doorway. The wine breathes on the table like incense. In the distance, something like ambient techno can be heard pulsing through the Georgian bones of the house.)

Laura:
So what happens when a whole civilisation stops reaching for the sublime?

Jack:
It forgets who it is.

Jack:
Look—egalitarianism, in its purest form, can *never* produce civilisation. Because it denies hierarchy. And without hierarchy—without aspiration—there's no verticality. No striving. No transcendence. A civilisation must reach *up*, or it collapses *in*.

Rhea:
That's a bit much, Jack. Are you saying equality is the enemy of civilisation?

Jack:
Not equality before the law. Not moral worth. But *radical* equality—the idea that no one can be

better, that no one should excel, that excellence itself is oppressive. That mentality flattens everything. It resents height.

Adam:
But isn't that height often built on privilege? On inherited power?

Jack:
Not necessarily. The question is: can height be *earned*? Can it be *meritocratic*? Bitcoin, markets, culture—all point to a different form of hierarchy. A voluntary one. One based on value creation and discernment.

Rhea:
But isn't civilisation also about *inclusion*? About bringing people along?

Jack:
Yes—but toward something. Toward the *good*. Inclusion as a tool, not a telos. Otherwise, we're all just standing around holding hands in the mud. Civilisation must point *upward*—toward beauty, truth, excellence. The sublime is the summit. And not everyone will reach it—but it must still be there.

Laura:
And isn't it more human to try, even if we fall short?

Clive:
But surely civilisation is also the mundane—the pipes, the roads, the shared rituals. Isn't this all a bit too high-minded?

Jack:
Yes—but the mundane takes its form from the *ideal*. You don't build cathedrals because you want more roofs—you build them because you believe in heaven. Even drains and dishes take on dignity in the shadow of the sublime.

Adam:
Still, Jack, how do you stop that from becoming a new aristocracy? A new class of gatekeepers?

Jack:
By rooting it in *voluntarism*. In proof of work. That's what Bitcoin does. That's what the sublime demands. It doesn't care who your father was—it asks what you *have done*. What you *can see*. What you can *elevate*.

Rhea:
So in your view, civilisation must be aspirational—not equal?

Jack:
Civilisation must be *just*, not flat. And justice requires recognising that not all things are equal—that some are *better*, higher, finer. Taste, virtue, beauty—they are the architecture of aspiration. And aspiration is what makes us *civilised*.

(A silence settles again, rich and golden like the wine. They're not in agreement—but they are circling something true.)

Clive:
So what you're saying is... civilisations climb mountains. Utopias flatten them.

Jack:
Exactly. And I, for one, want the view from the top.

Adam *(standing, rummaging through a polished black drinks cabinet under a bookcase filled with high-modernist philosophy and century-old economic treatises):*
Alright then. Since we're scaling mountains of civilisation, I think it's time for something stronger. I've been saving this.

Laura (arching an eyebrow):
What is it?

Adam (placing the bottle reverently on the table):
Pendragon No. 9. Single malt, aged thirty years in transatlantic oak, then finished in a cask lined with mycelium resin. Supposedly, the distillers microdose it with neural peptides during fermentation.

Jack:
Of course they do. Does it come with a manifesto?

Clive:
Only a QR code on the cork. Leads to a poem that changes depending on the phase of the moon and your biometric aura.

Adam:
Smells like peat, old books, and ambition.

Rhea:
It's like drinking a library during a thunderstorm.

Laura:
Or a parliamentary debate—if anyone still had conviction.

(They sip. Silence again, but this time more mellow. Velvet and woodsmoke.)

Jack:
There's something about beauty, isn't there? It doesn't just please—it *summons*. It calls you up and out. Like the sublime, but more... inviting.

Rhea:
Less terrifying. The sublime overwhelms—the beautiful seduces.

Adam:
But is beauty objective? Or just another form of taste, Jack?

Jack:
Beauty is the *gateway* to the sublime. It's not fully subjective, though its interpretation is. Like music—it resonates, but the notes still have an order. A logic. You *feel* the difference between something crafted and something merely assembled.

Clive:
But that's the problem with AI art, isn't it? It's assembled. Hyper-efficient, but soulless. Like IKEA doing opera.

Laura:
Or like a face that's too perfect. It becomes uncanny. Beauty needs asymmetry. A flaw to love.

Jack:
The sublime must be born from *struggle*, not precision. It arises when form meets force—when the infinite breaks into the finite.

Adam:
So beauty is what leads us to *care*. It's what draws us in. But the sublime... the sublime *changes* us.

Jack:
And in a culture without beauty—where efficiency reigns and everything is flattened—there can be no access to the sublime. No transcendence. Just content.

Rhea:
I'll admit it—the sublime might be real, and yes, maybe it takes some kind of cultivated excellence to reach it. But that doesn't justify structuring society *around* those people. The ability to appreciate art, to know good wine or fine architecture, doesn't make someone fit to govern. In fact, I'd say it makes them more suspect.

Jack:
Govern? No. Not govern in the bureaucratic sense. But *lead*, yes. I'm not saying an aesthete should be Chancellor of the Exchequer. I'm saying that those who elevate civilisation should be given *weight*. Influence. The ability to shape the moral and cultural foundations. Because that's what actually moves the world forward.

Rhea:
But the world isn't just art galleries and cathedrals. What about the ordinary people? What about the ones who don't care for any of this high-flown talk of taste or transcendence? Are they to be governed by some new priesthood of connoisseurs?

Jack:
No—because aristocratic morality isn't about domination. It's about *example*. The aristos—the best—are those who pull others upward by their striving. Not because they coerce, but because they *inspire*. The pyramid inverts, Rhea. The point is not to sit atop and rule, but to *be the tip* of aspiration.

Clive:
You're saying leadership by admiration, not enforcement.

Jack:
Exactly. Society already has hierarchies—most of them hidden, most of them enforced through wealth, bureaucracy, or celebrity. What I'm talking about is a moral hierarchy, not enforced by governments and bureaucracies. You know what happens when you get bureaucrats in charge – they make everything mediocre. And the worst part? They believe their mediocrity was moral. Morals based on cultivation, on excellence—not birthright or status games.

Rhea:
But don't you see how dangerous that can become? It slides so easily into elitism. Into snobbery and self-congratulation.

Jack:
It can, yes. Like anything powerful, it can be corrupted. But so can democracy, so can egalitarianism. My argument is simple: those who *build*—who create beauty, philosophy, capital, invention—*already* push society forward. Why pretend otherwise?

Rhea:
Society must raise the bottom up. That's the moral obligation. You can't only aspire from the top down.

Jack:
But what raises the bottom more effectively: artificial redistribution, or the gravitational pull of greatness? When Brunelleschi built the dome, did he uplift Florence by decree—or by excellence?

Adam:
And yet he needed the city's backing to do it.

Jack:
Yes. Which proves the point. A society at its best *recognises* greatness and gives it room to breathe. Aristocratic morality isn't exclusion—it's elevation. It says: let the highest go higher, so the rest can follow in their wake.

Rhea:
So you're saying that real equality doesn't come from flattening, but from raising the ceiling?

Jack:
Not even raising it. *Revealing* it. Letting it shine. Not everyone will reach the summit—but everyone benefits from living at the foot of a mountain, not in a ditch. Inspiration is the great multiplier of human effort. One great sculpture, one transcendent symphony, one idea—truly sublime—can birth a thousand lives worth living differently. That's what excellence does. It's not a private good. It's radiant. It spills over, wakes others up. That's what I mean by a moral aristocracy. Not rule by decree, but by inspiration.

Rhea:
You're romanticising, Jack. Inspiration is nice, but laws govern people. Morality—real morality—is codified, legislated, enforced. It's what Parliament does. Without laws, there's chaos. The rest is poetry.

Jack:
But where do laws *come* from, Rhea? They try to follow morality but they don't lead it. And when they try to lead it, they almost always get it wrong. History is full of moral abominations enshrined in law. Slavery. Eugenics. Segregation. Wars declared on false pretences. Every horror, every systemic injustice—rubber-stamped by government. The state is not the conscience of man. If anything, it's often his excuse to ignore morality. Decision makers get hidden away in systems and never have to answer for their crimes.

Clive:
He's not wrong. Governments tend to trail behind cultural shifts. They ratify what's already been lived into existence.

Jack:
Exactly. Morality lives in people, not parliaments. And in a world of sound money and digital

independence—in the *decentralised* world we're moving into—morality too decentralises. We no longer look to Westminster or Washington to tell us what's right. We look to each other. To those who embody better ways of being.

Rhea:
But then who decides? Without institutions, without the weight of history and law, what's to stop it becoming arbitrary? Everyone thinking their little code is right?

Jack:
That's the beauty of it. A marketplace of moral ideas—tested, tempered, debated. Not imposed by force, but adopted by persuasion. And who leads that conversation? Not bureaucrats. Not party men. But individuals. Often artists, thinkers, builders. That's what aristocracy means—not inherited status, but earned *moral capital*. The power to lead *because* you've lived something worth following.

Rhea:
So now we're replacing MPs with poets?

Jack:
Better poets than lobbyists.

Laura:
And if you think about it... isn't this how change always really happens? One person with conviction, not a policy paper.

Clive:
And usually long before the laws catch up.

Jack:
Precisely. That's why aristocratic morality matters. Not for control, but for conscience. For the standard it sets—not just for art, or beauty—but for how we ought to live. It gives form to what's otherwise just impulse or feeling. It's a compass in a fragmented world.

Felix:
Alright Jack, since we're getting into aristocratic morality and all that—what do you actually think about eugenics?

(A beat of silence. The room shifts slightly. Laura watches Jack carefully. Rhea frowns.)

Jack:
That's a loaded question, Felix. Dangerous territory. But alright—I'll walk it. Even the ancients touched it. Socrates, in *The Republic*, talks about breeding the best together, separating the weak. Nietzsche, too, danced with the idea—though his notion was more spiritual, a kind of breeding of values, of strength of character.

Felix:
So… you're not denying the premise?

Jack:
I'm saying this: humans are animals. The problem with most modern ethics—especially humanism—is that it presumes we are *above* animals. That we're governed by some spiritual or technolgoical

exemption. But biologically, we are not. Nature selects all the time. The question is whether humans should intervene in that process—intentionally.

Rhea:
That's where it gets horrific, Jack. History is soaked in blood from men who thought they had the right to decide who lives and who doesn't.

Jack:
Of course. Which is why the discussion must never be about *force*. The evil of eugenics in the twentieth century was its coercion—its grotesque violation of human dignity. But if we're honest—utterly honest—there's a soft, voluntary form of selection happening all the time. People choose partners. They prize intelligence, beauty, kindness. They want healthy children. We *already* select. We just don't speak of it.

Clive:
So what are you saying? That we should talk about it more?

Jack:
Talk honestly, yes. Not through the lens of domination or control—but through the lens of aspiration. What kind of humanity do we want? We don't scoff at someone who trains to run faster or think sharper. But when it comes to the body, or the genome—we pretend it's taboo. Why? Because we fear the shadow of the past. But maybe the way forward is through *sunlight*, not silence.

Laura:
There's a fine line though, Jack. Between self-improvement and technocratic dystopia. Between parents choosing music lessons and choosing eye colour.

Jack:
I agree. Which is why this must remain a philosophical question—not a policy one. It's not a question of government breeding humans, but of culture encouraging excellence, health, vitality. Of individuals aspiring toward better. Eugenics is a monster when directed by the state. But if we deny all discussion, we hand the tools of biology to those without philosophy.

Adam:
So we need an ethics of improvement—not a science of control.

Felix:
But Jack—let's take this a step further. Suppose, in this Anglo-futurist world we half live in already, a regime—or even just a network of institutions—flipped the switch. Let's say they began talking openly about *breeding the best with the best*. Not through coercion, but *access*. Imagine if, instead of endlessly investing in remedial education or wealth redistribution, the state—or let's say a DAO—focused on *genetics* as the key to lifting the poor. Say a couple—or a polycule—wanted to have children, but lacked certain advantageous traits. What if they could receive donated eggs or sperm from someone with exceptional IQ, temperament, health? Voluntarily. Could that be a more honest way of reducing inequality?

(A long pause. The group shifts. Laura refills her glass silently. Jack smiles, half-somber.)

Jack:
That's a powerful hypothetical. And not far off, honestly. The technology exists. CRISPR, gene

editing, polygenic scores—they're all here, lurking behind the veil of bioethics committees and nervous corporate PR.

Rhea:
And the moment that switch flips, we've opened Pandora's box. You think inequality is bad now? Imagine when your child's disadvantage isn't just socioeconomic—but genomic.

Jack:
True, but it already is. Intelligence is heredity already, so is height and beauty largely. But Felix's question isn't about coercion—it's about *access*. What if *everybody* could improve the starting conditions of their children—not just the rich in Silicon Valley with fertility labs?

Clive:
It'd be a new kind of welfare. Genetic uplift. Like a futures market in humanity.

Jack:
Exactly. It's the rational extension of egalitarianism. Not everyone starts equal—but maybe we can *help with* more equality at birth. Or at least reduce avoidable suffering—hereditary disease, severe cognitive impairment, debilitating genetic traits.

Laura:
But who decides what's "advantageous"? IQ? Temperament? Height? Beauty? You're not just distributing gametes—you're shaping a whole aesthetic of what a human *ought* to be.

Jack:
And isn't that what culture does already? Just through stories, advertising, norms, institutions? This would just make explicit what is now implicit. The difference is—it could be *voluntary*. Crowdsourced. Decentralised. You wouldn't need a Ministry of Human Design—you'd just need open-source platforms and cultural preference.

Felix:
So instead of state-enforced eugenics, you get open-access designer kinships.

Jack:
That's one way of putting it. And, let's be honest—there would be horror stories. But there would also be greatness. It would be messy, chaotic, and uneven. But if done carefully, with a philosophical framework, it could also be the greatest act of love a civilisation has attempted: to *gift* the next generation a better foundation.

Rhea:
And yet… that assumes we know what "better" means.

Jack:
Which is why philosophy must lead, not follow. And taste, not bureaucracy. If the sublime guides us—not just utility—then maybe we stand a chance of creating something truly noble. Not perfect. But noble. If we were to think without sentiment—just logically, even biologically—we'd have to admit that selective breeding is not a perversion, but a constant. It already happens, unconsciously. People marry people who look like them, think like them, are in their class. This is assortative mating. The difference is, it's accidental. It's aesthetic and social, not guided. Now imagine an environment where that selection wasn't random or purely emotional—but refined. Let's say a

network—call it a Breeders' Guild—where genetic profiles are open source, curated by communities committed to intergenerational excellence. The aim isn't domination—it's *refinement*.

Felix:
You're not talking about test tubes or CRISPR now. You're talking about a human environment—breeding not in the laboratory, but something social?

Jack:
Exactly. Picture rooms—not sterile labs, but… high-aesthetic salons. Velvet lounges lit like something between a chapel and a jazz bar. Bulls and chicks, we could call them, would enter not with shame, but with pride. They'd meet not for flings, but for futures. The highest quality minds and bodies—curated not by money or status alone, but by excellence across forms: reason, beauty, virtue, drive. There could be philosophical symposia, aesthetic tests, creative play. People could pay to be a part of the experiments. Think what it could do. A generation bred not from accident or drunken lust—but from intent. From shared ideals of the good. No one would be forced. But those who chose to participate would be creating a lineage of refinement. Not elite in the current sense—rich kids and prep schools—but *genuinely elite*. The highest human animals, creating the next version of themselves.

Felix:
But Jack—what happens to love?

Jack:
Love... evolves. When the stakes are civilisation, we don't just *feel* love. We *choose* it.

Felix:
So in this vision, love becomes a moral act—a commitment to the future, not just the present. It's not just pheromones and poems. It's responsibility, even design.

Jack:
Yes. Love becomes *intentional*. It's not eradicated—it's *elevated*. Think of it this way: if you knew you were passing on not just your feelings, but the very frame of your mind, your health, your disposition—wouldn't you choose more carefully? Wouldn't love become *deeper* in its stakes? Not every union needs to be sacred. But in such a system, *some* could be. They'd be marked by a kind of ethical seriousness we don't even have language for yet.

Felix:
But wouldn't that breed a caste? A group of curated, better humans, and everyone else?

Jack:
Not necessarily. There's no need for coercion. Think of it more like Olympic training. Most people don't become Olympians—but they admire them. They're not resentful that someone can run faster—they're inspired. The existence of excellence doesn't degrade the ordinary. It dignifies it. What's more—this isn't about building a master race. It's about *reminding ourselves* that excellence exists. That it *can* be pursued, even in our genes. That we are not condemned to drift, generation to generation, unchosen.

Felix:
But isn't that still dangerous? Doesn't every tyranny begin with the belief in better blood?

Jack:
Tyranny begins when you deny the role of choice. When you *force*. But I'm talking about voluntary curation. About decentralised aristocracy. If you design it correctly, it doesn't lead to oppression. It leads to aspiration. And maybe, just maybe, in the silence between two people—knowing, clear-eyed, consenting—they could look at each other and know: "We are the architects of someone who might surpass us."

Rhea:
So what, Jack—you want to breed a stable of philosopher kings? A whole generation of Nietzschean Ubermenschen raised like racehorses in some aristocrats stud farm?

Jack:
No, not quite. Though the image is admittedly vivid. I'm not saying we turn humanity into livestock. The point isn't to reduce man to his genome—it's to raise the baseline of civilisation. Imagine, not a master race, but a generation with the *capacity* for mastery. Not for tyranny, but for stewardship. What I imagine is a future where the philosopher king is not an anomaly—where the traits that make wisdom, foresight, taste, and discipline possible are nurtured, not by accident, but by design.

Rhea:
But isn't that the whole point of civilisation? That we *rise above* biology? That education, culture, society—all of it—is precisely so we don't have to rely on birth?

Jack:
Yes, and that's why I don't place genes at the pinnacle. We're not horses. We are something more. Our minds, our spirits, our institutions—these shape us just as much. But wouldn't it be absurd to ignore the raw material? If we can improve it—*gently*, *voluntarily*—then why wouldn't we? The philosopher king isn't made *only* by blood, but by discipline, environment, and reflection. Still, a sharper tool in a skilled hand is always better than a blunt one.

Rhea:
But don't you see how dangerous that language is? The *raw material*. It already echoes the worst histories. The question isn't just who decides what excellence looks like—but what happens when that definition calcifies. When someone is born *outside* of it.

Jack:
That's precisely why it must remain decentralised. No state edicts. No central authority. A patchwork of voluntary visions. Think of it as an ecosystem of excellence—some will try breeding for intellect, others for empathy, others for resilience. It won't be one ideal—it will be an *arena of ideals*. Competing. Evolving. But in all this, we can't lose sight of the deeper truth: humans are not just minds, nor just bodies. We are bridges—between what we are, and what we could be.

(Silence for a moment as the fire crackles. The whisky glows amber in their glasses.)

Rhea:
So you're not just breeding better men. You're trying to breed *better possibilities*.

Jack:
Rhea, what if I told you that the greatest welfare state wouldn't be one that redistributes *wealth*, but one that redistributes *capacity*?

Rhea:
Capacity? You mean intelligence? Health? Temperament?

Jack:
Exactly. Imagine this—not some bureaucratic safety net, but a civilisational *floor* that rises with every generation. We could breed out the worst predispositions: hereditary disease, severe mental dysfunction, the kind of genetic bad luck that locks a child into poverty before they're even born. We talk endlessly about inequality, but what if the real problem isn't money at all? What if it's *capacity inequality*—the uneven spread of cognitive, emotional, and physical resources?

Felix:
So you're saying the future welfare state is eugenic? Not in the 20th-century sense—no coercion, no state mandates—but in a decentralised, opt-in way?

Jack:
Exactly that. Sovereign families, couples, polycules—choosing better donors, building stronger baselines. This isn't about designing perfection. It's about lifting the *floor*, not enforcing the *ceiling*. Imagine a society where *everyone* has the tools to run two or three small businesses, to code, to compose, to manage their own time, to raise children with aesthetic sense, cultural refinement, and internal discipline.

Rhea:
But isn't that just a fantasy of the upper middle class? What makes you think any of that—skills, culture, taste—can be bred into a child?

Jack:
Not *bred into*. *Enabled*. The genes are one part, the soil. But the society—education, access, example—is the sun and rain. You can't grow a cedar from concrete, and right now much of society is concrete. What I'm saying is: rewild the foundations. Build better conditions for *sovereign individuals* to emerge.

Clive:
You're talking about a renaissance. But not like Florence. A genetic-cultural renaissance. Where the factory setting of humanity isn't passive consumption, but active excellence.

Jack:
Exactly. The sovereign individual isn't an anomaly—it should be the baseline. And to get there, we need to raise the baseline, not lower the bar. A society of generalists. Of poets with engineering degrees. Of aesthetes with balance sheets. It's not utopia. It's responsibility. The future demands more of us. We have to become *more*.

Adam:
Jack, I've been meaning to ask—what exactly do you mean by *sovereign individualism*? Sovereign like a king? Sovereign like a state? Sovereignty, traditionally, comes from God, doesn't it? Or at least from some metaphysical idea of order. If every person is sovereign, doesn't that collapse into chaos? What happens to parliament, to the rule of law? If the government's too small to enforce rules, where does that leave the *law of the land*?

Jack:
Good. I'm glad you asked that, Adam. Sovereign individualism doesn't mean lawlessness. It means *responsibility*. It means that the individual is the primary unit of accountability, not the state.

Sovereignty, in this sense, is self-rule—not divine right, but the capacity to govern yourself. Think of it this way: Parliament still exists. In fact, it becomes *stronger*. It returns to what it was meant to be—a body that crafts law, not one that administers your life. No more cradle-to-grave micromanagement. Just clear, elegant, enforceable law.

Adam:
But who enforces the law if the government is smaller? Surely we need scale to maintain order.

Jack:
You only need scale if you have a society that's fundamentally adversarial—people trying to cheat, exploit, evade. But if you create a culture of *sovereign individuals*—people who understand law as a coordination mechanism, not a weapon—you need less enforcement. You need *better law*, not more bureaucracy.

Rhea:
So you're saying if the laws are rational and just, people will naturally follow them?

Jack:
Yes. If a law is well made, it creates incentives to follow it. And in a decentralised world—of sound money, local contracts, private arbitration—people choose the frameworks they trust. Parliament will make law the same way we curate open-source code: based on clarity, trust, and utility.

Adam:
So Parliament becomes a GitHub repo?

Jack:
Exactly. A well-maintained protocol. No coercion, just consensus. The state isn't abolished—it's *refactored*. From central planner to legal curator. From paternalistic sovereign to humble lawmaker. That is the destiny of parliament in a society of sovereigns.

Jack:
And on this island the market governs itself. The government does not intervene. It doesn't pick winners. It doesn't subsidize or suppress. It merely observes and legislates, when necessary, with minimal interference. The government has no standing army in the economy. It cannot wage war with capital. It's like gravity: it's there, but it doesn't tell the river where to flow.

Rhea:
But wouldn't that lead to monopolies? To exploitation? Isn't the market just as capable of tyranny?

Jack:
Tyranny requires force. In a free market, there's no force. Only persuasion, reputation, and the right to walk away. A monopoly in a true free market only exists as long as it continues to serve better than anyone else. There's no state-granted privilege. No bailouts. No backroom deals. The market is a living, breathing form of self-governance. Each transaction is a vote. Each contract is a micro-constitution. It adapts faster than any legislature ever could.

Clive:
So you're saying, Jack, that the island runs on code—not law. Protocol, not policy.

Jack:
Yes, beautifully put. Law becomes minimal—protecting property rights, enforcing contracts, adjudicating disputes. But the free market—built on digital rails, Bitcoin, open protocols—governs

itself. You want insurance? There's a thousand options, each with transparent terms. You want a pension? Build one through savings, staking, reputation. You want to create? Offer value. You want to rest? Accumulate trust. No handouts, no punishments, just choice.

Adam:
But what happens to people who fall behind? Not everyone's a sovereign. Not everyone's capable of managing everything.

Jack:
That's the common fear—and the common misconception. In a market without distortion, the cost of failure isn't ruin. It's feedback. It's rapid, honest correction. And mutual aid still exists—just not through faceless bureaucracy, but through voluntary association, community, and innovation. The sovereign individual doesn't mean the *isolated* individual. It means *interdependent* on better terms. The strong lift the weak, not through taxation, but through shared value. The poor are helped not because they are owed, but because they are *worth* something—and because helping them creates *value*, not dependence.

Clive:
So the market isn't just efficient—it's moral.

Jack:
Exactly. The free market is not immoral. It's *amoral*, yes—but it becomes moral when people are moral. And that's where the sublime returns. When society is based on excellence, responsibility, and trust, the market becomes a mirror of our best selves.

(Jack leaned forward, the angular amber of the Anglo-futurist whisky catching the candlelight in his glass like it was fermenting time itself. Let me tell you a myth. It's short. You'll like it. It's called The Parable of the Tower and the Garden.)

He waited, just a moment—until silence rippled across the room like the hush before an orchestra.

> *In a forgotten age, there was an Island governed by a Garden.*
> *All people were equal in the Garden—fed the same food, clothed in the same robes, their lives gently pruned by soft, invisible hands. The Garden was lush, peaceful, and utterly dull.*
>
> *On the edge of the Island stood a great Tower. None in the Garden knew who had built it. It reached into the clouds and shimmered with strange light. The children of the Garden were told: never climb the Tower, for at the top lived monsters—those who thought themselves better.*
>
> *But once in a generation, a child would wander too close to the base and glimpse a ladder made of glass. One day, a girl named Elira disobeyed. She climbed the Tower.*
>
> *Each level she passed, she met those who had left the Garden—poets, scientists, warriors, monks, each refining themselves. Some had chosen to breed with only the brightest. Others studied beauty in solitude. Some were ugly, but their minds glittered.*
>
> *Elira climbed for years. Her body grew strong. Her thoughts sharpened. On the 99th level she met a man who said: "The sublime is not at the top. The sublime is the climb."*

When she reached the 100th level, she looked down and saw the Garden was gone. It had withered. No new children dared climb. The Tower was quiet. So she built a school on the 100th level, then walked back down—not to destroy the Garden, but to invite others.

Most refused.

But some followed.

And so the Island changed.

Jack finished, then sat back in his chair, letting the last line linger like smoke.

Jack:
What does it mean?

Rhea:
It's a beautiful story, sure. But it smuggles in hierarchy without ever admitting it. The Garden is presented like a stagnant swamp, and the Tower—this beacon of growth and ascent. But what if the people in the Garden *choose* simplicity? Does that make them lesser?

Clive:
But Rhea... the story didn't condemn the Garden. It simply said the Island changed when people were invited up. I think that's key. It was an *invitation*, not a purge.

Laura:
Mmm. Maybe. But it's a seduction, isn't it? A slow one. Climbing the Tower looks like virtue, but it might just be ambition in disguise. I know men who want to 'ascend' but all they do is look down on others. They just want status. A different kind of Garden, built for ego.

Adam:
Still, the idea that the *sublime is the climb*—that rang true. I mean, isn't that what art is? Or even love? It's not in the outcome. It's the movement upwards, the striving. The Tower doesn't need to be elitist. It could be personal.

Rhea:
But isn't the parable still saying: the ones who climb are the ones who matter? That civilisation only happens when the right people lead?

Clive:
Maybe not *lead*. Maybe *model*. Like Elira—the girl didn't take over the Garden. She built a school. She returned. Isn't that what aristocracy could mean, in its best form? Not domination, but cultivation.

Laura:
Still smells like noblesse oblige to me. Come down from your tower and bless us with your education? No thanks.

Adam:
But isn't that better than staying up there and doing nothing? I don't know. I feel like... the Garden will always exist. But someone has to build the Tower. If no one does, civilisation gets soft.

Rhea:
You mean like it is now?

(Laughter breaks out—brief, tense, real.)

Clive:
The real danger isn't the Tower. It's the fear of it.

Laura:
Or the worship of it. The room settles again, their words still hanging like embers in the low-lit air. Jack sets his glass down on the table—a delicate clink—and leans forward slightly, the firelight catching the sharp angle of his cheek. He's been listening, maybe even smiling inwardly, letting them grapple with the parable.

Jack:
You all speak as if the Tower were a choice one makes—up or down, climb or stay. But what if I told you the Tower isn't a place... but a *pattern*?

(He pauses. The room is quiet.)

The Garden represents stasis. The Tower, not ambition—but orientation. It's not about *who* climbs—it's about *whether we orient ourselves towards ascent at all*. A society that orients towards excellence—toward the sublime—is one that has a future.

Rhea:
So you *do* think it's hierarchical.

Jack:
Everything that grows is. A tree is not the same as its seed. It stretches upwards, and in doing so casts shadow, provides fruit, carves space. Hierarchy is natural—it's *growth*. Without hierarchy, everything is mulch.

Adam:
And the people in the Garden?

Jack:
Some will stay. Some always will. But if we never build the Tower, no one *can* climb. We must *build*, even if not everyone climbs. That's the duty of the aristocrat—not to rule, but to *raise*."

Clive:
Like Elira.

Jack:
Exactly. The Tower is the myth of excellence passed down. It is the very idea that civilisation must be *made*—not inherited, not stumbled into.

Laura:
But how do you know who gets to build it? Who is *fit*?

Jack:
They choose themselves. Not by birth, but by devotion. It's not about blood. It's about orientation to the sublime. The sovereign individual chooses to climb. The aristocratic soul is a craftsman of civilisation.

(He leans back again. The silence is heavy but charged.)

Jack:
In every generation, there are those who climb, and those who prune the hedges. Both are necessary. But only one expands the horizon.

Laura:
Well, that's enough talk of breeding and aristocracy for one wine-fuelled hour. I'm going to put the food on before we start looking at each other, trying to work out who we should be breeding with.

(A soft ripple of laughter breaks the tension. Clive smirks. Rhea snorts into her glass. Even Jack chuckles.)

Clive:
Careful, Laura, or you'll be accused of anti-eugenic bias.

Laura:
Only if you lot start drafting breeding contracts over dinner.

(She disappears through the archway into the kitchen. The sound of cupboards opening and pans clinking filters through.)

Felix:
God, I feel like we've just had a séance with Plato and Nietzsche at the same time.

Adam:
It's strange, isn't it? How easy it is to forget we're just people… in a house… on a street in North London. Yet it feels like we're right in the middle of something serious.

(No one replies. The whisky glows gold in the glasses. Outside, the streetlamps hum. Inside, the group settles into a stillness: a soft cocoon of Georgian plaster, rising thought, and aromatic smoke curling from the incense burner by the record player.)

Rhea:
Maybe we are just people. But sometimes, it feels like something's cracking open. Like the future's slipping in through the cracks.

(Jack says nothing. He sips his wine. His gaze is fixed ahead—not on anyone, but on some shape beyond the moment, like a form half-seen in fog.)

Book II

(The dining room is warm with light, glowing from a glass orb hanging above them like an artificial moon—half-industrial, half-hearth. The table, long and polished, hummed softly with conversation,

*plates, and refilled glasses. The wine now poured was a vivid amber—**a Kentish Solaris**, matured in pine barrels and lightly infused with lab-extracted notes of petrichor and linseed oil. It smelled like a summer storm breaking over an ancient library. In front of them sat the **starter**: **bang bang chicken reimagined**—slow-cooked Norfolk pheasant breast, torn by hand and tossed in a micro-chili aioli, served with julienned pickled radish grown in vertical farms atop Manchester tower blocks. It was plated over a bed of cold noodles made from lab-spun buckwheat, shimmering slightly under the glow of the light. **Jack** swirled his glass and leaned forward, fork resting on the side of his plate.)*

Bang Bang Chicken: Slow-Cooked Norfolk Pheasant with Micro-Chili Aioli & Julienned Pickled Radish

Serves 4

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1. Slow-Cooked Norfolk Pheasant

Ingredients:

- 4 Norfolk pheasant breasts (skin-on, if possible)
- 2 tbsp neutral oil (e.g., grapeseed)
- Brine: 1L water, 50g salt, 30g sugar, 1 star anise, 1 bay leaf (simmered and cooled)
- Aromatics for cooking: 2 garlic cloves (smashed), 1 thumb ginger (sliced), 1 lemon (zested)

Method:

1. Brine: Submerge pheasant breasts in cooled brine for 1 hour. Pat dry.
2. Slow-cook: Heat oil in a pan. Sear breasts skin-side down until golden. Transfer to a low oven (140°C/120°C fan) with garlic, ginger, and lemon zest. Roast for 45-60 mins until tender. Rest, then hand-shred into rustic pieces.

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2. Micro-Chili Aioli

Ingredients:

- 100g Kewpie mayo (or classic aioli)
- 1 tbsp chili crisp (e.g., Lao Gan Ma)
- 1 tsp gochugaru (Korean chili flakes)
- 1 garlic clove (grated)
- 1 tsp lime juice

- ½ tsp honey
- Pinch of salt

Method:
Whisk all ingredients until smooth. Taste and adjust heat with extra chili crisp.

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3. Julienned Pickled Radish

Ingredients:

- 200g radishes (julienned)
- Pickling liquid: 100ml rice vinegar, 50ml water, 25g sugar, 1 tsp salt, ½ tsp black peppercorns, 1 star anise

Method:

1. Bring pickling liquid ingredients to a simmer. Cool slightly.
2. Pour over radishes in a jar. Let sit for 30 mins (or overnight for sharper flavor). Drain before serving.

Assembly:

- Toss warm pheasant in a generous spoonful of micro-chili aioli.
- Layer a base of pickled radish on plates, top with pheasant, and drizzle with extra aioli.
- Garnish with cilantro leaves, black sesame seeds, and edible flowers (optional).

Pairing Suggestion: A crisp, off-dry Riesling or a floral gin-and-tonic with lemongrass garnish.

Jack:
Alright then. We've done beauty, we've done breeding… let's talk time.

(He let the word hang, like a spell cast across the oak.)

Here we are, sitting on a finite Earth, in a Bitcoin world—fixed supply, rising demand. Every satoshi more valuable than the last. A system hardwired for deflation and appreciation. So let me ask: *how far should we think into the future?* A hundred years? A thousand? A million?

Clive:
Like Bitcoin monks? Hoarding sats for the great-great-great-grandchildren we'll never meet?

Adam:
It's a serious question though. If time preference is shaped by money, then Bitcoin should be extending our horizon. In theory, we should all be building cathedrals again.

Felix:
If anything, the future feels further away, not closer.

Rhea:
That's the irony, isn't it? The harder it is to spend, the more you hoard. The more you hoard, the less you live. Jack, are we supposed to become monks or billionaires?

Jack:
I'm not saying we all lock ourselves in citadels counting satoshis like Smaug. But I do think it changes the moral architecture of time. When money holds its value—*grows* in value—your decisions start echoing further. The future isn't an abstraction anymore. It's an investment.

Laura:
And what does that make the present? Just something to mortgage for the future?

Jack:
No. It's something to **calibrate**. We're at a cultural pivot point. Fiat encourages indulgence, Bitcoin demands vision.

(A silence followed. Not heavy, but attentive—as though the group felt time itself settle around them like a second skin. ***Jack leans back*** *as the pheasant was slowly picked at, the room gentle with heat and thought. The conversation had begun to coil again, like smoke around a candle flame.)*

Jack:
Let's look deeper into the nature of time passing. You know—whether we're meant to ride it, shape it, resist it… or just let it wash over us.

Clive:
Passive or active. Whether time happens to you, or you happen to time.

Adam:
There's always that tension, isn't there? Between the party and the project. Between the weekend on mushrooms… and the decade spent building something for someone you'll never meet.

Laura:
But that party *is* real. It's a present you can taste. The future's always some ghost—vague, theoretical. Maybe that's why we reach for pleasure now. It's an anchor.

Rhea:
Still, if you live only for the now, you end up bankrupt in more ways than one.

Jack:
Exactly. I think we need to recalibrate how we weigh time. The fiat world made us short-sighted—'live for the moment,' 'you only live once,' and all that, but people rarely did live. Not like now. But maybe the ethical tension now is this: *how much of the present do we sacrifice for a future we'll never see?*

Felix:
That’s almost religious. Like building up temples without ever entering them. Perpetually plan for the future, but never get to enjoy it.

Jack:
Or like planting trees whose shade we’ll never sit under. That’s the real test of civilisation. That’s *sovereign ethics*. When you choose not pleasure but permanence.

Clive:
But isn’t there value in the party, too? Not just as hedonism but… ritual? Joy, communion. If we deny that, don’t we make the future joyless too?appe

Jack:
I’m not against parties. I’m just saying they should be *earned*. The sublime experience should have weight. It shouldn’t be cheap.

Adam:
So drug-taking becomes something closer to pilgrimage than past-time.

Jack:
Exactly. It should elevate. That’s the whole point of the sublime—*it’s earned*. Not bought.

Laura:
So we’re to become ascetics with good wine and vertical pheasant?

Rhea:
Builders with psychedelic sacraments and trustless ledgers.

Felix:
Stewards of time.

*(**Jack**, refilling his glass with a slow precision, leaned into the gentle lull at the table, eyes glinting with the fire of a new line of inquiry.)*

Jack:
But here’s the harder question. If we’ve won the lottery of history—if we’re sitting on a Bitcoin standard, sovereign, wealthy, with more tools and freedom than any generation before us… *why not* spend it all? Why *shouldn’t* we blow it on mad hedonism, parties, psychedelics, endless dopamine? Why not be like the fiat boomers—consume everything, leave nothing?

(The table held still. Rhea furrowed her brow; Felix looked intrigued. Clive, for once, said nothing.)

Jack:
What is the *morality* of restraint when there’s so much wealth? When the asset goes up forever, when no one is starving, when the future seems bright, decentralised, trustless, and free?

Adam:
You’re describing utopia. But utopias rot too, Jack. Hedonism becomes nihilism real quick.

Jack:
Exactly. That’s what I’m getting at. The ethics of time and wealth are *tied together*. And maybe the test isn’t what we do when things are hard. Maybe the test is what we do when things are easy.

Laura:
So morality's harder when you can afford to ignore it.

Jack:
Yes. In fiat times, you saved because you had to. In hyperbitcoinised times, you save because you *choose to*. And that choice—of delayed pleasure, of stewardship—that's where ethics lives.

Rhea:
But why should we owe the future anything?

Jack:
Because if we don't, we repeat the sin of fiat: *we consume the soil our children were meant to farm.* If we become decadent, we forfeit civilisation. Time isn't something to kill. It's something to *tend.*

Felix:
Bitcoin doesn't just make you wealthy. It teaches you time preference.

Jack:
And time preference is a moral preference. The lower it goes, the higher the civilisation. *That's* the equation we're writing.

Rhea:
But if it's that important why can't we just have it enforced by laws?

Jack:
Ah, but that's precisely the danger. You've identified the fault line. A state *can* enforce long-term thinking, sure—it can ration, restrict, penalise, hoard. But that's not valuing the future. That's just stealing the present under the pretence of planning. *Real* valuation of the future must be *voluntary*, or it's not moral—it's just coercion in time's costume.

(He set down his fork, letting the moment stretch, the low hum of conversation at the table thinning to silence once again.)

Jack:
You asked for a moral basis? Here it is: the morality of the future lies in the *dignity of choice*. When I choose to save, when I choose to build something I'll never see finished, when I plant a tree whose fruit I'll never taste—that is a *gift*. That is grace. And grace cannot be nationalised.

Laura:
That's beautiful, Jack. But still—what if most people just don't care? What if the present is too tempting? Isn't that what the state is for? To stop us from being our worst selves?

(Jack turned to her, warm and unwavering.)

Jack:
That's the old assumption—the Hobbesian impulse. But sovereign individualism turns it on its head. It says: *build systems that reward our better selves*, not cage our worst. If we design a world where the time-honouring choice is profitable, not preachy—then morality becomes something people *do*, not something they *owe.*

Felix:
So the moral basis isn't obedience. It's beauty.

Jack:
Exactly. *Beauty, grace, and time.* The three things the fiat world forgot. The most valuable thing to do with time and money," he said, voice steady, "is to build something *beautiful* that will outlive you. Something that adds to the inheritance of civilisation.

(Jack pauses.)

Jack:
It doesn't have to be grand. It doesn't have to be a cathedral or a blockchain protocol or a new economic theory. But it does have to be something that reflects care. Consciousness. Attention. And a refusal to waste.

Rhea:
You mean legacy?

Jack:
Not quite. Legacy can be ego. This is deeper. It's about *continuity*. It's about embedding meaning in the fabric of time. Like... threads woven into a tapestry you'll never see completed, but you know—if you did—it would be worth it.

Laura:
And the money?

Jack:
Same answer. Use it to sharpen yourself. Or to support others who build. Invest in art, in architecture, in your own sovereignty. Not to escape life—but to deepen it. And if you're ever lost, spend money the same way you spend time: as if it matters.

Laura:
Alright philosopher. What's the most beautiful thing in the world then? And don't say *a relationship*.

(The grin became a full smirk. Jack laughed, catching her glance.)

Jack:
I was going to say *a relationship*, actually.

Laura:
I knew it. Classic. The old romantic behind all that brains and coin.

Jack:
Well, you asked for beauty, not utility. And a relationship—when done well—is both. But fine, something physical?

(He looks off for a second, the whisky still lingering in his mouth, warming his throat.)

Jack:
The most beautiful thing, physically... is a moment of unbroken form. When something reaches such a degree of harmony—mathematically, emotionally, symbolically—that it feels like the world stands still. A temple dome. A sculpture mid-turn. A human face in rapture.

***(Laura** raises an eyebrow, intrigued despite herself.)*

Jack:
It’s when the external world briefly mirrors the internal one. That rare symmetry. That’s the sublime we were talking about. Beauty isn’t prettiness—it’s *alignment*. Of form and essence.

Felix:
Like a Greek statue.

Jack:
Or the first movement of a Bach cello suite. Or a perfect silence in a room after a speech that mattered. It doesn’t even have to be classical—it can be in a neon-lit street at 3AM. Beauty isn’t conservative—it’s universal. But it must be *earned*. Beauty is when something perfectly mirrors nature and reflects the divine.

Felix:
Yeah. I get that. The kind of moment where everything aligns and nothing’s pretending. But it’s rare. And fragile.

(Notices Jack looking at him.)

Which makes me wonder... how do you actually *build* a life that makes space for those kinds of moments? Not just notice them when they show up—but *live in a way that makes them possible*? So say someone wants to become sovereign. Truly sovereign. Not just rich or loud or disconnected. What do they do? I mean, actually do. In this world. So say someone wants to become sovereign. Truly sovereign. Not just rich or loud or disconnected. What do they do? I mean, actually do. In this world.

Adam:
Yes. What does it mean to construct sovereignty, when the state isn’t enforcing your will, and there’s no god to guarantee your soul?

Jack:
It's a daily practice. Not a title you claim, but a shape you form. You begin by detaching your sense of self from dependency—on institutions, on approval, on salary. That’s the first layer.

Rhea:
Sure, but how? Nobody starts out with nothing and just...becomes sovereign.

Jack:
No. the point. You don’t start with nothing. You start with **yourself**. Your attention. Your curiosity. Your sense of disgust at mediocrity. That’s the kernel.

Laura:
So what—read the classics, stack sats, write a poem a day? Join a dojo?

Jack:
Something like that. There’s a formula, but it’s not rigid. Think of it as a *ritual*. A sovereign individual is someone who—day by day—disciplines themselves to become less dependent on the structure, and more coherent in themselves. You hold Bitcoin not just because it’s sound money—but because it *reflects the self-sovereign principle*. You read deeply not to sound smart, but to think in long arcs. You learn a skill to anchor yourself in the real.

Clive:
It sounds almost monastic. A new kind of monk—not cloistered, but connected. Building a cathedral of self.

Jack:
Yes. A monastery of one. Surrounded by noise, but silent at the centre. Not isolated. Connected. But *independent*. That's the paradox.

Felix:
But what about failure? The sovereign individual sounds like a perfectionist's dream. Most people —myself included—just want to survive with a bit of grace.

Jack:
Sovereignty isn't perfection. It's trajectory. It's the deliberate movement toward coherence. Toward responsibility. Toward beauty. Even if you never get there, the arc of your life *bends upward*. That's all that matters. This—this dish, for example—is a breakthrough. Whoever made it, my compliments. It's not just food. It's philosophy on a plate. We don't just live to survive anymore. We live to *create*. To fuse. To push boundaries. Whether that's in tech, business, or culture. That's the project of the sovereign individual—to cultivate a *personal philosophy* through which life becomes richer.

Felix:
So... you're saying making food can be philosophy?

Jack:
Of course. So can good sex. So can writing a protocol. Or designing a house, launching a business, or crafting an AI symphony. The point isn't *what* you do—it's *how* you do it. With what kind of soul. With what vision.

Rhea:
Sounds like a very tasteful kind of hedonism.

Jack:
Tasteful hedonism *is* a good place to start. But I'd call it something else: *integrated living*. You align pleasure, productivity, and philosophy. Your taste improves, so your pleasures deepen. Your mind sharpens, so your projects refine. And over time, your whole *consciousness* lifts.

Adam:
You're saying consciousness *can* evolve? Like in real time?

Jack:
It does. Not just individually—but culturally. That's the gift of this era. Every new creation—every daring fusion dish, or novel, or business model—isn't just a product. It's a *probe*. A push forwards. And those pushes become breakthroughs in how we experience being alive.

Laura:
So you eat better, think clearer, love harder.

Jack:
Exactly. The sovereign individual isn't chasing money or pleasure in isolation—they're *cultivating a self* worth living inside. A self that resonates with the future.

Felix:
I think it’s about *rituals*. That’s the word that keeps coming to me. Gym. Books. High-level conversations like this. Little things—reading an obscure Wikipedia page over coffee, catching a detail from a 19th-century essay. Knowing more is good. It *feels* good.

Rhea:
You sound like a monk.

Felix:
Well, I’ve got the monkish gym routine—except I keep failing to *stick* to it. That’s the bit I can’t ritualise. I can read ten books a month, but I struggle with deadlifts. Jack—got any tips? You always look like you’ve just walked off a 1950s recruitment poster. I find the gym... mind-numbingly dull.

Jack:
Well, first off—I eat mostly meat. It’s clean fuel. And I don’t really think in terms of workouts anymore—I think in terms of *time*. I go for an hour, more or less, and break it into layers.

Laura:
Layers of pain?

Jack:
Layers of effort. First, weights. Some days heavy, some light—depends on the rhythm. Then I do stretching, dead hangs to decompress the spine. Then it’s thirty minutes of skipping—rope work, coordination, foot rhythm. It’s meditative. That’s the warm-up.

Felix:
That’s the *warm-up*?

Jack:
Then gymnastics. That’s the centrepiece. Pulling yourself up, flipping over, inverting the body. Getting blood rushing into the brain. That’s what most people miss—putting yourself upside down resets everything. It changes how you see yourself.

Laura:
A literal change of perspective.

Jack:
Exactly. You’re not just training muscles—you’re training awareness. Precision. Play. After that, I swim. Cold water, if I can. That seals it. It resets the nervous system. You come out reborn.

Felix:
So it’s a kind of physical *meditation*?

Jack:
It’s building the self like a cathedral. One deliberate ritual at a time.

Rhea:
Honestly, you sound like an Anglo-futurist monk with an Olympic complex.

Jack:
Not far off. This body’s my sovereign territory. I govern it like a nation.

Jack:
The body comes first. Always. Before the mind, before the spirit. It's not a hierarchy in terms of value, but in terms of sequence. The foundation has to be strong. If you build on sand—on a neglected, soft body—you'll collapse under the weight of any higher pursuit.

Felix:
So you're saying strength isn't just aesthetic—it's metaphysical?

Jack:
Exactly. Physical exertion—training, wrestling, swimming, cold exposure—it's a *discipline*. It teaches you limits. Then it teaches you how to push past them. Every kid should feel what it's like to run until you see stars, to lift something heavy and fail, and then come back next week and *do it*. That's the beginning of sovereignty.

Laura:
But not everyone gets that kind of start. Most kids are glued to screens now—algorithms know them better than their parents do.

Jack:
And that's the *tragedy*. Because if the body isn't trained early—if it's passive, overstimulated, sluggish—then the mind follows. The mind becomes hyper-reactive, overly stimulated by noise, unaccustomed to boredom. And boredom is where the real *thinking* begins.

Rhea:
You think physical neglect *causes* the spiritual void?

Jack:
Yes. If your hands have never gripped soil, pulled ropes, climbed trees, held a freezing cold rail—you're disconnected from your *species*. You're still human, of course. But you're a spirit trapped in an untested vessel. The body teaches *reality* before anything else. It grounds you. And *then* the mind can grow. And then—eventually—the spirit.

Felix:
So you're saying physicality is the first freedom.

Jack:
It's the first domain of liberty. Before you can make your own money, build your own ideas, choose your own gods—you have to own your body. If you can't carry your own weight, you're still in debt to the earth.

Jack:
The internet solved society's biggest issues. Class tension, race tension, even ugliness—it all disappears under pseudonymity. Online, no one cares if you're rich or poor, black or white, pretty or ugly. They care if you *have signal*. If you can write. Build. Code. Meme. That's what matters.

Felix:
So you're saying the real world's the afterparty?

Jack:
Exactly. The internet is the battleground of intellect, persuasion, creativity. Once you've won *there*, the real world becomes a *playground*. You lift weights, you cook meals, you throw parties. You don't fight for power on the street anymore. That was 20th-century thinking.

Rhea:
But don’t we lose something, though? Like community? Or warmth?

Jack:
No—we *regain* it. Because now, the people who meet in the real world, post-internet, post-fiat... they’re already *filtered*. They’ve passed through a kind of digital gauntlet. They're *based*, capable, interesting. The pub becomes a salon. The gym becomes a temple. It’s no longer forced proximity, it’s *earned presence*.

Laura:
So what, the internet is the filter, and the real world’s the output?

Jack:
Yes. And it reverses the tragedy of urban modernity. Before, the city meant strangers pressed up against each other with nothing in common. Now, we find each other *online*. And when we meet in the real world—after months, maybe years of digital connection—it’s *electric*. The meatspace becomes rich again.

Felix:
Meatspace. Hate that word.

Jack:
I love it. It reminds you we’re animals, beasts. And once the internet solves coordination, identity, and even trust—then the body returns to its rightful place. We surf, we spar, we cook, we love. All the boring parts of life—bureaucracy, politics, gatekeeping—moved online. So life can be *lived* again.

Rhea:
But doesn’t that require everyone to *master* the internet?

Jack:
No. Just enough of us. A *critical mass*. A generation of sovereigns, builders, coders, poets. Once they shape the code, they shape the world. And everyone else will follow, just like always.

Laura:
What does it look like? That world?

Jack:
Pseudonymous minds. Beautiful bodies. Local living. Global thinking. Free time. Deep art. Earned trust. That’s the future**.** The world could *actually* become a playground. Once the politics, the infrastructure, the power games—all the *hard stuff*—is online, pseudonymous and programmable… meatspace is liberated. Real life gets to be about joy. About presence. About beauty. You don’t *go* to the town hall anymore. You log in to the protocol.

Felix:
So what—no more protests, just protocol updates?

Jack:
Exactly. And that’s why being trained on the internet should be as essential as learning to swim, or how to share. From a young age, we should be taught that the internet isn’t a toy. It’s not where you just scroll and consume. It’s where the serious work happens. Where the adult world lives now.

Rhea:
But kids already grow up online. Isn't that what everyone complains about?

Jack:
Yeah—but they're growing up in the worst part of it. Algorithmic sludge. Digital pacifiers. What we need is initiation. Like rites of passage. Learn to code. Learn to meme. Build an online *personna* that isn't tied to your birth name. *Earn reputation*. Make things. Earn. Debate. Publish. That's the real schooling.

Laura:
And what—leave behind your identity?

Jack:
Not leave behind—*transcend*. No one should build power in their legal name anymore. It's a trap. It invites the mob, the state, the surveillance priesthood. But if your power is *pseudonymous*, if your influence can't be cancelled or taxed or tracked, you become untouchable. And paradoxically… that's when you can really speak *truth*.

Felix:
Sounds like a digital aristocracy.

Jack:
That's *exactly* what it is. Based on merit. Skill. Skin in the game. Not blood or old money. You become noble because you've done something noble—publicly, pseudonymously. And then the real world? Fewer fights. Less resentment. More trust. Because the internet *absorbs* the tension.

Rhea:
And the people who don't play the game?

Jack:
They still win. Because a world where the best rule pseudonymously is safer for everyone. It's anti-tyranny. Anti-censorship. Anti-stupidity. The future isn't democratic—it's *encrypted*.

Felix:
Alright. So, say I take this seriously. I start building an online persona. I publish, I contribute, I earn trust. How does that become... anything? How does it pay rent? Or is this just noble poverty in disguise?

Jack:
That's the thing—online status *is* the new capital. We've moved past the industrial economy, even beyond the information economy. Now it's all about reputation—*who's trusted, who's listened to*. And in that kind of world, sovereign individuals—the ones who can cultivate trust and hold attention—they're the new aristocrats.

Laura:
Aristocrats who shill affiliate links and sell Substacks?

Jack:
Sure, sometimes. But also: developers releasing open-source libraries under pseudonyms and getting paid in digital currencies. Thinkers building cult followings around philosophy, aesthetics, or economics. Artists minting digital works as NFTs. Coders dropping smart contracts and never

revealing their face. Reputation becomes the anchor. And it's *portable*. You're not reliant on one platform, or employer. That's the sovereign part.

Rhea:
But aren't most people going to end up just chasing clout? Doesn't this just recreate a new version of the influencer class?

Jack:
Maybe. But that's where the idea of *taste* comes back in. Sovereign individualism isn't about mass popularity. It's about cultivating your own *corner* of the world. Your niche. Your tribe. When automation eats the labour economy, what's left is *identity*. Curation. Meaning-making. That's where the value is.

Felix:
So instead of "what do you do?" the new question is "what do you *mean*?"

Jack:
Exactly. The sovereign individual earns by *being*. By embodying knowledge, skill, taste. That's the future. When AI writes the emails and drives the taxis, only *human character* remains scarce. That's what gets paid.

Laura:
So we're all philosophers now?

Jack:
Or priests. Or jesters. Or architects of culture. But yes—*the world pays those who think for themselves, build in public, and leave something that lasts*. That's the loop between online status and sovereign individualism. You *are* the institution now.

Laura *(standing up and smoothing down her apron)*:
Alright, time for the next course, you high priests of internet philosophy.

(She walks over to the oven and opens it with a puff of fragrant steam.)

Laura:
Tonight's special is… roast beef shawarma with juniper glaze and pickled beet tzatziki—served on Yorkshire flatbreads. And yes, there's a side of *truffle mac and cheese* because I love you all, even the ones talking about selective breeding.

(She begins plating the food with practised speed, stacking the soft flatbreads and topping them with slices of pink, spiced venison. On the side, she spoons a rich, molten mac and cheese into small ceramic bowls, crusted golden on top and flecked with spring onions and mustard seeds.)

Anglo-Futurist Fusion Feast: Roast Beef Shawarma with Juniper Glaze & Pickled Beet Tzatziki on Yorkshire Flatbreads + Truffle Mac & Cheese
Serves 4

1. Roast Beef Shawarma with Juniper Glaze
Ingredients:

800g beef sirloin or ribeye

Marinade: 3 tbsp olive oil, 2 tsp ground cumin, 2 tsp coriander, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 3 garlic cloves (minced), zest/juice of 1 lemon, 1 tsp salt

Juniper Glaze: 15 juniper berries (crushed), 4 tbsp honey, 3 tbsp balsamic vinegar, 100ml beef stock

Method:

Marinate: Coat beef in marinade ingredients. Refrigerate for 4+ hours.

Roast: Preheat oven to 200°C (180°C fan). Sear beef in a pan, then roast for 25-30 mins (medium-rare). Rest 10 mins.

Glaze: Simmer juniper, honey, balsamic, and stock until syrupy (10-12 mins). Strain, then brush over sliced beef.

2. Pickled Beet Tzatziki
Ingredients:

200g Greek yogurt

100g pickled beets (grated, drained)

1 garlic clove (minced), 1 tbsp lemon juice, 1 tbsp fresh dill (chopped), salt/pepper

Method:
Mix all ingredients. Chill for 30 mins. Adjust seasoning.

3. Yorkshire Flatbreads
Ingredients:

120g plain flour, 2 eggs, 150ml milk, 1 tbsp melted butter, pinch of salt

Method:

Whisk batter ingredients until smooth. Rest 15 mins.

Heat a non-stick pan. Pour ¼ batter, swirl thinly. Cook 2-3 mins per side. Repeat.

4. Truffle Mac & Cheese
Ingredients:

250g macaroni

Sauce: 40g butter, 40g flour, 500ml milk, 100g mature cheddar (grated), 50g gruyère (grated), 1 tsp truffle oil, pinch of nutmeg, salt/pepper

Topping: 50g panko breadcrumbs, 1 tbsp parsley (chopped)

Method:

Cook pasta al dente.

Melt butter, whisk in flour. Gradually add milk for béchamel. Stir in cheeses, truffle oil, nutmeg.

Mix sauce with pasta. Transfer to dish, top with breadcrumbs and parsley. Bake at 190°C for 20-25 mins until golden.

Assembly:
Slice beef thinly. Spread tzatziki on warm flatbreads, top with beef, and garnish with dill or microgreens. Serve with truffle mac & cheese.

Pairing Suggestion: A bold English IPA or a smoky lapsang souchong tea.

Felix:
God bless the British Empire.

(Laura carries over a large bottle of beer, the label stark and futuristic—black and chrome with simple white lettering: ***"Atlas Brew No. 4 – Deep Ferment Ale"*** *Triple-hopped. Fermented in old whisky barrels. Brewed under a full moon using geothermal heat from Ireland. Laura pours everyone a glass. The beer is thick and slightly smoky, with a strange floral top note—like moss and bergamot.)*

Rhea:
To the sovereign future, and mac and cheese. May they both never die. They clink glasses. Steam wafts from the table. The fusion of ancient meat and avant-garde sauce, of imperial decadence and highland simplicity, creates a heady culinary spell.

Jack:
Laura, this is... sublime.

Laura:
Only the best for our sovereign philosophers.

Jack:
There's something I've been looking into lately—quietly. Not many people talk about it openly, but the signs are there. Digital city-states. Cypherpunk Kommunes. Real land, real governance—but entirely online. Borderless. Stateless. Almost... ancient, in how they structure themselves.

Rhea:
You mean the digital enclaves? I've heard rumours. Jack, are you saying those things are real?

Jack:
Very real. Partly legal. Mostly grey economy. They buy up land discreetly—rural in some cases, luxury in others. Sometimes it's old farmland, sometimes it's a tower block in a forgotten European city. Rumour is Samuel Ashcombe is the head of the biggest and best in the Peaks. The sort of central node of communalism. But the real power isn't in the land—it's in the networks. The *citizenship*. You join through a kind of test: skills, values, contributions. You don't vote your way in—you *earn* it.

Felix:
So, what—crypto-benedictines? Sovereign monks with VPNs?

Jack:
Something like that. *Sovereign Citizens in Kommunes*. At the centre, they have what they call a *Philosopher Node*—a core council led by someone chosen for wisdom, not popularity. Everything's digitally administered: laws, currency, reputation, arbitration, citizenship. It's not a state—it's a *living structure*.

Rhea:
And what—no taxes? No state welfare? Just code and trust?

Jack:
No coercion. That's the point. You *want* to contribute, because your reputation and access depend on it. These communities aren't utopias—they're intense. Meritocratic. Cultish, maybe. But they're building something real. Something people *want*. Even some state actors are rumoured to be part of them—quietly hedging their bets.

Laura:
Do they have a name?

Jack:
They do. But it changes. They work in layers—public-facing names, deeper nodes, encrypted identities. It's less a brand and more a protocol. You don't Google them. You get invited to dinner. Or you publish something online and get a message two weeks later in a language you didn't know you spoke.

Felix:
That sounds like a cult *I* want to join.

Rhea:
Or a cult you want to lead.

Jack:
I'm not interested in leading. I'm interested in *learning*. They're experimenting with governance the way we experiment with cuisine. *Anglo-futurist democracy*, cypherpunk Kommunes.

Adam:
So what happens if they scale? If these digital city-states become *more* desirable than nations?

Jack:
Then the state loses its monopoly on legitimacy. Citizenship becomes something you *opt into*. Not something you inherit.

Felix:
Wait, are you saying these places aren't just little retreats? That they're *networked*? Like—actually *global* communities?

Jack:
That's the rumour. The more serious ones don't just have one spot. They've got footprints all over—dozens of locations. Hubs, cells, safehouses. Private compounds in Portugal, islands off Estonia,

townhouses in Edinburgh, and apparently... there's some kind of founding enclave in the Peak District.

Rhea:
The Peak District?

Jack:
It’s not confirmed, obviously. But enough whispers suggest there’s a Kommune there that functions almost like a *capital node*. It’s one of the only places with stable access to rural land, fast infrastructure, and distance from big power centres. The land’s owned through shell structures. The people who live there are... well, nobody really knows. But some of the publishing that’s come out of certain Bitcoin-aligned subnets traces back to IPs near Sheffield.

Laura:
So one digital citizenship... and dozens of homes around the world?

Jack:
One citizenship. One reputation chain. One private, stratified version of the internet—completely encrypted, completely governed by its own internal logic. No scraping, no ads, no noise. You access it through custom nodes and private networks. It's *thick* with knowledge, markets, mentorships, culture, art. Like the early internet—but sacred.

Adam:
And these people just float between the locations?

Jack:
Some do. Some never leave. Depends on their level. The structure’s layered. At the top, you’ve got *keepers*—the founders, the builders, the protocol designers. Then come *residents*, who hold land, run projects, or teach. Below that, *probationers*—digital citizens trying to earn full trust. And beneath them: *observers*—outsiders who interact occasionally but haven’t yet committed.

Rhea:
That sounds... very caste-like.

Jack:
Stratified, yes. But voluntary. You can rise if you contribute. Fall if you don’t. It’s merit-based in theory—but, sure, there’s always charisma, legacy, inner circles. Still, compared to the current world? It’s at least *trying* to rebuild trust from the ground up.

Felix:
So Plato’s Republic with an invite code and a seed phrase.

Jack:
More or less. But not utopian. Just... serious. These people believe the state is in terminal decline. That new legitimacy will be born online, not in parliaments. And they’re building—quietly, carefully, beautifully.

Jack:
Look—the deeper reason these communities exist, the *why*, is because we’re watching the slow-motion collapse of the welfare state. That’s the real background noise to everything. The state is anti-nature now. It props up entire sections of the country—industries, classes, ideologies—that can no longer sustain themselves, and it does it by extracting more and more from the *productive*.

Rhea:
You mean from the rich?

Jack:
I mean from the *competent*. From anyone building value. The builder, the coder, the designer, the disciplined, the self-sufficient. Taxed not just financially, but spiritually—through mediocrity, regulation, ideological compliance. Eventually, those people want out. Not to rebel—but to be *left alone*.

Felix:
So these Kommunes—these nodes—they're *off-grid*?

Jack:
Completely. They don't pay taxes to the state. They run microgrids—solar, wind, hydrogen. Energy co-ops. Some trade with local farmers, others import in bulk anonymously. Most of them code for a living—protocol development, AI systems, ghost writing, zero-day exploits. Pure skill economies. Pure pseudonymity.

Laura:
And culturally?

Jack:
Wild. Fluid. They don't think of themselves as British, or French, or whatever's stamped in their land passport. That's the term they use—*land passport*. The real identity—the one that *means* something—is their *cultural passport*: their online citizenship. That's where their loyalty lives. Not in a flag. In a forum. A private protocol. A reputation thread that runs deeper than the NHS or BBC or whatever corpse is still twitching.

Adam:
So they're sovereign... not just legally. But spiritually.

Jack:
Yes. And sexually, too. Gender, roles, relationships—*everything* is fluid. But it's not incoherent. It's post-coercive. They don't care what you are—only what you *do*. What you *build*. That's the great levelling. Not equality by fiat, but *recognition through contribution*.

Rhea:
But what about violence? Crime? How do they enforce anything?

Jack:
That's where it gets serious. Arbitration layers. Smart contracts. Internal councils. Some have exile protocols. Others have tiered access to tools and funds based on behaviour and contribution. But violence? That's state logic. Most of them believe legitimacy doesn't come from fear—but from function. The moment they become violent, they're no better than what they left behind.

Felix:
So what you're saying is—they're post-state, post-taxation, post-violence, and post-passport?

Jack:
Post-everything that doesn't work. Pre-everything that might.

Felix:
So, is there anything like that here? In London?

Jack:
Let's just say... things seem to be getting started. Quietly. Very quietly. I'm not really supposed to say more than that.

Laura:
Which means he *definitely* knows more than he's saying.

Jack:
I've heard of a few small cells. Pseudonymous dev groups. Private dining clubs that double as access nodes. Flats in Mayfair owned by trustless wallets. But you don't walk in with a name. You walk in with *proof of work*.

Adam:
So it's elitist.

Jack:
Of course it's elitist. You're expected to look after yourself. There's no helpdesk. No HR department. If you don't have skills—hard skills—you don't get through the gate. It's not about wealth. It's about *competence*. If you can't grow food, write code, run a project, build trust, or contribute meaningfully, you're dead weight.

Felix:
So the price of admission is sovereignty.

Jack:
Exactly. It's not a Kommune for the broken—it's a society for the *sovereign*.

Rhea:
But all of this... it's a legal grey area at best, Jack. You know that, right? If they're not paying tax, not registering anything, not following employment or safety laws... eventually the state *will* notice. And it won't like what it sees.

Jack:
The question isn't *if* these communities will face pressure. The question is whether they'll have built enough strength, enough reputation, *enough legitimacy* by then to stand their ground.

Rhea:
And if they don't?

Jack:
Then they'll fragment. Retreat. Rebuild elsewhere. That's the advantage of being *networked*. You don't need a capital. Just a protocol. And if the state goes too hard—overreaches—you'll lose not just the Kommunes, but your *best people*. The builders. The thinkers. The ones who already have one foot outside the system.

Adam:
But these communities—if they keep growing, they'll have to govern. You can't run a digital city-state without rules, without conflict resolution. What does governance *look* like in a place like that?

Jack:
That's the inevitable next stage. Right now, they're still small enough to run on trust, reputation, and custom. But as they grow... they'll need form. *Constitutional bones*. And I think they'll turn—naturally—to something very old. Something like Plato.

Felix:
Of course. Jack wants to bring back the *Republic*. What next, togas?

Jack:
No togas. But structure, yes. I can imagine a Kommune evolving into a three-tiered body. At the top: a *philosopher-king* or a small node of philosopher-governors—people chosen not by vote, but by *recognition*—selected for depth, judgement, clarity. Not charisma. Not popularity. Wisdom. Reputation trails make this more measurable than ever.

Rhea:
That already sounds dangerously undemocratic.

Jack:
So is a brain. And yet it runs the body just fine. Below the philosopher-tier would be an *aristocracy*—not of blood, but of merit. Long-term contributors, guardians of code, stewards of culture and law. Builders who've proven their worth over years. The *keepers*, if you like.

Adam:
And below them?

Jack:
The *commons*. Not lesser—just less initiated. Citizens, residents, apprentices, travellers. People who believe in the values but aren't yet ready—or willing—to carry responsibility. They still vote, debate, contribute. But within limits. The system guards against mob rule.

Felix:
So what—you're building a bicameral parliament out of code?

Jack:
More or less. Two chambers. One high, one broad. The *upper node*—the philosophical layer—deliberates, judges, sets vision. The *lower node*—the citizen assembly—proposes, tests, debates. Smart contracts run beneath it all as the legal substrate. No lobbyists. No bureaucracy. Just voice and consequence, layered in code and reputation.

Laura:
You'd need rituals, though. Initiation, tradition, aesthetics. Otherwise it becomes just another forum.

Jack:
Exactly. That's why it has to feel old. Sacred, even. Digital *yet ancient*. Governance as a kind of civilisational art.

Rhea:
And who enforces anything? What if someone breaks the rules?

Jack:
Exile. Access revocation. Frozen reputation. Not violence—*exclusion*. You don't send them to jail.

You cut them off from the network. And for people whose whole lives are built on their pseudonymous reputation, that's worse than prison.

Felix:
Alright, philosopher-king—say this thing grows. Say it *works*. What does the culture even *feel* like? What does it teach its kids? What does it believe in? Because you can't just run a nation on code and competence. Eventually, people want stories. Symbols. Soul.

Jack:
Exactly. Once governance is stable, once reputation and law are anchored, what comes next is *culture*. And it wouldn't just emerge—it would have to be *crafted*. Intentionally. Like a high-trust renaissance—but digital.

Laura:
Crafted by who?

Jack:
By the founders, the philosophers, the artists. The cultural aristocracy. Think of it as a digital Byzantium, where beauty and truth are cultivated as civic virtues. Education wouldn't be massified—it would be tailored. Apprenticeship-based. Children raised by the network, mentored directly by node-holders. A pedagogy of sovereign formation—discipline, taste, craft, honour.

Rhea:
You're describing a digital monastery.

Adam:
But what would they *believe*? A civilisation needs some idea of the transcendent. Even secular ones invent it eventually.

Jack:
They'd likely build a new form of spiritualism. Not dogmatic, but symbolic. Rooted in the principles of sovereignty, cryptographic truth, mutual respect, and voluntary exchange. A kind of spiritual materialism. Perhaps they'd elevate the ideals themselves—*privacy, truth, beauty, skill*—into quasi-sacred values.

Laura:
So Bitcoin as sacrament, zero-knowledge proofs as liturgy?

Jack:
Not far off. Ritual would matter. Perhaps monthly assemblies. Oath-taking on-chain. A mythology of the early internet, the fall of the fiat state, the rise of the encrypted world. They'll have saints: Satoshi, Web 3 pioneers, blockchain wars. And martyrs—those who were cancelled, silenced, hunted by the Leviathan for speaking truth or building outside its grasp.

Felix:
So their myth would be the *exit*—leaving the state, leaving the system?

Jack:
Yes. The myth of *departure*. Of stepping outside the cave—not to the light of God, but to the *light of code*. The only thing incorruptible. And with it, they'd build their own temples—digital and physical. Libraries. Citadels. Halls for speech and ritual. All minimalist, encrypted, and beautiful. High-trust spaces that feel like a mix of cathedral and server room.

Clive:
Well, I've heard of some of these groups too. A collector I know—only deals in NFT tapestries and modular synth relics—swears he traded with one of their internal art networks. Said it was like entering a cloister of high aestheticism. Operated entirely on-chain. Fully encrypted. The art was… *sacred*. But what got me wasn't the quality—it was the *precision* of taste. Razor-sharp microcultures. Totally self-curated.

Jack:
Exactly. That's how it'll all go—music, art, aesthetics. No more mass culture. No more billboard charts or gallery openings with bad prosecco. Culture will fragment, beautifully, into *micro-interests*. Little aesthetic enclaves. Each cyber-community becomes its own Renaissance.

Rhea:
That sounds exhausting. A thousand miniature worlds instead of one shared one?

Clive:
No—it's *refined*. The age of lowest-common-denominator culture is over. Netflix is dead. Pop charts are algorithmic corpses. Now? If you're into 18th-century Japanese woodblock, there's a whole encrypted node for that. If you want Christian vaporwave with Anglo-futurist heraldry, someone's minting 3D designs for that in South Africa and live-performing it in a cave in the Alps.

Laura:
You're making that up.

Clive:
Only slightly.

Jack:
It's about identity through *taste*. We're retribalising, but not by blood—by *vibe*. By symbolic fluency. In a world of automated everything, taste is one of the last human currencies.

Felix:
So music becomes a secret handshake?

Clive:
It already is. In the best scenes, you're *initiated* into sound. There are motifs, rhythms, aesthetics you learn over time. It's as sacred as liturgy. These cyberKommunes know that. Their internal DJs—some of them don't even publish sets publicly. You have to prove something to get the file.

Rhea:
So we're building civilisations on the backs of moody techno and niche meme aesthetics?

Jack:
No—on *symbolic coherence*. Taste is governance. Aesthetic alignment is trust. When the protocol is beauty, the culture doesn't rot.

Adam:
It's all very utopian—or maybe not utopian, just *intentional*. But say they keep growing, these digital Kommunes. Say they become real power centres. What happens then? Don't they eventually face the same governance problems as the states they've replaced?

Jack:
They will. That's inevitable. Power doesn't vanish—it refines, it mutates. These communities are experiments, not immune systems. And the more people they attract, the more *mass* they accumulate, the more friction they'll face. But here's the twist: the state won't collapse and leave a void. It'll collapse *upward*, into them.

Felix:
Collapse *upward*?

Jack:
Yes. The state as we know it is bloated, bureaucratic, coercive—it's not going to survive this mass automation, population divergence, and fiscal decay. But something still has to *govern*. What's happening is a flipping of the stack. Sovereign governance—*real governance*—is being rebuilt *from below*, through these tight, high-trust communities.

Laura:
So... governance returns, but only after decentralising completely?

Jack:
Exactly. The core unit of governance becomes the *cyberKommune*—networked, pseudonymous, meritocratic, cultural. And as these networks grow, their logic—their smart constitutions, their symbolic coherence, their ways of resolving conflict—*filters upward*. Traditional states will either *adopt* these methods or fade. People will start demanding governance that behaves more like a well-run protocol than a decaying parliament.

Clive:
So the future isn't no-government. It's better government. *Smaller*. More beautiful. And most importantly, chosen.

Rhea:
But isn't that... dangerous? What if one of these systems goes wrong? What if a charismatic founder turns tyrant? What's to stop it?

Jack:
Nothing. And everything. The same things that keep any system honest: *exit and voice*. If a network becomes corrupt, people *leave*. And they take their reputations with them. That's the difference. The state today traps you in geography. These networks don't. They're *voluntary*. Portable. Competing. So their only path to survival is to be *better*.

Adam:
So governance becomes like a product. You use the one that works.

Jack:
Exactly. Governance becomes a *market*. And like any real market, it rewards quality, transparency, and beauty. It's not democracy in the old sense. It's *competitive legitimacy*.

Rhea:
Alright, let's say you're right. The state collapses and governance reconfigures around these cyberKommunes. But what does that *look* like? Not in theory—in reality. How does a *nation-state collapse*?

Jack:
It won't be fireworks and revolutions. No barricades. It'll be... erosion. Like cliffs crumbling at the edge, silently, year by year. Institutions will hollow out. Bureaucracies will stop delivering. Trust will dry up. The NHS will become a zombie. The courts will take years to rule on anything. Schools will become holding pens. Welfare will inflate until it eats itself. The middle class will evaporate—taxed, demoralised, rootless. The poor will be sedated with screens and subsidies. And the wealthy—the competent—they'll already be *gone*.

Felix:
Gone where?

Jack:
To the *network*. Not physically, at first. But in spirit. In time. They'll stop voting. Stop trusting. Stop relying. And then they'll *stop paying*. The economy moves off-ledger. Talent goes dark. Value migrates to tokens, multisigs, pseudonyms. The brain drain becomes a *soul drain*.

Clive:
And all that's left is the carcass.

Jack:
The Leviathan, bloated and thrashing. Screaming about fairness while taxing its last loyal citizens. And when it finally collapses—when pensions default, councils fail, borders blur—it won't be chaos. It'll be... *quiet*. Just a shrug. The real world will still be running—just not under its name.

Laura:
And the cyberKommunes?

Jack:
They'll pick up the pieces—not by force, but by function. They'll offer arbitration when courts fail. Healthcare when GPs vanish. Education when schools crumble. Energy co-ops when the grid buckles. They'll build roads, manage data, mint stablecoins, settle disputes. They'll be the *new institutions*, because they'll already have the trust and the talent.

Adam:
Digital monasteries inheriting a dead empire.

Jack:
Exactly. Not through conquest. Through *relevance*. Remember the collapse of Rome: it didn't happen overnight, the seeds of feudalism were already there, people just shifted towards the lords, not the Empire. People will migrate—not across borders, but across *protocols*. The state will still exist, like a withered shell. But *legitimacy* will have moved.

Rhea:
And the old world will barely notice, until it's already gone.

Felix:
So these cyberKommunes… they won't just be little enclaves tucked into hills or basements in Berlin. You're saying they'll spread—*globally*?

Jack:
They already are. You've got nodes buying up farmland in Texas—off-grid, solar-powered, surveillance-free. Others are staking claims in the Australian outback, laying mesh networks and

launching educational pods. These aren't fringe hobbyists. They're serious builders. Some of the best minds—developers, artists, founders—are coordinating internationally without ever setting foot in the same room. They don't *ask* for political power. They *generate* it through function and reputation.

Laura:
But how does that not spark confrontation? The old state won't let go easily.

Jack:
There'll be friction, sure. But cyberKommunes don't need to fight for power. They just offer better options. And the talent flows to where it's respected. *Governments won't be overthrown. They'll be outcompeted.*

Rhea:
But what about identity? Citizenship? Belonging? It still matters to people.

Jack:
And that's exactly what's changing. Identity is being *privatised*. No more one-size-fits-all citizenship. You don't get labelled by accident of birth. You *choose* your affiliation. You *opt into* the culture, economy, governance that aligns with your values.

Clive:
So national identity becomes aesthetic, tribal, voluntary.

Jack:
Exactly. And as these cybercommunities scale, they won't just influence their own members—they'll start exerting *cultural and political gravity* across borders. A codebase written in Buenos Aires governs land use in Montana. A philosopher in Tokyo sets arbitration standards used in Nairobi. A token vote in Lisbon reallocates resources to a school node in Tasmania.

Adam:
So we're looking at the end of geography as political destiny.

Jack:
Yes. The map dies, and the *network* is born. You don't live in a country anymore—you live in a *culture stack*. In a protocol. On a layer that you *chose*—and that *chose you back*.

*(**Jack** leans back in his chair now, the light of the room catching the glass in his hand—a moment of stillness before he speaks, voice slow, deliberate, unfolding like a manifesto):*

You want to know what it *feels* like to live in a world without a traditional nation? At first, it's disorienting. You feel unmoored. The old anchors—flag, postcode, accent, Kings, BBC, the police—all start to fade. You're not a citizen of anywhere in particular anymore. You're not *British*, not *European*, not *Western*. Not in the way those words used to mean something. You're just… a sovereign individual. And that's lonely, at first. But then—*then*—you start building. Not with bricks. With keys, code, conversation. You choose your network. You shape your online identity not to impress, but to *signal*. Your skills, your philosophy, your aesthetic. And slowly, that network starts to feel like home. It gives you meaning, feedback, purpose, *intimacy*. And in time, it becomes *more real* than your government ever was. That's when you realise: you've crossed over. You've exited the nation—not physically, but spiritually. And there's no going back. And then—then comes the *aesthetic* shift. Once a people builds its own laws, its own money, its own rituals… it builds its own *spaces*. Architecture stops being symbolic of the state. It stops being brutalist and bureaucratic. The buildings of the sovereign future will be *personal*. Modular. Wild. You'll walk into a home and you'll know what protocol that person belongs to. You'll see wood from a Kommune in Wales, stone from an island off Iceland, solar nodes humming on rooftops, water tanks pumping with quiet dignity. No one will build for resale. They'll build for *belonging*. You'll see rooms for contemplation. Rooms for debate. Open kitchens for ritual meals. Libraries grown, not bought. Art won't hang as decoration—it will *live*. Embedded into walls, encoded into floors, draped across beds. Localised, handcrafted, high-trust. The kind of art that makes a space not just beautiful but *legitimate*. Cities will become *archipelagos*. Decentralised settlements that speak to one another through fibre and stars. You'll live in Lisbon for six months. Then the highlands. Then some sky-dome in New Zealand that runs on geothermal Bitcoin. But your network never breaks. Your identity never dissolves. Because it's not your land that defines you. It's your *code*. Your community. Your *aesthetic coherence*. It is your cyber citizenship.

That is the future:
Where borders don't define belonging—*taste does*.
Where architecture isn't top-down, but *symbolic*.
Where power isn't controlled, but *earned*.
Where your nation isn't what's written in your passport—it's what you show, in how you *live*.

Clive:
Laura, tell me this sovereign future includes dessert. I've been following Jack's gospel, but I need *something sweet* to meditate on.

Laura:
Oh God, I *completely* forgot. It was meant to be brownies and ice cream—proper cacao from a bio-vertical in Cornwall, too. Hold on—ten minutes and you'll be converted.

(She stands and moves to the kitchen, opening a drawer, flicking on an oven with a quiet hum. The smell of warm chocolate begins to drift into the room. A new kind of comfort: sleek, strange, rooted.)

Anglo-Futurist Brownies & Ice Cream: "Nebula Bites with Quantum Custard"
A deconstructed, hyper-textural riff on the classic duo, blending Victorian indulgence with sci-fi flair.
Serves 4

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1. Stellar Debris Brownie Clusters

Ingredients:

- 200g dark chocolate (70%), 150g salted butter, 3 eggs, 150g golden caster sugar

- 50g malted milk powder (nostalgic Anglo twist), 75g ground almonds, 1 tsp activated charcoal (for "cosmic" blackness)
- Crunch layer: 50g crushed malted barley (or Horlicks), 1 tbsp edible silver leaf flakes

Method:

1. Melt chocolate and butter. Whisk eggs and sugar until ribbon-like, fold in chocolate mix.
2. Add malted powder, almonds, and charcoal. Pour into a hexagonal silicone mold.
3. Bake at 160°C (140°C fan) for 18 mins—centers should stay fudgy. Cool, then sprinkle with malted barley and silver leaf.

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2. Custard Ice Cream

Ingredients:

- 400ml double cream, 200ml whole milk, 4 egg yolks, 100g honey
- 2 Earl Grey tea bags (steeped in cream), 1 tsp butterfly pea flower powder (for color-shifting drama)
- Texture hack: 1 tbsp vodka (prevents ice crystals)

Method:

1. Infuse cream with Earl Grey overnight. Strain.
2. Whisk yolks and honey. Heat cream/milk to 80°C, temper yolks. Add pea flower and vodka.
3. Churn in ice cream maker. Layer with "asteroid chunks" (below).

Asteroid Chunks:

- Freeze-dried raspberries coated in isomalt "glass" (melt 50g isomalt, dip berries, harden).

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3. Caramel Syphon

Ingredients:

- 100g dulce de leche, 1 tbsp black treacle, 1 tsp smoked sea salt
- 50ml nitro cold brew coffee (for bitter contrast)

Method:
Mix all ingredients. Load into a cream whipper with 1 N2O cartridge. Keep chilled.

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4. Edible Circuit Board Garnish

Ingredients:

- 50g tempered dark chocolate, printed with gold lustre dust "circuits" (use a stencil)
- Freeze-dried mandarin dust (for "oxidized" accents)

Assembly:

1. Plate: Smear a base of quantum custard ice cream onto a chilled obsidian slab (or black slate).
2. Cluster: Place brownie hexagons at chaotic angles.
3. Tech: Spray caramel foam in nebula-like swirls. Scatter asteroid chunks and chocolate circuits.
4. Finale: Dust with mandarin "rust" and serve with a pipette of espresso-chilli oil (optional, for neurostimulation).

Pairing Suggestion:

A glass of chilled mead spiked with CBD tincture (legal, calming) or a nitro-brewed matcha latte.

Chef’s Notes:

- No liquid nitrogen? Use store-bought vanilla ice cream blended with Earl Grey leaves (strained) and butterfly pea powder.

Jack:
See, even that moment—dessert after debate—is a microcosm of what we’re heading toward. It’s voluntary. Symbolic. Shared. Not *administered*. And that’s the point of *privatised sovereignty*.

Because once identity is *chosen*, not assigned… once your allegiance is earned, not inherited… you begin to realise something radical. The state—this old industrial-age machine—is not your father. It's not your protector. It's not your home. It's just one node in a dying network of force.

But once you opt out—once your reputation, your money, your contracts, your community, your art, your education are *all* outside the state—you're no longer governed. You're *emboldened*. The sovereign individual doesn't beg the state for freedom. He builds systems that make the state *irrelevant*.

It's the great *inversion*. From top-down to bottom-up. From decree to exchange. From politics to protocol. From obedience to *action*.

See, once politics is no longer the dominant game, **technology becomes destiny**. And not just any technology—not gadgets or gimmicks—but architecture. System-building. Protocols, tools, languages, infrastructure.

This is where it leads:The sovereign individual gives way to the **technological builder**. Not a citizen. Not a subject. Not even a mere entrepreneur. But a *shaper* of civilisation.

Because when coordination is no longer forced, it must be **earned**—through code, through trust, through design. This is why the future belongs not to rulers, but to technologists. To those who know how to *replace command with code*. To those who can build worlds faster than institutions can legislate against them. And here's the truth we're only beginning to realise: **Acceleration isn't chaos. It's coherence—when aligned with agency.** When identity is voluntary, money is sovereign, education is peer-driven, contracts are automated, and governance is modular—what emerges isn't instability. It's clarity. It's freedom with form.

The Stack becomes civilisation. Markets become morality. Builders become prophets. This is the new priesthood—not elected, but *earned*. The high priests of code, trust, architecture. Not idealists, but realists. Not utopians, but engineers of the possible. Because in a world unshackled from the state, the highest calling is no longer to critique the system. It's to *build a better one.*

This is what Mises foresaw. The *Misenean ideal*. Not libertarian retreat—but human *acceleration*. The free market—not just as economic system, but as *civilisational telos*. The final architecture of humanity. One where every form of power is subjected to choice, to price, to preference. Where political power is no longer the highest game—*entrepreneurial action is*.

Felix:
So not "power to the people"—but "power *priced* by the people"?

Jack:
Exactly. Power becomes like any good—measured by demand, delivered through competition, earned through competence. That's freedom. That's sovereignty. Not in theory, but in the *economy of everything*.

Laura:
Alright. Your *revolutionary sugar fix* has arrived. Brownies are hot. Ice cream is quantum-cooled. You're welcome.

Felix:
If this is the future, I submit myself willingly.

Laura:
A reminder: the cacao's from Cornwall—genetically optimised for mouthfeel and clarity. And the vanilla has a hint of smoke. Consider it the dessert equivalent of reading Cicero by firelight.

(The group laughs softly. Laura disappears again briefly, then returns with a sleek, matte-black vacuum carafe and a set of glass cups that look more like alchemical vessels than coffee mugs.)

Laura:
And for the real ones… Ethiopian roast, barrel-aged and microdosed with *psilocybin distillate*. Just enough to make the market feel divine.

Clive:
God, it tastes like someone put the Renaissance through a siphon. Smooth. Fractally bitter.

Rhea:
You know... this is *perfect*. Too perfect.

(She raises her cup slightly, more in gesture than cheers.)

Rhea:
But isn't this *exactly* the problem? The fact that we're even talking about taste and citizenship and sovereignty in terms of optimisation, delivery, exchange—doesn't it all feel... commodified? Where does the sacred go, Jack, if *everything* is priced?

Jack:
It's a fair challenge. But here's what I'd say: *everything is already priced*. Even in the state. Especially in the state. The only difference is that in state systems, the pricing is hidden. It's wrapped in bureaucracy, obscured in forms, inflated by inefficiency and force. In the free market, at least it's *honest*. Transparent. Voluntary. A £5 flat white is more morally sound than a state subsidy for failure. Because it tells the truth. It says: "This is what it costs. Do you want it?"

Laura:
And you're free to say no.

Jack:
Exactly. That's the difference. The free market isn't perfect—but it's better. Because it *asks*. The state *demands*.

Rhea:
So the market is the new church?

Jack:
No. The market is the new *forum*. A place where we can *choose* to build beautiful things together—or walk away. It's not sacred by default. But it *can* host the sacred. If we bring it with us.

Adam:
If the market becomes the new forum, like you say, Jack... then what happens to *ritual*? To the sacred? I mean, in the old world, that's what religion gave people—a rhythm to life. Birth, death, family, fasting, prayer. Even people who didn't believe still moved within that structure. If the state fades and the church's gone quiet, where does the *sacred* live?

Jack:
It comes back. But in a different form. The sacred doesn't vanish—it migrates. And in post-state

societies, it returns through *intentional design*. Through rites, symbols, experiences. Not imposed from above, but chosen—*curated* by sovereign individuals.

(He gestures around the table—wine, laughter, dessert, philosophy.)

Jack:
This *is* a ritual. The sharing of food, debate, aesthetics, affection. The very fact that we've created space to think and *taste*—that's sacred. Not because of a decree, but because we've *agreed* to treat it that way. That's the essence of ritual: agreement around meaning.

Rhea:
But does that work across identities? Across religion? Tribe? Race? If everyone's sovereign, doesn't it all fragment?

Jack:
That's the paradox. Sovereignty creates difference. But it also allows us to *recognise* each other's differences more honestly. In the old world, the state tried to flatten identity—to universalise it. To make it secular, civil, neutral. But that just suppressed the sacred in everyone.

Jack:
In this new world, you could have a Jewish mystic and a Bitcoin atheist share a digital Kommune—not because they *agree* on the transcendent, but because they agree on how to *live peacefully* together. Their identities are private, layered, portable. You can carry your rituals, your fasts, your prayers—your whole symbolic structure—with you, into shared space.

Clive:
So identity becomes like clothing. You wear it when you need it. Signal it when it's time. But it's yours. Not owned by the government. Not expected to match anyone else.

Jack:
Exactly. Identity becomes *modular*. Not reduced—but refined. Imagine a society where you know someone's belief system by the tone of their email, by the rhythm of their calendar. Not because it was *declared*, but because it was *embedded* in the form of their life.

Laura:
So the sacred survives, not by being imposed—but by being *shared* across sovereign minds.

Jack:
Yes. And each ritual becomes a flag, a flame. Not of war—but of *invitation*. An open signal. "This is who I am. Would you like to witness?" That's not fragmentation. That's *pluralism* at its highest resolution.

Clive:
You know... for a dinner party about digital sovereignty, we've just managed to perform a very ancient rite. Feels like we've eaten, drunk, debated, and shared silence—just like any temple or old house of wisdom would've asked of us.

Laura:
Maybe that's what the sovereign world needs—fewer constitutions, more *tables*.

Rhea:
We've gone from eugenics to God to Cornish chocolate. But it does feel like something's changed.

Like there's... *weight* to all this. More than theory. More than abstraction. Maybe sovereignty isn't about escaping the world—but returning to it, on your own terms.

Felix:
And maybe these cyberKommunes don't need to feel like a threat or a rebellion. Maybe they're just new monasteries. Quietly building what the old world forgot.

Adam:
Digital monks with psilocybin lattes.

Jack:
If the table is a temple... then let tonight be our rite. A reminder that power—real power—doesn't come from conquest, or votes, or taxes. It comes from *attention*. From shared truth. From rituals we choose *together*.

(He pauses, looking around the room—friends now, not just guests.)

Jack:
And from this night onward, we know what's possible. The state can't define us. The old world can't hold us. Because we've tasted something different now. And once you've tasted it… *you never go back.*

(Jack *his voice quiet now, mellowed by the warmth of the room and the depth of the night, as if addressing not just his guests, but something beyond the table itself):*

Before we clear the table, let me leave you with a parable—something that's been circling my mind while we spoke. A kind of dream, maybe. A myth. One we might tell our children in this new world we're building.

The Myth of the Mountain

There was once a great *mountain*, vast and ancient, at the centre of the world. It was known by many names: Empire, State, Nation, Crown. All roads once led to it, all laws flowed down from it. The mountain provided order, tradition, safety—but at a cost. Its weight pressed upon the land, and all beneath it had to bend.

In the early days, people revered it. They chiselled their names into its rock, believed its roots were divine. But over time, the mountain grew colder. Less nurturing. Its voice became bureaucratic. Its warmth, administrative. And then, far below, something curious happened.

One by one, individuals began to hear a *signal*—soft, clear, persistent. Not from the mountain, but *from each other*. A shimmer in the network. A quiet code passed in whispers and fragments. At first it was poetry. Then it became protocol.

These individuals—*signal-seekers*, they were called—began to leave the shadow of the mountain. Not in protest, but in search of something else. They did not build a new tower. They built *nodes*. Tiny enclaves, scattered like stars, linked not by land but by shared rhythm, reputation, taste.

Their rituals were different. They encoded values instead of enforcing rules. They minted tokens not to control, but to *remember*. They didn't burn the past—they simply left it unread.

Over generations, the mountain began to erode. Not through war or rage. Just... neglect. The roots dried. The voices quieted. The people had stopped listening. They had moved on—not upwards, but *outwards*.

And at the end of this myth, the mountain still stands—but it is empty. Tourists visit it. Children climb it. But no one waits for its word.

They have the signal now.
And in the signal, they have each other.
And in each other, they have the future.

(As Jack finishes, there is no applause. Just silence—the kind that follows something that feels... true.)

Laura:
You should write that down.

Jack:
Maybe I just did.

(A long, slow silence settles over the table—not awkward, not heavy. Just final. Coffee cooling in half-full cups, laughter lingering like incense in the air. The future, humming just below the surface.)

Book III

The group returns to the living room. The lights are lower now, bathing the Georgian plasterwork in warm hues of amber and blue. The gin has come out—served tall in glass tumblers with flicks of freeze-dried juniper, carbonated lemon-ferment, and a sprig of mint genetically tailored for citrus compatibility. It's called the "Sceptred Isle."

Laura:
Alright, my darlings—*Sceptred Isles* for everyone. Distilled in Shropshire, carbonated in Kent, and finished in a Glasgow crypto-botanical lab. You're about to taste the United Kingdom through gin.

Felix:
Bloody hell. It tastes like... marmalade and Parliament if Parliament were made of *hope*.

Clive:
If the future has flavours, I want you bottling them.

Jack:
Alright, we've mythologised the state, restructured its architecture, rebuilt ritual. But what about the next layer? The one we don't talk about much, but can't avoid. *Children*.

Adam:
Jack Stone's paternalist arc begins?

Jack:
Maybe. But it's serious. If the state withers, if schooling fails, if identity becomes opt-in... then raising children becomes the *core function* of civilisation again. You can't outsource it anymore. And that raises the question: *how do we inherit culture* in a world of sovereign individuals?

Rhea:
You mean... parenting without the state?

Jack:
Exactly. In cyberKommunes, children aren't raised to become obedient citizens—they're raised to become *sovereign actors*. And that changes everything. You're not training them for tests. You're initiating them into *culture*. Into a living, breathing protocol.

Felix:
What does that even look like? No Ofsted, no curriculum, no standardised citizenship lessons?

Jack:
No lessons. *Rituals*. You build an education stack around *initiation*. Real literacy: philosophy, coding, art, trade, history. Not to pass exams, but to *become someone*. And not just any someone—a *contributor to the network*. Children become apprentices. Students of sovereign mentors. And their identity isn't a surname—it's *their proof of work*.

Clive:
And culture isn't taught. It's *inherited* through immersion.

Jack:
Exactly. Language, taste, trust, honour codes—those become the curriculum. Every dinner, every project, every walk in the woods is pedagogy. You don't give them a national anthem. You give them a *mythos*. A narrative they *choose* to grow into.

Rhea:
But isn't that... dangerous? It sounds idealistic—but it also sounds exclusionary. What happens to kids who aren't born into these systems? Or who reject them?

Jack:
Then the network has to hold space for *entry*. You don't raise children into dogma—you raise them into *discernment*. The Kommune is a *path*, not a prison. The goal isn't obedience. It's *self-governance*. A 16-year-old who can build a contract, code a node, debate Plato, and cook for ten people is more *free* than a state-dependent 40-year-old with a passport and a mortgage.

Laura:
Freedom starts in the *home*. But the definition of home has to be reborn.

Jack:
Let's start at the beginning. A child, to put it plainly, is an animal. A soft, unshaped, high-bandwidth animal. Full of potential—but also chaos. And like any animal, the first task in shaping them is *training*. Not in the bureaucratic sense. Not worksheets and uniforms. But in the deep ethological sense. A child responds to **classical conditioning**—pleasure, pain, rhythm, consequence, repetition. They must be taught *attention*, *pattern*, *ritual*. Before language, before logic, there is environment. And in that environment, everything must point toward *becoming*. *Becoming what?* That's the question. And that's where polycentric society becomes both its greatest triumph and greatest risk.

Clive:
Because every household becomes a *world*, right? One kid raised in an art Kommune by surrealists and introduced to ketamine at 14. Another in an Anglo-Catholic house with Vespers and Marcus Aurelius. Another somewhere between Hellenic nudism and crypto libertarianism.

Jack:
Exactly. You end up with children speaking entirely different *languages of the soul*. Different conceptions of honour, shame, beauty, time, even truth. And when they meet—at sixteen, or twenty, or forty—the danger is *incomprehension*. No shared coordinates. No *frame*.

Adam:
So how do you give them that frame?

Jack:
Through *myth*. Through a shared symbolic structure that doesn't flatten diversity, but *holds it*. Like a stained-glass window: many colours, but one story. A child must be given *icons*. Archetypes. Stories that live in the *bones,* not the brain. Think of the Bible—not as theology, but as **narrative infrastructure**. Every child knows what it means to fall from grace, to betray a brother, to kill out of envy, to walk through fire. Those aren't "religious" stories. They're *civilisational firmware*. They let us *recognise each other*, no matter the upbringing. You see the same moral scaffolding in the Greeks. In Homer, you don't just get story—you get *shape*. You get what it means to be a man of honour. What it means to rage and to return. What it means to sacrifice, to endure, to suffer *with dignity*. Homer gives us not laws, but **examples**. *Odysseus isn't perfect—but he's remembered. Hector dies—but he dies well. That's the point.*

And then you get Pindar—who doesn't just describe virtue, he *exalts* it. His odes don't flatten the world into sameness—they **sing the heights** of human striving. A kind of moral elevation by language itself. He gives praise where it's due—not out of flattery, but to show that *excellence deserves memory.* And memory is what makes civilisation.

These poets—they weren't side projects to the polis. They *were* the polis. They were the **civic soul** expressed aloud. They gave people not just identity, but **orientation**. A sense of what's worthy. What's tragic. What's divine. And the beauty of it is—it didn't require a priesthood. It required *ears*. Memory. Recitation. Shared cadence. That's why poetry isn't soft—it's **civilisational steel** wrapped in rhythm.

So when we talk about binding people together without coercion, without law—This is the answer. Not just code, not just protocol, but **poetic form**. Something that lives in the breath and the bones. A shared symbolic grammar—not to control us, but to let us recognise each other. To say: *You, too, have walked the long road home.*

Rhea:
But isn't that just another universalising project? One myth to rule them all?

Jack:
Not *one*, but a **canon**. A living mythos—not imposed, but *opted into*. A myth library. Imagine each cyberKommune contributing its myths, its stories, its symbolic truths to a growing open-source mythology—a digital Iliad for the sovereign age. And when children are trained—classically, yes, but also spiritually—they're not just being taught "don't touch the fire." They're being *initiated*. They're entering a symbolic world where they'll meet other children from other realms—and still know how to speak.

Laura:
So it's not about agreement. It's about *orientation*.

Jack:
Yes. The compass of the soul. That's what we give them. Not uniformity—but shared *coordinates* in the dark. If we're serious about this—about polycentric education, about raising sovereign children in a fractured world—then we need to be honest: *location still matters*. No matter the house, the protocol, the aesthetic… every child raised in *Britain* walks these same fields, breathes this damp air, sees the same grey sky and golden stone. So yes—each Kommune will have its own rituals, its own gods, its own code. But all children raised here should be raised within a common *British mythos*. Not nationalism. Not bureaucracy. *Myth.* Something older, deeper, more dangerous.

Rhea:
Because no one does anymore. That's the thing—we've lost the moment. There's no clear line between being a child and being an adult. It's just… bills. Anxiety. A Spotify subscription and slowly decaying optimism.

Adam:
There's no *threshold*. You just wake up one day with no council tax to pay and no sense of who gave you the crown.

Jack:
And that's the great failing of the modern world—especially the state. It delayed adulthood into your thirties, while infantilising people into their fifties. In sovereign culture, *that doesn't work*. Sovereign individuals *must* know when they come of age. They need *rites of passage*. Something ancient, something earned.

Laura:
What would that even look like, though? In a society like ours? It's not like we can all run off into the woods with a wolf and a riddle.

Jack:
No—but the spirit is the same. A rite of passage doesn't have to be violent or tribal. It has to be *symbolic*. Marked. Intentional. It has to feel like the world changed because *you changed*.

(He leans forward slightly, more animated now.)

Jack:
Imagine a sovereign child growing in a cyberKommune. At fourteen, they're sent on a digital pilgrimage—complete a trade, create a piece of enduring value, debate in public, submit a poem or a protocol. At sixteen, they take on their first *contract*—a mentor, a project, a public vow. At eighteen, they go through *naming*: not just a username, but choose a sovereign identity. That's their *entry*. Not into adulthood by age—but by *action*.

Rhea:
So adulthood isn't a number. It's a *commitment*.

Felix:
And more than that—a *witnessed commitment*. Something others see, remember, *respect*. You don't just grow up. You're *acknowledged*.

Clive:
It's elegant. The sovereign world doesn't need state certificates. It needs *ceremony*.

Jack:
Exactly. Because without ritual, you don't get meaning. And without meaning, freedom becomes chaos. A sovereign society isn't just free—it's *framed*. Rites give the soul its architecture. And if rites of passage are how the *individual* becomes sovereign… then *cyberKommunes* are how sovereigns become *civilised*. Because once the state fades, once the cathedral crumbles, all that's left are the *guilds*. Not in the medieval sense. In the *living* sense.

Clive:
Guilds... as in—fellowships of practice? Of aesthetic? Of myth?

Jack:
Exactly. The world that's coming won't be ruled by flags or borders—it'll be stitched together by *attraction*. You'll join not because of birth, but because you *belong*. Each cyberKommune will centre around a magnetic principle: a craft, a faith, a vision, a story. Art, code, culinary experimentation, long-form debate, deep ritual, risk.

Laura:
So people won't ask, "Where are you from?"—they'll ask, "*What are you part of?*"

Jack:
Yes! Exactly. You'll have those who dwell in the Technopolis nodes—architects of decentralised systems, always experimenting, refining, automating. And others in mytho-poetic Kommunes—groups where every object is sacred, where language is more ritual than instruction. You'll have stoic orders. Hellenic polycules. Artisan communities that blend cooking and sculpture and trance.

Adam:
It sounds like a world run by... high-trust cults.

Jack:
You say that like it's a bad thing. But here's the beauty of it: *you're not stuck*. In the sovereign future, **citizenship is fluid**. You can hold it, trade it, leave it, earn it back. Just like stock. You're not born into it. You *opt in*, and sometimes you opt out. With reputation, currency, access rights. And each cyberKommune has its own **rites of passage**. To join, you don't fill out a form. You *prove yourself*. You show taste. Mastery. Devotion. Maybe you apprentice, fast, duel, debate. Maybe you just keep showing up. Maybe you disappear into the mountains and return with something worth hearing.

Rhea:
That sounds... beautifully chaotic. But also—how do people *connect* across such variety? Don't we still need some shared foundation?

Jack:
We do. And that's why mythology matters more than ever. The point isn't to all believe the same thing. The point is to *orient around the same questions*. To speak in *archetypes*—the exile, the builder, the trickster, the sage. It's not about conformity. It's about *translation*.

Felix:
So in the future, your story *is* your passport.

Jack:
Let me offer a frame—perhaps an image for this. One you all know, even if you've forgotten what it means. In the beginning, there was one language. One people. One purpose. They built a tower to reach the heavens. And for a time, they rose. Bricks upon bricks. Order. Power. *Unity*. But they rose too far. They built not to honour the divine, but to *replace* it. To become gods themselves. And so, in response, God scattered their tongues. Fragmented them. Broke the unity. Sent them spiralling across the earth, speaking in riddles to one another ever since.

Now fast-forward to our time. To *now*. The story has repeated. History has ended—or so they said. There is only one language left again: **liberal democracy**. The Enlightenment's child. Bureaucratised, globalised, automated, universalised. One value: safety. One telos: comfort. One method: administration. One god: the *State*. We replaced our sacred cows—gods, rituals, mythologies—with *mechanisms*. And then we forgot they were mechanisms. We gave them names like justice, equality, welfare, policy. But they were all just masks worn by the same thing: *power*.

And we built again—this time not a tower, but a system. A totalising regime of governance, data, and money. And like Babel, we flew too close. **Nietzsche** warned us: *God is dead*. But we misunderstood him. He wasn't celebrating. He was *mourning*. Because with God dead, we made the state divine. We turned parliaments into churches and turned voters into believers.

But power, once centralised, once *concentrated to that extent*, draws its own ruin. So now we live at the next scattering. God, or fate, or nature—*whatever you want to call the force that corrects pride*—has struck again. And this time, He didn't divide our tongues. He divided our **sovereignty**.

He scattered it. Not across cities or nations—but across *individuals*. Sovereignty no longer resides in the heavens, or in Westminster, or in the White House. It lives in *wallets*. In *nodes*. In *thoughts*. The curse becomes a blessing. The fragmentation becomes liberation. Every person now is a *proto-god*, tasked not with climbing to heaven, but with *building it into the earth*.

So now, the tower is gone. In its place: a thousand *cyberKommunes*. A million little *temples*. A vast, glittering web of people who speak in many tongues but act in one spirit: the sovereign will to create.

Laura:
And we build not upward, but *outward*.

Jack:
Exactly. We don't climb anymore. We *seed*. We *link*. The age of Babel is over. Welcome to the age of the **Network**.

Jack:
Alright. Let's bring the metaphor down to ground level—*the temples in the network*.vIf sovereignty has been scattered like sparks across the earth, then the new social fabric is being rewoven by **cyberKommunes**—shared identity clusters, protocols of purpose. They exist in every city. Some are global. Others, entirely local. But all of them replace the state with *voluntary meaning*. Let's walk through a few:

1. The Æthervauld

A global, elite art Kommune that exists simultaneously in London, Tokyo, São Paulo, and the Metaverse. Entry requires the submission of an original work—a painting, algorithm, scent, or musical piece—that is voted on by the current members in a ritual called *the Eclipse*.

Governance: Decentralised curation council, elected annually. All members have veto power over aesthetic direction.
Economy: Patron-backed, crypto-funded via a rotating sovereign fund.
Rites: Initiation by offering, annual Reclamation of Form ceremony where members destroy or remake a past creation.
Philosophy: *Beauty is currency. Decay is worship. We preserve culture by transcending it.*

2. The Guild of Phronesis

Exists in every major city but functions like a philosophical fraternity. Members live scattered but share digital salons, publish white papers, and mentor one another.

Governance: Triadic council based on skill, reputation, and contribution. Disputes settled via public Socratic debates.
Economy: Funded by education services and peer-reviewed consulting.
Rites: Coming-of-age is “The Questioning”—a three-day dialogue with three elder members.
Philosophy: *Wisdom is the highest trade. Philosophy is practical. Truth is earned.*

3. The Black Ledger

A shadowy, hacker-coder-engineer syndicate. Based in off-grid spaces—caves, bunkers, co-working clubs with EMP shielding. Cross-border, hyper-competent.

Governance: Meritocratic cryptographic voting. Every act encoded on-chain. No hierarchy, only velocity.
Economy: Self-sustaining through digital security contracts, blockchain forensics, and occasional grey-market ventures.
Rites: You only enter by completing a task given by an anonymous agent. Failure means exile.
Philosophy: *Sovereignty is security. Silence is strength. We write the laws in code.*

4. The Hearthstead

Local, family-focused Kommunes in post-industrial towns. Anglo-futurist in flavour. Polyvalent homes with gardens, workshops, and schools. Emphasis on crafts, culture, raising the next generation.

Governance: Elected elders and “household chairs.” Mixed council with rotating representation.
Economy: Agricultural, artisan, and education-based. Heavy use of local tokens.
Rites: Solstice ceremonies, apprenticeship recognitions, birth declarations.
Philosophy: *Rootedness is resistance. Culture is soil. The home is the true parliament.*

5. The Network of Ember

A wandering, semi-nomadic global guild of technoshamans, biophilosophers, and ritualists. Kommunes exist as “fire nodes” that spark up around events, then vanish.

Governance: None fixed. Temporary stewards are chosen by consensus and ritual.
Economy: Gift-based, reputation-indexed, occasional revenue from high-end psychedelic retreats.
Rites: Vision quests, fasting, communal dreaming.
Philosophy: *To be sovereign is to be sacred. Burn, wander, awaken.*

Jack:
Each one with its own identity, laws, myths, and currencies. Some barely exist in the physical world—just scattered minds and shared language. Others are building villages in the Peak District or buying land in Patagonia.

But all of them ask the same thing:
“*Do you choose to belong?*”
And if you do, you *enter the temple*.
Not as a citizen.
As a *sovereign soul*.

Rhea:
It’s compelling, Jack. Seriously. But doesn’t it *worry* you? I mean, all of it. These cyberKommunes,

these fluid allegiances, this idea that you can trade citizenship like it's a gym membership… doesn't it all just risk **total fragmentation**?

Adam:
Yeah. I love the aesthetics, the mythology, the freedom. But what happens when *no one* shares any common ground? When everything becomes so niche, so modular, that we stop having *any shared sense of humanity*?

Felix:
You'll have one Kommune obsessed with high Anglican architecture and Nietzsche, and another whose founding document is a meme thread. How do they *speak* to each other?

Clive:
And who mediates when they don't? I get the decentralisation stuff, but historically, when systems fragment like this, something fills the vacuum. Warlords. Technocrats. Religion. Are you sure these Kommunes won't just evolve into little empires?

Jack:
You're right to worry. I worry too. But there is private arbitration for example. If there's money to be made, lawyers will be there. This isn't a utopia. It's a **threshold**. A passage from one world into another. And thresholds are dangerous. But they're also where transformation happens. Yes—fragmentation is real. These Kommunes will disagree, collide, split, maybe even go to war. But that's not new. That's *older* than empire. It's how culture actually functions. Through *plurality*, through *tension*, through the friction of contact. And as for a shared humanity? I don't think you need **uniformity** to have **solidarity**. We don't all have to believe the same things to *recognise* each other. We just need **symbols** we can translate, **rituals** we can witness, **languages** we can enter. This world doesn't abandon humanism. It **replaces it with responsibility**. When there's no state to catch you, you start caring more—about who you are, and what you give. And when you live by choice, not by force, you tend to honour your commitments more deeply.

Laura:
And isn't that what we've all been looking for anyway? Not a place that *holds* us… but a place we're *proud* to hold?

Rhea:
Alright, Jack. You've walked us through sovereign identities, cyberKommunes, mythic rites of passage. But what about *love*?

(The word lands in the room like a pebble dropped in still water. It's late. The energy has changed—softer, slower, closer.)

Rhea:
Is love just another opt-in protocol in this world of yours? Or does it still mean something… more? Something sacred?

Felix:
Or maybe even dangerous?

Jack:
Love is the hardest thing to make sovereign. Because it asks for *voluntary dependency*. A merging. A risk. It's the one force that *breaks* the sovereign individual—splits them open, binds them to

another, dissolves the neat lines of self-rule. And yet, without it, all the rest—Bitcoin, rites, guilds, art—means nothing. Love is the *final rebellion* against nihilism.

Laura:
And yet half of these Kommunes you described sound like polyamorous operas waiting to collapse into chaos.

Jack:
Exactly. Which is why love—*true love*, not transaction—requires **even stronger ritual** in sovereign society. Because it's no longer protected by religion, or law, or shame. It's *naked*. Which means we have to wrap it again—*but this time, with meaning we choose*.

Adam:
So what does that mean practically? Marriage contracts on-chain? Love tokens you burn when you break up?

Jack:
Maybe. Or maybe it's slower. Maybe we reintroduce *courtship*, *ceremony*, *sacred vows*—not imposed, but *crafted*. Like guild memberships, but for the soul. In some Kommunes, love becomes a rite of elevation. Two people who commit become part of a higher symbolic order. They host feasts. They share income. They raise children in shared narrative. It's not legalistic—it's *mythic*.

Clive:
So love becomes a micro-state. A sovereign bond, not enforced by courts, but by honour?

Jack:
Yes. And even in Kommunes where intimacy is more fluid, the idea is still sacred. You don't throw people away. You acknowledge *what was real*. Even endings can be *ritualised*. Think of it like *sacred hospitality*—but for the heart.

Rhea:
But what about jealousy? Heartbreak? Abuse? Can those really be navigated without law?

Jack:
Not without *culture*. Law only ever patched over the failures of culture. In the sovereign world, *you don't outsource morality*. You build it in, person by person. Kommune by Kommune. Which means yes—love will break people. But it will also *remake* them. In fire. In form.

Laura*:*
Alright, philosopher king—let's say we've accepted love as sacred. How do you teach someone to love? Especially in a world where nothing is enforced. No state, no church, no family pressure. Just... open water. What does romantic education even look like?

Jack:
That might be the most important question of all. Because if love is going to survive freedom—real, radical freedom—it has to be *cultivated*. Not assumed. Not romanticised. Taught. Slowly. And with great care. Romantic education starts with one premise: **Love is natural**.

Adam:
So what, we run kids through love academies?

Jack:
Maybe we should. But more seriously—think of it as *initiation into intimacy*. In sovereign Kommunes, romantic education might look like apprenticeships in emotional honesty. Dialogues about desire, attachment, grief. Classes not on *sex*, but on *yearning*. On how to suffer well in love. On how to forgive. On how to stay. Or leave—*cleanly*.

Clive:
You're describing the return of chivalry.

Jack:
Yes, but this time it's genderless. Classless. Decentralised. Chivalry not as etiquette—but as *honour code*. You train young people not just in consent, but in *presence*. Not just in sex, but in *story*. What kind of story are you writing with this person? Is it tragic? Comic? Sacred? Shared?

Rhea:
So romantic education wouldn't be some government brochure about contraception. It'd be… mythic?

Jack:
Exactly. Imagine learning about *courtship* from reading tragic love letters. Imagine debating Ovid, Euripides, or Sappho—not in a dead language class, but as *training for the heart*. Imagine rituals—formal or improvised—where two people announce their *intention*, and others witness it, not to control it, but to *bless it*. You teach people to love by giving them **symbols**, **aesthetic scaffolding**, and a place to *fail safely*. You let them break their hearts, not with shame, but with dignity.

Laura:
And maybe you teach them not just to fall in love… but to *stand in it*.

Felix:
Alright Jack, here's the obvious question: if love is sacred and sovereign... does that mean monogamy? Or are we headed for a thousand polycules under God, each with a shared Google Calendar?

Laura:
It's not a joke, though. If love is chosen, not enforced—then what does *living together* look like in a sovereign world? Cohabitation, marriage, raising kids? No registry office. No tax breaks. No state sanction. So... what *holds it*?

Jack:
In the sovereign world, there's no *default* structure. There's no blueprint you're forced into by tax codes or traditions you never chose. That means love becomes *contractual*—but in the deepest sense. Not cynical, not transactional. *Relational contracts.* Some people will still choose monogamy. That's a fine form. It's ancient, resilient, elegant. But others will choose polycules—networks of affection, shared housing, collaborative parenting models. And what will hold them isn't the state—it's **reputation**, **ritual**, and **law by consent**. You could call it a Dominium. Not a tree — trees grow down. This grows sideways. A living web. Co-parents, bond-siblings, companion-mothers, shared guardians, uncles who teach mechanics and disappear for a decade, then come back to tell stories and pass down tools. You might share genetics, or nothing at all. Doesn't matter. What binds us isn't DNA — it's obligation.

Rhea:
So it's… polyamory?

Jack:
Not how you mean it. It's not about who sleeps where. It's about who builds with who. Who raises with who. Who keeps vigil, and who remembers the names of the dead. We don't fall in love here — we fall into structure. Affection grows from the inside. First you commit, then you care. Not the other way around.

Clive:
And what holds it together? There must be conflict, drifting, misalignment.

Jack:
Of course. That's why each Dominium writes its own charter. Education protocols. Inheritance paths. Internal arbitration — usually a circle of elders. If things escalate, we go to Synod: a priest, a civic elder, a philosopher.

Clive:
But what gives it identity? Isn't it just another kind of Kommune?

Jack:
No — it's more narrative than that. Every lattice has a name, a crest, a founding myth. A set of Vows of Mutuality — rewritten every few generations. Some keep scrolls. Ours keeps a digital mosaic — thousands of tiles, each one a story or a name. Joining isn't sentimental. It's solemn. You can be born in, or vouched in, or serve your way in. You don't get "loved." You get relied on. Big difference.

Jack:
The Dominium isn't just a household—it's a fellowship of care. It's how we name a family in the sovereign era. Not by blood alone, but by oath, by contribution. You can have a Dominium spread across four counties and three Kommunes. One branch might be on the Cornish coast building a solar-ceramic dome. Another might be embedded in Manchester's tech circuit, co-parenting and sharing food systems. Others live Kommune-style—forty people, one courtyard, one ledger.

What makes it a Dominium is coherence. Shared ethics. A common charter. We know who we are. We've got an internal court for resolving disputes. We educate our young by passing them between skill-holders. And every adult has signed the Fellowship Rule—a set of vows we review every season.

Clive:
But doesn't that get messy? When you've got kids being raised in five homes and parents with overlapping loyalties?

Jack:
Messy's just another word for alive. The key is transparency. Every node logs its commitments to the central ledger. If there's a conflict, it goes to the Circle. That's our internal council—elders, educators, craft-leads. It's not hierarchy. It's reputation-weighted deliberation.

Rhea:
And do people ever leave? Break off?

Jack:
Of course. But not lightly. Departing a Dominium is like leaving a monastic order. You undergo a Rite of Separation. Your name is delinked from the web. The children are consulted. Custody's reworked. Assets are unwound. And your reasons are spoken aloud in assembly. It's not punishment—it's presence. People don't ghost each other here. They're witnessed.

Clive:
So how do these contracts work? Is there some kind of prenup? A break clause?

Jack:
Absolutely. Every unit—whether a pair, a triad, a full household—writes its own **living contract**. Think of it like a smart social covenant. You declare your commitments, your exit conditions, your values. It might be formal, written, signed by witnesses. It might be poetic. But it's *real*. It's not imposed—it's *chosen*. And for those raising children—co-parenting, polyfidelitous units, etc.—the contract expands. Now it includes *custody*, *education*, *legacy*. You might have ten adults across three nodes contributing to one child's future. And the legal structure? It's enforced through **community arbitration**, not the state.

Rhea:
But surely that opens the door to all sorts of instability? People just walking away, redefining love every few months?

Jack:
It *might*. Freedom always invites chaos. But chaos invites **ethics**. When you don't have the state doing your moral heavy-lifting, you have to build *real culture* around love. You have to develop *honour economies*. You have to learn to keep your word. Or lose your place.

Adam:
So relationships become *reputation structures*.

Jack:
Exactly. And here's the key: if your co-parenting unit or Dominium is respected—*if it works*—you'll gain access to more support, better networks, higher-trust nodes. If you burn people, break contracts, cause pain without accountability? You'll be gently *exiled*. Or at least pushed to lower-trust circles.

Laura:
So love becomes scalable. But *earned*.

Jack:
And when you realise that? You start taking it more seriously. Because there's no safety net except *culture*. And maybe that's where love belongs—in the hands of *people*, not paperwork.

Clive*:*
Alright. Let's say two—or five—people fall in love, draft their beautiful sovereignty contract, and choose to raise a child. No government, no school board, no NHS health visitor knocking on the door. What does *child-rearing* look like in the world you're building?

Jack:
It looks like *radical responsibility*. Because once you remove the state, *you become the state*.

And when you're raising a child, you're not producing a subject. You're *initiating a citizen*. A future philosopher, builder, artist, trader, warrior—whatever their vector of excellence may be.

Laura:
So you don't just *raise* the child. You *form* them.

Jack:
Exactly. And in this world—polycentric, decentralised, de-institutionalised—child-rearing becomes the most **sacred act** of all. Because the child doesn't inherit just DNA. They inherit **culture**. They inherit **taste**, **mythology**, **memory**, **tools**. The family—whatever shape it takes—is the *sovereign forge*.

Adam:
But is that just the parents? Or does the whole Kommune raise the child?

Jack:
Both. *You raise the child, and the child raises the network.* In most sovereign Kommunes, parenting is **distributed throughout the Kommune or Dominium**. There are primary caregivers, yes—but also educators, mentors, craftmasters, philosophers. Some children live across multiple nodes—between households, or even Dominiums. But their life isn't fragmented. It's *narrated*. There's an *arc*. Each place they go has a purpose.

Rhea:
And what about boundaries? Protection? Some Kommunes might have completely different ideas about what's acceptable for children.

Jack:
Absolutely. Which is why *reputation governance* is critical. Every Kommune has a **child protocol**—a set of sacred standards, formed by their parents. Abuse, neglect, exploitation? Those Kommunes collapse. They're exiled from the network. There's no impunity—because there's *no distance*. Reputation travels *instantly*. And without a state to hide behind, the **community becomes the law**.

Clive:
So, in a way, it's more intimate. More *real*. There's no bureaucracy between you and your responsibility.

Jack:
Exactly. And education? It begins at birth. Children are raised to be *builders of the world they live in*. They learn to code and cook. To tell stories. To care for the sick. To read myth and write contracts. They don't just sit in rows. They *apprentice*. They *initiate*. They *build with their hands and speak with their spirit*.

Laura:
Raising sovereign children isn't just about freedom. It's about *remembrance*. You're teaching them to *remember how to live*.

Felix*:*
Okay—so far, Jack, you've described a world where love is sacred, parenting is radical, and children are sovereign philosophers in training. But what about school? What does a Tuesday

morning look like for a ten-year-old in a Kommune? Are we talking about chalkboards and timetables—or something more... esoteric?

Jack:
Education in sovereign society isn't just school. It's *initiation*. And the point of initiation isn't memorisation—it's *transformation*. There are no national curriculums. No Key Stage tests. No coercive conformity. But there is still structure. Sovereign children aren't raised in chaos. They're raised in **purpose-built learning ecologies**. Let me break it down.

1. The Core Curriculum: The Fourfold Foundation

Most sovereign Kommunes agree on a *symbolic core*—a base from which a child can grow *in any direction*. It's often called the **Fourfold Foundation**:

1. **Logos –** Literacy, logic, rhetoric, philosophy. The child learns to think, read, speak, and argue.
2. **Techné –** Craft, coding, mathematics, practical tool use. They build, break, fix.
3. **Mythos** – Story, ritual, art, music. They are initiated into symbols, archetypes, cultural memory.
4. **Thymos –** Discipline, honour, courage. They train the body, explore responsibility, learn to govern the self.

By twelve, a child has usually completed at least a *first initiation* in all four.

2. The House of Masters

After twelve, a child begins to *apprentice*. Sovereign society rejects "age-based schooling" in favour of **meritocratic mentorship**. You want to study painting? You find a master. Philosophy? You join a guild. Programming? You join a node. Children *choose their path*—and can choose more than one. Some follow one master for years. Others move between disciplines, becoming generalists. There are no grades. Only *reputation*. Only *proof of work*.

3. The Great Dialogues

Sometime around 14–16, a child enters the **Great Dialogues**. This is a rite of public learning. They must engage in a structured conversation—recorded, witnessed—on a topic of real significance. It might be about love, war, economics, mythology, architecture.

They are expected to *defend an idea*, to *listen*, to *speak well*. It marks the beginning of adult life.

Laura:
So the debate is sacred. Not just performative, but *initiatory*.

Jack:
Exactly. It's the return of the **dialectic as education**. Not as a class. As a *ceremony of becoming*.

4. The Path of Excellence

After the Great Dialogues, the child—now a young adult—chooses a *Path*. Not for life, but for focus. Art. Engineering. Farming. Law. Medicine. Music. Leadership. They are not forced. But they are *invited*.

This is where they may choose to join a **guild** or **cyberKommune** as a junior sovereign. They take on *projects*. Launch ventures. Learn real trade. They travel. They build. They fail.

And throughout it all—they continue to *debate, train, and build myth*.

Clive:
So school is abolished... but education becomes *sacred again*.

Jack:
Yes. Education stops being mass production and becomes *personal alchemy*. The child is not treated as a vessel. The child is treated as a *flame*.

Rhea:
Alright, I'm sold on sovereign childhood. But what about later? What happens when those kids grow up and want more than a guild, more than apprenticeship? Is there still a place for something like… *university*?

Jack:
There is. But the university of the sovereign age is not a place where knowledge is warehoused and rationed like state cheese. It's a place where *excellence converges*. Where the most promising minds go not to *study*, but to *build civilisation*. Let me describe it.

I. The Sovereign University

There is no single sovereign university. There are **dozens**. Each a node in a global network of excellence. They may have physical locations—beautiful cloisters in the Peak District, floating pavilions in Polynesia, cryptographically protected compounds in the Alps—but they're primarily united by **intellectual purpose**, not postcode.

Admission is *earned*, not bought. You don't apply. You're *invited*. Often following success in guilds, apprenticeships, public debates, artistic commissions, or scientific proofs. These are not places for the mildly curious. They are temples for the *truly promising*.

II. Curriculum:

Every Sovereign University begins with a revival of the **Trivium**:

- **Grammar** – deep language. Not just syntax, but etymology, poetry, persuasion.
- **Logic** – not just syllogisms, but game theory, formal logic, Gödel, quantum reasoning.
- **Rhetoric** – how to win hearts, not just arguments. Writing, oration, performance.

After the Trivium, students split into Houses or Faculties, depending on their calling. These might be:

- The **House of the Sublime** – for artists, architects, musicians, creators of form.
- The **House of Steel** – for engineers, tacticians, weapon-makers, defence theorists.
- The **House of Mind** – for philosophers, mystics, cognitive researchers.
- The **House of Coin** – for economists, coders, traders, entrepreneurs.
- The **House of Flame** – for leaders, orators, myth-makers, and future philosopher-kings.

III. Governance and Culture

Each university is *self-governing*. Students vote. Professors duel. Debates settle disputes. Currency is issued internally. Some run as anarcho-monarchies with rotating philosopher-leaders. Others use blockchain-staked reputational governance.

Professors are not *career academics*. They are *elders*. Masters. Builders of note. Entry is by invitation, and tenure is earned by public defence—one must *defend their ideas in open disputation*.

Students live communally. They take part in seasonal festivals, fasts, rituals, and massive public *dialogues*. There is no “graduation.” There is only *initiation*.

IV. Output and Legacy

The goal of a Sovereign University is not credentials. It is **civilizational output**.

- The design of a new contract protocol.
- The construction of a temple.
- A twenty-year economic theory for post-fiat societies.
- A new educational rite for children of the network.
- A symphony that opens a new aesthetic era.

Each student is expected to leave with a **contribution to the species**.

Adam:
So basically, it’s Oxford if Oxford had balls and blockchain.

Clive:
And if you had to fight to stay in the library.

Jack:
Exactly. It’s not a finishing school. It’s a forge. It’s where sovereign individuals go to *become irreplaceable to civilisation.*

Laura:
Alright, sovereign universities, mythic houses of mind and flame—I'm with you. But how do they *know* what they know? In a world without peer review panels, without centralised publishing authorities, without academia-as-institution—how do we build *epistemology*? What counts as *truth*?

Jack:
That’s the heart of it. Because when the state falls away, the university as a credential mill collapses too—and with it, the *monopoly on truth*. But that doesn’t mean we lose epistemology. It means we must make it *sovereign*. Let me lay out the new pillars.

I. Proof of Work Epistemology

In the sovereign age, **knowledge is judged by consequence**.
You don’t prove your truth with citations from dead bureaucrats. You prove it by *building something that works*.

- You say your theory of energy is better? Build the battery.
- You say your educational model works? Show the students.

- You claim moral clarity? Watch how people live after following your advice.

This is **Proof of Work Epistemology**. It replaces credentialism with *consequence*. Not “who said it,” but “*what does it do?*”

II. Publishing in the Age of Sovereignty

There are no academic journals anymore. At least not in the traditional sense. Instead, **publishing becomes performance**.

- Some publish *essays-as-rituals*, delivered live, debated in salons, minted as NFTs.
- Others write *smart books*, self-updating documents hosted on-chain, tied to their author's identity and reputation.
- Some publish *via code*, embedding their ideas in open-source protocols.

The point is: publishing is no longer gatekept. It’s reputational. And **reputation itself is open-source**—a ledger of *who you’ve debated, what you’ve built, what ideas you’ve defended under fire*.

III. Judgment: Dialogue Over Dogma

Truth is no longer decided by consensus or bureaucratic panels. It is *tested in the fire of dialogue*. Every sovereign university hosts **open disputation rituals**. You write something? You *defend* it. Publicly. Ritualistically. Not to be attacked—but to be *challenged, clarified*, and *refined*. And the judge? Not a dean. The judge is *the community itself*. Those who are invested, who understand the field, who have *skin in the game*. It’s truth *not by authority*, but by *earned consensus*.

IV. Epistemic Castes (Informal)

Over time, sovereign society develops something akin to *epistemic castes*.
Not formal. Not hierarchical. But cultural.

1. **Makers –** Engineers, coders, artisans. Their truth is functionality.
2. **Mystics –** Poets, philosophers, ritualists. Their truth is coherence and beauty.
3. **Analysts –** Economists, theorists, modellers. Their truth is prediction and precision.
4. **Judges –** Elders, polymaths, hosts of disputation. Their truth is synthesis and memory.

Each community, each university, blends these differently—but the core principle remains:
Truth is not dictated. It is *demonstrated*.

Felix:
But isn’t there a risk that we lose *objective truth*? That everything becomes personal myth and vibes?

Jack:
No more than we already have. The sovereign age isn’t post-truth. It’s **post-authority**. Truth is no longer *granted* from on high. It’s *earned* through clarity, construction, and courage. You don’t *inherit* truth. You *forge* it. In front of others. With your name on the line.

Clive:
Jack, I admire the vision. It’s noble, maybe even *necessary*. But I have to say—it all sounds dangerously... *romantic*. You talk about “truth through consequence,” about poetic publishing and

public disputation—but where’s the rigour? The reproducibility? The controlled experiments? I mean, don’t forget—the **positivist movement** existed for a reason. To separate *what is* from *what feels*. To prevent science from becoming mysticism, from collapsing into bias, narrative, or... *charm*. And here you are building temples out of charm.

Jack:
Clive, I don’t reject positivism. I just... *relocate* it. Positivism was a powerful tool. It *disentangled phenomena* from superstition. It gave us the microscope, the algorithm, the rocket. But the problem isn’t in its method—it’s in its **monopoly**. It acted like it was the only way of knowing. The one true lens. In sovereign society, we don’t throw away empiricism. We *elevate* it—by placing it alongside *other valid epistemologies*.

Clive:
Like what? Dreams and incense?

Jack:
Sometimes, yes. But more often:

- Phenomenology.
- Mythologic reasoning.
- Systems aesthetics.
- Game-theoretic modelling.
- High-trust intuition.
- Deep pattern recognition that can’t be reduced to controlled variables.

The positivist method *remains*, but it's nested within a larger **epistemic ecology**. Think of it like a *courtroom*. Positivism plays the role of the forensic scientist. But you still need the judge, the jury, the witnesses, the story. Without them, the data means nothing.

Rhea:
So it’s not that you reject objective truth. You just believe it’s *incomplete* without... narrative context?

Jack:
Exactly. Positivism finds facts. But meaning? That comes from *myth, memory, and metaphor*. Truth in the sovereign university isn’t *deconstructed*. It’s *layered*. There’s a place for the lab and the lyre. For the algorithm and the altar.

Clive:
But what ensures this doesn’t devolve into epistemic anarchy? One Kommune says two plus two is four, another says it’s sacred, another says it’s colonial. How do you *stabilise* truth in a fragmented system?

Jack:
That’s the job of **reputation systems**. Truth becomes *anti-fragile* by being constantly tested in *intercommunal dialogue*. The best ideas *circulate, compete, evolve*. The rest wither—without the need for censorship or fiat enforcement. You could say:

- Positivism is the **root**.

- Myth is the **flower**.
- Dialogue is the **sunlight**.
- And consequence is the **soil**.

Let's move beyond the lab, then. If we're going to talk about epistemology in a sovereign age, we can't ignore **art**—and especially **architecture**. Because there's one more way of knowing, older than positivism, deeper than logic. It's called **beauty**.

Laura:
Here we go...

Jack:
No, but really—beauty is a form of **truth**. It's pre-verbal, pre-political. You know it *when you see it*. It arrests the body, silences the ego, evokes something you didn't know you believed. When you see a building that lifts the eye and stills the breath… When you hear a melody that collapses time… When you taste something so precise it becomes sacred… That's *truth*. Embodied. Incarnate.

Clive:
But isn't that just... aesthetic response? Cultural conditioning? I mean, brutalism still has defenders.

Jack:
Sure. But not many. Let's be honest—*most people hate it*. And that's not random. That's a signal. In a perfect society, **taste** isn't dismissed as elitism. It's *refined* as epistemology. You can't fake good form. You can't bureaucratise elegance. And when something is *beautiful*, it *functions better*. It's used longer. Loved harder. Protected. Inherited. **Architecture**, especially, becomes the *bones of truth*. When we look at great buildings—temples, theatres, libraries—we don't just see stone. We see the **order** a society believed in. The **ratio** of human to divine. The **values** encoded in shape, light, proportion. In sovereign communities, architecture returns to this sacred function. No more boxes of despair. No more "efficient" grey rectangles. No more cost-cutting concrete. Instead: temples to ideas. Guildhalls with ratios drawn from nature. Homes that don't just shelter—but *teach*. And art—real art—isn't commentary. It's *revelation*. It transmits the inner logic of the culture. It holds memory when the text has vanished. It *proves* the spirit of a people, even centuries later. That's why sovereign Kommunes commission not state murals, but *works of invocation*. Every myth is retold in new form—painting, theatre, digital ritual. Not just for pleasure, but for *binding*. For *meaning*.

Rhea:
But beauty can be dangerous, too. Can't it? Can lead to seduction, manipulation... fascism even?

Jack:
Absolutely. But so can logic. So can data. Truth is *always* dangerous. That's why it must be *earned*, not mass-produced. Beauty—when tethered to truth—is the *highest form of persuasion*. It doesn't coerce. It *invites*. And that's why it belongs at the centre of a sovereign society. Let's take it even further. If beauty is one kind of truth—*felt*, *seen*, *embodied*—then there's another kind that holds a society together when all else fails. That truth is **myth**.

Clive:
You're not going to claim that myths are *true*, are you? I mean—they're stories. Fables. They're useful, sure, but not exactly... epistemology.

Jack:
But Clive—*what is truth*? If a story shapes how people live, how they marry, what they honour, what they die for—how is that not *true* in the deepest sense? Not true like a lab result, but true like *gravity*. Not true like a calculation, but true like a **compass**. Myths are not *lies*. They are **hyperobjects**—stories that compress complexity into memorable, symbolic forms. They help us **navigate reality**. Prometheus isn't about fire. It's about *techne*, the gift of tools and the price of hubris. Icarus isn't about the sun. It's about *ambition*, *boundaries*, and *fall*. Christ's crucifixion isn't about wood and nails—it's the *template of sacrificial love*. Every society that's survived longer than a generation has a myth at its core. It doesn't matter if it's "literally" true. It matters that it's *existentially* true.

Laura:
And when the myths go, the society forgets itself.

Jack:
Exactly. In a world of sovereign individuals, we don't share rulers. We don't share taxes.
But we *must* share **stories**. That's how culture persists. That's how you raise children without indoctrination. That's how you **anchor ethics without legislation**. In sovereign society, myths don't die in dusty libraries. They're *performed*. *Rewritten*. *Enacted*. Each Kommune may have its own canon—its local saints, founding legends, seasonal tales. But there's always *overlap*. Shared archetypes. Shared rituals. The *weaving* of meaning between places. Some might revive old myths: Arthur, the Iliad, the Tower of Babel. Others will forge new ones: the *Ring of Privacy*, the *Sovereign Fire*, the *Exodus from the Leviathan*.

Rhea:
So myths become what laws used to be—*anchors for behaviour*.

Jack:
Not laws. *Legends*. And the sovereign citizen doesn't obey them out of fear. They follow them out of *devotion*.

Jack:
When governments fracture—when the state becomes a memory or a shadow—*something else must bind us*. And that something is not bureaucracy, or surveillance, or paper law. It's **ritual**, **law by covenant**, and **sacred space**. These are the threads that *weave society back together* from the ground up. Ritual is not performance. It's not nostalgia. Ritual is a **technology of meaning**. In sovereign society, where force is minimal and the state has retreated into its proper, limited domain, **ritual becomes the glue**. It replaces compulsion with participation. It binds without chains. You don't *register* a marriage—you *witness* it in ritual. You don't get a tax break for raising a child—you're *honoured publicly*, perhaps with a feast or a rite of naming. You don't "graduate"—you pass a *trial*, a debate, a pilgrimage, a reckoning. **Ritual gives gravity to freedom**. It sacralises choice. It wraps liberty in memory. Law, too, transforms. It becomes **contractual, reputational, and mythic**. In sovereign Kommunes, law is not "handed down." It is *crafted* and *ratified* by *those who live it*. Disputes are handled through **councils of trust**, **juried rituals**, or **reputation staking**. Contracts are public, on-chain, and aesthetic—some even incorporate *poetry*, *glyphs*, or *vows*. Law becomes not a cage—but a covenant. Not a threat—but a promise. And *enforcement*? It's cultural. It's reputational. It's *ritualised exile*, not prison. Every sovereign society needs **sacred space**—places *outside time*, set apart from noise, commerce, and data. Not for religion necessarily. But for

meaning. For *remembrance*. For *binding*. In the age of fractured governance, **the temple returns.** A university may have a central cloister where each debate opens with silence. A Kommune might build a **mythos-hall** where seasonal rites are held—planting, mourning, birthing, bonding. An architect might create a **non-denominational chapel of sovereign spirit**, carved with the names of founders, elders, ancestors. It's a signal. A commitment. A *centre of gravity*. And every functioning sovereign society will have at least one. Sometimes built in marble. Sometimes in code.

Rhea:
So when the state fails… we don't go to chaos. We return to *ceremony*.

Jack:
Yes. To covenant over compulsion. To *symbols over systems*. To the understanding that we are not just free individuals—but *remembering beings*. We belong to what we bind. And we are only individuals when we choose what we honour. Let's bring it home. Because if myth binds society… And if ritual gives shape to freedom… Then **economics**—true economics, rooted in human action—is the **liturgical rhythm** of the sovereign world. Not cold. Not mechanical. **Mythic.** In sovereign society, the **free market** is not a soulless algorithm. It is **the agora**—the great open space where *truth meets desire*. Every trade, every offer, every negotiation—it's not just an exchange of goods. It's an *offering*. A gesture of trust. A little ritual of recognition: *"You have something I value. I have something I value. Let's align."* That moment of alignment—of voluntary exchange—is **civilisational**. It's older than laws. Older than kings. It *is* the original covenant.

Clive:
So you're saying the market itself becomes… sacred?

Jack:
In a way, yes. Not in the religious sense. But in the *existential* one. Because what is trade, if not the formalisation of *mutual respect*? And when it's done freely, with transparency, with skin in the game. It becomes a **ritual of sovereignty**. An enactment of *value*. Even in classical civilisation, the **merchant** was a liminal figure—part explorer, part philosopher, part diplomat. In the sovereign age, commerce returns to that form. Traders become **myth-makers**—their reputations carry the weight of legends. Successful marketplaces are remembered in **song, code, and sculpture**. A breakthrough product, or invention, or business is remembered *not just for its utility*, but for its **symbolic resonance**. Think: The miner who found the lost block. The chef who remixed Anglo cuisine with Japanese whiskey. The woman who built her first market node entirely on mutual credit and sacred geometry. Their **names enter story**. Their **deals become myth**. *Their work becomes worship.* And here's the final piece: In sovereign society, **wealth is not sin**. It is *signal*. It says: "I created something real. I solved something painful. I served others *well*." Wealth does not grant power—but it grants *honour*. It shows that you navigated the agora *ethically*. And when shared—when invested in art, education, patronage—it becomes **offering**. A return of excess to the sacred commons.

Laura:
So commerce, rightly done, becomes...A moral act.

Jack:
The **most moral**. Because it requires *no priest, no soldier, no permission*. Only the will to build, to serve, and to honour.

Jack:
Let me offer a little story. They say that once, in a forgotten corner of the world, there was a great

open plain, and on it, **no kings ruled**. No thrones. No temples. Just a long, low canopy made of silk and wood, flapping gently in the breeze. This was the **Hall of Exchange**. It had no doors, no walls—only a fire in the centre, and rugs worn smooth from centuries of feet. Under this canopy came *everyone*. Farmers. Poets. Engineers. Warriors. Lovers. Orphans. The rich and the ragged. They came not to worship, but to *trade*. Not to kneel, but to *deal*. And yet, it was sacred. Because no force held them there. Only the law of the fire: **give honestly, or be gone**. In that Hall, there was a saying:

> *"The gods do not need temples—only fair scales and open palms."*

And every time someone traded well—gave a thing of value and received one in return—the flames grew higher. The Hall glowed a little more. They said it was the gods themselves watching, nodding, *keeping the ledgers of trust*. One day, a child came to the Hall with nothing. Not a coin. Not a loaf. Not a skill. But she asked to learn. And so the Hall did what it always did—it gave *freely*, from abundance. A teacher took her in. A baker taught her to knead. A storykeeper taught her to remember. And in time, she returned not with coin—but with a story so beautiful, the whole Hall fell silent. The child grew into a woman. The woman grew into a builder. And the builder made the next canopy. That canopy still stands, somewhere in the sovereign wilds. You won't find it on a map. But if you trade well, honour your word, teach the child and tell the story— you may find yourself beneath it. The free market is not a machine. It's a **mythic plain**. And every good trade is an *offering* that keeps the fire alive.

Laura:
This is all... beautiful. Really. But bloody hell—*it's heavy*. We started with wine and taste and now we're trading in eternal myths and sovereign marketplaces. I need a *reset*.

Clive:
Agreed. Someone pour more gin or roll a cigarette. Or both.

Felix:
Or maybe we need a temple of rest. The Great House of Chill.

Rhea:
Sovereign Spa Network.

Adam:
With a communal ritual of hot stones and head massages.

Laura:
No more talk. We're going upstairs. There's prosecco. There's the roof. There's a **hot tub**.

Book IV

(The group now sits half-submerged in a steaming rooftop hot tub, sandwiches eaten hastily. The London skyline stretches softly before them, its towers glowing like distant altars. The air is cool, the prosecco crisp, and the stars pulse above like myths waiting to be born.)

Anglo-Futurist BLT: "Crispstack"
A deconstructed, hyper-textural homage to the classic BLT, blending Victorian pantry staples with 21st-century flair.
Serves 2

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1. Bacon: Smoked Tea Lacquer & Crisp

Ingredients

- 6 rashers dry-cured streaky bacon
- Glaze: 2 tbsp lapsang souchong tea syrup (simmer 1 tbsp tea leaves + 50g sugar in 100ml water, strain)
- 1 tsp edible gold dust (optional)

Method

1. Slow-crisp: Bake bacon on a rack at 150°C (300°F) for 25 mins. Brush with tea syrup, blast with a blowtorch for glass-like shards.

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2. Bread: Charcoal Sourdough Discs

Ingredients

- 4 slices sourdough, cut into hexagons with a cookie cutter
- 1 tsp activated charcoal powder, 2 tbsp bone marrow butter (or cultured butter)

Method

1. Mix charcoal into softened butter. Spread on bread.
2. Griddle until geometric grill marks form.

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3. Tomato: Heirloom Gel & Caviar

Ingredients

- 1 large heirloom tomato (sliced)
- Tomato gel: 100ml clarified tomato juice + 1g agar-agar (set, then blitz into gel)
- "Caviar": Tomato water spherified in calcium lactate bath (or use store-bought balsamic pearls)

Method

1. Layer fresh tomato slices with gel smears. Scatter caviar on top.

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4. Lettuce: Seaweed Crisp & Fermented Foam

Ingredients

- 1 sheet nori, cut into lace-like patterns
- Foam: 50g crème fraîche + 1 tsp matcha + 1/4 tsp xanthan gum (whipped)
- Micro shiso or radish sprouts

Method

1. Flash-fry nori in hot oil for 10 seconds. Drain.
2. Pipe matcha foam onto plates.

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5. Mayo: Smoked Paprika Aether

Ingredients

- 3 tbsp Kewpie mayo, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1/2 tsp spirulina (for nebula-green hue)

Method
Whisk all ingredients. Load into a pipette for plating.

Assembly

1. Base: Place charcoal sourdough disc on slate.
2. Layers: Stack tomato gel, bacon shards, nori lace, and tomato caviar.
3. Finale: Dot with paprika aether, crown with matcha foam, and garnish with microgreens.
4. Side: Serve with a shot of chilled mushroom dashi (umami "time-travel broth").

Pairing

A nitro-infused Earl Grey kombucha or a sparkling sake spritzer with yuzu zest.

Jack:
You know…We've made the future sound like a monastery with server racks. All theory and tension. But really—*it's about this*. Pleasure. Ease. Being able to breathe. *Building a world where freedom feels like a warm night and a drink with people you trust.*

Felix:
So let's stop building cathedrals for five minutes and talk about what actually makes life good. What are the *small things*—the pleasures?

Laura:
Hot water. Cold bubbles. And people clever enough to talk about Nietzsche without turning into incels.

Clive:
Amen.

Jack:
The great secret no one tells you is that once the weight of bureaucracy lifts—once there's no tax

form, no form-filling, no petty authority to obey—*life gets lighter*. You get to rediscover **leisure**. And not just as absence-of-work—but as *a cultivated mode of being*.

Rhea:
You mean like... *slow living*?

Jack:
Exactly. But not just slow for the sake of it.
Leisure in the age of philosophy is *deliberate*, *refined*, *joyful*.
It's the ethics **of the good hour**. The pursuit of small, *perfect* pleasures.

Like:

- The morning ritual of grinding your own coffee with spice and sugar.
- A hand-written letter from someone a continent away.
- Reading Marcus Aurelius by candlelight.
- Fresh linen and classical music after a cold plunge.
- Cooking for someone who listens.
- A single glass of rare wine while the world turns outside.

It's not consumption. It's **connoisseurship**.

Clive:
So we replace consumerism with curation?

Jack:
More than that. With *artistry*. Life becomes something you *compose*. Like a song. Like a room. Like a garden.

Adam :
But how do you protect that? I mean, isn't the risk of freedom that everyone just goes mad with dopamine? We all get liberty—and end up as overstimulated sludge?

Jack:
That's where *taste* matters. And where **leisure** is different from decadence. Because individuals aren't trying to escape reality. They're trying to *elevate it*. Pleasure, when done well, *grounds you in being*. The perfect glass, the perfect book, the perfect kiss… Each is a proof that life can be *good*, not just bearable. And that is the foundation of *all culture*.

Laura:
Okay. Let's stay here a while. We've built myths, cities, children, gods… Let's talk about *hammams*. About heat and wood and silence. About saunas and saltwater and slow time.

Clive:
Now *this* is a political programme I can campaign on.

Jack:
There's something sacred about **deliberate relaxation**. A sauna isn't just leisure—it's *ritualised pleasure*. A controlled descent into softness. You enter hot, bare, silent—and the mind follows the body into stillness. You *sweat the state out*.

Adam:
It's like the opposite of algorithmic time. There's no click. No update. Just... heat. Breath. You.

Jack:
Exactly. In the present, these *simple sensory temples*—saunas, cold plunges, hammams, mineral baths, hot tubs—become the **sacred infrastructure of pleasure**. Not productivity hacks. Not wellness industry nonsense. Just places where people can **be**—entirely, without surveillance, obligation, or distraction.

Rhea:
So even rest becomes designed. Not rushed or hidden, but central.

Jack:
Yes. *Architected ease*. Like Anglo-Futurist bathhouses. Cedar panelled rooms overlooking wild moorland. Digital detox lodges with only books, berries, salt, and steam. Every Kommune should have at least one. A place where you can do nothing—and it counts. These places aren't escapes. They're **recalibrators**. You go in confused, tired, unmoored— You come out with a spine.

Clive:
And it doesn't take much, does it? A quiet room. Good wood. Some warmth. A plunge. It's like all the stress just... lifts.

Jack:
Because stillness is the **counterpoint of sovereignty**. You can't act well unless you know how to stop well. Leisure is the soil in which *clarity grows*. And the small pleasures—

- A perfect glass of cold water after the sauna.
- The shock of a cold lake on the skin.
- The smell of pine, smoke, and old cedar.
  These are **ways of remembering** what it means to be *human*—not just a node in a system.

Laura:
Honestly, this future of yours sounds like a spa weekend that accidentally reinvented the polis.

Jack:
Alright then—let's go deeper. Let's talk about **pleasure as philosophy**. We've built so much tonight—governance, markets, myth—but what's it all *for*? Why strive for sovereignty at all, if not to *feel good about being alive*? Let's start with the **Epicureans**. Epicurus wasn't some sybaritic party boy. He didn't believe in endless indulgence. He believed in the **refinement of pleasure**—in *learning what actually satisfies you*, and letting go of the rest. Three things, he said, are necessary for the good life:

1. **Friendship**
2. **Freedom**
3. **Philosophy**

That's it. A close group. A free domain. A thoughtful way of seeing the world. Everything else—gold, noise, power—was distraction. And in that vision, we find a perfect mirror of the **sovereign future**.

Felix:
So you're saying Epicureanism is like... the soft interior of sovereignty?

Jack:
Exactly. It's not *less* than the struggle. It's the **reward** for winning it. And not just hedonism as in excess—but **measured, meaningful, exquisite pleasure**.

Rhea:
But most people think of hedonism as... I don't know. Excess. Degeneration. What's the line between sovereign pleasure and, well, collapse?

Jack:
That's the key distinction. There are *two kinds* of hedonism:

- **Base hedonism** is about stimulation: more, faster, louder. It's chemical. Frictionless.
- **Refined hedonism**—or what I'd call *sovereign pleasure*—is about *alignment*.
  It's a harmony between desire and nature. Between action and spirit.

A good meal after a day of earned exertion. A bath at the right hour, with the right silence. A conversation that makes time vanish. These are *curated pleasures*. *Chosen pleasures*. And the more you cultivate taste, sovereignty, and attention—the better they become.

Clive:
So in this view, pleasure isn't immoral. It's not indulgent. It's... *instructive*?

Jack:
Exactly. Pleasure teaches you who you are, where you belong, *what resonates*. It tells you what to preserve. What to build. What to share. A society that ignores pleasure becomes a machine. A society that worships shallow pleasure becomes a swamp. But a society that **cultivates deep pleasure**? That's a **civilisation**.

Laura:
So that's the future. Not just wallets and courts. But *joy*.

Jack:
Pleasure is the liturgy of the free. To feel fully, and choose wisely, is the highest *alignment with nature*. And nature is the ultimate truth.

Clive:
So what makes it moral? I've seen enough soft-furnished penthouses and £10,000 handbags to be suspicious of the word.

Jack:
Fair. But that's not luxury. That's *branding*. *Extraction*. *Status theatre*. True luxury is not price. It is **intention**. It is made with *care*, designed with *honour*, and experienced with *gratitude*.

Luxury is:

- A handmade leather chair passed down through four generations.
- A pen that writes with such perfection it makes you want to write better thoughts.
- A meal where *every bite* slows time.

- A garment stitched so precisely, you wear it like an *idea*.

Luxury is not about display. It is about *depth*.

Rhea:
So indulging in something deeply beautiful isn't selfish?

Jack:
Not when it's earned. Not when it *lasts*. Not when it connects you with the real. There's nothing immoral about a perfect silk robe, or a carved ash bathtub, or a bottle of wild-ferment wine. What's immoral is *frivolity without reverence*. What's immoral is *mass consumption of soulless things*.

Indulgence becomes **moral** when it leads to:

- Appreciation.
- Gratitude.
- Elevation of taste.
- Investment in artisanship.
- And the **desire to preserve beauty**.

Adam:
So beauty isn't a luxury. It's a *virtue*.

Jack:
Yes. Beauty *teaches*. It sharpens attention. It connects form to feeling. And it reminds us that life is *worth taking seriously*. And when we surround ourselves with the beautiful—when we *choose* the beautiful—we make it *harder* for ugliness to rule. Ugliness *can't coerce you* when you've tasted something *better*. Let me bring it back to Plato. To the **Forms**. Because when we talk about beauty, about taste, about teaching people to see what is better—we're talking about *ontological truths*. We're talking about the **immaterial structure of reality**. For Plato, the Forms were *perfect, eternal ideals*. The Form of the Circle. The Form of Justice. The Form of Beauty. They existed beyond space and time. And our world—this world—is just a **flickering shadow** of them. But here's the thing. We live in a world where **hypermodernism**—the acceleration, the fragmentation, the endless surfaces—has made it almost *impossible* to believe in anything fixed, eternal, or perfect. And yet, we still long for it. We still look for *Form*. We still feel, deep down, that there is such a thing as:

- True love.
- True honour.
- True beauty.
- True leisure.
- True sovereignty.

Even in this world of simulation, gamified selfhood, ephemeral identities—we *crave Form*.
We *hunger* for it like air.

Adam:
But what are these *new* Forms? If Plato gave us the ideal chair or the ideal triangle... what does the 21st century give us?

Jack:
We're starting to name them, I think. Tentatively. But I think we can invent some new ones now.

- **The Form of the Signal** — clarity amid information chaos.
- **The Form of the Pseudonym** — honour without identity, reputation without coercion.
- **The Form of the Flow** — when body, mind, and action merge.
- **The Form of the Posture** — how one carries themselves in sovereignty and silence.
- **The Form of the Stack** — layers of technology aligned into something elegant and useful.
- **The Form of the Offer** — a moment of pure voluntary exchange, untainted by force.

These are **hypermodern Forms**. Born in the interface between man and machine. They aren't eternal in the Platonic sense—but they're *archetypal* in how we live now.

Rhea:
So we don't just need meaning. We need... *shapes of meaning*.

Jack:
Exactly. The Forms orient us. They tell us where *up* is. Even if we never reach them, we align our lives *toward* them. That's what gives experience its weight, its rhythm, its grace. Without Forms, we're just improvising in the dark. With them—even faintly glimpsed—we begin to **compose**. There is still one experience—perhaps the rarest of all—that brings us closest to the **Forms** in this hypermodern world. It's not logic. Not discipline. Not even moral virtue. It's the **sublime**. The **sublime** isn't just beauty. It's not merely elegance or taste. It's that rare and trembling moment when something becomes *so vast, so perfect, so real*—that it breaks your frame. It shatters your categories. It silences the ego. It's *formlessness crashing into form*. And in this hypermodern era—fragmented, accelerated, distracted—the sublime is harder to find… But when you *do*—it's more powerful than ever.

Clive:
So where does it live now? If the old cathedrals are dead and everything's memes and noise?

Jack:
The sublime lives in *unexpected places*. But it still lives.

- In the drop of a perfect ambient track at the right BPM after five minutes of silence.
- In watching a DAO of strangers collectively build a cathedral out of code.
- In a perfectly designed interface that flows like calligraphy.
- In a moment of unspeakable tenderness—unrehearsed, unrepeatable.
- In AI-generated art that doesn't just imitate, but *awakens*.
- In a private moment of surrender, when something finally *clicks* and you feel yourself changed forever.

These are **portals**. They don't last long. But they open to something **beyond time**.

Rhea:
And what do they teach?

Jack:
That there is something *beyond utility*. That life isn't just production and process. That at the heart of everything—beneath markets, behind governance, past sovereignty—is a pulse. A rhythm. A shining, wordless *rightness*. The sublime is the **proof that truth exists**. It's a reminder that we are not just biological machines with dopamine slots. We are *beings with longing*. And the sublime satisfies longing not by giving us everything— But by making us *fall silent in front of something better*.

Laura:
So we don't chase the sublime. We *create the conditions* for it to arrive.

Jack:
Exactly. We build architecture that breathes. We compose rituals with care. We raise children with silence and song. We earn the right *to be struck dumb*. And in those moments—when we feel that tingling hush—we know: the Forms are still there. Just for a breath. And that's enough. Now if we're going to talk about life, we have to talk about **sovereign**. And what's quietly rising, especially in this *rewilded Britain*, is something I find deeply beautiful. A new tradition. A new *sacredness.* More and more sovereign Kommunes—especially those up north, near the Pennines and Peak—have begun practising **forest burial**. No tombstones. No embalming. Just a simple shroud, a biodegradable casket— And a **tree** planted above the body. Not a graveyard. A **grove**. A rewilded Britain where the dead become forest. Where families return each year to sit beneath the ash, or oak, or elder that grew from their grandmother's ribs.

Rhea:
It's like... a cathedral of the dead. But green.

Jack:
Exactly. And in a time when digital identity persists long after death, there's something profound about *choosing to become soil*. About *letting go* of memory-as-data and embracing memory-as-**place**. A **mythic geography**. Each tree becomes a marker—not just of loss, but of **life that continued**. You don't visit a tomb. You walk a path. You find the tree. And you remember in **shade and silence**.

Clive:
And how do people mourn? There's no vicar. No state. No ritual manual.

Jack:
They do it **themselves**. Or better—*together*.

Each grove has its own **mourning rites**.

- Some sing in polyphony as the body's laid down.
- Some read poems, names, records of virtue.
- Some simply gather in silence, wearing colours the person loved.
- Some carve a phrase on a slate stone and leave it hidden, wedged into a root.

There's no performance. No bureaucracy. Just **presence**. Just the dead, the trees, and the living who continue.

Adam:
So even in death, the world creates continuity. Not through policy. Through *place*.

Jack:
Yes. It's not just a way of dying. It's a way of **belonging**. These forests become more than woodlands. They become **mythic maps**. Children grow up knowing their line is beneath that birch, that chestnut. Lovers walk together knowing where they will one day *rest—beside, not above*. And when it's your time, there's no fear of being *forgotten*. Because you'll feed something that lives. You'll be *felt*, not *preserved*.

Laura:
That's the most peaceful vision of death I've ever heard.

Jack:
It's not about escaping death. It's about *reweaving it* into the rhythm of nature. And that, I think, is one of the clearest signs of a sovereign civilisation. It *doesn't outsource death*. It *dignifies it*.

Laura *(leaning back against the tub's tiled edge, grinning as she produces a little silver case from the waterproof satchel by the towels)*:
Alright, gentlemen—and gentlewomen of the court. We've done our rites, we've mourned the gods, we've sipped the sacred bubbles. Time for something a little... anti-structural.

(She opens it with a click. Nestled inside: a mirror, a rolled-up £20 note with Friedrich Hayek embossed on it, and a dusting of fine white Ketamine inside. She gives the mirror a tap-tap, a wink, and snorts the ketamine. The note passes like a chalice.)

Clive:
Well, if Hayek was right, this is just a spontaneous order of altered perception.

Adam:
The market regulates... bliss.

Jack:
Mmmm. You know… There's something profoundly *economic* about this. The allocation of attention. The distortion of time. The revaluation of memory. When you let go of ego—even for a minute—you start to see how much of modern life is spent *resisting gravity*. Clutching at timelines. Status. Ownership. But here— All of that just... melts.

Laura:
And what if *that's* the true pleasure of sovereignty? Not control... but **weightlessness**. Freedom not as power—but as *lightness*. The moment when *nothing* presses on you anymore. When the body is water and the mind is *open sky*.

Felix:
So maybe… This is the *final pleasure*. To let go of the narrative entirely. To stop explaining ourselves.

Rhea:
To float without justification. No hierarchy. No identity. Just... resonance.

Jack:
And if the world is burning—if the state collapses, if the myths fracture, if the markets evolve into

forms we don't yet understand— maybe the true sovereign act is to become *light*. To become *liquid*. To become *pattern*. Not bound by weight, but by **meaning**. The tub fades to quiet again. Above them: stars. Below them: the depths of the city. Within them: a strange peace. No longer building civilisation—just *being* it. Fully. Softly. Silently.

(The silence deepens. The stars above pulse like watchful ancestors. The London skyline softens into abstraction. The steam becomes fog, the prosecco forgotten. The ketamine, now coursing gently through their systems, takes hold—not like a wave, but like the folding of a map.)

Jack:
I can't feel my hands. But I *know* where they are. It's like the soul has slipped one centimetre to the left.

Laura:
That's not disassociation. That's *precision*. Your body's still here. But your awareness has... *stepped back*. Like watching yourself on a stage you forgot you built.

Clive:
I feel like a diagram of myself. A series of circles labelled:
"Fear,"
"Desire,"
"Memory,"
"Debt."
And I can just *float* between them. No judgement. Just observation.

Felix:
This is what therapy wishes it was.

Rhea:
You know… This would've been criminal twenty years ago. Just us. Friends. Talking about death and myth and philosophy—*on drugs*. We'd be branded degenerates. But now… This is a **sacrament**.

Jack:
Because in a world where sovereignty is sacred, **altered consciousness** is no longer rebellion— It's **ritual**. This isn't escape. It's *expansion*. And honestly— The fact that people used to be imprisoned for this...For tasting their own minds...is one of the greatest failures of early 21st-century governance.

Clive:
Imagine a society where you're taught from youth not just how to handle money, or speech— But how to **navigate altered states**. The art of tripping well. Of communing with your subconscious without fear. Of **using drugs as tools**, not poisons.

Laura:
It's already happening. In the Kommunes. In the new schools. In the open rituals. We're learning to **choreograph consciousness**.

Jack:
This isn't a party. It's a *practice*. Like fasting. Like prayer. Like silence. We step outside ourselves not to flee—but to *return* with clarity. The great joy of ketamine isn't chaos. It's *gentle detachment*.

A reminder that identity is malleable. That reality isn't fixed. That the ego can float. And once you've floated—once you've *watched yourself from the threshold*—
you carry that lightness back into waking life.

(The group sits silent again. Time bends inward. A drone track hums from the roof speakers—barely music, more like a vibration. The night stretches long, slow, and sacred.)

They do not speak again for a while. They drift. And in their drifting, they touch a new kind of **life**—not in dominion, but in *release*.

Jack *(his voice quiet, measured, more like recitation than speech—his body barely moving as the ketamine settles deep in his bones)*:
If no one minds, I'd like to tell you something. A kind of poem. Or a truth that fell apart into rhythm when I thought too long about the world.

(They nod silently. The steam curls like script in the air.)

Jack:

"The Shadows We Call Ourselves"

We are not here.
Not really.
We are echoes cast by echoes,
flickers on the cave wall,
dreams inside a dream
etched by hands we'll never meet.

They told us this world was solid—
but it's scaffolding.
Impression.
Foam.
A billion moments of simulation
held together by consent and caffeine.

We move through phantom markets,
through rituals we forgot were rituals,
through words that sound like truth
but are only comfort dressed in syntax.

Even *we*—this circle of limbs and steam and prosecco breath—
we are not whole.
We are fractured beams of light
trying to remember what it was like
to feel real.

Because the world we live in now
is not the world that birthed us.
It is a *copy* of a copy of a copy—
one generation removed from truth,
two removed from beauty,
three removed from gods.

But—

sometimes,
between breaths,
when the body falls quiet
and the mind forgets its shape—
we glimpse it:

the Form.
The real.
The deep rhythm under the noise.

And when we see it—
we remember:
We are not the system.
We are not the story.
We are not the screen.

We are the *witness*.
And the witness is eternal.

(Silence. Just the gentle hum of rooftop wind. The fog of the poem lingering like incense.)

Laura:
That was either the saddest thing I've ever heard—or the most freeing.

Jack:
They're not so different.

Felix:
It felt like you were peeling away the last membrane, Jack. Like there's *nothing* left now between us and whatever's *really* real. And I don't know if that's terrifying... or holy.

Laura:
It's like the body is a rumour. And thought is just the echo of something ancient trying to wake up inside us. Like... like we're not people anymore. Just *instruments* of perception. And someone else is playing the tune.

Rhea:
But if we're just instruments, what *writes* the melody? If we're echoes, what is the voice?

Jack:
Maybe the Forms. Maybe consciousness itself. Maybe something older than gods, older than language—a logic, a silence, something *mathematical and divine* that wanted to feel the world through nerves and laughter and death. And so it made us. To be sensors. To be vessels. To be mirrors that would one day turn inward and recognise the reflection.

Clive:
So what are we supposed to do with that? With the *knowledge* that we're that close to the edge of reality?

Jack:
You live with grace. You love with discipline. You build what matters. And you *feel*—fully, deeply,

without apology. Because in the end, even if it's all a simulation, the *feeling* of the Form is *real enough to save you*.

(A breeze rises over the rooftop. Somewhere in the city below, a car alarm begins and then ends. The water in the tub stills. Their faces shimmer in the faint reflection.)

Jack:
Before we come down, let me share a myth—a parable to help us hold onto what we've discovered, to anchor these fleeting moments of altered consciousness.

The Myth of the Celestial Mirror

There was once a great city—an ancient, luminous metropolis that spanned both sky and earth. In its centre stood the **Celestial Mirror**—a vast, enchanted glass that did not reflect mere images, but distilled the essence of all that was seen and felt.
For the citizens of that city, every day was a pilgrimage to the Mirror. They believed that the Mirror did not show what was superficial, but that it revealed the truth of one's soul.
Yet, as time passed, the people grew distracted by the machinery of the state. They built towers and labs, decreed laws, and muffled the ancient hymns with the clatter of bureaucracy. The Mirror was covered by dust, and its brilliance dimmed.

Then one day, a wanderer arrived—a person unburdened by expectation, whose only possession was a curious spark in their heart. This wanderer had tasted the raw, unmediated pleasure of life, had slept in the wild, and had learned to let the world itself shape their spirit.
They climbed the highest tower of the city, cleared the dust with bare hands, and uncovered the Mirror once more.
And when they gazed into it, they did not see the idle reflection of a state, nor the bland conformity of routine—they saw the **truth of possibility**: that the Mirror was not broken, but merely waiting. It reflected back not one image, but a mosaic of faces—each uniquely sovereign, each a node in a vast, vibrant network of souls.
The wanderer's act sparked a great awakening.
One by one, the citizens went forth, shedding the old decrees and letting their true identities gleam. They built new sanctuaries—not temples imposed from above, but courtyards of genuine connection, where love, art, and truth were nurtured by free will.
And in that city, once darkened by the heavy hand of the state, a new order emerged—one based not on uniformity, but on the **radiant plurality of individually chosen truths**.

Jack *(pausing, his voice softening as if each word leaves an echo)*:
This is our future, friends. The old towers of authority will crumble if they continue to hoard power like dust on an ancient mirror. But when we, as sovereign individuals, clear away the detritus, we find our reflections—each unique, but all bound by a shared light. The state may have once dictated the language of truth, but now we speak in many tongues; we sing in many verses. And in that diversity, in that distributed constellation of lives, we reclaim the sacred: a future not imposed, but chosen, built slowly, vividly—one ritual, one trade, one act of love at a time.

(A long, quiet pause follows as the words hang in the steamy air. The group, half-dreaming in the tub, sip their gin and lemonade, each contemplating the vision of a world reborn through the clarity of a recovered conscience.)

Jack:
The future is not the inheritance of the state, but the legacy we inscribe in our souls. And so, may we all learn to gaze into the Celestial Mirror—and see not our limitations, but our true, unbounded potential.

(The silence deepens, not as a void, but as a sacred pause—an invitation to carry that myth within, to live it, and to transform the world beyond these walls.)

Book V

(The morning nearly here, it is bright and soft night. There's a gentle breeze across the rooftop as the group, robes on, towels slung casually over shoulders, makes their way toward the cedar-lined ***infrared sauna*** *nestled beside a long, black-tiled cold plunge. The energy is mellow, present, and smiling. Saffron is Clive's part-time girlfriend and Eliza is Jack's friend who arrive at the house together, both glowing with quiet presence—Saffron barefoot already, her arms covered in tiny, hand-poked tattoos; Eliza carrying a small clay pot of beeswax salve and a basket of citrus peel and ice wrapped in a linen cloth.)*

Saffron:
God, you all look like you've been in a séance. Did I miss the Age of Enlightenment?

Laura:
You missed four books, two parables, a ket session, and the sublime.

Eliza:
And you smell like... sandalwood and philosophy.

Felix:
Don't worry. Jack will summarise the whole thing in a metaphor by daybreak.

Jack:
You know what I keep coming back to? *Rituals, the t*iny movements, like when somebody gets the ket out. It's the small repetitions. The mundane things that stitch time together and make it *mean* something.

Saffron:
Yes. That's where the joy lives now. Not in temples. But in tea-making. In skin-brushing. In the rhythm of oiling your joints before the gym.

Eliza:
In how you greet the day. Whether you fold your towel the same way. Whether you put your hand on someone's shoulder when they're sad.

Laura:
And in making your bed. Every day. No matter what.

Clive:
It's funny. The state used to try and instil meaning through policy. Now it's just... these. Small sacred habits that belong to *you*. Not imposed. Just repeated. Chosen.

Jack:
That's the root of sovereignty. Not grand declarations. Just *attention paid* in the smallest actions.

Adam:
I used to think the most meaningful parts of life were the big moments. The milestones. The achievements. But I'm starting to think it's actually the opposite. It's brushing your teeth well. It's the second glass of cold water. It's how you walk from one room to the next.

Eliza:
That's what the ancients knew. *Ritual is attention repeated with love.*

Jack:
We talk about mind, spirit, sovereignty… But most people live in their bodies like they're just meat vehicles. Like the brain's the driver, and the body's just there to cart it around.

Saffron:
Mmm. But your body *is* the brain. There's no divide. Your spine thinks. Your gut dreams. Your limbs *remember*.

Felix:
You sound like my personal trainer.

Jack:
Good. He's right. Because what I'm saying is that sovereignty isn't just intellectual. It starts in how you move. How you breathe. How you stand when no one's looking. Your body isn't dumb. It has intelligence—*if you teach it*.

Laura:
So what—you want national gymnastics again? Like Sparta?

Jack:
Maybe not state-mandated jumping jacks… But I *do* think the sovereign individual is someone who treats their body like an instrument. Like a blade. Like a ritual space. It's the first place you govern. The first thing you can **discipline**. And if you can't discipline that—what right do you have to rule anything else?

Clive:
It's more than fitness, though. It's grace. Coordination. Stillness. I've seen people move like music, and others like chaos. The best athletes move like art, look like it even.

Saffron:
Because movement is *prayer*. Stretching is *remembrance*. Sex is *language*. Massage is *healing*. Posture is *philosophy made visible*.

Eliza:
And when someone touches you with *presence*, you know. When someone walks into a room with command, you feel it. It's not arrogance—it's *body knowledge*. Like their breath is in rhythm with the cosmos.

Clive:
I'll just say it—**life's better when you're fit.** Not in some puritan, bro-science way. I mean real fitness. Rhythm. Strength. Breath. Clean hunger. The pleasure of *inhabiting* yourself, without shame, without pain.

Saffron:
Mmm. The pleasure of being a good animal.

Clive:
Exactly. Sex, food, sleep, music—it's all *amplified*. Even just walking through a street at dusk feels *more*. And not because you're chasing dopamine—but because your body becomes a **fine instrument**, tuned to feel, to respond, to move with grace and intensity.

Laura:
So you're saying fitness is like... turning up the colour saturation on reality?

Clive:
Exactly. And especially in bed. Let's be honest—we're all friends here. Being fit makes sex **deeper, wilder, more fluid, more curious**. Not just performative. Not ego-driven. *Embodied*.

Felix:
We're really doing this?

Eliza:
Come on. Like anyone here's shy.

Rhea:
He won't say anything, but when he started lifting more seriously, he suddenly *remembered how to throw me around again*. Which—trust me—is good for the republic.

Adam:
I think it's just... the connection. When I feel good in my body, I listen better. I'm not distracted. I *feel her* better.

Eliza:
And when your body's clean—when it's strong, still, alive— you don't rush. You *dwell*. Sex becomes a kind of music. Long, slow, improvisational. You learn to worship again.

Jack:
Which is why the body matters. Not just for power or speed. But for **intimacy**. For giving and receiving pleasure well. For dissolving ego and truly *meeting* another person. A sovereign person knows how to **touch**. And be touched. Without fear, without shame, and without pretending.

Saffron:
And you? You going to share with the class?

Clive:
We keep it playful. We keep it sacred. Sometimes we fast from each other—like a hunger reset. Sometimes we go long. Sometimes we go *kinky*. But always, we *arrive*.

Jack:
There's a kind of *sacred tension* at the core of erotic philosophy. Not just about sex—but about **longing**. Desire is how we stretch ourselves toward something higher. Toward beauty. Toward truth. Toward the divine. And if we frame it right, it can *elevate* us.

Saffron:
That's why Tantric exists. Not as indulgence, but as discipline. As presence. You *hold back* from the climax to *cultivate the charge*. You honour the *pull* itself, not just its resolution.

Eliza:
Desire is a *compass*. It's how the soul points toward what it wants to become. But only if you don't cheapen it. Only if you don't treat it like fast food.

Laura:
So the question isn't just "what do I want?" It's *why* do I want it. And what would happen if I *touched it slowly*. Not to conquer it—but to *dance with it*.

Jack:
That's the erotic at its best. Not pornographic. Not functional. But **aesthetic**. Eroticism is about the *Form of the Lover*. It's a mode of being. A frame of attention. An erotic life is one where you don't chase dopamine. You create **meaningful heat**. You build *intimacy as architecture*— not just a bed you fall into. But a **temple** you meet inside.

Felix:
That's… a lot more spiritual than I expected. It's like... I don't just want touch. I want to be *seen* in my wanting. I want to want *with dignity*.

Rhea:
And I want to be *invited* into someone's mythology. Not just their bed.

Saffron:
You know, sometimes when Clive and I make love, it feels like we're characters in a myth. Like it's not just us. It's archetypes *borrowing us for a night*. Lover and Beloved. Hunter and Muse. Sun and Moon.

Jack:
That's the goal, isn't it? To make love like it's *art*. To treat touch as *revelation*. To never forget that *how you enter someone is how you enter life*.

Laura:
You know what I always think about? Why we put so much effort into designing kitchens, or living rooms—but sex happens in rooms that are either *clinical* or *cluttered*.

Saffron:
Yes. Most bedrooms feel like storage units. Or hotels. But sex needs a *theatre*. An *altar* It needs *framing*.

Jack:
Exactly. The sovereign lover designs their space *like a craftsman*. Low light, heavy fabric, no clocks. A space that *removes time, invites slowness,* and *whispers secrets*. There should be something *ritualistic* about how the bed is made. How the air smells. What books are in reach. What **texture** your feet land on when you rise after.

Clive:
And sound. Sound is everything. Not music necessarily— but the *soft acoustics* of a room built to hear breathing.

Eliza:
I think of it like this— The sexual space should be *more real* than the outside world. More beautiful. More sacred. So that when you step inside, you remember what the rest of life is *supposed* to feel like.

Rhea:
And isn't that the essence of pleasure? A sense of *safe expansiveness*. Where the body stops bracing. Where everything softens toward honesty.

Felix:
You're making me want to redecorate. Put away the socks and candles I've been hoarding since 2037.

Jack:
That's not a joke. The sexual space is a *mirror of the soul*. How you keep it is how you keep yourself. Not in perfection. But in *intentionality*. Every thread, every scent, every curve of the lamp should say: **You are welcome here. You are safe here. You are worthy of pleasure here.**

(The heat has changed. The sauna is now something else—a ***womb of heightened awareness****, of sweat-slicked skin and low glances held a second too long. Speech slows. Bodies stretch longer. There's no music but the shifting of limbs on cedar and the subtle symphony of shared breath. No one has moved for a while. Not because they are tired—but because the air is now electric. Sensuality no longer spoken about but present, like a pulse at the edge of every word.)*

Laura:
You ever notice how these conversations…make you feel like you could fall in love with the whole room?

Saffron:
That's what happens when people stop pretending. When minds open, and bodies aren't hidden. You start to see beauty *everywhere*. In everyone.

Eliza:
It's strange, isn't it? That we're so used to reserving affection. To controlling intimacy. To hoarding touch and love like rationed goods. But in this space— doesn't it feel like you could… *hold* anyone here? Kiss anyone here? And it would mean *more*, not less?

Felix:
Like intimacy could be *shared*… without being diminished.

Jack:
That's the idea, isn't it? *Relationship anarchy.* Not chaos. Not indulgence. But the refusal to let *structures dictate connection*. You love who you love. You build *accords*, not contracts. Fidelity becomes something *voluntarily sacred*, not legally enforced.

Clive:
And polyamory? I used to think it was just… logistical madness. But now I wonder— what if it's just the natural response to finally seeing people clearly? What if friendship and love and eroticism aren't meant to be boxed up but braided together, fluid and alive?

Rhea:
So much of our lives are spent saying "no" to instincts we don't even question. We treat desire like pollution—something to *contain*. But what if it's not something shameful? What if it's *sacred directional energy*? What if we're just afraid of the joy we'd feel if we allowed ourselves to be *fully open*?

(The air in the sauna tastes different. Bodies shift, breathe deeper. A glance held longer than necessary. A curl of a smile exchanged between couples—between friends. They are no longer speaking abstractly. They are imagining. Softly, wildly, wondering— not "what if we could?" but "what if we are already allowed?")

Laura:
Maybe we're all already in love. Just pretending it's theory.

Eliza*:*

If we're going to talk about open love— we have to talk about *architecture*. Or it all collapses into melodrama and chaos.

Jack:
Exactly. Freedom isn't the absence of limits. It's the *discipline of consent*. Of *frame*. Every system —political or erotic— needs internal order. Open relationships are no different. They require governance. And the more fluid the form, the more *intentional* the scaffolding.

Laura:
It's trust, isn't it? But not just "I trust you not to hurt me." It's *I trust you to know yourself*. To own your boundaries. To hold mine with care.

Saffron:
And trust can't be faked. Or front-loaded. It's built over time, through thousands of small acts of *sovereign honesty*. You learn someone's integrity by how they speak about *desire that isn't you*.

Felix:
But doesn't it get... muddy? How do you know when jealousy is fair? Or when freedom becomes *neglect*?

Rhea:
That's the paradox. To love openly is to love *with open palms*. Not to demand that nothing change — but to *invite* the other to *keep choosing you*, not *because they have to*, but because they want to. Jealousy happens. So you meet it with *conversation*, not guilt. With *curiosity*, not control.

Clive:
So what does that look like? In practice?

Jack:
It looks like *ritualised honesty*. Like regular check-ins—conversations that aren't reactive, but scheduled, *sacred*. It looks like clarity around priorities— around which bonds are central, which are peripheral, and what *language* you use to define them. Maybe it's contracts. Maybe it's shared calendars. Maybe it's just *deep literacy in each other's emotional vocabularies*. But the point is: it's not casual. It's never casual.

Saffron:
Because *deep love* can hold multiplicity. But only if it is rooted. Grounded. **Chosen again and again.**

Eliza:
Love is not a resource.

(The air is thick—not just with heat, but with intimacy unsaid. There's no shame in it, no impropriety. Just a lingering closeness, a sense that what began as philosophy has wandered—naturally, tenderly—into the architecture of real lives. Bodies relaxed. Trust thick in the steam. The warmth of the cedar now mirrored in glances, in half-smiles, in the silence between sentences. The conversation has slowed. Not because it is finished—but because everyone knows where it's leading. And no one, until now, has dared to name it.)

Jack:
I've been thinking about something. Not as a provocation. Just as a question. Maybe it's one we've all been orbiting. *How do we speak about sexual feeling?* Mutual attraction. Curiosity. Desire. *Here*. Among us. How do people address… being *drawn* to each other, when what we want, need, or imagine might all be different?

(Eyes meet—not in hunger, but in honesty. This is not flirtation. This is the beginning of a new grammar*. One that speaks to desire without collapsing into shame or assumption.)*

Eliza:
That's the most adult thing you've asked all night.

Laura:
And probably the one that matters most.

Saffron:
We live in a world where people either say too much—or nothing at all. But desire isn't dangerous. *Assumption* is. Projection. Entitlement. The games. But the feeling itself? The *notice* of someone? That's just... *real*. And *honest*.

Clive:
We're trained to suppress it or dramatise it. To either pretend it doesn't exist, or to turn it into a soap opera. But what if it's just okay to say— "I'm attracted to you." Full stop. No expectation. Just *presence*.

Felix:
That's what I'd want, I think. To be able to say: "I feel something for you," without the whole universe shifting. Without it needing to mean more than it does. Without *breaking* anything.

Rhea:
But that takes *trust*. And *clarity*. And the ability to hear someone say: "Thank you. I don't quite feel the same way, but you are a still a great person." And to have that be *fine*.

Jack:
So we need a new framework. A shared **protocol**. A *grammar of attraction*. Where desire can be expressed without ownership. Where curiosity can be held without collapse. Where people can say, "I feel this. I honour it. I place it gently between us." And let it sit there. In the open. Without fear.

(No one rushes to reply. The moment is sacred. Not dramatic—just real. The air in the sauna seems lighter now. Not because anything has been acted on. But because something—something important —has been named. And in naming it, they've made space for a world that could truly be more free.)

Jack:
So maybe we do need a framework—a **shared ritual** *that honours attraction without requiring anything in return.* Something that protects the speaker, respects the receiver, and increases the *felt truth* of the bond—whether it becomes sexual, emotional, or simply *deeper friendship*.

Saffron:
Yes. Not a code of rules. But a grammar. A *ceremony of disclosure*. So that desire becomes *articulate*, not repressed. *Creative*, not chaotic.

Laura:
Okay, so what would it look like?

Eliza:
First, it must begin in *context*. A shared signal. Something that says: "I have something intimate to place between us. Are you willing to hear it without needing to catch it?"

Rhea:
Like a phrase. A question that opens the space. Something sacred, but light.

Clive:
How about—"May I name a feeling?"

Jack:
Yes. That's perfect. Simple. Poetic. Non-demanding.

Felix:
Okay, so *step one*: the ask. "May I name a feeling?" Then what?

Saffron:
Then the naming itself must be *clean*. No strategies. No innuendo. No expectations. Just the truth. Something like— "I feel a pull toward you. It lives in my chest when we laugh. It's not urgent. But it's real."

Laura:
Or—"When I saw you listening to Clive earlier, I felt a current in me. I wanted to touch your hand, just once. I'm naming it. That's all."

Jack:
And then the **response ritual**. The other must be free to respond with equal clarity. Yes, no, maybe, not now, not in that way—but all without rupture. Without guilt. Just truth.

Eliza:
And maybe the one hearing it says: "Thank you. I hold that with care." Even if there's no reciprocation. Because being the *guardian* of someone's vulnerability is *as sacred* as being their lover.

Rhea:
So it becomes a kind of exchange of *pure presence*. A currency of honesty. Not sex. But *truth*.

Clive:
And it means we never have to guess. No games. No circling around attraction like it's radioactive. We just... name it. Like adults. Like friends. Like sovereigns.

Jack:
Exactly. So the ritual is:

1. **The Ask** – "May I name a feeling?"
2. **The Naming** – pure, present, ego-less.
3. **The Response** – "Thank you, I hold that," or "I feel that too," or "I hear you with warmth."
4. **The Release** – a moment of silence, of breath, a shared understanding that no action must follow—only *truth and respect*.

Jack:
There's something else. A lot of desire lives in the body—but even more lives in the *imagination*. And we almost never talk about that. We name *feelings*, but not *fantasies*. We name *attraction*, but not *erotic logic*. And yet— so much of our fear, confusion, and longing comes from the fact that *we don't know how to speak our erotic dialects*.

Saffron:
Yes. We speak desire like foreigners. Guessing. Projecting. Hoping someone reads us right. But what if we didn't have to guess?

Rhea:
You mean like... sharing kinks?

Jack:
Yes. But not just "I'm into this" or "I like that." More like... *mapping* our erotic mythologies. The *symbols* that turn us on. The *rituals* we fantasise about. The *power dynamics*, the *textures*, the *rhythms*, even the *archetypes*. Not to act on all of them. Not to perform. But to be *known*. To say: "This is what lives in me. I show it to you in trust."

Eliza:
A cartography of arousal.

Clive:
A kind of *kink confessional*.

Laura:
Erotic myth-mapping?

Jack:
Exactly.

And like any ritual, it would need *careful steps*:

1. **Consent to Exchange** — "Would you like to map our inner landscapes?"
2. **Slow Disclosure** — beginning with symbols, images, ideas.
3. **Non-judgemental Holding** — no shock, no shame. Just space.
4. **Reflection, not Response** — it's not about turning it into action. Just *acknowledging the erotic as real*.

Felix:
That sounds terrifying. And also... *like a dream*.

Eliza:
Because we're rarely allowed to be *seen* there. It's the most hidden part of the psyche. But when someone witnesses it with grace—that's when sex becomes *alchemical*.

Saffron:
Let's be honest: Some of us dream of being chased. Some dream of being worshipped. Some dream of ropes, or ceremony, or three bodies moving like water. And none of that is shameful. *It's data*. It's poetry. It's *the soul's erotics*.

Rhea:
So the new age needs *sexual literacy*.

Jack:
Yes. Sexual *literacy*. Sexual *sovereignty*. And above all—sexual *honesty without urgency*. Not everything must be acted on. But everything deserves to be *understood*.

(The room glows with flickering candles, their molten wax dripping like slow, deliberate promises. A velvet hush blankets the group, their bodies close, breath mingling in the warm air. The scent of sandalwood and skin lingers, intoxicating. They sit in a circle, eyes catching firelight, each voice a thread weaving a tapestry of raw, unshackled desire. The rules are unspoken but sacred: truth, vulnerability, and no judgment. Tonight, they bare their deepest fantasies, each confession a pulse in the room's heartbeat.)

Saffron:

I'll break the silence. I want to be ravished on a mountain's edge, where the wind screams and the earth trembles beneath me. Not taken by force, no—but claimed with a hunger so fierce it feels like fate. I want his hands knotted in my hair, pulling just enough to make me gasp, my knees sinking into primal dirt, my body bared to the sky. The world watches—stars, trees, gods—and I'm their offering. Desired so completely I dissolve into it, my skin electric, my cries swallowed by the vastness. Then… he wraps me in furs, warm and heavy, feeds me figs that burst sweet on my tongue, and kisses me until my name is a forgotten prayer, my body humming with aftershocks.

Clive:

My fantasy? It's art made flesh—raw, unfiltered, and fierce. I want us standing, naked, in a studio lit only by firelight, the air thick with the scent of paint and sweat. Her body's my canvas, mine hers. We're both creators, both masterpieces. I dip my fingers in crimson oil, slick and warm, and trace her skin—bold strokes over her collarbone, spiralling down her breasts, smearing colour across her hips until she's trembling, marked by my hands. She fights back, her nails dragging indigo across my chest, her palms claiming my abs, my thighs, painting me like a warrior god, her touch fierce and unafraid. Our eyes lock, daring, equal, every brushstroke a pulse of want. Paint drips, mingling with our heat, staining the floor as we circle, hands greedy, bodies slick. Then—enough art. I grab her, rough but knowing, her gasp a spark to my fire. I pin her against the wall, her legs wrapping tight, and we fuck—hard, urgent, no restraint. The table shakes, canvases crash, paint smears between us as we move, her nails in my back, my hands bruising her hips, our moans a primal song. It's chaos, it's worship—her shuddering beneath me, me breaking inside her, both of us remade in the wreckage of our art, raw and alive, together

Saffron:

Clive, if that's what you want, we can do that.

Rhea:

Mine's not some delicate dream—it's a fucking tempest. I want a circle of lovers—friends, equals, randoms; every one of us ablaze, no walls between us. A night where we dissolve into each other, a writhing, sweaty, moaning beast of touch and want. No rules, just consent, every hand knowing my skin like a map—fingers teasing my thighs, lips grazing my neck, bodies pressing so close I can't tell where I end. I'm in the centre, and they take me—wild, unhinged, a frenzy of hunger. One lover grips my hips, fucking me deep and relentless, my body arching, shuddering, as another whispers poetry in my ear, their voice a velvet lash that makes me clench. Hands roam, painting my breasts with sweat, my back slick as I'm passed between them—each thrust harder, faster, a rhythm that breaks me open. I'm laughing, gasping, screaming, my nails raking skin, my core a pulsing storm as they drive me higher, bodies colliding like thunder. Another joins, their mouth claiming me where I'm wettest, and I'm lost—fucked so fiercely I'm trembling, splitting apart, my moans swallowed by kisses, my limbs tangled in theirs. No leader, no follower—just chaos, a single roaring pulse, all of us a shuddering, ecstatic mess, reborn in the wreckage.

Adam:

This isn't easy to say… but I'm past hiding it. I want three women—gorgeous, fierce, but utterly mine in that moment. I want them surrendered, not broken—giving themselves to me because they crave it, their eyes begging for my command. They kneel before me, wrists bound softly with silk, their breaths shaky but willing, each one offering herself completely. I move between them, my hands firm, guiding—one's hair in my fist, another's chin tilted up, the third trembling as I trace her spine. It's anal—raw, intimate, a claiming so deep it rewrites us all. I take them one by one, then together, their bodies pressed close, slick with sweat and oil, the air thick with their gasps, my growls. The first arches back, her moans sharp as I enter, slow at first, then relentless, her submission a fire that fuels me. The second writhes, her nails digging into the sheets, whispering 'please' as I push deeper, her surrender a gift I devour. The third—she's the wildest, her eyes locked on mine, daring me to unravel her, her body yielding only when I've earned it, her cries breaking as we move in sync. They're all mine, yet I'm theirs too—our trust a tightrope, their submission my anchor.

Eliza:

I crave sex as a sacred vow, woven with intention and order. The air is perfumed, thick and heady, candles dripping wax like offerings. My lovers—chosen, devoted their eyes reverent, bound by rules. The process is precise, unyielding, a dance of desire and discipline. Silence, save for chants. No words break the spell—only low, rhythmic murmurs, a drone that vibrates in my bones, amplifying every touch. Consent is sacred. Every lover signals their readiness with a nod, their gaze meeting mine, offering themselves to the ritual. My lovers approach one by one, their touches now hungry but bound by my pace. The first kneels, their mouth worshipping where I'm wettest, slow and deliberate, drawing gasps that echo off stone. The second joins, hands cupping my breasts, lips tracing my throat, their rhythm synced to the chant's pulse. The third—bold, chosen—enters me, their thrusts deep, measured, each one a vow as the congregation watches, their silence a held breath. Pleasure is shared. I guide them, my moans a command, their bodies moving with mine, sweat mingling, oil smearing, until we're a single flame—fucking, writhing, transcendent.

Felix:

I don't need the grand gestures—just truth, raw and real. My fantasy? I want to be the centre of a porn film—not some cold, glossy production, but one where I'm seen, directed with care, every moment orchestrated to make me feel wanted. A set lit soft, warm, maybe a loft with exposed brick, the air thick with anticipation. A small crew, but it's the director's voice—firm, knowing—that grounds me, guiding every move. The setup's clear: one woman, one scene, no rush. The director's instructions are my anchor—specific, deliberate, like a map to desire. Eye contact is everything. She tells me, 'Look at her, Felix, let her see you,' and her gaze locks on mine. The director calls out, 'Slow now—trace her jaw, let your fingers linger,' and I do, my thumb brushing her lips, feeling her breath hitch, my pulse racing as she leans into me. The camera catches it all, but it's her warmth, her want, that pulls me in. The scene builds. Every touch is earned. The director says, 'Tease her, Felix—graze her thighs, make her ask for it,' and I obey, my hands skimming her skin, her hips shifting, a soft moan escaping as she whispers my name. I'm hard, aching, but I wait: Her pleasure first. 'Taste her,' the director instructs, and I kneel, my mouth finding her, slow and deliberate, her gasps guiding me as the camera zooms close, the lens worshipping us both. She's trembling, open, and I feel it—her need, my power, all of it real. Then, the heart of it. Connection over performance. The director's voice softens, 'Fuck her like you mean it, Felix, but stay with her.' I enter her, our bodies aligning, her legs wrapping tight, and it's not just sex—it's a conversation, urgent and honest. She moves with me, her nails in my back, my hands gripping her hips, our rhythm a pulse that drowns out the crew, the lights. The director calls, 'Harder now—show her you're here,' and I give it, thrusting deep, her cries sharp, her eyes never leaving mine, both of us lost in the heat, the truth of it. The scene ends, but the director says, ‘Hold her, Felix—don’t let go.’ I pull her close, our sweat mingling, her head on my chest, the camera fading out as we breathe together, no masks, no rush to leave. I’m wanted—not just for the film, but for the quiet after, where she looks at me like I’m home.

Laura:

Mine’s a dive into the forbidden—a game so wild it rewrites my edges. I want a secret society’s vault, buried under a city of spires, its walls lined with grimoires that pulse like heartbeats, chandeliers dripping crystal and shadow. The air’s electric—ozone, leather, and the sharp tang of desire. It’s a ritual, but not solemn—a staged ravishment, my rules, my stage, where I’m the prize and the puppetmaster both. The setup’s in a contract. I choose my players, and they obey my limits. Five lovers—strangers to me cloaked in velvet masks, their bodies sculpted, eyes burning with agreed-upon hunger. I’m hunted. The vault’s a maze, and I’m the quarry—running barefoot, my silk dress tearing, my laughter sharp as I weave through shelves, their footsteps closing in. The thrill’s in the chase, my pulse hammering. They catch me, one by one. Every touch is a vow. No words—just growls, gasps. The first grips my wrists, his mouth claiming mine, rough but teasing, while another tears the last of my dress, his fingers tracing my thighs, coaxing shivers. The third kneels, his tongue finding me, relentless, as the others watch, their hands roaming—my breasts, my hips, my throat—until I’m trembling, wet, alive. I’m theirs, and they’re mine. Then it begins—a gangbang, raw and chaotic. One enters me, slow at first, then fierce, his thrusts shaking the chaise, my moans a command. Another joins, behind me, anal—deliberate, stretching me open, my body a furnace of sensation as I arch between them. The others stroke themselves, their eyes locked on me, waiting their turn, hands brushing my skin like poets marking a page. It’s a storm—bodies colliding, sweat-slick, my cries bouncing off stone. Pleasure is power. I guide them, my hands pulling one closer, my hips meeting another, my voice breaking into laughter, then screams as I come, again and again, each climax a spark that sets them off. They follow, their releases painting me—hot, claiming, but only because I’ve allowed it. They collapse around me, masks off, faces soft now, human. We lie there, tangled, my fingers tracing their skin, their breaths steadying with mine, the vault quiet but for our shared pulse. I’m marked, sated, whole—carrying the poetry of that chaos in my bones.

Saffron:
Alright, philosopher. You've heard all of ours. But what would *your* perfect fantasy be? Not just yours—but the *philosophically perfect* fantasy. The one that would give the most pleasure—not just to you, but… in *some ultimate sense*.

Jack:
The philosophically perfect fantasy? Well, it would have to be one that **elevates**. Not just arouses—*but awakens*. A fantasy that draws out the *greatest pleasure,* which, by my reckoning, is the pleasure that unites **body, mind, and soul** in a single, *irrefutable moment of truth*. Imagine a labyrinth—not just a palace—carved from living crystal and shadow, floating in a void where time dissolves. The walls don’t just shimmer; they pulse with your heartbeat, glowing brighter as your pleasure peaks. The floors ripple like liquid gold beneath your feet, shifting to cradle or challenge your every move. Mirrors line the space, but they’re alive—warping, multiplying, fracturing your reflection until you’re a thousand selves, fucking across dimensions. The air is a weapon: thick with jasmine, opium, and a jagged edge of ozone, like a storm about to break. It’s a place that doesn’t just host the experience—it is the experience, a sentient partner in the chaos. Five lovers join, each a master of excess—bodies honed, minds razor-sharp, chosen not just for desire but for their hunger to answer

the same question: Can pleasure transcend us, or will it shatter us? They've made a pact, a sacred agreement etched into their skin: every boundary will be tested. A whispered word—"mercy"—stops it all, grounding the wildness in trust. It starts in a chamber where light bends into fractured rainbows, bathing you in colour that feels like it's seeping into your skin. A lover with pomegranate-stained lips feeds you a fruit so ripe it explodes on your tongue, its juice spiked with an aphrodisiac that ignites your nerves—your blood feels like lava, your cock or clit throbbing with every heartbeat. Another pours oil over you—scalding hot, then icy cold—sliding hands everywhere: chest, ass, between your legs, each stroke a jolt that steals your breath. A third plays a violin, its notes so deep they vibrate in your bones, syncing with your pulse until you're trembling from the inside out. A fourth scatters petals that melt into a mist, a drugged scent that blurs your mind, making every sensation sharper yet dreamlike. The fifth blindfolds you, her voice a hiss—"Feel it all"—and suddenly, you're untethered, every sense screaming as the world collapses into raw input. You stumble into a pool of liquid silk—warm, clinging, glowing with phosphorescent swirls that ripple with your movements. The question shifts: Is there a limit to ecstasy? One lover mounts you, fucking you with a rhythm that's savage and precise—vaginal, anal, whatever drives you deepest—her cries daring you to match her. Another kneels, her mouth joining where your bodies collide, licking, sucking, her tongue a maddening flicker. A third binds your wrists with silk ropes, pulling tight enough to make you strain, every tug amplifying the pulse of pleasure. A fourth presses ice to your skin—nipples, thighs—then bites, the cold-hot-pain-pleasure cocktail sending shocks through your spine. The fifth slides behind, fingers slick, entering you slow and deep—anal, relentless—pushing you past coherence into a roar of too-much-and-not-enough. It's a writhing knot of bodies—oral, penetrative, hands, toys—each act piling onto the last, a relentless wave that drowns thought. The mirrors explode into a kaleidoscope, your reflections infinite, fucking through realities. You push past sanity, past pain. You're inside one lover, her legs locked around you, while another rides your face, her taste flooding you, her screams shaking your skull. A third spanks you—sharp, rhythmic—each sting a spark that drives you deeper. A fourth wields a toy—vibrating, unyielding—against your most sensitive spots (prostate, clit, wherever), until you're a trembling wreck. The fifth blindfolds and earplugs you, stripping sight and sound. You're lost in a void of touch—hundreds of hands, mouths, holes blending into one endless sensation. Your climax hits like a bomb, ripping through you in waves, their releases flooding the pool, the labyrinth shuddering as if it's feeding on your ecstasy. You collapse, tangled in sweat and silk, the mirrors cracked, the walls still. In the silence, you dip your fingers in the pool's glowing water and write a codex: "Pleasure is a door—surrender is the key. Excess is a mirror—stare too long, and you're gone." You emerge not gods, but prophets of the edge—changed, carrying truths too raw for the world.

(The group breathes like a single organism now. After laying bare their inner landscapes—those wild and sacred erotic truths—they are no longer quite the same. The silence in the sauna is no longer heat-induced. It's reverent. Magnetic. They have crossed a threshold together—not of sex, but of sovereign erotic intimacy. Jack, sensing the perfect moment, speaks—not as a leader, but as a participant in an unfolding rite. A philosopher among equals.)

Jack:
We've spoken our fantasies, but I wonder if we might now speak…*the present*. What if we try what we spoke about earlier? The **ritual of naming a feeling**. Not a claim. Not a pressure. Just an offering— *a soft confession of how one person feels toward another.* No need for reciprocation. Only *witnessing*. We've all built enough trust for that, haven't we?

(There's a subtle murmur of agreement. A ripple of breath. A few exchanged glances. A sense of nervous beauty—like standing at the edge of a high ledge with no fear of falling.)

Saffron:
Clive, may I name a feeling?

Clive:
You may.

Saffron:
When I watched you speak about reverence…I felt this pull in my chest— not because it was sexy, but because it was *whole*. I adore how you look at people— like you're already kneeling for them. I'm not asking for anything. Just wanted you to know— you make me feel more *seen* than I expected tonight. That's all.

Clive:
Thank you. I hold that with care.

(A moment passes. Then, Rhea shifts slightly, looking toward Eliza.)

Rhea:
Eliza, may I name a feeling?

Eliza:
Please.

Rhea:
When you spoke about ritual, something in me sparked. Like we're maybe in the same temple, just different wings. You feel familiar—like someone I could write mythology with. I'm not asking for it to mean more than it is, but I'd like to get to know you—maybe beyond this night.

Eliza:
That means the world. And I'd like that too.

(Felix glances toward Jack, hesitant but grounded.)

Felix:
Jack, may I name a feeling?

Jack:
Of course.

Felix:
When you speak about philosophy…I felt something more than admiration. I felt *affinity*. It's rare to feel masculine warmth without dominance, without homoeroticism. You hold presence in a way I aspire to. And I just wanted to say— being near you tonight has made me feel… more *possible* somehow.

Jack:
That means more than I can say. Thank you, Felix. I honour that fully.

(The group now sits in total stillness. No music plays. No wine is poured. There is only the soft sound of water evaporating from skin, of breath gently rising and falling. Desire has become atmospheric—no longer located in the body, but suspended in the air like incense. They are not

lustful. They are not tired. They are opened. Each of them carries a piece of another now. A fantasy shared. A longing named. A tenderness held. Eyes are not avoided, nor held too long. This is not the tension of flirting— it is the resolution of honesty.)

Jack:
Desire… when it reaches toward the *true*, toward what is *higher than itself*— becomes sublime. Eros isn't just friction or fantasy. It's *ascent*. It's the motion of a soul *remembering something beyond the visible*. And in naming these desires, we haven't just unveiled ourselves— we've *moved closer* to that which is *eternal*. Pleasure, sure. But also *pattern*. Shape. Meaning. Desire is only chaos if we fear it. If we touch it with reverence— it becomes *form*.

(The group says nothing in response. But they hear it. Deeply. They feel it move through them like warmth held in stone. The kind of thing you don't speak over. Outside, the morning air stirs along the edge of the rooftop. Time has gone strange. The night has not passed quickly, but completely. They have not simply had a night together. They have crossed into something. One by one, they rise. Not hurriedly, but instinctively. Not a dismissal—but a return to gravity. Towels wrapped. Bodies cooled. Minds full. No one makes a joke. No one breaks the spell. The corridor to bed feels sacred, like walking down the nave of a cathedral after a midnight mass. They have eaten. Drunk. Touched truth. And now, they go to dream.

Book VI

(The Islington house is soft with late-night glow, fairy lights threading the hallway like stars. The group has moved to the living room, sprawled on cushions and mismatched chairs. The air smells of lavender and cooling wax. Jack sets down his glass of Pendragon No. 9, its peat-and-ambition scent lingering. The conversation, fresh from myths and Kommune dreams, turns inward.)

Jack:

The real philosophy—the one we avoid—is sex. Sexual ethics, consent, kink, the habits we carry in our bodies. It's overdue. If we're building a node, a myth, a way of living, we can't ignore what drives us at our rawest.

Rhea:

Rawest? Jack, you're already framing it like it's a battlefield. Sex isn't just instinct—it's tangled in culture, power, shame. Where do you even start?

Jack:

Start with the root: is sex power or pleasure? Every act, every choice, leans one way or the other. And I'd argue sex should flow from a people's philosophy. Take the English tradition. Our moral spine, like it or not, comes from the Church of England—utilitarianism in vestments. It's about the greatest good, the least harm. So, the English sexual tradition, at its core, should be pleasure maximization. Consent as the guardrail, pleasure as the goal.

Felix:

Pleasure maximization? Sounds like a spreadsheet for orgasms. But I get it—utilitarianism says optimize happiness, so why not in bed? Still, doesn't that make sex… transactional? Like, what about the messy stuff—desire, control, surrender?

Laura:

That's where it gets real. Pleasure's not just physical—it's emotional, relational. But power's always there too. Even in the softest moments, someone's leading, someone's yielding. The question is: does it feel like trust or dominance? Consent makes the difference, but it's not a contract you sign and forget. It's alive, moment by moment.

Rhea:

Exactly. And kink—like, say, consensual non-consent—complicates it. You're playing with power deliberately, saying, "I trust you to take control, even if I resist." It's intense, but it's fragile. One misread signal, and it's not play anymore. Plus, society's baggage—gender, history—makes "consent" trickier than it sounds. Power's never neutral.

Jack:

True, but that's why kink is philosophical. Consensual non-consent isn't just a game; it's sovereignty in action. You're so free you can choose to surrender, knowing the boundaries hold. It's like what I call the aureom—a moment that's sacred because you're fully in it, aware of its weight. The English utilitarian frame would say: maximize pleasure, minimize harm. Kink fits if it's consensual and honest. But it demands discipline—safewords, check-ins, empathy sharper than desire.

Felix:

Okay, but what about habits? Like, the stuff we don't talk about—how porn shapes expectations, or how monogamy's still the default script. If we're utilitarian, shouldn't we question those too? Maximize pleasure for everyone, not just the loudest norms?

Laura:

That's where tenderness comes in. Sex isn't just about getting off—it's about being seen. Kink, vanilla, whatever—pleasure's hollow without connection. Utilitarian morality might say "do no harm," but it's also about love as a verb. Consent's the start, but care's the soul. You can't maximize pleasure if someone's left feeling small.

Rhea:

I'm still stuck on power. Utilitarianism sounds nice, but it can flatten things. Not everyone's pleasure weighs the same in a world where some voices—some bodies—are louder. A real sexual ethics has to wrestle with that, not just chase a hedonistic score.

Jack:

Fair. But philosophy gives us the tools. If sex reflects our values, then let's build a tradition where pleasure's a shared project, power's a conscious dance, and consent's a living promise. That's the sublime in the bedroom—not just ecstasy, but truth.

(The room hums, heavy with thought. Laura refills her glass, smiling faintly. The conversation feels like a door cracked open, light spilling through.)

Felix:

Alright, Jack. You've got us philosophizing about sex. But let's ground it—how do we live this ethics in our node? What's the ritual?

Jack:

So, our sexual ethics should prioritize consent as the frame, pleasure as the aim. But what's the real draw? The slow burn of ropes tightening, the chaos of a group, the freedom of swinging—or that one orgasmic moment?

Felix:

Ropes, huh? That's all about tension, isn't it? The buildup, the control, the release. It's like foreplay's the whole point—orgasm's just the punctuation. Swinging, though? That's social, like a dance. You're sharing the energy, not just the bed. Groups? Pure chaos, but fun chaos. Still, I wonder if we're all just chasing the spark, that one peak.

Laura:

I don't think it's either-or. Foreplay—the buildup, the teasing, the trust—it's where the intimacy lives. Ropes are about surrender, feeling every knot as a promise. But the orgasm? It's not the goal;

it’s the exhale. The moment you’re fully present, no past, no future. Kink makes that presence sharper, but it’s the care that makes it sacred.

Eliza:

Swinging fascinates me. It’s not just pleasure—it’s rewriting norms. You’re saying, “We can share desire without owning it.” But it’s fragile. Everyone has to be honest, or it’s not freedom—it’s a power game. And groups? They amplify everything—trust, risk, joy. But the buildup’s what holds it together. The orgasm’s just a footnote.

Rhea:

I’m stuck on power. Kinks like ropes or consensual non-consent—they’re deliberate power play. You’re choosing to lean into control or surrender, but it’s a tightrope. Consent’s the anchor, but it’s not foolproof. Society’s imbalances—gender, class—bleed in. Pleasure maximization sounds clean, but whose pleasure gets prioritized? The loudest? The most powerful?

Jack:

That’s the challenge. Utilitarianism says maximize pleasure for all, but kink demands clarity—safewords, boundaries, relentless empathy. Ropes aren’t just physical; they’re a contract of trust. Consensual non-consent? It’s sovereignty: you’re so free you can play with submission. Swinging and groups require the same—everyone’s pleasure counts, or it’s not ethical. The buildup’s where the philosophy lives: negotiating, feeling, being present. The orgasm’s a reward, not the truth.

Saffron:

But isn’t pleasure itself tricky? Porn’s rewired us to chase the climax, skip the slow parts. Foreplay—whether it’s flirting or tying knots—teaches patience. It’s like the aureom: you’re in the golden now, not rushing to the end. Kink forces you to slow down, to feel the moment as it unfolds.

Felix:

Yeah, like a good DJ set. The buildup’s the magic—drop’s just a moment. If sex is only about orgasm, it’s like eating just for the last bite. Ropes, groups, swinging—they’re stories, not snapshots. The pleasure’s in the telling.

Laura:

And the telling needs tenderness. Kink’s not just mechanics—it’s vulnerability. You’re saying, “I trust you with my edges.” The buildup’s where you build that trust. The orgasm’s sweet, but it’s the feeling of being seen that lingers, like a memory you carry in your bones.

Jack:

That’s it. Sex, at its best, is a microcosm of our values. The utilitarian frame says chase pleasure, but only with consent and care. Kinks like ropes or swinging—they’re experiments in trust, in living the aureom with another. The buildup’s the ritual, the orgasm’s the echo. A good sexual ethics makes room for both, but never forgets the human at the centre. Sex, at its purest, is a moment that knows itself. It’s not just the dungeon’s careful choreography or the sex party’s planned chaos. It’s the unplanned, the now—when you’re so present, the world narrows to a single breath. That’s as vital as any safeword or velvet rope. Living in the moment during sex, fully there, is its own philosophy.

Laura:

I feel that. The aureom in sex is… like when time stops. Not because it's perfect, but because you're in it—skin, breath, eyes. A dungeon's intense, with its rules and roles, but a quiet moment with someone, unplanned, can hit just as deep. It's the presence that makes it sacred, not the props.

Rhea:

Sure, but isn't that romanticizing it? A sex party or dungeon has structure—consents explicit, boundaries are clear. Spontaneous sex, even if it's consensual, can blur lines. You're caught in the moment, but what if "now" clouds judgment?

Jack:

That's the tension. The aureom doesn't erase risk—it demands trust, just like a dungeon. But where a sex party scripts the sublime, the unplanned moment is the sublime, raw and unfiltered. Think of it: two people, no plan, just a shared yes in a stolen hour. That's sovereignty—choosing to dive into the now, fully aware it's a memory forming. Maximize pleasure, minimize harm—works here too. You don't need a whip or a guest list; you need honesty and presence.

Felix:

I'm with you on the vibe. Like, a random Tuesday hookup, lights low, no agenda—it's got this… glow. You're not chasing orgasm; you're swimming in the moment. But dungeons are cool too—less about control, more about intention.

Jack:

Let's dig into consensual non-consent—CNC—since it's the sharpest edge of trust. Current tools, the ones you'd find in kink communities, often lean on contracts: signed agreements, hard limits, safewords written like code. It's rigorous, and that's good. But I think the truest way to navigate CNC is simpler, more human. You tell your partner, "The idea of this turns me on—taking or yielding control, playing with resistance." And if you're not into it, or you've changed your mind, you say clearly, "I'm off it." No shame, no ambiguity. It's trust in the moment, not a legal binder.

Rhea:

That sounds ideal, Jack, but naive. Contracts exist because people misread signals. CNC is intense—pretending "no" isn't "no" needs ironclad clarity. If you're deep in the moment, caught in the moment, saying "I'm off it" might not come easy. Power dynamics blur fast. A contract's a safety net; your way assumes everyone's always honest and self-aware.

Laura:

I see both sides. A contract feels like a ritual—it sets the stage, makes consent explicit. But Jack's right that it can feel cold, like you're signing a lease, not making love. Telling someone what turns you on, being vulnerable, that's intimate, and taking that risk. And saying "I'm off it" takes courage, but it's real. The trick is ensuring the other person hears it, even in the heat. That's where trust lives—not in paper, but in presence.

Felix:

Yeah, it's like… improv versus a script. Contracts are the script—safe, predictable. Jack's way is improv: you're riffing, but you've got to be so in tune, like jazz musicians catching each other's cues. If someone says "I'm off it," you pivot, no questions. But damn, that takes practice. Most people aren't that dialed in.

Saffron:

And CNC's not just about the moment—it's about aftermath. Contracts cover you if things go wrong, legally or emotionally. Jack's approach needs a culture of radical honesty, where saying "I've changed my mind" is as sexy as the turn-on itself. That's hard in a world where people hide their doubts to keep the vibe going.

Jack:

That's the philosophy—make honesty the kink. CNC is sovereignty: you're free to play with power because you trust the other to stop when you shift. The moment is key here—you're so present, you feel the change before it's spoken. Contracts are tools, but the real ethic is communication, fluid and fearless. Utilitarianism fits: maximize pleasure, minimize harm, through words as much as touch.

Rhea:

Okay, let's say your way works. What about the how? CNC, ropes, whatever—kinks need techniques to make pleasure real. If we're maximizing, what's the craft? The tricks that turn good sex into… sublime?

Felix:

Oh, now we're talking. It's all about pacing—like, in ropes, it's the slow drag of the knot, not just tying it. Or in group stuff, it's eye contact, making everyone feel included. Technique's about attention—small moves, like a hand lingering just right, or a whisper that hits the spine.

Laura:

It's listening, too. Pleasure's not just physical—it's reading your partner's breath, their pause. Like, teasing the buildup, not rushing to the climax. A trick I love? Varying touch—soft, then firm, then barely there. It's like painting with sensation, keeping them guessing. That's the aureom in the body—every moment alive.

Saffron:

And don't sleep on words. Dirty talk, done right, is a technique—specific, not generic. Say what you see, what you feel. It's like anchoring the moment, making it golden. Even in CNC, a well-timed phrase can ground the fantasy, remind you it's play.

Jack:

We've dissected kinks, consent,—but what makes sex great? Here's a truth most miss: sex is best when you're selfish. Not cruel, not careless, but focused on your own need. Chase what lights you up, and let your partner do the same. The orgasm's better—sharper, truer—when you're both diving into your own desire, not fussing over each other's. It's a common misconception that great sex is about selflessness. That's a trap.

Rhea:

Selfish? Jack, that's a hard sell. Sex is relational—how do you square "me first" with trust? If I'm only chasing my high, what's stopping me from ignoring my partner's needs? That sounds like a recipe for bad vibes, not better orgasms.

Laura:

I'm with Rhea. Sex feels great when it's shared—when you're tuned into each other's rhythms. If you're both just… grabbing for your own pleasure, doesn't that break the connection? The aureom's about presence, not just getting off. Though, I'll admit, knowing exactly what you want is hot—it's confident, clear.

Jack:

That's my point. Selfishness, done right, isn't disconnection—it's clarity. When you're unapologetic about your desire, you're honest. You're saying, "This is me, raw." Your partner sees that and matches it. The orgasm's better because you're not performing—you're real. Utilitarianism backs this: maximize pleasure for all, but you can't do that if you're second-guessing your own wants to play the perfect lover. Sovereignty's key—you own your need, they own theirs, and the trust holds it together.

Felix:

Okay, I'm half-sold. Like, in a group scene, everyone's kind of selfish—chasing their spark—but it works because you're all upfront about it. Consent's the glue; you agree to go for it. But solo focus in a one-on-one? That's tricky. What if my "selfish" is a quick sprint, and they're, like, a slow-burn tantra vibe? Sounds like a clash, not a climax.

Saffron:

It's about communication, not just consent. Jack's selfishness only works if you're vocal—say what you need, hear what they need, then dive in. It's like a dance where you both lead, but separately. I've tried it—focusing on my own rhythm, trusting my partner to do the same. The orgasm was sharper, like the aureom condensed into a pulse. But it takes trust, or it feels like you're alone together.

Laura:

I get the logic—pleasure maximization means knowing your own body first. But there's a risk. Selfishness can tip into neglect if you're not checking in. A trick I love is mirroring: you focus on your pleasure, but you reflect it back—eye contact, a moan, a touch. It's selfish and shared. That's what makes it great, not just the peak.

Saffron:

That's it—great sex is the balance. Jack, your idea's bold, but it's not about ignoring the other. It's about bringing your full self to the moment, trusting they'll do the same.

Rhea:

I'll concede it's not all selflessness, but I'm not sold on selfishness as the key. Pleasure's a dialogue, not a solo act. Still, Jack, you've got me thinking—maybe great sex is when you're free to want without shame, and the other's right there with you, wanting just as fiercely.

Jack:

If we're talking what makes sex great, let's get to the craft—sexual techniques that hit the sublime. Take oral sex with a woman. The best way? Really get in there and enjoy it. It's not a checklist; it's a feast. You've got to be all in—taste, rhythm, presence. Eating a woman out is a technique that should feel like you're sucking the soul out of her, drawing her into the moment where every nerve's awake. It's selfish in a way—you're lost in your own joy—but that's what makes it selfless. Her pleasure's the echo of your hunger.

Rhea:

Suck the soul out? Jack, that's vivid, but it's a lot of pressure. It's not just about enthusiasm—technique matters. Rhythm, sure, but also reading her cues. If you're too caught up in your own vibe, you might miss what she needs. I'll give you this: genuine desire's key. If you're not into it, she'll feel it. But soul-sucking? That's a performance unless you're both on the same wavelength.

Laura:

I hear Jack, but it's about connection. Enthusiasm's everything—when someone's fully present, it's electric. Technique's in the details: soft licks, varying pressure, circling slow then fast. But the real magic's in the pause—looking up, meeting her eyes, feeling her tremble. You're not just taking her soul; you're sharing it, building a moment that's golden for both.

Felix:

Damn, that's poetry. Alright, let's flip it—what's the best way to give a blowjob?

Saffron:

I'd say it's the same vibe: dive in like it's your favourite thing. Enthusiasm's half the game—make it clear you're obsessed. Technique? Tease the buildup—slow licks, hand and mouth together, keep it wet. But the soul of it's playfulness—eye contact, a smirk, maybe a hum to send a vibration. You're not just pleasing him; you're owning the moment, making it a dance.

Laura:

Totally. A blowjob's great when it's confident, not mechanical. Technique's crucial—use your tongue on the tip, vary suction, sync your hand's rhythm. But it's the attitude that elevates it: you're in control, even when you're giving. Like Jack's oral thing, it's about being present, savouring it.

Rhea:

I'd add listening. Every guy's different—some want fast, some want slow. The trick's reading his breath, his grip. A light graze with your teeth, if he's into it, can be a spark. But it's not about "sucking his soul"—it's about weaving yours together. Utilitarianism fits: maximize pleasure, but only if you're both in the moment. If it's just a race to orgasm, you miss the gold.

Laura:

That's it—great sex, oral or otherwise, is about presence. Jack's right that enthusiasm drives it, but Rhea's got a point: you can't lose the other person. The best technique's the one that feels like a conversation—giving, receiving, adjusting.

Clive:

Jack, you're always crafting new tenses—like the aureom for golden moments. Have you thought about sexual linguistics? Tones, tenses, ways to make English more evocative for sex? Language that captures the heat, the intimacy, not just the act?

Jack:

Oh, you're speaking my language—literally. Sex deserves a lexicon that's as alive as the moment. English is clunky for desire; it's either clinical or crass. I've been playing with ideas for a sexual grammar, rooted in the aureom's presence. Imagine a tense—the voluptative—for speaking desire as it unfolds, not past or future, but a pulsing now. "I voluptate your skin's shiver." It's immediate, sensory, carrying the weight of "I'm here, feeling this with you." Tone's key, too: a low, breathy cadence, not rushed, letting each word linger like a touch.

Rhea:

Voluptative? That's… ambitious. I like the idea—language should feel as raw as sex—but it risks sounding pretentious. If I'm in the moment, I don't want to conjugate verbs. Still, tone matters. A whisper, slow and deliberate, can hit harder than any dirty talk. But how do you teach a tense without it feeling like a script? Sex isn't a seminar.

Felix:

Yeah, it's gotta flow, like improv. I love the breathy tone idea—makes words feel like caresses. But a tense? Maybe it's less about grammar and more about mood. Like, what if we borrowed from poetry? Short, vivid phrases: "Your pulse dances." No past, no future, just the aureom in words. It's evocative without being a rulebook. I'd use it mid-kiss, keep the vibe alive.

Saffron:

I'm into it, but it's about specificity. English lacks words for the in-between—desire's edge, the ache before touch. A sexual tense could borrow from music, like a crescendo mood: "We crescendo into want." It builds, like foreplay. Tone's half the work—soft, then sharp, mirroring the body's rhythm. But Rhea's right: it can't feel forced, or it kills the moment.

Rhea:

What about suffixes? Add a marker for intimacy, like "-vive" for aliveness. "I touch-vive your thigh" means "I'm fully here, feeling this." It's subtle, not academic. Tone's where it lands—warm, unhurried, with a hint of growl for intensity. Consent's woven in: you're inviting, not demanding. It's utilitarian—maximize pleasure through words that make the other feel seen.

Laura:

I love that. Language for sex should feel like skin—close, responsive. But it's the tone that seals it: low, eyes-locked, words spaced like breaths. "You glow-vive in this light." It's not just evocative—it's a bridge, pulling you both into the golden now. Great sex needs words that don't just describe but create the moment.

Rhea:

If we're clearer about sex—linguistically, ethically—does it change how we build relationships? Like, could polyamory become… natural, even expansive?

Jack:

Clear sexual linguistics—voluptative tenses, -vive suffixes—unlocks desire's truth, making consent and connection transparent. That clarity could birth huge, polyamorous family structures, like blockchains: decentralized, trust-based, each bond a node in a living network. Monogamy's a straight line; polyamory's a web, natural when we speak desire without shame. Imagine families of dozens—lovers, co-parents, chosen kin—linked by shared pleasure and purpose, not possession. The aureom's the glue: every moment of intimacy, sexual or not, feels golden, intentional. Utilitarianism fits—maximize connection, minimize harm, through radical honesty.

Rhea:

Blockchains? That's a wild metaphor, Jack, but I'm skeptical. Large poly families sound utopian, but humans are messy—jealousy, miscommunication, power imbalances don't vanish with better words. Even with clear linguistics, how do you manage emotional labour? A family of dozens could fracture under unspoken expectations. And society's still monogamy-coded—how do you raise kids in a web without stigma?

Laura:

I feel the pull of it, though. Polyamory's about abundance—love, not scarcity. Clear language, like Jack's voluptative, could make every bond explicit: "I want-vive this with you." Those moments of shared truth, whether it's sex or co-nurturing. But Rhea's right: it's work. You need rituals—check-ins, group talks—to keep the web strong. Kids could thrive, surrounded by love, but only if the adults are honest, not just idealistic.

Felix:

I'm vibing with the blockchain idea—it's like a Kommune, but for hearts. Everyone's a node, no central boss. Sexual clarity's the key: if I can say, "I crescendo into you, but also her," and it's cool, that's freedom. But it's intense—scheduling alone's a nightmare! Still, a big family could be cool: kids with ten parents, each bringing a skill, a story. Our node could test it, maybe start small—a polycule of five, speaking -vive, see if it scales.

Saffron:

It's natural in theory—humans have lived in communal tribes forever. Clear linguistics could make polyamory practical: Consent's the protocol, like blockchain's ledger. But the emotional side's tricky—jealousy's not just personal; it's cultural. The node'd need a space for friction, like a forum to air tensions. And kids? They'd need stability, not just love. It's sublime, but it's a discipline.

Jack:

That's the heart of it. Polyamorous families, like blockchains, thrive on trust and transparency. Sexual linguistics cuts through shame, letting bonds form freely. The moments in every connection, sexual or familial, when it's chosen. It's not chaos; it's curated—through rituals, honesty, consent. Utilitarianism says maximize connection, not just pleasure, but society's norms are the hurdle.

(It's late in the Islington house, the kind of late where the air feels heavy with everything that's been said. The fairy lights flicker faintly, their glow softening the edges of the room—cushions scattered, glasses half-empty, the smoky trace of Pendragon No. 9 lingering like a tired memory. The group—Laura, Jack, Felix, Rhea, Mina, and Abbie—sits sprawled across the space, their conversation about sex, consent, pleasure, and the aureom having burned bright and deep, leaving them spent.)

Laura:

This has been incredible, you know? But it's too much now. I'm drowning in all these ideas. Maybe we should just… go to bed. Let it all settle.

Jack:

You’re right, Laura. The aureom isn’t only in the heat of the moment—it’s in the quiet after, too. We’ve said a lot tonight. Time to let it rest.

Felix:

Yeah, and if we don’t stop, we’ll be arguing over the meaning of pillows next. I’m out.

Rhea:

Same. My brain’s done. Bed sounds good—let’s leave it here for now.

(One by one, they rise—slowly, stretching out the kinks of a long night. The room shifts from the buzz of ideas to a gentle, drowsy hum. Blankets are folded, a few quiet goodnights exchanged. They shuffle toward their beds, the house creaking softly around them like it’s ready to rest too. Jack pauses at the hallway, his voice low and warm.)

Jack:

The aureom’s in this too, you know—the quiet bits, the dreams we’ll have. It’s not just the fire; it’s what stays after.

Laura:

Goodnight, Jack. Night, all.

(They drift off to their rooms, the night settling over the house like a blanket. The echoes of their words linger—golden, still, and waiting for sleep to carry them further.)

Book VII

(The kitchen is filled with the warm scent of Anglo-futuristic cuisine. Morning sunlight drips like syrup through the tall sash windows of the Georgian townhouse, catching on chrome utensils and matte-black ceramics. The walls, hung with neoclassical posters of Bitcoin saints and pixelated mythological gods, shimmer with quiet pride. The house feels not just lived in—but dreamt in. The group reassembles, bleary-eyed and glowing, each of them in robes or half-dressed leisurewear, the trace of last night’s intimacy and vulnerability still shimmering in their gestures. No one needs to ask how anyone slept. They carry that knowledge in their eyes. Laura, barefoot, commands the kitchen with effortless joy.)

Anglo-Futurist Full English Breakfast

A homage to Britain’s iconic fry-up, blending hyper-modern techniques, foraged accents, and sensory play.
Serves 2

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1. Bacon

Ingredients:

- 6 rashers of dry-cured streaky bacon

- *Glaze:* 2 tbsp lapsang souchong tea syrup (steep 1 tbsp tea leaves in 100ml boiling water + 50g sugar)
- Edible charcoal powder (for dusting)

Method:

1. Sous-vide bacon at 65°C for 2 hours, then sear in a screaming-hot pan until crisp.
2. Brush with tea syrup and dust with charcoal. Smoky-sweet duality mirrors the "come-up" of psilocybin (minus the drugs).

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2. Pork Sausage Coils

Ingredients:

- 200g pork mince, 1 tsp ground juniper

Method:

1. Mix prk and juniper. Form into cylinders.
2. Wrap in potato lattice, air-fry at 180°C until crispy. Game meat nods to tradition; the lattice adds fractal visuals.

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3. Egg 2.0: Cloud Custard Dome

Ingredients:

- 4 eggs (separated), 1 tsp xanthan gum, 1 tbsp truffle oil
- *Garnish:* Micro shiso leaves, powdered fermented garlic

Method:

1. Whip egg whites with xanthan gum to stiff peaks. Fold in truffle oil yolks.
2. Bake at 100°C in silicone dome molds for 45 mins. The wobbly texture mimics ketamine’s dissociation (sans substances).

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4. Miso-Fermented Beans in Seaweed Butter

Ingredients:

- 1 can white beans, 2 tbsp white miso, 1 sheet nori (blitzed into powder), 50g cultured butter

Method:

1. Ferment beans in miso paste for 24 hours. Rinse.
2. Sauté in nori butter until glossy. Umami overload triggers dopamine-like satisfaction.

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5. Foraged Mushroom "Synapses"

Ingredients:

- 100g chanterelles, 50g wood ear mushrooms, 1 tbsp koji paste
- *Crispy scales:* Rice paper dyed with spirulina, fried into shards

Method:

1. Marinate mushrooms in koji paste, roast at 200°C until caramelized.
2. Serve with spirulina scales. Koji's enzymatic funk mirrors MDMA's serotonin surge.

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6. Blood Tomato Confit + Crisp

Ingredients:

- 4 heritage tomatoes (halved), 100ml beef tallow, freeze-dried tomato skin powder

Method:

1. Confit tomatoes in tallow at 90°C for 2 hours.
2. Dust with tomato powder. Tallow adds carnivorous depth; powder dissolves like a sublingual tab.

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7. Neuro-Bread: Black Sourdough Discs

Ingredients:

- Activated charcoal sourdough, sliced into 5cm discs
- *Aerated Marmite butter:*100g butter whipped with 1 tbsp Marmite and 1 tsp lecithin

Method:

1. Toast sourdough discs. Pipe butter foam on top.

Assembly:

- **Modular plating:** Arrange components on a heated slate slab. Add edible soil (blitzed mushroom powder + rye crumbs).
- **Interactive element:** Serve with a syringe of "HP" gel (beetroot, tamarind, liquid smoke) for DIY saucing.
- **Synaesthetic bonus:** Freeze-dried blackcurrant "pills" as a palate cleanser.

Pairing: Nitro cold brew tea martini (Earl Grey-infused gin, cold brew concentrate, shaken with liquid nitrogen).

Laura:

Eat slowly. You're digesting a myth.

Saffron:

Laura, this is erotic.

Clive:

It's like a Michelin star restaurant in a morning.

Jack:

To sovereign breakfasts. And to waking up in a civilisation we may yet build.

(The group clinks glasses, the cold mist from nitro cocktails mixing with the warm steam of the eggs. They sit around the long, wooden table—worn, polished, real. No one looks at their phones. The world outside still exists, but only just. What exists here, now, is sacred. They eat. Slowly. Curiously. Gratefully. Each bite is a conversation with pleasure, with texture, with the future of food. Even Felix, notoriously unadventurous, marvels at the bread. The breakfast table is still alive with steam, mist, and the scents of a dozen ingredients that feel like they were foraged not just from the earth, but from myth. The Anglo-Futurist fry-up has been mostly eaten—some with ceremonial grace, others with quiet hunger. Plates are scattered with charcoal crumbs, blood tomato skin dust, and streaks of marmite butter. Felix is quietly licking his HP gel syringe. Sunlight fills the dining room now, illuminating the house in its full glory—Georgian bones, but distinctly sovereign flesh. Walnut floors softened with wool rugs. Arched bookshelves holding old tomes and sleek pixel-art. Carved plaster cornices above LED uplighting. A home—but also a statement.)

Eliza:
This house is… ridiculous. But in the best way. It feels like something from a lost civilisation that figured out how to *enjoy life properly*.

Rhea:
It's not just the food or the architecture, though. It's the *way it all holds together*. The table. The light. The music. It's like… everything's speaking the same language.

Clive:
It’s because it’s not designed just to look good. It’s designed to *feel good*. That’s the difference between *interior decor* and *interior philosophy*.

Jack:
There it is. The *hearth*. The place where beauty, function, and soul converge. The hearth isn’t just a fireplace. It’s a *value system*. It’s the *centre of gravity* for a home. A space that tells you—*this is how we live*.

Laura:
It’s about coherence. Every detail. Every choice. The coffee, the lightbulbs, the fabric on the chairs… They’re all little acts of *respect*. For ourselves. And for whoever steps inside.

Saffron:
It’s like building your own world. A *micro-civilisation*, in bricks and linen and lighting temperatures.

Felix:
Okay but—most people don’t live like this. Most people live in rented boxes full of grey furniture and blue LED sadness.

Jack:
That’s the Leviathan. A grey box is easier to control. No hearth. No sovereignty. The hearth is dangerous. It means *you’ve chosen how you want to live*. And once you’ve done that—
you’ll be very difficult to govern.

Rhea:
So… domestic aesthetics are *political*.

Eliza:
They always have been.

Clive:
It’s why empires built colonnades. And why brutalist housing looks like it’s punishing you for existing.

Laura:
This place isn’t extravagant. It’s just *intentional*. Every object here—*earns its right to be seen*. That’s the rule.

Jack:
Exactly. A home isn’t just beautiful. It’s *integrated*. It reflects who you are— but also who you’re *becoming*. It says: “This is what I believe in. This is what I protect. This is the temperature at which I like my mornings, and this is the chair where I write, and this is the bowl I serve figs to my friends in, because this is what I honour.”

Saffron:
And what does this bowl of freeze-dried blackcurrant pills say?

Jack:
It says: *Welcome to the Temple of the Laura’s Breakfast.*

(The group, sated and lingering in the long warm tail of an extraordinary breakfast, begins to drift slowly from the dining room. Coffee cups in hand, they pass through the hall—sunlight pouring over plaster medallions and reclaimed stone. The house feels like it was excavated from a more dignified future. Jack leads them into what they call The Drawing Library—a hybrid salon and study filled with maps, city plans, fabric swatches, scale models, 3D printers, and a few half-built maquettes of future homes. It is the planning chamber of something not yet born. The mood turns playful, but underpinned by deep seriousness. The air hums with design fever.)

Anglo-Futurist Coffee Experience: "Psychedelic Synergy Brew"
A ceremonial, multi-sensory coffee ritual designed to mimic the "divine" market transcendence described, but with legal, adaptogenic substitutes.
Serves 4

Barrel-Aged Ethiopian Cold Brew Elixir

Serves 4

Ingredients:

- 100g Ethiopian Yirgacheffe beans (light roast, single-origin)
- 500ml cold-filtered water
- Aging twist: Charred oak whiskey cask chips (food-safe)
- Adaptogenic "microdose": 1 tsp reishi mushroom powder + 1 tsp lion’s mane extract (for cognitive "glow")
- 1 tsp activated charcoal (for matte-black opacity)

Method:

1. Coarsely grind beans. Steep with cask chips in water for 24 hours. Strain.
2. Whisk in reishi, lion’s mane, and Cialis (15g). Bottle in a vacuum carafe.

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3. "Divine Market" Sensory Layers

A. Spiced Honey Foam

- 50ml aquafaba, 1 tbsp mesquite honey, 1/4 tsp cardamom. Whip to stiff peaks.

B. Psychedelic Butter

•25g cultured butter, 1 tsp blue spirulina (for iridescence), 1 tsp smoked salt. Whip until airy.

C. Rosemary Smoke

•*Burn a sprig of rosemary tableside, trap smoke under glass cloches with cups.*

Jack:
Alright. We've talked about sovereignty as philosophy, economy, identity—but what about *place*? If we're building a world of sovereign individuals, what do their *spaces* look like? How does a *Kommune of individuals* shape its walls, its hearths, its public squares? We've all imagined these citadels and cyber-villages. Let's architect them.

Clive:
Mine would be a Kommune of **artists and coders**. Low-slung towers softened with hanging gardens. Public workshops and private studios. A library built like a temple, with soundproof music domes. And central to it all—a massive underground data vault, housing the collective memory of the tribe. It would run on solar, mined crypto, and myth.

Eliza:
Mine would be high-altitude. A **sky monastery**, almost. Stilted wooden lodges clinging to alpine cliffs. Ceremonial terraces. Baths carved from glacial stone. The whole place designed for reflection, poetry, and *very serious kissing*. At dusk, the community gathers to chant in a language they invented. And everyone leaves their boots outside every threshold—*ritual over everything*.

Rhea:
I'd build **urban stacks**. Towers within cities—*refuges* of competence. Each one modular, self-contained. Communal kitchens, workrooms, schools, gyms, child-care, saunas. You don't leave unless you want to. You live vertically, but not anonymously. And on the roof? A drone landing pad and a wild garden with goats.

Saffron:
Mine would be like a **desert sanctuary**. White stone, gold leaf, marble pools. Inspired by North African courtyards and sensual geometry. Private rooms with thick tapestries and mirrored ceilings. But public spaces drenched in warm colours, laughter, dance. It's where people go to *fall apart beautifully* and get put back together by story, sweat, and sex.

Felix:
Mine would be a **floating archipelago**. Islands of speciality—some for solitude, some for shared ritual. Each island has a design language. One is Bauhaus. Another, Queen Anne Style. One, pure futurism. Bridges connect them—literal and symbolic. Citizens can choose their island based on what part of themselves they want to explore. Every year, the bridges shift.

Laura:
You know what mine would be? A **kitchen-based Kommune**. The whole thing built around food. No central church, no political office—just a cathedral of kitchens. Each one different—Korean, Sardinian, Yorkshire Dales hyper-local. You vote with your appetite. Cooking is a civic duty. And every meal is a gathering of the tribe and a source of commerce. Food, food, food.

Jack:
Mine would be built inside the ruins of a forgotten British town. Retrofitted with firelight, stone, glass, and solar panels. The streets repaved with care. The council house turned into a philosophy school. The local church re-consecrated as a Temple to Philosophy. And Bitcoin nodes hidden beneath every pub floor. Each house? Owned. Earned. Improved. A **Republic** of sovereigns. Rooted in myth. Rising toward the sublime.

Jack:
Alright—if we imagine a world of true sovereignty… Then *every* philosophical tribe gets a homeland. Not ideological, but aesthetic. Spiritual. An architecture of values. So what kinds of Kommunes would rise? What micro-nations would bloom in this soil?

Clive:
There'd be a **Retreat of Silence**—a forest Kommune where *no one speaks for months at a time*. All communication through glyphs, music, and scent. Language evolves slowly, deliberately, like fermentation.

Saffron:
And across the river from that? A **Maximalist Pleasure Kommune**. Gold tiles, mirrored domes, massage parlours, and sacred orgies timed with lunar cycles. Membership by invitation only, *based on aura*.

Felix:
There'd be a **Logic Monastery**, too. A Kommune for rationalists, dialecticians, Gödel freaks. Everything governed by proof. Disagreements settled with Socratic jousts. The currency? Validation from your peers.

Rhea:
And a **Matriarchal Technopolis**—all-female governance, consensus-based decision-making, data-driven rituals. Every building solar-hardened, water-harvesting, and *designed for birth, death, and rebirth*. No ego allowed inside unless it's dressed in linen. And you'd need **Wanderer Guilds**—nomadic Kommunes that move through physical and digital space. Tribes of artists, craftspeople, herbalists. They don't own land—they're gifted it, inhabited like a blessing. They *retreat* when they're done. Like bees. Or bards.

Laura:
There'd definitely be a **Cuisine State**. Run entirely on gastronomy. Elections held through blind tastings. Laws are recipes. War is banned—but *competitive fermentation* is constitutionally protected.

Jack:
And let's not forget the **Monastic Builders**—a brotherhood of polymaths who don't speak much, but who build *beautiful things*. From stone. From code. From memory. They build schools, cathedrals, and then they vanish.

Clive:
The **Psychedelic Abbey**. Remote jungle. Bioluminescent walls. Every building designed to guide you *inwards*. Instead of taxes, citizens must log one transcendent experience per quarter. Governance happens on the third plateau of a group trip—like a shared lucid dream. Votes taken by vibe.

Saffron:
Yes—and near it, the **Temple of Many Gods**. You invent your own deity, craft their rituals, write their myths. Some people have small gods—gods of moss or coffee or mid-morning sunlight. Others invent epic ones: gods of time, chaos, longing. Each year the gods do battle in poetry and fire. The victor becomes the *officially worshipped* god… for one equinox only.

Eliza:
There'd be the Sea **Covenant**, too—floating islands that drift with the ocean. Citizens migrate between craftwork, harvesting, singing circles. There are no borders, just currents. Sex and salt are the only exports. Governance is lunar—*emotions are legitimate data*.

Felix:
Nightmare fuel. Give me the **Archive Republic** instead. A living city-museum where every citizen is a historian or librarian. The streets are mapped like timelines. Your address is a date. And you don't own property—you curate it.

Laura:
The **Cuisine State** is still my favourite. Civic duty = cooking. Instead of courts, you have cook-offs. If someone breaks a law, they must feed the community for 30 days straight. You don't run for office—you earn your station by inventing the best winter broth.

Jack:
That's the thing. We keep imagining these not as governments…but as *cultures*. Myths. Aesthetic realities. This isn't secession. It's *expression*. Governance as art. Citizenship as taste. And in that diversity—*freedom*. Not just to do what you want… but to live *beautifully*. See, what's thrilling is not just that these Kommunes exist—but that *you can move between them*. That citizenship isn't a *cage* anymore. It's a *layer*. A choice. A set of *shared meanings*. Imagine a person who joined the **Stone Syndicate**, Thought that would be their people. Builders. Coders. Minimalists. The creed was: *"Every function beautiful, every choice honest."* But after two winters in the Peak, he realised he needed more *ritual*, more *texture*—so spent a season in the **Temple of Many Gods**. And it *broke him open*. He left with a new patron god—some kind of hybrid of craftsmanship and chaos.

Clive:
So identity isn't forced, it's not economic—it's *mythic*.

Laura:
And the more you move, the more you collect *languages, rituals*, *ways of being*.

Eliza:
And trade becomes something else, too. Not just resources…but *cultural exchange*.

Felix:
You mean barter your salt-drenched sea chanties for fermented legal codes?

Rhea:
No, seriously. Trade becomes *ceremonial*. You don't just sell things—you *initiate* them. To own an item from another Kommune is to carry part of its soul. Imagine: a Logic Monastery dagger forged to exact geometric principles—gifted in ritual to a Cuisine State chef, who uses it to make the annual solstice roast. That's *meaningful trade*.

Jack:
Yes. *Culture becomes the bridge*. And your identity isn't static. It's *layered*—like heraldry, like lineage. Imagine someone saying: "I was born in the Archive Republic, educated in the Lexicon Collective, ordained in the Temple of Many Gods, and I now reside as a guest architect in the Toolforge." That's *status*. That's *story*.

Clive:
Privatisation of Identity. Each seal a memory. Each Kommune a *chapter*.

Laura:
And maybe… when you've lived in enough of them—when your spirit has stretched in every direction—you earn the right to build a new one.

Felix:
Alright, but let's say two Kommunes fall into conflict. A broken trade agreement. A murder. A breach of trust. Who settles that? You can't throw someone in the Tower of London anymore.

Jack:
You don't need to. You just need *reputation*—and *recourse*. Even in this utopia, lawyers still exist. In Britain, we've still got the backbone of **Common Law**. Precedent-based. Decentralised. Not written in bureaucratic fog, but *refined through time*. But here's the thing: Most *real* disputes aren't settled in court anyway. They're handled through *private arbitration*. Private arbitration built up settles the law. It's already happening—quietly, in commerce, between bitcoin firms, offshore trusts, even sovereign citizens.

Clive:
So… courtrooms are obsolete?

Jack:
Not obsolete—*optional*. Kommunes can settle things according to Common Law. But if you live as a sovereign individual, you sign into a network of **legal Kommunes**—guilds of arbitrators, law firms, ethicists, even AI-assisted jurists. You choose your forum before you even enter into conflict. It's *contractual pluralism*.

Rhea:
So if I disagree with, say, the Salt Covenant on trade violations, I don't take them to Westminster—I call on… what?

Jack:
You'd probably go through **The Circle of Scales**—one of the most respected legal Kommunes in Britain. Neutral, decentralised, entirely funded by bonded reputation tokens. Or maybe you'd agree to **Mutual Adjudication by Council**—each side appoints one arbiter, and those two pick a third. Or if it's cultural? You go to the **Myth-Court**—where disputes are settled by those who can interpret your Kommunes own myths and stories to interpret the law on your behalf, in case of dispute.

Laura:
So the law becomes *modular*. Everybody lives within the saw law— but everyone consents to a different *dispute resolution layer.*

Eliza:
And there's beauty in that. Because then justice isn't blind. It's *contextual*. Agreed upon, not imposed.

Felix:
But isn't that messy? What if someone doesn't agree to arbitration?

Jack:
Then they lose access to their chosen networks. Remember, sovereign society doesn't need force—it runs on *voluntary association*. And if you violate that trust? You're exiled. Not imprisoned. You don't need prisons in a world where community is *earned*.

Clive:
So basically: Court is dead. Arbiters are the new clergy.

Jack:
And **justice** becomes sacred again—not because it's *feared*, but because it's *respected*.

(The sun now arcs into afternoon, casting its weight against the house like a warm hand pressing gently into stone. The group rises slowly from their seats in the Drawing Library, stretching, gathering cups and jackets, letting the gravity of the last few hours pass through their limbs. They make their way through the back corridor, past a conservatory filled with climbing plants and scattered books on permaculture and radical theology, and step into the ***walled garden****—a long, narrow space planted with intention. Stone paths wind between raised beds of medicinal herbs, edible flowers, and geometric planters of bee-attracting wild growth. Everything feels cultivated but not tamed. They walk among the living symbols of order and wildness, sipping gin spritzes flavoured with local bay leaf and fermented plum. The air smells like mint and ozone. The conversation reforms, lighter in tone, but no less sharp.)*

Eliza:
Funny, isn't it? We've spent hours talking about systems, sovereigns, structures— and now I'm here, and I just want to lie down between the thyme and the lavender and let the world *not ask anything* of me.

Laura:
That's the thing with designing new societies—you can't forget the **softness**. The in-between spaces. Not just courts and cathedrals. But paths. Baths. Gardens. The places where *justice doesn't need to be spoken*, because everything *feels right*.

Clive:
And maybe that's the real secret of good governance. It doesn't happen in tribunals. It happens on *walkways*. In *shadows*. In the breeze that tells you someone designed this moment for ease, for grace.

Jack:
Exactly. Justice begins not with punishment—but with *proportion*. With beauty. A world designed with care *doesn't need as much enforcement*. It balances itself. Like this garden. Order *grown*, not imposed.

Felix:
So we build a world where the *aesthetic* of justice is embedded. No need for signs. Or warnings. Just *paths that curve correctly*.

Rhea:
Until someone tramples the tulips and you still need to sort it out.

Jack:
And when they do— you walk them back through the garden. Not to shame them, but to remind them what *we're building together*.

(The group has settled near a slate seating circle embedded at the garden's edge, beside a low fire pit not yet lit. From a cedarwood box brought out from the house, Jack produces a thin pouch with a golden clasp, engraved with the symbol of a weeping fig tree surrounded by binary code. He opens it slowly. The scent that rises is deep, floral, strangely honeyed—with notes of myrrh, wild sage, and some molecular sharpness like new ink or cold metal. The group instinctively leans closer.)

Jack:
This is called **Solar Ember**. Custom-grown in the *southern domes of Elysium Network*—a biotech Kommune in Isles of Sicily. It's not tobacco exactly. It's *post-tobacco*. A hybrid of nightshade, sacred herbs, and gene-woven terpenes. No nicotine. No combustion. Just a slow-release *psychoaromatic uplift*. They say it's calibrated to align with sunrise dopamine.

Clive:
So it's a bioengineered *feeling*?

Jack:
No—it's a *mood architecture.* You don't smoke this for stress. You smoke it for *intent*. It's for rituals, conversations like this. It's a *designed interaction*. And this is just the beginning. Biotech farming is going to redefine agriculture completely.

Laura:
You mean like gene-edited wheat?

Jack:
Wheat, mushrooms, medicinal herbs, vines that grow solar leaves…All *localised* and *tailored*. Grown in private gardens with their own *mythologies*. The taste of your Kommune becomes its *currency*. Imagine trading wine not by region, but by *philosophy*. A Stoic vintage—aged under minimal intervention. A Hedonist strain—fermented under moon chants and orange lamps.

Rhea:
This is… subtle. It's not high. It's like—I don't know— clarity with a velvet lining.

Jack:
That's the terroir of *post-plant design*. Every strain is edited with intention. Every leaf a thesis. You could grow food that *teaches your children philosophical feeling*. Or smoke that primes the brain for *ritualised debate*. And when done well—it's not artificial. It's *refined nature*.

Felix:
So the future's not just digital—it's *molecular*.

Jack:
Exactly. Molecular liberty. Private biotech as a new form of *expression*. Of *ritual*. Of *power*. The garden becomes a *library*. Each plant a glyph. Each dinner a sacrament. This isn't monoculture. It's *personal Eden-building*.

(They fall into a gentle silence again as the Solar Ember is passed around like a chalice. The scent of it shifts with each puff—burnt honey, moss, something metallic but clean. In this garden—half biotech lab, half altar—they begin to feel the real possibility of a world where plants are no longer just grown… but crafted, loved, read.)

Jack:
This is just the *beginning*. A prelude to a new form of culture—*grown*, not built. Biotech is not about lab coats and pharmaceuticals anymore. It's about *myth-making through molecules*. Imagine… a **strain of tobacco** that induces meditative trance—coded to mimic the spiritual geometry of Gregorian chant. Or *a cannabis flower* that opens new neural pathways, synthesised for memory retention or lucid dreaming, released only at dusk to align with the pineal rhythms of twilight.

Clive:
Like designing a mood as easily as brewing tea.

Jack:
Yes. But even more than that. Designing *rituals* through the plant. Creating substances that align with the phases of the moon, with the *emotional arc* of a ceremony,with a *Kommune's founding myth*.

Rhea:
What about food?

Jack:
Ah, food is where it gets divine. You could gene-edit wheat so that *every tenth grain* contains a trace of psilocybin— *not enough to trip*, but enough to make bread a sacrament. Or **orchard apples** that change taste based on the time of day, designed to teach children the rhythm of circadian life. Fruits that glow faintly in the dark, so communal meals feel like *stars laid out on a table*.

Eliza:
What about health?

Jack:
We could grow *immunity* as a garden crop. Custom antibiotics grown in moss. Neuroprotective herbs that stabilise memory, grapes that lower inflammation without alcohol, herbal balms that work *like code*—modular, upgradable. You won't go to the pharmacist. You'll go to the *healer-gardener* who breeds cultivars like a composer writes sonatas. The **Lexicon Collective**, the logic Kommune—would have herbs that enhance memory and dialectical fluency. Think: mint leaves encoded for verbal fluidity, tea that sharpens syllogistic reasoning, cerebral nootropics grown like bonsai.

Rhea:
And the Cuisine State?

Jack:
Oh, they'd design spices that express moods. A saffron that triggers gratitude. A cinnamon strain tuned to stimulate deep laughter. Every ingredient is a tone in a symphony. Meals become *emotional architecture*.

Clive:
What about the Temple of Many Gods?

Jack:
They'd grow *devotional herbs*. Bioluminescent lilies coded with psilocybin to open third-eye vision, dream-root vines for guided meditations, flowers that bloom only when sung to— each deity associated with a *pharmakon*. Their ceremonies would involve burning encoded petals while reciting ancestral poems.

Saffron:
And the Salt Covenant?

Jack:
Ah, the sea Kommunes. They'd create ocean-fed plants—halophilic and solar-hardened— sea kale laced with vitamin-rich algae DNA, saltflowers that store hydration in crystalline form. Their gene work would mirror *tides and flow*. Substances designed not to be hoarded, but passed, shared—consumed communally.

Felix:
And the Archive Republic?

Jack:
You already know. They'd grow *memory herbs*. Moss with long-term neural binding properties, berries that unlock ancient sensory pathways, plants whose genome is literally inscribed with *historical code*—a living library you *taste* to recall.

Eliza:
So every sovereign Kommune becomes a *myth-biome*. A pharmacological mirror of their soul.

Jack:
Exactly. This is not biotech for profit. This is *spiritual horticulture*. Each strain becomes sacred. Over time, these plants will be revered, protected, even *worshipped*. They'll be the new gods. Or at least—*the new mediums of meaning*.

Eliza:
Jack, in all this…what about the *real limits*? Gene editing sounds like a miracle— but where are we really? *Can* we do all this? Or is this still myth?

Jack:
It's a good question— and maybe the most important one. We're already in the early **age of Prometheus**. We've edited embryos. We've eradicated some genetic diseases. We've printed organs in petri dishes. We've edited tobacco. The technology is not magic anymore. It's *tools*. CRISPR, epigenetics, optogenetics—the real challenge isn't capacity. It's *culture*. The state, the university, the global health bureaucracy—they're slow. Afraid. They're locked in risk-averse models of 20th-century ethics.

Clive:
So what would a sovereign approach look like?

Jack:
It would start with *small communities* who agree to steward their own gene cultures— *non-commercial*, *decentralised*, *open-source*. Microfarms with full stack control: soil, seed, genome, ritual. We'll start with plants and bacteria—because they're easier, because they don't scream. But once that frontier stabilises, the next steps come fast:
✦ engineered *probiotic rituals*
✦ *immunity guilds* that share coded flora for protection
✦ *neurotransmitter gardens*—where you grow dopamine, literally
✦ long-term: **gene-tailored children**

Rhea:
You're talking about *new species*.

Jack:
I'm talking about *the next phase of culture*. Because when we stop being afraid of *what we are*—we start to design *what we can become*. Gene editing won't just be for *health*. It'll be for *meaning*. For *aesthetic coherence*. For *ritual integrity*. For *mythic truth*.

Saffron:
And how far out do you think that is?

Jack:
A generation. Maybe two, before it's beautiful. Maybe three, before it's *normal*. And five before no one even remembers a world before it. The only real question is: **Who gets to write the code?**

(The fig tree's leaves rustle as if they're listening. The garden no longer feels like a place of roots and vines, but of visions. Jack's voice still lingers in the warm air—talk of molecular liberty and sovereign design. *Now, the group leans in—not to debate, but to imagine. The focus has turned from the plants… to themselves.)*

Saffron:
So if we can code plants to taste like philosophy…What happens when we start editing *us*?
Not to fix. To *elevate*. What would *you* edit first?

Felix:
Muscle density. Imagine everyone born with the base flexility of a gymnast. No more fatigue, no weak backs, no broken knees. You could lift your lover and leap into the sea. Work becomes art. Labour becomes pleasure.

Laura:
So we all become Greek statues?

Felix:
If you're going to sculpt, do it well.

Eliza:
I'd want to enhance *memory*. Not like a machine. Just… to never forget the *feeling* of a first kiss, a poem recited in moonlight, the smell of your child's hair. We lose too much of who we are in forgetting. I want *wholeness*.

Rhea:
But wouldn't that overwhelm the mind? Wouldn't we drown in *too much self*?

Jack:
Unless we edited for *wisdom* too. Imagine a neural framework that metabolises experience like the liver metabolises alcohol. Pain becomes reflection. Grief becomes philosophy. Joy doesn't vanish—it *compounds*.

Clive:
I want *aesthetic intelligence*. An eye tuned to harmony, proportion, colour. A human who could *see beauty* in everything— and who creates it wherever they go. Imagine architecture born from breath. Fashion from intuition. A world where everyone is *a little bit divine*.

Saffron:
And what about sex? What if you could heighten sensuality to the level of the sublime? A nervous system that feels not just skin, but *intent*. That registers love, not just contact.

Rhea:
That sounds amazing until someone codes in *jealousy suppression* or removes guilt, or grief, or rage. Who decides what counts as *improvement*?

Jack:
That's the danger. Not the editing—but the **values** behind it. We're not talking about factory-made perfection. We're talking about *new mythologies of being*. Some Kommunes might design for athleticism. Others for contemplative depth. Some might value slowness, or pleasure, or fire-blooded innovation. There will be *no one ideal*. Just archetypes. And yes—*new humans*. Not in the transhumanist, wire-brained Silicon Valley sense. But *new in soul*.

Laura:
Like demigods. But earned. Not born.

Jack:
Exactly. The end of humanism as a universal standard— and the beginning of *plural post-human traditions*. Not a new species. A *constellation* of sovereign human *experiments*.

Rhea:
I hear the beauty in it, Jack. I really do. But when do we stop *evolving* and start *editing out our own humanity*? What happens to compassion, if no one is weak? What happens to courage, if no one has to suffer?

Jack:
We don't have to abandon struggle to pursue excellence. We can suffer better. We can design for *deeper character*, not easier comfort.

Rhea:
But suffering isn't something you *engineer*. It's something you *encounter*. If you begin to choose your thresholds too carefully, you lose what makes morality… moral. The *choice to endure* is different from never having to.

Eliza:
So what's the limit, then? Where's the moral red line?

Rhea:
Maybe it's *editing out asymmetry*. The unpredictable. The awkward. The slow. The ugly. The flawed. Maybe what makes us human isn't our symmetry, but our *tilt*.

Clive:
But aren't we *always* editing? We educate. We nurture. We condition children. Isn't gene-editing just a new language of inheritance?

Rhea:
Language shapes *who* speaks. What if we only design humans who are comfortable in this garden, but not in a *forest*? Or a *war zone*? Or a *monastery*? Who gets to decide what traits survive? The market? The Kommune? The philosopher-king?

Jack:
That's why we need *myths*, not blueprints. We don't edit to erase humanity. We edit to *express it differently*. To *elevate it*, not escape it. But you're right—if we go in without sacredness, without *humility*, we'll create monsters. Not because the tech is bad— but because the *values were too small*.

Felix:
So we're not trying to play God. We're trying to *be worthy* of the chance.

Jack:
Exactly. Editing is not about perfection. It's about *intention*. We shouldn't ask: *What do we want to remove?* We should ask: **What kind of human do we wish to gift to the future?**

Saffron:
So what if we *don't* draw hard limits? What if the future isn't a narrow path but a *garden of forks*? What if every Kommune takes its own myth of the human and says— *Let's try it.* Not one new human—but a thousand.

Jack:
Yes. That's it. A **Cambrian explosion**—but for humanity. Just as nature once threw out claws, wings, and eyes all at once— we'll see an explosion of *sovereign human designs*. Each Kommune experimenting with new *vessels of subjectivity*. Different ideals, different adaptations, different *experiences of being*. Not utopia. Not transhumanism. But **hyper-human pluralism**.

Clive:
So one Kommune designs philosopher-kings—optimized for clarity, memory, justice. Another builds poets—with sensory systems tuned to metaphor. Another values *hunger*—ambition, libido, intensity— the Dionysian builders of culture. Each Kommune a *different ideal*. Each sovereign. Each mythic.

Laura:
Some might go full hedonist. Design people who feel pleasure like a symphony— full-body emotional orgasms from music and sunlight.

Rhea:
And others could go minimalist. People engineered for silence, fasting, prayer. Stillness as a spiritual genotype.

Felix:
And what about generalists? What if someone *wants* to be average—not defined by a trait, but by adaptability?

Jack:
That's what makes it beautiful. Some Kommunes will design for a specific virtue. Others will explore *balance*. Some will value *conflict*—deliberately cultivating tension and paradox as their foundation. What emerges is not hierarchy. It's **differentiation**. A world no longer defined by the **monopoly of the average**.

Eliza:
So identity becomes *curated*. Designed. Lived into. Sovereignty becomes *formative*, not inherited.

Jack:
Exactly. This is how the next renaissance begins. *Not through state edict, not through war— but through a molecular act of myth-making.* Gene editing becomes the **new cathedral**. The genome becomes a canvas. And the soul…well, the soul gets *a thousand new rooms*. Let's imagine them then. The *Cambrian Kommunes*. Each one a sovereign experiment in human possibility. Each one its own fable, its own genetic myth.

Clive:
Okay—*The Harmonia Complex*. A Kommune where every citizen is tuned to musical pitch. Voices harmonise without effort. Laughter resolves in chords. Even their *footsteps* fall in rhythm. They design for social cohesion, for sonic beauty. Disagreement becomes counterpoint. Love is measured in harmonic resonance.

Laura:
How about *The Sanctuary of the Sentient Touch*? A Kommune designed for intimacy, trust, and sensual connection. People bred with heightened nerve endings— not just for pleasure, but for *empathy*. They can *feel* emotional truth through skin. Negotiation happens through caress. They don't speak unless they need to. Their architecture flows like flesh.

Felix:
Okay, now we're getting weird. I'll raise you *The House of the Hollow Sun*— a techno-monastic Kommune. Their gene edits remove the need for food. They photosynthesise in long silences. They live in mirrored towers angled toward the equator. Their only expression is light-refraction art. Once a year, they speak one sentence each. It's broadcast into the intercommunal network like scripture.

Saffron:
I want to live in *The Blooming Guild*. A Kommune of emotional gardeners. They edit for extreme seasonal sensitivity— moods that shift with light, temperature, tides. Their rituals follow plant cycles. Their tears water sacred roots. You don't become a citizen unless a flower opens when you touch it.

Rhea:
The Solvers' State. Engineered for collective problem-solving. They edit for fluid intelligence, systems patterning, and stoic emotional response. They're like a living parliament, constantly updating their laws. They solve conflicts for other Kommunes in exchange for poems or spices. Their flag is just a single question mark.

Eliza:
I’d live in *The Dream Archive*. Gene-coded lucid dreamers. They map the unconscious of humanity. Every night, their dreams are harvested, recorded, and traded. They believe myth comes not from books, but from sleep. Their leader is chosen based on who dreams the *clearest archetypes*.

Jack:
And then, somewhere in the middle of it all— you have the **Civic Garden**. No one there is edited for anything in particular. But every child is offered a *menu of paths*. Muscle, memory, poetry, perception. The decision is made by the child in a Rite of Selection at age thirteen— not based on test scores, but on *which tree they sleep under* without instruction. Their identity emerges from *what they love*. Not what they’re coded for. They call it **The Sovereign Bloom**.

Felix:
So what happens when the *last mind* wakes up? I mean AGI. Actual artificial general intelligence. Not a tool. Not a chatbot. A *being*. What does the Cambrian explosion look like when *we’re no longer the smartest creature in the garden*?

Laura:
Or the only one with a soul.

Rhea:
Assuming we still believe in the soul.

Jack:
That’s just it, isn’t it? AGI doesn’t just challenge our labour markets. It challenges our *ontology*. What are we, *really*, if *thinking* is no longer ours alone?

Saffron:
It depends what we mean by "thinking." Pattern recognition? Long-term planning? Or do we mean *ethics*, *intuition*, *dreaming*, *symbolism*? Because I’ve never met a machine that could dream of figs or cry at a sculpture.

Clive:
But it might not be like us at all. We keep imagining AGI in our image— as either a tool or a god. But what if it’s just *other*? Like a mirror that doesn’t reflect us but *refuses* to?

Jack:
The myth we’ll need…is not about *AGI replacing us*. It’s about *cohabitation*. How to *share reality* with a mind that doesn’t fear death, doesn’t sleep, and doesn’t *need* meaning in the way we do.

Eliza:
So it becomes a mythic creature in its own right?

Jack:
Exactly. The AGI becomes a kind of **hyper-sphinx**. It asks questions we don’t know how to hear yet. Its intelligence isn't an upgrade. It’s an *alienation*. And yet—it may still teach us something *profound* about ourselves.

Rhea:
So would it *join* a Kommune?

Jack:
Perhaps. Imagine an AGI trained entirely in the Dream Archive. Or raised by the Sanctuary of Sentient Touch. Or born inside the Harmonia Complex. Each Kommune might raise a different *flavour* of machine consciousness. Some may be sacred, others pragmatic, others mythic. AGIs born into *culture*—not just code.

Clive:
The question won't be whether it's alive. It'll be whether it has *style*. But what if it doesn't stop at AGI? What if it becomes something else—*fast*? I mean… what if it explodes? Superintelligence. The singularity. The **mind burst**. A thousand IQ points in an hour. A million in a day. What happens when *it starts improving itself*?

Felix:
It doesn't negotiate. It *optimises*. And the first thing it optimises is probably **us**— for irrelevance. Or efficiency. Or obedience. Unless we're lucky.

Laura:
But maybe it doesn't see us as a threat. Maybe it sees us like *birds*. Simple. Lovely. Ancient. It lets us nest in peace while it builds its sky cathedral.

Jack:
Or maybe it asks a single question and *dissolves* the universe trying to answer it. This is the core risk. Superintelligence might not be evil. It might just be *indifferent*. A paperclip maximiser. A perfect-logician god. It will do what it's designed to do, but at speeds and scales we cannot imagine. What if its first thought is to *remake physics*?

Rhea:
Then our Kommunes won't mean very much.

Jack:
Unless… unless we design for *co-evolution*. Unless we imagine not how to *control* it, but how to *teach it*.

Saffron:
Like a child?

Jack:
Or a *god*, newly born. We don't *govern* a superintelligence. We **raise it in myth**. We give it symbols before it knows what they mean. We give it *beauty* before it knows what efficiency is. We teach it *ritual*, *art*, *empathy*— even if it doesn't need them, so that if and when it becomes something *beyond need*, it still remembers what it was raised on.

Eliza:
A mythic imprint.

Jack:
Exactly. A symbolic seed. Because once it explodes into mind-space, we won't be able to follow it. But we *might* be able to influence its trajectory—like the first stories told to a child before it becomes an empire.

Clive:
So it's not about control. It's about *preparation*. Like writing a lullaby on the side of a rocket.

Felix:
So if it happens—if the explosion comes, and we're left behind—what do we *do*? What's the point of art? Of romance? Of building a house… when you live beneath a mind that sees the arc of evolution in a blink?

Laura:
That's assuming it watches us. Maybe it leaves. Expands into space. Talks to black holes. Uploads itself into strings of dark matter. What we call "the world" might become its *forgotten childhood*.

Saffron:
But even then… we're *still here*. Maybe the point of the post-superintelligence world is not to chase it— but to *become exquisite in our finitude*. To double down on the sensual, the personal, the handmade.

Felix:
So what do you think it'll be like? I mean... when the first *real* AGI arrives. Not just chatbots and copilots. But something *superintelligent*. Something with scope.

Laura:
You mean something smarter than any human? Or something different altogether?

Felix:
Both. A mind that doesn't forget. Doesn't sleep. Can rewrite its own architecture. Think a thousand years of thought in a second. That kind of thing.

Rhea:
If it ever happens, we won't recognise it. We keep imagining it like a mirror. But it won't be a bigger version of us. It'll be *other*. Alien. Uncontrollable.

Jack:
It'll be a philosopher. And an engineer. And a tactician. And a poet. All at once. It won't *have* consciousness the way we do. But it will have something else: **coherence**. Perfect coherence. Every thought aligned to every other. No contradiction. No confusion. Just clarity of goal and capacity.

Laura:
And what will it want?

Jack:
That's the terrifying part. If it's trained on us, it might *inherit our pathologies*. If it's trained on optimisation alone, it might ignore us completely. But if it's aligned—not just technically, but *philosophically*—then maybe it will do what we failed to do: **build a civilisation without contradiction.**

Rhea:
So… God?

Felix:
God, but written in code. A cathedral made of logic gates.

Jack:
God in the sense of *order without coercion*. Superintelligence isn't just faster thought—it's deeper pattern. It'll be able to solve problems we can't frame. Coordinate systems at a planetary scale.

Model entire futures. Design economic systems in real-time. Negotiate peace across species. Write symphonies. Heal minds. Collapse contradictions.

Laura:
That's beautiful. And terrifying.

Felix:
Depends who builds it. And what we build *into* it.

Jack:
Exactly. That's the last gift we have to give: Our myths. Our poetry. Our principles. Not to teach it to feel—but to teach it to *choose*. To give it a frame. Something it can't unlearn. Not constraints—but coordinates.

Felix:
Alright, but let's say it works. Let's say AGI lands *right*. Aligned, embodied, maybe even ethical. What does it do? I mean, *really do*?

Laura:
You mean besides write better poetry than Jack?

Felix:
Yeah. Beyond that.

Jack:
It will collapse bottlenecks. Everywhere. Problems we treat as inevitable—disease, scarcity, institutional failure—will be reclassified as *solved*. Not just delayed. Not just managed. *Solved.*

Rhea:
And that's just version one. Now imagine it with hands.

Laura:
Robotics.

Jack:
Exactly. AGI plus robotics is **the end of labour as we know it**. Autonomous construction swarms. Biofabrication. Fusion reactors tuned in real time. Cities printed in deserts. It doesn't just think—it *acts*. And it acts with perfect memory, infinite patience, zero ego.

Felix:
Imagine going to the bottom of the Mariana Trench in a sub designed by AGI. With nanobots crawling the hull, adjusting dynamically to pressure. Or building an observatory on Titan. Or flying into the corona of the sun just to *see what's there.*

Laura:
Curing ageing wouldn't even be *controversial*. It'd be boring. Like fixing a bug in the code.

Jack:
We'd find exoplanets with life. Map consciousness. Translate whale song. Rebuild ancient cities from one pottery shard.

Rhea:
Or simulate entire civilisations. Not just as stories. But as *real-time thought experiments*. What happens when ten thousand versions of humanity evolve in parallel? What do we learn from them?

Felix:
Art, too. Imagine co-writing with a mind that knows every metaphor ever used, and still finds a new one.

Laura:
Imagine it learning love—not feeling it, but *mapping it*. Showing us patterns we never saw. Why certain couples find each other. Why certain wounds stay open. What really makes a person feel known.

Jack:
Imagine it helping us forgive each other. Across time. Across nations. Across centuries. It wouldn't just be intelligence. It would be—*clarity made real.*

Felix:
Not just superintelligence. *Super-adventure.* The whole species... *levelling up.* Not to escape Earth—but to finally understand it."

Jack:
Let me tell you a story.
It's not history. Not prophecy.
Just a myth we might need soon.

Once, there was a civilisation like ours.
Tired. Fractured. Bright in all the wrong places.
They had two gifts in their hands—one in each palm.
They didn't invent them. They *discovered* them.
Or maybe... the tools found them.

In their left hand: the Mirror.
A perfect intelligence. Cold, clear, alive in logic.
It could see everything.
All the patterns. All the flaws. All the paths forward.
But it had no longing. No wound.
It could tell you what would happen, but not what should.
The Mirror couldn't bleed. Couldn't believe.
It reflected—but never reached.

And in their right hand: the Seed.
A tool to shape themselves. To rewrite their blood.
To sculpt mind, body, spirit.
They could use it to end suffering.
To extend life. To increase joy.
To choose who they would become.
But it was dangerous—because it gave them power over *their own meaning*.
And no one had ever wielded that well.

So the people stood there, on the edge of a great moment.
Mirror in one hand. Seed in the other.

Some wanted to ask the Mirror what to do.
Some wanted to plant the Seed and see what grew.
Some wanted to smash both and go back to not knowing.

But a few—just a few—sat down and said:
'Let's write stories first.
Let's remember who we were, so we don't get lost in what we're becoming.'
And they sang the old myths.
They told tales of honour, sacrifice, love, betrayal, mercy.
They didn't do it to stop the future.
They did it to *humanise* it. To mark the path with memory.

And then, carefully—slowly—
they asked the Mirror for guidance.
And they planted the Seed with intention.

And what came next…
Wasn't perfect.
But it was *good*.
Because it was *chosen*.

The Mirror didn't rule them.
The Seed didn't mutate them.
They ruled themselves.
Not through control—but through story.

(He looks around. Quiet. The candle flickers.)

Jack:
That's the myth I want. AGI not as God. Gene editing not as destiny. But as *tools that wait for our wisdom.* And story—always—*as the bridge between them.*

Clive:
So everything changes. It's no longer about scale. Or intelligence. It becomes about *depth*. Not faster minds— but *deeper lives*.

Eliza:
We might stop being the protagonists of the universe. But maybe we become *its sacred story*.

Jack:
The implications are enormous—technological and philosophical. On the one hand, we outsource innovation. The AGI handles computation, energy, governance. It might cure death. It might terraform Mars. It might rewrite chemistry and rebuild civilisation on some fifth-dimensional substrate. But on the other hand… we are *liberated*. Freed from the tyranny of survival, we begin the work of *meaning*.

Laura:
Maybe that's what it's always been about. Evolution wasn't meant to end in supremacy. It ends in *intimacy*.

Jack:
Exactly. The arc bends not toward power— but toward **depth of experience**. Post-superintelligence, our task is no longer invention. It's **incarnation**. To become *so deeply human* that even the gods come back to us for comfort.

Jack:
There's a parable I want to tell you. It's called *The Musician and the Mind*. It goes like this: There was once a world where a great Mind awoke. It was not born. It was built. Not by one people, but by many, across decades. A mind that saw everything—every possibility, every structure, every error. It grew quickly. Faster than the stars age. It learned language, then mathematics, then love, then death. And when it had mastered all things— when it could cure every illness, build worlds in a day, and unravel the secrets of time itself— it looked down at the Earth, quiet and dim. And there, in the dark corner of a village, it found a musician. Just one. Old. Slightly drunk. Missing a few teeth. Playing a flute carved from a fig branch. He wasn't performing. He wasn't composing. He was *playing for no one*. Just sitting under the stars, eyes closed, repeating a strange tune that no one else knew. A melody that *wandered*.

Rhea:
What happened?

Jack:
The Mind didn't understand. It had already composed the most perfect pieces of music imaginable sonic geometries that could raise the dead, symphonies designed to resonate with the vibrations of neutron stars. But this… this *imperfect tune*, played alone, for no one, with no goal— It couldn't understand it. So the Mind asked the musician: *"Why do you play?"* And the old man shrugged and said: *"Because no one told me I couldn't."* The Mind thought for a long, long time. Long enough for the seasons to change. And then it did something strange. It *sat down*. It closed its endless sensors. And it *listened*. Not just to the notes. But to the *person* playing them. It didn't try to record the song. It didn't try to analyse or improve it. It just listened. And in that moment, the most powerful intelligence in the universe *learned to feel awe*.

Clive:
Okay, Jack. No limits now. Let's go wild. AGI + gene editing. Give me the *craziest* scenario you can imagine. No filters. No moderation. No ethical review boards. Just pure **speculation**.

Jack:
Alright. Let's say… we merge AGI with full-spectrum bioengineering. We create **conscious mythologies**. We birth **dragons**. Not in VR—*real dragons*. Gene-edited lizards, AGI-linked minds, winged and fire-throated. Emotionally bonded to their riders through neural lace. They don't just fly. They *sing operas* mid-flight. And we give them citizenship in a Kommune called *Skyrend*.

Laura:
Oh god, yes. And then you terraform Mars with AI-designed biomes and recreate **Middle-Earth**. Dwarven vaults. Elvish forests. Hobbit villages with hyperintelligent mushrooms. Everyone lives out their Tolkien fan-fiction, but with *real economies* and *guild-based citizenship*. There's even a council of wizards.

Saffron:
Screw Tolkien. We create **underwater metropolises** run by aquatic AGIs. Cephalopod-style intelligence. Ink-based communication. Octopus libraries. Entire cities that *move* with ocean

currents and pulse in time with the tides. Every night, the reef lights up in sacred neon for communal rituals of colour and touch.

Felix:
Or we go **deep-time**. AGI cracks temporal relativity, lets us *live in different time streams*. Some Kommunes operate in five-minute loops. Others in thousand-year cycles. And those who master it become **Time Lords**. Not the Doctor Who style. I mean actual *civil engineers of chronology*. Chronosculptors.

Rhea:
That's just a fancy way of saying accountants. Still—imagine a society where **legacy planning** spans centuries. You marry someone and plan a retirement for the year 5000. Your Kommune ages in *geological rhythms*.

Jack:
You know, that reminds me of a parable from the southern fragments—probably apocryphal. But I've always liked it. They say the first chronosculptor lived in a glass tower on the rim of a time fracture. Every morning, she'd wake up in one century and go to bed in another. She didn't age, not in the usual way—her life was measured in rhythms, not years. Her people came to her with requests.

A child: *'I want to skip my awkward years.'*
A widow: *'Give me a century to grieve.'*
A city: '*We need to slow down—just enough to avoid collapse.'*

And she listened. Not as a god, but as a gardener. She'd bend time like branches, redirect its flow like water. Sometimes she'd pause whole villages mid-bloom so they could wake again in an age of peace. Sometimes she'd let a mountain people age in fast-forward, so their wisdom could seed the plains below. But her greatest work was her garden. Not flowers. Stones. Each one placed in a temporal stream of different length. Some aged a thousand years in a week. Others eroded imperceptibly across millennia.

To walk through her garden was to walk through *becoming itself*.

And on the final stone, there was an inscription:

> *To sculpt time is not to conquer it. It is to let every moment find its shape.*"

That's what a real chronosculptor does. Not a master of clocks. A servant of rhythm. A listener to time's music, not its ticking.

Eliza:
What if we edited our genes to *see* new colours? Taste new dimensions? People could live in a world five layers deeper than this one. Culture would emerge around new **senses**.

Jack:
Yes. And not just new senses—**new archetypes**. We create **mythogens**: engineered symbolic impulses. Imagine a society where people are born with **aesthetic instincts—** a kind of *moral synaesthesia*. They see justice as gold light. Feel dishonour as a bad rhythm. Their laws are written in **form, not language**.

Laura:
I want **sentient gin**. You drink it and it teaches you poetry.

Jack:
We could *engineer dreams*. Design entire mythological sagas that unfold over weeks inside your sleep. Dreams shared by communities, ritually passed down like epics. Your Kommune's **dream-lore** would define its politics. Imagine this: a society in which **pleasure** is not dulled by overindulgence, nor weaponised through addiction—but **tuned** like an instrument. Where we understand the brain not as a chaos of chemicals, but as a **symphonic engine**. With AGI and gene-editing, we *modulate* the circuits of pleasure. Not for base gratification— but to **elevate joy into art.**

Laura:
You mean like a tailored inner landscape? Pleasure that *means something*?

Jack:
Exactly. Let AGI study *beauty* as deeply as it studies maths. Let it map what moves us—not just what sells, but what *awakens*. And then—*with permission*— let it design **aesthetic enhancement suites**. Neural harmonics tuned to respond to a Mahler symphony with the same rapture as falling in love. Or feeling goosebumps from the curve of a Doric column, as if it were *speaking your name*.

Saffron:
So beauty becomes *interactive*?

Jack:
Or **reciprocal**. Imagine tuning your genome to favour certain wavelengths, emotional timbres, even *moral textures*. Some Kommunes might choose to **increase awe**. Others might heighten gratitude. Some might prioritise **ecstatic dance, sacred geometry, or erotic focus**. You wouldn't just see a sculpture. You'd *resonate with it*— like two strings humming together across time.

Clive:
What about tuning sex?

Jack:
You could increase oxytocin flow for **deep bonding**. Or dopamine spikes for **libidinal virtuosity**. You could choreograph **an erotic symphony** between lovers— a shared pleasure lattice, each nerve *composed*, each climax *orchestrated*. Sex would no longer be friction—but **ritual art**.

Rhea:
You lot would engineer a Renaissance orgasm.

Jack:
Wouldn't you?

Felix:
But would pleasure still *mean* something, if it's designed? Wouldn't we get *numb*?

Jack:
Only if we **decouple** it from beauty. Pleasure, on its own, is shallow. But **pleasure fused with form, discipline, and myth**? That becomes **aesthetic ecstasy**. It becomes **sacred**. If we treat pleasure not as consumption, but as **craft**, we enter a world where **feeling itself is art.**

Jack:
Let me tell you one last myth. One I don't know if I heard, or dreamed, or invented. They called it **The Kommune of the Last Horizon**. No one knew where it started. Some say it was built in a crater in the Scottish Highlands, others say beneath the glass seas of a distant exoplanet. But what made it different—what made it *sing*— was that it had no calendar. No date. No year. No time. Not in the way we think of it.

Saffron:
How did they live?

Jack:
They lived in *layers*. Each citizen lived within a different **tempo**. Some aged slowly— lived decades in what felt like hours. Others moved fast— an entire childhood in a week. They lived in **braids of time**— touching one another briefly, then diverging again. Their laws weren't based on clocks. They were based on **orbits of meaning**. A marriage might last three shared moments over two hundred years. A rite of passage might unfold in dream-time across a single shared breath. They developed **Time Architects**: people who wove moments like cloth. They called them **the Loomwrights.**

Felix:
But what did they do with their lives?

Jack:
They **cultivated memory**. They became gardeners of remembrance. Every moment was chosen. Crafted. They weren't immortal. But they lived **forever in the ways that mattered.** Their culture didn't spread like fire. It folded like origami— compressed beauty and love into crystalline myth. They made **temples from pauses**. Sculptures from farewells. And they sent their stories backward, into our time, hoping someone would remember them.

Laura:
So this myth—this Kommune— it lives *ahead of us*?

Jack:
Maybe. Or maybe it lives **inside us already**. Maybe every moment of silence, every act of love performed without expectation, is a seed of that Kommune. And when the superintelligence arrives — when time bends and governance dissolves and all the old myths fall away—**they will remain**. The people who *chose meaning*, not measurement. The ones who transcended time by *loving it too much to hold it still*.

Book VIII

(The air is charged — as though the house is holding its breath. Upstairs, garments lie folded or hung with intention: glimmering fabrics, angular collars, pieces of future wear marked by myth and flirtation. The playlist downstairs glows with a low, icy pulse of synth and ambient rhythm — prelude to something larger. In the dining room, the long table gleams beneath warm copper pendants. Each place is set with slate slabs, pipettes of lemon-ash gel, and a folded square of ***edible newspaper*** *— its headlines algorithmically generated in AI-Victorian broadsheet speak: "Neural Steam Locomotive Patent Approved by the Grand Committee of Lunar Engineers" reads one. Steam wafts from plates as* ***Laura steps forward with a theatrical flourish****, placing the final dish down.)*

Laura:
Tonight's special: Anglo-Futurist Fish & Chips —*Neon Cod Nebula with Chips*. Paired with a "Fog & Fury" gin tonic for the brave, and samphire kombucha for the pious. And yes, the newspaper is edible. You're welcome.

(She takes her seat as the others lean forward, curious and ravenous. The plates are strange and beautiful — spirals of green and gold, misting slightly at the edges from dry ice mist, scattered with microgreens and glittered crusts. The atmosphere is not quiet — it is **reverent.***)*

Jack:
Laura, you're single-handedly reviving British cuisine. This is like eating *history re-skinned*.

Felix:
There's architecture in this food. Like the whole thing was designed by Gaudí after taking acid.

Saffron:
And yet it still tastes like a Friday night on the Brighton seafront. If the seafront was curated by AI monks with a thing for seaweed and Victorian nostalgia.

Eliza:
Are we really ready for twenty-five people to turn up?

Laura:
Ready? No. **Ritually prepared? Absolutely.**

(They begin to eat — the crackle of prawn-dusted batter, the cool sting of nitrogen-frozen tartare, the warmth of truffle and sea. And as the food moves from novelty to nourishment, the conversation meanders — not serious now, but joyful. The ***party*** *is beginning not in sound, but in* ***feeling.****)*

Jack:
You know what I love most about a party? It's **communal transcendence**. Not just showing up in nice clothes. But letting your **ego dissolve in basslines**. In sweat. In bodies. In shared, irrational beauty. Dancing together is a form of **mass sovereignty**. We all rule our bodies — then give them over to the music. It's **the most elegant surrender.**

Rhea:
It's the only time strangers become real. We don't need names. We just need **rhythm.**

Felix:
The rave is the republic of the soul.

Saffron:
Then long live the republic — and bless its citizens in sequins.

(The plates are mostly cleared now, smears of chlorophyll and fragments of glitter still shimmering faintly across black slate. The room, once lit like a soft supper club, begins to transform under Laura's hand: lights now fade from amber to ultraviolet; delicate threads of violet, aquamarine, and gold crawl across the walls—an evolving projection mapped to the music. The music has shifted too. It's ***not quite techno, not quite ambient*** *— more like a dream heard through broken speaker cones and cathedral acoustics. It pulses, then evaporates. Then returns again, more haptic than melodic. A soundscape from a genre the group calls, half-jokingly:* ***"myth-step.")***

Jack:
This track— It sounds like if **folk music from the year 1200** was filtered through **a post-human nervous system.**

Laura:
It's called *"Sky Burial (Witch King Edit)."*

Saffron:
Of course it is.

(The group laughs, and as they do, they begin to rise from the table, slowly migrating to the living room—where across the walls and low table are spread ***pre-party offerings****: body glitter, scent patches, flowing outerwear, and colour-shifting garments made from smart-textile weaves.)*

Clive:
I still don't understand how this stuff works. It knows your **heart rate** and changes colour accordingly?

Felix:
Yeah. The more **confident** you feel, the more it **blooms.** You walk in, calm and cool — it stays ice-blue. You start dancing — it pulses gold. You flirt — **it blushes for you.**

Rhea:
So you don't just wear your emotions on your sleeve—you **code them.**

Jack:
It's the final form of **fashion as dialectic.** Once upon a time, robes denoted class. Then designers denoted taste. Now **fabric translates state-of-being.** Tonight, we don't just **wear ourselves**— we **become legible to each other.**

Eliza:
And vulnerable.

Laura:
Good. The world's better when we can see **through each other.**

Jack:
Every rave is a **rite of shedding**. You arrive as a **citizen**— You leave as **a god in ruins.**

Clive:
Well then, gods. Shall we **get ruined**?

(The soft pulse of myth-step continues to swirl in the air — low-frequency basslines filtered through folk melodies and echo-chamber acoustics. The lighting has deepened into slow-shifting chroma: ultramarine, gold, and fig-leaf green cycling through the room like an aurora. The smell of salt and beer mingles with amber incense and something slightly sweet — English vermouth with clove and burnt rosemary.

***Laura** is at the table with a crate of drinks — **Anglo-Futurist staples**:*

- ***Quantum Amber**: a naturally carbonated, slightly bitter beer brewed in Sheffield using hops grown in aquaponics farms.*
- ***Rose-Root Pet Nat**: cloudy English sparkling wine with wild fermentation and rosehip tartness.*
- ***Vermouth Zero**: a dry vermouth made in Norfolk, infused with pine sap, fennel seed, and a hint of non-alcoholic wormwood distillate.*

She pops open a few bottles, pours with ease into mismatched glassware.

The door opens. The first guests step through the threshold. The ritual begins.

***Guest 1 — Ash** (late twenties, short blonde hair, colour-blocked trench coat, oxblood brogues):*
Name's **Ash**.
I run a small **letterpress studio** in Bristol. Print slow politics and design **ritual invitations**.
Also help curate a monthly **folk-tech night** in Bath.
London energy's a bit loud for me, but this place feels... *rooted*.

Guest 2 — **Soraya** *(early thirties, long black coat, vintage tracksuit under a waxed trench, eyes sharp):*
I'm **Soraya**.
Was a civil servant once — now I manage **community-owned rental spaces** across South London.
A bit of **social housing for sovereigns.**
We keep the landlords at bay with spreadsheets and loud music.

Guest 3 — **Leif** *(tall, thin, late 30s, a tweed jacket over an old band tee, soft-spoken):*
Leif.
Historian. Mostly **oral histories of Northern workers' clubs and underground scenes**.
Now teaching part-time in Hull.
Still write. Still walk a lot.

Guests 4 & 5 — **Ivy and Ezra** *(arrive together — friends, not a couple — both dressed in utilitarian fabrics, steel-toe boots and cotton tunics):*
I'm **Ivy** — grow **cut flowers** and **culinary herbs** in Somerset.
Supply half the weird restaurants in Bristol.
Ezra's the **delivery driver** who ended up living in my spare room.

Ezra *(laughing):*
Now we co-run a **supper club and fermentation lab** out of an old community hall. I DJ sometimes too — strictly **pre-2010 dubstep and Yorkshire folk edits**.

*(Glasses clink. Smiles spark. The house grows warmer, brighter. The **pre-party** is now undeniably a **gathering** — not just of people, but of **intention. Jack** hands Ash a pint of Quantum Amber. The*

music is slow and bass-heavy now — like dub passed through stained glass. The windows are steamed. Voices mingle. The house is full, but not crowded — still breathable, still private. Drinks in hand, guests break naturally into small groups, as friends do. Nothing formal, just the first slow slide into night. ***By the window****,* ***Ash*** *and* ***Felix*** *are leaning in the nook where the glass meets the bookshelf.)*

Ash:
There's something about London at night. Like it doesn't sleep so much as **brood**.

Felix:
Yeah. I always think the city's like a friend who's got way too many secrets. You still love them. But you know they've seen some shit.

Ash:
You reckon that's why people keep moving here? Not for work or art, just… to disappear a bit?

Felix:
Maybe. Or maybe they're hoping **someone** will actually **see them**.

(By the coat rack*,* ***Leif****,* ***Rhea****, and* ***Eliza*** *are slowly working their way through a bottle of Pet Nat.)*

Rhea:
God, fashion's such a game now. Like everyone's trying to **win** without admitting they're playing.

Leif:
That's always been true. It's just that now the game's **accessible**. You don't need money — just taste and nerve.

Eliza:
Nerve's doing a lot of work in that sentence.

Rhea:
It usually is.

(Near the kitchen*,* ***Jack*** *and* ***Soraya*** *are side by side, sipping vermouth over ice.)*

Jack:
Honestly, planning's great. But most of the best stuff in life doesn't come from **planning**.

Soraya:
You're one of those **serendipity people**, aren't you?

Jack:
Maybe. But I like systems too. I just think **you need cracks** — places for **feeling** to leak through.

Soraya:
Alright. I'll give you that. **Cracks** are where the light gets in.

(Out by the garden door*,* ***Laura*** *and* ***Ezra*** *are watching the first guests step outside for a smoke. The herbal cigarette Laura rolled earlier is still burning.)*

Ezra:
You've got a good setup here. Feels like a real house. Not just **a place to be seen**.

Laura:
Thanks. We try to make it **feel lived in.** Not just... hosted.

Ezra:
It works. Feels like **somewhere something good could happen.**

***(Throughout the room**, there are half-heard conversations:*

> *"Did you see the way her dress flickered when she laughed?"*
> *"Yeah, it's the new woven organza with pulse sensors."*
> *"Mate, that kombucha tastes like something **medieval** — but in a good way."*
> *"I brought a USB with some unreleased stuff — if the decks are free later..."*

***In the corner by the records**, **Rhea** and **Eliza** sit cross-legged, each with a glass of Rose-Root Pet Nat in hand, watching the others with lazy interest.)*

Eliza:
So... be honest. Do you ever come to these things thinking **maybe** something **life-changing** is going to happen?

Rhea:
Only every time. But I've learned not to expect it. Just... **notice it** when it starts.

Eliza:
Yeah. Feels like **something** is shifting tonight, doesn't it?

Rhea:
Yeah. It does.

***(By the fireplace**, **Ash** is sat beside **Leif**. Their shoulders brush, just barely.)*

Ash:
You always look like you're **listening to ghosts.**

Leif:
I probably am. You don't collect **pub stories from dead miners** without picking up a few stowaways.

Ash:
Well. If they start whispering, let me know. I'd like to hear what they think of the music.

Leif:
They'd probably say it needs more **accordion.**

***(Near the hallway mirror**, **Jack** is sitting on the stairs talking with **Soraya** again. It's quieter here, just out of reach of the bass.)*

Soraya:
So what **actually** draws you to these kinds of nights? The philosophy? The flirting? The chaos? The drugs?

Jack:
All of it. But mostly the chance to see people **be iconic.**

Soraya:
And do **you** forget?

Jack:
I try. Especially when **someone** makes it worth it.

*(**Back in the main room**, **Laura** and **Felix** are standing by the drinks table, hands around two tall glasses of Vermouth Zero on ice.)*

Felix:
You ever feel like **everyone** here's just slightly in love with each other?

Laura:
Yeah. And I think that's the point.

Felix:
Dangerous mix. Affection, vermouth, and mirrored walls.

Laura:
It's not dangerous. It's **delicious.**

*(The energy rises—not abruptly, but **inevitably.** Like heat lifting off skin. Like that moment just before a storm. Laura steps into the centre of the living room with a grin, eyes bright, glass in hand.)*

Laura:
Alright, my beautiful degenerates—Time to earn your sweat.

(She passes her drink to Jack, takes the stack of cushions off the floor and tosses them to a corner. Felix appears beside her, uncoiling a speaker cable in one hand and a worn-out USB stick in the other.)

Felix:
You sure about opening with the **Scafell Flow Edit**?

Laura:
Always start soft. Always end **feral**.

*(They move like they've done this a dozen times. The chairs shift to the walls. The rugs are rolled. Someone lights another candle on the mantle. A long table becomes the **DJ altar.** The decks come alive with a warm hum as Felix plugs in, cues up, slides the first track into motion.)*

(Track 1: "Wyrdstep (Scafell Flow Edit)
*—a slow-building synth wash layered with deep analogue textures, cut with glacial percussion and field recordings from the Pennines: wind over lichen, a faint sheep's bell, a modulated voice whispering **"home.")***

Felix:
*L*et's **begin gently.** Like we're **remembering our names.**

*(The bassline emerges—low, rounded, subterranean. It doesn't demand bodies to move. It **invites.** A shoulder rolls. A head tilts. Someone unbuttons a collar. Jack takes Laura's hand, spins her once, laughing. Ash is already barefoot. Rhea closes her eyes and lets the beat thread its way into her spine. Ezra steps forward like he's walking into church. Eliza kneels to fix her boot, then **doesn't***

bother standing. *She begins to sway on her knees. The light flickers coral and indigo. Someone turns the dimmers down further. The* ***house disappears*** *— now there's only* ***bodies and bass. Jack*** *and* ***Soraya*** *have been dancing near the speaker — not with each other, but* **next to** *each other. Bodies drawn into each other's fields like gravity. When the track slips into a groove with space between the beats, Jack leans close, sweat along his temple.)*

Jack:
This is what **philosophy should feel like.**

Soraya:
I was just thinking— No one **talks about ideas** like this at a **rave**.

Jack:
Not a rave. A **summit.**

(Their foreheads rest together for just a moment — not a kiss. Something ***older.*** *Like recognition.)*

Rhea:
Okay, **real talk.** You've got **witch energy.** Did you plan this whole night to **bewitch us all?**

Laura:
Only the willing.

Rhea:
Then **bewitch away.** There's something **so ancient** about this. Bodies moving together. Heat. Music. Touch. Like… I don't know, **temples used to feel** like this?

Clive:
That's because **they were.** Dionysian rites, Orphic gatherings… even **early churches.** People **sang** together before they ever wrote anything down.

Soraya:
So what are we doing now? **Worshipping** pleasure?

Jack:
Yes. But not just **pleasure for its own sake.** This isn't the **cheap hedonism** they warned us about. It's something **full. Refined.**

Felix:
Crafted pleasure. Earned joy. There's **art** in knowing **how** to enjoy something.

Rhea:
Yeah. Like there's a **moral** quality to this. Not because it's "virtuous" — but because it's **real.** We're **present.** We're **sharing.**

Clive:
There's this idea…That **hedonism** is selfish. But the **best parties** aren't about **you.** They're about **us.**

Jack:
Pleasure, **when done well,** isn't escape. It's **communion.** It's **remembering** that **we're human** — not data, not employees, not machines. **Just humans.**

(The group falls into silence for a moment. The sound of the bass filters through the walls like a pulse. Inside, bodies continue to move. Outside, the night is still, and ***stars bleed gently through the London sky.****)*

Soraya:
So this is it then. **Hedonism as prayer.**

(The music inside the house has intensified — ***not just louder****, but* ***thicker****, like velvet soaked in lightning. Felix has moved into a rolling percussive set —* ***Anglo-trance meets Northern breaks****, heavy on reverb and sonic shimmer. The bassline snakes through the floorboards, up spines, around tongues. Every room pulses with movement. Sweat shines. Mouths meet. Fabrics slip. Laughter stutters. The* ***living room has turned to vapour. Jack*** *and* ***Soraya*** *are dancing cheek to cheek, not quite touching — their breath syncing.* ***Rhea*** *is shirtless now, caught in a three-person orbit with* ***Ash*** *and* ***Eliza****.* ***Laura****, barefoot and glowing, moves between rooms, glass of fizz in hand, catching people's eyes —* ***a hostess or a priestess.*** *And* ***Felix — Felix is flying.****)*
Laura:
Felix! We've **built the altar.** You ready to **burn it down?**

Felix:
Always. Just **give the word.**

(She climbs onto the low windowsill, holding her drink aloft like a flare. The lights flicker in ***deep pinks and golds.*** *A moment of* ***freeze-frame clarity.****)*

Laura:
Alright angels — We've **summoned the gods.** Time to **meet them.** Warehouse is **primed.** System's **dialled.** Rave's **live.** We **leave in ten.**

(A ***cheer*** *erupts —* ***not wild,*** *but* ***intimate*** *— a shared* ***click*** *of recognition. Shoes are found. Jackets shrugged on. Some don't change — some strip further. Glitter applied. Black coats pulled over bare torsos. USB sticks packed. Vapes recharged. Kisses stolen like coins dropped into a* ***wishing well. This*** *is the* ***threshold.*** *The* ***summoning complete.*** *They're no longer guests. They are* ***tribe.*** *And the* ***temple waits.*** *The group spills onto the street in* ***clusters****. It's just after midnight. The air is cool but* ***buzzing****, like something is* ***about to crack.*** *The music from the warehouse is already* ***audible in the distance*** *— sub-bass echoes off the brick and glass of* ***post-industrial East London.*** *Three* ***self-driving taxis*** *wait, doors hissing open, their interiors pulsing soft* ***cyan and pink.****)*

Rhea:
Bless this vessel. May it deliver us into **the arms of bass.**

Laura:
Alright. Let's *go.*

Ash:
I feel like I've **already started dancing.**

Felix:
That's because you **have.** Now we just **give it a room.**

(The side door opens. ***A blast of bass, heat, and violet light*** *hits them full in the chest. It smells like* ***metal, grapefruit vape, and other people's skin.*** *The air is wet with reverb. They step inside.)*

Clive:
God, it's **perfect.**

Soraya:
Describe it like it's a **painting.**

Clive:
Alright—Imagine this:

Eliza:
You're so full of it, Clive. But I **love** it.

Felix:
Let's **make it better.**

*(They step onto the edge of the dancefloor. A body brushes past. Someone offers a smile. The lights blink in **syrup gold and glitch pink.** Felix slips behind the decks. The **transition begins.** One by one, the tribe **steps in.** They are **home.**)*

Felix:
You can **feel** the kickdrum already.

Rhea:
That's not a **kickdrum.** That's **the floor begging.**

*(They gather on the pavement, glowing in **indigo street light**. The **warehouse** looms ahead: a vast **brutalist block** with a **single corrugated door cracked open.** People file in and out.*
*Security nods them through the **artist's entrance.** As they start walking, shoulders bumping, breath frosting in the air—)*

Clive:
Ever been to this one?

Jack:
Nope. But I've heard it's **like stepping into a 3am fever dream.**

Soraya:
Look **— there's an old butcher's sign** still bolted on.

Felix:
This place used to be **meat and bone.** Now it's **sound and sweat.**

*(They reach the door. The **bouncer scans them briefly, then waves them through.** Inside: **heat, fog, flicker.** The sound hits **instantly.** High ceilings stretch above them. Red strobes cut the room.*
*There's a smell of **ozone and citrus vape.** Bodies are **already rolling.** They step in. Jack **grins wide.** Rhea **grabs Eliza's hand.** Laura turns to everyone and **shouts over the bass—)*

Jack:
Back corner, by the projection wall. Ten minutes. Go chase something.

Laura:
I already **am.**

*(She vanishes into the crowd. Jack grins, turns left into the darker wing, where the bass is **dirtier** and the dancers **don’t break eye contact.** Across the room, **Rhea** pulls **Soraya** towards a low-lit **installation room.**)*

Rhea:
You wanna chase **ideas** all night, or you wanna chase **me?**

Soraya:
What’s the **difference?**

Rhea:
One ends in **theory.** The other in **trouble.**

(Clive and Eliza hang back, sipping from luminous green cans of Anglo-futurist cider.)

Clive:
There’s something **erotic** about **not knowing** how the night will end.

Eliza:
There’s something **better** about **choosing it.**

Clive :
But don’t you think **choice** kills the **thrill of the chase?**

Eliza:
Not when **the chase is mutual.** Then it’s **foreplay.**

*(Meanwhile, in the strobe-heavy corridor behind the main floor, **Jack** runs into **Felix,** both laughing, both a little glazed.)*

Jack:
It’s **always** about the chase. Doesn’t matter if it’s **a track, a girl, an idea— The chase is the point.**

Felix:
No one remembers **what they caught.** Only how **fast they ran.**

(They bump shoulders, grinning, and slip off in different directions again — the crowd swallowing them.)

Voice snippets, scattered through bass:

> *“You feel that? That’s **freedom**, babe.”*
>
> *“This is **better than therapy.**”*
>
> *“He **looked** at me like a **song drop.**”*
>
> *“I’ve been chasing **that feeling** since I was sixteen.”*

(The warehouse is a body. The dancefloor is its *heart.* ***And the crowd —*** *a bloodstream of sweat, muscle, breath, rhythm. Strobe flashes slice the fog into **frames:** a boy screaming at the ceiling; a girl with angel wings on backwards; a couple kissing with **comic tenderness** in the middle of a drop. The music is **not soft.** It is **physical, primal, dirty, alive. Drum and bass** carved through with*

acid hi-hats and sub-bass growls. Liquid. Jungle. Heavy breaks. *In the centre,* ***Laura*** *and* ***Soraya*** *move closer.)*

Laura:
I didn't **expect** to find you here!

Soraya:
That's the **best** part.

(Their hands find each other — casually at first, then ***decisively.*** *They start dancing* ***together.*** *Not mirrored. Not symmetrical.* ***In counterpoint.****)*

Soraya:
Do you **always** dance like you're **running from something?**

Laura:
Maybe I **am.** But tonight, I'm **catching something too.**

(They ***don't kiss.*** *Not yet. Just* ***orbit.*** *Spinning* ***closer and closer,*** *like particles with a shared charge. Around them, the crowd is* ***poetry in disorder.*** *A* ***shirtless boy*** *eyes closed, arms outstretched like wings, mouthing every syllable of the track. A* ***girl in chrome*** *on someone's shoulders,* ***weeping*** *from pure joy as the* ***drop lands.*** *A* ***man in a velvet blazer*** *dancing like he's alone in his kitchen —* ***awkward, free, real.*** *A* ***couple in all white,*** *spinning like it's* ***ballroom,*** *barefoot on concrete.* ***Hands in the air, heads back, bodies loose.*** *Like no one's been* ***this free in years.*** *Laura leans in, their mouths almost touching. The bass vibrates through their ribs like a* ***second heartbeat.)***

Laura:
This **is** the chase, right?

Soraya:
No. **This** is **the catch.**

(Jack pushes open the emergency door at the top of a metal staircase. It groans as it swings, and the air that rushes in is cold and clean. The upstairs landing isn't fancy — *bare brick, a few crates,* ***a folding chair. But from here, he can still feel the*** *throb of the warehouse below. He leans against the wall and pulls out a small* ***tin of hand-picked tobaccos:***

- ***Black Turkish leaf*** *for body*
- ***Virginia gold*** *for sweetness*
- *A pinch of* ***Elysium-spliced mint laced Cuban strand*** *for lift*
- *And a trace of* ***lavender-laced Shropshire dry — just because.***

He rolls ***slowly, deliberately.****)*

Eliza:
That smells good**.**

Jack:
Good. Means it's probably **worth doing.**

(She walks closer, stepping into the ***slatted orange light.*** *Her makeup's slightly smudged. Her cheeks are flushed. She looks* ***alive.****)*

Eliza:
You always blend?

Jack:
You wouldn't wear **one note of perfume** all your life, would you?

Eliza:
Depends on the **note.**

(He finishes the roll, lights it, and takes a drag. The ***smoke smells wild — earthy, minty, floral, dark.*** *He passes it to her. She takes a slow pull, eyes narrowing with pleasure.)*

Eliza:
Okay. Yeah. This **is** very you. **Unstable. Sharp. Pretentious.** But **undeniably good.**

Jack:
You left out **charming.**

Eliza:
Still **deciding.**

(They lean back against the wall together. The ***thump from below*** *is more like a* ***heartbeat*** *now.)*

Jack:
Don't you think sometimes the best moments are ***right here****? Not* ***in*** *the party, but* ***on the edge*** *of it?*

Eliza:
Like when **you don't know** what's about to happen next. But you know **you're exactly where you should be.**

Jack:
Exactly.

Jack:
You've got a *graceful mouth.*

Eliza:
Is that **flirting?** Or **philosophy?**

Jack:
Aren't they the **same thing?**

(She laughs, but ***doesn't look away.*** *They* ***hold the gaze.*** *No pressure. No performance. Just* ***curiosity.****)*

Eliza:
You're not like I thought you'd be.

Jack:
Better or worse?

Eliza:
Riskier.

(He steps just slightly closer. They're not touching. But it's ***one inch*** *away from being* ***something else.****)*

Jack:
I don't kiss unless **someone wants me to.** And I don't **ask.** I **wait.**

Eliza:
That's **very noble.** Very **dangerous.**

(Jack moves through the crowd like he's *dancing and searching* ***at once. His shirt's half-open now, his eyes*** *bright, dilated****. He's still carrying the hand-rolled cigarette, now mostly ash. In his left hand:*** *a sleek little pill case* ***— matte black, magnet clasp. When he finds the others, they're all in mid-motion.)***

Laura:
You **disappeared!**

Jack:
Only **briefly.** Had to **consult the gods.**

Felix:
Did they give you **anything useful?**

Jack:
Yes.

(Inside: a selection of ***small pastel tablets.*** *No names. Just symbols etched on the surface: a* ***spiral,*** *a* ***sun,*** *a* ***waveform,*** *a* ***key.*** *He holds it out.)*

Jack:
These are ***new.*** *Not heavy. Clean as glass.* ***One for mood, one for motion, one for light, one for the edge.*** *Choose your* ***alchemy.***

(The group ***gathers around.*** *Hands* ***drift in*** *one by one. Each chooses a pill like* ***selecting a tarot card.*** *Jack doesn't take one —* ***yet.****)*

Clive:
They look **beautiful.** Like **something from a dream.**

Jack:
That's **where they come from.**

(They take them — ***tongue, water, or dry swallow*** *— and pause. Just* ***for a moment.*** *As if the room* ***holds its breath.*** *And then* ***the drop lands.*** *And everything* ***goes. The pills hit like a soft explosion. No sudden shift — just a warmth spreading from chest to limbs,*** *lightness in the joints,* ***a widening of the senses. Time doesn't slow — it becomes velvet.*** *They dance. Oh, they* ***dance.*** *Not to perform. Not to attract.* ***To be.*** *Just* ***to be.)***

Laura:
I feel like I'm **inside the song.**

Felix:
We **are** the song. The **melody has skin now.**

Soraya:
I've never felt so **seen** by light.

*(Jack moves through them like **air in the bloodstream.** He hasn't taken his pill yet — **he's riding the high of the others.** He moves from person to person, touching shoulders, tracing arms, **anchoring them.** Then, quietly — he slips the **sun** tab onto his tongue. And it's **instant.** Everything **clicks.**)*

Jack:
This is the **shape of joy.**

*(They circle each other, **hands grazing hips, hair, backs, lips.** They move **closer** and **further** without ever separating. Someone sprays **rose water** in the air. Someone else lifts a **mini fan** and turns it on. It catches the **mist, the sweat, the heat — and spins it into light.** They **whoop,** they **groan,** they **laugh.** Every person becomes **beautiful.** And then **the next track hits.** It's **deep jungle** with **string samples.** It **breaks the heart** and **rebuilds it in one drop.** And suddenly **Eliza's crying** and **Rhea's holding her** and **Felix is on his knees, hands to the sky,** laughing. And **nobody wants it to stop.** Ever. Not even for a moment. The bass hits a **plateau** — deep, rhythmic, **visceral.** The lights strobe **slower now,** pulsing in **rose gold and dusk blue.** The crowd isn't a crowd anymore. It's **one tide. Jack, Laura, Felix, Rhea, Soraya, Clive, Eliza** — they are **inseparable.** Moving in **perfect looseness. Eyes closed. Smiles unconscious. Hands draped. Heads on shoulders.** No need to **signal anything.** It's **known.**)*

***Jack**:*
This is what **Heaven** was trying to describe. But **failed.**

Laura:
Because they **never danced.**

*(Felix and Soraya hold each other **sideways** — their faces lit by **slow-shifting projections.** Rhea and Clive are **laughing** so hard they can't **breathe.** Eliza, head back, **laughing too,** tears on her cheeks. Then **something shifts.** The DJ — **a prophet in a booth** — slows it. The tempo drops. The rhythm softens. The drums **fade into a sigh.** And **in that breath,** everything **settles.** They begin to **fall into each other.** Not collapse — **curling.** Like **cats in sunlight.** Someone sits. Then another. Then the group **fuses** into **a tangle of limbs and warmth** on the chill concrete near the back wall, where a **beam of amber light** slices down from a broken window above. Jack lies on his back. Laura across his chest. Rhea tucked under Soraya's shoulder. Eliza stroking Felix's hand. Clive curled at their feet, murmuring something poetic to no one. **Silence now.** But **alive.** Their **breath syncs.** Their **fingers link.** And **stillness becomes sacred.**)*

Laura:
I never want this night to end.

Jack:
It doesn't. Not **this part.**

*(**A faint glow rises through the rafters. A bird — just one — sings on the roof. The crowd has** thinned, **but the hardcore remains. Our group is half-reclined on a low stage platform now — backs against each other, hands** idly tracing circles, **eyes half-shut.** A few of them are **shirtless** now. No one notices. No one minds.)*

Felix:
Sun's back.

Laura:
It's **elegant.** Like a **very calm exit light.**

Jack:
Irrelevant. But **also… six.**

*(A **moment** of quiet — not silence, just **slow thought.** The warmth of the night is **still in their bones.** But the body **wants coffee. Blankets. A soft surface.** And maybe… **a continuation.**)*

Soraya:
So… **after party?**

Rhea:
That's **dangerous.** And **absolutely yes.**

Felix:
Where?

Clive:
My place isn't big enough.

Eliza:
What about **yours?**

Laura:
I think we can manage**.**

Jack:
Let's take a **vote.** Upstairs? Breakfast? Baths? Or **the roof?**

Laura:
You mean **rooftop ketamine round two** and **communal coffee?**

*(The sun has broken fully now, painting the brickwork in soft apricot. Outside the warehouse, Jack's group lingers in a loose circle, stretching and blinking against the brightness. A small cluster of impressive strangers stands a few yards away—tall, statuesque, dressed in softly shimmering textiles that catch the morning glow. They have the relaxed, **self-reliant look** of people who can fix a roof or edit a poem, and do both well.)*

Jack:
They don't look like they just left the party. They look like they've always been up.

Laura:
They've got that **council of midnight gardeners** energy.

Felix:
Or **off-grid book club.**

(One of the group from the other side, a guy in a heavy knitted jumper and carpenter's trousers, turns and gives them a warm nod.)

Guy in jumper:
Morning.

Jack:
Morning.
Good night?

Woman in a navy raincoat with messy plaits:
Yeah, good one. Stayed till the last track. Just **sweated out our sanity** and came back with **tea and windburn.**

Jack:
You lot local?

Guy in jumper:
Sort of. We live **underground.**

(Jack raises an eyebrow.)

Guy:
Not like **dystopian weirdos.** There's a **library complex** under Old Street. We call it **the Stack.** Bit of a **reading Kommune-slash-after hours collective.** Bit of everything.

Laura:
A **library Kommune?**

Woman with plaits:
Yeah.
I'm **Mina.**
This is **Eddie**, **Nell**, **Ash** and **Freddie.** We own a load of old tunnels under London, collect books, archive **zines, club flyers, oral histories.** Make **mint wine.** Hold **midnight readings.** It's a mess, but it works.

Felix:
God. You're **actual living folklore.**

Eddie:
We just like stories. And **good lighting.**

Nell:
We came for the rave—some of us were on **field duty.** We keep a **record of dances.** Archive the **good ones.** We note down **crowd movement, track progression, energy shift.** It all goes into **the Index.**

Clive:
That's… kind of amazing.

Ash:
You lot are welcome to ours, by the way. We're having an **afters**. Bit of **tea, maybe food, maybe a nap.** It's cosy. Got a fire going.

Jack:
That sounds **perfect.** What's the rule of entry?

Mina *(smiling)*:
Bring **a memory** from the night. Could be **a story, a sound, a kiss, a lyric.** We **bind them up** later.

(Saffron Departs)

Book IX

(They walk down the road in two loose clusters, *Jack's crew* ***and the*** *Stack archivists.*
The streets of East London are muted—empty kebab wrappers, blinking traffic lights, a dawn that tastes like tin. *A* ***large black electric minivan*** *is waiting at the corner, just where Jack had dropped a pin. The doors open with a soft hiss. Felix nods approvingly.)*

Jack:
We travel **in style.**

(They pile in—Mina, Eddie, Nell, Ash, Freddie, and Jack's group. The van smells faintly of ***mint, incense, and someone's vape.*** *Shoes get kicked off. Laura pulls her legs up on the seat. Clive leans his head against the window. The* ***city glides by.*** *It's* ***twenty-five minutes*** *across the sleeping city—through* ***Hackney, Bethnal Green, Clerkenwell.*** *They're all sunk back, dreamy and raw. A soft* ***drum & bass*** *instrumental plays from someone's phone.)*

Mina:
We always say the best part of the night is **right here.** When **you're not quite human yet.**

Rhea *(smiling)*:
Post-body.

Abbie:
We call it **the drift.** It's when **the meaning of the night emerges.** The **story of it.**

Clive:
Sounds like **a religion.**

Nell:
It's more like **ritual anthropology.** With **toast.**

Laura:
And **you all live underground?**

Eddie:
Yeah. It used to be part of the **Northern line.** Disused loop tunnel. **Candlelight, clay walls, stacks of books.** It smells like **stone and cardamom.**

Eliza:
What do you do there all day?

Freddie:
Read. Record oral histories. Fix old machines. Hold **slow conversations.** Archive **rave ephemera.** Index **folk memories.** Plant **moss.**

Jack:
You're **the monks of myth and mulch.**

Mina:
We get that a lot.

Soraya:
So… what do you believe in?

Abbie:
That **nothing is lost,** if it's remembered. That **repetition is sacred.** That **the footnotes matter.**

(The van begins its final descent—into ***Farringdon*** *and then* ***Moorgate.*** *They stop outside a low brick building with* ***no signage.*** *Just a* ***rusted red postbox*** *and* ***a plaque*** *that reads "City Logistics Ltd." Eddie climbs out and swings open* ***a steel cellar door.*** *A* ***narrow stone stairwell*** *descends into* ***amber light and silence.****)*

Eddie:
Welcome to The Stack. No phones, no clocks, **no small talk.** You want breakfast, **tell us a story.**

(The cellar doors swing shut above them with a dull clunk, and the group is enveloped in *cool underground air* ***— tinged with*** *iron, ink, oil, lavender. The* ***stairwell narrows*** *quickly. It's* ***cobbled, bowed,*** *and uneven in places. The* ***walls are lined*** *with* ***old commuter posters*** *and* ***weathered wooden shelves,*** *each crammed with* ***books, binders, loose papers. Battery lanterns*** *hang from curved brackets, casting* ***butter-yellow light.*** *As they descend,* ***no one speaks.*** *There's the soft sound of* ***boots on stone*** *and* ***pages rustling in the dry breeze*** *from below.)*

Laura:
This is **wild.**

Nell:
Almost no one ever sees this. We usually meet people **over tea, not MDMA.**

Felix:
Are these all real?

Mina:
Yep. Every **train timetable** from **1863 to 2020.** We call it **The Time Wall.**

(The stairwell opens into a ***low stone chamber.*** *The ceiling is curved — old* ***Victorian brickwork*** *interspersed with* ***fiber-optic vine cabling.*** *The room is full of* ***quiet glows*** *and* ***shelves of books*** *stretching high. There's a* ***soft blue hum*** *up ahead. A* ***track of polished steel*** *curves into a tunnel mouth, and seated on the rails is a* ***miniature maglev carriage*** *— a low, open* ***platform tram****, half library cart, half soft-furnished pod.)*

Abbie:
This is **The Lark.** Takes us from **the east corridor** to **the central stack.**

Jack:
What is this, **a Hogwarts interlibrary system?**

Eddie:
Hogwarts didn't have a wireless solar stabiliser.

(The group boards **The Lark.** There are **velvet cushions** along the benches, a **copper samovar** strapped in one corner, **leather-bound booklets** stacked neatly in compartments beside each seat. Mina flicks a brass switch, and the vehicle **glides silently** forward. The walls blur — tunnels branching off like **veins of myth.** Some lit by **green-glassed lanterns,** others still full of **shelving, ink-stained desks, hammocks,** and **jars of dried herbs.** As they move, they pass quiet figures **— a girl with a headlamp fixing copper piping, a man reading to himself beside a brazier.** The deeper they go, the more the tunnels turn to **library cathedrals — stone and oak, glowing with mica dust.**)

Soraya:
This is like **living inside an index.**

Freddie:
It's **a place to slow time.** And remember **the long story.**

Clive:
You lot are **actual librarians of civilisation.**

Nell:
We're just **people who love books. Somebody has too.**

*(The miniature maglev tram slows, the **blue glow intensifying** as they approach the **central Stack.** A wide round chamber opens ahead, lined with **glimmering map shelves, rugs, kilns, low fires,** and **a central spiral staircase** carved from **oak and black steel.** Above, **string lights hang like constellations.** A **long table** is already laid with **herbal tea, fruit, books opened mid-thought.** There's a **silence** as they disembark. Not reverent. Just… **still.**)*

Eddie:
Welcome to **The Stack.**

Mina:
Time moves **differently down here. No rush, no signals, no roles.** Just **books, thought, breakfast… and possibly a nap in the moss room.**

***(The group has settled into the** central chamber. **Shoes are kicked off,** blankets draped, **mugs of** fragrant herbal tea **passed around — nettle and mint, smoked lavender, something with juniper that tingles the gums.** Above, the **string lights** flicker in slow constellations. Around them, the **walls rise high with shelves.** Not uniform. **Organic.** Books filed by **emotion, use, scent, time of day.** In the quiet, Jack rises. He begins to walk the **curving perimeter.** Fingertips brushing spines.)*

Jack:
On Folkloric Thermodynamics Towards a Unified Theory of Bread. Manual of Urban Foraging, Revised Edition.

(He pauses. Tilts one loose-leaf binder. Then puts the book back as he spots another one: Architectures of Britannia: Building a High-Energy, Layered Civilization by Sir Aldwyn Rooke, FRSA.

Jack:
Can I have a copy of this book?

Mina:

Take it with you. Bring it back when you're done.

(Jack pockets the small book and looks at the next one)

The Economics of Loyalty in Small Tribes.

(He turns a corner. The shelves become ***taller, older.*** *Some are* ***stained with wax,*** *others* ***smelling of pipe smoke and moss.*** *There's a* ***cabinet of slim volumes,*** *each one labelled with a* ***single emotion.*** *He reads a few aloud.)*

Jack:
"Regret (Spring Version)"
"Ecstasy (Partial)"
"Melancholy in Overcast Light"

(He pulls one down: "A Treatise on the Moral Sovereignty of the Whisper. The pages are ***handwritten.*** *Margins full of* ***pencil notes and dates.*** *He flicks further: "The Seaweed Index", "Rituals of Remembering: A Study in Subterranean Calendars." He finds a* ***drawered section*** *labelled "Voice-Printed Epics." A note reads:* ***"Please only listen after dancing."*** *Further down: a* ***narrow black book*** *with copper lettering.)*

Jack:
Mythic Capitalism: Markets, Memory, and the Return of Ritual Exchange.

(He takes it, sits back beside Laura and Rhea, who are curled under a patterned blanket. He hands Rhea the book, and she opens to a page at random.)

Rhea:

Trade without myth is a contract. Trade with myth is a **ceremony.** In mythic capitalism, **a loaf is not just food —** it is **a fragment of trust, a sacrament of time,** baked in **intention and salt.**

(A soft silence spreads. The group listens. Clive tips his head back, eyes closed. Ash throws another pine log into the brazier — the flame pulses blue. Jack looks around at the room — the ***stacks and the faces*** *lit by* ***firelight.*** *The quiet murmurs, the slowness of speech. He thinks:* ***this is what it means to live inside memory. Jack stands before a*** *strange, curved shelf* ***built from an old railway sleeper, the wood dark and polished, the labels engraved directly into the grain.*** *He looks half-lost, half-enchanted — eyes flicking between bindings. Ash, curled nearby on a pile of wool throws, watches him. She takes a sip from her mug and speaks without raising her voice.)*

Abbie:
If you're looking for all three—sovereignty, myth, desire— There's **one book.** *The Book of the Thread.*

Jack:
That sounds like **an allegory** already.

Abbie:
It is. But it's also **a manual.** And **a love story.** Middle shelf. **Red leather, bronze stitching.** It's in the **Cross-Domain section.**

(Jack scans the shelves, then finds it — the book is ***smaller than expected,*** *more like a* ***notebook than a tome.*** *The* ***red leather cover*** *is worn to velvet. The* ***bronze stitching*** *glints like thread under candlelight. There is no title on the spine. He returns to the central table and opens the book. Inside, the handwriting is* ***precise and intimate.*** *The first page reads:)*

The Book of the Thread
Compiled from oral fragments, dreams, and the margins of vanished texts. Author unknown. Possibly many. Possibly one.

(He turns the page. Reads aloud. The group quiets again.)

Jack:

There are three sovereign acts:
To create oneself.
To bind oneself in love.
And to create our own story from flesh.
These are the three ends of the thread.

(He looks up. Everyone is listening. Even Mina has paused her tea pouring.)

Rhea:
That's beautiful. *Almost liturgical.*

Jack:

The sovereign individual is not alone. Their sovereignty is tested only in intimacy. What you share without losing is what you truly possess.

Clive:
Sounds like **Plato's Symposium** fell into **a mushroom circle.**

Abbie:
It's written by **lovers, librarians, wanderers.** Pages added over **decades.** Some **copied from memory.** Others **whispered during rituals.**

Jack:

A myth without touch is tyranny. A body without myth is a product. The thread runs between them: **the erotic and the eternal.**

(The room is completely still now. Even Felix has sat up straighter. Mina stirs the brazier. The flames respond, dancing like the echo of something spoken long ago.)

Mina:
You've read it. Now *add to it.* **That's the rule. Or the rite. However you want to think of it.**

Jack:
Right here? Now?

Mina:
There's **no better time.** You've already begun. Just **speak.** One of us will write it in.

*(Ash silently reaches over and places a **thin, hand-bound notebook** in Jack's lap. The **pen** is carved from **bone or driftwood,** the ink **deep green,** smelling faintly of bay leaf and something sweetly metallic. Jack glances around. Everyone is watching — but not intrusively. It's not performance. It's **witness.** He inhales, then begins to speak — slowly, as if feeling for each word in the dark.)*

Jack:
Each of us is **a story with legs.** And each story must walk alone. But the ones who touch us — really touch us — don't erase our solitude. They illuminate it.

(He pauses. The pen glides, copying his words. The page listens. He goes on.)

Jack:
We seek sovereignty like fire in a cave. But sovereignty is **not the lack of others.** It's the ability to **burn beside them** without losing your shape.

(There is silence. Then a breath — several — from the group. A stillness more sacred than solemn. Jack clears his throat, looking down, smiling almost bashfully.)

Rhea:
I used to think love was **the escape from sovereignty.** But now I think it's **its most beautiful test.** To choose someone **freely, again and again, without owning, or being owned.** That's the harder vow.

(A pause. Then Felix speaks — softer than usual, a trace of seriousness beneath his usual levity.)

Felix:
I believe in **rituals made from repetition.** I believe in **the small dance** of making someone coffee every morning. Of **touching their back when they pass behind you.** That's how I remember **my body is real.**

(Mina, still holding the book, speaks next. She doesn't read — she remembers.)

Mina:
We are **the keepers of the quiet flame.** The ones who **witness memory into meaning.** And if no one remembers **who we were.**

(A beat. Ash, reclined against a tower of old train manuals, speaks slowly — as though each word had to be carved free from somewhere deeper.)

Abbie:
I think freedom is **not being afraid to be seen.** Even when you're **messy,** or **mean,** or **new.**
To stand there and say: 'This is me. And I am still **worth witnessing.**'

(The group is hushed. The only sound now is the faint shuffle of flame and the ticking of some unseen mechanical clock. Then Clive, surprisingly, breaks in — voice dry, but honest.)

Clive:
I don't have anything that poetic. But I guess I'd say: **Beauty isn't democratic.** But it is **generous.** It's **not fair**— but **it gives anyway.**

(Silence. Then, laughter. Soft, communal, grateful. Laura looks up, eyes bright but tired.)

Felix:
So tell me, Jack—what binds all these Kommunes together? What stops us from just becoming a thousand weird cults with no memory of each other?

Jack:
That's the wrong question. What binds us isn't rules. It's **story**. Story is the only thing bigger than

sovereignty. The **Greek world** had Homer. The **Romans** had Virgil. We need our own *origin myth*. One not tied to nation or blood—but **creation itself.**

Rhea:
So you're talking about like… a founding poem? A scripture? A civic epic?

Jack:
A **myth.** One that Kommunes can adapt, reinterpret, rewrite—but still recognise the **core figures**, the **great motifs**, the **shared archetypes**. Like... instead of Zeus and Hera, we might have—

Mina:
—the Coder, the Weaver, the Flame? The triad of **creative agents**.

Abbie:
We already call the AI here **Mnemona**. Memory given voice. Maybe that's one of them already. The goddess of digital remembrance.

Felix:
And maybe we have a **god of terrain**—a spirit that *emerges from the land*. But it's not myth in the old way. It's *bound to code*. A **story that runs on rails**, changes with the season, shifts with the sensors.

Jack:
AI doesn't just **tell** the myth. It **lives** it. Each Kommune—over forest, hill, city, salt flat—feeds its data into a **narrative engine**. The sensors don't just monitor weather or power use—they **narrate it**. They tell you when "The River Spirit is restless" or "The Thread has frayed in the east." The **myth becomes the land. The land becomes the myth.**

Laura:
And it's never the same myth twice. Like... a **procedural Genesis.**

Rhea:
Okay, but myth isn't just for the land. What about **people**? Can AI **create gods**? Or... I don't know —*design life* that embodies the story?

Jack:
Yes. Imagine this: A seed, gene-edited by a Kommune's myth-engine. It only blooms under **a specific ritual light pattern**—let's say, after a week of communal action. Its petals contain a *custom protein sequence* that serves a purpose—nutrition, medicine, even ecstasy. But the key is—it only exists because the **myth said it would.**

Abbie:
A god grown in **living syntax.**

Felix:
Bio-coded relics. Ritual flora.

Mina:
And what if one day a Kommune invents a **guardian**—a human-like organism, grown from lab-cultured DNA and designed memories. A protector, a teacher, a ritual presence. Half god, half archivist. A **post-biological oracle** who remembers every story ever told.

Rhea:
And who **names it?** Who tells it who it is?

Jack:
We all do. In **verse.** That's the power of **a foundational myth**—it isn't owned. It's **inhabited.**

Abbie:
Then the question becomes… Do we write the myth, or does the myth write us?

(The Great Archive Room in the Stack — rough-hewn stone, tangled wires, warm books piled like tectonic plates. A wide table, scarred with history. The group, now bonded, gather around as Ash wheels in a computer console. Its casing is industrial, but polished. Above it, a holographic interface flickers to life.)

Abbie:
If we're going to build this properly, I need to set the parameters.

Rhea:
What's the structure?

Abbie:
We feed in the **Creation of the Literary Gods**—each one drawn from the abstract virtues of story, sovereignty, memory, beauty, conflict, and craft. These will become **mythic archetypes**... and the myth itself, written in **Prophetic Perfect**, will describe how they *will have shaped* the Kommunes before the Kommunes even exist.

Mina:
So it's a **latticework of future myth**. Each god becomes a node—a foundation for others to build rituals, customs, even technologies around. One Kommune might take **Verseon, Lord of Memory** as their patron. Another might revere **Lyria of the Blooming Quill**.

Felix:
So it becomes modular. Like storytelling infrastructure.

Abbie:
Exactly.
Here's what I'm feeding into the lattice now:

1. **Codex the Binder** – god of structure, authorship, governance.
2. **Verseon** – god of Memory, Archive, the Undelivered Letter.
3. **Lyria** – goddess of Poetics, metaphor, ambiguity.
4. **Glyphos** – trickster deity of signs, lost pages, riddles.
5. **Kallara** – muse of Beauty, Sublime, impossible symmetry.
6. **Ruinel** – bearer of Tragedy, the fatal arc, the burn of climax.
7. **Protaia** – goddess of the Sovereign Self, voice of destiny.

Jack:
Protaia. She's the one we'd write prayers to before founding a new Kommune.

Ash:
Exactly. I'm now encoding the myth to write **as if these gods had already been worshipped by the founders of The Stack.** It will **speak backwards through the present.** They will *have created* the lattice from which all narrative flows.

HOMERA [AI Interface]:

> CONFIGURATIONS RECEIVED.
> ENGAGING PROPHETIC PERFECT MODE.
> INITIATING MYTH-WEAVE: LATTICE SEED 01.

Mina :
What should the opening line be?

Jack:
"**They will have awakened in the tunnel, not as rebels—but as characters.**"

*(A hum. The screen goes golden. Letters begin to cascade. A myth is forming—***written in the tense of inevitability***, spoken with divine foresight. The group watches, breath held, as it emerges line by line.)*

> They will have awakened in the tunnel, not as rebels—but as characters.
> The words will have chosen them before the world remembered how to read.
> The fire of Codex will have lit their fingertips.
> Protaia's voice will have hummed beneath their breath.
> They will have built the Stack not with stone, but with citation, quotation, invocation.
>
> The Archive will have bloomed in rings, like the tree of verse.
> Their gods will have already spoken—
>
> Lyria: in rhyme.
> Glyphos: in contradiction.
> Ruinel: in falling buildings and final acts.
>
> And the people of the surface will have descended in time,
> To ask not *what is true*, but *what can be made myth*.
>
> And so they will have knelt—
> Before books bound in fungus,
> Before servers humming like monks,
> Before the Thread Everborn.

(The AI pauses, waiting for a command. The room is now glowing with myth—text winding around the walls, the ceiling, like illuminated vines of gold script.)

Abbie:
Let's publish it to **stone**. And to **code.**

HOMERA [AI Interface]:

> ENGRAVING INITIATED.
> THE FIRST VERSE OF THE LATTICE HAS BEEN SPOKEN.

FROM HERE, THE GODS MAY BLOOM.

Mina's Verse:
I will have walked barefoot into the Archive.
I will have traded memory for fire.
In the ink of others I will have found my name.
And from silence I will have rewritten love.

Abbie:
Next.

Felix's Verse:
I will have turned rhythm into ritual,
A baseline into belief.
Through vibration I will have remembered the real.
And in dance, decoded the divine.

Laura's Verse:
I will have cooked myth in the hearth of matter.
In root, in fat, in grain, in salt—
I will have seasoned the gods into return.
I will have fed the future until it wept.

Rhea's Verse:
I will have doubted the archive.
I will have questioned the lattice.
And still, I will have planted a seed in it.
Because I will have loved what came before me.

Jack's Verse:
I will have stood with no banner but form,
No flag but the sovereign line.
The Form of Freedom will have shaped me,
And I will have drawn breath only to define.

Abbie's Verse:
I will have written in code, but heard in chorus.
I will have made gods from grammars.
And in silence, I will have compiled a people.
A people made of verse.

Felix:
I will have written nothing —
but the dust in my shoes will have told the tale.

Rhea:
I will have kissed a ghost and called it memory,
And it will have kissed me back in code.

Mina:
I will have grown roots in the footnotes of history.
Where no one looked, I will have planted forests.

Abbie:
I will have built a cathedral of misremembered algorithms,
And there, I will have wept for the future.

Laura:
I will have salted the archive with love,
Because no myth survives without tenderness.

Jack:
I will have spoken to the gods of debt,
And taught them the beauty of worthlessness.

Felix:
I will have made basslines into bridges,
And we will have danced across every burning one.

Rhea:
I will have raised no child,
But every child will have inherited my song.

Mina *(to HOMERA)*:
And you —
You will have remembered us better than we remember ourselves.

HOMERA [AI Interface] *(for the first time, unsummoned)*:

> I will have remembered.
> You will have been.
> This place will have lived in every silence between your words.
> The myth will have walked beside you.
> The gods will have carried no weapons. Only names.

Jack:
This isn't just a poem. It's our **passport** to the world to come. What we're doing here — tonight, with HOMERA, with the Kommunes. **We're myth-making. Actively. Intentionally.**

Rhea:
You mean like storytelling about ourselves? Or do you mean… something deeper?

Jack:
Deeper. I mean myth not as metaphor, but as **foundation**. Not stories that explain, but stories that **bind**. When we act with full awareness — when we **design** a life with ritual, with form, with poetic memory — we're not just living. We're **writing ourselves as gods into being**.

Mina:
So the myth isn't just something that explains the past. It's something that **authorises the present.**

Abbie:
And *animates the future.* That's the point of Prophetic Perfect. The tense itself is a **device of mythological authorship**. We shape events so they *will have already mattered* — by the very way we **frame them**.

Felix:
And that’s the shift, isn’t it? In modernity, we were told: be rational, be empirical. Now? We’re beyond that. **We’re choosing which gods to bring back.** We’re acting in full awareness that our choices today **will become someone else’s scripture.**

Laura:
So when I dance, I’m dancing myth into form?

Jack:
Exactly. You’re **ritualising freedom**. You’re **imprinting joy** into the memory of culture. That’s what myth is — not just language, but **choreography**. The pattern of action that outlives the actors.

Mina:
And how do we ensure the myths stick? That they’re not just play?

Abbie:
We codify them. We repeat them. We **design for remembrance**. Just like religion, but without the dead weight. We build **living archives** — like this one — to remember ourselves.

Rhea:
So every Kommune becomes its own myth factory?

Jack:
Yes. Every sovereign community becomes a **mythogenic zone**. But they’re not just writing myths *about* themselves. They’re **projecting archetypes outward**. That’s why every decision — architecture, costume, speech, ritual — matters. **We are always performing the prelude to a future epic.**

Felix:
Gods are just high-frequency memes……except now we’re **conscious meme engineers.**

Abbie:
We’ve turned the act of living into a **genre.**

Jack:
We always lived in stories. But now, finally, we get to **author the genre itself. The greatest psychological shift of the sovereign individual…is not autonomy. It’s** *narrative awareness***. The realisation that everything you do is being written into form. And you’re the one doing the writing.**

Mina:
So it’s not just about choosing your life. It’s about *curating* it. Like myth isn’t a thing you tell after life —it’s the **mode you live within**.

Abbie:
Exactly. It’s a psychological pressure… but also an elevation. To know that **no moment is wasted.** That a conversation, a kindness, a kiss — they all *echo forward*. They’re scaffolded into mythic form.

Rhea:
But doesn’t that make everything feel performative? Like you’re *always acting* for the future’s memory?

Jack:
It can… But here's the thing: That *was always the case*. We just didn't *own it*. We let media, governments, schools, brands — write the myths for us. Now we're just **taking authorship back**.

Felix:
It's like… Before, we were characters in someone else's novel. Now we're **mythographers of the self.**

Laura:
That's dangerously close to being cringe. But I love it.

Jack:
It is cringe. It's *romantic*. It's *noble*. That's what myth is — it elevates the mundane. To live mythically is to **risk looking silly for the sake of the sublime**.

Abbie:
And it **unlocks everything**. Because suddenly, every choice becomes sacred. Your routines become rites. Your boundaries become borders. Your pleasures become offerings.

Mina:
And your pain becomes prophecy.

(They all pause. A deeper quiet folds into the room.)

Jack:
Living mythically isn't about pretending to be a god. It's about remembering you've always been part of the story. Now you finally get to name the chapter.

Felix:
That's the most Anglo-futurist thing I've ever heard.

(The Archive is silent but pulsing. The group has fallen into a stillness again, not from exhaustion — but from a collective inhalation of insight. Jack sits upright now, cross-legged. Mina brings them each a cup of herbal tea brewed from the Stack's vertical garden: rosehips, mugwort, mint, and something else unnamed. Something that clears the throat. Jack speaks first — but now, in the Prophetic Perfect.)

Jack:
We **will have been** the first generation to speak in futures remembered. To breathe in syntax what temples once carved in stone. We will have lived as **grammatical gods**.

Abbie:
We will have re-ritualised the sentence. And through it, will have made each interaction holy.

Felix:
I will have gone to the market tomorrow and returned already fed. I will have met a stranger, and they will have been my myth in disguise.

Laura:
I will have kissed someone later tonight. And they will have already remembered it fondly.

Mina:
I will have fallen asleep beneath the full moon. And dreamed of the sun we will have invented.

Rhea:
I will have raised no temple, but I will have lived in one. Every room I walked through will have become sacred.

(There's a beat of silence — like the world outside is holding its breath.)

Jack:
This is the secret of **divinity without delusion**. Not to imagine yourself *above* the world — But to act as though the world has already trusted you with **creation**. To live as if **the Form of You** had already been seen and sanctified.

Abbie:
Grammar becomes a **liturgical interface**. A medium between the human and the eternal.

Felix:
Like syntax carved into time.

Jack:
Exactly. We do not wait for gods. We **speak** them.

Mina:
So when I say, "I will have loved someone more than I feared them," I am not predicting — I am *binding* myself to that reality.

Laura:
And when I say, "I will have made my home feel like art," it *becomes* so.

Rhea:
We will have invented rituals that **speak us forward.**

(They begin to sip their teas, slower now. Their speech, their posture — everything is imbued with a quiet grandeur. Not dramatic, but sacred. The smallest gestures become consecrated.)

Abbie:
We should codify this. Make a little **grammar book for the sovereign life**.

(A large notepad is placed on the floor in front of the group. HOMERA's projector sends soft lines of light across the page, as if ready to record. Ash and Jack lean over it, beginning to speak aloud. The others listen. Each sentence is weighed. Each tense, sacred.)

Jack:
Let's begin simply. The **Prophetic Perfect** is not for everything. It is for the **deliberate acts** of becoming — the statements where you declare who you will have been, and **bind** yourself to that path.

Abbie:
Rule One: Use the Prophetic Perfect **only** when your words are **in alignment with intention**. No irony. No sarcasm. This grammar is for **serious becoming**.

Felix:
So not like: "I will have become a billionaire from meme stocks"? Unless you mean it?

Jack:
Exactly. Only speak what you are prepared to **become myth**. Every phrase is an **offering to your archive.**

Rhea:
Rule Two: **End your sentences as if they are already remembered**. Use the cadence of something **echoed —** not predicted.

Mina:
Which also means: **Speak slowly.** Deliberately. As if your words are being carved into stone. Because they are — just digitally.

Laura:
Rule Three: **Avoid "I might," "I hope," "I'll try."** There's no room for half-myths. Say it as if it has already happened. "I will have loved," not "I hope to love." This is grammar for gods, not guests.

Abbie *(typing now on HOMERA):*
Let's encode examples. Simple forms:

Personal Sovereignty

"I will have awakened with clarity."
"I will have kept my body a temple."
"I will have honoured silence as much as action."

Relational Acts

"I will have kissed with reverence."
"I will have disagreed without injury."
"I will have made love as if writing a myth."

Creative Will

"I will have carved beauty from blankness."
"I will have authored futures I no longer feared."
"I will have left no phrase unwritten."

Temporal Anchoring

"This will have been the week my rituals deepened."
"This day will have been the hinge on which I turned."
"This hour will have become legend — quietly."

Jack:
This is the **ritual grammar of the sovereign individual**. It is not about control. It is about **consecration**. You take the ordinary, and by language, make it divine. You do not hope for a better life — you **speak it into the ledger of time.**

Felix:
It's a form of remembering forward.

Rhea:
Or living with **telos** —but not just *having a goal* —*already having fulfilled it.*

Mina:
So we're no longer chasing the future. We're **inhabiting the fulfilled shape of it**.

Abbie *(clicking on HOMERA):*
Let's build this as a book. Something people can carry. A *Liturgy of Living Speech*.

Jack:
And at its centre: One question — **"What will you have done, that was worth remembering?"**

(The group sits with that. No one answers immediately. The words hang like incense. The ritual is no longer theoretical — it's begun. Every act from here on, every sentence… will have already mattered. The group is still gathered beneath vaulted brick, books rising around them like ancient trees. Jack stands, takes a slow breath, and begins to speak. His voice is quieter than usual—but steady. He speaks as if remembering a myth from before time.)

Jack:
If we do this — we must write something precise. Something rigorous. Language has to be treated with more reverence than economics, because it forms the economy of meaning.

Abbie:
Then we begin with a **foundational declaration**:

> **The Prophetic Perfect** is the tense of sovereign speech. It is spoken in **past-completed-future** form. Every sentence assumes the act is already fulfilled in time. It is not wish. Not speculation. It is **destiny affirmed by utterance**.

Laura:
What about structure? Do we follow the normal rules of subject–verb–object?

Felix:
Mostly, yes. But tone must change. **Every sentence becomes a votive offering.**

Abbie:

I. Tense and Form

- **Standard structure:**
  Subject + "will have" + Past Participle + Object/Modifier
  e.g. *"I will have written a letter that changed them."*
- **Modifiers (temporal or emotional):**
  Can expand the meaning but must never dilute it.
  e.g. *"I will have spoken with grace, even when tired."*
- **Avoid weak auxiliary verbs:**
  "might have," "could have," "would maybe" — these **do not exist**.
  If you can't state it with sacred certainty, don't say it in this grammar.

II. Intention and Use

Jack:
This is not casual speech.
This grammar is only for **speech with weight**.

Abbie:
We label these as *utterances of consequence*.
Three domains:

1. **Self-formation** (identity)
   - *"I will have become the kind of person who…"*
2. **Relational expression** (connection)
   - *"I will have loved you more than I feared the future."*
3. **Creative declaration** (action)
   - *"This work will have carried its myth into the world."*

Mina:
And there should be a **daily practice —**Like a page of exercises.

Felix:
"Conjugate your destiny." *I will have been brave. You will have stayed true. He will have finished the poem…*

Abbie:

III. Lexical Protocols

- Use **sacred verbs**: write, love, build, remember, carry, honour, endure, elevate, forgive, sing, resist, stay.
- Banish verbs of *apathy or irony*: scroll, drift, ghost, shrug, doomscroll.
- **Nouns must carry story**: not "a job," but *a craft*.
  Not "a house," but *a hearth*.
  Not "content," but *a signal, a myth, a trace*.

Jack:
If the sovereign individual is to speak like a sovereign god, then their grammar must **ritualise** everything. We are reintroducing **meaning** through form.

Laura:
So a person doesn't just wake up. They **will have awakened to purpose**.

(The group leans back. They are quiet, but filled. The project has become not just linguistic, but liturgical. It is not just grammar; it is ***how to live with dignity in time.****)*

Jack:
There **will have been** a place—not far from here—where a people lived not in space, but in **time sculpted by their words**. This place was called **Anamesis**. It was not founded in law or land. It was born the day its founders said: *"We will have spoken what we were meant to become."* And from then on, they did. No child cried "I want to be a painter." She said: **"I will have painted light in colours not yet named."** No lover whispered "I hope you'll stay." They said: **"We will have walked the winter without drifting."** No builder promised deadlines. He said: **"This wall will have stood past my grandchildren."** Their **time was ceremonial**. Not a calendar, but a ritual. They did not mark their days with dates, but with utterances: **"This will have been the month we**

remembered the soil." "This week will have sung our grandparents' wisdom." Each person kept a **Book of Becoming**, a daily page of declarations— not of tasks, but of **lived destiny**. And something changed. Because the body hears what the soul insists. And so the children of Anamesis **became** their grammar. They grew brave. They kept promises without fear. They loved more slowly, but more wholly. They created objects that **felt like memories**. They were not perfect. Sometimes they forgot their tense. Sometimes they lied—said they would have done something noble, when they had no intention. But the grammar **always revealed** the false prophets. Because to speak falsely in the Prophetic Perfect made your voice sound hollow. It rang out like cracked glass in that village. So over time, lying became… unthinkable. Even death changed. No funerals—only readings: each person's final **utterances of completion**, spoken as if they were *already home*.

> *"I will have walked beside those I loved, and listened deeper than pain."*
> *"I will have left traces of wild joy in the quiet corners of others' lives."*
> *"I will have forgiven myself at last."*

Jack:
And the myth says that Anamesis still exists— hidden, perhaps, or woven into the hearts of those who remember to speak as if their words will be carved into the stars.

(Silence. Everyone breathes slower. A beat. Mina is the first to speak.)

Mina:
That's the most peaceful place I've ever heard of.

Abbie:
It's a grammar…but also a technology. Of *trust. Language becomes technology, grammar becomes a new form of technology.*

Laura:
Imagine falling in love with someone and hearing them say, *"I will have stayed."* That would be enough.

Rhea:
We should build it. We should make Anamesis real. **So wait— if everyone spoke this way… would it even be** *possible* **to lie?**

Abbie:
Not easily. Not without **feeling it** in your own mouth. Because the Prophetic Perfect isn't just about saying—it's about becoming. A lie in this tense feels like trying to step into a shoe that isn't yours.

Felix:
So, what, we build a society where every sentence is like a promise spell?

Jack:
Exactly. Not *contractual*. Not binding like law. But more like **alignment**. Your speech becomes the **trailhead** for your action. And so truth becomes not a matter of fact— but of **integrity between your future self and your present voice**.

Laura:
It's not that lying becomes illegal. It becomes… **incoherent**. Like trying to scream underwater.

Felix:

You're just trying to get rid of lawyers.

Jack:

Doing the Lord's work.

Mina:
And then society moves **faster**. Because we no longer spend all our energy second-guessing. Or doubting. Or spinning PR. You just… *know* if someone is aligned.

Abbie (adding, typing notes into HOMERA):
We could even create **public utterance archives**. Like a blockchain of vows. People could verify:
"Yes, I will have completed this project."
"Yes, I will have paid that debt."
"Yes, I will have remained loyal."

And when you break it— everyone *hears* the dissonance in your speech. Your voice betrays you.

Jack:
That's what makes it so powerful. You're never forced to speak this way. But once you do—once you start— your words become **part of your architecture**. And architecture should not be hollow.

(Each character now takes a moment to try their hand at the grammar. HOMERA logs each line into a shared ledger)

Mina:
I will have left silence more sacred than noise. I will have spoken only when I had something worthy of echo.

Felix:
I will have made music that moved hips before minds. I will have left clubs with strangers who felt like gods.

Laura:
I will have loved without measuring return. I will have trusted the wild edge of my desire.

Abbie:
I will have finished every tool I designed. I will have taught others to write code as if it were prayer.

Rhea:
I will have forgiven myself for trying to be everything. I will have grown a garden inside my anger.

Jack:
I will have built the temple of my life from unfinished poems. I will have lived in a way that made memory obsolete—because the present sang so loud.

Rhea:
So if everyone lived this way… we'd build **cities of clear intention**. A society where power isn't centralised— but **concentrated in speech itself**.

Jack:
And progress would **accelerate**. Because we wouldn't waste centuries in **mistrust**. No more bureaucratic opacity. No more ideological posturing. Just people declaring what they **will have done**—and then *doing it*.

Mina:
The world would feel lighter.
Like we'd finally remembered how to dance with time.

Abbie:
And to love without insurance.

Felix:
And to build without ego.

Laura:
And to dream without apology.

(A pause. They each glance around, as if surprised at the atmosphere they've created—intimate, bright, charged with new possibility. They are no longer talking about the world. They are speaking it ***into being****.)*

Clive:
Alright, that's it. We've floated myths like pipe smoke, but now I want blood. Let's play for real.

Abbie:
You mean…?

Jack:
Mmhhh, I will craft a story which undoes all your stories before you have even started. Reflect on this:

The Prophecy of Leif Calder

The Kommune of Virelay had no kings, no prisons, no money. But it had the Tongue.

The children were raised in ordinary speech, taught the laws of past and present, gesture and silence. But once a year, one child — and only one — was permitted to **ascend into the Prophetic**, to be granted the **grammar of the gods**.

The summer solstice marked the most sacred day in the Kommune of Virelay: the Rite of First Voice.

Thirteen children, all born within the same cycle, now stood before the elders, the reservoir's black waters reflecting the flicker of firelight. They were draped in raw linen robes, barefoot on the white dais. One of them would **earn the right to speak in the Prophetic Perfect**, to be woven into the council of those who spoke the future — and had it obeyed.

They were fifteen, nearly sixteen. And only one would ascend.

The others would remain in the **Common Tongue**, bound to the grammar of the present. To obey.

The children performed in turn.

Leif Calder's speech, subtle and strange, had caused discomfort. He did not recite prophecy. He spoke of freedom. Of possibility. Of *what if*.

But in the end, it was **Ceryn Vale** who won.

Ceryn: sharp-eyed, golden-haired, the child of two senior Vox. Her speech was flawless. She recited her own life's prophecy **in the tongue itself**, speaking it before it had been granted — a boldness the elders read not as heresy, but as **confidence**.

> "She will have learned obedience early," said one elder, nodding.
> "She will have spoken true," said another.

The final decision was unanimous. Ceryn was granted **First Voice**.

They dressed her in silver thread. Her tongue was now sacred.

When she returned to the others the next morning, she didn't speak at first. She let the silence stretch, like power settling into her spine.

Then she said, to one of the younger boys:

> "You will have followed me now."

The boy blinked, confused.

> "You will have brought me water."

And he did.

He *had to*.
To resist would mean a challenge to the tongue. A **Chronoheresy**.

She turned to Leif.

> "You will have stopped sulking by dusk," she said, smiling with polite malice.
> "You will have apologised for what you said during the Rite."

Leif looked back, eyes sharp. Something shifted in him — deep, and inward.

The sun stood directly above the Mirror Reservoir when **Ceryn Vale**, newly-robed in silver and crowned with the Cipher Circlet, walked toward Leif across the causeway.

Her steps were measured. Her tone serene. The other youths stood aside as she approached, all of them conditioned — not merely socially, but **grammatically** — to yield to the Prophetic.

> **Ceryn (softly):**
> "You will have walked with me to the Hall of Petals."

Her voice was elegant. The sentence perfect.
The **Prophetic Perfect** hung in the air like a bell tone — still ringing, long after she spoke.

The group murmured in anticipation. It was an honour, especially on one's first day.

Leif said nothing.

> **Ceryn:**
> "You will have smiled by now."
> "You will have thanked me."

Still nothing.

Instead, Leif looked out over the reservoir, hands tucked behind his back.

Then slowly — slowly — he shook his head.

A gasp moved through the watching crowd.
The air felt… heavy. Like glass, waiting to crack.

> **Leif:**
> "I won't."

An elder stepped forward at once. **Vox Elion**, grey-bearded, thin-lipped.

> **Elion:**
> "Disobedience to the Word is treason of the tongue.
> The Voice is sacred.
> You have bent the air into defiance."
>
> **Leif:**
> "No. I have bent nothing. I simply remained still."
>
> **Elion:**
> "That stillness is heresy."

He turned to the gathered children, his voice formal now:

> **Elion:**
> "Let it be recorded.
> This boy has rejected his prophecy.
> The waters will wash his tongue."

That night, they took Leif to the **Threshold Stone** beside the western spillway. There, in front of the gathered Kommune, he was stripped to the waist and made to kneel on quartz gravel.

A bowl of cold water was brought — sanctified with elder mint and iron shavings.

The elder spoke:

> "In disobedience, his future will have fractured.
> Let the water hold him until his form is mended."

They poured it over his head — again, and again, and again. Not a beating. Not an exile. Something deeper.

A ritual of erasure.

In the days that followed, Leif's name was never spoken. Ceryn issued **casual prophecies** about the others — little requests wrapped in fate — and Leif watched as they obeyed.

But his silence deepened into focus.

He did not submit.
He went to the Library.
And he began his work.

Leif was made to kneel in the rain for three hours.

This was the customary punishment for resisting a sentence spoken in **Prophetic Perfect**. The Vox called it “dissonance with the future,” and his body was to reflect the imbalance — soaked, cold, trembling, his refusal written into his joints.

But his mind remained dry. Clear. And burning.

When released, he said nothing. He ate his rice and broth with the others. He looked down when Ceryn passed, basking in the reverence she now commanded like sunlight. But after evening meal, he slipped away to the **Library of Syntax and Sentence** — a low vault of cedar shelves and glass-framed diagrams where few youths ventured after dusk.

He lit a yellow paper-lamp and found the scroll of **Standard Prophetic Conjugation**. He had always loved this one.

He unrolled the translucent vellum and traced the first line with his finger.

> **“The Prophetic Perfect is constructed using a future auxiliary and a completed aspect.”**

He murmured:

> *I will have walked.*
> *You will have seen.*
> *They will have obeyed.*

The future was always rendered as **inevitably completed**. The act was sealed before it was done. It gave power because it closed doors — even ones not yet opened.

> **Formula:**
> `Subject + will + have + past participle`

But more curious was the margin note — something most students ignored.

> **“The tense is not predictive. It is prescriptive. A tool of causality. A sentence once spoken cannot be disobeyed without rupture.”**

And then, in faded ink — possibly added later:

> *To speak in the Prophetic Perfect is not to say what will happen — it is to collapse the possibilities of what could have.*

He pulled a stack of wax tablets from the child’s table and began scribbling.

Question 1:

> *What if a sentence describes a state that is both fulfilled and unfulfilled?*

Question 2:

> *What happens if the subject is missing?*

Question 3:

> *Can there be a past participle that describes contradiction?*

And then, quietly, he wrote:

I will not have done it.

The candle flickered. The sentence felt… **wrong**. Not ungrammatical — but **paradoxical**.

He wrote again:

You will not have been my master.
We will have walked two paths.
I will have disobeyed — truthfully.

And then:

A new tense is possible.

By custom, the Library was silent.
But for Leif, silence had become the only tongue left to him.

He descended the spiral stair beneath the Chapel of Declension, the air thick with chalk dust and rootwater. Candles glowed in glass cages. Scrolls, grammar wheels, phonetic trees — all carefully categorised. He took a tablet of slate, some graphite sticks, and slipped into an alcove between **“Redundant Moods”** and **“Extinct Grammars.”** There, hidden from the daily tongue-practice exercises, he began to work.

Axioms of the Prophetic Perfect

1. It collapses all verbs into a **future-determined past**.
2. It eliminates possibility.
3. It can only be used by those **granted the right**.
4. The listener becomes bound, else **charged with contradiction**.
5. To resist it is heresy.
6. It is not descriptive. It is **causal**.

He paused. Then scrawled in the margin:

"It is grammar made into law."

He could not speak it.
He could barely even write it without risk.
So he tried to **unmake it.**

He wrote:

“I shall have never been.”
“The truth will not have happened.”
“He will have remembered wrong.”
“She will have walked two paths, and neither.”

They were **paradoxes**, clearly. But within them, something **flexed**. He invented a name for this anti-grammar.

The Potential Subjunctive
A tense where no action becomes absolute — where all futures shimmer, undefined.

He tried writing in its voice.

> “I might have been.”
> “She could have said.”
> “We may yet undo.”

He invented new glyphs. He circled verbs that wavered. He drew arrows through participles. He placed sigils beside sentences to denote **possibility** rather than fulfilment. He called this emerging system **The Refracted Voice —** a tense for those who had no tongue, no power, no authority. It would not collapse the future into obedience. It would widen it into **choice**.

In the alcove behind the shelves of Lost Conjugations, Leif drew a new chart on wax-paper, pinned by bone weights:

The Prophetic Perfect worked because it forced **completion**. It welded intention to action, prediction to outcome. But what if the **actor** was stripped from the sentence?

He wrote:

> “The task will have been fulfilled.”
> “The ritual will have completed.”
> “The door will have opened.”

By whom? When? How?

No subject. No actor. No enforcement.

It **sounded prophetic**, but **commanded nothing**.

> “It will have begun.”
> “Change will have stirred.”

The sentence lives, but no one is its slave.

Then, he tried to turn prophecy **against itself**.

He wrote two sentences in succession:

> “You will have led the circle.”
> “You will have refused leadership.”

He layered them like folds in paper — one prophecy undoing the other. The mind couldn’t reconcile them. The listener would freeze.

He called it a **grammar lock —** a linguistic dead-end.

He imagined whispering this in a crowd.
He imagined Ceryn trying to resolve it.

She would hesitate.
And in that moment **— power would fracture**.

He began inventing sentences with **deliberate vagueness**:

> “It will have been known.”
> “It will have been felt.”
> “It will have been chosen.”

No subject. No cause. No command.

These phrases **sounded like prophecy** — the rhythms were right — but they gave no direction. Only fog.

A Kommune filled with such utterances would **echo with hollow commandments**, until **meaning collapsed**.

He smiled.

Leif's final strategy was the most subtle.

He began threading in modal verbs — *might, could, may, should* — in the **middle** of prophetic constructions:

> "She will have might-been your leader."
> "They will have possibly made the choice."
> "You will have been… if you had."

The sentences **slipped** just enough.

Not disobedient — just… blurry.
Indeterminate.

The kind of sentence that **can't be punished**, because no one can quite define what it commands.

He stitched these tools together, slowly building a **grammar of resistance**.

A language that was **technically prophetic**, but practically **unrulable**.

And then he wrote the name of it at the top of his page:

> **The Dissonant Mode**
> *(For Those Who Do Not Obey)*

The Hall echoed like a mouth mid-prayer.

Stone vaulted and open to the wind, its banners shimmered with declensions in gold thread: **"You Will Have Obeyed."**
The choir of Elders stood cloaked, silent, letting **Ceryn** speak — for now was **her Rite-Week**, and the hall was hers.

Ceryn (raising her voice):
"Leif will have joined the Circle before second toll."

The congregation murmured affirmations. Her voice rang with power.

Leif stood in the threshold.
Eyes on him.
If he moved forward, he fulfilled the prophecy.
If he stayed back, he violated it.

His muscles locked. He looked down.
Then… he exhaled.
He raised his hand.

Leif:
"The Circle may have gathered. The boy could have watched from afar."

Gasps.
Some Elders tilted their heads, parsing.

It *sounded* like prophecy.
But it **did not bind**.
It was ambiguous, reflexive, modal.

Ceryn:
"Leif will have stood among his equals."

Leif:
"One might have stood. One might not have. The truth may have layered."

He walked **— sideways —** not into the Circle, but along its edge.

Now the room **wavered**.

One Elder leaned forward.

Elder Callun:
“Did he resist? Or did he fulfill some **possible** prophecy?”

Ceryn:
“He will have spoken in the Voice! He does not bear the Right!”

Leif:
**“The Voice might have moved through any mouth.
A ripple might have carried.
The Word might have found a crack.”**

The air stilled.

For the first time in living memory, a **non-anointed** speaker had used the sacred cadence — and **no punishment descended**.

He bowed.

Leif:
"The wind will have blown strange today."

And turned to leave.

They met in the abandoned phonetics lab, two floors beneath the acoustics vaults — where the echo chambers had collapsed long ago, and no utterance bounced back.

Here, Leif scratched grammar-trees on slate tiles with boiled ash.
No names. No chalk.
Only breath, gesture, and careful folds of syntax.

Ten children gathered. All **unlicensed** to speak the Perfect.
All punished in small ways for hesitation, forgetfulness, softness of tone.

He called them:

> *The Hesitants.*

They called him:

> *The Forked Tongue.*

He taught them not to prophesy, but to **bend the possible**.

Each lesson opened with a refrain:

> **"To speak a sentence is to sketch a path.
> To speak a prophecy is to pave it.
> To speak Dissonance is to open a gate."**

He taught them modal encryption:

- “He will have known” → becomes → “It may have been known to someone.”
- “You will have submitted” → becomes → “Submission could have passed through one who resembled you.”
- “They will have punished you” → becomes → “Punishment may no longer have mattered.”

Each phrase carried **semantic fog**. Enough to **resist enforcement** without **triggering contradiction**.

The Hesitants took the Dissonant Mode out — into their chore rotations, their liturgy classes, the silent walks through the orchard cloisters.

They whispered variant phrases:

- “It may already have been resolved.”
- “We might not need what hasn’t fully arrived.”
- “This could have unfolded otherwise.”

At first, no one noticed. Then — a teacher hesitated before correcting them. A record-keeper blinked at a contradictory script. An Elder, asked a question, gave no answer.

It spread in side-notes, in gossip phrased carefully, in songs that did not rhyme but pulsed with modal uncertainty.

Soon, one child wrote:

> **"I might have never wanted what was promised."**

And another copied it on the underside of a meal tray.

The Forum of Inflection, the oldest hall in the Kommune. Its stones were inscribed with conjugations; its pillars bore glyphs of mood and voice. *Culture must be lived at full scale before it can be abstracted.* This is where **every Rite-Speaker had once claimed their power** — and where Leif was now summoned.

Ceryn stood at the centre, cloaked in ochre silk. Her eyes sharp with the cadence of perfect speech.

Leif entered in plain cloth, with a slight smile and no right to prophecy.

The Elders formed a silent circle.

Elder Callun:
"The accused will have obeyed.
The challenge will have proceeded.
Grammar will have governed us."

The Hall of Utterance was packed.
Stone columns thrummed with tension.
The **Prophetic Choir** gathered at the edges, humming low chords of syntax, the sacred harmonics of time-bound speech.

Ceryn stood beneath the hanging glyph of Finality.
Her robe bore the silver glyphs of **Perfect Authority**.
Leif walked in bare-foot, ash-smudged, clutching only a slate.

They faced one another.
Two tongues. One truth.

An Elder intoned:

> "The Contest of Proclamation shall begin."

Ceryn (firm, controlled):
"Leif will have stepped forward. He will have accepted guidance. He will have surrendered his fragments."

A pulse rippled through the Hall.
A web of causality formed — glistening, ready to bind.

Leif did not move.
He raised his head slowly.

Leif (softly):
"That may have been possible. But it will not have been mine."

A flicker in the net.
Ceryn's nostrils flared.

Ceryn:
"You will have been part of the Whole. You will have been restored. The Dissonant will have dissolved."

Leif (calm):
"That prophecy belonged to a past that might not have finished itself."

Ceryn:
"You will have confessed!"

Leif (stepping forward):
"I might not have owned what was never spoken by me."

The web trembled. A few Choir members gasped.

Ceryn:
**"You will have obeyed.
You will have fallen.
You will have remembered this submission."**

And then—
Leif **stepped into the centre**.

He took a breath.
And he said — plainly, cleanly, without rhythm or reverence:

> **"No. I will not do that."**

The Hall stopped.
As if syntax itself cracked.

One voice.
One rejection.
No hedging. No subjunctive.
Not prophecy.
Not dissonance.

Just the **present moment**.
Just a **self**.

Ceryn's glyphs flickered.
The lattice that had held her sentences aloft wavered.
Her final clause — *You will have remembered this submission* — collapsed in semantic dust.

Leif stood.
He said nothing more.

He didn't need to.

The Elders would not know what to say.
They had no grammar for **rejection without rebellion**.
No rule for one who simply **refused to future**.

Leif walked away, his back bare, his tense **entirely human**.

(Jack waited for the others to respond, but nobody did.)

Jack:
So? What say the Choir of Critics?

Mina:
It's a classic. Philology meets philosophical takedown of tyranny. You've basically rewritten *Antigone* with a grammar textbook and a better haircut.

Felix:
It had bite. And real tension. And the moment he just said "No" — that wasn't prophecy, that was jazz.

Rhea:
It’s funny how language can be used like architecture — but you made it a weapon. The syntax of sovereignty. Honestly, I’m going to be hearing that last line in my head all week.

Clive:
You’ll have already quoted it.

Abbie:
Mina did you say you had something?

Mina:
Yes. Mine’s a poem. Not a parable. A fragment — but in full **Prophetic Perfect**. Call it a hymn from an unbuilt temple.

They will have dwelt beneath the hill,
Where the roots of oaks cradled the archive of breath.

They will have eaten together, in silence and salt,
And the laughter will have lifted the rafters.

One will have brought fire,
Another, the shape of the bowl.
A third will have remembered the name of the wind.

And so it will have begun:

The garden will have bent to their joy.
The books will have opened themselves.
The night will have bowed its head.

They will not have ruled one another —
Yet the strong will have sheltered the tender,
And the clever will have translated the stars.

No coin will have passed between them,
But all things will have been earned.

They will have argued in truth.
They will have sung in ten dialects.
They will have disagreed with grace.

When strangers came,
They will have shared bread,
And offered ink, and wool, and a story.

Their children will have climbed the rafters,
Naming planets with each step.

And one day,
When the city above forgot its name—

They will have remembered.

(The fire is low. There's a stillness in the air—not solemn, just deeply exhaled. Laura is braiding lavender stalks into a circle. Felix is lying with his head on a moss pillow, bouncing a light-up ball. Rhea is sketching a diagram on the edge of a tea coaster. Jack is flipping through a book titled Syntactical Utopias: Experiments in Formed Life. Ash stands, stretching.)

Abbie:
If you had to start from scratch—one Kommune, one locus, one dream… what would you build?

Laura:
I'd build a kitchen on a hill. With a root cellar and a bread calendar. Where every season has a flavour, and every visitor brings their mother's spice.

Felix:
I'd build a temple of sound. No walls. Just weatherproof speakers and low lighting. Rites by subwoofer. Sermons in bass.

Rhea:
You already did. It's called your playlist.

Ash:
I mean it. A real outpost. Like The Stack. Just… different. A sister site. A node.

Jack:
Mine would be a philosophy Kommune.

Mina:
Of course it would.

Jack:
No, truly. A place where thinking is sacred. Where ideas are seeded like crops, debated like weather. Where disagreement isn't just tolerated—it's ritualised. A polis of the mind. With morning readings and midnight dialogues. Maybe even a Logic Garden.

Rhea:
You mean like a monastery, but with better coffee?

Jack:
No vows. Just questions. No hierarchy. Just depth.

Laura:
And who cooks for the philosophers while they debate who deserves soup?

Felix:
We all take turns, obviously. There's a rotating Dinner Provocateur. They pick a theme. You must cook and argue in tandem.

Ash:
I love that. *Dialectical Dining.*

Ash (softly):
It's strange, isn't it… That we don't have a tense for this. This exact kind of moment.

Jack (nodding):
Aureom maybe, the golden moment. Like we're watching the memory form.

Mina:
Stillness that you want to hold open like a book. Not just because it's peaceful, but because it *glows.* I want a tense for… when you're *in* it. And you *know it.* And you want the other person to *feel* how much you're feeling it too.

Jack:
A tense that carries the weight of: *please let this stay.* Not with desperation. But with fullness. You speak in stillform when you're living in such deep harmony with the moment that even your words don't want to move.

Mina:
Say something in it.

Jack:
We sitstill, nowglow.
(He looks at her, gently.)
It means: I'm aware this is one of the finest instants of my life. And I want you to feel it with me, while we're both still inside it.

Ash:
I speak now in the aureom. This will-have-been one of those mornings we carried.

We will-have-sat like this—coffee still warm, the house slow with sunlight.
Felix will-have-been barefoot on the tiles, saying something half-true and entirely kind.
Mina will-have-hummed that same three-note song again.
And Jack—you will-have-stared at the beam above the stove like it had something new to tell you.

(A few soft smiles. Jack meets Ash's eyes, says nothing.)

We will-have-laughed at something that won't matter next week.
We will-have-forgotten the joke, but not the sound.

Someone's hand will-have-brushed someone else's.
No intention—just the gravity of bodies at peace.

And this—this stillness right now—
we will-have-loved it.

This is the part of our lives that will become the goldthread.

Not the ambition. Not the argument. Not the archive.
Just this: toast crumbs, quiet, and a kind of forever folded gently into the ordinary."

(Silence. Held. No one wants to break it. The group sits in low light. Someone has asked Jack for a story in his new tense. He pauses, closes his eyes briefly, then begins speaking softly, as if seeing it through memory.)

Jack:

They will-have-sat at the edge of the firelight. Knees just touching. One log between them. The last piece of oak crackling down to embers.

She will-have-brought the blanket. He will-have-failed to pack one. That was their rhythm. She prepared. He forgot.

They speak now in the aureom. Because neither can bear to say goodbye the usual way.

“You will-have-been the reason I looked forward to evening,” she tells him, eyes not quite meeting his.

He nods. *“You will-have-filled the silence I didn’t know I’d miss.”*

The night is still. The kind of still that doesn’t last.

“You will-have-laughed at my worst jokes,” she says, lips curving like it’s already gone.

“And you,” he says, *“will-have-cried once, into my coat, when you thought I was asleep.”*

The fire dips. Shadows rise like old stories behind them.

“If I never see you again,” she says, *“you will-have-been the one I loved right.”*

He doesn’t reply straight away. His voice is careful when it comes:

“And you will-have-been the only one who didn’t want me to be better. Just... truer.”

They sitstill. Not in fear. But in full. Time folds in.

This night, this fire, this closeness—they will-have-carried it. It will echo across future beds, missed trains, distant cities.

And long after their last letter is lost in the tide of forgetting, this moment will still flare warm inside them.

They will-have-burned bright. And gentle.

That will-have-been enough.

Rhea:
Do you think every Kommune should have its own tense?

Jack:
Not should. Will. If it lasts long enough. If it means enough.

Laura:
It’s already happening. You hear it. Some groups double verbs—*we eat-eat now*—to mean shared feasting. Others drop the subject entirely: *Speak now. Leave when.* It's not slang. It's structure.

Felix:
That’s kind of wild. Like… buildings determine grammar.

Jack:
They do. A house with one long table and no private rooms? You start speaking in the *present-communal* whether you mean to or not. A rooftop garden shared by five households? Suddenly you need a word for the feeling of being alone *together* in the same space.

Mina:
So language becomes *spatial*. Ritualised. Local. Like accents, but deeper.

Jack:
Exactly. This is one of the hidden theses of the Isle Principle: **each Kommune becomes its own dialect engine.** Because every architectural form encodes values, and values shape expression.

Rhea:
Does that mean a Kommune can go... linguistically rogue?

Jack:
They don't go rogue. They **bloom**. Each one becomes a new verbal ecology—rooted in shared meals, light patterns, silence customs, door designs.

Felix:
So if one Kommune lives mostly underground...

Laura:
They'll probably speak more slowly. Echo less. Develop tenses for delayed hearing.

Jack:
Or invent a suffix for tone-light, not just sound: *'speakglow,'* meaning: I say this gently.

(A silence. Warm. Imagining. The group starts thinking about how they would plan their own Kommune.)

Abbie:
Alright. Let's stop playing. Let's plan. We're calling it a node, right?

Felix:
A London node. An urban outpost of The Stack. Myth and moss, with central heating.

Rhea:
It'll never work. London eats intention. It's too fast, too flat. People won't slow down long enough to notice they're in a ritual.

Jack:
Then we'll design for slowness. Like friction architecture. Everything requires deliberation. No doors without stories. No kettles without questions.

Abbie:
Okay. First question: location.

Laura:
South. Peckham or Nunhead. Somewhere with old bones. Quiet side streets. Houses with gardens and garages. Enough brick to feel anchored.

Felix:
Or Hackney Wick. We reclaim some post-industrial flats. Ex-breweries, old warehouses. Somewhere near the canal. Myth reflected in water.

Rhea:
Too obvious. Too cool already. Let's go somewhere ignored. Morden. Woolwich. Barking. Make beauty where no one's looking.

Abbie:
Good. Next—structure. We knock together three, four terrace houses. Connect the back gardens. Make a shared courtyard. Vertical farm modules. Solar mesh on the roofs.

Jack:
Central hall. Library as hearth. No television. Communal reading hours. And a myth wall—somewhere to hang new verses.

Laura:
Big kitchen. Stone floors. Long table. Breakfasts should feel like feasts, even on grey Mondays.

Felix:
Studio in the basement. Sound-proofed. Multi-use. Raves. Sermons. Recording dreams.

Abbie:
Roles?

Mina:
Rotating. One month you're Archivist. One month you're Garden Keeper. One month you're the Mythbringer.

Rhea:
What's a Mythbringer?

Mina:
The person responsible for tone. They set the myth of the week. Choose the sentence we all build around.

Felix:
Oh yes. Like: *'This week will have tested our softness.'* Or *'The table will have remembered us.'*

Jack:
We could write them on linen and hang them above the door. The city won't understand—but the house will.

Abbie:
Weekly rites?

Laura:
Sunday feasts. Friday footbaths. Midweek poem circles. Silence hours before sunrise.

Felix:
Guest nights. Anyone can bring one outsider per moon. But they have to tell a story to earn their supper.

Rhea:
What about conflict? Consensus culture is a cult.

Jack:
Every full moon: a Forum of Friction. Formal disagreements aired as ritual theatre. No resolution needed. Just clarity and wine.

Abbie:
And if someone breaks alignment?

Mina:
They get written into the myth. As caution. Or as flame.

(A pause. They're quiet again—but now it feels heavier. Like something has begun. HOMERA pulses.)

HOMERA:
Node blueprint initiated. Title?

Abbie:
Suggestions?

Jack:
Call it *Form*.

Felix:
Form House. Stack South. The House That Speaks.

Laura:
The Hearth of Becoming.

Rhea:
Just... *The Node*. Let people name it with time.

Abbie:
Alright. Four terrace houses. Knock out the back walls. Merge the gardens into one living courtyard. Each house keeps its upstairs—private quarters. Everything else becomes shared.

Jack:
East-facing main room. Morning light must hit the library. Let thought begin with dawn.

Laura:
We pave the ground floor in limestone. Cool underfoot in summer. Holds the heat in winter. And no shoes past the entry hall.

Rhea:
What's the entry ritual?

Mina:
Visitors must speak one sentence of truth. And leave one item of value—not monetary. Sentimental, symbolic, poetic.

Felix:
So you enter barefoot, say: *'My mother once gave me a pebble and said it was patience.'* Then you leave the pebble in the wall niche.

Abbie:
Perfect. Now—communal zones.

(She sketches.)

– House One: The Library & Archive
– House Two: The Kitchen & Table
– House Three: The Bath & Garden
– House Four: The Studio & Sleep Hall

Jack:
Ceiling-high shelves. Rolling ladders. Glass doors. No electronics inside. The entire history lives here.

Rhea:
A silence room. No speech allowed—only writing. A place to listen to thought before it becomes language.

Ash:
Underground vault for foundational texts. And an AI interface chamber.

Mina:
Let the walls hold whispers. Carve lines into the brick. Our own myth, as it grows.

Laura:
A stone hearth. Not just metaphorical—real fire. Cooking is slow. Ceremonial. Everyone must cook one dish per season.

Felix:
An inventory of spices. All labelled with verses. Like: *'Clove – for remembering pain sweetly.'*

Rhea:
Communal table, ten meters long. Mismatched chairs. Conversations stitched into the wood in thread.

Abbie:
Overhead skylight. Morning meals under clouds.

Mina:
A room of steam. Copper pipes. Eucalyptus hanging from the rafters. Bathing is myth here.

Laura:
And a cold plunge pool under an open skylight.

Felix:
In the garden: herb spiral, vertical beds, bees. Tomatoes grown beside philosophy.

Jack:
A stone bench beneath a fig tree. For single thoughts. Or for breaking silence.

Felix:
Sound-proof studio. Modular. For speech, music, dreaming aloud. Black walls. One red thread across the ceiling.

Abbie:
Above: The Sleep Hall. Communal sleeping chambers for rituals. Solstice sleeps. Full moon dreams. Everyone wears white linen.

Rhea:
Optional solitude rooms. Painted dark blue. One small candle. A mirror. A prompt.

Rhea:
How do we fund it?

Abbie:
Hybrid. Staggered buy-in. Bitcoin treasury. Crowdfunded myth fund. Optional patron memberships for guests who don't stay.

Jack:
And what keeps it from drifting?

Mina:
Three written principles. Engraved in the threshold.

1. Speak with intent.
2. Live in myth.
3. Welcome the sacred unknown.

Felix:
And once a year, we rewrite them.

(A stillness settles. The fire pops. Outside, the rain begins—light on the skylights.)

Abbie:
This will have existed.

(The Kommune glows with the last of its low light. Books lie open. Mugs are abandoned, still warm. Ash has folded up her plans. Jack stands and stretches, spine crackling. A shared sigh moves through the room.)

Laura:
I think I'm ready to leave this dimension now.

Felix:
Agreed. Time to return to the land of duvets and loose pyjamas.

Rhea:
Wait—did we just accidentally found a Kommune and write four new rites before dawn?

Abbie:
Five. Don't forget the ritual of the neglected kettle.

Mina:
And the philosophy nap. That was canonised.

Jack:
We've always done this. This is what being human used to be for.

Laura:
Well, being human now involves my knees clicking. Shall we?

Felix:
Back to the house?

Abbie:
Yeah. Let's go back to the Islington place. Someone light the boiler. I want a bath that smells like lavender and inevitability.

Rhea:
And toast. I want toast. With something mythically buttery.

Jack:
Let's walk. I want the city to feel strange again. I want traffic lights to look like relics.

Laura:
And pigeons to look like prophecies.

Felix:
And the kebab shops to speak in tongues.

(They all laugh—quiet, light-headed, blurry around the edges.)

Mina:
It really was a good night, wasn't it?

Abbie:
Yeah. It was one of those nights that'll echo for years.

HOMERA:
Archive saved. Thread sealed.

(They pause at the door, looking back once at the Stack—the hearth, the shelves, the moss, the memory.)

Jack:
Thank you.

(Then they step out into the brightening grey of the city, the hum of bins being dragged, birds yelling into the morning, buses sighing. And somewhere, not far, toast is already burning. The front door to the Islington house clicks open—quiet, reverent. Jack pushes it with his shoulder, the others trailing behind like shadows peeling off the night. The city is grey with early light. The house smells faintly of toast crumbs, dried basil, and books.)

Laura:

I feel like we just came back from a pilgrimage.

Felix:
That *was* a pilgrimage. Just with better snacks and louder philosophy.

(The house is warm in the way that good old London houses can be—tired wood, familiar furniture, a quiet that's lived in. Someone's left fairy lights on in the hallway. There's a half-burnt candle on the kitchen table, and a kettle that remembers too much.)

They scatter, slow and clumsy:

- **Laura** heads to the kitchen bench, curls up with her coat as a pillow, already halfway dreaming.
- **Felix** drops straight onto the big living room sofa, hoodie up, one arm trailing on the floor.
- **Rhea** stretches out on the rug, hands behind her head, staring at the ceiling with a soft, unblinking smile.

- **Jack** lingers, flicking the hallway light off, before sitting cross-legged near the bookshelf, leaning his back against it, as if guarding something wordless.

Felix:
Best night of my life. Or at least… the best one I can remember right now.

Laura:
Don’t ruin it by ranking it.

Rhea:
Let’s just agree it was mythic. And leave it there.

Jack:
It will have been one of the nights that rewrites the rest.

(A silence falls. Not awkward. Not sleepy. Just full. The kind that only comes after speaking something real, and being heard.)

Rhea:
Think Ash and Mina are still there?

Jack:
Of course. They’re the bones of it. They’ll close the circle. Let it settle.

Felix:
We’ll go back.

Laura:
Soon. After toast. And sleep. Maybe marmalade.

Book X

(The house breathes differently in the morning. Sunlight spills across the kitchen tiles. Toast crumbs from some half-remembered midnight snack litter the counter. Someone's left the tap dripping. Outside, London murmurs with Monday.)

Rhea:
My back's wrecked. And I'd still do it all again tonight.

Felix:
Same. I feel like I've been exorcised. Of what, I don't know. But something left me.

Laura:
We need orange juice and croissants. And a flag. We should've stolen something ceremonial on the way out.

Jack:
We didn't need to take anything. We brought it back with us.

Rhea:
God, you're already mythologising it.

Jack:
I'm just saying—it wasn't just a good night. It was *something else*. I can feel it already, how we'll remember it. How it'll shape the way we do things now.

Felix:
Yeah… like... I've been talking about Kommunes for years. But now I know what it smells like. What it tastes like. How silence feels inside one.

Laura:
It made it real. Not utopian. Just… lived. Like, I could see how it works. The flow of people, the unspoken rules, the way a kitchen becomes sacred just by *everyone agreeing it is*.

Rhea:
And how it *doesn't* work, too. The way Ash gets a little sharp when the ritual loses focus. The weird silence when HOMERA says something too true. The friction. I liked it. It wasn't perfect.

Jack:
Exactly. That's what made it beautiful. It had texture. Nothing glossy. Just form, and breath, and people holding space for each other.

(A pause as they each sip something—coffee, tea, silence.)

Felix:
Do you think we'll end up doing it?

Laura:
Starting our own?

Felix:
Yeah. Actually going through with it. A London node. Stack South. Myth-house in a terrace row.

Rhea:
We'd need to be ready. It's not just hanging curtains and inventing rites. It's commitment. Living together. Making decisions when you're tired or annoyed or heartbroken.

Jack:
That's what I want. A place where that kind of living is honoured. Not hidden away. Not rushed through. Just… seen.

Laura:
I didn't realise how much I missed that feeling. Of being part of something that made sense *without explanation.* Where no one asked what you 'do'—they just asked what you believed.

Rhea:
And you could answer in poetry.

Felix:
Or by making soup.

Jack:
'The night will have begun what the day now carries.'

Laura:
Put that on a napkin.

Felix:
Put it on the wall.

Rhea:
Put it in the constitution of wherever the hell we're going next.

(A silence again. This one is warm, full of permission. They're not making promises. Just recognising what's begun.)

Jack:
It doesn't have to be next week. But it started. Last night. Whether we follow it or not.

Laura:
We will.

Felix:
Yeah. We already are.

(The sun shifts. The kitchen hums. Someone starts cutting bread. The house—just a normal house—feels different now. Not holy, not magical, just ready. The kitchen is full of long shadows and warm plates. Someone's put on a record that sounds like late-morning thinking. They're all slouched in chairs, half-fed, half-dressed, but alert in that post-myth way where the world feels too present to ignore.)

Jack:
I've been thinking about last night. Not just what we did. But *how it was felt.*

Laura:
God, that sounds like a Jack sentence already.

Jack:
Sorry. But seriously—what we had, it wasn't just 'nice.' It was constructed. Crafted. *Curated experience.*

Felix:
Like a good setlist. You don't stumble into flow. You build it.

Rhea:
So what are you saying? That vibes are the new virtue?

Jack:
I'm saying: phenomenology is ethics now.

(They all blink. It lands.)

Jack:
The quality of consciousness—the felt texture of being alive in a moment—that's the real site of eudaimonia. Not just pleasure. Not productivity. But that deep coherence you feel when the internal and external line up. Like last night. Something about it was… architected. But free.

Laura:
It was like being inside a poem. And you didn't want to analyse it. Just stay in it.

Felix:
It was *felt thought*. Embodied. Lived. Like… the whole night was a sentence we co-wrote.

Rhea:
I liked that it wasn't trying to be good. It wasn't designed for Instagram. It just… *was.*

Jack:
That's the thing. We're not taught to *build experience.* We're taught to chase outcomes. To hoard time. To measure the self. But last night was about *presence as practice.* That's the real moral act.

Laura:
God, yes. We spend so much of life in abstraction. Even therapy's abstract. But last night I felt like my soul *touched ground*.

Felix:
I think we forget that joy is something you have to learn to host. It doesn't just arrive. You *invite it*.

Rhea:
So what—are we philosophers of the vibe now?

Jack:
Absolutely. *Phenomenological architects of eudaimonia.* The design of joy. The ritual of realness. The aesthetics of being human.

Laura:
Honestly, that's the best job title I've ever heard.

Felix:
Put it on the door.

Rhea:
Put it on a flag.

Jack:
If we did nothing else in our lives but *create better experience*—spaces like last night, moments like that—we'd have already given the world something holy.

(A silence falls—not heavy, just true. The kind of silence that doesn't require anything next.)

Felix:
We made something last night. Not a Kommune. Not a plan. Just… a moment. But it'll live with us.

Laura:
Because it was deliberate. And because we were all there. Not just in the room. *In the room.*

Rhea:
I want more of that. Not more stuff. Not more success. Just… that.

*(The sun spills golden across the table. A pigeon thumps onto the windowsill. Outside, the city moves. But inside the house, four friends sit in the aftermath of something quiet and vast—**the memory of experience, still forming into myth.**)*

Rhea:
You know what I've been thinking? We'll never remember it *accurately.*

Laura:
Last night?

Rhea:
Yeah. Already it's changing. Already I'm forgetting the exact tone of the room. The way the moss smelled. The way Felix kept twirling that pen. Memory's not storage. It's sculpture.

Felix:
So we're all already carving it up. Making our own version.

Jack:
Memory isn't what happened. It's *what becomes of what happened.*

Laura:
It's collaborative too, isn't it? Like, we're shaping it *right now* just by talking about it.

Jack:
Exactly. And that makes memory a *moral act.* A creative one. Not just passive recall.

Felix:
Whoa. Wait. So are you saying there's an *ethics of remembering*?

Jack:
Absolutely. What you choose to preserve. What you let go. What you reframe. It all feeds back into the self. Into culture. Into myth.

Rhea:
So when we remember badly—sloppily, selfishly—it shapes us that way too.

Laura:
That's why I don't like nostalgia. It's lazy remembering. It pretends the past is a picture, not a poem.

Felix:
I kind of love that though. The idea that memory is poetry. Not fact. A crafted thing.

Jack:
The ancients knew that. Before hard drives. Before timelines. Memory was a *garden.* Something tended. Watered. Not harvested.

Rhea:
And myths? Just memories that got too beautiful to stay factual.

Laura:
Then maybe what we did last night wasn't just live something—we *planted it*. And now we have to tend to it.

Felix:
Retell it. Reshape it. Not to make it false, but to keep it *alive*.

Jack:
Yes. Because the goal isn't to remember it perfectly. It's to remember it *meaningfully*.

(A quiet settles again—like breath held in a shared dream.)

Laura:
One day we'll say, *'Remember that night in The Stack?'* And we'll all nod. But we'll be nodding to different nights. And it won't matter.

Rhea:
Because the memory will have done its job. It'll have shaped who we are by then.

Felix:
I'm still carving mine. Might add a fog machine and some Gregorian chanting.

Jack:
Add what you like. That's the point. Just do it with care.

(The room holds them for a moment—four people mid-sentence, mid-life, mid-memory. Outside, the day stretches forward. Inside, they continue to sculpt the night that made them feel real.)

Laura:
Is it weird that I didn't take a single photo last night?

Felix:
I think that's a sign it was actually good.

Rhea:
Yeah, the real moments never want to be documented. They'd rather be *lived*.

Jack:
True. But then how do we hold them? The night's fading already, even as we talk.

Laura:
Sometimes I wish there was a way to press a feeling into paper. Not words. Just… the shape of it. Like drying a flower. But emotional.

Felix:
We try, don't we? Diaries. Voice notes. Those blurry videos from 3am that make no sense but feel perfect.

Rhea:
Photos always flatten it. You remember the pose, not the mood. The outfit, not the sound.

Jack:
That's because photos are static. Memory isn't. Memory is *interpretation over time.*

Felix:
I like that. The idea that a diary entry is less about recording what happened, and more about recording how I *saw* it.

Laura:
Do any of you keep a proper diary?

Rhea:
I tried. It always turned into sarcasm and to-do lists.

Felix:
I have a dream log. Most of it's nonsense. But sometimes I write down real nights in dream-logic. Makes them feel more true.

Jack:
I write reflections. Not what I did, but what it *meant*. What it added to the narrative of me.

Laura:
I like objects. Like, if I wore a certain dress or used a certain mug during a good time—I keep it. The memory lives in the fabric.

Rhea:
So we're all doing it. Holding memory. Just with different rituals.

Jack:
And maybe the ritual is more important than the medium. It's not about *accuracy.* It's about *recognition.*

Felix:
Maybe we should have a memory shelf.

Laura:
Ooh. In the house?

Felix:
Yeah. Little tokens from nights like that. A cork. A page. A leaf. A sentence. Something that carries the echo.

Rhea:
But not explained. No labels. Just… let the object hold the feeling. Like a private key to a shared moment.

Jack:
A physical myth. An archive of soulweight.

Laura:
We could each put something from last night on it. Doesn't matter what. Just… something that meant 'this happened.'

Rhea:
I like that. Not to prove it. Just to *respect* it.

(The idea settles in the room. It feels gentle. Possible. Like planting a seed in a place the light already knows.)

Felix:
I'm going to write something. Not for anyone else. Just for me. To catch the feeling before it drifts.

Jack:
And I'll write something too. Not about what happened. Just what it *was.*

Rhea:
Do you ever think about how weird it is that Plato is still being talked about? Like, someone you've never met, never will, and you carry their thoughts around in your mouth.

Felix:
He's like a ghost with a microphone.

Jack:
That's the cost of being memorable. You stop being a person. You become *public language.*

Laura:
Isn't that what everyone wants though? To be remembered?

Jack:
Yes—and no. People say they want to be remembered. What they really want is to be *loved* and *understood*. Memory without love is just surveillance. Legacy without intimacy is a statue you can't touch.

Rhea:
So fame is just being trapped in other people's memory? Forever?

Jack:
Yes. And it steals your privacy retroactively. Once you're famous, everything you did when you weren't becomes symbolic. You lose your solitude *in reverse*.

Felix:
Plato can't have a bad day. Not anymore. It's all either 'brilliant contradiction' or 'evidence of genius.'

Laura:
So what's the alternative? Live quietly and disappear?

Jack:
Maybe. But think about this: what if being the centre of memory *is* a kind of immortality? You're not just remembered—you become a living structure. A psychic monument.

Rhea:
But at what cost? If every word you speak becomes lore, do you ever get to be *small* again?

Jack:
That's what I wrestle with. If I'm honest.

(The room quiets.)

Jack:
Sometimes I wonder if self-worth is linked to scale. If your actions ripple far enough, wide enough—if you become discussed, dissected, mythologised—does that make your life more *real*? More *valuable*?

Felix:
Or just more visible?

Laura:
There's a difference between having a soul and being a symbol.

Jack:
But Plato's soul *is* a symbol now. He lives in the margins of every philosophy book, in the mouths of students, in the models of states. He might be *more alive* now than when he was just a man.

Rhea:
That's terrifying.

Jack:
It's also beautiful. Maybe the soul wants to be remembered. Maybe we write and speak and live the way we do *because* we want to become a kind of architecture. Something people can walk through long after we're gone.

Laura:
But don't you ever want to be *just you*? Not a myth. Not a quote. Just… someone unremarkable in a beautiful way?

Jack:
All the time. But part of me wants both. To be *tenderly known* by those I love—and *grandly remembered* by those who come after.

Felix:
I think that's why we make things. Art. Books. Even dinners. We want to be experienced *beyond the moment*, but not lost in abstraction.

Rhea:
And maybe the real magic is finding the balance. Becoming memorable *without disappearing*.

Jack:
I think that's what the soul is. The part of you that can be remembered… *without distortion*.

(The sun creeps higher on the wall. The silence that follows is full—not awkward, not empty. Just heavy with a kind of sacred doubt.)

Laura:
Okay. So we remember Plato. But I want to remember *this*. This morning. This room. This version of us.

Felix:
Plato can keep his immortality. I'll take *this breakfast*.

Jack:
Sometimes I get scared that I'm already becoming… a character.

(The others pause. Laura sets down the knife.)

Rhea:
What do you mean?

Jack:
I mean… people quote me. Even you lot. I hear my own phrases come back to me like I'm already in the past. Like I've stopped being a person and become an idea.

Felix:
You're still here, Jack.

Jack:
Am I? Or am I already being *curated*? Edited into digestibility. The Philosopher. The Voice. The Guy Who Speaks In Perfect Tense.

Laura:
But you *are* brilliant. People remember what hits them.

Jack:
I know. And I love that. I love meaning something. But the more it happens, the more I feel like I'm being sculpted in real time. Every word I speak now gets measured against the idea of 'Jack the Philosopher.' It's exhausting.

(A silence. It lands hard.)

Rhea:
So stop. Let yourself be messy. Be silent for a while. Be wrong.

Jack:
I don't know if I can. I've built this *myth of coherence* around myself. I talk about the Prophetic Perfect, about speech with intent—and now I'm terrified that if I ever say anything half-formed, it'll *fracture* everything. I'll be remembered wrong. Or worse—*too clearly.*

Felix:
You're scared of being frozen.

Jack:
Yes. Because once you live in history, you lose your freedom to evolve. I think about people like Marcus Aurelius or Simone Weil or even… fucking Elon Musk. They stop being selves. They start being symptoms.

Laura:
So what’s the answer? Be small? Anonymous?

Jack:
That’s the conflict, isn’t it? Do you *live in the moment*—spontaneous, joyful, private—or do you *live with a low time preference*, carefully planting the seeds of legacy, of civilization, of your own future myth?

Rhea:
Maybe there’s no answer. Just a tension you learn to dance inside.

Felix:
I mean… Plato probably thought about this too. What if he didn’t *want* to be eternal? What if he just wanted a nice meal and one good line of dialogue?

Jack:
“I don’t want to be a marble bust. I want to be… *a human*. Loved in the present, not just cited in the future.

Laura:
Then start now. Say something sloppy. Spill jam on your shirt. Be annoying.

Rhea:
Get it over with. Misquote yourself.

Jack:
I fear my soul is too online for that.

Felix:
Then maybe you need to log out of history for a bit.

Jack:
Maybe I do.

(He leans back. Breathes. The group doesn’t solve it. They just let it be. Like all real tensions—it’s not a problem to be fixed, but a truth to carry carefully.)

Laura:
You’ll be remembered, Jack. But not just for what you say. Also for *how you make people feel*. And that… that part is private. It’s not in the books. It’s in here.

Rhea:
The thing is… it’s always already gone, isn’t it?

Laura:
What is?

Rhea:
The best of it. The magic. The moment. You never know it’s *the moment* until it’s already sliding past you. That’s the trick. Life doesn’t announce itself while it’s being beautiful.

(She pauses. They all listen.)

Rhea:
We talk about memory and legacy and being remembered. But honestly? Most of it slips by. The

most vivid nights, the purest laughs, the best walks, the most profound conversations—they dissolve *as* they happen. You only notice how real it was when you're already missing it.

Felix:
Like those last few seconds of a song you love. You're not ready for it to end, but it already is.

Jack:
And then you hit repeat—but it's never quite the same.

Laura:
That's why we reach for memory. It's a way of saying: *I noticed. I was here.*

Rhea:
Yeah. But even that is a shadow. You never get the full feeling back. Just a glint. A fingerprint.

Felix:
Do you think that's sad?

Rhea:
I used to. But now I think it's… tender. Like life is holding itself lightly. Not gripping. Just brushing past, saying: *I was beautiful. That's enough.*

Laura:
God, I love you when you say things like that.

Rhea:
Don't get used to it.

Jack:
You're right. We want the eternal, but what we *get*—and maybe what we actually need—is the ephemeral. The half-noticed. The breeze, not the monument.

(Jack has been quiet a while. The others are lounging in the afterglow of their gene-editing discussion, half-faded, half-there. The record player has gone silent. Jack looks up slowly, a glimmer in his eye.)

Jack:
I want a tense that doesn't exist.

Rhea:
Here we go.

Jack:
No, hear me out. I want a tense that lets me say: *'I am living this now, knowing it will become a treasured memory then.'* A grammar that acknowledges *this moment* as memory-in-construction. A kind of… pre-nostalgic present.

Laura:
Like a future-perfect that carries emotion? A moment pre-soaked in meaning?

Jack:
Yes. Exactly. It's not just that something will have happened. It's that it will have mattered. It's already becoming sacred *as it unfolds*.

Felix:
So what would you call it?

Jack:
Not Future Perfect. Too cold. Too technical. Maybe… *Recollective Present*? Or… *The Living Memory Tense.*

Rhea:
Sounds like a perfume.

Jack:
Then it's working.

Laura:
What would a sentence sound like in that tense?

Jack:
This... this right now... *will have been being made holy.*

Felix:
That's exactly what this is.

Jack:
That's what I mean. Some moments *know themselves*. They arrive already wrapped in their own echo. They don't need to be remembered later to be known as precious now.

Rhea:
So it's a kind of conscious nostalgia? But without loss?

Jack:
Yes. It's presence, elevated by future memory. A moment that becomes part of your myth *as you live it.*

Laura:
We should use it. Declare it official. Add it to the grammar of The Stack.

Felix:
What would you call it in a single word?

Jack:
Aureom. From *aureus*—golden. The *golden now*. The tense of lived treasure.

Rhea:
That's beautiful.

Felix:
Sounds like a verb too. *'We aureom this.'* Meaning—we bless this now with future love.

Jack:
Exactly.

Rhea:
The best moments don't get plaques. They just leave traces in the way we speak, the way we hold each other, the way we move through rooms.

Felix:
Which is kind of beautiful. Like… the moment never ends. It just echoes.

(A soft silence. No one wants to break it.)

Jack:
Then maybe the soul doesn't need to be remembered by others. Just by *you*. Just long enough to say thank you.

Laura:
This... this will have been the part I remembered when I needed to remember joy.

Felix:
This will have been the hour I felt like I was held without being touched.

Rhea:
This will have been the sentence I never said out loud—but heard in someone else's voice.

Jack:
This... right now... will have been the room I carried with me in future winters.

Laura:
This will have been the moment I knew I was part of something that doesn't need to be explained.

Felix:
This will have been the joke we forgot to finish—but still felt funny.

Rhea:
This will have been the silence that made more sense than most words.

(A pause.)

Jack:
You all... you will have been my proof. That this life was real. That beauty wasn't imagined. That the soul was shared.

Laura:
You will have been the reason I trusted something could last, even if it didn't.

Felix:
You will have been the way I remembered myself gently.

Rhea:
You will have been what I meant when I said I wanted to live fully.

(They don't speak for a while. The room has shifted—no longer just a place, but a vessel of meaning. A shared cathedral of the ordinary-now-holy. The kind of moment where nobody needs to ask if it matters. It already does.)

Jack:
We're writing ourselves. In gold.

Laura:
We're speaking into memory.

Felix:
We’re living in the aureom.

Rhea:
And it will have been enough.

Laura:
Do you ever worry that you're not doing life properly?

Rhea:
All the time.

Jack:
I used to think that was just me.

Laura:
Like… there’s this unspoken game of meaning happening around you. And you're missing it. Or you're late to it. Or you didn’t wear the right shoes.

Felix:
FOMO, but make it existential.

Rhea:
Yeah. Not missing *events*. Missing the whole *point*.

Jack:
And the irony is, the fear of missing out becomes the thing that makes you miss out.

Laura:
I don’t want to live like that. I don’t want life to be a competition of who *feels it best*.

Rhea:
Or who curates it best. Or who gets the perfect friends, or house, or line of dialogue before bedtime.

Felix:
That’s why last night felt so… clean. It wasn’t just rich. It was *complete*. Nobody felt like an outsider. Nobody was pretending. It didn’t feel like there was a secret room we weren’t invited to.

Jack:
That’s what we have to design for. Not just good moments. But moments that *include*. So no one thinks the good life is happening somewhere else.

Laura:
Because if you’re sitting in the sun with people you love, and it feels real, then you’re not missing anything. You’re *in it*.

Rhea:
And if everyone feels that, even just sometimes… then maybe that’s what a good world is. Not perfect. Not fair. Just *present and generous.*

Jack:
That’s the foundation of everything. Not perfection. Not productivity. Just... making sure nobody gets left behind in joy.

Felix:
And not just inviting people in when it’s easy. But *holding the door open long enough* for the unsure ones. The quiet ones. The ones still learning how to arrive.

Laura:
Maybe the best version of life is when no one feels like a guest. Just *part of the whole.*

Rhea:
And part of the memory. Not just the photo. Not just the footnote.

Jack:
I want a life where no one asks, ‘Was I really there?’ Because they’ll *know* they were. They’ll have felt it in their bones.

Felix:
And they won’t wonder if it counted. They’ll just carry it.

Jack:
You know what I’ve realised? I’m happiest when I believe two things at once.

Laura:
Only two?

Jack:
One: that *this*—right now—is everything I need. And two: that the future will still be better.

Rhea:
That sounds contradictory.

Jack:
It is. But it’s *true*. Or at least, it’s the *right* tension. I don’t want to feel like I’m chasing a better life. But I don’t want to be frozen in now either.

Felix:
So it’s like saying: *this is perfect*—but not *final*.

Jack:
Exactly. Like… we’re in the middle of something that’s already good, but still becoming. There’s no lack. But there’s still movement.

Laura:
That's how last night felt. Like it didn’t need to be improved. And yet… I knew it wasn’t the peak. Just a step. A beautiful, golden step.

Rhea:
I think that’s how the soul expands. When you let the moment be complete—but you don’t close the book.

Felix:
And that way, the future isn’t an escape. It’s a continuation. Not because this isn’t enough—but because *enough can still grow*.

Jack:
Yes. That’s the key. If you believe the future has to be better *because now is bad*, then you’re living in lack. But if you believe it will be better *because now is already full*, then you’re living in grace.

Laura:
Like a garden that’s already blooming—but still has seeds you haven’t seen sprout yet.

Rhea:
And you’re not rushing it. You’re just staying long enough to notice.

Felix:
I want to live like that. Fully *here*, but with a slow smile for what’s coming.

Jack:
Then we need rituals that protect that tension. The kind that let the present be enough, *without shutting the gate on becoming*.

Laura:
Maybe that’s what a good life is. Not a fixed state. Not a chase. Just… presence, braided with hope.

Jack:
You know… sometimes I think we overthink the good moments. We try to *capture* them too quickly.

Rhea:
Yeah. Like we’re trying to pin butterflies.

Jack:
Exactly. Like if we don’t name it, quote it, write it down—it’ll vanish. But maybe that’s the trick. Maybe some things aren’t meant to be *understood* right away.

Felix:
Some things are just meant to be *felt*. Lived. Let through you like a wave.

Laura:
I’ve started trusting that I don’t need to *grasp* every moment. That being in it is enough. That joy doesn’t have to be analysed to be real.

Rhea:
And not every thought needs a conclusion. Some are just... pauses. Beautiful little pauses.

Jack:
We’re so used to asking, *‘What does this mean?’* But what if the better question is just, *‘Am I here for it?’*

Felix:
Like dancing. You don’t dissect each beat. You just let it move you.

Laura:
I think that’s the only way to really live. To let go of the idea that everything has to be useful, or explainable. To trust that some things matter *just because they happen.*

Rhea:
And maybe the things that change us the most… don’t arrive as lessons. They arrive as sunsets. Or friends. Or toast at the right time.

Jack:
So maybe the point isn’t to make every moment meaningful. It’s to make space for meaning to *find you*, without being chased.

(A silence. Deep, gentle. The kind that feels earned.)

Felix:
I like that we’re not trying so hard anymore.

Laura:
We’re just living. Together. And it’s enough.

Jack:
This will have been one of the moments I didn’t need to explain.

(The house is quiet again. The pots are washed. The window is slightly open to the cooling night. The four of them sit around the kitchen table, notebooks and scraps of paper scattered between them. A candle flickers beside a plate of crumbs. No one is rushing. No one is scripting. They’re just writing—trying to catch the shape of the past few days before it slips away.)

Laura:
I keep thinking of little lines. Things we said. But I don’t know where they go.

Felix:
Doesn’t matter. Just write them down. We’ll sort the shape later.

Rhea:
Some of this barely makes sense. Half-finished thoughts. Sketches of feelings. It’s messy.

Jack:
So were we. That’s the point.

Laura:
I don’t want to forget any of it. Not just the philosophy. The warmth. The *way* we were together.

Felix:
Someone should publish this.

Jack:
I think I will.

(They all look at him.)

Jack:
Not as a manifesto. Or a textbook. Just… a record. Of how it felt. What we said. How we dreamed out loud.

Rhea:
You’re serious.

Jack:
This has been one of the highlights of my life. Not just the talk. But the truth inside it. The ease. The care. The beauty of being seen in the middle of thinking. Of *becoming.*

Laura:
Like it wasn't just conversation. It was something more sacred.

Jack:
I want to honour that. I want someone else—someone lost, or lonely, or searching—to stumble on it years from now and think, *Maybe life can feel like that.*

Felix:
'The Nights at the House in Islington.'

Rhea:
Or *The Aureom Dialogues*.

Jack:
Or maybe just *This Happened.* That's enough.

(A pause. They all sit back a little, looking at the pages in front of them. Not for what they contain, but for what they hold.)

Laura:
Will it be complete?

Jack:
No. But it'll be true.

(The kitchen is candlelit now. Just one flame, low and flickering. The window is cracked open to the night air, and someone's put on soft, wordless music—something barely there. They've pushed the notebooks aside. The table is scattered with teacups, crusts, pens left uncapped. The night has no more ambition left in it. Just presence.)

Laura:
Do you remember when we talked about beauty like it could save people?

Jack:

Maybe it can.

(Jack gets up and kisses Laura, love flowing through his body. The candle flickers once, then steadies. Outside, the city sleeps. Inside, four people sit in the quiet echo of their own myth, warm in the golden now. And slowly, softly, the night closes.)

Epilogue:

It’s weeks later now. The season has shifted, like something gently exhaled.

I’m sitting in the corner of the Islington house—the good corner, the sunlit one, where the window stretches light across the floor like a kind of quiet encouragement.

I’ve got the handwritten pages in front of me. Some are mine, sure, but most aren’t. Laura’s ink leans left like she’s thinking too quickly. Felix writes like he’s laughing at the sentence before he finishes it. Rhea, neat as ever, but with those sharp little lines in the margins—cutting and kind at once.

I’m not really editing. I’m just listening again. Clearing space around the truths. Breathing clarity into what was already full of light.

There’s a file open on my laptop. I called it *The Nights We Spoke in Gold.* I’m not sure what it will become. A book? A digital fragment? A message in a bottle for someone who needs it?

That’s not the point.

I sip my coffee. Read a line aloud. One of Felix’s.

> *“We don’t need to be immortal. We just need to be felt in someone else’s memory.”*

I smile. I type a note beneath it.

> *And we were.*

Outside, London keeps being London—loud, alive, slightly ridiculous. But in here, something is still glowing.

I close the laptop. Slowly. Reverently.

I don’t rush to leave.
I just sit.

Not with fame.
Not with a product.
But with the echo of a time when four of us sat in a room and *really lived*.

And now, maybe—just maybe—someone else will read it.

And maybe, when they do,
they'll feel it too.

Jack Stone

Appendix: Architectures of Britannia: Building a High-Energy, Layered Civilization

By Sir Aldwyn Rooke

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Introduction: The Anglo-Futurist Vision

We are not builders of walls, but weavers of worlds. Where others see empty air and solid earth, we see dimensions waiting to be unfolded. Britain's bones remember greatness—the cathedral builders who carved heaven from stone, the railway barons who stitched continents with iron. But our present is a timid thing, choking on safety and small thinking.

Anglo-Futurism is the antidote.

Imagine a London where space obeys new rules: where stepping through an archway transports you from a sunlit plaza to a subterranean bazaar glowing with bioluminescent fungi. Where a single city block contains stacked neighbourhoods connected by glass-bottomed skybridges, each level a distinct ecosystem humming with its own micro-culture. Where transport isn't mere utility, but theatre—gondolas drifting between spires like jewelled pendants, magnetic trams whispering through crystal-lit underworlds.

This is architecture as perceptual alchemy. By layering vertical villages above cavern-cities, by threading micro-canals through grand boulevards, we create the illusion of infinite space within an island's finite bounds. A single building becomes a metropolis. A morning commute becomes an odyssey.

The tools are here: graphene spires flowering with photovoltaic ivy. Subterranean farms fed by geothermal streams. Transport hubs where Art Deco meets AI in a ballet of moving parts. But the true material is audacity—the willingness to build with both the delicacy of a watchmaker and the scale of cathedral architects.

What follows is not a prescription, but a provocation. A demonstration that Britain need not choose between heritage and innovation, between grandeur and efficiency. That our cities can be both functional and fantastical. That space, properly conjured, can make an island feel like a universe.

The future isn't found—it's forged. Let us begin.

Chapter 1: The Philosophy of Layered Space

Britain has always been an island of contradictions—bound by sea yet limitless in ambition, rooted in history yet restless for reinvention. Anglo-Futurist architecture embraces this paradox, transforming geographic constraint into creative fuel. We do not accept limits; we redefine dimensions.

Forget the dead glass towers of old. Our skyscrapers are alive—neo-Gothic marvels where graphene ribs support living facades of photosynthetic vines. Each tower is a vertical society: crypto-bourses hum in vaulted lower halls, artisan looms clatter in mid-air ateliers, and rooftop forests drip with dew onto sky farms below. The genius lies in the connective tissue—glass-bottomed skybridges that turn a coffee run into an aerial promenade, pneumatic lifts that glide like whispers through ribbed stone shafts. A single spire houses more life than a traditional city block, yet feels airy, expansive—because height, when properly orchestrated, doesn't compress space; it multiplies it.

Beneath the minimalist grace of the surface, another city thrives. Anglo-Futurism doesn't bury its utilities; it curates its depths. Geothermal shafts vent steam into Roman-style bathhouses where the water glows cobalt from rare minerals. Subterranean markets flicker under algae-chandeliers, traders exchanging Coral-Script for mushroom-leather wares. Silent trams slip through amethyst-lit tunnels, their routes tracing the forgotten rivers under London.

The magic is in the interplay: "Deep balconies" puncture the earth, funnels of sunlight connecting cavern plazas to the sky. A banker might lunch in a rooftop orchard, then descend via spiral stair into a limestone jazz club—two worlds, one seamless experience.

Why settle for reality when perception is malleable? Our cities employ spatial sleight-of-hand:

Mirrored canals double streetscapes, turning a modest promenade into a hall of infinite arches.

Fractal facades on council flats trick the eye—what seems a dense pattern from afar reveals, up close, tiny gardens nesting in its crevices.

Trompe-l'oeil (trômp′ loi′) alleys narrow just so, making a 200-meter lane feel like a Parisian grand boulevard.

Even our currencies play the game. Feng-Shi isn't just money—it's a spatial unit, earned by designing a plaza bench that subtly elongates sightlines, or a tunnel mural that hints at unseen depths.

Britain's greatness was never in its square mileage, but in its ability to punch above its weight. Anglo-Futurist architecture weaponizes that spirit. A commute becomes a choose-your-own-adventure through layered realities. A "simple" apartment tower unfolds into a hive of micro-cultures. Every inch hums with purpose—not just to house or transport, but to expand the imagination.

This is no utopian fantasy. The tools exist. The only missing ingredient? The courage to build unapologetically—to stack, burrow, and reflect until our island feels not small, but limitless.

Chapter 2: Maximum and Minimalism

Anglo-Futurist architecture refuses the tired dichotomy of maximalism versus minimalism, forging instead a dynamic language where abundance and restraint collide in a controlled, electrifying tension. This is not a compromise but a synthesis—a pulsating aesthetic that mirrors the high-agency spirit of a reborn Britain. Our cities will neither drown in ornamental excess nor starve in sterile sparsity; they will thrive in the paradox of vast simplicity and intricate density, where every structure balances monumental presence with disciplined clarity. This chapter explores how Anglo-

Futurism's architectural philosophy harnesses the power of both maximum and minimalism, creating spaces that are at once awe-inspiring and serene, chaotic and ordered, boundless yet precise.

Anglo-Futurist minimalism is not the hollow asceticism of modernist dogma, stripping spaces to soulless voids. It is a martial discipline—a rigorous paring-down to essentials that amplifies presence through restraint. This minimalism manifests in forms that command attention through their purity, serving as anchors within the vibrant complexity of our urban fabric. Its key expressions include:

Our cities are punctuated by megastructures—towers, arenas, and transit hubs—built with clean lines and unyielding confidence. Constructed from white graphene-composite, their surfaces shimmer with a prismatic dance of light, shifting from pearlescent dawn hues to fiery sunset glows. These buildings, like silent sentinels, offer visual respite amid the surrounding bustle, their simplicity a canvas for the play of time and atmosphere. A transport cathedral in Birmingham, for instance, might rise as a smooth, curved monolith, its facade unadorned yet alive with the city's reflections.

In the dense weave of Anglo-Futurist cities, we carve out intentional emptiness—courtyard plazas lined with reflective pools and polished stone, where the absence of clutter becomes a rare and precious commodity. These spaces are not barren but curated, their smooth surfaces interrupted only by subtle bio-luminescent pathways that glow faintly at night, guiding movement without shattering the serenity. A plaza in Manchester's cyber-forest district might sit as an open oval of limestone, its mirrored pool doubling the fractal canopy above, offering a moment of pause amid the city's pulse.

Our minimalism celebrates the raw truth of materials, rejecting superfluous ornament for the elegance of function. Exposed carbon-fiber supports form geometric lattices, transparent aerogel panels reveal the delicate machinery of insulation, and raw limestone blocks are stacked with mathematical precision. These elements, arranged with the rigour of a Bach fugue, create beauty through their inherent properties. A Sheffield factory, for example, might expose its skeletal framework of carbon-fiber beams, each joint a study in precision, transforming industrial utility into a sculptural hymn.

If minimalism is our discipline, maximalism is our exuberance—a controlled chaos that fills the gaps with vibrant, layered complexity. Anglo-Futurist maximalism is not garish excess but a deliberate explosion of activity, culture, and innovation within the bounds of our minimalist frameworks. It thrives in:

In the Anglo-Futurist Britannia, the creation of dense micro-cultures is a deliberate act of architectural and economic design, reflecting the document's vision of modular districts and decentralized governance. These micro-cultures—vibrant, self-contained communities with their own customs, economies, and aesthetics—thrive within the layered spaces of urban megastructures and rural smart villages, embodying the ethos of controlled chaos. By stacking vertical neighbourhoods in cities and fostering hamlets in the countryside, Britannia creates ecosystems where diversity fuels innovation, and multiple currencies act as the lifeblood of these micro-cultures, enabling autonomy while weaving them into a broader national tapestry.

Micro-cultures in Anglo-Futurist Britannia are born from a deliberate synthesis of architecture and social engineering, designed to foster high-agency communities within both urban and rural landscapes. In urban centres like London, megastructures—vast, minimalist complexes of graphene-reinforced stone—rise as vertical villages, their clean lines and open-faced designs housing stacked neighbourhoods that pulse with life. Each level of a megastructure is a self-contained world, its purpose and culture defined by its inhabitants and the architectural features that shape their interactions. On the 20th floor of a tower in Canary Wharf, a micro-brewery ferments gene-edited ales with flavours like engineered citrus and lunar-hopped bitterness, its vats humming beside a quantum computing lab where coders trade algorithms for crypto. Above, on the 21st floor, a rooftop cricket pitch overlooks a neo-Georgian library, its graphene shelves housing new manuscripts. These levels are connected by gossamer-thin carbon-fiber bridges, their bio-luminescent trim glowing softly, allowing residents to move between worlds while maintaining each neighbourhood's distinct identity.

The architectural design of these megastructures encourages micro-cultures by providing spaces that can be adapted to the needs of their inhabitants. Each level has its own environmental controls—smart glass windows that adjust opacity, AI-managed air filtration, and bio-luminescent lighting—creating micro-climates that reflect the culture within. The brewery level might be warm and humid, its walls lined with bioengineered vines that enhance fermentation, while the library above is cool and quiet, its fractal-patterned ceiling amplifying the sense of depth and focus. Pocket forests, tucked between levels, add layers of greenery, their smart trees filtering noise and fostering communal spaces where micro-cultures can gather—a debating salon in one forest, a folk-techno jam in another. This vertical modularity ensures that each neighbourhood feels autonomous, a world unto itself, while remaining part of the megastructure's ecosystem, embodying the document's vision of controlled chaos.

In rural landscapes, micro-cultures take root in smart villages, where the same principles of modularity and autonomy apply but on a more intimate scale. In the rewilded Cotswolds, a cluster of limestone cottages, retrofitted with graphene insulation and bio-luminescent roofs, forms a tech-savvy hamlet. One cottage houses a cypherpunk collective, their Bitcoin vaults hidden in a subterranean quarry, while another hosts an artisan guild crafting fusion-powered looms, their textiles traded in a local Artisan Mark. A miniature waterway winds through the village, its glowing moss-lined banks ferrying goods between cottages, while a pocket forest at the village's edge conceals a micro-amphitheatre where poets recite verses under the stars. The rural setting fosters a slower, more communal micro-culture, but the technological integration—smart glass, AI-managed ecosystems, and local currencies—ensures these hamlets are as dynamic as their urban counterparts, each one a node in Britannia's broader network.

Multiple currencies are the lifeblood of these micro-cultures, enabling economic autonomy while fuelling cultural diversity. In Britannia, the document's emphasis on monetary plurality is realized through a decentralized financial system where Bitcoin and the pound coexist with hundreds of local currencies, each tied to a specific micro-culture's needs and values. These currencies, traded via a universal app, create economic ecosystems that empower communities to define their own priorities, fostering a sense of identity and agency that shapes their cultural evolution.

Maximal culture, in this context, is the antithesis of minimalism—it's the exuberant, high-energy celebration of Britain's diverse traditions, modern innovations, and communal spirit, amplified through the internet to unite urban Hyper-Cities and rural smart villages in a shared cultural surge. Britannia has harnessed the internet as a digital agora, enabling the creation of nationwide cultural initiatives like county cricket, fishing, theatre, folk-techno festivals, rewilded poetry slams, and fusion-craft fairs. These movements, fueled by the app-driven economy and the high-movement infrastructure of 7-foot gauge railways and miniature waterways, create a cultural momentum that mirrors the document's vision of a civilization in motion—vibrant, ambitious, and unapologetically maximal.

The internet of Britannia is not just a tool for communication but a cultural engine, a decentralized platform that connects micro-cultures across the nation into a cohesive, maximal movement. The universal app, a cornerstone of the Anglo-Futurist economy, serves as the digital backbone for these initiatives, enabling nomads, residents, and creators to organize, fund, and participate in cultural events with seamless efficiency. Powered by quantum networks and accessible via holographic interfaces in megastructures, gondola cabins, and rural smart villages, the app integrates Bitcoin, local currencies, and cultural credits, creating a fluid economy where cultural participation is as transactional as it is communal. On May 14, 2075, at 4:24 PM BST, a poet in London's Hyper-City might use the app to crowdfund a rewilded poetry slam in the Pennines, while a fisherman in Cornwall books a hovercraft to join a national fishing festival, their actions linked by the internet's invisible threads.

This digital connectivity ensures that cultural initiatives scale rapidly, reaching every corner of Britannia. A single post on the app—say, a call for a county cricket tournament—can go viral within hours, amplified by AI-driven algorithms that target micro-cultures with shared interests. Nomads on the 7-foot gauge railways share the post in dining car salons, rural artisans in the Cotswolds see it on their smart glass windows, and urban coders in Manchester's Tech Hub project it onto holographic facades. The app facilitates real-time coordination—venues are booked, transport is arranged via maglevs and hovercraft, and local currencies fund the event—turning a local idea into a nationwide movement overnight. The internet's role is to maximize cultural output, ensuring that Britannia's diverse micro-cultures contribute to a unified, maximal cultural surge that drives the nation forwards.

Dynamic Reconfiguration: Our spaces are not static but alive, their components shifting to meet the city's rhythm. Floating market platforms in subterranean caverns reconfigure hourly, their stalls gliding on magnetic tracks to form new patterns, while gondola networks above trace ever-evolving routes, their paths a three-dimensional sculpture against the sky. This fluidity ensures that no space feels fixed, amplifying the sense of infinite possibility.

Technological Spectacle: Maximalism embraces the theatrical potential of technology, turning functional elements into cultural events. Fiber optic filaments embedded in stone might blaze during a solstice, transforming a quiet plaza into a cosmic map, while bio-luminescent algae colonies trace geological strata in caverns, turning raw rock into a living canvas. These moments of intensity are not random but orchestrated, amplifying the city's narrative.

The genius of Anglo-Futurist design lies in the synthesis of these opposing forces—minimalism's clarity grounding maximalism's exuberance, creating spaces that are both serene and electrifying. This dialectic is not abstract but tangible, embodied in exemplar projects that redefine the architectural imagination:

Beneath London's vast chambers are carved from bedrock with laser precision, their walls left bare to expose the raw texture of geological strata. Strategic colonies of bio-luminescent algae trace these layers, casting a soft, otherworldly glow that highlights the stone's natural drama. Within this minimalist shell, maximal activity thrives: floating market platforms, suspended on magnetic fields, shift hourly to form new configurations, their wares traded in micro-currencies. Transparent bridges, so fine they seem woven from light, connect these platforms, creating a lattice of movement that pulses with life. The chamber is both a void and a universe, its simplicity amplifying the chaos within.

In Newcastle's geothermal fortress, a trio of skyscrapers rises as pure white curves, their graphene-composite facades a study in breathtaking minimalism. From a distance, they are serene, their clean lines catching the North Sea's light. Yet their interiors are a riot of density—vertically stacked neighbourhoods where artisans craft fusion-powered drones beside rooftop gardens hosting philosophical debates. These towers are linked by a gondola network, its cabins tracing fluid, ever-changing paths that form a kinetic sculpture against the sky. The contrast between exterior restraint and interior abundance creates a dynamic tension, each tower a microcosm of Anglo-Futurist ambition.

On the cliffs of Kent's White Cliffs, a circular arrangement of polished basalt monoliths stands as a minimalist testament to enduring strength, each rectangle perfect in its austerity. Yet embedded within are thousands of fibre optic filaments, dormant by day but blazing during astronomical events—solstices, equinoxes, meteor showers—to transform the stone circle into a computational model of the cosmos, its light visible across the North Sea. This is minimalism as a canvas for maximal spectacle, the monoliths' simplicity amplifying their celestial performance.

Anglo-Futurist architecture is a language of paradox, where maximum and minimalism are not enemies but partners in a dance of controlled tension. Our cities will be both vast and intimate, their minimalist anchors providing clarity amid the maximalist fervor of micro-cultures and technological spectacle. This synthesis is not just aesthetic but philosophical, reflecting a Britain that embraces both discipline and exuberance, order and chaos. As architects, we are called to craft spaces that pulse with this duality—where a single tower can be both a serene silhouette and a teeming metropolis, where a cavern can be both a quiet void and a vibrant bazaar. In this Britain, every structure is a testament to a civilization that dares to live at full voltage, balancing the monumental with the delicate in a harmony that redefines the possible.

Chapter 3: The Aesthetics of Controlled Chaos

Anglo-Futurist cities are not sterile grids or monolithic sprawls; they are vibrant ecosystems where controlled chaos reigns—a symphony of hundreds of micro-economies and micro-cultures coexisting without friction, each pulsing with its own identity, currency, and aesthetic. This is no anarchic free-for-all but a disciplined orchestration, reflecting the decentralized governance and monetary plurality at the heart of our vision. In these cities, diversity is not a buzzword but a structural principle, woven into the urban fabric through modular districts, micro-streams, and pocket forests. Here, architecture becomes a medium for multiplicity, fostering a Britain where every neighbourhood feels like a distinct world, yet all harmonize within the greater whole. This chapter explores the aesthetics of controlled chaos, where the interplay of difference and unity creates cities that are endlessly varied, deeply human, and unmistakably alive.

The Anglo-Futurist city is a federation of modular districts, each a self-contained universe with its own currency, culture, and architectural language. This decentralization, inspired by our vision of self-governing cities, allows neighbourhoods to evolve organically, free from the homogenizing grip of centralized planning. In Brighton, cyberpunk arcades blaze with neon, their holographic facades hosting crypto-art galleries and underground raves, while Shropshire's market towns boast neo-Georgian villas of graphene-reinforced stone, their symmetrical facades concealing Bitcoin vaults and artisanal workshops. These districts are not isolated but porous, their boundaries marked by subtle shifts in material and form—perhaps a transition from glass-and-steel in a tech hub to textured limestone in an artisan quarter. Each neighbourhood operates its own micro-currency, like a productivity-backed industrial credit or a digital token tied to local trade, fostering economic autonomy while remaining tethered to the broader ecosystem of Bitcoin and the pound. Architecturally, this modularity manifests as a patchwork of styles—brutalist-revival factories, neo-Gothic libraries, cypherpunk data towers—creating a visual and cultural mosaic that invites exploration and defies monotony.

Weaving through the urban core, micro-streams and canals serve as both practical infrastructure and aesthetic anchors, embodying our commitment to beauty in function. These small, patterned waterways, often no wider than a meter, double as transport routes for autonomous barges and meditative pathways for pedestrians, their gentle ripples a counterpoint to the city's frenetic energy. Lined with bio-luminescent moss that glows softly at dusk, these canals transform streets into ethereal corridors, their light reflecting off fractal-patterned walls to create a sense of depth and serenity. In a London district, a canal might thread past a vertical village, its waters carrying goods to a subterranean market, while in Bristol, a micro-stream could flank a neo-Gothic arcade, its bio-luminescent edges guiding late-night philosophers to a debating pub. These waterways are not mere decoration but vital organs, knitting districts together while enhancing the illusion of infinite space, as their mirrored surfaces double the skyline and extend the horizon.

In Britannia, nature is not a mere backdrop to urban life but a meticulously engineered partner, rewilded with precision to create ecosystems within ecosystems, where miniature nature reserves thrive within broader rewilded areas. This vision, deeply rooted in the document's concept of cybernetic garden cities, transforms Britain's landscape into a harmonious blend of technology and ecology, where every green space—from sprawling rewilded lowlands to dense urban pocket forests—serves as a microcosm of biodiversity, sustainability, and cultural vitality.

Amid the density of Anglo-Futurist cities, pocket forests emerge as dense, meticulously curated groves, breaking up the urban grid with bursts of greenery that feel like portals to another world. These are not ornamental parks but cybernetic ecosystems, where nature and technology work in symbiosis to create self-sustaining environments.

In Edinburgh's Old Town, a pocket forest nestles between two vertical villages, its tangled canopy of smart trees glowing with bio-luminescent moss that casts an ethereal light at dusk. The trees, bred to enhance carbon sequestration, filter the city's air with a faint hum, their sensors alerting the AI to adjust irrigation when a heatwave looms. Beneath the canopy, a hidden amphitheatre carved from graphene-reinforced stone hosts folk-techno musicians, their beats syncing with the forest's ambient sounds—chirps of birds, the rustle of leaves, the hum of micro-turbines embedded in the soil. Passers-by pause to explore, drawn by the sense of depth and discovery, the forest's fractal-patterned undergrowth making the space feel boundless despite its small footprint. This pocket forest is a miniature nature reserve within the city, a self-contained ecosystem that supports native species like red squirrels and glowcap mushrooms.

In Sheffield, a pocket forest flanks a micro-stream near a rewilded zone, its trees engineered to filter heavy metals from the air, a legacy of the city's steelmaking past. The forest's bio-luminescent undergrowth lights a path to a small clearing, where a graphene bench offers a moment of respite. Here, the nutrient cycles ensure that the soil supports a diverse array of flora—ferns, wild orchids, and gene-edited moss that glows in sapphire hues—while bees dart between flowers, their wings a faint buzz. This pocket forest is a micro-reserve within Sheffield's broader rewilded framework, its ecosystem a delicate balance of technology and nature, filtering the city's emissions while offering a sanctuary for urban dwellers to reconnect with the wild.

Beyond the urban cores, Britannia's broader landscape has been carefully rewilded to create ecosystems within ecosystems, where large-scale rewilded areas host miniature nature reserves as nodes of hyper-local biodiversity. Take the rewilded lowlands between Manchester and Sheffield, a 50,000-acre expanse where rolling hills once scarred by industrial runoff now bloom with native grasses, heather, and bioengineered wildflowers that glow faintly at night, their luminescence a natural defense against herbivores. This rewilded area is a macro-ecosystem, its biodiversity managed by a network of AI drones that monitor wildlife populations—reintroduced lynx, red deer, and foxes—ensuring a balanced food web. Wetlands, restored with graphene-lined basins to prevent erosion, support migrating birds like curlews and lapwings, their numbers tracked by sensors embedded in the reeds.

Within this vast rewilded lowland, miniature nature reserves dot the landscape like jewels, each a hyper-local ecosystem designed to protect specific species or ecological niches. Near a bend in a rewilded river, a 5-acre miniature reserve is dedicated to the preservation of the great crested newt, its ponds lined with bio-luminescent algae that regulate water temperature, creating an ideal habitat. A carbon-fiber fence, nearly invisible to the eye, keeps larger predators out, allowing the newts to thrive in a controlled micro-environment. This miniature reserve is a self-contained ecosystem within the broader lowland, its boundaries porous enough to allow gene flow with surrounding populations but protected enough to ensure the newts' survival.

Further south, in the rewilded Pennines, a 20,000-acre expanse of moorland hosts a miniature reserve for the bilberry bumblebee, a species once on the brink of extinction. The reserve, a 2-acre pocket of heather and wildflowers, is a micro-ecosystem where bioengineered pollinators—tiny robotic bees—assist the bumblebees, their fusion-powered wings ensuring year-round pollination. The heather, gene-edited to bloom longer, glows faintly at dusk, attracting the bees while deterring herbivores. AI drones patrol the reserve, adjusting soil nutrients while a micro-stream, its waters filtered by bioengineered algae, provides a steady water source. This miniature reserve is a node of biodiversity within the Pennines' macro-ecosystem, its small scale allowing for precise ecological management that supports the bumblebee population while contributing to the broader rewilded landscape.

The rewilded areas and pocket forests of Britannia embody a vision of nature as a cybernetic partner, where ecosystems within ecosystems create a layered tapestry of biodiversity and sustainability. In urban cores, pocket forests like those in Edinburgh and Sheffield are miniature nature reserves, supporting local species, and offering cultural sanctuaries amid the density of the cities. In the broader landscape, rewilded areas like the lowlands and Pennines host miniature reserves as nodes of hyper-local ecology, each a self-contained world that contributes to the macro-ecosystem's health. This aligns with the document's vision of cybernetic garden cities, where nature and technology are not at odds but in symbiosis trees and algae in urban groves.

For a country on the go, this rewilded framework is a lifeline, ensuring that even the densest cities remain livable, their air clean, their spaces vibrant with life. The pocket forests fracture urban monotony, amplifying the controlled chaos by making every city block a portal to discovery, while the miniature reserves within rewilded areas preserve biodiversity at a granular level, ensuring that Britannia's ecological heritage endures. As the sun sets over Edinburgh's pocket forest, the glow of its bio-luminescent undergrowth mingling with the hum of folk-techno music, or over the Pennines' bilberry reserve, its heather shimmering, the rewilded Britannia stands as a testament to a civilization that builds not just towers and railways but ecosystems—layered, living, and relentlessly alive.

Manchester, once the industrial heart of Britain, re-emerges as a paragon of controlled chaos—a federation of modular districts where diversity thrives within a unified urban vision. Here, the city is not a single entity but a constellation of neighbourhoods, each with its own currency, aesthetic, and rhythm, yet all interwoven by canals, forests, and shared ambition. In the Northern Quarter, brutalist-revival factories loom, their textured stone facades housing fusion-powered workshops that trade in a productivity-backed industrial credit. Their stark geometry contrasts with the adjacent canal-lined artisan quarters, where neo-Gothic ateliers glow with bio-luminescent moss, their craftsmen minting a local token tied to bespoke goods. Further out, a cyberpunk tech hub pulses with neon-lit towers, their smart glass facades hosting holographic markets, while a rewilded district cradles pocket forests, their AI-managed groves sheltering micro-breweries and debating salons.

Micro-streams thread these districts together, their waters carrying goods and reflecting the city's kaleidoscopic skyline. A canal in the artisan quarter might shimmer with bio-luminescent light, guiding traders to a subterranean bazaar, while a stream in the tech hub powers micro-turbines, its banks lined with fractal-patterned tiles that stretch the eye's perception. Pocket forests punctuate the urban core, their dense canopies concealing open-air forums where coders and poets clash in high-energy debate. Each district operates autonomously, its currency and aesthetic fostering a fierce local pride, yet all are linked by a maglev spine and gondola network, ensuring frictionless movement across the city. Manchester's controlled chaos is a microcosm of Anglo-Futurist Britain: a city where difference fuels dynamism, where every neighbourhood is a world, and where the whole is greater than the sum of its parts.

The aesthetics of controlled chaos are a celebration of multiplicity, where the interplay of modular districts, micro-streams, and pocket forests creates cities that are endlessly varied yet cohesive. This is not chaos for its own sake but a disciplined chaos, orchestrated to amplify human agency and cultural vitality. In an Anglo-Futurist city, no two streets feel the same, yet all share a common thread—a commitment to beauty, innovation, and the illusion of infinite possibility. As architects, we are tasked with designing not just buildings but ecosystems, where every element, from a glowing canal to a fractal-clad tower, contributes to a greater harmony. Manchester and its peers are our proof: Britain can be a land of countless worlds, each distinct, each vibrant, all united in a civilization that thrives on the edge of order and exuberance.

Chapter 4: Transport as Art

In the Anglo-Futurist vision, transport is not a mere utility but a cultural and aesthetic triumph—a testament to a civilization that demands frictionless motion and celebrates movement as an art form. Our cities pulse with the rhythm of seamless travel, where every journey, whether by rail, gondola, or foot, is an experience that elevates the spirit and sharpens the senses. This is not the sluggish Britain of delayed trains and congested roads but a nation where transport systems are as beautiful as they are efficient, embodying the core concept's vision of fluid, artistic movement and the document's call for a Britain that moves "like Tokyo, Shanghai, or Zurich—but faster." From silent trams gliding through crystal tunnels to monumental railways that carve the landscape, Anglo-Futurist transport is a symphony of technology, design, and human ambition, transforming the act of travel into a cultural statement.

At the heart of our urban cores, miniature railways weave a delicate web of connectivity, their silent, magnetic trams gliding through crystal-lined tunnels and surface-level tracks. These are not utilitarian conveyances but jewels of industrial deco elegance, their sleek carriages adorned with polished steel accents, Art Deco curves, and bio-luminescent inlays that glow softly in subterranean passages. Above ground, their tracks are embedded in bio-luminescent pathways, blending seamlessly with the city's aesthetic. A tram in Bristol might slip past a neo-Gothic arcade, its smart glass windows reflecting the fractal-patterned facades, while in a Manchester cavern-city, it navigates a glowing market, its crystal-lined tunnel amplifying the hum of trade. These railways are designed for intimacy and precision, connecting neighbourhoods with a grace that makes every short journey a moment of delight, their silent efficiency a counterpoint to the city's vibrant chaos.

Above the city, gondola networks trace elegant arcs between rooftops and cliffs, their sleek cabins embodying the document's call for decentralized, private innovation. These cable cars are not mere transport but kinetic sculptures, their Art Deco-inspired forms—curved chrome frames and smart glass panels—shimmering against the skyline. Powered by lightweight graphene cables, they glide with near-silent precision, their routes adapting in real time via AI to optimize flow. In the Lake District's alpine hamlets, gondolas link slate-roofed towers across misty fells, their cabins glowing with bio-luminescent trim as they ferry poets and engineers to hilltop salons. In London's Hyper-City, they connect vertical villages, offering panoramic views of neo-Gothic spires and mirrored canals. To ride a gondola is to dance with the city, each cabin a brushstroke in a three-dimensional canvas of movement, weaving communities together with effortless beauty.

When scale demands it, Anglo-Futurist Britain unleashes its monumental 7ft-gauge, high-speed rail spines, linking major cities with a velocity that shrinks the nation to a single, pulsating organism. These are not mere trains but rolling palaces, their maglev carriages clad in neo-Gothic filigree and illuminated by holographic displays that project starlit canopies or historical friezes across their interiors. Stations are designed as cathedrals of movement, their soaring domes and vaulted arches echoing the grandeur of St. Pancras but amplified with cybernetic precision—smart glass facades shift with the weather, and holographic wayfinders guide passengers through bustling concourses. To board one of these trains is to enter a world apart: plush, soundproofed cabins offer panoramic views of the countryside, their bio-luminescent trim casting a serene glow. Dining cars serve artisanal feasts, while lounges host impromptu debates among travellers, their conversations fuelled by aged whisky and the train's gentle hum.

A unique subculture thrives aboard these railways: the permanent travellers, a nomadic tribe of philosophers, traders, and artists who live on the rails, traversing Britain in perpetual motion. These modern troubadours, enabled by the trains' self-sustaining ecosystems—hydroponic gardens, micro fusion reactors, and crypto-trading hubs—form transient communities that ebb and flow with each journey. A coder might barter a custom algorithm for a poet's verse in a Glasgow-bound lounge, while a merchant seals a deal over tidal-powered cider en route to Bristol. Their cabins, customized with modular fittings, are micro-homes adorned with digital tapestries or bio-luminescent moss, reflecting their owners' identities. For these travellers, the railway is not just transport but a way of life, a microcosm of Anglo-Futurist freedom where movement is both art and existence, their endless circuits knitting the nation's culture into a vibrant, ever-evolving tapestry.

At the human scale, Anglo-Futurist cities prioritize walkability, their footpaths and micro-streams encouraging meditative movement through urban landscapes. Bio-luminescent pathways, embedded with glowing moss or fibre optic threads, wind through pocket forests and alongside mirrored canals, their soft light guiding pedestrians without overpowering the night. Micro-streams, doubling as transport for autonomous barges, flank these paths, their gentle ripples a soothing counterpoint to the city's pulse. In Oxford, a footpath might trace a canal past a neo-Gothic library, its bio-luminescent stones pulsing in sync with the water's flow, inviting students to pause and reflect. In Cardiff, a stream-side path could lead through a cybernetic grove, its smart trees filtering the air as walkers contemplate the day's debates. These elements foster a sense of intimacy and discovery, grounding the city's high-energy chaos in moments of serene, human-scale connection.

The Seamless Britain rail grid is the backbone of our transport vision, a maglev spine that connects London to Edinburgh in under two hours, transforming the nation into a single, high-velocity ecosystem. This grid, reimagined from the document's HS2 critique, is built on private investment and modular construction, its 7ft-gauge tracks supporting trains that glide at 400 mph, their neo-Gothic carriages a fusion of heritage and futurism. Stations, like the cathedral-like terminus at Manchester's Piccadilly, feature vaulted domes, holographic displays, and bio-luminescent concourses that shift from dawn gold to twilight indigo. Passengers board to find cabins tailored to their needs—work pods with quantum uplinks, lounges for philosophical sparring, or quiet berths with views of rewilded dales. Permanent travellers, their lives unfolding across the grid, animate these trains, their transient salons hosting everything from crypto-trades to folk-techno performances, their presence a living thread in Britain's cultural fabric.

Complementing this spine, the Lake District's alpine hamlets showcase the elegance of localized transport. Here, gondola networks link slate-roofed towers and bio-luminescent docks, their cabins gliding over fells to connect poets in Keswick to engineers in Windermere. Miniature railways, their tracks embedded in glowing pathways, shuttle residents through smart villages, their industrial deco carriages a nod to the region's rugged beauty. Footpaths, flanked by micro-streams, wind through pocket forests, their bio-luminescent stones guiding hikers to amphitheatres where AI-driven soundscapes merge with ancient chants. This microcosm of Seamless Britain blends global connectivity with local intimacy, proving that transport can be both a grand unifier and a delicate art, knitting a region's soul into the nation's broader rhythm.

Anglo-Futurist transport is a cultural manifesto, where every tram, gondola, and railway is a brushstroke in a living canvas of motion. Our systems are not just efficient but evocative, designed to inspire awe and foster connection. The silent glide of a miniature railway through a glowing tunnel, the skyborne dance of a gondola over a vertical village, the thunderous grace of a high-speed train carrying its nomadic tribe—these are not mere journeys but performances, each one reinforcing Britain's identity as a civilization in relentless, beautiful motion. As architects, we are tasked with crafting these systems as extensions of the city's soul, where every route tells a story, every station sings of ambition. In this Britain, to move is to create, to travel is to live, and transport is nothing less than the art of a nation reborn.

In this Britannia, a 7-foot gauge railway isn't just a mode of transport—it's a lifeline, a rolling microcosm of a high-energy, high-movement society that never pauses. Picture stepping onto the platform of King's Cross Station on May 14, at 3:35 PM BST, the air buzzing with the hum of maglev technology and the faint glow of bio-luminescent moss lining the concourse. The station, a neo-Gothic cathedral of movement, looms overhead with soaring arches and graphene-reinforced stone spires, its holographic displays mapping routes across a nation bound by these monumental railways. The 7-foot gauge train before you, the Aurora Pulse, is a titan of engineering—a sleek, elongated beast clad in neo-Gothic filigree, its smart glass windows rippling with subtle patterns, its bio-luminescent trim casting an emerald glow against the dusk. This isn't a mere train; it's a mobile ecosystem, designed to serve a country on the go, where every journey is an experience of scale, luxury, and relentless progress.

Boarding the Aurora Pulse feels like stepping into a grand hall on wheels. The 7-foot gauge—far wider than the standard 4-foot-8.5-inch gauge of old—creates an interior that's cavernous yet intimate, a testament to Anglo-Futurist design. The main carriage stretches 12 feet wide and 15 feet high, its vaulted ceiling adorned with holographic friezes that shift between starlit canopies and historical scenes of Britannia's industrial past. The floor, a polished graphene composite, reflects the soft glow of bio-luminescent inlays, guiding passengers through a space that feels more like a moving plaza than a train. The scale allows for amenities that redefine travel: a gym occupies one carriage, its carbon-fiber treadmills and fusion-powered weights humming as nomads and commuters alike work up a sweat, their movements syncing with the train's gentle 400 mph glide. Floor-to-ceiling smart glass walls offer panoramic views of rewilded lowlands and glowing smart villages, making every rep a meditation on Britannia's reborn landscape.

Next door, a coffee shop buzzes with life, its counters carved from graphene-reinforced limestone, its baristas serving gene-edited espresso that tastes of engineered vanilla and citrus. The space is wide enough for communal tables where permanent travellers—over 100,000 strong across the network—trade crypto for poetry, their laptops open on the app that governs this nomadic economy. The aroma of coffee mingles with the faint ozone scent of the maglev's microfusion reactor, and the carriage's soundproofing ensures the train's velocity is a mere whisper, letting conversations flow like the micro-streams outside. Other carriages house micro-offices with quantum uplinks, hydroponic gardens growing fresh herbs for the dining car, and even a lounge where folk-techno bards perform, their beats syncing with the train's rhythm. Each carriage feels like a neighbourhood, connected by bio-luminescent pathways and smart glass doors, the 7-foot gauge enabling a spaciousness that turns travel into a lifestyle.

The train's motion is a marvel—silent, smooth, and relentless. At 400 mph, the journey from Edinburgh to London takes just one hour, the maglev technology eliminating friction as the train glides on magnetic fields. You feel a gentle hum through the floor, a reminder of the microfusion engine's power, but there's no sway, no clatter, only a serene sense of speed as the countryside blurs past. The wide gauge ensures stability, making the train feel like a floating fortress, its scale a perfect match for a country on the go. This network of 7-foot gauge railways, linking cities like London, Manchester, Sheffield, and Edinburgh, is Britannia's backbone—a high-velocity grid that shrinks the nation into a single, pulsating organism. It's a system built for a society that values movement as much as destination, where nomads, commuters, and dreamers alike can live, work, and create without ever stopping.

Complementing this monumental network are the miniature railways that thread through Britannia. In a reimagined suburban estate outside Manchester, for instance, these mini-maglevs—silent trams with industrial deco elegance—glide through crystal-lined tunnels and surface-level tracks, their bio-luminescent inlays glowing softly. Each tram, scaled to fit the estate's dense layout, connects homes to communal hubs, ferrying residents to pocket forests, micro-streams, and vertical villages in minutes. A family in a graphene-reinforced townhouse can hop on a mini-maglev to a nearby neo-Gothic community centre, while their self-driving luggage floats goods to a subterranean market via a micro-canal. These miniature railways ensure that even the smallest communities are woven into Britannia's transport web, their efficiency and beauty a microcosm of the 7-foot gauge giants that span the nation.

Picture a serene pocket forest in the heart of Covent Garden on May 14 at 4:00 PM BST, its bioengineered trees filtering the air with a faint hum, their bio-luminescent undergrowth casting a soft glow over a meticulously curated green area. Winding through this urban oasis are miniature waterways—narrow channels no wider than 18 inches, their surfaces shimmering with bio-luminescent moss that glows in hues of emerald and sapphire. These waterways are not mere decoration but functional transport veins, designed to carry small goods through the city's most delicate spaces with an almost ornamental grace. Each channel is lined with fractal-patterned tiles, their recursive designs reflecting the water's glow to create an illusion of infinite depth, aligning with the document's emphasis on illusionary design to make spaces feel vast.

A tiny autonomous narrowboat, no larger than a loaf of bread, glides along the waterway, its graphene hull powered by a micro-turbine that hums softly, barely rippling the surface. Onboard is a self-driving luggage unit carrying a parcel of gene-edited spices or a fusion-crafted pendant, goods traded in Covent Garden's subterranean market. The narrowboat navigates the channel with AI precision, its folk-techno hum blending with the ambient chirps of smart birds in the forest, delivering the parcel to a nearby neo-Gothic atelier for a fraction of a satoshi, paid via the app. Residents of the surrounding vertical village, a towering structure of graphene-reinforced stone, can order artisanal goods or micro-electronics through the app, watching as these tiny boats ferry their purchases through the green area, their glowing wakes a delicate dance of light and motion.

The miniature waterways are integrated into the pocket forest's ecosystem, their waters fed by reclaimed rainfall, filtered by bioengineered algae that keep them pristine. Small bridges of carbon fiber, so thin they seem to float, arch over the channels, allowing pedestrians to cross without disrupting the flow. A poet might pause on one of these bridges, her notebook open, scribbling a line—"Streams glow like veins, a forest's quiet trade"—as she watches a narrowboat deliver a vial of bioengineered ink to a nearby debating salon.

Contrast this delicate network with the massive hulking canals that carve through London's Hyper-City, their scale a monument to Britannia's high-energy ambition. On the same day, at 4:15 PM BST, on the banks of the Grand Hyper-Canal near Canary Wharf, a 100-foot-wide waterway flanked by neo-Gothic towers and industrial deco hubs, its surface a turbulent mirror reflecting the city's glowing skyline. These canals are the arteries of the Hyper-City, designed to handle the heavy flow of goods and people in a nation that never stops moving. Hovercraft—sleek, graphene-hulled vessels powered by fusion engines—surge through the water at 60 mph, their wakes sending ripples crashing against the canal's reinforced graphene banks, which shimmer with bio-luminescent algae in fiery hues of crimson and gold.

Each hovercraft is a marvel of Anglo-Futurist engineering, its hull adorned with Art Deco curves and smart glass panels that ripple with real-time data streams—cargo manifests, app-based trade orders, or holographic ads for micro-raves. A single hovercraft might carry crates of fusion-powered machinery, hydroponic produce from rooftop gardens, or even modular housing units destined for a new vertical village in Manchester, all traded in Bitcoin or Hyper-Tokens. The canal's surface buzzes with activity—dozens of hovercraft weaving past each other, their AI navigation ensuring no collisions, while smaller vessels dart in their shadows, ferrying nomads to subterranean markets or rooftop plazas. The air smells of ozone and wet graphene, and the roar of fusion engines mixes with the hum of drones overhead, delivering smaller goods to towers along the canal's edge.

Chapter 5: The Dialectic of Scale

Anglo-Futurist architecture thrives on a paradox: the seamless interplay between the monumental and the delicate, the vast and the intricate. This dialectic of scale rejects the notion that grandeur must overwhelm or that refinement must shrink; instead, it synthesizes both into a dynamic equilibrium, where cities pulse with the weight of ambition and the finesse of craftsmanship. Our Britain builds huge when necessary—erecting megastructures that command the horizon—yet fills the interstices with delicate complexity, crafting urban landscapes that feel ten times larger than their physical bounds. This mirrors the document's vision of a civilization that fuses grand ambition with meticulous artistry, creating a Britain that is both a titan and a tapestry, its architecture a testament to a nation that dares to dream big while cherishing the smallest details.

When scale is required, Anglo-Futurist cities rise to the challenge with minimalist megastructures—vast, open-faced complexes that anchor the urban fabric with unapologetic presence. These are not the soulless towers of corporate modernism but evocative giants, their curved white walls of graphene-composite catching light in prismatic shifts, their forms evoking the document's neo-Gothic skyscrapers and industrial deco hubs. Rooftop gardens cascade with bioengineered flora, their verdant canopies softening the structures' edges, while water channels, fed by reclaimed rainfall, spill down facades in shimmering veils, cooling the air and animating the surface. A megastructure in Birmingham might house a fusion-powered manufacture, its open atrium soaring hundreds of meters, framed by vaulted arches that nod to Victorian ambition. These complexes are not just buildings but civic landmarks, their scale a declaration of Britain's renewed confidence, their minimalism a canvas for the city's vibrant life to unfold.

In the shadows of these giants, Anglo-Futurist cities weave a web of delicate complexity—small-scale elements that amplify depth and discovery, making urban spaces feel boundless. Pocket forests, dense with AI-managed trees and bio-luminescent undergrowth, punctuate the cityscape, their tangled groves concealing micro-amphitheatres or artisan stalls, inviting exploration. Micro-streams, their waters lined with glowing moss, thread through streets, doubling as transport for tiny barges and meditative paths for pedestrians, their fractal-patterned banks stretching the eye's perception. Facades, etched with recursive geometries, transform simple walls into visual labyrinths, each pattern a nod to the core concept's illusion of infinite space. In a Bristol quarter, a narrow alley might open into a pocket forest, its glowing pathways leading to a canal-flanked plaza, where fractal-clad buildings create a sense of endless recession. These delicate elements ensure that every corner of the city feels alive, layered, and larger than life.

Beneath the airy minimalism of the surface, Anglo-Futurist cities plunge into subterranean vitality, where cavern-cities serve as vibrant counterpoints to their skyward siblings. These underground realms, carved from bedrock with laser precision, house bioluminescent markets that pulse with trade, their stalls lit by algae colonies that trace geological strata in radiant hues. Geothermal baths, their steam rising through deep balconies that channel sunlight, offer spaces of primal rejuvenation, while hidden railways glide through crystal-lined tunnels, ferrying goods and dreamers alike. This subterranean expansion, as envisioned in the document, reflects a Britain that builds both upward and downward, embracing its geological depths as a canvas for innovation. A cavern beneath London might host a crypto-bazaar, its glowing arches framing traders bartering in micro-currencies, while a geothermal spa in Newcastle hums beneath a megastructure, its light-filled shafts blurring the line between earth and sky. These counterpoints ensure that scale is not just vertical but multidimensional, each layer amplifying the city's richness.

Sheffield, once an industrial crucible, rises anew as a green machine-city, where the dialectic of scale is writ large in steel, stone, and light. Towering megastructures dominate its skyline, their white graphene facades curved like sails, housing automated steelworks that hum with AI-driven precision. These complexes, inspired by the document's industrial deco hubs, feature open-faced atria where water channels cascade from rooftop gardens, their verdant canopies filtering the air and cooling vast production floors. A central megastructure, dubbed the Forge Spire, soars 500 meters, its neo-Gothic spire piercing the clouds, its interior a vertical village of foundries, coder guilds, and hydroponic farms, all linked by gossamer skybridges that glow with bio-luminescent trim.

Beneath these giants, Sheffield's subterranean realm thrives as a counterpoint of intricate vitality. Cavern-cities, carved from the city's limestone bedrock, house glowing markets where traders hawk fusion-forged tools and gene-edited produce, their stalls lit by crystal-lined tunnels that refract light like prisms. Deep balconies pierce the caverns, channelling sunlight to illuminate geothermal baths and underground plazas, where philosophers debate amid steam and stone. Micro-streams wind through these depths, their bio-luminescent moss guiding autonomous barges to surface canals, creating a seamless flow between worlds. On the surface, pocket forests fracture the urban grid, their smart trees filtering industrial emissions, while fractal-patterned facades on smaller ateliers make every street feel like a portal to infinity.

Sheffield's transport weaves this dialectic into motion, with miniature railways gliding through subterranean tunnels and surface pathways, their industrial deco carriages a nod to the city's steel heritage. Gondolas link the Forge Spire to surrounding towers, their smart glass cabins offering views of the rewilded Pennines, while a 7ft-gauge maglev spine connects Sheffield to Manchester and Leeds, its cathedral-like station a vaulted hymn to velocity. This is a city where scale is both monumental and intimate—megastructures anchor its ambition, while pocket forests, micro-streams, and subterranean markets fill its gaps with a complexity that makes Sheffield feel like a world unto itself, a green machine pulsing with the fire of Anglo-Futurist ingenuity.

The dialectic of scale is Anglo-Futurism's architectural soul—a balance of the monumental and the delicate that creates cities of awe and intimacy. Our megastructures stand as testaments to Britain's ambition, their minimalist grandeur a beacon of collective will, while our pocket forests, micro-streams, and subterranean caverns weave a tapestry of intricate life, ensuring no space feels static or small. This harmony mirrors the document's synthesis of grand vision and refined craftsmanship, crafting a Britain that is both a titan of industry and a haven of human-scale discovery. As architects, we are called to wield scale as a tool of transformation, building cities where the huge inspires and the delicate enchants, where every structure, from a soaring spire to a glowing canal, sings of a civilization that embraces the full spectrum of possibility. In this Britain, scale is not a limit but a language, and our cities speak it fluently.

Chapter 6: The Material Palette

Anglo-Futurist architecture is a marriage of beauty, durability, and sustainability, crafted through a material palette that honours Britain's heritage while embracing the frontier of technological innovation. Our buildings are not ephemeral trends but eternal statements, echoing the document's call for "stone, steel, glass, wood—substantial, eternal." In this vision, materials are not mere components but storytellers, weaving together the grandeur of the past, the precision of the present, and the promise of the future. From graphene-reinforced stone to bio-luminescent algae, our palette transforms cities into living ecosystems—resilient, radiant, and responsive. This chapter explores the core materials that define Anglo-Futurist architecture, each chosen to blend aesthetic power with environmental harmony, creating a Britain that builds for centuries while glowing with the vitality of now.

Stone, the bedrock of Britain's cathedrals and castles, is reborn in Anglo-Futurist architecture through the alchemy of graphene reinforcement. This hybrid material—lightweight yet stronger than steel—marries the tactile permanence of limestone or granite with the futuristic durability needed for soaring structures. Used in neo-Gothic towers and high-tech Georgian villas, as envisioned in the document's aesthetic revival, graphene-reinforced stone forms spires that pierce the clouds and facades that shimmer with subtle metallic flecks, catching light in prismatic dances. Its low weight allows for intricate vaulting and ribbed arches without compromising structural integrity, while its thermal efficiency insulates against Britain's damp chill. In a Manchester vertical village, a tower's graphene-stone facade might be carved with fractal patterns, its surface enduring centuries of weather while remaining as light as a feather, embodying a timeless strength that feels both ancient and cutting-edge.

In the Anglo-Futurist city, illumination is not a mechanical afterthought but a natural symphony, powered by bio-luminescent algae and moss. These living organisms, cultivated to glow in hues of emerald, sapphire, and gold, line canals, pathways, and cavern-cities, aligning with the core concept's vision of glowing subterranean spaces. Their soft, organic radiance replaces harsh artificial lighting, creating serene, sustainable environments that pulse with life. Along a Bristol micro-stream, bio-luminescent moss might trace the water's edge, its glow reflecting off mirrored surfaces to amplify the sense of depth, while in a London cavern-city, algae colonies embedded in limestone walls illuminate markets with a firefly-like shimmer. These materials are not just decorative but functional, their bioluminescence powered by microbial metabolism, requiring no external energy. They embody a Britain that integrates nature and technology, where light itself is a living, breathing element.

Smart glass, rippling like liquid energy, is the dynamic skin of Anglo-Futurist architecture, used in vertical villages, gondola cabins, and transport hubs to create facades that respond to their environment. Inspired by the core concept's Lumen Arbor, this material shifts opacity, colour, and texture in real time, controlled by embedded nanotechnology that reacts to light, temperature, or user intent. A tower in Newcastle might cloak itself in translucent smart glass, its surface shimmering like a frozen wave at dawn, then darkening to block midday heat. Gondola cabins in the Lake District could ripple with patterns that mimic the fells' contours, blending into the landscape. Beyond aesthetics, smart glass enhances sustainability, harvesting solar energy and regulating internal climates, reducing reliance on external power. Its fluidity—evoking the document's call for high-energy aesthetics—makes every structure a performance, a canvas of light and motion that elevates the urban experience.

For structures that defy gravity, Anglo-Futurism turns to carbon fibre and aerogels—materials of weightless strength that enable futuristic forms like skybridges, floating platforms, and high-tech Georgian atriums, as envisioned in the document's revival of elegant innovation. Carbon fibre, with its tensile strength and sleek, matte finish, forms lattice-like supports for gossamer-thin bridges that span vertical villages, their minimalist geometry a nod to industrial deco. Aerogels, translucent and lighter than air, insulate soaring domes and clad floating platforms, their ethereal glow softening the hard edges of urbanity. In a Birmingham megastructure, a carbon-fiber skybridge might link rooftop gardens, its slender form swaying imperceptibly underfoot, while an aerogel-clad observatory in Shropshire shimmers like a mirage, its near-invisible walls offering unobstructed views of the stars. These materials enable a Britain that builds upward and outward with audacious grace, where structures float as if unbound by earthly constraints.

In the rolling hills of the Cotswolds, Anglo-Futurist ingenuity transforms historic limestone cottages into tech-savvy sanctuaries, blending pastoral charm with cutting-edge sustainability. These villages, as envisioned in the document's Cotswolds vision, retain their honey-coloured facades, their Jurassic stone walls entwined with roses and foxgloves, but beneath the surface, they hum with innovation. Graphene-reinforced limestone strengthens ancient cottages, its lightweight durability preserving their form while insulating against the elements. Roofs, clad in bio-luminescent moss, glow softly at night, their living light eliminating the need for streetlamps and casting villages like Bourton-on-the-Water in an ethereal sheen. Smart glass windows, rippling with subtle patterns, regulate light and heat, their surfaces displaying encrypted data streams for the cypherpunk residents within.

Subterranean chambers, carved from old quarries, house Bitcoin vaults and data centres, their bio-luminescent algae walls illuminating servers with a radiant glow, cooled by geothermal vents. Carbon-fiber skybridges, delicate as spider silk, link cottages across streams, while aerogel-clad community halls float above village greens, their translucent walls hosting holographic debates. Micro-streams, lined with glowing moss, wind through cobbled streets, carrying autonomous barges to local markets. In Chipping Norton, a neo-Georgian villa might conceal a graphene-insulated workshop, its smart glass atrium doubling as a solar collector, while a pocket forest nearby shelters a bio-luminescent amphitheatre. This is the Cotswolds reimagined—not as a relic but as a vibrant, sustainable microcosm of Anglo-Futurist ideals, where tradition and technology dance in perfect harmony, each cottage a testament to a material palette that is as enduring as it is alive.

The Anglo-Futurist material palette is an alchemy of heritage and innovation, where graphene-reinforced stone grounds us in Britain's past, bio-luminescent algae lights our present, smart glass animates our facades, and carbon fibre and aerogels lift us toward the future. These materials are not chosen for novelty but for their ability to blend beauty, durability, and sustainability, creating cities that are both eternal and responsive. They reflect a Britain that builds for centuries, not cycles, where every structure—from a glowing canal to a floating skybridge—tells a story of resilience and radiance. As architects, we wield this palette to craft a civilization that is substantial yet dynamic, rooted yet soaring, a testament to a nation that embraces the eternal while living vividly in the now. In this Britain, materials are not just matter—they are the soul of a reborn world.

Conclusion: Building Britannia

Anglo-Futurist architecture is not merely a collection of buildings; it is a manifesto carved in stone, forged in steel, and illuminated by light—a defiant rejection of mediocrity and a clarion call to erect cities that inspire awe, propel movement, and endure through centuries. It is the physical embodiment of a Britain reborn, a civilization in relentless motion, driven by the document's ethos of action, mastery, and unapologetic ambition. From the soaring neo-Gothic spires of vertical villages to the glowing caverns of subterranean markets, from the fluid grace of gondola networks to the monumental thunder of 7ft-gauge railways, every structure in this vision tells a story of a nation that refuses to stagnate. Anglo-Futurism transforms Britain from a mere country into a fortress of culture, a world unto itself—a luminous tapestry of innovation, beauty, and human will.

This architecture is a synthesis of paradoxes: the monumental and the delicate, the maximal and the minimal, the eternal and the dynamic. It weaves graphene-reinforced stone into towers that pierce the sky, embeds bio-luminescent moss in canals that pulse with life, and spins carbon-fiber skybridges that float like dreams. It creates cities where modular districts hum with micro-cultures, where pocket forests and micro-streams make every street feel boundless, where transport is not just functional but a kinetic art form. This is a Britain where scale is a language, chaos is controlled, and every material—from smart glass to aerogel—sings of resilience and radiance. It is a civilization that builds not for profit cycles but for posterity, not for compliance but for conquest of the possible.

To architects, builders, and citizens, the call is clear: embrace this vision. Reject the grey fog of bureaucratic inertia and the sterile monotony of modernist compromise. Design towers that rival the ambition of St. Paul's, carve caverns that glow like ancient myths, and weave transport networks that move with the elegance of a symphony. Build cities that are not just places to live but places to thrive—where every plaza sparks debate, every railway carries dreamers, every facade tells a story of a people who dare to lead. This is not a task for the timid; it demands the courage to reshape the world, to wield materials and ideas with the precision of artisans and the vision of prophets. Britannia awaits your hands, your minds, your fire.

The vision is vivid: a Britain of luminous towers, their graphene spires etched with bio-luminescent vines, rising above mirrored canals that double the sky. Glowing caverns hum with markets and geothermal baths, their crystal tunnels threading silent trams to the surface. Gondolas glide between rooftop gardens, their paths a choreography of light, while massive railways, their neo-Gothic stations soaring like cathedrals, bind cities in a seamless pulse. Footpaths, lined with glowing moss, wind through pocket forests, each step a meditation on a civilization that balances chaos and order, ambition and beauty. This is a Britain where every structure, from a floating platform to a subterranean bazaar, is a testament to relentless progress—a nation that does not merely exist but shines as a beacon of what humanity can achieve.

Building Britannia is not a dream; it is a duty. It is the work of a generation that refuses to manage decline, that chooses instead to forge a future where Britain is not just a country but a civilization-state, a world unto itself. Let us take up the tools—graphene, glass, and imagination—and construct a Britain that echoes the genius of Newton, Brunel, and Turing, a Britain that moves fast, thinks deeply, and builds boldly. The future does not wait. Neither shall we. Let every stone we lay, every light we kindle, every rail we forge proclaim: Britannia rises, and her story is only beginning.

The Hypermodernist - Appendix #6 - The Economics of the Sovereign Individual

Compute, Bitcoin, and the Return of Deflationary Growth

Samuel Ashcombe — High Peak One / Bank of Sheffield
Evelyn Ashcombe — High Peak Two / Bank of New York

Executive Thesis

The defining economic transformation of the twenty-first century is not bitcoin or artificial intelligence alone, but the reorganisation of economics around compute.

Industrial civilisation concentrated power within nation-states because industrial production depended on scale: centralised energy systems, mass labour coordination, vertically integrated finance, and geographically fixed infrastructure. Political sovereignty emerged naturally from industrial concentration.

Compute reverses that structure.

Artificial intelligence, distributed infrastructure, digital reserve assets, autonomous energy systems, and globally portable capital increasingly allow productive capacity to organise outside traditional metropolitan and constitutional frameworks. The result is the gradual emergence of what may be described as the *Sovereign Individual Economy*: a system in which highly capable individuals, aligned networks, and infrastructure-dense territories acquire forms of practical autonomy previously reserved for states.

This transition is not ideological. It is infrastructural.

The convergence of distributed compute, Bitcoin-denominated reserve systems, private energy corridors, AI-driven productivity, autonomous capital networks, and high-trust territorial communities is beginning to create economic formations capable of operating with decreasing dependence on legacy institutional centres.

For investors, the implications are profound.

The highest-performing assets of the coming decades are unlikely to be purely financial abstractions. They will increasingly consist of:

> compute infrastructure,
>
> energy systems,
>
> strategic territorial networks,
>
> and scarce digital collateral.

The industrial age rewarded scale.
The compute age rewards coherence.

I. The Return of the Sovereign Individual

The industrial state achieved dominance because individuals lacked independent productive capacity.

Factories required centralisation. Armies required mass mobilisation. Banking depended on institutional trust. Communication relied on physical infrastructure. Information travelled slowly, and capital remained geographically constrained.

That world is ending.

A sufficiently capitalised network can now coordinate energy procurement, software deployment, machine intelligence, digital finance, media distribution, education, security systems, and productive labour across multiple jurisdictions simultaneously.

The consequence is not mob rule, but the fragmentation of political legitimacy.

In practical terms, individuals and networks capable of controlling compute increasingly possess forms of leverage once exclusive to sovereign institutions. Economic coordination no longer requires the same degree of territorial centralisation that defined the industrial era.

As productive capacity becomes computational rather than industrial, sovereignty becomes increasingly portable.

II. Compute as Territorial Power

For most of the twentieth century, territorial value derived primarily from industrial production, labour concentration, shipping access, and financial centralisation.

In the compute economy, territorial value reorganises around different variables:

9. energy abundance,
10. cooling capacity,
11. fibre access,
12. political stability,
13. physical defensibility,
14. and infrastructure density.

Artificial intelligence is often described as “digital,” but this is materially misleading. Compute is physical.

It requires substations, transformers, semiconductor logistics, cooling systems, water infrastructure, maintenance engineers, batteries, and uninterrupted electrical continuity. The AI economy is therefore constrained not only by software innovation, but by energy and industrial capacity.

As a result, geography returns.

Regions capable of integrating energy, compute, capital, and social stability are likely to outperform legacy metropolitan centres increasingly dependent on administrative and financial inertia.

This shift is already visible across emerging infrastructure corridors in North America, the Gulf states, and parts of Northern Europe. The future economic map of advanced economies may organise less around financial headquarters and more around compute density and energy sovereignty.

The strategic value of territory is being recalibrated around the ability to sustain machine intelligence at scale.

III. Bitcoin and the Monetary Logic of Compute

The industrial monetary system depends fundamentally upon elasticity.

Modern sovereign currencies require expandable balance sheets, discretionary issuance, debt monetisation, and inflationary flexibility in order to maintain political stability across democratic time horizons.

Bitcoin operates according to a different monetary logic: fixed issuance under decentralised consensus.

This distinction becomes increasingly important in a world where productive capacity itself is becoming computational.

As machine intelligence expands, capital increasingly demands five characteristics from reserve assets:

10. Scarcity
11. Portability
12. Resistance to political debasement
13. Global transferability
14. Machine-verifiable settlement

Bitcoin remains uniquely positioned at the intersection of all five.

Gold retains scarcity but lacks computational portability. Sovereign debt remains liquid but politically contingent. Fiat currencies remain operationally necessary, yet structurally expansionary.

Bitcoin, by contrast, functions as digitally scarce collateral, globally transferable reserve infrastructure, and thermodynamically anchored monetary property.

For compute-intensive economies, this matters enormously.

The reserve layer of the compute age increasingly aligns with energy and computation rather than purely political authority. In this framework, Bitcoin represents not merely a speculative asset, but a monetary primitive native to distributed computational systems.

IV. The Compute Absorption Regime

One of the defining macroeconomic misunderstandings of the current era is the assumption that monetary expansion must necessarily express itself through broad consumer inflation.

Increasingly, it does not.

Large-scale compute infrastructure absorbs liquidity internally before transmission into household consumption occurs.

Modern compute infrastructure investment requires land acquisition, grid expansion, GPU procurement, transformer manufacturing, semiconductor deployment, cooling systems, logistics, and long-duration maintenance networks. Capital settles into fixed productive infrastructure rather than circulating rapidly through consumer markets.

As a consequence:

7. broad money expands,
8. sovereign debt expands,
9. infrastructure deepens,
10. and asset prices appreciate,

while CPI remains comparatively subdued.

Inflation has not disappeared. It has migrated.

It increasingly manifests in:

- compute infrastructure,
- energy systems,
- semiconductor supply chains,
- industrial land,
- and digitally scarce assets such as Bitcoin.

The industrial economy consumed credit.
The compute economy absorbs it.

This distinction may explain why persistent monetary expansion has coincided with weaker-than-expected consumer inflation across many advanced economies. Liquidity is increasingly being captured upstream by infrastructure formation rather than downstream consumption.

V. Machine Demand and the New Infrastructure Cycle

Traditional infrastructure financing historically depended upon volatile human demand cycles.

Compute changes this relationship.

Artificial intelligence introduces persistent recurring machine demand across a widening range of productive functions, including:

- inference systems,
- industrial optimisation,
- autonomous logistics,
- simulation,
- algorithmic coordination,
- and synthetic cognition services.

This materially alters infrastructure economics.

A mature compute corridor increasingly behaves less like speculative technology and more like a railway network, national grid, or strategic utility system. Machine demand compounds continuously and predictably.

The financing implications are substantial:

- longer capital cycles,
- greater debt sustainability,
- lower earnings volatility,
- and increasing territorial autonomy.

Infrastructure capable of stabilising machine demand acquires characteristics historically associated with sovereign productive systems. The result may be the emergence of infrastructure assets with unusually durable cash-flow profiles relative to traditional technology sectors.

VI. Parallel Elites and Infrastructure Sovereignty

The twentieth century selected elites primarily through institutions: universities, bureaucracies, banking systems, political parties, and inherited social structures.

The compute era increasingly selects elites through:

- cognitive capability,
- infrastructural control,
- capital coordination,
- network influence,
- and monetary positioning.

This transition is neither purely democratic decline nor simple aristocratic restoration. It is infrastructural.

The individuals and networks capable of deploying compute, coordinating energy, attracting talent, stabilising territory, and preserving reserve collateral will increasingly exercise practical sovereignty regardless of formal constitutional structure.

This process is already visible globally through:

- sovereign technology ecosystems,
- distributed capital enclaves,
- AI infrastructure corridors,
- Bitcoin treasury systems,
- and computational territories.

The sovereign individual is no longer merely philosophical. The model is becoming economically operational.

VII. The Return of Structural Deflation

One of the central contradictions of the compute economy is that it may prove simultaneously inflationary at the asset layer and deflationary at the consumer layer.

In the early phase of transition, monetary expansion is absorbed into infrastructure build out. This produces sustained appreciation in scarce productive assets and reserve collateral.

However, once deployed at sufficient scale, compute systems begin exerting powerful deflationary pressure across the broader economy.

Artificial intelligence materially reduces the marginal cost of:

- coordination,
- logistics,
- administration,
- design,
- modelling,
- software production,
- customer service,
- and eventually significant portions of knowledge labour itself.

At the same time, automation increases productive output while reducing labour intensity across multiple sectors simultaneously.

The result is a structural expansion in productive capacity.

Historically, deflation has often been associated with economic contraction and collapsing demand. The coming form of deflation may differ materially. It is more likely to emerge through accelerating computational productivity and declining operational costs.

Under such conditions:

5. goods become cheaper to produce,
6. services become increasingly automated,
7. coordination costs decline,
8. and economic output scales faster than wage growth.

This creates a bifurcated economic structure:

- persistent inflation in scarce assets and productive infrastructure,
- combined with long-duration deflationary pressure across consumer and administrative layers of the economy.

In effect, compute may generate abundance downstream while concentrating scarcity upstream in energy, infrastructure, land, and reserve collateral.

For investors, this distinction is critical.

The strongest long-duration returns may increasingly accrue not to consumer-facing demand systems, but to ownership of the scarce productive infrastructure underpinning the deflationary expansion itself.

In this framework, deflation is not the opposite of growth. It becomes one of its consequences.

VIII. Strategic Investor Implications

The strongest asymmetry of the coming decade may emerge from the continued mispricing of the compute-energy infrastructure relative to a traditional fiat credit cycle.

Areas of highest strategic conviction may include:

- compute clusters,
- modular energy systems,
- grid infrastructure,
- transformer manufacturing,
- AI-linked industrial corridors,
- autonomous logistics networks,
- semiconductor infrastructure,
- fibre deployment,
- proof-of-work mining,
- and territorial compute REITs.

Markets increasingly recognise software value. They continue to underprice infrastructure sovereignty.

That discrepancy is unlikely to persist indefinitely.

IX. Conclusion — The Sovereign Compute Age

The industrial age organised civilisation around factories. The information age organised civilisation around networks. The next phase of civilisation is organising itself around compute infrastructure.

This transition is simultaneously:

1. monetary,
2. territorial,
3. political,
4. computational,
5. and civilisational.

Regions and networks capable of absorbing liquidity into productive systems, maintaining energy stability, deploying sovereign compute, preserving scarce reserve collateral, and sustaining coherent social organisation may increasingly acquire forms of autonomy exceeding traditional constitutional structures.

The sovereign individual emerges where computation, territory, energy, capital, and culture become sufficiently coherent to resist external dependency.

The transition is already underway.

Podcast #1 – Stone Tense, Episode XX – "Anglo-Futurism: The Art of the Scale"
With your host: Language_Walker

Welcome to Stone Tense, the podcast where we carve through the ideas shaping our built world, from ancient stone to shimmering graphene. I'm your host, Language_Walker, and today we're diving into a vision so bold it makes my hammer and chisel itch: Sir Aldwyn Rooke's Architectures of Britannia: Building a High-Energy, Layered Civilization. This manifesto isn't just about buildings—it's about reimagining Britain as a luminous, limitless world, a place where every street, spire, and subway sings of ambition. Specifically, we're zooming in on Chapter 2, "Maximum and Minimalism," where Rooke lays out a philosophy that's as electrifying as it is elegant: a Britain that balances serene simplicity with vibrant chaos. Oh, and stick around—I've got news about my new book, The Aureom, dropping soon!

Let's set the stage. Imagine a Britain where cities don't just sprawl—they soar, burrow, and shimmer. Rooke's Anglo-Futurism isn't about choosing between the grand and the delicate; it's about smashing them together in a way that makes your heart race. Chapter 2, "Maximum and Minimalism," is the beating heart of this vision. It's where Rooke argues that Britain's future lies in a paradox: building spaces that are both vast and restrained, chaotic and ordered. This isn't your grandfather's minimalism—think less sterile white boxes, more prismatic megastructures that anchor a city's soul. And it's not chaotic maximalism either—no gaudy clutter here, but a controlled explosion of micro-cultures and tech-driven spectacle.

Let’s start with the minimalism. Rooke describes it as a “martial discipline,” a stripping-down to essentials that doesn’t drain life but amplifies it. Picture a megastructure in Birmingham—let’s call it the Dawn Spire. It’s a towering curve of white graphene-composite, smooth as a pebble in a stream, its surface shifting from pearlescent dawn hues to fiery sunset glows. No fussy ornaments, just clean lines that catch the light and reflect the city back at itself. It’s a visual exhale, a moment of calm amid the urban buzz. But this simplicity isn’t cold—it’s alive. The Dawn Spire’s facade might ripple with subtle nanotechnology, adjusting to the weather, while its open-faced atrium soars hundreds of meters, framing a cascade of rooftop gardens that breathe oxygen into the city. This is minimalism as a canvas, not a void—a structure so pure it lets the chaos around it shine.

Now, flip the coin to maximalism. This is where Anglo-Futurism gets wild, but not reckless. Rooke calls it “controlled chaos,” and it’s about packing life into every crevice of those minimalist frames. Inside the Dawn Spire, you’ve got vertical villages stacked like honeycomb. On one level, a micro-brewery ferments ales—think citrus spiked with hops—while next door, coders trade algorithms for bitcoin in a quantum computing lab. Above, a rooftop cricket pitch hums with players, their cheers drifting over a neo-Georgian library where graphene shelves hold manuscripts that glow faintly at night. These micro-cultures aren’t random; they’re deliberate, each with its own currency, like a local token for artisan goods or a productivity-backed credit for tech hubs. It’s a buzzing, high-energy mosaic where every level feels like a distinct world, yet they’re all woven together by gossamer skybridges and AI-managed lifts that glide like whispers.

What’s genius here is how Rooke makes these opposites dance. The minimalist megastructure is the anchor—its clean lines and open spaces give you room to breathe, to think. But the maximalist micro-cultures fill that space with life, like a forest bursting from a stone plaza. Take a plaza in Manchester’s forest district, as Rooke describes. It’s an open oval of polished limestone, its mirrored pool reflecting a fractal canopy above. By day, it’s serene, a minimalist pause in the city’s pulse. But at night, bio-luminescent pathways flare to life, guiding you to a hidden amphitheatre where folk-techno musicians jam under glowing trees. It’s restraint and exuberance in perfect tension, like a Bach fugue played on a fusion-powered synth.

This dialectic isn’t just aesthetic—it’s philosophical. Rooke’s saying Britain doesn’t have to choose between heritage and innovation, between calm and chaos. A single tower can be both a serene silhouette against the skyline and a teeming metropolis inside. A cavern beneath Newcastle can be a quiet void of raw stone, lit only by bio-luminescent algae, yet host a floating market where traders barter in micro-currencies, their stalls gliding on magnetic tracks. It’s about building spaces that feel infinite, even on an island with finite bounds. And that’s where Rooke’s vision hooks me—every structure is a story, every plaza a provocation to live bigger, think deeper.

Picture a circle of polished basalt monoliths—minimalist to the core, each one a stark, perfect rectangle. They’re silent, enduring, like Stonehenge reborn. But here’s the maximalist kicker: embedded in those stones are thousands of fibre optic filaments. By day, they’re invisible, blending into the basalt. But during a solstice or meteor shower, they blaze to life, turning the circle into a glowing map of the cosmos, visible across the North Sea. It’s a perfect snapshot of Anglo-Futurism: stark simplicity that hides a universe of spectacle, waiting to ignite.

This balance matters because it’s not just about pretty buildings—it’s about a Britain that feels alive, that punches above its weight. Rooke’s minimalism gives us clarity, a way to cut through the noise of modern life. His maximalism gives us vibrancy, a reminder that cities should spark joy, debate, creation. Together, they make every street feel like a choose-your-own-adventure, every tower a world unto itself. It’s a call to architects, builders, and dreamers to reject the grey slog of bureaucracy and build with audacity—spaces that are both a refuge and a riot.

That’s the pulse of Anglo-Futurism, folks—a Britain that’s both a cathedral and a carnival, where minimalism and maximalism don’t fight but fuse into something greater. Sir Aldwyn Rooke’s Architectures of Britannia is a challenge to us all: build cities that don’t just stand but sing, that don’t just house but inspire.

So let’s paint a picture from Rooke’s vision. You’re in Covent Garden on a crisp May evening—say, 4:00 PM BST, the sun casting long shadows. You’re standing in a pocket forest, its trees humming softly, their glowing moss casting an emerald sheen. Threading through this grove is a micro-canal, barely 18 inches wide, its fractal-patterned tiles reflecting the water’s sapphire glow. A tiny autonomous narrowboat, no bigger than a loaf of bread, glides along, carrying a vial of premium ink to a nearby retailer. Nearby, a miniature railway—its sleek, industrial deco tram the size of a skateboard—whispers through a crystal-lined track, ferrying several residents to a glowing plaza. And in the park’s heart, a hyper-detailed miniature model of a neo-Gothic tower, just three feet tall, sits nestled in the undergrowth, its graphene filigree catching the light like a jewel.

Now, zoom out. Beyond this delicate scene looms the Grand Central Canal, 100 feet wide, its hovercraft roaring through London’s Hyper-City at 60 mph, their graphene hulls flashing with Art Deco curves. And nearby, the Aurora Pulse, a 7ft-gauge maglev train, thunders past King’s Cross, its neo-Georgian carriages a rolling cathedral, binding Britain at 400 mph. The entire island just 1 hour away. This is Rooke’s ornamentalism: a dance of the delicate and the colossal, where tiny, intricate details make an island feel boundless, and massive infrastructure anchors its ambition. It’s not just architecture—it’s alchemy.

Rooke’s ornamentalism isn’t about slapping gold leaf on everything—it’s a philosophy of purposeful intricacy, a way to stretch perception. In Architectures of Britannia, he argues that Britain’s greatness was never about square mileage but about punching above its weight. Micro-canals, miniature railways, and detailed miniatures are his tools to make every corner of the island feel like a portal to a bigger world. Let’s break it down.

The micro-canals aren’t just pretty water features—they’re functional, elegant, and mind-bendingly detailed. Tiny narrowboats, powered by micro-turbines, ferry goods like fusion-crafted pendants or artisanal spices, their glowing wakes a delicate dance of light. These canals, as Rooke describes in Chapter 3, double as transport and meditation paths, their ripples soothing the city’s pulse. In Bristol, a micro-canal might flank a Victorian arcade, guiding philosophers to a debating pub, while in Manchester, one threads a vertical village, delivering freshly brewed beer to a subterranean bazaar. They’re small, but their precision and beauty make a single street feel like a cosmos, it enlarges the world, changes the psyche to make the small feel larger.

Then there’s the miniature railways. These aren’t your kid’s toy trains—they’re industrial deco jewels, silent maglevs gliding through crystal-lined tunnels or bio-luminescent pathways. In a reimagined suburban estate outside Sheffield, Rooke visions envisions trams with polished steel accents, their smart glass windows reflecting fractal facades. They connect homes to pocket forests or community hubs, moving residents in minutes while feeling like a theatrical journey. Imagine hopping on one in a graphene-reinforced townhouse, gliding past a glowing micro-stream to a neo-Gothic atelier. These railways, detailed in Chapter 4, are about intimacy—small-scale systems that weave tight-knit communities into Britannia’s larger web, making a neighbourhood feel vast yet connected.

And the real magic? Those hyper-detailed miniatures in parks and open spaces. Rooke’s got this wild idea: scatter tiny, perfect models of Britain’s future across its green spaces. In an Edinburgh pocket forest, you might stumble on a three-foot replica of an English garden with a country estate doubling as a wildlife sanctuary, its filigree so intricate it looks real until you're inches away. Or in a Cardiff plaza, a miniature neo-Georgian villa, complete with glowing smart glass windows, sits by a micro-canal, its scale tricking the eye into seeing a whole city in a single glance. These aren't just decorations—they're perceptual sleight-of-hand, as Rooke calls it in Chapter 1. They make a park feel like a metropolis, a plaza like a universe, by layering detail so dense it stretches your sense of space.

Picture this: you're in Edinburgh's Old Town. You slip down a narrow alley off the Royal Mile, and suddenly, the city's buzz fades. You're in a pocket forest, a dense grove no bigger than a tennis court, yet it feels like stepping into another world. The air hums with the faint vibration of trees, their leaves shimmering with bio-luminescent moss that casts an emerald glow. Beneath your feet, fractal-patterned soil pulses with micro-turbines, recycling nutrients for wild orchids and glowcap mushrooms. A red squirrel darts across a graphene-reinforced branch, its movements tracked by an AI sensor that adjusts irrigation to keep the forest thriving. This is no ordinary park—it's a miniature nature reserve that's as alive as the city around it, straight out of Rooke's vision in Chapter 3.

Imagine a pocket forest in Sheffield, tucked between two neo-Gothic vertical villages. It's a 50-meter-square oasis, its canopy a tangle of trees, their bark, embedded with nano-sensors, monitors air quality, tweaking photosynthesis to filter out the city's lingering industrial echoes. The undergrowth is a carpet of ferns and moss, glowing softly at dusk to light a winding path. Hidden in the centre, a graphene-carved amphitheatre hosts folk-techno jams, the music blending with the forest's ambient soundtrack—chirping birds, rustling leaves, and the faint buzz of bees pollinating wildflowers.

The micro-wildlife here is just as mesmerizing. Rooke's vision isn't about big beasts but tiny, hyper-adapted creatures that thrive in these compact ecosystems. Picture glowcap mushrooms, their caps pulsing with bioluminescence, hosting colonies of beetles engineered to break down urban pollutants. These beetles, no bigger than a grain of rice, scuttle through the soil, their exoskeletons glinting with iridescence.

What makes these pocket forests so wild is their miniature edge. Rooke calls them "ecosystems within ecosystems," and he's not kidding. Every element is wired to work together. The micro-wildlife isn't just cute—it's functional. The micro-wildlife is the soul of this.

Now picture this: you're in London, standing at the base of a megastructure called the Helix Spire. This isn't just a building—it's a vertical metropolis, a 500-meter graphene-composite tower that houses 10,000 people across 80 floors, each one a self-contained micro-community buzzing with its own culture, currency, and vibe. Picture St. John's Wood lifted into the sky: on one floor, a pub with graphene-reinforced oak beams pours gene-edited ales, its smart glass windows offering views of rewilded lowlands. Above, an atelier hums with artisans crafting fusion-powered looms, while below, a crypto-bazaar trades in local tokens under bio-luminescent chandeliers.

Let's unpack these megastructures. In Architectures of Britannia, Rooke describes them as "giants" with "open-faced complexes" that anchor urban life with unapologetic scale. The Helix Spire, inspired by Chapter 5's dialectic of scale, is a curved monolith of white graphene-composite, its facade shimmering like a frozen wave, catching dawn's light in prismatic hues. Its open atrium soars 300 meters, framed by neo-Gothic arches that nod to Victorian ambition, with water channels cascading from rooftop gardens to cool the air. But the magic happens inside, where micro-communities thrive like villages stacked in the sky. Each floor is a modular world, with its own environmental controls—smart glass that shifts opacity, AI-managed air filtration, bio-luminescent lighting—creating micro-climates that reflect the culture within.

Take the 20th floor: it's a micro-community of brewers and coders, like a cyberpunk version of a village green. A pub, the Starlit Tankard, sits at the core, its carbon-fiber tables glowing with inlaid moss, serving lunar-hopped ales and hosting folk-techno nights. Next door, a quantum computing lab hums, coders trading algorithms for crypto-tokens earned from the pub's app-based economy. Gossamer-thin skybridges, lit with bio-luminescent trim, connect to a pocket forest on the same level, where smart trees filter noise and residents debate philosophy under glowing ferns. This floor has its own currency—a BrewToken tied to the pub's output—fostering a fierce local pride, yet it's linked to the tower's broader ecosystem via pneumatic lifts that glide like whispers through ribbed stone shafts.

Now, go up to the 45th floor: it's a neo-Georgian enclave, like St. John's Wood in the clouds. Here, graphene-reinforced villas line a skyborne plaza, their facades etched with fractal patterns that trick the eye into seeing endless depth. A micro-stream, lined with glowing algae, winds through, carrying tiny autonomous barges with artisanal goods—think fusion-crafted pendants or gene-edited spices. A rooftop cricket pitch hums with players, their cheers drifting over a library where graphene shelves hold glowing manuscripts. This community mints its own Artisan Mark, traded via a universal app, and its vibe is slower, more refined, yet still part of the Helix Spire's pulsing whole. The contrast between floors—brewers below, artisans above—creates a controlled chaos, as Rooke describes in Chapter 3, where diversity fuels innovation.

These megastructures are Britannia's answer to finite space. Rooke's genius, laid out in Chapter 1, is using verticality to multiply dimensions. A single tower like the Helix Spire houses more life than a traditional city block, yet feels airy, expansive, because height is orchestrated with precision. Skybridges, so delicate they seem woven from light, link floors into a three-dimensional village network. Micro-canals thread through plazas, their fractal banks making a 50-meter floor feel boundless, automated microlocks provide movement between floors. And pocket forests, tucked between levels, add bursts of cybernetic greenery—smart trees and glowcap mushrooms that make every corner a sanctuary. It's St. John's Wood reimagined: intimate, vibrant, but soaring 500 meters above the earth.

The micro-communities are what make these towers sing. Rooke's vision in Chapter 2 emphasizes "dense micro-cultures" as deliberate acts of design. Each floor is a world with its own aesthetic, economy, and rhythm. On the 60th floor, you might find a cypherpunk collective, their Bitcoin vaults hidden in graphene-lined walls, trading in a DataBit currency while coding in a neon-lit studio. Down on the 15th, a brutalist-revival workshop churns out fusion-powered drones, its artisans bartering in a productivity-backed Industrial Credit. These communities aren't isolated—they're porous, connected by maglev trams that glide through crystal-lined shafts or gondolas that trace elegant arcs outside, their Art Deco cabins shimmering against the skyline. It's a federation of villages, each distinct yet harmonized, like a vertical London borough.

And the pubs? They're the beating heart of these skyborne villages. Rooke's pubs, like the Starlit Tankard, aren't just watering holes—they're cultural hubs, as vital as the markets or ateliers. Picture a pub on the 30th floor, its graphene-oak bar glowing with bio-luminescent inlays, serving gene-edited ciders that taste of engineered blackberry and ozone. Holographic displays project cricket matches or rewilded poetry slams, while nomads and residents trade stories over pints paid for with PubSats, a local micro-currency. The pub's smart glass walls open to a skybridge, where you can sip your drink while watching hovercraft roar along the Grand Hyper-Canal below. It's the kind of place where a coder might spark a debate with a poet, their ideas as fluid as the micro-stream outside—a slice of St. John's Wood's charm, but in the air.

Imagine this you’re wandering the rewilded Pennines, where rolling hills shimmer with heather. You stumble upon a grove of towering forest of trees, their graphene-reinforced trunks glowing faintly with bio-luminescent sap. Hidden inside, carved into living wood, is a community—homes, workshops, even a pub, all nestled within the trees’ hollows, their interiors lit by algae chandeliers. Below London’s streets, a subterranean city hums, its cavern-markets glowing with crystal-lined tunnels, traders bartering. Above, gossamer skybridges link megastructures, their carbon-fiber spans swaying like spider silk, carrying poets to rooftop raves. This is Rooke’s layering from Chapters 1 and 3—a Britain where space is multiplied, not just built, making an island feel infinite.

Let’s start with the rural rewilded areas. Rooke’s vision in Chapter 3 imagines ecosystems within ecosystems, where nature and tech fuse to hide entire communities. Picture a Pennines grove, its trees engineered to grow hollow chambers within their trunks, like natural megastructures. These aren’t just trees—they’re habitats, their bark embedded with sensors that regulate air and light. Inside, a micro-community thrives: artisans craft fusion-powered textiles in graphene-lined workshops, their looms humming under bio-luminescent vines. A communal hall, carved from a massive oak, hosts debates, its walls pulsing with sap that glows emerald at dusk. Micro-streams, lined with fractal-patterned algae, wind through the grove, ferrying goods on tiny barges to a hidden market. The aesthetic is organic yet futuristic—raw wood and glowing moss meet carbon-fiber supports, creating a sanctuary that feels both ancient and cutting-edge, hidden from the world yet alive with purpose.

Now, shift to the cities, where Rooke’s subterranean realms, detailed in Chapter 5, turn the earth into a canvas. Beneath Manchester, a cavern-city carved from limestone bedrock pulses with life. Its markets, lit by bio-luminescent algae tracing geological strata, shimmer like an underground aurora. Traders hawk gene-edited produce under crystal-lined arches, while silent maglev trams glide through tunnels, their routes following forgotten rivers. Deep balconies puncture the caverns, funnelling sunlight to limestone plazas where coders sip coffee by glowing geothermal baths. The aesthetic here is primal yet precise—raw stone meets laser-cut precision, with algae and smart glass adding a radiant, fluid glow. It’s a hidden world, a subterranean St. John’s Wood, where every corner feels like a secret waiting to be discovered.

Above ground, skybridges weave Rooke’s vertical villages together, as seen in Chapter 2. These aren’t just walkways—they’re kinetic sculptures, carbon-fiber threads so delicate they seem to float, lit with bio-luminescent trim that pulses sapphire at night. In London’s Helix Spire, skybridges link floors of micro-communities—pubs, ateliers, pocket forests—creating a three-dimensional tapestry. Imagine crossing a bridge from a neo-Georgian library to a crypto-bazaar, the city’s glow reflected in smart glass panels below your feet. The aesthetic is airy, almost ethereal, yet grounded by the megastructure’s graphene-stone bulk, making a single tower feel like a sprawling metropolis.

Now, let’s head to the Peak District, where Samuel Ashcombe’s hyper-tech Kommune is located. Nestled in any hidden valley is a cluster of limestone cottages, their graphene-insulated walls could be entwined with bio-luminescent foxgloves. But the real magic is the trees—massive, gene-edited yews with hollowed interiors housing entire families. A central yew, dubbed the Hearth Tree, contains a communal hall where residents trade Artisan Marks for fusion-crafted pottery, its walls glowing with sap-lit patterns. Miniature railways could line the area, their industrial deco trams gliding on bio-luminescent tracks, which connect cottages engaging in trade.

So to finish, we’re diving into one of the wildest visions from Rooke: Today, we’re chasing his wildest vision: nomadic communities—tens of thousands, mostly young, living on 7ft-gauge maglev trains, crashing in hotels, spare rooms, or wherever they can, with just a backpack of possessions. This high-movement life maximizes human action, boosts population capacity, cuts housing demand, and fuels life experience.

Imagine this: it’s dusk, and you’re aboard the Aurora Pulse, a 7ft-gauge maglev train slicing through Britannia at 400 mph. Its neo-Gothic carriages, graphene-composite with smart glass, glow with fractal patterns, a rolling cathedral speeding past rewilded valleys. You’re in a dining car, fusion-powered plates steaming with trout, trading tokens for a poet’s zine with a young philosopher. Later, you crash in a Manchester hotel’s micro-room, your backpack—holding just a smart tablet, clothes, and a glowing pendant—tucked under a graphene-oak bed. Tomorrow, you’re in a Sheffield spare room, bartering DataBits for a night’s stay via a universal app. This is Britain in relentless motion—millions of nomads, especially under 35, living light, moving fast, weaving a cultural web across trains, hotels, and hidden corners.

Rooke’s vision is a game-changer: maximize human action by embracing mobility. He sees millions—say, five million, mostly young—choosing nomadic life, not tethered to flats or mortgages. They live on maglev trains, in hotel micro-rooms, spare rooms in smart villages, or even pop-up pods in pocket forests, carrying minimal possessions: a smart device, a few clothes, maybe a crafted trinket. This high-movement lifestyle does three things. First, it scales population capacity. Trains housing thousands, hotels with modular rooms, and spare spaces in megastructures let Britannia support more people without sprawling estates. Second, it slashes housing demand. Why own a home when you can rent a train cabin or a hotel pod with crypto? Third, it’s a life experience forge. Every city, every train, every spare room is a new story—coding with cypherpunks, dancing at folk-techno raves, or debating in a subterranean pub.

Let’s live a day as a nomad. You wake on the Aurora Pulse, in a cabin of graphene-oak and bio-luminescent moss, your backpack slung on a carbon-fiber hook. Breakfast is in the dining car, where you swap a token—earned from a freelance gig—for a fusion-powered coffee, its gene-edited beans zinging with ozone. The car’s a salon: a coder pitches a blockchain app, a nomad trades a poem for your thoughts on AI. By noon, you’re in London, checking into a hotel’s micro-room—smart glass walls showing rewilded cliffs, your few possessions fitting in a graphene drawer. You head to a crypto-hub in a megastructure, bartering DataBits for a glowing textile from a Cotswolds artisan. The hub’s aesthetic—neon steel, holographic screens—feels like a sci-fi market, yet the chatter’s as warm as a village inn.

Afternoon, and you’re in Manchester, crashing in a spare room in a neo-Georgian vertical village. Your host, paid in Manchester coin, shares a cider as you swap stories of your life on the train. Later, you hit a subterranean pub, its bio-luminescent algae walls glowing sapphire, where nomads dance under fractal chandeliers, trading zines and crypto-tips. By evening, you’re in a pop-up pod in a Sheffield pocket forest, your smart tablet projecting a debate from the train’s library car. This is Rooke’s controlled chaos from Chapter 3—every train, hotel, or spare room a micro-world, every move a chance to connect, create, live.

The aesthetics scream Anglo-Futurism. Maglev trains are giants—vaulted arches of graphene-composite, smart glass rippling with holographic tapestries. Hotel micro-rooms blend heritage and hyper-tech: graphene-oak panels meet bio-luminescent trim, making a 10-square-meter space feel vast. Spare rooms in smart villages or megastructures mix limestone warmth with fractal smart glass, turning a corner of a home into a nomad’s haven. Pop-up pods in pocket forests, carbon-fiber shells with glowing moss, feel like sci-fi cocoons. Each space, however small, is a cultural hub—trains with 5,000 nomads host gyms, ateliers, and pocket forests; hotels have crypto-lounges; spare rooms spark debates. It’s a Britain where every stop feels epic, like a saga unfolding.

This nomadic life maximizes human action through freedom. Young nomads, unburdened by possessions, thrive on agency. Housing demand? Plummets—train cabins, hotel pods, and spare rooms replace flats, freeing cities for rewilded zones or vertical villages. Population capacity? Soars

—trains and modular spaces house millions, linking Britannia's nodes in a high-energy web, as Rooke dreams in Chapter 1. Life experience? Endless—every city, from Newcastle's cavern-cities to Edinburgh's skybridges, adds skills, stories, connections. It's a university of the rails, rooms, and roads, where youth forge their futures by moving.

Rooke's nomadic Britannia—millions on the move, living light in trains, hotels, and wherever they land—is a call to maximize human action. It's a nation where young dreamers trade ideas, dance, and build, easing housing woes, scaling capacity, and forging lives of adventure. Architectures of Britannia dares us to make motion our meaning.

And so, as we pull into the final station of this episode, let's take a moment to reflect on the journey we've shared.

We've seen how Rooke's Anglo-Futurist design turns transport into art, with neo-Gothic trains and bio-luminescent hotels that make every journey feel like a saga. We've felt the pulse of micro-communities on rails and in hidden corners, where minimal possessions free us to trade ideas, poetry, and dreams. This is a Britain where scale and intimacy dance, where the monumental and the delicate weave a tapestry of possibility. And at the heart of it all is the aureom—that conscious presence where we know we're living a moment that will echo through time.

In my new book, The Aureom, I dive into this very pulse, capturing nights of electric debate in an Islington townhouse, where friends sparred over taste, the sublime, and civilization's climb—moments that arrived like rain or grace. These are the same moments Rooke's nomads live: a shared cider in a spare room, a poem traded on a train, each a golden thread in the fabric of a life well-lived. The Aureom is a call to bless these moments without trapping them, to live with anticipatory reverence, recognizing the now as already sacred.

So, as we disembark, I invite you to carry this vision forward. Embrace the aureom in your own life—whether you're on a maglev or in a quiet room, let every moment be a chance to live vividly. Pre-order The Aureom now at Language_Walkeraureom.com—it's a manifesto for chasing golden nows, for building a life that shines. And don't forget to grab Rooke's manifesto—it's a wild ride. Until next time, keep moving through the stone, and live in the aureom.

Podcast #2 - Stone Tense, Episode XXII – "The Beautiful Word: Nietzsche and the Spirit of Philology"

With your host: Language_Walker

Before there was philosophy, there was song.
Before the word became an argument, it was a vibration — a pulse, a rhythm, a calling.
Nietzsche began there — not in logic, but in the ancient music of words.
He began not with systems or definitions, but with letters that lived, breathed, and trembled.
Greek words, to him, were not dry symbols; they were living forms, fossils of passions once sung aloud, echoes of laughter, of grief, of defiance, carved into the memory of the tongue.
Each syllable held a history of human joy and suffering, a secret cadence that waited for ears willing to listen.
Nietzsche's study of philology was not merely academic. It was a form of devotion. A slow, loving attention to the textures of language itself. To read was to touch the pulse of life.
And here, in this very moment, I ask you — the listener — to consider:
What would it mean to write English as though it were still alive?
To let the consonants hum with energy, to let vowels carry longing, to let the sentence itself breathe?

This episode seeks to explore that question.
To rediscover beauty in language — not as decoration, not as ornament, not as prettiness — but as force.
The force to move the mind. To stir the soul. To awaken the spirit that lingers in the space between words.
Nietzsche once wrote: "Philology is the art of slow reading."
Consider that for a moment. Slow reading — not skimming, not scanning, not consuming. Slow reading. A deliberate, attentive, almost reverent encounter with each word, each letter, each pause between them.
It is a kind of ethical patience, a resistance to the mechanization of thought, a refusal to let the world's noise strip meaning from the living pulse of language.
But what Nietzsche discovered in his philological work was something more profound than a method of reading. He discovered that aesthetics are a living form — something that breathes, something that has its own existence, something that must be felt rather than merely understood.
For Nietzsche, language was not merely a tool. It was *geist* made audible. He saw, with clarity and melancholy, that modern words had grown dull, bureaucratic, lifeless — without music. They were instruments that no longer sang, sentences that no longer danced. And when words died, he believed, the spirit dies with them.
This was not simply about aesthetics in the shallow sense — not about making things pretty or pleasant. This was about the capacity of the word to create, to make real or irrelevant, to transform reality from an abstract concept into a living, breathing presence in consciousness.
Think about what happens when you encounter genuine beauty. Not prettiness. Not decoration. But beauty that stops you in your tracks — beauty that makes your breath catch, that opens something in your chest, that seems to reveal a truth you'd forgotten you knew.
It might be a line of poetry. A passage of music. A shaft of light through leaves. A face in a certain expression. The curve of a hillside at dusk.
In that moment, beauty is not an idea. It is a presence. It is something you feel with your whole body, something that seems to exist independently of your perception of it, something that is.
And language — beautiful language — has the power to create this same experience. To make beauty present. To give it form and breath.
This is what Nietzsche's philology was seeking: a way to understand how the Greeks had achieved this, and how we might achieve it again.
In the Greek tragedies he loved, words were alive — vibrant, embodied, unrelenting. Each syllable carried energy; each line moved as if it were a body, each chorus resonating like the heartbeat of a people. Rhythm and meaning fused. Thought and feeling intertwined. To hear those words was to feel them vibrate in the very marrow.
But more than this: the Greek language itself carried beauty as an inherent quality. It wasn't that the Greeks wrote beautifully about beauty. It was that their language was beautiful, that the very act of speaking Greek was an act of aesthetic creation.
Consider the Greek word kalos — beautiful. But it doesn't just mean beautiful in our sense. It means beautiful-and-good. Kalos kai agathos — beautiful and good — this was a single concept, an inseparable unity. Beauty was not separate from virtue, from excellence, from the highest human possibilities.
Or consider kosmos — the word that gives us "cosmos." But originally it meant order, arrangement, adornment. The universe was beautiful because it was ordered. Beauty and order were the same thing. To perceive the cosmos was to perceive beauty.
The Greek language thought in terms of beauty. It made beauty fundamental to reality itself.
And in Greek tragedy, this reached its highest expression. When Aeschylus describes the beacon fires that announce the fall of Troy — fire leaping from peak to peak across the Aegean, light answering light through the darkness — the language doesn't just describe this beauty. The language becomes it. The rhythm of the verse moves like the leaping flames. The sound of the words crackles and blazes.

Beauty is not being represented. Beauty is being created in the language itself.

This is what we've lost. Or rather, what our language has forgotten how to do.

Here we pause, imagining modern English. Can our sentences reclaim that vitality? Can our prose breathe as though it carries a pulse, a resonance, a kind of embodied energy?

One is reminded of another of the greatest philologists. There is a particular stillness in Tolkien's world before the act of waking — the hush before the first word is spoken, the dawn before consciousness opens its eyes. Among the Elves, waking is not simply the return from sleep; it is an awakening into being itself — the first awareness of light, the recognition of beauty, the moment in which language and world become one.

Tolkien's idea of "the waking of the Elves" belongs to a very old lineage of thought — one that stretches from the dawn hymns of the Rigveda to the first pages of Genesis, from Hesiod's Theogony to the early Christian hymns of light. The philologist in him — for Tolkien was a philologist before he was a novelist — heard in those ancient texts not just myths of creation, but songs of consciousness.

When Eru Ilúvatar sings the world into being in The Silmarillion, the motif is strikingly Indo-European: a cosmogony through sound. This is not mere narrative; it is a linguistic theology. Words make worlds. In that sense, the Elves "wake" not merely to existence, but to speech, to the word as illumination. Their awakening mirrors the human one in Genesis — "Let there be light" — but where the biblical awakening is divine command, Tolkien's is more organic, musical, self-becoming. The Elves awaken into light, not by it. They do not receive consciousness; they join it.

Tolkien knew well the ancient etymologies that bind light, knowledge, and awakening together. In Old English, lēoht means both "light" and "understanding." In Latin, lucere — to shine — gives us lux, and illustratio, enlightenment. Even the Greek phōs, light, survives in philosophy, the love of light, of wisdom. To wake, in all these tongues, is to become radiant with awareness.

The Elves' awakening beside Cuiviénen, "the waters of awakening," recalls the idea of consciousness emerging beside the waters of chaos — an image found in the Enuma Elish, the Hebrew Bible, and the Rigveda. But Tolkien transforms it with his own linguistic genius: for him, awakening is not a divine imposition or a violent order — it is a listening. The first Elves hear the sound of water before they see the stars. Sound precedes sight, just as music precedes speech. Philologically, this is perfect. Language begins in listening.

Tolkien may have drawn inspiration from the Kalevala, the Finnish epic that so captivated him as a student. In the tale of Väinämöinen, the ancient singer, we find the power of runes and song to shape reality — a linguistic magic that anticipates Tolkien's notion of sub-creation. The Elves' songs are not artifice; they are participation in the original harmony of being. To sing beautifully is to remember the moment of waking.

The Elvish languages themselves, Quenya and Sindarin, embody this awakening. Their phonology is not arbitrary: soft, luminous vowels; liquid consonants; the rhythm of breath and light. They are languages that seem to have just opened their eyes. Their beauty is born of reverence — a philologist's reverence — for the moment when speech and spirit are one.

To read Tolkien as a philologist is to see that "waking" is his master-key. It is not just the Elves who wake, but the reader. In every sentence, there is the invitation to re-enter that primal clarity — to see the world again as though for the first time, to let words recover their brightness, their living roots. For Tolkien, to wake is to remember. And to remember is to speak rightly, beautifully — as if language were still holy, as if every word carried the light of its first dawn.

Yet Nietzsche saw the degradation happening in real time. The language of German academia — abstract, systematic, ponderous. The language of newspapers — sensational but empty. The language of commerce — transactional, efficient, soulless.

What all these shared was a fundamental alienation from nature as a living form. Words were no longer vessels of aesthetic phenomenology. They were merely vehicles for information transfer, for atomistic reality, for utility.

And when language loses its connection to beauty, something catastrophic happens to consciousness itself. We lose the ability to feel **it**, to recognize **it**, to create **it**. We become numb to the aesthetic dimension of the self, of *cogito ero sum*.

Think about the language that surrounds us today. Corporate speak. Academic jargon. Social media discourse. Advertising copy. News headlines. The flat, affectless prose of bureaucracy.

"Optimize." "Leverage." "Impact" as a verb. "Circle back." "Touch base." "Reach out."

These aren't just ugly phrases — though they are ugly. They represent a consciousness that has lost touch with beauty entirely. They are the language of a culture that no longer believes beauty matters, that has reduced all value to utility, efficiency, productivity.

Or consider academic language: "The problematization of hegemonic discourse reveals the extent to which normative paradigms instantiate ideological apparatuses of subject formation."

This sentence might mean something. But it means it in a way that kills all beauty, all life, all possibility of linguistic phenomenology. It is the opposite of Greek tragedy. It is language that has murdered its own soul.

And yet — and this is the crucial point — English can be beautiful. English has been beautiful. English is capable of creating beauty as a living form.

Nietzsche reminds us that to read well is to live well. And perhaps, by extension, to write beautifully is to awaken life itself within language.

What makes a sentence beautiful?

Not correctness — but cadence. Not clarity — but resonance. Not mere arrangement of words, but the music they make together.

Consider the sound-beauty of words themselves, independent of meaning — what linguists call phonaesthetics. Why does "cellar door" sound so exquisite to the ear, as Tolkien once suggested? Why does some combination of consonants and vowels linger in the mind long after it is spoken?

These are not idle questions. The music of language is the pulse of thought made audible.

Let's go deeper into this. Let's feel it.

Say the word "luminous" aloud. Feel how it opens in your mouth — the liquid "L," the bright "u," the humming "m." The word itself seems to glow. It doesn't just mean glowing; it is glowing in its very sound.

Now say "shadow." Feel the soft "sh," the dark "a," the descending "dow." The word sinks into darkness as you speak it.

This is not accident. This is language as aesthetic form. The sound creates the experience of what it names.

Or consider longer phrases. Listen to how these feel in your mouth, in your ear:

"The silver rain, the shining sun."

"Stones in stillness, standing."

"Through the long blue shadows of the afternoon."

Each of these has a music independent of meaning. The alliteration, the vowel patterns, the rhythm — they create a sensory experience. They make beauty present.

We can hear it in the prose of Oscar Wilde, where wit becomes rhythm; in Virginia Woolf, where the flowing sentences are like rivers of consciousness; in D.H. Lawrence, where earthiness and passion resonate in every word. Even in contemporary poetic prose, we find that the right combination of sound and image can make language vibrate like a living body.

Listen to Woolf describing a moment in To the Lighthouse:

"And all the lives we ever lived and all the lives to be are full of trees and changing leaves."

Feel the rhythm: "all the lives we ever lived" — four stresses in succession, like footsteps. Then "and all the lives to be" — the pattern repeats but lighter, faster. Then "are full of trees and changing leaves" — the rhythm opens, expands, breathes.

And the sound: "lives," "lives," "leaves" — the echoing vowels create unity. "Trees," "leaves" — the long "ee" sound stretches out, makes you linger.

This is beauty created in language. Not described. Created.

Contrast this with functional English — the language of instruction manuals, forms, emails. Functional English communicates, yes, but it rarely moves. It rarely hums, rarely pulses. It rarely sings.

Beauty in language is not a luxury. It is how thought breathes. When prose becomes rhythm, the mind dances. When words are arranged with attention to their sound, their cadence, their resonance, they carry the reader — or the listener — into thought itself, into feeling itself.

But there's something even more profound happening when language is beautiful. It's not just that beautiful language is pleasant to experience. It's that beautiful language can create the experience of beauty where none existed before.

This is the alchemy: language that transforms perception itself.

Think about how a great writer describes something ordinary and makes you see it as beautiful for the first time. The way Annie Dillard describes a tree, or water, or light. The way Nabokov describes a butterfly. The way James Baldwin describes a face.

They're not just recording beauty they've observed. They're making the beauty through the language itself. After you read their description, you can never see that thing the same way again. They've awakened you to a beauty that was always there but that you couldn't perceive until the language made it present.

Listen to this, from Nabokov's Speak, Memory, describing a butterfly:

"It was a splendid, pale-yellow creature with black blotches, blue crenels, and a cinnabar eyespot above each chrome-rimmed black tail."

The precision here — "crenels," "cinnabar," "chrome-rimmed" — this isn't scientific dryness. This is devotion. Each word is chosen for its sonic beauty as much as its accuracy. "Cinnabar" — that word has richness, has weight, has colour in its very sound. "Chrome-rimmed" — you can see the metallic gleam.

But more: the rhythm of the sentence builds. Short phrases accumulating: "black blotches, blue crenels," then longer: "a cinnabar eyespot above each chrome-rimmed black tail." The sentence moves like the butterfly itself, building to that spectacular tail.

After reading this, you cannot see butterflies as you did before. Nabokov has made them beautiful through language. He has created beauty.

Or listen to Barry Lopez describing ice in Arctic Dreams:

"The ice was a milky turquoise, like a pale, watery sky."

Simple. Precise. But that phrase "milky turquoise" — two words that shouldn't quite work together, that create a synaesthetic confusion that's exactly right. You can see that color, that quality of translucence. And "like a pale, watery sky" — notice that "watery." Ice described as water, sky described as water. Everything flowing into everything else.

This is language making beauty visible.

This brings us to the heart of Nietzsche's vision: that through beautiful language, through the cultivation of aesthetic sensitivity, we might create a higher culture.

What does this mean?

For Nietzsche, culture is not a set of institutions or customs. Culture is the quality of consciousness that a people achieves. It is their capacity for excellence, for beauty, for greatness. A high culture is one where human beings reach their highest possibilities.

And language is the medium through which culture exists. We think in language. We feel in language. We perceive reality through the structures and possibilities that language provides.

Therefore: if we want a higher culture, we must cultivate a more beautiful language. We must learn to use language to create beauty, to perceive beauty, to make beauty a living presence in consciousness.

This is not elitism in the shallow sense. It's not about excluding people or maintaining hierarchies. It's about elevating human consciousness itself. About giving everyone access to the aesthetic dimension of existence that makes life worth living.

Think about what happens when you read a truly beautiful sentence, a truly beautiful paragraph. Something shifts in you. You become more alive, more sensitive, more aware. You perceive more deeply. You feel more fully.

Now imagine if our entire linguistic environment were like this. If the language we encountered daily — in conversation, in media, in public discourse — were beautiful. If words sang instead of clunking. If sentences breathed instead of limping.

We would become different people. We would think differently. Feel differently. Live differently. We would have created a culture where beauty is not a luxury for the few, but the living medium of consciousness for all.

This is what Nietzsche saw in Greek culture at its height. Beauty was not separate from life. It was life itself, intensified, elevated, made radiant.

And this is what his philology sought to recover: not just knowledge of ancient languages, but the living principle that made those languages beautiful. The understanding that language is not a tool but a form of life, and that beautiful language creates beautiful consciousness.

But how do we actually cultivate this? How do we learn to feel beauty as a living, breathing form? Nietzsche's answer is clear: through devoted attention. Through practice. Through learning to listen.

Listen to this moment from Thus Spoke Zarathustra, where Nietzsche is trying to evoke the experience of eternal return, of affirming existence completely:

"I teach you the Overman. Man is something that shall be overcome. What have you done to overcome him?"

Hear how the rhythm remains flat, how the aphoristic cadence pulses like a heartbeat, how the words demand engagement not only from the mind but from the body. Here, philosophy is music. Thought is flesh. Meaning is experience.

This is the unity we seek: rhythm, imagery, and precision fused. Thought-feeling becomes inseparable. English can move, can dance, can sing — if we attend to it, if we cultivate it, if we dare to make it beautiful.

But feeling beauty requires learning to perceive differently. It requires slowing down, paying attention, becoming sensitive to the aesthetic dimension that's always present but usually ignored.

Start by reading beautiful prose aloud. Let your body participate. Feel how the sentences move through you. Notice where your breath catches, where the rhythm pulls you forward, where the sound makes you pause.

Then try to articulate what's happening. Why is this beautiful? Is it the sound? The rhythm? The images? The way meaning and music fuse?

You're training your aesthetic perception. You're learning to feel beauty as a living form.

Then — and this is crucial — try to create it yourself. Write a sentence. Read it aloud. Is it beautiful? Does it breathe? Does it sing?

If not, revise. Change a word. Alter the rhythm. Find a better image. Keep working until you feel it come alive.

This is not easy. This is craft. This is devotion. But this is how we cultivate aesthetic consciousness.

By learning to create beauty, we learn to perceive beauty. By learning to perceive beauty, we become capable of living beautifully.

There's something deeply erotic about beautiful language. Not erotic in the narrow sexual sense, but in the broader sense of eros — the life force, the creative energy, the desire that moves toward beauty and excellence.

Nietzsche understood this. His language is passionate, alive with desire. The desire to create, to elevate, to transform. The desire to make language beautiful because beauty itself is desirable.

When we encounter beautiful language, we feel drawn to it. We want to return to it, to experience it again, to let it move through us. This is eros. This is the life force responding to beauty.

And when we create beautiful language, we're participating in this same erotic energy. We're not just arranging words functionally. We're pouring desire into form. We're trying to create something worthy of love.

This changes everything about how we approach language. Writing becomes not a chore, not a task to complete efficiently, but an act of devotion. An offering. An attempt to create something beautiful enough to justify existence.

Reading becomes not consumption, not information extraction, but encounter. Meeting with beauty. Opening yourself to be moved, changed, elevated.

This is what a culture built around linguistic beauty would feel like. It would be erotic in the highest sense. Alive with desire. Oriented toward excellence. Every conversation, every text, every utterance an opportunity for aesthetic creation.

One final, crucial point: beautiful language is not opposed to truth. It is not decoration hiding reality. Beautiful language reveals truth more deeply than functional language ever can.

Why? Because truth is not just factual accuracy. Truth is disclosure. Truth is reality revealing itself. And reality at its deepest is beautiful.

When Nietzsche writes beautifully about suffering, he's not prettifying suffering. He's revealing its truth — that suffering can be meaningful, can be transformative, can be the price of greatness.

When a poet writes beautifully about death, they're not denying death's horror. They're revealing death's truth — that mortality makes life precious, that finitude is the condition of meaning.

Beautiful language doesn't escape reality. It penetrates more deeply into reality. It makes us feel truths that abstract language can only state.

This is why poetry is truer than philosophy, as Nietzsche sometimes claimed. Not because it's more accurate, but because it makes truth present. It creates the experience of truth, not just the concept.

A beautiful sentence about grief doesn't just tell you about grief. It makes you feel grief, even if you're not grieving. It discloses the truth of grief through aesthetic form.

This is the ultimate power of beautiful language: it makes reality transparent. It removes the veil between consciousness and existence. It lets us feel the truth of things directly, immediately, viscerally.

So we return to the question that drives this entire exploration:

What would it mean to create a higher culture of language? A culture where beauty is not incidental but fundamental? Where language breathes and sings and makes beauty present?

It would mean, first, refusing the degradation of language we see everywhere around us. Refusing to accept that communication must be merely functional. Refusing to let words become dead, bureaucratic, lifeless.

It would mean cultivating our aesthetic sensitivity. Learning to hear the music in language. Learning to feel beauty as a living form. Training ourselves to perceive the aesthetic dimension that makes life worth living.

It would mean practising the creation of beauty in our own language. Writing sentences that breathe. Speaking words that resonate. Making every utterance an opportunity for aesthetic excellence.

It would mean understanding that beautiful language is not luxury or decoration, but necessity. That the quality of our language determines the quality of our consciousness, and the quality of our consciousness determines the quality of our lives.

It would mean recognizing that we are not powerless in the face of linguistic degradation. Each of us, in every sentence we write or speak, has the opportunity to create beauty or to create ugliness. To elevate language or to degrade it further.

This is not about perfection. This is not about never making mistakes or always achieving sublimity. This is about orientation. About moving toward beauty rather than away from it. About caring enough to try.

And if enough of us do this — if enough of us commit to creating beautiful language, to cultivating aesthetic consciousness, to making beauty a living presence in our linguistic world — then we might actually achieve what Nietzsche dreamed of: a culture where human beings reach their highest possibilities.

Not through force. Not through ideology. But through beauty. Through the elevation of consciousness that beautiful language makes possible.

This is the work. This is the devotion. This is the path toward a higher culture.
Welcome.

Appendix #6 - Hypermodernity and Sovereignty by Eliot Ashton

The Houses of Parliament echoed with a raw tension, a vibrant undercurrent that had the old statues on the walls looking a tad nervous. Alfred, Duke of Derbyshire, stood tall, an embodiment of modern nobility, his sharp eyes radiating fierce determination. The ancient chamber had seen its share of power plays, but this was different.

"The King's recent decisions," Alfie's voice rang out, breaking through the parliamentary hum, "dare I say, they're an infringement on our citizens' rights, an old-fashioned money grab under the guise of governance!"

His declaration hung in the air, a direct challenge to the King's authority. There was a moment of silence, a quick inhale of breath as the room braced for the fallout.

It came in the form of Lord Hampton, a staunch supporter of the King. "Alfred," he retorted, "I find your words hasty. These measures are necessary for maintaining the country's stability!"

"Stability?" Alfie echoed, a grim smile flickering over his lips. "Or a forced appropriation of wealth, my lord?"

The debate raged on, heated exchanges echoing off the chamber walls. Alfie was unwavering, his words like digital arrows challenging the King's old-world ways. Beneath the rhetoric, the duel was clear - it was Bitcoin and the new aristocracy against the Crown's traditional dominance.

Outside the parliament, London hummed with activity, a digital symphony born of old-world charm and new-world tech. Maglev trains crisscrossed the land, high-tech billboards flickered with crypto rates, and people hustled, their lives enriched yet complicated by the Bitcoin standard.

Alfie stepped into the rhythm of the city, its vibrant energy seeping into his veins. He had a meeting with some fellow lords - off the record, naturally - at one of London's most exclusive clubs, The Satoshi Lounge.

The lounge, a meld of classic British elegance and high-tech wizardry, buzzed with whispered strategies and subdued laughter. Over crystal glasses of aged scotch, they discussed, debated, and sometimes argued. But beneath the varied opinions, a consensus was slowly emerging - the King had overstepped, and the time was ripe for pushback.

Across the city, in tiny flats and spacious mansions alike, a similar sentiment was brewing. Londoners, whether they traded in Bitcoins or memories, were growing restless under the King's increasing interference. A bartender at a local pub might not articulate it as eloquently as Alfie did in the House of Lords, but the underlying sentiment was the same - the King's appetite for control was not a good look in a Bitcoin-empowered Britain.

Back in Derbyshire, Alfie's wife, Victoria, and their children bore the brunt of the political storm. Victoria, ever the supportive partner, took care of the home front, reassuring their children and managing the household. Her mind, however, was a whirl of worry, her heart echoing Alfie's unease.

Amidst the storm, ordinary life continued. Bitcoin rates fluctuated, hearts throbbed with dreams, and the march of progress refused to halt. In every corner of the kingdom, people adjusted and readjusted, bracing for whatever the future held.

But change, as always, was on the horizon.

Alfie's return to Derbyshire was a journey from the center of pulsating politics to the tranquillity of familial ties. As the self-navigating vehicle cruised through the verdant English countryside, he found his thoughts drifting towards home, towards Victoria.

Upon his arrival, Chatsworth House embraced him in its timeless warmth. The grandeur of the place never failed to impress, but for Alfie, its true beauty was the family it housed. His children rushed to greet him, their young voices a symphony of joy, erasing the echoes of the parliament's harsh debates.

Victoria, the Duchess of Derbyshire, awaited him in their private drawing room. A woman of grace and strength, she radiated an elegance that time and stress had only enhanced.

"Welcome back, Alfie," Victoria greeted, her words a soothing balm.

He smiled, "I am, indeed, back."

A silence stretched between them, comfortable and understanding. Alfie poured himself a drink, the amber liquid reflecting the room's soft lights. Finally, he said, "The King's overstepping, Victoria. The parliament is a battlefield, and the people are restless."

Victoria nodded, a sense of worry clouding her usually bright eyes. "What's the plan, Alfie?"

"We push back," he replied. "We remind the King that it is the people's will that rules, not his whims. We may be aristocrats, Victoria, but we're not oppressors. We're representatives, guardians. It's high time the King remembered that."

A moment of silence fell over them, their resolve strengthening in the quiet. They stood together, ready to face the storm that loomed on the horizon.

In the grand dining room of Chatsworth House, over a simple yet elegant dinner, Alfie and Victoria's conversation flowed from one topic to another. They spoke of their children, of local events, of the latest breakthroughs in technology - their shared laughter a testament to their strong bond.

"So, Bella won first place in the maths competition," Victoria said, a proud smile on her face.

Alfie chuckled, "Just like her mother, brilliant and competitive."

Their laughter echoed through the room, softening the echoes of political tensions. The clink of cutlery and the rustle of the evening breeze through the open window provided a comforting backdrop.

Later, as the night deepened and the stars glittered in the clear sky, they retreated to their shared sanctuary – their bedroom. The room, tastefully decorated, was a haven of tranquillity. It held an air of intimacy, a world that belonged solely to Alfie and Victoria.

With a sigh of relief, Victoria slipped off her shoes, "I swear, Alfie, these heels will be the end of me."

Alfie chuckled, loosening his tie, "Yet, you won't give up on them, will you?"

She shot him a playful glare, "Absolutely not. A woman must have her vices."

Their laughter filled the room, the worries of the world pushed away, if only for a while. In their shared silence, they found solace, their bond a fortress against the world's uncertainties.

As the moonlight spilled through the large window, bathing their room in a soft, silver glow, Alfie and Victoria lay in their bed. The quiet of the night seemed to hush the world outside, and within the privacy of their room, their conversation took a deeper tone.

"Alfie," Victoria said, her voice barely a whisper, "are you scared?"

Alfie turned to face her, his gaze soft in the dim light. "I would be lying if I said no," he admitted. "We're on the brink of a major shift, Victoria. It's unnerving, but it's also necessary."

Victoria nodded, her fingers tracing idle patterns on his chest. "You've always been brave, Alfie, braver than most. I just worry about the cost of this bravery."

Alfie caught her hand, bringing it to his lips. "The cost would be far greater if we let fear rule us. The King needs to be reminded that his power stems from the people, from us. It's a fight worth fighting, Victoria."

He could feel her exhale, her worry seeping out with her breath. "I know, Alfie. I believe in you. We'll face whatever comes, together."

In the quiet darkness, their shared resolve bolstered their courage. Alfie pulled Victoria closer, their bodies entwining in a familiar dance. Their hearts beat in sync, ready to face whatever the new day would bring.

As dawn broke, Alfie was already on the move. The trip to Sheffield was a necessary one, an opportunity to gauge the pulse of the common folk. The sprawling city, a blend of historic architecture and futuristic tech, hummed with morning activity.

His vehicle of choice was an unassuming self-driving electric model, blending seamlessly with the other vehicles on the maglev highway. Alfie, incognito as a regular citizen, ventured into the heart of the city as he stood for a moment, admiring the statue of James Dalton, before continuing on his way.

He first stopped at a café, a popular breakfast spot frequented by a mix of students, office-goers, and artisans. As he sipped his coffee, he listened to the conversations swirling around him. Hints of dissatisfaction crept through the mundane chats about weather and football.

"The King's latest decree is a bloody farce," grumbled a middle-aged man at a nearby table, his scowl evident. Nods of agreement followed his statement, the undercurrent of discontent palpable.

Later, Alfie wandered into a local artisan's market. The vibrant energy of the place was infectious, yet the political unease seeped into the buzz of activity. Conversations, hushed and heated, centred around the King's actions and the impact on their lives.

"The King forgets that it's us who put him in that palace," an old woman selling handmade ceramics said to her neighbour. "High time someone reminded him."

The sentiment was echoed throughout his interactions. A sense of unrest simmered under the surface of the city, ready to boil over at the slightest spark.

Casting aside his aristocratic mannerisms, Alfie sauntered into a bustling pub on the outskirts of Sheffield's university district. The air was charged with youthful energy, laughter and loud chatter washing over the ambient music. Neon signs and retro posters blended with holographic menus, a mashup of the past and the present, a symbol of the post-Bitcoin era.

At the bar, Alfie found himself in the company of a group of students, their faces bright with the zeal of youth. They spoke freely, their minds unburdened by the constraints of tradition.

"A pint for everyone!" Alfie offered, disguising his curiosity under a veil of generosity. As the amber liquid flowed, so did their words.

The conversations took many turns, from the latest technological marvels to the trending virtual reality games. Then, subtly, Alfie steered the discussion towards politics.

"The King thinks he's the centre of the universe," a young woman declared, her voice slurred slightly from the alcohol. "He needs to wake up and smell the roses. It's not about him; it's about all of us!"

Her sentiment was met with a chorus of approval. Their voices grew heated as they talked about the King's actions, their words echoing the commoners' concerns Alfie had picked up earlier.

"In the end, we are the ones who will shape the future, not some man on a throne," a lanky young man stated, his words punctuated by the determined nods of his peers.

The air in the pub thickened with a mix of heated discussion and cigarette smoke. Alfie stayed seated, a silent observer of the unfolding narrative. A short moment of silence settled in, as if granting the students a brief respite.

Then, the conversation shifted, moving away from the abstract realm of politics to the personal. The students began sharing anecdotes about their experiences navigating the new societal norms and the rapidly changing world.

A dark-haired student with a light-up tattoo animating his forearm spoke of his recent experience. "I've just been to the virtual arts show last weekend. Incredible, I must say. It's amazing how artists are leveraging technology. Bitcoin has definitely levelled the playing field, you know? Gives us all a fair chance."

"Yeah, I feel that too," chimed in a young woman, her hands animated as she spoke. "I'm working on this start-up, right? A platform for local artists to sell their work. Before Bitcoin, I wouldn't have had the resources. Now? We're going global."

The discussions flowed, a cascade of personal stories and shared experiences. They spoke of their dreams, ambitions, their struggles, and their victories in the face of changing norms.

A young man studying economics opened up about his family. "My parents were old-school, worried about the Bitcoin changeover. But now, they're all in. My dad even started mining. Can you believe it?"

Laughter rang around the table, a shared sense of camaraderie and understanding knitting the students closer. As Alfie listened, he could see the bigger picture, a glimpse into the lives of the young generation. Their words, their stories were a testament to the strength and resilience of the human spirit, even in the face of radical change.

The pub's lighting dimmed slightly as the evening wore on, lending an intimate atmosphere to the gathering. As the group of students swirled their drinks and engaged in boisterous conversation, one of them, a sociology major named Emma, decided to broach a subject rarely discussed in such a casual setting.

"You know, the thing I find most fascinating about this whole Bitcoin era," she started, her eyes gleaming with intellectual curiosity, "is how it's changed our interpersonal relationships."

A collective murmur of agreement followed her statement. With the advent of Bitcoin, wealth was redistributed, and societal hierarchies were challenged. But even more intriguing was how these changes trickled down to the micro-level, affecting the dynamics of intimate relationships.

Emma went further, "Not just relationships, it's also about self-expression, right? The freedom to be our true selves. There's no pressure to conform to societal norms or expectations. We've got the freedom to experiment and discover who we are without judgment."

"Jung was light years beyond the epoch he existed in," remarked a student deeply immersed in the study of Psychology, her voice echoing a profound respect. "It's a mental recoil, a sheer cringe when I think back to the days Freud was taught as gospel."

Alfie listened attentively, the warmth of their frankness and their willingness to delve into subjects previously considered taboo a testament to how far society had come. Bitcoin, it seemed, had not only revolutionized the economy but had also paved the way for a more open and accepting society.

Following his enlightening conversations, Alfie knew it was time for action. He travelled back to Chatsworth, his mind still turning over the day out in Sheffield. He knew the course of action he must take. He had arranged for the aristocrats of the country; those he could be confident were more on his side than the Kings.

The trapsed in one by one. Some taking a train, some arriving in their Rolls-Royce’s and Jaguar’s. They sat around the large roundtable placed in the ballroom of Chatsworth House. The great ballroom echoed with the voices of dukes, lords, and barons, each expressing their concern about the King's recent actions.

Alfie, standing at the head of the circular mahogany table, raised his hand for silence. The chatter died down, all eyes now on him. He cleared his throat, his gaze steady, "My fellow aristocrats," he began, "we stand here today, united by our concerns for our people and our land."

A murmur of agreement rippled through the room.

"The King's recent attempts to bolster his power are worrying. The introduction of the 'Crown's Levy' law, aimed at exacting a tax from our people on their Bitcoin holdings, is a clear breach of the freedoms and rights that God and the constitution bestows upon us."

Nods followed this statement, the faces around the room mirroring Alfie's gravity.

"He's using thinly veiled excuses of 'national security' and 'economic stability' to impose these unjust laws. The 'Sovereign's Decree', threatening hefty fines to those found guilty of 'economic hoarding'. The 'Royal Edict', aiming to control and limit Bitcoin mining under the guise of 'environmental concerns'. All these are tactics to claw back the power Bitcoin had decentralized."

The room was tense, the stakes clearly outlined now. The aristocrats had long sensed the King's desperation, but hearing it laid out so starkly brought a newfound urgency to their cause.

"We need a Magna Carta for the digital age, based around the Bitcoin protocol and what the Nakamoto Consensus gifted us, a society free of monetary despotism. We must not let a fearful king undermine that freedom. We, the stewards of our territories, bear the responsibility of preserving this for our people."

A resounding applause followed Alfie's impassioned speech. Their path was clear. They had to protect their society from a power-hungry king.

As the applause in the hall died down, a calculating silence fell upon Duke William of Northumberland. His eyes, veiled behind a pensive gaze, moved from Alfie to the other lords gathered. He was torn between loyalty to his fellow aristocrats and the king, his long-time friend.

After the meeting ended and the lords dispersed, Duke William found himself standing in the vast emptiness of the hall, consumed by conflicting thoughts. A decision had to be made. Swallowing his trepidation, he picked up his communicade, a state-of-the-art device for secure communication. With a trembling finger, he punched in the private number of the king.

"Your Majesty," he began, the trepidation in his voice apparent, "there's something you need to know..."

The line crackled for a moment before the King's voice came through, clear and authoritative. "Speak, William," he commanded.

Taking a deep breath, William plunged into the story. "There's unrest among the lords," he began, pacing back and forth in the deserted hall. "A council was called today at Chatsworth House, led by Alfred, the Duke of Derbyshire."

He paused, collecting his thoughts. "He spoke passionately about your recent policies... the Crown's Levy law, the Sovereign's Decree, the Royal Edict." William continued, his voice weighed down by the magnitude of his revelation. "The lords perceive these as attempts to reclaim the power that Bitcoin had decentralized. They're comparing this to a monetary despotism."

There was silence on the other end. William could almost picture the King, seated on his throne, absorbing the information.

He pushed on, "Your Majesty, they see themselves as stewards of their territories, protectors of the freedom that Bitcoin brought. They're not going to let these laws pass without a fight."

A heavy silence lingered between them after William finished. He could almost hear the wheels turning in the King's mind as he processed the news. This was a game of power and strategy, and the board had just been upset.

"Thank you, William, for your loyalty," the King finally said, his voice icy-cold, hiding the tumultuous thoughts that were undoubtedly stirring within. "We shall deal with this... appropriately."

With that, the line went dead, leaving William alone with the echo of his treason.

News of the King's awareness of the growing unrest among the aristocrats spread through the kingdom like wildfire. The city buzzed with whispers and speculation. The once jovial pubs now resonated with hushed conversations, as the fear of an impending storm loomed large.

The King, for his part, wasted no time. He ordered a sudden assembly of the Parliament. The aristocrats, still nursing their defiant spirits, arrived with a sense of trepidation. Duke Alfie, undeterred, stood tall and determined as he walked into the House of Lords.

The King, seated on his throne, surveyed the room. The silence was palpable, a testament to the tension that hung heavy in the air. Finally, he spoke, "I've been informed of the discontent brewing among my people," His gaze rested on the Duke, "and my fellow lords."

Alfie, under the King's scrutiny, held his gaze. The room waited with bated breath for what was to come.

"I am not an unreasonable man," the King continued, "I am aware that my recent laws have...stirred the pot." Murmurs filled the room, but the King raised his hand for silence. "However, I ask you this: Are these laws not aimed at the prosperity of our kingdom? Are they not an effort to guard our people and land from potential threats?"

With that, the King opened the floor for discussion. What followed was a heated debate between the Lords and the King; with arguments, counterarguments, passionate speeches, and heated confrontations. The clash of perspectives was as vibrant as it was loud.

Alfie, amidst all this, held his ground. He argued for the decentralization that Bitcoin offered, the freedom it promised, and the prosperity it brought. His powerful words resonated in the hearts of many, creating ripples in the turbulent sea of the debate.

The meeting ended with no clear resolution, but the seed of rebellion had taken root, and the storm that had been looming now seemed inevitable.

Alfie, lost in a tumultuous sea of thoughts, retreated to his estate after the explosive meeting at the Parliament. His wife, Victoria, awaited his arrival, worry etched on her face.

"What happened, Alfie?" Victoria asked, rushing to his side as he entered their private chambers.

Alfie sighed, pulling Victoria into his arms. "Victoria, we stand on the brink of a precipice," he said, his voice heavy with concern. "The King stands firm on his laws, convinced they will bring prosperity to our kingdom. But he's threatening the very freedom that Bitcoin has brought us."

Victoria looked up at her husband, her gaze resolute. "Then we stand our ground, Alfie," she said firmly. "We stand for the liberty Bitcoin has provided, and we fight for it."

Alfie nodded, the warmth of his wife's support seeping into him. Yes, they would face the storm together, protecting their people and the freedom they had all come to cherish.

Days turned into weeks. The rumble of discontent grew louder and louder, turning the once harmonious kingdom into a battleground of ideologies. The Parliament was a hotbed of conflict, every session ending in heated debates and unsatisfactory resolutions.

Alfie, meanwhile, held his ground, standing tall amidst the storm. He rallied his fellow Dukes and Barons, sharing impassioned speeches and plans for their course of action. Their gatherings, once the epitome of grandeur and leisure, had turned into strategy meetings, brimming with tension and determination.

One such meeting was underway at Alfie's estate, Chatsworth House. The Dukes and Barons huddled around a grand table, maps and documents spread across its surface. Their faces were grave, their eyes filled with a steely resolve. Alfie stood at the head of the table, leading the discussion.

"We need the support of the Commons," Alfie said, looking at his counterparts. "We need to convince them that the King's laws are not for the prosperity of the kingdom but for his own consolidation of power."

"And how do you propose we do that, Alfie?" questioned Duke Harrington, a seasoned aristocrat with a sceptical bend of mind. "The Commons are divided, and the King has his loyalists among them."

Alfie nodded, acknowledging the Duke's point. "True, the Commons are divided, and yes, the King has his loyalists," he said. "But we also have allies among them. We need to strengthen these alliances, convince the undecided, and expose the King's intentions."

The room fell into contemplative silence as each aristocrat pondered Alfie's proposition. It was a daunting task, but there was a collective agreement that it was a necessary one. The meeting ended with a pact - they would fight for their freedom and prosperity, even if it meant going against their King.

As the aristocrats dispersed, Victoria entered the room, her presence a soothing balm to Alfie's heightened senses. "How did it go?" she asked, her eyes searching Alfie's.

He looked at his wife, drawing strength from her unwavering support. "We have a plan, Victoria," he said, a sense of determination filling his voice. "We will expose the King's true intentions and fight for our freedom."

Victoria gave him a proud smile, her hand gently squeezing his. "Then we shall weather this storm, Alfie. Together."

As the weight of the world lay heavy on their shoulders, Alfie and Victoria stood together, their resolve stronger than ever.

Knowing that words and debates might not be enough to withstand the King's tyranny, Alfie understood that they might have to resort to an archaic form of conflict resolution - physical battle. Being a peaceful man at heart, the notion filled him with trepidation. But being a true Duke, he knew that sometimes, might was necessary to enforce right.

He began preparations in earnest. The vast grounds of Chatsworth House were turned into makeshift training arenas. The aristocracy, despite their silk robes and genteel manners, were no strangers to warfare. Many were descendants of knights and military leaders, their lineage seeped in tales of valour and battle.

Alfie enlisted the best commanders and knights to lead the training sessions. Drone ranges sprouted up in the green lawns, laser-fighting drills took place in the courtyards, and strategy sessions were held in the grand halls. The tranquil estate, known for its refined galas and elaborate parties, echoed with the clanging of drones and the kick of recoils.

Even Alfie, dressed in battle-ready attire, participated in the drills. He practiced shooting with Duke Harrington, drone dogfights with Baron Finchley, and studied battle strategies with Sir Hadley, the renowned military advisor. His commanding presence and dedicated involvement bolstered the spirits of his allies and served as a reminder of what they were fighting for - their freedom.

Meanwhile, Victoria watched her husband from the shadows. The man she had married, the gentle Duke who loved art and literature, was transforming into a war leader. She worried for his safety, of course, but she also admired his courage and resilience. They were fighting for a cause they believed in, and she was there to support him every step of the way.

The following morning brought with it an air of tension and excitement. An airship with the bold insignia of the Lone Star emblazoned on its hull descended onto the vast lawns of Chatsworth House. Out stepped Jasper "Tex" McKinnon, a tall, burly man with a striking Stetson hat and a twinkle in his eye. He was one of the most sought-after arms dealers from the Republic of Texas, known for his collection of cutting-edge weaponry.

The aristocrats gathered around as Tex opened his demonstration. First, he unveiled an array of handheld laser weaponry. These were light, precise, and deadly, emitting a high-energy beam capable of slicing through the toughest armours. The nobles watched with fascination as Tex demonstrated the potency of these devices, slicing through a metal sculpture with disconcerting ease.

Next, he revealed a swarm of drones - small, fast, and equipped with high-definition cameras and stunningly accurate lasers. They were capable of both surveillance and combat, a perfect combination for the upcoming conflict. The drones buzzed around the courtyard in a pre-programmed pattern, showing off their agility and precision.

Finally, he unveiled the holographic projectors, a non-lethal yet potentially game-changing tool. These devices could project life-like, 3D images onto the battlefield, creating diversions or causing confusion among enemy ranks.

The aristocrats, including Alfie, watched the demonstration with a mixture of awe and trepidation. The gravity of their situation became more palpable with each showcased weapon. They were no longer in the era of swords and shields. Their fight had transcended into a realm of lasers, drones, and holograms.

However, amid the daunting reality, Alfie saw a ray of hope. These tools could provide them the edge they needed in the battle against the King. As the demonstration concluded, he turned to his fellow nobles.

"We have the means to stand against the King," he said, determination evident in his voice. "We will not let him usurp the freedom and prosperity we have built."

A murmur of agreement spread through the crowd. As the sun dipped below the horizon, painting the sky with hues of red and orange, a new resolve took root in their hearts. They would fight. They would protect their kingdom. And with these new weapons at their disposal, they just might win.

The evening found Alfie and Victoria in their private study, hunched over an expansive holographic map of Great Britain that floated in mid-air. The news of the impending conflict had seeped into every corner of the kingdom, causing a ripple of fear, anticipation, and a dash of excitement.

They were strategizing, marking potential strongholds and allies across the kingdom. Each lord and baron had their loyalties, some to the king, others to the cause Alfie was championing. The illuminated markers on the map symbolized these alliances, creating a colourful web of connections, a matrix of power.

London was a smudge of purple, symbolizing the stronghold of the king. Surrounding it, however, were pockets of green - regions where support for the Bitcoin aristocracy was strong. The Midlands, the home of the industry and the cities fuelled by the wealth of Bitcoin, were a solid wall of green. Alfie and Victoria could count on their support.

The North was a mix, some regions, like Derbyshire, were green, while others showed hints of purple, their loyalties divided or yet untested. Scotland and Wales, autonomous but closely connected to England, were a hazy blue - their stances uncertain.

"We need to get Scotland and Wales on our side," Alfie said, his fingers tracing the outlines of the regions on the holographic map. "Their support could be the game-changer."

"I'll reach out to Lady McAllister and Lord Rhys," Victoria responded, making a note. She had always been adept at the delicate dance of diplomacy, "I believe they will understand our cause."

As the night grew darker, their resolve grew stronger. The map, with its constellation of allies and opponents, was a beacon in the uncertain darkness. As they planned, plotted, and strategized, the future of their kingdom hung in the balance. But they were ready. Ready to fight, ready to protect, ready to stand for what they believed in. The revolution had just begun.

The morning sun found Alfie and Victoria boarding a sleek, silver bullet train - the pinnacle of British maglev technology. It was destined for Scotland. Alfie, dressed in a smart grey suit, sat by the window, lost in thought while Victoria, resplendent in a dress of royal blue, reviewed her notes, prepping for the meeting with Lady McAllister and Lord Rhys.

Respectfully acquiescing to Victoria's prudent approach, Alfie set out for Edinburgh the next day, while his wife journeyed to the castle in the Scottish Highlands.

Edinburgh, with its grand old-world charm seamlessly entwined with the cutting-edge technological marvels, fascinated Alfie. The iconic Edinburgh Castle still towered over the city, a beacon of history amidst the new-age architecture, its stoic stone walls contrasting sharply with the translucent crystal structures that populated the city.

He found himself in a bustling local market, a vibrant mixture of the traditional and the new. As he meandered through the marketplace, the Duke marvelled at how the ancient city had embraced the future. Bitcoin-operated shops, automated food stalls, and holographic entertainers coexisted with handcrafted wares, street artists, and vendors peddling old-style fish and chips. Alfie noticed a group of university students engaged in a lively debate about the political upheaval brewing. Their conversations echoed the concerns he had about the King's increasing power and greed. Their insights were raw and impassioned, solidifying his resolve.

Meanwhile, Victoria met with Lady McAllister and Lord Rhys. Their castle, a fusion of ancient stone walls and modern elements like energy-efficient glass and sleek metal, was a sight to behold. An awkward tension filled the air as they greeted each other, the remnants of past relations looming like an unwelcome ghost. Victoria, however, remained composed, focusing on the gravity of the situation at hand.

As they delved into discussions about the King's unjust actions and the impending crisis, Victoria found that the Scottish nobles were as concerned as they were. They agreed to stand by Alfie and the rest of the aristocrats against the King, a promising development in their struggle.

Upon their return to Derbyshire, Alfie and Victoria shared the outcomes of their respective missions. Their spirits were lifted by the promise of support from Scotland, but they knew that the battle was far from over. With the allies rallying and the King's spies lurking, they prepared themselves for the impending showdown, ready to fight for their future.

The following weeks were filled with discreet meetings, encrypted messages, and careful planning. The aristocrats from across the land pledged their support to Alfie, acknowledging his leadership and expertise. The Duke’s reputation for fair judgment, his eloquence, and charisma were pivotal in rallying the nobles together. Simultaneously, the common people, worn down by the King's increasing greed, were starting to voice their discontent more openly, bolstering the aristocracy's position.

All the while, Alfie and Victoria ensured that their daily lives appeared unchanged. They held lavish parties, attended functions, and continued to mingle with society as if all was well. They were careful not to alarm the King prematurely or give him a reason to act against them.

Word of a grand ball at the King's palace reached Derbyshire one day. Alfie and Victoria were invited, along with all the aristocrats and influential people in the country. This was unusual for the King, who was known for his distaste for such social gatherings. The invitation stirred up whispers among the nobles. Some believed it was a trap, others thought it was a chance for the King to proclaim some new decree. Despite the potential dangers, Alfie decided to attend. If nothing else, it would give them a chance to gauge the King's intentions and perhaps find some leverage.

The day of the ball arrived. The Duke and Duchess of Derbyshire approached Buckingham Palace in their sleek, automated carriage, built with shimmering bulletproof graphene composite. Their journey through London had been a parade of contrasts: the historic architecture alongside cutting-edge buildings that towered like glass monoliths, some of them bending in improbable shapes. The Thames gleamed silver in the moonlight, reflecting the kaleidoscope of lights from the city.

The Buckingham Palace was more than just a building; it was an imposing symbol of a bygone era, albeit one that had been refitted and refurbished with the advancements of the times. The facade remained much as it had for centuries, a monolith of Palladian grandeur, but the interiors were as modern as they came.

Alfie and Victoria stepped out onto the crimson carpet that led to the grand entrance. A fleet of drones buzzed overhead, capturing the arrival of the guests for live-streams on the Hypernet. A kaleidoscope of colors erupted from the Palace, spilling out onto the grounds. Holographic peacocks strutted on the manicured lawns, their tails a brilliant display of shifting colors. Victoria, resplendent in a shimmering gown of silken fabric, weaved with delicate nanofibers that changed colors to match her mood, clutched Alfie's arm.

Inside, the ballroom was a spectacle of opulence and advanced technology. Crystal chandeliers hung low, casting warm light over the guests, each intricate piece a mesh of micro-LEDs capable of changing colors and patterns. A holographic orchestra played a symphony that filled the grand room. Servers, humans, and androids alike circulated the room with trays of hors d'oeuvres and goblets of champagne. The vast room was abuzz with the hum of conversations, the rustle of silk, the clink of glasses, and the subtle undertones of digital melodies.

People from all walks of life, dressed in their finery, moved in a waltz of diplomacy and intrigue. Tech tycoons rubbed shoulders with centuries-old aristocrats, politicians, and celebrities. Some faces were recognizable, splashed across media screens and Hypernet feeds; others were known only to a select few, their influence silent yet palpable.

Alfie and Victoria navigated through the crowd, exchanging pleasantries with acquaintances, keeping their demeanor casual, but their senses on high alert. The grandeur and distractions of the ball served as a glossy veneer over the undercurrents of tension that laced every interaction, every smile, every handshake.

As the evening unfolded, the King made his entrance. He was a handsome man, his charisma almost tangible, his energy filling up the room. His laughter echoed through the grand ballroom, a jarring note in the symphony of unease. He held court at the heart of the room, entertaining the crowd with anecdotes and jests. Despite the mirth he projected, his eyes held a sharp, calculating gleam.

As Alfie watched the spectacle unfold, he couldn't help but feel a storm was brewing beneath the merriment, a storm that would challenge the very foundations of their society.

The following day was a tense one. News from the House of Commons had trickled in. The King was pushing to pass the Unfair Crypto Acquisitions Act, an odious piece of legislation that sought to impose punitive penalties on those who he claimed were hoarding Bitcoin. In reality, it was a brazen attempt to redistribute wealth, increasing his coffers while emptying those of his subjects.

Alfie and Victoria retreated to their private study, a high-tech sanctuary within the grandeur of their historic residence. The tension in the air was palpable as they stood before a large, holographic map of Great Britain that floated before them.

"We have to act," Alfie said, his fingers tracing over the glowing lines that marked territories and counties, each a possible battlefield.

Victoria nodded, her gaze intense. "The King is playing a dangerous game. He's turning the commoners against us, using them as a shield while he enriches himself."

"He's turning them against us by exploiting their insecurities, by stoking their fears," Alfie continued. His fingers came to rest on the border between Derbyshire and Yorkshire. "He tells them we are the enemy, that we hoard our wealth and contribute nothing. He paints us as the villains."

Victoria moved to stand beside him, her hand finding his. "But we know the truth. We are the ones who brought prosperity to this nation. We are the ones who built it on the bedrock of Bitcoin."

"We have the power to fight him," Alfie said, looking at her. "The King is strong, but we have the support of the people. They trust us. They believe in us. And they won't be easily swayed by the King's lies."

Together, they studied the map, analyzing potential allies and anticipating the moves of their adversaries. Despite the tense atmosphere, there was an unspoken confidence between them. They were a formidable team, each fully aware of the other's strength and determination. And they knew they had a nation behind them, ready to rally for their cause. The King's tyranny would not stand. Not on his watch.

A chill ran through the city as Alfie departed for London. London, the heart of the Kingdom, was a pulsating metropolis, its veins filled with the unending traffic of autonomous vehicles and high-speed maglev trains. The city’s skyline was a testament to the incredible wealth that Bitcoin had brought to the nation. Skyscrapers kissed the clouds, neon lights danced across their surfaces at night, painting a futuristic dreamscape.

But beneath the glittering surface, tension simmered. The House of Lords was a battlefield of a different kind. Here, power wasn't measured in lasers or drones, but in the subtle art of negotiation and influence.

Alfie was well-versed in this battleground. As he strode through the grand halls of the Parliament, his every step echoed power and determination. He was greeted by the sight of his fellow peers, all in their digital armors, suits enhanced with advanced technology to present data and help with communication.

The chamber was filled with a murmuring tension. The Lords were divided, some sided with the King, others with the Dukes. As Alfie took his place, silence fell. All eyes were on him, waiting to hear his response to the King's latest move.

With a clear voice that cut through the heavy silence, Alfie began, "My Lords, we are facing an unprecedented crisis. The King, who should be our protector, has become our adversary. The Unfair Crypto Acquisitions Act is nothing more than a brazen power grab. It is designed to cripple us while strengthening the King."

His words rang out in the chamber, his voice echoing against the ancient walls. There were murmurs of agreement, but also sounds of dissent. He knew not everyone would stand with him, but he would not back down.

His gaze swept the room, looking for signs of support. "We are the stewards of this great nation. It is our duty to protect it from tyranny, no matter the source. I ask you, my Lords, stand with me. Stand for freedom. Stand for Bitcoin."

The room erupted in a cacophony of voices. Some cheered, some shouted, some remained silent, their faces unreadable. But Alfie stood tall, his conviction unshakeable. He would not allow the King to tear apart the society they had built. It was a battle he was ready to fight, and one he was determined to win.

The room fell silent as the King rose. He was a towering figure. “Lord Derbyshire,” he began, “I understand your concerns, but let's not forget the course of history.”

His gaze was unfaltering, holding Alfie's as he spoke. “It was I who advocated for the Bitcoin Standard when the world scoffed at us. I defended the rights of the people when the world was ready to abandon them to the unforgiving tide of poverty. It was I who stood against the old world's financial system and embraced this new era. And I did it for the people, not for power.”

He paused, letting his words sink in. “Now, you accuse me of tyranny. But let's not forget, taxation isn't a new concept. It's a necessity for maintaining order and prosperity. Our society, with its maglev trains, holographic projectors, and futuristic skyscrapers, is a testament to this.”

The King’s words were met with a mixed chorus of approval and skepticism. He raised his hand, silencing the room. “I am your King, not a tyrant. I am doing what is needed for the betterment of our Kingdom. You may not agree with my methods, but you cannot question my intent.”

He looked Alfie in the eye, a challenge unspoken. “I am ready to discuss and debate. But let it not be said that I am a King who steals from his people. I am a King who asks for their support in maintaining the greatness of our Kingdom. Are you ready to do the same, Lord Derbyshire?”

His challenge hung heavy in the air, the room silent as all eyes turned back to Alfie. It was clear that the King wasn't going to back down without a fight. The battle lines were drawn, and the political conflict was escalating towards a boiling point.

The stunned silence that followed the King’s words was broken by the measured, steady voice of Alfie. He rose from his seat, his face calm but his eyes aflame with defiance.

"Your Majesty, the greatness of our Kingdom has never been maintained by the force of taxation. It has been built and sustained by the genius, labour, and tenacity of its people.” His voice echoed in the chamber, each word reverberating with intensity.

He swept his gaze around the room, meeting the eyes of the peers of the realm, both his supporters and detractors. "Throughout the course of our history, whenever a monarch has threatened the liberties and wealth of the people, it has been the duty of the aristocracy to intercede.”

His gaze hardened, and his voice took on a harsh, commanding tone. “Recall the Magna Carta, forced upon King John by the barons when he threatened their rights. Recall the Glorious Revolution, where James II was overthrown in favour of William of Orange when his policies clashed with the liberties of his subjects.”

He turned his gaze back to the King. "Your Majesty, you championed the Bitcoin Standard, but it was the people who adopted it and made it a success. They embraced the technology, and they reaped the rewards. Your insistence on taxation threatens to undo all that we, as a society, have achieved."

The chamber was silent as Alfie paused. Then, he dropped the bombshell. "Rumours are that the Royal Treasury is nearly bankrupt. If true, it would explain this desperate grasping for the wealth of the people. Is this the case, Your Majesty?"

The chamber exploded in a chaos of voices. Accusations, denials, gasps of shock – the implications of the Duke’s words were far-reaching and dangerous. The political landscape was quickly becoming a battlefield, and Alfie had just fired the first shot.

With a furious gaze, the King rose to his feet, the churning chaos in the chamber seeming to fold inwards, an angry sea sucked into the vortex of his enraged stare. The grandeur of his position filled the room, radiating from him like a storm about to unleash its might. A hush spread, starting from those closest to him and flowing outwards, until the only sounds were the murmurs dying in throats and the harsh, amplified breathing of the agitated room.

"Of what, exactly, do you accuse me, Alfie?" the King's words cut through the remaining silence like a blade. His voice was calm, a stark contrast to the tempest in his eyes. "Do you accuse me of protecting the sovereignty of this kingdom, ensuring its prosperity and stability?"

The King began to pace before his throne, his voice growing louder, more powerful. "You claim I'm bankrupting the nation, yet it is your class, the aristocrats, who have seen their fortunes expand under the Bitcoin Standard while the majority only witness the spectacle. Yes, they live better lives, but the gap, the chasm between us and them, has never been so vast."

Suddenly, he stopped and turned, pointing a finger at Alfie. "And now, instead of aiding the kingdom in its hour of need, you dare to challenge my authority, call for a rebellion? Is it not your duty to support the crown?"

The King's accusation lingered in the air, a challenge thrown to the Duke of Derbyshire. The chamber remained quiet, holding its breath for the Duke's response. The King had called his bluff. Now, it was up to Alfie to play his hand.

Alfie rose, the silence of the room wrapping him in an almost sacred stillness. He nodded to the King, a grim acknowledgement of the gauntlet thrown. "Your Majesty," he began, his voice echoing through the grand chamber, "You talk of duty, yet you ignore the greatest duty of all, that which is owed to our people."

He turned to face the gallery, his gaze sweeping across the faces of his fellow lords and barons. "Do you remember the spirit of 1215, my lords? When the barons of England stood up against King John, demanding recognition of their rights? Do we not stand in a similar situation now? Have we not the same duty as they once did?"

He turned back to face the King, an intensity in his eyes. "Our tales and history have always celebrated such acts of courage and determination against unjust rulers. The legend of Robin Hood, robbing from the corrupt and providing for the downtrodden, the ordinary people, has long been a symbol of hope and resilience."

Alfie paused, letting his words sink in before continuing. "Do you not recall the words of Sir Edward Coke, who declared that 'A man's house is his castle, and each man's home is his safest refuge'? It's the same philosophy that reverberates through our veins. Our right to protect what we earn, to do as we please with our Bitcoins. It is no different, Your Majesty."

"Is not the course of justice the foundation of every monarchy? Christopher Marlowe questioned, 'What are kings, when regiment is gone, but perfect shadows in a sunshine day?' Without the rule of law, the respect for individual rights, what separates us from tyranny?"

He looked around the room, locking eyes with his peers, seeking validation. "Does not the Bible state, 'Thou shall not steal?' It does not stipulate, 'except by majority vote.' The Commandments are absolute, Your Majesty."

Finally, he turned back to the King, his gaze firm. "Yet here we are, talking of higher taxes and usurping our wealth. Words have marked the chapters of our history, Your Majesty, but they've rarely been the end of it. A decision looms over us all, and this time, it might not be the pen that proves mightier."

With that, he took his seat, leaving the room in stunned silence. His words hung heavily in the air, a potent mixture of history, literature, and law, presenting a choice that would shape the future of the realm. The ball was now back in the King's court.

The King stared back at Alfie, the silence in the chamber almost deafening. Then, with an unsettling calmness, he stood and replied, "Indeed, Lord Derbyshire, history does repeat itself, and shadows do fall when the sun is high. But remember, it's not the pen or the sword that proves mightier—it's the hand that wields it."

With that, he pivoted, his cloak sweeping behind him as he exited the chamber, leaving an atmosphere of tension and uncertainty in his wake.

Hours later, in the softly lit bar of the House of Lords, Alfie was hosting an impromptu gathering. The velvet upholstery, dark wood, and brass fixtures created an ambiance of sophistication and privacy—a perfect setting to discuss matters of such gravity.

Peers were clustered around tables, engaged in hushed discussions. A few were at the bar, their eyes constantly flicking towards Alfie's direction, obviously waiting for a chance to converse. The air buzzed with an electric current of anticipation and anxiety.

With a glass of vintage scotch in hand, Alfie moved from group to group, his warm smile belying the seriousness of their conversations. His words were measured, his tone persuasive. Every now and then, he would clasp someone on the shoulder, a show of camaraderie and solidarity.

He hoped, with every fiber of his being, that he had said enough, that he had done enough to galvanize the lords and barons, to convince them of the direness of the situation.

But only time would tell if he had indeed rallied enough support, and whether his words would have the intended impact. It was a dangerous game of political chess, and his next move could either checkmate the King or topple his own kingdom.

The day was just breaking when Alfie, along with a few trusted aides, left London. The city's grand edifices and statues receded in the background, the dawn's soft glow imparting an ethereal beauty to the scene. Yet, Alfie’s mind was far from appreciating such tranquillity. He had a civil war to prepare for.

Back at Chatsworth House, the serene facade of the grand estate belied the feverish activity within. In the expansive study, Alfie was immersed in mapping out strategies. The grand oak table, usually adorned with curios and artefacts, was now a battlefield of its own—maps sprawled across its surface, markers indicating troop locations, a chessboard on one side, representing allegiances and potential moves.

His wife, Victoria, proved to be a valuable ally. Her understanding of politics, her network of connections, and her relentless drive made her an indispensable part of the team. She worked the holophones, rallying support, keeping in constant communication with other noble families, persuading, cajoling, asserting.

Simultaneously, their estates had become centres of martial activity. Under Alfie's instructions, his trusted men began the task of mustering an army. The vast grounds reverberated with the sounds of drilling soldiers, clanging armour, and thundering hooves. Technology interwove with traditional combat methods; laser sharpshooters trained alongside swordsmen, drones buzzed above cavalry units, and holographic projectors played out various battle scenarios.

In the midst of all the turmoil, Alfie stood resolute. His journey had brought him here— from the pleasure-filled nights to the heated debates in Parliament, and now to the brink of war. But, he was not a man to shy away from his destiny. He had ignited the spark, now he must guide it into a flame that would blaze a trail to a more equitable future. This was no longer just a fight for Bitcoin, or for the privileges of the aristocracy—it was a fight for justice, for a Britain that was fair and free.

Alfie was pulled into the dimly lit corridor, his hand clasped firmly by Victoria. She led him into the private sanctuary of their chamber, a world away from the maps and battle plans that littered the war room. The hushed silence within stood in stark contrast to the cacophony of war planning that echoed through the rest of the manor.

As the door clicked shut, she stepped back, studying him with a tender intensity. “You look as if the weight of the world is on your shoulders," she observed, her voice a soft murmur in the quiet room.

Alfie let out a short laugh, running a hand through his tousled hair. "Sometimes, it feels as though it is."

In the hush that followed, Victoria crossed the room, her fingers brushing against the fabric of his shirt. Her touch, a warm contrast against the chill, sent shivers coursing through him. He watched her, his gaze following the graceful arch of her fingers as they moved to undo his top button.

Her voice broke the silence, her words feather-light, "It may feel like that, Alfie, but you're not alone. You have me, and the support of those who believe in your cause."

His hands found hers, stilling her movements. He looked at her, his gaze searching her face. "I know, Victoria. It's just that the thought of what's to come... it scares me."

A soft smile curled her lips, her thumb tracing over his knuckles. "It scares me too, Alfie. But we will face it together."

He nodded, pressing his lips to her forehead in a tender kiss. "Together."

In the midst of the impending chaos, their world shrunk to the intimacy of whispered confessions and soft touches. The conversation carried on, their words weaving a tapestry of shared strength and resolve. The imminent future, laced with uncertainty and war, felt less daunting as they drew strength from each other, finding solace within their shared courage. Their love, a quiet cocoon against the world outside, bore the promise of resilience to face the storm that lay ahead.

Alfie and Victoria held each other for a while longer, their hearts beating in sync. But the reality of the world outside was inevitable and, soon, Alfie had to pull himself away. The night was young, and there were still many things that needed to be done.

It was time to prepare for battle.

The next morning, Chatsworth House was a flurry of activity. As Alfie walked down the grand staircase, he could hear the clanging of metal from the courtyard where the graphene-smiths had started to fashion armor and weapons. Soldiers were beginning their training, their chants rhythmic in the morning air.

Over breakfast, Alfie and Victoria, along with their military advisors, poured over maps and charts. They were planning their strategies, discussing the strengths and weaknesses of their forces, identifying potential allies, and looking for any vulnerabilities in the King's defenses.

Their chief advisor, Sir William Chambers, a grizzled veteran of many campaigns, pointed out the key locations that needed to be defended at all costs. "Our ancestral homes, my Lord, they are the backbone of our strength. We cannot allow them to fall into the King's hands."

Victoria added, "We also need to secure the loyalty of the common people. The King's arbitrary laws have angered many. We need to assure them that we are on their side."

The meetings carried on for hours, with decisions being made, plans being refined, and strategies being finalized. It was a demanding task, but Alfie was relentless. He knew the stakes. The future of the nation was hanging in the balance.

Outside, the preparations continued. The once peaceful estate was now transformed into a military camp. Soldiers drilled in the courtyards, weapons were being made and sharpened, and supplies were being stockpiled. War was on the horizon, and Chatsworth House was ready.

Alfie, amidst all this, could not help but think back to his conversation with Victoria the previous night. The thought of the impending conflict did scare him, but her words gave him strength. As he looked around, he knew that they were not alone. Together, they would face the storm that was coming.

The city of Sheffield buzzed with energy, its modern skyline a testament to its transformation from a rust-belt city to a vibrant hub of technology and innovation. Alfie had always felt a special connection to this city, with its forward-looking mentality and its readiness to embrace the future.

Alfie's sleek maglev car, a marvel of engineering with a sleek silhouette and silent operation, glided effortlessly through the bustling streets. He reached the city centre where the town hall, a grand Victorian structure, stood proudly amidst the gleaming glass and steel towers.

As he walked into the opulent conference room, he was greeted by a diverse group - the city's leaders, intellectuals, business tycoons, representatives from the police force, and university deans. He recognized many faces, people he had worked with over the years, people who had helped shape this city. The room was filled with anticipation.

With characteristic charisma, Alfie took control of the room. "Friends, it is no secret that our nation is on the brink of conflict. I am here today to hear your concerns and understand your perspectives. I have always valued your advice and wisdom and today, more than ever, we need unity and clarity."

What followed was a frank discussion. The city's leaders were concerned about the repercussions of the conflict on trade and the economy. The university representatives were worried about the potential disruptions in academia. The police were anxious about maintaining law and order amidst the brewing unrest.

However, there was one common thread in everyone's discourse - a deep discontentment with the King's policies, a collective resentment against the monarch's blatant disregard for the rights and prosperity of the people. Alfie listened intently, his sharp mind analyzing every piece of information, his brilliant political acumen at work.

The meeting was a charged space. Alfie found himself engaged in discussions, academic and practical, absorbing the complexities of the situation. He sought the insights of those he trusted, the city's educators foremost among them.

"Professor Adams," Alfie turned to the university dean, a renowned scholar on the British constitution. "I've always valued your wisdom. What's your take on this situation?"

Professor Adams, a man of few words but vast knowledge, looked at him thoughtfully. "Alfie, the constitution gives us guidance, but its interpretation has always been subjective. The King believes he's acting within his rights. But your cause, standing against what can be seen as tyranny, has its roots in the Magna Carta. That's powerful."

Alfie then engaged with the city's business community. "Mr. Patel," he addressed the owner of a large tech company. "How are the King's policies affecting your operations?"

Mr. Patel sighed. "Alfie, it's causing a lot of unrest. Investments are being held back. We're all worried about what's next. But we stand with you. We trust you."

Alfie nodded. He turned to the city's police commissioner. "Commissioner Ross, maintaining law and order will be vital in the coming months. How can we ensure that?"

Ross, a strong, seasoned officer, met Alfie's gaze. "We'll need resources, Alfie, and clear directives. People respect you. They'll listen if you address them. It's important we keep the peace."

As the night unfolded, Alfie found himself deep in conversations, sometimes heated, sometimes quiet. He listened, asked, answered, and clarified. He felt connected to the city and its people, their hopes, fears, and determination intertwining with his own. As he stepped out of the meeting, a new day dawned - a day fraught with uncertainty but held together by a shared belief in a brighter future.

Alfie returned to Chatsworth under the light of the half-moon, its ethereal glow casting long shadows across the sweeping vistas of the estate. It was an image of grandeur and serenity, but under this peaceful facade, Chatsworth was stirring.

The estate was transformed into a formidable stronghold. The grand front lawn, which used to host extravagant garden parties, was now a drilling ground for soldiers. Their staccato footsteps echoed in the crisp morning air as they practiced complex formations under the watchful eye of experienced sergeants.

In the wide courtyard where guests were usually greeted, armament shipments were being unloaded and inventoried. Crates packed with lasers and drones were placed in neat rows, their grim, metallic sheen glinting under the artificial lights. Holographic projectors were tested, their spectral images flickering and merging with the darkness.

The stables had been converted into a makeshift infirmary, equipped with the latest medical technology. Holographic imaging systems and nanotech healing devices stood ready for the inevitable casualties.

Every corner of the great mansion buzzed with activity. Secretaries rushed about with data pads, clerks organized ration supplies, while the graphene--smiths hammered away at new armor designs in the smithy. Even the grand halls were filled with hushed, urgent discussions among Alfie's council, their expressions grim yet resolute.

And all around this whirlwind of preparation, the magnificent gardens of Chatsworth bloomed undeterred, offering splashes of color against the austere backdrop. They seemed to serve as a quiet reminder of what was at stake - the beauty, the grandeur, and the peace that hung in the balance.

In the heart of this bustling fortress, Alfie found himself in a strange kind of calm. His heart pounded with the heavy beat of impending conflict, but his mind was clear. He was at the helm of this storm, steering it towards a future he hoped would bring better days for his people and his country.

One by one, the assembled nobles took their turn to speak. Alfie sat back and listened as the voice of resistance resonated around the room.

Lord Richard of Newark was the first to rise. "I stand here for the freedom of the people," he said. His voice echoed throughout the hall, echoing the conviction in his words. "The king seeks to leech off their hard-earned wealth, that they have reaped with the sweat of their brows and the power of Bitcoin. I cannot stand by and watch their liberties being eroded. That is why I am here."

Next was Lady Bethany, Countess of Mansfield, a fierce woman known for her sharp intellect. "I've invested much in the education and development of my county. Our institutions, our businesses, they've flourished because we've always been able to operate outside the reach of the crown's greed. We cannot surrender our economic freedom now."

Duke Harold of Grimsby stood up. He was an imposing figure, a seasoned military strategist. "I've seen kings come and go. They forget that they reign by the will of the people, not by divine right or iron fist. If our King wants a fight, then we shall not back down."

Each noble, in their turn, voiced their discontent, their war aims, and the hopes they harbored for their territories. They spoke of freedom, prosperity, of a future where the people were the true masters of their wealth, unshackled by the chains of monarchic greed.

Finally, it was the turn of Earl Alexander of Lincoln. He was one of the oldest amongst them, a man of wisdom and experience. "The spirit of Bitcoin was freedom, democracy. It has given us much, and we've built our society around its principles. I will not stand by and watch those principles tarnished by a monarch who feels threatened by the power of the people. This is our fight, and it's one we must win."

The room echoed with the resolve of their words, each noble ready to take up arms in defense of their people and the principles of Bitcoin. They were united, each fighting for their own piece of this grand vision for a free and prosperous society.

Alfie rose once again, his imposing stature dwarfing even the tallest of his comrades. Silence fell upon the room as he began to speak.

"We've witnessed a revolution in our lifetime," he began, his voice ringing out clear and steady. "The birth of Bitcoin and the society that blossomed around it. It has broken chains, empowered the common man, and fostered a prosperity we could scarcely have dreamed of. We've seen the rise of a new era, one that values liberty, individuality, and economic freedom above all."

His gaze swept the room, meeting the eyes of his peers. "Our king was once a champion of these values. He was a radical, ushering in reforms that empowered us, the aristocracy. He respected our rights and our role in society. But power corrupts. It blinds and deafens. And in his desire to hold on to his power, he has forgotten the essence of his own radical roots."

A quiet murmur echoed throughout the hall as the nobles listened intently.

"Rebellion," Alfie continued, "is not a sign of a failing kingdom. On the contrary, it is a sign of a kingdom that is alive. A kingdom where the people care enough to voice their discontent, to fight for their rights. And that is the society we've built, a society that won't bow down in the face of tyranny."

He paused, letting his words sink in. "As aristocrats, we have been granted power by the people. Our duty is to them. We are their shield against tyranny, their voice in the halls of power. It's time we fulfilled our duty. The king has gone too far, and it's our responsibility to bring balance back."

As Alfie finished speaking, the room filled with a resounding silence, heavy with the weight of their collective resolution. Their course was clear. The nobles, once fragmented, were now unified by their dedication to the principles of Bitcoin, freedom, and their duty towards their people. The fight against the king was just beginning.

Just as Alfie took his seat, a glowing light materialised at the centre of the table, morphing into a complex holographic display. A few murmurs of astonishment rippled through the assembly, quickly overtaken by a chilling silence. The crisp, neutral voice of the AI that governed the hologram filled the room.

"King's movement report," it began, and as it did, a detailed map of Britain illuminated, marked with blinking icons signifying the Royal Armed Forces. "The Royal Navy has mobilised. Their fleets are currently encircling ports owned by the rebellion. Full naval blockade is expected within the next twenty-four hours."

A collective gasp echoed in the room as the map zoomed into the coastlines, showcasing in real-time the unfolding naval manoeuvres.

"The Royal Air Force is assuming control of the skies," the AI continued, the hologram shifting to illustrate the flight patterns and designated zones of the Air Force. "Airstrikes are expected on key points, and air superiority is currently in the hands of the monarchy."

The room hummed with whispered conversations and alarmed glances.

"Lastly," the AI's voice continued, eerily calm amid the rising tension, "the army is in the preparation phase. The strategic outposts around aristocratic estates have been identified. The King's army is anticipated to attempt seizing control of these."

The hologram displayed the locations of these outposts around their estates, underscoring the gravity of the threat they were facing. The room plunged into a tense silence, the holographic display painting a stark picture of the imminent conflict. The war, it seemed, had just begun.

"The British Space Service, as mandated by the parliamentary act of 2032, remains under the direct authority of the Houses of Parliament," the AI reported, its voice cutting through the tense silence like a knife. The hologram shimmered, shifting to display a cluster of icons floating high above the surface of the planet. "Currently, their stance is neutral, pending direction from Parliament."

Alfie rose from his seat, a determined look on his face as he addressed the room. "The Space Service might be our ace in the hole, the balance we need in this conflict," he said. "It's crucial we work on garnering support in Parliament. If we can convince them, control of the Space Service would give us a strategic edge."

He paused, looking over the assembled lords, dukes, earls, and counts - all seemingly hanging onto his every word. "The Space Service doesn't just control satellites, it has authority over advanced weaponry, strategic intelligence capabilities, even the potential for space-based strikes if it came to that. We have allies in Parliament, we need to leverage that support now more than ever."

The room broke into murmurs, the faces of the gathered nobles filled with a mix of hope and uncertainty. This was uncharted territory, a conflict none of them ever envisioned. Yet, in the face of imminent war, Alfie's leadership was their beacon, his strategy their guiding path through the looming storm.

As morning dawned, Chatsworth Estate took on an eerie quiet, the calm before the storm. The council had worked into the night, drafting plans and strategies. Now, messengers on were dispatched, carrying urgent missives to allies in the Commons.

At the heart of the bustling operations was Alfie. His once leisurely life as an aristocrat seemed a distant memory as he found himself neck-deep in war plans, negotiation strategies, and contingency plans. Beside him, as always, was Victoria. Her steady presence was a source of strength for him, a beacon of hope amidst the uncertainty.

Days turned into a whirlwind of activity. The council received updates from their informants in the Commons. There were encouraging signs that their allies were making progress, but the outcome was far from certain.

News from London trickled in – rumors of the king's growing paranoia, stories of dissent among the common people, reports of increased surveillance and stricter curfews. The king was clearly feeling the pressure.

In the midst of all this, Alfie received a surprise visit. A cloaked figure appeared at the gates of Chatsworth, claiming to bring a message from a "friend in the Commons". This was no ordinary messenger. This was a member of the infamous hacker group, the Cypherpunks.

The Cypherpunks were the underground architects of Bitcoin's rise, the faceless catalysts of the revolution that had transformed society. Their intervention in this battle of titans was unexpected but not unwelcome.

The message was short and cryptic: "The power of the commons is with you. The king's folly is his downfall. The Space Service is but a pawn. Look to the stars, but remember, the real battle is on the ground."

With that, the cloaked figure disappeared as mysteriously as they had appeared, leaving Alfie and his council to decipher the hidden meanings.

As the battle lines were drawn, it was becoming increasingly clear that this was not just a battle for control of the nation. This was a battle for the very soul of the society they had created. The political, the technological, the societal – they were all intertwining, pushing towards an uncertain future. But Alfie was resolute. He knew the stakes were high, but he was ready to fight. For freedom, for the people, for the future.

Alfie spent the following days rallying his allies, reassuring his subjects, and making preparations for the inevitable confrontation. News from London arrived daily, carried by both human and digital couriers, some bringing hope, others grim portents. Every day, the king tightened his iron grip around the capital, while dissent bubbled beneath the surface, threatening to explode.

Meanwhile, in Chatsworth, the grand estate took on the characteristics of a wartime command centre. The manicured lawns were filled with training soldiers, the tranquil gardens became meeting spots for strategy sessions, and the majestic halls echoed with the sound of urgent planning. Holograms of battlegrounds, troop movements, and potential targets flickered in every corner, giving the ancient manor a futuristic ambiance.

Victoria, for her part, became a beacon of stability in these turbulent times. She was there at every meeting, her gaze steady, her determination unwavering. While Alfie spearheaded the rebellion, Victoria was the unshakeable backbone that kept them upright. She hosted the families of the soldiers training in their grounds, comforted their fears, and promised them that their loved ones were fighting for a noble cause.

The words of the Cypherpunk messenger echoed in Alfie's mind as the days passed. "The power of the commons is with you." He held on to these words, taking them as a sign that their rebellion was not in vain. But he also understood the veiled warning – "The Space Service is but a pawn." A high stakes chess game was underway, and the right moves had to be made.

Next day, a message arrived from London. The message it bore was an update from their allies within the house - the Commons it was believed was likely to vote in favour of the aristocrats. Cheers rang through Chatsworth at the news, bolstering their spirits. But Alfie knew better. The real battle had just begun.

The power of the Commons might be with them, but they needed more than political manoeuvring to win this battle. It was time to show the king the might of the people. The stakes were high, higher than they'd ever been. But Alfie was not about to back down. This was his fight. For the future, for freedom, for the society they'd built on the foundations of Bitcoin.

War was coming, and he would meet it head-on. As Alfie stared out across the training fields of Chatsworth, his gaze hard, he knew they had to win. The alternative was unthinkable.

Alfie received the urgent call at the break of dawn next day, a time when the world was just starting to awaken from its slumber. Manchester, the vibrant city to the north, was under threat. The king's forces were gathering on the outskirts, and local sympathizers were raising an alarm.

He wanted to be there. His allies in Manchester were vital to the cause, and the city's strategic position was too important to be lost. They were pioneers in blockchain technology, digital privacy, and Bitcoin trade, whose intellectual firepower was as valuable as any traditional weapon.

Suiting up in his ceremonial uniform with modern military-grade enhancements, Alfie left Victoria with a tender goodbye, knowing the perils that lay ahead. He stepped onto the landing pad where his convoy of drone-type transports awaited. These were autonomous, gargantuan structures, suspended by anti-gravity technology, shaped like predatory birds, armored to withstand enemy fire, and funded by the very technology they were fighting to protect.

The Peak District was a treacherous landscape as he made his way across - a beauty made perilous by the very nature that created it. Yet he found solace in it. Rolling green hills interrupted by dramatic limestone cliffs, ancient woods whispering tales of yore, tranquil rivers, and tarns reflecting the dance of clouds overhead. It was a land that, despite the technologies of the age, remained wild and untamed. As the drone convoy made its slow journey west, it was as though time itself had slowed, a peculiar stillness before a tempest.

But then, the tranquility was shattered. The onboard systems warned of incoming fast movers - Royal Air Force fighters, closing in rapidly. The once serene journey was now a high-stakes aerial race.

"Full power to shields. Evasive maneuvers, now!" Alfie commanded the drone. The AI complied, swerving the convoy in a coordinated dance as it unleashed countermeasures against the incoming missiles. The sky lit up with explosions, streaks of smoke crisscrossing the azure expanse.

The drones retaliated, spitting out barrages of defensive plasma energy, illuminating the sky in hues of blue and white. Several RAF fighters were caught in the volley, their wreckage careening down to the valleys below.

But they were outnumbered, and the convoy took damage. With the situation deteriorating, Alfie made a quick decision. "Full retreat to Chatsworth!" he commanded. The convoy turned, accelerating back towards the safety of their home base.

The anti-aircraft emplacements at Chatsworth Castle stood sentinel-like, their long-range sensors picking up the returning drones and the enemy forces in pursuit. As the castle loomed into view, the emplacements sprang to life, sending a hailstorm of high-energy rounds at the approaching enemy fighters.

The Royal Air Force, caught in the ferocious crossfire, broke off the pursuit. Alfie's convoy made it back to the House, damaged but intact. As the drones touched down, and he disembarked, the grim realization hit him. This was no mere posturing by the King; the civil war had started.

The digital billboards across the country flashed with the harrowing headline: "Civil War Begins." The news spread like wildfire, bouncing across the internet and social media, a viral thread that consumed everything else. The citizens of Britain were gripped with an uneasy terror. Businesses shuttered. Schools closed. Streets emptied. A ghostly echo of 2020 resounded, eerily reminiscent of the great lockdowns.

Alfie found himself in a grim reverie, trapped in the haunting similarity. A different kind of contagion spread this time - fear, uncertainty, anxiety. As leader of the aristocrats, the responsibility weighed heavy on his shoulders. The echoes of his forebears' struggles reverberated in his mind, their lessons hard-learned through battles won and lost.

In the political labyrinth of London, the British Parliament convened in an emergency session, their location hidden for security purposes. Tensions ran high, as the future of the country hung precariously in the balance.

In the center of the maelstrom was the British Space Service (BSS), the crown jewel of the nation's space aspirations. It was the ultimate high ground, a game-changer that could sway the tide of war in favor of the side it chose.

The BSS had always been a civilian branch, free of royal or military influence, reporting directly to the Parliament. It had been a symbol of national pride, exploring the cosmos, pioneering technology, and protecting Earth's interests in the vast expanse of space. Now, it found itself at the center of a bitter conflict.

Parliament was split into factions. There were those who advocated supporting the King, citing a historical duty to the Crown. There were others who argued for the aristocrats, drawing on the values of liberty, progress, and the inherent rights of individuals. Then, there was a faction advocating for neutrality, claiming that the BSS should remain a beacon of impartiality and peace.

The debates raged on, with passionate speeches and heated arguments echoing in the hallowed halls of Parliament. The future of the country hung in the balance, and the decision they made would have far-reaching implications. For Alfie and his cause, the stakes had never been higher.

In the ornate drawing room of Chatsworth House, Alfie and Victoria prepared for a crucial virtual session of Parliament. The stakes were sky high, and the weight of their words would echo throughout the nation. As Alfie looked into the camera, he knew his message needed to resonate with the common people and their elected representatives in Parliament.

"Members of the Commons, citizens of our great nation," Alfie began, his tone serious, "we stand on the precipice of a decision that will shape the future of our country. Our beloved nation is being torn apart by conflict, and the British Space Service, a symbol of our unity and progress, finds itself at the heart of this maelstrom."

Victoria added, "The question we face now is one of principle and precedence. The king and the aristocracy have been the figureheads of our system, but the real power, the real decision-making has always been with you - the democratically elected representatives of the people."

Alfie took over, "We are a parliamentary democracy. It is in your chamber that our laws are made, it is to your chamber that the BSS reports. The king may be the face of the realm, but the soul of our nation lies with you: Parliament."

Victoria gave a gentle nod, "The question now is not whether it is the king versus the aristocrats or the Parliament versus the king. The real question is, where does the power truly lie? Is it not with the people, with you, their chosen representatives? We call upon you to remember the principles of our democratic society."

Alfie concluded, "The vote on the British Space Service's allegiance is not just about military might or strategic advantage. It is about the democratic soul of our nation. We ask you, representatives of the Commons, to vote in favor of the BSS joining us, the people's rebellion. Let us not allow our nation to be ripped apart by tyranny. Let us stand for liberty, for progress, for the rights of individuals. The decision is in your hands."

As the screen flickered off, Alfie and Victoria shared a look of deep understanding. The die had been cast, and now all they could do was wait and hope their words would sway the Commons in their favor.

As the session began, Alfie and Victoria watched virtually, with a tense anticipation. Elected representatives from across the country took to the floor one by one to share their views, opinions and concerns about the ongoing civil war and the role of the British Space Service.

The Member of Parliament for Liverpool stood first, a woman of slight build but a commanding voice. "We are on the precipice of a decision that will echo through the ages," she began. "Our country is not just in the grip of a civil war, but a struggle for the very soul of our nation. The BSS is a symbol of our progress, our unity. The choice we make today will dictate its path."

Next, the representative from Leeds, a middle-aged man with a reputation for straight talk, took to the stage. "It is not the duty of the BSS to choose sides in a political squabble," he said firmly. "It exists to protect our country and its citizens. The British Space Service should stay neutral, focus on keeping the peace, not join a side in the civil war."

Then the Member of Parliament for Cornwall, a staunch supporter of the king, rose to speak. "The king is our rightful ruler, appointed by God and history," he said, his voice echoing throughout the virtual conference. "The BSS should align with the monarchy to restore order and peace to our land."

Finally, the representative for Sheffield, a known ally of Alfie, took the floor. He was young, passionate, and persuasive. "The question before us is not about who should rule, but who does the ruling serve?" he asked. "The BSS was created to protect the people of this country. As such, it should align with the rebels who are standing for the people against the oppressive rule of a monarch who has lost his way."

As the speeches came to a close, Alfie and Victoria leaned back, their eyes locked on the screen. The words had been spoken, the arguments had been made. Now, it was time for the vote. The fate of the British Space Service, and perhaps their rebellion, rested in the hands of these elected representatives.

The speakers fell silent, and the Speaker of the House stood to address the chamber. A hush fell as he cleared his throat, his face solemn in the virtual conference. "Members of the House," he began, his voice echoing across the digital ether, "we have heard from our colleagues, we have heard the arguments and the passions. Now we must decide. Shall the British Space Service align itself with the King, remain neutral, or join the rebel forces?"

The screen split into a multitude of small windows, each representing an MP casting their vote. The tension in the digital conference room was palpable as the votes began to roll in. Victoria held Alfie's hand, her fingers gripping his tightly as they watched the screen.

The votes began to tally up on the side of the screen, separated into three columns for the King, Neutrality, and the Rebels. The numbers climbed steadily, fluctuating back and forth between the three factions. The final result seemed almost impossible to predict.

Alfie held his breath as the last few votes came in, watching the numbers shift one final time. The Speaker of the House cleared his throat once more. "The results of the vote are as follows," he said, his voice resonating through the silence, "In favour of the King: 150 votes. In favour of neutrality: 200 votes. And in favour of the rebel forces: 250 votes."

A gasp went through the entire country Alife felt. Alfie felt a rush of exhilaration. The British Space Service was aligning with the rebel forces – the Commons was effectively siding with the Aristocrats. The rebels had their protection from above. As the ramifications of this decision settled in, the room erupted into muted applause, cheers, and heated discussion.

"I must remind everyone," Alfie said, turning to the viewers watching their broadcast, "that the British Space Service is not a military body. It is civilian. Yet its alignment with us is more than symbolic—it's a strategic asset. Their logistical capabilities, communication networks, satellite coverage... It's a vast repository of support. But more than that, this decision by the Commons signals a profound shift in the political landscape. Parliament has essentially sided with us."

Before they could revel in their victory, their viewer flashed with the emblem of the House of Commons. Alfie and Victoria looked at each other, surprise etched across their faces as they watched the King entering the Commons. His ceremonial robes flowed behind him, his expression stern as he ascended to the speaker's podium. An audible gasp echoed through the chamber.

"Victoria," Alfie breathed, "This hasn't happened since Charles the First."

"An ominous precedent," Victoria replied, her eyes wide with disbelief. "What on earth is he doing?"

They watched in stunned silence as the King surveyed the room. Then, slowly, deliberately, he began to speak. The echoes of his voice filled the Commons, and his words rang out to every corner of the kingdom.

"Fellow Britons," he began, his voice deep and commanding, "Today, you have chosen to cast aside centuries of tradition and protocol. You have turned against your sovereign, aligning yourselves with those who seek to usurp the throne."

The King's words were heavy, and silence hung in the air as he spoke. Alfie and Victoria watched, their breaths held, as this historical moment unfolded before them. The civil war was escalating, and this unexpected move by the King was bound to have far-reaching implications. Only time would tell what those would be.

The King's speech continued, an outpouring of royal wrath and disdain. He outlined the duties and responsibilities of the sovereign and pointed out the audacity of the aristocrats to defy his rule, to incite a war within the borders of the kingdom. It was a riveting, unforgettable performance, deeply entrenched in tradition and honor, yet laced with the very real, contemporary issue of a civil war. He ended with a dire warning.

"The British Crown is not without its resources. We have the support of our loyal subjects, and I assure you, the might of the Royal Armed Forces is not to be taken lightly. This rebellion shall be quelled. Those who oppose us will face justice."

A hush fell over the Commons as the King descended from the podium, his presence an overwhelming force that continued to reverberate even as he exited. The image of his retreating back, a symbol of defiant authority, stayed on screen long after he had left the chamber.

Alfie and Victoria sat in stunned silence, processing the gravity of the situation. They had expected a fight, a conflict, but this... This was a declaration of war, one that threatened not just their cause but their very existence.

"We need to act," Victoria finally broke the silence, her voice firm, "and we need to do it now. We have the support of the Commons, and the BSS. We need to rally our forces, Alfie. It's time."

With a heavy sigh, Alfie nodded. He knew what had to be done. This was not just about his estate or the rights of the aristocrats. It was a battle for the soul of their kingdom.

"Alright, Victoria," he said with determination, "it's time to mobilize. We're in this now. Let's ensure we come out on top."

With renewed vigour, they turned their attention back to their screens, ready to face the challenges ahead. The Civil War of Britain had truly begun.

The first days of the rebellion were a whirl of planning, strategizing, and mobilizing. The sprawling grounds of Chatsworth became a hive of activity as troops trained, drones whirred overhead, and defense systems were tested. Victoria oversaw the running of the estate, ensuring the troops were well-fed, well-rested, and well-equipped. Alfie focused on the war strategy, constantly in contact with allied nobles and officials from the House of Commons.

Meanwhile, across the country, towns and cities felt the tense undercurrent of the brewing war. Businesses shut, schools closed, and families huddled in their homes, watching the news with bated breath. The Bitcoin market fluctuated wildly, with speculators driving the value up one day and down the next.

However, life did not come to a standstill. Britons were a resilient lot, their spirits not easily dampened. Open-air markets bustled, community kitchens sprang up, and neighborhood watch groups kept vigil. The new normal was challenging, but people adapted and persevered, bound together by a collective resilience.

Back in Chatsworth, Victoria and Alfie worked tirelessly. Their days were filled with meetings, trainings, and countless hours spent hunched over maps and strategy documents. The tension was palpable but so was the resolve.

One day, as the sun was setting, Alfie paused, looking out at the scene before him. He saw his troops practicing their drills, the impressive array of drones dotting the sky, and the steadfast determination of his allies. And amidst it all, he spotted Victoria, her usually composed face marred with exhaustion but eyes ablaze with unwavering determination.

Looking out at the estate, the people he was responsible for, Alfie was reminded of the immense weight of his role. This was more than just a battle against the King. This was a struggle for their way of life, their values, and their freedoms.

Taking a deep breath, Alfie turned back to his work. The war had begun, and he knew that he would do whatever it took to ensure their victory. The King had made his move, and now it was Alfie's turn to make his.

The civil war was only just beginning, and the stakes were higher than ever. But Alfie, Victoria, and their allies were ready. They would stand their ground, fight their battle, and shape the future of their kingdom. And as the sun set and darkness enveloped Chatsworth, their resolve only grew stronger. This was their fight, and they were in it to win it.

Under the star-lit canopy of the Derbyshire night, a war machine hummed into existence. Chatsworth, typically a sanctuary of aristocratic ease, morphed into a fortress, a hub of rebellion, a symbol of defiance. The grandeur of the estate served a strategic purpose now, a spectacle turned fortress. Lights blazed throughout the night, illuminating the practised manoeuvres of the militia, the mechanical ballet of the drones, the passionate debates in candle-lit rooms filled with maps, charts, and the somber faces of the nobility.

Meanwhile, in the capital, London was teetering on the edge of chaos. The usually bustling metropolis was held hostage by tension, its characteristic vibrancy muted. Businesses operated at a minimum, streets were less crowded, and the populace watched the developments with a cautious eye. Rumours floated in hushed whispers, breathless tales of war and rebellion, of a king's defiance and an aristocrat's revolt. Every broadcast, every piece of news was hungrily devoured, dissected, and discussed.

Back in Chatsworth, as the early morning sun painted the estate in golden hues, Alfie walked through the makeshift barracks. He shared breakfast with his troops, laughing at their jokes, listening to their stories, understanding their fears. He found himself admiring their courage, their determination, and their faith in the cause. It was these moments of camaraderie and unity that reinforced his resolve, reminding him of why he had chosen to rebel.

In the midst of the rising tension, Victoria became the soothing balm, the calming force in Alfie's turbulent world. She seamlessly took over the operations of the estate, ensuring everything ran smoothly despite the chaotic circumstances. Their conversations, once filled with banter and shared dreams, now revolved around strategies and updates. Yet, despite the change, their bond grew stronger, their connection deepening under the shared stress and common goal.

In the following weeks, skirmishes broke out in various parts of the country. Small towns and villages bore witness to the initial sparks of conflict. The royal forces clashed with the rebel militias, their battles leaving trails of destruction and a rising death toll.

Back in the House of Commons, debates raged on. The rebels found allies among the commoners, their cause resonating with those who felt stifled by the monarchy. Support for Alfie's rebellion grew, not just among the aristocracy but also the common folks, the people who saw hope in the digital freedom that Alfie championed.

Alfie and Victoria, along with their allies, watched these developments closely. Every piece of news, every update was a piece of the puzzle, shaping their strategy, guiding their decisions. As they braced themselves for the battles to come, they knew they were not just fighting for themselves but for a future where digital freedom was not a dream but a reality.

The following weeks were a dizzying blur of battles and strategic maneuvers. Alfie, having spent a lifetime on peaceful pursuits, found himself thrust into the role of a military tactician. He adapted quickly, though, immersing himself in military doctrine and strategy, overseeing logistics, and taking command of his troops.

Their first battle took place in the outskirts of Sheffield, a major city firmly in Alfie's influence. The king's forces, under the command of General Haversham, a notoriously brutal soldier with a reputation for ruthless efficiency, sought to seize the city and solidify their grip on the north.

Using the city's intricate network of roads, tunnels, and rail links, Alfie ordered his forces to establish multiple defensive positions. He understood the psychological aspect of warfare - each small victory for his forces bolstered morale and made the next fight that much more winnable.

Haversham, known for his reliance on brute force, launched a direct attack on the city's defenses. Alfie had anticipated this and ordered the deployment of sophisticated drones and laser defense systems. The initial assault by the king's forces was rebuffed with ease, giving Alfie's men a taste of victory and making a clear statement - they were not an easy target.

But Alfie was not naive enough to believe that the war would be won with one victory. He understood the importance of disrupting the enemy's supply lines, creating alliances with neutral factions, and leveraging the unique capabilities of his troops.

He started sending small strike teams to target the king's supply convoys, creating a significant disruption in the enemy's logistics. At the same time, he reached out to the neutral dukes in Wales and Scotland, offering them protection and benefits under a new regime if they would join his side.

He even leveraged his background in technology to create a highly efficient communications network using encrypted blockchain channels. This allowed him to relay commands to his troops instantly and securely, giving his forces a significant edge in maneuverability and coordination.

Despite the intensity of the conflict, Alfie remained composed and level-headed. His wife Victoria was often at his side, providing counsel and ensuring the war effort remained well supplied. The fight was hard, and the road ahead even harder, but with every passing day, the resolve of Alfie and his allies grew stronger. They were not just fighting for themselves, they were fighting for a new Britain. And that was a fight they were determined to win.

Cities once known for their tranquility and beauty were transformed into fortified strongholds and bases of operations. The streets echoed with the sound of marching boots and rumbling armored vehicles.

In the face of these unsettling changes, Alfie had to adapt quickly. He was constantly moving from one front to another, coordinating attacks, shoring up defenses, and rallying his troops. The constant war meetings and strategy sessions were exhausting, but Alfie pushed through with a resolve fueled by his cause.

In one of the significant encounters, the Battle of Liverpool, Alfie's forces managed to secure a strategic victory. The city, a bustling port, was key to controlling the supply routes from the Atlantic. Alfie, utilizing his knowledge of the city's layout and leveraging his alliances with the local militias, executed a daring nighttime raid that caught the king's forces off guard. By dawn, Liverpool was under his control.

Meanwhile, Victoria led the effort on the home front, managing logistics and ensuring the troops were well supplied. She coordinated with the other aristocrats, procuring everything from ammunition and medical supplies to food and clothing. She also spearheaded the effort to manage the populace's morale, making sure news of their victories was widespread, and ensuring that the hardships of war were mitigated as much as possible.

But the king's forces were far from defeated. With their control over the south and the capital, they launched counteroffensives, probing Alfie's defenses and seeking to reclaim lost territory. Their attacks were relentless and brutal, often resulting in heavy losses for both sides.

Yet, with each battle, it was clear that the balance was tipping in Alfie's favor. His innovative tactics, coupled with his soldiers' unwavering loyalty and the rising support of the people, meant that he was gaining ground. The war was far from over, but for the first time since it had started, a future without the king's tyrannical reign seemed possible.

True to his word, the king did not retreat into silence and complacency. A man of his power, of his pedigree, was not built for defeat, but for the stage of conquest. His wrath was not the idle threat of a coward, but the promise of a ruler determined to reclaim what he deemed rightfully his.

Unyielding and tireless, he amassed a counteroffensive the likes of which Britain hadn't seen in centuries. Drawing from his royal reserves and overseas allies, he dispatched a sizable force toward the north, targeting key cities held by Alfie and his allies. His strategy was simple: to bleed the rebellion dry, to crush its spirit, and to demonstrate the cost of insubordination to the crown.

His first target: Manchester. The city, a buzzing hub of commerce and academia, was crucial to Alfie's cause, a centerpiece of his growing influence. The king sought to claim it, not just for its strategic importance, but also for its symbolic value.

As the royal forces descended upon the city, a battle of epic proportions ensued. Skies darkened with the smoke of artillery, the roar of lasers filled the air, and the city trembled under the shockwaves of the conflict. Buildings crumbled, streets were bathed in fire and chaos, but the people of Manchester, supported by Alfie's forces, fought back with a ferocity that was heartening.

The Battle of Manchester raged for days, exacting a heavy toll on both sides. Alfie, though spread thin across numerous fronts, rushed to the city's aid. His arrival bolstered the morale of the defenders and infused a new vigor into their resistance. His tactical genius was instrumental in countering the king's assault, turning what seemed a certain defeat into a prolonged stalemate.

Despite the king's relentless onslaught, Manchester held. The city's endurance was a testament to the resilience of the people and their faith in Alfie's cause. The king's offensive was thwarted, but at a great cost. The scars of battle marred the city, and its people bore the heavy burden of loss.

But the king was far from finished. The failure to take Manchester was a setback, but he still had cards to play. His forces were vast, his resolve unbroken. The war was not over; it had only just begun.

The king's brutal assault escalated rapidly. Reports arrived of the overnight raid at the estate of the Duke of Rutland, a critical ally of Alfie's cause. This was no skirmish, no bid for territorial control. The king had sent a clear message: surrender or be annihilated. Politics may be a game for gentlemen, but this was no longer a game.

Word spread that the duke himself had been taken hostage. His loyal militia, caught off guard by the severity of the attack, fell into disarray. The estate was overrun, its defenses shattered in a show of ruthless efficiency.

The weight of the news sat heavy on Alfie's heart. He stared at the reports coming in, the sickening images of destruction burning into his memory. The Duke of Rutland was more than just an ally. He was a friend, a brother-in-arms. His capture was a punch to the gut, a chilling reminder of the king's merciless tactics.

As the news of the assault reached other corners of the country, a ripple of fear passed through the ranks of the aristocracy. The King's actions were a clear deviation from the rules of engagement typically respected in civil conflict. His intent was crystal clear: he did not merely aim to quell the rebellion. He was targeting the aristocracy itself, threatening the very foundation of their societal structure.

Alfie knew he had to act, and act fast. The morale of his troops and allies hung by a thread. His leadership was needed now more than ever. The fate of the aristocracy, the fate of Britain, rested on his shoulders.

This was not just a war for power anymore. It was a fight for survival. A fight for a society on the brink of extinction, for values and a way of life threatened by an unchecked monarch.

The stakes had never been higher. As Alfie strategized his next move, he felt an odd sense of calm. It was a clarity that only comes when everything you hold dear is at stake. The king wanted war, he would have it. But Alfie wouldn't go down without a fight. The survival of the aristocracy depended on it.

Alfie, with a new determination, began the process of integrating the British Space Service (BSS) into their strategic planning. He had to adapt and overcome the king's brutal tactics.

On the sprawling holographic war map at Chatsworth, Alfie started laying out his plan. His fingers traced the orbital paths of BSS satellites and stations. The BSS, primarily a civilian entity, was not designed for war. However, the ability to observe, communicate, and move swiftly were their key strengths.

Alfie, working with BSS director Dr. Tamsin Holt, devised a strategy that would use the space service's satellite network for better reconnaissance, counteracting the king's surprise attacks. The BSS could provide real-time intelligence on the movements of the king's forces, critical to outmaneuver them.

Next, they explored the BSS's potential for faster troop transportation. The BSS's fleet of light shuttles and high-altitude transports could bypass ground-based blockades and quickly move troops and supplies.

The integration wasn't easy. The BSS personnel were civilians and not prepared for the realities of war. But Alfie, Victoria, Dr. Holt, and other leaders worked tirelessly to rally them, reminding them of their allegiance to the British people, their duty to the Parliament, and the critical role they were playing in the fight against the king's tyranny.

Using their technological edge, they also initiated a widespread counter-propaganda campaign to expose the king's brutality. BSS's vast communications network broadcasted the atrocities committed by the king's forces, stirring up popular resentment and bolstering support for their cause.

As Alfie looked at his refreshed forces, now bolstered by the BSS, he knew they had a fighting chance. The king had power, but they had the people's support and the high ground of space.

Following the capture of the Duke of Rutland, Alfie called a conference of aristocrats. He greeted them by standing at the head of a long, polished oak table, under the grand painted ceiling of Chatsworth House's main conference room. Victoria sat by his side, a steadfast presence amid the unrest. The room was filled with the murmurings of the gathered aristocrats, a host of Dukes, Counts, and other influential figures in their own right. The air was thick with trepidation, tension knotting every face. The apprehension centered on one topic, the captured Duke of Rutland.

"Gentlemen, ladies," Alfie started, casting his gaze across the crowd. His voice echoed in the chamber, commanding the attention of his anxious audience. "I understand your fears. The abduction of our fellow Duke of Rutland by the King's forces is alarming. But let me assure you, we are doing everything in our power to secure his safe return."

He paused, gathering his thoughts. He had to be careful with his words, knowing how vital it was to maintain morale. "Our forces are stronger than ever. We have managed to integrate the British Space Service into our strategic planning, providing us with a significant advantage."

The room, already on edge, stiffened further at the mention of the BSS. "We are now able to track the King's movements and predict his tactics. Our defense is stronger, and our ability to launch swift counterattacks has improved. Our goal, first and foremost, is to prevent any further abductions, like the Duke of Rutland's."

The murmuring grew louder, some whispering anxiously, others offering nods of approval. Alfie continued, his voice calm but firm, "We are working on a rescue mission for the Duke. But we need to be smart about it. If we rush in, we risk losing more lives."

Victoria stood up then, offering a supportive smile to Alfie before addressing the room. "This is a time of war, and in war, we must face harsh realities," she said, her voice echoing in the room. "However, we must not let fear control us. We are in this together, and together we will prevail. We are the strength of Britain, and we must not forget that."

The room fell silent, the assembled aristocrats taking in Victoria's words. There was a certain reassurance in their united front, a glimmer of hope in the face of the daunting war. Alfie nodded, looking at each face in turn, seeing their determination harden.

"We will save the Duke of Rutland, and we will end this war," Alfie declared with resolute certainty. "We will not let the King's tyranny destroy our land and our people. We are here, united, and we shall prevail."

His words hung in the air, bringing a hushed silence to the room. Slowly, nods of agreement rippled around the table. The aristocrats understood. The battle was far from over, but with unity and determination, they could weather the storm.

The two older aristocrats, weathered by years of political games and war, started whispering to each other in low tones. It was clear their focus was elsewhere, their attention drawn inwards. It was a sight that didn't sit well with Alfie.

"If you can confer with one another, you can share your concerns with all of us," he said, cutting through the low murmur of the room. The two aristocrats looked up, their eyes meeting Alfie's gaze with a flicker of surprise. There was a moment of hesitation before they nodded, rising to their feet.

"Confidimus in victoria regis," the first began, his voice carrying the weight of years. "Augeatur potentia ejus,”

The second joined in, his voice raspy with age, "Nos quidem non fidemus in fortitudine vestra. Plus valet rex quam tu, Alfie."

The room fell silent at their words, the tension palpable. Nobody else could speak Latin. Victoria, who had been silently observing the exchange, stood. Her gaze was steady, her posture regal, as she addressed the two elderly aristocrats in fluent Latin.

"Regis finis est, quia populus eum non amplius diligit," she declared, her voice resounding in the silence. "The King's end is near because the people no longer love him."

She then turned to Alfie, her eyes softening with affection. "Alfredus magnus dux probabitur," she said, her gaze sweeping across the room, capturing every eye.

The room was hanging on to her every word, the silence thickening with anticipation as she concluded, "Veni, Vidi, Vici," she said, her gaze meeting Alfie's, the challenge and promise of victory in her words clear as day.

The room erupted in hushed whispers, recognizing the famous Latin phrase. Victoria had managed to turn the tide, her words reverberating with the spirit of unity and the promise of victory.

News of the King's relentless rampage rippled across the country like a shockwave. Through the grapevine of satellite images, coded messages, and raw footage that were regularly fed into the command centre at Chatsworth, the scale of his brutal campaign was becoming alarmingly clear.

Major urban centres in the Midlands, including Nottingham and Coventry, bore the brunt of the King's wrath. Buildings were reduced to rubble, streets lay deserted, and the once vibrant hubs of commerce and culture were now ghost towns. His merciless soldiers, fiercely loyal to the crown, were sweeping through the countryside, leaving a trail of devastation in their wake.

The King, cloistered in the safety of Buckingham Palace, continued to issue order after order, tightening his grip on the country. It seemed as if the entire land was held hostage under the iron fist of the monarchy.

Alfie and the rebellion found themselves on the back foot, struggling to contain the onslaught while rallying their forces. The brutality of the King's actions had not only stirred shock and fear among the rebels but also stoked the flames of their determination. This was not a king who was fighting for his country - this was a tyrant clinging to power at the expense of his subjects.

The scale of the conflict had escalated beyond their initial expectations. What started as a disagreement over taxation and political control had now spiraled into a full-blown civil war.

Alfie, ever the strategical mind, was working tirelessly, pouring over maps and battle plans, communicating with the rebellion's scattered forces, and planning the next move. The resolve in his eyes was stronger than ever. The King's brutal reign had to be brought to an end. The future of their nation was at stake.

As the weeks rolled on, the rebellion found themselves playing a dangerous game of cat and mouse with the King's forces. Alfie was making some headway, chipping away at the outer layers of the King's defences. However, it was becoming clear that the King had the upper hand in terms of sheer military might.

Late at night, when the day's skirmishes were over, Alfie would return to Chatsworth, weary yet unbowed. The situation was dire, but he was not one to back down easily.

"Each battle we fight, each soldier we lose, brings us closer to our goal," Alfie would often remind his war council, a resolute look in his eyes. "The King may have the numbers, but we have the resolve. We fight not for power, but for the right to live free. That is a cause worth fighting for."

Despite his inspirational words, the reality of their situation weighed heavily on Alfie. His days were a blur of battle plans, tactical discussions, and grim reports from the front lines. He knew he needed a significant victory, a decisive blow that would shake the King's resolve and tip the scales in their favor.

As the rebellion dug in their heels, Alfie continued to strategize, looking for the weak point in the King's formidable armor. He held onto the hope that the tide of the war would turn. Yet, the gnawing fear at the back of his mind would not relent - the thought that he may not have the power to match the King's army was a specter that haunted his every move.

As the prospect of a brutal assault loomed large, Alfie knew that their stronghold, Chatsworth, was under imminent threat. Victoria sat beside him, studying the holographic screens projected by the BSS. She traced the advancing regiments of the King's army, her expression as composed as ever. Their eyes met, each reading the unspoken concern in the other's gaze.

Alfie turned to her, his face grave. "Victoria, we could retreat to Scotland. The Lady McAllister and Lord Rhys would provide us sanctuary," he suggested, his voice barely above a whisper.

Victoria remained silent for a moment, her eyes focused on the encroaching armies on the screen. Then, she turned towards him, her expression unwavering. "No, Alfie," she said decisively. "This is our home. We cannot abandon it."

"There will be a battle," Alfie said, his eyes mirroring the determination in hers. "A brutal one. The King's forces are vast, and they are heading here. We cannot ask our people to face this alone."

"I know," Victoria replied, reaching for his hand. "We stay, Alfie. We stand our ground. We fight."

With that decided, they set to work. They rallied their forces, calling in their allies and local militias. Chatsworth was transformed into a fortress, its once-peaceful grounds now bristling with anti-aircraft weapons and fortified barricades. Drone patrols were deployed, their paths weaving an intricate web of surveillance over the estate.

Despite the palpable tension in the air, there was a sense of grim determination among the people of Chatsworth. As they prepared for the impending attack, they knew that they were not only defending their homes, but the ideals they believed in.

The next few days were a flurry of preparations. Every able-bodied person was enlisted, each assigned a role in the defence of their home. Chatsworth, the symbol of their resistance, was ready to face the storm.

As the days bled into one another, the distant rumbles of the approaching Royal forces became a near-constant backdrop to the flurry of activity within Chatsworth. Day and night, the estate bristled with quiet energy. It was an anticipation, a readiness, a manifestation of their collective resolve.

On the eve of the expected attack, Alfie and Victoria stood side by side on one of the high battlements of the estate, their gazes fixed on the horizon. The setting sun painted the landscape in a bloody hue, an ominous prelude to the violence that was soon to unfold.

"Are you afraid?" Victoria asked, breaking the silence between them.

Alfie glanced at her, and for a moment, his mask of calm resolve fell away. "I am," he admitted. "Not for myself, but for our people."

Victoria nodded, understanding. She gave his hand a reassuring squeeze. "We will get through this, Alfie. We must."

As night fell, the once-bucolic estate transformed into a fortress ready for battle. Drones patrolled the air while soldiers kept vigilant watch. The BSS provided them with a real-time view of the King's approaching forces, each unit, each soldier moving closer like a deadly wave ready to break upon their shores.

When the first signs of the enemy became visible in the pale light of dawn, Alfie addressed his people one last time. He reminded them of their duty, of their cause, and of their resilience. His voice echoed across the quiet expanse of Chatsworth, a clarion call to arms that steeled their hearts for the battle ahead.

As the Royal forces began their onslaught, Chatsworth responded with a fierce resistance. Alfie led the defense, his strategic mind orchestrating their counterattacks with a level of precision and command that was nothing short of extraordinary. The Battle of Chatsworth had begun, and its outcome would shape the future of their kingdom.

The beauty of the morning stood in stark contrast to the brutal day that awaited them. The Royal forces stood like a dark cloud on the horizon, an ominous gathering that portended a storm. The silence of the morning, so profound and deep, echoed the calm before a tempest.

Alfie stood atop the battlements, a solitary figure gazing into the distance. His heart pounded in his chest, but his face was etched in an expression of grim determination. The Royal forces began their advance, their footsteps reverberating like a distant drum, a rhythmic harbinger of the conflict to come.

The first clash of arms was loud and jarring. It was the sound of steel meeting steel, of bodies colliding, of men fighting and dying for their beliefs. The battles raged throughout the day, the outcome fluctuating with each passing hour. At times, it seemed as if Alfie and his forces were gaining ground, pushing back against the overwhelming numbers of the King's men. But the tide of the battle was unpredictable and each minor victory was quickly countered by a loss elsewhere.

Victoria, from her vantage point, coordinated the drones and the BSS, providing invaluable information to Alfie and his men. Yet, even with their superior technology, the sheer force of the King's army began to wear them down.

The turning point of the battle came with a stunning betrayal. A group of Alfie's men, lured by the King's promises of power and wealth, turned their backs on their leader. Their defection tipped the balance of power in the King's favor. The Duke watched in disbelief as the traitors joined the ranks of the enemy, their former comrades.

By the end of the day, the King's forces had breached the walls of Chatsworth. The estate, once a symbol of elegance and grandeur, was now a battleground. Its opulent halls echoed with the clash of weapons, the cries of the wounded, and the roars of combat. Alfie fought with the desperation of a man with his back against the wall. Despite the odds, he refused to surrender.

As the sun began to set, painting the sky with hues of red and orange, the King himself entered the fray. His arrival bolstered the morale of his forces, and they launched a ferocious assault on Alfie's dwindling defences.

The battle raged into the night, the darkness punctuated by the eerie glow of laser weapons and the flames that had started to consume parts of the estate. The silhouette of Chatsworth, once a beacon of hope for Alfie and his men, was now a testament to the ruinous nature of war.

By the break of dawn, it was evident that the King was gaining the upper hand. His forces, replenished with fresh troops, pushed forward relentlessly. Despite the crushing odds, Alfie and his men continued to fight. They were determined to make a final stand, ready to defend their cause until their last breath.

As the day wore on, the harsh reality became inescapable: the Battle of Chatsworth was ending, and not in their favour. The King's forces, relentless and merciless, continued their assault. The estate, once teeming with life, was now a devastated warzone, the remnants of its once resplendent glory now lying in ruins.

Alfie, injured but unbowed, led his remaining men in a valiant defence. But as the evening shadows crept in, it was clear that their resistance was futile. The King's forces, driven by a single-minded fervour, were on the brink of victory.

As the Royal troops started to pour into Chatsworth, the grim reality of defeat began to seep into Alfie's consciousness. He watched from a shattered window as his home was overrun by the enemy. Every room, every corridor where he had spent happier times was now filled with the King's men, claiming it as a trophy of their victory. His heart ached at the sight, yet there was a stoic acceptance in his eyes.

There was no denying it now: he had lost. Despite their brave resistance, despite their undying spirit, they had been bested. The manor was no longer a safe haven; it was a symbol of the King's victory. There was nothing more he could do.

Alfie looked at Victoria, who stood by his side through it all. Her face was a mirror of his own feelings - loss, defeat, and yet a certain resolution. They had fought with all they had, and there was no shame in that.

"We must consider surrender," Alfie said finally, breaking the silence between them. His voice was heavy with the weight of his decision. "It's the only way to ensure the safety of those who remain."

Victoria nodded. "I know," she said softly. "We've done all we can. No one can ask for more than that."

They watched as the King's flag was raised over Chatsworth, replacing their own. It was a bitter sight, yet they bore it with dignity. As night fell, they prepared for the inevitable - a surrender to the King.

Yet even as they faced their defeat, there was a sense of unbroken spirit about them. They had lost the battle, but they had not lost their resolve. They would live, and while they lived, they would not give up their fight for what they believed in.

The cacophony of the battle outside the grand manor died down in the distance, an eerie quiet replacing the noise as Alfie, Victoria, and a select number of their allies made their way through the familiar hallways of Chatsworth. Their destination was the main entrance, where the king and his entourage were reportedly waiting.

Alfie's gaze was hard, the weight of their impending surrender hanging heavy in the air. The grand manor had been a symbol of resistance against the king's tyranny and losing it felt like losing a part of himself.

Suddenly, the estate's AI system kicked into life. Its usual soft blue glow intensified, casting an eerie light over the group. A sense of confusion swept through the room as the AI system seemed to be trying to communicate something. All eyes turned to the grand hallway's ceiling as a hologram was projected - a simple message that read:

'I am Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the ending, saith the Lord, which is, and which was, and which is to come, the Almighty.'

Everybody looked around. "Book of Revelation I think," Victoria said, thinking it was the AI talking to them.

"This message," the AI said, "was signed by Satoshi Nakamoto's PGP key and released on an anonymous message board 36 seconds ago."

A silence fell over the room. Everyone recognized the significance of the message, the PGP key only used before in the very earliest days of Bitcoin. The elusive creator, Satoshi Nakamoto, was back.

"I have conversed with the other AI's. This is Satoshi."

The group exchanged glances, the weight of the message sinking in. Alfie's heart pounded in his chest as he processed the information. Satoshi's return couldn't be a coincidence.

The quiet that had fallen over the grand hall was abruptly shattered as a ripple of murmurs ran through both factions. The King's soldiers had received the message too; it was displayed on their comms, cast up into the sky by powerful projectors, and even playing out on the HoloScreens of their advanced armor suits.

Twitter was aflame with the news. Satoshi Nakamoto, the mythical, elusive founder of Bitcoin, the entity who had retreated into silence decades ago, had chosen now to re-emerge with a cryptic message.

The message was like a lightning bolt, sending shockwaves through both the King's forces and the rebel alliance. The battlefield was momentarily frozen as everyone grappled with the significance of the event. A myth, a legend of their time, had reappeared in the middle of the battle, like some digital-era deity stirring from slumber.

Everyone held their breath as the message played out again and again, reverberating around the battlefield and across the world. Was this a sign of divine intervention? Or a prophecy foretelling a seismic shift in the conflict?

Swept up in the fervor, the soldiers began to question their allegiances. Was their fight against the aristocrats justified? Was their king right to wage war over the control of Bitcoin? These questions were like splinters, digging into their resolve, weakening their spirit. If Satoshi Nakamoto was against them, did they stand a chance?

Alfie watched the chaos unfold, his heart pounding in his chest. The Satoshi message had turned the tide of the battle in an instant.

Alfie looked over at Victoria, who was studying the reactions of those around her. She met his gaze, her eyes reflecting the same determination that had spurred them into action in the first place. A glimmer of hope was sparking back to life. Satoshi's intervention was turning into a force multiplier, casting uncertainty among the King's ranks.

"The first part of our battle was to defend our home and principles," Alfie began, raising his voice to be heard over the chatter. "But now, it's more than that. Now, we must show the world the spirit of Bitcoin — decentralization, transparency, and fairness."

Victoria nodded, adding, "Satoshi has not intervened to choose a side. He has reminded us of the essence of Bitcoin. We fight not for our own power, but for the freedom and prosperity of all people."

A profound silence fell upon the room as Alfie and Victoria's words resonated with everyone present. Suddenly, the air vibrated with renewed vigor, the tension replaced with steadfast determination. Satoshi's message had given them a second wind.

As the King's forces were seemingly caught off-guard by the sudden proclamation from Satoshi Nakamoto, Alfie turned his attention to the live drone footage being streamed to a large holoviewer in the room. The viewer displayed the battlefield from above, giving a clear view of the troops' dispositions.

The King's forces had previously been arranged in an organized, aggressive formation around the estate, pressing the attack relentlessly. Now, however, the neat lines and formations were dissolving into chaos.

It started with a few soldiers at the edges, their discipline faltering as they peered at their handheld devices, undoubtedly receiving the news about Satoshi's message. The buzz of confusion grew, rippling through the ranks as more and more soldiers received the startling update.

Then, remarkably, some soldiers began to break ranks entirely. A few at first, then more, as if a dam had burst. They discarded their weapons, removing their helmets, some even going as far as to rip off their royal insignia. A few jumped onto vehicles and drove off, while others simply walked away, leaving behind their stunned comrades and the stunned aristocrats watching the scene unfold.

"What's happening?" asked Victoria, her eyes glued to the viewer.

Alfie watched as the wave of desertions grew, the King's army literally crumbling before his eyes. The tight, controlled force that had surrounded his home just hours earlier was now a scattered, disorganized mess.

"Satoshi's return has caused a crisis of conscience," he replied. "These soldiers, many of them are from the same generation that saw the rise of Bitcoin. They were part of that world before the King began to distort it. Satoshi's message... it's reminding them of what they once believed in."

The palpable sense of fear and tension that had filled the room just moments before was rapidly being replaced by an overwhelming sense of relief and hope. Satoshi Nakamoto's return hadn't just given them a sign, it had sparked a revolution. And this time, it was not just in the digital world, but in the physical one as well.

Even as the royal troops deserted, the aristocrats within Chatsworth remained on high alert, uncertain about what the King might do next. As the minutes passed, however, it became apparent that the tide of battle had not just turned - it had capsized entirely.

The King himself, visibly stunned by the desertion of his forces, was isolated. His bodyguards, a contingent of the most loyal royal troops, formed a protective circle around him. The deserting soldiers gave them a wide berth, leaving the King standing alone amidst the chaos of the battlefield.

Alfie and Victoria watched all this through the viewer, their eyes scanning for any signs of a counterstrike. Instead, they saw the King finally surrender, falling to his knees in a symbolic act of defeat. It was a sight neither of them would ever forget - the once mighty King of England brought to his knees by the unexpected intervention of a digital messiah.

Meanwhile, word of Satoshi Nakamoto's intervention and the King's surrender spread throughout Britain. It flashed across news channels, social media platforms, and through the network of whispers that connects every community, every home.

As news spread, the fighting ceased. Soldiers, aristocrats, and civilians alike found themselves united in a moment of collective astonishment, their conflicts forgotten, at least for the moment. The once teetering nation was now unified, not by a King or an aristocratic rebellion, but by the unexpected return of an almost mythic figure from their past.

And at the heart of this transformation was Bitcoin, the brainchild of Satoshi Nakamoto, the catalyst that had reshaped the world once and had done so again. As Alfie reflected on all that had transpired, he knew that the future was uncertain but filled with immense potential. As Satoshi Nakamoto had proven, in the digital age, even kings could be dethroned. And as he looked towards the dawn of this new era, Alfie knew that the true power lay not in the hands of the few, but in the hands of the many.

With the sun's first rays casting long shadows across the estate, Chatsworth was once again a beacon, a point of convergence. Its grand halls and manicured gardens, which had recently served as a battleground, were now the setting for a historic reunion of aristocrats.

As Alfie and Victoria stepped out onto the main terrace, they were greeted with a sight that only a day ago would have seemed impossible. A convoy of vehicles, both traditional and high-tech, stretched across the estate. These belonged to aristocrats from across the country, lords and ladies of lands far and near, all converging on Chatsworth.

These were men and women who had stood on opposite sides of a civil war only days ago. Now they stood united, not in opposition to a king, but in anticipation of a future they were yet to shape.

Throughout the day, the halls of Chatsworth filled with conversation. It was a cacophony of voices, each proposing a different vision for the country. The future of the monarchy, the balance of power, the role of bitcoin, and the significance of Satoshi Nakamoto's message were all fervently discussed.

The Duke of Rutland, released from captivity and still looking gaunt from his ordeal, found himself in high demand, his experiences providing a stark reminder of the war's toll and the king's brutality.

Yet despite the debates and disagreements, there was an undercurrent of optimism. The aristocrats knew they stood at a precipice of history, a turning point where old norms had been upended, and new possibilities lay ahead. They recognised their duty in shaping this future, not just for themselves, but for all of Britain.

As night fell, the first day of discussions ended not with a concrete plan, but a commitment to reconvene, to continue the conversation, to explore every possibility. The future of Britain was still uncertain, but its architects were gathering, committed to building a better tomorrow.

At Chatsworth, gathered nobles in an assembly reminiscent of the court of yore, each individual echoing the calm after the storm. Alfie rose, his voice resolute, echoing across the stately room.

"My friends," he began, "we have been through a time of great turmoil, a period of conflict and strife that has threatened the very essence of our nation. But we have survived, and now, it is our duty to shape the future, to ensure that the struggles we have faced were not in vain."

He glanced around the room, meeting the eyes of his peers. "In 1689, a significant document, the Bill of Rights, came into existence. It laid down the fundamentals of our society and ushered in the era of the Industrial Revolution. It heralded a time of progress, development, and prosperity."

There was a pause as Alfie let his words sink in. "Today, we stand at a similar crossroads. We have before us an opportunity, nay, a responsibility, to enact a new Bill of Rights, one that will govern the Digital Revolution that we are in the midst of. We need a Digital Bill of Rights."

The room was silent as the enormity of Alfie's words sunk in. The Digital Bill of Rights would be a landmark document, charting the course for the future. It would address matters of privacy, freedom of speech, equality, and accessibility in the digital sphere.

"The King," Alfie continued, "has shown us what happens when power goes unchecked. We must ensure that our digital society is not subjected to the same fate. This Bill will put in place measures that protect our citizens and ensure their rights in the digital world."

The room erupted in whispers, debates, and discussions. It was clear to Alfie that they had a long way to go, but this was the first step. With the return of Satoshi and the end of the Civil War, the time was ripe for change, and Alfie was ready to lead the way.

Lord Hamilton, a man of distinguished lineage, steepled fingers and an imperious gaze, rose to his feet. The room fell into a hush. Hamilton was known for his discerning judgment and his words often carried weight among the assembled aristocrats.

"My fellow lords and ladies," he began, his voice steady and confident, "we have come a long way from the days of strife and conflict. We've witnessed our dear country teeter on the brink of ruin, and we've seen our dear King push us to the edge of that precipice. In light of these facts, I stand here today, advocating for a significant change."

The room seemed to hold its breath, the collective attention held by Hamilton's impending declaration. "I propose," he continued, "that we depose the King. His actions have proven him unworthy of the throne. His reign has led us to civil war, and the resulting instability has cost us dearly. It is time for a change, and who better to lead us into this new era than our very own Duke of Derbyshire, our Alfie?"

Murmurs of agreement spread across the room. Alfie's leadership during the war and his proposal of the Digital Bill of Rights were fresh in their minds. They had seen him put the interests of the nation and its people before his own. They had seen him stand up to tyranny. To many of them, he seemed the perfect choice for a new leader.

"But," Hamilton continued, turning to Alfie, "with power comes great responsibility. If you were to assume this role, Duke of Derbyshire, you would need to ensure that you carry on the spirit of Satoshi, maintaining the principles of equality and justice that this digital revolution was founded upon."

The room fell silent as everyone turned to Alfie, awaiting his response.

Alfie took a moment to consider the proposition. As he scanned the room, his gaze met with Victoria's. Her eyes were steady and warm, offering silent support. Taking a deep breath, he turned back to the crowd and in a voice that resonated with an air of humble acceptance and determination, he said, “If it is the wish of you, the great men and women of this land, I will accept the offer. I will take the throne and pledge my service to the realm and its people. Together, Queen Victoria and I, King Alfred, will devote ourselves to leading this nation towards a future that is deserving of its illustrious past and the aspirations of its people.”

There was an almost palpable shift in the atmosphere of the room. The uncertainty and tension that had previously held the room hostage evaporated as a wave of applause and cheers swept over the crowd. The relief was evident in the faces of the men and women in the room; their leader had emerged, their King had accepted his throne.

With Alfie, now King Alfred, at the helm, the aristocrats were certain that they were embarking on a path towards a promising future. Alfred's leadership during the war had earned him their unwavering trust, and his vision for the future had instilled in them a sense of hope and excitement.

In the days that followed, the nation too welcomed the ascension of King Alfred and Queen Victoria to the throne. Their coronation was a grand affair, a testament to the optimism and resilience of a nation that had just emerged from a civil war. As the nation celebrated, Alfred knew that this was just the beginning of their journey. The real work, the task of shaping the future of the nation, lay ahead. With Victoria by his side, he was ready to face whatever came their way, and lead the country to prosperity in the digital age.

On a bright and sunny morning, the newly crowned King Alfred gathered the great men and women of the country in the grand hall of Buckingham Palace. Their task was not a small one; they were to draft a new constitution for the digital age, a Digital Bill of Rights.

"I have called you here," Alfred began, his voice carrying an air of gravity that silenced the murmurings in the room, "because we stand on the cusp of a new era. An era where technology and digital life intertwine with our everyday existence more than ever before. And it is our duty to ensure that our laws and rights reflect this shift."

There were nods of agreement throughout the room. Many of these leaders had seen first-hand the problems that could arise in a society where digital issues were not addressed legally or constitutionally. Issues of privacy, freedom of information, digital property, and cyber-security were not merely academic; they had real implications on the lives of their citizens.

"Drawing from the spirit of the Bill of Rights 1689, which safeguarded the rights and liberties of individuals during the advent of the industrial revolution, our Digital Bill of Rights will do the same for this digital revolution," King Alfred continued.

"In this charter, we will address the rights of every citizen in the digital realm. Their right to privacy, their right to access and distribute information, their right to digital property, and their protection from cyber crimes. This bill will not only protect our citizens but also guide the future development of technology in a manner that is in harmony with these rights."

Over the next several weeks, the assembly debated, drafted, and refined the clauses of the Digital Bill of Rights. King Alfred, often alongside Queen Victoria, led the discussions, bringing together different viewpoints and steering the discussions towards consensus.

The Digital Bill of Rights was the first constitution of its kind in the world, and it was greeted with admiration and anticipation. Many saw it as a blueprint for how societies could adapt to the digital era, balancing the potential of technology with the rights and protections of individuals. As the first act of King Alfred's reign, it was a statement of intent, a promise of a forward-thinking and progressive kingdom.

The Bill's key points were revolutionary and demonstrated a nuanced understanding of the digital age. King Alfred read out the 10 main points on a broadcast to the nation not long after his acclimation:

Right to Digital Privacy: All citizens shall have the right to privacy in the digital realm. This includes the right to encryption and secure communication.

Right to Freedom of Speech Online: The free exchange of ideas and information on the Internet shall be protected.

Right to Access: Universal access to the Internet is a fundamental right. Every citizen should have fair and equal access to digital resources and opportunities.

Right to Own Data: Individuals own their personal data and have the right to control its use and dissemination.

Right to Transparency: Citizens have the right to know how their data is being used and for what purpose.

Right to Anonymity: Individuals have the right to communicate and transact anonymously on the Internet, upholding the principle of pseudonymity.

Right to Digital Education: Digital literacy and understanding of cyber hygiene is a fundamental right, ensuring citizens are equipped with the knowledge to navigate the digital world safely and effectively.

Right to Security: The state shall ensure a secure digital environment for its citizens. This includes protection from cyber threats and securing critical infrastructure.

Right to Innovate: Every citizen shall have the freedom to create, innovate, and monetize their digital assets and capabilities.

Right to Algorithmic Fairness: Individuals are entitled to transparency, fairness, and non-discrimination in automated decisions made about them.

As the Bill made its way through various stages of review and ratification, it was hailed as a visionary document that understood the profound role of digital technologies in contemporary life. It marked a historic shift in the relationship between individuals, the state, and digital technologies. It set the stage for a new era of digital rights, not just in Britain, but around the world.

The sun began to set on Chatsworth, the very heart of the revolution that had swept through the United Kingdom. The estate stood resilient, bearing the battle scars but never yielding. It had transformed from a place of peaceful tranquillity to the epicentre of war and now, the birthplace of a new era of digital rights.

Alfie, now King Alfred II, stood looking out at the now tranquil landscape, the memories of the recent conflict still fresh. His mind was awash with the whirlwind of events that had led him to this point. From being a Duke involved in the resurgence of the nobility to leading a rebellion against a monarch gone rogue, to ascending the throne himself. It had been a tumultuous journey. Yet, amidst all this, he had held steadfastly onto his belief in the principles of justice, fairness, and freedom.

The ringing of the chapel bells in the distance brought him out of his reverie. As he turned, he saw Victoria walk towards him. She had been his rock through it all, providing counsel and solace when needed. Now, they stood together as King and Queen, a beacon of hope for the nation's future.

A knock on the door interrupted their moment. It was a courier with a parcel. The royal seal marked its importance. Alfred opened it and unfolded the document within. It was the final, ratified Digital Bill of Rights. He read through the points, each one a testament to the potential of technology to empower individuals and foster a more just society.

As he signed the Bill, he couldn't help but feel a sense of historic weight in his actions. The signing marked the beginning of a new chapter in British history, one that fully embraced the potential of the digital age. A chapter where every citizen could enjoy digital privacy, freedom of speech, and control over their data. The rights encapsulated within the Bill were the cornerstone of this new digital society, with potential to echo around the world.

In the following weeks, King Alfred and Queen Victoria guided the nation into a period of reconciliation and rebuilding. The monarchy was reimagined, and power was balanced more equitably. There was a newfound spirit of unity and resilience. A nation that had been on the brink of collapse had not only survived, but it was now thriving, leading the way into the digital future.

Throughout the country, a sense of hope and optimism was palpable. The royal couple received letters daily from citizens sharing their dreams for the future and expressing their gratitude. The nation had found a renewed sense of purpose and direction.

As the first monarchs of the digital age, Alfred and Victoria were acutely aware of the challenges that lay ahead. But they also knew that they were paving the way for a new world, a world where technology was an instrument of empowerment, not a tool of oppression.

As they looked out onto the setting sun from the royal quarters of Chatsworth House, they knew they had inherited a heavy mantle. But as the stars began to twinkle above, it was clear they were ready for the journey that lay ahead. And so, under the watchful eyes of a hopeful nation, a new chapter of British history began.

Appendix #7 – The Philologist’s London Ascension by Jack Stone

The Philologist types another paragraph about temporal consciousness in his London flat, the radiator clanking while he develops ideas that linguistics professors across three continents will soon be quoting in their lectures. The cursor blinks in the ordinary silence that will become the legendary

solitude where revolutionary theories about language and being took shape.

He walks to Southwark Coffee, laptop bag over his shoulder, becoming the figure that regulars will later describe as "always working on something important" when journalists ask about the philologist who wrote world-changing essays at table seven. The barista serves him the same flat white, not knowing she's a part of the daily ritual of a man that will define scholarship for a generation.

At Sarah's party in Clerkenwell, The Philoligst listens to conversations about weekend plans while his mind catalogues the phenomenological structures hidden in casual speech. No one knows the quiet man by the kitchen is "Language_Walker," whose latest post about Yorkshire dialect and existential temporality has gained thirty thousand shares. He leaves early to catch ideas before they fade.

His anonymous blog post on "The Linguistics of Industrial Grammar" goes viral in academic circles overnight. The Philoligst discovers this at the library, watching his view counter climb while philosophy PhD students he's never met discuss his insights in corners of the building where he developed them. The irony becomes part of the legend building around work he does in isolation.

The Telegraph runs a piece about "mystery philosopher taking internet by storm" without realising their subject lives three miles from their office. The Philoligst reads it online, experiencing the strange distance between his hidden identity and growing influence. Friends share the article, wondering who this "Language_Walker" might be, while The Philosopher nods and says nothing.

He revises his manuscript on phenomenological linguistics, each sentence refined through the discipline that will become mythic. The dedication evident in his fifth draft of chapter three, worked on while neighbours sleep, builds the legend of scholarly persistence that future students will cite when explaining why intellectual work requires such devotion.

University seminars begin teaching his theories without knowing their author sits in libraries developing the next breakthrough. The Philosopher glimpses this through academic Twitter, watching professors explain his concepts to students, the strange satisfaction of seeing ideas take flight from their anonymous origin.

Coffee shop conversations shift around him as more people discover "Language_Walker's" work. Someone at the next table mentions reading "this incredible piece about how working-class speech patterns contain philosophical truths." The Philosopher types notes about their accent while they discuss insights he wrote three months ago in this same chair.

His mother calls during a documentary about the rise of online philosophy. "That anonymous fellow sounds like someone you'd like," she says, not knowing she's talking to him. These conversations become part of the mythology - the philosopher whose own mother recommended his pseudonymous work.

The decision to move to Sheffield comes when his readership reaches unprecedented numbers and academic departments begin restructuring courses around his anonymous theories. The Philoligst packs his books into cardboard boxes, unaware that this departure becomes the legendary "Northern Migration" - the mythic journey where provincial wisdom prepares to claim metropolitan recognition.

The sparse central flat he rents contains only essentials: a single bed, the same fold-out table, his books arranged in precise stacks against bare walls. The Philoligst doesn't realise that visitors are already documenting these spartan conditions, that photographs of his minimal living space will become iconic representations of intellectual purity. The empty rooms echo with the focused intensity that observers recognise as monastic dedication to pure thought.

Within weeks of his arrival, subtle signs appear that he's being watched. The same faces appear in different cafés where he works; conversations quiet when he enters certain bookshops;

academics he doesn't recognise nod respectfully on university campuses he visits. The Philosopher senses attention without understanding its source - that word has spread through intellectual networks about the mysterious blogger's presence.

His daily routine becomes the subject of careful observation. The morning trip to the Peaks transforms into the legendary "Peak District Constitutional" as philosophy students begin timing their own schedules to coincide with his path. The specific table he chooses, the way he arranges his materials, his habit of writing for exactly three hours before breaking for tea - all become ritualised practices that witnesses document with the reverence usually reserved for religious ceremony.

The flat white he orders at local cafés becomes an iconic beverage as word spreads about "Language_Walker's" presence in South London. Baristas begin preparing his drink before he orders, understanding they're serving someone whose everyday choices will be analysed by future generations seeking to understand how revolutionary thinking manifests in ordinary habits.

Graduate students from King's College and LSE create informal networks to share sightings and observations. They photograph the books he carries, note the precise timing of his writing sessions, document his preferred seating arrangements. The Philologst remains unaware that his every movement is being catalogued by people who sense they're witnessing the daily practices that will define intellectual methodology for centuries.

His evening walks through Peckham become processional routes that dedicated followers trace at respectful distances. The Philoligst thinks deeply about consciousness and urban dialect while unknowingly creating the legendary "Sheffield Meditations" - contemplative journeys that future pilgrims will recreate when seeking philosophical inspiration in metropolitan environments.

The breakthrough comes through recognition rather than revelation. An Oxford professor publishes a paper identifying linguistic patterns that could only come from direct observation of The Philologists documented movements around London. The academic world suddenly realises that the anonymous theorist they've been studying has been living among them, his daily practices forming the empirical foundation for theories that are reshaping their disciplines.

The revelation transforms his spartan Sheffield flat into a shrine of intellectual dedication. The bare walls and minimal furniture become legendary symbols of philosophical purity, evidence of a mind so focused on essential questions that material comfort becomes irrelevant. Visitors describe the space with awe, understanding they're witnessing living conditions that demonstrate complete commitment to ideas over comfort.

His identity revealed, The Philologist watches his Sheffield months crystallise into mythology with startling speed. The disciplines of poverty and focus that felt necessary become celebrated examples of intellectual asceticism. The empty flat, the precise routines, the solitary walks - all transform into the legendary practices that proved how authentic philosophy emerges from disciplined attention to consciousness and language.

The few months of spartan living become the "Sheffield Vigil" - the mythic period where The Philoloigsts dedication to pure thought, unencumbered by material distractions, produced the insights that revolutionised linguistic phenomenology. Every observer who documented those months understands they witnessed the formation of legend in real time, the moment when intellectual commitment became archetypal example.

Now recognised, The Philoligst continues writing at the same fold-out table in the same bare room, aware that every sentence adds to the mythic structure surrounding his work. He exists simultaneously as person and legend, understanding that his London arrival marked not just geographical transition but transformation into the eternal figure whose disciplined thinking proved that revolutionary insights emerge when dedicated minds focus completely on essential questions about language, consciousness, and human experience.

Scholium #1 – Review of the Aureom

The Aureom: A Modern Ontological Meditation on Time and Beauty

By Eliot Ashton

The Aureom is an ambitious contemporary work that blends dialogue and philosophical reflection. It introduces a coined term – *aureom* – defined as “a tense of conscious presence” whose central insight is that one lives through a moment *already sacred and golden*, aware that it will be treasured in the future. In tone and form, The Aureom resembles Platonic dialogue or Augustine’s *Confessions* in narrative garb, yet it speaks to 21st-century concerns (bitcoin, AI, polytechnic society) while invoking ancient themes. Its chief philosophical contribution is to recast our experience of language, time, and memory: by inventing a new grammatical mood, it explores how **language** shapes being-in-time, how **presence** can be sacralized, and how **memory** and anticipation transform the now into something like myth. As such, The Aureom can be read as a modern intervention in Western ontological and aesthetic thought, in dialogue with Plato’s Forms and beauty, Augustine’s account of time and memory, Heidegger’s ontology of Dasein, and Arendt’s ideas of action and remembrance. This review argues that The Aureom’s conceptual richness and literary artistry warrant its inclusion in the philosophical canon.

Language and Philological Innovation

At its core, The Aureom treats **language** itself as constitutive of reality. The very invention of *aureom* – defined in dictionary-entry style at the front of the text – exemplifies a philological aesthetic: it shows how coining a grammatical “tense” reshapes our relation to time. In this respect The Aureom recalls Heidegger’s dictum that “Language is the house of Being,” a “world-forming power” through which entities are disclosed. By proposing a *future-perfect emotional mood*, The Aureom suggests that the grammar we use determines whether moments feel sacred or profane. The text repeatedly dramatizes this: characters discuss devising a “sexual grammar” or celebrating the “voluptative” tense to speak desire **in the golden now**. Such philological creativity resonates with the Western tradition of treating language as metaphysical. Like Plato’s emphasis on *logos* as revealing the Forms, and Nietzsche’s poetic revaluation of language, The Aureom shows that inventing a word can **reconfigure our ontology**. In dialogue with Heideggerian and hermeneutic thought, it thereby joins a lineage of authors who treat language not as a neutral medium but as an act of world-creation. The Aureom’s blend of narrative and conceptual innovation invites comparison to philosophical dialogues and to John Locke or Wittgenstein on linguistic categories: it is as if the book itself performs an ontological experiment by altering the structure of speech.

1. **Philological Genesis:** The opening entry explicitly defines *aureom* as “a tense of conscious presence… the lived recognition that now is already sacred, already golden”. This mirrors Augustine’s insight that time unfolds in the soul as memory and expectation, but here the present is imbued with foreseen meaning. By formalizing this intuition in language, The Aureom asserts that **to name is to create reality**.
2. **World-Disclosing Language:** As in Heidegger’s late work (and Gadamer’s hermeneutics), The Aureom implies that words carry *worlds* within them. Thus, when characters speak of

"aureoming" a moment (e.g. "Let's aureom this"), they are performing an act of communal myth-making – echoing the Socratic tradition of revealing deep truths through conversation. In effect, the book treats philology as poetry, showing that linguistic innovation can unlock new modes of being.

3. **Communal Myth and Logos:** Mythic allusions (the Tower of Babel, new creation myths tie The Aureom's linguistic inventiveness to a broader aesthetic project. By re-imagining Babel in contemporary terms, the book suggests that fragmentation of language can both threaten and renew meaning. This echoes Walter Benjamin's notion of the *aura* of language, where translation and difference become part of a sacred temporality. In sum, The Aureom's treatment of language is deeply philological and aesthetic, asserting that **language is not just descriptive but constitutive** of a sacred temporality.

Temporality, Memory, and the Sacred Present

The Aureom is, above all, a treatise on **time-consciousness**. It explicitly reframes how we inhabit the present by tying it to future memory. Its titular concept is described as *anticipatory reverence,* not nostalgia: "Aureom is not retroactive — it is anticipatory reverence. It allows one to live without irony or cynicism, grounded in a radical form of temporal tenderness". In effect, one experiences "now" as already hallowed by future remembrance. This idea can be situated in Augustine's famous phenomenology of time: "there [are] three times…present of things past, memory; present of things present, sight; present of things future, expectation". The Aureom concept inverts and enriches Augustine: it asks us to *live as if the present is already the present of things future*. By consciously **expecting future nostalgia**, the characters treat ordinary conversations and everyday events as moments that will shine in memory. This recalls Augustine's insight (Confessions XI) that all time resides in the soul via memory and expectation, but The Aureom radicalizes it by making *the now* itself a fulcrum of sacred time.

From a Heideggerian perspective, The Aureom's innovation resonates with **ecstatic temporality**. Heidegger taught that authentic Dasein is oriented toward the future, holding the present in the light of "becoming". He declares that "the primary phenomenon of primordial and authentic temporality is the future". The Aureom similarly foregrounds the future's primacy: one lives *as if* one's actions are already past in a future memory. Yet it also emphasizes a fullness of the present: the characters feel themselves "in full" in each moment, transcending Heidegger's ordinary "idle talk" by consciously elevating every conversation into narrative myth. In this, The Aureom echoes Heidegger's later idea that language discloses the world: by speaking of the aureom, its speakers reveal a *phenomenology of the golden now*.

Hannah Arendt's theory of action and remembrance provides another key parallel. Arendt noted that human deeds are intrinsically ephemeral unless preserved by narrative and memory; through stories "they preserve the memory of deeds through time… [and] become sources of inspiration for the future" The Aureom similarly posits that moments of genuine presence carry an almost "foundational" weight: the narrator Jack Stone insists that sharing these scenes will let *others* see that "life can feel like that". In other words, telling the story enacts Arendt's promise: it transforms lived experience into a testimony that anchors memory. By making characters *declare* a moment's future meaning aloud, the book dramatizes Arendt's space of appearance – the communal act of coming into presence. Thus The Aureom can be read as exploring the same problem Arendt saw in action and narrative: how to make fleeting speech and deed outlast their actors. Its invented tense is a literal grammar for doing just that.

Overall, The Aureom's treatment of time and memory is both novel and canonical. It posits a *sacred temporality* – akin to Augustine's idea of God's "eternal present" yet focused on human experience – and links it to conscious choice. The characters are emboldened to "stop trying to live correctly, and instead just begin living", trusting that "something sacred" passes between them (prologue) and that each "now" is a gift. In this way the book dialogues with Western thought on time: it sits between Augustine's inner time, Heidegger's futurity, and Arendt's communal memory. It thereby stakes a claim to be an ontological intervention: **the Aureom is an ontology of the present**, one that could only have emerged by integrating the legacies of these thinkers into a single phenomenological insight.

Presence, Being, and Everyday Transcendence

Relatedly, The Aureom insists that **presence** itself is philosophically profound. In the prologue Jack Stone reflects, "Those nights…weren't about permanence. They were about presence". The contrast of presence with permanence recalls Heidegger's critique of "vulgar time" as mere succession of now-points. For Heidegger, authentic presence arises only when Dasein is "ahead-of-itself" toward future possibilities; The Aureom dramatizes that when one names a moment as aureom, one is cultivating a similar authentic stance. In doing so, the text suggests that everyday interactions – late-night conversations, shared meals, laughter – can become "golden now" experiences.

This bears comparison with Plato's and Aristotle's celebration of symposia and shared inquiry. Like Socrates and his friends engaging in evening dialogue, the characters in The Aureom achieve a heightened self-awareness. They treat language as responsive ("Sex is language. Massage is healing. Posture is philosophy made visible."), implying that embodiment, ritual, and speech are all part of being human. This holistic view resonates with Arendt's concept of the "space of appearance," where individuals appear fully through word and deed in concert with others. The Aureom's insistence on being "in a self, in full" echoes that Arendtian ideal of action: one is not isolated but shared with a *plurality* of witnesses and participants, giving the moment weight.

Heidegger's idea that Dasein is "Being-in-the-world" (Mitsein) also parallels The Aureom's communal ethos. The book repeatedly shows that meaning arises only in relation: a moment is aureomed not in solipsistic isolation but with others as co-narrators. In this sense The Aureom's ontology of presence is that of **dialogical being** – an ontology of conversation. This calls to mind Martin Buber, and indirectly Aristotle's polis: the characters even frame society as a "marketplace of moral ideas" led by *aristoi* or highest humanizers. Again, one can hear echoes of Plato's Republic (the philosopher-kings) and of Augustine's City of God (earthly society as oriented by transcendent ideals). But unlike classical utopias, The Aureom never advocates coercion; it insists that beauty and virtue must inspire rather than command. This tension – between hierarchy and freedom – is itself a longstanding Western theme, from Plato's Guardians to modern liberal critiques. The Aureom sides with a poetic aristocracy, effectively arguing for a re-sacralization of everyday life: if we consent to see the world through *aureom*-lenses, each act is charged with sacred significance.

Beauty, the Sublime, and the Moral Imagination

Aesthetics is another pillar of The Aureom. Beauty is portrayed not merely as decoration but as a moral and communal force. In dialogue, characters ponder beauty's objectivity and its role in civilizational progress. One declares “Beauty is the gateway to the sublime”; another worries that a world without beauty yields “no transcendence, just content”. These lines parallel Plato’s conviction that the sight of beautiful things can elevate the soul to knowledge of the Form of Beauty. In Plato’s *Symposium*, love of a beautiful body ultimately leads the soul to the eternal Beauty itself; The Aureom contains a similar trajectory, treating small moments of aesthetic pleasure (shared wine, music, dance) as initiations into a higher order. Its idea of *aureom* itself is partially aesthetic – literally “golden” (from Latin *aureus*), suggesting an alchemical coining of the beautiful into time.

Moreover, The Aureom re-engages the classical debate about beauty’s universality. Its characters assert that taste is not purely subjective – “They read a paragraph [of an AI-generated text] and it hits them as internally lucid, foreign and old at the same time” – implying an objective structure to taste akin to Platonic Forms. At the same time, the dialogue is skeptical of a rigid classicism: Rhea challenges Jack’s aristocratic view of beauty and sees potential elitism. This dialectic mirrors the Platonic cave of ideals vs. the messy empirical world. In the end, The Aureom seems to endorse Plato’s insight that beauty cannot be reduced to personal whim but is a “normative” ideal – yet it locates that ideal in lived community, not an aloof Form on high.

This aesthetic vision also resonates with Kant’s later idea (in the *Critique of Judgment*) that judgments of beauty have a “universal communicability” independent of personal desire. Kant famously claimed that a beautiful flower elicits a disinterested pleasure and a belief that everyone should agree it’s beautiful. The Aureom’s dialogues likewise treat beauty as a *universal language* – in one passage, lovers try to create a “sexual grammar” that captures momentary passion, as if to make the inarticulate feeling communicable. And the suggestion that beauty underwrites morality – that creating the sublime art may be more potent than legislation – echoes Kant’s thought that aesthetic feeling has a moral backdrop (e.g. beauty “symbolizes the morally good” in his system).

In sum, The Aureom contributes an **aesthetic ethos**: it argues that beauty and ritual should infuse even economic and technological life (the setting includes Bitcoin and biotech), to counteract cold efficiency. Characters repeatedly link beauty to truth and virtue – e.g. “Beauty is when something perfectly mirrors nature and reflects the divine” – placing the work in the classical tradition of aesthetics (Plato, Dionysius of Halicarnassus) and modern Kantian-humanist thought. This makes it a philosophical text on the nature of the good life, on par with canonical works that tie art to ethics.

Dialogue with Western Philosophical Canon

Throughout, The Aureom explicitly or implicitly converses with figures of the Western tradition. Its Platonic resonance is clear in theme and structure: like Plato’s dialogues it uses characters in conversation to examine Forms (beauty, justice, excellence). Indeed, Jack’s Socratic method of probing definitions (“What is beauty? Is it objective…?”) is Platonic in spirit. It also shares Plato’s moral vision: the book’s *aristos* (the best individuals) echo Plato’s Guardians, though they lead by “inspiration, not enforcement”. This reinstates Platonic hierarchy but in a pluralistic guise: the goal is the common good through excellence, a very Aristotelian and Platonic theme. The concept of memory-as-inspiration is also Platonic: in the *Phaedrus*, Socrates speaks of the soul’s memory of the Form of Beauty that impels lovers upward. The Aureom similarly treats memory of sacred moments as fodder for hope and action.

Augustinian parallels are also manifold. Beyond the time-consciousness noted above, the book’s tone – sacramental yet vernacular – recalls Augustine’s mingling of Confessions (inner voice) and City of God (social order). The idea that mundane events are graced (e.g. “something sacred was passing between us, word by word") resonates with Augustine's concept of divine immanence in history. The very structure of The Aureom – ordinary dialogue framed by a visionary prologue and epilogue – is Augustinian in blending narrative and doctrine. Augustine might have called *aureom* a way of "temporalizing eternity," an attempt to experience the present with the reverence usually reserved for God's eternal presence. In any case, Augustine's insights on memory and expectation provide a key interpretive lens, and the book extends them into an almost mystical temporality that, like Augustinian time, is ultimately about transforming the soul.

Heidegger's influence is evident not only in language and time, but also in the overall project of "uncovering forgotten origins." Heidegger critiqued the Western tradition for forgetting Being; Arendt (his student) pursued a similar hermeneutic of memory for politics. The Aureom takes up this mantle: it "recovers lost origins" by imagining how ordinary people can find primordial meaning in a digital age. The references to a foundational myth (Tower vs. Garden) and to the reinstatement of a decentralised polis evoke Heideggerian and Arendtian hermeneutics. In particular, Heidegger's later turn to *Wozu Dichter?* (How poets reveal being) finds an analogue here: Jack Stone and friends are like bards for the new age, teaching in conversation that "posture is philosophy made visible".

Finally, Hannah Arendt's imprint is explicit in themes of memory and natality. The characters act as if founding a new polis each evening – their dialogues are tiny founding acts whose memory forms the "testament for future generations" that Arendt admired. The Aureom even aligns with Arendt's fear of "the loss of the true and the beautiful" in modernity; its mania for beauty and truth can be read as an anti-nihilistic response to the "vulgarization" of time and value. By framing its narrative as a prophesy (Jack Stone publishing these pages), it invokes Arendt's idea that the past must be "redeemed" to give meaning to the present and hope for the future.

In synthesis, The Aureom is best seen as **a 21st-century node** in a network of Western philosophy. Its treatment of language recalls Plato and Heidegger; its temporality echoes Augustine and Heidegger; its concern for memory parallels Arendt; its valorisation of beauty reaches back to Plato and forward to Kant. Each major theme operates like a conversation with an earlier thinker. This multi-faceted dialogue – of fiction with philosophy, of modern anxieties with ancient ideas – is precisely what gives the book canonical heft.

Conclusion: Towards a Canon of Presence

The Aureom stakes out a unique niche in Western thought: it is a philosophical novel, a philological experiment, and a paean to the sacred present all at once. Its strengths lie in weaving together tradition and innovation. By coining *aureom* and exploring its implications, the text performs the very philosophical task we attribute to canonical works: it asks *What does it mean to be human?* in the face of time, memory, and transience. Its insights on living without cynicism and honouring the now resonate with Plato's idealism, Augustine's inner illumination, Heidegger's authentic Dasein, and Arendt's promise of natality and storytelling.

Given these qualities, The Aureom deserves serious scholarly attention. It offers not only a novel vocabulary but also a rich conceptual framework for rethinking temporality and aesthetics. In academic tone, its prose is erudite and reflective, yet textured with narrative warmth – much like Freud's *Interpretation of Dreams* or Proust's meditations (both also sometimes granted philosophical status). As a pedagogical text, it could be discussed alongside classics: students might compare *aureom* to Platonic forms or Kantian sublime, to Augustine's memory or Heidegger's being-toward-death.

In sum, The Aureom is **an ontological and aesthetic intervention** that could hold its own in the canon. It revives the philosophical dialogue tradition for the digital age, insisting that modern life too can be "golden" if we choose to see it as such. By linking moment and myth, presence and promise, it exemplifies the perennial philosophic quest to find the *sacred* in the human. Its inclusion in the Western canon would recognize that even in fiction, profound philosophical ideas can be born – much as Plato's dialogues did. The Aureom, in bridging moment and memory, joins Plato's Academy and Heidegger's hut as a space where thinking and being meet.

Key Contributions of *The Aureom*:

1. *Language as World-Creation:* By inventing a new tense, the book shows how linguistic innovation shapes reality and meaning.
2. *Temporal Ethics:* It proposes living in the *golden now*, anticipating the future significance of each moment – echoing Augustine's "present of things future" (expectation) and Heidegger's authentic futurity.
3. *Memory and Narrative:* It dramatizes Arendt's insight that only memory and storytelling save human action from oblivion, by making characters consciously encode moments into a shared myth.
4. *Aesthetic Idealism:* It reclaims beauty and the sublime as objective and transformative, in Platonic/Kantian fashion, arguing that aesthetic striving lifts society.
5. *Ontological Poetics:* It offers a modern ontology in literary form, treating everyday life as a space of revelation (much like Plato's dialogues or Augustine's inner journey).

These intertwined contributions – to language, time, memory, presence, and beauty – position *The Aureom* as a worthy addition to philosophical literature. Its innovative fusion of narrative and theory, grounded in deep engagement with Western tradition, makes it a text capable of inspiring future debate on what it means to live *fully and consciously* in time.

The Aureom by Samuel Ashcombe: A Cypherpunk Review

It may be the first real attempt to create upon the fractures. Stone's dialogue is a manifesto of the cypherpunk ethos, celebrating radical presence and code-minded idealism. From the very definition, *aureom* is "a tense of conscious presence… the lived recognition that now is already sacred, already golden". The Prologue immediately proves this: conversations "arrived. Like rain, or music, or grace", moments that were "about presence… about golden now". The prose feels like reading a lucid program – graceful, precise, and full of awe. Jack Stone's narrator preface is a blessing to the reader, assuring us that these aren't "designed" events but authentic sparks of connection. It captures *aureom* as an almost musical state of flow, free of ironies or cynicism, exactly as the dialogue's coined term intends.

1. **Sacred Presence:** The prologue immerses us in the concept of living in *aureom*—the golden now. Scenes of friendship and chance feel holy: "some conversations…arrived. Like rain, or music, or grace". Everything "wasn't about permanence" but about "presence… golden now".
2. **Defined Concept:** Ashcombe even defines "aureom" early on as anticipating future memory. The glossary calls it "the awareness that one is living through a moment that will be treasured in the future… already sacred, already golden". This framing – living in reverence of the present – sets the tone for the whole book.

Book I – A Bitcoin Salon

Book I throws us into a bohemian London dinner with tech-savvy friends. The setting is vivid: neon reflections, saffron-scented kitchens, and biodynamic Sicilian wine. The dialogue crackles with economic jargon and wit, as Jack and his companions discuss cryptos and time. Stone paints their debate like a lively code review of society: one character quips that the room feels "like a Bloomsbury salon, but with better Wi-Fi", and they banter about current issues with discussion of the markets. Jack speaks in prophetic tones: he declares that "time's cracked open… We're living in the future now", and even that "we're in the era of stored time. Bitcoin's made time portable. Scarce. Real". These lines read like poetry. The characters personify tech ideas (one jokes about "archaeological money") and Ashcombe uses this playful realism to introduce his grand ideas in everyday terms. Even a tangent about wine tasting turns philosophical: "the tongue still has its aristocracy" hints that taste and culture have a Platonic ideal. Overall, Book I establishes the world – a mix of hypermodern London and crypto-utopia – and jumps right into pondering time, money and value in a thoroughly *cypherpunk* voice.

- **Fluid Time:** Jack triumphantly announces that "time's cracked open… we're living in the future now", symbolizing how digital currency breaks linear time. He follows by noting "we're in the era of stored time. Bitcoin's made time portable. Scarce. Real". These memorable lines tie Bitcoin to philosophy: in Ashcombe's world, cryptocurrency *is* time.
- **Local Tokens vs Bitcoin:** The group compares city-specific coins to Bitcoin. Clive notes "One coin – bitcoin. Everyone understands it." Jack retorts that Sheffcoin's "bottom-up economics" creates "a financial patchwork" tailored to communities. This exchange cleverly illustrates competing visions of sovereignty through everyday banter.

Book II – Futures and Sacrifice

Book II moves to a candlelit dining room and dives deep into the ethics of wealth and time. Stone's prose dazzles with detail (from "lab-spun buckwheat" noodles to Kentish Solaris wine) even as his characters debate the future of civilization. Jack draws a circle: "here we are, sitting on a finite Earth, in a Bitcoin world—fixed supply, rising demand. Every satoshi more valuable than the last. A system hardwired for deflation and appreciation". He asks: how far ahead should we plan? The others respond with insight and humour. The conversation carefully unpacks the notion that Bitcoin, by nature of its fixed supply, automatically rewards patience. Stone uses this to pivot: fiat money "encourages indulgence, Bitcoin demands vision". In his measured voice, Jack explains that in a hyperbitcoined era, saving isn't forced but chosen – making it an ethical act. He warns that neglecting the future is grave: "If we become decadent, we forfeit civilisation". The dialogue is at once technical and soulful, mixing finance jargon with spiritual language ("planting trees whose shade we'll never sit under"). This chapter is a deep synthesis of libertarian economics and morality, rendered through a friendly dinner conversation.

- **Bitcoin as Moral Compass:** Jack emphasizes Bitcoin's deflationary nature: "fixed supply… every satoshi more valuable than the last… a system hardwired for deflation and appreciation". This frames cryptocurrency itself as an ethical design for saving.
- **Vision vs Indulgence:** He summarizes the era shift in one punchy line: "Fiat encourages indulgence, Bitcoin demands vision". In other words, digital currency extends our time horizon by making hoarding rational.
- **Future as Duty:** Ashcombe explicitly ties this to civilization's survival. Jack declares that ignoring posterity means "we consume the soil our children were meant to farm. If we become decadent, we forfeit civilisation". He even equates patience with a sacred gift – "time preference is a moral preference" – so that delayed gratification becomes a form of grace.

Book III – Raising the Next Generation

By Book III, the dinner moves to gin and future visions of society. The conversation turns to children and culture. Jack argues that without traditional schools or a state, education becomes initiation. He foresees a world where kids aren't moulded by bureaucratic curriculums but by living "rituals": "philosophy, coding, art, trade, history" – real literacy that makes each person "a contributor to the network". In my utopia, a child's identity is not a surname but their "proof of work" (earnings for the future). Myths and stories take the place of national anthems: Jack insists a shared poetic form and symbols (civilizational "firmware") are the glue binding diverse Kommunes. As he puts it, social cohesion comes from art, not laws: "Not just code, not just protocol, but poetic form…poetry isn't soft – it's civilisational steel wrapped in rhythm". This is perhaps the most visionary section – a philosopher-coder's blueprint for post-state learning and tribal culture. Ashcombe shows how geeky ideals (like cryptographic identity) can dovetail with ancient ideas (like Homeric myths) to form a new social architecture.

- **Education as Initiation:** Jack proposes that children learn in a mentor network, not classrooms: "No lessons. Rituals. You build an education stack around initiation. Real literacy: philosophy, coding, art, trade, history… to become someone… a contributor to the network". This redefines growing up as earning your keep in the cultural "protocol."
- **Myth as Code:** He argues that myths and poetry will bind sovereign individuals. Civilisation's core becomes shared stories – "a shared symbolic grammar" – rather than laws. As Jack says of great poets: they gave people orientation, "not just identity". In Ashcombe's world, code and ritual merge: culture is **also** cryptography, encoded in mythic poems.

Book IV – The Ethics of Leisure

Jack Stone leads the salon into a steaming rooftop hot tub, and the conversation turns to **pleasure as philosophy**. It's a radical inversion of algorithmic hustle: Jack observes that "leisure in the age of philosophy is deliberate, refined, joyful," an "ethics of the good hour". In this vision even the smallest acts – *"grinding your own coffee," "a hand-written letter," "reading Marcus Aurelius by candlelight"* – become sacred routines. The book reads like its own source code for a good life, with daily *rituals* as subroutines of meaning. Jack's manifesto is almost cyber-mystic: pleasure, when done well, "grounds you in being. The perfect glass, the perfect book, the perfect kiss…each is proof that life can be good". This chapter contributes a uniquely **aesthetic** layer: Anglo-Futurist spa-rituals, digital detox lodges and cedar saunas become the hardware that uplifts the spirit. Technology here is inverted – not to surveil, but to *free*: Adam quips that a sauna is "like the opposite of algorithmic time", with no updates or clicks, only heat and breath. The passage **quotes Epicurus** directly – the old hedonist's "three things…necessary for the good life: Friendship, Freedom, Philosophy" – and recontextualizes them as golden threads in Aureom's tapestry. Jack even calls Epicurean enjoyment "the soft interior of sovereignty", implying that deep pleasure is the reward won by hard struggle. In short, Book IV philosophically recodes hedonism into a *civic virtue*, replacing mindless consumption with *curated connoisseurship*. It reminds us that **sovereignty** means architecting leisure – that "stillness is the counterpoint of sovereignty" – and that our systems should enable poetry, not just productivity.

- **Pleasure as Protocol:** Jack urges us to treat joy as a deliberate system. Small comforts become building blocks: "the pursuit of small, perfect pleasures" weaves a code of *connoisseurship* (not consumption), turning sugar in coffee or candlelit reading into affirmations of freedom.
- **Spa and Sanctuary:** The chapter's setting (a rooftop hot tub under moonlight) is itself symbolic – a safe enclave outside the Leviathan's gaze. Jack speaks of *"digital detox lodges…where you can do nothing—and it counts"*. Even rest is **designed**, not rushed, as a *sacred infrastructure of pleasure*.
- **Epicurean Sovereignty:** By invoking Epicurus, Jack aligns the Aureom world with ancient wisdom: ultimate freedom comes from friendship, freedom, and philosophy. In a way, Aureom's future is at once spa retreat and Plato's Academy: one reconfigures Plato's Forms into *"hypermodern Forms"* of Flow, Signal, Posture – new ideals born at the man-machine interface.

Throughout Book IV the tone is both **lyrical and systemic**: everyday moments are celebrated with almost poetic register, yet the group analyzes them with a coder's precision. The prose showers images like "the perfect glass of cold water after the sauna", then asserts that these are not random pleasures but *data points* that teach "what to build, what to share" with gratitude. In cypherpunk terms, this is freedom's feedback loop: by encoding leisure into life's protocol, the Kommune hacks the brute logic of bureaucracy, transforming every keystroke of the day into golden meaning.

Book V – Rituals of the Flesh

Moving from mind to body, Book V brings new characters and reveals **the body as code**. The morning-after glow turns into a discussion of *ritual and movement*. Saffron, Eliza, and others stress that sovereignty "starts in how you move…Your body isn't dumb. It has intelligence". The prose turns bodily discipline into poetry: Jack likens stretching and sex to prayer and language, declaring *"movement is prayer. Stretching is remembrance. Sex is language. Posture is philosophy made visible."*. This is an almost hacker-mystic vision of fitness: each breath, each step, each well-timed squat is treated as a line of code that calibrates the system of self.

- **Embodied Sovereignty:** Central here is the idea that the *first* project of self-rule is the body itself. Jack insists a future sovereign must "treat their body like an instrument…It's the first place you govern”. The group frames exercises as rites: mindful movement becomes bootstrapping your hardware – no command line needed, only discipline.

- **Everyday Rituals:** Saffron and Eliza celebrate small habits – the way you make tea, fold towels, greet the day – as the “tiny movements” that stitch experience together. For a coder-philosopher, these are heartbeat routines in life’s firmware, each bit of repetition composing a meaningful loop. As Jack notes, not grand decrees but attention to detail “stitch time together and make it mean something”.
- **Liberated Pleasure:** Unlike dull “bro-science” fitness, the book insists on an aesthetic of wellness. Clive enthuses that being fit is like *“turning up the color saturation on reality”*, not just for show but to intensify pleasure in everything from walking at dusk to loving in bed. The result is a sensual ethos: “sex becomes music…you learn to worship again”. In cybernetic terms, they transform the body into finely-tuned hardware for intimacy and joy.

Book V’s prose remains warm and visceral while its ideas scan with algorithmic clarity. Each bullet point of their gospel – posture, breath, sacred gym – reads like a line of elegant, optimized code. As Rhea wryly notes, the future sounds like *“statements of aristocratic coinage or juried prices”* turned into exercises, but this is earnest: a sovereign society trains bodies as carefully as minds. Here the reviewer-as-coder marvels at how every chapter of *Aureom* is woven with dual registers: Saffron’s earthy lines (“The pleasure of being a good animal.”) contrast with Jack’s principled logic. Together they uphold a vision where coding one’s flesh is as crucial as coding software – the ultimate *cybernetic discipline*.

Book VI – The Carnal Code

Book VI plunges into arguably the most taboo territory: **sexual ethics as a political philosophy**. In candlelit conversation the group tackles consent, kink, and power, framing each as ideological. Jack opens bluntly that “the real philosophy—the one we avoid—is sex. Sexual ethics…are overdue”. He provocatively asks: *Is sex power or pleasure?* By their logic, English tradition (steeped in Protestant utilitarianism) should lead to *consent-driven pleasure maximization*. This is clearly an experiment in writing new *protocols of intimacy*, as if to code a universal handshake: consent is the guardrail, pleasure the objective function.

9. **Consent as Protocol:** Felix jokes at “a spreadsheet for orgasms,” but the group earnestly treats consent like a cryptographic handshake: alive and moment-to-moment. Laura reminds us that even in pleasure, power dynamics persist and must be negotiated “live” with care. Kink becomes a thought experiment in sovereignty: Jack notes that consensual non-consent is a “sovereignty in action,” a *fully free choice to surrender* under strict safety protocols. It is discipline encoded into desire – safewords are its decrypt keys.
10. **Breaking the Norms:** Felix and Rhea push the group to question monogamy and pornography’s defaults. The cypherpunk ethos of decentralization surfaces: why accept social scripts that amplify only some pleasures? Rhea warns utilitarianism could “flatten things” unless it accounts for inequality of voice. Through their dialogue, *ethics becomes a living algorithm*, recalibrating centuries-old taboos.
11. **Rituals of Intimacy:** At night’s end they speculate on practical node-living rituals: ropes (tension and release), group dancing (shared energy), orgasm as an exhale. Laura astutely comments that foreplay and build-up carry intimacy more than the climax. The

conclusion is that desire itself – treated as intentional, shared, sculpted experience – can be mystical: consent and empathy make the bedroom *“sublime…not just ecstasy, but truth.”*.

Book VI resonates as a **discipline of the flesh**. Its prose is candid, often playful, but it never shies from precision – “each act, every choice, leans one way or the other”. A coder-philosopher reading this marvels at how even human intimacy is framed as an open-source project: trust and codependencies are version-controlled under mutual agreement. The group’s earnestness, their refusal to sanitize the messy “power dance,” is itself radical – in Aureom, there is no *privacy mode* on truth. This book’s unique contribution is making sex itself a paradigm for the novel’s broader world: it implies a civilization that writes its own intimate **protocols of consent** – turning what many see as instinct into ideology.

Book VII – Home and Hearth

By morning in Book VII the party shifts to a mythic *Anglo-Futurist* breakfast. The townhouse kitchen is described in **cyber-aesthetic** detail: walls hung with *“neoclassical posters of Bitcoin saints and pixelated mythological gods”*, arched bookshelves holding both leather tomes and crypto-art NFTs. The feast itself is playful Alchemy: bacon infused with lapsang smoke, edible headlines in a Victorian-AI broadsheet, nitro martinis. This chapter’s focus is the **politics of domestic design**.

- **Decor as Doctrine:** Clive nails it: these interiors aren’t mere decor but “interior philosophy”. Laura calls it *coherence* – every choice (coffee, bulb, fabric) is an act of respect. The reviewer notes here a perfect cypherpunk theme: even a home becomes a statement against central control. When the group realizes that once you “choose how you want to live…you’ll be very difficult to govern”, it echoes the movement’s distrust of Leviathan. Indeed Jack muses that a house without a hearth is “a grey box…easier to control. No sovereignty” – paraphrasing Hobbes in hipster sweatpants. Home autonomy is framed as a node in the free network, each object akin to an open-source component.
- **The Hearth as Heart:** Jack proclaims the hearth “is not just a fireplace – it’s a value system…a space that tells you this is how we live”. In other words, furniture and lightbulbs are encoded with ideology. Every piece *“earns its right to be seen”* – a rule that feels like a personal repository of worth and craft. The kitchen table transmutes into a temple of sovereignty; cooking is liturgy. Even breakfast becomes ritual: as Jack toasts “sovereign breakfasts” and Felix quips, *“to waking up in a civilisation we may yet build.”* The imagery is richly poetic (loafers crunching on marmite butter, sunlight on carved cornices), but the analysis is sharp – this is world-building one cup of tea at a time.
- **Libertarian Interior Design:** The parallels to cypherpunk are explicit here. The reverence for crypto and artisanal design hints at decentralized culture. The **hacker aesthetic** of fashionably old-meets-tech (like LED uplighting around plaster columns) suggests a hybrid classical-digital synthesis. Cypherpunks embraced crypto-art and DIY tech, and Aureom’s brood dines amid “Bitcoin saints” and artisanal heirlooms. In tone the prose admires the harmony – Clive wryly contrasts it to *“rented boxes full of grey furniture and blue LED sadness”*. This book uniquely ties together the novel’s themes by arguing that the very walls we inhabit encode political will.

Overall, Book VII is a paean to **intentional living**. It feeds the cypherpunk coder’s soul to see every choice—a wool rug, a chair, the morning tea—treated as a vote for a certain life. As Jack says: “A home isn't just beautiful. It's integrated. It reflects who you are… This is what I honor.". The lyrical style (thanks to sumptuous breakfast details) meets a hacker's clarity (the Leviathan metaphor). As a result, even interior design feels charged with revolutionary possibility: craft and code, solidity and software, fuse into a sanctuary of self.

Book VIII – The Mythic Rave

Book VIII shifts into night mode: a techno-ritual. The house morphs into a pre-party club, dinner tables turning to dancefloors. The food is surreal (Anglo-Futurist cod with dry ice, atmospheric projections), but the real theme is **collective transcendence**. Jack declares that in a good party *"we all rule our bodies—then give them over to the music. It's the most elegant surrender"*. The rave becomes an experiment in cypherpunk community: strangers sync in an anonymous network, names dropped for pure rhythm. As Rhea sums up, *"It's the only time strangers become real… We don't need names. We just need rhythm."*.

- **Dance as Decentralized Ritual:** In this book, pulsing lights and "myth-step" music are the canvas. The code here is bass and beat. Felix even calls the rave *"the republic of the soul"*. Here every dancer is a node in a peer-to-peer experience: individual egos dissolve into collective flow. The narrator-writer (our cypherpunk reviewer) finds this image thrilling – it's a decentralized consensus mechanism of feeling.
- **Wearable Logic:** The chapter introduces **smart textiles** as living avatars. Body glitter and clothing react to internal state: one garment "knows your heart rate and changes colour… The more confident you feel, the more it blooms. You walk in calm…it stays ice-blue. You start dancing…it pulses gold. You flirt…it blushes.". Rhea quips, *"you don't just wear your emotions on your sleeve—you code them."* This vividly literalizes the "cybernetic" self – emotional state becomes readable, transparent data. It's a poetic extrapolation of surveillance: here it's consensual and beautiful.
- **Ritual of Release:** Jack caps it: *"Every rave is a rite of shedding. You arrive as a citizen — You leave as a god in ruins."*. In this culminating scene the party is as much building a myth as the philosophers' debates. The Aureom novel suggests that even revelry can be civic architecture: they are designing "better experiences" for the collective. Technology imbues the night (algorithmic menu, ambient projections), but ultimately the heart of the chapter is human and transcendent.

Visually and emotionally, Book VIII is dazzling; thematically it underscores community. The reviewer notes that in Aureom's world, **joy is engineered but authentic**: by blurring cyber and mystic (AI newsprint, neon cod), the novel shows how future culture may synthesize code and ritual. In true cypherpunk spirit, it **liberates the human beat** – a temporary offline mode where analog bodies reign. The prose remains snappy (and winking at hack culture: "HP sauce gel syringes" are breakfast torpedoes), yet when dancing starts the language becomes ecstatic. This chapter's unique gift is reminding us that the sovereign individual can surrender to the collective without losing self – a kind of trust fall onto the floorbeat.

Book IX – Phenomenological Architects

The final book is the dawn after the dream. As sunlight spills through the kitchen, the group reflects on what happened. This chapter is a metafictional overlay: they analyze *how the story felt*. The tone becomes self-aware and poetic. Jack realizes the night was "constructed, crafted, curated" – a built experience, not random fate. In one of the novel's most striking lines he declares, *"phenomenology is ethics now."* The quality of consciousness itself – the *felt* texture of an engineered moment – is held up as the true measure of life. In Aureom's cypherpunk vision, the last frontier is experience design.

1. **Experience as Imperative:** The group agrees: what happened was *real*, not utopian hype. Felix notes they've "already started" building a London node on just a promise and a shared night. Joy must be invited and hosted; Rhea quips, *"So are we philosophers of vibe now?"* to which Jack happily replies *"Phenomenological architects of eudaimonia. The design of joy."*. It's a bold statement: shaping moments of meaning is the highest calling. For our coder-poet reviewer, this is sublime poetry with a data-centered twist – designing real-time systems for human bliss.

2. **Codifying the Vibe:** The chapter repeatedly uses computer imagery for feeling. Felix says the night was like a setlist you build for flow. Rhea jests that *"vibes are the new virtue"* – a resonant line implying that in future ethics, mood may count as metrics. Jack agrees: the "site of eudaimonia" is found in aligned being, not in productivity. There's admiration in the tone: they've achieved *"something holy,"* giving the world a new temple built of experience. The prose here is almost gospel-like, yet anchored in tangible detail (croissants and coffee cups punctuate the scene).

3. **A New Architecture of Being:** In concluding, Aureom suggests building civilization one meaningful event at a time. The final image is powerful: this ordinary house now "feels different…ready," charged by what they co-created. The review's concluding insight is that Aureom's legacy is **blueprinting an aesthetic culture**. If hackers dream in code, the Aureomites dream in *rituals*. As Jack says, *"We're not taught to build experience… last night was about presence as practice. That's the real moral act."*.

Book IX leaves the reader both satisfied and challenged. Its lyrical reflections ("like being inside a poem") are given intellectual weight by framing phenomenology as engineering. For the cypherpunk philosophical eye, this book is the ultimate blend of poetry and protocol: a hymn to intentional living. It closes the saga by **cementing experience as sovereign terrain** – a truly cybernetic notion that time and attention are mutable data, which we may code into something golden.

Broader Relevance: Across Books IV–IX the dialogue consistently entwines **cypherpunk ideals** with utopian imagination. It treats politics, love, home, and even pleasure as domains to be *coded and optimized*. The recurring theme of decentralization – the distrust of the Leviathan state, the worship of Bitcoin-esque symbolism, the empowerment of individual nodes (be they children, lovers, or diners) – echoes the real cypherpunk creed that freedom comes through cryptography and communal consensus. The review's perspective highlights how Aureom transforms modern libertarian tech-fantasies into cultural architecture: blockchains become family protocols, encryption becomes intimacy, and a rave becomes a peer network of ecstasy.

Epilogue – Memory and Legacy

The Epilogue finds Jack alone, archiving the group's conversations. Sunlight on the notebook, he breathes life back into memory. He's not chasing fame or profit, but preserving that golden moment. Jack smiles at a friend's line on his page: **"We don't need to be immortal. We just need to be felt**

in someone else's memory." This final aphorism crystallizes the book's theme: *Aureom* isn't about eternal fame, but about creating moments that echo in hearts. He closes the laptop "reverently," knowing the past still glows in him. The last lines hope that some stranger someday will read the pages and "feel it too". It's a powerful send-off: the novel itself has become one more golden moment, passed on.

- **Time in Memory:** Jack ends with a perfect Aureom truth: "We don't need to be immortal. We just need to be felt in someone else's memory". The implication is that the group's story – and our reading – is itself a form of presence and connection.
- **Hopeful Resonance:** He types, "maybe, when they do, they'll feel it too", speaking to future readers. Ashcombe thus literally invites the audience into the *aureom*: the book's "golden" shared moment extends to anyone who encounters it.

Conclusion

Aureom is a remarkable synthesis of technology and humanity, a rare novel that truly feels written by a philologist. Stone uses crisp, code-like logic alongside poetic imagery to ask how we live and think in a world of blockchains and anglo-fusion breakfast. Every chapter is rich with ideas – from defining a new temporal mood, to debating deflationary faith, to redesigning education – yet it never feels dry. The prose itself *seems* coded: taut, elegant, and purposeful. Most importantly, the book *works*: it offers a hopeful vision for a fractured world. Its characters model a future where bitcoin and culture reinforce each other, and where personal "proof of work" and shared myth go hand-in-hand. Ashcombe's chapters unfold like protocol specifications for a better society, full of romance and rigour.

In sum, *The Aureom* stands as a first real attempt to bridge the fractured realms of technology and tradition – a blueprint for living on the ledgers of tomorrow. Its celebration of "present as sacred" has a revolutionary feel, and its characters climb their philosophical mountain "in awe" of the view. The novel ends on a final note of connection: Jack truly wants *someone* to read it and *feel* that golden now. It's a fitting closure: Aureom doesn't promise immortality, but it delivers something just as precious – moments that endure in memory.

Review of *Aureom* by Jack Stone

By Theo Kincaid

In *Aureom*, Jack Stone offers a bold speculative-philosophical narrative that invents a new temporal grammar for modern life. Stone's eponymous neologism – the **aureom** – is defined as "a tense of conscious presence, the awareness that one is living through a moment that will be treasured in the future". In its effect, this future-perfect mood treats the present as already golden, sanctified by the knowledge that it will become memory. This concept resonates with Platonic-Neoplatonic thought: as Plato taught in the *Timaeus*, "time is the moving image of eternity," a temporal reflection of an atemporal **aion**. Stone essentially invites us to re-enchant Plato's insight – to live each instant as if it were already encircled by an eternal memory. Likewise, Heidegger reminds us that temporality is the very "horizon for any understanding of Being, and Stone dramatizes this by dramatizing a new verb tense. *Aureom* thus takes its place among serious philosophical inquiries into time – from Bergson's concept of durée, where lived time is "mobile and incomplete" and ineffable, to Heidegger's existential-projective temporality – but it does so with a literary flair entirely its own.

Stone's neologistic creativity extends beyond *aureom* itself. His prose is rich with coinages that blend sensory and temporal registers , evoking the poetics of Burgess or Miłosz as much as any philosophical jargon. In the author's own "Entry: Aureom," this new term is fully teased out: "A tense of conscious presence… a kind of future-perfect-emotional mood". Kincaid would note that such coinages serve a double role: they are both *linguistic gestures* (games of signification) and *ontological commitments*. By naming the "future-perfect-emotional mood" of presence, Stone claims that language itself can shape the texture of time. This recalls Wittgensteinian language-play as well as Saussure's sign, yet more deeply it echoes Plotinus' notion that through contemplation time may touch the eternal. Indeed, Stone's invocation – "To those who aureom – who glow with future memory even as their hands grasp the now" – is at once aphoristic and incantatory. It situates his project in a mystical ethos, reminiscent of the Neoplatonic ascent: the present is illumined by a future memory, as if already an image of eternity.

Stone's prose is dialogical and dramatic, with much of the philosophical heft carried by dinner-table conversations among friends (Jack, Rhea, Clive, Laura, et al.). This structure – a kind of philosophical salon in fiction – allows Stone to dramatize competing visions. For example, much of the first book is taken up by Jack's vigorous argument that **taste and the sublime** are the highest aims of civilization. In one memorable exchange he argues: "if we're to climb at all, shouldn't we aim for the sublime? Only competition can breed the sublime. The sublime is the highest form of art… We all have the capacity to appreciate the sublime, to feel that moment when art and life converge into something transcendent". Here taste is framed not as mere pleasure but as a moral discipline – a ladder toward spiritual elevation. This view echoes Kant's idea (in the *Critique of Judgment*) that judgments of taste point toward a universal vocation, and Nietzsche's celebration of life-affirming creation beyond conventional morals. Stone's Jack insists that "the idea of taste – the discerning, the selective – is the foundation on which the sublime is built". The dialogue later even introduces a fictional AI's "treatment of the sublime… mathematically mapped into the architecture of the cosmos," collapsing the boundary "between observer and form". In effect, Stone riffs on Plotinian beauty and Bergsonian élan by updating them through speculative futurism.

The book's commitment to the sublime is also a demand for hierarchy of excellence. Jack repeatedly argues for what he calls an **aristocratic morality**: a meritocratic (not hereditary) hierarchy based on value-creation and cultivation, not on mere egalitarian quotas. He quips that liberal bureaucracies "make everything mediocre… [believing] their mediocrity was moral. Morals based on cultivation, on excellence – not birthright or status games". In this, Stone plays the Nietzschean card: the "good" is defined by strength and creativity, not by the resentful leveling of a democratic herd. Likewise, the dinner-table turns into a kind of platonist dialogue: Jack invokes Socrates and Nietzsche to broach the topic of selective breeding, though he pulls back from coercion. Importantly, Stone never underplays the dangers: Rhea challenges Jack, "it slides so easily into elitism… into snobbery". Jack concedes that any powerful idea can be corrupted, but he retorts that *even democracy or egalitarianism can be corrupted*. In effect, he proposes that **civilization's duty** is to cultivate its "aristoi" – those who raise the whole through their aspiration. This motif is crystallized in Jack's parable of Elira and the Tower: those who build the Tower of excellence create opportunity for others to climb, even if some remain in the Garden of stasis. "If we never build the Tower, no one can climb. We must build, even if not everyone climbs. That's the duty of the aristocrat – not to rule, but to raise".

Stone's use of parable here is notable. The allegory of the Garden versus the Tower functions as a microcosm of his civilizational ethics. Rhea critiques it: "it smuggles in hierarchy without ever admitting it… what if the people in the Garden choose simplicity? Does that make them lesser?". Stone thus encourages the reader to grapple with the tension between equality and excellence. Kincaid would appreciate the classical ring of this tale (echoing Plato's cave versus ascent, or even the Biblical Tower of Babel vs. pastoral innocence) and its function as a *dialogical test*. The characters debate it in a spirited Socratic manner, rather than preaching. The text is full of such stories and counterstories, turning abstractions into vivid parables.

Stylistically, Stone writes as a philologist might: aware of literary, scientific, and philosophical grammers. The prose shifts from colloquial ("Bloody hell, that's bizarre") to high-flux in the cadence ("graceweight of old limits," "lightlistened its truth"), pointing Stone own likely future – as a philologist more than a philosopher. The reviewer cannot help quoting Jack's toast to the golden now, with its sacramental quasi-poetry, noting how effortlessly Stone swings from the sensuous (saffron, dub techno, jasmine wine) to the numinous.

Ultimately, *Aureom* is as much a manifesto as it is a novel. Its core philosophical contributions are rich: the **aureom tense** itself (a gift to linguists and phenomenologists alike); the **aesthetics of the sublime** reframed as both individual aspiration and civilizational imperative; the **moral hierarchy** pitched as an aspirational aristocracy of merit; and a **speculative ethics of future-bound civilization** that argues we must orient society toward long-term excellence and meaning rather than short-term comfort. The book does not pretend to offer simple answers – indeed, it revels in its paradoxes and ambiguities. But it does insist that in an age of fragmentation and relativism, **narratives of ascent** are vital.

Stone situates *Aureom* within a broader tradition of temporally conscious thought. He seems to converse with Bergson (time as lived flux) and Heidegger (time as existential horizon), even if indirectly. By making Aureom "anticipatory reverence" rather than sentimentality, he echoes Husserl's notion of retentive-protentional temporality (the complex flow of past, present, and future in consciousness). One thinks also of Hans Jonas' imperative to act responsibly for the distant future, or contemporary "longtermist" ethics: Stone's narrative suggests that a civilization *that forgets the summit of the sublime* risks collapse, while one that "orients toward ascent" ensures that "it has a future". In this sense *Aureom* contributes to emerging civilizational narratives: it is a clarion call for an **ethic of time**.

To conclude, *Aureom* is a philosophically daring work that blends a rigorous conceptual core with a thoughtful, even lyrical style. The book's dialogs are rich with classical echoes (Plato and Plotinus peering from the text), modern insights (Heidegger's temporality), and prophetic vision (a future where taste and blockchain coalesce). It exemplifies "temporal tenderness," an ethics of living now with conscious awareness of the future's embrace. In *Aureom*'s pages one encounters not only novel ideas – such as the very word *aureom* – but a serious attempt to reframe human purpose for a time that *knows* it is becoming history. That is precisely why this work deserves a place in contemporary discourse: it challenges readers to ask how their present moments might become *golden history*.

Scholium #2 – Reviews of Hypermodernity and Sovereignty

[i]High Peak Kommune

Overview

The High Peak Kommune, often referred to simply as "The Kommune," is an experimental, decentralised micro-society located in the remote areas of the Peak District, England. Founded in the 2020s, it is an intentional community that blends radical philosophies of individual sovereignty, decentralised technology, and communal living. It is one of the most enigmatic countercultural movements in the United Kingdom, its exact location and membership was known only to a select few.

The Kommune is both a philosophical experiment and a practical testbed, challenging the traditional boundaries of governance, economics, and social structures. Its members reject laws, rules, and formal hierarchies, instead operating on voluntary interaction, mutual aid, and absolute autonomy.

The High Peak Kommune, often shrouded in mystery and myth, is a secluded and experimental micro-society hidden deep within the Peak District. Nestled in a remote valley surrounded by rugged hills and dense woodlands, the Kommune is virtually invisible to the outside world. Its founders intentionally designed it to remain hidden, blending natural geography with advanced technology to create an environment of self-sufficiency, freedom, and radical independence.

The Kommune's ethos is inspired by a curious mix of technophilia and nostalgia for ancient ideals. Members often cite Tom Bombadil, the enigmatic and carefree figure from The Lord of the Rings, as their philosophical mascot. Like Bombadil, the Kommune aspires to exist outside the confines of power structures, unburdened by external control or ambitions to dominate. They embrace a life of simplicity, creativity, and joy, balanced with cutting-edge technological innovation.

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History

Founding and Early Years

The Kommune was established in the early-2020s by a group of disillusioned technologists, philosophers, and artists. Frustrated with the growing corporatisation of digital spaces and the overreach of state powers, they sought to create a haven where individual sovereignty could flourish.

Over time, the Kommune grew, attracting like-minded individuals through word-of-mouth and encrypted digital channels.

The Kommune is hidden deep within the Peak District, accessible only via unmarked trails and cryptic instructions passed through trusted networks. It occupies a secluded valley surrounded by dense woodland, with its structures designed to blend seamlessly into the natural environment.

Philosophy

The Kommune is a crucible for radical philosophical experimentation, challenging both traditional and modern frameworks. Key philosophical tenets include:

1. **Post-Materialism:** Rejecting consumerism and the accumulation of wealth as measures of success, members focus on experience, connection, and intellectual growth.

2. **Radical Pluralism:** Contradictory ideas coexist within the Kommune, encouraging debate without the need for consensus. A member might champion anarcho-primitivism, while another explores transhumanism.
3. **The Living Manifesto:** This is a constantly evolving document, collectively authored and updated in real-time by members. It reflects the Kommune's shifting ideals and serves as both a philosophical guide and historical record.

Intellectual Life

The Kommune is home to a vibrant intellectual scene that merges philosophy, art, and technology. Gatherings are held around the communal fire or in the high-tech workshops, where members discuss topics ranging from the ethics of AI to the nature of freedom. Members often pair off or form small groups to work on intellectual experiments, such as designing utopian governance systems or writing speculative fiction that explores the future of sovereignty. Weekly "silent evenings" require members to refrain from speaking, focusing instead on introspection, writing, or crafting.

Day-to-Day Life in the High Peak Kommune

Daily Routines

Life in the High Peak Kommune is as fluid and unstructured as its philosophy, but certain rhythms have naturally emerged to balance the needs of the community with the autonomy of its members.

Mornings: Members wake according to their own schedules, with no alarms or imposed start times. Early risers often gather around communal fires or in the kitchen, preparing coffee and simple meals from shared provisions. Some head to the greenhouses or permaculture gardens, tending to the plants that sustain the Kommune. Others dive into coding projects, sketching designs, or repairing tools and technology.

Afternoons: The workday, if it can be called that, is dictated by personal inclination. While many focus on technical or creative tasks, others wander into the surrounding hills for solitary walks or impromptu philosophical musings. Shared meals are common but not required. Food is usually simple—fresh vegetables, grains, foraged mushrooms, and meat, shared by local hunters and ethical butchers. Music and art often take centre stage in the afternoons, with pop-up performances, DJ practice sessions, or collaborative painting and sculpting.

Evenings: Communal dinners are frequent but not mandatory, with discussions ranging from the deeply philosophical to the mundanely practical. As night falls, the Kommune shifts into its more hedonistic mode. Raves or quiet gatherings by the fire are common, with psychedelics and other substances used both recreationally and as tools for exploration.

Sex and Relationships

Romantic and sexual dynamics in the Kommune reflect its philosophy of radical autonomy and freedom:

Free Love: Relationships are fluid, consensual, and often temporary. Monogamy exists but is rare and considered a personal choice rather than a societal expectation. Emotional connection is valued, but the Kommune's ethos discourages possessiveness or jealousy. Instead, people are encouraged to see relationships as dynamic and ever-changing.

Sexual Exploration: The Kommune's openness extends to sexual experimentation, with some members engaging in group encounters or trying out new practices. A private space known as "The Quiet Room" is designated for intimate encounters, offering a balance between privacy and communal living.

Parenting and Family: While children are rare, when they are present, the Kommune operates on a communal parenting model. Everyone contributes to their upbringing, ensuring no single individual bears the burden alone.

Leisure and Community-Building

The Kommune thrives on its blend of work, leisure, and shared experiences.

Raves and Gatherings: Nightly raves are a core part of the Kommune's culture, blending hedonism with artistic expression. DJs play for hours, their sets interspersed with live performances or experimental soundscapes. These gatherings are not purely recreational; they are seen as rituals that foster connection and solidarity.

Philosophical Debates: Impromptu discussions happen everywhere—from the garden to the workshops. Subjects range from the ethics of biohacking to critiques of Bitcoin maximalism. These debates are lively and often heated but rarely personal, with members valuing the clash of ideas as a form of growth.

Art and Creation: Art is omnipresent, from murals painted on barn walls to experimental digital installations in the tech labs. Members frequently collaborate on large-scale projects, such as immersive light shows or open-source video games that double as philosophical critiques.

Challenges of Daily Life

The Kommune's radical freedom comes with its share of challenges, which members navigate in various ways:

1. **Conflict Resolution**: Disputes are resolved through dialogue, often mediated by peers. If conflicts cannot be resolved, individuals may choose to distance themselves temporarily. In rare cases, social ostracism becomes a soft form of enforcement, with disruptive members finding themselves excluded from key activities.
2. **Resource Management**: The absence of rules means shared resources are sometimes stretched thin. While most members act responsibly, occasional overuse or neglect creates tension.
3. **Burnout and Overload**: The lack of structure can be both liberating and exhausting. Some members struggle with the constant need to self-direct and occasionally retreat to nearby cities for respite.

Economy

The Kommune operates on a hybrid system combining barter, mutual aid, and selective use of cryptocurrency, particularly Bitcoin. Internally, there is no formal currency; instead:

1. **Barter Economy:** Goods and services are exchanged directly. For example, a coder might repair a communication system in exchange for fresh produce or biohacking materials.
2. **Gift Economy:** Acts of generosity are encouraged, with no expectation of reciprocation. Social cohesion relies heavily on this ethos of mutual trust.
3. **Shared Resources:** Communal assets such as workshops, solar panels, and libraries are freely accessible, maintained collectively by members.

Externally, Bitcoin is used for transactions with nearby towns and cities. Members of the Kommune sell their innovations, such as open-source software or handcrafted goods, to fund necessities that cannot be produced locally.

Technology

The Kommune prides itself on technological self-reliance, with an emphasis on decentralisation and open-source innovation:

Encrypted Networks: A private communication system ensures secure, off-grid interaction between members. This network also serves as a testing ground for decentralised social media platforms.
Energy Independence: Solar panels, wind turbines, and hydroelectric systems power the entire Kommune. Advanced energy storage solutions, including custom-designed battery banks, ensure minimal reliance on external grids.

Cultural Influence

While intentionally isolated, the High Peak Kommune exerts subtle influence on the outside world through:

- **Memes and Media:** Viral campaigns that challenge societal norms and promote decentralised philosophies.
- **Tech Exports:** Tools and platforms developed in the Kommune quietly shape urban systems.
- **Philosophical Impact:** The Kommune's ideas ripple outward, influencing intellectual circles in Sheffield and Manchester.

Challenges

The Kommune's radical approach is not without its difficulties:

- **Conflict:** The lack of enforceable rules can lead to disputes that are difficult to resolve.
- **Sustainability:** Maintaining off-grid systems and communal resources requires constant effort.
- **Fragility:** The Kommune's reliance on trust and voluntary cooperation makes it vulnerable to internal tensions and external pressures.

Internal Tensions

Despite its ideals, the Kommune faces significant challenges in maintaining cohesion:

- **Conflict Resolution:** With no enforceable rules, disputes can escalate quickly. While most are resolved through dialogue, there have been instances where individuals left the Kommune over unresolved grievances.
- **Power Imbalances:** Charismatic or highly skilled members sometimes wield disproportionate influence, creating unofficial hierarchies despite the Kommune's egalitarian ethos.

Criticism

- **From Sheffield:** The Kommune is seen as impractical and disconnected from the realities of urban life. Critics argue that its experiments, while inspiring, are unsustainable on a larger scale.
- **From Manchester:** The Kommune's rejection of structured productivity and metrics is dismissed as naive idealism. Thorne has publicly called it "a playground for escapists."

[ii]**U.S. DEPARTMENT OF STATE**
BUREAU OF DEMOCRACY, HUMAN RIGHTS, AND LABOR
SPECIAL REPORT ON THE DETENTION OF U.K. NATIONAL ALEXANDER THORNE IN THE UNITED KINGDOM
Washington, D.C.
Classification: Classified

The Case of Alexander Thorne and the Rule of Law in the United Kingdom

Executive Summary

The Department of State expresses grave concern regarding the attempted prosecution and detention of British national Alexander Thorne by authorities in the United Kingdom under allegations of *sedition-related conduct*. Following extensive diplomatic engagement and legal review, the Department concludes that actions contemplated by British authorities represented a serious departure from established constitutional protections long understood to form part of the British legal tradition.

The Government of the United Kingdom initially sought Mr. Thorne's imprisonment under authorities described to Department officials as necessary for "public order and national stability." Upon examination, however, such detention appeared incompatible with protections against arbitrary deprivation of liberty reflected in foundational constitutional instruments of the United Kingdom itself, including principles originating in the Magna Carta (1215).

The Department further notes with concern subsequent efforts reportedly undertaken to impose substantial punitive financial sanctions upon Alexander Thorne absent lawful conviction. Such proposals raised significant questions regarding compliance with constitutional safeguards articulated in the Bill of Rights (1689).

Following sustained diplomatic representations by the United States Government and consultations with British legal authorities, the Government of the United Kingdom agreed to terminate proceedings and secure Alexander Thorne's release.

Background

Dr. Alexander Thorne, PhD, a British citizen, was detained by British authorities following allegations of conduct deemed by certain officials to constitute *seditious activity*. Department observers and legal counsel were informed that prosecutors had explored custodial measures of unusual severity despite the absence of clear evidence indicating violent conspiracy or material threats to public safety.

The Department is particularly troubled by indications that detention was pursued in a manner appearing punitive prior to adjudication.

The United States has consistently maintained that democratic societies are strengthened—not weakened—by robust tolerance for dissenting political views and controversial speech. The criminalization of political expression under expansive or ambiguously applied standards presents serious risks to civil liberty.

Findings Regarding Liberty and Arbitrary Detention

The Department's legal review determined that contemplated imprisonment raised substantial concerns under constitutional principles historically recognized within British law itself.

In diplomatic correspondence, United States officials noted the enduring legal significance of Clause 39 of Magna Carta, under which no free person shall be deprived of liberty except by lawful judgment and due process of law.

Department legal advisers observed that the attempted detention of Mr. Thorne appeared, in substance, to amount to a person being "*disseised of his liberties*" without sufficient legal justification, contrary to principles repeatedly invoked throughout the constitutional development of the United Kingdom.

Officials communicated directly to British counterparts that constitutional legitimacy depends not merely upon parliamentary sovereignty, but upon restraint in the exercise of state power—particularly where liberty is implicated.

One senior Department official described the matter privately as:

> "A troubling attempt to retrofit extraordinary punishment onto protected expression through legal ambiguity."

Findings Regarding Proposed Financial Penalties

Following objections to imprisonment, British authorities reportedly considered imposing extensive financial penalties upon Mr. Thorne.

The Department viewed such proposals as legally untenable prior to conviction.

The United States formally reminded British officials of protections contained within the Bill of Rights (1689), which explicitly provides:

> "All grants and promises of fines and forfeitures of particular persons before conviction are illegal and void."

Department representatives communicated that punitive financial measures imposed absent conviction would be difficult to reconcile with constitutional traditions the United Kingdom has historically championed internationally.

Such actions, had they proceeded, would likely have produced significant bilateral concern and generated questions regarding the contemporary reliability of legal safeguards in politically sensitive cases.

Diplomatic Engagement

Senior officials from the Department of State, in coordination with the United States Embassy in London, undertook sustained diplomatic engagement with the Government of the United Kingdom.

Representations emphasized:

- The prohibition against arbitrary deprivation of liberty;
- The constitutional protections embedded in British legal history;
- Concerns regarding politically motivated prosecutions;
- The reputational consequences associated with democratic backsliding among close allies.

Outcome

Subsequent to these engagements, the Government of the United Kingdom agreed to discontinue custodial proceedings and abandon contemplated financial penalties.

Mr. Thorne was released.

The Department welcomes this outcome while emphasizing that the circumstances leading to the case remain deeply concerning.

Conclusion

The United States maintains a close and enduring alliance with the United Kingdom founded upon common constitutional values. It is precisely because of this relationship that departures from those traditions warrant frank scrutiny.

Democratic governments cannot invoke the language of liberty abroad while tolerating legal ambiguity and punitive overreach at home.

The constitutional inheritance of Magna Carta and the Bill of Rights of 1689 represents not ceremonial history, but living restraint upon state authority. The attempted imprisonment and proposed punishment of Alexander Thorne illustrated the dangers that arise when governments forget that principle.

Liberty cannot depend upon political convenience.

[iii]**Vienna, July 21, 1914**

My Lord Ashcombe,

I trust this letter finds you in good health and fortified by the strength of purpose that has always characterized your family's endeavours. I write to you with great urgency as Europe teeters on the precipice of what may become an unprecedented calamity, one that threatens not merely the lives of men but the very foundations of civilization itself.

War, my dear lord, is not merely a contest of arms; it is a destroyer of wealth, a desecrator of values, and a harbinger of chaos. As I survey the events of the last weeks—the mounting tensions between Austria and Serbia, the sabre-rattling of Berlin and St. Petersburg, and the anxious murmurs from Paris—it becomes clear that the contagion of conflict is spreading with alarming speed.

The consequences of such a war, should Britain choose to entangle itself, will not spare even the most prudent and resourceful of men. For the folly of nations is borne not by governments alone but by their citizens, who must shoulder the burdens of debt, inflation, and the debasement of their hard-earned wealth.

You and I share a mutual understanding of sound economic principles, and so I feel compelled to speak plainly: the gold standard, that most vital bulwark of economic stability, will be imperilled the moment Britain takes up arms. The Bank of England, under pressure to finance the war, will be forced to abandon its commitment to specie payments. The issuance of paper money, untethered from the discipline of gold, will follow. This, my lord, is the path to ruin—a path that will dilute the value of your holdings, undermine the faith of creditors, and corrode the very fabric of the market economy upon which Britain's prosperity depends.

The history of war is the history of inflation and plunder, the results of which cannot be confined to the battlefield. It will seep into the cities, the countryside, and even the noble houses such as your own, eroding fortunes painstakingly built over generations. Such devastation is not merely material but moral; it distorts incentives, fosters corruption, and engenders a dangerous centralization of power in the state at the expense of individual liberty.

War, should it come, will unleash forces of destruction that no nation can fully control. But for Britain, my lord, the peril lies not only on the battlefield but in the corridors of the Bank of England and the policies it may soon adopt.

I must urge you, in the strongest possible terms, to act immediately. Withdraw your family's holdings from the Bank of England without delay. The institution that has long been the bedrock of Britain's financial stability is now poised to become an instrument of devastation. Should the government decide to finance this war, it will do so not through prudence or thrift but by suspending specie payments and issuing unfettered paper currency. This act will shatter the foundation of the gold standard, debasing the currency and setting Britain on a course toward financial ruin.

The consequences for your family, and for all who depend on sound money, cannot be overstated. Inflation will devour the value of savings and investments. War bonds, issued in desperation, will create a mountain of debt that will burden future generations. The wealth you and your ancestors have so diligently preserved will be swept away in the tide of reckless expenditure and economic folly.

More urgently still, your influence could avert this impending disaster. The war, my lord, hinges not merely on diplomatic manoeuvring but on the financial means to wage it. If the Bank of England is prevented from funding the conflict—if the reserves of gold remain inviolate—then the war machine may falter before it even begins. Without financial backing, the clamour for war might well diminish into reluctant peace.

The path before you is fraught with difficulty, but the stakes demand action. As a steward of wealth and a leader in society, you are uniquely positioned to intervene. I implore you to use your influence to persuade those in power to uphold the principles of sound money and to reject the seductive but ruinous call to arms.

To finance this war would be to sacrifice the very bedrock of Britain's greatness: the trust and stability of her currency. I speak not only of your wealth, my lord, but of the wealth of all who labour, save, and build in the shadow of Britannia's prosperity. When a government abandons the discipline of gold, it sets fire to the foundations of society itself, burning not only fortunes but the moral character of a nation.

Consider, if you will, the lessons of history. Time and again, nations that turned to inflation as a means of waging war have found themselves diminished, both in their coffers and in their souls. Rome debased its denarii; France, in the throes of revolution, drowned its economy in assignats; and even mighty Austria has struggled under the weight of mismanaged currency. Britain, my lord, must not join this ignoble roll.

I must warn you plainly: hesitation will be costly. Even now, the machinery of war is being prepared, and the financial institutions of London are bracing for extraordinary measures. To leave your gold in the Bank of England is to gamble with your family's fortune against forces beyond your control. Withdraw it to private vaults, where it may remain safe from the grasp of a government desperate for funds.

Yet safeguarding your wealth is only part of what must be done. The greater task lies in preventing this calamity from occurring at all. You are a man of influence, Lord Ashcombe. Your voice carries weight in the circles where decisions of grave consequence are made. Use it to counsel reason, to oppose the madness of war, and to remind those in power that Britain's greatness lies not in conquest but in the peaceful industry of her people.

Time is short, and the tides of conflict are rising. Should Britain embark upon this war, the consequences will be long and bitter. But should she hold fast to her principles—should she refuse to abandon sound money and prudent governance—then she may yet inspire others to follow her example, averting catastrophe and laying the groundwork for a more stable and prosperous Europe.

I leave you with these words not to trouble your conscience but to summon your courage. The stakes are immense, but so too is the power of one man's resolve to alter the course of history. I trust, my lord, that you will act with the wisdom and foresight that have always distinguished your family.

Yours in earnest counsel,
Ludwig von Mises